



감방에서 남자주인공을 만났습니다

문서현 로맨스판타지소설

비나리드

Information

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I Met the Male Lead in Prison

Author: [Moon Shi-hyun](#)

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I Met the Male Lead in Prison novel is a popular light novel covering Drama, Fantasy, and Romance genres. Written by the Author Moon Shi-hyun. 257 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

I met the male lead in prison.

Okay. I get that I transmigrated into an R-19 tragic romantic novel, but why is he like this?

“Bark! Bark! Bark! Grrrrrr...”

I can’t believe this guy is held by a curse that makes him act like a beast... And that’s not the end of it, because when he returns to normal for a moment.

“I-i-if you aren’t g-going to take responsibility for what you did to me, th-th-then don’t t-touch me!”

At any rate, I felt relieved that I probably wouldn’t have any sort of romantic interactions with this guy.

A year later...

“Th-th-the day I leave this place, please...m-meet up with me!”

Well it wouldn’t be a big deal to meet him once. But, then, when I was released from prison...

“Welcome back. My lovely younger sister.”

The day of my release, a man approached me. Turns out, I’m the villain’s sister.

“You must have suffered going to prison in my stead. I waited only for you.”

...F*ck. My brother’s the male lead’s sworn enemy?

3 years later, I met the male lead. He looked totally different than when I last saw him.

“It’s been a while, Iana. I’m going to kidnap you now.”

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Chapter 1

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 1

Chapter 1. What? Meeting the male lead in prison?

It was a day of wilting flowers and falling summer leaves. I finally accepted my situation.

Three months ago, I opened my eyes and found myself in a totally different world, a world of a book that I had read in my spare time.

I had transmigrated into a book. And it obviously wasn't your typical transmigration.

I hadn't transmigrated into a fancy room with a lavish bed or one in a dilapidated wooden shack.

<Why a prison!>

I had transmigrated into...a prison. Right in front of me were a group of people dressed in drab clothes of striped gray patterns, with prisoner numbers hanging near their chests.

...I mean, how could I have opened my eyes to a prison!

<A prison? A PRISON?>

Even if I was only dreaming, I would rather have a different dream than a pathetic one like this. But though it was the most pathetic place for transmigration, this prison, 'Kambrakam,' was definitely the setting from that book I had read before. I could tell from the strangely familiar 'European Middle Ages' setting.

Of all stories, why did I have to transmigrate into this X-rated tragic romance novel. The book was something I had casually read to pass the time, so the details were fuzzy, especially of the male lead. I only remembered that he was super handsome, but a bit peculiar.

I was in a sort of special prison cell with other prisoners. In a time period in which human rights were thrown out the window, we were given proper meals and even taken to a place for daily exercise.

This was because all the prisoners here were of noble class. As for me, my character was in prison in my father and older brother's stead.

"Hey, Iana."

I didn't know what exact crime I was here for, but I knew I was some sort of extra character named Iana that hadn't even been worth mentioning in the novel.

"Hey, hey. You listening?"

"Ah, yes, yes!"

Though I didn't know everyone's last names, the people in this prison cell with me were nobles, so I assumed that I was part of an aristocratic family as well.

I turned my attention to the middle-aged, pot-bellied man sitting in front of me. He cleared his throat and continued speaking.

"The reason why we don't have personal rooms and have been stuffed into a prison cell together? Simple. They want to set an example. That aristocrats can be punished too. It's a show of the emperor's authority."

"Aha, I see."

Baron Paladis, who had been caught and imprisoned for selling fake money despite his smarts, was a useful confidante.

"So that's why all the nobles are imprisoned in here."

Here's a rundown of what I remembered of the pretty strong plot.

The female lead. A lovely, kind, and friendly lady, Francia was imprisoned in Kambrakam in place of her father. This innocent lady couldn't control her always insatiable curiosity, and one night, took a secret tour of the prison, only to get lost in the deep parts of Kambrakam. She chanced upon a prison cell with a single man imprisoned inside, but...

[Who are you?]

The man who had been chained by his hands to the wall, was the longest-term prisoner in the history of Kambrakam. In other words, the male lead, Heinrich Dorean von Hel.

The future Archduke of the Hel estate.

An incredible power was passed down to the sons of the Hel family, but unable to control his powers, he had been imprisoned in the depths of Kambrakam, and wouldn't be released until there was someone who could help him with his control.

It was because this incredible power apparently turned the wielder into something like a 'beast.' Strictly speaking, one would gain power that surpassed human strength but would lose human awareness and reasoning.

[What a pitiful person...]

The kind and innocent Francia pitied the male lead after hearing about his situation, and released him from his bonds. But because of his power, as soon as he was free, he became a beast and ended up knocking down the female lead.

[Ahh~...!]

Ehem, you can guess what happened next.

Anyway. After an intense night together, the female lead became the male lead's 'companion,' the only one who he allowed to free him from his

shackles. In this case, ‘companion’ referred to a lover to the duke that was connected to him by their souls.

And then there’s more stuff about the villain and such, but for now, the male lead, the supporting male lead (villain), and the female lead developed their relationships with this prison as the setting in the X-rated novel. So, a love triangle was formed.

The love triangle concept continued throughout the story because the male lead had a relatively unstable personality and the villainous supporting male lead was consistently fixated on the female lead.

“The contents are quite...what a relationship those three must have had.”

As far as I knew, the villain and the male lead were of rival aristocratic families, so the love triangle persisted even in high society.

I stood outside the male lead’s prison cell as I thought to myself.

“Hmm, so I guess that’s him.”

Though I couldn’t see that well because of the darkness

“Ugh, I can’t see.”

I could make out a shape, but it wasn’t clear. Though the cells on the second and third floors had windows, this cell didn’t have any. Maybe because it was situated in the basement? Though they could have probably installed windows in the basement cells...

It made sense that the male lead had a gloomy personality. Even if he wasn’t born with it, he could probably only feel gloomy after being in such a dreary cell.

“Iana, I think you should go.”

“Aw come on mister, just a little more.”

I smiled at the prison guard Hans and hit his shoulders in a playful manner. He looked at me knowing that he couldn't convince me to leave and shrugged.

"You know that such a thing like this shouldn't even happen, right? If the boss finds out about this, I'm dead. Hmm?"

"Of course. Know that my lips are sealed."

"Huh. You really are a little different. Usually the precious ladies of noble families wouldn't mingle with lower class people like me, you know."

As I smiled at him without an answer, Hans smiled bitterly and shrugged his shoulders again.

"Well...though I probably wouldn't have talked with you if not for what you gave me."

Kambrakam was a prison for the nobles, so all the guards were knights. Especially for the male lead's cell, the guards were those with pretty high-level abilities.

A characteristic of this prison was that there were less chances of interaction between women and men than outside of the prison. And then, of course, there were a few people like me who struck up conversations with anyone, causing the bewildered knights to shake their heads. Though now that three months had passed, they had all gotten used to my actions.

"Did you like what I gave you?"

"Of course. Exactly where were you able to get such a high-class cigar? A middle-class knight like me would obviously drool over such an item."

"I don't know. I just asked for it in a letter to my family and they sent it to me."

The knight looked at me as if he didn't believe me, but I was telling the truth. As soon as I opened my eyes in this world, the first things I had seen

were the desk I was sitting at and an almost blank letter with a small note scribbled at the top.

[Write to me what you want me to get.]

From then on, a blank letter would arrive every month, and if I wrote what I wanted and sent it back, those items, whatever I had asked for, would arrive.

Even items that were normally banned in prisons, like alcohol and cigarettes, were delivered to me if I asked. At first, I didn't know what this letter was, so I just left it alone, but the next month I received a letter asking, 'You don't need anything?'

To the others who couldn't get anything they wanted like I could, I quickly became a superstar.

<If you don't mind, could the lady tell us exactly which family you are from?>

There were people here who went by their first names and others who went by their full titles. There wasn't anyone who was called by their number, like, "Nobleman 3615!"

<I'd like to just be called by my first name.>

Anyhow, to the people who were curious about my family name, I always shook my head and asked them to call me Iana.

Because the thing is, I didn't know either. So I didn't let anyone know who my family was.

If my family was someone that I did know from the novel, then they would probably be someone with a high enough status based on how they could get me anything, but...it was difficult to see family members during imprisonment and other than the blank letter that arrived every month, there wasn't anything else for me to work with, not even a name.

So I just assumed that I was from a relatively stable noble family. Because if I was from a family that appeared in the book, I would have figured that out by now. Well, it's not like there were a lot of characters in the novel. I mean, other than the steamy hot nights between the female and male leads, nothing else was really that important.

Hans shook his head when I told him I didn't know where I got the cigars.

"Well anyway, you are an interesting person, Iana."

"Am I? I can't really tell. Ah, more than that, Hans, I have a favor to ask of you."

I pointed at the vague outline of a figure collapsed in the dark cell.

"Can you let me inside there?"

"No I cannot."

"Really?"

Hans shook his head in a firm no, but I knew what these guards were most weak against. I smirked at him and spoke.

"Next time I'll give you two of the same kind."

"...I cannot."

"3 cigars?"

He flinched at my smile.

"But still..."

"3 cigars and a pipe. If you don't want to, I'll just ask and give it all to Talmin-"

"Now that I think about it, I think going in for a few seconds is okay."

Talmin was another prison guard who was a rival of Hans.

“Deal.”

I couldn’t stop my chuckle. Hans cleared his throat and turned his head the other way. He tried to hide his embarrassment.

“You really can only stay there for just a little bit, okay?”

“Oka~ay.”

Perhaps it’s because the novel’s events hadn’t happened yet. Unlike how the cell was under strict surveillance in the novel, the male lead’s prison cell wasn’t heavily guarded. Perhaps it was because no one knew the male lead’s power? In the novel, the prison cell was strictly monitored after the male lead caused a huge ruckus. So.

“You need to put in the key and turn it. Two times to the right. It’s a bit rusty, so you have to put in some strength.”

“Yup. Got it.”

I pushed open the door after unlocking it. I could smell something like wet moss past the rusted door. This cell hasn’t been cleaned at all, has it?

I took a few steps towards the wall and then stopped, blinking my eyes repeatedly. Someone lay on the ground, his body chained to the wall.

‘So this is the male lead who hasn’t met the female lead yet, huh...’

He probably hadn’t been eating well because he was rather scrawny, but he still gave off a sacred, saint-like feeling. Maybe it was because of his silver hair. Or maybe because of his long eyebrows or his eyes with a color like the sky.

My throat made a sound as I gulped.

Heinrich Dorean was hella fine.

Chapter 2

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 2

Chapter 2: This isn't a person, this is a dog (1)

He wasn't the most presentable-looking he could be. His appearance was slightly worse than a dirty ghost or worn-out clothing, I guess. For obvious reasons, I couldn't keep looking at him.

"I guess just 'ghost' wasn't exactly the way to describe him."

Let's see, I was currently 18 years old. The male lead, Rick Dorian, who had been trapped in here was 16, right...?

It was exactly 4 years before the plot began. 16 meant he was almost a grown-up, but with closed eyes, his face gave off a feeling of childlike youth.

Wow. He looked like an angel while sleeping.

"Is he alive? I feel like someone with such a face wouldn't be able to live in a place like this."

On the boy's neck lay a special sort of necklace. Honestly, more than a necklace, it seemed like some sort of shackle. Wasn't this the restraint tool that was used on the male lead as described in the novel?

Though he seemed heavily guarded and firmly shackled by this tool, his handsome appearance couldn't be hidden. Honestly, I had come here just to make sure I was really in the world of the novel I thought I was in, and now I had no choice but to admit that I was.

The male lead's beauty was too high to be in the real world and could only exist in a novel that had described his looks exactly as I saw them now.

'He's breathing, right?'

Without thinking, I stretched out my hand towards him.

Flinch.

I stopped. Hoping that I had seen incorrectly, I once more reached out to the male lead, but saw his eyelids twitch. And then he opened his eyes. My breath stopped as I looked into his sparkling blue eyes, which slowly blinked at me.

I had no time to appreciate the sight before me.

"Grrrr! Bark! Bark!"

"Oh my gosh!"

I was so shocked at the dog sounds that I fell on my butt. And then realized I had to get away from here.

...Do iron chain get longer? Because it just did!

I quickly avoided the male lead to a safe spot in the cell, barely escaping from his attempt to bite me. I looked at him, shocked.

Didn't the novel say he would just go crazy? And that though he was supposed to end up having a violent personality, he was definitely still supposed to be human?

"Bark! Bark Bark!"

That's just a dog! A! Dog! I stood speechless in front of the boy who, at this point, had forgotten any sort of human speech and behavior.

But after looking at the lad who continued to bark at me for awhile, I got used to it, and began to grope around my surroundings. Eventually, my

hand hit an object. I wasn't sure why exactly there was a random stick in the cell, but.

I quietly and carefully approached the male lead while holding the stick towards him.

Chomp.

“...Ah. He bit it.”

The male lead stared at me with a guarded expression on his face, but he continued to hold onto the stick.

So, this means he doesn't hate the stick, right? He likes it, right?

I looked at the male lead with interest and then lightly touched the end of the stick. His gaze towards me immediately grew more hostile.

Hmm, he's still not letting it go? He looked exactly like one of those puppies who didn't want their chew toy taken from them. I blinked with surprise at this realization and chuckled. Though rather than a puppy, he looked more like a baby predatory animal.

I soon realized my mistake in giving him the stick and held out my hand.

“Oh no no no. You should give that to me now. It's dirty.”

He shook his head.

“...Huh, wait, you understand my words? Really?”

As I spoke, he looked at me with a violent gaze. Sort of like, how dare you look at me like I'm an idiot? Wow, I guess he did understand me. But then why did he bark instead of talk?

But if I just left him like this, his teeth were going to rot.

“Grrr....”

For now, I needed to get the stick away from him. If I teased him in any way, I knew I was going to feel guilty later. So without taunting him, I said ‘Ahh,’ and put my hand out towards him with my palm facing up. And since it didn’t look like he was going to give me the stick, I needed something else to replace it.

I undid my hairdo and dangled the hair tie in front of the male lead.

“Look at this, Rick Dorian. Hmm? Come on, look. This is softer and squishier than that stick. Pretty, isn’t it?”

Although he kept watching me carefully, I saw his gaze blur as his resolve wavered for a second.

Well, now he was acting like a cat. While he was distracted I quickly grabbed the stick from his mouth. And before he could start barking again, I shoved my hair tie into his mouth.

“Now, how is it? Nice, right?”

“...”

“There you go, there you go. Coochy coochy coo, you’re such a good boy. You’re really chewing it well.”

“...stop.”

“Hmm?”

“Pl, please stop.”

Tik. The hair tie fell to the ground. My eyes widened.

I moved my lamp to get a better view of him. The sparks of the lamp I was holding surrounded his glowing face.

“Ahh...st, stop...”

The lad opened and closed his mouth, and then made a tearful face.

“Wh, wh, what d, d, d, did I do to deserve this?”

As soon as he saw me, his face flushed. As if he was embarrassed over his actions from earlier. His eyes began to tear up as he looked at me. I began to feel flustered.

“Ri, ri, right now, you, my first time...”

...Hm?

What crap was this guy spouting now. First time? First time of what.

“First time?”

Without thinking, I went along with the flow. And I realized when I spat out those words. He had a completely different expression than before, even his gaze was different.

“How, how could you do this, be the first bitten...you are the fir, first...”

“No. No, no, wait a second.”

I stopped him from continuing. This male lead was just blurting out fantasies with sexual innuendos, left and right.

That was close.

Chapter 3

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 3

Chapter 3: This isn't a person, this is a dog (2)

“So, what you’re saying is, I’m the first person you’ve ever bitten, correct? Please speak clearly so people don’t misunderstand.”

“It, it is no-not a m-m-mi-misunderstanding.”

“It is.”

What kind of a situation was this, seriously. This meant that whenever he returned to his senses, he acted like this.

“S-so, it’s a misunderstanding?”

“Yes, that is correct.”

He looked at me with watery eyes. Any signs of his previously beast-like, predatory gaze had disappeared, but he continued to stare at me with sharp reproach.

I thought I could see the ocean in his blue eyes, especially when his eyes, akin to blue jewels were filled with tears...

If a single tear fell, I was going to be nailed down with an immense sense of guilt.

Fantastic.

I felt my conscience unnecessarily pricked, and spoke as I turned my head.

“Well, I’m sorry.”

I rubbed my cheek with my hand and looked around the room, avoiding the staring eyes of Rick Dorian. For some reason, he looked surprised.

“Tha, that’s the first time some, someone has a-a-apologized to me...the, first.”

...What. What was with this guy and his whatever-firsts?

“No. No no no no no no. Let’s get this straight.”

I walked up to him and held his hand that was fastened to an iron chain. Rick Dorian’s eyes shook. I was worried that his hands were hurt, but there weren’t any wounds. Anyway, I held his hand and spoke sincerely.

“Firsts are not important.”

“...”

“It isn’t important that today was the first, it’s important that you will experience things like this in the future, so get used to it. Ah, except the part when you were biting and chewing things.”

So please don’t stick the first label anywhere. I looked at Rick Dorian, hoping that he would seriously listen to me.

— Tak.

He slapped away my hand. I heard the sound of the iron chains rattling against each other. His eyes roamed around the room and his angelic face was now quite red.

“You, you shouldn’t just t-t-touch someone’s han, hand, like that!”

“Hand? It’s not like I’m hurting it in any way. Wait, more than that, were you even listening to me?”

“But it’s a man, man, man’s hand!”

Who was he calling a man. Though his body was a bit large, his face was still like a child's...was he really referring to himself.

I wondered if I should ask himself something like, 'Who are you calling a man,' but I shook my head. He might end up bawling if I said that, and then I'd really suffer.

Pretty boys weren't my type.

But maybe a grown-up Rick Dorian would be, who knows. He fit the phrase, 'a beastly beauty' to a T as the male lead, a fountain of overflowing, unpolished charm and good looks. But, really.

He was a beast, a beast.

'Phew, especially at night.'

Though his elegant presence was also very charming when he wasn't a beast, I'd never heard of him being a crybaby. Maybe it was because he was still young?

Four years could really change a person.

"Iana!"

I heard Hans yelling for me from outside.

"Ah, I've got to get back."

I looked at the lad and smiled.

"Time's up, Iana!"

"Yes, coming!"

I quickly muttered one more apology to Rick Dorian before picking up my lamp and leaving. I was a little sorry to be leaving in the dark cell. He was still young, after all.

“I’ll come again.”

I couldn’t see his face because my lamplight didn’t reach him.

I kept remembering the male lead’s tearful appearance as he told me about ‘firsts,’ but I didn’t worry about him too much.

That this male lead seemed to be labeling everything as a ‘first,’ even more than a female lead would say in a typical romance novel!...is maybe what I might have been worried about if not for knowing what sort of novel I was in.

There were tasks that only the female lead could do, and this X-rated novel revolved around the male lead and female lead. Their first meeting was an important event that would free Rick Dorian from his restraints, specifically, the shackles on his neck, wrists, and ankles.

With the female lead Francia’s unique healing ability, Rick Dorian would be free from his prison cell. Let me explain.

Rick Dorian would be freed from his shackles the day after their encounter. Evidently, Francia was the only one who could heal and save Rick Dorian from his curse, and so the only one who could help the male lead get out of prison was the female lead.

The male lead would get discharged from the prison according to the novel’s timeline.

Speaking of prison, I wondered when I’d be getting out of here.

“You’re sighing. Thinking of when you’ll be discharged?”

“Please don’t use that term. It makes me really feel like I’m a criminal.”

“What, why’re you like this all of a sudden~”

The smiling nobleman sitting next to me was Baron Paladis, the one who had been imprisoned for selling fake money.

He was pretty good company when I was bored.

Amusingly, though this was a prison, there was even a living room for the nobles. So anyone could meet up and share a conversation with the others. I found a bit funny seeing how everyone would languidly talk to one another, enjoying their privileges while all wearing the same striped-patterned-shirts.

That we were wearing these clothes while acting like nobles.

Did it even make sense to call ourselves nobles at this point?

“But more importantly, did anything fun happen today?”

“Do you want something from me, mister?”

Everything in our prison lives were for free, as was written in the law. To be precise, it was free because it was stated so in a law.

“Ehem, no, it’s nothing.”

Paladis didn’t see how society was any different than how it was in prison, and though I hadn’t experienced the noble society of this novel yet, I could see his point.

And if that was really true, I didn’t want to be released.

“Then tell me more about the Domulit family. You said you’d tell me the last time we talked, remember?”

“Oooh, right, the Black Rose of the capital.”

Duke Domulit. One of three dukes of the empire. Moreover, a member of the Domulit family was a very important character in the novel.

dubuu: I'll probably stop putting up manhwa illustrations now (maybe one more)! updates for this novel will be irregular. basically, I won't stack chapters; whenever I finish a chapter, I'll upload it.

Chapter 4

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 4

Note: From now on, the male lead's name will be Ricdorian. Thank you to Lyds for recommending Ridorian, and sorry it's not the exact same as you asked for. haha.

Henrich Dorean -> Rick Dorian -> **Ricdorian**

Chapter 4: I became a Jean Valjean for you (1)

“That’s right, you have a lot of interest in the capital’s Black Rose.”

Baron Paradis knew many matters regarding the empire and was the type of person who liked to flaunt this knowledge of his.

And though I enjoyed listening to him talk about this and that, I specifically wanted to know more about the Domulit family.

Because that’s where the main villain was from.

“A flower that blooms underground will give off a scent that only people living underground will like. Some time ago, someone reported that a box to been auctioned off would contain a tiara that the emperor had previously lost.”

“I thought auctions could only be hosted by members of the imperial family?”

“Of course. That law has never changed, but that doesn’t stop the underground flower from holding their own auctions and markets.”

A flower that bloomed underground, a black rose. The black market. This was the Domulit family's symbol. Actually, such illegal black market stories were typical of a villain's actions, so I wasn't surprised. A true villain indeed.

I knew about the emperor's tiara. In the novel, that was what the female lead discovers in the villain's room after she is released from prison.

So, the villain, Chaser Rube Domulit, goes to prison for a time under the crime of stealing the tiara, and later, after the female lead is put in prison, again, but under false charges this time, they have a reunion in Kambrakam.

"The imperial family has issued a searched throughout the empire, but they still haven't found any traces of the tiara, nor do they have evidence to convict the thief. Though they have strong suspicions against the Domulit family."

"I see."

Well, since it's the novel's main villain, he must be extraordinary, enough to escape from the clutches of the imperial family.

Hmm...interesting. Wasn't it? Despite being in prison, this baron knew so much about what was going on outside. Sensing my gaze, the baron smiled cheerfully at me.

"But Iana, have you heard that the Domulit family's most precious treasure is hidden very deeply? I'm not exactly sure, but there are rumours that they are actually hiding a daughter. I know it's just speculation, but isn't it so exciting?!"

"Ah, I've heard about that rumour."

"It's a very widespread rumour throughout high society, after all."

The villain Chaser Domulit had a younger sister. But other than that, there was no other information in the novel about her, not even a name, except that she had an early death.

I guess the sister was to show something like, ‘even the villain has something or someone he cherishes?’ So I quickly lost interest in this mysterious sister at that point.

“Anyway, I heard that the ‘adventure’ event you told me about was a lot of fun?”

“Ah, of course.”

Ricdorian was a bewitching beauty. The image of his teary face came to mind, and I shrugged it off.

“Wait. That’s right, Paladis. Do you know a way for me to meet the chief prison officer?”

“Chief officer? Hmm. I’ve heard that his office might be at the very top on the west side of the building.”

I nodded, thinking of the tightly tied and chained Ricdorian. Alright, let’s keep that location in mind.

We soon moved on to another topic.

Paladis was a great storyteller. Whenever he noticed I lost interest in what he was talking about, he would swiftly move us to another topic in a very natural manner. Thus, I would often leave from our conversations thinking that I had an amazing conversation with him. What a con artist.

“Paladis, you are one of the most skilled con artists I’ve ever seen.”

“That is the greatest praise I’ve ever heard in my life.”

I rummaged in my pocket and pulled out an elaborately wrapped square container, handing it towards him. Inside the box was a high-class cigar.

Though the baron kept refusing, I firmly placed the package into his hands.

“I should give you this at least for the information you’ve given me. And I’m doing this because I want to. Aren’t you a tobacco lover?”

“But Iana, con artists don’t accept tips.”

“Hmph, then you should accept more so that it isn’t just a tip.”

I smirked.

“Because if you don’t accept anything after giving me information, I’ll know that you were actually conning me.”

At my remark, Paladis had a blank expression on his face for a couple of moments before laughing out loud with me. Saying that he couldn’t win against me, he reached out and accepted the box and stuffed it into his clothes while the guards weren’t looking.

– Creaak.

The heavy door opened, and I could smell the familiar damp smell of the prison cell.

‘Nothing’s changed since the last time.’

It had been three days since the last time I’d been to Ricdorian’s cell. If I’d visited him everyday, the prison officers would soon reject my visits, even if I was the “superstar.” So I waited a few more days before visiting for the second time.

Just like the first time, I handed Hans a cigarette before opening the door. Carrying a lamp, I carefully stepped into the prison cell.

Would he be asleep, just like a couple of days ago?

I raised the lamp as I approached the wall and then stopped.

Ah. I guess not. As I met eyes with Ricdorian’s ferocious gaze, I knew which side of him was awake.

Chapter 5

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 5

Some footnotes in here this time around. Enjoy!

Chapter 5: I became a Jean Valjean for you (2)

“Bark. Bark bark bark! Bark!”

“...Hello to you too.”

“Grrrr. Grrrr.”

Instead of words, he spit out animal sounds from his mouth.

“Grrrr!”

I tilted my head.

“Are barking and growling literally the only things you know how to do?”

The male lead shook his head in response to my question.

“Right. You can understand human speech. But then why don’t you speak? Maybe...are you able to understand but unable to speak?”

This time he nodded his head, still glaring at me ferociously, of course.

...Well. Despite the glaring, he was behaving pretty obediently.

I looked at him, feeling a little weirded out by his glare, and then took a pouch out of my chest pocket and handed it towards him. As soon as I

opened the pouch, a delicious smell drifted out. Ricdorian's eyes widened.

"Do you like bread?"

Head tilt.

"I'm saying, I've become a Jean Valjean for you."¹

I dangled the bread that I had stolen from the kitchen, wait, no, technically, the bread I had hidden in my pocket during mealtime, in front of Ricdorian. The male lead's bright blue eyes followed the bread as I waved it in front of his face.

Well, what do we have here.

If the bread moved right, the eyes went right. If left, then left...and so on.

Wow. How cute. Though I shouldn't be teasing him with food.

"Want some?"

"Bark!"

"No, not that. Repeat after me. Please, give me some."

"Bark? Bark bark bark?"

"Please give me some."

"Bark bark bark bark!"

"...Exactly who taught this guy to speak in dog language."

The fact that he could understand but couldn't speak the human language meant that someone had taught him to do so. Ugh. Exactly what kind of crazy bastard only taught this guy to speak in dog language?

I stopped looking at the male lead, shaking my head.

“Okay, wait.”

I moved my hand back. The blue eyes followed the bread in my hand, with a ‘why aren’t you giving it to me’ look. I flinched at the gaze of the starving beast.

...If there wasn’t a chain, I would have run away by now.

“Now that I think about it, if I just give this to you, you’ll just devour it without thought. So just wait a second. Oh don’t look at me like that, I’ll give it to you, I’m just afraid you’ll choke on it!”

Maybe he didn’t hear me, because his gaze was growing more vicious by the second.

– Clank. Clank.

I ended up giving him a piece of bread when his chain started rattling from his pulling.

“Eat up.”

As soon as I gave him a piece, he gobbled it up.

“Eat slowly. Otherwise you’ll get a stomachache.”

He gently bit my hand and closed his mouth over it. My hand tickled.

“...Does it taste good?”

There were bread crumbs stuck to the side of his mouth. Ricdorian’s eyes shined as they looked up at me.

Ah. I guess this means he likes it. ...And who exactly taught this guy to act like a dog, too?

He kept licking my hands to indicate that he wanted more, so I handed him another piece.

“Cough, cough cough!”

Told you so. I knew he was eating too quickly. The male lead looked up at me with teary eyes and grabbed onto his throat. Unfazed, I quickly taking off the cap of the water bottle.

...He won't bite me now, will he?

Perhaps because of his parched throat, Ricdorian was only focused on drinking water.

– Gulp gulp.

But while I was blankly watching him drink water.

Wait a second.

...When did he get so red?

Under the lamp's light, I could see the male lead's red ears, red cheeks, red shoulders...in fact, everywhere below the neck too. When I put my hand on his cheek to check, he blinked his eyes and tried pushing away my hand away.

“Pl, pl, please st, stop. Pl, please t, t, take off your hand.”

I smirked.

“But you ate pretty well from my hand a few minutes ago.”

At my remark, his face flushed red as if it was going to explode. It was the reddest I've ever seen a person's face gets. I looked at him, interested, and tapped his cheek. His eyes shook with tears as he stared at me.

Wow. It's quite easy to tell when his personality switches.

“I-i-if you aren't g-going to take responsibility for what you did to me, th-th-then don't t-touch me!”

...Uhm. There's already another person who will take responsibility, though.

The female lead, obviously. Pretty and kind Francia, with the ability to free the male lead. She was the perfect match for Ricdorian.

And that's why I visited the cell without a care about 'taking responsibility' and whatnot. I mean, the female lead would easily appear in front of the male lead, so before that happens, I was going to have a good time looking at his pretty face.

"You aren't hungry anymore?"

I looked at Ricdorian after thinking through my thoughts. The male lead, who had regained his rationality, still had a flushed face. He looked as if I was bullying him.

"N, n, not, not hungr-"

— Goreureuk.²

Well, that wasn't my belly, for sure.

Wow. I never thought his face could get even redder than it already was.

"Pfft-"

I put on a straight face and looked at the male lead who looked like he was going to burst into tears at any second.

"Hunger isn't something to be embarrassed about. Do the prison officers not give you your meals?"

I was sure he was given food. After all, Ricdorian was the only heir to an archduke. He was only imprisoned here because he couldn't control his powers, so of course he would get food to eat.

Though his meals weren't of the best quality. I looked at the dirty food bowl and sighed. Seriously, what was that, were they feeding a pig. How could

the prison officers give him something like animal feed to eat.

“Come over here and eat. There’s a lot left.”

I had brought enough bread. After all, the prisoners were nobles, so we were given more than enough food to eat. According to Baron Paladis, though we were prisoners, if we weren’t given enough to eat, the prison officers would get in big trouble.

Anyway, because of thi, I was able to steal a lot of bread into my pouch, which I dangled in front of the male lead now.

Huh. His eyes were shaking, but why wasn’t he coming over?

“Should I go over there? I can go over there and feed yo-”

“I’m go, go, going!”

He reluctantly approached me, but slowly.

“Okay I’ll just come to you.”

So I moved over to him instead. As I neared him, he flinched.

Come on. It’s not like he was a kitten who’d ventured outside for the first time, why did he keep reacting so strongly to the smallest of actions.

It was cute, though.

“Go ahead and eat.”

“...Bu, but I want to eat with my hands.”

Chapter 6

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 6

Chapter 6: A big shot supporting character makes a sudden entrance (1)

“No one’s calling you a little kid. I’m just helping you eat since it’s probably difficult to eat with your hands while chained to the wall.”

“This, this, someone who gave me food li, like th, this, is the fir, first...”

I quickly thrust the bread into his hands.

Not this first times thing again.

“...Just eat it on your own.”

But just like I thought, the chains that bound him were a huge obstacle while he tried to eat. His wrists had to totally bend if he wanted to take a bite, and his posture was so unnatural that I felt uncomfortable as I watched him.

“Come over here.”

I couldn’t watch any longer, so I grabbed the bread and let out a deep breath.

“I’ll just take off small pieces and give them to you. There’s nothing we can do, you know? And I have to leave soon, so quickly. And none of that first times thing. I’m just helping you out, okay?”

Oh yes, yes, coochycoo, good boy. You could do it on your own but I’m just helping you. Got it?

I quickly split the bread in half, and then took off smaller pieces from each piece.

“Open your mouth.”

“Mmm...”

“Come on, quickly.”

The reluctant Ricdorian slowly opened his mouth. It was just his small mouth opening, so why was there such an ambiguous atmosphere around us now.

I slowly turned my head after seeing the snow-white skin underneath his ripped clothes. Thankfully, he ate well, and didn't notice anything, and of course, his face was red, as always.

I grabbed the water bottle, even fed him water, and then tied my pouch again.

“I was wondering if you would eat, but you really ate a lot.”

My pouch was now empty. Rather than having leftovers, this was the much more satisfying option.

By the way, why...

I had no idea why the male lead was trembling in the corner as if he had just had his virginity taken or something.

“...Hey, the only thing I've done is committed the whatever crime of helping you eat, what's going on?”

“You, you, your hand touched my li, lips!”

“I mean, yes, sure, because I was feeding it to your mouth with my hands. Where else should I have fed it to, your nostrils?”

“A-and you touched my, my ch, cheek...”

“I wiped it. Should I have just left the bread crumbs on your face then?”

Though I said all this, Ricdorian continued to look at me with reproach. Eventually, I looked at him with my hands up and surrendered.

Well anyway, as long as he didn't start with the whole first times thing. Ah, it should almost be time for Hans to call me.

I had run out of the short amount of time I had in here while tussling with the male lead over feeding him food.

‘And I had something to say to him today too.’

Ricdorian was blushing like usual, his mouth opening and closing. Would he even be able to listen to what I had to say in this state, though.

I clapped my hands.

“You know. Isn't it too dark in here? There's no sunlight and it smells like moss. Even the air smells bad in this cell.”

And though the this cell was in the basement, the worst looking spot was actually Ricdorian's little corner.

“The prisoners here usually go out on a walk once a day. Though the outside is mostly dried grass and withered flowers.”

We could do things like walks because we were nobles, so if prisoners like us could use facilities with our noble status, wouldn't Ricdorian also be allowed a stroll outside?

And since Ricdorian hadn't finished growing yet, if he lost control of his powers, even the middle-level prison guards would be able to subdue him.

“Hey, don't you want to go out for a walk?”

Though a walk was something simple and boring to me, it was probably something very rare for Ricdorian. At least, until the female lead appeared four years later.

“A walk...is, what is that?”

I looked at Ricdorian with a dumbfounded expression.

Oh man. Don't tell me I have to start explaining from there?

People cannot understand a term that they don't use. Just like how a person who hasn't seen glasses before wouldn't know what they are.

“It means going outside.”

“I, I, I can't go outside...”

“What if you could go outside? Would you go?”

He looked at me, sitting in a crouched position. We held gazes like this for awhile, and he didn't give a reply.

I watched as the light in the male lead's eyes slowly died away. They had been shining, only to dim as if the fire in his eyes were extinguished, like the ocean in them were contaminated. It was a sad sight.

Meanwhile, I heard Hans call for me.

“Ah, I've got to go.”

The male lead opened and closed his mouth, but I didn't hear his voice.

“See you again.”

I now had a small project laid out for me. The name was ‘Make the male lead go on a walk.’ The words sounded a little strange for a project, but whatever.

There was no real reason for me doing this. Honestly, I was bored with this prison life, just eating, sleeping, and then meeting people everyday.

The usual purpose of the prison to education and reform criminals? Nothing but crap in here.

Among the prisoners, there were those who were planning their next crime, but none who were repenting of the ones that put them in the prison cell.

Since they were all from the seemingly superior families, they all had an 'it's just prison' mindset.

The only good person here, was me. Is what I, who used cigarettes and alcohol to commit bribery, thought to myself.

I'm not shameless. Not at all.

Littlemetaball: Sorry for the late update. School starts this week eck.

Chapter 7

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 7

They say that good looks are the best.

...but I came to talk to the supervisor so why was I talking to this guy?

I looked at the golden eyes under the glasses and swallowed.

“Would you be the prison’s supervisor?”

I’ll say this again but the supervisor was in a middle position of power. In a company he would be the deputy section chief, or at best a section chief.

“Yes.”

So someone explain to me why I was talking to a big shot.

The man in front of me was Lenag Tuge Valtege.² He was an important supporting character in the novel as one of the empire’s marquesses³ and the head administrator of the Kambrakam prison.

In other words, the boss.

He was a special character because after the number one villain Chaser Rube Domulit, he was the second most dangerous guy in the book.

Why? Because he was on the same side as that villain named Chaser. Lenag and Chaser had worked together to make the female protagonist go into a prison cell and get tangled up with Chaser.

It was left ambiguous why Lenag would have helped out Chaser in the main novel, but since I read the side stories, I happen to know.

He was in love with Chaser's younger sister, right? Lenag, this guy.

The fact that the very man who had held hands with that evil villain Chaser was actually such an innocent guy shocked me. Though this isn't really important right now.

"I heard that you asked to see me."

Why this marquess was acting like the prison supervisor was beyond me. I tried to seem calm and casual, though I was nervous, instinctively on guard.

"Yes. I had a request."

"What kind of request might that be?"

Most of the time, when prisoners asked to meet with the prison supervisor, it was because they wanted a certain item brought in from the outside.

Though, even though they are nobles, that does not mean all requests are approved. For example, not too long ago countess had badgered the supervisor for a dress, which was rejected.

"I was told that all the prisoners here receive the same treatment, is that true?"

"On the surface, yes."

...Unexpectedly, he was pretty honest, and what was this answer of his, like there was more to the story?

But I swallowed my bitterness and nodded my head. Because honestly, the fact that treatment wasn't fair was something even I knew.

"If we follow this principle, as long as their crimes aren't treason or felonies, all the criminals are allowed a period of time each day for a hike

outside or to enjoy an activity in the common room. Right?”

“Correct.”

I held back my emotions. This next part was crucial to getting my request approved.

Zolen: Rule of thumb, the usual structure is:

Baron = Owns a castle, usually has a small collection of guards. This title is a common reward for a military general.

Viscount = Owns a castle and small town, has the right to make a platoon.

Count = Controls a large area of land, usually including several towns, can make a small army.

Marquess = Owns a sizable territory, and usually has a few Counts under their command. You can not earn this title, you have to be related to royalty in some way.

Duke = Has rights to the territory of a Marquess or two and related to the royal family, so has a lot of political say.

Emperor/Empress = Owns the empire.

littlemetaball: *bows down at zolen’s vast knowledge*

Also zolen: a prison full of nobles, those poor guards.

also littlemetaball: GET IT? Like, *poor* guards, because they aren’t as RICH as the criminals?! hahahahahahaa–

Chapter 8

I Met the Male Lead in Prison Chapter 8

Okay so ive been gone for more than two weeks apologies apologies, but I am going to translate imtmlp because it won in the poll! thanks guys~~

This chapter was brought to you by metaball and zolen.

Chapter 8: You're a little bit too much today

“W...while talking to the other prisoners I happened to learn that there was a young prisoner at the lowest floor of my building.

I clenched and then unclenched my fist.

“I heard that this prisoner was trapped in isolation, unable to enjoy even a speck of sunshine.e.”

“Yes. There happens to be such a prisoner.”

There was nothing off about his soft-spoken tone. Seeing this, I nodded.

Just as I thought, Ricdorian wasn't a threat to Lenag yet. Since the male lead and Lenag only started fighting eachother after Chaser got involved.

“From what I heard, this prisoner was banned from hiking even though he hasn't committed a serious crime. Isn't he a little pitiful?”

“So Iana, are you saying that this young prisoner is of concern to you?”

Though it was for a second, the eyes behind his glasses sharpened slightly.

Was I just seeing things?

I tilted my head after looking again and seeing his soft eyes.

“Yes. That’s right. I came because I was hoping to talk to you about this matter.”

“I see, so you are a nice person.”

“Uhm...yeah.”

This pricked my conscience. After all, I didn’t have completely pure and innocent motives for doing this.

“I mean, I have a younger sibling, so I can’t pretend like I didn’t see or hear anything.”

“...You have a younger sibling?”

“Yes.”

Honestly, I didn’t know if Iana had a younger sibling. Though I did hear that she was in prison in place of her dad and older brother.

Well, she probably has a younger sibling, so.

I heard that amongst noble families, first cousins and even third cousins twice removed counted as being in the same family. Then in those countless family members, there should at least be one such younger cousin. And it’s like Lenag could do a background check on me right now.

“Please. Let the young prisoner go hiking.”

“Alright. I will grant your wish.”

Okay, so at this point, he should be rejecti-huh?

“Wait, what did you say?”

“I said I would grant your request.”

My eyes widened.

He'd grant my request? Why? Why? This easily?

The prison had kept Ricdorian in a restricted and isolated cell because he was unable to control the powers that were passed down through his family line. This administrator guy definitely knew all this.

So I had predicted that he would reject my plea and had come up with a plan to suggest a compromising request, but....

“I have already told your father and older brother that I would listen and grant any of your request.”

“Ah, oh, yes? Yes...My older brother and father...”

...exactly what kind of people are they??

I mean, what kind of people could they be that they could just ask this Marquess, a man known as the Iron Blood Marquess, this man rarely approved any sort of requests to, ‘listen and grant any of your request’.

There were a couple of scenes where the prisoners met with Lenag, and begged him with request, but they had to pay an unreasonable amount of money if they wanted it approved.

...Maybe. I'm...actually from a pretty well off family?

“Ah, ah. Yes, then-”

“The young prisoner will be able to hike while accompanied by prison officers, but since he is a magic criminal offender, he will hike separately from the other criminals. Does this complete your request, Iana?”

It seemed that Ricdorian was imprisoned here under magic offense.

I nodded, lost in my thoughts.

“You’re a good person.”

Lenag grinned and stretched his arm towards me. Did he want me to put my hand in his??

He led me to the door when I took the hint and grabbed his arm.

What a smooth move.

I didn’t have any complaints, though, since I got what I wanted. Except, I was a little uncomfortable that it had been achieved so easily.

“I have been asked by your father and brother, so I will make sure that your request gets processed.”

The door creaked open, but then Lenag pulled back on it.

– Tak.

The door was closed again, and the man that was towering over me then slowly hunched his upper body to match my height.

Lenag smiled as he stepped closer, leaning in a polite distance. His eyes curled mischievously.

“Even if you don’t book an appointment, if there is something you want, I will be sure to hear any of your requests.”

No, who would say this guy was the cold and indifferent prison administrator.

I thought the novel said he was thorough and calculative.

I haven’t even seen their faces yet, but what exactly did my brother and dad do for this to happen?

“Please visit me again.”

I blankly stared at him, and then decided.

...No. I never want to come here again.

lilmeta: thank you for the name suggestions Jeffhyun97, pokeito, Rose! I am going with Lenag Teuse Valtege.

zolen: I wonder if this guys mustache is as impressive as the iron blood alchemist? Na, impossible.

—after—

meta: What should Lenag's name be: Lenag Teuse Balteiz?

zolen: or captain eyebrows

meta: lmaoo wheeze cofff *dies before spring break even starts*

Chapter 9: You're a little bit too much today! (2)

Chapter 9 – You're a little bit too much today! (2)

The next day it rained heavily. While some may consider this as a blessing, others may not. Lucky for me, it seems like the weather is in my favor, as this was a great opportunity to secretly visit Ricdorian. As a matter of fact, I went to the Prison's Head Office and met Lenag Tuge Valtege.

I wanted to have a talk with him in regards to the current situation of Ricdorian, pretending to be a person of good soul, and persuade him to give Ricdorian the same freedom that other prisoners have... even asking him to let Ricdorian take some walk sometimes. And to my surprise, Lenag agreed immediately.

Furthermore, I didn't expect him to know who Iana really was. And, it's not only her that he knows but also her father and her older brother who even asked him to grant any of my requests.

I know two villains when I read this novel, and Lenag is definitely one of them. He is a 19 year old, cold-hearted person, who tortures and punishes prisoners whom he doesn't like. What more to those people who get on his bad side? The combination of Chaser Rube Domulit and Lenag Tuge Valtege would definitely make the world around them suffer from cruelty and coldness. I shivered at that thought.

I thought I would never see him in this novel, but I didn't know we'd run into each other that way.

By the way, what kind of people are Iana's older brother and father? After making him accept my requests, does that make them kind? Do they care?

I wondered about it for a while, but then, after this imprisonment, I will probably get to know them soon.

“Once I will be released, I’ll find out.”

In fact, the Chief guard said that my crime was light, which means that I would leave this place soon. That’s why for my remaining time here, I will have to see the male protagonist from time to time.

I know Lenag had a temper, but he was so calm when I approached him.

Is this what you call the golden parachute?

The monetary power of Iana’s family is so compelling. I should say ‘*thank you*’ to them after I got out of here.

But... no, I came here on behalf of the crimes they committed.

Ugh, I don't know what to think anymore!

It’s so hard to grasp such things. Anyway, thanks to them, I was able to live freely inside this prison. So I have no ill feeling, at all.

“How are you?”

“Haven’t seen you for two days. How’s life?”

I came to the room, bringing with me a small box for Hans as a trade for my visitation, smiling at him then talked casually.

“Are you going inside the cell today?” He asked, while opening the small box I handed over him.

“What’s new?” I have always come here ever since I saw Ricdorian. It almost became my habit seeing him. Everything was thanks to Hans, though. I even got somewhat closer to the wild Ricdorian.

Of course, since he always did me great favors, a physical reward is a must. He even said, he has never met someone like me before, so I think the most satisfying thing that Hans could ever receive are cigarettes.

“Ah, Iana. Today is a little dangerous, so be careful.”

“Dangerous? Why?”

“Oh, it’s no big deal, but today the floor is slippery, so be careful on your steps. On rainy days, the floor is a bit damp because of the leaks.”

“Didn’t you build this building to be sturdy and strong?”

“Yes, but the basement is built underground so leaks are possible.” Hans scratched the back of his head, showing an uncertain expression.

“Oh, and sometimes the prisoner screams, maybe because the basement is colder. Also, be aware... the underground cell is very cold.”

Standing outside, I heard him scream and saw bugs crawling anywhere. Such a number of bugs I had never seen before. It is really true that no matter how well you construct a building, a prison will always be just a place for the confinement of prisoners. Nothing else, nothing more.

If I was given the freedom, I would definitely give him a good room to stay here in the prison. It could have been better. I’ve seen some humps in every cell, but the place where this felon stays is worse, with rats and bugs crawling everywhere.

I shrugged my shoulders. I think it’s a little chilly today, so I put on a shawl, wrapping myself like a Burrito to stay warm.

“Thanks for your concern.” I said, in reply to his warning earlier. It is always best to stay healthy and strong in times like this.

Soon, I left Hans and opened the bars. One’s advantage!

The bars were originally rusty, so it made a louder noise today and as I walked inside, a mossy smell pierced my nose. This tingling smell is much

worse than usual.

Is it because of the rain? As soon as I took a step forward, my feet were wet.

“There are puddles in here!?”

There’s too much water on the floor as if it is flooding in here. At that moment, a small water droplet touched my cheek and when I looked up, I found that water was dripping from the ceiling.

“If anyone sees this, they’ll probably think that it’s raining inside this cell.”

Somehow, it became very humid. It was as if the waters gathered and accumulated on the floor. This is bad, the floor is very dirty and bugs are crawling. Could this be any worse?

Tap, tap, tap.

Even though it was underground, I could hear the sound of the rain clearly from the ceiling. I raised the lamp from the floor, with a frown, saw Ricdorian’s face, and started walking towards him.

My leather shoes were heavy and my trousers were wet, but it didn’t stop me. Seeing the boy in front of me, soaking wet, I just couldn’t stop.

“Grrrrrr!” He’s grunting at me, glaring with anger.

It seemed that his rational side, which I wanted to see the most, was asleep as of the moment.

“Aren’t you cold?” I asked, trying to sit down the usual way, but later chose to squat. Soon, his blue eyes wailed.

“Grrr! Ruff! Ruff! Ruff!”

“You can’t tell if you’re okay or not.” The chains made a noise as he moved. He was unusually rough today. I moved my ass a little as it seemed uncomfortable squatting.

“I would like to ask you what’s bothering you, but I think it’s too much to ask you to speak in human language...”

“Ruff! Ruff! Grrr... All the time!”

“Shhh. Good boy. It’s raining, so it’s ringing more.”

“Ruff!”

...he made a lot of dog noises today. Everytime I ask him a question, he answers me with ‘*Ruff*’ and ‘*Grrr*’. Seems like there will be no proper conversation this time, so I just decided to leave.

I opened the shawl wrapped it around my shoulder, tried to reach him but hesitated a bit.... What if he’s gonna bite me?

His barking is louder than usual and I could see, at a glance, how vigilant he is when I tried to reach him, as if it what I was doing was big deal. I wanted him to get used to it, but seeing his furious face each time I attempted to, I guess it was so inconceivable.

But something’s really making him uncomfortable today. What’s the reason for this? Is it because he hates water and he feels like it’s stinging him?

Before I came into this novel, I read that Ricdorian has an aquaphobia. He was especially afraid of water. So I think that must be it.

<A person like you is a disgrace to the entire family.>

Chapter 10: What progress is this?!

(1)

Chapter 10 – What progress is this?! (1)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Typically, people in the Hel family who were born with curses, were able to control their powers before reaching the age of 15. They would be confined for the time being and were quickly released when they got a hold of their powers.

They were actually wild beasts and they lacked control of the curse they possessed, which made it difficult to communicate with them. That is why, Ricdorian, who has been imprisoned for so long was considered a disgrace to the Archduke of Hel estate.

<You bastard.>

<Ah..Fa.. Fath... fa...father!>

The way his father, the current Archduke of the Hel estate, treated him was brutal. He would always tuck Ricdorian's head into the washbasin, keeping his breath away.

Just how could a father treat his son that way? He is more than a beast. He's a savage.

It was so cruel and pitiful.

Even in his father's coercive way, Ricdorian still couldn't control his power and eventually became petrified of the water because of his father's doings.

The fact also that he was abandoned there a dozen of times added to that fright.

That's why they were left with no choice but to use their last resort which is a '*companion*'.

It wasn't until later that his family found out that he had so much power, that's why it was difficult for him to control it. From that moment, he will be imprisoned until the time he meets the '*companion*' they were waiting for, who will release him from the shackles.

However, the Archduke had lost his interest in him, so he did not try to find him a companion and let him be. Then by chance, Francia came into this room and met him.

I was staring at Ricdorian who's sitting like a lion, when suddenly he wavered a little. It was said that the moment when the beast became the sharpest was when he was hungry and wounded. Unlike humans, revealing weakness is something they are ashamed of. It is as if showing a little weakness makes them a frail. That's why they needed to be vigorous in order not to be pitied and oppressed.

I didn't know that the phrase I stumbled before coming into this novel could be of any relevance to him.

'A trauma is a wound.'

It surely relates to him.

I raised my hand and he flinched at my sudden action, so I muttered '*sorry*'. Soon, my hair tie that had been loosened, slumped down on my back. I shook the hair tie off before his eyes.

Ding. Ding.

"Do you like the bell?" I asked as he stopped trembling, his tremor was interrupted by the dangling sound of the bell, and he bawled.

Like the sea, his blue eyes moved along with the bell and ribbon-decorated tie in front of him. Once again, with a small rattle, the little bells on the tie made a clear sound.

“I thought you’d like this.” This was from my brother who always sent me a letter. Sometimes gifts came along with the letter.

“Ruff.”

There’s a lot of time off and too many things that can be done while in the prison so I thought he might like this and play with it that’s why I wore it to show him today.

“This is better than the sound made by the rain, right?” His fierce eyes stared at me then rolled himself as I swung the tie in my hand...he looked like a dog who saw a ball, wanting to play it.

I smiled at that.

I tried to reach out to one of my pockets and pulled out a headdress that he liked when we first met. It was a head strap with plump decorations.

So, you like things like this, huh?

Maybe I should wear stuff like this every time I go see him. I decided to give him the head dress, and reached it out to his mouth.

“Burr...” Oh, he’s really good at biting things.

“Oh, that’s good.”

“Yes! Good job. It’s good to bite something fluffy, right?” He nodded in approval.

“...I’ve asked you to answer me properly.” How can he answer like this?

“Come on, play.”

While he was busy with the headdress, I took the opportunity to tie the hair tie into his hand and patted him.

Good boy.

Ding. Ding.

Once again, he was distracted by the sound of the bell, so I lifted my shawl and put it on his head to dry him.

“Shh. It’s alright. Ok, That’s right. You’re all wet. Let’s wipe it off so you’ll not catch a cold.” Surprised by my sudden actions, Ricdorian struggled to get away from me, but soon he calmed down as the shawl was soft and made him warm.

From the looks of it, he’s feeling good, isn’t he?

Even though he is a beast, he’d still have the tendency to get a cold. A beast still has feelings after all.

But what about me?! Am I the narrator of this story? But I have never read one in the book. I shook my head and stopped thinking about it. I’m not sure if this is an environment where people can get the flu or sick, but this person in front of me is a half-beast, so I am not really sure.

“Chirr”! At that moment, I instinctively bit the back of my hand as I heard the sound of a rough chain. He suddenly advanced towards me!

“Ow!”

“Well then mister, but you can’t.”

I saw Ricdorian’s hand, which he lifted up in the empty air feeling anxious with the chains. Wow! If it weren’t for the chains, my hand would have been caught right away.

I sighed in relief.

The boy stared at me with the shawl in his head. He looked adorable.

But the more I stared at him, the more I realized that he looked like a beautiful man. A man who looked as if he was a young saint, which blended together with his silver hair. His clothes were soaked and clinging onto his body which emphasizes his curves. Even though he was sixteen, he already had a slightly broad shoulders and firm-looking arms.

This made me swallow a lump on my throat.

I don't think his facial features and his body match. It is like mixing water and oil together. Not in a bad way, but in a way where his face was so angelic and innocent while his body looked evil and sinful. He is a real work of art.

"You tried to catch it, right?" I tapped the back of his hand, which was holding the hair tie tightly. "Don't you feel pain holding the tie like that? You're breaking it." I don't know if the tie will really break, but the bell is a little bent. Oh my, the bells are all bent.

I shivered slightly. Wow, can this be done by mere human power? Well, he's not really a pure human after all..

IMTMLIP will be updated 5 days a week

Chapter 11: What progress is this?!

(2)

Chapter 11 – What progress is this?! (2)

Translator:SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

In the novel, there was a time where Ricdorian was unable to control his strength and hurt Francia, leaving her with bruises. Of course, it's a story while they were making love, but still, it doesn't differ from what had just happened to my hair tie.

In his entire life, he was never taught not to hurt others. Though he did it unintentionally, I still think he should have learned it by now. *'Early education is a must.'* But how can he learn if he's not being taught?

I slowly raised my hand and Ricdorian's gaze followed, but rather than trying to catch my hand as before, he just stared at it blankly.

"Now, I'm going to wipe you with this towel." I took my towel from my pocket to show it to him as my shawl was already soaking wet.

"If you stay calm, I will give you something good. Do you understand?"

It's not that he doesn't understand what I say, it's just that I wanted him to stay still so that I could completely dry him. Unexpectedly, Ricdorian lowered his head slowly, allowing me to wipe his hair. This is like washing a dog with a muzzle, but it's different since he was in shackles.

"Right, well done. Now I'm gonna give you something, but you can't bite or catch my hands either!" I took food from my other pocket and I gave it to him, who was still sitting calmly.

A famous trainer once said that the success of training comes from carrots and sticks. But how am I going to teach him? By using carrots and sticks? I wondered at that.

I sighed deeply at the sight of him eating the food deliciously. It's a good thing I bought him food. Let me see, well, it would be good if the heroine's bruises are reduced once he's trained.

"Delicious, right?"

"Ruff!" he said and nodded. Wait! How can I not hear and see those?

I'm so surprised. However, when I turned my head to him I saw him sweeping the remaining food in his chest.

A bluff.

I was kind of disappointed, I thought he answered.

"Right. Eat well." I grinned and continued drying his hair.

Meanwhile, the teen beast took the entire cookie and ate it with his mouth full. He looks so cute! His cheeks are bulging, looking like a greedy squirrel. For a moment there, I realized I gave him everything that I stole and watched him devour it until the last one.

I smiled tenderly while looking at him.

Is this how people feel when they watch an eating show? Feeding him all of it to the end never felt this satisfying before.

Soon, when he finished everything, he stared at me. Somehow, his glaring gaze turned somewhat bright.

"Huh? More? I don't have cookies anymore." He tilted his head.

"...you don't look cute. No. Turn around. Go!" I said, a bit troubled by his cute and pitiful actions.

I stared at him, I unknowingly stared at his chest. His clingy silver cloth almost became a transparent outline, making his bare skin visible. I could see a vivid shape under that fabric.

That's the pattern! The tattooed red-colored moon on his chest indicating 'jangma – a rainy season' with a very red rose. That rose symbolizes the Archduke of Anguish, but in more detail, it is the curse itself.

As I said a while ago, the male protagonist escapes from the shackles once he meets the '*companion*' and this period of waiting for that '*companion*' is not infinitely long.

If they do not meet at a certain time, both of them will die. The time remaining is indicated by the rose engraved on his body. The cursed one is born with a full bloom rose pattern. And the petals disappear from the roses one by one as time goes by until meeting the '*companion*'. If they are unable to encounter each other, they die along with the last petal. Meeting each other means being together, and that is why they have to unite the moment they met.

Indeed, it's a rated-19 novel. Anyway, Ricdorian was still in trouble, he had to wait for Francia for 4 years.

“Oh, I have to go.”

It was time for Hans to call me. I tried to get up from my position and get the blanket on my knees but I was stopped.

“..you”

I turned my head to Ricdorian, who just caught my attention. By any chance, was he staring at me? But why?

Suddenly, I felt a cold sweat flow at my nape.

“Now, what?!” I was startled when the boy who could not control his power just grabbed me without any reason and pulled me into his chest.

Holy cow! I was so embarrassed, I'm facing his chest right now. No, I don't want to take a closer look at the pattern in his chest.

"Uh.." This is so f*cked up, right? It is my fault for being so careless and loose, while being fully aware of the dangers of Ricdorian.

I swallowed hard... I think he was so cute when he said that. Enough bullshit! I should focus. What should I do?

I'm starting to feel anxious.

But then I tried really hard to retain my composure. I shouldn't be embarrassed when he is just a mad dog. Now, I am pondering why I ended up treating the male lead as a dog.

I looked at his dazzling handsome face and then I found his cold-blue eyes staring at me tenaciously. I could sense his fierce and violent nature.

It was at this moment, when the chain clanked the loudest. His face drew closer... It's a...It hurts.. I groaned a little at his tight hold of my wrist. Even though he stopped at some distance, I could hear his breathing and his eyes were still casted on me.

He was able to catch even the smallest movements I make without hesitation and he seemed to be a beast moving instinctively.

Sniff. Sniff.

I could feel his breath from my neck. His face went down slowly, lifted my wrist, and looked up at me. He slowly opened his mouth and put my hand inside it. I glanced at my finger that he was about to bite.

Goodbye.

I am going to be the beast's feast...

Slurp... Slurp... Lick.

No, Wait... Wait. What? I felt my earlobes burning at the lewd sound of the wet tongue licking my hand. All of a sudden, I am having a hard time. This wasn't in the novel!

What progress is this, author!?

No chapter tomorrow

Chapter 12: You are my first, too!

(1)

Chapter 12 – You are my first, too! (1)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

“Oh... Pastry crumbs.”

Right! When I handed him the cookies earlier, there were pastry crumbs left in my palm.

I stared blankly at him who's now frantically coveting my palm. Now, I know why he suddenly grabbed my hand. And from now on, I am not bringing him cookies anymore, even though he likes it.

This is not good. I've been putting malice on his actions when in fact he's not fully aware of what he's been doing.

Lick. Lick.

I stared at him and swallowed a lump without realizing it... he looked so indecent with his tongue out.

Argh!

What have I been thinking! I brush off that thought. But then, I couldn't really do anything. I couldn't resist the strength of his grip on my wrist. So I just decided to put my wet shawl on his head using my other arm while he's simultaneously licking my hand and fingers. When suddenly, his face got closer once again .

Looks like...

“Wait. Just a second...”

The blanket on his lap fell into the puddle and was now soaking wet. After watching the poor blanket being drenched, I slowly turned my gaze back at him and it seems like he got nervous about our closing distance.

“Ah...” Ricdorian got startled, he immediately took his hand away and almost threw me with his vigorous strength. I was caught off guard!

“Ouch.” As a result, I ended up sitting down on the dirty floor, drenched with mud.

“Oh, why, why, why, why, all of it! My hand and face! Ugh!” I can’t believe this!

“Let’s get this straight, you’re the one who licked my hand.”

“Ah, ah, licked, hmmph!”

“Yes, you licked it!” I quickly added before he could make me the assailant. Why am I the one who’s being blamed when in fact he’s the one who initiated the skin ship? Just sheer luck.

The chains clung louder than before, so I lifted my head to look at him. His back was now facing the wall.

Suddenly, he looked back at me with my shawl covering his chest. He tried pulling the chain tightly. Then I saw tears forming at the corner of his glaring eyes... Why does it seem like it’s my fault now? Like I’m the perpetrator of the crime?

“I, I, I, woke up, and you-”

“Oh, so you remember now?” He uttered words so maybe he’s back to his senses.

I've never seen anyone whose arms turned red like that. It was as if I was looking at a flower bed of red roses. From his neck, which was not covered by the shawl, to his earlobes, till the back of his hands, there was no place that wasn't red.

"Fir...first time.."

"Let's stop talking about first times." Doesn't he get tired of it?

"Co... cookies were delicious, why, why, your hands..."

"What do you mean? Ah.. Does my hand taste like a cookie? That's what exactly you were thinking before your rational being came back. Devouring my hands like it was a cookie." I said sarcastically.

This is a little interesting. I took this opportunity to make fun of him so I tried forming my hand like a calyx and teased him.

Ever since his clothes got soaked with the rain, it became translucent which made the redness in his body stand out even more.

"Do you now remember everything?"

He nodded.

If people lay their eyes on him, they might think he's cute when turning red. And then blame me for hurting him.. Then they would assume that I'm the perpetrator. That I did something bad at him. It was so unfair!

"So it's a force majeure." Am I guilty? I only gave him the cookies. I never intended anything bad.

"Ha, but..." He stammered, covering his face with the back of his hand. Feeling embarrassed.

"It's really my, my, first..."

"Sh*t! I'm sorry." I said, just to ease whatever he's been feeling.

Did he even think about the purity of my palm? I've never experienced something as vulgar as that in my life.

However, I think it will only make things worse if I say that it is also my first time experiencing such a thing. So I just chose to conceal it.

I stood up.

There was really no more time. Things for sure will calm down over time. I glanced at him and saw that he put his face on the shawl, but expressed difficulty in moving his whole body as he was chained. The chain was being pulled as he continued trying to cover his face. The tightness of the chains makes it seem like his hands were about to be cut off.

Isn't he too strong?

I saw that the tears in the corners of his eyes were about to fall. What is wrong with the male protagonist of this impoverished rated-19 novel?

I looked at him with an embarrassed face and shook my head. His eyes are nowhere to be seen as it was buried under the shawl, so I don't think he can see my expression right now.

I woke up from my thoughts and tried to get rid of the mud. I turned my back on him and promised myself that the next time I come here, I should secure a safe distance. This should never happen again.

"All, all, part..." I turned my head for the last time and saw Ricdorian's face protruding from the cloth, like a turtle trying to come out from its shell. His cheeks are still as red as an apple.

"... What's your name?" He asked, only his eyes were blue amidst the redness of his face. Like the stars shining in dawn, or a gem among the pebbles, his eyes are always stunning.

"Iana."

Now I wonder, he just got curious now? I've already visited him two times. I turned my back and laughed. What a peculiar being.

See you again, *'Mr. Goof'*.

As soon as the lamp moved away, the redness of his face faded.

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The rain continued to fall for a while.

Tok. Tok. Tok.

And sometimes the rain shoots hard at the ceiling. I could hear it dropping all the time. I even wondered why it was raining when it was summer. But I just shrugged my shoulders and thought that it might be natural. Climate change must also be a thing in this novel. I guess.

At first I really didn't know that it was summer. But it's a good thing that the prison has a cooler temperature compared to the season. At least it's not hot.

The guards told me that they had done something, but they didn't give me any details about it. I wanted to tell the other prisoners about what they did, but I don't want to feed them half baked information.

"You might escape." The guards said, and did not further enlighten me about it.

Chapter 13: You are my first, too!

(2)

Chapter 13 – You are my first, too! (2)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Of course I have no intentions of breaking out of the prison. I am not that stupid. I know that my crime is light and in no time I would be able get out of here. So, for the meantime, all I have to do is entertain myself.

Now, even if I flirt with the male protagonist, I don't really have to worry about the growing affection. It won't be long before I go out, and once I am gone, it'll take much longer for the heroine to appear, therefore the male protagonist will have ample time to forget our interactions.

What a brilliant thought Iana.

So for the time being, Ricdorian and I will have a lot more interactions until the nice and cool heroine appears. When that time comes, she would then be the one to take care of Ricdorian.

Anyway, since I'm worried about the rain, I decided to stop visiting Ricdorian as of the moment.

It kept raining, and I was a bit annoyed with Baron, who kept asking me where I went that day. Well, there was a big reason as to why I did not visit him, but... For now, I have to reflect on my actions and why it turned out to be that way. I reminded myself to always bear in mind that Ricdorian was a half beast under a curse, and he was a careless beast rather than a barking puppy. Just why was I treating him as a cute puppy?

I sighed.

It was just a relief that I was able to leave his cell that day. In fact, I don't even know when everything will be ironed out. If I remember correctly, in the novel, he tore the iron bars. I shouldn't have ignored that fact, just because he was still a teenager.

Safety first. But actually, the biggest reason why I can't visit him is...

“Why aren't they coming?”

It was because there was nothing more that I could bribe to Hans. I tilted my head and kept thinking about my empty table. The letters along with the cigarettes or alcohol would always come for about two or five days. But I haven't received anything for almost two weeks already. Usually, at least three gifts were piled up on my desks, but today, no gifts were present.

I didn't ask for the letters in the first place, but what I thought could be useful for my stay here inside this prison was quickly gotten right away.

As a result, I lost my freedom and just stayed inside my cell since I had no object that I could use to lure Hans or the other guards. In fact, the room of prisoners with light crimes, like me, was an ordinary-sized room. There was a bed, a carpet and a desk in the room. There was also a small window where we could see nice views depending on the location. Rooms like mine are usually about five times smaller than that of a noble room. I didn't live in a mansion, so I didn't know if this place satisfies the other prisoners.

Anyway, a letter from my brother would always be put on the desk or under the bars. But it's been a while since I've received one from them... Why is it that no letters came? Are they now tired of my requests?

I was about to tilt my head to the other side to look at the window, still thinking about my empty desk when I was suddenly interrupted.

“What are you troubled about, miss?”

“Oh, hello Baron.”

The man who sat at the end of the table was Baron. He sat naturally across from me, stretching his arms.

I've crossed my legs, but since I was not wearing a suit, I thought that doing so wouldn't look fashionable and cool in these striped clothes.

"You look like you're in deep trouble. What is it?"

"Oh. You've seen right through me. I was thinking about what we are having tonight." I lied.

"Oh, I can easily solve that. They are preparing a turkey dish that is not cheap but also not fancy. Ugh, I'm about to miss the little lamb steak."

Baron said he really wanted to eat a high-class steak. Since he was so funny, I mimicked him and teased him a little.

"It's funny how a prisoner talk in a high-class manner."

On purpose, he slowly spoke with elegance and smiled.

The turkey served in here tastes amazing and I don't know why they find it cheap. Sometimes it's hard to keep up with the prisoners' minds here. Maybe it's because I am not born with any nobility in my genes.

"What else are you going to tell me? It would be nice if you could."

"It's a pleasure to be a good storyteller for the young lady. Well, talking to you is more of a hobby. Oh, did you hear about Count Andrea?"

Baron has a wide connection inside and outside the prison. They say that networking is the basic virtue of aristocrats, but looking at Baron, everyone should be careful because they are looking at a swindler. Perhaps this is why I was very impressed with the news and stories he told.

"You mean the lord who fainted from hysteria? The guard told me. It was in the room next door."

Among the prisoners, there were some who could not admit that they committed a crime, and the Count is one of them.

“I woke up a few days ago because I heard a scream.”

He used to scream every night saying that he was innocent. Not long ago, I was also surprised to hear a loud noise and hysterics.

“Yes. The hysterical one. It wasn’t just a simple thing. Count Andrea is dead. He exploded.”

“Hey, do you think a Count can be easily killed in one night?”

Is that possible? I ate cookies, eyes wide open with the idea of him being killed that easily.

Oh, eating cookies reminded me of something that I should forget...I shouldn’t have eaten a cookie today... I should never eat cookies from now on. Well, It’s not really that easy to forget a boy licking my hand, though.

“Of course it can’t happen quickly, but this is what Black Roses do.”

“Domulit?”

Why are they coming out here?

“Don’t tell me... Do you think they did it?”

“Yes. Chaser Rube Domulit, the next Black Rose of the family, has made a big scene.”

Oh, is it possible because they’re a bad family?

“But the problem that will shock you was that Count Andrea was the right-hand man of the Archduke of Hel.”

“Oh, my God! The Red Rose?”

“Yes. That Hel!”

Chapter 14: Lavish Prison Life (1)

Chapter 14 – Lavish Prison Life (1)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

The Archduke of Hel and the Domulit, along with Ricdorian, were close to the Iron Support Reservoir. They are known to have a deep rooted history with each other. Not a good one though.

Red Roses and Black Roses. Their family's symbols, which have symmetrical tendencies are of contrasting colors.

Well, one side is the main character while the other is the villain with its side villain, Lenag. So the confrontation between the two is fierce and violent. However, this deep-rooted hatred from the two families has led to a love triangle. And this was the original plot of the story.

In fact, Ricdorian, who was abandoned by the Archduke, had no idea about the Domulits. But it was only in the beginning for he was still lost in his hatred towards his father.

The good male protagonist couldn't come to kill his father and later on Chaser killed the Archduke of Hel, his henchman, and all of his comrades. It's a good thing for him, right? That he would no longer be the one to kill his violent father. He wouldn't need to stain his own hands with blood.

Funny enough, Ricdorian hated Chaser for killing his father. Perhaps he still had affection left for the Archduke despite all the bad things he's done. After all, he is still a family. No matter how deep the scar they left on us, we still choose to forgive. And I think that is enough reason for his anguish towards Chaser.

I felt the writer's will to make a mess of their relationship. Well, basically, this is a rated-19 novel with harsh executions and passionate sexual unions.

"Chaser Rube Domulit is a fine young man. But this time he did the wrong thing... Also, the Archduke of Hel had made his command and sent a squad of knights to find evidence for the destructive blowing up of Count Andrea."

"That's a very big issue. What happened next?"

"Now he's missing."

What? Now, that's not what I was expecting. Is he really? I don't think so. As what I had read in the novel, Chaser Rube Domulit is a tough villain, who mercilessly killed Ricdorian's father, Archduke Harmin. He wouldn't just run away and hide so maybe, he was setting up things for the success of his veracious plan.

Is this the time for that? I suppose not.

I don't know if our conversation was just to entertain ourselves anymore. But, in any case, the villain won't be caught or killed easily. It would take a very long time for that to happen and that will surely not occur in my time here in prison.

"I don't know what's going to happen now that Archduke Harnim's eyes are focused on capturing Chaser Rube Domulit. But then, don't stress yourself out with that, rather, take care of yourself."

I nodded, putting the remaining pieces of cookies in my mouth.

"But how do you know so much?"

"Oh, it's underground hearsay."

Oh. The information's a fraud. Looking at his posture, he was really swindling me right now. But nevertheless, I wasn't bored listening to his detailed outside stories.

Anyway, it is also necessary for me to listen for the people involved here are the Hel and the Domulit family. If I get out of prison, I will for sure try to stay away from them and live in faraway lands. But, how can I do that?

“Now, what was your problem? Is it worth exchanging for the information I just spilled?

“What a joke. It wasn’t a big deal. It’s just that I didn’t receive letters from my brother. He’s not the kind of guy that would leave me hanging.”

I always thought that he was a sincere and considerate person for always sending me letters. Now I’m kind of uncertain about that.

“You mean the brother who kept sending you the letters? Hmm... something urgent must have happened. Don’t worry too much. People don’t change that easily. I assure you.”

“Thank you.”

I hope so, too. I’m a little worried. I don’t know what I could do since I am imprisoned here. Right now, my best option was to just wait. That’s what I always do, though.

Half an hour later. Our free time in the living room was over, so I returned to my room. And still, looking at my desk empty never felt this painful.

“...If I was released from prison, I might get abandoned. I wish I had asked for more before this happened.”

I kept thinking that I was here because of my brother and father’s sins. They are responsible for my stay here. I closed my eyes and buried myself in bed feeling dejected. Fortunately, there is a bed that I can rely on.

☼☼☼☼☼☼ ☼☼☼☼☼☼☼☼ ☼☼☼☼☼☼☼☼

A few days later, the heavy rain that was falling hard turned light with a precipitation rate of less than 2.5 mm per hour. I presumed.

“The rain will be completely over in a while.”

“Yes, I see.” The guard must have read my mind.

It’s a good thing that it will be over soon, I miss walking outside. Slouching in the living room, which at first I thought was great, became boring after a few days.

As I was lost in my thoughts while sitting on the living room’s couch, someone sat at the opposite side. It was Baron again. Looking at him, his face somehow seems to be full of interest. Hmm. When we first met, that’s the face he wore and did his scam.

“Iana, have you heard? No. You must not have heard!”

I laughed, he was so amusing with his approach.

“Of course. I haven’t heard anything. What is it? Please tell me quickly. ”

“Hmmm, aren’t I awesome?”

Oh my! Praising himself first. What a vain man. I turned my head up.

Ugh!

I’m itching to get the rumor!

“Well, there’s a rumor that Archduke Harnim was seriously injured. But the good news is... The *‘real criminal’* who blew up Count Andrea was caught.”

At that moment I caught a clue of Chaser’s original plan, which was laid out in fragments, basing on the information Baron gave me.

“I guess the real culprit wasn’t Chaser Rube Domulit... or maybe he was still in the process of achieving his *‘true crime’*.”

Chapter 15: Lavish Prison Life (2)

Chapter 15 – Lavish Prison Life (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

Oh. Right. When Chaser killed Archduke Harnim, he gave him a serious injury, and then wounded him once again in that area.

Looks like that's what gonna happen.

The information Baron gave that was passing smoothly through our conversation matched the scenes in the novel. I guess this is really it. It's really happening.

“I think the missing Chaser Rube Domulit is now back into action. For now, he seems to be a very good lad, but I'm scared of what he will become when he grows up.”

Baron strongly urged that scary and powerful people have the tendency to play the innocent ones. I nodded, emphasizing that what he just said was right.

“I really want to meet that young man! On the other hand, I also don't want to meet him... Ah, my mind is messed up.”

I hope this guy doesn't take Chaser lightly, as if he was someone he could easily mess around with. If you try to cheat him with a villainous character, it won't end up with just your wrists being cut off. As for me, I have no intention of messing around with him either. Apparently, this place was notorious enough, even at the very beginning of the novel. I've had enough trouble right now.

“Well, you or I might see him in the future.”

He said calmly, looking down at the window with drizzling rain.

“What? Why? I don’t want to. Having a connection with him is like having a world that is uncertain! People will have no idea of what will happen to their future. It’s like risking your life for the unknown.”

“What do you mean by ‘*having a connection*’?”

I’m afraid that I can’t even pick my bones. I don’t want to be associated with such a frightening family. Just hearing the word ‘*Domulit*’ gives shiver to my bones.

Oops... It looks like the rain is going to stop soon. I wonder if I could go for a walk after the land dries up.

When our free time ended that day, we returned to our designated cells. The guard, who was checking in front of my cell, smiled.

“It’s been a long time since you got a letter. Iana.”

My eyes opened widely at the guard’s words. True enough, an envelope was placed on top of the desk.

“Lock the door.”

When the door closed, I quickly picked up the letter. Wow, I’m so glad to see you.

The envelope contains a blank paper as always. It’s as natural as it was without spaces. I stopped, trying to get a pen, and found another letter instead. What is this? The letter that always came was an envelope with an empty blank sheet of paper without anything written on it. But why is it that another letter appeared?

Not long after, I decided to open it.

[How are you, my lovely little sister?]

The handwriting was neat, it was as if the one who wrote this was a person of beautiful appearance. A person's handwriting reflects his own appearance as some say. Thinking about having a beautiful brother was great.

And after reading the letter, I quickly replied.

[I am doing well.]

Well, that's not enough. Ah! I suddenly remember. I continued writing on the blank letter, but it is not something that you would expect from a lady like me.

[Alcohol, high-grade cigarettes. My request. Lots of it!]

Now that's enough, right? I am fully satisfied and happy now. Gone is the sorrowful and gloomy Iana.

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The good thing about living inside this prison is that the clothes are very comfortable and cozy. My movements are not restricted at all, and I don't need any other outfits to change to. I think it's good because it has more advantages. What's more is that they gave us spare clothes of the same style as much as we wanted. Everyone hates me because I like the idea of wearing this prison uniform, but I don't mind them because I like it. On the other hand, the bad thing is that we all wear the same striped clothes which may have added up to their annoyance.

<Nasty! It's ugly, sloppy and tacky!>

This fashion was full of resentment among the noble prisoners because there's no way they would look elegant in this kind of clothing.

Usually, people imagine an elegant dress with layers of laces when they are inside a medieval romance novel, but it seems that I am having a unique experience here.

Suddenly, I thought of what I would do once I got out of prison?

Hmm, I haven't thought about life outside ever since I woke up here in prison. The image of a prison uniform is so strong and it's a little strange that I ended up being inside this establishment. It was a little unrealistic. Even now, I still want to live as much as I want. Of course, life here is boring, but I will do all possible ways to make it amusing.

"You're not going to drink?"

Lenag laid the teacup down before my eyes. I secretly rolled my eyes and nodded. I hope my smile was not that awkward.

"...maybe. Thank you for the drink. Thank you."

Sheer luck. I took a sip of the tea but...Tsk. I burned my tongue. I bit my tongue slightly and wiped off the tears that formed at the corner of my eyes, a little hesitant to do so because Lenag was still staring at me.

His eyes were gazing like that of snakes staring at it's next prey. He's not mean-looking, rather, he looks like a very cold and sharp person. The glasses over his nose made him look even colder. But his handsomeness was enough to cover everything.

Why am I having a cup of tea with the villain's assistant? I must be out of my mind... I would rather like to meet the guards, than him.

<Come in.>

This horrible encounter that I wish would not happen did come true. Ten minutes ago, I heard from the wards that the boss was calling for me. I don't know why he was looking for me and what he needed from me. I also wondered what the hell would he do to me the moment we meet, but to my surprise he just remained silent.

For ten minutes! For that entire time, he just stared at me, giving me a chance to watch him, but all of this was making me uneasy.

I glanced sideways.

"Well..."

His long brown hair that was neat, did not make him look less of a man, but made him look more appealing, and his golden eyes under his glasses, make him look like a scholar. Combining all, gave an impression that none of the needles would fit in. In other words, he looks so strong.

In the novel, he even overthrew a violent killer and blew up prisoners' arms. After all, the villains in this book weren't '*merciful*' people and that's why I am nervous right now.

“You were looking for me because...”

Chapter 16: Lavish Prison Life (3)

Chapter 16 – Lavish Prison Life (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

It was possible for the prisoners to acquire goods from outside of Kambrakam. However, a rigorous inspection had to be carried out before it could be brought in. And the goods can typically be delivered by or obtained from the guards after the inspection.

But some packages were handed over by the prison's head guard that ordinary prison guards are not allowed to. Perhaps due to the title that a convict holds as well as the confidentiality of the goods. That's what I thought.

When I first encountered this kind of situation, I felt like Iana's house must be a very fancy place to live in. She must have been born from a well-off and high-rank family.

“I have something to give to you.”

My brother sends me a gift once every other week. And the reason why Lenag called me here today is to give that gift to me. He stretched out his hand on the table and laid down a little box.

“Take it, Miss Iana.”

I got the box and peeked inside, slowly opening it.

Wow, It's a hairpin again...

Soon, I closed it and tried to avoid making eye contact with him. Moreover, I was hesitant whether to get up or not since we don't have anything else to talk to and my reason for being here was already achieved. I badly wanted to leave. I don't feel comfortable being around him. And with my prejudice of him, I don't think I will ever be.

"I've had everyone call you by your first name here, as what your brother wanted. I didn't understand the reason at first, but I think I do now."

"What? Oh, Okay..."

Aw. He must really be a great and caring brother. No wonder everyone calls me "Iana" inside the prison. I nodded blankly at him. I can't wait to get out of here, as I'm starting to feel nervous with his gaze. All this time, he never once took his eyes off me! I can feel it even though I'm not looking at him.

"Thank you for your concern. My brother and father would be very grateful."

"...would they?"

"Yes."

I have no idea he'd be so concerned with the request of my brother. Anyways, I am so grateful to them even though I don't know their names. The mere fact that they still care is all that matters to me.

Soon, I caught Lenag staring at me. He blinked for a moment realizing that I had caught him, and then turned his head to the other side slowly, pretending to be innocent and unbothered.

"You are a good person... unlike them."

Wait...what?

I don't know why it all boils down to that. Moreover, I could barely hear the last words he uttered because he was like whispering in the air. I just laughed and said what I thought Iana's family was.

“They’re good people.”

Who would think that they are bad people when they always send me food and gifts while I was in prison? Bringing me everything that I want, I could tell that he’s a good brother. Atleast, that’s enough reason for them to be good.

“Yes, at least for you which is also a wonder.”

He lowered his head slowly, trying to remember something.

“Oh, come to think of it, what Miss Iana wanted will be done soon.”

Lenag’s gaze was soon redirected at the rain-swept window. Two days later, the rain was lessening and it seemed to stop soon. He stared at me, taking his eyes off the window.

“When the rain stops, the young prisoner you mentioned will be allowed to take a walk sometimes. But he will be guarded with several mid-level knights.”

Suddenly, he pulled out a smile on his face. I blinked for a moment, surprised by what I saw.. However, his cold image did not disappear.

But...he did laugh, right? I got goosebumps. It was somewhat creepy. I know he is trying to be warm and sincere but still, I find him nerve-racking.

His appearance right now looks so pure– as if he was innocent and kind. But don’t be deceived with that face cause behind that is a knife that is ready to cut off your head.

Was he trying to scare me? If he was, then congratulations! He succeeded! I rubbed the sweat that formed on my palm against my clothes and pretended not to panic.

This guy suddenly became a pure and innocent man in front of a woman like me. Unbelievable!

Where in fact, he is a very cruel and cold-hearted supporting villain. I could not imagine him being like this unless I read it in the novel. He was a man who looked at people as if he was dismantling their bodies, and then feeding them to starving wolves. What suddenly changed that?

“If you need anything, please, feel free to tell me.”

I don’t know if his smile was sincere or not so I just dodged my eyes away from his sharp gaze. I swallowed hard.

How much did my brother and father pay this man? I have no idea... but it must have been an astronomical cost. After all, it’s not easy to be in Lenag’s good side.

“Yes.” I nodded and then looked at his capitalist smile.

Hail for my favor! Hurray for the wealth!

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The rain finally stopped, and a full-fledged summer time appeared. Fortunately, it wasn’t too hot in here. I don’t know if it is because of where this country or region is located, but it’s good because I don’t like the heat nor the cold. I just want it neutral.

“It’s been a long time since I had a walk.”

Two days after the rain had stopped, the guards allowed us to take a walk. And the air in the garden, after the so-called ‘quarantine’, was not bad. In fact, it feels so good.

“Wow, breathing the air outside never felt this refreshing.”

The garden is full of flowers and turf-grown lawns, enough to call it a garden. The prisoners, including me, were much more satisfied here. It would be worse if the rain didn’t stop, for all of us will be kept inside the prison all the time. And I’m just grateful the worse didn’t happen.

Come to think of it, this prison already has it all! From a splendidly decorated living room to a garden as lovely as this. It's like this prison already has everything a mansion has. So if that's the case, should the prison be considered a mansion?

Surely enough, this is an ideal place to live in but for the nobility, it's not really a comfortable dwelling place to the point of calling it a home.

By the way, how's Ricdorian? I haven't seen him for about two weeks since the time I thought my brother and father had forgotten about me because I haven't received any letters. And even after a letter came, I didn't have the chance to visit him because I was sick.

Chapter 17: Lavish Prison Life (4)

Chapter 17 – Lavish Prison Life (4)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Not to mention, there have been slight changes on the guards' timetable, which made it even more difficult for me to visit him. So now, I was waiting for Han's turn in supervising this side of the prison.

Frankly speaking, since Hans and I were closer than before, he tends to overlook more things than the other guards. Plus, I can easily bribe him with high-class cigarettes.

"Look, the ground dried up quickly. Oh, my gosh! When the sun's heat is too strong, it becomes the skin's enemy."

"Sally's skin is white enough, though." I said and smiled at her, who was walking beside me. She was a prisoner that was situated in a nearby room.

"Well." She grinned. Her red hair and the slight freckles on her face made her look charming and cute.

"On days like this, I want to beat my brother who put me in his place."

"He deserves it."

Sally's brother embezzled taxes, but he couldn't go to jail because he was the breadwinner of the family, so they decided to send someone of his blood instead, and that was his sister, Sally.

"I'm afraid that if I go back, he won't be able to save his third leg. I will surely cut it off."

“...Well, Sally, come to think of it, even though you’re here, you have gotten closer with the knights. Your stay here isn’t really that bad.”

Her words were so intense. Thanks to her brother, who suddenly got into trouble, the young lady, who was about to get married, had her last name retained instead of changing it into the last name of her significant other. Maybe that’s why she was so angry about being imprisoned.

I was about to go back when she grabbed my wrist. Oh my gosh, the guards might complain since we’ve been out for two long hours.

“What is it?”

She widely opened her round eyes as if she had seen a horrible thing. I wondered what was wrong so I followed her gaze, and immediately opened my eyes wide in surprise.

A group of people were walking on the other side of the garden.

“Isn’t that a mid-level guard?”

Among the guards, there was one wearing a blue suit which indicates that he was a mid-level knight.

Due to the nature of Kambrakam, several prisoners were not allowed to gather during their walk in order to prevent any attempts of escaping. Additionally, prisoners don’t have any care for petty criminals and some lazy aristocrats which is why it is rare to see a lot of prisoners crowding like that.

I soon discovered a relatively small figure among the crowd.

It was Ricdorian.

“Hey, that’s a familiar cloth...” He was holding the shawl I had given him on my last visit and was looking like a scared puppy as of the moment.

“Are they having a walk?”

“I think so.”

I was surprised at Lenag’s course of action. He said that when the rain stops, Ricdorian can take a walk. The funny thing is that I didn’t expect him to do it so soon.

I soon stared at Ricdorian with absurd eyes...What kind of walk is that? This is crazy!

I heard murmurs from the other prisoners and also, there are too many knights on guard who’re prepared in case he makes a wrong move.

In addition, the men who surrounded Ricdorian all looked masculine and tough. Though he was unusually physically fit for a 16-year-old teenager, the number of guards around him are too many. Isn’t this too much for just a mere walk?

“That’s not a walk, it’s just a one minute stroll before the lynch.”

I looked at them with a slight frown.

“I agree.”

I cursed Lenag in my head at what I saw. He really doesn’t care about this young prisoner. Ricdorian may have developed claustrophobia during his imprisonment and might be the reason why he’s acting like this.

Furthermore, I’ve never seen him outside since I came into this novel, and this is probably the very first walk that he did inside Kambrakam but everything turned out like a monkey walk performance.

I kept cursing Lenag in my mind but I came to realize that no matter how many times I execrated him, he already had his fair share of the deal. He let Ricdorian go outside but... the walk looks suffocating. I can’t stand this.

As far as I can tell, it seems that Lenag and Chaser held hands in screwing with Ricdorian. Which was too conspicuous.

There were a lot of prisoners whispering trying to find out Ricdorian's crime. I was gathering any ideas and excuses in my mind in order to be able to go towards him but, realizing the series of events occurring, I hesitated a bit.

Because of this, I'm confused if I would be able to approach him. I am not confident going through that crowd. Also, I was kind of worried because I didn't know if he was a beast or a rational person at this moment. Looking at them, I don't know what to think anymore.

But suddenly, our eyes met.

His blue eyes held me, and I could see it shaking, even when I stood on this side of the garden, which is not far away from him.

"Iana, Iana, that's a chain, right?"

"Yes, it looks like it."

And the way he flinched... I knew it! He's not a beast right now, he's a rational person.

"...completely restrained and suppressed."

He wore a belt around his neck, handcuffs around his wrist, and clasped claws on his feet. The chain attached to the belt in his neck was held by a guard standing next to him. And it could be perceived that they were having a transportation, not a walk.

"I just asked the guard about that prisoner, and he said he was a magic criminal."

"Ah." I replied blankly.

The prisoners who were crowding that moment left, one by one. Which is a good thing because it would lessen the suffocation Ricdorian might be feeling right now.

Sally, who was shaking my arm, went to another prisoner named Aegean when I showed a little response. I was left there alone and took a step while looking at Ricdorian. I was trying to get close to him.

The heck!

What happened made me blink my eyes. What's this? How could he?!

Ricdorian turned his back on me.

“What the...”

I stared sharply at the back of Ricdorian who was walking fast.

“Ah, prisoner! Hey! Slow down...”

The guards followed his fast-paced steps and almost fell down as they tried to keep up with him. They also seemed to be not in the mood.

As soon as my eyes met with his, Ricdorian hurriedly ran away.

“...why is he running away?”

I was suddenly filled with embarrassment. I felt repugnant. How can he treat someone, who let him take a walk that way?!

It's the only opportunity he'll have where a villain agreed to let him enjoy his freedom and let him breathe some fresh air outside his cell.

What's wrong with him? I tilt my head to question myself and soon turn my back. I'm so confused right now.

I don't know why this is happening. And I will definitely ask him about it.

Chapter 18: Will I get imprisoned once again if we do something improper? (1)

Chapter 18 – Will I get imprisoned once again if we do something improper? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“I’m here to ask something.”

As soon as he heard my voice, he tilted his head, and looked at me. His blue eyes speak a thousand words as it stares at me. He looked troubled and wondered about my sudden arrival.

I am so lucky his rational side is awake today, I thought to myself. Thinking about getting some good responses from him makes me exhilarated.

“Yes, yes, what is it?”

“Don’t get red. I haven’t done anything yet.” He flinched at my sudden bluntness.

“Well, what are we going to do then...”

“What were you doing a while ago? It was a complete mess. You’re making a big deal out of it.”

“Oh, oh, oh, no!”

What was he thinking? He was acting like I made a bad decision by making him walk outside. As if it wasn't for me, he wouldn't have experienced that kind of walk that is worse than an animal's quadrupedalism. Moreover, I haven't done anything to him, but the way he responds to every move I do, people will think I'm bullying him.

I looked at him with absurd eyes and squatted down to level my face with him.

"Oh, C'mon. I know it's hard..."

Actually, I ran as fast as I can in here, which left me gasping in air. I was worried as to why he walked so fast and avoided me. I thought he had a problem or maybe he got sick because of the new experience.

I felt guilty and responsible for what had happened as I was the one who asked Lenag to let him take a walk outside, if that could really be considered a walk. Now I'm just glad nothing serious has happened. I've learned my lesson.

To be certain, I scanned Ricdorian meticulously from head to toe, never missing a single spot of his body. He looks fine. However, after examining him, I was welcomed by his face that became redder than before.

"Why the hell are you turning red? Was it because I am looking at you?"

Even if I am treated like a pervert, I still wanna know why. Was it because he's not comfortable with my gaze? Am I even doing things right?

Then suddenly, he pursed his lips.

"Well. If you make eye contact... Uh, ah."

"I'm listening."

"No one ever looked at me in the eye..."

He hesitated. So I stared at him, whose face was now hidden in the shawl, but his eyes were peeking. But soon, he removed the cloth covering his eyes

and looked at me, perhaps because I didn't respond to what he just said.

"Amazing... Are you curious?"

Ricdorian moved his lips.

"Can I be curious?" He said that and quickly hid his face again, embarrassed.

The moment I saw his red lips glistening under the shawl I gave him, I quickly turned my eyes away from it.

Oops, that's enough staring. Ricdorian had a smooth and pale complexion. His lips were as red as a freshly picked rose and so was his cheeks. I think I'll feel strange if I keep looking at him.

Frankly speaking, when I read the novel, I liked the appearance of the adult Ricdorian, and did not care about his teenage look. But what I am seeing right now is something that is ethereal. His whole being takes my breath away...

It must be due to the fact that this male protagonist doesn't have a face that could be compared to a mere human being. He's more like a celestial being with an exquisite beauty that is out of this world.

"I see, Uhm. Oh, I gotta go. I just came here in a hurry because I was wondering what happened."

His shoulder, wrapped in a blanket, flinched a little as he heard me. But before I could take a step, he lifted his body up a little, making me turn around. I looked at his finger in daze.

He slightly looked at me in the eyes, holding only a tiny area of my cloth, so small that I wondered if an ant could walk in.

"Go?"

Actually, I was in a hurry, because I only asked an ample time from Hans to go in Ricdorian's cell and check on him.

After he saw me nod, he looked up even more, somewhat disheartened. His silvery hair swayed and his bluish eyes stood out even more with his gesture. With all of his aspects, he could easily beguile someone's heart.

“Why...”

Those tantalizing eyes that held mine seem blinding at this moment.

“...you didn't come?” I swallowed hard, a little tense with where this is going.

“Oh, when?”

“For the last weeks, in my room...”

Wait.... What do you mean? In my room? Why use such misleading words?

He blinked, with tears clinging at the corner of his eyes.

I soon realized what he meant. Oh. But, wait a minute. Oh no, hold on.

“...I've been waiting.”

Will I get imprisoned once again if we do something improper things right here?

I quickly gathered myself when I saw Ricdorian rubbing his eyes and wiping his tears that flowed down his cheeks. He looked like a crying little kid whose lollipop was stolen. But he's not a kid nor does he have a lollipop, so why was he crying?

For a while, I am uncertain if I'm emotionally stable as I couldn't keep up with the male lead's emotional changes. Because of this I have a doubt, but... Yes, I am still capable of handling adversity and withstand difficult situations. To boot, I still feel sadness and grief whenever I think of the movie 'A Dog of Flander'...even so, why did I think of a dog? I must be out of my mind.

The Ricdorian who desperately covered his red face with his palm, made the sound of the steel chain clank loudly.

“...will this be our last?”

Hearing those words from him who was weeping like an abandoned puppy, made my heart heavy. I squatted back immediately right in front of him.

“Nope. I didn’t say anything.” I said, trying to console him.

I kept interfering with his life and as a consequence he has hit the bullseye as I am now having a soft spot for him.

I felt a bit sorry for him. I clearly understand every bit of what he was feeling right now. It’s the first time he had ever felt this way in his entire life, right? And It was so strange to hear such words from him, who had never done anything for the past month except for crying and growling.

I have no idea why I ended up playing the role of the heroine just for this time. It’s the heroine’s job to save him and tame his beast side. But maybe, even if I help him ease his feelings just for now, he would forget this occurrence after a long period of time.

I feel a little lighthearted knowing that I am not the chosen one. I recognize my limitations in helping him because I know that I wouldn’t be the one to free him.

Chapter 19: Will I get imprisoned once again if we do something improper? (2)

Chapter 19 – Will I get imprisoned once again if we do something improper? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“Walk, was it that bad?”

“A walk?” He grinned slightly, wiping his tears away.

“That’s what I asked from the head guard, to let you have some walk..” His eyes, still full of tears, looked at me with confusion. But I returned it with a bright smile to ease the shaking of his blue eyes.

I’m not capable of anything. If I touch that shackle on his neck, it won’t open and the rose pattern won’t stop. That’s why I’m relieved. For the meantime, I can only appreciate his beauty and be his aid.

Yeah, that’s it. That’s the only thing I can accomplish as a side character.

“How about a ‘Thank you’?” I hesitated a bit to say those words.

But he suddenly walked on his knees. Wait a minute. No, don’t walk like that! You’re not an animal! I wanted to tell him but...

“...you?”

“If you’re asking if it’s true, Then I would say yes. But can you ask me using human words, not just by means of eye contact?”

“Out...outside.”

“Yes. Outside. Was it nice?” He nodded as a response to what I had asked him.

I gazed proudly at the wet nod. Yes, this is what I wanted to do. It’s a fate that will pass by anyway. I’m also very happy for this run-through experience.

Won’t it be a win-win situation?

In fact, the novel is shorter than any other commonly read novels. Therefore, the sexual union of the protagonists were immediately done after he was released from the shackles.

We all know that love is good, but they could have enjoyed a little bit more of small happiness by doing other things. But what do you expect? This is a rated-19 novel so readers might have expected a conjugation soon. That’s what it’s supposed to be.

Same as the heroine, I saw Ricdorian in a cell too, but that was because I had read this novel and knew about him. While theirs are the work of fate.

“Let’s take a walk together next time.” Speaking of it, I felt like what we will be doing is a dog walk. Maybe because I’m looking at him still kneeling like a dog. But still, I want to do this.

His shaking gaze calmed down and turned to me. The mere sight of him made me sweat.

Not long after, he wet his lips with his tongue. Unconsciously, my eyes rested on those lips.

“Mas.. Master, what do you call it?”

“Me? Uh-uh. Well take a walk together...but...Master?”

“In, in, interested!”

“What a lame joke.” I laughed. Why would he call me Master?

I was puzzled when I saw that he’s still not releasing me. So I glanced at his hand and poked the back of it.

“When are you going to let go of me?” His hand was still holding onto the hem of my clothes.

It’s difficult to break off his hold, he’s a mobster so I tickled the back of his hand with my fingers, and then slipped it down, liberating the trim.

“Oh, oh, I didn’t do anything.”

“You’re the one who’s holding my clothes like this!”

“Not a, ha...ha...no hands.”

“What? So you’re the only one who was allowed to touch anything or whatever you like?”

When I touched his fingertips with mine, Ricodorian was startled.

“...well, not that.”

It’s cute to keep teasing him. I wanna try touching once more because he keeps acting like a naive baby kitten. I giggled at that thought, while covering my mouth.

“Unfair..” Because I laughed at him, he just turned his head.

“Next time when you take a walk, don’t run away.”

“Arff!”...when did you become a dog?

I laughed at him absurdly. I don’t know if it’s intentional, but I’m sure he will turn into a beast at an exquisite timing.

Before I knew it, the blush disappeared from his face. I looked at his fierce eyes on the spot as his rational side retreated after sunset.

I narrowed my eyes and looked at him.

“You don’t listen to anything you don’t want to hear, is that it?”

“Ruff! ruff, ruff?”... This young man is talking nonsense only when it’s convenient. Aish!

Hey! I tried to bark with him in a fit of anger, but I changed my mind and turned my back.

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The day I took a walk with Ricdorian came earlier than I thought.

“Long time no see. Iana.” The guard greeted me gladly.

To my surprise, it was not difficult walking with Ricdorian. Beforehand, I was worried that I might be a burden to the guards surrounding the young man and then be rejected and ignored by them, but I was unexpectedly placed together with him in the center.

Furthermore, from time to time, the other guards that I knew greeted me as we approached each other and most of them were those who had received something from me.

My capitalist smile was winning over me.

“I haven’t been going to the laundry room lately. I’m sorry.”

“You don’t feel bad about anything else, not me?”

After exchanging a few words with the laundry guard who brought me new clothes, I glanced at Ricdorian. The boy was waiting for me, along with the guards surrounding him, and turned his face away the moment our eyes met.

“Hi.”

Hmph! Why is he averting his eyes?

Whenever our eyes met, he would always look away, spinning his head, and stare blankly at the other side. But I would always catch him looking at me before he averts his gaze.

What’s the matter with him again? Thinking about something like this, throbs my temple.

“Don’t you feel uncomfortable with this?”

When I got back to him, I immediately asked him and tapped the handcuffs, which were clenched against his wrists.

“I...I’m not uncomfortable...”

After saying those, he nodded visibly, making sure that I could see it. But in his nod, I saw his red ears peeking through his silver hair.

The prisoners in Kambrakam were so eager to find out the real identity of Ricdorian after his first appearance on the outside. But after a few days of searching, it seemed that no one was able to gather information regarding him. This just indicates that the real identity of Ricdorian must be a classified information. Furthermore, the guards only knew Ricdorian as a prisoner with ‘magic crime’.

A Magic Crime Prisoner was specifically a prisoner involved in heavy law offenses, and was classified as a prisoner who often caused uproars and sudden outbursts.

The number of people who were watching might still be wondering about him.

On the other hand, I realized, as I entered the walls of these guards, that it was not as threatening as I had seen it from the outside.

However, just in case Ricdorian tends to be aggressive, I'm hoping that no one would get hurt, especially the ones who get near us.

"But what's that on your neck?" I tilted my head then looked at Ricdorian's neck, also wondered what that thing was.

His neck was filled with another kind of shackle other than those he wore since he was born. It looks more like a necklace.

Soon, the guard next to him answered back.

"It's a necklace especially created for magic criminals. It activates whenever the prisoner turns wild and violent. Though, it is also a useful tool to prevent them from running away and escaping."

I looked more clearly on the necklace. Iron...It is made of iron.

The guard grabbed the chain that he was holding, and Ricdorian groaned as he was strangled, "It's just a small thing but with a very big purpose."

Chapter 20: The Impoverished Ricdorian Is In Full Swing (1)

Chapter 20 – The Impoverished Ricdorian Is In Full Swing (1)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Seeing the guard haul the chain roughly, annoyed the hell out of me. Can't he see that Ricdorian was being asphyxiated in this instant?

“Wow, I see. It's amazing.” The prisoners who were crowding exclaimed as if they were in a circus, unbothered by the forlorn situation of the young prisoner.

How pathetic, making someone's suffering their own source of glee!

While they were busy laughing, I figured out the chain loosened a little bit, which eases the tightness around Ricdorian's neck...I didn't like the forced treatment that the guard just did. I know this was a prison but still, treating prisoners harshly is exorbitant.

“If you pull the chain like this during a sudden paroxysm, the magic of the necklace will naturally occur...”

The guard continued giving explanations without being asked. I grimaced.

Show off!

“Aha.”

I'm not interested at all and I don't even give a darn thing about it. He can do his act all day for all I care as long as he's not dragging Ricdorian into

this.

The jailer who was talking was a little young. Maybe the same age as me. Must be why he's loving all the attention he's getting.

In a moment, I watched Ricdorian while the guard was still busy attracting the other prisoners with his explanations, whose cheeks blush subtly.

Ricdorian was staring at the garden, his deep blue entrancing eyes were full of innocence like a new born baby who had never seen the sky or the earth.

Is this really his first time relishing such experience?

Looking at him, I felt so peaceful— as if I am a mother watching her kid chase a butterfly in a park. I took my time looking at him tenderly who has now gotten quite fond with his surroundings.

“Ricdorian?”

At that moment, I saw his back bent. Unlike the usual, he quivered briefly. It was different from the way he looked at me before, scared and waving.

However, not long after that, came the loud roar of a familiar beast coming from Ricdorian's mouth. I pulled back quickly and stared at him, mystified.

What's happening? Why did he tremble like that? Did he change without any warnings? The atmosphere was so bizarre. Something feels odd for some reason.

“Grrr.”

“It's a paroxysm!”

“It's an outrage! Pick up your sword!”

The guards lifted their swords calmly but some did not take them out as they didn't want to hurt the other convicts as well as the feral magic prisoner. I've only seen incidents like this in movies. Seeing it personally isn't really that awkward since they are all knights.

“The magical prisoner has turned wild. Get everything ready! Arthur!”

Anton Lee, a senior jail warden, was the one who did the command. Shortly, someone gave him a quick answer. It was the youngest guard who boasted and explained everything about the binding necklace earlier.

“Activate the necklace!”

“Yes, Sir! Hey, stay still! Stop!” Arthur shouted as he heard the commander and tightly pulled the chain connected on Ricdorian’s necklace.

“Huh, what’s wrong with this?” He asked as nothing happened.

Maybe they didn’t know how to trigger it. But, not long after, I felt the guards around me panicked.

I know that the necklace needs to be activated, but I am also oblivious how. I can’t be of any help right now.

“Bad luck, the magic doesn’t work!”

“What?”

Others rushed in, pulling the chain and shouted words I can’t fathom, however, they were inept of controlling the raging beast.

In the meantime, Ricdorian, who was confronted by another guard, swung his arm which made the guard and his sword fly to the side in an instant....and then everything turned bloody.

It took less than a minute for most of the guards to lie on the ground. Some of them were mid-level knights. And even the best ones were barely holding on to their numerical dominance against a sixteen year old boy.

“The magic prisoner, don’t let him go! Don’t let him go near any inmates. Ah!”

“No!”

The truculent Ricdorian was so occupied with his surroundings that no one could ignore his presence.

The moment I decided to step back, I saw the chain swung in front of me. I alternately gazed at the snarling Rickedoran and the guards and then quickly grabbed the chain. Now what? Is this my moment now?

I looked blankly at the white-tinged chains. Why did it suddenly change color? I was flabbergasted. Is this normal?

My eyes met with the different staggered and agape faces of the guards and prisoners when they saw me get a hold of the chain. The commander of the guards immediately screamed.

“That’s it Iana! Shout now!”

“Eh, eh? What, what are you talking about?”

“Anything is good! Hurry!”

He said before he was confronted again by Ricdorian, and then fell to the ground.

Rickedoran all of a sudden turned his glare towards me.

Did he see me now? This is bad. My defenses are down. The immensity of the bloodlust and salaciousness he had was different. It’s not comparable to the one I perceived in the basement. It is more than that! It’s immensely dangerous!

I don’t know what made him so violent. There was a story in the book about his “aggressiveness.” It was said that they lose their memories of being a beast.

Ricdorian stamped his foot, facing me.

“Anything! Shout! Say it now!”

Despite the fervent cries of the commander, Ricdorian still rushed to where I am. I closed my eyes tightly, rattled with what I should say.

“Uhm, Ah, sit down!”

The surroundings went silent for a few seconds.... Is it over? I opened my eyes, still blurry, and looked at the chain. I turned my eyes to Ricdorian and saw him sitting down on the ground. What...what is this?

“Be vigilant! Keep on shouting!”

What? And just like the guard’s words, Ricdorian rose from his seat. As if he was not bothered by it and was not influenced by it at all.

“Uh, get down!”

Boom!

“Roll! stand up! Sit down! Roll again!”

He surrenders with my every command.

When he came back to his senses after the ecstatic shouting, the devastated surroundings became quiet. The fine dirt pit was already at the ground, and the people around were staring at me with pale eyes, manifesting the emotion of fear and bewilderment.

And I slowly looked down because of embarrassment instead of looking back at them.

Sob...Sob..Crying...Weeping.

I slowly swept my face away, staring at the male protagonist, exposing his belly while squalling.

...What kind of idiot is this?

Chapter 21: The Impoverished Ricdorian Is In Full Swing (2)

Chapter 21 – The Impoverished Ricdorian Is In Full Swing (2)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Ricdorian's vicious eyes from a while ago were now nowhere to be seen. But one thing was clear, whether he was sane and calm from the beginning, he could still turn into a wild beast out of nowhere.

I whispered quietly to Ricdorian, who came to me running with a slight groan.

“... Sit down.” Okay. That's good.

Prisoners and guards: “...”

I washed my face for the second time. My gosh, mister, why are you walking around like that.

When did the male protagonist learn how to walk like a dog? I wonder if this was even possible in the first place!

The sense of self-destruction came to me like an expeditious wave. Do I have the talent of a trainer...?

“This, Iana. Are you a wizard?”... No. I've never read nor heard of her being a wizard.

I stared at the guard in dismay at the realization of my unintentional talent.

The guards and I haven't said anything for a while. The deafening silence was the only sound present in the garden. Ricdorian could only blink his eyes and enjoy the surroundings without anyone.

This place is unoccupied. Other prisoners were not seen in the garden except for me, the guards, and Ricdorian.

Will he get away quickly? ‘Probably.’

I looked down, turning my eyes to him. I'm glad that many prisoners have not seen this preposterous image of Ricdorian. I just saw him rubbing his face...Jeez, don't scratch your head with your legs.

“Who taught you that?”

“Arff?”

I squint at this young man's dull blue eyes. Right now, there's a dumb fool, eerie sitting like a whelp. What would I say to him now?

Clank. Clank.

Once again, the chain was pulled when he tried to reach me. I still couldn't conceal my intricate expression as I looked at the chain, which had changed to white.

“...uhm.” I opened my mouth and spoke quietly so that the guards won’t hear me.

“... Sit down.” Good boy!

“Get up.” I said, eventually.

But the sudden realization hit me. Oh, no...These...These behaviors. These are all actions of a dog.

Now, what the hell is this? What kind of situation is this? When did the handsome man with an enchanting beauty in the novel become a dog?

This was simply a different matter from his barking. So far, the language he used is the communication medium of dogs. But it's just not that, he even ate his food using his bare hands!

I thought about the contents of the book, but there was no such thing as this. Clearly, the book imparts that Ricdorian suffered from the curse of being a "beast,". But being a beast is not about turning into a dog! It was about being ferocious and being ten times more powerful than human beings.

Right now, it's easy to say that he's a dog rather than a beast, for that's the way he acts, like a mad man...But I didn't think that the description of 'dog' in the novel was real. I crouched down unconsciously as I lost all my energy thinking about all of these.

Clank. Clank.

I heard the sound of the chain once more, and caught eyes with Ricdorian who approached me directly.

"Don't bite."

"Arff!" Ricdorian barked and shook his head, assuring he wouldn't do it. But, how should I believe him?

"Come on. You're a good boy, right? Bite this one instead."

I pulled out my head lace skillfully, as he waited for it with his mouth wide open. Perplexed by what I did, the guard next to me, clapped his hands.

"It's stupendous! The magic prisoner was perfectly tamed!"

Sir, don't clap. Is this a situation to be credulous? Everything became too complicated now...Don't you know that I'm unfamiliar with all of these?

He wasn't a dog but as I looked at him, who felt so good having a soft, woolly hair tie in his mouth, I baffled even more.

I looked at Ricdorian with a head lace on his mouth and reached out.

“Hands.”... The guard was still laughing out loud.

“Can’t you get your hands on it? No, not your forefoot...I don’t think you can’t do it.”

Oh, he wants to play pretend.

“...”

I looked into his eyes, squeezing his hand, who seemed to have given up the human way. I wonder why he does it with paws instead of hands.

It’s hard to repudiate, but it was clear that there was a lunatic who taught Ricdorian the unspoken language of a f*cking beast.

In any case, even if he was a beast, he seemed to have heard and understood some human words, so things seemed to be short-circuited.

“Iana. I’m going to the office of the Prison Head.”

Just as I wanted things to plain sailing, the chief guard approached me.

“It’s hard to get past what has happened.” He added. I looked at the chain once more and nodded in response.

“But now that the Prison Head has been away for a while, I will place the report on his room and see to it that once he comes back he will see you immediately. All of it should be known.”

“I got it. But for now, Ric..ah.. I mean... what happens to this magic prisoner?”

I was a little uncomfortable seeing Lenag again, but it was an absolute order so it’s impossible to back out.

But for now, that doesn’t matter. I should be more concerned about the wild beast who caused a commotion in the garden.

The chief guard frowned for a moment and spoke again.

“I don’t know why the redemption necklace didn’t respond to our commands. Moreover, it’s strange that it’s still unresponsive, even if I tried activating the trigger many times.”

“Have this happened before?”

“It’s definitely the first time I’ve ever used this... I have never heard of anything like this before.”

“I’m not sure.” As he spoke, he turned to the other guards in query. Then they shook their heads one by one.

Whenever I pull out my hand from the chain, it would quickly turn black.. Will it unorthodoxly turn white to whoever catches it? Hmmm. I don’t know why this is transpiring.

“Are you alright, by the way?”

“Me? Oh! Of course, yes, I don’t think there’s anything more dreadful other than being nervous and powerless.”

I didn’t know if he would turn into a wild beast again, but I was still clutching the chain as it had the power to stop the wild Ricdorian. Just to be sure. But my fingertips had been quivering strangely for a while now.

It might be that I laid all my strength in my hand. Why is it that all of my energy is falling apart? It’s not really a big deal, but I feel a little breathless. Then, with the feeling of power being lost, still grabbing the chain, I felt myself falling from my position.

‘This is not good.’

Chapter 22: The Impoverished Ricdorian Is in Full Swing (3)

Chapter 22 – The Impoverished Ricdorian Is in Full Swing (3)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

One of the guards grabbed my wobbling hand, stopping me from falling over. Good thing he was just on time!

“Are you alright, Iana?”

I looked up to him wanting to express my gratitude in saving me from plummeting. When suddenly, a loud noise from the chain filled the garden.

Clank. Clank.

I felt a rigid entity hooked around my waist. I paused a little then heard a familiar low breath, creating a titillating sensation in my ears.

“Ricdorian?”

Ricdorian, who stood up immediately, wrapped his arms around me possessively, and snarled at the guard who held me by my hand. What the hell is he doing?

My heart was beating so fast. His tickling breath doesn't help, it makes me more nervous. Afterwards, I held my palms up in front of the guards, gesturing that I am fine.

They seemed worried as I was enclasped by the magic crime prisoner.

“It’s ok. I am ok.”

The trepidatious guards kept their eyes on us, afraid that the young beast might mutilate me in no time.

“Shh. Shh. Good boy!” I said, trying to quell his abrupt aggressiveness, at the same time enshrouding my tension. Then, I slowly raised my hand and brought it to his face.

What if he bites me?

As luck would have it, he didn’t bite. And as I touched his face, I felt a puffy sensation on my palm. His skin is as soft as a cotton ball, as if it was well maintained. I wonder what his skin care is? I chuckled at that notion.

But a moment later, he shook his face.

“Well, Ricdorian.”

“Arrff?”

All this time, his arm, enclosing my waist, held me up. I felt the tightness of his hold loosened a bit, he must’ve felt soreness in his arms. Grabbing the opportunity, I immediately tried to strip off his arm from me.

“Get down.”

Thud!

I swiftly turned away from the fallen man, and uttered the magic words.

“Ah, sit down!”

With a boom!

“Who told you to get up? Get down.”

“Hum!”

The tension I was feeling earlier disappeared as I heard him whining. He looked so uncool with his belly protruding. I grinned.

Still, his disheveled look makes me feel anomalous.

As expected, his beauty is a crime. That should be the reason why he's in jail, and not for being a magic criminal.

“Hu..”

I stroked my waist with my other hand that was not holding the chain. His arm, which was tightly wrapped around my waist a while ago, as well as his firm touch that made contact with my skin was surreal.

I swallowed my saliva thinking of those...

‘I see. His masculine physique did not flourish for nothing.’

When the situation was over, the senior guard quickly approached me.

“Hmmm, Iana. I think...For now, I have to send this prisoner back to his cell, will you help me?”

I nodded, agreeing with his request as I'm the only one here who can use this restraint, even though I was oblivious as to why this eventuates... But that was not the end of the guard's entreaty.

“And I'm sorry, but I'd like to ask you one more thing. It will take a few more days before the Prison's Head Guard comes back.”

The chief guard said trudically, scratching the back of his head.

“Will you accompany us in the future walk of the prisoner?”

“What?”

“Oh, We'll try to find another way. But so far, this is the only way that we come up with. We need your assistance. Of course, I'm going to give you a separate case for this.”

In the fullness of time, the place where everything wind up, was at Ricdorian's cell. Upon arriving in his basement room, the guards bound him. Afterwards, they all went out, leaving only Hans and the senior guard, who explained everything that had happened.

“Hey, I don't think one of the restraints fell off his neck.”

They tapped his neck and just like what I said, Ricdorian still had two restraints around his neck.

“Hmm, I'm going to keep that restraint tied up until the general manger comes back.”

The senior guard glanced at the woeful young prisoner, who was now tied to the wall, and said, “We still have to do this.”

“Tomorrow, even if the tool won't work with our commands, we still have to keep using it and get help from Iana instead.” The guard gave me a silent salute.

“If that happens, then please take good care of me as well” The guard bowed his head and went outside.

At the moment, only me and Hans were left in the room. Soon after, I asked Hans for a moment with Ricdorian.

“You must come out soon, Iana.” Hans said then left, while I remained in my spot alone, staring at the tied up Ricdorian.

He hasn't come back to his senses yet, as he showed his dissatisfaction by pulling the handcuffs around his wrists and banging the shackles in his feet. But as he returned to this basement, he looked more vigorous and at ease.

TLN: Otter was used to describe Ricdorian, since an otter is considered as cute/soft/cuddly and a dangerous wild animal at the same time. If you have any suggestions please share it on discord. Thank you very much!

Chapter 23: The Impoverished Ricdorian Is in Full Swing (4)

Chapter 23 – The Impoverished Ricdorian Is in Full Swing (4)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Exhausted, I squatted down, with a little distance away from him, gazing at him with sincerity that I couldn't express earlier.

“I'm sorry.”

I can't help but feel compunctious. I was ignorant that something like that would happen when I supplicated Lenag. ‘Everything would be fine’, that's what I anticipated. But realizing his true strength, even the guards Lenag assigned to him are incapable of handling him.

But didn't I enjoy reading this book with him tied up in chains? I caught myself staring at his deep cerulean eyes but then as I remembered something my forehead frowned.

I asked for nothing. I didn't ask to wake up in this novel...inside this prison, in the first place! I ranted in my mind.

Lamenting, I poked the end of the chain with my fingertips.

“But...I don't feel happy doing this.”

Ricdorian, growling at the handcuffs with his teeth exposed, stopped and gawked at me.

“Was it good though? I really do hope it's good.”

Ricdorian: "..."

His eyes that looked ravenous, in a flash, turned diaphanous.

His sapphire eyes that I once saw on the outside as violent, rough, and feral...now, convey calmness and are so fiery like blue flames.

I reached out slowly, despite being afraid of getting bitten, believing that the whole shooting match will turn out well.

As expected, he gently laid out his cheeks for me to touch. His coarse silver hair rubbed against my palm, as well as his soft skin.

I still can't believe his skin is this good when all his life he was placed in prison. Life is indeed unfair!

I was about to unwittingly pinch his cheek when he suddenly paused.

But no, it's more like he became stiff rather than he paused...And in just a blink of an eye, his ears gradually turned red, his cheeks in a feverish bloom....his neck was red as an elmo doll.

"You're back, aren't you?" I asked, "Then why didn't you run away from my touch?" I added and held his ear.

Just then, he bawled and stepped back. I felt this before when he was a beast, but I was still startled at his speed.

He doesn't have to run away like he saw a very wicked person...though being mischievous at times like this is not appropriate.

"Why, why, ah, you're still here?"

"Do you want me to go now?"

I caressed the necklace that had not been taken off his neck. His eyes shook as a response to my question.

“Don’t be too shaken up. It’s embarrassing. Also, I stopped your sudden berserk today.” Of course I’m partly to blame for what had happened.

I poked his neck. Just looking at the two restraints in his neck feels so heavy, what more for him who wears it.

For the meantime, I just couldn’t take my eyes off the necklaces when I promptly felt a pull. As I lowered my gaze, I saw Ricdorian vaguely pulling the hem of my dress, pursing his lips.

“...you don’t have to be sorry to me.” I said it with a little bit of hesitation. “Do you remember everything?”

“Most of the time. I don’t.. I don’t remember some of it but they’re part of my dream. ”

Most of them have no memories of turning into a wild beast. And I think that’s a very cruel thing for them. However, when I think about it, it’s still a good thing since Ricdorian doesn’t really make a big deal out of it. He seemed to be not ashamed of his outburst. Well, the sense of shame seems to be more critical to his other personality.

“...I love it... being out.”

“Do you still want to take some walks in the future?” He nodded.

I lowered my head slightly as I shook my head furtively. He didn’t seem to care about the treatment he received when he was a beast. Also, he doesn’t have any interest in the extra restraints placed on him.

Wasn’t he subjugated too much? I suppose so. This novel was unnecessarily scrupulous about his restraints and misfortunes.

“I’m glad I didn’t make a mistake.”

Well, wouldn’t it be a relief that I contributed to his small happiness in the future? It’s too much to just look at the dark walls of this room and wait for more than four years for Francia.

I smiled tenderly as I gazed at him, his cheeks were bulging and somehow, he was trying to avoid making eye contact with me.

This is really endearing. I can't believe this weird person is going to be a decadent male lead someday and it would be so fulfilling thinking he became that with my help. Oh well, if you look at it heedfully, he was still in the process of becoming a mature person.

My eyes fell on his worn clothes.

"You're going to catch a cold."

I quickly grabbed a blanket and covered his body. Hmm, I brought it not too long ago, but it's already dirty.

I think I should get him a new one.

Without further ado, he turned red. But soon, he winced which made me jump off.

His poignant eyes seemed to shout, 'You vulgar woman!' ... Just when did putting a blanket on someone become an assault?

"Hmm, do you hate it so much?"

The cell was colder, with the fact that it was deep underground. Though he might seem to be stronger than humans, but, I don't even know if he might be able to catch a cold. Still let's play safe.

Ricdorian: "..."

"Okay. I won't touch you again."

However, it is fun to see him flinch, but I don't have the vigor to do it today.

If you look at me full of tears... I feel like I'm going to do something really uncanny.

All of a sudden, I noticed that the time Hans set is almost over. I got up from my seat and thought of lying on my bed hastily.

I was so tired today, so I turned my back without minding anything else.

If only he hadn't caught me apace.

Chapter 24: This Is What I Wanted To Do At First! (1)

Chapter 24 – This Is What I Wanted To Do At First! (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“Now, what again?”

Ricdorian slightly grabbed the end of my clothes, making sure that there was no skin contact. I wasn't caught, but it was enough to stop me from walking away. I realized, he's really fond of grabbing the hem of my clothes.

He had developed a new hobby, huh!

“Why?”

As I tilted my head, he bowed down, letting me see his red nape and back behind his collar. Wow! his entire body has turned ruby.

And despite that bonny sight, I endured the urge to poke him.

“Don't worry, without your consent, I will not touch you...” I said immediately as he looked alert with my adoring stare at his whole being.

Eventually, his hands moved, grasping my fingertips as if giving me the consent to touch him.

“Ju...just a little”

“Only a little bit?”

“Hmm.”

I remembered that moment when he turned into a beast and hugged me from behind. His body temperature was as hot as the solar radiation that heats the earth. If he embraced me longer, I might have been a melted glacier by now.

I wonder if it's a trait he adapted from not being a human.

I blushed then swallowed hard at the sudden venture of Ricdorian in my fingers. His daring and bold deeds electrified me wholly.

“... This is a... this is okay.”

His head slowly crept up, and his blue eyes, which could easily catch everyone's attention, turned to me.

How many more years do I need to stay here? I was seriously troubled.

Mister...this is a fervent temptation. A temptation I couldn't resist any longer if you keep on teasing me like that.

However, he was even aware that it might be wrong to touch me hastily.

He is the male lead while I am not. I am just a side character of this story so it is best to live a long and worry-free life while I'm still inside this rated-19 novel. I don't have any idea when I'm going back home. To my real world.

I'm not complaining, it's just that the more time I spend here, the more I am becoming attached to Ricdorian.

I wiggled my finger and dropped his hand carefully, ensuring not to hurt his feelings as I don't want him to think he's been brushed aside. Then, I carefully patted his cheeks.

This, for sure, is acceptable, right?

“Okay. I'll go now.”

I slipped away from him, whose cheeks were like a blooming red flower, and shook his hands awkwardly. Afterwards, I turned my back on him.

“See you on the next walk.”

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The next afternoon, the senior guard came to me. I was told that no restraints were used on Ricdorian this time.

“It’s very strange... I’ve never done this before.”

Apparently, restraints that work well on other magical prisoners don’t work on him. I thought maybe it was related to the beast curse he had, but I still don’t really get it. In the end, the curse he had would remain a mystery to me.

There was no way I could know anything because first of all, I was unknowledgeable here. Though I have read the novel still, I am clueless about the actual extent of his curse.

All I knew was that he had a deadline because of that rose pattern in his chest. And only the heroine could release the shackles off from his neck that he had been wearing since birth.

“Anyways, I hope you can help me take the magic prisoner his walk now.”

“Well, yes, of course.”

Eventually, I decided to help him until Lenag came back from his business. In fact, I would really do so even without the request for help from the senior guard.

So somehow half of the day started as a mandatory walk, and a few days later, the fourth walk came about.

It was a good stroll. But not really a peaceful walk that was without ups and downs, twists and turns. After all, a bit of trouble makes life interesting.

As I stared into the distant sky, I turned my head to the sound of footsteps approaching.

“Arff!”

“Huh? Did you pick it up?”

I looked, with a vague glance, and saw what Ricdorian was doing...you really are coming around, huh.

The whole thing was different from a conventional walk. During our saunter, I realized for the second time that despite having the beast’s curse, he still manifests good physical strength.

<Sit down!>

<Arff!’’>

It’s been a long time since I shouted ‘Sit down’. How busting it was. I’m sick and tired of this, but at the same time, it was fun.

<What a beautiful face...>

<I know.>

This is because his diaphanous handsomeness, whether he is a beast or a rational person, stood out even more under the broad daylight. Furthermore, his tousled silvery hair, his blue eyes with a bit of fierceness, and even the appearance of the sweat rolling down look sacred.

“Arff!”... If only you’re not biting a ball in your mouth, that’s it. You would be quintessential!

“You want me to praise you?”

“Arff! Arff!”... Don’t be a dog like this, Ricdorian. Please I beg you! I cried inside.

Why do I think I know all the expressions in this version of the beast? He doesn't even speak the human language. Well, it must be because I'm his trainer. I felt proud of myself.

Staring at him with a complex gaze, I quickly threw the ball away. He had good physical strength. I thought of treating him like a puppy as a temporary measure, at least he's not bursting out like a wild beast. However, doing so made it seem like I was pushing him away from this human behavior.

I threw the ball steadily, feeling anxious whether I should feel guilty or relieved now that he is at ease.

"Well done."

Finally, when I threw one more time, I turned my head away from Ricdorian running away to fetch the ball.

The guards, standing like a statue, met eyes with me. They looked at us with a slightly embarrassed face and smiled.

"... She's very good at dealing with that prisoner."

The senior guard, Anton Lee, would always be the one to explain the situation.

"Have you done this before?"

...*What do you mean?*

Chapter 25: This Is What I Wanted To Do At First! (2)

Chapter 25 – This Is What I Wanted To Do At First! (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“This is my first time.” I rolled my eyes and shrugged.

In fact, they look edifying to me, but I was amazed at the nonchalant guards watching Ricdorian, who is like a hound.

“He seems to be more natural today, but does ‘that thing’ happen often? Well, I mean... the prisoner...”

“Do you mean the sudden uproar and outbursts?”

Anton got what he wanted to say.

“Not often, but it happened once. Magical crime prisoners have symptoms. They’re mostly prisoners who come here using bad magic, suffering from different side effects.”

Anton turned naturally.

“The prisoners who have spots all over their bodies, the ones who lose their memories everyday, hallucinations and so on. Long-time guards like me have seen different kinds of prisoners.”

“So you can say that the magic prisoner isn’t too awful?” I asked, as I became more interested with the conversation.

“I must say so. They are just out-of-control.”

Strictly speaking, Ricdorian wasn't aware of doing it either. When he saw Anton during his third walk, and thought of the guards who had fallen to the ground with his extraordinary power, he smiled awkwardly as if he had remembered that disastrous occurrence.

Also, Anton thanked me.

“I was able to carry out the order with your help. Thank you very much. I sincerely appreciate your help.”

“I would like to express my sincere gratitude coming from the Prison Head as well.” You don't even need to mention him. If it's Lenag, it's better not to listen to it.

Sooner than later, I heard the sound of footsteps running from afar. With my chin up, I held out my hand without looking at him.

Receiving the ball like that felt weird somehow.

“Go, get the ball...it's my first time...”

As I turned my head, I saw a whole flushed Ricdorian. I held back my laughter at his burning hot ears. Oh, his rational side is back.

Is this his way of talking? Mentioning his first times? I grinned.

After I received the ball, I shook my head as I put it down. Then I sat down and stared at him, who looks even bigger

“Hey.”

Ah. My neck hurt as I lifted up my head a little and made eye contact with him.

“Your firsts. Don't you get tired of mentioning it?” Then the blue eyes, as blue as sapphire, shook like a leaf.

“Ah, but. It’s really my first time...”

“This is what I really want to do at first.”

“Eh..eh...What?”

Doesn’t he know it? There’s a big difference between the firsts he is implying and the first that I just uttered.

I swallowed my saliva with a big gulp and smiled at him, tapping the free space beside me for him to sit.

“Sit down.”

“Yes, yes, yes!”

Well....why are you sitting on the floor, looking like you are waiting for something?

“Hey...why are you sitting there? Hey, don’t sit there, but here.” I wonder if animal traits affect him even when he’s rational personality is awake.

Now. I gravely felt the seriousness of the situation.

“Hurry up and sit down here properly.”

“Yes!”

For now, I think there is an urgency to teach him the human language!

I stared at the side of Ricdorian, who was looking seriously at the ground. As the saying goes *‘there’s must be something in the water’* as somehow he looks a little outlandish.

Glancing at his hair, which is undulating from his red forehead, I feel like I’m losing all the thoughts of innocence and purity. Maybe I needed to pour holy water in my head!

This doesn’t appear to be a righteous outlook!

But yeah, wouldn't it all end up in the book anyway?

I know that I'm complacent and imperturbable. But what can I do now that I am already here?

I was not supposed to make colossal changes to this story. I also understand that it is not good to alter the plot. But I would feel remorseful if I will not give a little bit of happiness to Ricdorian, at the present time.

It would be funny to say this, but I knew my part and role very well. So hereafter, I will just keep on watching him instead of giving him any advice. Of course, I noticed that my actions so far had a great impact on him, but she is the only woman who can save his life. It's absolutely not me! I already imprinted that on my mind as I needed to know my place.

I wish I could go home someday after all of this. And forget everything...

Thereafter, I glanced down at the squeak of the chain and saw Ricdorian's hand, slightly larger than mine, once again holding my clothes' hem but this time he was silent, all throughout.

Ricdorian:"..."

I smiled a little as I looked at the redness of his hand as if it were touching my fingertips.

This is definitely bad, isn't it?

Soon enough, I wouldn't be able to control this.

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After a week, the ninth walk of Ricdorian had come and unfortunately, it was also the time of Lenag's return. And as soon as he arrived, I was immediately called to meet him.

"How are you, Iana."

Lenag was dressed in a clean suit, he wore on the day we first met.

It was a prominent outfit or a uniform, I think, for most of the prisoners like me. Furthermore, a sleek silhouette stood out in the suit-like robe.

Wow, his body is in great shape. I can't help appreciate his wholesomeness even though he is a villain in this novel.

I sat down at the seat he pointed out, admiring his stylishness and sleek honest appearance. Then, he tilted his head with his eyebrow raised.

“Well, hello. You're not working as the Prison Head today?” I've always come here to see him working as the Prison Head Guard but to my surprise, he was not in duty.

“Yes. That's right.”

The place I met him today was the top floor where the general manager stays. The guard, who guided me, said that nobody could get inside except for me. The feeling of being someone important was very mystifying.

Honestly, I was blindfolded coming in here, that's why I felt a little bit awry. But it doesn't really differ from what I always feel whenever I meet him.

Lenag, who noticed my nervousness, pushed the cup on the coffee table in front of me.

“I heard the story. The things that happened during my absence.”

“Yes.”

I put the cup down, without realizing, instead of drinking it. It's too hot when I held it. Drinking it might burn my tongue again.

When suddenly....

“You're great.” He said, baffling me.

“Gre... Eh?????!”... Which part?!!!

Chapter 26: The Sudden Realization (1)

Chapter 26 – The Sudden Realization (1)

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

If it's with reference to what occurred during his absence, then he must be talking about the redemption necklace that was supposed to deal with Ricdorian when turning berserk or it might be possible that he was pointing out the idea of my treatment of Ricdorian as a dog....But I believe he's pertaining to both...

As a matter of fact, what I did was nowhere to be considered '*great*'. I was just merely taming his beast side.

Moreover it's a good thing that I didn't drink the tea. Because if I did, I would have definitely choked the moment I heard him say it. It must be because it was so unusual for a villain like him to praise anyone.

Was he even really complimenting me? Or he's just being sarcastic?

"Honestly, I commend the concept of treating him as a dog."

"Ahem."

Ugh!

As I coughed, I eventually caught his stare look from the blue lens which coolly reflected the light. He looks breathtaking. If only he's not a vicious, cold hearted, stern being.

However, he's using the wrong words right now!

"Is everything part of what your brother talked about? Did he ask you to do it?"

...and why is my brother's name being brought up right now?

I'm confused.

Despite his incomprehensible query, I tried to remain calm and pretend that I wasn't flabbergasted. My actions toward Ricdorian do not involve anyone. It was my heartfelt commitment to help him.

"...he didn't tell me anything. My..brother... doesn't know." I said cautiously as I don't want him to be suspicious of me.

My life inside this prison was something my brother was unaware of. If I try to remember, the two of us haven't had a proper conversation ever since I woke up. I had only written 'I am doing well' on the prior letter. Nothing more, nothing less.

I don't even know who my brother is in the first place!

To boot, the letters that I had sent were most likely requests of goods for my bribery purposes....but right now, I just had the most dubious idea ever.

There's no way he would think I'm using all those for myself, right? Or did he? Really?! I wasn't able to think of that possibility beforehand!

I closed my eyes and shrugged my thoughts off. I became serious as I tried to quantify the amount of cigarettes and alcohol I had requested so far... what if he thinks that I have too much alcohol addiction? And what if I cannot be released because of that?

I tried to imagine myself persuading my faceless brother and father that I wasn't an addict, but I am having a hard time visualizing it. I don't even know what they looked like and what they are capable of. I just hope they won't disown me.

Surely, I was careless and I am aware of that. I didn't care what kind of person I was, what kind of family I had, and who they are.

But one thing's clear, I am gonna be out of here someday and I have to face them. Maybe I have to postpone my requests, then. You need to be careful Iana. I said to lift up my spirit.

With that in mind, I looked up and met Lenag's gaze....why is he staring at me again in a ferocious manner? I would liquefy if he won't take his eyes away from me anytime soon.

It seems that it became a hobby for Lenag to stare at me, especially when I was lost in my thoughts.

I could feel his gaze all this time.

“Are you saying that it was Miss Iana's will? Everything that has happened so far was solely your choice?”

“Yeah?” I said in an unsure manner, trying not to upset him.

At this moment, Lenag was emitting too much coldness, enough to freeze me. So I unmistakably decided to shut my mouth and gaze at him similar to that of a trembling prisoner. As the saying goes, ‘no prisoner is right in front of a guard’. It seemed as if he didn't take much of a liking with my answer to his question.

Soon, I flinched as he spoke.

“Ah...Oh. By the way.”

I knew that I haven't sinned, but seeing Lenag stare at me like that, made me a scaredy-cat.

In a moment, Lenag nodded, as if he had just processed my answer earlier.

“Okay, then that means you're dogmatic... Anyway, the prisoner's walk will continue as scheduled.”

“What? Why?”

I knew I just uttered a word or two but that didn't stop me from opening my eyes widely.

Is he serious?

No! At times like this, he was supposed to ask me questions like *'how were you able to use the restraints?'*, *'why are you treating people like dogs?'*, *'who do you think you are?'* although, he already knows information about my true identity.

Anyway, isn't it normal to be surprised by the suddenness of things? But it was me who was unable to hide my obfuscation.

However, Lenag answered with a stoic expression.

“Because that is what you want.”

His answer made me more puzzled. And as soon as he realized what he just said, he further added a clarification.

“I made a promise to your father and brother to listen to whatever you want.”

“... You said the same thing the last time. But do you really want to do this?”

Then I remembered, how much did my father and brother really pay him? Did they give all of their money to him? Or was he in debt of gratitude to them for him to obey them to this extent?

“Yes. That's what I was supposed to do.”

But Lenag was too tight-lipped as he replied.

Why? Why? Why is he too reticent? Why can't I know more?

I can't read him like an open book. He's too mystical.

I lifted the teacup that turned warmer with a slightly sullen face.

“... To be honest, I was surprised that you treated him like a dog.”

It would be strange to see a person treat another like a dog. However, I noticed the subtle nuances. Lenag, who said, *‘Treated like a dog’*, seemed to be having fun as of the moment. As if making a fool out of Ricdorian gives him entertainment .

Do you think this is funny?

But, come to think of it, why would my brother ask me to do such a thing? And why would Lenag think that it was my brother’s request to treat Ricdorian like that?

Soon, with my rising conjecture of Iana’s family, I narrowed my eyes and opened my mouth to question Lenag.

Chapter 27: The Sudden Realization (2)

Chapter 27 – The Sudden Realization (2)

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“It’s not a good place to live with my family.”

I just threw it just in case he would provide me more details about them.

“That’s true. I didn’t know you were paying much attention to the dispute of the two families right now.”

It took a long time for me to grasp what he just said. My eyes widened in an instant with my sudden realization! I quickly covered my mouth with the teacup, swallowing a lump, desperately concealing my confounded expression, and pretended to drink tea.

My eyes rolled towards Lenag and saw him grin back at me.

Now, why do you keep displaying such an expression? What are you trying to relay?

Oh my gosh! I think I am going through an atrial fibrillation at this instant!

I did another sip of the tea that had already cooled down, thinking that my assumptions were absolutely right. As I heard from Baron, the current aristocratic empire was roughly divided into two, if not exactly.

It’s the Archduke of Hel, Harnim, alongside Ricdorian and the Black Roses villains Domulit.

In addition, I am now au courant.... Oh, My Gosh! I am so dumb! Why didn't I notice this earlier?!

I connected the dots and came up with a conclusion that....

Iana's family must be an accomplice of the villains in this story!!! In addition, Lenag knows my brother and father so, my guess must be true!

My brother that I intuit as a good person, must be working under the ghastly villain and the sworn enemy of Ricdorian!

This is so messed up! What have I gotten myself into?!

"Iana, I hope you enjoy yourself here but please keep in mind that your safety is the most important thing here."

He keeps smiling evilly that I felt I was being stabbed to death.

Finally, when I realized the meaning of his gruesome smile, I nodded, tightly gripping the handle of the teacup.

Every time those cold eyes behind the glasses looked down, I rolled my eyes. Soon after, I laid down the teacup and wiped my palms with my trousers.

"Yes..."

Is that a smile that's gonna wipe all of your teeth? No! But Iana, let's stop being nervous right now. Rather, I need to think of a solution with all of these sudden revelations!

"I wish I could spend more time with you, but today is not just the right time."

"Did my brother ask you to do that, too?" I asked Lenag, who pretended to be nonchalant. His golden eyes rolled slightly towards me. The sharpness of the gaze made me gawk.

“Well, maybe, but right now I have other important things to do...” Lenag said.

“...just talking to two people.” He added.

This room is the same as the other cells inside the prison, but something feels weird. It was when he tilted my head, that I thought he was a polite man.

“...Just two. So, are you thinking of...?”

“...What? Yes.”

Then who else is in this room? I tilted my head in query.

Then Lenag, who was silent for a while, soon caught me staring at him in question. And as I looked at him, he swept my face away without any trace of expression. So I decided to turn my gaze.

Why did he do that? Did I do something wrong?

“...We should better stop talking now.”

Right now?

I was flabbergasted by the sudden deportation, but it wasn't a bad thing, so I got up with his guidance and led me to the door with a cool expression.

“I will have the guard guide you.”

“Ohhh...Okay.”

He squeezed the doorknob firmly.

Why is he holding it so hard? It could break with the way he grips it. His blood vessels are visible right now. I can clearly see it.

The door opened and at that moment, the wind blew. I have closely seen his expression for a moment. Why, under those eyeglasses, his cheeks slightly

manifest redness?

“... see you again.”

However, I was blinded by the door that was quickly closed, so I thought that maybe I was just deceived by my eyes. There's no way he would blush!

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<In the future, you can do whatever you want here.>

As I left Lenag's office, I frowned, it was because I felt an excruciating pain in my heart. I was having a complex state of mind right now!

Wow! I can't believe this! I just found out that I'm a villain's subordinate and it didn't make me a bit happy! Everything made sense now. And it was strange to realize that Lenag, a ruthless character, used me.

I got it. I've joined hands with my brother and Chaser, at this time. Both of them. Lenag and Chaser. It feels like I'm no different from them with the way I treated Ricdorian.

Both are the notable villains in this book! Chaser, the main villain, and Lenag, who assists him, a villain that has an unknown brutal side.

If Chaser and Lenag were at it right now, then this cell is like Chaser's. Then Lenag would not be pleased with Harnim's son, Ricdorian, who was the sworn enemy of Chaser. Considering how he enjoyed the notion of treating Ricdorian like a dog, my bad intuition must be right.

One might have wondered why Ricdorian ended up in this prison, which is like Chaser's chattel, and that is because the Archduke of Hel didn't know the partnership between the two and left his son in the custody of Kambrakam.

Of course, since it is Lenag, he would unequivocally hide his cooperative relationship with Chaser, and insist on neutrality as what was being set forth

in the novel. Not to mention, there was no better place that could stop him from paroxysm except for Kambrakam.

“Wow. Holy crap.”

Anyway, if he has already fallen into Chaser’s hands, the situation will never be propitious for Ricdorian. But what matters most right now is the fact that my brother and father are a family that Lenag always listens to, and in addition to that I am one of the villain Chaser’s subordinates.

It’s frightful! But it was better though. I am not a person who is directly connected to them. The goal of getting out and living in faraway lands still hasn’t left my mind. I still have a chance.

In fact, Lenag opened the door just after I took a step and grabbed me immediately.

<I needed to go somewhere again for a while and if anything happens please speak to me through the guard and I will definitely come back.>

He’s going to be away again after meeting me. And if something happens to me, he will come back right away. But, I think no disasters will occur here. Still, I was so glad to hear it because we will have a lesser chance of contact as I don’t look forward to meeting him.

“If only I’d be released from prison sooner.”

Reminiscing of the rustic breeze, I took a walk to the basement where Ricdorian was situated.

“It’s raining.”

Drops of water rolling from the window were seen as I stared at it, which was just right in front of me as I walked down the basement. I couldn’t hear his murmur because he muttered so little as if he was just talking to himself.

Soon, I raised my voice for him to hear it.

“Hey, it’s hard to walk around today because of the rain. That’s it.”

“Yeah? Yes. right.”

Before going, I asked the warden who guided me about Ricdorian taking his walk, but as expected, he said that walking under this rain would be too difficult.

“Would you like to go to the living room?”

“Well, no.”

I shook my head. I didn't go to the living room, because I thought of seeing Ricdorian for a while. Shortly, I checked my pocket. Which were always thick as it was always full of whimsical emergency snacks, and each time they moved, they made a crackling sound.

He said he likes sweets but I wonder if he would like the ones that we brought. The pocket of the guard was also filled with snacks for Ricdorian.

“You look very pleased.”

“Ah yes? Ah...Do I?.”

As I went down the stairs along with the warden, I laughed at Ricdorian's shy face as I recalled it. He has a funny and unnatural taste. However, after a while, I arrived in the underground cell and stopped walking without being able to enter the cellar.

“Mister Hans?”

The atmosphere was strange, but it's not that something has changed.

“Oh...we're here, Iana.”

Chapter 28: Unwanted Visitor (1)

Chapter 28 – Unwanted Visitor (1)

Translator: SKAIS **Editor:** SKAIS

Seeing the door of Ricdorian's cell half-open, Han's expression promptly turned red while trembling. Even the lamps on the walls emitted redder light today. I simultaneously stared at Hans and at the cell, then looked down. I wonder why he looked so distressed.

Before long, I finally lifted my head from a puddle on the floor, as what I deemed it to be.

"...why is the door open?" I asked, confused.

Hans awkwardly smiled at me in return. His expression right now was so unnatural– as if he was hiding something. It's eerie!

"Today, there was a visitor who came in first."

"Oh.. Really?"

Instead of looking back at Hans, I stared at the iron window and nodded at his response. That must be the basis for his behavior right now.

"Well, Iana. I think it would be better to just go back today... "

"No, it's okay. I don't mind. Can I go inside?"

Apart from noticing the odd expression Hans displayed today, I also noticed an unusual feeling in this place. Whenever I visit Ricdorian, the door of his

cell would always be closed. Moreover, through the slightly opened door, I smelled something familiar but was difficult to illustrate.

“No matter what I see inside, I will keep it a secret. I’ve been doing that, haven’t I? Don’t worry. I am too tight-lipped.” I said, persuading Hans, who hesitated for a while but later on sighed in defeat, and gave me permission.

He might have construed my stubborn expression. For sure, he was afraid that our good-fellowship may be destroyed and that he would no longer receive any first-rate goods from me.

Inside the prison, it is natural to meet guards who are friendly, calculative and selfish. However, with great responsibility, the prisoner in charge cannot evade retributions once he causes trouble. No matter how peaceful they may seem on the outside. And therefore, I understood their selfish rationality.

I decided to hand over the cigarettes as I always did and teased him. These things surely are handful.

“Sigh”

I went inside the cage, feeling nauseous, and then stopped for a while to fix the lamp. The short distance felt so long. But I tried to stay calm, shaking my head. A little while ago, in front of the rusty cage were the puddles on the floor which I thought were because of the rain, soon turned out to be blood.

Holy cow! It’s blood!

I had read this part in the novel. It’s just that...

“... I didn’t expect to see it myself.”

I don’t know why the narrative part that was written in the novel came into my mind clearly—as if it was just passing through. Was it because of the blood?

Ricdorian's father, Archduke Harnim, thought of him as not of his own flesh and blood. He was even considered a disgrace to the 'prestigious' Hel lineage. Reason why he did not hesitate to violently maltreat him and leave trails on his body...and even threw him in this cell! He even proudly told Chaser that he had abused his son before his own death.

My blood suddenly boiled thinking about his immoral acts.

What I couldn't understand was the reality that Ricdorian was still saddened by the death of his murdered father and loathed Chaser for slaughtering him. Perhaps avenging him is the only thing he could do for him in order to express his affinity, as he had no one to give his affection to. It might also be that the lonely beast just turned his hatred towards the villain. Or maybe it's like Stockholm syndrome. I don't actually know.

After all, human emotions are complicated.

Sigh.

Soon, I lifted up the lamp in front of the wall. Under the swaying flame, I saw a boy, ragged and savaged, bloodied and scrabbling. What happened to him?

"Ricdorian." I uttered, capturing his attention.

He trembled as he slowly raised his head, then opened his mouth.

"Arfff!"

From the stained, wounded body, only the azure eyes looked clean.

And at this moment, he tried to get up, his arms' staggering, thinking we were going out for a walk. I felt sorry for speaking a little too late.

"Don't get up."

"Arff?"

When I squatted down, I touched his wounded cheek.

“... It’s the first time I became happy not to be able to talk to people.”

“Grrrr! Arff, Arrff!”

Ricdorian slightly frowned, but soon he barked. I gazed at him with an ambiguous expression that was neither laughing nor gloomy.

“...I’ve been out for a walk to see you. But, what am I supposed to do?”

My finger rubbed his soft knife-like silver hair. However, unlike the other days, the tip of my finger caught something as I caressed his head. When I pulled out my finger, there was blood.

“Arff. Arff?”

Afterwards, I wiped the blood on his chin with my clean thumb.

“We will not walk outside today. Do you understand?”

“Wuff?”

He sounded dismayed as if he was really looking forward to our walk and it felt a little strange as his voice contrasted with his bloody appearance.

“We can’t have a walk outside today with the way you are right now. I’m sorry.”

I ran my hand across his cheeks under his unscathed eyes and I saw him closed his eyes as if he were enjoying it. Surprisingly, when he was a beast, he liked the essence of touch—as if he was hungry for love. My heart felt a pang of pain looking at him.

Funny enough, the two of us just met for over a month and got on a walk a few times. That’s not too many times as much as a finger. However, I understood how he must’ve felt when I looked through the dark prison blockages everywhere. This place is lifeless and forlorn like a hell place where no love and kindness is apparent.

What kind of sane person would've felt happy living half of their life here. I chuckled sarcastically.

“Arff?”

“If I leave it like this, it will hurt, right? Do you feel pain anywhere?”

He needs treatment at this instant. So I tried to stand up.

Ugh! Oh, come on!

Chapter 29: Unwanted Visitor (2)

Chapter 29 – Unwanted Visitor (2)

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

As I gazed down slightly, I saw Ricdorian grab me, with eyes befuddled. For a beast, he looked confused. It was like he didn't want me out of his sight.

“I'm not going anywhere. Just wait a minute.”

He was like a dog that instinctively felt his owner disappearing or leaving him, and even so, he shook his head and cried.

“Arrrrfffff.....Arffff.”

“Huh? Good boy. Wait here.”

Speaking firmly, he may not be wearing the redemption necklace right now, but I felt his power slowly dropping. I took off the remaining fingers grabbing me and when I was about to pull out the last finger, I abruptly stopped.

It was because all of a sudden his hand held me. But it was a very cautious touch. Just enough to hold on to the fingertips. I stared at him and saw a very red face in the midst of that bloody appearance.

“Where...go...?”

The watery eyes stared at me, with tears at the corner of it that seemed to be proof that he was going through a painful state.

“...don’t go...”

I looked at my hands with a disoriented face. I don’t know what to do with this crybaby despite sensing why he is weeping right now. Ugh! I can’t handle him.

It’s unfair! I can’t stand that look on his face. I might give in.

I wasn’t even trying to run away from him. So I just firmly closed my eyes then exhaled deeply, and said..

“I’ll be back.”

“Rea...lly..?”

I always knew that promises are meant to be broken, but there’s nothing else I can do at this moment. I needed to treat his wounds and I cannot do that without any first aid kit.

“You know pinky swear? I promise. Hang your fingers.”

I placed my hand on his little finger. Maybe it’s a move that he is ignorant about, but he simply stared at me and let me do it.

Shortly, I felt like someone was coming so I stepped back and turned my back. And the boy, who fell behind his back, wiggled, but there was something else that was more urgent.

Rattling.

I opened the cage and entered to see Hans, who stared at me with a slightly surprised look with his mouth opened.

“Mister, do you have any medicine in here...” I asked him about some treatment but I was immediately stopped.

“No. No.”

No matter how kind a guard is. A guard will always be a guard. I bit my lips at his response. Then I put down the lamp and ran swiftly on the stairs.

“Iana? You’re leaving already?”

“Yes, but I’ll come back in an instant!”

Ricdorian’s wound was too severe. Will it heal quickly? Only I knew that the wound would one day be better, and that he must meet the heroine in that kind of condition. But I don’t like seeing him wounded and bloody. I don’t like him being in pain.

Where should I go? Where should I ask for help? Lenag? No. Definitely not! He may have already been out on personal business. I don’t know if he would come back once I asked him for help about Ricdorian.

“Haaaaa! haaaaa!” I was gasping for air when I arrived in my room and searched everywhere but there was nothing worth using for treating Ricdorian’s wounds. Of course, since I had never asked for medicinal goods before.

As I quickly browsed through my desk, I remembered the blank letter my brother would always send to me.

Yes, the letter!

Then, I quickly lifted the pen.

[Send me a medicine. The best one for treating wounds!]

It was the best thing I could do right now. For there was no medicine nor bandages available in my room. Only basic necessities are given to us.

“I don’t want to use dog poop as medicine.”

Long ago, bandages were forbidden inside the prison because it was used as an escape means and for self-harm. Of course, there were patients here, and there was a medical room for those patients. However, even if I go into the infirmary, it is prohibited to take herbs or medicines outside the vicinity.

There was once a man who tried to purloin sleeping pills from the infirmary and he was placed in the most eerie cell ever!

Soon, I knocked on a door and called the warden who was guarding the room.

“Hey, the letter. Can I send it today? It’s urgent.”

“You can. Today is the day we send out the bulk mails.”

All right! Good timing! It was really helpful to get along with the guards.

Everyday, I would frequently ask the warden about packages for me and today, he happily approached me.

The letter was delivered immediately that night and surprisingly, just two days later, a package arrived.

“Wow, my God.” I opened my mouth wide at what I saw.

Bunch of medicines in crystal bottles were delivered that seemed very expensive, even though I didn’t know these various medicines and medicines. Of course, this was an item that should be obtained from the Prison Head but due to his absence, the warden manager was the one who delivered it to me.

He seemed to have a suspicious look, but he didn’t further ask me. I just made up words and told the general manager, that Lenag, told me to look after myself well. Moreover, I had no time for him so I hastily turned my back and walked outside, pretending to be calm.

“I’m in a hurry.”

I quickly ran to Ricdorian’s cell. Since two days have already passed, my mind was extremely upset. I can’t help but feel restless these past few days.

Hans let me in casually, bringing with me a beautiful pouch with medicines inside...there was no sign of surprise or embarrassment seen on him as the two of us became acquainted with each other. Although Hans knew what

Ricdorian is like, he was still not in a state of agitation or worry. It's not his job though, to be obligated with a prisoner's state.

As I entered the room, I was flabbergasted, because I saw something from Ricdorian that I was not supposed to catch sight of considering that I am just a side character of this novel.

That means this has happened all the time.

I just knew what kind of past the protagonist had as I read the book, but it was different being able to see it right in front of your eyes.

I'm sure I came here in a hurry knowing that he'll get better someday....but..

"...who, who?"

When I lifted the lamp, I could see the figure of a flinching little boy.

"It's me."

Chapter 30: You are pretty

Chapter 30 – You are pretty

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

The shivering boy who looked up to me, stopped and then stepped back. I don't know if it's because he's terrified or embarrassed.

I couldn't read his expression right now.

His movements were like a flapping bird... this made me bite my lip tightly. Something was strange. Even his actions right now were also weird which made it hard for me to recognize who he was at first.

It didn't take me too long until I figured out why because the moment I got closer to him, I saw his appearance....there were wounds in his eyes!

It was exactly on top of his eyelid. It is a kind wound that I haven't personally seen before.

The appearance of his new bruises were vividly seen in the dim-lighted room. It was like he was beaten till he crippled.

That looked terrible!

The blood that flowed from his cut hardened, which prevented him from opening his eyes...well, he might be able to open them but it seems painful for him.

Soon, I squatted in front of him, and opened the pocket of medicines I brought. I used the water that I had brought to wet the handkerchief and wiped his face slowly with it.

“...oh...” He grunted.

As I wiped away the blood, his eyes that were half-opened trembled...And as I stared at it, I could see his sapphire eyes gazing at me. But as soon as he saw me, he shook his head.

“Now, stay still, for a moment.”

“Even if it’s uncomfortable, just please bear with it for the meantime.”

I followed him as much as he stepped back. The sound of the chain clashing was so loud that it echoed inside the basement.

Eventually, when his back hit the wall, he stared at me with a puzzled look because there was nowhere he could run.

“Huhu.hu...hu.. ”

His face, which was covered with wounds, and his teary eyes, seemed to be filled with sadness.

In many ways, the sight of him is not good for me. My heart, specifically.

I couldn’t take it. Every time I look at him, my heart feels like it was clenched in pain.

I knelt down in front of him and kept him in place to prevent him from running away. Slowly, I wiped his face. I was lucky that his rational side is awake today. It would have been a bit difficult if it was the beastly Ricdorian whom I had to deal with.

I would prefer wiping a Ricdorian whose neck up to the face was as red as a tomato than a growling Ricdorian. Much convenient, I guess.

But my thoughts were suddenly interrupted when I heard him groan.

Did I touch a wound?

Ricdorian’s neck crouched.

I think it would be better to wipe his face instead. I needed to be careful not to hurt him more.

When I thought that his face was clean enough, I laid down the handkerchief and lifted the pocket once again. And when I raised my head, I realized I was too close to him. The boy's trembling eyes were right in front of me. My blinking eyes are close enough to his enchanting deep blue oceanic sight and it is drowning me.

Realizing that, I immediately shifted my gaze but then, after a while, I settled my eyes on him again.

“Ah...”

He seemed to stay in place not just because there was no place to run but also because of the chain.

I didn't mean to see him this close, but... he definitely has an indisputable appearance, the reason why I couldn't take my eyes off him.

It'd be awesome if I grew up here. I would be able to witness more of the evolution of this stunning work of art in front of me.

His blue eyes, which glowed under the light emitted by the lamp, glowed more in this dark room.

His slender neck like a deer, and his white skin that flinches and turns like a red rose whenever I touch him are all captivating. It's still too pure for this male lead with a decadent beauty to star in a rated 19 novel.

“Don't tremble. I am not going to eat you.”

“Food...food..food?”

“No, I am not eating. This is not for me. I am preparing this for you.”

“I'm going to apply the medicine later. Tell me if it hurts. Okay?”

“Yes? Yes?”

“But still, I will keep applying it.”

“I am the one who...”

“With that hand? Then what about the chains?”

Ricdorian: “...”

A few moments later, Ricdorian shook his head, wrapping himself with his arms... the wounds would hurt too much if he kept on doing that position, I thought out of concern.

I gently lifted his bangs so that his hair wouldn't touch his forehead.

“Oh my God. You look better than me.” I said in disbelief.

After my unannounced defeat, I blinked and smiled. My face is incomparable to his. It looks more natural than mine. I didn't feel any jealousy though.

He's a beast with a beauty of another level after all.

“Why, why, why, why are you laughing?”

“You're prettier than I am.”

“That..... Not! You are!”

“What?”

I opened my eyes, screaming those words. He then tilted his head.

“What? Am I pretty?” I asked again, to make sure if I heard it right.

“... That, that's it.”

Ricdorian lowered his head quickly, feeling shy. Oh, I thought I misheard it. I chuckled. How cute.

This made it hard for me to do a treatment in one go. But soon, he slightly lifted his chin with both hands.

“I see. You don’t have to tell me that. I know you were just kidding. Just stay still. And don’t forget to take care of yourself always. You need more treatment. I know your body aches.”

I took out all the medicines with one hand and lined them up one by one. I wanted to pour it all out, but I was careful because most of the medicines are inside crystal glass.

Kind enough, my older brother sent me not only the medicine but the instructions about the medicine as well.

“Um, so you have a scratched wound...this one is for burns..No! Why did they send me burn medicine?”

He said in the letter that it was a manual, but I was so impressed that it was all written by him. I admire my brother’s sincerity. I guess he’s not that bad after all.

Just seeing them send me what I wanted, I could feel their affection and care.

But no! I shook my head. I needed to remember the facts! I shouldn’t be swayed easily by their sympathetic acts. In the first place, I wouldn’t be in jail right now if it wasn’t for them. I saved them for goodness sake. Of course they have to return the favor!

When I was classifying drugs for a long time, I realized...that I asked them to send me a wound medicine without specifically writing its purpose. This is why I received so many medicines. It’s a good thing to have this much medicine though, in case of emergencies. But! This is too many that I couldn’t find the right one to use in treating Ricdorian’s wounds.

I scratched the back of my neck....Hmm... this is urgent.

Chapter 31: Open your mouth

Chapter 31 – Open your mouth

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I picked up a medicine and opened its lid. I get it as it looks the most helpful to Ricdorian's state. There was a bitter smell of medicinal herbs as soon as it was opened.

“Well, it's not the smell I least expected. You can no longer endure the pain, right? Good medicine is the best for the body. It will hurt for a while but then your wounds will heal faster.”

Ricdorian: “...”

Now he accepted my hand without making a sound and without flinching. To boot, he also patiently closed his moist eyes.

This made me wonder.

Do you feel so ashamed?

Or not...Do you hate it that much?

“Huh, hey, a little slower...slower”

“...why do you talk like that?” You're giving me the wrong idea, mister.

I thought my cold hands might be a little irritating to his skin as it was extremely hot right now.

It's comforting for me though as it gives warmth to my cold hands.

“What do you mean?”

I shook my head and moved my hands slower than before.

I applied the medicine starting from his face, went down and stopped at the neck and collarbone. My hand that enters the recesses of the inside of the collarbone move slowly, from side to side. At this point, I can't help but to become aware.

If I apply the medicine quickly, I would have easily done treating him. But.. It's getting slow. I must be crazy right now. This also contributed to the increased redness and warmth of his skin.

As of the moment, only the sound of our breaths were heard. The silence filling the empty room made me a little uncomfortable, but that was it. I took out another finger of medicine and put it on him. I badly wanted to finish this. It's getting hot in here.

Hooh!

Soon, I applied the medicine all the way under the thighs....between his wrists and ankles....and torn clothes. I lifted up his hand that I was holding onto, and then blew on it.

“Huh.”

Flutters.

“Why are you shaking?”

“wi...wi... Wind!”

“Why, it's just your hand. I blow it up to dry. I have to do this especially in that area because of the handcuffs.”

Once again, I blew on his hand.

“...oh..oh..ah, just one time is enough... I think you did enough.”

“Can’t you stop moaning?”

Why do you test a good woman? I’m getting the wrong ideas here!

His forehead furrowed and then gazed at me with wide eyes.

Oh my gosh! I swallowed my saliva because I saw his jade-like tears rolling in his cheeks....He’s crying again!

But no. I’d rather not look.

“That’s it. Next...Is the painkiller. That’s right. It’s a painkiller.”

The round medicine rolled in the glass bottle like a ring. I laid my eyes on Ricdorian, staring at me in wonder.

“I’m supposed to eat this first, to test how much longer it lasts but I forgot to do it because I was in a hurry to treat you.” He didn’t understand.

I’m sure he needs painkillers. In fact, I visited Ricdorian yesterday but I couldn’t get inside the cell. The items that I asked did not arrive yet. I was worried about him all this time.

Since I couldn’t get in, I just stood outside then I heard him groaning. His loud groan echoed inside the cell.

<Ughhh...Ahhhhh....Ahhhh...Ughhhh..>

It was clear that he was groaning because of how painful it is. He was suffering a great deal of excruciating pain from his wounds and bruises. I couldn’t go inside the cell because I know I wouldn’t be able to watch him without feeling pity.

And also I hated the fact that despite seeing Ricdorian all beaten up, Hans remained calm, showing no concern for the prisoner. So as soon as the medicine arrived, I immediately came here. I want to ease his pain. I want to cease his suffering.

“Shall we take the medicine now?”

This beaten boy inside the dark cell is nothing compared to what he will be four years from now.

“Medicine?”

“Yes, that’s what people take when they are sick. I just want to make you feel better.”

My guilty mind always comes in times like this....I’ll be out soon....that’s what I always thought...Ironically speaking, I can help him because the four years of waiting is quite long.

It’s sad.

Just please hold onto this until you’re saved one day, Ricdorian.

I know I’m selfish for thinking this way, so I hope Ricdorian will forget all of this and live happily with Francia. I just want and wish him happiness. After all, he had suffered enough already.

“This type of medicine needs to be swallowed.”

I said, slightly sweeping his bangs that covered his eyes.

“Can you eat it? I brought it here, and I would be sad if my sincerity is ignored.”

“I’ll eat, I’ll eat.”

“Yes, that’s good.”

He took the pills, his face was still as red as a red rose. He then lifted them up in front of him, but he tilted his head and did nothing after a moment.

“Was something wrong?”

His eyes narrowed as he looked at me, slowly removing the medicine from in front.

“Uh, how do I eat this?”

“Oh, you never tried it before?” He nodded in response.

It was surprising in many ways, but soon I remembered that medicine is usually taken with water. The infirmary had that type of medicine too. The doctor said that it would be hard to swallow a pill without the aid of water.

“You can take it like this. Drink the water, put the medicine inside and then swallow.”

However, despite my explanation, he was still unable to swallow the medicine. He was like a little kid who cannot take any medications.

Soon, I stared at him with a stern face. I was wondering if I could grind the medicine, but there were no mortar and pestle or any grinding tool in here. The handcuffs could be used but they are too unsanitary.

Uhhmm, how about this?

“Would you like to give it to me?”

Once I got the pill back from him, I blew the dusts out.

“I’m gonna feed you. Don’t say anything else, I will do this because you cannot swallow the medicine.”

“Eh, Eh? Ugh, yes.”

He hesitated for a while, rolled his eyes, and then nodded lightly.

Oh my, his reddish face looks strange today. It felt a little weird that he was so obedient this time. I tilted my head and I slightly grabbed his chin.

“Open your mouth.”

His red lips were partly opened.

Open it more.

Just like what I had commanded in my mind, Ricdorian opened his mouth wider. By that time, I put it inside... using my fingers.

“Uhhh, You can’t chew my finger. Okay?”

“ugh..ugh..”

Chapter 32: When are you going to let go (1)

Chapter 32 – When are you going to let go (1)

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“Yes, I’ll push it back on your throat. Don’t spit it out. Swallow it. Okay?”

I pressed his tongue so that he wouldn’t vomit, and his eyes which automatically watered turned to me. I flinched for a moment at the sight of his moist, wet eyes, but then focused again on his tongue, pretending to be calm.

Cluck.

His soft tongue intertwined with my fingers.

It’s better to use my hand in feeding since I can easily push it in his throat.

He stared at me, while my fingers are still inside his mouth, forgetting to take them out at this moment. But after a moment, his stare turned tenacious. Maybe because it’s painful for him to swallow the medicine.

The touch of his tongue was so soft as it wrapped around my fingers. I could feel the wetness of it.

In an instant, I’m starting to think about various lewd ideas. And it’s definitely not good. Holy crap! My innocence!

I wanted to get my hand out, but I wasn’t able to move because his hand was clutching it.

Was he stopping me from going further or he just didn't want my hand out of his mouth? I'm confused.

But No! When are you going to let go of my hand? When it turns red from the tightness of your hold?

Unable to endure the moment of silence, he decided to open his mouth.

"Grrrrr." He suddenly growled at me.

"Huh?" Did his beast side recur?

He tilted his head away.

"Oh, come on." I said impatiently. But he's still growling at me.

"How long are you going to keep it?" I said, referring to my slender fist in captive.

The surprised Ricdorian, who just came back into his senses, let go of my hand immediately.

Oh... Was what he did right now an act that he didn't even realize? So he's still the sane Ricdorian? Good grief.

I wiped my fingers using my other handkerchief and offered the water to Ricodrian. And while he was drinking water, I quickly washed my hands with water from the other bottle and stuffed the medicine container in my pocket.

My gut feeling told me that I shouldn't be here anymore. It was an odd feeling but then I just shrugged it off.

But since I already achieved my main objective for coming here, I decided to leave.

"I'll be going now. Your wounds will no longer hurt tonight. And, I did keep my promise, right?"

I kept my promise to come back. At the same time, I felt it would be better not to make an appointment with him again.

If I keep looking at those strange guilty eyes, I'll declare I'll do anything for him. Like a dedicated soldier ready to sacrifice his own life for his country. The only thing is that he's the country I'm willing to die for....I'm beginning to be like that. And it seems like that thought of mine would declare war on this already messed up plot.

Thinking about that, all I can do is sigh.

“Wait...”

I was surprised.

This is the first time he stopped me this way instead of grabbing my clothes. But soon, I decided to turn my back and ignore him.

Today doesn't seem to be a good day, mister.

[illegible]

As I entered my cell, I sighed deeply. I was so exhausted! Phew. What happened a while ago was so dangerous.

Ricdorian's appearance stimulates a person's heart. He would constantly make me go beyond my boundaries. If he looks like that when he's still a young person, what more when he grows up? Ugh, his features would definitely be way more than a celestial being.

I think it's a pleasure to meet him before he grows up.

If I didn't have self-control earlier, I would have slapped him in the face. And I'm sure he'd be flustered.

My wrist hurt because of what he did!

But there was something in him that I couldn't talk and stop thinking about.

I swept my face down and messed up my hair.

“...what am I even thinking?”

This is all because of the genre of this novel! I shook my head and looked down.

“Oh.” I said as I found a piece of paper on the floor.

After lifting it, I soon realized that this was the letter that came with medicine. A letter from my brother.

Did I drop it in a hurry? Must be.

When I opened it, I immediately recognized his neat handwriting.

[My lovely sister. ...Are you sick?]

Yes. Still neat and elegant. Well, I also have a neat handwriting but because I requested the medicine in a hurry, I wasn't just able to write beautifully. I pouted, then continued reading the succeeding messages.

[I always worry about you and there's no time I didn't think about you. I miss you.]

My gaze soon stayed on the last passage.

[Shall I go there and visit you?]

My eyes widened, I read the last sentence once again to make sure I'm not hallucinating.

He's coming here?

I tilted my head.

Well, it's not strange. We're family, so it's normal for my brother to come and see me. Especially that this is where Lenag reigns.

Additionally, my family visiting me here seems to be okay. Sure enough, no problems might be encountered. And for sure Lenag wouldn't think twice if they ask him to visit Iana.

Most families of noble prisoners do not visit them because of the tight security and also the fact that aristocrats don't like the prison head, Lenag of the Marquess.

The success of this huge prison is all because of him. His harsh, cold means and lack of humanity in leading this prison had brought it to its triumph. As what I had heard from the prisoners.

It is said that the Lenag came from a place where he dominates. He is fond of controlling things so it is expected for him to go to a place where he is in authority. And this prison is the perfect place for that.

Of course, it's sudden for my brother to say that he would visit me. But it wasn't really a bad thing for him to do.

I am not that excited to meet him but my face right now is a bit pale. So far, They've sent me this and that. And, I just couldn't face them right now when the issue about those alcoholic drinks and cigarettes I've asked for is still fresh.

Although I don't know what this brother thinks about Iana. But still.

“What was really their relationship? Are they close?”

I've heard that I've been taken in place of my brother and father's sins, and those who have been taken here in place of a family member have been at odds with the family that put them in here.

<If I get out of here. I'm gonna turn my brother into a dead man! I'm going to make it his worst nightmare!>

Remembering what Sally just said, I wonder if my brother and I have the same relationship as what Sally and her brother have. I looked at her in the next room, who was chewing food. I shook my head and remembered

another prisoner who has a similar situation but instead of getting mad he just accepted his undesirable but inevitable situation.

This is what prisoners in Kambrakam feel: it's either anguish or resignation.

Chapter 33: When are you going to let go (2)

Chapter 33 – When are you going to let go (2)

Translator: : SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

But the good news is, I didn't think much about those because I wasn't the true Iana in the first place.

“Hmm. Are you being nice to me because you're sorry?”

So my older brother who sends me a lot of things feels sorry and will do things for me. I appreciate the materials he sends and I'm using those well, but what should I think?

Anyway, as stated in the letter, he's worried about me, right? I was confused for a while but his neat handwriting distracted me from my thoughts earlier.

Since he's a family maybe I resemble some of his facial features. So in less than a minute, I turned my head slightly and looked in the mirror.

I wonder what my brother looks like?

I put my hands on my waist and proudly said..

“If you look like me then, you're a good looking guy.” I grinned.

In the mirror, I have light pink hair. A dark impression could also be perceived on my pale-colored eyes... A very mild impression...seems like this is something that I inherited from them as accomplice of the villains.

Jade hairpins suit very well with my hair. I must've inherited all these hair ornaments from my mother. Was she a warm woman?....I don't have any idea at all.

In addition, my eyelashes were so long and plentiful that I feel like I am a deer. I could see my pale purple eyes. It was a strange color with a bit of redness.

To be honest, I think the actions and behavior of the guards and fellow prisoners who are nice to me might be because I am somewhat good looking.

I laughed. I sound conceited right now.

But I look pretty, though.

That just means that my brother is of handsome features. Perhaps my brother had a similar hair color to me. Siblings, right?

“Okay, but I have never encountered a man with pink hair. That would be surreal.”

And none of the main characters in the book have the same pink hair as me. Iana reminded me of the fact that she is so far from the main characters of this novel.

Soon, I opened the desk drawer and placed the letter on top of the stacked up letters. There were already a lot of neatly arranged letters on the left side of it. Although most of these are empty stationeries.

I sneered as I looked at the letters piled up and closed the drawer. Then I lay on my bed and closed my eyes.

“Ahh, applying medicine was a very tiring job.”

Suddenly, my fingers got itchy. I wondered why this was happening but I was too tired to think of anything so I decided to sleep.

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A few days later, the rain that was falling hard stopped for a while, and the sunny sky showed up again.

The day was clear but taking a walk on the muddy ground was such a bother.

This country is experiencing an intermittent rainy season. And therefore, most of the noble prisoners are crowding in the living room.

“This might be the last rainy season for this year.”

As always, I nodded as I listened to Baron, who likes to explain and share various hearsays. Then I looked around inside and tilted my head.

It’s strange that the atmosphere wasn’t that exciting. It wasn’t like I was bored, it’s just that it was noisier today than the other days. I am not talking about the male prisoners but the female ones.

“Haha, really? Are you sure?”

“Yes! I told you so!”

A group of female prisoners filled the sofa area on the right side of the room, chatting in a friendly manner. Some of them even burst out laughing, which was clearly heard in the entire room.

No matter how peaceful a cell is, it will always be an enclosed area. Loud noises are easily echoed.

A desolate place, nothing more.

A while ago, there was a prisoner who cried endlessly because of the sadness he felt while being locked up.

Because of them, the serene and calmness of the living room had turned chaotic and noisy. Moreover, there were more women inside the prison who claimed the crime of their family than those who committed bad deeds.

As I looked around, I saw Sally also chatting but rather she was a type of prisoner who has a calm ingenuity.

“It’s quite a mess today.”

Moreover, Sally is having a pleasant conversation with another prisoner, who is a cafe house owner, with a slight blush in her cheeks.

I was wondering what was going on, but I decided to not bother and got up from my seat as I have other plans for today.

All I did was steal a bunch of cookies on the table into my pocket. The pastries served in the living room taste better than the ones given at mealtimes. This was the real reason why I came here today.

In fact, I said it was a secret, but the way Baron questioned me was enough to make the guards look at us.

“Where are you going?”

“An exciting adventure?” I said nervously.

I waved at Baron and left the room in a hurry.

Of course, I was headed to Ricdorian’s cell.

Screech.

As soon as I reached the cell, I opened it. Right now, I was accustomed to the rusty sound of the bars opening.

“Hello, Hans.”

As usual, I greeted Hans and handed him the cigarettes in exchange for my visit in Ricdorian’s cell. I stepped inside and the smell didn’t feel any more breathtaking. It’s still a bit annoying thinking that he was beaten up to that extent, so the next time, I’ll ask my brother to bring detailed directions about the medicines.

“Arfff?”

“Hi.” I said and Ricdorian looked up to me. His beast side is now welcoming me to his manor.

“Arff!” He barked at me with excitement.

His round eyes were filled with joy. I paused for a while and then walked towards him....hmmm, he grew up a little.

It was strange but he looked bigger than before. It’s not that much, but it’s a subtle difference.

It’s been two months since the last time I saw him, and he grew bigger in this short period of time.

“I must have been dreaming.”

I sat down in front of Ricdorian. I tickled his chin because he looked like he was waiting for me to do it, and then I stroked his hair.

“Today’s snacks are cookies. You like cookies, right?”

When I removed the wrapper, Ricdorian grabbed the cookie and devoured it as if he hadn’t eaten for a long time. But no matter how hastily he ate the cookies, some of them were spilled on the floor.

“Oh, wait a minute!”

Seeing him looking at the remnants on the floor, I hurriedly grabbed him by the head....No, wait a minute. Stop!

You can’t eat those! Those are dirty!

“No, no, no!”

Ricdorian! Let’s protect our dignity as human beings!

Chapter 34: The prince trapped in the tower

Chapter 34 – The prince trapped in the tower

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I grabbed his head, stopping him from what he was about to do.

“No, wait. Stop!”

Ricdorian blinked his eyes and then quivered the moment I held his head.

“Arfff. Grrrrrrr. Grrrrr.”

“No, you can’t eat those.” What a stubborn man!

“Arfff. Arfff.”

“Stop pretending like a cute puppy. Stay still and wait.”

Even though the floor is filthy, he’s still trying to pick up the fallen cookie crumbs. I scanned the ground and it seemed like it was never touched by a cleaner for like decades. I doubt if it was even cleaned at all...

But, this is not the right time to think about cleanliness.

“Come on, I’ll give you a new one. Eat this instead.” I said as I offered another pocket of cookies. “Why are you trying to eat something that fell on the floor, huh?”

“Arfff!”

“...do you think you can stop people from talking if you bark like that?”

Isn't it ironic that he was talking to me with dog words but I can still understand him? Maybe I'm already turning into a dog, too! No way! I shook away that horrible thought.

As I settled my sight at Ricdorian who had already eaten half of the cookie, I remembered the thing I brought aside from those treats.

“Hey, wanna see this? Ta-da! Guess what this is!”

This is what I've been trying to do with Ricdorian recently.

“It's a book, a book!” I said happily.

It was a fairy tale book with occasional paintings that I took from a small library inside the prison. I have no idea why there's a library inside but according to Baron, a noble aristocrat's hobby is reading various books. However, I haven't read about that in the novel.

Anyway, the limited recreation built for noble prisoners is a wonderful idea. I guess that's the reason why most of them are not bored spending their sentenced time in jail.

“Well, come to think of it, I know you listen and understand what I read, but it doesn't make sense that you can't talk when your other side is awake.”

“Arfff?”

“Hmmm? Not that crap. What I mean is talking using the language people use, not the way a dog talks.”

Come to think of it, I'm sure that the Ricdorian I read in the novel is still a human being whenever he turns into a beast. Moreover, it was said that he learned or was trained to talk until he met the heroine. But it doesn't seem like that when I met him. Well, obviously I'm not the heroine but if you're talking to people anyways, wouldn't it be better to understand each other?

“But it’s strange that you’re still acting like a dog.” Can I keep up with these when all he does is act like a puppy?

”No, don’t lick.”

“Arff! Arfff!”

“...wait.”

Cluck.

No. Why don’t you listen to me?

I sighed heavily and opened the book. Right, he might change if I try to teach him. After all, it wouldn’t be long until I would be released from prison anyway. I reminded myself.

“Come on, listen. No. Don’t turn around hastily. You don’t even have a tail. Stop and sit down!”

Thud.

“...Good job. Sit right here.”

I can’t understand what he was trying to express by spinning around, acting like a dog when he doesn’t even have a tail. I thought his behavior was getting better and better. I sighed. I guess not. He still has a long way to go.

“This is a star, and this is a moon. That’s it. Let’s start with something simple. Now, do the moon.”

“Arfff!”

“...now do the sun”

“Arff! Arff”

“...you don’t have the will, do you?”

I grabbed his cheek and pinched it really hard. He groaned at my grasp. After walking and being together with him for months, I've found out that he no longer shows his teeth or grits it. Of course, his eyes are still fierce, but through time, I got used to it. Furthermore, he doesn't bite me whenever I pinch him like this.

"No, that's wrong. Not a big star!"

"Arrff?"

"No, stop acting like a dog."

I've tried teaching him a few times, but he just can't get it right. Soon, I heard him growl like a mad dog, so I decided to put down the book.

But I still didn't give up so I opened a fairy tale book that has more stories than pictures. That's it, if he keeps listening, maybe he'll talk in the near future.

"...so she finally met the prince who was born with a curse."

I glanced at Ricdorian and for some reason, he just sat quietly, listening to the story.

I tilted my head and continued looking at him. That's amazing. A few minutes ago, he couldn't stay still but look at him now, he's like a very disciplined little kid listening to bedtime stories. He seemed to be very indulged with it.

Not long after, I turned my eyes back to the book and continued reading the story.

"The prince was bitten by a dragon. His wounds were worse, and his clothes were burning. The girl asked the prince if he was in pain. And the prince asked in response to her question, '*What is pain?*'"

Fairy tales are of typical content. But this story was about a prince who was locked in the tower, and the warriors came to the rescue. Usually, the

princess is locked in the tower, however this fairytale story is unique. How odd.

In fact, this story was a little different because the main character went to save the male lead as if she was his destined queen.

“*‘I don’t know what it’s like to be in pain.’* The prince’s words made the girl cry and grieve in sadness. *‘What the prince is feeling right now. Something hot and stingy. That means you’re in pain.’* This time, the girl decided to save the prince. But in order to save him, she has to defeat a bad and mighty dragon.”

Eventually, the girl defeated the dragon with nothing but wisdom as her weapon. And the moment the dragon collapsed, the girl rescued the prince lifting the curse and they lived happily ever after. That was the end of the story.

As soon as I read the last passage, I lifted my head slightly and thought of something.. It turns out Ricdorian has the same situation as that prince trapped in a tower.

Only that, he was in prison. Behind these rotten cell bars that separates him from his freedom.

Chapter 35: Who are you?

Chapter 35 – Who are you?

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“The lady who rescued the man is the heroine.”

The heroine of this novel had bright scarlet hair. And as far as I remember, Ricdorian would always compare her beauty to the color emitted by a sunset, which was very sweet and beautiful.

The relationship of the male lead and the female lead in this novel was really a match made in heaven. Well, I also read that Francia is really pretty.

Being released from the curse and living happily ever after, it's exactly the same with Ricdorian's situation.

Before I knew it, the quiet Ricdorian instantly turned his face towards me. I pushed his head away to create some distance between us but he's so big that I felt like pushing him won't sway him at all. He may look thin but his body was so firm and masculine. I knew it after touching him.

“Stop pushing. I'll fall.”

He supported himself with one arm and slightly leaned forward in accordance to his strength, trying not to fall. And then he took my hand and sniffed it. Uh oh, my hands smell like cookies right now.

Suddenly, I spoke as I carefully stroked his hair like a silver thread.

“You know, I have an older brother. He said he is coming and that he'll visit me in prison soon.”

Ricdorian, who was rubbing his cheek and sweeping his hair, lifted his head slightly. Today, I might not be able to see his rational side. And it wonders me when is the right time for his changes to occur. But I guess that time would be really hard to predict.

“I’m curious about my brother’s face. On the other hand, I don’t think it will matter if we don’t look alike.”

Ricdorian: “...”

I kept talking even though I didn’t get any response from Ricdorian.

My brother said he would come and visit me, but I haven’t heard much since the last letter he sent me. Even though he only said it once, it really made me a lot more curious about him.

I slowly tilted my head and smiled slightly at Ricdorian.

“I wish you could speak a little bit of human language.”

I’d like to talk to you but since you are a beast right now, I guess it would be difficult. Right?

“It’s been a long time since the first time we’ve and my life has become a little boring.”

The prison was more regular than I imagined but a bit more demanding that rules concerning prisoners’ behavior are obeyed and observed.

Soon, Ricdorian’s hands that he used in rubbing his cheeks and sweeping his hair a while ago were now put together on the floor.

Hmmm. It’s been five months since I came here. That’s a long time huh?

“When can I get out of prison?”

I stroked his head once more and got up from my seat.

“See you again.”

Bang.

00000000000000000000000000000000

However, there was no written message in it with regards to what he previously wrote about him visiting me or worrying about me.

I stared at the blue sky and felt like I was at a total loss this time. It was subtle to say that it was regrettable. I just wanted to see Iana's family once.

<Oh, are you awake now? Oh, my God! Your heart stopped beating!>

In fact, after I opened my eyes and heard about Iana's heart stopped beating, I had a thought that came to my mind like a pure instinct. The original Iana is dead. It was a fact that I accepted naturally, as if someone whispered it to me.

It was very confusing.

Having this form from the very beginning made me uncomfortable. I had a hard time adjusting with all these transitions and irregularities of the occurrences, but I eventually coped up and became myself. This is me right now. I have to live with that fact.

It's a big deal if people would take my situation lightly.

I thought I'd go home one day if I lost some screws.

I knew my life would be easier after I was released from prison, but I'm starting to think that it will not. No, I don't think so. Not after everything that has happened. I feel like trouble follows me wherever I go.

Sigh.

I just want to take a rest somewhere with good air.

Soon, I stared calmly at the beautiful landscape I saw. Right, I don't have to think about it right now. I'll worry about the future when I get there.

"No walk for Ricdorian today."

This morning, I was told that I don't have to come and assist them in Ricdorian's walk. They had a new restraint and had to do some experiments with it.

I decided to stay in the garden instead of the living room because of the complexity of my thoughts. Sitting on the bench, I exhaled. Indeed, breathing the air in the garden was clean and refreshing.

"Are you bored?"

I turned my attention to the person with an unfamiliar voice, then I saw a man smiling.

Who is he? It's my first time seeing him. Without realizing it, I looked through the garden. And saw more prisoners wandering in the garden today

than usual.

“Today the garden is open for the prisoners situated in Kambrakam’s middle east side. You didn’t know that, did you?”

Unlike me, who has a light crime, there were more sinful people inside Kambrakam. Our crimes are not as severe as those people who committed murder, arson and treason.

Those are considered heavy crimes and will never be legalized in this place.

Unlike the people on my floor, who came here instead of their family members, they are the “true sinners.” They are dangerous.

“Don’t be too wary. I’m not a bad guy.”

“Well, I’m pretty sure bad guys are the ones who usually say that.”

Chapter 36: The Appearance of The Accomplice (1)

Chapter 36 – The Appearance of The Accomplice (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

The man, with a good-looking face, shook his head and smiled. I instinctively looked around once again to ensure that I knew the positions of every guard just in case something bad happens. Sure enough, there are more guards today than any other day which I think due to the number of prisoners wandering in the garden.

Now, who is this man?

“I’ve heard that this time, the prison head was out and brought a lot of guards and therefore were allowed to take a walk with prisoners from the other side because of the insufficient number of jail wardens who will monitor the walk of prisoners from the middle east side. I’m just saying this because I thought you were wondering.”

I wasn’t really curious about that. But soon, I saw him shrug his shoulders.

“Don’t be too wary. This was only applicable to carefully selected prisoners.”

“Carefully selected?” That caught my interest.

“Here we go.” The man lifted his hands and massaged his temples.

“Only ‘normal’ people are allowed to walk.”

I observed the man with keen eyes. His harmonious brown hair, which blends well with the background of the sky like how rainfall goes naturally well with the blue, shook gently. I narrowed my eyes even more and looked at his somewhat mischievous green eyes.

“My name is Jair.”

I flinched as soon as I heard him say his name. No wonder why I thought the color combination was so familiar.

“And I really want to meet you for once.” He added.

Jair! That’s it, Jair Yuta Tupen Foss was a supporting character in the book! He helped the heroine and Ricdorian escape from prison.

I didn’t know he was here from the beginning. I thought I’d never meet him.

In this cell, it seems like all important plots were not met. I’m not happy with this. He also said he wanted to meet me. Why are these sudden turn of events so unfamiliar to me?

“I’ve seen you take a walk before. Well, to be exact, I saw you training someone. You’re all done?”

“I don’t think you’re seeing the right thing.”

“You’re making it hard for me to say it. I broke out of prison.” I looked at him with disapproval...is that something to be proud of?

He’s smiling like a good man now, but for all I know, he has an unrivaled ability to escape from prison.

Moreover, in the book, he was not just a person who helped them escape from prison. He was only pretending to be a sinner, and was on the side of the Hel estate. He was also the right-hand man and an aide of Ricdorian, who later became the Archduke.

“Anyway, I got interested when I saw it. Actually, I’m a wizard. I’m sure you know those wizards who have the tendency to turn their eyes around on the streets for research. They’re quite famous.”

He put his hand on his chest. I frowned at his action.

“If you’re really a wizard then you shouldn’t just casually tell me that in here, of all places. Should we go to a different prison location?” I said, a bit bothered.

“If you’re saying that because you’re afraid someone might hear you, we don’t have to. Fear none for after all, no one will hear us.”

He unfolded his palms. I was surprised and Jair quickly stared at the nearby guard. The guard looked calm. But looking closely, it seems like the focus of the guard’s eyes was blurry.

“That guard won’t remember anything. Just for the next five minutes.” His thick eyes, as green as the forest, gazed at me mischievously.

From what I remember, in the novel, Jair had a very funny personality. He would always make me laugh whenever I read the novel.

“I’m just here to tell you a funny story. About the prisoner you cared for.” Jair lowered down his head.

“You know, that’s the curse of being an animal? It’s an old curse. An ordinary person probably doesn’t know.”

The curse that came down to Archduke Harnim’s Grand Palace was a curse that only a few of them know. So I’ll just act like I don’t know and talk about it openly to avoid any suspicions.

I couldn’t figure out why he was doing this especially that he just suddenly came to me.

“It’s a curse to be a beast. When you become an animal, you can’t even speak a language. He’s only human in appearance, and he’s a beast in speech and behavior. But isn’t it too uncomfortable and pitiful to live like

that? For those who suffer from such a curse, the awakening is just a temporary solution. The wizard is usually part of this.”

“Why are you telling me this story?”

“You’ve also heard of this, right? That’s why you’re curious.”

I frowned a little at his words, which had no more sense. I’m curious, really curious. I wanted to know more about it. Especially the fact that it involves Ricdorian.

“But when I saw the prisoner who was with you, I can tell that you haven’t awakened him yet, right? And as long as he hasn’t awakened, he would always live a miserable life of repeated words and actions of a beast.”

No.... So Ricdorian who wasn’t able to speak was because of the curse and not because he was taught how to act and speak like a dog?

I misunderstood everything. Despite learning all of this, I pretended to be calm while hiding the nursery book behind me. And soon, I realized why Jair came to me. Jair was a loyal man who devoted his life to Ricdorian.

I do not know exactly what he’s thinking right now, but it seems like he was really doing his best to help Ricdorian. Otherwise, he wouldn’t have talked to me at all, tell me about the curse Ricdorian is under and worry about being caught.

And sure enough, he doesn’t know what I know.

In the book, when Ricdorian was a beast, Jair used and paid a lot of people to awaken Ricdorian.

Chapter 37: The Appearance of The Accomplice (2)

Chapter 37 – The Appearance of The Accomplice (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“As I looked at you, I see that you’re quite curious, and I know you’ve noticed the condition of the prisoner, haven’t you?”

“You’re not wrong. But are you saying you’ve seen more than enough?”

“Of course. Escaping is my hobby.”

Yeah right. That’s his forte.

What an enviable hobby. If I were a felon, I would have done it, escaping from this forlorn place. Give me some tips on how to escape, mister.

“What do you want from me?”

“What?”

“I’m sure you didn’t come here to see me just to say something and use me as a protection.” The green eyes which seemed to stare at me, bent down. He whistled for a moment and then suddenly froze.

I, on the other hand, felt the burden of those shiny eyes.

“I was hoping you’d help me satisfy my magical curiosity”

“Curiosity?”

“Yes, I am a sorcerer who can awaken him, the prisoner under the beast’s curse. I’ve been studying for a long time, and my hands are itchy as they are dying to awaken him already.”

I pretended to be curious, to see the real intentions of Jair. So he’s going to cast a spell on him through me? That’s it, huh? But why? Why are they taking risks now?

Will that make Ricdorian’s prison life more comfortable?

But....

“There’s no reason for me to listen anymore.”

“Oh, if you turn back and won’t help me satisfy my magical curiosity, I won’t hurt you...for now.”

“Are you threatening me?” I asked him with narrow eyes, not feeling any fear..

I scoffed in disbelief and Jair’s eyes have become as thin as a twine.

“It’s a joke. I’ll help you with anything anytime. You know that having a sorcerer’s help is a rare opportunity.” I said.

It certainly wasn’t a bad deal. But the opportunity to use the sorcery skills of Jair was not beneficial for me. There’s no reason for me to use a supporting role.

If I get out of prison, I’ll go somewhere that doesn’t have anything to do with the original plot, eat well and enjoy my life. And also forget everything!

I was about to look away but later turned my gaze back at him as he said something that caught my attention.

“Maybe the prisoner could use a spoon when eating instead of lying on his stomach and picking up everything from the ground. It sounds like a joke, but it won’t be a bad thing for the prisoner either.”

Now that's the suggestion I like. It's a better bait than what he said earlier. He should be more straightforward rather than acting as if he was being kind. Moreover, I was also tired of picking up cookies.

“Will it be difficult?”

“Not at all. All you have to do is hand this over.”

That's what Jair said, as he raised his one hand. He also explained that he would cast a spell on my hand, so I only need to approach Ricdorian and memorize the incantations.

“This is my magic and it will be activated as soon as I say so.”

The magic he created is a temporary magic that only Ricdorian can hear. Based on his fixed plan and sequential explanation, an intentional approach is the most effective way.

“You're very prepared, aren't you?”

“Yes, I've already made it before, and I've been thinking about persuading you. I am smart and I always think in advance.” He then winked at me.

Aside from that, I shook my head as I was trying to answer why he was even in this prison.

Why not? He's from the Hel estate's side.

The prisoners inside Kambrakam were mixed. Some were on Archduke Harnim's side but the prison head was on the Chaser's side.

However, realizing that Jair was inside Kambrakam, this just proves that no matter how much the Archduke has forsaken Ricdorian, still he didn't just leave him alone. He has eyes inside this prison.

I was about to say yes and reach out my hand when suddenly, he spoke.

“But what can I do? You have to do this at night.”...What?!

“This magic is influenced by the moon’s power.”

Jair’s hand held my wrist indiscreetly. And not long after, a faint light glistened around his hand.

“Hey, what are you talking about? Do you think I can get out of my cell at night?”

“That’s why I’m trying to help you.”

When Jair pulled something off, a bracelet appeared on my wrist.

It was a green strap bracelet that had a similar color with his eyes and a translucent jewel twinkled in the center.

“You can use this.” Jair whispered and a blue light rose on the back of my hand appeared.

As the light disappeared, a stick pattern was drawn on my wrist. Is this a magic symbol?

“That’s it.”

He grinned. Afterwards, he stepped back a little and clapped.

“With that magic, you’ll be fine. But...he may suffer from side effects.”

Side effects? I stared at him in a worry but Jair quickly shook his head.

“It’s not a big deal. Maybe just a sudden growth? I’ll be back soon.”

Jair snapped his hand and whispered that he had already unfurled the magic. Then he quickly turned his back.

Being together for a long time is not good for the both of us.

I narrowed my eyes and looked alternately at the blue rose pattern at the back of my hand and the green bracelet on my wrist.....this isn’t a big deal, right?



—*Midnight*

I stood up from my bed and tied my hair. I stuck my curly hair with a pin which made a loud noise, making my eyes open wide.

“Haaaaah...” I sighed in relief.

I need to be careful not to make any noises, especially that I am already heavy-eyed.

It may be due to what happened earlier that I haven't slept all throughout but the main reason is that if I sleep, I might not even wake up at this time.

“I almost fell asleep.”

Chapter 38: You're more than happy to see me tonight, aren't you? (1)

Chapter 38 – You're more than happy to see me tonight, aren't you? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I always sleep at night, and it was so unusual for me not to do so tonight. Of course, it's natural for every human being to be in a deep slumber at this hour. Besides, I haven't encountered someone who doesn't sleep in the evening.

Thoughts aside, dozing off right now or even just a few seconds of unconsciously closing my eyes would lead me to a deep sleep, which would make me miss the right time to visit Ricdorian without noticing it. So I think it is better to stay awake from the very beginning until in the middle of the night and keep my guard up.

<Are you asking if they're more alert at dawn? Of course, they might be. But it's looser in your area than the other side of the prison. That's what I think. >

I also heard information about the vigilance of guards at dawn when I pretended to offer a drink to one of the guards I'm close to.

<In fact, it's a secret that most prisoners in this area have committed light crimes... and that's why we rarely see roaming guards on our side of the prison at dawn...But still, the nobles cannot go out smoothly. Same goes for escaping this prison.>

According to Baron, aristocrats usually stay up all night or play at night in social circles. It's rare for them to sleep at the right time and get up early in the morning—the privilege of being a nobility. Of course, there is a difference between men and women, but he said that the difference was very little.

However, the more the prisoners get used to the regular life inside this prison, the more they adapt to life here, and that is why some of them, especially in our area, prefer resting at night. As a result, this area is very peaceful at dawn to the point where nothing happens.

<Sometimes the guards and the prisoners get together and flirt with each other. By the way, did you enjoy what Iana gave you this time?>

<Aha. The alcohol? I was wondering when I should secretly drink it, and sneak up at dawn.>

<Hahaha. You're still keeping this a secret from the Chief guard?>

<Of course.>

Apparently, there are a lot of guards in this area... Uhm, five or four on average. I swallowed a lump...I didn't know I'd be playing the role of an undercover agent inside this cell. As if I'm shooting some scenes from a movie.

I silently laughed.

In any case, I've already made up my mind, I am determined this time to do everything, even the impossible. Yeah, I can do this. Well, thinking about it, all I did inside this prison is live an ordinary and a bit dull life. Also, whenever I saw Ricdorian barking, I would always wonder when he would act like a normal human being.

“I was told to use the bracelet first.”

As I prepared some candies and other stuff with me, I grabbed the bracelet Jair gave me. The bracelet had three jewels, I firmly rubbed the first one,

which was gently placed on the cuff.

“Yaram [야람]”

When Jair muttered the starting incantation, a subtle emission of golden lights wrapped around his body.

“Wow, amazing.”

I looked at my hands and the golden light that instantly appeared suddenly vanished. Is this how it works?

“Will they see me?”

I have no choice but to go out and check. I crept to the door, grabbed the doorknob, and muttered another starter incantation. A total of three magic silver jewels hung on this bracelet. The purpose of the second one is to open and silence the sound of a rummaged door.

I stuck my head out through the open door.

Is there anyone?

No, there isn't. There was no one in the quiet hallway.

Of course, for five hours, I counted the number of footsteps I heard. And at this moment, there was no guard on watch in this hallway. The guard is being replaced every 40 minutes, and it would take 5 minutes for the new guard to appear in this area. I have to maximize that time well.

One thing about this area was that it is so peaceful. Which is a good thing for me, right?

I walked silently like a stray cat, even though I knew this was an empty hallway, but knowing that fact didn't make me less nervous.

At the end of the hallway, there is a staircase that goes down, which was usually used in going to the dining hall or the garden. However, as soon as I

turned around the corner, I paused. There were guards right in front of the stairs!

I was startled!

I almost screamed...but good thing I managed to hold myself from doing so.

“...huh? Did you hear something?”

“No? Maybe that’s just your breathing? You should stop blowing your nose. The noise is killing me.”

“Oh, my gosh”, I whispered in the air. Were they just taking a break and decided to rest on the stairs, and not because the other was about to be replaced?

The distance between the guards and me was less than three steps. I swerved around and stuck myself to the wall with my hands covering my mouth.

They certainly didn’t see me even though I was in front of them. The magic that Jair put on the first jewel, the invisibility spell, was very useful. It made my whole body transparent. I wanna praise Jair’s ability right now.

<With this magic, your body will become invisible, but only in other people’s eyes.>

I went down the stairs carefully with my eyes flickering. Fortunately, the conversation between the guards seemed to hide my small footsteps.

After a long and anxious walk, I took a short and deep breath.

“Haah,”...Now I am confident that the magic of Jair was working properly.

After safely overcoming the crisis, I headed to the basement stairs. It was a stairway that leads all the way to the west side of the prison. I turned round after reaching the corner, however, when I reached the wall, I heard footsteps.

“Hey, why is the Prison head back this time, and at dawn? He just came back all of a sudden.”

“You were the one who almost lived in prison. Don’t you know anything about him or his goals? You know what? Even though the work on the capital is of peak season, he keeps on coming back here. Don’t you ever wonder why he’s trying to stick to the cell more lately?”

“I think so, too. Maybe he has hidden jewels in his room, that’s why he can’t leave it for a long time, but why would he leave it in his room of all places?”... Did he?

I was tightly stuck to the wall, and after a group of people had passed, I held out my breath. This time, I heard the footsteps rushing right before the corner. Oh my gosh, I think I’m in trouble.

Chapter 39: You're more than happy to see me tonight, aren't you? (2)

Chapter 39 – You're more than happy to see me tonight, aren't you? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

Thank goodness no one noticed my presence.

By the way, was Lenag back this dawn? What a workaholic. Sure enough, he might have reached such a position by working hard like that.

Soon, after looking at the back of the guards who passed right through me, I turned my back quickly. Fortunately, I didn't meet any more people until I reached the basement. Well, I can consider myself lucky...for now.

When I finally got down to the last step, I realized my back was sweaty. It is because it took me too long to arrive at the underground.

And when I reached the end, I realized, the change from day to night was very subtle; as I wasn't able to comprehend this unusual place that I'm in right now. I didn't know that the basement that I was so familiar with during the day would feel this strange at night.

I sighed and raised my head a little. Then I saw Hans, who was dozing off in front of the cell.

In the beginning, Hans is not the only jailer assigned in Ricdorian's cell. But after the daily walks of Ricdorian, instead of guarding other prisoners, he became the only jailer exclusively assigned to him.

It may also seem that Ricdorian was assigned to me considering our very close relationship and the fact that my presence is required every time we take a walk. It was a good thing for me, as well.

Hans was kind, decent, and a good person. But, he has a rational, dual, and calculative personality.

Thinking more of Ricdorian, it's unusual to hear him moan in pain and I would really be surprised to see him hurt again this time. At the moment, I couldn't help but think of those days when he was beaten and suffering.

Fortunately, even though Jair wasn't with me, he was smart enough to help me take care of something like this.

Soon, I slowly approached Hans, who was asleep, but I stopped. It was because Hans's eyes opened in an instant.

"Yes, what is it? The flag... Was I mistaken?" Surely, he wouldn't be called a guard for no reason. Like now, even though he is asleep, he's still alert and active.

I shouldn't have taken him lightly.

A cold sweat broke out. I squeezed my sleeves and stepped back a little. And before Hans turned his head, I quickly pressed the bracelet's third jewel three times.

<The third gem should be used carefully. The important thing to take note is to use it up close.>

And while Hans hadn't seen it, a flood of gold light stuck in his neck...I feel like a cartoon detective.

My name is Conan! Woah, a detective's job is tough. I think we should commend such a profession.

"Oh, what is it? A Mosquito?" Hans, who was patting his neck, muttered, "What is it?" He added, and soon, his eyes closed slowly.

I gradually backed out while breathing heavily, then looked at Hans, who was in deep slumber.

“...I lived.” He muttered once more.

That was so close!

Then, I sighed in relief.

I looked at the bracelet with a perplexed look.

The magic that Jair cast on the last jewel was a sleeping spell.

<I assure you, even the person with the most considerable mana will fall asleep.>

When I heard that, I was shocked. I wonder if it is okay to use this kind of magic to people. But Jair guaranteed the safety of those who were under this spell, so it might be okay. I know he was someone who wouldn't talk nonsense when it comes to magic.

Of course, I also read this part in the book, this will also happen a few years from now, and I hope so too.

Thinking about those, I clenched my fists.

Creeeeekkkk.

Soon, the door opened with a rusty sound of iron. And that noise sounded louder at dawn. Looking at the rusty iron bars, I thought it was a good idea putting Hans into a deep sleep.

Even so, I also thought a little suspicious of myself for doing this at dawn.

The familiar smell of the moss after I opened the bar was reeking. I slipped in and put down the lamp. I couldn't bring one from my room, so I brought the one next to Hans.

Soon, I met Ricdorian's sparkling round eyes.

“Who is it?”

I paused.

Oh, my. I haven’t taken off the magic yet, so he won’t be able to see me... But to my surprise, Ricdorian looked precisely to where I was. Not just where I was, but to my face to be exact.

I cut a spare bed cloth, turning it over like a cloak. But I still didn’t know why he knew my exact location.

Does Ricdorian has magic, or his instincts told him where I was?

Moreover, it was amazing to see him not stammering. When he looked at me, he would always blush while staring at my face.

I wanted to watch him for a while, but unfortunately, I don’t have time. Blinking my eyes, I took off the magic and threw the cloak I was wearing, and his blue eyes shook slightly in the dark.

“...you?”

The blue eyes seem like questioning me ‘*why*’. But he couldn’t say and ask anything, because I blocked him from speaking.

“Shh. very good.” I placed my index finger on his lips.

“Shhh.” I whispered one more time and slowly took my fingers off.

The chain was quite loud, so someone might hear it. But of course, no one will come all the way here early in the morning, but we still need to be careful not to get caught.

“You’re more than happy to see me tonight, aren’t you?” I said as I really wanted to say this right now.

Oh, there’s no window. I don’t think Ricdorian would know if it’s day or night.

It was the moment when I was about to correct my mistake when he suddenly spoke.

“...Yes, it’s night, I was surprised you came.”

Ricdorian pinpointed the time and made me forget what I was about to say. So I looked at him and soon remembered what I was about to ask.

“Do you know it’s night-time?”

“What? Yes. I can tell it through my senses, even if I don’t see the sky. Also, it’s not hard to infer between meals.”

I looked at him with bewildered eyes. But as I stared at him, I saw his cheeks were slightly stained. Soon he shyly looked down to the ground, as if he noticed my gaze at him.

He was quite intelligent when he was rational, and his words were full of courtesy. But he was still stuttering a little. On the other hand, his beast side would utter words that I can’t understand.

What an impressive being.

I narrowed my eyes even more and questioned him.

“How long have you been in this cell? It’s not like you were here since birth.”

Chapter 40: You can't eat the candy without doubting my intentions

Chapter 40 – You can't eat the candy without doubting my intentions

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I was in a hurry, but the question just popped in my mind without me realizing it. Yes, I know it's not the right time to ask, but I'm just curious.

“Well. No.”

I shook my head quickly, emphasizing to him not to mind what I just asked if he doesn't want to answer.

Silence enveloped the entire room as if an angel just passed by. When suddenly, the sound of a loud chain interrupted the awkward silence between us. Soon, he spoke.

“Ten years old. You know, I was ten years old. I've been here since then.”

My sight turned to his shaking eyes. So he's been locked up in this room for six years? I nodded as a response to his answer, a little bit shocked.

I don't even think I could survive being in here for that long. He might have forgotten the feeling of freedom, wander around and do whatever he wants. Yes, he was able to go out in the garden and have a walk, but that's not even considered being free. Because having real freedom is living a life without cuffs and restraints.

“I see. Well, I’d really like to hear more about it, but I have something more urgent to do today.”

“Ur, urgent?”

“Yes.”

Ricdorian’s past was only analogous to the conversations in the book, hence I don’t know everything. It’s an obscure past.

My curiosity about him was raised to notch once again, but I soon remembered Jair and the reason I came here.

“You’re curious, right? That’s right. This is why I came at night.”

I reached for my pocket, opened it, and pulled out a candy. Using the hand, which Jair casted the magic on, I jiggled it in front of him. First, this was the trick, give him the candy, and then second, explain the magic.

“There is something I wanted to give you. This is it.”

For a long time, I’ve been thinking about how to cast the spell inside this room. How about casting the magic on his cheeks?

Ugh!

I can’t do this, explaining to him might be difficult. But I still decided to continue.

“If you eat this, you’ll see something extraordinary.”

It was a magic that ordinary people couldn’t see. Besides, this is what Jair had prepared, especially for Ricdorian.

“In fact, this, after eating...”

I was about to tell him that this was from someone who wanted to help him. But...

“Can, can I eat?”

““Yes, you can eat.....eh?” I widen my eyes.

No, like this? That’s not the response I was expecting. He’s so innocent!

I couldn’t hide my absurdity.

“No, why don’t you don’t ask me why?” I said and quickly raised my hand.

Hearing me, Ricdorian pouts.

“What should I ask?”

I don’t know if he’s a hungry beast who wants to eat everything he thinks is edible, or he just really trusts me this much.

Gosh, he tilted his head when he asked the question, and his silver hair fell.

I looked at his innocent eyes and was speechless. He looks so cute.

I shook my head and then shifted my eyes to the candy. I looked at him and at the candy alternately.

Oh, come on, I always brought you food but still you shouldn’t just eat whatever I give you.

His face looks tantalizing that I ran out of words to say.

Ricdorian, you can’t just eat the candy without any doubt.

“From now on, you have to be vigilant and careful. You can’t eat what others give you, especially medicine and drugs.”

Yes, I wanted him to eat this treat in order for me to say the spell, but he needs to be aware that there are evil people out there and that he shouldn’t trust too much.

I sighed. It’s just a candy, though.

Frustrated, Ricdorian stammered.

“Ea...Eating that.. I’ll be fine.”

“Of course not. What if I’m a bad person?”

“But...”

Wait. Why are you looking at me like that?

His gaze that seemed to contain the color of the sea caught me. I flinched at his glistening eyes, wherein his tears looked like it were about to fall the moment he blinks.

“...are you going to hurt me?”

Ba-dum. Ba-dum.

My heart throbbed rapidly as if it had its own instinct.

He was already soaked with his sweat, but still, his beautiful face covered that imperfection. The shackles in his hands under that sacred face evoked a stimulating imagination.

I immediately lowered my face, what am I thinking. I am not a pervert!

“You didn’t hit me, you didn’t beat me to pulp. You didn’t break plates... well, you always give me something delicious!”

“But you can’t just trust me. Haven’t you ever heard of the saying ‘*Today’s friend is tomorrow’s enemy*’?”...He just shook his head.

Oh, maybe there’s no such thing as that in here.

While agonizing, Ricdorian, who just answered me, tilted his head.

“You can... hit me.”...What? What is he talking about?

With a puzzled look, I raised my head and stared at him.

“... who’s gonna hit who?”

“Bu...but last time...”

“You still remember that joke? You’re such a persistent man!”

He always takes jokes seriously.

I shook my head, then this time, stared at him with a ludicrous look. Not long after, I put the candy in his hand, hoping that time would pass. I need to get out soon because the atmosphere’s getting weird.

“Let’s just say I am not dangerous today. Next time, don’t trust me easily. Anyway, eat this. We don’t have time.”

Ricdorian: “...”

“You hear me, right? Do you understand?” He nodded.

I guess he’s not turning into a beast anytime today.

I saw his fingers grabbing me, but I pretended not to know.

I prepared the candy because I didn’t know if the magic created by Jair would hurt Ricdorian. To boot, I brought it because I thought it would be much better for Ricdorian to bite something sweet while I perform the magic.

With his hands up, Ricdorian put the candy in his mouth without hesitation. He put his hand on his cheek as he sucked the candy.

I felt strange at this sight. How could he eat that without even doubting my intentions?

Chapter 41: Feed me

Chapter 41 – Feed me

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I genuinely mumbled the spell and saw a blue light from his wrist faintly lingering. But to my surprise, as I looked at him, he was about to fall.

And I widely opened my eyes in shock.

“Ricdorian!”

The chains moved, and I grabbed him by the shoulder. But still, he stumbled and fell forward. He laid on his stomach and groaned.

“Are you alright? Ricdorian, can you hear me?”

He let out a groan, let alone a reply. This is driving me nuts. Jair never talked about this. He just said it would sting him a little!

Jair said that Ricdorian would grow a bit after experiencing a little pain, and I anticipated the degree of body growth. But I didn’t expect to see him suffering like this. I stomped my feet while looking at him. I don’t have the time to run to my cell and get the painkillers. If only I knew that suffering from this would be the side effect, I would not have consented this!

I bit my lower lip, anxious about what to do.

“...huh?”... When did it grow?

I felt that his shoulder gradually grew thicker. It wasn’t just the shoulders. I could see firmer and longer legs and arms. I am astonished by what I am

seeing. His torn clothes fell on the floor.

Soon, Ricdorian slowly lifted his head and stopped breathing the moment he stared at me.

His breathtaking face was now gazing right in front of me.

I tried to step back as I felt uneasy; however, the hand that held me was faster than the speed of light. He grabbed me firmly like an iron clasp. And with this, the chain was pulled tightly. The shackles on his neck were still attached. His mouth, which became plump and redder as he grew, opened slowly.

“Why are you avoiding me...?” He said. “Where do you intend to go?” Ricdorian added.

His pureness remained the same, but his ferocity right now was like that of his beastly side. And as I heard him say those lines, it felt different.

It didn’t take too long for me to realize that Ricdorian was speaking in the form of a beast.

As he tilted his head, his long silver hair scattered over his forehead. I bent my head to see him even more. His eyes were looking at me deeply, making me feel like I’m drowning in the ocean. I heard his deep breaths. And his eyes seemed to be staring at my neck.

“Let me go.”

“...why?”

Ricdorian’s head tilted deeply. At that moment, I opened my eyes wide.

“Why... why are you trying to avoid me?”

Those strange and bitter eyes were watery. His long and mesmerizing eyes were in subtle harmony but more stimulating....this is not just because of the growth.

I grinded my teeth and thought of Jair. That bastard! He fooled me! I'm surely gonna pinch him in the ears!

Holy cow! I know it's just a slight improvement. But I was so sure. This is the look of Ricdorian in the book. This is him, the grown-up Ricdorian four years later.

My heart pounded. I squeezed my sleeve with the other hand. It was strange to see him with that kind of beauty. It's more than ethereal!

But soon, I gathered myself and thought that there was no time...this is not the right time for this.

"Let me go. I have to go."

There's no time. I had to go back before the patrols turned. But his grip did not budge. No, I could feel how powerful and robust his hand was.

But at the moment, tears fell from him.

"Don't go."

No, why are you seducing me! With my face swept away, I quickly tried to pull his hand away from me. Soon, our eyes met, and I flinched as I saw the gaze of the beast.

"Where are you going?"

The eyes on me were filled with tears, but I knew that he's an animal that could turn berserk anytime and bite off someone's neck.

I swallowed a lump as I think of his capabilities.

He was in an imperfect condition as of the moment. I could see him shaking even when he was a beast, but he still had the consciousness of a rational person. We shouldn't have done anything in a rush. Maybe he wasn't able to bear the power of the spell?

“Ricdorian, you’re a good boy. Look at this, I brought you something you like.”

While I opened my pocket with one hand, Ricdorian glanced at it. Ah, I know for sure he must have seen his favorite cookies.

“It’s for you.” I said and showed him the pouch of cookies I just grabbed.

“Mine?” I nodded nonchalantly in response.

His eyes that caught me, stared alternately at the cookie and my face. Then I offered my hand with the pouch of cookies.

“What, what should I call you... I don’t remember. Ah, Master?”

“No.”...Master....I pursed my lips, determined not to feel pampered once again.

“Iana. Call me by that name.”

“Name?”

He bent his upper body, and the distance between us was narrowed. The tension I am feeling right now was similar to that of a wired copper. Looking at the gentle but ferocious beast, I slowly tried to gather my thoughts.

“...yes. Iana.” I said.

His deep gaze was now too close to me and the blinking blue eyes curled slowly. It seems like the purpose of his sudden growth was now forgotten because of his overwhelming smile and the strangeness that flowed in his sight.

“Iana.”

Iana: “...”

I only heard him say my name, but why do I feel so perturbed? Once again, I swallowed hard.

“Iana.”

He licked his lips with his tongue, and his gaze slowly turned towards my hand that was holding the pouch.

Then, he held my hand and grabbed a cookie from the pouch, and he put his mouth on my wrist.

Then he smiled visibly as he looked at me straight right through the eyes.

“...Feed me.” He said, with a subtle blush on his cheeks.

I blinked, wondering if I had misheard him for a moment.

Chapter 42: Let go

Chapter 42 – Let go

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

Wait. What did you say? Feed you? What the heck are you saying right now?

Ricdorian was still holding my hand, and I could feel the touch of his soft lip being pressed on my wrist as well as the scabs next to his lips.

“...Can’t you?” Ricdorian, who vaguely glanced at me, tilted his head. Then his lips moved in a sensible manner.

Why did his lips get redder when he grew up?

Staring at it, I unconsciously bit my lower lip without turning my gaze away. His whole being right now screamed perfection.

“Iana.”

I think making him call my name was a bad idea... It felt so strange hearing him say Iana as if it was really my name.

Soon, I closed my eyes, then opened my mouth. It seems like he was waiting for my response as he held me by my hand. In any case, he was ready to release me unless I fed him.

Time is ticking at this moment.

“Oh my, loosen your grip for a bit.”

I said it multiple times, fiercely looking at his eyes. Then I waved my hand around the cookie.

“This is what you want, right? Then let go of my hand so I can feed you.”

Ricdorian gradually let go of my hand as he looked right into my eyes. Assessing if I’m true to my words. However, he seemed not convinced for his eyes manifest a trace of doubt.

Staring back at him, I felt like there was a beast walking around in front of me. It would be better to feed him quickly and get out in an instant than encountering other unfortunate events.

At last, his hand completely fell off; however, he raised his hand to make sure I was within his reach in case I would run and leave him. His form may be a beast, but the way he acts right now is like a baby afraid of being abandoned by his mother.

I grabbed him by the chin, making sure that I would not touch the scar on his lips, feeling the smoothness of his cheeks.

“Open your mouth.”

Ricdorian: “... .”

His watery eyes crossed with mine as if those were not owned by an animal.

Now tell me, how can I not abide this man’s bidding when he looks like an innocent little kid who needs care?

“Come on.”

Looking at his slowly opening mouth, I put in the cookie I was holding and his lips moved as if it was eating candy.

However, even though I gave him the cookies, I still couldn’t move my hand. I stared at him who was intentionally swallowing my fingers in his mouth....why is he devouring my hand?

This wasn't the first time he did this obscene act. I just sighed and shook my head.

In the past, when he was a beast, he devoured my hand, which he mentally thought was a cookie too. But now... it's different. Yes, he's still a beast, but he's a rational beast as of the moment. He must have realized that he was eating my hand, not just the cookie, but nevertheless, he still did not let go of it despite knowing it.

"Let go of my hand. Right now!"

But rather than letting go, I felt his fingers squeezing my wrist, slowly sucking my index finger. Moments of savoring, he looked up and stared at me.

"How about you? Don't you want to eat it?" He tilted his head, his eyes were moist and watery...

After asking me to feed you, you wanted me to eat next? What a good thought, Ricdorian. Just how thoughtful of you!

But no. I quickly shook my head, then narrowed my eyes.

"That's not eating. Let go. Quickly."

The sound of my resolute voice made him stop for a moment. But after a while, he continued doing his thing with my fingers, moistening it with his tongue. He then tried to shift his gaze, ignoring what I just said.

"It's sweet."

"...Ugh!" I unintentionally said out of frustration. I then felt a more profound gaze coming from Ricdorian the moment he heard me moan.

I stepped back since I thought this sudden turn of events would be dangerous at this rate. Fortunately, my hand was completely out of his mouth this time.

But my heart was pounding violently.

The chain was moving, and his hand reached for me; however, he stopped right in front of me because the chains were not long enough for him to be able to catch me.

“Iana.”

There was a mixture of innocence and fascination in his thirsty voice.

“One more time... ..feed me one more time. Please?” I glanced at the floor and lifted my head.

“...No?” He asked as I did not respond to him.

“No, I don’t like people who don’t behave themselves.”

I let go of my hand, which I enclosed with the other and showed him my wrist with a visible bruise caused by his tight grip earlier. His eyes shook slightly, realizing he did wrong. As expected, his rationality and beast side coexisted. Then, at the time of his realization, he did not do any strange things anymore.

I shove the pouch of cookies instead of giving it kindly to him. So he picked it up himself and opened it.

“Eat it yourself.”

Then the eyes, which had been fierce all along, slightly turned despondent, and with his head down, he ate the cookies on the ground.

“Yes. I’ll eat.”

No. Why not use your hands?

I was caught in a strange mood as I stared at him, who was eating the cookie with his mouth like a beast...or a dog... I don’t know right now, but he felt like neither a human being nor a beast.

As I looked at the blue-eyed man eating the cookie, I swallowed my saliva and clenched my hands. Everything I did and the magic to help him was out

of little goodwill and curiosity, but somehow I feel like he was paying a higher price for it.

I think I shouldn't be here anymore.

I was about to pull the hem of my sleeves, when suddenly I heard a groan. And as I turned my head, I saw a Ricdorian with an arched body like a ripe banana.

“Ricdorian!?”

Chapter 43: Is this mine too?

Chapter 43 – Is this mine too?

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I moved towards him and grabbed him by the shoulder as fast as the lightning. He was so hot! Not just the part where I held him but his entire body was so hot.

Cold sweat dripped from my forehead due to anxiousness. And the well-drenched man looked more blatantly irritated. Turning my eyes, I decided to touch his forehead.

“Arrghh, it hurts... .”

“Are you alright? Where does it hurt? Can you talk?”

“My body is hot...”

What the hell did Jair make me do under the power of the moon? He said I just need to say the incantation.

I gnashed my teeth.

He was a loyal dog who swore allegiance to Ricdorian in the book. I didn't think he would do anything harmful to him. And if this is part of the process, it seemed too painful for him.

I bit my lips, wiping away the sweat and tears on his eyes.

“Tell me where it hurts.”

Then the tormented blue-eyed child stared at me—his eyes, which manifested a deep-sea color smeared with tears, perhaps because of pain.

“It’s strange. In here... no one came and cared for me...”

He got my hand and buried his face on my palm and I felt like rubbing his cheeks as he was like a beast seeking for love and attention. Those words were enough to make me feel remorseful of his pitiful situation.

“Is this mine?”

What he pointed to was the remaining cookie and so I nodded.

It’s yours, Ricdorian. It’s yours.

But, what’s with that sudden question? Right, that’s not important right now.

“...then, is this mine too?”

The next thing he pointed at was my hand.

All of it are yours, Ricdorian. Wait, no!

It wasn’t appropriate to point at my hand this time. What is he thinking?

I frowned at him when his lips was pressed on my wrist. I could feel his hot breath on it.

Swoosh.

Suddenly, I got shivers. I just hope he wouldn’t notice my trembling hand.

“Why will this be yours? It’s my hand.”

His innocent eyes looked up, and tears rolled down, showing a beastly smile under that suffering expression.

“So, what should I do?”

I stared at him, pulled out my hand, and covered his eyes. What else should Ricdorian do? Get some sleep!

He's been out of strength for a long time. So it was not difficult to get out of his grasp. Also, it was on my mind to leave him like that as I have less time left. However, I decided to wipe his sweating face and body with a handkerchief. Not long after, I rummaged through my pockets.

"...hold this."

I want to leave now, but I can't because of my guilty conscience.

I put my hair tie in his hand and stood up. I pulled an old blanket and covered his back. As of the moment, he noticed the hair tie I gave him, hugging it tightly in his hand as if it was his treasure and slept soundly.

"No... this is more..."

His sweat-soaked hair, bulging tanned cheeks, worn-out clothes, and so on has soon transpired.

Ricdorian was back in his original form.

Before I knew it, I closed my eyes tightly after looking at my sweaty small hands...Iana, think of this as a good thing... A good thing.

I placed my hand in my pocket and turned my back.

It's been a long night.

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Of course, I didn't sleep well after that day.

Early in the morning, as I walked down the hall, the guard who was looking at me from the side, spoke.

"Iana, are you alright? If you are sick, you can go to the infirmary."

“No. No. I want to take a walk. I want to get some fresh air.”

After that occurrence, I came out for a walk with a stiff face. When I get back to bed, the dawn was near, so I had little time to sleep. Furthermore, I encountered no problems going back to my cell.

It took me less than 10 minutes to get out of Ricdorian’s cell, lock the door, release Hans from Jair’s magic, and go back. The way back to my cell was smooth. It’s just that my problem is I wasn’t able to get enough sleep.

Who can sleep comfortably after experiencing such a thing?

To be honest, I was so confused. I didn’t know what to do when I saw Ricdorian suffering. He looks like he was carrying the pain and suffering of the entire world. On the contrary, it seemed that I underestimated Jair’s magic. I thought the side effect would be just a faint pain. I have no idea it would torment Ricdorian

I brushed off my thoughts aside as I felt a strange expression coming from the guard in charge of the walk who just spoke to me.

“Iana? Your face is red. Go to the infirmary right now.”

“No, it turned red because of the walk. I guess this was over-exercise.”

“...over-exercise?”

The guard glanced at me, who’s now sitting on the bench, rather than taking a walk...Yes, I know my excuse is crap. But in the end, the guard didn’t do anything anymore and walked to another prisoner.

I looked away and sighed heavily. Today, I’ll promise myself to just rest and do nothing.

Then, suddenly as I massaged my temples, an idea came into my mind.

“Oh!”

A good idea!

In the distance, a group of female prisoners gathered. Sally, the prisoner assigned next to my cell, was chatting with them. They were all laughing as if they had no problem. Usually, I would have involved myself in it, but I closed my eyes and decided not to go to them because I didn't have enough energy to be there right now.

It had been three days since I met Jair.

“I felt the magic was activated. Maybe I was successful?”

New magic restraints arrived from the capital city, and for some time, I was forbidden to take a walk with Ricdorian. Thanks to that, I was walking alone today.

Soon, I stared disapprovingly at the uninvited guest.

“Oh, hello.”

Oh, come on, I was waiting for you for three days.

Chapter 44: Unknown Inside (1)

Chapter 44 – Unknown Inside (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“How would you know if what I did was successful?” I curiously asked him.

“It’s simple.” Jair smiled freshly as if he just had a cold refreshment in a hot summer. His green eyes depict confidence and sureness.

“If you fail, I wouldn’t have seen you here anymore.”

I paused at what he said. And when I looked up, I was welcomed by his smiling face.

Right now, I’m kind of like clenching my fists. I’m in a disposition wherein I don’t know what I should feel about him.

“So you know what could possibly happen if I fail? But still, you chose to leave the magical thing to me despite knowing those possibilities?”

“You were willing to do it, and I really appreciate your participation. Thanks to you, my magical curiosity was satisfied.”

He looked so unbothered and cool despite what happened and what could have happened.

It was a funny act that he was still trying to pretend as a sorcerer. But if I didn’t know what was going on with him, the idea of calling himself a wizard would seem quite plausible.

“Yes, I participated in your idea because I was also curious. So, I am not putting all the blame on you on this one.” I said, a little bit irritated of him making fun of the situation.

I know things didn’t go smoothly, but it also didn’t go way beyond worst, and I’m thankful for that. However, loosening up seemed a little hard for me after everything that happened, which almost gave me a heart attack.

“Oh.”

“But at least you know that I’m not having fun like you; instead I am more worried about the prisoner.”

I got up from my seat and took a step back away from him. Then I stared at him with a contemptuous expression. If he really cared about the welfare of Ricdorian, he would have spoken with a little bit of conscience.

Sure enough, Jair looked uncomfortable at the sight of my unpleasant expression. But soon, he bowed down politely to me.

“I don’t want to fight you. Furthermore, I don’t know when we’ll be able to say hello to each other again. I can’t tell you everything that I know, but what you did meant a lot to me.” He said sincerely.

This time, he was serious.

“I’d be grateful if you’d really used the magic I gave you.”

Come to think of it, today’s not the day when the prisoners in the middle east side of Kambrakam are allowed to walk. I forgot about it because he came to me so naturally.

So was he walking around while using his invisibility magic? I guess so.

“I came here to see him even though I, myself, know that I am taking too much risk. The owner of this cell had returned, and it would be hard for me to move. This place becomes dangerous for wizards when he’s around.” He said as if he had read my mind.

He was referring to Lenag, the prison head and the owner of this place.

No matter how natural his ability to escape from jail, it's still not easy doing so.

Only then did I soften my expression a little as I felt relieved. This just proves that Ricdorian is a significant person for him. At least, I know that there is really someone who truly cares about Ricdorian.

"You walked stealthily, didn't you?" I asked.

"Yeah, but it's no big deal." Inevitably, not at all.

"Do you know how many nights of sleep I think I have lost because of that night... Well, it was such a terror! I think my lifespan has shortened because of the fright it gave me." I said. "Oh, by the way, will the prisoner be alright now?" I stared at Jair and thought of that moment when I heard Ricdorian groaning from pain inside his cell.

Jair seemed to be contemplating for a moment but soon relaxed his face.

"Yes, he'll be fine before you know it. I was impressed that you did it earlier than I planned. And by the way, this is where his initial state ends before he becomes an adult... If it wasn't for you, young lady Iana, it would have been me who would walk very late and do the spell."

Anyway, it sounded like we were waging on this. As if we were on a gamble unsure of the future. Well, if it doesn't work, I'm still going to move forward.

I sighed deeply.

It's a little too early to walk away from this situation. I'm going to finish what I started.

"What about the sudden growth?"

I briefly told Jair a summary of what happened last night. And expectedly, he listened attentively and nodded as I talked. His face gradually relaxed as

my explanation continued.

“Was that natural?” I asked.

“Yes, it’s natural that the prisoner would undergo a ‘sudden growth’ at that time. It’s a temporary phenomenon. The process of honing his body in shape means he had adapted the magic. I guess it would be convenient for you to think of what you did as a test.”

I’m glad I didn’t make a mistake.

“Yes, it’s temporary, and I’m not going to draw it anymore...” He said.

I sighed deeply, then suddenly raised my head.

That was the first time I met Jair, and I accepted his offer without much thought, but...now that we met once again, I suddenly questioned myself.

“Why me? Why did you bother giving me the spell and perform it?”

“Hmmm. Well, I didn’t expect you to ask something like that.”

He cocked his head as if asking why and smirked a little.

Why would he not expect such a question?

“I felt that you and the prisoner were so close to each other when I saw you take a walk together. And that is why I asked you to do it.”

Close to each other?... More like a woman who treats Ricdorian like a dog. But in Jair’s eyes, who said he knew everything, basically, it might look like that— as no one had the guts to approach Ricdorian except for me.

“In fact, a man who suffers from an animal’s curse does not let his guard down on anyone. To boot, I was a prisoner in the middle east side of the prison who was not allowed to approach anyone I want to and Ricdorian’s cell is inaccessible for us. Miss Iana, that prisoner lowered his guard down on you...this just means something, and you did a good job for that.”

Jair then chuckled, feeling thankful.

“Anyway, why are you helping the prisoner? Oh, this is part of my research as well.”

The wind blew, and Jair’s hair shook gently. The eyes seen between them pretended to be mischievous, but they were quite serious.

Is he going to judge me whether I am hurting Ricdorian or not?

After scratching my cheeks, I gently wrapped it with my hands and laughed.

“I want to be handsome,” I said, then I looked at Jair, who was now showing a hilarious look.

“Wow...that’s an unexpected answer.” He smiled faintly, then afterwards a blank look on his face appeared. His smile was as lifeless as a desert. And his short hair then gently shook on rhythm with the wind.

“May I ask you one more favor, then?” he asked.

“No, you can’t.”

He burst out laughing at my answer. I said no, but he acted like he didn’t hear anything and opened his mouth casually.

“If you see him again next time, will you let me know if there’s any progress?”

That was a much better request than I expected. If his request was to make me sneak in again at night, my foot was prepared to kick him in the shank.

“That’s not hard, but what kind of progress do I need to observe?”

“Just some simple changes on him. After all, the wizards have this saying that if there’s no progress, then just let it be.”

I soon nodded as an acceptance of his request. It wasn't that difficult to give him details about Ricdorian's progress.

"I'll contact you somehow. By all means." He said.

Chapter 45: Unknown Inside (2)

Chapter 45 – Unknown Inside (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

About ten minutes later, Jair went back to his cell in a hurry. He looked as if time was running after him because he quickly walked away without saying anything.

He looked so busy that it seems not the right time to talk to him. But seeing that look on his face made me curious. I definitely wanted to ask him more questions.

On my way back from the garden to my cell, I happened to meet Sally. She was on her way back from the walk just like me, and next to her was the officer-in-charge of her.

If I remember correctly, she was chatting with the female prisoners in the garden earlier. Thinking of her who has been in high-spirit these past few days, I decided to approach her.

“Sally!” I said and waved at her.

“Oh my, Iana!” Sally turned her back and looked at me with widely opened eyes when she realized it was me who called her. She glanced at the guard beside her and shooed him away as if dismissing him.

“Iana, where were you earlier?”

“Earlier?”

“I saw what happened in the garden, and, unfortunately, I didn’t find you there. Hey! “

I have forgotten that Jair used magic at that time, and she must have been caught up under it, and that’s why she hadn’t seen me.

I smiled nonchalantly and said I have a meeting with a prison guard.

“Aha, so you’ve gone upstairs, haven’t you?”

“Yes.”

Anyway, it’s a good thing she knows that I often go there, and the guard who talked to me earlier while I was in the garden wasn’t here, so she won’t know the truth where I really was.

Sally nodded, convinced.

“Right. You were a daughter from a noble family, weren’t you? I don’t know the family name, though.”

“Eyyy, I’m not.”

So a prisoner who is capable of meeting a jail warden by himself in this place meant that he came from a pretty wealthy noble family. What an idea, Sally!

“By the way, what happened? You said you were looking for me.”

I also don’t know my family name, though. But what’s the point, of course?

I looked at her with a shrug. Then Sally patted me on the shoulder.

Soon, she clapped her hands.

“That’s right!”

Suddenly, her face blushed, which in turn made me open my eyes wide. And I questioned myself, *‘Why is she doing this all of a sudden?’*

“Iana, female prisoners are all over it. You haven’t heard of it, have you?”

“What is it about?”

“A very handsome man who visited the prison caused this!”

Because there was nothing to do in prison, there was a limit to what prisoners could do. As a result, each of them developed their own hobbies, and some of the prisoners, including Sally, had a hobby of gossiping about the male prisoner’s faces.

It is called the ‘*Handsome Pursuit*’ and the ‘*Prominence Gathering*.’ In fact, this was the reason why I became acquainted with her.

“Oh my gosh! Listen!. Don’t tell me he’s more handsome than Erobs!”

Erobs is a young and handsome jail warden that female prisoners like the most.

“At first, the viscount’s wife, Aisha, said that she saw a big black carriage when she came back from the dining hall.”

“If it’s a black carriage then that means a guest?”

“Of course! Blue carriages are used for prisoners, right? And she saw someone getting off the carriage. She said she has never seen such a good-looking man in the world like that before.”

A viscount’s wife, Aisha, is a young noblewoman who is 20 years younger than her husband. She was sent to prison because of scandal rumors.

Typically, it wouldn’t be a problem to have rumors, but her husband, who was afraid of her causing any more problems between the family, sent his wife to prison to ease his mind.

What does he mean? Using the prison to cool off? Now, that’s what I call a sane husband!

I remember something as I looked up. The only best character of him, according to her, is that he draws incredibly beautiful paintings.

“Listen. Doesn’t she have a family member who likes to paint? How I wish that family member could draw what she saw, but... really.”

“Was his looks that magnificent?” I asked.

“Yes!”

I was so aware that Sally was making a fuss without any detailed explanation. She only wanted to chat.

“Well, I’m sure he’s really a person of beauty. Mrs. Aisha herself is a woman of high standards.”

I certainly didn’t seem to be a woman of high maintenance. But these people grasp the concept of family origin. The meeting was so different from that of aristocrats hanging out. Especially the fact that his own wife is an important person to him.

Sally’s chatter continued after that. Soon, after more than 10 minutes of exciting stories, our time limit slowly came. Even her guard looked at her with a sick expression.

It was when I nodded when someone shouted my name.

“Iana!” He shouted while running, then puffed. He was the one guarding my cell.

“It’s urgent.”

Looking at his worn-out look, he seemed to have been searching for me in my cell, and to any possible places, I could be. Good thing, he happened to see me chatting in the hallway.

Upon reaching us, he looked at Sally stealthily. Sally might have felt that the guard wanted to talk to me alone, so she said hello to him and bid goodbye to me afterward.

“See you again. Iana!”

Well, thanks to the guard who called me, our talk ended shortly.

I glanced at Sally, who had gone straight into her cell.

The guard watching my room was a blunt middle-aged man named Jason. He had a hard time interacting with me because I'm a female prisoner. But not only with me but for most female prisoners.

So I rarely talk to him except when I have some business.

With a little perplexed expression, he whispered in my ear.

“You are called by the inspection officer.”

Chapter 46: My Brother Came To Visit Me (1)

Chapter 46 – My Brother Came To Visit Me (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

The inspection officer?

The jail warden who whispered to me tilted his head.

Did my brother send me an item again this time? I'm kind of delighted.

Every time an item came, I would always be called by the inspection officer or by Lenag, so this kind of setup was no longer unusual for me. I thought I wouldn't be able to cope up, but surprisingly I was able to get used to it.

“Hurry up.”

The inspector general office was located on the floor above my cell, so it will take some steps before getting there.

While walking lightly on the stairs, we happen to witness a commotion taking place. At a glance from the railing, I saw a crowd of prisoners.

“Hey, Jason. Why are there so many people over there?”

“Oh... it's probably because we have a guest today. I've heard he's an important guest, but I don't know who it is.”

Kambrakam was a strict prison, but visitation was not forbidden. And most of them say that you had to pay a lot of money to take a visit here.

<All that money goes to the owner of this prison.>

When I heard Baron's words, I came to realize that Lenag was a very resourceful man. How could he make so much money that way?

Of course, some said that this prison was a national property, but Lenag's share must be of a large sum. Anyway, I don't think he's just an ordinary visitor because he was already labeled as a distinguished guest. I wonder what's his business here.

Looking once again with a light curiosity, I found a broad back that was unusually noticeable in the middle of the crowd. Not because the man was huge and fat, but because I thought that view of him was so elegant. The mere sight of his broad shoulder could make me tell that he's a stern person.

"Wow. Was that the one Sally mentioned earlier?" I muttered unconsciously.

I can slightly see the nose, but that's enough to say that he's so beautiful. He has this silhouette that will make you want to see what was in front. Wow. Even his silhouette looks refined.

He was standing in the shadows with a beret on his head, and therefore, I couldn't see the color of his hair or its detailed outline.

I just stared at the slim silhouette until it remained an after image. And only after the man disappeared, I headed to the inspection office with Jason, who thankfully waited for me.

Unexpectedly, it was Lenag who was waiting for me at the office.

Oh. I thought it was the inspection officer whom I'll be seeing today.

"Miss Iana."

Lenag, who welcomed me naturally, closed the door.

"Well, I heard you were out of town..."

While saying so, I suddenly remembered the conversation I heard from the guards on my way to Ricdorian at dawn a few days ago.

They said that despite the busy work in the capital these days, Lenag still keeps on coming back to the cell and not on his own house to rest.

...Was this cell that good? Well, I suppose it's an excellent place to stay. And comfortable enough. For me, at least.

Lenag looked at me and gave me a silent salute.

"Yes. That's right. I came back for a while. Something urgent came up, and I needed to get back here. More than that, I'm sorry."

Huh? What? What is he apologizing for?

I blinked then stared at him, and in my curious gaze, he showed me a serene smile.

"Your brother came here."

"My brother?"

I paused.

If he came here, why haven't I seen him? Moreover, why didn't he show himself to me?

"Your brother came all the way here for the first time in a while, but something came up, so he went back immediately."

He lifted the teacup and spoke.

"He came all the way to the Oval Office, but unfortunately, some unexpected things happened. I'm afraid your family has a lot of work to do."

"Ah...yes." I sighed.

I can't really do anything about that as I don't have control of our family's duties. Also, I recalled my assumption that maybe my brother is working under Chaser. He was a man who had been rolling his hands and mind with a lot of conspiracies.

I'm sure that even if he's here, his mind would still wander around all the workloads he had to do. I felt a little sorry for the burden my brother has to face with his job. Furthermore, it somewhat made me sad not to see his face.

I unknowingly twisted my hair, I laid down my eyes and looked at my hair color.

Since I have pink hair, my brother must have a similar color to mine. Iana must be a figure who did not even hear him say her name before. Soon, I made an expression that made my face look creepy.

I tried not to make it obvious, but Lenag right now was gazing at me like a mad dog but soon fixed his gaze. The sound of his tapping fingers goes well with the ticking of the clock.

"This is usually a violation of the rules; however, I can't help but say I'm responsible for you. Here it is."

My eyes widened at the sight of what Lenag had taken out.

"It's mine...?" I asked, so unsure.

Right now, I felt more absurd rather than being joyful. This is too much!

What Lenag brought out was a bouquet. If you try holding it with both hands, it occupies your entire hand. The size itself wasn't that big, but it's enough to cover my sight when being carried. But that's not really the problem here.

The only problem was that inside the bouquet are not real flowers. It was a jewel. The jewel was arranged gorgeously inside the bouquet like a flower... No, wait a minute. Can I bite this?

The center of the gem was a white flower, and the petals seem to be jewels.

I swallowed my saliva while looking at the unusual jewel.

It's about the size of four fists... Wasn't this enough to buy a house?

"... my house, it's not gonna go down, is it?"

"I doubt it. If you're referring to your family's affairs, rest assured, your brother's doing great."

No, I didn't ask about that. What I mean is that we're not going to go bankrupt with this present, right? I wanted to tell him that, but in the end decided not to.

Slowly lowering my eyes, I stared back at the bouquet that my brother had left behind for me. I took out the small letter inside it as my eyes already got tired of staring at the jewels. Not long after, I quickly opened the letter.

Chapter 47: My Brother Came To Visit Me (2)

Chapter 47 – My Brother Came To Visit Me (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

[My dear beloved sister.]

It's the neat handwriting that I've always seen.

[Instead of not seeing me today, will you look at this? A beautiful flower like you, once in a lifetime. The flower that won't wither.]

I was caught up in my illusion that these flowers would have scent even though they don't have any.

[You'll be disappointed with the withered flowers.]

I felt sorry that this letter was written after knowing that he couldn't see me. Lenag also told me that the letter was written abruptly here.

[I didn't want to see you disappointed. I only want you to have all the good things in the world.]

Soon my line of vision stopped for a moment in the last passage.

[I'll pick you up soon.]

I opened my mouth so wide that I couldn't measure it.

What the hell?! Iana's family is wealthy?

More than that... Can I take this jewel in my cell?

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I looked at the bouquet and Lenag alternately.

For the first time in my life, I received a strange, and the rarest thing I could call a jewel flower, and I don't know if I can show even a part of this to anyone. Maybe not. As receiving something like this wasn't allowed.

However, I tried to stay calm as much as possible.

“Can I take this to my room?”

As I said before, this novel's cell was very simple as what we usually see in reality. A dangling bed, a desk, and windows and curtains. But here, the curtains also look noble like the prisoners.

From the infirmary up to every single cell, everything was no different from a normal cell.

Anyway, if I keep these flowers in my room, it would certainly stand out as it's the only thing that would look stunning inside that shabby place.

“You can take it with you.” Lenag nodded lightly.

I see, so he permitted me to place this in my room, didn't he?

As I was about to nod, I opened my eyes in shock as I didn't expect him to say something in addition.

“I won't let anyone touch it because it's yours.”...No. I wasn't worried about it being robbed.

Before I knew it, I looked up to him and leaned my back slightly.

For some reason, it's like he had given me the advantage to take a good look at him as I am now seeing him at close.

He had this pair of golden eyes that were gorgeous and reasonable enough to praise him

But hold on. Those glasses... Was that a prescription? I don't think he really needed those glasses to see better. It seems like those lenses don't have grades. It looks precisely ordinary as if it's just there for fashion purposes. I suppose he doesn't really have any eye deficiencies.

"I know it's strange to ask you a question this time, but are your eyes that bad for you to use glasses?"

I don't think there was a phrase in the book about Lenag's vision.

He paused a bit when I asked him the question. It must have been an unexpected question.

"Not really. If I have to say it, I'm using this for a different reason."

Different reason? Trying to look cool? To look scary? Hmm. But I think a Lenag without glasses will look more violent.

"Just for someone... I thought I would look better with glasses."

On the contrary, the glasses seem to replace the fierceness of his eyes with coolness. But looking closely, his eyes were not really that fierce. That is because his golden iris was so pretty. It shines brightly like that of sunlight.

I smiled slightly at him. Then he stopped for some reason.

"...those flowers are too huge. It might get in your line of sight. It might be difficult for you to walk." He said. "I'll help you take them in if you want to. To avoid any trouble." He added.

"What? Oh, really? Thank you."

Surely, it was too much of a fancy bouquet of jewels just to carry. I thought I'd be the only one to take these back to my room. Still, it's good to use some lending hands.

But, I never thought he'd have such a level of caution.

"You're kind."

"Really? That's something I've never heard of." He then laughed.

A kind of laugh I would never want to hear from him. I don't know. It just seems like laughing makes him more intimidating.

Well, you could hear more of that often if you won't laugh like that, won't you?

I puffed slightly upon hearing him laugh then I laughed awkwardly along with him. This seems a little sweet, but it was still scary. In the novel, many prisoners were killed by his sword that could no longer be counted with fingers. He took part in Chaser's plot as his sidekick, and he also did not hesitate to take in cruel measures.

When I recalled those scenes, I could certainly not relax.

In the novel, he said that swordsmanship is as good as managing guards. Lenag became a ferocious man. After all, he is not that young prosecutor anymore. All his experiences made him evolve into an undefeated prosecutor.

Soon, I felt like touching my soft hair that was falling with my head down; however, I think it would be inappropriate to do so right now. He might get the wrong idea.

I know that his friendly attitude towards me was asked by my brother and father, but I felt that his kindness was too much when it comes to me. Obviously, he wasn't this pleasant to anyone from what I had read even if it was requested from him.

At this point, I am starting to wonder about my family....seriously.

"I'd like to ask you a question," Lenag said, lowering down his head.

"Don't you wonder why your brother locked you up here? I thought it was weird not to ask you this for once."

Yeah, I was just wondering about that.

Chapter 48: My Brother Came To Visit Me (3)

Chapter 48 – My Brother Came To Visit Me (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I glanced down.

“Well, at first I thought there must be a reason for this. I believe he’s not the kind of person who does things without basis.”

I think he’s a loving and caring person with the way he looks after me, sending me gifts and letters. And if he would’ve done that every day, I would certainly be convinced that my brother is a kindhearted man. No doubt at all!

I’m just not sure if this is just his way of making it up to me. He might’ve been doing all of this out of guilt for letting me be in prison, or maybe he’s just sorry for coming but not seeing me.

On the other hand, his actions might also be due to his genuine affection, which I really hope is the real reason.

“... I see. So Miss Iana still believes in her brother.”

I narrowed my eyes thinly and looked at him in subtle nuance.

Hmmm...Lenag seemed to know my brother so well from the way he talked. He appeared not swayed with my perception of my brother. No, of course, he knows him that much since my family asked him to do things for me.

Soon, I felt somewhat upset by the idea of not seeing him. But afterward, I shook my head gently. Then, the moment I raised my head, I stopped.

...when did you get so close?

The distance between the two of us was so narrow.

“Well, yeah. He’s my brother, so it’s expected for me to trust him. And uhmm...Do we really have to talk about him this close?” I said, a little bit bothered.

He paused, and his face, which turned stiff for a while, quickly moved away. It’s as if he had awakened from a daydream.

“... I’m sorry.”

“No, it’s fine.” I said, to ease the tension between us.

Hmm. This is a situation I didn’t foresee.

Soon, he parted his lips against that bewildered face.

“I will go.”

Before going, he held out a small box and hesitated for a while, but soon, he decided to put it back in his pocket.

I was about to ask him what that was, but he immediately turned his back at me.

He’s so strange today. If only he hadn’t spoken to me like this and called me out, I would’ve gone back to my cell immediately.

“...that...” What I said stopped him from his track.

He faced me, but for the first time, Lenag hesitated to look at me and then tilted his head.

Seriously, what is wrong with him?

The calm gold eyes staring at me slowly descended.

“It’s nothing.”

I felt like he wanted to say something but chose to keep it with him. His expression right now was blank, no matter how I look at it.

I stopped myself from asking more, as I don’t think he wanted to talk about it right now. Furthermore, I don’t think he will tell me what it is even if I beg him.

Soon, I unknowingly moved under his guidance. And the door was closed behind my back.

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When I returned to my room, the jewel flower was placed on my desk, and I was lost in agony.

Are they living so comfortably? My family?

I think I should start thinking more about them.

I was so easy-going inside this place, knowing that I’d know more about them once I’m released from prison. But thinking about Lenag’s attitude towards me earlier, I guess it should be best to be more aware of them. What Lenag seemed to convey earlier does not suggest that my family has anything to do with the villains in this story.

Or maybe not.

Because I’m becoming more and more convinced of the other possibility that my brother was working under Chaser.

I woke up from my thoughts and headed to the living room with the guard. The living room, which was still open for prisoners, was relaxed amidst the crowd.

“You look troubled, young friend.” As I was about to sit on the sofa, I looked up to the one who talked. And as expected, it was Baron, who sat on the opposite side.

For some reason, Sally sat rather modestly next to him. It was unusual for the two of them to be together.

“Iana, you look worried. What’s the matter?”

“There’s something that bothers me, mister. Can I ask you something? Is that okay?”

Sally and Baron were originally familiar with one another, but they became more acquainted with each other through me. In fact, aristocrats don’t know each other well, and it’s a virtue for them to pretend to know.

“Oh, if it helps you, young friend, it’s okay. Just ask me anything as much as you want.”

“And from now on, I’m going to talk about something quite interesting.” I said.

“It’s a funny thing to hear you say that, but I’m looking forward to it.”

Baron’s look turned to Sally, and Sally, who knew the meaning of that gaze, laughed.

“Do you want me in?”

Sally was a veteran lady with a long list of social parties she attended. Not to mention Baron.

“You’ve been wondering about my family, haven’t you? What do you think my family is like?”

Sally’s eyes widened as she looked at me with her chin up and lips grinning. The man who was sitting beside her was no different. Of course, I took precautions before asking them this, like a con artist.

“Oh, that’s an unexpected mystery.”

Most of the time, during my stay here in prison, I answered with a smile whenever someone asked me about my family. Of course. I didn’t know. I thought I’d find out when I got out of here. But now, I can’t just watch things with ease.

What if they really have something to do with Chaser?

I am worried because I already intended to live in peace and comfort once I’m out. And if my family really works under Chaser, that would be trouble. So now I’m trying to get some information.

It’s better to know something beforehand so I can be prepared and maybe find a way to be out of their radar and go to a faraway land.

“That’s a mystery, and I’m sure every prisoner thinks that your family background was a funny issue. Well, to be honest with you, if you’re a family member who has met the head of the guard, so maybe you’re a *Yeong-ae** who’s never been seen at this age just like with the... Einte’s of Leeman. Furthermore, some would sort of express this like a hound prisoner.”

“Oh, my. I thought so, too. I’ve already heard about this at Leeman, so I thought she might be an Einte or a hound.”

“The wife of Count Einte is a woman from the southern region. Her skin is a little dark. And she used to say she looked like her daughter. So maybe she’s not the child they are talking about.”

I made sure my smile didn’t fade as their conversation deepened. As if I really had an idea of what they were talking about. But later on, I turned my head quickly.

The Eintes was situated in Leeman, and most of the hound prisoners were of Marquess’...If that’s the case, then ‘*Iana*’ must be a family member of at least a count.

* *Yeong-ae* – an honorific term for a noble daughter.

TLN:

Hi all,

This is to inform you that starting next week chapter release rate will be reduced to 3 (friday, saturday, sunday). But there will be times when I update 4-5 chapters whenever I can translate more in my free time.

I would really appreciate your understanding. Thank you and have a nice day.

Sincerely,

SKAIS

Chapter 49: My Brother Came To Visit Me (4)

Chapter 49 – My Brother Came To Visit Me (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

According to Baron, the criterion for a noble prisoner to see the prison head is the size of the territory, but the minimum size of that territory was already set. The vastness of that was not just limited to the dimensions of the land because it should cover everything, including wealth and properties. That's how they were graded. So, it must really be so challenging to set an appointment with the prison head.

In other words, the door to the prison head's office relies on the wealthy hands of a prisoner. And I felt that it was quite disgraceful for every nobleman to be distinguished by the prison head using that means.

Outside, being judged by jail wardens who are familiar with you was also not a good thing, especially for those who don't have wealthy relatives in the outside world.

If you are not well-off, then you are just as powerless as a baby pup. That's probably why prisoners pay more attention to those knights who often meet with the prison head.

That's good, I think. At least it means that some prisoners have a long-term precaution.

It wasn't precisely a problem for me, though. I know that.

I listened to their conversation, and I hurriedly gave them a small hint of what I know for now.

But by this time our free time in the living room was slowly reaching its limit.

I grinned at those who wanted answers from me.

And when I was about to open my mouth, Ghanshu called out. ‘*All, go back!*’ indicating that it was the end of the free time.

“Oh, my. Should we postpone your answer for the next meeting?”

I smiled at the two sad and discontented faces.

I'm sorry. I'm also not sure who my family is.

Fortunately, they returned to a rather intriguing look.

In fact, exciting things were rare in a slightly dull and free cell. Thinking about our situation right now, I guess it is terrible that things ended quickly.














































“Iana, you look happy.” On my way back to my cell, I answered with a smile to a friendly guard’s question.

I certainly felt better today than the other days. To be honest, I really liked the jewel flower.

“Yes, I got a very nice present.”

“Oh, from the brother?”

“Yeah, that’s right.”

When I came back to the room, I greeted the gatekeeper and walked in. I opened the drawer with the flowers on my desk. Taking out one of the piled-up empty letters, I wrote quickly.

Earlier, I asked Baron and Sally because I was curious and was expecting a plausible answer. However, their opinions, which are well-versed in aristocratic physiology, may be close to the answer, but they were not enough for me to know the truth.

And from the beginning, I already thought of another way.

And since I am inquisitive about my family, right? Then I will resort to the fastest method I can only think of.

[Brother, what kind of family are we?]

Looking at the letter satisfactorily, I mailed it the next day...with pride.

How many days will it take to receive a reply?

While waiting for the letter, I was thinking of going to see Ricdorian inside his cell. But, first of all, I think it's going to be hard since it's already late.

"I'll go and visit him tomorrow."

And so, the next day, I headed to the basement stairs.

"I think you have gone the wrong road, Miss." However, I had no choice but to stop. It was because several guards blocked my way in front of the basement stairs.

I blinked at the face of the guards I saw for the first time. I thought I saw most of the guards' faces in my district, but I realized I don't know them at all.

Soon, I smiled serenely.

"Well, I see. I think I took the wrong road. It happens sometimes. So, where was the dining hall?"

"It's on the left. This area here is so complicated that you need to have a guard for guidance."

They looked at my prison uniform and slightly relaxed their expressions. The shapes of the prison uniforms were different in each section. Most guards were relatively generous and kind to prisoners in our section because that is where most of the aristocrats were designated.

Sometimes, without a guard, it's easy enough to slip through this area.

Looking at them, I could tell that they must have believed my excuse of going to the dining hall.

But I was aware this time that I must have judged that the risk of going to Ricdorian's cell is not that great.

"Thank you. But...did something happen? I don't think I've seen you before."

"Ah...yes. It's not classified. We are guards from the West wing side of Kambrakam. By the way, this is an underground area where the worst criminals are imprisoned... and it looks like there was an intruder a few days ago."

'...intruders?' I flinched.

Something didn't feel right. I felt a strange sense of dampness at the back of my neck.

The west wing is home to prisoners with the most oppressive quality of crime, including murder, arson, and treason. It was a place with the strictest surveillance and worse environment than any other section.

Besides, a strange guard said the underground area was the place to detain the worst criminals, but in fact, the basement was occupied by Ricdorian alone. It's the only space that was allocated for the Hel family.

Originally, Lenag's family was a neutral faction that managed this prison cell for generations, so they allocated this space for the wealthiest nobles. But Lenag abandoned neutrality and joined hands with Chaser

“I’m so scared of intruders. What kind of accident would happen here... right? I’m scared...”

“Oh, no. You don’t have to worry about anything. You’re in the safest area. However, they say that an intruder’s *‘item’* was found next to the prisoner in this basement.”

“Ah...That. I see.”

I felt another cold sweat flowing on my nape. I tried to maintain my composure while trying not to expose my agitation.

Maintaining a nonchalant smile, I bid goodbye and turned my back to the last minute. Then suddenly my ears slightly turned red, it was as if the guard, who was looking at me while smiling, dyed it.

I didn’t have the time to spare, Oh my gosh!

But wait a minute. I’m sure...

I gave Ricdorian a hair tie, didn’t I?

The intruder...Was it I?

As of the moment, my hands were moist.

Chapter 50: You...Why are you doing this to me? (1)

Chapter 50 – You...Why are you doing this to me? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I remembered I once had left two blankets in Ricdorian's cell before. But I already spoke with Hans regarding that and asked him to retrieve those blankets I left behind.

<Okay, I'll take the ones that you left. But can't we go somewhere else and talk?>

And that's exactly what Hans was good at, doing favors but of course with an exchange. Also, I promised him that I'll never leave anything behind for Ricdorian again.

It was because there's a rule that special prisoners should not be given any convenience. That's why afterward, I didn't bring him a new blanket, although every time I see him in that specific situation, I would always feel sympathy.

But that day, I forgot about the rules and the promise I made, the moment I saw his seemingly pitiful appearance, who looked like a person who had lost his soul...like a fool in the streets.

I stood still in the middle of the corridor as my head was about to burst with all the various complex thoughts shuffling in my mind. When suddenly, a guard who passed by asked if I was okay. I just answered him back with a smile and continued with my track.

As a matter of fact, I was more concerned about Ricdorian than the tie I had left that could pinpoint me as the intruder.

What if I put him at a disadvantage? What if he would suffer the consequence of my carelessness?

I stared blankly in the air and thought of that cell he was in. The treatment he received here was not appropriate already, what more with the regulations I had broken.

I shook my head and sighed. I shouldn't be thinking negatively.

"Everything will be okay. Everything will end in a good way. Really..." I said, convincing myself.

In just a blink of an eye, time seemed to pass by very quickly. I don't know what kind of spirit I have today. Maybe a lifeless soul? Since, I have been so down recently.

I didn't realize I fell asleep, and surprisingly, it was already dark. The moment I noticed the moon hovering out of the window, I felt nauseous.

"...in my room, I can tell whether it's day or night." Clearly, because there's a window. I mused sarcastically.

After minutes of deep thoughts, I eventually got up. I opened the drawer and took out the bracelet that Jair gave me.

I didn't get an opportunity to give it back to him. And I assumed this was something I would never use nor take out of the drawer again.

<Just in case something arises, each jewel can be used four times. Oh, I'll double the opening order so you can't make mistakes.>

The magic for door opening and the invisible magic was used twice that day. I only used the sleep spell once. And therefore, I can still make use of all the magic.

I promptly grabbed the bracelet and popped a sigh out. I've made up my mind.

"So...yeah. Let's see if he's all right."

Just once. I only want to know if everything's fine. I really couldn't stay still whenever I remember the captivating face of Ricdorian full of tears.

The guards in the West wing are almost entirely different from the guards I see every day. They were senior knights.

Recalling the guard patrolling the stairs made me bite my lower lip. They seemed more intimidating...stronger and powerful.

They said senior knights were rough. I guess it's because they're dealing with vicious criminals.

What if Ricdorian was treated roughly than before?

My heart swiftly felt like it was stabbed, but I just shrugged that feeling off.

"Just to confirm." I told myself repeatedly just to defend what I am about to do.

I opened the door and moved into the hallway. There was no one in the corridor at dawn. Same situation a few days ago when I tried to go to Ricdorian's cell.

But no, a guard was patrolling on the other end of the hall. Shortly, an idea came up. I decided to make fun of him because, after all, he wouldn't see me.

My heart was jittery.

Fortunately, when I came down the stairs, I didn't encounter people like what happened before, which almost gave me a heart attack.

And in front of the stairs, I picked up one of the rolling stones. Afterward, when I walked all the way to the basement stairs, I gawked at the guard,

who was also one of those who were patrolling earlier in the morning.

...fortunately, there is only one guard right now. I was relieved by the sudden change in number. That's great. At least I only have to worry about one.

I was fiddling the stone, and I threw it forward as hard as I could. And that's what I call a perfect throw!

The guard turned his head at the fallen sound of the stone that just hit him.

"...what is it?"

The guard tilted his head for a while, and afterward, he wandered to the place where the stone fell. I made sure it was far away from where I am.

I waited for him to go through the shrubs, and then I quickly ran down the stairs. I almost stumbled in a hurry. Good thing, I got support from the walls and safely arrived in front of the bars. And to my surprise, there was no one in front of the cage.

Hans was not here?

Perhaps, Hans' seat was left empty for now, and therefore Ricdorian was guarded from the stairs. I'm sure they had presumed it wouldn't be a problem since a senior knight was safeguarding the stairs.

In any case, I'm glad this befell.

But isn't this a little sloppy? However, I just shook my head. I shouldn't concern myself with that; rather, I must hurry and see Ricdorian.

I opened the bars moderately, which created a minimal noise, in order not to draw any watch man's attention. After opening the bars, I closed it but not entirely, just enough for the guard to see at first glance that it looked like it was entirely close.

But why does it feel like going to his cell was like walking in an unending path? It's giving me stress.

Soon, I put down my hand that happened to hold a lamp.

The boy's face was revealed under the dim light shed by the lamp. And this time anew, my eyes were parched.

"Iana." I paused because he called me.

"How did you know it was me?" I said as I broke free from the spell.

And because I was in a hurry, I just came to the realization that I had come too close to him.

Forthwith, the chains moved roughly. Now, he had captured me and it was too late for me to escape from his grasp.

Chapter 51: You...Why are you doing this to me? (2)

Chapter 51 – You...Why are you doing this to me? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

But after a while, he drew back his hand.

The boy with round eyes smiled at me. And seeing that gorgeous smile against the backdrop of scarlet light made me speechless for a second.

“...you smell like it.” He answered. “...you.”

“Your own...scent.” He added, finishing his sentence.

I blinked as I looked at him holding my hand and bringing it to his lips. He always looked dirty and handsome at the same time.

Unbelievably, his actions, which I sometimes mistook as something sensual, would still be covered by his innocent look. Well, a devil’s work can sometimes be masked with an impeccable face of an angel.

An angel and a devil.

...which one is he, by the way?

Hmm...Since his actions prevailed, for now, I presumed it was the opposite side.

“Well, I’m glad that you are trying to welcome me. But you’re touching my hand. Do you like me that much?” I said, teasing him.

“...what? What?”

“It’s a joke.”

But then, he shook me off. And the white face glowed as if red flowers were blooming.

Oh, so it’s his rational side.

*You don’t even know what you did because you were so happy to see me?
But why do you look at me like I’m the perpetrator again?*

I’m not the guilty man here. Besides, I didn’t do anything to you. You’re the one who touched me.

I rolled my eyes.

“Don’t look at me like that. That’s too much. Don’t you know how much I’ve struggled just to come here.”

“Oh, me, I, I, impure? I am not!”

“Excuse me? Who said what?”

I’m glad he’s on his rational side because he wouldn’t do harmful things to me.

Holding his chin, I turned his face around.

...That doesn’t seem like a scar, right?

His hands, feet, and neck were all intact. There were no new wounds right now, only those scars left from his family members’ torture not long ago. Thanks to the medicines I requested from my brother, he got better. I’m relieved.

I can finally be able to calm down now that I had checked him thoroughly.

“...surprised.” Ricdorian said.

I would be upset if something big really happened, especially with the unusual turn of events here. But thinking about it right now, the cell won't be too bad for Ricdorian to stay.

Anyway, as what I've read from the book, Lenag pretends to remain neutral to both sides. So it only means that it would have been a bit impossible for him to treat Ricdorian, the Archduke's son, without any care.

And no matter how much the Archduke throws Ricdorian away, he would always remain as the symbol of Hel as long as he suffers from that curse.

Yeah. I knew I was hasty, but... I don't think I would be able to get over it. I'm a sheep that has given a lot of affection to this male lead, who flinches whenever I touch him.

I'm afraid. Because the more I come close to you, the more I'll get you into trouble, so you better run away. But No. Actually, you can run to me. Run to me, all you want. I will always welcome you with open arms. That's the only thing I can do for you. Nothing more.

"I'm sorry."

"What?"

"You might have a hard time because of me. Of course, it may not come. But, I felt a little remorseful because there might be a possibility."

This is a complicated world, I should be cautious while living comfortably here. I should be more mindful of my actions as it could possibly harm other people.

Ricdorian, who shyly looked at me, grabbed my fingertips.

So he advanced now, huh? I smirked.

Before it's only the hem of my clothes that he touches, now, he had leveled up to my fingertips? How unpredictable.

I felt the warmth of his fingertips, and soon he spoke.

“Will...you still come?”

Raising his head, his crystal bright eyes, which captured mine, reflected my startled face.

“Tomorrow and then the day after it. Continue in the future. Come here. Then, I am willing to get beaten all day. I’ll endure it all... “...what?

I shut his mouth with my hands as soon as he tried to add more. He frowned because of my sudden action, and his round eyes opened so wide.

I’m sorry, but what are you trying to say?

“What are you talking about? What the heck! Why do you think I brought those medicines? Are you going to waste my effort like that?”

“Mumbling.”

“I won’t listen to any of your excuses. You’re a bad child.”

Then his eyes narrowed thinly. It’s a disgruntled gaze. Perhaps he wanted to say that he is no longer a child, he was acting like a kitten screaming.

Acting like a child but wanting to be treated like a grown-up. He’s so confusing.

After a long silence, I let go of him. I was so amazed by the fact that he was stronger than me but he didn’t force himself to get away from me.

“Don’t say any more weird things. You understood it, right?”

Ricdorian’s face reddened. He looked at me with sad eyes, which made me avert my gaze.

Does he know that every time he does that, it’s utter torture for me?

I guess not.

I can’t really stand that look on his face.

His eyes showed a trace of dejection, and his reddened face looked like it was screaming words he can't express out of sorrow. I felt like my heart was being squashed until it's out of blood.

"Now, are you going back?"

"No. I'm just here to talk today. There's still some time."

After saying those, I looked at the time and quickly decided; I could stay a little longer.

Then, his face lit up. A bright blush of red flushed in his cheeks.

"You said you've been stuck here since you were 10."

So far, I've been a little excited and short-spoken, but I quickly changed my tone as usual.

"Well, before that, you were at home or whatever you call that place?" Oh, please, Iana... stop. You've been asking too much.

Ricdorian has this contrasting image of a child who seemed to be ignorant of everything but spoke more straight and continuous than expected.

That might be a figure that lived in the grand mansion, right? A kind of Ricdorian that no one's ever seen in this cell.

"So, was there someone nice in your mansion? A good man, perhaps." Thinking about it, I just couldn't seem to cease myself from asking.

Right now, Ricdorian, who was looking at me, slowly descended his eyes and parted his lips.

"You know, it was...my uncle. It's Merida."

The name alone did not tell what kind of person he was, whether he was a knight or a nobleman or a poet, but the look of Ricdorian seemed peaceful for the first time.

“And here, you’re the best person.”

I guess so. I’m the only one you’ve ever met here that didn’t hurt you.

The guards would not have been ‘*people*’ to him. I smiled warmly at him as I could see how he felt.

“I see.”

However, Ricdorian, who grabbed my clothes, hurriedly opened his mouth.

“Well, I’m telling you. All the time. I am just thinking about you.”

“Thinking?”

“That and...”

He closed his eyes and shouted.

“All of it. It grows whenever I think of you!”

Wait.... what?!

Grows?...WHERE?!

Chapter 52: You...Why are you doing this to me? (3)

Chapter 52 – You...Why are you doing this to me? (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I wanted to shout back and ask, but I couldn't say anything. Right now, I was in deep shock because of what he just uttered.

If you ask me why, well, I think you'll get a stern answer.

To be honest, I think everyone knew that no matter how pure and innocent a man's heart is, there is always that glint of evil residing inside of it. This is what I discerned after hearing Ricdorian's statement.

But since I am a good adult in this new and unfamiliar setting I'm in, I just slowly pretended to skim the floor, avoiding the attractive gaze of Ricdorian.

Was he even aware of what he had spoken in the first place?

Ugh.

I need to think of good thoughts...Good thoughts and good life angles. Iana, think of rainbows and unicorns and restrain yourself.

I said it 20 times in my head. And when I turned back to Ricdorian, my eyes met those blue eyes still gazing towards me. As a matter of fact, it seemed like he didn't take his eyes off me.

Staring at the tantalizing display made me wonder.

How could his eyes be so blue?

It was so blue that I felt like I'm diving at the bottom of a deep-sea where all those mythical creatures dwell.

We kept our stare with each other, and this time, I didn't even try to avoid his gaze, rather, I faced him straight. However, after a few seconds, Ricdorian's cheeks flushed red in embarrassment. He immediately averted his eyes and parted his lips. Even his ears were as red as the eyes of a rabbit.

"Don't look at me like that."

What? So you can freely stare at me, while I can't?

"Why?"

"Well, that's because it's getting bigger!"

Oh....

So... where is that really?

I want to hear as much detail as possible regarding that but...I can't. Yeah, it's just not possible. I know this boy is only two years younger than me, but still! He's younger than me! That would be bad.

This time, I kind of hesitated whether I should ask for more words of enlightenment or not, but fortunately, Ricdorian opened his mouth first.

"When I think of you, my arms and my legs keep on... I feel like I'm getting bigger. My fingers are also getting longer."

Ohhh...

"...Okay? Anything else?" I asked curiously.

"The other thing..."

For some reason, in the end, he hesitated, and his cheeks turned redder than before. His mumbling mouth murmured more, and therefore I could not hear the last part.

I didn't know if it was a part of his body or not, but I think he talked about something. Something that would be best not to hear.

Oh no. No!

As I tried to erase my lecherous thoughts, I lifted my hand and let my chin rest on it. My imagination was getting more and more creative that I needed to splash myself with holy water to be cleansed.

“So, to sum it up. When you think of me, you feel like you're getting bigger.” I said hastily to stop him from feeding more ideas to my dirty imagination.

“Eh? Yes...”

“Have you already tried experimenting with the capabilities of your new form? Well, I needed to examine you and measure the changes you've undergone by asking you questions. From your arms to your...everything.”

Ricdorian shook his head. He blinked naively and tilted his head like a dog. He looked like he was clueless.

“I... didn't think about that.”

I took my eyes off him and looked all over the prison. The walls looked like it was made of bricks, so it might not be difficult to check his body measurement changes or do the experiment.

And as I glanced back at him, I realized that he didn't really seem to have any idea with the experiment.

“By the way, have you been awake all day?”

Come to think of it; it seems like he never falls asleep.

Then, the thought of our first meeting crossed my mind. That's the only time I saw him asleep. Was it just by chance that every time I visited him, he was awake or... maybe not?

“When do you sleep?”

I've never seen you asleep. Do you usually not rest well?

“That...I don't usually sleep. And now, I don't want to sleep.”

“You don't want to sleep? Why?”

Ricdorian, who had been struggling to answer me, lowered his head for a moment but soon lifted it to talk.

“When I fall asleep, I can't see you.”

His blue eyes caught me. But the eye-to-eye contact didn't last long. It was because the young man, who blushed, lowered his head once again.

Then, he bit his lips hard.

“What.... what if the moment I close my eyes, you'll be gone? What if you'll leave me once I'm asleep? What if you're going to disappear just like that?” He said as if the thought and possibility that those things might have happened pains him.

Oh...

I was shocked. I can't find the right words to say.

His hand beside mine slowly approached me. But unable to reach mine, his hands were left hanging in the air.

I knew that a man's body could turn red when feeling certain emotions; I just didn't expect that it would include a man's fingertips.

“...are you going now?”

His fingers, which were turned red only at the tips, looked even redder compared to my pale hand.

As a matter of fact, I felt sick after I woke up.

And because of that, my fingers were boney and lean, and the skin was so pale. But it wasn't too hard for me to move around despite being sick. I can manage it.

Soon, I rolled my eyes.

His embarrassment quickly disappeared, and indifference filled the place.

Hey, isn't it necessary to turn on the hazard before turning or changing direction? That's most likely the basic rule of driving! He should've at least made some warning signs whenever his mood's going to change. What an unpredictable man!

Right now, Ricdorian displays himself like a man as beautiful as a lily flower moistened with water. A lily has this beauty that blooms in the daytime but hides itself at night. And even though it doesn't live for a long time,* still, it is perfect during its lifetime.

The only difference Ricdorian and this flower have was that even though Ricdorian's time to bloom fully hasn't come yet, he's already as beautiful as a blossomed lily in it's right time. So if that's currently the case, what more would he become a few years from now?

As a matter of fact, I've seen it once before.

He was so mature that time that he can be considered a super sexy dynamite**, but I turned my head away and brought out a rather childish expression.

"I'm not going right now."

*Vase life of lilies is around 10-14 days

*****Dynamite*** – a slang term defined as outstanding, super dangerous or powerful

P.S. Previous comments were accidentally removed because of the changes I did for the chapter. I am sorry. 🙄

Chapter 53: You...Why are you doing this to me? (4)

Chapter 53 – You...Why are you doing this to me? (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

As of the moment, I looked at my watch. To speak of, this watch was an item I brought to this room and one of the few *'Iana'* items.

I wonder why a lady from a noble family, like her, used such an old thing, but it's quite helpful because I could track the time.

There was something inscribed on the back of it, but the words were so hard to recognize because it was scratched with a knife. But I guess she treasures this because this must also be given to her by the man she called *'brother'*.

The reason I brought the watch here was because I had set a time on when I will get out of his cell. As far as I know, the timing of the shifting of guards was constant. This was applicable even with the newly assigned guards. And that would be around 4:00 a.m. at dawn, just before sunrise. So, in other words, it was time for me to get out of Ricdorian's cell quietly.

And at this moment, I still have lots of time to spare here inside this young man's cell.

I put my watch back in my pocket and looked at Ricdorian.

“But, of course, I have to go before dawn.”

Come to think of it, I've been looking after him a lot, and therefore, I haven't had the time to relax and enjoy my own leisure time at ease and in

peace.

So far, I avoided attracting any guards' attention, so I had little time to spare for him.

"I still have some time left. Aren't you excited?"

"Yes. What?"

"You're happy I'm not going, or is it just me who thinks like that."

I said it in a playful tone and glanced at him, but somehow, Ricdorian, who was staring at me, rolled his eyes. Those glassy eyes rolled down like a surfer riding on the waves of the blue sea.

Nod.

Soon, Ricdorian nodded and wiggled his fingers, thinking that I couldn't see it.

"I...I like it."

Before I knew it, Ricdorian's hand slightly held the edge of my dress. I turned my head and pretended not to see him instead of taking it away.

What is this man doing?

With this cuteness, I would definitely have a heart attack.

I was a little worried about letting go of his hand, but I decided to let it stay there and leaned back a little bit.

"Since we still have some time, let's talk."

"Ta..talk? About what?"

"Well, I haven't thought of any topic so far."

I glanced at the hem of my clothes; he was clutching and put up my legs and rested my chin on top of it. Then, my hand unconsciously extended towards him.

He was startled.

Soon, I touched his head.

Ricdorian's hair was so fluffy like cotton candy. I touched him without thinking, but my urge to keep my hands away from him completely disappeared.

The reason why I acted so natural was because I already did this many times during his walk schedule and there were also times that I unintentionally tamed him when he was a beast.

<Puppies liked being touched and caressed! I've raised one, so I know it very well.>

A guard, who said he had a lot of dogs in his household, told me. He also said that when they listen well or behave accordingly, you have to give them compliments.

“Good boy.”

I thought it might be challenging to deal with him right now as his rational side was awake. I thought I might struggle or encounter some trouble doing this kind of action, but for some reason, Ricdorian remained still.

But not totally. Earlier, Ricdorian shrugged his shoulders, but that was it. There were no more reactions after that.

Currently, his back was facing the guard's room with a small lamp. And under the pale scarlet luminescence of the lamp and the twilight dawn light the moon emitted, his hair radiated a slightly silvery-blue color.

I took my hand off his head as I felt a little strange with the atmosphere. And a moment of regret passed through his azure eyes.

“Then I will tell you what I was talking about earlier. I’m also sorry for telling you that you might get in trouble because of me.”

I came here because I was worried about him. Because everything’s my fault.

“What do you mean *‘because of you’*?”

“Do you remember the hair tie I gave you?”

I smiled despite feeling sorry. Because that’s where it started.

“You must have noticed someone entered your room because of the hair tie I gave you. But I don’t think the guard I’m close to exposed me. Besides, the guards must have assumed that there was an intruder among the jail wardens.”

Hans might look like an insensitive person, but he didn’t speak. It was the right thing he should do, though. Because if he brought up my story of going in Ricdorian’s cell, then he was just like putting himself in trouble as we would have had to bring out the cigarettes and other items he received from me.

Moreover, as long as I am a noble prisoner who is not treated as an ordinary one, it will be his loss once he reveals that I was bribing him and the other guards. Well, my items are initially for bribing, but...

“Anyway, my fault is done and impossible to be fixed, and for that, I am really sorry.” Ricdorian gently shook his head.

It was a determined gesture.

“...it is not your fault.”

It seemed that he was giving me strength using his hand that was holding my clothes.

“Speaking of what you gave me, I was more...scared because of the emptiness of this place. And the hair tie was new to me, I like it.”

“What do you mean?”

“You can think of it like...” He said and then paused for a moment.

So does that mean he also wanted it? That he found comfort in it? I have been told that children liked soft stuff because it was good for emotional development.

“If I have those things, I don’t have to look at the blank wall.” He added.

But it was so unlikely for this man, who was a victim of child abuse and torture, to think that way. I didn’t know that a mere hair tie would mean so much for him, so I felt a little moved with the way he had given it importance.

For this man, a day in this cell is just another ordinary day that would pass by quickly. It would always be the same for him until the day I appeared.

In other words, I was a tiny glass of water that appeared before someone who was suffering from thirst. You can moisten your lips, but you can’t quench your thirst.

Furthermore, in order for this man’s life to become happy, he must resolve the curse, and the time to unravel it will be quite a while. And I’m not the one who could solve it. Of course, even if it’s not a curse, I could fill some of the man’s emotional thirst, but I chose not to.

“By the way, you haven’t changed for quite a while today? Isn’t that a new record?”

I laughed as I remembered that his personality hasn’t changed today and brought up that new topic. Ricdorian looked at me and saw his slightly stammering lips, but soon he looked down.

“That’s... I don’t know. It’s just...”

“Just?”

His lips barely moved, and his ears were flushed red that looked like a red flower.

“I...I want you to remember me a little more... with this look...”

Chapter 54: Don't you feel uncomfortable changing all of a sudden?

Chapter 54 – Don't you feel uncomfortable changing all of a sudden?

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

Since then, Ricdorian, who seemed to have wanted to say something, hesitated. I could hardly hear what he muttered at the end. It was as if his voice was stuck in his throat.

Anyway, you don't know why you're flipping into animal mode at some point, do you?

“Well, you don't know why, do you? I think it would be more convenient for you if you knew what situation you're in or the cause of your sudden changes.”

I knew for sure that even Ricdorian would feel uncomfortable whenever he shifts. He's still a human, after all.

“...uhh...”

“...say what?”

Ricdorian, who was now hugging his shoulder tightly, raised his head and tilted it a little. When swiftly....

“Arff?”

Hearing him, I burst into laughter.

...Ha! Look at this.

You've changed suddenly, didn't you?

Those eyes gawking at me were very innocent, like a newborn child, sinless, and untainted.

However, when I looked closely, I felt something unusual.

It was like the pure feeling I sensed earlier was gone as fast as the wind.

Ah, Ricdorian, who was now a beast version of himself, didn't bark at me but strode towards me.

"No, don't bite."

"Arff?"

I quickly pulled my leg back.

And for some reason, Ricdorian, who had been biting the end of my clothes, looked like he was about to cry. It might be possible that stepping back away from him made him feel like that. He must've concluded I abhorred being near him.

"I won't get close to you if you bite. Instead, I'll go back to my cell."

Whimpered.

"...Do you understand?"

...I doubt he understood it clearly. But he did what I said. So I assumed he grasp situations through instincts?

I wish you could just tell me what you're buying here.

I was about to sigh when I suddenly remembered what was in my pocket.

I didn't plan on bringing these from the beginning, but... There were still snacks left in my pockets. Good timing!

When I opened the pouch I grabbed inside, Ricdorian's eyes sparkled like fireworks in a New Year's sky.

Hmmm. You like what you see, huh?

"I'll give you a snack before I go."

It's been quite a while, and it was about time for me to get ready to go back. I stepped back a little and narrowed the distance between my two hands, peeled off the bag of candies. But when I was about to tear it apart.

Grip.

I was startled because Ricdorian's hand held mine tightly. I almost loosen my hold on the bag.

Is he back? Is Ricdorian sane now?

"What's wrong?" I questioned.

"...."

However, there was no response from him. It was a little uncanny. Only then, I was able to apprehend what was happening after observing him.

His breathing was a little rough. It was as if he was having a hard time doing so.

Then, it wasn't just a strange feeling. He was sick!

Surprised, I grabbed him by the cheeks to check his temperature.

He's hot, right? He's literally boiling hot right now!

A few minutes ago, he was still fine. But now, he looked pale as if color had left his body, and his complexion wasn't that red as he usually is... This is

worse than a person who has a very high fever. I just couldn't figure out what this is.

"Sigh..."

While grabbing my hand tightly, he leaned his head. I couldn't even push him away because I could feel his suffering from his rough breathings on my shoulder.

Oh no. Are you seriously that sick?

The thought of Ricdorian going through the same situation flashed in my mind. Yes. That time when I was doing the spell of Jair. He also felt this sick.

But I didn't think this state would happen during his beast mode. Is it possible? That he's going through the process of having the form of that Ricdorian four years from now?

Because as I recall, he was in his rational condition when his changes occurred before.

On which side does this really occur? I'm so confused.

It was a moment when I was contemplating whether to touch his hair or not. I wanted to ease his pain but..

Wait a minute.

...was Ricdorian's body this big?

The hand that was holding me was bigger than I remembered. And his shoulders were so broad that it felt like he immersed himself in doing physical training.

Everything was so strange that I was so unsure of what to do. Why was I not able to notice this?

He was no longer a boy in a loose prison uniform.

Soon, the young man with a figure of an adult slowly lifted his head. He looked full-grown like that of Ricdorian 4 years from now, hunk and sturdy.

I swallowed a lump as I saw those strangely long eyelashes and gorgeous eyes up close.

Hey, it's close. It's very close!

"...are you going to give it to me?"

"Eh, what?"

"Are you going to give it to me? That's what I asked."

He moved his red lips to lift the corners of his mouth.

"Well, I mean...Master?" What? No. That's not it. Absolutely not that.

"No. Iana." I said sternly.

"Oh... yes, that's it. Iana."

He kept saying my name over and over again, making sure that he would never forget it.

The hotness of his body hadn't receded yet, and his bloodshot eyes had been burning. His whole being right now created an odd feeling.

"That, are you going to give it to me?"

I nodded while alternately looking at the candy and his face...more like a bewildered nod.

I was thinking of giving this to him swiftly and then leave him. But I doubt that will happen.

My hand that was on Ricdorian's cheek was now held captive. And he held me steady using his other hand, then tilted his head as it was.

And his sweaty silver hair shakes.

What a beautiful sight!

Ugh! The more I stay here, the more I become enthralled by his enchanting beauty.

He grabbed the bag of candy from me, placed his hand on one side and the other on his mouth. And the bag of candy was torn open.

Why do you have to open it with your mouth? You could use your hands, you know.

I wanted to say that, but I know it would be useless as it's already been done.

Soon, the decadent atmosphere made me shut up.

Afterward, his eyes bent lightly.

“Now, because I ripped it off. You can feed me, right?”

...Yeah, right, and then I would return to my cell to sleep.

“...okay, eat it.”

I moved my hands in defeat and was about to feed him. But I stopped. As there was no need to do so at all, for he already did the job himself.

He moved his head, opened his mouth, and bit the candy with his teeth.

I happened to see this sight close, and I felt skeptical for a while, so I immediately tried to pull my hands out.

If only he hadn't caught me again.

“Are you going back now?”

The animal-like glare was half languid.

Why does it feel like I should be careful of what to answer him?

“... I’m going to sleep now.” I said.

“Yes. Go to sleep.” Ricdorian said, still staring at me.

And soon, a low voice whispered to me. “Here.”

Chapter 55: Don't you feel uncomfortable changing all of a sudden? (2)

Chapter 55 – Don't you feel uncomfortable changing all of a sudden? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

The moment I heard it, I stepped back. It was almost an instinctive action. And fortunately, because of a bit of unusual luck, I was able to escape quickly, perhaps due to his carelessness.

I turned around, opened the cage, and got out. The chain was clanging so hard that I'm afraid it could be heard from the outside.

I knew it was because Ricdorian wanted me to get back, but I decided to leave him behind that iron gate without looking back.

I didn't forget to lock the iron door although I was in a hurry, and my mind was still thinking about what happened. Above all, I should no longer make mistakes that would harm him in the end. I learned my lesson.

However, my mind was still messed up like all of my thoughts had been merged by a blender.

Regardless of this, I have to go back to my cell.

That's right, I should go back and lie down and sleep tight. Then, forget about what happened tonight as fast as I can.

However, I decided to lean my back against the wall and took a breath first instead of going up the stairs. Then I thought that my decision to visit Ridorian wasn't a bad idea after all.

But I kept remembering it.. The thing that just happened.

Ugh! So much happened tonight.

Oh my gosh, I need to think of good thoughts and good life angles again right now.

But at this point, I thought there might be a problem with the male lead's behavior that causes him to do things sensually. However, I pondered more on it and told myself that such things could not be blamed on the curse and torture victim, who had a very different mindset from evil criminals.

After thinking for a moment, I took my back off the wall. Now, all I have to do is get out of this underground cell safely.

All set, the magic of transparency was now applied, and then I climbed up the stairs. I should practice myself never to leave any trace amidst my chaotic mind.

Maybe I should get out of prison and get a job as a spy or an undercover agent. I guess that's a good plan.

But

“...no.”

I should get out of this prison and live somewhere else where I wouldn't be caught up in the dispute between the two families. Yeah, I'm going to live far away, peacefully and happily.

Although I don't know how this new world I'm in works, I am not a criminal, and I think I don't have any disadvantages in searching for a job.

I deliberately thought about those and sighed heavily.

“...Is there anyone?”

When I listened, I could not feel any signs of people near the basement entrance. Maybe I was right. It was time to shift guards now.

All right. I was wondering if I should wait for a little, but I guess it's all good now.

I poked my head out every time to check if there was no one in the hallway. But only the halls, torched by the light of dawn, which already seemed to be nearing morning, welcomed me.

I checked thoroughly before I walked out. Then, I strode silently as I could, taking small steps.

...I should go back to my cell like this.

Somehow it was a long night. I breathed out a little and closed my lips tightly. It was when I took a step further.

Step.

I heard footsteps approaching from around the corner, not in front but behind me.

I wanted to look back, but I stopped because I thought I would make a noise. And at this moment, the sound of footsteps was getting closer from a distance.

No, the pace was so relaxed and fast that it seemed to be getting closer quickly.

...what should I do? Should I move fast, or should I wait for him to pass me by?

Either way, standing in the middle is a bad thing. And for some reason, I couldn't move my body comfortably.

It was because I was nervous about the heavy sound of footsteps that I could hardly hear. Yes, I already had the experience of walking through the corridors at night a few times, but I felt it with my whole body that the footsteps I was hearing were different from those I knew.

This one gave me shivers to the core.

Step.

The sound of footsteps kept on getting closer. No, I need to stay out of here first.

To the edge! I could go to the side leading to the garden stairs!

Ding-ding-ding.

I felt like there was a bell in my head, like a warning that I shouldn't look back and shouldn't do it.

Right now, I felt as if I had become a minstrel who had gone to the underworld to rescue my mythical wife. Who was warned that everything would go down the drain the moment he looked back.

It's best to follow that warning and never look back.

The sound of footsteps approaching the braille stopped.

Iana, don't look back. Please, do not look back.

I mumbled, but eventually, I gave up and looked back.

Swoosh.

The wind blew, and the long brown hair swung in the air before my eyes. My cloak was swaying as well because of the wind, but he would not see me because I had used magic.

... I'm sure he won't.

But a pair of golden eyes were looking precisely at me. No. It didn't take a single second for that sharp but soft-looking eye to turn toward me.

Long limbs and hard shoulders. The slim silhouette was like a Mowgli jaguar dyed by this dawn light.

My eyes widened in shock.

It was Lenag.

He looked at me and slowly opened his lips. With a smile, he lifted his lips, acting like he was a good person.

“The walk, was it fun, Lady?”

I was stiff, and the numerous thoughts that came to mind were erased and were replaced by a new one. I thought of it over and over again.

Why, how? How?

It was ridiculous.

I held my breath and didn't budge. Slowly, I put my eyes down.

No, maybe he's just trying to talk. Not Yet.

His eyes were now fixated on my clothing's sleeve, on my wrist to be exact, where the bracelet was placed but was covered by the cloak I am wearing.

The sorcerer of the Hel estate. The face of Jair, the closest aide to the future Ricdorian, passed by in my mind.

Apparently, he told me he put transparent magic on this bracelet. And that's what I used to sneak into the cell of Ricdorian.

However, I've been grazed by a guard that was resting on the stairs the first time I used the magic, but they didn't recognize me.

Would that mean that the magic of the bracelet was broken now? If that's the case, I would have been recognized by the senior knight who was patrolling on the basement stairs.

Furthermore, as evidence, this magic could erase even the shadows. And as of now, I had no shadow.

...so, there's no way Jair's magic was flawed. It couldn't possibly fail. I bet on that! And never would there be a chance that someone would catch me as long as I'm under Jair's magic.

Am I right? Or not.

Chapter 56: You are always an exception (1)

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Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

Also, he was a supporting character, and the right-hand man of Ricdorian who helped him and the heroine escape the prison. So his magic could be not just some average spell from typical wizards. The same was true that even if I made use of this magic several years before the original plot occurred, it could still be of function for the heroine in their break-free mission in the future.

At this point, even if his magic hadn't reached its perfection; if one would try to look on the brighter side, he was able to sneak into the Kambrakam prison and use magic secretly. And those facts spoke something. That his skill may have some lapses, but still, it was exceptional.

I bit my lower lip hard and breathed lightly so that I wouldn't be heard.

Oh no, I was almost holding it in and tried not to spit out words. I was still not sure of my situation right now. There's a possibility that Lenag really saw me or maybe not? But I do hope it's the latter. I need to have a rosy outlook.

Right. What if he just did it out of nowhere? Like he was talking to himself or something.

But I heard him say ‘Lady’, but... *Arghhh!* Still! just in case. Maybe he’s just putting on an act?

However, when I thought of it rationally, Lenag had no reason to do so, but I couldn’t afford it.

...I hope he just felt something and tried saying it out of the blue...I hope so... and for as much as possible, I wanted to avoid creating trouble.

And if he really did notice me, I wouldn’t know what to do at all.

Right now, I’m trying to suppress any noise coming out of me and my front teeth, which have been biting my lower lip, bit harder in a tense.

“I don’t bite.”

Lenag’s body, which had been stationary for a while, moved. He was going exactly to where I was, curiously. And without a single hesitation.

“And I won’t hurt you.”

All my hopes went down, and I realized that my wishes were just pure hallucinations. What’s worst of all was that everything turned out to be my worst nightmare ever. Lenag indeed saw me, and his eyes were piercing right through me.

...how on earth could this be possible? By what means?

While short thoughts crossed my mind, Lenag raised his hand.

He was just raising it at a speed that was not a threat at all, but I quickly twisted my body because I was nervous.

I trembled.

Lenag’s hand stopped in a flash.

“...I didn’t mean to threaten you.” He tilted his upper body slightly.

A faint, weak wind passed by, making the hat of my cape fall.

And not long after, the wind blew once again, and my hair, which had stretched out to my waist, shook.

And of course... I saw that the magic worked until now since my own shadow was still nowhere to be glimpsed.

Lenag's thin eyes were now focused on my scattering hair.

"...how, how did you know it was me?" I asked breathlessly.

My still voice was small enough to be heard, and Lenag's eyes turned slightly towards me.

The lenses of the glasses placed above his pointed nose were fogging up in coldness and illuminated the dawnlight's brightness. It seemed that the sun would rise in a few minutes, but judging from the surroundings' color, it was still a dark dawn.

"How can I not...this prison doesn't have that color except you, Miss Iana."

"No, I mean, how did you know it is me when I am wearing a cape... That's it!"

After a moment's hesitation, Lenag answered my question.

"Your size and your gait made me aware that it is you."

...No, that's not how you knew it was me. That was not the answer I wanted to hear.

I was speechless, and I thought of something that had a little probability of being the answer that left me flabbergasted. No. I was just hoping that what I thought was not really the reason he could see me.

My hand clasped the hem of my dress tightly.

“Did you think I wouldn’t recognize you when I saw your face? My vision is not that bad...”

“...no, I mean.”

“Or were you surprised because I had discovered the magic that was hung on your wrist Miss Iana.”

Lenag’s words, which were previously beating around the bush, suddenly hit the bullseye and asked frankly.

Mister, why did you suddenly hit the mark?

In other words, he was a straight-to-the-point type of person.

I couldn’t keep my mouth shut like this.

“Exactly... Yes, that’s exactly what I wanted to ask you.”

“Then may I ask why Miss Iana was walking on the hall of the first floor at this hour? Using magic, too.”

Iana: “...”

I was speechless.

..I was the one doing the interrogation but suddenly, he turned the tables and was now questioning me.

Glancing up, I looked into Lenag’s eyes, and I couldn’t figure out what he was thinking as of the moment. He’s harder to read than the most challenging book.

Was that his way of answering my question, or was he just purely asking me a question?

For a moment, it occurred to me that his golden eyes glistened extraordinarily because of the dawn and morning radiance that dyed it with bluish light. To better visualize it, using a metaphor, his eyes were like that

of an eagle crouched in the dark, where only his eyes were glowing amidst the darkness.

“I am very surprised.”

Surely his eyes were sharp, and that gaze made me feel like I was in my final judgment with the grim reaper himself and that I should start admitting all my wrongful deeds and sins right now. Furthermore, I felt like I was being swallowed wholly up to my bones.

“...this is a situation I didn’t expect at all.”

Well, it seemed to be hiding in the softness, but the peculiar sharpness still flowed through that gaze.

I tried not to make it noticeable, but I couldn’t help but breathe heavily.

Before I knew it, I folded my hands and put it on top of each other. Then I pressed them over my chest. Soon, the eyes, gazing keenly, slowly turned downward. I was guilty, okay. Moreover, I was caught in the act.

“That.”

“What?” I asked as I was confused.

“That on your arm.”

Chapter 57: You are always an exception (2)

Chapter 57 - You are always an exception (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

To my surprise, he was looking at the exact spot where the loose bracelet had fall down around my wrist.

“Was that *‘thing’* given by your brother?”

It was clear that I had underestimated this man. Yeah, the final black-rose villain Chaser, who dominated all the stories in the book, was not the one who caught me. Rather, it was Chaser’s right-hand man. How good was that?

Maybe this man had hidden abilities that I didn’t know.

I nodded slowly.

“...yes, I told him I wanted some magic stuff, and he gave me this as a gift.”

...I feel so sorry for my nameless brother for using his name to save my ass. I just hope I won’t get him in trouble for this.

Cross fingers.

Yes, it would be difficult if Lenag would ask my brother about this later on, but, alas! It was an excellent opportunity to avoid him right now. Even if he comes back and brings it up again, I can come up with a story anytime to tell. And my excuse could be planned thoroughly.

Anyway, I'll just worry about the future when it comes.

For now, a man named '*brother*' gave me many things as a gift. Also, he sent whatever I wanted. Furthermore, a parcel comes in every day, and Lenag knew my brother. There was no way he didn't know this.

However, I don't know if my brother includes magic items in the parcels he sends...

If I argue more here, I could tell that he secretly gave this to me because he terribly cares for his little sister. Okay, that's it. I can do this!

I smiled inside in triumph.

"I see."

Even though my resolve was not grounded with facts, he readily accepted it without a doubt.

Oh, his response surprised me.

That convinced you? Really? Just like that?

"Well, is... is this something that cannot be brought inside the prison?"

"By principle, it is."

Lenag answered in a decent tone. Then he put his gloved hand on his chest.

"But you don't have to mind any rule in this prison... You are an exception, Miss Iana."

"...exception?"

“Yes. It’s also what your brother asked me to do.”

The frosty voice pierced gently into my ear.

“To let Miss Iana be free whatever she tries to do.”

What was in front of me at this moment was this guy, but why do I feel like my brother’s presence was strangely growing? What the hell is he? How can he have the mighty Lenag follow his commands?

And most importantly, what does he think of Iana? I can’t believe that Kambrakam would be a place of such convenience.

Was that how much my brother cared for me?

I was a little confused.

Obviously, aristocratic prisoners were freer to wander than the other prisoners who really committed crimes. Of course, this was partly due to the fact that they were not guilty and that they were not real sinners. However, this didn’t mean that there were no rules to abide.

“And I personally hope so.”

This means that even the aristocrats had to follow the rules; they should be on time for meals and never go out at night.

“Did you go for a night walk?”

“...yes. However, when I came out, I noticed the change in the number of guards and the rules. It’s not the way things normally go in here. It is like the laws set here have changed.”

Before I knew it, I regained my deposition and gave a calm reply. Of course, I didn’t forget to show my perplexed expression. If I stay too calm here, he might be able to see right through me.

But at this moment, my consciousness was slowly decreasing because of drowsiness.

As a matter of fact, Iana's body, which had been in a lot of pain until I woke up in the clinic, was more comfortable than I thought, but there was one disadvantage: this body was quite vulnerable to staying up all night just like what was happening right now. It seemed to be not used in doing so.

Like before, I once stayed up all night writing to my brother, and I dozed off until the next day's break.

"Are you tired?"

"Oh, did it show?"

When I laughed, Lenag wavered. But it was only for a short time, and he naturally turned his back halfway.

"... I'll take you to your cell."

Lenag then began to walk beside me, and I followed his footsteps. And just that, I regretted walking with him, but soon shrugged off that thought.

Yeah, what can I do when he says he'll take me to my cell?... by the way, I still don't have a shadow right now.

And as if to prove that the magic was still working, we encountered a guard who was in mid-shift, but he only bowed politely to Lenag and gave no attention to Lenag's side. It was proof that there was still invisible magic on my body.

Lenag did not ask me why I wanted to take a walk until the end, and therefore I couldn't ask him how he recognized me.

Soon, we finally arrived in front of my cell, and our eyes suddenly met.

"Rest well."

He paused for a moment and added that I don't have to come out for breakfast if I was so tired.

It seemed like he was trying to make everything convenient and in favor of me.

“Are you okay with that?”

“Isn’t Miss Iana’s body weak?”

That’s what I’ve been told, but.... I scratched my cheek with a little awkward expression.

“I think I’m treated way better than the others here. It’s not that I don’t like it. But just like that? No reason?”

I think I’m seeing a lot of goodness right now, too much of it. I’m also starting to feel something strange, but I can’t tell what exactly it is.

It was like there was a big picture in front of me, but I can’t see the whole thing because I’m looking at the corner.

“... in this cell, especially to the noble prisoner, we give special privileges for those who are not well. So to be clear, it’s not limited only for you or for your comfort. It’s not even favoritism.”

Oh. I guess I was just overthinking.

“Oh, is that so?”

“But you can surely do whatever you want anytime. Don’t worry about those who say that this is prejudice or partiality.”

...what are you going to do to them?

For a moment, a bloody and gory imagination flashed through me, but Lenag remained silent. I was just smiling, but I felt like I was hearing many things— the agony and suffering of people.

“Anyway, don’t worry about it and do whatever you want. Whatever it is, I’ll let you do it.”

“Why is that?”

Before saying his answer, he closed his mouth for a while and then parted it.

“Because that is what I wanted.”

Chapter 58: You are always an exception (3)

.Chapter 58 – You are always an exception (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

...so that was what you wanted?

While Lenag was briefly lost in thought, with his eyes glued to the floor, a brief greeting distracted him, which made him turn his back from me.

“Excuse us, Marquess.”

I was about to speak when his attention was diverted to the guards who addressed him. After contemplating for a while, I decided to just say it because I thought it might be possible given all the favor I had. Right, I’ll just say it.

“Yeah? What are you saying...” He said. “Oh, that? All my colleagues call me that.”

“...no, no, no. Please tell me.” He added.

He covered his mouth gracefully with the back of his hand.

Taking advantage of my spare time, I continued to talk swiftly.

“You said I could do whatever I wanted. Then...”

He turned his head as I spoke.

“Going to the cell in the basement is allowable?”

Lenag: “...”

He did not respond.

Silence embraced the area, and I could hear the accelerated beating of my heart. Those eyes behind his glasses, staring at me, gave me goosebumps, and I felt a cold sweat flowing down my nape. Being under this serpent’s unexpected gaze would make me faint in no time. However, I tried so hard to endure it.

Oh no, Iana, you must have asked a wrong thing at this moment! I shouldn’t have done that!

You’re not going to allow me, are you?

There might be another occasion when I should go and meet Ricdorian in the future. And it’s just tiresome doing this kind of tightrope bridge every time I went to Ricdorian’s cell.

So I just threw my idea thinking it might be worth it. Anyway, I thought it could be possible since he’s giving me strange favors.

“...do you enjoy playing with him? Well, you can do whatever you want as long as you think it’s worth it.”

Lenag forced out a vague answer to my proposal.

What does that imply?

I pretended to understand it in context, and most of all, I’m not playing with Ricdorian. Why would he think like that?

“I’ve heard that you humiliated him while taking a walk, such as throwing a ball or holding a leash and so on.”

...I was like a sheep who took care of a beast on a walk. Also, I did not intend to humiliate him. I was just trying to teach him.

“I don’t care if you’re going to be there any time in the future. But preferably...”

It was taken more lightly than I thought, and I felt a queer sense of despondency.

No, so in the first place, I could’ve just asked him for permission to visit Ricdorian? So those efforts I made in bribing Hans with cigars were just to make me suffer in distress? If I had known this would happen, I would have brought it up earlier. I wouldn’t have resorted to those hard ways.

I just mentally face slapped myself. All this time, I’ve been doing things wrong. And soon, regret consumed my whole system.

Suddenly, a shadow covered my line of sight. It was Lenag who was now near me and he tilted his upper body gracefully.

“...instead?” I asked in a careful manner.

What was he trying to say?

In the moment of nervousness, his head bent down and stopped at a distance that would not be too rude. He then whispered softly with a cold voice...with slight hesitation.

“Can you spend that time with me?”

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“Iana!”

I was startled that I stopped dozing off.

“Are you all right?”

“Eh? Yes. Yes...”

I laid my head down like a sick chicken. Soon, Baron was in front of me, and Sally was right beside me.

“Huh... Why do you look so exhausted? What are you thinking?”

“I know. She’s been in this phase since this morning. It seems like she had lost her consciousness. Iana, where are you? Come back to Earth Iana.”

“No, no, no, no... .”

Yawn.

My fatigue was squeezing like a wave. I never felt this tired my entire life, and my shoulders felt so heavy as if I’m carrying a sack of rice on each side.

Lenag told me I didn’t have to come out until breakfast, but I got up on time instead of grabbing his offer, which was truly tempting.

Regardless, I thank him for his kindness, but it was better not to accept his offer for now unless I really needed to. Because if I get used to it, I might someday become in debt of gratitude to him, and as what they say, everything comes with a price, and I know when the time comes, he would for sure ask for a payment. And I would be defenseless—like a person disappearing on a deserted island without anything to help myself. So as early as now, I wanted to prevent things like that from happening.

Of course, I’ve already received a lot of convenience inside this prison. But I have always used what was given to me, such as ‘*medicine*’ or ‘*gift*’ from my brother, to solve my light-hearted curiosity like secretly handing Hans drinks and cigarettes to see Ricdorian.

I thought there’s nothing more challenging to handle.

...But it seemed that being caught walking out in the middle of the night was the hardest thing I had ever come across. I miscalculated everything, and because of that, all that I’ve been doing secretly was ruined.

“You look a little depressed. What’s the matter? Oh, isn’t that it? Letter.”

“Letter?” What letter?

“I haven’t seen Iana read a letter lately. Hey, Iana. You haven’t got a letter from your brother recently, right? Is that why you’re sad?”

Oh. Right...

Come to think of it, how many days has it been since the last letter was sent?

The reply of the letter should always be on time. But now, the reply was exceptionally late.

I was wondering what’s going on since it was late once again. Actually, it was weird to get a reply every day or two.

“Not a big deal. I’m just tired because I didn’t get enough sleep.”

I stretched out myself all the way, like how a foldable chair was unfurled. It’s only been an hour since I had lunch, and I fell asleep.

Baron and Sally, who were talking to me, soon left me alone and started talking to each other. The living room, which was decorated with elegance, was jammed with aristocratic prisoners who were resting today.

Wait, there’s a lot more people today... And it’s noisy.

I slowly leaned over and closed my eyes. However, I was disturbed by the noise and opened back my eyes. In addition, as I looked around, in the middle of a large living room, there was a man with a serious face.

What was he doing?

Chapter 59: You are always an exception (4)

Chapter 59 – You are always an exception (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I narrowed my eyes thinly and turned my head. I'm not sure about all of this, so I'll ask Baron. Maybe he knows. However, the moment I parted my lips, someone exclaimed.

“Oh my gosh!”

Our eyes moved to where the sharp voice was heard. The noisy background abruptly calmed down. Not only me but also two other men, who were gathered earlier, headed towards the male prisoner.

The middle-aged man raised his head with a pale look on his face, whether he was looking or not, he just showed an extremely horrible expression.

There was a small letter in his trembling hand. It was about the size of a leaflet.

Tremble.

“Bunton Art Museum exploded! A terror bombing; it was a blast!”

I was able to hear and process what he just read from the letter, and the other noble prisoners present in the area as well.

“That, that accident caused the Archduke to receive remedy....”

“What?” A noble prisoner exclaimed.

And with that, the silence in the room, that was out of curiosity, exploded like a bomb after hearing the man’s words. Shock was clearly evident on all of their faces.

That’s what he would do. This was one of the two pillars supporting the empire, along with the Hel family to which Ricdorian belonged. The two families were bitter enemies, but they had no choice but to coexist at the same time.

The owner of such a family suffered from an ‘*accident*’ and was remediated.

“Maybe he’ll die.” A prisoner uttered, who also heard the scandalous news.

That was none other than the black rose and the father of Chaser, Archduke Domulit.

“No wonder. That’s the work of the son, Chaser...”

“Hey! What are you talking about, man!?”

A man with a beard, who just talked, quickly blocked the other man’s mouth with the letter in order not to further offend the other prisoners, acting like they were friends.

Hmm, did Chaser’s notoriety spread this far? Judging from his character, it was clear that he would go this far just to kill a person.

“Heh... this is ridiculous... it just happened casually.”

Baron, who tried to speak calmly, was also stiff. It was a big deal for him because the death of the head of a huge family meant that the power structure of even a small country would change.

Scratching my cheek, I stared at the window after pretending to be surprised like them for a moment. Right now, I was probably the only one who was calm and indifferent.

Hmm... something big happened. It was a story from the original plot. The villain, Chaser, caused a bomb attack on a historical art museum.

With this incident, he succeeded in driving his father out of his seat under the guise of an accident, and got a hold of the position as the head of Domulit. However, even after achieving that position, he took the time to remove the internal forces that were dissatisfied and not in favor of him.

Eventually, a few years later, after the original work began, he became as powerful as a duke. In fact, he's a lot more evil and wicked than before. But Chaser had a situation, too. His father abused him countless times. And that was what made him like this.

“Will Lord Chaser take over his father's position now?”

I think the reason why the two main characters were attracted to the heroine was because they both wanted to have someone who would care for them and tend to the wounds that they could never cure.

“This is a big deal, Iana. The game of power will now change.” Baron stated, still concealing his perplexed expression.

“Really?”

“I don't think Lord Chaser tainted his hand... Oh, come on!”

Anyway, it already happened. Their world seemed to stop, but I felt like mine was working well. Soon, I lost interest in those gossip-obsessed people.

Chaser was the culprit, whether you like it or not. There was no way he would do something noticeable. He had no mercy, even with his own family.

Well, guess what, he's a brutal, sadistic murderer.

Once I'm out of jail, I should definitely achieve my goal to live a quiet life and dream peacefully.

Soon, I walked out quietly of the living room and left the prisoners who were still arguing regarding the news. Then I went straight down the stairs and headed for the stairs that I usually take going down the basement. However, there was a strange guard in front of the basement, but he coolly opened the way.

“You’re Miss Iana, aren’t you? I’ve heard from the prison head. I’m Rubin, a senior guard.”

He said he knew I would come. Maybe Lenag ordered it. I just admired Lenag’s skill at doing things in only one day.

“I’ve been ordered to allow you to do whatever you want. What do you want right now?”

“Hmm. A walk?”

At my words, the guard looked at the iron gate and nodded. Soon a few more guards appeared in the cellar, and I went for a walk with them. Of course, there was Ricdorian right next to them.

Afterward, the intimidated Ricdorian held the hem of my clothes tightly because there were so many guards surrounding us.

He seemed to have recognized the overwhelming and menacing spirit and potentials of the superior knight, perhaps because of his beast’s instinct.

“Don’t be too nervous. They won’t hurt you.”

“...yes.”

Even if I said this, I understood very well why Ricdorian’s reacting like this. For him, the new guard was the one who filled him with new restraints and chains, oppressed him, and so on. It was no way a good memory for him.

Going out into the garden, I deliberately settled in a place where the sunlight was the best, and the scenery was beautiful.

And as the number of people decreased, Ricdorian looked a little relieved. Soon, I asked the guards around me to step aside.

And they paved the way while showing reluctance. Perhaps due to the difficulty in hearing our voices at such distance.

However, after a while, the guards noticed the uneasy ambiance between us. So they turned their backs and then began to talk to each other as if they were trying to be considerate of me.

Thanks to them, I can finally talk to Ricdorian comfortably and at ease.

Chapter 60: Can I bite you instead?

(1)

Chapter 60 – Can I bite you instead? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“...is it uncomfortable and hard?” I asked him.

Ricdorian shook his head in response. Then, he lifted it and stared in fascination at the clouds.

“... it’s okay. Yes, it’s okay... .”

“Okay? What do you mean?”

“Oh, ahh.”

Ricdorian, who was tightly clasping the end of my sleeve, fixed his gaze on me. It seemed like it was now quite natural for him to make eye contact with me. And as expected, the color of his eyes stood out in a radiant and alluring manner under the influence of the sunlight.

“Be... because you’re next to me... It’s okay.”

His voice, which seemed to stutter a little, calmed down as he continued. For a moment, I couldn’t say anything. I felt like I ran out of words to say to what he just enunciated.

Did I understand things in a wrong way?

In the meantime, I heard a burst of booming laughter coming from the guards who were talking about something. It was like they were in an amusing argument as I could see that they were betting on each other. It was a good thing for us since they kept moving further away from the place where we settled down.

I hurriedly stared back at Ricdorian.

...But I don't think my comprehension was wrong, either.

And before I knew it, a grown-up Ricdorian, who used his hand as a support, leaned his head over. When his eyes met mine, my vision suddenly felt drowsy, and so I blinked.

"Not master...Iana." He said. "I remembered it accurately this time. Wondering how?"

What has gotten into you that you flipped so swiftly? Why did you get big all of a sudden?

Dug-dug.

My heart was throbbing so fast, not with excitement but because of the nervousness I'm feeling right now.

The transformed body of Ricdorian was distinctly different in comparison with his timid form. I'm just relieved that the guards were quite far from us. They wouldn't recognize the sudden body changes of Ricdorian. However, if one would try to look closely at him, it would undoubtedly be noticed easily.

In the meantime, my tension has dropped.

"Aren't you glad to see me?" He asked.

"Do you think now is the right time to question me about being happy?"

I didn't know what the consequences would be if ever I got caught. I'm sure they'll find out that I'm involved with this. And I don't know what kind of

danger I'm putting Ricdorian into. He might be tormented mercilessly or whatsoever!

Soon, cruel and bloody images were flashing into my mind. I feel a little frustrated right now.

I bit my lower lip hard.

“...it hurts when you bite it like that.”

The slender, elegant fingers touched my lips. I was surprised by the unfamiliar touch from his delicate skin.

“It hurts”.

Iana: “...”

His forehead creased, and his eyes turned half-closed like that of a frowning face. Then, he bent his head and looked closely, assessing my lips. Even with the current situation, I still chose to ignore him and did not bother removing my teeth dug in the flesh of my lips.

“Can I bite you instead?”...what the f*ck is this? This is another bullsh*t.

I restrained myself from saying those because I knew those words would hurt him like hell, and he would probably start weeping like a dog. But this guy! Seriously?!

Ugh!

“...can I do it?”

Upon hearing him say those, I quickly pulled back. My body was also ready to push him away any time he attempted to get further close. He was in an open garden where he was chained to the wall the same way he was in his cell.

No, you thought you could break out in the garden!

However, he was suddenly loud when I tried pushing him away...He is drawing the guards' attention.

This is what I've been trying to avoid from happening. As much as possible, I didn't want the guards to have a glimpse of the changes in Ricdorian's features. Moreover, I didn't want the guards to capture us! Because if they ever did, everything would for sure go down the drain.

This is terrible.

Clank. Clank.

The sound of chains around his wrist was so loud. However, that did not stop him from what he was about to do.

A delicate hand held my fingertips. His hand tickled it up for a while and then settled in my palm. Soon, he rubbed it gently.

The odd sensation of his thumb rubbing my palms made me breathe loosely for a moment.

What the...

"Are you feeling good? I miss the feeling of you touching me like this."

"...Me? When did I..."

"Why? When I picked up the ball... This is how you touched me, right?"

What?!

So you do remember all those memories you had while you're in your beast form?

When he first changed, he didn't seem to remember it himself.

The sudden realization stopped me.

Why does it feel like it's changing little by little?

In the meantime, his body advanced to me. To be exact, his upper body tilted before me.

“Why, aren’t you touching me now?”

I always thought that maybe it would be better to see him under the sun than a dark, cryptic room.

But now, I realized I was wrong.

I gulped down my saliva.

Growing up, he has this pure and innocent beauty that can go against the Greek gods’ beauty. His face was so beautiful that it exceeded the standard of being a handsome man. However, when he came down to me, he was languid, frail, and delicate. He created a strange atmosphere like a midday afternoon with drowsiness.

“You touched it...like this. Right? Iana.”

Slowly, Ricdorian held my hand and lifted it in front of his face. Then, he lowered his head and opened his mouth, the place where my hand would soon be buried.

Tickle. Tickle.

Long eyelashes brushed through my hands. And I felt butterflies in my stomach the moment it scratched it. The redness of his lips were slightly covered by my fingertips. He soon faintly bit my finger and didn’t go all the way, as if he was a beast savoring his moment by teasing me.

“If I can’t get your lips, then maybe just your hands?”

The sight of him burying my hand with his mouth was so creepy and gruesome.

Thud!

An unusual sound rang out in the garden.

“Miss Iana?”

I took a deep breath. I felt like I shouldn’t exhale anyhow, and I did not. I held my breath for as long as I could.

Then, the guards, who came running, reached out to me.

“What’s going on?”

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Chapter 61: Can I bite you instead? (2)

Chapter 61 – Can I bite you instead? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I looked at the guards with a pale face. The sound that rang just now was because I pushed Ricdorian away, which made him fall hard from the bench.

I wanted to apologize to him, but he immediately turned rational when I looked back at him.

I covered my lips with the back of my hand and took a deep breath, and quickly regained my composure and said.

“Well, I’m not feeling well, so I’ll go back to my cell first. Could you please lead this prisoner to his cell instead?”

“What? Oh, yes, I will.”

“Thank you.”

Fortunately, Ricdorian was also breathing like a man with a fever. He seemed to suffer from these side effects whenever he changed his appearance.

Yes, I cared about his well-being, but I decided to turn my back on him. I wasn’t feeling good, as well.

I headed to my cell at a rapid pace. But in the middle of the conversation, some of the guards gave Ricdorian a personal apology, but there was no chance for them to receive a proper response.

No, I don't even know what spirit possessed him.

Bang.

I closed my cell door and gasped for air.

“Ha. Ha... .”

Only after several deep breaths did I manage to calm down. First, I need cold water, cold water.

It was said that people who take too much stimulation cause them pain. Whether it's joy, sadness or pleasure, it could create too many emotions that could lead to being unstable. Even the opposite of those feelings.

In my case, it was the aftereffect of seeing more than necessary. In other words, Ricdorian aroused me with his relaxed personality, especially when he spoke those stirring words and did those malicious acts on me.

Now, I found that a handsome man can sometimes cause dizziness. But of course, his handsomeness was just one of the reasons why.

“Whoa... I think I can finally live.”

At this point, I think I should dig into it seriously. I just can't leave Ricdorian like that. At the time being, I felt responsible for it... Because I was the one who gave him the magic for growth. Jair said that it was magic principally created for Ricdorian, but the more I looked at it, the more that magic became bizarre.

...Maybe I should see Jair one more time.

Technically speaking, every time I met Jair, it would always be him who comes to me, not the other way around.

I slowly leaned my back thinking of how to contact him. Then I stopped because I remembered that there was an unfamiliar letter on the desk early in the morning.

A letter, huh?

“...He might have sent it, didn’t he?”

I quickly opened the envelope and then looked at the elegant and delicate handwriting. As expected, it was my brother’s letter.

“Come to think of it... I asked him what kind of family we were last time, right?”

Will this letter contain the answer? I’m looking forward to it.

For a moment, I forgot about Ricdorian and opened the letter, blinking my eyes in anticipation.

[My lovely sister.]

The contents of the letter were fairly simple.

[Who’s bothering you?]

It was like he was angry.

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“...is he angry?”

I said it out loud. But it was an unusual reaction.

Angry? Why are you mad? In which part?

I tilted my head in query.

No. You’re not really mad, are you? Am I right? Or maybe I’m just mistaken.

To say so, the letter was unusually dull. My brother's letters have always been filled with affection towards me, and I've never received a short message from him like this one.

I was lost in my thoughts for a moment.

What was the problem with what I asked?

“Yes, that's right. Our family*.”

I just asked him about what kind of family we are. Did that make him angry?

Soon, I put the letter down. I didn't mean to be so sensitive. But even if I try to comprehend things further, I would still come up with a conclusion that it just doesn't seem right. It was as if there was a missing piece to this puzzle. There's nothing that acts as a bridge, and so I wonder if I could see the connection as to why he's angry.

Furthermore, he doesn't have any idea about me. An Iana that had no idea of her own family name. Of who her real family was.

In the end, I decided to put my worries aside and closed my eyes. I buried myself in bed, turned my head, and sighed.

I didn't do much today, but I felt worn out.

No, I was troubled and was always working.

Watching the change of Ricdorian a while ago, I recalled the fact that I was frantically wary of being caught by the guards. That's right. This fatigue was due to Ricdorian. I swear.

Yeah... I'm exhausted, not physically, but mentally and emotionally.

I nonchalantly put my hands on my chest.

Thump. Thump.

My heart was still frightfully beating.

“...that makes people think hard.”

The more I recall what happened a while ago, the more my hands felt sweaty. As I said, he looked like a pure and innocent young saint whenever one would stare at his face, and this was not much different from when he grew up, just think of it as a Ricdorian with eyes burning under passion.

Furthermore, his skin was so white that I could see the redness vividly, and his clothes were so tight that it hugged his figure and made his broad shoulders and muscles clearly defined.

I closed my eyes.

Whoa, think of other things, Iana.

“For now... let’s get some rest.”

...Heavens! I can’t think of anything. I’m telling you the occurrence earlier kept flashing on my mind.

I just felt like I was just lying here and blankly closed my eyes.

I wanted to forget about the sultry stuff. I tried to forget the complexity of things for a moment.

I suddenly remembered my favorite motto in life, which was to live comfortably in this complicated life. I did try to do what I wanted, gave up on what I couldn’t, and did everything else with caution.

Anyway, I wanted everything to submerge down the iceberg, so I closed my eyes and focused my mind on sleeping. Then I stretched my body in a very satisfying way that made me relieve all the stresses hiding in every part of my body.

Then I fell asleep.

Diving into a deep slumber and unintentionally neglecting to reply to my brother's message as usual.

***가문** – Family crest or heraldry, means social status or cover of the family. This is the term used by the author but I decided to use the word family alone.

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Chapter 62: We need to talk (1)

Chapter 62 – We need to talk (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

-The next day.-

“We need to talk.”

Recalling the memory of our previous interaction made it hard for me to come up with a decision whether to go and see Ricdorian or not. It took me more than eight hours to find my courage to look at the man’s face who made me feel a bunch of emotions with his innocent but lewd actions.

Right now, I’m standing here in front of him at precisely twelve o’clock at noon.

Actually, I already decided to stay away from him for a few days and then come back to see him, just to ease the tension between us for a while. But that plan backfired as it just gave me the urge to see him more. As a matter of fact, I was a lazy person, but once I made up my mind, it was my principle to get things done quickly rather than wait for some other time. And with that, you could tell that I’m not really good at making decisions.

Also, I have this driving force that makes me want to visit him. It’s like we’re that both sides of a magnet; the North Pole and the South Pole.

And he’s that North Pole that keeps on attracting me and pulling my soul to be in one with him.

“Arfff?”

And so the next day, neither of the grown-up nor the rational Ricdorian showed up to me.

Instead, it was the beast Ricdorian who did.

I had noticed that these past few days, his beast, rational, and grown-up side would always show up alternately. The so-called ‘three-faces’ of this man, each of which has a randomly designated personality, making them unique from each other. And sadly, this side of him got the deficiency of not being able to talk. Indeed, the name of a beast suits this one.

“Hey, not that side of yours. Can you change to your other modes?”

“Grrrrr!”

“Yes, I’d rather have a rational conversation right now.”

“Arfff? Grrrr! Grrrr!”

“...you shouldn’t have said anything.”

I stared down in difficulty.

How can we have a proper talk in this state?

I sighed because of the struggle.

At this moment, the male protagonist was displaying a brute’s personality as he was exactly wearing the mask of a beast. Obviously, he seemed to be saying something using his current form’s language, but I cannot understand it. And to think that he was the male lead of a novel made me sigh.

Come to think of it, in my whole life’s existence, how many times have I encountered such a main character?

“Yeah right. Just him. A male lead with different characteristics. One of them is a cry baby, while the other is a beast that doesn’t speak.”

This beast can't communicate in another sense, and he should be able to do so with others since he was this romance novel male lead. Of course, it was his job to seduce the heroine with flowery words.

But how can he do that when he can't even have a proper conversation with me right now!? He just can't.

I squatted down and sighed heavily for another time.

I can do nothing about his present state, but since we're already here, all I could do was to make an effort to understand his mode of communication just like what I usually did.

Wait.

"...I haven't seen scars these days. This is a good thing."

It felt somewhat unusual seeing Ricdorian without marks from the torments he's been suffering in the basement. Truth be told, Ricdorian has always been hurt. This was because even though he was bound by chains, he tried to forcibly move around despite the chains' length-limit being reached. Furthermore, Archduke Harnim, who came to see him every time, abused him.

Also, not long ago, one of the guards went into his cell and hit him. I've heard about this from Ricdorian.

<You got hit? By whom? What kind of man?>

I was surprised to hear that a guard, not anyone else, had hit him, but fortunately, the guard was fired for another reason before I even appeared in this prison.

<I have to be hit. That's how I can become a person...>

Ricdorian did not know why beating himself was bad or wrong. In fact, the agony I felt while listening to that story was nothing compared to seeing it happen in person. Witnessing him groan in pain and grunt in front of me

makes my heart bleed in affliction. That's why I brought a bunch of medicine for him last time.

“Oh, by the way, I'm here to ask you something.”

Tilting.

I smiled and gritted my teeth in admiration at him, who adorably tilted his head.

Hmm... what's wrong with this cute puppy?

I wasn't able to get the right timing this time. I thought that it would be hard to hear an answer from him, as this was the only way I could question him.

With my head down, I swung my head, and my hand laid on the floor felt cold.

When I slowly lifted up my head, I could hear the clatter of iron chains.

What? When did you get so close?

The beastly Ricdorian had his face on the back of my hand.

“Arfff...”

He stroked his face against the back of my hand like that of a dog wanting to be petted. It seemed like he's asking me to caress his face.

I could hear him growling from the inside of his neck, mingled with a jolly and cute voice, which I found really strange.

So I tried pulling my hand out of fear that he might all of a sudden bite.

Grab.

However, it appeared that Ricdorian had this sort of beastly instinct as he reacted faster than me. Without second thoughts, he grabbed me and brought my hand closer to him. I tried resisting, but it was hard because he

held my hand tightly as if his life depended on it. The tightness of his hold also depicts fear that I might be gone any time he loosens his grip.

I glared at him.

The things that this form of Ricdorian knew were barking, biting and sucking... And among them, the most common thing he did was to 'bite'.

I quickly reminded and warned myself of these before my poor hand would become a victim.

"You... you can't bite."

"Arrff?"

"You are a man, not a beast. You can't just set my arm in place and start grilling it with that teeth of yours. Come on."

Pretending to hear nothing, he still positioned his mouth near my hand. He even pouted his red lips and blinked naively. Soon, with half-eyes open, he looked at me as if saying that he had done a good job.

"No. I don't have anything for you to eat today."

As soon as I spoke, Ricdorian's eyes rolled down.

We may have spent a short time together, but I already knew what he wanted.

"Wait a minute, why are you eating that..."

Ughh!

Ricdorian placed my finger inside his mouth before answering me and once again gave me an innocent blank look as if he was saying he had done another great thing.

I don't remember asking you to bite me, but why did you just interpret what I said as eating?

“Hey, don’t eat it. Why...ah.”

It was the moment when his tongue was moving sensually around my finger that made me frown slightly. It twisted around my fingers which was like eating a persimmon that was moving at different angles.

“Ah...”

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Chapter 63: We need to talk (2)

Chapter 63 – We need to talk (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

Ricdorian's hand that was holding mine slowly took my hand out of his mouth. And when I stared back at him, I saw his calm eyes— indicating that his rational side was awake right now.

Soon, I looked at my hands and shook them without hesitation. Oh, was his rational side back?

“Well, that...”

“Huh?”

“I'm, I'm sorry.”

His face, which turned red, managed to apologize. And this was an excellent opportunity to tease him.

I raised the corners of my mouth, lifting the fingers that just had an intimate contact with his mouth. The moment he caught a glimpse of my hand, his cheeks were dyed redder than before.

“Why, don't you wanna ask for more?”

“Then...”

I withdrew my hand after throwing a nasty joke and wiped it with a handkerchief. Glancing back at Ricdorian, I could tell that he was lost and didn't know what to do.

But not long after, I became so absorbed in cleaning my hand that I took my eyes off him for a moment. However, when I looked up again, I saw Ricdorian's chin resting on his chained hands.

"Can I ask for it one more time? Really?"

What?

No, why can you easily change like that?

"...when did you change?" I asked in disbelief.

How about a little notice? Those words I said went out of my mouth in unconsciousness. No way, this was not the way things should be.

Here I am, already celebrating that finally I can have a proper talk with him but why the sudden change?

I sighed in frustration.

You can't blame me for thinking this way because, from my past experience, I realized that the only way we could communicate was through his rational side as that's the only part of him that could speak well plus it's his only side that was sane enough not to do such inappropriate actions.

As for this grown-up Ricdorian, he may possess the ability to talk, but he still doesn't understand people at all. It was like that only his instinct remained in him.

This was not good.

I moved my butt further away from him.

"There."

Apparently I had no sweat, but I felt like I had a cold sweat hanging on the tip of my chin. And as he looked at me, I couldn't help but think that he was like a fluffy badger with a seemingly languid gaze.

“Why are you following me?”

“Because you keep on stepping back?”

“Aren’t you a beast?”

You want to go after me?

At this instant, his arms and legs grew longer, and this distance between us was already within his range. Sure enough, he moved his hand to block my only path to retreat fully.

“Why are you avoiding me? Do you hate me very much?”

“...why are you asking me that... .”

How can you say that with that face?

“Why the hell did you change?” I asked. “Can’t you change back?” I asked further.

“No, you can’t, but... You’ve changed over time before.” I finished questioning him, but he just tilted his head.

The hair that flowed down along the loose tilt of the head covered the forehead slightly. And between them, the grown-up blue eyes slowly blinked.

“I don’t know, Master. I’m sick of it. It was always like this.”

“I’m not your master. How many times have I...”

“Yes, I know. Iana.”

He bent his knee and then grabbed my ankle. It may be fortunate for him because his limbs were now more prolonged, but he was still not free because the length of the chains was limited.

“But when I say master, you show a better reaction.”

His white fingertips brushed my cheek slightly. And with a languid smile, his eyes glowed.

“Just like now.” I could feel his blue eyes staring right deep in my being.

“Hey, let me see, let me see your face. Why don’t you say it? Say it, don’t cut it off.” He added.

I’ve talked to this side of Ricdorian before, but he had an exquisite visual that was quite unbearable for me. And all I felt right now was like a chick caught by an eagle.

I paused for a moment as I felt my cheeks were turning red. But that’s it because I felt a sense of crisis that I should not just leave him like this.

“You don’t like this?”

“...No, not that.. I mean, why do you keep moving? Stay there. You’re pulling the chains.”

“But.”

I frowned at his short response.

That’s it? You had nothing else to say?

I was wondering why he did not continue but soon as I saw a loose smile on Ricdorian’s face, I pretended that I didn’t hear him.

I grabbed his approaching hand from the air. The fingertips were cold. And what’s remarkable was the fact that his clothes weren’t torn despite his growing figure. This seemed to be because Ricdorian was usually wearing clothes much larger than his own body.

As a result, the shirt was still a little loose despite his current appearance. This opened up a sight that was dangerous and, at the same time, pleasing to the eyes. His pale skin and his perfectly sculpted physique could be seen through that piece of clothing.

As I tried to avoid his eyes, he slightly raised his hand and used this opportunity to turn the tables.

Ricdorian's hand grabbed mine, and this time, he intertwined our fingers.

"... don't avoid me."

"When did I ever."

The way he held my hand might have felt forced, but it didn't feel uncomfortable since he did it cautiously with a weary face.

"You avoid my eyes."

The chain pulled tight. It was because it came to the limit.

"I'm not going any farther."

"...are you sure?"

I held my breath and nodded slightly.

"Yes, I will, so stop. You and this. It hurts."

What my fingertips pointed at was the tightly pulled chain. I was almost trapped in his arms, and I felt like I was going to cry if I was pulled any longer. I touched his shackled wrist with a trembling hand, and he even grabbed it instead.

Ricdorian slowly bent his upper body and lightly bit at my fingertips.

"Iana, what do you want to know?"

"...Oh, are you curious?"

"You said you wanted to ask me something."

At that moment, I recalled that I said, *'I'm here to ask you something'* earlier.

I blinked my eyes.

“Oh, so do you remember your memories when you were also a beast?”

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Chapter 64: We need to talk (3)

Chapter 64 – We need to talk (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“Little by little. I think.”

Apparently, I was so sure that his memories from each of his modes were limited only to themselves. Hence, it couldn't be possible for a specific personality of Ricdorian to be able to share memories with one another. But right now, I'm kind of baffled. I wondered if those three modes, or three personalities, gradually remembered each other. No, except perhaps for that beast who can't communicate.

So, will there be a day when the three will be merged into one? There could be a possibility.

“Yes, so you remember everything, right? Even when you're different?”

“I think so. But, Iana, what do you mean by 'different'? Why are you asking me like that? It was inside of me, too. That was also me.”

As he grew up, his hair grew longer, and the silver-colored hair brushed all over his eyes. I could see his enticing eyes well from that young face as small as a fist because of its slight curliness.

But then, he repeatedly covered the blueness of his eyes with his hair and exposed them afterward.

Soon, Ricdorian gradually elevated his hand.

“Which one do you think was best, then?”

“Which one?”

“If you base it on what Iana likes...”

He kissed my hand lightly with our fingers intertwined.

“I presume you’d like me more.”

Then he bit my fingertips slightly with the tip of his teeth.

“...Ah, don’t bite me like that.”

Instead of responding, he slowly pried his eyes as if asking for an answer.

“Then you...” I swallowed my saliva and then breathed profoundly.

“Do you know Jair?” I added.

Jair, who was a wizard and the right-hand man of Ricdorian, asked me to cast a spell on him. Whether Ricdorian knew the name or not, I could tell that his eyes widened for a while.

“That’s not the answer to my interrogation, Master.”

“Who’s your master? Before that, please answer me first. Then I’ll answer you. You must be...”

It was when I was saying the last part when someone rang the stone wall.

Bang. Bang.

“Miss Iana, it’s mealtime!”

The voice heard outside was from the guard. He was also a senior guard who was recently assigned to Ricdorian’s cell. And because of that, it might be difficult to demand to extend my time here.

I looked at Ricdorian regretfully and pulled my hand away from him.

“I’ll be back after I eat.”

“Really?”

Unexpectedly, he let me go.

“Is that a promise to be kept?”

“...I don’t know why you’re asking that.”

I blinked for a moment, then meticulously removed the little dust from his forehead.

“I always keep my word. Every time I say I’ll come back. I will come back.”

Then I turned my back, leaving Ricdorian still and for some reason, I think he looked a little bit bitter.

“You must come back, Iana.”

And that was his last words until I completely vanished from his ken.

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But my plan to go to Ricdorian after the meal fell majestically. It was because of an urgent call for my appearance.

“What does Miss Iana like?”

I blinked.

Why am I here? Moreover, what were these?

“Anything good... you know?”

That was Lenag right before my eyes. I knew I had to answer him who was sitting on the opposite side, but my lips didn’t utter a thing as my mind was preoccupied and distracted by the table in front of us.

<You were called Miss Iana.>

Actually, I had been called out in a hustle after the meal.

After having lunch, my friend and I planned to hang out together in the living room for a while. Then, I will visit Ricdorian's cell once again after leisure, but a low-ranking guard came to me.

I first wondered if he was suggesting a walk because his face was a little pale, but he said it was an order from the prison head.

Ever since I went to Lenag's office, I was always called for different concerns, and therefore being called once again after seeing the pale face of the guard made me so nervous. And when I walked into his office, he was standing there as if he was waiting for me. I doubt if he was patiently waiting, though, as I was called in haste.

The table in front of me looked extravagant. It was like there was a huge event or something. Were we going to have a feast right now? No, maybe this was a ritual like that of the last supper.

It was a feast with all kinds of desserts.

“Well, before I answer that. What are these for?”

“It's a dessert.”

“No, I know it's dessert.”

I have eyes, of course, so I know what it was. But I don't know what I like when something as lavish as this was presented in front of me.

“You seem a little flustered, so may I ask you again?”

Lenag, who called me here, held out his hands to me.

Does that mean I should raise my hand?

Slowly, I awkwardly lifted my hand, and soon, he tilted his upper body gently. My eyes widened in surprise by his sudden approach.

“Miss Iana, what do you like?”

His soft lips brushed against the back of my hand, and at the same time, I blinked my eyes in bewilderment.

Oh, my God! What was that?

“No, that, that cake and... Sorbet. I like those. But why are you giving me this?”

“I told you about it.”

“What do you mean?” I asked as I still couldn’t seem to figure out what he’s been trying to connote.

Lenag, who held my hand, bent his eyes as if his sight’s normal stance were not enough for him to see me clearly. The transparency of his golden eyes was crumbling in the light. And I just stood still, hardened just like a frog caught by a snake.

I roamed my eyes around the room, trying to avoid his gaze.

‘You’ll make time for me.’ he said, and past memories flashed through me.

Oh, right...

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Chapter 65: We need to talk (4)

Chapter 65 – We need to talk (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“You spent time with him.”

Admittedly I had an agreement with him. I just don’t know if it’s good to say that the conversation we had was a promise. Maybe it was better to call it a deal. Anyway, it would benefit me since I would no longer sneak out just to see Ricdorian. I just don’t know how it goes for Lenag.

I deliberately gazed elsewhere.

Even though he held my hands delicately, it would not be uncommon if he pulled out a sword and pointed it at my neck any moment from now. This was probably because he had a spitting image of blood and death.

“Yes, I did. I did... .” Eventually, I nodded.

Actually, it wasn’t a bad condition for me either.

Come to think of it. He asked me to spend some time with him, maybe because he had tons of spare time. What I needed to do now was to go with the flow and never be against him. Follow that, and there would be no need to feel nervous.

Of course, just looking at Lenag’s face was a task that requires great courage. It’s all because I know too well how cruel and violent this man has been in the book.

“By any chance, are you uncomfortable being with me?”

“Oh, no.” I answered the opposite of what I really felt.

Yes. Yes. Very much! That was supposed to be my genuine response. But I could not let myself say that. Maybe after some time, if I already wished to be on my deathbed.

“Not really. You’ve helped me a lot.” I added.

I laughed as smoothly as I could, pretending to be indistinct on the outside. And not long after, Lenag’s hand fell moderately. I quickly brought my hand to my chest in case he would attempt to hold it back.

“Thank God.”

I don’t know what others thought, but his voice was a little cold; however, it was quite pleasant to hear. It has this profound sound, soothing and euphonious, that could be compared to a lullaby singer. The tone of his voice was music to the ears.

“Would you like to sit down?”

He was polite enough to pull out a chair. I peered down at my clothes for a moment. Well, I don’t think he was an escort for a striped pants model.

As I sat in the seat he pulled out, I could see more details on the table.

“...wow.” The round table was full of desserts.

On top of that, the whipped cream had glossy texture as if it had just been made. The fruit on the topping was so fresh and mouth watering as well.

Would it be possible to make something like this inside this prison? Maybe I can sneak some and bring it to Ricdorian.

“Let’s eat.”

“Oh, yes.” I said in a formal tone, masking the excitement building up inside me.

Erasing strange thoughts, I get the fork. I'm afraid I'll have to take a bite to get that piercing gaze away from me.

"Ah." I opened my eyes wide as soon as I had it in my mouth because there was a burst of admiration.

"Delicious." I couldn't help but say that.

It's not that it was really delicious, but it melted gently in my mouth and then remained there for a long time until the sweetness was tasted.

Perhaps he heard my small murmur because his sharp face had momentarily loosened up.

"That's good to hear."

He stroked his chin as if he felt some stubbles on it and then slightly tilted his head.

"Do you like lemon sorbet?"

"Well, I'm good at eating sweets." I glanced at Lenag while my tongue licked the stain on my lips.

At the moment of eye contact, Lenag seemed to have hesitated.

Oh, was I getting too casual with him?

"Because I haven't been able to eat them often."

This was my childhood story—the real me in the other world. I was suffering from atopic dermatitis during my childhood, a disease that makes skin red and itchy. And therefore, I had to control my consumption of sweets as I grew up. It was because the rash just occurred immediately.

"Oh... I understand. It was an environment where you couldn't eat these things, Miss Iana."

...sorry? I paused at his unexpected response.

My lips just stopped eating the strawberry whipped cream cake. Then, I swallowed the remains quickly, and discreetly opened my mouth.

Suddenly my interest in sweets disappeared and moved onto him.

“Do you know me that well?”

“I don’t know how I knew you. I haven’t seen you very often, but I’ve always heard of Miss Iana. That’s the kind of relationship you must be asking about.”

“Aha...”

Are you referring to your relationship with my family?

Come to think of it, Lenag has been talking to my family and me as if he knew them and me very well. My father and brother seemed to have some sort of closer relationship with him.

I’ll try to find out about this.

“You heard about me?”

“Yes, that’s right.” He said, then I paused for a moment.

It would have been easier for me to gather information about my family by telling him that I couldn’t remember anything from the day I woke up in the clinic. But what can I do?

I already pretended to be a clumsy kid Iana; thus, it would be difficult to correct things. Also, I’m still a little scared of Lenag’s face and the storm that might happen due to my facade. So for now, I’ll just continue the act that I had started.

Hence, let’s talk about something else and then dig into it naturally.

“And I remember you asked me to spare you some time... .”

“Yes.”

“Never in my life, I’ve never heard of a prison head serving me... .”

I was about to finish my words, but my words instantly sank and drooped when I saw his face. It was because of his long, sharp eyes. On top of that, he was emitting extreme pressure.

My heartbeat was now as fast as the sprint of a cheetah.

Did I offend him with my words?

I wondered if there was anything that I could use as a peace offering for him not to kill me right now.

At this moment, the eyeglasses he was wearing barely neutralize his almost invincible look. But, without glasses, I thought that he would look pretty tough and ferocious.

“Can’t you?”

He leaned his head with his chin up. Then, a deep and keen gaze was directed at me. At the same time, a gentle and tender smile crossed.

“Can’t you give me the opportunity to serve Miss Iana?”

Oh. That’s not what I anticipated him to say.

No. I don’t think so. Was there even an opportunity in the first place?

I’ll be thankful for your courtesy and kindness, but that’s just it. Like now, you fed me well. But after we’re done eating, let’s part ways. For I fear that a story that’s not part of the original plot of this novel would magically appear out of nowhere.

“Well, why?” I questioned Lenag.

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Chapter 66: What am I? (1)

Chapter 66 – What am I? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“Why do I want to serve you? To tell you why... it’s just.”

For a moment, he lowered his eyes as if he felt a little disconcerted. And his gaze, which seemed like penetrating right through me earlier, was now slightly folded. Furthermore, the tickling effect of his subtle voice had never left my ears.

And when he hoisted his head back, he slowly stroked his chin with his fingers. I noticed that he had a habit of doing that every time he was in deep thoughts.

“... can’t I just want to?” He added.

The look in his eyes was burning with passion. And if I’m not mistaken, it was like he was very determined right now to do what he desires.

But the moment I blinked, it was already gone.

“No...there’s nothing that can’t be.”

Out of nowhere, I scratched my cheek and bit my fork. But realizing what I did made me feel so awkward that I decided just to eat a lot of cream to divert my thinking.

“Let’s have tea together too.”

“Ah, thank you.” I laughed awkwardly as I let go of the fork I was biting after eating the cream.

“It’s dried black tea. I took it out because I thought Miss Iana would like it.”

“Eh?”

“It’s a gift from your brother.”

Lenag even filled my glass. His service was really over the top today, and of all people, he’s the man I least expected to have some gentleness in the bones.

The way he did his series of acts was extraordinarily calm and elegant. Like a fine young man from a noble family. However, the tranquil atmosphere between us felt uncomfortable. It was like he may appear to be near, yet he felt extremely distant. Good thing, the sound of filling the glass in the middle of the moments of silence replaced those.

“Oh, come to think of it, Miss Iana.”

“Yes.”

I lifted my gaze at his call just as I was about to lift the cup to my mouth. The tea that’s falling over my throat was so sweet. It’s so amazing. I had always liked black tea. And I guess the real Iana really liked it, too.

I found it amusing, and at the same time, I was delighted as I had discovered a surprising similarity between the original owner of this body and me.

“It looks like Miss Iana’s release date will be decided soon.”

I almost spat out a mouthful of tea that I just sipped. And it was purely because of the man’s face in front of me that I managed to endure not doing it.

His cold, sharp eyes resemble those of a serpent. One wrong move, and you’ll get attacked. So maybe if I spat it out here...then my life would be

over. I might have even been stabbed to death if I wasn't able to hold it back.

I inhaled deeply to calm my nerves before opening my lips.

“Out of prison?”

No, my gosh, Lenag! I don't even know my prison sentence and what kind of sin I am here for. And to hear that right now? I don't know what I should feel.

“Literally. Miss Iana, you will be released from this cell soon.”

When I woke up inside this establishment, I realized that I was a sinner, a prisoner and that this place was a prison. But I was so comfortable walking around that I recognized this as a place where I could wander freely wearing these striped clothes that were cozy.

Moreover, I couldn't help but feel a little disheartened as I had already incredibly accustomed to this place. I've gotten so comfortable lurking in here that it saddens me to think that I need to conform to my new life once I'm out of here.

It seemed suspicious, and I knew for sure that this man here pulled some string for me and did me another favor. It's really becoming apparent that Lenag here has a bias on Iana. Well, not to assume, but it could be a possibility... Because what could be the other interpretations of the actions of this young man.

I stared at Lenag, whose eyes were closed, in front of me.

This was a prison, but it's definitely different from the other prisons I knew, especially those in my real world. Maybe it's because of the word “prison” that one could generalize and think of it as obsolete.

Not long after, Lenag's face, which had a soft expression a little while ago, looked very indifferent in this instant.

I just felt dazed.

“...was that possible?”

“What are you talking about?”

“Out of prison.” No. Was being released this quick and straightforward? That was what I really wanted to ask.

Like those ceremonious moments in a drama, I recalled a prisoner’s happy face with a voice saying, *‘I will be released’* countless times. But why did I feel like it didn’t go well with my situation?

Soon, a detached look had appeared in Lenag’s face as he was looking at me.

“... aren’t you happy?”

I think I missed the timing to be happy. If only I were released from the beginning of my stay here, I would definitely feel happy, but I don’t think I could say the same matter right now.

“No. I came here because I have sinned. I didn’t think it was so easy for a sinner to... .”

Thud!

I couldn’t complete what I wanted to say because I was stunned, as the man in front of me stood up beside the table. He seemed to have hit the top of the table lightly, but that was enough to create a vibration to shake the four-tiered tray.

“Miss Iana, have you always thought it like that?”

An ambiguous expression passed through Lenag’s face. I didn’t know why he was acting like that, but I just nodded nonchalantly.

Did you think so too? That I am a sinner? So, I didn’t say the wrong thing... But why were you coming out like that? What’s going on with you?

“It’s not your fault.”

“What are you talking about?” I asked again the question that he had asked me earlier.

“You are not a sinner.”

I am not a sinner? Then what am I?

I looked at him with a harsh expression, but still, Lenag had no intention to answer. Instead, an unknown light appeared in his aurum eyes.

Lenag was silent for a moment; it seemed like no words would come out of his mouth for the time being. So I took this chance to let go of the fear that I had slightly felt while watching him.

“This is the infamous Kambrakam prison. I’m one of the prisoners in this place. What do you mean when you say that I am not a sinner?”

Chapter 67: What am I? (2)

Chapter 67 – What am I? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I admit I've been at ease here. But that didn't change the nature of this establishment. I slept in a room with bars and couldn't escape from this prison. And no matter how free I was, my freedom was still limited. This was the only time I had admitted it because I did not have the opportunity and courage to complain.

"It's different. Every prisoner here had sinned, but you are different. Miss Iana."

Lenag declared firmly. The embarrassed look earlier was nowhere to be seen as if those were sucked by the pair of glasses he was wearing.

"That's an exaggeration. I've seen a lot of people in this prison and I could say we were no different from each other."

"Maybe. But you shouldn't overlook the fact that people can lie."

Lenag touched the edge of the table. At the same time, his upper body tilted slightly.

"The people here are usually hideous, cunning, and wicked. A noble prisoner is no different."

As he got closer little by little, I felt like a big beast was lying on its stomach in front of me. Like he's going to lift his body and reel me in with his fangs at any minute.

“...what is the distinction if I’m different from them?”

Gulp.

I swallowed and held on to my trousers for a moment. It felt like cold sweat was forming on my palm, but I tried not to show it. I also didn’t think I should show my back here at any moment.

“What am I like in the way you see me?”

“That’s...”

Actually, it’s a great relief that our conversation came back a little. Ever since I stepped my foot inside his den, I was already looking for an opportunity to gather information. However, it’s ironic how it was only now that I finally had a chance to identify Iana’s family and real identity when I’m already feeling a sense of crisis.

“...I know it’s clear that you didn’t commit a crime or anything else. You were sent here to be protected.”

“...to be protected?”

“Yes. Someone was after you. Among the crowd.”

I shut my mouth for a moment at the sound of those unknown words. Someone was aiming for Iana. Who? And why was she being targeted?

Also, she was sent to this prison to be protected?

I don’t know who sent her here, but I thought it was a very horrible but unique scheme.

Who would send people to jail for protection? I couldn’t even think of this as a safe place, so who in their right mind would?

Thinking about it, Iana was a nobleman. It’s not bad considering the jewels and things my brother sent me. That means he was living a luxurious life.

But no matter how good the welfare or the life of a noble prisoner was, a prisoner was still a prisoner. It can't be compared to a noble mansion or a splendid room that was outside of prison.

And therefore, I thought it was a very embarrassing and awkward way.

Or... or maybe that person was desperate enough to protect her.

"And the man who sent you here for me to protect was none other than your brother."

"My... my brother?"

"Yes, as you may have guessed. I thought you would feel embarrassed the moment you're being placed in here. And knowing that you're from a noble family, you might've felt new to this kind of environment. That's why I decided not to show up for a moment to make you feel at ease."

"So you were waiting for me to adjust. Is that what you're trying to relay?"

"Yes."

I learned from this that Lenag here had a much closer relationship than I thought with Iana's family. Not just to give me convenience and favor, but to protect me as the head of this vast prison.

"Was it typical for you to receive requests like this and do their bidding?"

"Well, if you've been asking for a record. It's been a while now, so no. Requests like this are rare, and this one is of the essence."

I erased some assumptions concerning his statement. I also thought that if she was related to the main characters' family, then my daydreams could change after my discharge.

I had to remember the genre of this book. I evoked myself one more time just in case.

“You seem to treat me as if I were a Marquess’ concubine or a Duke’s Yeong-ae. Unreasonably.”

For a moment, his golden eyes turned to me with an unexpected radiance. The different colored gaze crossed in the air for a moment.

“... that’s not true.”

“No?” I asked.

“Yes, Miss Iana, you are neither a Marquess nor a Duke’s Yeong-ae.”

With that said, I was relieved. Good. As long as I didn’t have to be connected with any of them. Both the families I spoke of were of the main characters in this story. The latter belonged to the black rose Chaser, and red rose Ricdorian, and the other was the family of the wicked.

While relieved, Lenag stood up to get something. He came back with a small round table with a crab. Soon, his big hand touched the table.

And, I blinked at the close distance.

“Miss Iana, it is a basic knowledge that I know who your family is, but it’s not my right to tell and not the right time to tell.”

His manner was perfectly polite while saying those words.

“Because I know how much you hated your family.”

He moved his hand in front of me as if he was about to console me, but when he’s already halfway, he hesitated for a second and then pulled back his hand in an instant as if he had awakened from a nightmare.

“I hope you won’t hate me.”

Slowly, his long hair covered the sun. I raised my head, rather than watching his long hair sway.

So this guy knew Iana longer than I thought. And Iana didn't like her own family?

I was about to query him when someone interrupted.

Knock, Knock.

We heard a knock, and this uninvited person seemed unwelcome to Lenag as well as to me. We were still at the hype of our conversation, and this person, whoever this was, disrupted us at the wrong timing.

Lenag's brows furrowed. I, on the other hand, didn't bother moving at all.

Soon the guard opened the door and came in.

“This is an urgent letter, Sir.”

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Chapter 68: Guests are coming to the prison (1)

Chapter 68 – Guests are coming to the prison (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

The guard who showed up was Arthur, the youngest jailer I knew in this prison.

My eyes passed through his trembling hands, which were grasping the red envelope. He seemed a bit hesitant in stating what his intention was, and if I'm not mistaken, judging from his flushed face, he looked like he was in a rush because of the red colored envelope, which denoted urgency.

Soon, he handed over the letter and left in haste.

Lenag read it without delay.

“Oh, Miss Iana...”

Soon, a frustrated look was shown on his face. I desperately wanted to know why he was looking at me with dismay.

I didn't know what was happening. I'm kind of lost as of the moment.

Suddenly, he turned to me.

“Something wrong?”

Lenag closed his mouth for a moment, and then with deep thoughts in mind, he began roaming the space at a snail's pace.

“He says he’ll be here right away.”

“Eh? Who?” I asked in confusion.

A moment of silence had passed until he spoke.

“Your brother.”

Brother. I paused as of the moment because of the familiar word.

“Oh, Miss Iana. Have you made a mistake to your brother?”

“...What?” I still couldn’t apprehend the sudden delivered news.

His eyes crossed mine as if he was trying to read me.

“A mistake...”

Mistake? What did I even do to make a mistake to my brother? In the first place, I didn’t do anything like literally nothing at all.

Ohh...

That thought brought my mind into sudden realization.

Come to think of it. I didn’t send my brother a reply, right? I just noticed now that I missed what I was supposed to be doing all the time. It was just a petty reason to be referred to as a mistake, but for some reason, I felt anxious to the point that goosebumps started to rise.

Somehow I asked myself why I haven’t done it. Why did I not send a single response to his question? I thought it wouldn’t be a huge deal, but surely, I was mistaken.

At that moment of questioning myself, Lenag delivered a neat sentence.

“He needs to see you immediately.” He said so and then tilted his head for a moment. There was a hint of wonder in his eyes as to why the sudden need of seeing me and such.

“No, I think I made a slip of the tongue. I’m the one who screwed up, not you. I don’t believe you made a mistake.”

“What?” I looked at him, wondering what he meant.

“You can’t possibly make mistakes.”

“Eh?” Unconsciously, my inner thoughts slipped out, like it was an intentional response. But I managed to patch it up as quickly as I could.

“Oh, ah... Yes. Uh, um, thank you for your kind consideration...” I retorted, a little unsure how to acknowledge his positive insights of me.

Then Lenag responded resolutely. “Do I look like a good person now?”

When I raised my eyes, Lenag’s face was full of sincerity even after knowing the possibility of me making a mistake. Besides, hearing a thing or two about my brother’s urgent coming would certainly make one believe that I did something terrible.

However, staring intensely at his gaze, I felt like I saw something a little different. Those gleaming eyes with long lashes blinked slowly, and a gentle smile formed on his lips. I was dumbfounded as this was the first time I saw his smile reach his eyes.

“I always look at you as who you are. Miss Iana.”

“Uh-huh.”

Where did the burdensome look from earlier go? I think his eyes right now were no different from those fans adoring their idols.

I just shrugged that notion off as I wasn’t interested in that. Also, I decided to let the growing awkwardness pass on for a while. There was something more important than that.

“By the way, this is a tough job... .”

In the meantime, Lenag, who bowed his head for a while, murmured as if he were talking to himself. It sounded better without me knowing it, but I could hear it clearly because he and I were quite close.

“What’s the trouble all about?”

“Oh, did you hear that? It’s nothing different...”

He hesitated for a moment and then opened his lips with a slightly perplexed expression.

“A guest from the Hel estate will visit soon.” The moment I heard the name, I paused.

“Is it the Archduke?”

“Yes, he is the family of the prisoner whom you enjoy playing and walking with.” Archduke Harnim. A family of Ricdorian.

“...the one you were with this morning.”

“Yes, he is.”

For a moment, it seemed that Lenag had a very calm voice, but his tone was basically cold, so it’s nothing new besides, I’m kind of getting used to him speaking those phrases sternly.

On the other hand, did I hear it wrong?

After a quick grin, I tilted my head for a moment and concentrated on what I had just heard.

Archduke Harnim will visit. Well, this wasn’t so special. But in the book, it was a worthy plot that was described in detail. It’s just that....the last time they went in this prison, Ricdorian was tortured. His body was left with bruises and wounds, which took a long time to heal. His form was even barely intact.

Archduke Harnim. In particular, the Archduke of Hel estate, the father of Ricdorian, was a self-propelled abuser of the male lead. He was a remorseless human being. I don't even know if he can be considered a human being with how he treats his own son.

The reason for his brutal actions was that his capable son was only swayed by a curse that came down from generation to generation without obtaining the slightest talent. Of course, as a male protagonist, he had more powerful talents and abilities than anyone else, but it was only a matter of time before this came to light. At least after meeting the heroine. So until then, he was continuously subjected to this kind of violence.

'I was so hurt a lot at that time.'

I closed my eyes when I remembered the last time someone went to visit him. I didn't want to dwell on that day once again. No matter how good my life was, no matter how easy it was to live, it was so hard to ignore and forget the sight of the blood smelling Ricdorian in front of my eyes. I didn't want to see him again like that.

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Chapter 69: Guests are coming to the prison (2)

Chapter 69 – Guests are coming to the prison (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

I clenched my fist. The mere thought of seeing him like that made my heart bleed in pain, what more if I personally saw him like that. Heaven would surely turn like hell. But still, I couldn't do anything to prevent him from hurting at least for now.

Thinking of my past endeavors, I had cast a spell on Ricdorian at the request of Jair, the sorcerer of the Hel estate. That led to the fact that Ricdorian had an abnormal form of growth, which I couldn't believe.

'I don't know anything else, and I know I shouldn't be doing this.'

At the very least, it was clear that the Archduke Harnim visiting him would not lead to a good result. Strangely enough, Ricdorian had grown up for a while, but that did not mean he had grown up or developed abilities.

If he had indeed grown-up or awakened, he should have already freed himself from the chains that stifled him, the same as what had happened in the original story.

As I said, Archduke Harnim hated his son because he was incompetent and useless. At the same time, he hated the fact that Ricdorian lost the ability to communicate because of the curse.

By the way, if he finds out that he has grown up a little bit this time, and that there's no great significance in that and no abilities were discovered...

His usual abuse might have gotten worse.

“When will they come?”

“Do you mean Archduke Harnim? You must be so concerned about it Iana.”

My family has a close relationship with Lenag. And Lenag advocated neutrality on the outside, but in fact, the Marquess who followed Chaser, and my family was more on the villain’s side. This was also confirmed in my previous conversation with Lenag.

“As you know, when your family encounters the Archduke of Hel, it’s not very pleasant, and the state of affairs will become chaotic.”

“Ah... That’s right.” I nodded, pretending to know and understand it, but my head was so confused inside.

I wondered why the state of affairs would be in turmoil if anyone in our family made an encounter with the Hel family, but soon, I made a rough guess.

The bombing that the prisoners were talking about. The father of the villain, Chaser, did die there, right? Chaser, the real culprit, was silently working on his plan thoroughly.

It was something that the House of Harnim, who protects justice, would not have been able to see. To be honest, I don’t know how a person, who was said to be a protector of justice, can beat and abuse his own son.

How ironic is that? Protecting the justice system, but he himself was a man of injustice.

The novel’s contents were like that. Human beings were so stereoscopic that they tend to trick another person’s brain into believing that they were godly good when, in fact, they were as dirty as evil.. Anyway, if Archduke Harnim would come here, I guess it wouldn’t be a good thing for my brother to meet them here.

Ricdorian was also from the Hel family. So does that mean we're forbidden to meet?

The letters that I have been receiving from my brother have passed by my mind. However, I didn't want my brother, who was kind and friendly, to be in such trouble.

But what can I do?

"How long does it take?"

"What? Oh, Archduke Harnim?. Maybe... it'll take about four days if it's on schedule."

Then Lenag grabbed his chin and immersed himself in thoughts for a moment, and soon said, "In the case of your brother...I think it'll take about four days...if he's using the normal route."

Normal? Strangely, it was long, but as the navigation foresaw, the expected timing depending on traffic conditions was about average arrival time.

"Anyway, he might run into him, right?"

"Yes, as of now, it is possible."

I pursed my lips tightly and soon parted it. "...do you expect conflict when Archduke Harnim and my brother meet?"

I thought my family would be broken down the next day.

"Yes, that's right. The cell may be overturned for once. And it's not good. This is a place where disturbance is not tolerated because it is a place to confine sinners. The Archduke will not just stay put. He will surely fume in range if their paths cross."

Although he had joined hands with Chaser, on the surface, he was a prison head responsible for peace and tranquility inside Kambrakam. I understood his situation. It would be difficult for a powerful man like Harnim to make a scene.

“Yes. The problem could get bigger.”

I raised my finger and grabbed my chin like Lenag did. It was a habit of mine when I was lost in thought. And Lenag seemed to wonder at me for a moment, but gently waited in silence.

Unlike his scary face, he was a man of good manners and conduct.

“More than anything else, I’m afraid Miss Iana was more involved in this.”

Out of thoughtfulness, he added a word that didn’t surprise me since it’s already expected for him to look after my welfare ever since I’m told that this man was protecting me whatever it takes at the mercy and request of my family.

I gently reached out and grabbed a small piece of paper, and wrapped a snack from the table. Then, he slowly put his hand on top of the table.

I could feel Lenag’s keen gaze at me. Soon, I raised my head and laughed hard. Although he looks sharp and frightening, I didn’t know he was doing what I was doing.

“Thank you.”

I stretched out my hand to get the snack. Eventually, it reached my fingertips.

“I feel like I’m getting too much consideration. You worry about me a lot.”

I said wholeheartedly. Even though this was the request of my family, he still could’ve chosen to reject them, but he didn’t. So I’m grateful.

“That’s right because we have that kind of relationship.”

For a moment, Lenag somehow avoided my gaze. And his long hair swayed gently along with the head. It was so distracting, but it seemed much more than that. It was something rare.

The moment he looked back straight into my eyes, I saw the eyes of this not so cold man burning with the color of blood. His face remained nonchalant; however, there's just something with the manner he stared that I couldn't figure out. And his face, which portrays calmness, was something I couldn't be sure of.

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Chapter 70: Guests are coming to the prison (3)

Chapter 70 – Guests are coming to the prison (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

“Can’t we stop him from pursuing his trip to visit me? We should warn him now while it’s still early. And just like what you said, the possibility of my brother and the Archduke running into each other will surely create a commotion. So as much as possible, I think we should avoid that collision.”

“I don’t think your brother will listen. Most of all, if he had already established his decision, he doesn’t have the means to stop. Furthermore, it won’t be long until he arrives.”

“... well, then there’s nothing I can do about that.” I sighed in surrender.

For now, there was no other way. Lenag said my brother might be in trouble, but there were no other options I could think of to help him, so I felt a little useless and embarrassed.

My brother and my family will be in trouble soon.

“I know it’s not my fault, but I’m sorry.”

“What? You don’t have to be sorry, Miss Iana. It wasn’t Miss Iana will.” Lenag shook his head firmly, disapproving my remorseful attitude at the same time, consoling me.

“Thank you for saying that.”

Hahaha.

I laughed out loud and scratched my cheek to avert the awkward mood from rising. Although it was not the proper way a lady from a noble family must act, Lenag's persistent stare at me made me roll my eyes in blithe.

"Well, I see. But for now, I will head back to my cell." I said, and turned my head.

Unfortunately, our conversation ended here because of the guard's letter, who entered this room in a hurry a while ago, but I heard the countless footsteps coming to this place at this time.

The footsteps were getting louder and louder that my dull ears could hear it, so I presume that the person in front of me had a busy schedule. Sure enough, I'm scared but smart enough to say it.

Soon, I heard a knock on the door.

Knock. Knock.

It was a very courteous knock that came from someone who arrived from a run. And I knew it's my cue to exit.

It was when I was about to stand up from my seat when I heard Lenag call me and advanced towards me.

"Miss Iana."

Lenag caught my fingertips. It was a careful and feeble force that I could easily shake off if I try to resist.

Soon, Lenag bent his upper body, still holding my fingertips. And his soft lips brushed against the back of my hand, like that of a prince, hand-kissing a princess which indicates courtesy, politeness, respect, admiration, and devotion.

"I forgot to say goodbye."

His long brown hair flowed gently when he bowed down his head.

“Please don’t forget, I’m always here to grant you favor and protection.”

Lenag also said that it was not the first time he had received such a request of protection in his prison. Then, there was someone like me before.

Do they usually tend to people under their care, who need protection, up to whatever extent it is?

I laughed awkwardly when I caught sight of his golden eyes that were glistening in persistency like a hawk who already set his mind on his aim.

“...Yes, thank you.”

I wonder why being caught by his hand felt like I’m tightly captured on the hook.

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Leaving Lenag’s office, I walked leisurely.

Archduke Harnim, who keeps on violating Ricdorian’s body, would soon come, and my brother, who had sent me a lot of letters with questionable kindness, would come as well.

They will gather together in this cell. Sadly, there was nothing I could do because I was barely a prisoner with no capability to prevent things. All I could do was talk to the guards.

But soon, I opened my mouth with sincerity.

“So, you’re saying that it’s almost impossible for middle-east prisoners to take a walk?”

“Yes, Miss.”

I nodded at the guard’s response.

In front of me was a new mid-level guard standing with a serious face. After Lenag caught me that day, the guard assigned to me changed always, and I, Iana, had to be as cautious as possible because I felt that he was always watching me.

Sometimes I wonder if every guard assigned to me was a spy.

Aside from continually changing guards assigned to me, nothing has really changed even the surveillance team, nothing's really new with them, so it wasn't that uncomfortable.

“There are some prisoners from the middle east side of the prison who are quite vicious and guilty of minor crimes. Of course, some of them were given a chance to walk in the garden. But it doesn't often happen because of the lack of management personnel.”

“Aha, You've seen it once, then?”

“Yes. That's right. You must have seen it too.”

In addition, he answered my question without any hesitation. It must be due to Lenag's strict instructions to allow me to do everything at my bidding.

“Well, the next walk of some Middle east prisoner is... I'm not sure. That was the work of the management area. Oh, well, I guess I heard from my colleague that it would be done soon.”

“Oh, is that so? When?”

“I think it was ten days from now.”

How come it won't happen soon?

I tried hard not to make a grimace expression, but it seemed that I failed in doing so as the guard with a serious face looked at me, wondering if something was wrong.

As I've said, it's a little uncomfortable because the guard keeps changing to a new one. Usually, if you were close to a guard, you would have said,

“Don’t do that. Ask me, or pull me, or I’m curious.”

Since the guards in charge of me always changed, I felt like I have discovered different types of people with different personalities. Some of which were strangely conservative while some were business-minded.

And since it goes like that, I don’t think Lenag was giving any guard a chance to be attached to me. It was a good strategy for him, though, to ensure the loyalty of his underlings.

I shook my head lightly.

Thought aside, the main reason why I asked about the Middle East side of the prison was to find an opportunity to meet Jair, the wizard of the Hel estate. Perhaps he was staying here quietly, looking for an opportunity as well.

Above all, since he asked me to let him know about Ricdorian’s progress, wouldn’t he want to run into me if he’s curious about it? Just in case, I chose to ask questions about the prison’s Middle East side by subtly mixing them with other questions.

It’s good to help Ricdorian, but it’s better not to cause him trouble in the future. Anyway, Jair was the only one who could explain everything about the acts and abnormalities of Ricdorian.

The only question was, how am I supposed to meet him? When even his shadow was hardly showing up to me.

“Miss Iana, the sun is so hot today. Why don’t you go back inside?”

“Oh? Yes, I will.”

Chapter 71: Guests are coming to the prison (4)

Chapter 71 – Guests are coming to the prison (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: SKAIS

After meeting Lenag, I came out to inhale some fresh air and have some time to think alone. At the same time, I tried to get information from the guard attending to me, but I didn't get that much.

So I ended up thinking that I should just spend my remaining time like this in peace and tranquility. However, I decided to end my time enjoying the garden and go inside, as suggested by the guard.

Back in the lounge, there were a few aristocratic prisoners who took a rest. Among them, Baron Paladis, one of my closest friends, found me and waved his hand.

“Iana, here!”

I had no reason to ignore him, so I walked towards them and joined the group. The group included Baron and Sally, as well as female prisoners whom I had spoken several times.

“Where have you been?”

“Long time no see, Miss Iana.”

“I found you, Iana!”

“Oh, yes, yes. Where have I been? On my bed? Hello, Miss Roana. Hello, Sally!”

One of the people who greeted me with a wave was from a fancy priestly quarter. Her face didn’t ring a bell even when we’re wearing the same striped clothes.

I roamed my sight in the area, and a strange excitement was evident in every face that I looked at—like a child before a picnic.

Not only I nor the flock I’m with, but the entire lounge was strangely scattered.

I tilted my head.

I remember seeing this exciting crowd last time, but at that time, it was because of the shocking news about the bombing of the Bunton Art Museum and the suspicion that Chaser was the culprit.

“Well, I feel like everyone was a bit excited today. What’s the matter?”

“That’s right, of course. Oh, my Iana. I told you about it before. Did you already forget about it?”

“Oh, did you?” What I only remember was that I was lost in thoughts and lost track of what others said at that time.

I sneaked a smile so that they won’t hate me.

“Oh, my God, where the hell did your mind wander to?”

“It’s been two days since she became like this. An absent-minded woman.”

“That’s true. Well, anyway, the special visiting day is coming soon.”

“Visiting day?”

“Yes, that would be the day after tomorrow! For three days!”

Instead of asking them, I shrieked. There was something I remembered.

“A three-day event in prison that happens once a year! That’s the day when a noble prisoner was allowed to have tea time and have visitors.”

“But it’s hard to dress elegantly.”

“A simple cloak or robe is allowed, but what about you, Iana?”

Come to think of it, I’ve heard of this before because it wasn’t long since I opened my eyes in this world. At that time, this guy, Baron, explained it to me excitedly then.

Only in Kambrakam, a noble prisoner was allowed to have a large-scale visit once a year, allowing them to act like free nobles for a day.

As seen in a drama’s cell visitation, it was not like having a meeting with a hole between them or a telephone for conversations. It was a great pleasure for noble prisoners to be given privileges like that.

I think it’s been a while since I heard this, but how long has it been? Even though there was such a big event like this, I was surprised to learn something this outrageous.

In the meantime, I’ve been losing my mind. Then I blinked.

Wait a minute. Wait a minute. Does it start the day after tomorrow?

So that means the Archduke of Hel and my brother wouldn’t just meet each other like that?

I felt a little relieved.

I felt sorry for my brother for whatever he might go through for visiting me. Still, I thought it was also a good thing since Archduke Harnim wouldn’t bother visiting Ricdorian and engage him in his brutal acts as lots of people would surround him and this prison.

So that’s a blessing in disguise, right?

“Mister, people are coming all the way through the event, right? Would there be a huge crowd?”

“Oh, not really. I only know that after a brief event on the first day within the prison, guests are allowed on the second day. And on the third day, another special event will be held.”

“Like the teatime you told me about?”

“Yes, it’s a time that only prisoners enjoy”

I pondered about it for a while. This indicated that the day when Harnim and the people coming for the event won’t overlap.

What? No, that’s not good.

At least it would be easy to think of a method since it would be a crowded day. But suddenly I had a different idea.

The Hel family visited Ricdorian’s cell at regular intervals. So every time he visited Ricdorian must have been of benefit to the Archduke. So right now, what I should do was to think on the same boat as him.

The original visitation period was adjusted because of the three-day event. The fact that Kambrakam will become crowded as it would be opened to the outside world would mean that it would be difficult for the Archduke to visit Ricdorian. And therefore, he was planning to visit him on the day when there was a private event.

I slowly measured the intentions of Archduke Harnim.

He doesn’t want to stand out, and if he can’t see Ricdorian inside his cell for a period of time, he’ll probably go back without making a scene.

And in order for Archduke Harnim to miss Ricdorian on the day of his visit, I’ll visit Ricdorian’s cell first. Until then, Ricdorian will be safe.

And, why don’t I try hiding Ricdorian during this three day event?

Is that possible? But it would be too obvious.

Of course, this may be considered deceit, but he did not wholly escape. Let's just say he disappeared for a while.

Right. I admitted that there was a limit to what I could do. And this was the only way I could help Ricdorian.

Wouldn't it be better if he won't be maltreated for a while? Also, it would be nice if Jair would find an answer to his abnormal growth pattern during this period of time.

That's why I have to meet Jair as soon as possible...

Chapter 72: Guests are coming to the prison (5)

Chapter 72 – Guests are coming to the prison (5)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

While I was busy dealing with my tumultuous thoughts, the conversation between Baron and the group had begun to drift elsewhere. Just before I had entered the room, they were already holding a newspaper and talking amongst each other about the upcoming event.

I wasn't certain what they were really talking about, but I could deduce it somewhat through what they were currently saying.

“Didn't I tell you? It's going to be a battle of roses.”

“Do you think the Archduke-”, I was certain they meant Chaser's father, “-would be so easily fooled in such an obvious scheme?”

“Well, if that was really the case behind that incident, then I'd be willing to bet my name on it.” snorted the other.

I turned away from them, glancing around me when I spotted Sally. In her hands was a newspaper, and on it was a picture, which Baron was pointing at, his index finger rubbing harshly against the flat plane.

Staring at it rather intently, I could see it was a strange design of two giant roses. On closer inspection, it wasn't just a picture, but rather a painting. It's elaborate design was clearly visible, not just on its brush strokes, but their patterns as well.

“It’s a rose.” I remarked softly, drawing their attention to my presence.

“Oh, Iana.” Baron looked down to where I had my gaze on and nodded, “Ah yes, indeed it is. It pertains to the empire’s infamous five roses. I reckon the other countries are envious of our pride and glorious legends, seeing as it’s still well-known and well established even to this day.”

He gave me a rather knowing look.

“Even you’ve heard of it of course.” he added.

“Why of course.” I quickly responded, feigning my knowledge, when in fact I barely have any clue to what they were talking about. I knew what they meant, but not much of it. So I merely smiled, and tried to act cool and composed as possible, to conceal the fact that I was all but a novice to the inner workings of this entire empire.

But despite that, I find myself greatly drawn to these *roses*.

“In fact, I don’t mind hearing the stories from time to time.” I prompted, giving them a charming smile, hoping they’d tell me more on what these roses actually were.

“Oho, so you just love listening to stories then?” Mr. Paladis piped up, seemingly excited about the prospect of speaking. It didn’t matter what the topic was, he’d love to talk your ear off just about anything and everything he knew about.

Although many times he would be mistaken as swindling someone inside this prison. He just carries that certain charm and habit whenever he talks, like a charmer.

But aside from his charming tongue, Mr. Paladis was a mastermind. His success in many fraudulent exploits can be mostly attributed to his meticulous planning, just before he would lure them into his perfectly woven trap. The added silver tongue was just a bonus.

“Three things make this empire a cut above the other countries,” he began the story...

“The first was known as ‘*The Imperial Palace of the Sun*.’ The first of the legendary inventor’s greatest of masterpieces. The second came in the form of a prison, named the *Kambrakam*. It has been built since ancient times, and has remained standing even over a thousand of years. And the last, but certainly not the least, are special people, with special powers, dubbed as **Roses**.” Baron straightened up, flashing me with a lenient smile while he recounted the story for me.

“There’s a famous legend regarding these Roses, the five gates of the Empire, and what abilities these five great families have.” Baron explained.

“That’s right.” the other piped up.

I know that if I had a special ability, I would know it from this story, because I had a feeling it was related to what I’ve read about the contents of the book. After all, even the curse of Ricdorian was another special ability that has been passed down from one to another.

“Though despite there being five families, only three are left. One is already gone, while the other has gone missing. But the most notable of them were the **Red** and the **Black** roses.”

“You mean the Hel and the Domulit?” Sally interrupted, with a curious tone. She too already knew the story, but she still seemed rather interested to hear the story despite the numerous repetitions.

I’ve heard of the saying that the expression on a person’s face changes in the event they become ecstatic, and with the added information that there was an upcoming event seemed to have contributed to such a feeling.

“Correct!” Baron praised her, “Though the Domulit especially. They’re rather well-known for the worst ability amongst the families, explosion.”

“Isn’t the Hel family, who have a long-standing rivalry against them, embody the talent for justice?” I asked.

Odd, I thought as I tried to hide my amusement. I had known what Ricdorian's ability was, just as well as I knew Chaser's, but I don't think they knew for sure what they really are.

But the red rose...

The more I thought of it, the more I was convinced that the symbol of the door lies with them. Additionally, the more I thought Ricdorian out of place amongst them. He didn't seem like a red rose.

No, I would have thought him something like white. A striking contrast to the passion of red.

"...meanwhile the rest is left to the Yellow Rose, the symbol of equality, and neutrality. Famously known as the Lenag Tuge Valtege, the Marquess." Baron continued, as he locked eyes with me,

"The one managing this prison."

Lenag was what? It's the first I've heard of it.

I resumed to listen in earnest to the legend once more, committing to memory every detail behind each of the families. For some reason, I found it important to remember even the littlest of information.

"Though to be honest, I'm rather curious more about the white rose." Sally interrupted midway, "They're a rather infamous bunch for a long time now, until they suddenly vanished. I'm not sure if the other families knew, but they were quite well-known throughout the empire for their ability."

"Ah, you mean their ability to heal?" Baron asked, his voice taking a rather somber tone, "Up until a few centuries ago, they were revered as something akin to saints. The White Rose were greatly wise, and virtuous in nature."

"Right."

It gave me pause as I heard that. Healing, huh? It reminded me of someone.

Francia El Rosenia.

The heroine of the book.

“Rosenia...” I muttered softly, “Didn’t they say that the bloodline was no more?”

“Yes, that is true, even the Emperor was greatly intrigued by such travesty.”

Gone. But that wasn’t really a surprise, after all, that’s how the story was supposed to go. It’s just like I’ve already thought before...

No matter how great the story seemed to be in the beginning, thirty seconds in the story, I could already see the many plot holes due to the many settings incorporated in the story. After all, it was only halfway across the book did the heroine, whom I first thought was a normal person, did have the ability to heal.

She was soon discovered to be a saint even! It certainly made my body tingle and give in to the urge to scream. At that point I had thought it to be quite an unexpected twist in the story, but now...

It wasn’t that unlikely after all.

“Well, speaking of an ability that disappeared, I can only think of the blue color that was already forgotten.”

“That’s it, it’s the name that’s gone to the back of history.”

Chapter 73: Guests are coming to the prison (6)

Chapter 73 – Guests are coming to the prison (6)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

Eventually they steered off the topic of roses, and rather delved into something much more similar to that of a history lesson. I mentally sighed, whatever they were talking about were no longer crucial to the book's story.

They continued to share story after story, about the empire, and everything else. They talked until eventually, the break ended, and soon, it was time for everyone to go back to their respective cells, up until the time dinner rolled by and they could come back out once more.

As everyone was busy moving back, I stayed in my place, waiting as they all piled out, until I was the last to leave, and made my way to the guard.

I stopped right in front of him, and the guard raised a brow towards me.

“To the cellar?” I asked with a little hesitancy. The guard only sighed quietly before nodding.

“Miss Iana, last to leave, I see.”

“Yes, that's right because I'm trying to go somewhere else,” I told him, “By myself.” I added for good measure, “There's no particular reason, I just thought that's a good idea.” I shrugged.

The guard and I then prepared to leave for the cellar, but just as we were about to move, I could hear footsteps coming towards us in urgency.

Someone was coming towards us.

“Aha! There you are!” a man remarked as soon as he reached us.

“Aha.” It was when we were about to leave the empty lounge together.

Tadadak.

He wore the same clothes as the person beside me, a mid-level guard of the prison. The guard’s face hardened as he whispered something to his colleague, his voice soft that I couldn’t hear what he had said. His gaze shifted to the hallway, and then to me.

When he finally stopped, he looked at me with a grave expression.

“Miss Iana, I apologize, but may you go to the cellar?” he asked, and when I looked at the other guard, he continued, “Alone?”

Usually it would be absurd to even leave a prisoner on their own, but as someone with a noble status especially because of my brother, even in prison I was free to do what I wanted. But not everything.

Ricdorian’s cell was off-limits, especially since a senior guard was tasked in keeping it. Eventually I nodded to the guard’s request.

Immediately, the guard in charge bowed his head before leaving swiftly.

What was going on?

Soon enough, I found myself walking along the empty corridor, curiosity thrumming beneath my skin. Despite the corridor being vacated at every hour of the day, this time, it seemed more isolated than usual.

Like the calm before the storm.

Slowly I trudged downwards the spiral staircase, thinking I was alone but...

“Hello, Miss Iana.”

I stifled gasps as I whipped my head around. I had been startled to hear someone greet me, but wherever I looked, no one was there.

At least, no one was visible for me to see.

“Here you go.” the voice continued and I fought hard to keep myself from stuttering...

“...here?” I asked in confusion.

“The arm.” Arm? ***“Your arm.”***

I lowered my line of sight, and stared in shock at the slight glow that surrounded my arm.

It was the bracelet. The one Jair gave me from before, and I had worn it every day since. Once more I looked up to see if anyone was there, but still I remained alone in the corridor. That was good.

Breathing out a sigh of relief, I looked back down on the bracelet, and brought it up to my lips.

“Mr. Jair? Is that you? What is it?” I asked in quick succession.

“Yes. That’s right. I’m glad you remembered me.”

“Is this the right time to talk about that? Anyway, how were you able to do this...” I asked with great wonder. I was going to ask if I could use magic as well, but before I could, a laughter echoed in the hall. His voice was full of embarrassment.

“My apologies, Miss Iana, but I’m running out of time right now. Is there anyone nearby?”

“Yes.”

“Then can we go to a place where there’s only a few people? As quick as possible. A more private place where we could talk.”

Jair's tone was impatient, which in turn made him seem quite suspicious, but I decided to listen and follow his request anyway. Besides, I was hoping to be able to contact Jair, too.

"By the way, I didn't know we could get in touch quickly like this. You must be very curious about what happened to the prisoner."

"Hahaha. I'm sorry. This is a matter..." he trailed off.

I completely understood where he was coming from. After all, the purpose of him blending in as one of the ordinary prisoners was so he could hide in plain sight. I continued further down towards the first floor, passed through an open area, and into the garden, to the plot area filled with radishes.

I couldn't see any guard nearby as I was walking around, and deemed it empty enough for the conversation. It was easy enough getting inside the garden, and thankfully for Jair, he kept me relaxed enough as he continued to talk to me despite my caution to get here.

Although perhaps he was also checking the range of our communication.

I could easily deduce this wasn't a place where any of the guards would allow the prisoners to wander in. It was no wonder there were no guards after all. Doing a last sweep of my surroundings, I raised the bracelet up to my lips once more.

"Alright, I'm clear."

Strangely enough, Mr. Jair was silent.

Why wasn't he talking?

It was then I realized the bracelet was no longer glowing.

"Hello?" I tried again, was the signal lost, or something? "Mr. Jair?" I pulled the bracelet away and looked at it with a frown.

Did we lose our means of communication?

I dropped my arm back to my side and sighed in dismay.

What was I supposed to do now? Should I leave? Should I wait for Mr. Jair to come back? Or, did I jostle the bracelet too much? Hit it against some concrete or something without knowing about it and destroyed the communication?

I was just about to jostle the bracelet like a maracas, when I felt my stomach drop and the hairs at the back of my head stand up...

And just like that, everything went black.

“Wait, wait, wait, what!?” I gasped in surprise. I couldn’t see anything. Why couldn’t I see anything in front of me!?

The more I struggled against my sudden blindness, the more I could tell someone was covering my eyes. I could feel the warmth emanating from its palms, warmer than the normal body temperature of a person.

I quickly grabbed the hand covering my eyes, trying to yank it off, when I heard some shushing sounds right beside my ear, my struggling eased up as I heard his voice...

“Shh, shh, Iana, relax. It’s all right.” his sweet voice was like honey, almost melting away my fear and panic. “It’s just me Iana, just me.”

His voice reminded me of springfields. The flowers are blooming after the cold winter, the cool breeze fluttering about, hitting my skin gently.

I’ve never heard his voice before in my life, but it felt like I knew him...

“How are you, my little sister?” he asked me. And I felt my breath hitch in my throat.

It was my brother.

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Chapter 74: I missed you (1)

Chapter 74 – I missed you (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

Brother. It was my brother.

It was the one word that made me want to bleach my hair all over, or even rip it out of my head. For a moment I hesitated.

I must've misheard. Surely I didn't hear right...

But the more I struggled, the more it became clear that I had been correct.

But brother?

This was my brother?

I could feel the tip of my fingers beginning to shake at the thought. I could hear my heartbeat echoing in my eardrums.

Why is he here? Is he really? Or am I only dreaming he was?

It was confusing, drowning even, my head felt like it was spinning around in circles. But I also knew there could only be one person who would call me in such a manner...

So sweetly...

So *affectionately*...

It was him, truly, my brother.

No one else could tell me otherwise, for I have read the letters.

My chest tightened up, my finger began to numb. I know why I'm so nervous to see him.

For while I stayed inside the prison, I had been acting with my own volition. What I wanted, I'd do, what I wished, I'd ask. No questions were asked, no refusals were made...

Simply because I knew I was with the people who didn't know the real Iana. But now, there was such a person here with me...

What would happen to me now that this person could tell me apart from the real one?

I swallowed the lump in my throat involuntarily. Cold sweat forming on my temples.

"Surprised?" he asked, slow and cautious. I could feel my breath begin to shudder, as my eyes darted nervously around beneath my eyelids.

The only silver lining I could see in this situation was that he was behind me right now, and could not see my expression becoming so unhinged, which included my nervous swallowing.

Time kept ticking the more I could not voice out my reply, and I eventually opened my mouth...

"Th-that... uh..."

I couldn't form the words. I didn't know what to say.

His sudden presence rendered me speechless that I couldn't summon an answer. Before I knew it, I could feel a warm breath hit my ear as he spoke once more...

I could imagine he had to dip his head to have spoken right next to my ear. Just thinking about his proximity made me want to shrink into myself, even as I felt my voice get caught in my throat.

“Iana.” he spoke once more. His voice sounded so smooth, so cool, his tone deep and beautiful. It was so sweet, I could feel the sound sending tingles in my ears.

“Are we on speaking terms now, Iana?”

My skin ran cold, I could feel the new chill run up my spine when he asked me that.

“Say, can we talk?” he prodded.

Never in my entire life had I heard such a voice. It was a first for me to hear such a smooth tone, so soft, I could feel myself melting the more I listened, never mind what he was actually saying. I could lose myself just listening to the sound.

Fortunately I finally managed to regain my senses.

Speaking terms? I thought in confusion. What are you talking about?

“To be honest, I didn’t think you’d come, especially since you knew I’ve been looking for you.”

As the silence continued, I suddenly remembered what Lenag had said.

<Your brother came here.>

My brother came to Kambrakam to see me.

However, we haven’t met with each other sooner because of an urgent matter. At that time, I felt dispirited about it, but when I saw the bouquet left by my brother, the morose mood I had was soon gone, replaced by embarrassment.

But currently, I was keenly aware of the warm body right behind me, cementing the fact that this person, right here with me now was no longer just a person I would meet in the form of words on paper.

It never felt so real as it did now.

“I hadn’t seen your face in so long,” he continued as I tried to deduce further what he was getting at. Did this mean they haven’t been in contact for so long? “You also mentioned you wouldn’t talk to me again.” he added

It wasn’t much, and didn’t seem like something I should be concerned about. However, it was at this time I felt his breath brush against my ear again.

“I feared I’d never hear your voice again.”

I could feel myself melting once more at the sound of his voice. It was just too irresistible. What’s more was that his fingers kept brushing up against my cheeks gently, caressing them from time to time.

It’s just as they said. Take away one sense, and the other senses heighten for compensation. As he took away my sight, I couldn’t see him, but the combination of his honey-like voice, and smooth caress, it felt a lot more intimate.

Like I was being doused with cold water that gently ran down my skin.

It felt like the bow was being strung tighter, but no, wait, let’s go back just a bit. What did he just say? Ah, yes...

The former Iana had said she’d never speak to him again. And though it could be interpreted in a number of ways, there was one being most probable. Iana and her brother had a falling out, and it did not end well between them.

But when did this happen? What was the argument about? Was it light? Was it drama heavy? That, I don’t know.

“Especially since you entered this place for my sake.”

Maybe it was Iana that was at fault, it would explain why Iana was in prison.

While I was busy thinking about that, I felt his hand grab mine, like a crocodile snapping up its prey. I felt him bring my hand up, lifting it

slowly...

What is he doing?

It might be presumptuous of me, but I could feel him smiling. He then draped my hand over my shoulder, the touch moving to the back of my hand...

“I missed you so much.”

I was startled. It was very weird, so confusing.

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Chapter 75: I missed you (2)

Chapter 75 – I missed you (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

I could tell someone was behind me. And obviously, I was correct. I could hear him, feel him, but for some reason, he didn't feel like a *person*.

My mind flashed back to the letter with a beautiful handwriting, and a friendly tone that was sent to me sometime ago.

“Iana, did you miss me, too?”

“I...” I hesitated. Should I even grace him with an answer?

I could hear him breathe out, without opening his mouth. And at that very moment, an enchanting fragrance flowed through the air. It was faint, but definitely a good scent.

And it came from this man.

The only pleasant scent I've ever smelled in this prison was from Ricdorian. And this man felt completely different from Ricdorian, who had a pure, sour fragrance, dashed with a hint of subterranean air smell.

But why would I think of Ricdorian now?

Maybe because he's the only one I've interacted with this much all this time.

After I took a deep breath to calm myself, I finally managed to make a proper response this time.

“Oppa.” when I spoke, when I called him that, the hand he splayed on my back stilled before I could feel slight vibrations.

Perturb.

He was shaking. The man’s body was trembling greatly. He seemed quite surprised I would speak with him, it seemed.

“...oppa?” He whispered in disbelief, “Iana. You...” He trailed off...

So far, his voice, which had been slow and relaxed all this time, had been suddenly cut off. He was suddenly flabbergasted.

Was it so surprising? Did Iana address him differently before? Was there a problem?

He called himself my brother in the letter, but should I have called him differently after all? Would calling him by his name be enough instead? But I didn’t mean to call him that, I just didn’t know how else to address him.

True, I’ve been called many things before. But surely it would be believable that she had changed. I’d been in prison after all.

Worse comes to worst, I could always feign memory loss, not too big, just something small. It would prove to be the least problematic solution too.

“You’ve forgiven me?” his voice finally asked, the slight tremor evident with his breaths. Listening to him would prove dangerous in the long run, but right now, I was simply fascinated by it.

Forgive me. I didn’t know what I did wrong. It was a matter of course.

Soon, I held his hand slightly.

“Time...” That’s it. As soon as I started talking, I raised my head.

Rumbling.

Not far away, I heard a rumbling sound from the grass. It was the sound of people approaching. And not long after I heard someone talking.

No, not talking, it was someone shouting. Loud enough I could even hear it.

“Is he there?”

“I don’t think he’s here either!”

“Search thoroughly!”

“Yes!”

The busy footsteps erupted all over, there were shouts heard from all sides, gradually getting closer to where we were. I could tell it was only a matter of time before they would finally reach where we were.

For some reason, it seemed like the hand of my *‘brother’* who grabbed me, had suddenly gained a lot of strength. Even at that time the sound was becoming clearer every second.

The man behind me took a deep breath, as if he had made a decision. He was sighing, taking deep breaths in, and then out, then in, then out, in, out...

I could tell he repeated it until he was calm enough.

“Iana, I’m glad because you look fine.” he finally spoke. I mentally shrugged in agreement. I certainly feel safe.

“If he touched you...I wasn’t going to let it go this time.” he growled lowly, and before I could even answer, his other hand moved so abruptly...

They now rested against my throat, tightening up. I could hear the shouts grow frantic.

“Did you find him? Look everywhere and at every corner!”

“I don’t see him yet!”

He gave one final squeeze, and finally let go. Then I noticed there was something soft in his hands. I still couldn't see anything, but it felt something like a cloth.

"Iana, I'm going to pull your release date." His voice sped up, contrary to his tone earlier.

"How long do I have?" I asked.

"You'll find out soon enough." he told me, I could feel the promise behind his words.

I haven't even had a proper conversation with him yet, but what I can tell so far was that his voice was really great. My hesitation to ask didn't even last long because I had been distracted by my enjoyment of listening to him.

"Why are you suddenly pulling the release date?"

If he was going to pull the release date, he would have mentioned it once in his letter, but I couldn't recall him mentioning that.

"Because I miss you." he said in a very low voice. "And I think I can arrange a place where you are no longer in danger." He explained further.

Of course I couldn't understand at once. The lost memory could only make me assume the context of what he was trying to tell me.

At one point, his voice became even lower.

"My little sister, forgive me, for doing it. I'll make sure you won't regret it." His hand fell slowly, detaching itself from me. "Just wait a little bit, Iana." he pleaded, before he removed what was covering my sight.

As I opened my eyes, everything seemed to blur around me for a while. Probably because it was blocked for some time now.

While I was too preoccupied with blinking, a soft touch grazed my cheeks.

Stroke.

Surprised, I opened my eyes wide. And a voice whispered for a moment.

“I’ll pick you up.”

The sound from behind gradually faded away. Instead, the sound of the footfalls approaching steadily gradually grew louder.

When I turned around, I could see the back of the head of a man moving away from me. The only thing that could be recognized about him was that he was wearing a brown robe, a tall man, and his silhouette was as sturdy as a beast.

“...and it’s been a long time.” were his parting words.

He had an outstanding back, if I do say so myself. Suddenly the bushes in front of me rustled, as a man burst through.

It was a guard. A senior guard.

“Here! Oh, hello.” he greeted me as I continued to blink.

“Yes, hello?”

I saw this face once. He was with me on a walk with Ricdorian. The man was silent because of the awkwardness between us, and it showed plainly on his face.

“Where were you going?”

“Dining room.” I blurted out suddenly.

Actually, this was the way to the underground cell, but it still wasn’t fixed.

Looking back, the guard was looking at me with this strange expression because he saw me between the bushes but within a few seconds, he seemed to have interpreted it as something with a plausible explanation rather swiftly. Maybe he thought of Lenag’s order which was to allow me everything that I wanted to do.

Sigh.

He gave me a light salute, and then glanced around. He seemed to be looking for something.

“Then, Iana... have you seen any other person around here?” he asked me warily.

“Someone else?” I asked as I tilted my head, feigning ignorance. “You mean a prisoner?” I continued to ask.

Chapter 76: A new hint about the family has been added (1)

Chapter 76 – A new hint about the family has been added (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“No, not a prisoner...” the guard answered, and I blinked in surprise.

“Oh my, not a prisoner?” I said so, pretending to look around in curiosity and glanced to my back.

I couldn’t see anyone behind me, which meant he must’ve gotten away. I frowned. They must’ve been looking for someone else. So I turned back to the guard.

“If it’s not a prisoner, then who are you talking about?” I asked him some more and looked around again. “Hmm, I’m sure there’s no one except for me at this hour. I haven’t seen anyone around here.”

Technically it was true, I hadn’t seen anyone except for my brother who was with me earlier. Soon, I continued to pretend that no one was with me, even though I knew my brother was here just a moment ago.

“But what’s the matter?” I was curious why they were so adamant to find... whoever this was. The more I looked at the guard, the more troubled he seemed.

“The... the truth is...” he began, before he abruptly shut his mouth. At that moment, he hesitated but then continued. “A special guest had just arrived in Kambrakam today.”

“A guest?” I blinked.

“Yes. But, he... Well.” The man lowered his gaze and scratched his cheek. I figured it was because he was ashamed of something. “He seemed to have lost his way and this place is not safe at all, and therefore all guards came looking for him.” he finally explained and I nodded.

I tried not to let my true thoughts show. What did he mean by *lost*?

On second thought, I think they are looking for my brother.

Was this related to my brother’s sudden disappearance?

But it’s odd, I couldn’t see him as the type of person who would get *lost*. I may not have seen him, of course, but it’s just a feeling I got when we have met. Still, it didn’t change the fact that I couldn’t afford to be obviously lying, so I looked back up, despite remembering the echoes of my brother’s sweet voice...

“Alright, so you haven’t seen anyone, yes?” the guard asked and I nodded in confirmation, “But did you sense something? Anything?”

“Sense?” I asked with a frown, before humming in thought...

“Anything would be fine.” he added.

I crossed my arms over my chest, tapping my chin lightly with my forefinger, as I continued to feign recalling what had happened.

“I might have heard something strange.” I finally said, and the guard looked at least intrigued.

“You mean something weird?” he asked, “When? Where?”

My brother certainly didn’t seem lost. He even went off as soon as people were beginning to close in on us, people who had been looking for him. I grinned minisculely and pointed towards a random place...

“I think it was somewhere over there-”

“Thank you, Ms. Iana!” he thanked me before rushing off as fast as he could. He rushed off so quickly I hadn’t had the time to finish explaining. He just moved as soon as I gave a direction.

But, nonetheless, I wasn’t offended, merely amused.

“*Sigh*, you really shouldn’t thank me.” I sighed before looking back at the actual direction my brother had taken off.

Oops, I just gave him the opposite. I smirked, before I let out a soft chuckle at the thought of sending them off to a wild goose chase. This situation felt so much like that of a traditional fable, an honest woodcutter.

In the story, the woodcutter lost his axe, and afterwards prayed for a god to help him find it. God heard his prayer and helped him find the iron axe. Impressed with his honesty, the god rewarded him two more axes after finding the right one. I felt like I’m the god in the story seeing as I helped my brother escape. And I felt that I’ve repaid all the favors I had asked from him.

“This must have repaid my requests for cigarettes and the bouquet, right?” I mused to myself. I raised the tip of my index finger and blew on it for dramatic effect, before schooling my features once more.

I trailed my gaze lower and suddenly frowned.

Something was on my hand, something I had not noticed before.

“What is this?” I muttered to myself as I clenched the small handkerchief in my hand. I turned it around a few times, before deducing this had come from my brother. Frowning, I looked at it carefully once more, but I found nothing unusual.

It was nothing but an ordinary piece of cloth.

“Why would he give me this?” I asked myself the more I looked at it carefully. Still nothing was out of the ordinary. Nothing special at all... except... maybe...

I squinted a little as I looked at the crest. It took me a great deal of time staring, but eventually it dawned on me what it really meant. I couldn't help but stare at it longer with my mouth agape.

After looking at the handkerchief for a long time, I suddenly felt something else.

Ah! It was from my sleeve!

I looked at my sleeve, and indeed there was a torn piece at the side. I hissed as I touched my left arm. Through the tear, I could see a long cut. I was wounded. When did I get hurt?

The wound was still fresh, and blood stained a few of the torn edges. It hadn't even clotted yet.

I hadn't even felt it when it happened. It must have been a papercut wound. On the other hand, I am feeling a little sick the more I stared at the wound. My gaze flitted back and forth from my wound to the cloth in my hand.

In the end, I let out a sigh and covered the wound with the cloth.

Since he gave it to me, it must mean he intended for me to use it somehow. I looked up at the sky before scratching my cheek absentmindedly.

I still didn't know why he came here. Why? What was his purpose?

Furthermore, why would he run away at the sight of the guards if they were only looking for him? It was all coming in too fast, threatening to drown me in waves of questions. Everything I've been trying to run away from was finally beginning to catch up to me...

Soon, I know I won't be able to escape the question of who I really am.

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"Hello, Mister." I greeted them when I arrived at the living room.

Evenings were rather peaceful around here, especially after dinner. However, it seemed there was a little excitement in the air tonight. It must be involving the upcoming event that will be happening the day after tomorrow.

Even Baron and Sally, who get along just fine, were now seated right next to each other.

“Why, Iana, rather late this evening aren’t you?” Sally remarked, and I shrugged.

“Indeed, I’ve been running a little late.” I admitted to her, and I plopped myself right next to her, starting a conversation. “Why are you two here?” I asked, rather curious.

Despite Sally and Baron being close, Sally usually took two other female prisoners with her around. To not see anyone else but the two of them was rather strange.

The answer came, but not from either of them.

“They both went to the living room first because they were tired today. Well, that’s what they say, but I’m guessing they’re planning to go to bed early.” One of the prisoners answered me.

Sally then gave a mischievous smirk, before lightly tapping herself on her cheeks as she tilted her head in a haughty manner.

TLN: Hey guys, I would like to address a question made by one of the readers.

So in the story, Iana used the term 오빠 [oppa]. I decided to translate it to ‘brother’ after discussing it with Dict Groiler, but if you guys think it would be better to use the transliteration of the korean word, then I would change it.

P.S. The story’s progress is getting slower than I imagined.....and it’s so frustrating. >.<

Chapter 77: A new hint about the family has been added (2)

Chapter 77 – A new hint about the family has been added (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“Well of course, I couldn’t take care of my skin the way I used to outside prison, so I need to get as much beauty sleep as I can! I’m sure even the young prisoners would agree.”

I snorted.

“And why would I need that?”

“Why?” Sally looked at me aghast, but I knew she was doing it on purpose, “Skin care exists even in prison, you know. After all, the skin is essential for both us women, and men.” she winked at me, and I couldn’t help but laugh alongside her, before the laughter died down.

“But to assume what it is to be of youth, isn’t that like trying to win the favor of the women who went to sleep earlier as well?”

“Not really, you could say it’s more of a hunch.”

I left them to their conversation as I pulled out the stained handkerchief out of my pocket. They continued to converse for a while longer until they took more of my silence, and stopped to see what it was that had been troubling me.

“What is it?” Baron asked me a little irritated by my lack of attention.

“Oh you mean this?” I asked cheekily, “I think it’s what they call a handkerchief.” I teased and Sally giggled with me. Baron shot us an unamused glare, before he looked closer at the handkerchief I was holding...

“That handkerchief...” he muttered as he leaned in, “Was there a pattern? I think there was...Aha!”

He exclaimed, making me jump at his sudden excitement which made me even more clueless to what he was seeing?

“I can’t believe this! Iana, is this the answer to the final question?” He asked me, but I didn’t have an answer for him. I wasn’t even following their conversation earlier.

What I didn’t realize, of course, was they were asking about my family. I still did not have an answer though, but I might know soon enough.

If this did belong to my brother, then it would make sense that the crest did belong to the family I belong in, too. And who better to get my answers from than the people with me?

After all, it wouldn’t make much sense to assume he had been carrying something with the crest of a different family.

“Isn’t that Einte’s crest?”

“Oh, that’s right. I’ve seen it before!” Sally gasped as she clasped her hands.

“Well, Iana, are we right? Was it Einte’s? I’ve heard a lot about that place. I didn’t know you were an Einte, really!” She slapped me on the arm, looking at me with great anticipation.

Why didn’t they tell me earlier?

Einte.

Come to think of it, Sally and Baron were the ones who helped me think of candidates and helped me speculate about my family.

What did they say about Einte again?

The masters of the east side gate.

It's a family that has become synonymous to many a great and revered Count, based mainly on its owned lands. I remembered it very clearly because it was a conversation to sort out candidates for my family.

"Isn't that where the Golden Gate is?"

"Right. What a surprise." Baron could not hide his surprised look as he touched his chin, seemingly in thought. "I didn't think it was an ordinary family. I think that if you have the capability to see the prison head then you belong from a tougher family."

A praise, though it was, Baron had an unpleasant expression on his face. Like something's on his mind. Even Sally noticed as she tilted her head to make sure she was not imagining things by herself.

"What's wrong with your face, Baron? Why is your expression like that?"

"No. No. It's nothing special." He scratched his chin slightly. "It feels like Iana's burden to bear. Though for sure I expected it like there would be a great identity reveal." He assured us, "Truly, nothing else is wrong just what my gut feeling was telling me."

"No, Einte is a great family, you know?"

"No, I know but." Oh, Baron looked like an old man who couldn't seem to make sense of what he knew before to what he knew now.

I smiled at him.

"Isn't that just Baron's scammer-sense?" I teased, trying to steer them off-topic. He then scrunched up his nose as his forehead creased.

“You can’t ignore a swindler’s instincts. Do you know how many times my gut feeling saved my life?” He told us indignantly and proceeded to briefly list all his achievements. Most of the time, he could’ve been caught and died, but he managed to cheat death and survive.

“Excuse me, Baron. An ordinary person dies only once. They stop when they’re given another chance to live.” Sally interrupted as she shook her head in a motionless manner.

“Well, it’s like crying out for something more. That’s strange. Have you lost your senses?”

“That’s what it is, like my fashion sense dying.” Sally patted me on the top of my prison uniform.

“I’m completely in prison.” He complains that if he goes out after wearing clothes like this, he would rather rip his eye out and then die.

“My fashion sense is like this. Do you think I’m alive with this fashion sense? Give it up.”

“Ugh.”

The two exchanged blow after blow of horrendous compliments with each other, completely making new conversation of their own. And while they were busy at each other’s throats, I lowered down my gaze, once more, and looked at the handkerchief.

Einte.

That’s my family name.

I tried to recollect all my memories and searched in my head, but I couldn’t remember reading about that name at all. In other words, it was not mentioned in the book.

This was the Chaser’s subordinate family.

Which meant, I don’t know anything about them.

I may not be able to remember it, but it doesn't matter as much as I can't remember it. This was also very close to the information I had always wanted to know.

"Iana Einte" I told myself, trying out the name, as I felt the odd way it rolled off my tongue.

Mmm. So this is my name.

But why? Why was it that I'm afraid of something? I felt uncomfortable knowing what it was.

There was a saying that a name is an embodiment of what one knows of it. The same could be said right now with my family name.

It was much too unfamiliar for me, perhaps that's why it's been a little off.

Soon, Sally turned to me, talking my ear off and therefore my thoughts about my family didn't last long.

"But Iana, where did you get that handkerchief?"

"What? Oh, yeah." I automatically answered. And Sally frowned when I forgot to elaborate. Luckily, I've thought about the answer on the way here.

"Oh, was it from your brother, the one who sends you letters every time?" Baron asked me, and I nodded.

"Yes." I answered him.

Sally was silent for a moment as we conversed.

"That's strange..." Sally murmured softly, but her voice was so deep that I could feel it.

Chapter 78: Can you call me by name? (1)

Chapter 78 – Can you call me by name? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“What is it?” I asked.

“What do you mean by strange?” I asked again.

“Oh, no. Uhm... about the Einte family...” Sally’s voice trailed off as she glanced at me apprehensively. My frown deepened as I looked at her suspiciously.

I moved my head to look closely and ascertain if everything was alright. I wanted to know more about what was bothering her, she had been acting strange and secretive for quite a while.

“I remembered one of my mother’s acquaintances who had a little bit of connection with the Einte’s, and I’m sure that... she said there was only one daughter in the family.” Sally replied and I let out a sigh.

“Iana has a brother, but maybe I was mistaken since I was still little back then, my memory may not be accurate. However, the last time we talked about them, Countess Einte was a person from the South region.” Sally answered as I stared at her inquisitively.

“Is that so?” I replied while pursing my lips. She suddenly looked like she was thinking deeply.

“Well, I guess I was wrong.” Sally laughed awkwardly and waved her hands in the air as if she was shrugging off what she just shared as something nonsensical. She looked apologetic that she had changed the mood around her for something that seemed quite silly now.

“Ah, I don’t think that is what it is.” Baron said.

I didn’t deny or affirm the statements they shared. However, the whole conversation made me feel bad. I guess I just felt a little uncomfortable inside.

Was this really my family? Was this really the family where I belong to?

Furthermore, we had nothing more to talk about.

Even if we wanted to prolong the conversation, that wasn’t possible because dinner break time was over.

“Oh, I think I should go and visit Ricdor...” I announced and let out a sigh while looking down.

Truthfully, I was worried as I made my way to see Ricodorian, when I was stopped in my tracks. There was a blockage in the short distance and when I tried to go further, I was instead asked to wait until the stairs were fully mend. It seemed like it would take awhile for me to get to Ricdorian.

“I was so distracted with my brother and family.” I thought as I waited at the sidelines. I asked again the guard stationed if he would let me pass but he shook his head and told me it would still take time to repair the stairs.

“Repair the stairs?” I asked.

“Yes, one of the guards must have made a mistake and dropped a torch, while making rounds which almost caught the entire floor on fire.” The guard explained and I nodded my head in understanding. The place was prone to accidental fires after all.

The torches here used to be made of iron. And as I looked down, I spotted that one of the corners of the stairs had a smashed part, as if something

heavy was purposely dropped over it.

“Then what about the prisoner in the underground cell?” I asked again.

“Oh, he’s all right. It happened only in the staircase passage the prisoner is safe.” The guard reassured me.

However, I was still worried.

The problem was that I could see smoke and soot coming out of the passageway. I can’t get past it and take a better look because of the guard standing in front of me, but my gut tells me it may have been a big mess.

“Did this happen today?” I questioned him.

“Eh? Yes, it did.” The guard answered.

If only I could turn back the time. If I had not been distracted and met Ricdorian as scheduled, I would have had enough time to see him before this whole incident happened.

I bit my lips in frustration, I came down here for nothing.

From the news of Archduke Harnim’s visit to Jair’s contact and to my brother’s unexpected appearance, everything happened at a timing that I always end up missing. Was the god of time upset with me?

“It’ll be over soon.” The guard may have noticed my panicked look, and said that to calm my nerves.

When I thought of Ricdorian, I remembered that day when I saw him fall on the floor with a terrible wound and therefore I decided to close my eyes for a moment.

‘No, stop! I don’t want to remember.’ I told myself as I willed for those images to clear out of my head.

My fists were clenched. I need to figure something out, I was growing anxious by the minute.

Lenag said that it would take four days for Archduke Harnim to get here. That means that not counting today, he will arrive in three days.

Would there be a way to make contact with Jair within that time?

Okay, I'll find a way to make contact with him somehow.

Soon, I realized I could try something because I still had the bracelet Jair gave me. But I didn't even try that option. It was because I was called out from my room not long after I returned that I had not the time to test it out.

"Hello, Miss Iana." I was pulled out of my thoughts by the sudden intrusion of a familiar voice. I turned around to face the one who called me.

It was none other than Lenag. I wasn't even surprised, who else would call me here?

Looking at the clock, it was now closer to dawn than evening.

"I thought you'd be surprised by the sudden call." Lenag told me.

"No. I'm not." I answered.

It was strange being called at this time of the night, but I tried to suppress expressing it.

I've had some guesses. I wonder if it's about my brother.

He kissed me gently on the back of my hand and I could not help but gaze at his falling hair. My already anxious mind was more rattled and my nervous heart was pounding harder by the gesture.

He held out his arm towards me, as if noticing my unstable state. I placed my hand on top, the area where my heart was, and pressed my fingers down on it with more pressure before following Lenag. When we seemed to arrive at the place he intended I sat down where he led me.

"You saw your brother." He told me.

“Ah...”

I didn't know this would come up right away. I let out a sigh instead of an answer. My brother didn't come to see me, but he saw me. That's what really happened.

“How did you know?” I asked.

“Yes, he told me and left.” He answered briefly.

‘Oh, he told you? That's expected I guess.’ I thought.

“Well, then.” I nodded at him. This time I was sitting with a little composure, and feeling more comfortable.

“I've waited for him for several minutes, but he came straight to you.”

Lenag's voice was flowing smoothly like that of a river running serenely, but for some reason, I felt pale.

For a moment, I saw his eyes sharpened like a forged sword.

Even if his eyes were not blades, the sharp-looking person before me hardened his expression wherein I felt scared. I was facing such a gruesome man, that I almost choked on my own saliva as I swallowed.

The sight of him right now was so cruel and bloody that I wanted to run.

Chapter 79: Can you call me by name? (2)

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Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“I’m sorry. ...You must have been surprised.” Lenag suddenly said. He must have seen the terrified look on my face.

“No, no.” I waved my hand in front of him hurriedly to wipe away those thoughts. “It’s not something you have to apologize for.” I replied.

“...your brother turned the cell upside down once. I’m sure you’ve seen it.” Lenag told me and I nodded.

“Ahahaha. Yeah.” Of course, I felt like my brother wandered inside the prison ignoring the rules and procedures, just like what he did but...

“It certainly seemed like that. I was afraid he would hurt you.” Lenag hesitated before carefully adding, “...I told him to stop one more time.”

“No...” before I could finish my reply, Lenag bowed slightly to my dissuasion.

“It’s my job to make you feel comfortable...but I was doing a poor job.” He told me with a somber look on his face.

I sighed. I’m afraid I don’t know what to do when I see this big man sulking before me. That gold-colored eye showed a feeling of regret, which made me even more at a loss on what to say to comfort him.

No, you always look so sharp. Why are you being timid at this moment?

I thought as I continued to blankly stare at him.

Even though he was a villain, I didn't want to see him bowing down for a long time. He had been so nice to me ever since we met after all.

"No, I wanted to see him too... Well, don't blame yourself." After I said those, Lenag quickly lifted his head.

"You wanted to see him. Did you two reconcile?" Lenag queried.

I hesitated and shook my head slightly.

Uh, I heard him correctly, right? I thought.

Lenag was talking about forgiveness, and oppa also said the same thing to me before. It seems that the siblings had a big fight.

In addition, the sharp-faced man forgot his usual expression and even seemed surprised as if this was not a great achievement for him.

"...are you all right?" Lenag's voice was more cautious than ever.

"You said you would never forgive." The moment I heard those words come out of his mouth I was taken aback, and for a moment I hesitated.

Huh? Why did I hesitate? But rather than thinking that I hesitated, I felt like my body wasn't my own, it felt like it had stopped. It wasn't my own will, but it was my body that stopped functioning, akin to the response to one's own involuntary movements.

"So all this time, your brother's been sending you letters. I thought you wouldn't even send him any replies. You did say that you didn't want to see him again." Lenag said.

Flabbergasted, I decided to carefully pick the right words to respond. For a moment, I was silent before giving him an answer.

“Yes, I did. But I’m fine with it now.”

“I’m okay now.” I repeated these words to myself.

I’m not the former ‘**Iana**’.

So what I’m going to build up in the future was bound to be different. And I think I’ve already done it, I felt that I had changed it.

But I was still wondering why Lenag was so surprised by my answer.

As for me, it seemed like the puzzle was going to be solved, like I finally and slowly knew what her relationship with her brother was. Iana and her brother fought to the point where they decided to cut off their family ties towards each other, and she said she didn’t want to see him again.

The former Iana did that, right?

“I guess I’ve felt a lot better since I opened my eyes.” I told Lenag.

He seems to have noticed something when I was talking because he stared at me with a curious look on his face.

It was when I opened my eyes from this body that I slowly began changing.

At that time, Iana’s heart stopped once, it can be assumed that she had died.

Wise men said that after a person has passed the hurdle of death, he or she will change. I guess that must be the catalyst to her too.

Lenag seemed to have agreed with me, albeit he sported a slightly stiff face, perhaps that reason was easy enough for him to understand.

He seemed to have interpreted it in his own way, I guess.

“Miss Iana, I’ll always be at your service. Call me when you need help, whatever it is.”

It's funny, why does it seem like I'm seeing more heat in his eyes now than awhile ago?

Sir, what the hell?! Why is there so much fervor and heat emanating from you?

Whatever the algorithm was to Lenag's sudden reaction, I looked away from him and smiled awkwardly.

He bit his lips thinly and pressed his teeth on top of his lower lip.

"I hope our relationship will last for a long time." The gold eyes on me were so serious that it made me self-conscious. When I looked up at him reflexively, I avoided his eyes for some reason.

Our relationship? What did he mean?

Oh, I guess he was talking about our relationship inside this cell where he would help me at all times.

Furthermore, if he keeps on helping me, I'd be grateful to him. I'll always be indebted to him.

"Yes, thank you. I'm so grateful to the Prison Head. It's very reassuring."

"You mean that, really?" Then his face stared at me carefully. But I still could not look at him properly. I was confused.

What's wrong with you all of a sudden?

I wanted to ask him but I dare not say those words out loud.

"Eh? Of course." I said, then Lenag's eyes rolled on me.

The villain, who was one and a half bigger than me, came silently facing me with sharp eyes as if he was carefully watching me.

The gold irises of his had reminded of a snake while he stared at me, but his eyes looked more elegant than that of a snake.

“Then...” Lenag started.

“Eh?” I opened my eyes wide as I was looking at him expectantly. His eyes gradually faded into one color.

“Call me by my name. Will you do that for me?” This time, really, I saw it wrong.

“Just once.” This big villain was looking at me while rubbing his ears. Everything was so clear to me now.

“I’d like to be called by my name.” He told me.

“Ah.” I blinked.

No, what kind of situation was this?

The embarrassment spread through his cheeks, but he tilted his head down, while waiting for my response. I decided to grant his request after all, I thought, it wasn’t a difficult task for me.

“Uh, Prison Head Lenag?” I asked.

“You can leave out the title.”

“Mr. Lenag.” I repeated.

“You don’t have to use honorifics.”

What? Suddenly I felt scared. Why was he so insistent? He was a powerful man, do I dare?

I hesitated and at last corrected myself.

“Lenag?” I spoke carefully.

At that moment, there were cries!

I thought I heard a sound.

He turned his head away from me, but I saw it clearly. His cheeks were as red as a tomato.

No matter where I look at, his image right before me doesn't seem to match that of a cold-blooded villain. In the book, the final villain's subordinate was also the strongest commander-in-chief.

Still, I was confused.

“But why did you suddenly ask me to say your name? Well, uh, can I ask?”

Chapter 80: We need to save the male lead (1)

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Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

I felt like my head was spinning, round and round until everything around me was turning at a disorienting speed. It took a while, but eventually I calmed down enough to convince myself as I finally understood.

There's just those times in life, where people would prefer to be called by their names instead.

"No one's called me that since I sat in this position so..." he trailed off.

So it was like that, huh? I mused.

Not many people in government positions would request such a thing. He's the only one who finds his position difficult. He's never made a friend doing this. But I mainly think it's more because of how he looks.

So serious... fierce...

"Ah, yes, I understand." I quickly answered, "Well, if you don't mind having me..."

"I doubt I would." he quickly answered.

"Well, yeah, that's great." I stammered.

That really wasn't where I was trying to get here. I'm trying to ask whether or not I could call him that sometimes. But somehow I got a feeling I would need to call that everytime I would meet with him.

Is this what they call power? The driving force? The one that is responsible for a villain to land themselves in a place of authority?

"So, Lenag," I said once more, testing out the way the name rolled off my tongue, "Do you have anything else to say?" I inquired, but Lenag gave no answer. Instead, he brought a hand to his chest, lightly pressing on it.

I couldn't help but be curious. I've seen that gesture before.

I wanted to make an excuse for it, but the gesture was so similar to what my friend had done when she went to a fansign event, telling me she was speechless after meeting that icon.

"No, there isn't." he finally answered. I took a deep sigh.

So that meant the abrupt call for my presence had only happened because of my brother's impromptu visit. Still, it didn't change the fact I was still thankful for the way he reached out to me, asking after my thoughts, and whether or not I was surprised by it all.

Has he been paying that much attention to me?

The moment I'd get out of prison soon, I'll be sure to send him some sort of present before I go. Sure, I won't be seeing him when I get out, but that's why it's imperative I would get to see his sincerity while I still could. I am grateful for him, though.

Having thought so far ahead of myself, another idea struck me. It was one that's always been at the back of my mind, ever since I've arrived here.

"In that case, I have a question for you." I told him, and I could see Lenag swallow visibly. I couldn't help but wonder why, despite his request for me to call him by his given name, would he avoid my gaze whenever I'd do so?

He looked like he was regretting something, but it was quickly changed the moment he realized I was staring at him.

“Ask me anything.” he responded.

“Is the Archduke of Hel, the one you mentioned before, going to visit the prisoner as scheduled?” I tried to ask nonchalantly and Lenag nodded.

“Ah.” he muttered softly. It might be of the way I asked it, but Lenag didn’t seem to think much of my question.

“To be honest, the biggest concern was the conflict between your brother and the Archduke. And as you know, your brother’s gone.”

“Yes, that’s true.”

“Also I don’t believe the Archduke would be pressed to visit. I am still unsure.” he admitted, and I couldn’t help but be even more curious.

“Is that so?” I asked, it seemed the Archduke Harnim may not visit after all. That should be a good thing, but what changed his mind? And why? Furthermore, it did not abate the worried feeling I was having, and I couldn’t pinpoint why.

“Yes.” Lenag confirmed, “Also your brother’s carriage, which belonged to the imperial family. Somehow it gave off the impression that it wanted to arrive and reach the prison in a haste. So that’s why.”

What? Carriage? Wait a minute, where was this carriage now? Couldn’t he have picked a better timing to have told me this? But since this was Lenag, it’s to be expected he wouldn’t tell me.

“Your Majesty seems to have been upset because the Imperial Household’s commander, who was with you earlier, witnessed your brother’s,” he paused, trying to look for a better word, “-*disturbance* in person. I think your brother misunderstood that something was going to happen in the sacred cell.” Lenag continued to share.

“And did he?” I prodded, “Misunderstand it?”

“Yes.” he confirmed, “In fact, it seemed he just wanted to meet you quietly.”

I can’t believe he was trying to meet with me quietly. The only place that was quiet in this prison was a meeting, which turned out to be the opposite of its intended purpose.

But there was still something strange, specifically regarding the story. What the hell was he doing?

“And that’s why I’m doubtful of the Archduke’s visit taking place. He’s a loyalist after all, it’s not in his nature to visit, when he knows the emperor is keenly watching over the prison. It’s uncomfortable for him.”

“I see.”

If that was true, and the Archduke really won’t visit Ricdorian, then everything else should already be given, thanks to my brother. But suddenly it came to me just how unfamiliar I was with my brother, and his affinity.

Though it would be great if things would be solved like this, but rarely do things go the way they are planned.

“But, I am not sure, it’s more of a hunch really.” he told me, “But, for some reason, he does make it a point to visit that prisoner around this time.”

Well, that bit I knew, and sure of. After all, I’ve been to Ricdorian every time.

“The last time I heard from him, he said he must see his child. Additionally, the cell is contractually bound to open its gate whenever he wants to visit.” he further explained.

I took his words to heart, though it’s best not to bank so much on the idea he won’t be coming, especially when unsure about it. I’m sure there’s some other way.

“Well, I think that’s all I’m curious about today.” I finally answered, beaming a smile at him. “Thank you, Lenag.”

He turned his head, as if waiting for me to say his name again. I'd have thought this was the end of our conversation, but eventually he spoke up once more after a moment's silence.

When he spoke, it was with a low voice, but not once looking my way. I couldn't help but feel perturbed by it.

"Also, Miss Iana, it's finally been fixed."

I blinked.

"Huh? What?" I asked, confused what he was talking about.

"Your release date." He calmly elaborated. I couldn't help but feel like a convicted felon, walking my way to trial. I was suddenly terrified. Not that it was different, but it certainly was unfamiliar.

"Ten days," he continued, clueless to my trepidation, "You'll be released in ten days."

Chapter 81: We need to save the male lead (2)

Chapter 81 – We need to save the male lead (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

I soon left Lenag's oval office in haste. My heart was still palpitating, pounding against my ribcage in anxiety. I decided to stop worrying about that for a moment, and focus on the more urgent matters I still had.

'Slap!'

The sound echoed through the empty halls for a moment. My cheeks stung from where I slapped it with my palm. However, it did the trick and made me calm down.

First on the list, my release date. On second thought, maybe I should save that for later. The important thing right now is the probability of Archduke Harnim visiting Ricdorian in the next two to three days.

As Lenag had, more or less, implied, the odds of Harnim visiting were fifty-fifty. Still, it did not abate my worry. After all, I was someone who had been raised with the favor of my brother. He'd been responsible for giving this so-called *opportunity* to me.

It was already in the middle of the night when I finally left Lenag's office. It was then I decided to stop by and visit Ricdorian.

But of course, the stair renovations were yet to be finished. As it was already night time, passing through the charred stairs were extremely

dangerous, so that meant I would need to wait until it was safe to pass through.

‘Why would this happen now?’

I was nervous but couldn’t help it. But that didn’t matter. Right now, I was in my room, stuck with figuring out how I was going to contact Jair again. I’ve got three days, and additionally, the day after tomorrow would be when the event would begin.

“But the question remains, how do I meet Jair?”

Staring down at the blanket with my legs crossed in the bed, I noticed, there was a bracelet that Jair gave me on top of it.

Sigh.

Is it wishful thinking if I assume this will connect me to him? I wondered, picking it up. Of course, I have no ability to even use magic. I didn’t even know if it was possible until I met Jair, let alone do magic spontaneously.

I know each of the main characters have a special ability, but in the book they described it as ***ancient magic***. Anyway, by this point, all I could do was wave the bracelet meaninglessly around me.

Bored out of my mind, I suddenly threw the bracelet and huffed a breath.

Ugh, what am I supposed to do now?

I find it extremely difficult to be this one-person association, that was living in this pretty complex world. I was not only a sole member, but also I had no one to turn to. I haven’t even cared much about someone like this before, much less do something about it.

I threw my head back and groaned into the thin air.

“Come on, do something!”

I picked up the bracelet once more.

Can I pinch it? Oh what the hell.

I pinched it and pulled it as far as I could so it wouldn't break. Furthermore, I kept bumping the jewels against each other, hoping for a reaction.

At this point in time, I decided it was time to use my fists. Not a second longer I was furiously pounding the bracelet.

Whoo-hoo!

"Mommy!!!" I exclaimed as I stopped pounding the bracelet in and jumped away in surprise.

The bracelet was shrivelling right before my eyes! I blinked and rubbed my eyes, but it was still happening! It wasn't an illusion!

It was just like the last time Jair had called. Hurriedly, I picked the bracelet back up and wore it.

"Miss?"

I could hear him, as I wore the bracelet and was very pleased to hear Jair's nice voice.

"Jair!" I exclaimed in relief, unknowingly raised my voice.

Realizing my mistake, I quickly looked at the door, before lowering my volume. *"I know my voice is so low, please understand. I'm in my room right now."*

"Yes, that's fine. Are you alone?" Jair had a slightly puzzled voice. And then I knew why. *"I didn't know it would be connected this time. It all depends on the line. When the prison head is present, the surveillance becomes more intense."*

I guess communicating through magic was hard under Lenag's presence.

"I've tried it over and over again before, but I failed."

“Good job.” I patted on the bracelet as if I were praising him. Of course he couldn’t feel it, but I was very happy to finally reach him. “I haven’t even eaten because I’ve been waiting for you.” I admitted.

“What?”

“Yes, won’t it bother you if it cuts off just like that?” I was a little irritated, especially when Jair laughed at my expense.

“Yes it would.” he answered, but I could still hear his amusement, ***“Thank you, Miss.”***

“Yes. Be thankful. I’ve been waiting all day.”

An indeterminate voice came out like the day I first met Jair in the garden. No, it was even playful. I’m going to give him a straight answer for this wasn’t what mattered right now.

“But why did you contact me? You seem to be in a hurry this time.” I may have had a rough idea of why, but I pretended not to know it. Seeing an opportunity to confirm my suspicions, I had to ask it first. We had to make the most of what we can right now because we don’t know when the communication would suddenly end like last time.

“Yes, it’s an urgent situation, so I’ll just go straight to the point.”

The sea I’ve been wishing for.

“Do you remember the prisoner whom I had asked you to cast magic before?”

I paused.

“I can’t remember.” I admitted, I heard him sigh.

“It’s about the prisoner.”

His relationship with Ricdorian seemed to be completely hidden. But will that be okay? I’m almost certain that would limit what Jair can say to me.

“In fact, the prisoner is a precious man.”

What?! I jolted in surprise. He completely caught me off guard!

Cough.

“I found out by accident that he was the son of an unexpected man.”

“*Cough! Cough.*” I tried to stop coughing so I could listen to him.

“Oh, you’re that surprised?”

“No,- *Cough-* I just heard something unexpected.” So this is how it comes out, right? “Keep on talking.”

“Anyway, he was a precious son of a significant person.”

He’s a precious man, but he’s not a precious son with the way his father treated him. Jair seemed to be making up a story in due course.

“And this significant person thinks and acts like Confucius.”

Except for his relationship with Ricdorian.

“That’s why we’re in trouble.”

“What do you mean in trouble?”

“We used magic on the precious son.”

“...who? We? I only did what you asked me to do.” I said it with this meaning, but I could hear him laughing mirthlessly, as if under the impression I did understand it perfectly what I was asked to do.

“That’s true. But should they try to go into investigation, you will also be discovered.”

So basically we’re both screwed on this one. I still don’t know why he scares me. Even if he doesn’t put much pressure on me, I can’t help but be

compelled to listen.

“So what are you trying to say?”

“A precious man will soon be in this cell. The prisoner’s father.”

That was to be expected. Jair’s purpose was the same as mine. I know now, Archduke Harnim is coming here.

“Is that so?”

“Yes, and once he arrives, he would undoubtedly notice something strange had happened to the prisoner.”

Chapter 82: We need to save the male lead (3)

Chapter 82 – We need to save the male lead (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

I'm sure that would be the case when he does arrive. His appearance changes intermittently. We dodged the bullet with the guards, mainly because they don't go visit his cell. Furthermore, they haven't noticed any of Ricdorian's changes at all.

But that didn't mean we can fool the Archduke, who, from time to time, would come visit Ricdorian.

“That would turn this prison upside down, and neither you nor I would be safe.” proceeded Mr. Jair. I was silent for a moment, before eventually speaking up.

“You're being so... indifferent to this matter.” I told him suspiciously.

“Well, to be honest, you seem a little bit cool with it yourself.” he shot back after a moment's silence. I frowned. Personally, I think I was beginning to be a little sloppy.

“No, I don't think so.”

Truthfully, I don't know if everything would turn out to be okay with the Archduke's visit, however, I'm prepared for everything. Furthermore, there was no reason for me to tell Jair that I already knew everything.

“You seem to be a very unusual girl, which was exactly my first impression of you.”

I snorted.

“I hear that a lot. Anyway, what’s our plan?”

I heard a short chuckle coming from the bracelet. But instead of it sounding as if they were joyful, they sounded more like in pain, or at least trying to chase it away with laughter.

“You’re on the verge of getting caught, my dear. And in this situation, there are only two ways to solve this problem.” I nodded as I listened to his solutions.

“First, one of us is to put the prisoner on the wall and erase all traces of magic.”

Me?! I thought in alarm. “Erase it?”

“Or...” He paused, ***“We must not, at all costs, let the Archduke visit this place from the very beginning.”***

If it were up to me, I’d definitely choose the latter. It’s a much better option in my opinion.

“Okay, I think I’m seeing everything now. So, how do we go about them?”

“Well, first things first, it’s highly unlikely we’ll be able to pull off the first option. Once the magic has been activated, it cannot be easily reversed.”

“So we go with the second option.” I tell him in a matter-of-fact voice.

“Yes, we do. We stop him from coming, blocking out the source of our problems.”

“So, how can I help with that?”

“It’s quite simple really.” he starts, ***“The one thing we’re certain of, is that the Archduke only ever visits his son when he is healthy.”***

I nodded, finally seeing what strategy we would be going with. The Archduke would want to wait until his son’s health is good enough, before trying to visit him, and potentially abuse him all over.

He probably wants a clean slate to marr and bruise over again.

But that gave me pause. I might have understood, but that didn’t mean I could put it out in words. If the Archduke visits his son only when he is back in peak health, then that would mean if Ricdorian isn’t...

Archduke Harnim won’t come. And that’s what we’re going to do. That was what Mr. Jair was implying.

Are you trying to force me to hurt him now?

“Are you suggesting I purposely make Ricdorian ill?” I asked, aghast at the prospect of what I would be expected to do.

“Yes, that’s right.”

I had no words, I was completely speechless! I took deep breaths and bit the inside of my lower lip.

Did I think it was an amazing plan? No.

But is it groundbreaking? Of that I have no doubt!

I thought rather sarcastically. Mr. Jair was Ricdorian’s right hand man, and he wanted me to ***hurt*** him?!

Deep breaths, Iana. Let’s try to calm down. I haven’t even heard everything I should do yet to make this plan happen.

“You mean, of course, is to make it ***appear*** like he is sick?” I asked for clarification, because he might only be talking about not really as in ***sick*** sick, but just ***like*** sick.

“No.” Mr. Jair corrected. ***“I meant what I said. Make him sick.”***

“The person who will be visiting him is not someone you can just fool with mere parlor tricks.”

Well that’s just great! Note the sarcasm. It was going to take a whole lot of work to do this. But is this really the only method we have? Should Mr. Jair even suggest this? Especially if he cared for Ricdorian, as much as he claimed to?

Even if our relationship isn’t really much like the one portrayed in the original story, we still have the same goal here.

However, for now, all complaints will be saved for later. I should probably hear him out until the end.

“It doesn’t have to be something that would hurt him too much. At the very least he should be seriously ill enough for the guards to confirm and report back to his father that he, indeed, was sick.”

“Are you mad!?” I hissed at him.

“It would be nice if he were to exhibit a severe body condition or vomit blood.”

What? Make Ricdorian vomit blood? I was astonished. I don’t know everything about Jair, but I don’t even feel an ounce of respect and consideration coming from him for Ricdorian’s well-being the more I listen to him.

Nadda. Zilch. Any angle I could think of, I’m not sensing any! It wasn’t even like he was bothered at all because he kept speaking!

“Oh, how about the magic that causes the body aches, like before, the one that you..”

“Mr. Jair.” I cut off his words calmly. “I was trying to ask if you wanted to hurt the prisoner on *purpose*.”

There was a pause in Jair's continuous monologue on how to hurt Ricdorian. But I could tell the connection was still there. I could still hear him breathing.

“Miss Iana, it might be impossible to comprehend, but what you don't understand is that you are being deceived-”

“Mr. Jair.” I interrupted, my voice sounding a little more authoritative. “I wonder, did you know, not too long ago, I've seen him collapse and fall on the floor.” I seethed.

I could imagine him swallowing down, finally stopping to suggest ridiculous things. So I pushed on...

I told him how I found him, bloodied, on the floor.

And who did he think broke the rules just to clean him up? Nurse him back to health? Brought him medicine? Fed him?!

Of course it's me.

“Did you even sneak into the cellar late at night so that the prisoner wouldn't get sick anymore?” I asked him furiously.

I had taken every risk and measure I could think of, hoping that Ricdorian would be less sick by the time I returned to check up on him! The bloody appearance I found him in was so painful to look at. I thought it would be not bad if I could help even a little to ease his pain.

And now...

“And now you want me to get him sick on purpose? I can't!” I all but yelled at him. “If anyone else saw that terrible condition he was in, no one else would agree with what you were planning.” I was more determined than ever.

“He's sick! But you know what? He couldn't make a sound, not even a groan, because it hurts so much!”

It was like he wasn't even aware of these things! Because if he did, he wouldn't even dare suggest such a thing! I'm sounding like a broken record here, but from what source did he even get the idea from? Was Ricdorian just a mere doll to play for him?!

Chapter 83: We need to save the male lead (4)

Chapter 83 – We need to save the male lead (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

My jaw tensed up in frustration. I was trying to stop myself from lashing out.

Did I understand the need for it? Yes, of course I did. But no matter how much he tried to convince me this was the only way, I refuse to believe that.

There were some things we did for desperation, and there's just some things that crossed the line, *even* in desperation. I breathed in deeply, before closing my eyes and pinched the bridge of my nose, calming myself down.

I don't care who I had to ask, my brother, or Lenag, anyone, for this I will.

"I got the wrong person." I muttered to myself. There must be another way to resolve this. If there's no other way, then I'll use this as my last resort.

"I thought Mr. Jair was thinking of the prisoner's well-being at the very least. Come to think of it, it didn't even matter at all."

As I continued to mutter to myself, Jair only remained silent, but I could tell this was a different type of silence from before. Rather, I could tell his breathing was getting harsh.

"Yes, I'll pretend I never heard you suggest such a horrid thing." Just as I was about to untie my bracelet, Jair had finally spoken up.

“The prisoner’s health status is no matter of concern now.” he told me tersely.

Why was I still listening to this lunatic? This was complete nonsense, I shouldn’t even waste time thinking about it! However, all the fight had left my voice, as I could no longer find it in me to speak with him.

However it wasn’t just me. I could also tell Jair was serious about this. No longer do I hear his easy-going tone, or playful attitude from before.

“This is really the only way.” My hands wound over the bracelet, before refusing to touch it longer. ***“I tried to protect his highness...”***

The way he addressed Ricdorian changed. In addition, his spirit seemed to have changed as well. If I could hazard a guess, I could almost feel his regret.

“Ha, why am I even talking about this?”

I couldn’t help but roll my eyes, scratching my cheek absentmindedly. Despite my resolve to not listen, I remained to.

“Did his highness finally,” he paused. ***“-groan?”***

“He did, well,” I blinked, “As a matter of fact I think it’s been a long time since he did.”

There was a pregnant silence that followed my statement, when Jair spoke up again.

“I must say, you are most unusual. You don’t even seem surprised, even when I addressed him differently.”

“Well forgive me if I’m more concerned by a magician in this prison.” I all but spat back. Well, not really that surprised about that tidbit. I already knew there was one.

“Well, we’ve come this far, haven’t we?” he asked resignedly, ***“What else is there for me to hide?”***

And so Jair spoke, and he shared everything he knew about Ricdorian's identity, about the Archduke Harnim, and finally...

About himself.

"Really? I see." Despite knowing all I could hear was a voice, and so should he, I was still concerned that he would see right through me. I wasn't a very good actress.

"I'd like to ask about why you were so calm when I was talking."

Well, about that, it's just that I felt a little bored.

"Ay, you're mistaken. I was confused." I waved my hands, trying to shrug it off. Honestly, really, it was like reading a Korean novel! As a matter of fact, this detail was something I've been fascinated by.

"What an unusual girl."

Jair murmured quietly. Eventually he sighed, but he seemed to have understood. But our conversation is yet to be over for just a short while after, a serious and another complicated conversation took place.

"I do care for him, from the bottom of my heart." he insisted to me, "And I'm telling you, I'll continue to do so, therefore your worries are unfounded. It's far from what you think. "

"Thinking of his highness like a ragdoll to use and toss aside was never okay. And it was never alright for me either."

Oh. That word must have pissed him off, I mused. Well, he wasn't wrong.

"...but I admit I didn't want his wounds to come back. First of all, I know that his body heals whenever he is in pain. Sigh... it was wrong to believe in his abilities."

In the book, Ricdorian boasted a beastly self-sustaining power that would allow him to heal under just a few days after getting hurt. Another special

ability. However, this awakening had only been due because of his nearing encounter with the heroine.

I couldn't help but feel more frustrated. Why does no one ever take into account that Ricdorian is...

A...

Boy!

He's sixteen! Just two years younger than I am! Much younger, much more innocent than I, and whom I treated like my younger brother even. He was always too shy, and so flustered whenever I saw him. As I was battling with this turmoil inside my mind, Jair only proceeded to explain his side of things.

I narrowed my eyes when he mentioned there truly was no other way. The guards have seemed to begin paying extra attention to him, more than I had even thought about.

"We must be certain that the guards are deceived."

That much I can agree with.

"I get it. I get it." I told him, stepping back to think for a moment.

Our best option remains the same. Archduke Harnim must not come to visit. And in order to make that happen, our ruse must be believable enough to deceive even seasoned guards.

"Either way, we must ensure that whether Ricdorian is sick or pretending to be sick, the guards have to be fooled."

"That's right."

"Then let's get this done with." I glanced at my watch, and almost balked at the time. I hadn't realized that time went by swiftly because of our argument.

Besides, I don't have much time for Jair either.

"The magic, can you lessen its effects?" I asked hurriedly.

"By how much?"

"Make it so it looks like it hurts on the outside, but not within. Just to the point where he would appear to have a fever, but without the pain."

"It's possible. What are you going to do?"

"I'm going to take care of him." I told him resolutely, "You said that the guards will report if he's sick or not, right?"

Jair was silent for a moment, trying to get a measure of what I would be doing. After a moment of silence, he finally spoke up to answer me.

"It's a difficult task, but I will do my best."

"You agreed faster than I thought." I remarked, but I was grateful nonetheless. I still needed his help after all.

"It's because I now know you're more capable than I thought you'd be."

That, too, is true. I'm putting myself in the line after all, in a situation where I'm willing to go out in the morning and, possibly, get caught by Lenag.

"And since he doesn't like him, you should know, he's the one that suffers the most should we make rash decisions." he warned me. I had to bite my tongue from lashing out in frustration. For now, I must play nice, and think one step ahead.

I needed to be careful around him, especially with his observant nature.

I agreed quickly.

"Please take good care of him." he added lastly

"Thank you for trusting me." I bid back.

Chapter 84: Beautiful tears (1)

Chapter 84 – Beautiful tears (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

It wasn't long before I found myself fretting once more. I paced back and forth, wondering how Jair would even deliver the magic in time. Which reminds me, it had to arrive by dawn today, there wasn't much time left.

"How would you deliver the magic to me?" I finally asked. Jair huffed out a small chuckle.

"You aren't the only one who can bribe guards, miss."

That statement gave me pause. Bribe? Did that mean Jair had a guard on his paycheck? Even amongst the ones that were watching Ricdorian?

But one thing I know for sure, tomorrow would be the decisive battle.

"Then that means I must figure things out by tomorrow." I mumbled, and Jair agreed. Because if we don't succeed, then Archduke Harnim will come and visit, and when that happens, a terrible abuse would be bestowed upon the young boy.

What's worse is he'll figure it out, my and Jair's involvement in his affairs, and we'd be caught red-handed.

"Did you know? That this could only be done when I'm here?" I did wonder about that.

Both Lenag and my brother had informed me just shortly before that I would be getting out soon. And even if I did get out in time to escape the

Archduke's clutches, it wouldn't guarantee that would be the end of it. Plus, this plan would only work if I was inside the prison myself. Otherwise there'd be no use.

I could feel Jair had understood me, and he couldn't help but let out a soft laugh.

“Fret not miss. There should be no problem at all. We only need him to not visit for the short time being.”

“Why?”

“Probably the Archduke would never visit him again.” Jair declared, his voice filled with conviction. It was a vague answer to my question, but he seemed confident that we would succeed. I can't help but hope for it to be true.

“After all, I hadn't cast a spell on him for nothing.”

He had been referring to the magic that I casted on Ricdorian that day, but he didn't bother to explain to further prolong our conversation. And our connection had finally been cut off.

Come the next day, in the early morning, Jair had finally managed to hand me the new magic item rather successfully. It was an item that would enable me to speak to him wherever I might be, which was a great deal of an improvement compared to the bracelet he'd given me before.

At least this way, if I do have a question for Jair, I could ask him immediately without waiting for him to contact me first.

However, the current problem I have was that the guard, who I'd met with before at dawn, was him...

<You're the guard!?!> I had thought out loud, startled at who I saw.

<Not exactly.>he had shrugged, <To be exact the guard is keeping watch over my cell.>

I'm not exactly sure what to think about this development, but I can't help but feel even more worried. This man has no concept of the word danger.

I hadn't been able to talk with Jair as I did the other day because he'd been so busy. I felt terrible with just the thought of being a distraction. But there was still something I wasn't sure of, something that's been bothering me. I eventually grabbed a hold of him and pulled him aside...

I had to know!

When I spoke with Jair the other day, he told me something about the growth Ricdorian's been experiencing to be temporary...

But from what I've seen, it didn't seem to be. I would've asked more in detail had I been given enough time, but I could only ask one at the time...

<His Highness,> he began, <Has grown often?>

<Yes, he has.> I answered.

<I see,> I felt relieved that this wasn't something new, that Jair knew this could happen. <I didn't realize this was the case, especially since I haven't seen in before, but seeing as it's not permanent, then I guess it's not so bad.> Jair said.

<Yes, this is great news if I do say so myself. The stronger the force, the longer the transition will be.> He added.

He still hadn't given me a direct answer, now that I thought about it. Upon hearing my question, I narrowed my eyes slightly. Jair looked quite pleased with the news. Initially, I had thought he was just pretending to be, but it seems he actually is happy with the fact.

I knew I had to see Ricdorian immediately, but there was another dilemma I had to face. It was something that kept slipping from my mind amongst the many other things I had to worry about.

“I’m sorry, Ms. Iana. I think we’ll have to repair it by today.” one of the guards told me.

Because of the repairs, only the guards were allowed to go to the underground cells. It didn’t matter what I said to convince them to allow me to pass through, I just kept being turned away because of the danger it posed. I had no choice but to heed their warnings, so I reluctantly returned, trying my best to swallow down my ever growing nervousness...

By the next day, it was already the *special visitation* day. And it was exceptionally bright, which was no surprise as it was the most awaited celebrations for even the aristocratic prisoners. Even I had been stunned the moment I stepped into the dining area this morning.

I was struck by the feeling that I’ve stepped into another different world.

I didn’t just feel excited, but even everyone around me felt a little bit extraordinary. But what could bring this sudden atmosphere out from everyone here?

All around there were multitudes of color, be it in the shape of shawls, capes, flowers, or even stylish hats! Every man and woman were dressed for the special occasion!

<You can dress up, wear your capes and cloaks even, but what do you think?>

It’s only now that I can fully understand just how special and a rare occasion it was for these people to be allowed to dress up the way they want to. But I remember them mentioning that every one of us could have separate tea times if we so wish...

That’s a brilliant idea! It just fills me up with more excitement! Even mealtimes hadn’t disappointed me!

I could hardly hide the amazement in my eyes the moment I stepped foot inside the living room afterwards. Everyone looked so in tune with themselves, so confident, comfortable, and very elegant. Even Sally looked a little affronted when she saw me.

I was the only one who didn't bother to change for the occasion.

However despite the festivities, I couldn't help but feel a little more uneasy. While everyone was busy laughing and chatting around as if they weren't prisoners, I couldn't bring myself to fully enjoy it. I still had things to do, and things to worry about before I could fully rejoice.

Especially since I'm so worried about what was happening with him, or what might happen if I don't succeed.

But I was never a good actress, and my worry was plain for all to see. All I could tell them was that my family wasn't able to make it this time to visit me, which was fortunately believable for them, and they'd left me alone.

Just one good moment. That's all I need, then I could go and see Ricdorian.

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Chapter 85: Beautiful tears (2)

Chapter 85 – Beautiful tears (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

It was after a while, when a moment finally presented itself to me. I quietly got up, and left the place, leaving behind the gathered noblemen prisoners in favor of the underground cells.

Once I arrived, I greeted the senior guard keeping watch, before going into the cells to see Ricdorian.

“It’s been a while, since we last saw each other.” I muttered to myself. It’s only been for a few days, weeks tops, not even years, but it felt a lot like it was more.

Every night and morning I thought about our next meeting. The more I thought about him, the more I could feel the distance between us, and the longer it seemed since we last saw each other.

There’s a pang in my chest whenever I think of him. I promised him before I’d seen him after the meal, but I broke that promise. I kept it before, but I couldn’t do it now. I don’t even want to use the repairs as my excuse this time...

I felt so much shame.

But the time for games was finally over, I must get to Ricdorian and help him out, though that did nothing to quell my guilt. I must apologize to him first the moment I see him again.

I looked up, filled with determination to make amends and succeed in my task.

But when I did, I stopped in my tracks and blinked in surprise.

In front of me was a boy, and he was unconscious.

“Ricdorian?” I whispered, hurrying to his side and dropped beside him.

Are you sleeping?

My first worry was that he’d fainted so suddenly once more. Immediately, I placed a finger beneath his nose to assess his breathing. I gasped in surprise.

His breathing was normal.

Then that would mean he’s just sleeping. Now that I think about it, it’s the first time I saw him sleep. Every time I’d gone to visit him before, he’d always be awake.

Even the first time we met, I had thought him asleep, but as soon as I got close, his eyes snapped open. Ricdorian had always been high strung, even to the point of paranoia. I was even surprised I could get this close to him to check if he was okay.

He’d possessed an incredibly good sense for danger, almost animalistic. Some of it I might be able to attribute to the abuse he’d gone through, but he wasn’t waking up. Not even when I was this close to him.

My fingers twitched when I looked at his hair.

I want to touch it.

And then I did.

I stifled in a gasp at the soft feel of his strands, soon enough I found myself rhythmically stroking his hair, caressing him to sleep gently as I watched over him.

I marvelled at its softness. He'd been in a cellar for some time now. How is it that it stayed this soft? It looked even smoother than last time I'd seen him.

He moved slightly, which gave me pause.

I looked back into his face, but he was sound asleep. I don't want to risk waking him up.

"That's interesting." I muttered.

Suddenly, his face scrunched up, pupils moving beneath his eyelids, before fluttering open. He was blinking away the sleep and haze, focusing his sight. A slight crease formed between his brows the more he awoke...

"Huh?" My hands stilled as I watched him open his eyes.

He rubbed his eyes blearily, and I noticed his nose was tinged in red. Most probably because he'd been sleeping with an arm over his face...

"...are you here?" he mumbled. He's so cute like this, and definitely bad for my heart. Soon, I resumed stroking his hair.

"Yes, I'm here."

"...this is my dream, too." he muttered softly.

"Huh?"

What was he talking about? My eyes were blinking as I was so curious.

"Hey, what do you mean by that, hmm? What are you talking about?"

Was he still half asleep after all?

I kept my eyes on him, and indeed, he still looked like he was sleeping. I narrowed my gaze, before my eyes widened in realization.

He looked like he needed a good night's sleep. He was looking like someone who hasn't slept well in days. Suddenly his hand snatched my wrist in a grip, his arms shaking like a leaf...

"You only ever appear in my dreams." he continued to mutter, "I won't let you go, not here."

"What?" I watched him closely.

His eyes were slightly red from when he'd rub it earlier. He was blinking his silver eyelashes rapidly, wiping something away...

And then I saw it, when the light hit the teardrop.

He was tearing up, I watched as some trailed down his cheeks, down to his pale white neck...

No, stop it Iana!

I berated myself for a moment in embarrassment!

Good thoughts only! Pure. Good. THOUGHTS!

I quickly shook the ever growing impurities out of my head. I would not cross that line.

Belatedly, I remembered that the basement cells didn't have any windows. And it was so dark inside. I wouldn't have been able to see anything at all if it wasn't for the torch that was lit up. He might have been able to distinguish night and day for a moment, but the days pass by in a blur after a while inside these cells.

His sense of time might be messed up, for all I knew, more time might have seemed to have gone by for him. He then began pulling at the hem of my sleeves...

"Don't go... please..."

I just stared at him in confusion, and the more I stayed, the more I felt sorry for what he had to go through.

<I always keep my promises.> I told him just as I was about to leave, <So when I promise that I'll come back, I will come back.>

I did come back, but not at the promised time I told him I would. Furthermore, with the added repairs on the stairs, I had been delayed. And though I asked the guards to relay my message to him, it seemed now that it never reached him.

So had he been waiting all this time for me? How long? All night, half a day?

How long have you been waiting in such a dark place?

It's been a short while for me, but I've forgotten things momentarily. However to him, it seemed my promise was everything. I bit my lower lip in frustration and shame, trying to stop them from quivering for him.

It was at that moment, Ricdorian looked up, and locked eyes with me.

Then I saw it. That beautiful tear sliding down his cheeks and dropping to the floor...

Ttuk.

"Ricdorian?" I meekly called out...

"I..." he tried to say, but something else was threatening to spill from him aside from words...

"No, no, wait." I tried to hush him, so I reached out my hand, but it's already late.

Another tear fell down. He hurriedly raised his hand to wipe the growing water spills away. But that only seemed to prompt them more into spilling out of his eyes...

His body shook as he was racked with sobs, crying desperately to himself, heaving for a breath. I could do nothing else but watch him cry. It was mesmerizing, I didn't know I'd find his tears so beautiful. He looked so beautiful when crying...

"Are you going to throw me away? Are you sick of me?" he sobbed, which brought me out of my trance.

"Huh?"

"Answer me, are you...?"

"Ahhh."

I mumbled, finally realizing what he was asking of me.

"No." I told him without an ounce of hesitation.

Chapter 86: Not what siblings do (1)

Chapter 86 – Not what siblings do (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“Throw?” I asked, taking pity on him. “Of course I won’t throw you away. I’d never do such a thing.”

His tearful eyes turned towards me once more, more of his tears spilling down his cheeks...

“Is, is it my fault? If you let me know what’s been bothering you, I can fix it! Why are you like this?” he begged me...

I suddenly felt like I had committed a heinous crime towards him. I watched him as he lowered his face and nuzzled his cheeks against my palm that was cradling his face...

Was he aware of what he’s doing?

For now, the only problem I could see was his height. For someone who’s two years younger than I am, he’s rather tall. Not like an adult, but certainly tall enough for me. Even when I’m standing, he doesn’t have to crane his head up to look at me when sitting down himself.

“Oh.”

I noticed his face growing closer to mine. Instinctively, I had to step back to prevent the distance between us from lessening further. But he only grabbed me by the hem of my sleeves once more, keeping me in place...

As if afraid of me disappearing.

“Where are you going?” he asked in panic.

“I’m not,” I answered quickly, “It’s, you’re too close.”

Despite my insistence to keep some distance, Ricdorian drew his face even closer as he slowly closed the gap...

“Can’t we be close?” he whispered and I could feel a slight panic forming inside me...

No! We mustn’t!

It’s too dangerous and yet...

And yet...

When he’d stare at me with those tearful eyes, I could feel my heart clenching painfully once more, taking my breath away. I swallowed down my outgoing protests as my eyes trailed down to his shirt, which had fallen off place to expose pale, yet strong looking shoulder blades of his...

I mustn’t. I reminded myself.

This was someone I saw as a little brother. Someone who strived so hard to remain strong, yet deep inside was quite soft and tender in personality...

My eyes caught his reddened lips...

Why was it so red?

The moment I regained my senses, I immediately pulled away, but his grip was stopping me.

“Okay, sleep time’s over, wake up!” I pleaded, but he refused to budge.

“I don’t want to.” he admitted, the grip on my shoulder tightening up,
“Once I do, you’ll be gone, and I’ll be alone.”

Was he dreaming? Did he still think this is a dream?

Alas, I couldn't stand it any longer and squished his cheeks between my palms. He paused as I continued to push and pull at them...

"Get up quickly. Come on, wake up for real now! How much longer are you going to sleep for?" I asked, intentionally making my voice louder. When he didn't move, I hesitated for a moment and stopped talking.

I took a good look at his surroundings and felt a little guilty. He didn't even have a blanket to sleep with. That fact broke my heart a little.

And then Ricdorian blinked, finally gaining semblance of alertness as he gazed at me.

"Not... a dream?"

"Of course not, silly," I gently chided, "Now come on now, stop being half-asleep." I said, squishing his cheeks more to aid him in escaping sleep. I gave him a bright grin. "Did you miss me that much you started dreaming about me?" I teased, booping him on the nose with my index finger.

His eyes widened fractionally as he finally caught up to what he was doing before, and shook his head as he sat up properly.

"Oh, that... the, uh," he stammered.

I could feel his cheeks warming up against my palm that was still holding him up. If the lighting of the place was great, I could have seen his pale cheeks flush red from the neck up. Like this, he resembled greatly a tomato as he struggled to let some words out, smacking his lips, and licking them to wet his mouth...

"That, the...cheek." he stuttered...

"Cheek?" I asked, tilting my head in confusion.

"...let go of it." he softly told me. Well, that certainly didn't make me let go of him. Come now, was he embarrassed?

“Nope.” I told him with a smile, popping the ‘p’ sound for emphasis. His eyes looked up at me with a slight quiver. “You’re still clinging to me, remember?” I pointed out, casually nudging my head to the sleeve that was still caught in his grip. “My sleeves?” I pressed on.

Ricdorian’s gaze trailed down my sleeves to his hand that was clutching it like a lifeline. He was shaking like a leaf, yet he still refused to let go. Rather, he slowly raised his eyes back to lock with mine, but I could see a new hint of cautiousness behind them.

“... can’t I hold on to it?” he finally said and I was startled by his speech pattern.

Normally, when Ricdorian spoke, he would do so formally, but now, he spoke to me as if I was someone familiar...

Someone he was comfortable with.

I felt myself die a little bit inside! My heart was threatening to jump out my throat! He’s going to send me to an early grave, this one...However, his next words were like an arrow to the heart.

“You—you didn’t keep your word, you know.....Ω” he pointed out to me, sounding a little betrayed, but the way he said it was a little awkward to hear, I couldn’t help but burst out in an uncalled for laughter.

He was trying so hard to talk so informally it seemed.

“Why, if you’re going to do it, do it till the end, without honorifics.” I told him in a matter-of-fact tone.

“But-” he began to protest, but I stared at him sternly, stopping him in his tracks.

“But?” I prodded. Eventually he broke away from my gaze and bowed his head in embarrassment. He glanced up to look at me, but refused to raise his head...

“I was... afraid,” he began, “-that you wouldn’t like me if I continued to speak that way.” he mumbled out, rubbing his arm. I decided to take pity.

“Well, I don’t hate it, you silly goof.” I told him gently, smiling to ease his nervousness.

“You don’t... hate it?” I giggled at him lightly, before shaking my head. Still, he seemed a little skeptical to believe my words this time around. “You’re not just pretending? I mean, I did everything I could already.” he told me.

I blinked at his words.

“What?”

“I already let out what I thought about you.” He murmured. The grip he’d had on my sleeves had loosened up a bit. It seemed as though he’s back to his old self already. I can see that usual playful glint in his eye the next second our eyes met. “Don’t you think so?”

“No..?”

I could barely process his words, too focused on the reddish tint still apparent on his face.

“Indeed, I missed you so much.” He answered me, with a tinge of longing in his tone, “So much so I started to dream about you.”

The words he spoke were achin to melody for me, like a song. He spoke with a childish wonder, children much younger than him usually spoke with. But when he would say it like that, it was like something would tug on my heartstrings.

“Don’t you think so too?” he asked me.

I watched the receding red tint on his skin which had from his cheeks to the tips of his ears, run up the length of his neck. No longer did he feel tense, or strange...

And all I could think of was how adorable he looked right now.

I was struck with the sudden remembrance that this boy was indeed just a boy, someone younger than I am, not yet an adult. Without realizing it, my hand moved on its own, and rested on top of his disheveled silver hair.

I rubbed it in a fond manner, and marvelled at the sensation.

It was so fluffy, I wanted to coo at him!

“I do, and I’m glad.” I answered him with a genuine smile.

And then it dawned on me.

I’ve been with him so long, been so invested in his well-being, I hadn’t realized just how much I had grown attached to him. Suddenly, the bars that stood between us no longer mattered to me.

No longer did I think they would only separate us permanently.

Chapter 87: Not what siblings do (2)

Chapter 87 – Not what siblings do (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“Don’t be cheeky though,” I chided him softly, “There’s still much you need to learn about me, about people in general.”

Ricdorian puffed out his cheeks as he pouted. Eventually I had to speak up first before he could, for I feared he might stun me again by whatever he might say next.

“Shall we speak of something else, then?”

“How about,” he thought for a moment before he brightened up fractionally, “-another story, ㄹ?”

My hands still rested on his head, but he hadn’t bothered me to let go of his hair, nor did he mention it. So I kept stroking his head, petting him as I gave him some tidbits of our time away.

“Actually, I met oppa just the other day.” I confessed.

Ricdorian seemed dumbfounded by that. He tilted his head up, leaning more to my stroking hand, and looked at me inquisitively...

I remembered then that Ricdorian had no experience with brothers. He didn’t have any.

“However, it was a very strange encounter.” I confided.

“What is...? “

I slipped my hand away from him. Could I tell him?

Can one even be that sweet to a brother?

The more I thought about it, the more I was convinced the encounter was indeed strange. I tried my best to articulate the encounter clearly but, even I couldn't.

Eventually, I threw my hands up in the air and let out a resigned sigh. Ricdorian blinked and only stared at me as he didn't understand what was happening.

Still, it made me think...

Could siblings do what we'd done yesterday?

I couldn't shake the feeling that it was simply something not what siblings do.

Back when I met my brother, I hadn't had enough time to think about it. I had been so surprised by his presence, so dazed, even when I had been dealing with the guard and allowed him to escape unhindered.

“He touched my cheeks,” I began as I caressed him the way I remembered my brother did, “-like this.” I explained. I stared at him, and Ricdorian met my gaze, and alarm bells rang at the back of my mind by our close proximity...

It was too sweet, now that I think about it now.

Was this how it was in this world? In this world, are siblings allowed to do such things?

“And he kissed the back of my hand...” I trailed my hand down his cheeks, to grab Ricdorian's hand and circled my thumb on his knuckles...

Lenag kisses the back of my hand sometimes, whenever we meet. It was just something nobles do, even prisoners, so long as they're of a noble background as well. It was etiquette I know that stemmed from the Europeans in the mid-modern period...

Well, I guess so. It would be like that.

The reason why I worry so much is that I don't know this world well enough as I should. I was an only child in my world, and thus had no experience to compare it with.

Back then, people around me would share stories of their siblings to me, telling me the only thing they shared with each other was blood, and nothing more. They didn't seem to even care much about each other even.

“Ugh, whenever we touch, I just feel that sudden urge to wash my hands!”

I shook the thought out of my head.

There wasn't much answer to be had when one worries as much as I do about this one small thing.

“Yes, there's not much point worrying about it.” I told myself out loud as Ricdorian proceeded to look at me with great curiosity. And so I smiled at him brightly as I looked at his deep blue eyes.

And then I blinked. I spoke too much already.

“Oh that's right, have you had any brothers?” I was reminded that this one fact was something I didn't know yet.

Ricdorian shook his head, just as I expected he would.

“No, I don't.”

“Well, believe me, I thought at first I didn't have any,” I admitted to him, thinking about my life in my previous world, “But it turns out, I did, and I

finally got to meet him... my oppa.” I mumbled, my thoughts trailing off once more...

“But it didn’t seem real, even now...” I admitted softly.

It didn’t matter that I was actually there, that I knew it happened, and I had a scratch to prove it, but...

It was a struggle. For so long I was used to being an only child, and suddenly I have a brother.

“Both you and I are used to being an only child, am I right?” I grinned at him as I squatted down to meet his gaze.

For some reason, Ricdorian wouldn’t look at me. I wondered what was wrong.

Was he still ashamed after all?

Either way, my legs were beginning to hurt, so I needed to sit down. The stone floor was cold beneath my bum, but it was better than standing for my entire visit. I don’t know how people could stand being locked up like this...

Especially when they’re innocent.

Finally, Ricdorian raised his head, biting the inside of his lower lip in thought. And before I even knew it, my hands were already reaching out to him, holding his gaze...

“Once again, I remember that I’m the older one.” I murmured softly.

“Older?”

“Mhm,” I nodded, “Even at first glance you look much younger than I am.” I beamed at him. He blinked for a moment, before tilting his head, and asked for my age instead. Naturally, I answered him. He looked absolutely astonished by my reply.

Was it that surprising?

Well I knew guessing my age from my looks alone was a bit difficult. But I was certain I definitely looked my age.

“Either way, you seem to be younger than I am.” I huffed out at him and squished his cheeks, “Like my little brother even. Namdongsaeng.”

It was natural to think of him this way. I took care of him, fed him, spent time with him...

Maybe this was how it feels to have a sibling.

Somehow, I knew, deep down, I had thought of him like some kind of mongrel animal for a companion, more than I did see him as a younger brother. But for now, I will stamp that thought down. It was an unpleasant one.

For now, I must continue to spend time with him the way I usually did.

“Namdongsaeng...” Ricdorian repeated what I said in a whisper. Somehow, he looked like he was being tortured at the thought.

He looked up at me.

“Ammaya, you surprised me.” I gasped in shock as he did so. I had almost bumped into him that very moment. It was a little too late for me to move away in time to put enough distance between us.

However, there was no time left for me to be surprised as I realize Ricdorian’s face was growing increasingly closer to mine...

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Chapter 88: Not what siblings do (3)

Chapter 88 – Not what siblings do (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

The sound of chains being dragged echoed as Ricdorian moved to lean in closer to me, his grip steadfast. I watched the way the irons clicked and clanged against each other. So thick...

So heavy...

But Ricdorian made it seem like it was light as a feather.

I couldn't help but gulped down my saliva the more I watched him draw in closer towards me.

What is he doing? I couldn't help but wonder.

I tried not to feel too conscious about myself, but it's difficult. Everytime I look at him, all I can see is the face of a young saint...

Is this how he'd come on to me?

I could not bear the silence, to not say anything. He situated himself between my legs, making it difficult for me to move. But if I move too quickly, I would probably fall on my bottoms.

Finally, I found my voice once more, despite being stuck in such a compromising position. I wasn't even sure at this point what was

happening. Did I accidentally lock him between me like this? Or did he mean for this to happen?

“Wha- why are you-?” I stuttered out my question, feeling the blood rushing to my face.

“I don’t like it...” he murmured softly. I stopped backing away at that and tilted my head.

“What don’t you like?” I couldn’t help but ask.

“I don’t like your brother.” he gritted out in frustration. At this point, I was certain I had begun blinking rapidly.

“Huh? Did I hear it correctly?” It sounded so soft this time. I don’t think I heard him completely.

“No, no...”

I gulped again. We’re so close now... so close...

“No, I said no...” he hissed softly. Our faces were so close now, I could already see the way his lashes were fluttering despite the subtle movement.

“No, but. You are...” I spoke slowly, trying not to show that I was embarrassed.

“You don’t know what having a brother means, do you?” I asked through gritted teeth.

I was trying to not ignore him, but... I couldn’t help but wonder as well.

Does he not know what *walk* meant?

If so, he mustn’t have enough knowledge to go by with things he’d yet to experience, or something he doesn’t have. It would also make sense he wouldn’t understand what having a brother, or even sister, would mean, and what was proper...

And what isn't.

Ricdorian was already right in front of me, his face looking so fierce, as if he wanted to stab someone to the death.

"Oh," he paused as a thought dawned on him, "I know."

"You know?" I couldn't help but ask in confusion.

"Yes, I know!" he hissed out loudly, practically angry about my doubt on him.

I found it fortunate enough no one was around to hear us at this time. No guards or watchmen had been posted outside. If we were heard, then they would have cut my visit short without hesitation.

Though, I can't help but wonder why the room was so hot all of a sudden?

"No, that's what it's like to—well, yes." And then a sudden thought entered my mind. It's a far-fetched idea, but that's possible too in this situation.

"Then what does it mean?"

We were still so close to each other. Ricdorian was beginning to cage me in, and I can't exactly say it's uncomfortable...

Thanks to that position as well, I could even see his pupils clearly at this distance, but also the chain wrapped around his neck.

I could see the reddened skin beneath, irritated, as he moved closer.

Oh.

"This... I know for sure," He mumbled to himself, his voice dropping a little lower than usual. There was a strange feeling in my gut, I could feel my temples beginning to sweat.

And then his hand moved from beside me.

“Merida told me.” I felt his hand graze my fingertips, “Friends don’t do this...” he murmured, “Not even cousins.”

Our eyes locked on to each other. And his hand wrapped around my own.

“Iana.” he breathed out.

I couldn’t help but flinch at the sound of his voice. It was raspy and dry.

“You held my hand, just like this,” he continued, holding our hands up between us, “When you gave me the cookies, do you remember?”

His hand was shaking, I could tell he was nervous about this. Strange, I thought, there was a growing tension within me, like a cold dread creeping up from my hands...

It was rather breathtaking.

Had Ricdorian always been this big? I didn’t think he’d grown since last I saw him. I watched as the redness returned on his face, blooming from his cheeks. He was bending over me, his face hovering just above mine...

Any lower and our lips would just about to touch.

“Didn’t you like it?” he whispered.

No, I didn’t like it. But that moment was a different story.

That was when I gave him the spell.

“No,” I gulped, “No, I didn’t.” Though to be honest, in the situation I’m in right now, I don’t think there’s much room for me to refuse.

“Then?” he whispered. Goodness, he was still coming closer, looking at me so endearingly. This was getting awkward.

“Don’t come closer, stop!” I couldn’t help but snap at him, “Stay right there, and talk at that distance. Please.” I added for good measure.

Honestly, that face of his was just unfair.

“Where do you come up with these ideas? Is it Merida? Who is that person?”

I swear I’ve heard that name before, Ricdorian mentioned that name in passing some time ago. I wasn’t that curious, but I’d take any opportunity just to change the topic.

“Merida was an old maid. Who sometimes comes by to bring me clothes and water.”

So that person was like some kind of nanny. It wasn’t a name I had remembered from the novel, so it probably wasn’t an important piece. But here, it seemed like that person is, in Ricdorian’s life at least.

“Merida was quite important to me.”

I moved my hand, dragging his along with mine as he refused to let go of me.

“Still, I don’t think siblings, or even friends hold hands like this.” He informed me, showing our entangled hands.

I knew that friends, especially those belonging to the opposite sexes, such actions were frowned upon unless you both were beyond that. And if you were brother and sister, doing things like this were just plain taboo.

At least in my original world. In this world however...

From Lenag’s actions, my brother’s...

It seemed casual touch was normal, so I could be wrong...

Right?

“So what?” he asked, and I blinked.

“What do you mean?”

“Is this okay too?” he asked again, tilting his head.

“What?” I accidentally slipped out.

I didn’t want to ask it like that. I was planning on gently slipping my hand out of his hold, but I didn’t get far as he clung onto it tighter than before.

It didn’t hurt, when he grabbed me. The only thing that registered was the feel of the sharp cold of the chain that grazed my hand.

“Merida did it.” he shared, resuming his actions to lean in closer to me.

Chapter 89: Not what siblings do (4)

Chapter 89 – Not what siblings do (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

At that moment, all I could think about was being dwarfed by a younger boy who happened to be a little taller than I was.

I could already feel his breath hit my skin.

“We really shouldn’t be doing this, okay? Not like this.” I insisted.

Then I caught a whiff of his scent.

That’s strange. He didn’t smell one bit like the damp cell he lived in. He smelled something a little cooler, fresher...

More elegant...

He smelled like lilies.

Is this one of the main benefits of being a main character? Mentally, I shook my silly thoughts away. Plot armors rarely exist in real life.

“Like this...” he murmured.

I shuddered at the thought of it. He jerked up his face.

I couldn’t help but wonder what he was doing now?

And then I felt something soft graze my neck, brushing up against my collarbone in the process...

A hot breath hit my skin.

Oh.

It was his lips. It was unmistakable. He just kissed me.

“Are you telling me we can’t do this?” he asked me again, I couldn’t help but feel more flustered.

“Wa-wait, wait!” I protested weakly. I could imagine himself rolling his eyes at me as he looked up at me, his face still hovering insanely close to my neck. Once again, I find myself drawn to his lashes, looking up at me like an innocent, naive boy.

Unconsciously, I wetted my lips in my nervousness.

“Why can’t you do it with me too? Don’t you want it?” he kept asking, “Can’t you think of any reason to do it with me? At all?”

I swallowed the lump in my throat and grabbed a hold of his hand. His free hand moved behind me, keeping me in place as he held me still on the small of my back.

In this moment, I felt like I was the child instead, so naive of the ways of this world. It was like I was being reproached, as if everything I knew was wrong.

“That thing you did,” I began, “When you kissed my neck, where did you learn that from?”

“Ah, Merida described it to me before,” he explained, “told me not to do it.”

I couldn’t help but feel my sweat drop in exasperation.

“Then why do it at all?”

Thinking about this, maybe Ricdorian was but a small child when he had Merida take care of him. As a young child, it would have been so natural for him to want to snuggle in, nuzzle his face closer than what was proper. Affection to, and from, children were always more lenient in what was proper and what wasn't.

The problem was, now he's older, it should have been already clear that this isn't something he must do so casually. Hmm, if that was true, then it seems I have misunderstood Merida-ssi after all. That person has taught him well.

I cleared my throat.

"Well, you were told correctly, so, don't do it again." I attempted to scold him. He seemed to be mulling over his thoughts well, frowning in confusion.

I waited until he spoke up once more. I hope there won't be any more incidents like this later on. That would be too troublesome to correct.

"Then," he began, "You'll come back to me again? Visit me again?" he asked, looking like the little boy he was supposed to be. I nodded at him, hoping to ease his worry, and my guilt while I'm at it.

"Of course," I affirmed, "How about Monday?"

I then heard him whisper something, something only he could hear. It sounded an awful lot like *Namdongsaeng*, but I couldn't be sure. For some reason, that word only made him clam up fractionally.

I could feel the tension in his body due to our proximity.

I should have asked him if he really wanted to be seen as someone's brother. But I couldn't seem to get the words out...

All because he'd been too bold in front of me. Despite his shivering and obvious nervousness, he still pushed on and grabbed onto me like a lifeline.

Everything about him, his body, voice...

Even the tip of his fingers...

He was never one to be someone considered as a younger brother. Not even the type as that *cute-next-door-neighbor-who-is-like-a-brother* type.

“This feeling,” he began to mumble again, “Even now... don’t you feel it too?”

“Still going on about that, huh? Even when you’re shaking like a leaf.” I pointed out. When I did, I saw him flinch and tremble some more. His face flushed a deeper red, as he averted his head, turning to the side. It wasn’t like I thought it was wrong, but even I could see the way his ears turned red.

“But I, I’d like to do this,” he continued, “I want to do this.” he seemed confused. Determined, but still confused. So innocent, even as he asked me of this.

He couldn’t even look at me anymore.

Suddenly I felt him rest his head on my shoulders, a shaky breath emanating from him.

“Hey, I notice,” he whispered, “Why won’t you look at me today?”

I felt my entire frame freeze up when he asked me. It was like he knew, the guilt I was hiding within me. It made me feel quite vulnerable.

But how could I look at him? How can I bear to look at him in such proximity? When there is but a hair’s breadth between us.

“Tell me, what can I do to get you to look at me.”

He kept pleading, but I found it too much to even think to look at him. This moment, at this instant, I just couldn’t bear to do it. Not at this distance.

“I knew it.” he hissed to himself, “You don’t want to be here. You don’t actually want to see me, don’t you?”

I could hear the tremble in his voice, the tears threatening to fall the more he insisted. I couldn't bear to see him. But that isn't why. But I can't tell him...

I can't tell him how I didn't want to see him if he was just going to send me to an early grave. When did he become so comfortable to the point he'd let himself be so vulnerable in front of me?

I let out a shaky breath.

"That's not true." was all I could offer him right now.

"Then-"

"Shh," I hushed him, "Let it go for now. Okay?"

Ricdorian hesitated, I can tell, even as he began to back away from me. The warmth I felt from him went away as well, spreading a chill through my body.

I'd heard before that an animal's body temperature normally ran higher than a human's. Was this it? Was Ricdorian's body naturally hotter than mine? I couldn't tell.

I rarely saw him shiver in this cell whenever I came by the visit, even when it's supposed to be a cold underground. Except maybe that time he was ill due to the beatings he got from his father.

But even when he began pulling away, there was something in me that wished he wouldn't. When I looked at him, and stared at his eyes, it was like he was beckoning me to hold on to him...

To not let him go, as he won't let go of me either.

Chapter 90: Things no one has told me but you (1)

Chapter 90 – Things no one has told me but you (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

I'm not sure if he was doing this because of longing or it's just that out of naivety.

I took a small breath and shut my eyes tightly as I did. Then, I opened them as I gave out a deep sigh.

Glancing over at his hand, there was something that bothered me a little while ago...And my eyes stopped in one place.

Oh, of course.

His wrists had been slightly scratched and reddened by the handcuffs. Furthermore, I heard that the sound of chains being pulled is unusual. Poor thing.

He looked at my eyes, then followed the place where my eyes stayed, then turned his head to his side as if wondering what was wrong with it. In a matter of seconds, our eyes met, afterwards, I gave out a slight shrug and spoke.

“Doesn't your wrist hurt?”

He was an unsusceptible child; no, a beast, who couldn't say he was sick. He has no idea what pain is, or how to feel ache on his body.

“It doesn’t hurt.” he answered after a moment.

I chuckled lightly when I heard a small voice that came from him. What should I do with this man? I thought. I don’t know why I laughed, but I’m amused that he’s talking, glad even.

“Yes, I hope one day I know what it’s like to be sick.” Ricdorian said.

Maybe this is not something I can tell him now, but soon.

In time, he’ll understand. It’s really difficult to explain something to someone who has never felt it, or known it. I held his hands together.

The chains gave clinking sounds as I did. It echoed throughout the entire cell. Silence followed. Between me, and the chains, and him, there’s nobody here besides us. I broke the creeping silence when I spoke.

“Because it’s important to realize the pain,” I said, then he flinched. At the same time, he looked at me with a slightly ragged face. He pressed his lips together then looked down.

“Pain is also a warning sign of a greater danger. So you could avoid getting into something more dangerous. Please don’t ignore it. And don’t let things hurt you.” I carefully explained.

“Things that make you sick.” Ricdorian muttered.

“Yes. If you can’t do anything right now, you can do other things to get by. It’s not bad to not feel anything at all, for now.”

I raised his hand and put it on my chest. He looked at his hands then at me. I could see his eyes narrowing a bit, but then it disappeared.

“You can wait for the right moment, for the right opportunity.”

I don’t know how much I can do to let him know. But it would be okay to show him something that would be easier for him to understand. Something that would be easy for him to remember. At least he wouldn’t be confused.

“Someday, everything will return back in time.”

That day will definitely come to you.

He didn't seem to understand it at all, but he nodded slowly.

“Okay? If it hurts, say it hurts. But I'm telling you, you don't want to get hurt. Nobody wants to get hurt. Now, follow me. Wait, no...I can't, I won't live.”

I jokingly added at the end.

He narrowed his eyes, and I know what his expression meant. He wasn't buying my joke. Or maybe he just doesn't get it? Of course, it was a joke that wouldn't work here.

Soon, Ricdorian reiterated whether he understood only the preceding expression. He's honestly quite clueless about most things.

“You don't want to?”

“Huh. I don't want to.”

I hate him, I hate him... I mumbled softly like a mantra. Then he straightened his head and looked right through me.

“...Remember, I will.” The cold blue eyes stared straight at me as if they had stuck me in their eyes.

“Nobody else...told me... about all you just said...” He tightened his fingers around mine.

I almost forgot he was clutching my hands while we talked. His tightened grip on our interlocked hands made me feel like he's pouring his strength in it, as if telling me those words with conviction.

“Other than you.” He added

He looked happy.

I once saw a video of an abandoned dog smiling brightly at his adoptee. It was amazing that even a speechless animal could feel so delighted.

Furthermore, I'm the very first person who let him out of the basement, so I can't help it. Even if it were me, I wouldn't forget who would do such a kind thing to me. I would owe that someone with my life, for sparing me, taking care of me. But I know, even if I do something unreasonable, that's it.

"And one more thing." I pulled up the corners of my lips and grinned as if I was ready to prank someone. He pressed his lips together. He gave out a surprised expression that only lasted three seconds, then he spoke in a low, slow voice.

"Don't give it to me."

Just to be clear. The limitations to what I can give him is very easy to understand. I already told him about it before. So, I won't be saying it again and it doesn't mean I can give him food anytime you want.

"You remember what I said before? Say no. Don't take the food even if you want to ask me for some. Food, no. But it doesn't mean you have to starve. You also have to learn to take care of yourself, and eating is one of them."

He stopped. I figured that I need to keep talking now that he's listening.

"Someone may cheat you anytime, anywhere and hit your back. The food might be dangerous or not even safe. So don't even trust me." Because I'm that type of person, someone who will disappear after gaining the favor I wanted.

"...no." Ricdorian said.

"What?" I asked, making sure if I heard him right.

"You told me to say no, if I don't like it." He said with certitude.

I couldn't hide my surprised face.

“Wow... you learn fast.” While saying this, I felt like I did a great job.

I didn't think this was something that can't be easily done to people... I wondered if this was how it felt to raise a pet. It is a little difficult in the beginning. But I have to say, it's getting a little easier now.

“But what I said is true. Engrave it in your heart. Always remember. There's nothing good in receiving treats from me. Remember, okay?”

“Why...” He said as I poked him in the cheek.

“First of all, I can't treat your wrists unless I bring you medicine.” He glanced down slowly, skimmed his wrists and took them down.

“In addition... I'm here to do something bad to you.”

Bad deed, cancer. Yeah. It's a bad thing.

Thinking of the tool that Jair had given me, I kicked my tongue inside. I can't let my tongue spill out everything.

“Bad... act?”

As I said so far, I wanted to be in the lookout for Ricdorian. I thought about it for a long time, but I couldn't help it if it would come out like that, and I was thinking of stepping down.

Even so, no matter how hard I think about it, it was neither my principle nor my conscience to make this man sick. I couldn't leave him alone. But at the same time, my body moved slightly.

“Then, that bad thing, if you get hit.”

“Uh... Hmm...”

“Are you going to stay with me?” Ricdorian said as he pulled me towards him, but I was so embarrassed by what I heard that made me stumble.

Still, Ricdorian caught my body that lost its balance. However, he failed to brace himself on the added weight by the sudden catch and we both toppled to the floor.

Ahhhh, My gosh!!

Eventually, Ricdorian's body carried me backwards. I closed my eyes tightly, feeling dizziness beginning to take over me. And it took some time for me to register just what position I was currently in.

Chapter 91: Things no one has told me but you (2)

Chapter 91 – Things no one has told me but you (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

If I remember correctly, as I fell, there was a pretty loud noise. And what's strange is that I didn't hurt at all. I just felt a little tingling and soft thud.

Then when I opened my eyes, I saw a white shirt. At the same time, I could see Ricdorian frowning with his eyes closed. He looked like he was in pain.

Was he hurt that much?

“Ri...Ricdorian? Oh, my God, are you okay?”

“Uh...no pain.”

No matter how strong he was, it seemed to be painful to hit the floor. He groaned slightly...languidly. I almost blushed because I forgot the situation, but I quickly gathered myself together and got up. This felt awkward, but I think he could never notice.

“Have you hit hard? Why did you even catch me? No. No. Don't catch me next time.”

Should I blame the person who grabbed me? I felt so bad for shouting at him. What he did wasn't really a bad thing.

I gave out sigh because I realized I was overreacting.

I patted my cheek and studied him. The way his chain fell with him made it seem heavier than it was, sounding louder than I expected it to be, but fortunately there seemed to be no major injuries other than a bump. No wonder he fell even though he was very strong. He looked okay though, but still ragged. I should have been more careful.

I glared at the shackles and chains for no reason. Then I sighed.

“...I’m glad you didn’t bleed. It’s not pleasant.”

“It’s okay-“

“Don’t say you’re okay. You don’t look okay.” I stopped him from saying those words.

I came down from his body and tried to help him up. At the same time, I realized once again how heavy this chain was, as it was heavy enough to even make my body go down with its weight.

The curse of Archduke Harnim, who can’t even look at his son’s face, suddenly came to mind.

“Excuse me, Ricdorian. I know it’s not my right to say this, but I’ll just say it.” I grabbed the handcuffs and looked at it disapprovingly

“Don’t ever forgive the one who filled you with this. Okay?”

“...forgive?” He asked and stared at me blankly.

Before I knew it, he seemed to have clearly forgotten the pain from the tumble. It’s a quick recovery, I guess.

“Yes, forgive. Is he crazy trying to fill in something like this on a young person like you? Even in this basement alone! He is a bad person. A very bad person, Ricdorian.”

Of course, I already knew. Later on, Ricdorian would forgive everyone. Furthermore, he does not hide his grudge against Chaser, the villain who killed his father. His father who tormented and tortured him. Because, he

was, however, the guardian of the righteous Hel family, and the one and only who inherited that noble spirit.

Is that why he still has eyes that can't hate anyone?

But I decided to seal my lips. I shouldn't have said that to him.

I suddenly realized why should I tell this to a man who knows no pain, hates, and forgives all in the future? For some reason, I decided to keep my mouth shut because I thought his father would just say, *'I'm such an imbecile woman'*, if I keep talking. I'll just keep everything under wraps.

Even so, it was Ricdorian who opened his mouth in this situation.

"forgive...don't forgive him?" Ricdorian asked, oblivious of what I really meant.

"What? No... No. Forget what I said. Just let it slide."

I tried to let go of the handcuffs. But faster than that, he caught me by his hand.

"If you thought that what you think is right, if that's how you feel about it. Well, okay. I won't... forgive." Ricdorian declared.

"...eh, really?" I queried.

I burst into laughter as I stared at his face. He had a puppy-like face whose paws seemed to have been grabbing the edge of his company owner's clothes. I couldn't get why I find him really cute just now. Is it because of that puppy face? Maybe because I liked dogs. Puppies, even more.

Shortly, I shook off the thought, and continued talking.

"...but no, don't do that. Even more because I said so. I'm not always right, you know." I hesitated at first, and in the end I spat out what I was going to say.

"I'm getting out of prison soon." I announced.

“Out of prison?” He asked.

“I’m going out of this cell.” I said and placed my right hand on the back of his resting hand.

“We may not see each other again.” I told him the words in a soft, sad voice.

I’m not sure, but I think so. Oh yeah, I do know that we may never meet in the future again.

Because later, when Ricdorian goes out of jail, he becomes the noblest person in the country. Having the great and simple status of an Archduke.

On the other hand, it was obvious that I belong to a not so bad family. I’m sure I’m not going to do anything worthwhile if I continue to stay on the sidelines. But I had no intention of coming out to the center of attention either.

“That’s why I came to do something bad to you before I’ll leave.”

At this point, I could see that even Ricdorian couldn’t help it, his eyes trembled helplessly. As I always expected, it won’t be too long for people before they do bad things, right? I can feel that this moment right here, right now, is the moment that I think suits such expectation.

“Are... you going... out?”

“What? Oh, yes. That’s right. Go out, me. I am going out. Definitely. ” I nodded. This must have been a slap in the face to him.

His eyes shook violently. He looked betrayed.

“Here...”

Well, you couldn’t have been without a shock, could you?

I remained silent for a moment to give him the time to accept what I just told him...to take in reality.

At the same time, he slipped his gaze. It wasn't pleasant to see him sloppy...Because it's not that I wasn't attached to him.

Moments of spacing out, I lightly looked at the cell wall and gently rubbed it.

Creaked.

Oh, what's this? I felt curious. My fingers rattled in one place. I think I was touching a brick in a certain array. I took my hand off. But then I touched it again. This looked like a crevice.

Hmm.. strange.

Honestly, I couldn't resist my curiosity and took a closer look.

It's a little dreary, but when I tried to look carefully, it looked a little different from other bricks. Thinking about it now, it's dark and this is something I've never seen because it's where Ricdorian's back has always been. I would have noticed this sooner if Ricdorian was concerned so much about changing spots in the cell.

After taking my time looking at it, I could barely realize what it was. No, it can't be. I stepped a few paces back, and stood there, staring at that particular spot on the cell wall.

Could I be right?

“...Flower? No, a rose?”

Chapter 92: The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (1)

Chapter 92 – The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (1)

Translator: SKAIS

Editor: Nym13

It seems to have dug a groove as if it were drawing something from it, but I could not quite guess what it was.

However, it looks like flowers, especially roses.

Before I knew it, even Ricdorian looked my way, his eyes were filled with curiosity as he did so.

“Oh, there’s something weird over here. Come on and take a look.” I told him and he slowly took tentative steps towards him.

It was time for me to tap the stone, I did so by putting more pressure against it and I knew my actions needed to be a little hard to be able to scrape the groove slightly.

As I was doing this, the thing that was wrapped around my arm collided with the stone, the motion caused an unavoidable shaking sound. I was certain that the noise definitely came from the bracelet Jair gave me.

Again, the moment the jewel touched the brick, it caused a sound

Shring.

Suddenly, a pure white light burst out.

“..Light? What is this... .” I exclaimed in shock.

“Iana!” He screamed at me, but I was too distracted by the noise that surrounded us.

Clank. Clank.

I could hear a rough wobble of chains clashing against each other, as if moving in a labored motion. I could feel a firm grasp on my body. Ricdorian was clinging onto me tightly, his glare boring deep into my very being, as if drilling his thoughts into my own.

I shut my eyes tightly and willed myself to push aside these unnecessary thoughts. This was just a fantasy, I told myself. It has become more often now that I forget that I’m in a romance fantasy novel and am trying to get rid of the curse.

As I slowly opened my eyes, I saw a huge cavity in front of me.

“...Cave?”

I could only describe it like this.

The wall of the chain that used to restrain Ricdorian was open on that side. Turning my head and looking at Ricdorian, I could tell that he was just as puzzled as I am.

“I’m asking you, do you know about that?”

He shook his head. His eyes were also quite surprised by the sight before us now.

“More than that, your chains... .”

The wall where the chains were inserted had disappeared, and of course, naturally his chains should be well-knit together and clinging from his side, but surprisingly they were not.

Rather, his neck and arms and legs were chained at a place that we could not see. And his eyes followed the trail of the chain as if he was a bystander overlooking a train that was passing by.

Surprisingly, his chain seemed to be connected to the endless hole. Furthermore, I couldn't see the inside of the hole because it was too deep and endless.

“My gosh, what did I do... .”

I frowned.

This was the perfect time for Ricdorian to lie down for a while, and not draw attention to himself. And to receive the magic I got from Jair would be enough to make him deliberately ill.

But what if some greater force had intended for this thing to happen? What if they had foreseen this situation?

Not only Lenag, but...Archduke Harnim also? What if they knew about this?

A cold sweat ran down my back at the thought of this.

Victory never comes easy to good people after all.

However, it was also possible that the Archduke Harnim had seen this situation in a different light, for people may have varying interpretations of what is good or bad. It is a known fact that every villain considers himself as the hero of his own story. Their concept of what's right and what's wrong differs from the common good.

If something does not go according to plan, people are bound to feel disappointed. Such is an unpleasant feeling and no one wants to experience it. It would be a problem if the Archduke would think that Ricdorian did this. He would mistakenly believe that Ricdorian has awakened.

And right now, I could foresee his impending disappointment once he realizes he has not actually awakened yet. Ricdorian probably didn't even

know future torment and abuse that he was going to encounter.

I bit my lower lip at that thought.

“What do I do now?” I asked myself.

I can’t just go outside and inform the senior guard of the new developments. Things will get too complicated, and I already feel like I have bitten more than I could chew.

Then, Jair’s bracelet caught my eye.

For some reason, it was emitting a faint glow, a light that shone brightly in front of the dark hole before us.

‘The light seemed to be pointing in one direction.’ I thought to myself.

Its white touch spread against the road that led towards the cave. Like a compass, it seemed to be teasing us, prodding us to look inside the cave.

To be honest, the bright light seemed to be pulling me inside, it felt like there was an invisible force that wanted to drag us in.

“Well, Ricdorian... I’m going to go inside now.” I swallowed a heavy lump that was stuck inside my throat and took a deep breath to calm my erratic heart. I could feel sweat sliding from my forehead, but despite my nervousness, I knew I needed to go.

“If after going inside, I still haven’t come out, you should create a very loud sound... .” I stated.

“N...no.” Ricdorian said, with hesitation in his eyes.

“What? No, don’t worry, I’ll be out soon. Just in case, please do it for me.” I told Ricdorian.

“Go... Can’t I go with you?” He asked.

Clank.

His chains made a sound as he moved and I smiled sadly at him. He grabbed me by the hem of my dress and shook his head, he did not want me to go alone.

“I’m coming with you.”

He bit his lips, then formed his hands into fists as if telling me that his decision is fixed.

Looking at him, I thought that aside from his walks outside the cell, there would come a day where he could freely walk despite the chains that held him.

“Yes, then let’s go together.” I said.

I didn’t know why the wall had suddenly disappeared into thin air.

But there should be a reason for it, right? Perhaps there was a clue I was missing. Wise men did say that answers to problems are always under our own noses.

Maybe the answer would only come to me if I wouldn’t look for it? Maybe only then will it come to me? Perhaps it wasn’t the time yet for me to find it.

“Well, shall we go? I should be the first to step in, if you think it’s dangerous, even just a little dangerous, you should run without even looking back. Remember to run, do you understand me?” I stared at him in intensity. It was clear I did not want him to dismiss my concern.

“Yes, I understand.” He replied to me while nodding his head.

He spoke with a gentle face and I felt relieved when he agreed. He suddenly looked like a puppy in my eyes and for a moment I imagined myself and Ricdorian turning around and running together. It feels like it would look like a race between a human being and a hound when that happens.

I was amazed at my own imagination, my thoughts were wandering so much. I shook my head to clear it of nonsensical thoughts and grabbed the

hem of Ricdorian's sleeves.

"You know, you have to run with me right? You can't leave me because it's scary. I'll be a ghost and follow you around if you do." I told him with a slight smile.

"What? Oh, yes. Okay." Ricdorian gave me a nod.

He moved his head like an obedient beast. It was a half-meant joke on my part but he seemed to have taken it seriously. Anyway, thanks to this joke, I felt my heart easing up.

Chapter 93: The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (2)

Chapter 93 – The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

I pulled out a decorated lamp from the walls and held on it tightly. The guard would periodically change lanterns or torches, but fortunately today the one that was placed in Ricodrian's cell was a torch enclosed in a glass dome. It was an oil lamp. Good, it will last longer, I thought.

It's been shedding light in his cell for quite some time now and it seemed that the fire wasn't subsiding at all. They were lucky that today the guards decided to place oil lamps.

"Okay, shall we go now?" I asked as I finally took a tentative step forward.

I walked with a slight grip around Ricdorian's finger.

"Hand..." Ricdorian told me with a little hesitation.

"Huh? Why?" I asked.

Ricdorian was trying to say something but when our eyes met, he shook his head quickly as if washing his thoughts away. His cheeks seemed slightly red under the light of the torch. He seemed to be blushing.

The inside of the hole was rather dark. We could not help but move slowly and take careful steps.

Even with the torch lighting our way, we could barely see more than three steps ahead, so our pace was inevitably slow.

“It’s too dark, isn’t it?” I asked him.

“Yes...” Ricdorian replied simply. I grabbed on his sleeve tighter.

As we moved deeper into the cave’s cavity, I noticed that it was quite cold here, and only the torch in my hand gave me warmth.

“Now that we’re in here, I still can’t see the end.” I told Ricdorian as I squinted my eyes.

I can’t see well, but this cave seemed to be in a long corridor format. The chains of Ricdorian were leading infinitely in front of us.

How far did it go? Where do they end?

“Have you ever heard about this cell before?”

It was a question that I asked thinking that he would say that he had never heard of this. He was trapped in the basement when he was very young, when he wasn’t even sure where this was.

“I’ve heard of it before.” Ricdorian answered and I was surprised.

Him knowing about this was quite unexpected.

“You’ve heard of it?” I asked again.

“Yes... before...a long time ago from my father.” He replied as he stared ahead.

Having heard this, I could not help but nibble on my lower lip. I asked him the question but in certain circumstances, knew that there were questions whose answers I did not need to hear. If my question provoked in him memories he was uncomfortable with I did not need an answer.

“Well, if it’s hard to tell, you don’t have to tell me.” I reassured him.

“What? No, no. It’s not like that. I was just reminiscing.”

Contrary to his normal tone, Ricdorian’s voice, when he answered me, was flat, devoid of emotion.

Somewhere in the heavy, dreary space, in which we were in, his clear voice seemed to purify the air around us.

“My father said...He said this is a very old place. It was built a long time ago, a very long time ago we never knew existed...beyond imagination.”

As I listened, I recalled something. I have heard about this. Among the things that Baron was excited about, was the story about this cell.

<There are three special things in this empire that are not in other countries. This prison, ‘Kambrakam’, has been built since ancient times for more than a thousand years.>

I remember there were two other things besides that. Was it the Imperial Palace and the Roses? Anyway, if it’s a prison that’s been around a thousand years since ancient times...There would be at least one strange thing in here. Right?

“I’ve heard of it. You said it was from ancient times, right? I heard it’s been a thousand years since it was built. Then maybe there’s something here.”

I paused in my steps as I found myself in deep thought.

“But what do you mean by ancient times?” I asked him because I still lack basic knowledge of this new world.

If it’s about Korea, I know he doesn’t know anything about Gojoseon, Ungnyeo, Hwanung and the likes of Korean History.

But the only thing I know was that this place is a historic place after hearing stories from Baron.

“That’s probably the era before this empire was built.” Ricdorian suddenly said.

“Eh? You do know?” I asked.

I turned my head with a little surprised look. Because I didn’t think he’d tell me the answer.

“A little bit? My father and Merida once told me a story.”

That Harnim.

*You’re saying that the godd*mn Archduke hit a kid while giving a lecture? What?*

My perception of the Archduke has gotten worse. No matter how I think positively of him, I just can’t.

“My father said that it was a time when roses were in full bloom.”

“Roses?” I asked.

That’s when I gave out a large sigh.

Rose, I didn’t think that was just about the **roses**.

<Roses are very famous for being the five families of the Empire. And the special abilities each family has.>

I guess Archduke Harnim told Ricdorian stories about the ***‘families.’***

“At that time, well, it was an era when a rose could become a king. But it was said that it’s better to have only one emperor.”

One emperor? Is the king and the emperor different? It wasn’t just governing the land, but governing the country and gathering it to become an empire.

“The Emperor? Doesn’t he still exist?” I asked.

“I heard it’s a little different.” Ricdorian replied.

“Different, how?”

“Yes. He’s the one who only rules the roses. Although I don’t actually know what it means.” Ricdorian, who had paused for a while, answered me slowly.

“I think I heard my father say that I must find it.”

You must find it.

At least it was clear to me that Archduke Harnim would die without finding it. But, if I try to remember correctly, there was no such thing as these in the contents of the story I read.

This was a rated-19 romance novel between the heroine and the male lead and the villain. Maybe? But I wasn’t sure anymore, ever since I have been here the story got more complicated.

I stared at Ricdorian’s face one last time before finally looking forward again. Then, Ricdorian stopped on his tracks and rubbed his chin as if in thought.

“Apart from the stories about the prison, Ricdorian.” I told him.

“What?” He asked.

I turned around and faced him. I scanned his face. He was a sixteen year old boy, just two years younger than me, and had been locked up since childhood. Furthermore, I never had any idea of Ricdorian’s education. I don’t know just how much he knew of the world he was living in.

The more I looked at him, the more I understood why the book was so vague from the very beginning.

Dear heroine, I hope you’ll thank me later.

“You, you need to learn a little from me. You should not remain naive.”

“Le..learn?” He asked, and I gave him a nod.

“Yes! You are going to learn.”

TLN:

Gojoseon – Ancient kingdom on the Korean peninsula

Ungnyeo – Bear woman

Hwanung – Korean term for Supreme Divine Regent, an important figure in the mythical origins of Korea.

Chapter 94: The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (3)

Chapter 94 – The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

It took some time for me to realize that I'm feeling a little tired. In fact, the torch I was carrying inside this cave was quite heavy. The iron is used as a core and body, and the weight of the glass dome seems to be adding some weight to its total mass, making my arm feel a little sore.

Perhaps it would be easy for Ricdorian to take this torch and deal with the crisis while holding this. He does seem stronger compared to me. He's a man after all! But holding this thing might come in handy if I needed to use it as a weapon to protect myself.

However, if a situation came and I needed to throw the torch away, I might not be able to throw it far enough. So, I guess it would be better if he's the one carrying it.

Still, he didn't seem to offer any help at all. I hated that he's not asking me. I felt my nostrils heating up with escalating internal fury.

"You know what, next time, or maybe later." I waved him and his hand back and forth as I gave out a long and heavy sigh.

"If a woman walking with you is holding something heavy, ask her at least once. Oh, you don't have to ask right away. Here, like this."

I took his arm and put it on my hand that was holding the torch.

“Listen, if you feel like her hands or arms are shaking a little, or her face looking miserable, how about asking? Okay? Hey, are you listening? If you do that, I’m sure she will like you.”

It was all about the heroine.

Perhaps in the future, he’s able to discern these things for himself without anyone telling him, but it wouldn’t do him any harm to learn some thing’s in advance either.

Ricdorian rolled out his big eyes, like clear glass beads, and stared alternately at the torch and at my hand. Soon, he nodded as if he understood.

Even with that figure, he seemed like a well-behaved beast.

“... hmm...you listen well, don’t you?” I smirked a little as I said those words with a clear voice and a proud heart. Yes, I was feeling a lot of pride having made him listen to anything I have to say. It’s as if a bundle of clouds were carrying me up everytime he listens. Let’s face it, it’s not easy to boss someone around, especially someone like him. Anyway, I think I did a pretty good job.

I looked up at him, as I turned my smirk into a warm, incandescent smile.

The next thing that happened took me by surprise. Ricdorian grabbed me with a single stroke, it’s as if I was nothing far from an empty hay sack, I was weightless to him. My field of view turned upside down as he lifted me into a fireman’s carry.

...what? no...no..Oh my.

“No, Ric, Ricdorian! Wait a minute.”

It was a strange feeling, the weightlessness, or even the concrete beneath my own feet. My feet were hanging in the air.

I had only meant he should carry the lamp instead, not carry *me*. And now here I am, swept off my feet like a damsel in distress.

Then he stared at me with a naive face as if asking me what had gone wrong.

“Well, not this one.” I said.

“I lifted it, Iana.” He said, looking at me innocently, smiling.

“No, I mean...”

It's not supposed to be me whom you should lift, Ricdorian.

I lifted the torch up so he could see me gesturing to it. I waved it deliberately in the air.

“This is light. But this is so... It is so heavy for Iana.” He laughed brightly. Not only that, he even hardened his face with determination.

“...I'll remember.” I quickly shook my head violently.

No. I said no, didn't I?

My insisted protests didn't seem to cue him that it's time for him to put me down.

Seeing him misunderstanding the situation firmly made me feel something was wrong.

“Iana, it's too light.”

“That's because you're strong, and I'm not. No! Ricdorian, can you put me down now?”

“...I don't want to.”

I looked at him sternly, but he slipped away from my gaze. His eyes drooped.

“You told me, if I don't like it, I won't do it... you forgot.”

“Don’t use all of what I told you here.”

I asked him to say no to things he doesn’t like, but he used it on me. His sullen face did not loosen the strength of the arm that was holding me still. I never really pictured him to be this stubborn, nor to be in a situation where he would be lifting me with his strong arms.

“.....can’t I?”

“Don’t do that. It’s foul, foul, so foul! You listen to me! Ric...dorian!”

Soon, I was able to come down to the floor at the end of a scuffle with him. After putting me down, he immediately asked for the torch. I shrugged, then gave it to him. I could not understand why he’s still plastering that bright smile on his face.

“Woah, we don’t have much time anyway, so let’s go.”

He came after me with a proud look for some reason. Perhaps, it was after my promise to let him hold me if my legs hurt. Huh, I guess that made him very happy.

That face.

I feel like I’m seeing more of a dog from that beastly appearance...

No, it must have been fate from the time I shouted ‘**sit.**’

The cave was very dark and I always wondered what else could be revealed in such an uncanny place. I couldn’t help but think of some scary thoughts in my head.

All the unpredictability I’ve encountered ever since we’ve found ourselves in the cave made me feel like even I can’t prepare myself for what is to come next. I felt frustrated, clueless, and useless...

The dark cave was full of mystery, after all.

I'm just glad I allowed him to come in here with me, or else...I don't know. But I guess it didn't really matter what could have been, if I came to the cave alone. All that mattered now is I'm here with him, proudly carrying that heavy torch like a trophy. In a setting like this, what else could scare me?

I cleared my thoughts as I walked over and then stood against the wall, checking the material. It was just like in the cell, a cold and hard stone. However, unlike the cells which were provided with dim light, the place was pitch dark...

I didn't think such a place existed.

"...it's too dark."

The silence was deafening, save for the few we could hear.

Leak.

Tak. Tak.

I opened my eyes wide.

"The fire... they are on...?"

The lights came on at a good time. It also witnessed a strange scene that lit like waves.

"What did you do, Ricdorian?" I queried and Ricdorian only shook his head in reply with a dumb expression on his face.

Then, I glanced at Jair's bracelet. It may be possible that this made this mystifying occurrence.

Did the bracelet do this?

Chapter 95: The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (4)

Chapter 95 – The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

How did the bracelet do something as enchanting as this? But what it did only set off faint fire for us to see the path and no more else.

That's it! It's good that the torches were lit with fire however it's not that bright. The color of the light was dark blue, so it felt dreary.

But perhaps this was due to the blue-colored jewels, or minerals, all over the walls around us. Taking a closer look at it, it was starting to look a lot like sapphire or crystals that were often mined in caves.

Why is it they're blue jewels? Blue light is a kind of light that is not commonly used in horror movies. Green lights are.

I shuddered at the thought of the past horror movies I watched. It was bright, but the atmosphere felt gloomy. This could not be good.

My decision earlier was to go a little further from here and then go back. But now, I felt like my desire to go far had disappeared. I wanted to go back so bad, back to the entrance of this very scary cave.

Fortunately, the trail did not continue any longer because it was not long before I reached the end of the path.

“Maybe this is the end?” I said that and checked the space which was a little wider than I thought.

If the place where I walked earlier was a long corridor, this one was a circular space. And here was a mixture of minerals of different colors, instead of rarest indentations of blue minerals. Thanks to that, I could see more clearly than in the hallway.

Not long after, I heard a chain strike. Ricdorian was tugging the iron chains tied to his wrist.

“I think my chains are connected to something over there.” He stated, pointing his fingers to the edge.

I turned my gaze to where he was pointing at.

“I can tell that they are connected but...what is that?”

The end of the chain was bound to the edge of this space, to a circular pillar that was about the waist of a man. The pillar was similar in form to the altar.

I slowly raised my head and stared ahead. It had been standing out, but I couldn't figure it out because of the shallow space that seemed to be sucking most of the light in.

“What the hell is that?”

There was a huge stone plate in front of me. Remains? A tombstone? No, the only thing I could say so was a huge stone plate.

Furthermore, there were sharp carves all over it, like knives struck at it and cuts decorated the huge stone plate, as if it was created a long time ago, that would have been seen in history books.

Should this be called a stone painting or mural painting?

However, there was no answer from Ricdorian. Maybe he doesn't know. Because he had a bewildered expression similar to mine.

“That is... like a rose, right?”

The mural overlapped a huge circle with countless circles in it, with incomprehensible characters halfway between.

Various shapes such as triangles and pentagons, as well as circles, appeared, creating a strange and geometrical feeling.

I felt like I was peeping at an archaeological site. Then I saw a picture that was barely recognizable between the indescribable text and a list of shapes.

“...I think so.”

Ricdorian would recognize only the rose. One of them was a red rose, his family pattern. He lived in a mansion when he was young, so he must have seen it everywhere.

There were five roses in total.

The four roses were arranged in diamond or rhombus form.

I slowly raised my finger, pointing at the figures I could see.

“... red rose.”

In addition to the painting of rose painted with red dye, there were large red gems embedded in each petal.

Holy Sh*t!

I couldn't believe my eyes. They're real! Like, actually real. The jewels revealed a mysterious red color. But somehow, some of the jewels were broken or lost their light. From a distance, it looked like a rose that had lost a few petals.

“That jewel, how much will it cost?” I could feel my eyes widened as I asked him without deviation.

“...what?” He blinked at my nonsensical question.

...you shouldn't touch something that looks expensive. Too bad. Either way, I had a dream of a fortune for a while and disregarded it.

It's a strange place, and I couldn't imagine what would happen if I messed with it. One should know how to behave when ended up in odd places.

If truth be told, I was astonished by the sight of the jewels, but I pushed down the urge to grab one and behaved.

"There seems to be something strange next to the red rose."

In addition, there was a strange animal shape next to the rose, which was hard to recognize at first glance. It looks like a cat, but its ears are round and small. Its fur was gray with black spots and it had a very long tail.

I think I saw an animal like that a long time ago. What was it?

I asked Ricdorian, but he replied that he doesn't know.

"And next... Yellow rose?"

My finger traced down to the right. There are bright yellow roses. Unlike the red roses, the petals were wide open, as if they were in full bloom.

Not only this, but this yellow rose was wrapped with a shiny golden band. Red rose petals were embezzled as jewels, and this one looks shiny like it was covered with gold foil.

Like it was made of gold.

"I see. It's a snake."

Next to the yellow rose was a white snake wrapped in thorns and leaves. Roses and snakes. It was a strangely well-matched combination even though it was perceived to be unsuitable for each other.

Soon, my finger moved downwards and pointed at something once again. This time, it was a rose that was halfway opposite the red rose.

It's a black rose.

"...but doesn't that look a little weird?"

"I think it's ruined."

"Yes, that's what it looks like, right?"

The appearance of the black rose was slightly damaged, as Ricdorian, who had been silent, nodded.

Unlike other roses, which were in full bloom, this felt as if someone had haphazardly stuck it on the wall without the care they did with the others. It was so torn apart as if someone went as far as burning it to ashes. And as I looked at it, my heart pounded and I felt a strange sensation.

Furthermore, the jewel on the center of the black rose was shattered. If it had been in its original state, I was certain it would have been like a black diamond, which I could barely guess from the shattered pieces.

"...who could have possibly...broken it? Exactly! How does it feel like breaking something very exquisite as that?"

Someone who did it really doesn't value jewels, at all. Once again, I looked around the rose with a spooky feeling and saw an animal-like form around the black rose. Not only one, but two.

"An eagle on one side? Like a crow. Huh? And a cat? Is it Jaguar?"

The color of the rose and the animals beside it were in both dark color. In particular, the bird's wing was black, but its beak was curved like an eagle, making it difficult to know which species it was.

My fingers turned once again in almost one round. The rest of the side were occupied by white roses.

"Even the white roses are beginning to deteriorate..."

That's strange. The white rose was in half-bloom form, but the tight white mineral that was embedded in it, as if drawing a line, was stained with black spots. With this, anyone could tell that it was contaminated.

From afar, it was like a rose eaten by insects or pests or a rose that has withered. The interesting thing was that some of the minerals were slowly regaining their white light.

Like trying to regenerate itself.

A healing.

Chapter 96: The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (5)

Chapter 96 – The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (5)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler and Eyeful Solstice

It's loss of colors were in deep contrast with the original red-rose pieces from before. However, like the other roses, I noted that it was also accompanied by an animal.

The animal by the white rose had round ears, perched like the rose petals with it.

I couldn't help but trace my fingers lightly around the edges, circling all the way round the intricate design....

Finally my fingers stopped in the center of the magnificent piece...

The blue rose.

All four roses were interconnected with it, branching towards the middle.

"Huh, why is it like that?" I mumbled to myself, unable to stop the words from escaping.

There was no flower though, like someone had cut that part out, or even dug out the flower. All that remained in its wake were patches of thorny stems and leaves...

I only knew it was blue based on the remnant hue that was left on the edges where it once stood. Even the animal by the blue rose was gone, much like

the flower. All I knew was that it had a long body, and a long tail.

“Among all the roses here, the only ones that seemed to be in perfect condition are the yellow roses.” I mumbled to myself, before turning back to head towards Ricdorian.

When I finally reached within earshot, I immediately spoke up.

“Everything else but the yellow roses are damaged, aren’t they?” I asked, and he nodded.

“Yes.” he answered softly. His eyes gazed in my direction, before nodding, confirming his own suspicions, but he did not seem particularly interested, nor surprised really. In fact, I think we only stayed so long because I was keen on taking a tour around the whole place.

“What do you think happened to the other roses?” I asked him. Perhaps he could shed some light on the montage of flowers.

But Ricdorian did not offer me an answer, in fact, with the way he blankly blinked at me as we stared at each other, and tilted his head at my question made me retract my presumptions.

I don’t think he knew, and now I didn’t know what made me think otherwise as well.

I glanced back at the roses, eyeing the red rose in particular...

Rose...

The representation of an empire.

<Three things make this empire a cut above the other countries.>

This was it. The one Baron told me, the third thing that made the empire so special...

The roses with special abilities.

<There's a famous legend regarding these Roses, the five gates of the Empire, and what abilities these five great families have.>

I wonder what the chances are that this montage of roses and stone paintings are irrelevant to the story of the five families I've heard from Baron?

Not likely really.

Now that I remembered, Ricdorian's family was part of the roses, particularly the *red rose*.

Glancing back at the montage, most of the red roses' petals were adorned and embezzled with red jewels, though some of them appeared to have lost their majestic glints.

And above all, this only told me that Ricdorian must find his *companion* soon, before all the light has disappeared from the petals.

Should the petal's light fade completely, and fall to the floor, Ricdorian would die.

I couldn't help but muse... that part of the story was strangely familiar.

"Huh..." I tilted my head.

Then the heroine of the story belonged to the white rose. I glanced back, looking down at the speckled white beauty of a flower.

My eyes darted to the next rose, the black one. That would be Chaser's rose. But why did it look broken?

The image before me was very puzzling, hiding an intent with so much beauty, but so little information to go by...

I shook these thoughts out of my head. This doesn't concern me. It's not even part of any of my business, I shouldn't have to lose sleep over this. But that didn't help me feel any less uneasy.

This entire story revolved around this part of the world, around these characters. If by any chance they were telling me the story has been changed after all, then things might not go as I have expected them to be.

Like a butterfly effect. One small change can cause a chain of reactions. For now, I'll just have to keep in mind what was relevant to me, and what was beyond me.

My eyes darted around us, scanning the mural at one wall to another with a critical stare. I had initially thought we'd eventually find a way back to the cells when we reached this deadend, but the more I looked around the more I was convinced otherwise.

There was nothing to indicate that there was a way back here. Just the walls, the montage, and pillars...

"What should I do?" I thought to myself outloud.

If we stay here any longer, then Ricdorian's empty cell would be most likely discovered, and when that happens, more complications will arise.

My end goal here was to prevent the Archduke from visiting him, not prompt him a certain visit to this prison.

I took a deep breath. Panicking wouldn't help anyone in any situation. I glanced at my side, looking at Ricdorian, who was suddenly hunching in on himself, groaning, as if trying to imitate me...

I frowned.

No, that isn't it. What was wrong?

"Hey, you don't look so good. Why are you groaning?" I asked him. He shook his head, before turning back towards me.

"Hey, you look tired, Iana." he pointed out, "Oh, can I hug you?"

"What?"

I blinked my eyes. This guy just doesn't feel shame, does he? Who am I kidding, of course he doesn't. I scowled at him with exasperation.

But why would he ask something like that? Ofcourse, I was undeniably taken by surprise.

Now. I frowned.

“.Why don't you tell me what you're thinking about?” I finally asked him, partially amused by the blush on his face, “And you're so red, and you can't even make eye contact?” I pointed out in awe, “Ricdorian, look at me.”

“Well, still...” he stumbled on his words.

He shrugged his shoulders at me, looking sullenly while doing so. I couldn't help but think he was cute. Even so, that didn't mean I could stand the clumsiness, and immediately burst out into laughter.

And just as I did, something had caught my eye.

There on my wrist, a small and unassuming line.

The bracelet.

The bracelet Jair had given me had a soft white glow, immediately, I raised my hand to inspect it carefully.

“There's a light on the bracelet,” I whispered, glancing at it intently before I realized the light was leaning brightly in a certain way...

There was a small line of light, connecting right to his chain.

There must be some clue on the bracelet then, something it was trying to tell me. Possibly the way back.

Immediately my feet moved, walking towards the pillars where the chain was leading me to...

Ricdorian sputtered behind me.

“Iana-” he began to call out. I almost forgot he was there.

“Don’t move, Ricdorian,” I told him, the command coming out harsher than I intended, “Just, stand there for a while.”

He did as I had asked with minimal protest, and I quickly closed the distance between me and my destination. I stopped in front of a pillar, the chain lying still on the ground in front of me. Crouching down, I lifted the chains, and almost buckled beneath its weight.

Then I looked carefully at the part that connected the chain. I don’t think the bracelet pointed at this side for no reason. Instead of just staring at it, I carefully let the bracelet touch it.

Boom!

The ground shook. I quickly widen my eyes. What the hell was that? I turned to look back at the bracelet, hoping it’ll give me more clues where to go...

But the bracelet had already reached the end of the light.

Boom!

The ground shook wildly.

Chapter 97: The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (6)

Chapter 97 – The Genre Has Changed All Of A Sudden? (6)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler and Eyeful Solstice

What is it? An earthquake? Is it really an earthquake? This is crazy! It felt very strong and powerful.

I hesitated as soon as I looked back at Ricdorian with a puzzled look.

“Ricdorian?”

With his upper body bent, he held his stomach in both hands, groaning. I rushed to him, forgetting the earthquake.

“Ricdorian, Ricdorian! Are you sick? Are you okay? Come on, stay with me!”

He was fine a little while ago. Then, in a flash, he was suffering from a cold sweat. His lips were swollen and it felt like he was running out of breath.

All the same, the ground was still shaking.

Should I have not let it touch the bracelet then? What was I supposed to do?! I was blaming myself for it, but I knew a solution wouldn't come out just because I blamed myself.

“Ricdorian, don't pass out now. We still have to go back!”

The shaking ground was rocking greatly beneath our feet, making us tumble out of balance..

Wasn't this a very old place? Somehow, it seemed to be not strong. But if it collapses here, it's all over for us as well!

I felt something strange when I was shaking his body. What?

The body of the Ricdorian... I think it's gotten a little bigger than before. I blinked my eyes a couple times just to make sure I wasn't just imagining it. This was not an illusion.

His face, which I slowly raised, had longer hair than before and covered its forehead and eyes slightly.

There was a languid blinking eye between the half-sweaty hair. And as soon as it peered into mine, I felt my eyes abruptly squint.

"Master."

I bit my lips, stifling in a gasp of surprise.

What did he just say?

Does he still have enough strength to play a joke in this serious situation? No, that's not right. He'd been in pain before. He must be hallucinating.

"No, it's Iana, my name." I corrected him.

I quickly grabbed him by the hem of his shirt. I could swear he got heavier this time, as I surrendered pulling him up when I realized it's no use. I could barely lift him up before, I definitely couldn't now.

"We don't have time for that, get up." I told him urgently.

It didn't matter what personality he has today, I had to take him out of this place. We have to get out of here, and go back to his cell...

No, everything will be alright. I tried to convince myself.

Thud. Thud.

The stones began to fall from the ceiling. I don't know why the ceiling's trying to collapse all of a sudden, but this place is absolutely falling apart.

I glanced back to look at the bracelet on my wrist once more, but I hadn't had the chance to when he quickly engulfed mine with his hand.

“Are you worried about me?”

The thinning slits in his eyes were oddly beautiful to look at, as if it was an angel that fell from heaven, but there was no time to indulge in it.

“Now, I don't have time for it!”

“Please! Wake up, didn't you hear that?” I said, then he grinned.

I couldn't help but be incensed with his reaction. He didn't seem to look worried or afraid that we're gonna end up dead covered by piles of stones.

“Ricdorian! What is wrong with you?!”

He kept grinning as if the chaos around the wrecking place doesn't bother him at all. He finally spoke after noticing my fury.

“What? What is it, Iana?”

I did not give him an answer. I was so frustrated by what's happening that I didn't know what to do. What's worse, is that Ricdorian doesn't seem like himself — that part of him who always listens to anything I say.

I buried my head into my palms as I was about to give up.

There's no way we're getting out of here, I thought.

The next thing that happened took me by surprise.

Both of Ricdorian's arms came up over my shoulders. My mind went blank when I felt the weight of his arms coming up around me.

It was oddly comforting as well.

“Can you come over?”

“Really, I’ve got a bad word coming out of my mouth, you want me to say it?”

Why is he being like this? I thought I should tear up a cloth and keep my mouth shut, but Ricdorian jumped off from his seat.

His hand pulled me hard, and my vision shook. When I opened my eyes, I leaned into the arms of Ricdorian. There was a pretty big stone away from where I was.

“...you see? It’s an emergency.” I said.

We have to get out of here quickly, I whispered as if he could not hear me. Furthermore, my heart thumped at the sight of the stone.

Oh, was my voice too small? A warm hand clasped my hand before I could even open my mouth.

“Okay.”

He smiled playfully, in a saintly manner.

“I’ll listen to anything you say.”

He said so, and then suddenly lifted my body... Why are you lifting me up?

“Wait, what’s the connection with listening and lifting?”

“You told me, didn’t you? Hold the heavy ones. You are heavy, Iana.”

“Huh, you seem to remember something different. But I’m not that heavy! Hmm!”

With our faces getting closer, I hurriedly closed my lips and bent my head. His arm didn’t fall into the barrel that held me tight, but he wasn’t even that

far from me. Instead of being embarrassed, Ricdorian closed his eyes and smiled beautifully.

“Oh, what a waste.”

As his lowered voice flowed into my ears...*Thump-thump*...I couldn't tell if it was my heartbeat or his own coming from his chest.

“Oh, never mind. Once you heard, run, come on!”

Rush.

Vibrations kept ringing on his chest as he spoke. Ricdorian turned his body as if he had been waiting for a cue.

“As per command.”

Master... don't forget the title that you used to make fun of me. To my surprise, he held me in his arms and ran with a torch in his hand.

In addition, chains unbelievably stretched out on his neck, hands and legs. As he was running, I peeked at the back to see the shaking ground behind us. It gave me goose bumps to see the walls and the floor split.

“...somehow it feels like the passage is closing.”

“You must not have seen it wrong.” He answered. Ricdorian murmured in a low, serious voice.

“The front passage is also narrowing. Hurry!”

If he's running, we'll be right. Because he was a much better man than I was.

“What should I do, Master?”

His voice sounded as if he was having leisure at this moment. He doesn't seem scared.

But my fears have been growing and growing as Ricdorian was running. The entire place is completely falling apart, and I've been hoping we make it in time before we get closed in and trapped for good. We tried hard to get rid of the tension and exchanged trivial conversations. But the next thing was the main point.

"Can I run faster, Master?" He asked.

"Of course you can... and yeah, I think you should." I answered.

At that, I glanced toward his leg, then I looked ahead. There was still no sign of an end for this bluish-blinking corridor. I couldn't help but feel worried about him. Surely, he must be feeling worn out.

"...I mean, can you?!" I asked him in a loud, almost shouting voice, to hide my worry. Clearly, he wouldn't possibly hear me if I kept my voice down to myself.

"Shouldn't we try?" Ricdorian laughed languidly.

"Yes, we should. We have to go back. We can't stop now." I said those words in a delicate, encouraging tone. Surely, he needs them now. It's the least I could do, with him carrying me around.

Ricdorian still daubed that languid look on his face. Then, the words that came out of his mouth gave me a sudden relish elation.

"To save Iana."

Chapter 98: It's Time To Eat The Candy (1)

Chapter 98 – It's Time To Eat The Candy (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler and Eyeful Solstice

“...Haha! Come on, don't make such a joke.”

I had never thought about ending my life in a cell, would never have imagined myself dying in a place like this.

It's too... lonely.

Especially if you were to die in this cell, and none would be any wiser if you did. This is not a place I would choose to die in, nor do I wish such fate to anyone.

“Let me hold this thing.” I tapped the torch in his hands. The torch's light was blazing wildly and majestically swerved as Ricdorian moved.

“If I hold it like this, you can see well ahead, right?” Ricdorian, who was running forward, turned to me for a moment with an unrecognizable gaze, as he passed the torch on my hand.

“It's certainly a possibility.” I added. .

Of course, I didn't really get to see his face clearly with this position. Nonetheless, I could tell that he was serious, judging from the tone of his voice. That's why I added a sentence playfully.

“Don't worry, I'll be the light beside you with this in my hands.”

I patted the glass dome and said those words so sweetly— as if we were the main characters of a spectacular movie. But he never answered back...he just ignored my words. He's so focused on running.

Because of the awkward atmosphere surrounding us, I looked up at him and was startled. Right now, the man carrying me who was running nonstop, had his eyes fixated on me.

“Ricdorian! Front, look in front!” I screamed.

“Iana.” A deep, low-sounding voice called me.

“Do you intend to keep your words?” he asked me, and I couldn't help but feel confused.

What does he mean? Word?!

I didn't tilt my head nor did I nod. The situation right now was very dire for me to respond too soon. Nevertheless, he smiled and faced forward to what seemed to be an endless path.

But I was so surprised that I opened my eyes wide. He was running at a completely different speed than before— it was as if he was just warming up earlier.

“...you're light, Iana.” I heard Ricdorian mutter, but I couldn't take it lightly.

As a matter of fact, he was just 16 years old. His body was still that of a teenage boy. But wasn't I told that his body was forced to mature?...for the awakening that was supposed to happen in the future.

That's what Jair explained to me.

So isn't it a burden for him to use the power that was supposed to come out in the future? He was supposed to take it slow.

There were things that supported this. One of which was that Ricdorian, after undergoing some changes on his body, would always end up hot and

feverish.

And it was also on my mind...the way he ran right now was somewhat impossible for a normal being to do. He should have been exhausted by now, or should have been desperately gasping for air, but he wasn't. He's as pristine as just before he started running. It's as if no trace of energy has been stripped from him at all.

But there was no other way to proceed. This was the best possible solution we can get. It was faster for Ricdorian to carry me while leaving this place, if nothing else goes wrong, no one would be any the wiser we even left the cell for a while.

I gently bit my lips, clasping the torch with one hand and holding his chest with the other.

Not long after, I finally saw the end of the corridor.

"There!" I screamed. However, at that same time, a loud noise was heard from behind.

Creak. Creak.

It was a very peculiar sound and somehow, I think I've heard something like it before.

Curious as I was, I decided to look over his shoulder and was blown away by the scene behind us, making me open my mouth wider than before.

The passage's really closing, right?

I took another glance just to make sure what I'm seeing was real. It really was closing. Literally. The corridor was disappearing behind us. The wall was narrowing from afar, and the path disappeared after the walls collided with each other.

"Ric..Ricdorian, fas..faster!"

His feet got faster, as if he had noticed the urgency of my voice.

Dash!

Clank! Clank!

In addition, the chains on his body sounded rough against the ground.

Just a little bit, just a little more...! Please!

And as soon as the wall reached us...*echo! echo!*

A huge reverberation pulsed through my eardrums. It was so intense that I was not even sure if we made it. The ringing lasted for about a minute, making it difficult for me to figure out if we're saved.

I couldn't even feel the soreness of my back. I just breathed heavily and looked through the area where the dusts from the closing walls started to settle.

"Haa..haa! The hole, it's gone. We made it!" I said, in between breaths.

There was no hole in my sight, anymore. It was just the wall. The same wall where Ricdorian's chains were fixed. It was as if nothing ever happened.

Slowly blinking my eyes, I soon met Ricdorian's gaze.

He stared at me just like what he had always done and didn't even look at the wall. Even so, he wasn't bothered by the fact that the hole was gone.

"...have you seen it?" I queried but he just tilted his head slowly.

And with that, I burst out laughing.

No way! Am I the only one who's surprised here?, I thought to myself.

Ever since I got here, this was something that's been bugging me greatly. This was, for sure, the major incident I've ever been to.

How could he be so indifferent on the things that were too overwhelming for me?

I stopped at the thought and turned my eyes on the ground, blankly. Then suddenly, I felt something from my pocket. Fortunately, the things I brought here were still in my pocket. And when I took my watch out, it took my breath away.

There was no time. No, the time has passed so long. Then, I continued to grab for more things from my pocket, scanning for some items that might help us out.

As I looked at Ricdorian, I could tell that his other personality came back because he's looking like an innocent saint right now. Moreover, the hair that grew on his face earlier became shorter.

"Well, well. Look who's here! When did you come back?"

"What are you saying, Iana? I've been here since earlier." He said jokingly, but then lowered down his head. Not long after, he looked at me.

It was easy to discern when I was interacting with a rational Ricdorian. The key was in eye contact. If he was feeling rational, he would have difficulty looking at someone's eye when talking to them.

I prefer the times when he had to look down, and I thought it would be easy for me to handle this side of him. It's always easier to deal with someone who looks more human and less monstrous, and someone who doesn't look at you straight in the eye.

But of course, his handsomeness was as burdensome as ever. I could say if angels were ever true, his face would be an example on how they would look like. Sometimes, I got the tendency to wallow in his dreamy face. Angelic, ethereal, and dainty.

"...Could you please stop showing your face to me?"

"Huh."

"Well, don't answer." I winced and pushed his chest to create some distance between us but he was so fast that he was able to seize my hand.

I sighed slowly as I glanced at my hand that he was holding. Then he raised his hand and pulled me closer to his chest in one quick motion.

Chapter 99: It's Time To Eat The Candy (2)

Chapter 99 – It's Time To Eat The Candy (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler and Eyeful Solstice

I then began to remember the events that've been unfolding today; the walls disappearing into thin air, the dark path opened up for us...

I was reeling at the continuous disturbances we've been encountering. And now, the path was disappearing this time, as the walls began to resurface as falling rocks, mending itself back together, finally concealing the hidden path we took.

I don't know how this commotion would sound outside this cell right now, but...whether it would be a minuscule vibration or an evident earthquake, everything may have been detected.

And as of now, I had to do what I came here for as quickly as possible because I have no time left.

What I was trying to do was to make Ricdorian sick to prevent Archduke Harnim from visiting him in this prison.

Not long after, I looked up and faced him. I wanted to talk to the sensible side of him as much as possible. Soon, I reached out and grabbed him by the hem of his clothes.

"Listen carefully." I said.

Ricdorian put his hands over my enclosed fists that were holding the hem of his shirt. Then, he tapped my hands lightly and slowly, observing them like a scientist looking at a specimen on a petri dish. He deliberately nodded his head afterwards.

“You always hold it like this. My clothes... you do it so well.” I added.

...where on earth did I learn this gesture? In a trice, I forgot the situation and was curious of what I was doing, but this was not what was relevant right now.

I looked awkwardly at my clenched hands and quickly raised my line of sight, looking straight into his eyes.

“I’m going to do a bad deed from now on. It doesn’t matter if you won’t forgive me.”

It’s been a long time since I’ve been hesitating whether to do this kind of thing or not. So I deliberately emphasized the words ‘**bad deeds**’ to Ricdorian, who was in his rational state right now. Because if he would say no, then I wouldn’t do it.

But things have changed. The earthquake or shaking just a while ago may have reached the people outside, especially the concerned officials, so it seemed like I have to go ahead and do it.

“Bad deed? What bad deed?” He asked and stared at me in silence.

The dim light of the torch painted a shadow on his nose. Then, I took something out of my pocket and held it out to him. And remembered the two things that Jair had given me.

One was the magic tool, an upgraded bracelet.

The other one is... “Candy?”

“Yes, it’s candy.”

It was a candy. I'd say it's a special candy with an intricate spell of Jair's magic. But Ricdorian didn't have to know about that. All I needed to do was to make him eat this right now.

<Do you know any snack he wants?>

When Jair asked me that, I had no idea how he would cast the magic, and I never thought it would be casted on any of the snacks I would suggest. Of course, it was between cookies and candy for Ricdorian. As both were his favorites.

"Eat this candy."

"What is this?"

"Just eat it."

I pulled him and his knuckled hand. He's definitely much bigger than me, but he's drawn to me easily as if he was waiting for me to give him the snack.

"This candy will make you suffer if you eat it." I wasn't lying when I said those. After all, there was no need to deceive him or even reason out.

Not long after, I decided to pull him, but instead he came closer to me.

"Pain." Ricdorian mumbled.

He was so close that I could hear his breath because he was standing right in front of me.

"Oh, aside from being sick...Will Iana stay with me?" He added.

I could feel my heart thumping wildly from the way our hands clasped with each other. He doesn't look out of breath, despite the rigorous activity he'd done. He hadn't even broken out in sweat either, rather, there was a pleasant scent wafting through, tickling my nose.

"Me...compliment me." Ricdorian stated.

“Compliment?” I asked, not aware of his reason.

“I called you Iana, not master.” He said. And his breath has this pure fragrance that was no different from his other personalities. But as he spoke, there was a certain huskiness in his tone.

I felt strange, it was as if a little stick was piercing one side of my heart.

“If I eat that, will you stay with me?”

I gave him a relentless look but that didn’t make him tremble. And therefore, I nodded slowly. Then, his blue eyes grew a little bigger, and soon his irises were as deep as the sea.

“Really?”

“...yes, but only until you get better.” I answered.

Jair said this magic won’t make him sick for so long. In that case, I would have the right amount of time to nurse him until the day of my release. That’s what I thought.

But his face flashed a hint of disappointment. It was only for a short time, but I didn’t miss the chance to witness it.

“And then what?” He asked.

“I-Um” I stuttered.

I could feel his breath right in front of my lips.

“Are you leaving me?”

My hands trembled but it was quickly dwindled by the hand that was holding me, securing them, and keeping them from shaking. It was like he was pouring into me his strength through our intertwined hands. But this thing, it was too much for me to take. Yeah. That’s right. I just remembered one of his personalities.

I rolled my eyes and gave out a heavy sigh. I have to face him and tell him what he needs to hear. There was really no point in being untruthful.

“That’s right. I’m leaving.”

My release date was beyond my control. Because from the beginning, I said I was here for my family’s sins, not mine. Neither my admission nor my release was as I wanted, but the fact that I was going out of this prison was still very important for me.

“But I promise.”

I didn’t avoid his eyes. I kept looking at the deep azure pair of orbs in front of me, as if I wanted to float in them. However, I slowly turned my gaze into a cold glare, to make him think that I am being serious.

“I’m not leaving until you’re all better. I swear.”

This is also a matter of my responsibility. At the very least it was my decision to get myself involved with Ricdorian, and therefore I had to finish it. This was all because of my inquisitive personality. The smell of curiosity easily persuades me.

“I’ll be by your side.”

Ricdorian was thinking. He was taking his time looking downwards. Then he rolled his eyes at a slow pace.

“Well, fine.” He said.

The beast version, the rational side, and the adult side of him all had their childish facets. When I get satisfied, I used to smile the way he smiles right now. But my concern was that I couldn’t figure out what his curved lips meant at this moment.

Not long after, he conversed.

“Give it to me.”

“...okay.” I said those words slowly, holding out my hand, ready to give him the candy casted with magic.

“With your lips.”

“Okay... what?”

So taken aback by what he just said, I shot him an affronted look, but when I looked at him, I could tell he was serious. He looked at me intensely, lips pursed in expectation...

“With your lips. Feed me, Iana.”

Chapter 100: It's Time To Feed The Candy (1)

Chapter 100 – It's Time To Feed The Candy (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

The grip I had on the candy tightened up until my knuckles turned white. What was wrong with him? And just what does he think he's doing?!

The only thing left in my mind was how ridiculous the things he was spouting on about right now.

This was all nonsense!

Right?

Of course I couldn't allow this to continue.

I was well aware by now that my face had settled into a frown. I must stand my ground. I will refuse...

But then he looked up at the ceiling, with eyes like a beast, before he shot up to his feet, as if trying to mark his territory. I could see, from my point of view, that there was a dangerous glint in his eye...

Maybe he heard something from the floor above us. That is why he looked up to see what it was about.

"Oh, I think someone's coming." He muttered, following the sounds as it moved. I turned back to him.

“What?” I asked in slight alarm, “People?”

“Yes.” Ricdorian nodded, he then closed his eyes, his eyeballs darting back and forth beneath his eyelids. I could tell he was trying to listen to something...

“There could be three of them, no,” he murmured, eyes still closed, before he opened them up, “There’s a lot of them up there.”

My eyes darted back up at the ceiling.

It’s quite obvious that I didn’t hear anything. I could only hear the silence in the cell. But I knew Ricdorian had sharp senses. He couldn’t be wrong with this, especially with what I’ve seen him do before. He’s less likely to make stories up now.

I bit my lower lips at the thought of people headed our way. But why? Why were people on their way here? Usually it was just the lone senior guard making his rounds before going back to stand guard by the entrance of the prison cell.

I remember him telling me once that Lenag had specifically assigned him here because there was no immediate danger, and quite comfortable.

Perhaps it was just a delay in the motions, and was just reaching them now? It could be because there was nothing much happening at this section. But one thing was for sure, I was beginning to get impatient.

I could feel the nervous thumping of my heart threatening to burst out!

If guards really were on their way here, then that would mean time was running out. Ricdorian must become sick by the time they arrive!

That way the guards would see for themselves that Ricdorian isn’t fit for the Archduke’s visit.

“What shall I do, Master?” Ricdorian asked me.

My fidgeting continued, my thumb running circles over my palm as I thought of what to do quickly. Meanwhile as I was doing this, my gaze trailed off to Ricdorian's, seeing the smoothed lines of the calluses of his palms...

The urgency splurged me on, and clutched onto the candy resolutely as I turned to him and thrust it his way.

"Come on, eat this quickly." I told him, and he looked at it with slight apprehension.

"Why should I?" he asked me.

Unfortunately I neither had time nor luxury to explain to him in detail why for I heard a distinct click off a distance...

I could hear the footsteps now. The sound of hinges creaking, and the iron door sliding across the floor.

"I think they opened the door." I murmured.

I remembered the way down clearly. They'd pass through a long spiral staircase first. It took me a long time to walk down here, and therefore it'll take a while for them to reach down here.

I turned back, whipping my head at Ricdorian, eyes darting between him and the candy. Why doesn't he eat it yet?

Steps. Steps.

The echoes of the steps rang throughout the desolate cell. Whether it had been heightened by tension and nervousness, or purely hallucination on my part, I couldn't care less. It didn't change the fact that I needed to hurry.

I doubt that even if I was to shove the candy down his throat he would swallow it by the time they'd arrive.

He has no idea of the gravity of this situation. But I couldn't explain. If I do, he'll demand more answers, which would take me a longer time, which

I don't have presently.

Frustrated, I gripped the collar of his shirt, fisting it in my hands. He then straightened up, as he looked down on me with his imposing figure.

My mind's made up and I looked at him resolutely.

"You, won't regret it."

This was it. I brought this on myself.

For so long I've been a coward, never wanting to get myself involved because I shouldn't be. But then he'd look at me with such an innocent expression...

His eyes are full of trust in me...

I found myself at a loss for words. When faced with such innocence, what could I say? I don't deserve to look at him like this...

But now is not the time for it. Nodding to myself, I squared my shoulders and looked at the candy still in my hand.

I plopped the candy into my mouth immediately, and pulled Ricdorian down facing me.

"Open your mouth." I told him, and wasted no time in pulling our lips together.

Just right before I closed my eyes, I saw his eyes widened in realization. The moment I closed my eyes, I could feel his lips more clearly against mine.

"Ugh."

I pushed the candy past my lips to his with the help of my tongue...

And when it did, the candy had begun to melt, as if recognizing this was the mouth meant to house it. Once that was done, I began to pull away, but a

firm arm wrapped me around my waist and pulled me closer...

“Well, uh...uh..uh.” I protested weakly.

The grip around me was stronger than I had anticipated, Immediately he pulled me along with him, settling me on top of him until I was seated on one of his thighs...

I was rendered speechless by our proximity. I felt thoroughly embarrassed by this whole ordeal.

My eyes shot up and I was startled when I realized Ricdorian was staring right at me. I had wanted to convey my wish to be released, but I folded, giving into his desire...

And the kiss between us deepened. I could feel my breath slowly leaving me the more we continued.

Ricdorian was rough and insistent against my lips, my heart thudding wildly against my chest. The blood was rushing to my head, as I felt dizzy.

It didn't feel like Ricdorian was trying to trick me, it just felt awkward. But in some ways, I couldn't help but think what a skilled kisser he was.

His hands brushed up against the small of my back, my toes curling up at the touch...

But no...

I must focus.

Had the candy finally melted?

My hands found purchase on his shoulder, as I tilted my head sideways to listen more to the sounds outside his prison cell...

Steps. Steps.

They were significantly louder than before. They've gotten closer.

Chapter 101: It's Time To Feed The Candy (2)

Chapter 101 – It's Time To Feed The Candy (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

I pushed my tongue past his lips, for which he greedily accepted, and sought out the candy...

I managed to snag a feel of it, and frowned. It's been melted halfway already.

That was quicker than I thought.

Jair had given me instructions to make sure this candy would be melted and eaten fully by Ricdorian. Doing this sort of stunt might have complicated things, but it's not like I had much of a choice.

I had asked Jair to make it as painless as possible, and though I'm sure Jair had tried his best to meet my demands, it was a difficult task to accomplish.

"Hah, ha..."

I was trying to think of something else, when suddenly Ricodrian moved, pulling me up against him...

Shallow ragged breaths echoed in the cell, but most of it I knew had come from me. Ricdorian finally pulled away, eyes never leaving me as he wiped the stray saliva with the back of his hand. I could see the corners of his mouth quirk up with a smirk as he lowered his face closer to my ears...

“When it’s this good, how could I refuse?” he whispered huskily.

“Wh- What?” I flushed.

“How do you call it Iana?” he asked her, “That urge to break it just because you like it?”

“I don’t know,” I gulped, “Call it whatever you want.”

Our voices were equally hoarse from the kiss...

“Do you like it like that?” he asked me, “Doing whatever you want when you go crazy?”

His eyes were hypnotizing. I feel the strength leave my body as I lost the strength to push him away. My lips felt a little chapped, unconsciously I licked them in anticipation before he surged forward and captured my lips into another bruising kiss.

I moaned as I felt his tongue sweep the insides of my mouth. The movement of his lips only served to make me reeled in to ask for more...

It was just a kiss, but somehow I felt like he was devouring me instead.

Step. Step.

The sound was getting closer still, and I remembered why I went to kiss him. My tongue slipped into his mouth, battling for dominance as I tried to look for it...

Did the candy melt fully already?

But he was moving his lips and tongue so much, I can’t sense it properly, or quickly. I placed my hands on both sides of his cheeks and held him firmly in place...

“Wait a minute, just stay put.” I huffed out urgently.

I couldn't even reach further in to check it. I changed the way I tilted my head to reach deeper, and at the same time, I felt arms tighten around my waist....

Wait.

Does his shoulders seem lower than before? I thought in confusion. I tried to think back and was certain. He was positioned higher before...

Then that meant...

Suddenly I reached the end, and continued my examination...

Finally, the candy was gone. But that did nothing to abate the flush on my cheeks as I realized what I had done. And then I heard a moan...

That wasn't mine either.

I pulled away and stifled in a gasp of surprise. I was right, he'd gotten smaller.

"Ric..Ricdorian?" I hesitantly called out, and then our eyes met.

Gone was the intense predatory gaze from before, and in its place was a teary eyed boy. The rational Ricdorian was back, I felt relief flood my body. But when did he change back?

I could sense tears were threatening to fall from his eyes, and so I attempted to fall back, but his hand shot towards me, clinging needily onto my arms...

"No! Don't go!" he pleaded. "Please, don't go." his face was blushing red, like a lost child that has no idea what to do next. I tried to pull away, but he hung on tightly, refusing to let me go, "Wait, don't!" I protested, "You'll fall." I added. But then, he pulled me flush against him...

Our breaths mingled as he gazed at me...

And before I knew it, we were kissing again.

Compared to the previous kiss, this one seemed more awkward than lust-inducing...

But it made my heart beat in a different way than the previous kiss did. Our eyes were closed, our lips pressing up against each other that it was more of a peck than a kiss. But I feared if I were to open my eyes now, I'd be damning myself to something I couldn't return from...

"...after."

I murmured, my trembling hands brushing up to touch his needle-like soft hair. But just as I moved my hand up, I was barred by the chain fastened onto his neck.

His father, Archduke Harnim, had ordered for such restraints on his son. A restraint that could only be undone by the heroine of the story, whom he would someday meet...

My fingers opted to brush up against the cold, hard metal instead...

I wonder if I could do it...

My fingers tapped against. For a moment, I thought I heard a clicking sound, daring the restraint to break open and fall uselessly as it freed Ricdorian...

But it was all just wishful thinking. Silly musings from a silly girl.

Step. Step.

They were closer now! Immediately, I managed to successfully pull myself away from him. Unfortunately, I hadn't accounted for the strength I pushed him with, nor the way he was bracing himself on anything and promptly fell back down with a painful thud!

"Ricdorian!" I gasped in alarm. He did not stir, not even in pain. He just lied there, limp.

Did he faint? I crouched down beside him, shaking his shoulders urgently, “Ricdorian? Are you awake?” I asked, but I received no response.

I brought a hand up to touch his forehead and felt relief flood into me.

He was burning up, which meant the spell was doing its work. Finally!

But it did nothing to appease the distaste I had in witnessing him suffer, and knowing I had done so deliberately. I moved him back to lie down more comfortably than he did before, and just as I finished, the footsteps stopped, and were replaced with a screeching sound coming from the bars being pried open...

A single man stepped inside, looking purposefully at me.

“Ms. Iana.” It was the senior guard I was familiar with. But why was he here? No one else but one only entered this place, “Ms. Iana?” he repeated, and I realized I never acknowledged him.

“Ah, yes?” I asked, not really interested in what he wanted to say, too lost in thought.

“I’m afraid to inform you that your visit will be cut short.” he informed me almost sheepishly. I blinked. No one usually bothered to tell me where or when to leave, often leaving me to decide so for myself.

As if sensing my confusion, he decided to elaborate.

“You’ve been summoned Ms. Iana.” he told her.

“Summoned?”

“Yes, the prison head guard has summoned you.”

Lenag called for me. That was understandable then. Every guard listened to Lenag as if he was the word incarnate of the heavens.

“Please follow me.” he gently prompted and I nodded.

“Of course.” I replied, standing up, before I caught sight of the ceiling once more...

Strange. I see only one.

“Uh, excuse me,” I called out to him and tilted my head, “You wouldn’t happen to hear anything strange a while ago, did you?”

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Chapter 102: Those People Who Think Of You (1)

Chapter 102 – Those People Who Think Of You (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

“Hear anything strange?” the guard tilted his head.

“Yes, like the ground shaking or something. Even rocks falling not far from here. Like an unexpected occurrence? Anyway... I know it sounds a little weird.” I said.

“Well, I don’t know... ..I’ve been at the entrance all this time, but I never felt anything like that at all.” The guard stated.

The guard scoured Ricdorian’s prison cell as he was talking, and grappled the metal buckle of his belt as he walked slowly back and forth. His eyes were scanning the entire place as if looking for something hidden. All the while, he displayed a plain suspicious look on his face.

“Well, it’s deep underground, so the sound of the water chamber wall falling apart and the sound of some small stones falling down would make a loud sound. I understand that you might be surprised. It’s a cave here after all.” The guard added.

Following his eyes, I saw a huge and deep hollow. Within it was a puddle that didn’t dry out since the last rain. There were some pretty large stones next to it which was probably a result of the successive wall-splitting and wall-colliding that had happened here.

Well, I guess I was just too conscious of what took place here.

I didn't say another word. If I say any more things, the guard might get more suspicious. I tried to make myself relax and took some time to calm my breathing.

Right now, everything made sense to me...nothing was detected outside, right? Hmm, it seemed so, given the guard's reaction and response.

Clearly, the earth tremor was remarkable and intense. Scores of gigantic stones fell from the ceiling and even from the walls. Even if we were all the way down here, that doesn't mean that people from the outside wouldn't know about that. They surely must have felt even a little vibration. I'm pretty sure of that.

Suddenly, my eyes diverted back to where the deep hollow was... and thought to myself '*What in the world is going on here?*'

I blinked my eyes repeatedly and even shook my head a little briskly, to register in my brain what I just witnessed. Now the place where the giant hole opened was now just a plain wall. Everything that's been happening in this prison cell has never failed to blow my mind. I'm surprised I never had headaches from all of these things.

What the hell is this...this cell? I thought.

While my head was rumbling with countless questions that were still left unanswered, I struggled to keep my composure. The guard must not be given any slight clue of the mysteries Ricdorian and I witnessed down here. I had to keep myself together.

Please try to relax, relax. Calm down and breathe. I thought.

"Ms. Iana?" The guard called, whisking me out of my jumbled thoughts. I quivered at his call, trying to pretend that I was feeling a little somnolent.

"Oh, yes." I turned my head at the call. And smiled slightly at a guard with a puzzled face.

“I’m going to have to leave you now. I have to go back outside. Everything seems perfectly fine down here. These falling debris are normal, given that you’re underground.” The guard suggested, and turned his back at us as he was about to leave.

“Wait! I’m going. I’m... and uh, by the way...” I said to the guard and he turned his head as soon as he heard my call.

“What is it?” He asked.

I held Ricdorian’s hand slightly out of sight to the guard. I don’t know if he’s awake or exhausted, or if he’s fainted. But for sure, I wasn’t going to break my promise with him anymore. Because once is enough.

“I think this prisoner is very sick.” I spoke. “He has a very high fever.” I lowered my eyes with a wistful expression.

“He was with me, and he suddenly collapsed and...” I added.

The guard took some time looking at me and at Ricdorian as if he could not believe it. As soon as he let out a deep sigh, he held his chin, thinking, and made a grim face.

“Oh... that’s a big deal. He is a prisoner who needs special care.” He uttered.

The guard was rubbing his chin this time as if he was really having a hard time.

“Well, for now, I’ll report this to the superiors. Can you wait for me?” He added.

“Yes, I’ll wait here.” I answered, giving the guard a hopeful nod.

I tried to hide my smile inside as I continued to nod at the guard, and turned to look at Ricdorian. It would have been good for me if he would report this to Lenag. But the most important thing, for now, was for the guard to report this right away.

This was what Jair and I had talked about. He told me very specific instructions. Jair also said that it is very important that this should be heard by those with higher positions.

The guard moved away as soon as silence broke into the air between us. I kept holding my breath until I saw that he had climbed the stairs completely.

The breath that I held for the longest time finally escaped my lungs as I exhaled it out of my mouth and nostrils. I imagined it spreading throughout the prison cell, even though I could not see it at all.

I gave out a giggle—almost laugh while listening to the echo of my breathing resonating back towards me. Soon, I turned my sight and looked at Ricdorian, who breathed laborly and violently. The sight of him makes me sad and feel sorry.

“... I kept my word, didn’t I?” I patted his palm and held his white fingertips short. I could feel a little heat from them. His fever must be getting really serious.

I felt his fingertips twitch. He must be having a bad dream. I felt a pang of worry at the back of my head. Then, I exhaled for a long time. I moved my hand from his fingertips to his forehead. I rested my palm deliberately on his forehead drenched with sweat.

It was scalding hot, as if I was holding a kettle fresh from the cinder.

But I resisted from the burning sensation for a while. I must have only imagined it being too hot. Then, I let go as soon as I couldn’t take it anymore. He must be feeling literally like hell. No wonder his breathing seemed unpleasant and throbbing.

“Hang in there, Iana. You’ve passed this task over.” I whispered in a hushed tone.

With everything that has happened, I could see the next thing coming: I will be the male lead’s caretaker... and I’m getting a hang of it.

XX

The plan that Jair and I schemed had worked perfectly. Archduke Harnim gave up his visit. Of course, the news didn't come to me right away, but Lenag gave me the announcement.

Furthermore, the guard who ran to us that day seemed to have delivered the news very well. In the meantime, Ricdorian's state was examined immediately from head to toe. Every little bit of progress would directly be reported to Lenag.

I stood in the corner of the prison cell now full of guards. I looked at them one by one, each displaying serious looks on their faces.

One of them was probing Ricdorian, as if he was a little boy patching a broken toy. He even changed Ricdorian's worn out shirt that was torn on all edges.

In spite of myself being too uptight about Ricdorian's condition, I have seen the problems being resolved quickly, but I couldn't tell that he's getting any better.

On another note, I never thought their system was better than I imagined. Here, having just two harmless-looking prisoners like Ricdorian and I, they still managed to allocate a number of guards down here to watch us, and there would be a couple more guards outside, waiting to spot a deserter.

They were not even just guards. They look like real knights or soldiers. They looked really scary to me. If anyone tries to escape this prison, they will surely be caught immediately.

As days went by, I managed to take care of Ricdorian. There were guards to do that, but still, I insisted on doing most of the task of taking care of him. Because I didn't want to break the promise this time. This will probably be my last promise to him, so I better not break it.

Chapter 103: Those People Who Think Of You (2)

Chapter 103 – Those People Who Think Of You (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

“Hmm...” Ricdorian would mutter between his breaths and I could tell he was really struggling.

His fever was very high and his body was sore everywhere and he would groan from time to time. Even the guards that would come down to look at him would say that his condition has become worse and very serious for any of them to medicate. And when I couldn't stand it, I didn't think twice to contact Jair right away.

The day Jair and I talked was the day that only Ricdorian and I were alone in the prison cell. The moment he answered, my fury came rattling up... and so I finally blew my temper.

“You said he wouldn't get sick too much, right? What the hell!” I told him, almost shouting.

“I'm sure that's what I set it up.” Jair had a perplexing voice. He quickly protested as if he had never expected it or even thought of it.

But for me, it sounded much like an excuse.

“If you set it up like that, why was he still hurting? I'm sure you said it would only hurt for two days.” I queried.

“That’s a little strange. I’m sure I made it based on what we had agreed... It looks like another external factor was intervening.” Jair assumed.

Beyond the bracelet, Jair seemed to be agonizing.

“You said he was still changing personalities when you two were inside the cell, right?”

“Yes, that’s right.” I answered him, still flushed from my worries.

“Maybe it’s the change that caused this unexplainable side effect he’s going through.” Jair concluded.

“...Are you saying it’s a burden on his body?” I asked in disbelief.

“Yes.” Jair answered plainly.

I didn’t hide my absurdity. What was he talking about? It was him who made that happen in the first place. So why didn’t he see this coming?

“You were the one who made the change in the first place, right?” I asked.

“As a result, it’s a good thing for his highness’ body in the long run.” Jair assured.

“Huh... in the short term, he’ll keep hurting like this?” I asked, almost shrieking in skepticism.

I’m talking like a trifle but still, I held back my anger. Then, I took a deep sigh. Yes, it was useless to be so angry this time.

“You can’t do anything about it, can you?” I said in a calmer tone.

“Yes, time is bound to pass. Because that’s the process of his highness adapting to his own strength.” Jair answered.

‘You’re a real quack.’ The words that I was trying to shoot at him right this instant came to my mind. Jair’s powerless voice sounded distressing.

“...you said he didn’t even take the pills you had.” He stated.

“Yes, that’s right. He didn’t even listen to me.” I said.

I’ve already used the medicine my brother sent me. From cold medicine to body aches medicines to painkillers. None of them worked even a little bit to ease Ricdorian’s pain.

“...I see.” He answered somberly.

So far, I thought he was being rude to Ricdorian, but I guess it wasn’t without affection.

“First of all, I’ll get back to you if anything special happens.” I told Jair.

“Okay, but I don’t think I can reach you in two days.” Jair spoke.

“Two days?” I asked, worried about what he just said.

“Yes.” Jair’s voice has dropped a little. ***“Tomorrow I have to hear something from my people here.”***

Huh?! He doesn’t even hide it from me anymore. Jair and I are not really far from being the same. Like me, he is also a prisoner. We both share a secret scheme that we both agreed on. But he sounds very busy in this big cell when he talked about his people.

If one would become a person of Jair, then that would mean they’re Ricdorian’s. In other words, there seemed to be quite a few people from Harnim side infiltrating a bit in this prison. Anyway, I just shook my head as this was something that had nothing to do with me.

“Can I ask you one thing?” I asked, unable to overcome my curiosity. “Why are you helping Ricdorian so much?”

“What?” Jair shot back. He sounded surprised.

I was just curious. Before the original work, Ricdorian was just a man who was abused by his father, a child who had no power in the arms of the

Archduke.

In fact, there was a phrase that said Archduke Harnim did not think of Ricdorian as his successor before he died, and that he had brought someone else as a collateral. But later on, he will be chased by Ricdorian.

Anyway, is there any reason to follow a boy who has no power or power from now on? I just wondered purely at this thought.

“That’s an unexpected question.” Jair stated.

“I’m just curious. It doesn’t mean much. The Ricdorian I’ve seen is a prisoner who sometimes appears wounded. In fact, I’m not sure about the nobility you said.”

“You’re mistaken.” Jair protested.

“Well then, why can’t you leave ***his highness*** be?” I asked Jair.

“...hmm.”

“Isn’t it right to wonder about that?” I added.

Jair was inaudible for a moment. I was almost convinced that he’ll never give me an answer, but suddenly he spoke in a low and still voice.

“He helped me.” It was a short and bold remark. However, those words that seemed to contain the truth had enough power.

I didn’t ask any more questions, and I said, ‘*I see.*’ It’s not that I don’t care how Ricdorian helped him, but I didn’t want to dig that far.

“I think we’ll just have to wait another day for his highness to see his condition. I feel like it won’t last until the 5th.” Jair declared.

“Just a feeling?” I asked him.

“The magician has a good sense of feeling, miss.” He quickly returned to his usual playful and relaxed voice.

I somehow get the feeling that Jair was really getting more suspicious. Although he answered my questions, I still have something in my gut that some things don't seem to play right. Anyway, maybe he's really not capable of sharing some sentiments with me, and I respect that.

"Okay, I'll see you in two days." I told him.

"Yes, please take good care of his highness."

He removed his mischief and playfulness and then asked for it with a grave and serious tone. Then, Jair disappeared.

Taking my hand off the bracelet, I looked down at Ricdorian. Then I reached out and smoothed out the hair covering his face. He looked more peaceful this time, and he wasn't groaning any longer.

"Thank goodness." I mumbled, smiling down at him as if he could see my smile.

Upon touching the hair covering his face, the sweaty bangs were subdued, but the unwet parts were as soft as fluff.

"There's someone who thinks of you." I whispered as I continued to play with the tips of his hair.

Well, he'll be loved as much as he can later, but not right now. It's heartbreaking to think that this young man was left alone in the cold underground. Soon, I grabbed his hair and folded the tip.

The memory of kissing someone whom I described as young was forgotten for a while. I guess that would be good for me.

"Just hang in there." I said.

His eyelids flinched. Rough breaths came through his scarlet lips.

"Hah, uh..." Rough breaths came off his mouth but his eyes were still closed. He must be having a nightmare because his face looked troubled.

I wonder what he's dreaming about.

I bit my lower lip as I thought about how this story ends. I'll be taking my time as his caretaker for now. Because as soon as all of this is over, he'll be happy, even without me.

I felt an ache in my chest at the thought, and sighed as I touched his cheeks.

"You'll be happy soon." I whispered.

Chapter 104: A year later (1)

Chapter 104 – A year later (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

His hands groped. Was he looking for something in his dream? I slowly untangled his crooked fingers one by one and laced my hand with his, our palms were now resting against each other.

Squeeze.

As he squeezed my hand, I felt some pain from the pressure but I just ignored it. It would have been nice if there were other people who were beside him and would hold his hand like this.

Furthermore, wouldn't it be a good idea for him to have a memory of warmth? Even for just four years, a warm memory would keep him going.

I scanned his face, tracing the chain around his neck.

“This...unwind sooner please.” I muttered under my breath.

For some reason, right at this moment, his hand that held mine suddenly went limp, as if its strength flew off, and when I glanced at him, I was taken aback.

The rough breaths that came out of his earlier have now turned into calm soft sighs.

Was he in deep slumber now?

“The floor here is too cold.” I mumbled as I began to feel chills.

This place was a really bad environment for people to stay in. It's not even a suitable dwelling place for someone who was still sixteen years of age. Furthermore, this was definitely not an appropriate place for someone to grow up.

"My butt is cold." I complained to no one in particular.

Didn't they know that raising a child who was cold to the bone will make one lose his tongue?

I felt unsettled.

Then, I turned my eyes. One of my hands was still touching the restraint on his neck....And I wondered how it felt to have something so cold and heavy hugging the expanse of one's neck like this?

I'm sure it would feel dreadful.

I covered my eyes while I looked at Ricdorian's sleeping form.

I remembered last time when my brother covered my eyes like this, I felt safe..secured.

"You'll be happier if you pull this out." I muttered so, still touching the restraint.

In addition to his comfort, I too would feel at ease if the restraint would be removed. Due to the time we spent together, I have grown attached to him and if I see him happy and comfortable, then I will also feel the same.

After some time, I thought I saw his eyelids seemed to flutter open, but I was mistaken, maybe I just wanted to see him awake so bad or I was slowly having delusions.

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The next day, when I went into Ricdorian's cell, I found myself taken aback because of what I saw. Ricdorian's fine face greeted me and it also seemed

like he was recovering fast and well. I was particularly pleased to see that the spot from where he was hurt and wounded, healed completely. He even stood up quickly from his seat with great enthusiasm and with his extraordinary physical ability. And from that, he seemed to be gaining his strength back.

I was just looking at him in a daze, it was so incredible.

How can I not feel confused? After all, I have seen him struggling until yesterday but today he was appearing before me seeming so healthy. He looked like the version of himself when I first got into the room, is it strange for me to think this? Well, there have been obvious differences since that time, but still, that was the feeling he gave me.

In addition, I noticed that when he greeted me he had a slight blush on his cheeks.

“Oh, welcome.” Ricdorian said to me as he stepped aside and tapped the spot next to where he had sat.

...does he want me to sit down? I thought to myself as I stared at the empty space next to him.

The seat he gestured to was covered with a blanket that I had given him a long time ago when Hans was still the one guarding his cell.

Oh, I have to wash that, I can't believe it is still here though. I thought.

“Oh, you want me to sit down? Thank you.” For some reason, Ricdorian bowed his head then and averted my gaze. Then, he slowly nodded his head as lightly as possible.

“...Yes.” he told me.

What is it? I said to myself as I watched his odd behavior.

Why do the expressions on his face change so quickly?

Sometimes his face would turn red, and it seemed like the heat on his cheeks does not completely go away even when some time passes.

Were there still magical effects left on him?

“Well, can I touch your forehead?” I asked, wanting to make sure he was no longer sick.

“What? What, what? What?” Ricdorian asked repeatedly, he looked so flabbergasted.

“...what are you so surprised about?” I asked him. He had taken a few steps back and was now standing far away from me and my outstretched hand.

If he doesn't like me touching him then I won't force him. I took my hand and brought it back to my side.

“Come back, your chains will pull you and it will hurt you.” I told him and tapped on the tightly pulled chain for him to see that moving that far will cause him pain.

And when Ricdorian noticed the chain, he slowly stepped in closer. Now he was about three spans away from me. To be honest, I was a little peeved by his reaction, but I also feel like I'm seeing a dog next to his owner who doesn't want to leave.

Well, not that I was sulking. I then rested my chin on my palm as I stared at the sight of Ricdorian's gradual redness.

“Why are you turning red? What did I do?” I asked him.

“What? Oh, the... .” He muttered.

“Ah. Do you like me that much?” I teased him.

At that moment, I seemed to be seeing a red tomato appear before my eyes. Yes that's right, what I saw could only be described as a tomato. But thinking about it now, I may have seen a red cotton camellia instead.

Not long after my question, the room was filled with silence. As the dead air between us became more apparent, more seconds passed by. Then suddenly, I thought it was the right opportunity for me to ask Ricdorian 'Why'.

Why was he suddenly healed, was his body better now? Or was he still in pain? And why does he suddenly turn red like this, could it be some weird after effect?

But I wasn't able to ask him those questions, because of the sudden appearance of an uninvited guest. Ricodorian's beast version was now suddenly awake.

"Arff!" Ricodorian barked.

It's been a long time since I saw this personality of his. When he greeted me with dog barkings, I could not help but burst out laughing at him.

"Why am I so happy?" I asked myself, wiping the tears that formed at the edge of my eyes.

"Arfff, Arfff!"

"Oh, okay. Shh. Don't pull it." I warned Ricodorian.

But he was staring intently at the thing that I was holding. My eyes alternated between him and to the ribbon I held. Not long after, I decided to throw the ribbon, just like in the fetch pet game for dogs.

"Go get it and bring it here. " I said as I tossed the ribbon away from us.

"Arfff!" Ricdorian ran excitedly to fetch the ribbon.

Of course, the ribbon was purposely in a moderate distance within the reach of the chains so he wouldn't get hurt.

However, seeing Ricdorian right now, I felt absurd.

“You know... why don’t you bring it like a normal person does? Do you really like to **‘bite’** it?” I asked, with sarcasm.

“Arff?” Ricdorian responded.

When he was in his beast state, he usually loved to play throw as well as to eat, but that moment when I said **‘Bring it here’** didn’t budge him.

What kind of crazy person would allow themselves to get treated this way... where’s your human dignity now, eh? Of course, I knew it’s useless to say this because he wouldn’t understand and so I chose to shut my mouth.

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Chapter 105: A year later (2)

Chapter 105 – A year later (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

I decided to hold out my hands towards him instead. My outstretched hands extended all the way towards his face, and my palms grabbed his cheeks.

“You look like a glutinous rice cake.” I told him as I rubbed the sides of his face.

“Arff?” Ricdorian responded.

I noticed that he no longer showed his teeth to me even though he was in his beast mode. When I first met him in this state, I remembered how he truly resembled a beast, looking so agitated as if he was just caught.

His behaviour back then was no different from a wild dog. Seeing him now, I can’t help but tilt my head at those now innocent and appealing looking eyes.

“Come here.” My pulled my hands inwards that were still holding him on the cheeks. His red-liquored mouth popping out like a crucian carp.

Then he blinked and his clear blue eyes shined.

“I, I know why you turned red earlier.” I stated.

“Ruff?”

It’s useless to talk to this version, but I know that each personality remembers the memories of the others.

When I saw his face turning red all of a sudden, I thought it was weird. Honestly, I haven't thought of any reason why he turned red a while ago. No, I didn't want to remember that incident but it suddenly came into my mind just now.

"You, you've kissed me, and you've felt guilty for doing that, don't you?" I asked.

"Arff?" Ricdorian groaned as if he didn't know what I was saying to him, but I didn't let him go.

Though I wish I hadn't remembered. But I just thought I couldn't.

First and foremost, he suddenly got sick, and I thought that maybe because he's ill and was in bed all day, he might have considered the kiss as a dream. Furthermore, I quickly pushed aside those thoughts in order to take good care of him awhile back, that I also almost forgot it happened.

However, this version of Ricdorian with me seemed to have remembered the incident I was talking about for he finally shut his mouth.

"Now come on. You won't believe it's a dream, do you?" Well, I guess so." I said to him.

"*Crying, whining!*" Ricdorian seemed to be crying now or like a dog who was whining and I sighed.

"To be honest, I don't think I believe it either. Well, let's just bury our heads in the sand."

I slightly let go of his cheek then. However, Ricdorian grabbed me by the cheek instead and I involuntarily stared at his misty eyes. The beast didn't bite me, even if he was so close to me. I thought it was a great development.

For a moment, I forgot the situation I was in as I felt moved.

But then, I quickly detached myself from his hold. Oh, this isn't the time for me to indulge with this. Soon, I started to converse.

“I just know this, actually, the first kiss...” I looked at his big eyes...

Kiss? No.

“About first kisses....did you know that they say that the person who gives the first kiss, if you don’t kiss her again within a year, you can’t see her forever.” Clearly, I was lying to this dog.

I’ve heard stories about first kisses before. There’s a romantic story that tells that if you kiss for the first time when it snows, love would last a long time. That is bullsh*t, of course, and to be honest I had no remorse in considering those tales as one.

Promptly remembering the kiss, to be honest, I was so surprised that my tongue went up and started kissing with him.

I’m sorry, but I don’t have a conscience, Ricdorian. You must have been having a lot of fun with the impostor, but I’ve also gotten a little shameless over time.

Of course, the beast version of Ricdorian just blinked his eyes as if he didn’t understand what I was weaving at him. I smiled and moved away from him. No, I tried to move away from him but his hand was holding on to the hem of my clothes the moment I got up.

He stared at me silently and I turned my head slowly. Then before I knew it, he was on both knees.

“Ricdorian?” I stared at him in confusion.

It was him who was kneeling on the ground but I felt uncomfortable as he looked so different in his posture. The menacing aura was indeed odd.

“Really?” He asked me.

At first glance, I could see his reddening cheeks under his fluttering bangs. His face was slightly hidden but his high nose and red cheeks were visible under the dim light. And so, I couldn’t tell what exactly his expression was like. In addition, Ricdorian was biting his lips.

He let go of his hold on my hem and then moved to my thighs.

“Oh, my father did.”

Father? Archduke Harnim? Why did Ricdorian suddenly talk about him here?

I decided to stop trying to move away from him.

“Lis..listen well, be patient. I’ll get out a year later.”

At that moment, several emotions crossed inside me when he said that word. **‘Patient’**, I could guess a lot from that word.

What was he standing up against? It must be the pain from the abuse..

I bit my lower lip tightly. I know he couldn’t see me, but I also couldn’t see his face clearly so he might not notice my perplexed expression right now.

“Hey, promise me.” His fists popped with veins as he clenched and loosened his grip repeatedly against the fabrics of my clothes.

“Wait for a year. A year from now is the day I will get out of here.” Ricdorian slowly lifted his head up. “Meet me when that happens... please.”

Suddenly, a face as red as a flower seemed to have sprung in this cold prison cell. A flower that was so bright that I could not escape its light even if I moved several steps away from it.

“See...I want you to see you then “

I blinked at him. What should I answer him? Then I rolled my eyes. In an instant, I remembered I was the master of stone-hearted people.

But I knew from the moment I gave him my affection, that one day, maybe he’d come to me too, and that is something I had to be prepared for, something I knew I had to face.

“Okay.” I replied.

He doesn’t know it yet, but I was indifferent and selfish. Getting along well with con artists and prisoners means I can blend in with their essence.

“By the way, you know what. I’ll tell you this.” I patted him on the forehead with a big smile.

“What I said earlier, it’s a lie.”

“Eh, eh?” He turned red and opened his eyes wide.

“Oh, you don’t know that word? Lie. It’s a complete lie.” I sat down before him with a big smile. “A year later, if you don’t kiss me again, you won’t see me. There’s no such thing in this world.” I repeated again.

I lowered my head and stared at his eyes. His cerulean eyes were red as if they were going to burst into tears.

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Chapter 106: Iana's Release (1)

Chapter 106 – Iana's Release (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

“But, still...” I muttered.

Before more words would come out of my mouth, Ricdorian unexpectedly grabbed me by the arm. I was keeping my body rigid and still, to prevent him from locking me in an embrace, which I think is what he was about to do next. I tried to swerve his hands away. But as I did that, he didn't take his eyes away from me.

“If I will be really out of jail in a year or so. You come back here... Can you do that... for me?” Ricdorian requested. I was looking at his face while he said those words. I cannot help but notice his blue dazzling eyes and his cheeks that were slowly turning red. “You'll be out of here first.” He added.

I gave him a little smile, took a deep breath and started talking.

“You want me to come over and visit you?” I asked him.

He nodded with his lips slightly pursed. His face turned redder this time.

“If you come...Can you meet me?” Ricdorian asked.

I was taken aback with his words and suddenly burst out into laughter. I found myself really amused by his plea, he sounded like an innocent child. Then, I felt a tear coming out of my right eye because of laughing and wiped it away with my finger.

“You know where I would be.” He stated. And I kept silent. “Hey, meet me!”

“Well.” I shot back, tapping my cheek with my forefinger gently as if I was thinking hard.

“Meet me... please. Meet me.” He continued to beseech.

“Well...” I continued to say. I moved my fingers to rub my chin and was trying to concentrate on making my final decision.

“...Ia...Iana.” Ricdorian muttered, looking very desperate.

“Don’t look at me with those eyes.” I blurted at him. It was against the rule to look like you were about to shed tears. It’s very perturbing.

At this point, he would have turned away and avoided my eyes first, but he didn’t. In the end, he waited for a very long time, hence I had no choice but to answer. I surrendered and started to converse.

“Yes,” I thought it wouldn’t be difficult to meet him, and I accordingly agreed. “I will.” I added.

However, if we can really meet, it would make sense. I mumbled in my thoughts. But can he really get out of prison then?

A bitter smile accompanied my thoughts. It would be better if we can go out together but that would be impossible.

Ricdorian touched my chin and lifted my face. I can now see the hope in those blue eyes of him and I felt satisfied by the look on his face.

At the very least, he’ll have to stay here longer and that’s unfortunate. Moreover, one year later, Archduke Harnim will not easily let him off the hook.

“Promise me, will you do it for me?” He asked in a low, soft tone.

“Yes, I will... I promise.” I answered.

I let out a weak smile just to assure him that I will meet him again. After a while, after giving him that promise, I could not help but think again of the possibilities. Before going out of this prison, I must at least tell him that I'm terribly sorry.

But I can't bear to rip out the excitement he has right now. Still, saying sorry will not be enough. It will never be enough for the things that were bound to happen. I just hope he won't dwell too much on his expectations.

But no, I must set aside my conscience. But really, I wanted to tell him how deeply sorry I am. He must at least know that he won't get out of here after a very long time... and I'm not sure if I'll be able to come back and visit him here once I get out.

Sooner or later, he'll realize that promises are really meant to be broken.

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Time has passed again. It was said that the time and season are what no one can take control of. They come and go as they please, changing everything as they pass by, yet leaving a lot of memories.

At last, the long wait was over and the day I have been waiting for has come. It was finally the day of my release.

"That's amazing." Jair, who got back in touch with me after a few days, couldn't hide his surprise.

"You haven't delivered such big news to me." Jair added.

"Ay, I'm not obliged to tell you, am I?" I checked the room, ensuring no one was inside and answered at ease.

The guard was not yet here, and I already knew from experience that the cell was soundproofed. At least I'm aware that nobody will hear our conversation. It would be suspicious enough if a guard would hear me whispering.

Furthermore, I had already informed Jair that Ricdorian had already returned to his original state. I could say he's all better now, and it gives me peace of mind that he's not sick anymore. However, he's also now back to making fun of me. Yeah, he does seem to like doing that very much.

"The release is important news." Jair stated. I could hear a sudden change of tone in his voice.

Why didn't I tell him about my release from prison? Well, like I said I was not obliged to do so. So, I did not bother to tell him at all.

"You're not loyal, Miss." Jair remarked.

"Strange, why do you sound sulky?" I asked him teasingly.

There has never been a loyalty agreement that Jair and I have talked about. Yes, we have agreed on some things, and planted out a very discrete scheme between just the two of us but loyalty has never been spoken of. But how did he know about me getting out of here?

I let out a laugh as I thought about this. On what grounds could he tell that I'm not being loyal? He sounded like he's accusing me of something I'm not. I couldn't help but think he's being ridiculous.

"Who made a poor prisoner go out in the middle of the night?" I teasingly questioned him.

"I'm astonished you have such shamelessness in you." Jair's voice is serious and hard this time.

"You can't change your attitude." I smiled crookedly and shook my bracelet lightly.

"How did you know I was getting out of prison? I'm just curious, but I won't ask further because my mouth hurts right now." I added.

"That's sad. But I'm confident I can explain it." Jair declared.

What kind of hefty person are you? Jair would have recruited someone from the guard. Or the guard was of Hel's from the very beginning.

“What’s interesting is that I never found out anything about your family.” Jair said.

Well, I wasn't even hiding my ancestry anymore. I thought, as I looked at the bracelet with a ridiculous face. *Hmm*. Come to think of it, the bracelet reminds me of something.

“I’m curious, but did you really not cast any other magic on the bracelet?” I asked him.

“Yeah, I’m sure of that. Why, wasn’t it the same as before?” Jair asked. **“Did something happen that changed it? Is the bracelet broken?”** It’s funny how rattled he sounded; he must have not been aware that he asked too many questions already.

“Well, it’s not like that.” I answered.

I was going to ask about the bracelet that caused the hole in the cell, but Jair said he didn't cast anything else on it. He didn't seem to be lying, as well.

Chapter 107: Iana's Release (2)

Chapter 107 – Iana's Release (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

“But if this thing is executing something unusual, that means this is broken, right? Did you just give me the defective product?” I asked.

“No! That’s not it. Well, it’s all about magic stuff, so when you run into something that has a more powerful mana, you’ll fail. It wouldn’t have happened unless you fought a senior knight with it.” Jair stated.

“Strong mana...” I mumbled.

“Yes. A typical example would be the prison head who is like a monster.” Jair declared.

Is he really that strong? Well, that’s right. Lenag must be strong and powerful. After all, he’s the villain’s right-hand man. I bet he is.

Speaking out of the blue, because of the fact that I’m leaving this prison, I unknowingly forgot about visiting the basement cell.

“So, what kind of family do you belong to, Miss?” Jair was still eager to know about my family.

“What are you going to do about it? Anyway, we’re not going to be seeing each other.” I told him.

“Ay, I’m curious.” Jair said plainly.

I tossed my clothes in without putting them in order. Heh, what's the use of organizing them too much. They're just... clothes.

"It's a great family, okay?" I reassured him.

What was the family name, again? Ein? Aici? Aninte? Oh, no. I forgot what Baron had told me. All I remember is that it's a great family in the east gate.

But thinking about it right now, made me uncomfortable.

"I know, that's what it is. But you know, it's a fact that we can only discover what we have not yet found out." Jair stated.

"Yes, yes. That's right."

"I'm just being careful, Miss. My personal curiosity cannot be resolved." Jair replied.

So, wondering about my family was your personal curiosity? I gave out a false laugh. This guy is completely out of bounds.

"Forget that interest today." I said and then tapped the bracelet.

"On a second thought, what about this bracelet? I don't think I'll have time to give it back to you." I asked.

It's true. The time left before my release was extremely short and I did not have enough time to think about contacting Jair. Although I am somewhat ignorant of magic and this world, I know that this bracelet is not an ordinary thing, so I better return it.

"Oh, just keep it." But with a sense of concern, Jair replied with great equanimously. ***"You can have it."***

"...just giving it to me that easily? I think you're nothing like that." I said flippantly.

"You have not only done such a precious thing, but you have also risked your life to help." Jair said, his voice warm and grateful.

Life, he said, I reflected on what I had done. That's the right thing to say. If only such a noble prisoner could do what I have done...

When I met Lenag in the hallway that one night, I thought he was not from this world. It's creepy to think of it...but I couldn't help it. I know what happened. And I don't have to argue about the past.

"Well, I appreciate it. Thank you." I replied, with a smile, even though he can't see it right now.

The bracelet still had the magic that Jair had casted on it. Since there were two bracelets, one would be used in communicating Jair while the other had various spells. It wasn't a bad thing for me because I didn't know what I was going to go through in this world. Life has never failed to surprise me after all.

"Yes. Enjoy using it. Don't throw away anything you received from me that could be of use." Jair said, laughingly.

"How did you know?" I asked him. I'm aware Jair could see me flush. It's embarrassing.

"You're kidding, aren't you?" I could tell that there was a pinch of 'seriously?' look painted all over Jair's face. Also, laughter came over my bracelet.

What should I do? I'm not kidding. I can't believe he's laughing at me right now.

"Please keep it. You don't know that maybe I can help you someday." Jair tried to clear his throat this time as he ceased his laughter.

"...if it's within a certain distance of the road." I mumbled.

Though I grumbled so much, I got both bracelets. Well, if you happen to have a chance in your life to get help from one of the original characters, the supporting role of a sorcerer; whom I of course met coincidentally.

Indeed, it was a good chance. I was not going to let that good chance slip away to a waste. I was not missing the probability here.

As someone who opened my eyes in this world, it's difficult for me to not think about it...the things that I have yet to be experienced.

"Anyway, stay fine." I told Jair inexpressibly.

"Wow, thank you for your 'sincere' greeting." Jair also took my greeting lightly. ***"I truly appreciate you."***

I thought he was just playing along with me but surprisingly, a pretty deep voice was heard from the bracelet. Hmm. What's wrong with him? That seems unfamiliar!

"There's something I've learned from you. All this time, I was thinking wrong." Jair said. There was laughter in his voice this time, but a serious one.

"Was it about making Ricdorian sick?" I asked.

"Yes." Jair replied.

He must have realized a lot, after everything he said something at that time. However, it wasn't a bad thing to think about the future of Ricdorian. He was indeed destined to have great things in the future.

"That's good." I passionately smiled as I stared at the bracelet.

"Yes." He answered. ***"I don't know if I can tell you..."***

"Then don't." I said, trying to cut off what he's about to say next.

"...I don't think it's a good idea for him to leave. He doesn't listen to everything. Didn't I say my people here provide me news about him?" Jair stated. It was evident in his voice that he was really concerned.

"You did, didn't you?" I replied. Does that even have anything to do with me?

“I’ve told you that maybe a noble person will never come here again.”

Jair’s voice dropped. ***“I don’t think that’s going to be easy.”*** Jair said.

Archduke Harnim of Hel Estate will continue to come to this prison. And he would not overlook it, even when he can’t visit Ricdorian.

“So, you’re just going to let it go?” I asked.

“No.” He answered firmly. ***“We have been passive for the meantime because we decided to wait until his highness awakens. But I realized it was a wrong decision. So, I decided to change the direction.”***

As his words continued, I gradually changed my posture.

“In the future, we will protect him as much as possible from external violence.” Jair said.

It would have been violence and abuse from the outside by his biological father, Archduke Harnim.

“Saying it like that means there’s a way, right?” I asked, very intrigued.

“Yes. It may not be complete...But I’m going to try.” As I listened, I pursed my lips.

I was going to ask what it was. But he didn’t open his lips. As if a line had been drawn in front of me.

Then I thought. *Okay, don’t cross this line, Iana. Just until here.*

“I’ll ask you one question. Can Ricdorian...” I lowered my gaze. The cold stone floor, the flooring of this prison, might be the last thing I would see here.

“Can he be released from prison in a year? He said to me that he might be released in a year.”

“That’s... it’s impossible.” Jair answered firmly. Suddenly, I was filled with sadness. ***“I know what you’re talking about. But that will not be observed.”***

Archduke Harnim is a noble man who is capricious.”

He went on calmly explaining.

“At the very least, his highness can’t come out of the prison until he’s fully awakened...and therefore, I don’t think so.”

With Jair’s words, I stared blankly at the floor once again. This cold stone floor. I could picture out what Ricdorian’s days would feel like for a year or more.

Chapter 108: Iana's Release (3)

Chapter 108 – Iana's Release (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

For some time, I repeatedly closed and opened my eyes. Yeah, that's right, it was a fact that I already knew.

I was a selfish person who messed up Ricdorian's world, strung him along but had no confidence to take responsibility for him. To be honest, what I've done for him was just a small thing, with the least amount of conscience, and out of shallow generosity. I only gave the desert drifter enough water to keep him from dying.

Awakening.

That was the only possible way for Ricdorian to be released from the restraint that his father put on his neck.

"I see. Thank you for your answer."

[Perhaps...]

Jair seemed to have something more to say to me, but he looked like he hesitated to speak, probably because of my firm response that he decided not to continue talking about it.

[Stay healthy.]

And that's how my conversation with Jair ended.

Soon, the jewel's light went out, and I raised my head and stared at the ceiling. Now this ceiling would be the last one.

I haven't really thought about it, but for quite some time now I observed that the summer and winter here were opposite. It may be summer but the temperature is cold. It feels like it was always winter in this world. In other words, the twelve months here started with summer and would still end with summer.

Soon, a year would pass. And the new year will come again. And then three years later... The original plot of the story will begin, and Ricdorian will come out of this prison.

It's longer than I thought. But not long after, I shook my head.

You don't have to think about it anymore, Iana.

And so I decided not to meet Ricdorian for the last time. Since we've already said our goodbyes to each other.

"By the way, the guard is late." I muttered to myself.

I thought he'd come at any moment for a while now, but he still hasn't.

The person who said he would come here soon was late. I've been talking to Jair for a long time, but he still hasn't shown up, so I wondered if there's a problem on his end, perhaps he had encountered trouble while making his way here.

"Did a prisoner escape?" I gazed at the desk, asking those words.

On the desk, was a wooden box and inside it was where my luggage was placed. The contents of my luggage was composed of letters I received from my brother during my stay here, an old pocket watch that Iana had, and the jeweled flowers my brother gave me.

In sum, all of the things that I have that were related to my brother were in there.

Isn't it obvious by now how much I relied on my brother?

I just have to eat what he gives me and wear what he makes me wear.

I was about to stretch my hands to fight off my impatience when I heard something open.

Click.

The window on the cell door was pushed to the side. It was a window with bars and wasn't completely covered so that the prisoners could only see the faces of the people outside.

"Iana!" A voice called out.

I could see a familiar face through the bars. It was that guard who had been in charge of my cell. I tilted my head to the side because I was curious about the urgent look on his face.

"What's going on?" I asked.

"Well..." He said then stopped.

He seemed hesitant to tell me what seems to be bothering him.

I did not expect him to appear so dumbfounded and for sometime he was speechless and his face appeared timid. As a matter of fact, I was growing impatient with him, I'm not the kind of person who wants to wait.

"...You cannot be released today." The guard finally told me and my mouth gaped in shock.

"What?"

No, why not? Why?

"That's the order of the Emperor."

His Majesty? The Emperor?

The sudden realization made my eyes blazed with dismay.

No, why did the emperor suddenly come into the picture?

“200 years ago, was the slaughtering of Lowellton, the son of Job. To commemorate that day, there will be a ban on all prisons from being pardoned. No one will be pardoned for a year. This special period will be strictly observed...That’s what he ordered.”

“No amnesty?”

Apparently, if there was a slaughter in history, it would seem like the people of that time encountered a great and immoral villain of that era. Therefore, if the Emperor was a special envoy for Liberation Day, then it was customary to hold off all villains of the present time, and so they were not letting any prisoners go out.

It was ridiculous!

Right now, it wouldn’t be so absurd if I find a hidden camera here.

“The Prison head also wants to apologize...” the guard told me.

But what can I do?

It seemed Lenag himself can’t do anything about it either, and if they say nothing can be done then, it’s impossible to alter the decision.

“Okay, I can’t help it if that really is the case.” I replied.

I accepted this fact more easily than I thought.

After all, this was a place where I lived for a long time now and from the moment I opened my eyes. I have grown accustomed to this place and to be honest, there seemed to be no difference if I stayed here a little longer.

“You’ll be able to go as soon as the specified period ends. He said that is a pledge.” The guard informed me.

“That’s fine, but how long would that period last?” I asked.

“...three months.” He answered.

“Ahh...I see,” the guard began as he scratched the back of his head.

He then proceeded to tell me that Lenag was busy and that is why he delivered the bad news instead.

Somehow, Lenag’s name seemed to have a different bearing now. It seems that Lenag was now representing the Imperial family and they too carried his name.

I accepted explanations without protest and sat down on bed.

Then, I proceeded to unpacked the luggage.

But fortunately. time passed by easily.

For those extra three months I spent in prison, I hardly ever got out of my cell. Honestly, I did not do much during that time.

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Chapter 109: Iana's Release (4)

Chapter 109 – Iana's Release (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

All I did was stay in my cell and if I had the chance to go out I only went to the dining room to eat, but rarely took a walk in the living room. Moreover, I didn't come in contact with Ricdorian or even went to his cell to see him.

And as I did not go to Ricdorian's cell, I naturally didn't even go to Lenag's office.

Well, my previous visits to Lenag's office was because of the agreement that I would spend as much time with him as I did whenever I met with Ricdorian. There was no particular reason though for my visits, in truth I just wanted to.

There was an axiom that I used to hear from the elders, they said that sometimes a person becomes emotional for no reason...and I think it is not true.

Well, for me, as long as I was released from prison, I thought I might not have to be close to the main characters of this novel anymore. But I realized even if I tried to move away for some reason there would be instances that even if I don't want to, they could easily come back into my life.

There are times Jair occasionally contacts me but I have decided to ignore him.

Then there was this one time, the guards worried that I would be depressed, hence they asked me if I wanted to see Ricdorian, but I smiled and refused.

Sometimes Lenag would tell the guards to tell me to come and see him but I refused and I didn't go. In strange moments, he was a man of good manners, I observed that but even his goodwill I did not heed.

He hadn't forced me to keep him company and for that I was grateful.

In my remaining time, I also made certain that I said my goodbyes to those prisoners I became close with such as Baron Palladis and Sally, whom I haven't bid goodbye to before because I haven't had enough time to see them.

"Oh, Iana. We shouldn't forget about our relationship even when we're outside. Do you get it?" Baron said.

"Of course." I reassured him.

The ties, which were clumped up by Baron's fraud experiences will probably never be cut off, and Sally snorted while answering in a playful tone.

"Bye bye, Iana. I'm sure, east, ah, Einte, I'm going there. I'm going there. "

"Yes, come and see me. You'll be welcome anytime." I said, smiling at her.

I patted Sally one last time and left.

After that, I didn't even go back to the living room, so the remaining time I naturally spent in silence. I was reading or meditating in my room. I don't hate spending time alone, so it wasn't that bad.

And surprisingly, I was never bored, even right now, I was holding a letter from my brother that filled the rest of my time and it would be enough company until I was released from prison.

[...I'm sorry.] I don't know why he is apologizing. He didn't hurt me and it wasn't even his fault. The Emperor's whimpering was at fault this time.

"It's all right." I muttered to myself after reading that.

[I should have done something about the Emperor.] My brother replied back.

Sometimes I would burst into laughter due to his excessive comforting.

What are you even capable of doing to the Emperor? I thought he was such a bluffing brother.

[...the day is so long without you. Should I wait a little longer? I think I'm just waiting all the time and I do nothing more. But even so, it is alright for me to wait, because it's you whom I am waiting for.]

And sometimes I would be a little childish.

On such days, I just stared at his elegant handwriting without much thought.

How well did the siblings get along? Maybe he was more affectionate than others I knew. I don't know if that trait of his was common or rare and if it truly exists in this world...

Was it normal for siblings to be this closed?

Hmmm. Let me see. There's Sally. His brother committed a crime and sent Sally over instead...well. Prisoner companions are unlikely to be the usual examples.

I gave up on comparing and finding the reason why these siblings seemed to be in a good relationship.

And finally the day of my release came.

"Oh, the day has finally come." Fortunately, on the second day of release, there was no guard who visited me. Instead, a janitor with a bright face was the one who informed me that I could finally really get out of prison today.

He seemed to be so concerned about me though, I had been stuck in a cell for a while, and it looks like he had become attached to my being here. He's a good person, after all.

Not long after, I asked the guard, who seemed to have just come back to his station and was conducting the checkout procedure, if I could take a walk around even for a short while. My request was easily granted because the checkout procedure had already been almost completed on paper.

I took a familiar path after saying my thanks.

There was a senior guard stationed near my direction, but thankfully he moved out of the way and allowed me to pass.

“I heard you were going to be released. Congratulations to you.” He greeted me.

“Yes, thank you. Take care of yourself.” I replied.

When I smiled, the superior guard shyly smiled back. I wanted to release my hard face and show my real expression. But at the end, I went straight down the stairs.

Perhaps because it’s the last sound I will hear here, that’s why it sounds both pleasant and sad to my ears. After a short while, I was face to face with a familiar underground bar.

Clank. Clank.

Even though I hadn’t heard it for three months, I could hear a familiar sound of iron chains banging the floor. Soon, I stood outside the bars and went in the innermost corner. If the length of the chain I remember was right then...

“Ricdorian.” I spoke softly as I heard him move.

Rattle. Rattle. Rattle.

Yes. Here he could reach the bars, as well. As expected, he responded to my voice. I let out a small laugh as I saw his hands holding onto the bars.

“I’m sorry I couldn’t go in today.” I told him.

I sighed to myself as I couldn't see him and therefore I couldn't figure out what kind of expression he has now. To be honest, I was somewhat thankful that the light was so weak in here that I couldn't see him well.

"Arff, arff, arff! ." Ricdorian responded.

And at this moment, I was deeply moved by the fact that he was nothing but a beast.

"I don't know if I should say that this is good timing." I said.

"Grrr, grrr, grrr, grrr!"

"Yes, it's me. How are you?" I asked and squatted down.

This distance between us now was probably the same as that of our first meeting in this place.

"I really came to say my last greeting today." I informed him.

Even when he was a beast, he was still aware of what was happening. Perhaps that's why his whining voice grew sad.

I was told by the senior guard that Ricdorian knows I stayed in prison for three more months without being released.

The guard told me that and I have this urge to ask him right now, *'How did you feel about me not coming?'*

But I decided that I was not going to ask him that. It would just make it harder for me to leave this place.

"Someday, whatever happens, eat well. You have to be strong."

I squeezed his hand one last time and let go of it. The beast version of him cried all the more mournfully as he looked at my hand helplessly.

"I wish you could speak right now since this will be our last. But perhaps it is better this way for the both of us." I don't know what to say even if I say

something I don't know if it will make it easier for him either.

"Lastly, I'll give you advice." I have no great will aside from this one.

What are you going to do with your restraint or how you want to change your life for the better?

I was not as bad as a villain, nor was I as good as a saint.

And so, I sat on the sidelines knowing that this moderate affection would poison him. Nevertheless, by not apologizing for this, I will atone for it instead of easing my heart up.

"Leave only good memories. Forget about the parting." I added.

I won't see you again.

I smiled and gently held his cheek. The cheeks of the beastly man were now tearstained.

"At the end of the day, don't trust me." Look, I gave him too much affection and ran away like this. Wasn't I cruel?

"Don't believe in the shallowness of the heart. Because it's selfish. Just like me." I told him one last time.

I lowered my gaze and prepared to leave.

Chapter 110: I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (1)

Chapter 110 – I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

“If you can't give everything, then don't give it. If possible, don't give your forgiveness to the one who locked you up and hurt you like this.” I told him.

Love only those who will give you everything, especially the heroine, and I hope you will not forgive the father who made you this way.

In the book, the red rose defended justice. Right, Archduke Harnim also defended justice. The red rose symbolized the passion, and the cold blue eyes of the Ricdorian symbolizes justice and spirit.

But what mattered most and what he should remember was that his father, who was righteous to others, was not righteous to him.

“Justice is good, but I'd rather be a villain when it's difficult.” I advised, despite knowing it would be difficult for him to follow.

Well, if that happens that would be good, and even if not, I guess it would be a good food for thought, something for him to think about again.

“Don't cry.” I said as I stole the gem-like tear that slowly fell from his eyes gently with my inner thumb.

Ricodorian continued to whimper.

His harsh hands grabbed me which shook the harshness violently. He was whimpering, even at this moment, and even in his beast state, it seems that he still can cry like a human does.

Is this a good thing for you? Is that a good thing for me?

Instead of pulling out my hand, I held his cheeks and lowered my head close to his. His lips brushed against my forehead as I did so.

“You’ll be fine.” I told him.

Jair told me that he would try to prevent the abuse of Harnim as much as possible. I’m already at my limit, I already did all that I could do to help him and there is nothing more I can do for him. What I’ve done has been drawn up already.

“Goodbye.” I told him as I finally let go of his face.

I knew too well about the extent of the chain’s power. I knew when to pull out of his hand before he had the chance to go any further. But the moment I was just getting farther away from him, it seems like my fingertips were caught....*Was I just caught?*

It was a distance that I thought he could never reach.

Pitter-patter.

Sure enough, something red fell to the floor and made a black mark on its landing.

It was blood.

“Ricdorian!” I exclaimed.

“...promise.” He said, still holding onto my fingers.

His wrist was torn. The chains that have been stretched by force made his arms tremble with blood.

Blood was gushing from his wound, he tore his flesh by trying to reach me while his chains held him back. I wanted to see the extent of his wound and how badly he was hurt, but I couldn't move because of my fingertips that were barely caught by him.

“Are you going to keep...” Ricdorian began to ask.

This was a place where the light was dim. And I couldn't tell what condition the crouching Ricdorian was in. Whether it's the rational or grown-up side of him who was talking.

“Promise, you'll keep it.” His cracked and desperate voice made it impossible to guess what personality he's in right now.

“...Make sure to treat your wounds.” I rummaged through my pockets and passed the ointment to his hand. I came to give this to him from the very first place anyway.

He smiled faintly, “I will. I always listen to you very well.”

I still did not know which side of him was talking to me, but Ricdorian kissed my fingertips and let them go slowly as if he wasn't hurting presently.

I saw his fingertips tremble as I gradually stepped back.

“You'll keep your word, Iana.” He said it over and over again making sure I would never forget it.

His gaze, along with the slow raising of his head, pierced straight right through me and made my chest ache painfully.

Staring back at me were deep blue eyes, like that of the transparent sea. Seeing his irises made me self-conscious and I quickly averted his gaze and casted my eyes downward. Shortly afterwards, I lifted them up again to answer him.

“Yes, I will. ”

I said and then he smiled broadly.

“A year from now. If you get out of prison.”

Ricdorian’s face was beaming at my words. Indeed, it was a farewell.

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“I am finally out!”

The process of getting out of prison was ridiculously simple. I’ll just grab a bag full of my stuff and go towards the main gate, just like that and I’m done here.

“The road is also easy to take.” I observed.

Besides, I didn’t have that much luggage. That was because my luggage had been transported in advance and I arranged my belongings that would be good for three months.

“...but still, it’s not too simple.” I muttered dejectedly and lifted my baggage.

“The sky is also clear.” I said to myself as I stared at the clear blue expanse without a cloud in sight.

It was such a blue sky.

It may be hot in the summer, but surprisingly, the temperature in this area is not that high. The guard who guided me as I walked towards the gate, politely greeted me, I also gave him a polite greeting and bowed my head in response.

But then he stared at me in surprise with his eyes wide open.

Why did he look so surprised?

It was the first time I saw the face of the guard reveal such expression. No, I suppose it’s because I was wearing clothes that were unfamiliar to the

guard's eyes. Maybe that is why he was showing off a face like that. At this time, I shook my head roughly, erasing the face with a tearful blush that kept coming to my mind.

Let's enjoy our freedom for now.

Freedom!

I breathed deeply and felt my lungs expand as fresh air filled it. Even if I lived a prisoner's life, I was still not like a prisoner after all. Anyway, I was more likely in custody of a knight.

But I was glad to finally find my freedom. All right, now I can go anywhere I want to.

I grinned and unfolded what I held in my hand. It was a small piece of paper that felt light in my hand. In it were words still written in an elegant and beautiful handwriting.

[I will pick you up on that day.]

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Chapter 111: I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (2)

Chapter 111 – I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Nym13

It was my brother's letter. He said he's coming to see me when I'm out of prison. I thought it was a joke, but I didn't refuse his offer.

"Where are you?" I asked, looking around for signs of someone who could be my brother.

It was good to be out, but everything was so vast in front of the gate that I couldn't tell where to go. Then at that time, something caught my eye and I turned to look at my side.

Swoosh.

The wind blew and the scent of flowers pervaded in the wind. It was like a strong, seductive scent that feels like it came from a garden that was in full bloom during the spring.

Do flowers bloom here in summer? I wondered.

I couldn't see clearly after because my hair was blown by the passing wind and was haphazardly sprawled on top of my head and blurred my vision. When I barely lifted my head to pull the strands away from my face and turned to face the front, a big shadow fell before my eyes and filled my vision.

"Iana." The man standing in front of me suddenly spoke my name.

A sweet spring-sunny voice which I seemed to have heard in the recent past pierces my ears. Then, I slowly lifted my head higher and I met with the sun's blinding light.

The backlight made me squint my eyes. I knew for sure there was a very big man in front of me. I could barely see the figure in front of me, when suddenly something huge came between us and I stared down at it.

Flowers?

No, it was a very large bouquet.

A huge bouquet of flowers that I can't even hold with both arms. It looked so heavy and large, it seemed to weigh heavily because of the suffocating scent it was buried with. One could tell there were so many flowers in it since it produced such a vivid scent.

The bouquet of flowers was full of roses. The bouquet even had an orange rose, orange roses that were quite rare.

"Wow..." I gaped as I stared at the precious flower.

Was this where the scent I perceived came from? Now, I heaved my eyes higher toward the hidden man, covered by the bouquet of flowers. I can't see his face. Perhaps, the unseen man noticed what I was doing because the bouquet was descending little by little.

And when the flowers completely had gone down, I saw for the first time the face of the man that was smiling tenderly at me.

"Welcome back, my lovely dongsaeng, who is as lovely as a flower." It was a low, sweet baritone that rang around the base of the neck.

He had a very distinct tone, and his voice sounded reliable, as if he could take care of the most precious thing in the world. But I couldn't care less about the ecstatic voice.

I blinked my eyes wide...

Wait a minute, hold on!

His long bangs shook in front of my eyes, slightly covering his eyes. It was as dark as pitch black. Half up and half down, his hair looks great, but that was not what I was engrossed with.

My fingertips trembled wildly. Was this how people should feel whenever they sense something horrific?

The bloody-red eyes were staring at me and were softly bent.

Black hair, red eyes.

“Have you had a hard time coming back to me?” The man, boasting a slim silhouette like a black jaguar, leaned closer towards me.

“I’ve been waiting for you.” He spoke.

A chillingly beautiful voice spread deep into my ears- as it passed it seemed to be carving itself inside the walls of the cavity.

No, no you were not...

The chill that started at my fingertips continued to spread and travel all over my body and wrapped itself around my shoulders. I quickly clenched the fabrics of my dress.

<That’s strange...> Sally said. **<I’m sure that... she said there was only one daughter in the family.>**

Einte.

They said my family is like that. However, I couldn’t turn away from the truth that was lying before my eyes.

His astonishingly, neatly hawked Kravat, his straight forehead, white nose, and even his tempting, enticing eye as if he would not tolerate a single fine wrinkle...as if he were a sculpture made by God, a perfectly-made handsome man that smiles only for me.

But the only black hair, red eyes, that I knew, was that one remaining beauty that seemed to fascinate people.

“...Chaser.” I stated.

“Yes.” He said then, smiled sweetly. “Congratulations on your release, my dongsaeng.”

Ring ring, ring the bell. I could hear the sound of the arrow of truth piercing through my heart. It was an unavoidable truth. It was a truth I had never expected. Out of all the characters of this story, why should I be siblings with Chaser?

“Wait. My Iana.”

I was the villain’s younger sister!

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“Shall we go home?” He asked me gently, still showing his charming smile.

The second he gradually blinked his eyes and kissed me on the back of my hand, made me want to go back to my cell right away.

I’ll just be a prisoner! Give me my prison uniform back! Give it back!

But like how he caught my hand without warning, the situation I was in continued to flow like running water and I was powerless to go against the tide that carried me.

When I came back to my senses, I was already riding in a carriage with eight different horses tied to it.

“I was hoping to bring you a better carriage, just in case you were uncomfortable...” He murmured, his eyes drooping sullenly.

“It doesn’t seem enough for you.” With his needlessly pleasant voice mixed with gloom, I felt like I would become a bad person if I didn’t listen to the warnings inside my heart.

But my head, on the contrary, was in a state of absurdity...it was engrossed at the sight of the carriage before us.

Wasn't a small eight-horse carriage ride like a big one?.

I wanted to ask, but I kept my mouth shut. I thought I'd get a bigger answer if I asked. After that, I took a deep breath and stepped inside.

Let's calm down for now.

Even if I'm caught in a tiger's den, I'll live as long as I am vigilant ...then what do I do in the lair of this bloodstained tiger? Maybe the only way I can escape his clutches is for me to bleed out away from him.

I kept slipping into useless thoughts.

It was proof that I was out of my mind as of this moment. I carefully took deep breaths and slowly sorted out my thoughts.

'Yes, I wanted to do something, somehow.'

<However, the last time we talked about them, Countess Einte was a person from the South region.>

I remembered that moment when I was talking with Baron, who spoke confidently with his words, and with Sally. That was the moment we were trying to figure out to which family do I belong.

<I remembered one of my mother's acquaintances who had a little bit of connection with the Einte's, and I'm sure that... she said there was only one daughter in the family.> Those were Sally's words as well.

<It feels like Iana's burden to bear. Though for sure I expected it like there would be a great identity reveal.> Baron has these suspicions already, but I just steer clear of it.

<Isn't that just Baron's scammer-sense?> That's what I asked him, which was somewhat provoking.

<You can't ignore a swindler's instincts. Do you know how many times my gut feeling saved my life?> And again, there he was, Baron who had the string aura of being a fraud.

As of this time, I have decided to recognize Baron as a professional swindler. I should have been suspicious back then. I shouldn't have relied wholly on that handkerchief to give me the information I needed to establish who my family was.

That's right, Iana Einte. I recall I thought that the name combination was a bit odd..a little unbalanced.

Chapter 112: I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (3)

Chapter 112 – I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

I'm on the verge of self-destruction. I wanted to hurt myself. *How could I let this happen?*

I shook my face trying to erase these thoughts. Even though I was overreacting, I could not help but let myself drown in self-regret. I really wanted to hit, punch, or kick myself violently or throw myself in a pit. If only I could do that, I would. But... it's hopeless.

As of the moment, one of the things that I regret was leaving. I'm no longer Jair's reporter, if that's what you'd call what I used to do. Sometimes it makes me think of the times when I get to talk about things with him, even though all he did was give me orders or even suspect me of keeping secrets from him. After all, Jair was good to me. Most of all, I'm no longer Ricdorian's caretaker and trainer. I regret leaving the young man and the comfortable life I had in prison.

I can't believe anything could be worse than what I had in that prison. This might be it. This might be the "worse thing".

My fists trembled as these thoughts ran through my head.

I swept my face down roughly. I wanted to sigh deeply, but I couldn't. It felt as if I couldn't even breathe because there was a man staring at me. His eyes were so cold—as if those icy orbs could see right through me.

Chaser Rube Domulit.

He's the black rose of the empire, and the Duke of the Great Family that competes with the Hel... and the greatest villain of the book.

The man stooped his eyes and smiled affectionately as if he was ready to give me everything that I needed. His smile brought chills down my spine. I could feel my lips tremble.

"Do you need anything?" He asked.

"...huh?" I muttered, confused.

With his long legs crossed, he held one arm against the armrest of the chair, his head resting. I thought that the oblique angle I was seeing as of the moment, was a piece of art. He was one hell of a sight despite the cold aura he's portraying.

"I've been thinking about what you need." He said and cocked his head to the other side. "Well, do you want me to change the carriage in the middle of the trip?" He added.

Carriage? Why would he mention the carriage out of nowhere? I could feel my face turn into a complete "what?" expression, but he continued to talk.

"After all, twenty horses drive..." Chaser was really determined to explain it to me.

"No, no, no." I hurriedly opened my mouth, stopping him from speaking further.

Twenty? Why do you need twenty horses? Just for one carriage? That's such a waste of energy, and seriously unnecessary.

"No need." I added further, making sure that he will forget that proposal.

"Really?" Chaser smiled and I could tell that he was an amazingly gorgeous human being.

“Then shall I open the hood for you?” He asked.

...why would you open the hood of the carriage?

“Oh, that’s right. This time of the year got cold. I’m sorry.” He said, still smiling at me.

Did I hear him correctly? Did he say sorry? My eyes rolled over. I’m not used to it. He’s not the kind of person who would apologize.

“I have forgotten the fact that it is summer. So, would you like to have the coachman run next to you so you wouldn’t get bored?”

“...why is the coachman driving next to you?” I asked when I noticed a knight seated just beside him.

“Well then, let’s see him do a stunt.” Chaser stated.

“A stunt?” I asked. “Can he ride a horse upside down?”

...What’s wrong with the knight? Something’s not right here.

I felt a sense of repulsion as if I had been bossed around by Chaser, whom I seemed to have no feeling of inferiority.

“Don’t do it. I think you’re bothering the knight for nothing.” I told Chaser and saw his expression changed into a tight smirk.

“You’ve said that before.” He said.

Something about what Chaser said made me realize that the previous Iana was a woman with a proper mind. I was pleased to learn that Iana had an upright soul.

If it weren’t for what he said, I would have imagined a villainous brother and sister laughing at

the poor knight doing stunts...and wouldn’t that be because he said something nonsense?

“Well, you didn’t laugh a lot no matter what they showed you.” Chaser stated.

“I don’t think anyone would laugh at it.” I shot back at him.

“That’s right, you said that, too.” Chaser smiled gladly.

Finally, the true personality of the true Iana became clearer to me. Soon, he closed his eyes. I could tell he’s awake by the way he’s breathing.

“Oh, well, do you want me to breath out fire?” He said, jokingly.

“...let’s just go.” I brushed my face down again.

This man and the Chaser I knew from the book seem like a different person. Yes, it looked like he’s someone else. Because he felt somewhat odd.

What’s going on here? Did I do something that changed the entire book?

The biggest villain in the book, Chaser, was a half-crazy human and cold-blooded villain who could put a knife in his smiling face. Not a man who is so kind and unspoken.

“Not that one? Then what else do you need?” Chaser asked once again.

When will he ever stop asking me what I want?

“Please... I don’t need anything. Nothing.” I didn’t know what to say at all.

What do I need here anyway?

When I glanced inside the carriage there were flowers that had filled the floor. It was what he gave me a little while ago.

In addition, there were cushions. The chair was so comfortable and spacious that I thought I could lie down whenever I wanted to.

“I see.” Chaser glanced down. As his gaze went down, his long and black eyelashes fluttered softly. They’re so visible despite the scarcity of

illumination inside the carriage.

This man is one hell of a view. His face is a painted perfection. It's the kind of face any man would want to possess. It's also something someone would not get tired to look at. His loose flicker made me squeeze my hand. He's so handsome.

If he was ever a real person in real life, and not just a man from a book, it's like God really mixed up all the perfect ingredients to come up with such a pretty and seductive face. But I could sense a tinge of sadness from his eyes whenever he lowered them. What must be the reason behind it, then? Hmm.

I can't get used to it. I can't. I've only been here for a little while and it seemed like I could memorize every delicate detail of his appearance. This is not normal.

"Then what do you need?" Chaser asked one more time.

"...none." I immediately answered.

"None?" He asked then I nodded slowly.

"Come to think of it, I don't think it's a good idea." He whispered in a small ecstatic voice that was well-harmonized with his slick face.

What's not good about it?

"If I had asked the knight to do a stunt, then your eyes would only look at him. Well..." He gently rubbed his chin with a sullen face.

I could not understand how this man could turn so gloomy just because I refused to torture a knight?! If he doesn't look at it as torture, well it's improper... to make fun of someone.

He should have known a thing or two about "being in someone else's shoes". Well, he's a privileged rascal after all, who has never such thought in mind.

The journey still went on and we seemed to be passing by a rough and bumpy road. There was a long silence between Chaser and I and the lumps caused uncomfortable vibrations to the moving carriage.

From across where I was sitting, I could see Chaser's closed eyes beneath the hanging little tips of his hair. The moment he opened them, the red eyes subtly curved in a delicate manner as he breathed.

"You must not have been in a good mood." He rubbed his chin once again and spoke slowly. It was a voice of agony. Then he raised his head and looked at me.

"It's hard. I want to give you something good. But you keep on saying you don't need anything again, and again." He continued to say.

The previous Iana must have been very sharp in her refusal.

"But I'm used to it." He smiled convincingly. The curving eye tail once again created a breathtaking feeling.

"It's all right. Because it's you. I'll enjoy this." He conversed. It was a very sweet voice, but I couldn't tell how the voice kept me from being relaxed.

Chapter 113: I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (4)

Chapter 113 – I Was The Villain's Younger Sister (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

No. Set aside your thoughts first, Iana. If I were this man's younger sister anyway, it was something I should keep looking at from now on. What's the point of getting stressed out if it's already like this?

That's right. First and foremost, I should get some rest. Dragging my mind to overthink this situation would only burn out my thoughts. I should give this a rest.

"I thought of something that I needed." I told him and put on a little smile on my lips.

He lifted his eyes. The ruby-red eyes seemed to glow like how jewels illuminated lights. The tips of the thin, curved eyes looked white like snow. Unlike his ascetic worn body, his eyes were savage.

Not being mistaken, but his face was like that of a child waiting for his snack. I'm not saying he's innocent, but he's full of expectations.

...I've abandoned a puppy behind, but why do I feel like I'm facing a bigger beast?

"What is it?" Chaser asked, a wide smile painted all over his face.

"Sleep." I answered.

“...sleep?” He asked, confirming what he just heard.

I nodded. Yes, sleep.

Somehow, he turned his head for a moment and smiled. Even that appearance was very aristocratic. In many ways, Chaser was unarguably handsome, but he was a man who didn't fit the word cute at all.

I paused for a moment. First, I'll have to lay down my body with eyes open. It would be hard for me to close them immediately knowing the fact that I can't trust anyone here. I might wake up with a knife on my throat, or not ever wake up at all, because I was murdered.

“I haven't had enough sleep while I was in prison.” I told him and he suddenly looked distressed.

“...was the bed in there uncomfortable for you?” He asked.

“Not exactly.” I answered.

“Who bothered and harassed you?” His face was serious this time. I should tell him to calm down.

“Not that either.” I stated.

I replied firmly because I felt that he would turn the carriage around if I said the wrong thing here.

“I'm just tired.” I added, to assure him that I was not bothered.

This man. He's a tall man, with broad shoulders and he's big. Remembering the time when he handed me those bouquet of flowers, his shadow surrounded me like an eclipse. His sleek silhouette didn't feel like it was insipid and soulless, but rather incessant.

“...sleep.” He plainly stated.

He grabbed his chin and relapsed into agony. Holding the chin seemed to be a habit of him when he was in grievance.

Soon, he clasped his both hands.

“Shall I put on a pillow on my lap?” He asked.

...what? I looked at him for a moment, wondering if he had eaten something wrong. A sense of bewilderment prevailed over me, but I should keep calm and be still...it may be possible that they were those kinds of siblings that were doing this sort of thing.

I have always wondered about it from reading the letters I received from him when I was in prison. Those could mean a lot of things but when I met him in the cell before, his words and actions were all too much. Maybe, just maybe... he's that kind of a brother.

But still, those weren't enough proof. I might have misread them or interpreted them differently.

Chaos is here. I must ask him about this without hiding anything. But how? What else can I do?

“We used to do that, huh?” I was asking out of sheer curiosity. But Chaser burst out laughing.

“No?” I asked. “But then?” I further added.

He opened his smiling eyes slightly.

“No tree will stand firm if chopped ten times. I try to take things like a tree.” He stated. I could not get where he's going with this.

“...Usually, I give up on a tree that doesn't fall after I chopped it ten times.” He further added.

“That's too much.” I said, not really understanding what he meant.

He made a gloomy look again. I haven't noticed that I have been rubbing my cheeks in confusion. But he didn't seem to mind my reaction. So, I guess that's the end of our conversation. *Nice try, Iana.*

“I’ll sleep well.”

In fact, I didn't know how Iana had acted before. When I first knew that I had someone called brother, I was so eager to dig into my family relations, but my motivation suddenly disappeared.

What if he thinks I've been acting weird? But I guess it wouldn't be a big deal for him. He'll understand. Knowing that her sister has just got out of prison, surely, he must have already imagined that the Iana that got out was a little different from the Iana before... or may be the same. Any person who came from prison would have changed values and seen life more differently. Prison changes people, and that's a fact.

I thought it was a very comfortable idea, but I was already overloaded by the fact that my ‘oppa’ in front of me was Chaser.

“Yes, sleep well. Iana.” He replied with a calm voice.

Chaser relaxed his face as if he had been sulky, and gently shook his hand with his chin up. It was an act that was both elegant and alluring.

Not long after, I closed my eyes from him. But before that, I could see the carriage door opened slightly through the blurred vision. I guess there wouldn't be any harm if I sleep on this huge chair right now.

“... drive the carriage slowly.” I could hear Chaser’s voice talking to someone.

I hoped my situation would change after I slept. But I knew it wouldn't happen.

“I wish you to have a good dream now.” Chaser whispered.

It was just a moment before my eyes closed, he seemed to have hesitated. However, it disappeared from my memory as if it had been a dream.








“Um...”

When I opened my eyes, the carriage had already stopped, or was I just dreaming it? Looking around, it still looks like I was still inside the carriage. Not long after, I saw a huge window, then I realized that the carriage door was wide open. The sun had already tilted a lot indicating that it had been a late afternoon.

Soon, I opened my eyes wide while looking at the window.

Wow, where am I? And what kind of building would have a window that big?

“Huh...” I mumbled to myself.

A huge mansion was in front of me. It wasn't an exaggeration, but it was a scale that I couldn't really measure. It looked amazing just by looking at a part of this place.

I was thinking about how the person living inside this place would feel and then I realized that it was me.

Ugh, I'm still tired even though I slept. I felt sore at the back of my neck. The chair in the carriage was so soft but it was not that good for lying down and sleeping.

“Ah...hem.” Chaser suddenly came out of nowhere while I was in the middle of yawning.

I stopped yawning droopily and paused. It was because I faced a pair of eyes staring at me.

I was surprised.

...what, why aren't you even showing signs of that you are there?

“...O..ppa?” I said, with a sleepy expression.

“Yes.” Chaser answered with a smile. It was a natural response coming from him unlike me who finds it awkward addressing him as oppa.

“Did we arrive?” I asked him.

“Yes.” Chaser answered in a calm sweet voice. It was like honey was melting slowly and gently.

“When?” I asked further.

“About an hour ago?” Chaser replied.

“What?” I asked, completely astounded.

I felt embarrassed. He should have at least woken me up from my deep slumber to keep him from waiting.

Chapter 114: Home Sweet Home (1)

Chapter 114 – Home Sweet Home (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

If we had arrived an hour ago, why have they not woken me up? They could have also left me behind. Or maybe even carried me inside the palace if they didn't want to wake me...

Either way, I find it difficult to understand why he'd rather wait.

"Why didn't you get off?" I asked him.

"I was worried," he answered me.

Worried? What was there to worry about?

"You were in such deep slumber, I found it difficult to wake you up." He said and gave me a stiff smile. It made him look awkward. What was more awkward was how I just kept staring at him in silence.

As if he read my mind not too long ago, he continued to explain his actions.

"I did think about carrying you myself as you slept soundly, but I had been worried." He mused, absentmindedly bringing up a hand to brush his chin in thought, "If I had proceeded to carry you, I would have woken you up. That would make me feel sorry."

That's weird.

If this was the Chaser I knew from the book, it would be more than likely he would have woken me up, greeting me with a malicious smile. Did I misunderstand him when I was reading?

He had done so many crazy things in the book. Anyone who knows the content of the book will probably expect it like that, I'm almost sure of it. There were already countless lives lost because of those hands.

I knew I had just woken up from a sound sleep, but I still couldn't get used to how different his appearance is from the book's description.

"You could've just shook me if that's what you're worried about," I mumbled, and he chuckled back.

"Then you would have woken up, and made me no less guilty."

"And why would you?" I snapped irritably, "You could've gone on ahead. You didn't have to wait, I didn't ask you to."

Wow, was waking me up that difficult? I blinked slowly.

"Really? Then I would have carried you anyway and we'd be back to the problem all over. I didn't want to wake, nor leave you, is that so hard to understand?" Chaser told me almost chidingly, chuckling at my irritance. "Shall we get off then?" he hummed when he realized I wouldn't have accepted any.

I waited for the moment he would say so. And the door opened as if it was waiting for his magic words. Chaser got up first from his seat and got out of the carriage.

As I was about to get off the carriage following him, a hand popped out before my eyes. It was Chaser's hand.

His hands looked white, big, and firm. But what surprised me more was to see a scar on his fingertips.

'Hmm, I think I got away with the villain.' I looked at him and his hands alternately.

The basics of manners in this world are definitely different from the world I used to live in. It will take awhile for me to catch up on these things.

Just as I was about to take the hand, thinking it was just there to aid me, I felt the ground disappear beneath my feet. My world seemingly shifted on its axis, and then strong arms cradled me against a warm chest...

I was lifted...

I was being carried...

“Ah.”

And just as quick as I was carried, I was quickly put down.

The ground beneath my feet was a welcome sensation...

Still...

For him to be able to lift me like that... as if I weighed no more than a feather...

Just how strong was he, truly?

“Are you surprised?” he asked me with a slight lilt in his voice, as if he found my reaction amusing.

“Oh, uh? A little...”

He dropped his eyes down. The eyelashes were clearly visible.

“I’m sorry. I didn’t think of that.” A deep and profound voice filled my ears. He seemed quite apologetic, as if he wanted me to not be crossed with him.

There was that velvety voice once again. It really does wonders to my nerves. If he was a modern day radio announcer, I would have no doubts he’d gather a large fanbase, even if he was placed in the late night slot.

I took my hand off his firm shoulders.

But I was a little curious. I have yet to see him so surprised by my thoughts. Was he faking it? Or did he just not notice anything was amiss with me?

Perhaps the reason why he doesn't complain about my reactions was that my behavior is already closely similar to the previous **'Iana.'**

If that wasn't the case, then I have to wonder. Would he even recognize my different reaction from the former **'Iana'**? Or would he chalk it up as a result of my imprisonment?

Oh, there was something that reminded me.

"Oppa, do you remember when you stopped by the prison, met me in a secluded place then gave me a handkerchief?"

Chaser hesitated. When I turned around, he had a soft face.

"I remember. Why?"

"The handkerchief you gave me then, why did you give me something that wasn't in our family?"

"Hmm," he hummed in thought, barely bothered by it, "Well, that was the only thing I had."

Was it really? I couldn't help but think.

"The province is famous for its beautiful fabrics. The embroidered fabric, which is dedicated to Einte, is of the highest grade." Chaser's hand dropped with a slight tap on my shoulder.

I felt like there was a different explanation from what he had told me.

Did he rip it off of someone?

No way. It would have not been a bluff, it must have been obtained legally. But remembering Chaser's line of work, I quickly accepted his explanation.

As beautiful as a statue, he was a man worthy of the name *'King of Crime'*. In the meantime, Chaser smiled gently.

“After all, you’re going to use it.” He told me, “And I can’t give you something useless even if it’s for a very small use, hardly befitting for a sister of mine, don’t you think?”

I gave him a lighter nod. I was only curious about the origin of the handkerchief because it had given me a huge misunderstanding. At least now I understood it a little better.

“Shall we go inside?”

He held out his hand. Each of his actions were very natural. But I didn’t hold that hand while I was thinking about how Iana would have acted.

“Uh. Can I go in?”

I can’t be the former Iana anyway. I don’t know, and I don’t have the confidence to act that naturally as if I was someone else. I can’t help but only be me.

Furthermore, it would be better to act as I usually do. That way if he doesn’t like it, I could get kicked out. That would be a huge weight off my shoulders actually. I’d be free and living in peace.

Chapter 115: Home Sweet Home (2)

Chapter 115 – Home Sweet Home (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

Perhaps the sleep did do me some good. I've lost some few worries I've previously had, and regained a sense of clarity. Being alone in this world would be actually preferable.

"This way." Chaser didn't say much, even though I didn't hold hands, and ignored him.

Judging by our interactions so far, I think he was more interested in the person *Iana* had become since prison. More so than he ever did before...

But that's only mere speculation on my part. We shall see more as the events progress, I suppose.

As soon as Chaser and I went inside the mansion, I was quickly led towards a room through long corridors. But what surprised me the most was that he guided me personally without letting someone take charge of me.

I would have assumed he'd be too busy to guide his dear little sister to her quarters. Surely even the servants, or lackeys, or whoever's around could handle this part.

Only then when I had arrived at my room did I find myself unsurprised by what I saw.

"This is your new room."

“Uh...”

Perhaps he did notice a few differences a while after all. The sight of the room before me made me feel faint. I might have even paled at the sight of it.

Such a long line was my only thought.

What I thought was my room wasn't a room, but another long corridor. Lined on both sides were numerous maids, in their black uniforms, all standing at attention...

I felt like I was getting ready to be walked down a presidential procession.

<..*huh*>

I wondered how many pairs of eyes would be watching me with this many people to greet us. Just the thought of it made me feel frozen and stiff in place. The fact that the tension forced me to straighten up my own back was because I didn't want them to pay much attention to me.

I'm a person who wants to live a life of peace and ease... I was not the kind of person who wanted attention in this way.

And so we walked, and as we walked, they greeted us amicably. Surprisingly, Chaser was kind and friendly to the servants. It wasn't what I was expecting. Not from him, at least.

<*You can go back.*> The voice he used when talking to them was so gentle.

This was also unfamiliar territory. And it's times like this I keep coming back to my knowledge taken from the books.

This person in the books was indeed very different here. Chaser was painted as a cruel man, who would abuse and decimate any one he deemed lesser than himself.

We've finally passed through the long corridor, and I couldn't help but feel relieved and exhausted. All I did was walk with the stairs of who knows

how many eyes on me. I had even completely missed Chaser explaining the details with regards to my room.

“I don’t know if you like the new room.” he told me, “Due to some circumstances, we are unable to use the room we have had before.”

“Huh? Oh, yeah.”

Only then did I raise my head and look at the doorknob. It’s a very luxurious door handle. Something like a bird was engraved on it.

Come to think of it, while we’re walking all the way here, I saw a bird or a four-legged cat and a beast. It seemed to me that I had seen the same sculptures all over the place. Ought I saw the same piece carved here and there. The most visible thing I could see was none other than the black rose.

“First of all, since the sun is down, take a good rest until dinner time. I’ll visit you on time for the meal.”

I tried to pull the doorknob and turned my head. He’s coming here in person for dinner time? Why won’t he send someone else? Why not one of the maids lined up in the hallway earlier?

“Why are you coming here in person?”

Again this time my lips opened without even thinking much of what I was about to say. His eyes seemed to be appraising me for a moment. “Because I want to?” He had stated, quite uncertain before he cackled and laughed out loud.

Suddenly I’m taken back to my previous image of villains. People who’d maniacally laugh as they swung their swords haphazardly. Uncaring and unnerved by the blood they would spill...

It’s so different here.

I read in the books was a madman so cruel and vindictive. But here...

I’m faced with nothing but the soft version of a brother.

“Oh, I see,” I said.

I nodded coolly. I wanted to go in and rest because I didn't feel all better. Soon, the door was closed with Chaser's face behind it. With a sigh, I raised my head and was surprised.

“...what? so wide?”

There was a living room in front of me, the size of a playground. Looking back, it was a room. But it's a room that's bigger than a living room.

Yes, the right word is the living room, usually as big as a few living rooms in an ordinary apartment.

The problem was that this was very new to me, who had lived in a small cell all the time. This was so unfamiliar.

I was a small citizen in the previous world, it's probably hard to adapt to this new setting.

“This is it. First and foremost, I feel like I'm a Cinderella.”

I brushed my hair up and stood. The long hair was casually untied, but the one-piece I wore was unsuitably luxurious and extremely soft.

It was a gift from Chaser about a week before I was released from prison. At that time, I thought he was a really affectionate brother.

“When I finally got out of prison, I prayed that I had no plain clothes to wear.” At first, I thought Iana was a poor prisoner. I was worried if I should wear a prison uniform when I get out of prison.

“I wish I won't wear a jumpsuit anymore.”

But...is this really a good situation?

The scheme that I have been drawing when I was still in my cell was to wait comfortably for the time of my release and then to live in a quiet place where pastoral scenery could be seen.

YOLO, to put it mildly, that's all you say. It's all about getting loose.

At this time. I'm in a world where I don't know. It's better to be comfortable and not get tired than uncomfortable.

I was only grateful that the unemployed, the person who had no money to earn before, was someone who came from a noble family in this world and therefore a noble prisoner.

Even so, the problem is that my family is not the great Count Einte family in the East...because it was the villainous family in the eyes of the storm.

I took a deep breath and sat on the bed. It feels like I walked for three minutes to the bed.

It's so big.

I rolled my dress up to my thighs, put one leg on the other, and put my chin with my arm on it.

That's strange.

Chapter 116: Home Sweet Home

(3)

Chapter 116 – Home Sweet Home (3)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

“This is serious. Why don’t I feel nervous?” I thought.

Is it because the Chaser I see right now is completely different from what was described in the book? But I’m sure that’s not the only thing bothering me right now. I knew myself well.

I used to be very relaxed and easygoing when I heard jeers from my acquaintances. I’ve never been nervous when I took the college entrance exam. I always wondered why I never did. Some people would get sweaty and shaky and stuff like that, but I was the complete opposite.

One reason was that I always believed getting nervous would never benefit me in any situation I could end up with... like exams. Fidgeting will never help and the result will come out as much as we did anyway.

This was how I felt. This was no different even now.

I decided to shake myself from the thought of being too relaxed by this current situation. Thinking too much made me forget how admirable the bed was. It was soft in a way that’s beyond any bed I have ever seen or laid upon.

I continued to trace the bed’s soft surface with my hand. This must be how it feels if you sit on clouds. I giggled at the thought and jumped with my butt. It was so satisfying, and I felt like a child once again.

Looking at the bed wonderfully, I saw the inscription on the bedside. I was surprised that I could read it although the symbols were not from my world. When I opened my eyes in this world, in Iana's body, I knew I could read this world's writings based on some letters I've written from before. I somehow shared some of Iana's knowledge.

The letters were carved in beautiful cursive form on a piece of wood cut. I've read the spelling very carefully.

"...Iana." I said. "Iana Rose Domulit." I mumbled it.

"This is my name." I thought.

I gently caressed the letters with my hands and laid my back down. I covered my face with one hand and muttered.

"...Iana Rose Domulit." That's a pretty name.

Born in a rose, her name is a rose.

It may be possible that I would have changed the nature of the story the moment I had crossed the dimension.

To be honest, I was simply a human being. I wasn't fully tired now, but when I laid my back, I fell asleep not long after.

"Oh, my brother said he was coming in person..." I mumbled just before I drifted to sleep. Thinking of this made me stop the urge to sleep a little. I wanted to open my eyes but my eyelids felt too heavy for me to move them. Great o' slumber is really pulling me back in. I hope it's okay if I just give in and sleep.

I tried to blink and closed my eyes deeply. After a long time, something seemed to have moved by the bedside.

I turned around holding only what was draped over my body. For some reason, I felt like I had a dream of flying in the sky and then sinking back down again.

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When I opened my eyes again, my sense of hearing was so clear that I was able to depict sounds rather than see the surroundings. How long did I sleep?

Chirp, chirp, chirp chirp.

The clear chirping of birds sounded pleasantly. I woke up and rubbed my eyes, then raised my upper body. I seem to have slept too long.

“...Oh, it’s morning.” I mumbled in between yawns.

I stared at the nearest window as soon as I sat up on the bed. I wonder what time it is. As what I could see beyond the window, the sun still isn’t way up on the blue sky, so it’s not yet midday. I could see the source of the chirps from a nearby tree. I followed the birds with my eyes as they flew into the fresh morning sky and the chirps somehow started to diminish as they flew away.

Wait, morning?

Ugh. I opened my eyes wide. The hazy slumber was gone suddenly out of nowhere. I moaned, exhaled, and swept my face down. This bed did not fail to hypnotize me with its soft and alluring powers. I just sighed at the thought. I can’t believe that just happened.

Wow, I’ve really slept a whole day and a half huh? I must have been really worn out from the inside the moment I surrendered myself to bed. Still, I feel too tired to get up. I guess sleeping too much is as tiresome as lacking sleep. I shook my head in amusement.

“Amazing.” I mumbled.

But I tried to forget it quickly. What can I do if I already slept? I soon got up and tilted my head instead of putting on slippers. The marbled floor is cold. I stretched as I yawned once more, reminding my muscles that we’re not asleep anymore.

Strange. Did I fall asleep in the middle of the bed? Apparently, I'm sure I fell asleep uncomfortably thinking that Chaser might come.

'I guess he rolled me over.'

Thinking insignificantly, I dragged my slippers to the door. The clothes were exactly what I wore yesterday.

Oh no, I'm hungry. First, I have to go out and call someone.

It was the moment I opened the door when I heard some arguments.

"Yes, you do. Huh?"

"No. You do it! You left it up to me, you know."

When I opened the door, there was a scuffle between two women not far away. I glanced up the door. The door is opening without a sound. That's strange.

Are doors here different by spending too much money? I'm pretty sure they must have someone check up on the hinges to see if they make a sound every day; or they pay someone to make sure the hinges are free from rust or corrosion or things that would make it give a sound when it moves. Anyhow, that's funny... and practically unnecessary.

"No! Now, if you do something wrong..."

"Hello." I greeted out loud with a smile. They stopped arguing the moment they heard me.

The two women in maids' uniform shrugged. Quirky, they turned their heads and directly lowered them down. They looked scared like they've seen a ghost or something like that. I could even see that one of them had her eyes tightly shut while her head was bowed down.

You don't have to act it like you've seen a ghost in a horror movie. I'm not going to eat you!

“Oh, hello, miss. I’m sorry. Our voices are loud, so...” One of the maid stated. I could sense she was nervous, or scared of me? I’m not quite sure.

“No, no. That’s fine.” I told them and gave them a smile.

I just shook my hand to keep them from talking hoping that they would understand what I meant. The two maids looked at each other as soon as they noted that my voice was not angry or annoyed. I lowered my head for a second and I saw one of the maids mumble something to the other one. They must have thought I wasn’t able to see it.

“Well, I’m hungry.” I told them immediately after they mumbled something to each other.

“I’ll prepare breakfast right away!” The maid said in a really loud voice.

Oops. It’s okay if it’s not this loud. *My goodness*. Rather, I was surprised that it made me narrow my eyes. However, I couldn’t make it obvious when I saw them with pale faces. Maybe the maids in this world are really trained to talk like this, like they’re announcing something every time they say something to their masters.

“Again, we’ll come back to you once it’s done!” The maid stated and they immediately took their leave.

I scratched my cheek at the rushing girls. They really talk too loud huh. I guess I’ll have to get used to that now that I live here. That’s interesting yet strange... but I’ll take note of that.

“Looking at this...” I blurted to myself.

The villains’ mansion is really a villainous mansion.

Chapter 117: Home Sweet Home

(4)

Chapter 117 – Home Sweet Home (4)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

To be honest, I almost got confused when I saw Chaser yesterday. But I can't think too much about it now. It's pointless.

There won't be any problems. *I hope there won't be.* Not long after, I closed the door behind me and roamed around the room for a while then walked straight to one place.

What I had in my hand was parchment paper and pen. Fortunately, the pen was moist with ink so that it could be used at any time as if it were new.

“...I have to try some things I couldn't do yesterday.” I told myself, almost whispering.

Yesterday was so exhausting and traumatizing because of the extended prison life and the sudden appearance of Chaser overlapped. Now that I've felt more light, all I'm trying to do is simply write things down. I can't miss out on something.

Books, leads, villains all the whole time. I used to ruminate on this, but I never thought of the exact contents. I just thought that the male lead was in prison, the villain was a rival and a sub man, and that it was better to be vaguely good.

But what should I do now that I have come into the eye of the storm?

Even if I try to look back on my memory, I must find a way to live well.

“...I knew he had a sister.” I mumbled.

But...How would I know it was me?

Shaking my head, I walked toward the table and sofa across from where I’m standing. Something caught my attention and I suddenly stopped.

“A carpet?”

As my room is big, I thought there would be all sorts of special things, like this carpet before my very eyes.

But what kind of carpet was hung on the wall? I just stopped without knowing it. There’s already a thick carpet on the floor. After watching carefully, I realized it was a fabric decoration, not a carpet.

Oh, I’m also very ignorant. I smiled at my stupidity, tried to pass over it but I turned my head again.

“Huh?”

Wait a minute...

The engraving on the ornament was a geometric figure. A geometric figure that was familiar.

Where did I see it? I kept thinking as I was tapping my lips. Then my hand stopped.

“...That’s right! I saw it on the hidden cavity in the basement cell, didn’t I?” I could feel my eyes were so wide when I realized I was almost shouting to myself. That’s embarrassing. Anyway, I looked at the hung carpet once again.

A large circle overlaps with small circles in it, and in the innermost circle is where a diamond or diamond shape is placed. It was quite similar.

That's what I saw in the inside of the underground cell where the hole suddenly appeared.

I tilted my head closer and closer to the cloth ornament. If there's anything different from what I saw in that place....At that time, that would be the many roses.

"There are only black roses here." I whispered.

Inside the diamond was a black rose. At the same time, what appeared to be a bird's wing was spread out like a rose, and the teeth and claws of the beast were woven together with the string like thorns.

Mmm, is this really a coincidence? Or was this geometric figure common in this place?

I pulled it out because the decoration material was interesting, but it seems that the material was more lively than I thought.

Ripped.

It was torn!

"Huh... I didn't even hold it with much strength." I could feel my palms were cold from being anxious this time. I must be imagining this. This can't be easily ripped, right?

I was captivated that I gave out a perplexing laugh because of the ripped-off ornament and the wall exposed behind the tear.

Uh, what do I do? '...I won't be kicked out because of this, right?'

No, I'm fine with him kicking me out. If he asks me for a little money when he's kicking me out, I'm going to crumble. Wait, no! Chaser won't do that. He couldn't possibly ask me for some money. He's rich!

This can't be happening.

"It sucks."

I was so good at reasoning with myself. Thinking so, I folded the torn piece of ornament and looked at the wall again, what to do. Oops. I soon moved my hands to get rid of the ragged parts.

“What? The wall had the same patterns on it?” I grew more curious as I continued to move the carpet.

The geometric patterns embroidered on the cloth were also carved on the wall. The only difference was that the pattern seen on the cloth was cut in half. It was only the half piece.

On top of that, there were only black roses on the cloth, while on this wall, several roses could be seen just like what I saw on the cavity inside Ridorian’s cell. In addition, the image of the animal, which I’m not really sure if it is an animal, was the same as the one I saw in prison.

Although it was cut in half.

Well, let’s see. Are those empty spots where red and white roses are supposed to be? Somehow, I felt a bit uncomfortable that there were no symbols of the male and the female leads of this book in this wall.

As I keenly looked over the wall, I saw a small symbol next to the half cut pattern.

“A sign? No, it looks like a painting...”

It was a picture of a door...a tightly closed door. There was another door drawn beside that door... a door that is wide open. Furthermore, there was an arrow pointed on the open door which was drawn using words.

“You will see everything special.” I couldn’t take off my eyes on the words even after reading it.

The door. This door. It must have something to do with what I’ve seen in Ricdorian’s cell. The figures, the symbols, and the colors. Everything! They’re all the same. There must be an answer to all of this, a connection. But what is it?

Surely, there must be something behind this wall next to my room. That's where the door from the ornament was pointed. There has to be. Half of this whole ornament must be next door, or maybe this was intended to be just presented in half?

Who does such a thing? I've never heard artists or painters from my world making something that is only half of a whole picture that could have been a result of pure symmetry.

Ah, I see. As usual, I couldn't let go of my thoughts easily. When I looked up, I decided to step down a little. I didn't want myself to get bothered with this. Now that I'm in a different situation.

Relax, Iana.

But I couldn't relax. I'm curious.

Fine, let's dig a little further, Iana.

When I opened the door of my room, the hallway was quiet. No one even passed by.

I opened the door right next to mine because I didn't have time to feel strange here. No way, I didn't think so. It was my state's intention not to let things go by just in case. The next room was empty. It was similar to my room, except for the bed, furthermore there was almost no furniture.

“Well, the location of the bed and the bookshelf are similar. “

One thing in common was that the room was decorated with cloth.

However, this cloth ornament had no patterns and was plain red. I approached it without delay and shook the clothes up.

I knew it. It seems that the assumption that I was supposed to have was correct. The other half was engraved on the exposed wall.

“Hey, that was a quick answer.”

I found it amazing but at the same time ridiculous. But overall, really clever.

What the heck...this is not even an escape room. Jeez, but my situation right now was like that of an escape room.

I was right! The picture of the door drawn in my room pointed to the door next to my room. Furthermore, the arrow was like really asking someone to go in. So I did, didn't I?

I couldn't help but admire myself for being too curious... and clever for figuring it out.

I burst out laughing.

Nice one, Iana.

Surely, I didn't know this would be right.

Yet, here I am.

Chapter 118: As expected, this genre is a waste (1)

Chapter 118 – As expected, this genre is a waste (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

And there was another symbol, a picture, in this room. The picture of the door I saw in my room and this, were not just carved on the wall, but seemed to have been scratched with a knife.

Who could have possibly done this? From the look of it, carving the picture using a knife seemed like a very tedious process. There could have been other possible ways, right? They could have hired a skilled wall carver... and there are supposed to be other tools... but this?

I narrowed my eyes as I looked at the wall.

“Hmm...by the way, there’s nothing else aside from the red rose. If I remember correctly, was there an animal next to it when I was in the cell?” I whispered to myself.

In the cell, there was a strange-looking animal next to the red rose, but there was only a red rose on this wall. Furthermore, next to the white rose is a beast crouching as if it was holding a rose from what I’ve seen in the cell.

Not long after my wander, I went back to my room. If I try to roam any further, my attention would easily divert.

Then I squatted down in front of the table and started what I was going to do with parchment paper and the pen. The work of ruminating the original plot.

I don't know what the relationship between the roses and the animals and the patterns is, but it won't be too late for me to know once I finish this.

"Okay Iana, let's start from the beginning." I told myself, and let out a deep breath.

It started when the heroine went to the Kambrakam cell because of a crime.

The pen pressed down on the parchment. I could only hear the sound of the pen scraping against the surface of the stiff parchment paper resonating inside the room. But soon my hand holding the pen stopped. I stared at my hand holding the pen, and then on the parchment paper.

It felt strange.

No. This is a rated-19 romance novel with a love triangle. Or at least that's how this story was supposed to be. There's still a lot of other things going on in between the scenes aside from the events and information I just gathered along the way. There are more things aside from the contents. In fact, there were a number of them I could remember.

Several scenes, in the cell, in the bed, in the lawn, and three people moving... But instead of writing, a so-called "reality hit" came to me.

"No, no. The moment I was out of the cell, I should think back about it."

I didn't panic and calmly drew a line and wrote the word scenes, and little by little recalled the contents and events of the novel.

This time, the normal contents gradually lined up. The more my hands went down writing, the stranger my expression grew. I could say it was because of the tightness I could feel on my forehead. I have been frowning all this time, that somehow, I could not return my face to its resting expression no matter how hard I tried to relax.

"...It wasn't just a rated-19 novel because it was erotic." I mumbled to myself, and this time, I felt my lips smirked.

I read the scenes that I wrote.

–In the cell, the prisoner held the hand of the heroine. (Support)

–The person who tried to sell the heroine to another country was taken away and dragged to death.

-The heroine and her sister were dragged into a coal mine.

– Reporter trying to stalk the heroine suddenly crippled.

-The mysterious death of an aristocrat who was obsessed with the heroine in the social circle.

– Those with resentment explode the villain's house with bombs.

-The female lead's escape from imprisonment...

The moment I read this far, I let out a long, deep breath. I wrote until the ending, and I didn't need to read it any further. In addition, there were some that came to my mind, but there was no need to write it anymore.

I've already made up my mind.

That's it. This is it.

Somehow, all the scenes I've jotted down were about the villains' journeys. Not all of them were Chaser because there's about Lenag's as well, but most of them were of Chaser's.

Has this novel gone like that? It's not a love triangle... not at all...

Strange.

It was not the time to worry about the heroine, who will be imprisoned in the future.

'... will my neck get cut off first?' I wasn't just saying it. It was real. There's a huge possibility that I might even end up being the first one to die.

The afternoon glow of the sun somehow made its way to my room's side windows. A thin ray crept to the edge of the bed and I stared at it for a while. I stood up, and made my way towards where the sun's ray was directed, and turned my back on it to see my silhouette from across the room.

I was ready to go out. My silhouette grew smaller and smaller as I made my way to the door, until it disappeared, revealing the thin ray once again. I closed the door of my room to take my leave and there was no sound. All these doors...they still give me a strange feeling by the fact that they don't click or crunch or tweak even a little when they're being moved.

Although I was determined to go off in the morning, it was not something that could be done immediately. I can't just go empty-handed. Anyway, I haven't familiarized myself with the geography of this zone. Furthermore, I'm going to take a look at some of the housekeeping.

When I thought I was an Einte, I had this little desire to live as a high-ranking aristocrat but it suddenly disappeared. It was because I thought it would be a good idea for me to work in a bakery and live a normal life in a quiet neighborhood. Moreover, it is also a skill to set such a simple goal.

Well yeah, I'm not suddenly asking for a bakery. When I was in prison a long time ago, I heard about the bakery from Young-Ae, who was a cell mate of mine. She had been a maid because her half-brothers bullied her, and from her story, which could not be heard without tears, she found that the empire had a better urban system than expected, and that there was a bakery in a quiet city where wheat was the staple food.

Chapter 119: As expected, this genre is a waste (2)

Chapter 119 – As expected, this genre is a waste (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Eyeful Solstice

In addition, there was something I had learned from this mansion while thinking about it.

“hmm... it’s snack time again.” I whispered. I scurried back to my room when I remembered. The maids might wonder why I wasn’t there at this hour. I’m still full but perhaps I could entertain some more food.

We had breakfast in the morning, had dessert prepared for after an hour for some reason, and even tea after tea time an hour later.

This I knew, for the duration I’ve spent here.

Oh, this place has the heart and generosity that feeds people even though they’re full, just like in Korea, before Chaser lost his humanity. But full generosity in a villains’ mansion were words that didn’t fit with each other just like peppermint on milkshakes.

I said good things are the best and my stomach was satisfied. It’s better to have a kind mansion than to eat in a harsh place that could be usually read in a book. I might not have even lasted for more than three days if I ended up on the streets; where there could be thieves and murderers.

As I was knocking on my bursting stomach that morning, Chaser came in. Oh, correction, he wasn’t rough enough to rush in. He opened the door and showed up with a very graceful step.

“Iana, did you sleep well?” He asked as his entire being entered my room.

I looked up at the sky instead of answering. Well, the time was already past 2 p.m. which was not exactly the right time to ask if I had slept well.

“I don’t think that’s the right time to ask.” I replied.

He smiled slightly when I replied with a face that was neither laughing nor grumpy. It was a friendly smile that was not different from the day before.

“But I’m always curious. I’ve been curious once again. Whether you sleep well or eat well.” He said.

If that’s the case, it’s better if you didn’t send me to jail. I didn’t spit it out to that extent. Chaser didn’t look angry even though I fell asleep the day before without a word. On the contrary, he seemed to have a softer and more charming smile than before.

“As you can see, I’m well.” I answered to fill his curiosity.

“Yeah, it looks like it.” He said as he clapped casually and came closer to me. “I have something to show you.” He uttered, making me curious.

“You want to see it?” He added.

He seemed to have decided to take it naturally no matter how I reacted. I was confused yesterday, but now I am convinced that this was Chaser. I nodded my head as if I was having great pleasure.

“Would you like to come with me?” He asked.

Come to think of it, he was also a great duke of the empire. Oh, isn’t it now? Even so, duke is now also a position of power. That would mean there’s a lot of work to do. He must be a very busy man based on his position. But he still managed to visit me once in a while.

If Ricdorian’s father was only trash inside the house, Chaser’s father was considered trash outside. He was authoritative and rather than busy with

writing and filling his position, he had a great pleasure in wielding his swords.

Because of this, Chaser has been working as a duke since childhood, which was also a sentence in the book describing him.

The reason I remember this was because, in the book, this man said, ***‘I am a bad guy, but I had a story and was deprived.’***

I felt sad at the time. Reading that makes me pity him.

“Are you not busy?” I asked him.

“Yes, I’m not busy.” He replied back. Chaser naturally took my hand and kissed the back of it.

“I’m not always going to be busy in front of you.” Chaser added.

He was neatly dressed today as well. Looking at the tightening of the pants or wrinkle-free suits, I thought it was a very ascetic dress unlike his face. Even though he’s like this, in the book, and when he’s in bed... He was like that, by the way, always... having that seductive face.

‘and the body... that big.’ I felt my face flushed from realizing what the hell was I thinking.

‘Oh no, think of good thoughts and other things, Iana.’ I thought to myself. I felt the need to snap out of it, especially now that Chaser is in my room.

I stroked my stomach and erased my stern imagination.

“I’m sorry, but I don’t think I can make it. I’m so full.” I said.

“Is it because you’re full? That makes you uncomfortable to walk?” Chaser asked.

“...right?” I said, feeling uneasy. Then, his smile grew thick, making me more anxious.

'Oh please stop smiling.' I thought as I looked at him.

"Then I can carry you." Chaser remarked.

"What?" I was lifted up before I could answer anything.

What kind of man is this guy, lifting my body so effortlessly? Without panic, he quickly grasped the hem of my clothes swaying at the center. No matter how much he laughed and smiled, I was careful because he was a villain, but now I had to say what I had to say.

"Hey, don't you ever ask permission?" I asked him in a strong and loud voice.

After much consideration, I tried to express the sense of propriety in my own way.

"Also, you aren't polite when cutting the breakfast steak this morning, right?" I added.

He laughed lightly and replied. "I've solved it now. It's settled."

Settled...? Didn't he hear me saying that I was full? I snorted. But why does it feel like I was farting with my mouth?

"I don't call this a solution." I said with a frown. "Aha. I will not do this next time. I learned from this."

I saw his face, but I didn't think he would let me down even if I asked him to. I think I'll let go of my situation this time because he's showing a straight face, and I don't think it'll be good to protest here.

In addition, it was a face that was not good to be seen for a long time anyway. I gave up quickly, wondering what it would be like to have a scuffle.

"Where are we going?" I asked.

“It’s close.” He strode easily even though he was carrying me. It was marvelous that there was no hint of shaking in his body. It would be evident that this man’s body was that strong.

He was not a knight. To be exact, he did not have to have a knighthood because he was a duke. Nevertheless, I knew well that he was both physically and mentally fit. It’s just that it was unusual and extraordinary. He’s got both a strong mind, and body.

In the book, his weapon was not a normal sword...

“Here it is.” Chaser blurted as we ended up facing a huge door.

Ricdorian has a special ability. As I saw, it was an abnormal physical ability that wasn’t human. And for him, his opponent, for the villain...

Chaser...

I swallowed my saliva when I remembered his ability.

Click, the door was opened.

Regardless of whatever I imagined, I opened my eyes round to the scenery in the room. The scenery in the room was more ordinary than I thought. No, it was different from what I imagined because of the chronological table, which might contain the plot of the original story or the biography of Chaser’s misdeeds.

But it was hard to stand in here in a different sense.

‘...[I’m] not even a mafia boss.’

There were countless people standing on both sides of the room, just like in the hallway yesterday. But since this was a room, there were fewer people than yesterday, but these eyes were more burdensome.

“Here you are.” One of the people exclaimed as we made our way into the center of the room.

Chapter 120: Then, what do I want? (1)

Chapter 120 – Then, what do I want? (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

Everyone bowed down to us in greeting. Swords were drawn and raised overhead above us, creating an arch for our passage. People of different physiques held onto them, some I was certain weren't swordsmen at all held it up the same manner.

They didn't even look surprised with the way Chaser had me in his arms. They just looked straight ahead of themselves and indifferent.

I couldn't help but wonder that maybe Iana had always been held like this by Chaser. None even bat an eye at our position. But maybe they were just trained that way too. I wasn't too sure.

Finally, at the end of the line, there stood three people...

The three black maids that wore colored dresses.

Chaser strode over and put me down. My butt touched a soft cushion. Looking at it, it was a soft chair, yet elegant in finesse. Then he, himself, sat next to me.

"What the hell is this?" I had wished I wouldn't have to talk anymore, but this is something I couldn't help but ask about.

Ignoring my question, Chaser only smirked before he gestured for the maids to come over. Immediately they moved in perfect synchrony, and

procured many extravagant things right before my very eyes...

Dress, shoes and jewelry.

Immediately I got a sense of what they were going to do.

They brought so much stuff out of thin air... I couldn't help but wonder where they got it. I was like an avatar in a game, where in just one swipe, I would have all these beautiful things. Immediately I couldn't help but compare it to Cinderella.

I bet even the fairy godmother couldn't make this many things.

"All the old stuff burned out, so I bought new ones." Chaser stated, with a seemingly charming smile.

"...eh?"

"Right, there was a fire in my place."

"A fire?" I asked, this time to make sure I heard it correctly.

"Yes." He said and gave the world his sweetest smile but erased it not long after. "There are so many strange people in the world." Chaser muttered those words with a sullen face. The face of the beauty, whose smile had suddenly disappeared, now seemed grim, but all I felt was absurdity.

...isn't that the revenge of someone you beat up?

Such words rose to the top of my throat, almost blurting them out, but I managed to stop myself. He may have beaten up someone in a rage, and perhaps he had parted with his son or daughter from this world.

Ugh, my head hurts at these complicated thoughts. It felt as if the reality had finally come to the present

"So, how are these? Do you like it?" He held his chin and gave a deep look. It seems like there were a lot of things going on with his chin. I wasn't sure what to say so I stayed silent...

“What do you like?” He prodded me once more, seemingly not satisfied with my silence.

He looks like he would buy me everything, even if it looks like I’m going to buy something that could cost 120 million in cash.

I shook my head. What was I thinking right now? I feel like I’m the main character of the classic movie ***My Fair Lady***, but this romantic comedy movie wasn’t romantic at all, that it simply became a comedy.

“...there isn’t?” My remarks were light, but the impact wasn’t light at all.

“Is that so?” He just smiled and nodded.

Bang! Thud!

Suddenly the maids pulled out a large box, and began to pour every trinket they procured into the box. I had no idea where they got it, or who brought the box, much more so what was happening and what the maids were doing.

“What are you doing?”

“I am throwing it away.” He said nonchalantly.

I was frozen as it was. What are all these crazy sounds?

It was as though he sensed the incredulity of the situation and held up his hand, making them stop. He then grabbed my chin and softly made me turn towards him.

“My pretty dongsaeng, fret not,” Chaser held my hand lightly and released. But he left a greeting at my fingertips. “We can always throw them away later, there’s no rush for you to choose something now.” he assured me.

His eyes were full of affection towards me.

“What if it’s not here?” I asked the question just in case, but it was answered back with a smile. Then shortly afterwards, he spoke.

“Don’t worry. I can bring you all the jewels in the world if you want.” The tone was as soft as the handwriting in the letter he sent me. The only thing that changed was that he spoke it. “There’s nothing I wouldn’t do for you.”

I stared at the new things on the box. All of them are flashing. I swallowed my saliva and pointed at one.

“I would like that. That looks better.” I said.

“Give me everything that is like that.” Chaser ordered the maids.

...what?

“That’s an excellent choice.” someone suddenly remarked. My gaze whipped immediately to their direction. The person in a dress, which had been silent until now, gently waved the folding fan and took the back of her hand to her cheek. I guess that’s the merchant.

“The things in our salon are certain. Ho Ho Ho Ho.” The merchant voiced out.

“Well, I know what you’re capable of.” Chaser uttered under his breath.

“Yes. It’ll look really good on her.” She didn’t even make eye contact with me for some reason.

“Would it suit you, Madame?” She asked, still without looking at me. “Yes, I know it well. Sky blue would look really good on you.” she continued to say, seemingly speaking to me, but not at all.

No, I don’t think it’s something to say without even looking at me. I scratched my cheek absentmindedly. Since then, I have chosen one for everything that was brought in, and Chaser, who seems to be waiting for me, has been buying things by color or anything that was similar to what I chose. I didn’t really buy it. I just picked it.

I looked at things with a weary face.

“Madam, would you like to try this on?”

“All right.” I was already tired of choosing and therefore I just nodded my head. “I’ll be back in a while. I’ll just change.”

I guess, even here, people can’t escape the endless money mess...

I really hoped I was past this already.

Chapter 121: Then, what do I want? (2)

Chapter 121 – Then, what do I want? (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

Chaser burst out laughing as he looked at my white face.

“Yes, go ahead.” he encouraged further.

I went into the partition in the next room and began to change my clothes with the ones I was given. And those people who helped me change to the clothes that I picked didn’t talk to me at all.

It was like they were ignoring me.

Or was this what people from here called courtesy?

Ricdorian flashed into my mind, and immediately felt a pang of guilt stab me in the chest. If he had any idea who my brother was, that I was Chaser’s sister...

I wouldn’t be surprised if he refused to see, nor be nice to me at all.

Though that wouldn’t change the fact that I would probably do everything that I could have to help him still.

I shook the thoughts out of my head.

There was nothing more that I could do. I probably have made things... no, I certainly made things more complicated for him already. I have impacted

him far greatly than I have anticipated, burdened him with my existence...

Especially since it won't be for a while until we would see each other again.

While changing into a new dress and unfolding the hem, someone approached me. She was one of the middle-aged women in a dress.

"Oh, it looks good on you." She strode over and bent down without hesitation to fix the edges of the skirt before straightening up. She then looked at the dress from top to bottom, giving me a few suggestions while she was at it...

She said it's prettier if it has wrinkles like what she did.

I decided to look down, but honestly? I couldn't tell the difference from before to after. Then I looked at her once more. It was obvious that her smile was filled with faux joy.

"It's worth the rush to the back door!" She stated.

"The back door?" I asked, filled with curiosity. What back door was she talking about?

The woman seemed to pause at my answer. But she soon smiled softly.

"The rumor was true, ho-ho. The back door is the door where salon managers, merchants and servants who have been called in like us could enter."

She said so and I could not hide my curious eyes. This was a place where Chaser was not around and so I displayed such expression. The word rumour was bewitched and I quickly caught the tail of the horse.

"Don't you use the front door?"

"Eh? Yes. The main gate of the Domulit is currently closed. It is the owner's will not to go out. In this case, neither guests nor anyone else can use it."

Closed? So the only door that could be used is the back door? But why was the front door closed off?

“The back door, actually, is very uncomfortable. It’s the only road that connects to the stables behind the mansion, so a dressmaker like me doesn’t like it. If the mud splashes...” She trailed off as soon as she noticed my gaze. Originally, she seemed to be a person who constantly poured out the water once the bottle was opened, but perhaps I should give her more credit.

“Ho-ho, I’m sorry. I just suddenly launched and rambled your ears off. Though it would be quite nice if you could open the front gate.” She finished her speech in a hurry. Soon, I showed Chaser my changed clothes then he whispered in a polite and ecstatic voice.

“You are beautiful, Iana.”

The more I saw him, the more convinced I was that he is *very* capable of seducing people. Even the servants who were solemn saw him without realizing it.

“You know, I don’t need so much.” After a while I shook my head when I saw a pile of things. It seems like there’s already a lot, but Chaser didn’t seem like the type to know how to stop, nor did he look like he wanted to.

Is the Duke’s fortune as vast as the ocean?

As a small citizen, I was sick and tired of scenes where unexpected goods kept on coming. The fact that I’m wearing clothes that were comfortable is enough for me. And I thought the most comfortable clothes in the world were prison uniforms.

When I refused with a perplexed face, he stared at me with a formidable face. If a stranger saw it, they would definitely feel like an abandoned animal.

“Iana, I want to do it for you.” he admitted, before he took on a hurt look, “Did I happen to offend you once more?”

I had made up my mind to be firm this time, to make him stop with this extravagance. I had even steeled myself and my mind to not be persuaded, but the words were caught in my mouth as soon as I saw his hurt and wary expression...

I couldn't go through with it.

"...Oppa?" Chaser knelt on one knee. I looked at him with amazement, the moment he became lower than me.

"What are you doing? Why are you kneeling?" I asked.

"Iana, can you give me one more chance, please? I want to do anything for you when you get back from Kambrakam." His long fingers held my hand. It was in no time for hands to get tangled.

"Don't think of this as your reward, but still, I want to do it." The man who had lowered his eyes slowly lifted them up. "No?"

It was so confusing. I know for a fact that this guy is definitely the villain in the book, Chaser. He may be a man crazy about love and madness, but he never asked anyone so kindly or politely. At least in the books he didn't.

But this man, once again, he was a man who smiled gently as if he was sweet and would have seemed to barely lift his sword against a person.

"...just get up." I softly demanded of him.

...your servants are looking this way with a look of alarm.

I sighed softly. "I'll take it. I'll take it." I finally relented.

It was something I can't use even if I'll take it anyway. Chaser smiled before my eyes.

"Yes... I can give you this mansion if you want." he immediately began to say as soon as he rose up to his feet. He brushed off the dust on his knees, but I immediately cut him off.

“I don’t need it.” The bushy tail of the eyes created a distant feeling.

“Shouldn’t I give it to you?”

My refusal followed by another. Come on! What if Chaser comes by courier? It’s not enough to ask for a refund.

Why is this guy acting like a fool? With a face that doesn’t suit him at all.

At a glance, he was holding a flower cup with a sullen face.

“You don’t like this either. My dongsaeng is always picky.”

I felt like an ornament, seemingly good to look at, but quite breakable. Here I was, all dressed in riches, but the character inside me was almost in a state of collapse. It was like he was ready to give me everything, even if it costs his life. It is also possible that he would give his title to me. What kind of retaliation does Chaser want in the future?

If you’re going to give me something, just give me a bag of gold coins and send me away the next time.

And that’s how the odd shopping with this man ended. Chaser came out with me after giving the maid a new arrangement.

“From here on, I’ll go alone.” I stated.

Chaser looked at me for a moment and considerably let me go. It was not that he wanted to let go, so I nodded and allowed him to hold my hand.

However, he said something like a baby with those red lips.

“I don’t want you to be alone.” His eyes curled sensibly with his lips on my hand.

Chapter 122: The Role of the Villain's Sister (1)

Chapter 122 – The Role of the Villain's Sister (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

It was right after I told him that I wanted to see the mansion that he agreed. And so he offered me his hand, and I took it as he led me around for a tour.

He asked me about my time in prison, and I answered him as much as I deemed was necessary.

“Wouldn't it be more logical to not befriend anyone in prison?” he asked me, and I shrugged.

“Well, I do like being alone,” I admitted, “And I often was, too. I just stayed in my cell.”

It was only in the living room of the prison where we were allowed to chat and stay with others, but every one of the prisoners would be alone in their designated cell room.

“I see, but don't think you're alone anymore.” He leaned over closer to me up until he was within my eye-level. His eyes as beautiful as red jade never failed to amaze me. “Not anymore.” he whispered, “And never again.”

He was a really soft man, even though he had a strange and shocking side. But I'm sorry I couldn't tell him that all this time I've been out of my cell visiting someone.

He was still the villain.

“See you later.”

I had Ricdorian back in the prison, so I barely had time to feel alone. Suddenly, there was a new realization that hit me. Ricdorian may have been the sole reason my boredom and even the loneliness that might have come during that time didn't arise.

I tend to feel that way when I was left alone for too long. Anyway, it was true that I was happy, and had grown attached to him.

I walked quickly and alone. Somehow there were no people on the floor where I and Chaser were, but as I went down, I saw servants occasionally. I moved and approached those who seemed friendly.

But most of the servants used to look around when I talked to them. However, they would answer me knowing that I was alone.

So I asked the servants and arrived at the section.

Neigh! Neigh!

The horses' cries were loud. I thought the barn has a lot of horses in it because of the intense noises. From a distance, someone might have thought this was a small house. But it has the size of a mansion. However, it has less horses growing here than I imagined.

I looked wearily at the space that seemed to be bigger than a person's ordinary house and turned my head away. Then I saw a small road.

“It must be that way.”

Is that where that madam was talking about? I arrived here easier than I thought. I rummaged through my pockets and slowly spread out my palms.

There were little jewels and gold coins in my palm.

I just took these things while changing my clothes. Even though I only lived in a cell, I knew how much this gold coin cost.

<One gold coin is enough for common people to live for a month.> Mr. Palladis, who is idle, told me a lot of things.

“I could go right now.”

I looked alternately at the road next to the stable. There were two knights who seemed to guard the stable.

...yes, it is. There's no way we can have no one to protect this place.

And if someone leaves without a word, they should be the one to keep track of it.

Now, if only I could leave behind the man who just wants to be nice to his sister. It's only now, that the urge to disappear from this place began to grow within me.

It's like I've finally had a clearer head now. All those things he was saying...

It doesn't match up.

He's sorry? He wants to do all these nice things for his sister? Well Iana is gone, and in her place is me. Even if he was truly sorry, the facade he was showing me now didn't make it seem like the type of person to put all the blame on his sister...

It would be strange for him, the type of man he's in front of me now, to allow his sister to serve time in jail for his own sins.

His apologies don't matter now, nor do his regrets. What's done has been done. The bus that had long passed, won't come back.

“I don't think it's going to be easy right now...” I mumbled to myself, the weight on my shoulders beginning to turn into a burden. “It seems difficult to escape immediately.” I sighed as I continued to look around.

It was time for me to turn around and take a step but I paused as soon as someone called me.

“Hello, miss.”

I turned my head away in surprise at the sudden sound of his voice. There stood a boy of my age wearing long boots. I didn’t know where he came from. I didn’t notice him before either.

“Do you need any help?” He asked rather curiously. I took my time in observing him, wondering if he was of any importance.

It was a soft voice: a servant’s coat and short hair...

Ah...

It’s only now that I realize my mistake. This was not a boy...

He... was a girl. And *she* had quite the short hair on her pretty head. She straightened up, before giving me a respectful bow.

“I’m Yozuna, the stable servant. I was wondering if you needed anything...” she introduced, trailing off as I just kept appraising her. Catching myself on my rudeness, I snapped out and gave her a slight nod.

“Huh? Oh, no.”

“Really? Were you looking at that road?” She said and pointed at the road I was looking at earlier.

I must have been looking at that road intensely that even those who watched me would notice. I admitted it without reserve. There could be no harm, I suppose, being a little truthful.

“That’s right. Well, I was wondering where that road leads.” As I was her age, words came out of my mouth comfortably.

“That’s the way out. It’s connected to the back gate!” She said immediately, seemingly happy to be of help.

“Oh, I see.” I turned my head away after getting confirmation of the facts that I knew. Okay, I was right. Then, it was my plan to go back after saying

goodbye to her like this yet...

“Well, do you want to go out?” She whispered softly. If only the little whisper of the girl didn’t catch me. “If you want to go outside, I’ll help you.” she offered.

My eyes widened in shock, as I looked at her in surprise. I didn’t think I would be that obvious, but why would she even help me? It didn’t make sense.

And so I refused, giving her a reassuring smile, because the uneasiness was growing. There was a cold dread settling in the pits of my stomach...

“I heard from the older servants you used to pay them before.” she admitted softly. My breath caught in my throat at the unexpected honesty.

Never did I imagine I could get any tea in this place, from this stablehand... An unexpected story about the previous Iana. And then I watched Yozuna, stare enviously at what was in my hand. My eyes glanced at my hands, and saw the trinkets Chaser had given me before...

“I’ll help you,” she reiterated, “I’ll just need one gold coin in exchange.” she told me. There was some horrifying greed flashed through her eyes, that I was torn.

I probably have enough on my person that I wouldn’t miss a single gold coin, but I was scared what she would do if I were to refuse.

Chapter 123: The Role of the Villain's Sister (2)

Chapter 123 – The Role of the Villain's Sister (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

“There were knights there, wouldn't I get caught?” I asked her, gesturing slightly to the sentinels.

“There is a side road that only horse riders use. Because some smells like horse manure, I made them use a different route from that.” she told me confidently.

I was worried for a while.

This seemed too easy, almost like a coincidence. Would getting out of here be too naive? That's true. But if a servant, or a maid, had offered me this offer, I would have refused it immediately. The immature girl with greedy eyes only looking at gold coins will shake if I said this.

‘I still have no intention of going out.’

Today is not the right day. And even if I don't go out anyway, it's not bad to know the way out.

“All right.”

So a contract was established between the girl and I, and I followed her along.

The bushes were quite tough, but it wasn't that difficult for me to get used to it because I've been passing a lot on the bleak cell garden.

"You walk well. Usually, ladies and gentlemen have a hard time." She conversed.

"Try visiting a prison." I stated.

The girl burst into a small laugh.

"The house is full of rumors about you."

"Really? But I thought so, too" I didn't want to hear it, so I kept my mouth shut, hoping to dissuade her from further story-telling, mainly because I wasn't interested. It may be about the younger sister of Chaser who went to the cell and I have a feeling that it's not a pleasant story.

"I think you've become a completely different person." She eventually pointed out, finally stopping as she had nothing more to say.

I asked calmly, pretending nothing was wrong. "Really? Do I look very different?"

"Yes." She answered without any hesitation.

Before I knew it, we reached the end of the road. And not far away, I could see a wooden door. That was the shape of the back door. For some reason, there was no one guarding it even though it was wide open.

"That's why I like it."

My gaze on the door turned back to the girl. The girl smiled lightly as she noticed the question in my gaze.

"Now we have groceries coming every three months, so we don't have anyone to watch."

Oh, that's why there are no people.

I nodded because I was convinced with her elucidation.

“Really? Then go back... .” She stopped. “It’s also time for my people to come in easily.” She shut her mouth by herself. I couldn’t understand what this girl was saying.

“I’ve been working really hard when I heard that you’re coming back, but I’m a little bit frustrated.” She added.

“Why is that...” I asked but she cut me off.

“The previous lady here was very wary...to the point of annoyance.”

The girl’s eyes grew sharp. She smiled and didn’t stop talking. She faltered and tried to step back, but her foot caught a stone.

There was that cold feeling once again.

“I’m sure they’re all crazy about you. Chaser,” she clicked her tongue distastefully as she said his name, “It’s not easy to get back at him.” She added, before looking at me knowingly.

At the same time, I felt myself lurching forward as I felt a strong shock in my stomach and neck and tilted to my front. Something was definitely wrong here...

What did she do? Was she an idiot? What would happen if Chaser were to discover what she did to me!?

This bastard!

Ugh, I feel like throwing up...

“I don’t have much emotion.”

The girl continued, a cold smile drawing on her face as suddenly she tossed and played with a single gold coin in her hand before catching it...

“Your brother is simply too cruel,” she hummed, looking uncaringly at my painful state, “It’s no wonder many hold deep grudges against him.”

Immediately she caught my chin between her fingers and forced me to look at her. Her grip was painful as the nails dug into my cheeks...

The illusion of youth faded from her face...

And in the place of the young girl, there stood an elderly woman.

It was just like Jair’s magic.

“Quite naive of you, my Lady,” she said, “To be so trusting when you know who your brother is.”

Suddenly, I remembered what my friend, a swindler, had said.

<Iana, keep this in mind. Conceit shows up in the face of the nicest person.>

Well, I think it’s too late, mister. I’m sorry I didn’t listen to you properly before. In addition, my last memory of this moment was my body flashing and heading somewhere.

That’s what I thought.

Ricdorian, you’ve been through this pain periodically...I should have applied the medicine less painfully. I regret that I’ve caused you more pain...

And then there was nothing but the darkness once more.

When I opened my eyes after a long time, it was dark. I just thought this space was dark, but I soon found out that it wasn’t. It was already dark outside the window.

It was night. It was nightfall as well when I was taken wasn’t it? My memory’s all fuzzy right now. Well, how long have I been asleep? One day? Two days? Or was it still the same day?

Did we teleport? Where was I?

I looked around more calmly than I thought. I was already aware that I was stupid. I thought this world would be more innocent because they fed me well here. Tsk, the world is still the same, no matter the appearance.

No, I knew there would be people who would be after me the moment I knew who my brother was. At the very least I thought it wasn't as much resentment as the latter part of the book.

I guess it wasn't. It's just as dark and as unexpected.

"Exactly just how much grudge did you gain for yourself, older brother?" I mumbled to myself, but it's useless. He isn't here to answer my questions.

I didn't know that just a short look at the road would be the shortcut to the peak.

Well, let's stop reflecting on ourselves. The first question that I should resolve is...

How do I get out of here?

"I think my wrist is tied tight," My stomach was still throbbing. But it wasn't to the point where I couldn't move.

The woman earlier was trying to unravel her grudge against Chaser on my stomach. I should find something sharp around here. I sighed and looked around.

How far have I gone into? This must be the base of a force that bears a grudge against Chaser.

How do I escape?

Chapter 124: Oppa will always protect you (1)

Chapter 124 – Oppa will always protect you (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

My eyes wandered through this seemingly empty space and, at the same time, my mind began to concoct various thoughts. Different reasons, and different outcomes I imagined the more time I was left alone by myself.

What were they planning on doing with me, I wonder.

But then my gaze was drawn to my legs, halting any further impeding thoughts. They were still tied up, as I expected, but wait...

Being tied up would definitely limit any mobility I would have. A most unfavorable situation indeed, but not the worst. Then suddenly, a thought ran through my mind, and I hummed in agreement...

‘There was that.’

It could possibly work.

With my hands also tied together, there wasn’t much I could do. So I stretched out my fingers, skimming them over my wrist...

I wondered if they noticed...

Aha! There it was.

I caught onto the edges of the string of the bracelet *he* had given me, the magic bracelet. Huh, maybe I gave them too much credit after all that they didn't notice it. Or perhaps he was just too good.

"Can the bracelet do magic in here?" I couldn't help but wonder as well. There were a number of spells on the bracelet Jair had given me that still remained on it.

I then began to list the ones I remembered before I found a good enough of a spell. I'm not exactly locked up, more like tied up, but the spell of unlocking latches might work here.

And so I concentrated on that spell, and felt the rope on my wrists gradually loosen up. The ropes by my legs soon followed, and finally, I was fully unbounded.

I released both my breath and the spell in relief.

"Wow, that is so good."

I'm glad that I received it with not much hesitation when Jair said he would give it to me. Not long after, I rubbed my ankles several times before getting up from my position. Even though there was a slight feeling of cramps, I had no problem walking. The only thing that keeps me moving right now is the urge to escape this place quickly.

"Before, I was the one who'd been taming animals in the cell." Joking around was my only way to calm myself down.

It wasn't that there were no bad guys among the noble prisoners. Rather, some had committed quite a crime under the name of other nobles. Since I've been under more surveillance, I was less afraid of my situation inside. I'm sure it's also because of my easy going personality.

Soon, I found out that this place was like a warehouse. There were lots of wooden boxes piled up around. When I found a suitable pipe among them, I grabbed it and crept up to the door with it.

The door's locked, right?

What should I do? It may be better to use magic one more time. Because I have to find out who's been waiting outside the door. But despite that, it was difficult to make a decision since I didn't know what was going on outside the door.

In addition, the number of spells available is limited. Since this was a deep place, if there would be another locked door after casting this magic, everything would be a disaster. And that frustrates me.

But there was no time for me to fret any further. I need to hurry up. With that settled in my thoughts, I gripped the pipe tightly for a while before releasing it. I then carefully propped it up on my side, when I heard a noise...

It was right outside. Was it just my imagination? I certainly had hoped so, but it wasn't so.

Bang!

I flinched at the sudden clang as it echoed. What was happening outside? I could hear it grow closer to where I was, the sounds getting louder every time..it did...

What is it?

“Are they fighting amongst themselves out there?” I whispered to myself. My entire body was frozen, goosebumps breaking out of my skin as cold sweat ran down my spine. The more I listened, the more I could feel my entire body shaking with tremors.

It was an uproar and I had no choice but to think so. On top of that, I could hear the sound of weapons hitting and swords clanking. I tightly held the pipe with tension.

It was then I could smell something acrid through my nose.

“It's..a....burning smell?”

I knew that something was burning due to my numerous experiments gone wrong in the kitchen in the previous world. And the smell was beginning to sting my eyes as well.

Was I going to suffocate to death? Should I cast a spell now instead?

“Fire! Fire!”

“Fire!”

I suddenly heard multiple shouts as well. So there was a fire indeed. It didn't do anything to help my nerves, only sent them into overdrive.

I was beginning to get impatient. I was becoming desperate to leave this place, and yet I stood here, unmoving in what seemed to be a hidden room. It won't be long for the smoke to invade the room, and then I would suffocate for sure.

It was now or never. I refuse to die here. And so I moved to grab the door knob, only it turned just before I could reach it...

The door swung open, and my breath hitched as someone immediately darted inside.

It was a woman, middle-aged, and quite familiar. I stood there unmoving, listening to her heave in her breaths before my memories finally caught up to me.

It was the woman from before, the one who tricked me.

“Huh...” her hands shot forward, gripping onto me for stability. She was clutching her stomach, letting out pained groans, and the more I looked, the more I was certain she was indeed hurt. Particularly her abdomen was, judging by the massive stain of blood on her clothes...

The fear multiplied two-fold as more dreadful scenarios ran through my thoughts. What was happening outside? Who did this? Was I in danger?!

I was first and foremost shocked by the ever increasing series of events that I was with the sight of her blood pouring out of her...

“Sa-save me,” she immediately vomited blood, her grip tightening up on me, “Help me!” she begged, clinging onto dear life by the hem of my dress. My eyes flitted to her chest area, the torn tatters of her dress drawing my attention, and I couldn’t help but feel more flabbergasted at the sight...

“...man?”

The person whom I thought was a middle-aged woman was a middle-aged man. I was not able to recognize it because of its thick skin, neutral voice, and ambiguous appearance. But there wasn’t much time to be surprised.

“Please, *Bleurgh*. Please, save me. Save me....” he kept begging me. It did nothing to calm me down, but it did give me some sort of satisfaction that it was him that kept begging me.

“No, you’re the one who brought me here.” I told him, before I tilted my head in faux confidence, “Besides, what in the world are you talking about?”

His hands only shook as he gripped tighter onto my dress, tugging it down desperately.

“Please, tell him, I’ll forget about my grudge.” The man grabbed my skirt as if it were the hem of a Savior. “Ac-actually, I didn’t even have a grudge. Well, I’m just trying to make things big. I’ll just gather the guys I want. Oh, my God! Oh, come on! Tell him to spare my life...”

Who the hell do you want me to tell that?

“Iana.” A low voice penetrated my ears and I was frozen as it was. “There you are.”

Chapter 125: Oppa will always protect you (2)

Chapter 125 – Oppa will always protect you (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

He called out to me in a friendly and soft voice, but in the place of that soft velvety tone I was used to hearing, was replaced by dual tones, both light and dark speaking at the same time.

There was something guttural and blood-curdling in his tone, the screams outside amplified as I slowly turned towards him...

Only then did I get a good view of the open door. The ceiling of the building was half blown away, and countless people fell down while others were fighting with black uniformed men.

A fierce fire was soaring from the outside.

Stuttering.

Not far away, the person who was walking with the fire as the background stopped. Then he smiled snugly. It was Chaser.

Against the backdrop of the fire, the wind blew from somewhere, shaking his black hair like a flame. It felt like a beautiful devil who had just risen from hell right now.

“Good thing it didn’t take long to find you.” Blood splattered on his cheeks, but it matched well with his melting smile dissolving the creepiness. “I was worried.”

Clank! Screech! Chaser's long sword scratched the floor. When I rolled my eyes, the sword was dried up with blood that had turned black. He approached me and leaned his upper body. Soon, a middle-aged man who was holding onto the hem of my clothes ran away.

Bleurgh!

The sound of a man coughing up blood was loud. But Chaser leaned down without giving him a glance. The affectionate eyes came before mine.

"Why did you run away?" I knew. I've never seen this man like this before.

"...I didn't run, I didn't."

"Oh, then should I say this?"

My body was trembling but I couldn't take my eyes off of him. Why do these soft eyes go well with the fire behind him?

"Why did you think about running away?" This is what the Chaser in the book was like. "I thought it wouldn't be when I let you go, but you betrayed me."

He reminded me of the moment when we parted ways. When I said I wanted to see the mansion, he simply stepped back.

"Iana, my lovely dongsaeng." A soothing voice filled my ears as if to give everything. "Why did you try to run away from me again?" Chaser raised his hand to his cheek.

The blood splattered on his cheek smeared and scattered more. It was like a red painting on a white porcelain. There was no sense of realism.

"No, I don't think I need to hear it." He said. But the shadow of the fire was still rumbling. "I didn't make a mistake sending you twice." The villain in the book whispered softly. He took my hand.

Flinched.

He brought my hand to my cheek.

“...I learned a lot.” It was a hand that was careful and unmatched as if it were dealing with tender things. Even though he is friendly and kind...

But I felt madness in those eyes.

“These are the guys who’ve been infiltrating since the moment they knew you were getting out of Kambrakam and maybe there’s probably more of them inside the mansion? There are still humans who’re going to live here. Don’t worry about it at all.”

Chaser stretched out a knife. Something black flew in with his stretched arms. A bird?

It was a big bird. It was a black bird, but the beak could barely tell the species. Eagle? Was it an eagle? Even the eyes were mysteriously black as a rock. Black feathers fall down underneath the bird with all its black plumage. I suddenly realized something like black rose petals.

Inside the stone slabs carved on the wall, a black rose... And the shape of the animal next to the black rose. The bird. What was with that bird? At the same time as I reached that thought, the bird cried long.

“Everything, I will give up my existence in this world.” A red flame shot up behind Chaser’s back with an enchanting beautiful voice. At the same time, the black eyes of the bird turned red just like his. “...are you not going to let me hear your voice?”

I managed to open my mouth. “...Oppa.”

“I’ve always felt sorry. Iana.” The red eyes returned to me with a giddy smile that would fascinate the audience.

“Why....” The black hair shook violently in the wind.

“I don’t think my ability is working on you. My dongsaeng.”

Ah, I remember.

Ricdorian's special ability is a tremendous physical ability that is not human-like. And his enemy, the adversary. The ability of Chaser Rube Domulit...

It was a fascination for everyone.

The ability to brainwash anyone who literally looks into his eyes and raises his voice. This was the man who took the empire's underground in one hand. Atleast, it was until the future Ricdorian created a method for that destruction.

The red eyes were all over me with madness and fascination.

"So Iana. When will you tell me?" An eagle that creates fire. Chaser's ability, the black rose in a lithograph...

Everything was mixed up. However, it was clear that one should not be missed.

I remembered the appearance of Chaser one by one. The way he had been looking at me all the time...the way he'd made me feel unharmed. It was naturally associated. He didn't show any agitation, at least except when I briefly encountered him in the prison.

My lips opened themselves.

"...Oppa, I actually lost my memory." Chaser smiled naturally. The eyes bent gracefully.

"Yeah. Now you tell me you've lost your memory." he said, eyes cold as he looked at me.

It was at that moment I had realized he had been playing me this whole time. Wondering how long it would take for me to make a mistake...

I hadn't been cautious enough, I've made one too many blunders. Everything that's happened since then rushed unto me as the cold dread returned to me in full force...

I was frozen stiff.

“It’s all right.” His hand gently swept down my cheek. “You’re always my dongsaeng.” The red eyes roll slowly.

My lovely dongsaeng. His lips were moving.

“Don’t worry.” It felt distant and slow, like watching a movie in slow motion. “I’ll burn everything that harms you.”

There was viciousness behind his smile. I couldn’t help but suddenly feel the terror the more I looked at him.

I shouldn’t have doubted the books.

“I’ll protect you any time.” Even in the midst of raging flames, his words were clearly conveyed.

“I wish there was a cell in the mansion so that you couldn’t escape.”

Chapter 126: A Familiar Life Of Imprisonment (1)

Chapter 126 – A Familiar Life Of Imprisonment (1)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

Roughly a year had passed since the incident. Just as the saying goes, time can be likened to an arrow that had been shot in release. You can't imagine catching it with your bare hands, blink and you would miss it indeed.

And that's exactly what happened.

But it's not a full year, not yet in all honesty. Roughly nine to ten months had only passed, but still enough that I thought it had been a year already.

Clink. Clank.

The clanging of a chain could be heard every time I moved.

I learned to not mind it anymore, I had gotten used to such a treatment from my so-called brother.

Sometimes, I thought, if I weren't to look at my ankle, I would forget the chains I was literally shackled with. But then I would have to look down at some point, and be reminded all over of just how powerless I am.

Stopping in front of the hallway, I lifted my head.

The season has come again, summer, when the sound of grass bugs is heard, is just around the corner.

And when the year ended, it ended with summer, instead of the usual winter. It reminded me greatly of Australia in the world I had previously lived in.

Where there should have been winter, summer stood in its place. The blistering cold was replaced with scorching heat. It was something I failed to acclimate to before, but as I stayed here, greeting it for a second time...

I think I've finally gotten used to it after all.

Summer is approaching, which means the end of the year is coming soon. In other words, I'm about three months away from being released from prison. And a year later...as I was counting the days, the silver-haired boy came into my mind.

Soon the figure was erased from my mind and a new figure of a human being appeared.

"Lady." The woman in the maid's uniform bowed politely. "The meal is ready."

My eyes lingered a little longer on her, watching the new maid. Her hair was wound so tightly onto her head, I feared her hairline would recede further back into her scalp. She looked oh so prim and proper. I let out a soft sigh before I averted my gaze and finally moved.

"I've never seen you before." I said but an answer did not come back.

She might be newly employed then. The ones Chaser would choose ahead of time, right before the new year would arrive. Though now that I was paying attention to her, she seemed to be out of focus.

She has yet to pay attention or even glance my way, so I held my stare. It seemed as though she'd finally come to her senses and steeled her nerves as she finally made eye contact.

"Ah...." The maid quickly shook her head. Her gaze had trailed off some direction though, her eyes widening in choked surprise.

I followed her line of sight and suppressed the urge to chuckle at her expression.

This, too, was something I had gotten used to. People, especially those new to the mansion, would be surprised the moment they would lay eyes on the chains by my feet. It was understandable.

Who would have expected the lady of the house to be shackled like a dog?

Even the people here deemed it strange for such a treatment to be done unto me by my own brother.

“Are you interested?” I asked, drawing her gaze back to my face, “About the chains on my ankle?”

“I’m sorry... .”

“There’s nothing to do about it.”

She smiled and raised her fingers as if I could see them. Then she whispered a little...as if she was telling a secret.

“Let’s end this once.”

You’ll be in big trouble. Then I brushed past her. Maybe it was late, but the maid rushed to me and walked in front of me.

It shouldn’t have been so puzzling to me. It was a little wishful thinking on my part after all. I wanted her to be smarter than the others, just like the way she presented herself with her hair. It was a daunting sight to see Chaser run a sword through someone...

I don’t want her to be the next body under his belt. It wasn’t the first time someone tried to help me.

The walk had taken a while, but eventually I reached a room, not the dining room. I didn’t always get to eat in it, for very good reasons.

“Sa, save me! Please, please... .” there was a pleading echoing through the walls.

I glanced around the room, trying to figure out what was going on. What had I walken into now?

It didn't take long for me to understand. It wasn't surprising as it should have been, as I liked. It happened so much around here, I've already become desensitized to such sounds already.

“Save me.” the whisper persists.

I heard a sweet voice. “What should I do, Iana?”

It may not be noticeable, but even his voice changed within the year. Before, his voice was velvety, but light. Now, gone were the traces of a boy, as his tone dipped deeper, but still as velvety smooth as before.

“I'm troubled.”

Liar, I thought. You're capable of much more than that, much worse than that.

“Save me, I, I didn't do anything. Nothing, nothing!”

Even considering that, it was a beautiful voice.

I rolled my eyes at a glance.

Without answering, he let go of the man who squeaked for help. It seems like he already lost half of his blood, but there seems to be no fatal injury. Even so, I think he still has the power to scream.

“Come on, come on! I, I, I didn't do anything! I didn't do it! Argh!”

I saw the entire scene of the room. A surprisingly fluffy bed, various cute props, and sky-high lace hanging from the ceiling. Wherever I look, I can't think of this as a man's room.

Which, once again, was to be expected. This was my designated room after all.

“Iana, I’m waiting for an answer.” At the last turn, there was a man with long legs with his face straight. In nearly a year, his long bangs tickled as they were covering his eyebrows.

“Why do you ask?”

Now, coming into someone else’s room and asking me ‘What should he do?’

“Of course, I’m here for your advice.” Chaser answered casually. In contrast to the sweet voice, the voice this time was dull.

“I don’t think my opinion matters. In the end, you’re going to do whatever you want.”

I wanted nothing to do with him, but I know he wouldn’t leave until he got what he wanted. Now is not the time to be stubborn, as I have learned.

“Though I must say,” I began, trailing off lightly as his gaze on me grew heavy and intense, “The more I looked at the person, the more I’m sure someone is to blame for directing their attention to me.” I finished tersely, giving him the deadliest glare I could muster.

I couldn’t hear an answer from the side for a moment. After my eyes pointed at Chaser, he opened his lips.

“My Iana knows me so well.” Instead of answering, I’ve seen him for almost a year, don’t you know? I sent him a glance.

Chapter 127: A Familiar Life Of Imprisonment (2)

Chapter 127 – A Familiar Life Of Imprisonment (2)

Translator: SKAIS Editor: Dict Groiler

He squeezed his chin and tilted his head.

“Should I kill him?” he spoke it as if he was choosing which tie would suit him more. I was absolutely disgusted by him. His voice may sound good, but he’s as vile as any villain is. In fact, red eyes, like ruby, did not change in terms of affection. Since I had nothing to do with these trembling words, I kept silent and not long after, opened my mouth and asked.

“What crime did he commit?” I asked. He remained silent for a moment, before there was a slight shift in his expression.

I noticed it by the way the shadows casted by his nose changed in angle.

“I once approached a salon owner,” he began, “We struck a deal together. I proposed he’d be a servant here, in the mansion. And he agreed, quite smoothly, and quickly. It was quite suspicious, I thought it was an infiltration attempt.”

The more he spoke, the more I thought there was no lesson to be learned in listening. Nothing new to be acquired, and so I decided to tune him out.

“You caught him anyway.” I told him, “What else is there to do? It’s not like they tricked you.”

“Yes, that’s right, Iana.” He smiled sweetly. “I’ve known for two months that the owner of the salon has betrayed me.” His voice sank in my ears. But I knew, he sits comfortably and swings it, knowing that the knife he held in his hand already had blood.

This was my dressing room, Flore’s dressing room. We might have spent only three months together, but it felt longer than that. Far more pleasant memories with it overshadowed by the current grim events.

“Okay, bring me my meal.” I swept down my face. I eat my food in my room and not in the dining room. But what if I make it like this? “I’m hungry.”

An answer came back to me with a low voice. “What if I kill him?”

He asked again, ignoring my request. I shrugged in nonchalance. It was quite pitiful, watching someone die from torture, but it was an inevitable outcome. The salon’s owner knew what he was entering the moment he made a decision. He should have known better.

Shamefully, I turned away from the spectacle, opting to be busy with other matters instead.

He poisoned me and almost succeeded. But still, I don’t want to see you die. I knew from a long experience.

“Do as you please.” If I don’t show interest, he gets rid of it too.

A kill order, that’s waiting only for my approval. How terribly my life has become. And he knew that if he tried to kill someone in front of my eyes, I would jump in front of the sword. For less than a year, we learned from each other.

“Are you not interested?” Chaser tilted his head. The slanted and twisted gaze seemed naive at first glance.

A naive glance? That was a funny thought, indeed. If there’s a word that doesn’t go with him the most, that’s it. Chaser was anything but naive.

Conniving, more like it. Pretentious, maybe, but never naive.

When I didn't answer, Chaser's eyes continued.

Snapping.

I heard a feeble sound of chain that came from my ankle. It was the sound of chains and shackles colliding.

Two pairs of eyes looked down as if they had an appointment. Chaser was the first one to laugh. Then, he waved his hand with a smile.

"Now, wait, where am I going to... Uh, where are you taking me, go, Duke? My duke! My duke!" Shouted the man in a hurry.

He was dragged away by Chaser's men, making him shout incessantly. Finally, Chaser turned his eyes.

"I won't kill you." His eyes folded seductively.

"Because my coal mine needs a lot of slaves."

But I would have only seen him as I was right next to him. The eyes that appear between the glaring flashes are not smiling at all.

"Ahhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhhh!"

That man must be well aware of what happens in Chaser's coal mine and how he is being taken away and treated in that place. That's why he's screaming like that.

I swept my face down...no matter how hard they tried to kill me it still wasn't easy to see them being dragged. Nevertheless, it was not a comfortable sight for a person to be dragged.

The room where everyone left was very still and terribly quiet. But I still know my brother is sitting next to me. He was a man who showed his extraordinary presence even if he didn't say a word.

I felt him getting up from his seat. Chaser, who came close by, knelt before me. My head turned when I was looking elsewhere with my chin on it.

There, I saw a black hair in front of me. The pitch-black hair shuffled on his forehead like a shadow. Kneeling before me, he pulled up his lips.

“What are you thinking about?”

“I didn’t think much.”

Just various thoughts? Maybe?

A small breath escaped through his lips. Followed with a devilish and fascinating smile that had just come out of hell ready to mess up the world.

He grabbed me by the ankle and slowly lifted it up. I wrinkled my brows in a delicate way.

“Why the ankle?”

“Just because.” My ankles, which weren’t a handful, appeared thin in his large hand.

“Put it down.”

Chaser ended with a smile at my firm command. The eyes full of kindness bent to the shape of a half-moon. It’s like a chagrin.

“Isn’t it uncomfortable?”

I glanced at my ankle held by him and turned my eyes away.

“I’m hungry.”

Instead of answering, another word came out of my lips. Whether he grabs my ankle or not. I could feel the pounding pulse coming from his fingertips, but I didn’t care. Instead, I crossed both of my arms.

“Give me rice.” I wasn’t agitated. I’ll say it wasn’t something to be upset about anymore.

This man has been like this ever since he revealed his true form to me a year ago.

“What else? Other than rice?” he asked me, eyes as sharp as ever. It grated on my nerves.

“I don’t need anything else.” I all but snapped at him, “Now, if you don’t mind, I want the rice as quickly as possible, I’m quite hungry, you see.” I told him.

He quirked up an eyebrow at my irritants before finally conceding. He tilted his head slightly in a bow, before he kneeled and took my foot and placed a soft kiss on my sole...

My eyes softened at the gesture. I may have decided to not trust him, but that doesn’t mean I can’t be civil about it.

“...don’t do that on my instep. It’s dirty.”

“Is that so? Can you wash it for me?”

What do you mean? [Wash] the lips?

Chapter 128: Familiar Confinement Life (2)

Chapter 128. Familiar Confinement Life (2) (Chapter 65 According to Raw)

What nonsense are you talking about? With a small breath, I responded casually.

“It’s going to rain soon, standing with your mouth open.”

Our gaze crossed at my voice. Chaser was the one who burst into laughter. He wiped his cheek with the back of his hand.

“You’re not supposed to say that.”

“Then, should I not wash my feet in the future?”

“My sister, do you want me to wash it myself?”

Chaser who was saying that rubbed his chin as if it were interesting.

“Ah... it sounds like a good idea, can I practice it?”

“... Come to think of it, I’ll stand with you when it rains.”

What is this pervert saying. It’s better if you wash me up.

He squeezed my ankle slightly and released it. I could feel the texture of the shackles.

The room was filled with luxurious bedding and pillows that were made from a hundred goose down.

In addition to this, from rare gemstones that cannot be obtained even if you search through the empire, clothes and shoes that cannot be worn completely for a year and 12 months, and an air freshener made from grass that you can only pick up once in 10 years.

It embodies luxury.

I finally gazed over Chaser's shoulder.

A large pillar in the room, a black chain wrapped around the pillar. The pillars rotated like a pulley. It was also the power of magic.

Was it possible to wind up this mansion if all of that was unpacked?

Thanks to that, I was able to move around freely in the mansion even with these shackles. It was tied up at the same time.

I took my eyes off the pillar and looked at the man who gave me these things.

Imprisonment.

Yes, for the past year or so, I have been imprisoned.

How is it?

You are comfortably being imprisoned.

The world is full anyway, you might feel stuffed.

I decided to enjoy life.

“Hurry up and feed me.”

About a year ago, it took less than three months to think this way.

A year ago, I was rescued by Chaser from a burning base and changed the room occupied by Chaser.

The feet were shackled thicker than they are now.

Looking at the finished room, I felt absurd.

.... It's more realistic than any other cell.

At that time, the chains were shorter than they are now. Just enough to barely walk around the house?

This was also possible by Chaser's subordinate who was a black magician that casted a spell.

When Chaser showed his true self, the house adapted to it as if it had waited. No, the people in the market seemed more familiar with the appearance of this side.

Countless people came and went as if when the mansion was quiet. Of course they didn't see me trapped.

<Ahhhhhh!>

Oh, a lot of people came and screamed that the mansion was gone. I knew. I thought it would never be a welcome scream.

I was surprised, but it wasn't unfamiliar. Scary or whatever, this was how it felt like this was a villain's mansion.

In fact, I knew I was quick to adapt, but I didn't know that I would be so quick.

Surely, who would have known I would adapt to the shackles.

But the situation made me remarkably adaptable to it.

Crash!

It has been a month since I was shackled by Chaser.

Suddenly, a dagger flew in and broke the glass, and his hand was cut long. I couldn't move. Because the sword was right in front of me.

The culprit was a butler who had been working in this mansion for 11 years.

In addition, his grudges were not directed against Chaser, but toward Duke of Domulit, Chaser's father.

Duke Domullit was unable to receive the butler's resentment, who was currently recuperating in a secret place with fatal injuries. It turned to Chaser, who instead was standing firm and strong.

<... I'm sorry, Iana.>

Chaser apologized, dripping blood from the sword. His eyes looked as if they were crying.

At first I thought he was talking about being struck in his place. But I knew it wasn't that with his following words.

After that, the meal was poisoned. The victim of the massacre by Duke Domulit was the culprit.

Chaser replaced everyone in the kitchen that day. I realized.

Oh, not everything is just a grudge against Chaser.

<I'm sorry.>

Duke Domulit was a vicious human before Chaser became a villain. What he did came back.

Even Chaser got involved with that resentment against him. I found out naturally. That Chasel was holding all of this in the meantime.

<... Still, you can't run away, my Iana.>

I learned after trying to escape after saying ‘third time’s the charm’ or something like that.

Ah, my face is known to his enemies.

Wherever I went, my popularity peaked. It was a disgrace that I was taken negatively.

Thanks to these attempts, I felt that it was impossible to live in peace even when I went out.

When there was an assassination attempt while walking on the first floor, the bedding in the room changed drastically.

Clank.

Around that time, I knew the utility of the shackles and chains that wrapped around my ankles.

Chaser could know wherever I was with this chain. It was because of this that he was able to run just before I was hit by a knife to my neck.

<Iana!>

When I was in danger, he ran like mad.

.....It’s better than I thought, right?

It was a change of mind in an urgent situation, but I concluded that I was satisfied in my own way.

What can I do? Can you live outside here? My unfortunate life, and will crying change the situation?

If you can’t change the situation, you can change your mind and live comfortably.

How difficult would that be?

I'll just be the villain's sister.

This was the beginning of my comfort confinement life when I was satisfied with my stomach and back.

It was a 'comfortable' and 'convenient' confinement.

At least, Chaser did not starve my meal, and always gave it the highest grade and filtered out the poison that was mixed with it.

"Good is good."

I sat down, knocking on my stomach and muttering. Chubby. There was someone who looked closely at my hand knocking on the belly.

"What are you looking at?"

I turned my head towards the person sending their gaze.

In front of me, the cheeks that seemed like new white and glutinous rice cakes were twitching. It's not really scary to puff up your peach-colored cheeks.

"Oh, do I have to say this."

Raising my arms up on the table, I grinned with my chin resting.

"Wat ah yu looki at?"

My pronunciation was crushed, and the other side knocked on the table, banging at my voice, as if it were a baby muttering.

Bang bang!

His little fist pounded the table.

"Hey, lady! Don't talk like that!"

Would a strong table shake with a small fist like a child's? It wasn't like a child, it was more like a baby.

“Ah, then, what should I say?”

“Don't say anything!”

The teeth in front of its eyes were burning.

The fluffy, dark, sky blue hair and darker green eyes were round, as if they had beads inserted into them, and the face was full of color.

This child, who was only like a 6 years old if it stands, was Chaser's subordinate, the black wizard Marshmallow.

Currently, he was getting angry with a wand that is difficult for that body to handle, and as you can see with that wand, he was the wizard who enchanted my shackles and the one who extended the chain.

“Why are you, Mr. Marshmallow. Have a joke.”

“It's Majimello!”

“It's difficult to pronounce. It's easy to shorten it.”

The name is difficult to pronounce, so it is roughly shortened and called it as Marshmallow.

“What's that. That's not a joke, Jana!”

Oh, yes, it's not an abbreviation.

“Ah, it's a mistake. It's a mistake. Don't be angry at small things. Aren't you small

“I'm all grown up! My body is taller!”

“Not that body, but this body.”

“My body!”

“Yes yes, did you get taller?”

As you can see, he looks like a small child, but the inner core is a fine adult man.

‘He moves well with that size. Oh, I thought he said he was flying.’

I have seen it in a book. A black wizard who serves Chaser and was his left arm in charge of all kinds of work behind the scenes.

That’s the side effect of studying black magic.

Right now, he’s working on a way to get back to normal, but it looks like it’ll be a long way off. Because Chaser puts so much work for him.

Due to the nature of the black wizard being rejected and ostracized, it would be good for him to be by Chaser’s side. He wouldn’t even be able to run away with that baby face.

If Ricdorian had the wizard Jair, this person was the opponent of him.

He seems to be a great wizard, considering the chains on my ankles and the skill of extending the lengths of those chains.

When I think of Jair, he has a pretty cute visual though.

“Agghh! Lady!!”

But it’s this fierce.

“Come on, go! Go! Look at your book.”

He slammed the palm of my last month. There was no dignity at all, but at least I pretended to concentrate.

He was my teacher. There was also the reason why the words were so short. I didn’t like the way the baby was treated with extreme respect.

“But why should I study the history of the empire?”

Recently, Chaser happily assigned his busy Black Wizard as a study partner.

“Do you want to live a good life?”

“That’s right.”

“You don’t want to have a sore stomach and sore back right? You dog pig.”

“... don’t call me a dog pig with that face.”

(T/N: I couldn’t find an Eng equivalent of dog-pig, but it’s a slang that means a greedy, foolish person that speaks ill or belittles people. Just negative.)

I answered in a quibble way.

I didn’t feel the need to study, and here this little wizard’s misery began.

“Then, you need to know what you’re doing in the house.”

I need to know what about our house, our family. I questioned seriously.

“Even if I don’t know about that... Wouldn’t my brother feed me?”

“This parasite!”

“Yes. Yes, please make me a pretty moth.”

Chapter 129: Missing Heart (1)

Chapter 129: Missing Heart (1) (Chapter 66 According to Raw)

After the scuffle, I managed to read a book.

‘I’m serious.’

I mean, Chaser won’t let me go. In addition, it was also difficult to go out and live thanks to the rush of resentment.

I didn’t know why Chaser made me study.

The age standard of an adult here is 18, but I lacked common sense. I thought it was unnecessary while I was protected from a resentful attack, but now I’ve decided it wasn’t.

Clink. The chain shook.

I’ve been wagging my feet over a much lighter and thinner chain from about four months ago.

“What you do. Do it quickly!”

... Sometimes this person’s pronunciation isn’t like a baby, but it’s like a foreigner’s poorly spoken Korean. Or it may sound like the tone of a 6-year-old child who just outgrew the baby stage.

I looked at the book.

[Therefore, there are as many as five families in the empire-]

It was a passage from a history book. It was easily interpreted to fit the title of liberal arts that everyone should know.

Among them, I found a familiar pattern.

I had forgotten a report a long time ago. I pulled this out of my memory.

“Hey, Mr. Marshmallow, what is this pattern? Please explain.”

“It’s not Marshmallow, hey!”

“Yes, okay. Mr. Pudding. What do you say?”

His dainty face huffed but his eyes were steadily falling. I held back my laughter.

However, it was the eyes that was pathetic to return.

“Lady, do you even have a basic history?”

“Whether it’s ‘lady’ or ‘you’, choose one. Yes, I don’t know. Didn’t you know I’m ignorant?”

I was confident.

“... why are you so proud?”

The Black Wizard explained to me while showing a ridiculous expression.

“This is a magical pattern that has been passed down from ancient times. It is known that only the imperial family and Rose Family can use it as gatekeepers.”

I roughly interpreted it in his words as : a pattern that most of the people know that only the royal family and the rose family can use.

“It’s also basicl. Know a little bit. Don’t embarrass the master. You don’t know that?”

“It’s a very basic thing, isn’t it?”

I looked at the pattern carefully. No matter how much I look at this, I saw it in the prison cell.

It was a pattern seen from inside a hole in an underground cell. However, it was very different in shape. It feels like it was taken out and expressed in abbreviated form, so to speak?

And it seems to have been transformed. It was drawn simply so that anyone could recognize it.

It was purely because of the strange animal figures painted together with the roses painting.

I looked at each of the fragmented patterns and stopped.

It was a bright red rose. Ricdorian, it was his pattern.

“Hey, Mr. Tart, what’s this animal thing? I’m so curious.”

“....lady, don’t you have to call me properly?”

“I know, I know, I know, Mr. Marshmall.”

The little black wizard sighed. Even so, the little cheeks were cute mumbling, but I hid the fact. He knows he’s cute so he gets angry when I say he’s cute. He wants to be a dignified black wizard.

“Do you know about the Rose?”

“Yes, roughly.”

“The Rose Family has a special ability of a guardian deity. This is called ‘Numen’, and it is also called the god of protection.”

“God of protection....”

You mean the thing that my brother has too.

I often thought of a bird that started a fire. Now, more than a year later, I was accustomed to the appearance of a bird burning the head of an intruder.

Subsequently, he said that the Rose and the Domulit were a family with two gods.

I also saw another beast that my brother had. I nodded at that. The little warlock liked my attitude of listening.

Not surprisingly, I pressed my face and turned to the sentence. The reddish red rose was particularly noticeable.

Then this is the guardian deity of Ricdorian. The words only felt odd.

“Have you seen a Rose?”

“Huh? No, it’s just because it’s amazing.”

Being a guardian deity, if there were such things, would the man live a more comfortable life?

That man is, of course, Ricdorian.

It was purely because of Marshmallow that I learned in detail about the Rose and their power. Because Chaser told me that he had exceptionally strong and powerful power, there were people born with strong abilities even within the Rose family, and there were people born with weak powers as well as ordinary people.

“Look, it’s insignificant. The guardian deity is now just a name but no reality*.”

“Wow, it’s amazing how you use difficult words with that face. She sells seashells**, try it.”

“Don’t make fun of me!”

Anyway, with this ability, it was born only in Grand Duke Hel’s. The reason for the abuse towards Ricdorian was obvious.

‘Now I have an idea.’

After sharing a few more words, the class ended. It was like chatting under the guise of a class. After class that wasn’t so class-like, I was left alone in the room. I moved in the room and opened the familiar door.

When I first came here a year ago, it was the room that Chaser gave me.

It hasn’t been a long time, but the room was clean.

Now, I came to a room with pillars, and I don’t have to sleep here anymore, and now I don’t think I want to escape the room. I was curious.

“‘The guardian deity is now just a name but no reality.’What does this mean?”

When Marshmell spoke of the rose guardian, he just pretended not to know, but was curious.

I couldn’t wonder about others in front of the little black wizard.

I knew how Chaser regarded my interest in others.

It’s just a light curiosity, and I wanted to be comfortable.

‘So let’s see. To the extent that only a little curiosity is met.’

As seen before, I lifted up the fabric decoration. There was still something on the wall.

“Half here.”

I went to the next room. It was still inscribed on the wall there.

“And here are red and white roses.”

There are red and white roses, which are the crests of the male and female lead families. And next to the white rose was a guardian deity.

One red rose has no guardian deity.

“You mean to find this, right?”

About a year ago, I was busy looking at it, and I forgot it. At this moment, I was willing to try to escape the room. The big thing was that there wasn't much to do.

And....

<... The promise. You'll keep it...?>

I closed my eyes and then opened them.

I needed to focus.

Like the first room, the room had something like a symbol under the pattern, as if scraped with a knife. Probably a clue to finding something that isn't in this pattern.

It was drawn like a mountain and a sun and an arrow down was visible. The sun is rising between the mountains. And the part corresponding to the east of the symbol is circled. And this looks like a bookcase. The square was full of books.

“The second downstairs to the east, next to the bookshelf?”

I stopped muttering and took a quick step. It wasn't long before I arrived at the room where I was aiming for.

As soon as I opened the door, I approached the bookshelf. Not to be confused, there was only one bookcase. I squatted in front of the bookshelf and removed the small decorative pots next to the bookshelf, and I smiled.

Bingo.

There was a small beast depicted there.

“Found it.”

But soon I tilted my head.

..... I found it, but what do I do now?

I scratched my cheek. As soon as something started, it felt like I had found an escape route. Well, what to do.

‘It’s too sad.’

Thinking so, it was when I tapped the animal shape.

Puk.

What? My finger....., what is it? Unsurprisingly, the animal-carved parts were spinning around.

What is this? As I stared blankly at the turning of the bricks, I stuck my hand out like possessed. It seemed that someone forced me in.

The bracelets and jewelry on my arm shook with a pretty rough pull. And the moment the jewel touched the stone, a familiar light flowed out. It was the same process as the one in the cell hole.

“Ugh, what is it....”

When I frowned in the glare and closed my eyes and opened them, there was something I couldn’t see.

It was a small figure. No, something that was translucent enough to be mistaken for a hologram gradually took on reality.

The little thing looked at me and tilted its head.

It had round ears, gray stripes on a white background, and hair with black dots. The shape was like a baby cheetah, but the tail was thick and long.

But the moment I looked into the gray and blue eyes and the eyes of a beast that was so clear and transparent, I thought of a man.

“Ricdorian?”

The thought was not long. It was because the beast revealed its teeth.

-Human!

I blinked my eyes.

The animal’s eyes are finely curved. At the same time, the little black wizard’s words passed through my head.

<Don’t you know this?>

“... a snow leopard?”

I muttered abruptly. Even the white, gray hairs that are close to silver, or even the blue eyes were all drawn from Ricdorian.

-Ahem, human. Oh, did you save me?

“It doesn’t suit your ancestors.”

It felt like the atmosphere was breaking. That’s because the snow leopard in front of me was too small.

But whether or not, the snow leopard came to me and smacked the soles of its feet, which were large compared to my body, on my thighs.

Kang Kang! Weong Weong!

-Take me! Get me on your back!

Curiously, the cry of an animal and a human voice were heard together.

Kwaang!

-I’ll give you glory!

The problem was that the human voice was a childish voice like the small black wizard.

“...what glory what nonsense, what are you?

Kang Kang, listening to the sound of the beast with a sharp feeling, I felt like I remembered one of the scenes that I missed. I quickly erased my strange feelings.

... It has the same color.

Waong! Kyang Kyang! Kyaooh!

-There is no need to hide the truth. I know everything! You woke me up because you have longed for me!

—

Notes:

*: The word used was actually an idiom that means has a name but no reality or more like exists only in name.

** : She actually gave him a Korean tongue twister, but it doesn't make sense translated to English. But if you want to try, she gave him the short version of the tongue twister: 간장 공장 콩팔.

I think the long version was this: 경찰청 쇠창살 외철창살, 검찰청 쇠창살 쌍철창살.

Chapter 130: Missing Heart (2)

Chapter 67 Missing Heart (2)

“Truth something, you’re talking the same thing.”

-Oho, human, come on~! Do you think anyone can get me out!

“.... you don’t have to do that with a childlike voice.”

And if I let you out, does that mean I’m even more amazing? I blinked with wide open eyes.

I think I got into an accident.

In my head, I was just thinking about how to handle this.

No. My peaceful life!

-You’re not honest!

So what is it?

“.....Are you Hernim’s magical beast?”

-That’s right!

The snow leopard revealed his teeth and cried kyaong.

-I’m finally released from the seal, I’m going to take this great body! It’s been 9 years!

Thanks to the pink gums with little fangs, there was no dignity at all as if he was an ant's nails.

"I don't think that's a boast."

-What?!

Waaaeeonng!

... Whether this is a cat or a wild bear. I sighed as I stroked its fluffy tail. What kind of animal has a thick tail like this?

In my head, the voice of the small black wizard rang loudly in my head.

<"Look, it's insignificant. The guardian deity is now just a name but no reality.">

Don't tell me this was it?

The situation fell right. Hernim's beasts or something is here.

In addition, the snow leopard itself said it was sealed. Listening to the time, it just seems to fall perfectly.

.... And I know that Ricdorian was locked up around that time.

Is this Chaser's job?

Then it gets worse. With an embarrassing expression, I alternated between the broken bricks, stone chips, and snow. How do you seal this thing again?

"Is it possible to lock you up... No, no. Can't you go back in?"

I squeezed the beast's head. Can't it fit into the wall?

"Please go in."

Then the snow leopard had a shocked face. Its open mouth and sky blue eyes was filled with water.

-What are you talking about! Hey, who will confine this great body! No! Don't want!

Kyaaong! Waong! Waaaceonng!

"... Are you not familiar with human language? Why do your speech change back and forth. But please go in."

-Yes, I know your heart! You're not being honest!

"So what's the point of being honest, no. I'll be in trouble now because of you. Please go back."

Before I could add anything, the fluffy thick feet like cotton covered my lips.

-I....I tried not to do this! I'm telling you to be honest!

"Eup, eup!"

So what the hell is it! What do you mean to be honest!

My eyes sank before he even cleared his little feet. It was flooded out of nowhere. I tried to resist, but my eyes were forcibly closed as if someone had hit me.

And when I opened my eyes, I was in a completely new space.

I breathed low afterwards. I swept my face down with a complicated mind. It feels like I'm getting caught up in something

This is the first time I've felt this way since I saw Chaser burning the bases of those who kidnapped me more than a year ago.

"...I want to live in peace."

I didn't know what this space was, but it was dark and stuffy. Seeing nothing also played a part. There must be something that the snow leopard hopes for... If I don't say anything, wouldn't you let me go?

Let's hold on.

With that, I decided to try to wait for a long time.

I firmly determined that I would not speak, and I grabbed the hem of my clothes.

It was then.

A pure white hand appeared in the air. Then he squeezed my hand lightly. It wasn't even giving me strength, it was a very weak force.

Mom!

I was surprised and shook my hands. Oh, that scared me. I thought it was a ghost. But the hand hesitated and grabbed me again.

".... don't."

A familiar, or now, strange voice hardened my shoulders.

This voice.

"Don't avoid it."

The shadows gradually lifted from the dark. Arm to shoulder, shoulder to face... The moment I saw the slowly revealing figure, I opened my eyes wide.

My lips were wide open.

"... no, why are you avoiding me?"

In front of me stood a tearful Ricdorian.

"Is it you?"

Tears dripping down his cheek.

“Is it really you?”

The hand that held me gained strength.

“The days were long without you.”

He lowered his head.

“Umm.... the night, it was longer”

Drop, drop, drop. Fallen water drew black circles on the floor. Before I knew it, he and I were sitting on a stone floor.

It was the cell.

“Ricdorian?”

Why is the place in a cell? Why?

Whoop, a stretch of view, filled the surroundings. Torches and cold walls, the drips and chills. No matter how hard I looked at it, it was the cell.

And finally, there was Ricdorian, dressed in the same clothes as when I saw him.

“Well, though, I waited well.”

He stuttered and continued.

It was a little unfamiliar as the tears formed like dew. He was still white and neat, but it gave a sense of maturity that I could not see if there was water. It was only about a year, and he felt like he grew up a lot.

The moment I looked up, I realized that I wasn't mistaken.

The face that had the right view was suddenly higher than me.

He took the tip of my hand to his moist eyes and rubbed it on his cheek.

“... did you wait well for me?”

A wet voice that seemed to be hungry for praise, and it felt like my saliva was dry.

“That’s why you came here?”

I squeezed my lips, but his gaze stuck to my lips and didn’t fall off. It had transparent eyes with water hanging from it.

“Did you wait well? Tell me.”

Why aren’t you stuttering now? I felt like my heart was pounding because I was focused on the slightly hoarse tone.

Why am I in front of you?

It wasn’t long to be sentimental.

It was because there was something scratching on my head.

That, that...that cat!

Hernim’s guardian deity had been downgraded to a cat. The moment I caught it, it disappeared, so it was obvious that it was the culprit.

However, I couldn’t see the beast anywhere in the space, the only thing that was there was Ricdorian.

What the hell should I take this as? Fantasy? Fake?

I calmed myself down.

“Hi, Ricdorian.”

Fortunately, my voice didn’t shudder.

“How are you?”

I reached out and tried to stroke his hair, but I paused.

But it's weird, this wasn't the last Ricdorian I saw, whether it's fake or anything. His appearance with the opposite sex still remained childish.

I regarded this as an illusion created by the beast. However, when I thought so, there weren't one or two strange things.

Did you usually see something you didn't see in your fantasy?

Why is he so big in just over a year? Did I even imagine unconsciously of something I had never seen?

Warmness touched my hand, which was still in the air. He pulled my hand. He brought my hand to his head, and put it down. As our gaze met in that state, he smiled slightly. He grabbed the back of my hand and let me gently stroke his head.

"I'm not... I'm not doing well."

I couldn't take my eyes off the face. He slowly closed his eyes, lowered my hand and leaned it on his cheek.

"I miss you. "

I felt the tears in my palm. Did the beast even reproduce the chill of the cell? The cold tears were cold. However, his cheeks were hot, like a fever.

"You know, Iana."

The silver eyelashes that were long and slightly curled up in front of my nose moved like a butterfly. I wondered if the trembling like the wings of a butterfly had settled in my heart.

"It's about a year of the promise."

"Ah...."

I came to my senses. Has enough time passed for him to say this? No. I forgot.

“You haven’t forgotten either, have you?”

“That’s...that’s right.”

I can’t forget it. I laid my eyes down.

I parted with that face, how can I forget it?

But I didn’t put it on my lips.

“... you seem a little skinny.”

“The guard said that I... was tall.”

“Yes, I think so.”

“I ate well. Because you told me to do that.”

In the last greeting I gave, there was also a story about eating well and growing up well.

I expected him to be blatantly struggling with this harsh environment. I hoped he was doing well.

However, I didn’t think he would have lived with a face like this waiting for praise.

I’m sorry to tell you, but I haven’t thought of you all the time. No, I couldn’t.

<Iana!>

<Cough! Cough... >

My life, which I thought would flow calmly, was more like a war than I thought.

My unhurriedness helped me to adapt to the urgent situation, but that did not mean that the urgency of the situation had disappeared.

“Well done.”

Instead of telling him about this situation, I moved my hand. I could feel the texture of the cheeks softer than usual as it bent at the fingertips. It was soft like silk.

For some reason, he feels more refined. No, it is natural for people to grow up.

Previously, he used to have a very cute red face. I didn't raise him, but I felt a little disappointed.

“Is the image of the beast coming out now?”

Then he shook his head with a gloomy face.

“It's still not yet....”

It didn't seem to have been fixed yet. It's a long way for the original work to begin. Until then, you'll know how to speak even in the form of that beast.

Is that possible?

“Is that so? It's not a good thing....”

I said honestly.

“I know that, but I am a little happy.”

I'm sorry to say that to you, though.

“Because that's you too, Ricdorian.”

I poked his cheek once.

“I liked it too, you know.”

Your beast mode was also very cute. As time passed, the firstly watchful figure followed me very well like a cute dog.

I was lost in the memories that came to mind. I overlooked the possibility the words I spit out could be misleading.

“...That, uh.... do?”

“What?”

“Yo, you too, I....”

Ricdorian was holding my hem with his hand that was not holding my hand.

“I, I like you. .”

Ah. Only then did I realize what I said.

Chapter 131: The Heart is Both Physical and Emotional (?)

Chapter 68. The Heart is Both Physical and Emotional (?)

“...Uh, yes, but. That’s why I said I like the animal side. You’re cute.”

“Cu, cute...”

“You’re cute.”

Hwaaaak.

His face burned fiercely as soon as I finished speaking. Unlike before, he was embarrassed and flustered and avoided my gaze.

I suddenly remembered our first meeting and burst into laughter.

“Did I make you embarrassed? I’m sorry.”

Ricdorian couldn’t answer with his head down. I thought he was different. Seeing this look, the reassurance and regret subtly crossed.

“I’m glad you seem healthy.”

I was hoping you were well. Jair offered to stop the abuse, but what happened to that? He shook his body slightly, but I couldn’t tell.

There was no trace as his upper body healed quickly due to his healing power. So it wasn’t clear if he was still being abused. I can’t even ask.

I felt embarrassed as I looked into the sparkling eyes.

“Well, are you hurt anymore?”

I turned around and asked a question.

“...I’m not hurt.”

He looked into my eyes and mumbled. But in the middle of telling me why, I looked puzzled.

“No, it hurts. It hurts!”

“Are you hurt?”

I tilted my head. His body looked fine. You don’t look hurt.

“That... it hurts.”

“Where?”

“....that.”

I watched in real time his neck slipped in like a turtle. He touched my hand, leaning on his cheek, and lifted his eyes slightly.

“....If I’m hurt, you’ll be worried...”

“Oh, God. Can a person be so cute?”

“What?”

“I’m at loss.”

I rubbed my eyes with a hand that was not caught by him. I thought he was a little bigger, but the harm to the heart is still there, right?

A laughter leaked out. Look at those eyes closed. Huh. Now it’s just asking for it.

In addition, he’s taller than I am, so bend over and look up from below... .

“I want to make you cry.”

“....what?”

“Well, no.”

The voice of my heart popped out by mistake. Good idea. Good idea.

For the first time in a while, I shouted out a good idea, closed my eyes from him, and pressed the back of my hand against his lips and then released it. Ricdorian quickly grabbed my fingertips.

“Are you hurt?”

“Huh? Me?”

My hand that fell from his mouth made a wacky sound. It seemed that what he was looking at was my hand.

“On the finger.”

“On my finger...? Ah.”

There was a long scratch at the tip of my index finger. It was a thin and long wound, as if it was cut on paper.

There is solid blood on it, perhaps it was bleeding or not. I didn't even know it got hurt.

I held my finger and straightened it. It was that moment. Tuk. The wound burst and blood formed.

“Bleed, bleeding.”

“That's all right.”

Why is this bleeding? I overlooked the size of the wound, so there was more blood coming out than I thought. I tried to wipe the blood formed like red beads, but Ricdorian was faster than that.

“Ricdorian?”

By the time I called, he had already put my finger on his lips.

“What, huh....”

His tongue swept through the joints. My words got lost without knowing. It was an unfamiliar feeling of the tongue wrapping my fingers.

I thought he would be more embarrassed than me, but for some reason, Ricdorian was staring at me with serious eyes.

I stiffened my shoulders at the cold blue iris. It was for a moment, but he looked like a different person. No, rather like when he grew up...

His mouth was warm and wet. As the mushy tongue swept and wrapped around the wound, I felt weird without knowing it.

My spine stiffened naturally.

“Ricdorian , stop. Stop it.”

But as Ricdorian was looking into my eyes, he seemed unwilling to quit.

Usually, in this case, he has to be surprised to let go first.

Only after he had wiped all the wounds, he removed my finger from his lips. His cheeks blushed.

“...Don’t get hurt.”

His tongue glanced over his lips, dripping of saliva. No, my eyes didn’t fall even though I thought so

“You shouldn’t be hurt. Iana.”

The blood has stopped, but it seems that my heart is thumping and pumping blood. It doesn’t really calm down.

“Huh?”

Hence, his head was just around my ears, so I felt his low breathing through my ears. My stiff shoulders bent over this time.

Perhaps after putting a finger on his lips, his voice sank low. I felt my toes curl up.

“....Okay, okay.”

This is a mistake. I muttered a little. When I think about it, I can guess where this wound came from. It seemed that my hand was tingling when I pulled out Von Her’s beast, that shitty cat.

It disappeared faster than it appeared. Yeah, what can I do if I’m angry about it?

“Don’t get hurt.”

The warmth moved back to the back of my hand. He took my hand and muttered a little.

“You will come to pick me up in good shape.”

The voice that seemed to scratch the inside of my neck aroused the tension I had forgotten. My ulterior motives slipped over my head.

“I hope you don’t get hurt either.”

His cheeks were blushing. He slowly lowered his gaze while remaining there. With a contradictory face in which purity and oddity coexist.

“After two months, will you come to pick me up?”

The inevitable question has arrived.

“You will, won’t you?”

I touched my lips, neither answering nor being completely silent.

“You didn’t answer. Then.”

He seemed unbroken with the silence.

“It’s a dream anyway, and you’ve always been.”

Dream? The temperature that had become hot stopped for a while. The cheek that was about to heat up.

What do you mean by a dream?

Everything was vivid to me. This space, and Ricdorian in front of me. It feels like the time has turned back to the extremely vivid cell....

“It’s a dream...”

Ricdorian said it was a dream.

“Because it’s a dream. Is it okay?”

“What?”

My eyes, which had been facing the ceiling of the cell for a moment, turned to him again. Then I pushed my back. But I had nowhere to retreat. Because I felt a cold wall on my back.

From the beginning, I was in front of the cell wall. I overlooked it because I was focusing on him all the time.

With nowhere to retreat, his face was right in front of me.

“Even in a dream, please make me miss you.”

“...Ricdorian.”

Now you, you’re under a lot of illusion. The words just passed through. It was because he came closer.

“You know what? For a long time... it’s only the second time.”

“Second...?”

“The number of times you appeared in my dreams.”

So even if I am not your dream. A cold sweat flowed on my spine. I wiggle my fingers, but this seemed to stimulate him even more.

Touch- The lips touched lightly and then fell off.

His eyes were stained with hue as if it was coloured. Even the ears seen through the hair are red.

“Because it’s a dream... It’s okay. Yo, you and I are the only ones here.”

The moment I raised my eyes, I couldn’t move as if caught by the eyelashes moving like a butterfly at that moment.

“Do not avoid.... Huh?”

Then it seemed like his lips were opening slightly, slowly.

The moment when the clumsy and filthy lips hover around my lips, then opened and touch my lips.

It was dark in front of my eyes.

“Haa....”

His warmth disappeared, I stared at my hand quickly. Ricdorian’s hand disappeared, but I still felt as if I was caught.

‘This... What. How.’

The place was again in Chaser’s mansion room. The time hadn’t passed at all.

Yes, it was the time when the strange beast was taken out.

“What the..”

-Have you seen it, human!

As if waiting, the cry of the beast, the voice of the child, and both voices were heard.

Weeoweeoweeong Kyaang.

I just rolled my eyes. The beast, who I didn't know whether it was a snow leopard or a cat, was crying proudly with its soles on my thighs.

“What have you done to me now?”

The snow leopard was very small and light enough to hold in my hand. I grabbed the beast and lifted it.

-Let go, let go! What are you doing! Let me go!

“Speak quickly!”

The lost feet swam wildly in the air. The snow leopard made a shocked expression as I showed no signs of letting go.

-I, I helped you, Nyan!

“Nyan? Don't say nyan. You show people a strange fantasy and what?”

-Don, don't shake me, don't shake me, nyan!

Since I am in a hurry, I think my original way of speaking comes out.

-It's not a fantasy, it's a dream!

“Dream?”

The snow leopard cried and nodded quickly.

-That's right! There was a human there, right? It's that human's dream.

As soon as I stopped shaking it, the tone of the snow leopard returned to the strange ancestor's body.

“Huh?”

Dream, what dream! I think I'll shake you up so you can't move. As I shook it again, the snow leopard hissed.

-What, what did you do to this body that helped you, it's rude!

“What did you do to help me.”

Rather, 'that human', Von Hel 's beast acted as if he didn't know Ricdorian well.

“Hey, you don't know him? The one who was there.”

-Are you talking about the human in the dreams? I don't know! I was just showing you that human's dream!

“Why don't you know?”

-I don't know, what this body saw is that human bumping his mouth at you, Nyan! Don't shake me!

“You're talking nonsense.”

I shook the snow leopard. The thick tail hit the back of my hand, but it didn't hurt at all because it was a cotton bat.

-Haven't you been honest in your dreams?

“Honest?”

-You released me while thinking of that man! So in return, I let you see him because you didn't know the reason. Nyan!

The snow leopard that said 'I showed you because you didn't know the reason for releasing me Nyan!' was a cry full of resentment.

“... You really don’t know who he is?”

Chapter 132: The Magical Beast Who Lost Its Contractor

Chapter 69. The Magical Beast Who Lost Its Contractor

-I said I don't know, Nyang!

“Why don't you know? He's the successor to Hernim?”

The snow leopard's eyes widened. Is it such a surprise?

-Su, su, successor?!

“Yes.”

No, the color is perfect for him. The fur color and pupils of the snow leopard match exactly with Ricdorian's.

“You don't have to look at me like that. He's Hernim's successor.”

Originally, you were supposed to be the guardian deity of Ricdorian's, right? I think so.

“Isn't he your original owner?”

-You are the owner!

“Oh, I'm surprised.”

-The, there is no master of this great body! The guardian deity and the contractor do not have a master-slave relationship, Nyang!

“Yes, yes. Not ‘the’ owner, right?”

The eyes of the baby snow leopard shook a lot because they were full of confusion.

-N, no wonder. It was said the guardian deity, Nyang, can only enter the dream of a contract candidate...

“... You realize that now? Are you stupid?”

-Eek, this body is not a fool!

“Yeah, yeah, then you’re an idiot.”

-Hiiik!

Haak, haaak!

Now this cat did a lot of ‘haak, haak’. Even if it’s young, isn’t it a great cat?

I didn’t even treat it as a beast anymore.

“Yes, anyway. Why is the great idiot in this mansion?”

-I’m not an idiot, Nyang! And I’m sealed!

“Yes. Sealed. Why are you sealed?”

-That’s... .

The child’s voice in my head was blurred. Even the baby’s cotton-bat-like feet trembled. I felt the chaotic feeling overwhelming it.

-I don’t know... .

“You don’t know?”

-I... . This body was originally supposed to be in the candidate’s body upon birth. Nyan.

The snow leopard stuttered.

-But one day, a human caught me and then I opened my eyes and it was a dark space, Nyan. And I was sealed somewhere. Nyan.

Waeong, waeong, it weeped altogether.

-I can see the outside, but no one listened to this body, Nyang.

“You can see?”

-Yes, Nyang. I could climb the wall, but... No human beings noticed me, Nyang....

I can't believe it had been climbing the walls. I remembered the fragmented patterns that made me come to this place. Is it related?

-. . . . Except for the humans who have captured me.

The snow leopard trembled.

-Human, you were the first!

The small soles of its feet were lifted up. The snow leopard jumped into my thigh. It's fur was fluffy, but at the same time it was anxious.

-So, I'll give you a chance to help this great body!

“Rejected.”

As expected. My guesses for these points are always good. For example, things that can be bothersome or difficult.

-Why?! Help this great body!

“Umm, I refuse.”

-Why? Why!

“I don’t help cats.

-Weren’t you able to be honest thanks to me?*

“Is that ancestral accent a habit? Why do you keep using that accent?”

Instead of talking, the snow leopard asked back ‘accent?’. It tilted its little head while doing so. I should teach it a way to speak.

-This, to be polite... If we do this, we will overflow with dignity.

Polite?

“Are you talking about the beasts of Grand Duke Hernim’s?”

Grand Duke Hernim was said to have the ability too. Maybe it asked because they might have beasts too.

-Yes, Nyang.

“Hmm. Let’s get rid of it. It doesn’t suit you at all.”

-N, no! This great body will be a guardian deity full of dignity!

It’s stubborn. Yes, do whatever you want. I shook my head slightly.

“Yeah yeah. Great uh, um yeah. I’m done.”

And why don’t you go back there? I took turns looking at the broken stone chips and the snow leopard.

-Oh, I won’t go in!

“If you don’t change that tone, immediately.”

-I’ll fix it, fix it!

The snow leopard screamed loudly.

-No, I'm not going in!

"I'll put you in anyway."

I didn't say I wouldn't put it in. Then, as if the snow leopard realized that I wasn't too serious, it raised its claws and grabbed me.

-That's too much!

"Yes, yes, I have too much radish. I have lettuce too."

-This, don't be ridiculous! Nyang, I shouldn't be like this!

Waaaoonngg!

At that moment, the snow leopard cried desperately. Without knowing, I removed my gaze and turned to the snow leopard again.

Why are you shaking?

-I, I don't want to disappear, Nyang....

"Why are you like this?"

The baby beast's body was trembling. It was different from the previous surprise trembling.

Only then my face got serious.

-Originally, the body of the contractor candidate and I were one. By if we're far away for so long....

The voice coming into my head was whimpering.

-The contractor candidate will die. I also have no place to go back, Nyan. I will disappear too.

"....Die? What do you mean? Tell me in detail."

The watery blue eyes of the beast captured me. I felt as if Ricdorian was looking at me.

-I, I am the guardian of the red rose. We call the future contractors, the state before signing the contract, the contractor candidate. Nyang. And when the contractor of the red rose awakens.

Awakening, I don't know what to say.

-Originally, I should have been sleeping in the body of the contractor candidate. But someone took me away, Nyang.

“So?”

-The contractor candidate must have been short-lived and incomplete, Nyang. It is a characteristic of a red rose. We are one body.

The little snow leopard buried its head on both feet.

-He is also a contractor candidate... Did I lose my ability to recognize? Nyang.

The baby beast cried, and said that he couldn't recall its abilities right after seeing Ricdorian in a dream a while ago.

-This, this body isn't stupid, Nyan. I am weak enough to forget we're connected to a dream.

It's not because you're stupid, but because you're imperfect... .

“Not only you, but the candidate successor is incomplete?”

-Because me and the candidate successor in the first place, mature by being together... Nyang.

Why, what passed by is Ricdorian's appearance. Among them, he was barking loudly.

... I certainly never read something like that in a book. Why does the male protagonist bark, I was amazed. I do.

Wasn't this just because it was a time before the original book?

I couldn't decide.

-And after the preparation for awakening, the successor candidate meets the 'companion' who will help the awakening, I also show up outside, Nyang.

Companion, this must be referring to the original female protagonist. My expression subsided.

"You. Who is the person who sealed you? Remember?"

I don't want to be bothered anymore or give up my comfort, but my mouth moved.

-I... I remember, Nyang! It was a young human. Black hair....

The baby beast thought it was scary, and he dug in my palm and buried my head.

-Ot, other humans called the human 'Chaser'. I remember it!

Chaser.

The moment I heard the name, my heart sank. As I put my hand on my chest, I heard a thumping and beating sound. I could hear it, but it was a distant feeling to hear that.

I knew it.

The prediction was correct, but I just wondered if it was possible. It could have been Duke Domulit, not Chaser.

I wondered how the young Chaser got this beast out of Ricdorian.

But I couldn't bring it up.

However, I couldn't even put my face on my fingers and let go of the trembling baby beast.

"You know, Hernim is originally known to have a short lifespan. You said that if he doesn't meet his companion, he dies."

This tattoo of a red rose, born of Von Hel's, led to death if the destiny partner was not found until all the leaves of the rose fell.

-Right, right. However... If it remains in this state, the successor candidate will die sooner.

Ricdorian will die.

At least three more years left until the time of the original book. Until then, the story began under the assumption that Ricdorian was alive.

"...How much do you have left?"

-It's three years, Nyang.

The baby snow leopard explained that it is also the time when it disappears.

3 years.

It was about the same time as the beginning of the original book. When was the season of the beginning of the original work?

Listening to snow leopard's words, it was a few months after the original work began.

A few months apart, that is, when Ricdorian's life span is only a few months left, he will meet the heroine.

Until then it must meet him.

The beast trembled and said that he had no idea what would happen if he was still away from Ricdorian.

I held the snow leopard to my chest for now. It was like the shivering snow leopard looked up at me.

“...Just move and talk to him.”

I sighed a little.

Oh my life.

I couldn't get rid of it now that I've heard this far. Although I want to live quietly and comfortably as much as possible.

I can't let Ricdorian die. In addition, I am the younger sister of the current villain who is not willing to help. My brother was the villain who took this small guardian deity and sealed it.

Why are you feeling guilty when you've never felt like him as a brother?

“I'm going to my room.”

Right now, I shook the heavy story to the lighter side.

“Yeah, now I know your situation. Even showed Ricdorian.”

Honestly, it wasn't unwelcome to see Ricdorian after a long time. It's because the feeling is a bit complicated.

The moment I thought of rubbing my face on my fingertips in my dream a while ago, it felt like my hands were burning again.

... Why do you want more?

“But there is one thing I don't understand yet, why do you want me to be honest?”

I understood most of what this cat said. Except for this.

-When pulling me out, didn't you think of that human? Nyang.

The snow leopard, who I didn't know if it was a beast or a cat, tilted its head.

"I didn't think about him?"

-No, you did.

Well, it was Ricdorian's family pattern, so it could be..

"Yes, let's say that, you showed me the dream and told me to be honest."

-Wasn't you honest in your dream?

"Speak clearly."

-This great body speaks with dignity...

"Do you want me to help you?"

-..... Didn't you?!

"Yes. Did I become honest in the dream?"

The snow leopard tilted its head.

-Rubbing snouts with that human...

"Ah, ah! Ah. All right. All right. Stop there."

(T/N: the Deity was using a way of speaking that is mostly used in historical dramas and not used now.)

Chapter 133: Cat Pudding(1)

Chapter 70. Cat Pudding(1)

I hurried to stop the cat from speaking.

“What is it, then you forced it?”

– What are you talking about, Nyan? This body did nothing! I didn’t force it.

I looked down at the snow leopard instead of trying to grab the doorknob.

-All I did was make you more honest in the dreams, Nyan, dreams are where the original shell is peeled off, Nyan!

It was awkward to say philosophical words like grandfathers in such a young voice, but I had no time to point out.

– He was the person you longed for when you took me out. I didn’t know he was the heir of the Red Rose, but I was only helping you to see that human, Nyan!

The innocent blue eyes turned to me.

-Human, you could refuse, Nyan!

I rolled my eyes at the poignant words.

– You could do anything, Nyan! Hold that person there... .

“Stop, stop.”

I cut it off and raised the back of my hand. He just rubbed his lips with the back of my hand.

“Stop talking. I know what you are talking about.”

I don't want to know what you're thinking. This isn't the way. It felt like a fever burning on my cheeks.

“..... go ahead and talk about the rest.”

I think I should go to my room and rest first. The heat also cools on my right cheek.

Thinking like that, I opened the door and turned around.

“Iana.”

Someone was leaning lightly against the wall. There was no way I could not have known the owner of this familiar voice, a man who felt elegant like a swan, even in a posture that seemed to be simple.

“I'm looking for you because I wondered where you went.”

Chaser turned around gently. His hair gently shook in the soft breeze.

“I was wondering if it was a dangerous situation again..... I was worried.”

It was a voice of infinite tenderness. However, his bright red eyes were moving slowly.

Before long, it stopped in one place.

“But what is this?”

His back hardened. What Chaser was looking at was the snow leopard in my arms.

Next to him was a slender black jaguar.

“...This is Von Hel’s dog.”

He smiled warmly. His eyes were not smiling at all.

Of course, I was terrified to see it.

“Why are you here?”

Chaser’s eyes were not on me. From the moment he brought it up to the time he said these words, those red eyes were only looking towards the snow leopard.

I can’t even say a word when I look from the side, but I can’t imagine what the pressure will be on the little snow leopard.

<Iana, get out of the way.>

The baby snow leopard dug into my chest. It was a gesture full of fear. Instead of rejecting it, I gave my hands strength.

I’ve been watching him for the past year or so. A figure that can be cruel to any place if he raises a sword. And I remembered myself shaking my head in front of the tip of his sword.

“Brother.”

It was only at my call that Chaser’s eyes moved. No, it was a reflex movement, as if waiting.

Then, the smile on his face was as soft as waiting for my call.

“Hey, what’s going on?”

I just listened to Chaser and asked something obvious. It was an attempt to have a kind of peaceful conversation.

Chaser seemed to be squinting at my hand for a moment.

“I came to look for you.”

Chaser stopped talking about the snow leopard, but instead reached out his hand. His hand grabbed mine, which had been away. It was the hand that supported the snow leopard's feet.

Kiss.

He kissed my finger lightly. It reminds me of Ricdorian, who was kissing at the fingertips..

Curiously, the two had a similar way of kissing my hands, but the atmosphere was different.

“Coming all the way here to find me, it must have been troublesome. This is a floor you don't frequent.”

I tried not to catch my gulping breath. Fortunately, I was able to show my expression and voice calmly.

“That's right.”

“Don't worry.”

I smiled.

“Because I wasn't trying to run away.”

Chaser's hand that was holding me stopped. I continued without missing a moment.

“No assassin appears. I wasn't poisoned.”

I made eye contact with him. His eyes bent in a half-moon shape.

“Okay.”

Intertwining my hands with his hands. he murmured

“Then what is this?”

He asked softly, but I knew. That this is a situation on the brink of danger, like a giant black beast crouched down.

I gulped.

A question that has been asked countless times over the past year.

<Don't kill.>

I knew well that my answers would determine what he said and did the next moment.

“This is Von Her's beast.”

A voice came out of my mouth calmly.

“Didn't brother say that himself?”

My voice was quiet and calm. The face that said this would have seemed dull at first glance.

Of course, in the corner of my heart, I had an idea of what I had to do with this. I was just as selfish as any ordinary person had.

And I thought I would have just that much sympathy.

“And this told me directly. He is Von Hel's beast.”

It seemed to me that the snow leopard couldn't say anything, even cry, and he was trembling. Even though I felt this, I didn't stop.

“I heard that brother brought it here. Kidnapping or something.”

Chaser smiled.

“A kidnapping is a term used for people.”

“Then say it's poaching?”

I replied calmly.

“Well, Iana. Do I need to get someone’s permission or secretly catch it?”

I just want to hunt. Chaser whispered softly to me. Then his thumb gently rubbed my palm.

“It means that brother brought it anyway.”

“That’s right.”

Chaser readily agreed.

“Why did you bring it?”

But instead of answering this question for some reason, he stared at me. Long enough to be persistent.

.... Did you step on a mine? Or did I ask the wrong question?

As my worries grew, Chaser’s face came with a soft smile again. His voice was lower than before.

“Are you finally curious about me?”

The moment I face the gaze that scans me, I feel chilly. I felt a strange feeling going down my spine.

Even after revealing his true nature to me, he sometimes acted like a fool, behaved like a fool, or showed a sloppy appearance.

But his nature remained the same. He always held the sword at last.

<Pl, please save me, save me... .>

<Ahhh!>

I know the tip of the sword doesn’t point at me, but I know how to deal with it. Because I saw it right before my eyes

“Anyway, Iana.”

As my silence grew longer, Chaser smiled brightly.

“That, give it to me.”

His voice was kind and soft, but it contained irresistible power.

Ordinary people would have given up this beast here, bewildered by his powers, or nodding as if possessed.

The snow leopard was still trembling in my arms without making a single cry. His tiny claws pressed against my heart. It was a heart all of a sudden.

“Even if you say that, my brother’s abilities don’t work for me.”

Chaser’s ability was enchanting, and he was able to completely brainwash the humans he wanted to make up his mind for. However, he also had limitations and restrictions, so he was not able to use it as he pleased.

“Right.”

Chaser rolled his eyes.

“But I didn’t use it. I just want to give you the best voice.”

“Even if you tell me that way, nothing comes out.”

“Why not. Aren’t you looking at me?”

... Don’t you hear a lot about how you feel?”

“That’s what it sounds like all year round.”

Chaser burst into a small laughter.

“But you prefer soft things to scary things.”

He said, gently sweeping my hand. His veined fingers were nervous.

That's right.

Rather than doing crazy things with a sword, it was better to be like this. Like a big brother who cares for his only sister... . It was more convenient to act like this than to act like a crazy person.

I faced Chaser head on. I felt that I could no longer avoid it..

I took a small breath in. Making my fists open and clenching them was an act of resolving my own determination.

"I don't want to give it to you."

My lips trembled slightly with tension, but moved slowly, pretending to be normal.

"I'll have it."

I purposely hugged the snow leopard to my chest. like a child does. But my expression remained relaxed.

"I want to have this. Give me this."

No more avoiding my brother's eyes, I stared straight ahead.

The jewels piled up like a pile of stones, the most comfortable bed in the world, clothes that change every day, and the maids who rushed at a glance.

"Will you give it?"

My comfortable confinement was all a gift from him.

He laughed

"Sister, I can give you something other than this."

"Aha. Can't this be done?"

Both Chaser and I knew it. That I wasn't interested in everything he gave me.

For over a year, he asked me as a habit. I smiled as if imitating him at this moment.

“You asked me to tell you when I had something I wanted to have?”

I hugged the beast a little roughly. Then I took my hand from Chaser and lifted it up with both hands.

“I want this, brother.”

“....”

Chaser does not welcome the interest I show to others. Although I have rarely shown interest in others.

It was the same with things... It will also be the case for animals.

He was a very strange man.

Asking what I need

Even though he doesn't really like it if I pay attention to him.

What could have been the relationship between 'Iana' and you?

I inadvertently erased my interest. It didn't matter now.

The most important thing is that I know. That you cannot change Chaser's will by saying this.

So I added one more thing.

Chapter 134: Cat Pudding(2)

Chapter 71. Cat Pudding (2)

Clink.

As I took a step closer, the chains rattled as if waiting to reveal their presence.

“Brother, I didn’t say anything about a year ago when I was put on shackles and chains.”

It was true. When Chaser put a chain on me, I was like, oh, is this a new cell?

I may have tried to escape a couple more times.

“I never complained.”

You’re a smart person, so you’ll understand. I didn’t say anything about what you did.

Now please I want it.

I put the snow leopard between my arms and smiled.

“So, will you listen? I want this.”

Chaser was a villain, a man whose morals and conscience had already been sold. However, I learned over the course of a year or so that the only one who he didn’t do that to was me.

So,

“...okay.”

I knew this man would allow it.

“Okay, you keep it. Iana.”

The low voice was like looking at a sword wrapped in cloth. Even though it was soft, it couldn't hide its blade.

The blade was not directed at me.

“I can't do anything for you.”

The refracted anger was directed at the young beast.

“But you know what?”

Snarl. I saw a black jaguar crouching low beside him.

The jaguar's name is Rattan, the guardian deity who protects Chaser, just like the black bird that caused a fire about a year ago.

And Chaser commanded these beasts.

It's different from the little wizard's explanation, but I think this one is more appropriate.

Because those animals have been so loyal that they would die for Chaser.

In addition, they reacted sensitively to Chaser's emotions.

– Hiikkk! Hu, human. Take me away, get me out! Nyan!

The snow leopard, who had been unable to do anything because he had been frozen with fear, did not hesitate to lower his jaw when he saw Ratan. The only good thing is that the opponent is over there.

Of course, the black jaguar didn't seem to even snort at him.

“I have a question.”

The hand that was holding the snow leopard was grabbed by Chaser’s hand and was lifted up again.

“Why do you want this, simply because of this?”

I knew this was referring to the snow leopard.

“Or is there another reason you wanted it?”

Our fingers intertwined with each other. Chaser’s face came closer.

“I’m curious, Iana.”

The blood-red eyes came close as if I was reflected in it. At the close distance, I held my breath.

My fingers didn’t hurt, but it felt like my knuckles were pounding. It was because of the tension.

It felt as if Chaser was observing me, narrowing the distance as if chasing a liar.

“...what are you talking about?”

I barely opened my lips.

“I just liked how it looked.”

“I didn’t know you liked animals.”

I haven’t paid any attention to Chaser’s animals in over a year. Of course.

“I like cute things.”

The response to those words came from something other than me. Kiingg, the jaguar Rattan below cried.

“Hey, is my Rattan sad?”

“...why are you sad?”

“That’s, because you haven’t even looked at it in a year?”

Chaser shrugged his shoulders, leaving a light kiss on the back of my hand.

“I love you, my sister.”

Chaser reached out a hand that didn’t hold me. Flap, flap. Something passed in front of him and sat naturally on his arm. It was a black bird.

The bird, who I did not know where it appeared, gracefully folded its wings and looked at me.

Krrrr!

Then it bowed its head and cried. Somehow, this one also looked different than usual.

“Look, Aquala is upset too.”

I think it’s angry rather than upset. I embraced the snow leopard, thinking about what the bird had been burning for over a year.

– Hu, human. You must not let me go!

For some reason, it seemed that the eyes of Rattan and Aquala looking at the snow leopard became sharper.

“Why are they not cute, huh?”

“Yeah.”

At first, I wasn’t interested in these two animals.

Even saying it was cute a while ago was just trying to get over the situation. Of course, there are some that are cuter than snow leopards.

“...isn’t it cute?”

I can’t be honest, so I just spilled it roughly. It seems this was more of a mistake.

Now that I’ve found two beasts that look at me with their shocked eyes.

“Oh, I’m surprised.”

“No, why are you surprised? They’re all grown up.

“No. It’s been a while since this one was born... ah it’s been 10 years.”

“Wah.”

If the lifespan of an animal is 10 years, it is the age to have children and have grandchildren. It was a time when I shook my head.

Paaah!

A black light flashed in front of me.

“This....”

It was accompanied by Chaser’s troubled voice, who hardly ever panicked.

And when the black light and smoke disappeared, the eagle-like bird on Chaser’s arm was gone.

Beep!

Instead a very small black. Something like a sparrow was beeping.

.... Sparrow? Sparrow right?

I stared at the sudden change in absurdity.

“Look, it’s doing this because it’s sulking.”

“No. Why are you sulking...?”

Chaser shrugged his shoulders. It was an expression of not knowing too.

Rattan was not a jaguar, but a little cat. No, this one is also a jaguar, but it's as small as a snow leopard.

The two animals seemed to be at a loss as they could not elicit a particular reaction even when they became smaller.

“Hey, I thought you were cool enough even if you weren't cute.”

I reluctantly opened my mouth.

“I like cool things too.”

Then, Rattan's ears, who had been ignored, stood up. It came over quickly and rubbed its face against my leg.

... .What simple animals. For a moment, I wondered if this really was the guardian deity, but I shook my head.

Aquala, who burns anything, or Rattan, who pursues and kills intruders until the end.

The power of the two animals had already been felt.

“...let's go back and rest.”

It seems that the tension has been loosened due to the transformation of these two animals, and it seems to have softened like a jellyfish. If this is a talent, then it is a talent.

It wasn't bad for me.

“Can I go if we're done talking?”

I wanted to increase the distance as he got closer, but my hand was still clasped with him.

Come to think of it, there was one more thing in common between this man and Ricdorian.

They both like to clasp when holding hands. I usually don't catch it.

It felt like I couldn't get out of the hand that was interlaced with me, so it was creepy sometimes.

"My Sister, you don't have to ask me for permission. No, you're the only one who doesn't have to ask."

"Yes. I'll be going back."

"By the way, Iana."

If his voice was a sponge, it seemed that sweet honey would ooze out when pressed. But he was always a person who did not hesitate to say bloody words with such a voice.

"Is there really no reason?"

He was also a person who casually throws even words that pierces, just like this now.

"You just like it?"

"Yes. I like it."

I said so, then opened my mouth again and added.

"It's because it's a bit quiet. I have my older brother and the small wizard but... I don't have any friends, right?"

I don't know if 'Iana' had any friends. All I knew was that her friend passed away early.

If they had died when Iana was this age, they would have died very early. because she was young

“Friend?”

I came up with this to convince Chaser, huh. It wasn't my intention, but it seemed to work better than I expected.

Because he smiled and was troubled. But he also raised his lips for a moment.

“Isn't me enough?”

I didn't want to say yes or no here, so I just kept silent. He smiled as he had before.

The eyes that didn't smile at all, even with a nice smile on them, looked at me for a moment and they were gone.

“Yes... ..a friend.”

His hand fell.

“If you needed a friend, you should have said it.”

“...uh?”

“I got it. As long as it wasn't for some other reason, that's fine.”

He smiled

“You can have it. ...please don't like it more than me.”

It wasn't that he had grabbed my hand too hard, but my hand felt tingling, so I hid it behind my back and opened it, then hugged the snow leopard.

“Get some rest, my sister.”

Well, that word “rest” didn't feel like simply saying “rest”. I turned around and walked, ignoring the strange anxiety that felt like the beginning of something else.

Clink, clink.

Anywhere in this mansion, with the clear sound of chains announcing my presence.

A few days in, I kept the snow leopard safely in my hands. The snow leopard is temporary for me, but I got the name Pudding. No particular reason, it was because I like white pudding.

The pudding I ate that day was also white, and it was mixed with white.

The snow leopard objected, saying that the name had no dignity at all, but the name of this guy, who had already become a cat for me, won the bid as Pudding.

Pudding became quiet at one word.

-Broccoli? What is it, nyan?

When I showed it the broccoli, the dissatisfaction went away.

And if there was a slight difference from before, it was that Rattan and Aquala came all the time.

And for some reason, each was in the form of a small baby jaguar or a small sparrow.

No, baby jaguar aside, why is Aquala a sparrow? It must have looked like an eagle... .

– They, they're here, Nyang! Human, they're here!

Weeoongg, waong! Kaooo!

-Human! Take me away, Nyan! I got pecked with its beak! It pecked!

Kyaaaongg! Waaong! Waong!

“I know. Rather than that, can’t you have only one of two voices, a cry or a normal voice?”

It’s going to be noisy because it’s ringing in my head and ears and on both sides. However, it answered that it could not be controlled and I gave up. Instead, I turned my head.

“Hello, Aquala.”

Today, only Aquala came alone without Rattan. The black sparrow beeps, chirps, cries.

Come to think of it, I understood what this Pudding was saying, but why haven’t I been able to understand Rattan and Aquala?

I mean, it’s weird.

Chapter 135: Let's take a walk (1)

Chapter 72. Let's take a walk (1)

I squeezed and released Pudding's soft feet while I was absorbed in a fleeting thought.

Unable to resist the moment, Aquala chirps as it climbs on my finger.

“Okay. Okay. I haven't forgotten.”

Even though I couldn't understand the words, I barely understood the meaning of the gestures.

“Can't you talk to me?”

Chirp?

Aquala tilted its head. I grabbed Pudding and shoved it in front of Aquala.

– Hu, human! What are you doing! Nyan! Nyaaang!

“You, too, are like wild beasts, aren't you ashamed of them?”

– Hey, this body is young! I mean, I'm young!

“Young one, you were born similar to when Ricdorian was born.”

-No! It's different from being born. Our age begins to grow from the moment it materializes into reality!

“What?”

Without knowing that, I stopped shaking Pudding and headed towards Aquala.

Chaser said they must be over 10 years old... .

.... So it's been more than 10 years since the Chaser materialized them?

Chaser must be only four years older than Iana. If it had been 10 years ago, he would have been less than 14 years old.

What a villain really.

I shrugged and straightened my shoulders for nothing, and put Pudding down.

Pudding quickly hid behind me, I saw Aquila sitting on my finger.

“Aquala, then you can't talk?”

Chirp?

“No, that cat was talking loudly. I thought you could.”

Rattan and Aquala liked me.

<They like you, my sister.>

I thought about it all the time, but when I heard Chaser's words, I felt sorry again.

How many times have you protected me?

But Aquala only tilted its head. Ummm, even if you can't speak, will you understand what I'm saying?

“Do you understand what I'm saying? There's pudding, that one's name is pudding.”

Uwoooo!

“There, that one making a fuss. Anyway, that one keeps talking in my head. I thought you could do it too.”

I gently rubbed the bird’s head with my other hand. It was softer than expected.

Chirp, Chirp chirp!

Aquala flapped its tiny wings wildly. Ummm, I thought it wanted to convey something, but I couldn’t understand it.

Sorry, I think I’m still a beginner in the new language.

It was the moment when I was trying to talk like that.

Hwaaaaa!

A black light burst out. It was the black light that I saw when Aquala transformed into a small one. There was also black smoke.

-Human!

It wasn’t hard, but I closed my eyes to the smoke that obscured my view.

And when I opened my eyes, I was standing in a completely unfamiliar space.

However, I only blinked a few times and did not panic. It was something I had experienced once with Pudding.

Shaaaaa!

It was a rainy landscape in front of me. The sky was overcast with gray clouds, and it was a grassy forest that felt a little gloomy under the thick dark clouds.

Before observing my surroundings, I captured this realistic landscape one by one in my eyes.

‘It must be Aquala that showed me this.’

It looks like all the guardian deities can do it. As I looked around, I saw a familiar figure.

It was Chaser.

However, he did not seem to be in any leisure at all. Rather impatient... He had an angry face.

The eyebrows, which had always been neat, were horribly distorted. His forehead was wrinkled and his lips were bitten. He was a person who didn't even smile when he got angry.

I couldn't take my eyes off of it.

Shaaaa!

The rain was still pouring heavily. Under the pouring rain, he hugged someone.

The distorted face harmonizes with this landscape in the most gloomy way.

In the rain, he barely opened his lips.

“...Iana...”

I raised my eyebrows. Iana? Chaser lifted his upper body and a figure was seen in his arms.

“My little sister.”

It was definitely me in his arms. To be precise, ‘Iana’. The dripping rain strangely looked like his tears.

“...I will do it.”

The distance was far away and it was raining, so I couldn't hear everything. I just glanced at the figure like I was watching a black-and-white movie.

“...because... ..don’t get sick.”

At the end of his very sweet voice, he laughed in the rain. It was a sad laugh.

The moment I was about to open my mouth, the surroundings went dark.

When I opened my eyes again, it was a familiar room. I may not have moved in an instant, and it must be a principle similar to that was shown by Pudding.

I glanced at the fluttering bird.

“Did you show me that?”

Chirp-Chirp!

Now, it seemed that it understood my question by answering quite a bit. What, so until now you understood but pretended not to know?

“What, then, did you understand that I asked you to tell me the way to escape?”

I flipped the bird’s beak with my index finger.

About 9 months ago, when I was in the midst of running away from Chaser, I spoke to Aquala as well. *If you know the way, please let me know.*

I said it out of frustration, but did you understand back then?

Of course, after realizing that I was in a difficult situation with all kinds of grudges lurking, I stopped.

“You showed me this, then?”

I spoke to the bird.

“Chaser is not the only bad guy, is he?”

Aquala chirps and cries loudly. It cries very loudly in the form of a small sparrow.

I thought it understood me, but the problem is that I can't understand it.

“Yes. Okay. Are you saying I'm right?”

I understand what Aquala wanted to show me. Chaser takes his sister seriously. It want to show me that its owner is such a person.

Even if you don't show me like this, I've seen and felt it for about 10 months.

“By the way, what am I from what I saw before? Am I sick?”

Anyway, my condition is known as amnesia. So I asked at ease.

Aquala blinks its eyes, and then started crying. Oh, that's a surprise. Why are you suddenly crying?

I immediately felt stunned as I watched the bird chirping on the palm of my hand.

Chirp Chirp! Chirp Chirp Chirp Chirp!

I take back what I said a while ago.

.... Is this a yes or a no?

I thought Iana was weak. It was strange that a sick person was being squeezed in the rain, but I thought there must have been a reason.

Chirp! Chirp! Chirp! Tweet!

“Okay. Okay. It's about getting along.”

Tweet! Tweet! Chirp!

“You don't have to say that, we'll get along well.”

I shook my head and replied indifferently. Until the early days of meeting Chaser, my feelings for Chaser were foreign.

All I said was contradictory.

Have you ever heard of being ambivalent? He's sweet, but I can't believe that kindness. He revealed his madness, and there was still that image from the book! Yet there was still a friendly look.

"I know, he tried so hard to protect me."

That man really worked hard to protect me.

I can't even explain how many threats there were. It was that much, and it was dangerous, and I learned that all these grudges were not Chaser's own.

I also realized how bad the Duke of Domulit was.

There were also crimes committed by Chaser, but more because of the duke's blatant blaming of his son.

'Why is this novel, all the men are garbage.'

Slowly lowering my head, I saw the chain hanging from my ankle. This chain has also always been ambivalent to me.

"I don't know why you're concerned."

This chain may have been a symbol of redemption, but it was a milestone that saved my life.

"I don't hate someone who even got hurt while trying to save me. I'm not that harsh."

The person who saved my life from time to time was just the villain.

Now even that ambivalence has faded.

I raised my head and looked up at the sky. The sky was very blue unlike the scenery that had rained a while ago.

“Shall we go for a walk?”

I held out my hand. Tweet? Aquala seemed to tilt its head.

Looking at it this way, it seems that I understand roughly what you are saying. Is it possible to master the language of birds like this?

I waved my palms in an odd thought.

“Shall we go together?”

Chirp!

Aquala flew as if waiting. As if it couldn't hide its excitement, it returned to the form of an eagle.

“Hey, hey! Think of your size, ooh!”

Suddenly, my face was buried in its feathers, and I breathed out. Aquala smelled of Chaser.

I barely removed the feathers and sighed. Why are these animals pushing their heads first at me?

With it or not, Aquila, who had shrunk to the right size, frantically rubbed its beak against my cheek in the form of an eagle.

Dududuk!

“Alright alright. Stop it.”

Is this the way to get a job as an animal trainer? I shook my head and turned around.

“You too, come out.”

– Me, me, me... you mean? Nyang?

“Then who will it be?”

I lifted my hand, but the frightened Pudding did not come closer. How is it that the frightened appearance is so similar to the beast-shaped Ricdorian?

“Aquala.”

I turned to Aquala.

“I’ll get along well with Chaser, so you get along well with that.”

I raised my head towards Pudding. It is said that people form affection from the moment they give them a name. Be it animals or things. I did too.

“It’s the kid that I named.”

Even though I knew I was going to let it go, I couldn’t help but give affection to that little poor baby guardian.

“Yes, can you do that for me?”

Saying it kindly, I scratched the underside of Aquala’s beak. Then I whispered a little.

Although it is a terrifying animal that could burn things outside. It was a good bird to me

Aquala’s eyes widened as it stared at Pudding.

Flap, flap. I knew this flapping of its wings was a gesture of reconciliation. As if the animal recognized the animal, and as Pudding felt it, it came closer. Then it sat down on my hand and rubbed its cheek with the palm of my hand.

– Talking to that scary bastard, human, You’re amazing!

“It must be a scary bird only to you.”

It's a good bird for me. I smiled slightly and opened the door.

Chapter 136: Let's take a walk (2)

Chapter 73. Let's take a walk (2)

Squeak.

Hey, why is the door open? As if it was half open... When the door opened and I saw a man standing in the middle of the gap, I widened my eyes.

Chaser?

“....brother?”

Why are you here? I looked at him with this expression. Chaser smiled faintly.

“Because I want to see you?”

“I didn’t ask that question.”

“You said it.”

He tapped his eye with his index finger.

“With the eyes?”

“Ah.”

I just nodded my head. Being here means he heard the conversation with Aquala?

“From where have you been listening?”

I asked without hesitation.

“From “It’s the kid that I named”? I wonder what you were doing, Iana.”

Looks like he just arrived. I nodded and replied indifferently.

“I made a peace agreement with Aquala. Don’t fight with Pudding. We decided to take a walk of reconciliation together as a celebration.”

Having said that, he shook his head.

“Would you like to go for a walk?”

Chaser paused.

It was as if his red eyes had grown in surprise. But in an instant, as if he had always been, the man who returned to his original state moved his head neatly.

“As you wish.”

We quickly reached the garden. Unlike the old-fashioned grass near the stables, the front of the mansion was well decorated.

Fresh garden and brightly blooming flowers under the splendid sunlight, the refreshing scent of the wind blending in thickly, and the sparkling glass greenhouse that appeared in the distance.

Actually, it wasn’t like this when I just came to this mansion. Rather, it was a place that was devastated by raids day by day, and no one restored it.

<... You want to take a walk? Alright.>

It was this man who made it like this.

“It’s become very pretty.”

“Because it’s your path.”

Well, it's what I say and what I do. Whatever it was, he was a man who couldn't stand it unless he made it the best.

Sometimes bringing things while wielding a sword with mad eyes. I felt it when he held out the blood-stained jewel.

“You will continue to walk this path. My little sister.”

I thought the block head had turned crazy. After making such a definition, I felt more comfortable.

“Iana.”

He lowered his head and put my fingertips on his lips. Now it was a familiar greeting.

Kiiik!

In the sky, Aquala was flying freely in the blue sky. Perhaps it was because of the reconciliation with Aquala, Pudding was also running and chasing butterflies in the garden.

– Hey, human! What is this Nyan! It's moving! Nyanyang!

... That bastard is a complete cat. Chasing butterflies is a perfect domestic cat behaviour. I laughed bitterly. The appearance soon turned into a wide smile.

It was because of how ridiculously cute and funny Pudding was jumping like a fool, or Aquala who was spinning around Pudding looking like it wanted to show it to me.

Flutter, flutter.

As the sun was warm in summer, yellow petals like sunflowers flew. Occasionally, orange petals were mixed in.

Perhaps it is from the field of orange roses in full bloom over there.

I smiled for a while and then turned my head to see a gaze looking at me. Chaser's eyes are at the end of it.

He wasn't smiling.

... What's wrong with you?

"Brother?"

As the man with strange eyes did not smile, he created a breathtaking atmosphere. I called him, but there was no answer.

After a few seconds, his lips slowly opened.

"Iana."

The tenacious gaze that seemed to pierce me and made my lips dry up for no reason. He came closer. I stood motionless like a frog in front of the snake, momentarily overwhelmed by the atmosphere.

He slowly tilts his upper body. His hand stretched out to me and pulled something off. It was orange petals.

Ah, I wanted to scream, but no more words came out. The distance was very close. Instead of falling back, he opened his mouth.

"Iana,just once."

Let me ask you.

It was a low, low voice. Not knowing what to do, I lowered my gaze, and his feet came up at the chain and pulled it off.

"Do you hate me?"

The voice that seemed to seduce people was as serious as ever.

"...No, you don't like me."

There was no playful temptation as usual. Still, it felt like a child who was playing a foolish lure.

Are you worried about the chains now? I could only guess by the act of stepping on the chain. Why are you asking all of a sudden? You're a weird person.

"...It's not like I don't like you."

As I rolled my eyes, I quickly spit out.

"I don't hate you."

My voice was calm.

"You don't really not like me, you don't hate me. Finish?"

He shook the ankle I was looking at.

"Of course, I think it's crazy to be shackled and chained like this."

Well, just because he's nice doesn't mean that I'm happy, this brainwashing.

I don't really not like him or hate him. I acknowledged the chains because of their utility, but there was no justification for this man's nonsense.

<If not shackles, what do you like?>

Just, I was frustrated about the chains and when I said the word, he looked like he just knew.

Even if he loosened the chain, it would just take a different shape. I knew he was the kind of person who would bind me in a different way.

A year or so was enough to know that.

"But you're crazy, aren't you?"

There's no difference. It's a piece of cake.

I tilted my head and said it bluntly. Even with my direct expression like this, Chaser only smiled.

As far as I know, he wasn't unaware of what he was doing. At least he was a madman who knew he was a madman.

“Yes.”

Chaser covered half of his face with one hand.

“Yes. Iana.”

At that moment, I opened my eyes wide. It was because something was dripping down from the bent eyes of the man who smiled softly.

Under the wild curves like a fox that seduces people, the tears that flowed down seemed thick and beautiful.

Why are you crying? I couldn't take my eyes off of it as I muttered to myself.

Because it was so beautiful.

The figure of Chaser holding 'Iana' was drawn in my head. With that smiling face in the rainy landscape.

... Is it related to that?

Chaser opened his arms and put me in his arms. I didn't feel anything. It's just that he's so big. On the other hand, I just felt that I was small.

His hands dug into my waist, but I remained calm without pushing him away.

I was willing to lend a shoulder to someone who would cry. That was it, though.

“I want you to be with me forever.”

Although more than a year has passed, the relationship between ‘Iana’ and Chaser was incomprehensible to me. Unknown, value unknown.

I just rolled my eyes and squinted. The man with his forehead on my shoulder.

The people in the mansion didn’t talk to me. It’s not that I don’t have friends for nothing. There was the little warlock, so I wasn’t bored, but....

I was so busy that I couldn’t even say it. It’s assassination, it’s poison, it’s threat....

“Don’t leave me.”

I thought this guy was the bad big brother who sent Iana to prison. It was like that at first, and then there was a situation, but I still thought he was a bad guy.

But looking at him like this.

Red eyes filled with tears were looking at me.

“...will you stay by my side?”

After all, like in the book, he seems like a half-crazed person. I unfolded his hands that clasped behind my back. I couldn’t help but be nervous. I saw him wielding a sword... I can’t help but worry about a man as big as this beast.

His quirky and sensual face and contrasting body exuded an elegant and sensual feeling.

“Brother.”

He released only one hand, grabbed my hand, and released it. Then he grabbed it again and brought it to his lips.

Kiss. From fingernails to skin. Again, the lips are pouring between the words.

I was confused.

Why? Even after a year or so, is he the same as before? Now that the poisoning and threats have subsided a little, and it's peaceful? Because it was peaceful, was it possible to have other thoughts?

A slow shiver crept down my back.

A lightning bolt of enlightenment hit me through the bloodstream.

"Brother."

"It's good to be your brother."

Instead of kissing his lips against my fingertips, he lifted his head.

It was a lazy gaze.

"It's okay if I'm not your brother."

My head tilted as it was. *Spread*, fine black hair is scattered. I ran out of breath.

"...that's kind of weird."

I managed to open my lips and continue. My saliva was dry.

"I lost my memory."

"Huh."

It wasn't because it was peaceful. So it must have been something I hadn't thought of. He lightly bit my fingertips and let them go.

"Tell me."

He rubs his lips against my fingers. The strangeness increased even more at the kiss that fell like rain on my fingertips again. I thought it was weird

This sibling relationship is too good. I just thought so.

However,

Even if I wake up here and don't know common sense and everything.

"I don't think this is something an older brother would do to his younger sister."

.... Isn't this really weird?

Just a friendly kiss on the back of a hand between a man and a woman was nothing more than a universal gesture.

But even considering the world, it's strange.

So I spit it out frankly.

"No, I don't think this is right."

Chaser didn't panic. He just put his cheek to my finger and smiled.

He just raised his eyes.

"Why not?"

Reddish-red eyes that seemed to shine even in the dark were holding onto me.

"Why not?"

That's.. .

"We are siblings..."

"We are not siblings."

Shaaaaa. The wind blew. Only the thick scent of flowers filled our silence. Finally he laughed out loud.

Chapter 137: One of the secrets of birth

Chapter 74. One of the secrets of birth

“Adoption.”

You know?, he muttered a little.

“I am the Lord.”

He grabbed my index finger and poked him in the cheek. Then he pointed at me with his index finger.

“You are an adopted child.”

I stopped and opened my mouth wide.... What kind of nonsense is this suddenly? Birth secret?

“Don’t lie.”

There was no time for confusion. Because he narrowed the distance and bowed his head.

“You must have lost your memory, so I didn’t have time to tell you.”

“...that.”

What are you talking about? The words I was about to spit out just fell back inside.

“I’m not lying to you. Iana.”

It would be right to look down when I'm in front of the jewel-like eyes and the overwhelming atmosphere.

"And whether I told you or not, it doesn't matter, does it?"

He put his hand to my cheek and said.

"It doesn't matter because you'll be by my side. My little sister."

The friendly voice contained an erotic atmosphere that could not be hidden. At the same time, he seemed to be judging that I couldn't escape him.

"You're my brother."

"Yes. But I'm also not your brother."

He rolled his eyes and drew a dazzling smile. His low voice seemed to contain his ability. Even though this ability is useless to me, it seems like I will be possessed right away. He asked,

"Then can I look at you differently?"

I licked my lips. I was breathing, but my mouth felt dry.

It seemed like a question that didn't need an answer. Nevertheless, I responded.

"...No."

Even though I spoke firmly, he just smiled. Between the scattered orange petals, and the black petals that were mixed up.

As if he doesn't need my answer.

"Shall we wait then?"

For the first time, a warning light sounded deep in my heart. The warning light that I couldn't reach even when I knew I was the villain's sister was now ringing all over my body.

“I can wait any time. By your side.”

When I closed and opened my eyes, a stranger was standing in front of me.

The dazzling sunlight gladly became a light to illuminate him. Even the fluttering petals were like decorations for this shrewd man.

Have you ever eaten something that tastes like *jajangmyeon* when you thought it was *ramyeon*? I don't have one, but I think it felt similar.

At that very moment when Chaser said those words.

I swept my face harshly.

Iana and Chaser aren't siblings, what kind of improbability is this? No, well, my character dies early, so I'll yield. But even if you put it away.

No, really what is this?

“...what kind of bullshit is this?”

-Bull? Did you find a bull, Nyan?

Pudding, who was sitting quietly, tilted its head. Its ears were moving up and down. It wasn't enough, so it passed between my legs and rubbed its head.

“Hey, you're distracting.”

Waong?

“Don't do it. I'm serious.”

— What's wrong, Nyan?

Pudding cries and cries ‘what's going on with you’, but I just pushed the head of the animal that I didn't know whether it was a snow leopard or a

cat.

Three days after Chaser dropped the bomb fact out of nowhere, he treated me casually.

The problem is that I'm having a hard time dealing with him like I used to. No, of course he's annoying.

“...I thought you'd become a little more friendly now.”

This was an honest opinion. Here, 'friendliness' is not a feeling of friendship.

It means that I have adapted to the crazy nature of the guy who is kind, but who takes up a knife and cuts everything when something's wrong, and doesn't hesitate to give presents dripping with blood.

I never thought he would become a real brother. I just said that I would have been smart enough to become a human being who could adapt.

That is.

But why!

I swept my face again and again.

In fact, Chaser's bomb itself wasn't that shocking. It seems that I unconsciously thought it was strange

But, what if my brother is not my brother? At that moment I asked.

'I thought of Ricdorian.'

I quickly rubbed my face. Let's forget it, forget it. This time with both hands. My face stings from the sweeping but I didn't care.

Now it's too late to run away.

<If you want, I'll stay with you as a brother, Iana.>

He said so, but in other words, it was only heard as a voice saying, “Good luck, only if you don’t offend.

After contemplating, I floundered on the chair. There was no solution, but it was overloaded. I do not know.

I just want to live comfortably. Why was it so hard?

Should I just stop thinking. Yes, I’ll wait.....you’re saying that you’ll stay as my older brother anyway?

He didn’t seem like a bother for me to approach. As long as I stay calm.

He even gave me the cuffs, so I guess I’ll just have to pretend I don’t know about this. It’s like spitting while lying down.

I suddenly felt as bad as I imagined.

.... For some reason, I feel like I’m falling into a pit.

Like laundry that had been thrown on the chair, my mind was all over the place. In fact, I was told not to worry too much about the headaches.

It is said that 80% of human worries are useless.

Well. Things will work out somehow.

I knew that I was avoiding it rather than finding a solution and ending my worries, but I knew it and ignored it. Thinking of putting it off for a while.

And that day, I realized that I shouldn’t have put off this worry.

“Good day, Iana.”

Suddenly, Chaser, who had sent ‘my little sister’ title somewhere, greeted me in a refreshing way.

I glanced at him, imagining grabbing his heart and throwing it away if it had a shape.

It wasn't unusual for Chaser to come to my room.

"Where did the word my sister go?"

"If you want. My sister."

Why is it that when he added it with a kind heart it was so hard to see? I sighed a little.

It's all because of this guy that I'm letting my worries go away. Whether I worry about it or not, whenever I see the calm smiling face, I want to live without thinking.

But the moment I saw him coming after me, my thoughts flew away.

"...Brother. What is that?"

Should I ask this or not? I felt anxious pulling the tip of my tongue, but I finally asked.

"It's a present. Iana."

Chaser raised his lips as if waiting.

I alternately glanced at what Chaser and his men had put down. So the meaning of *what this is* must have been conveyed directly. Chaser noticed this right away and added.

"There was a story that bothered me."

"I don't really want to hear it."

His eyes were whispering.

You need to hear it.

“Your words that you don’t have friends bother me.”

He gently looked into my arms. I felt Pudding in my arms tremble.

– Human, human! That guy was staring at me! I saw it!

... I know it too, so be quiet. I patted Pudding’s head.

I know very well that you shouldn’t touch that person when he has eyes like that. Every time this happens, I get into trouble.

But this time, I couldn’t help but go.

“...what kind of gift is a ‘person’?”

It was. It was neither an object nor an animal that was dragged behind Chaser.

It was a ‘person’.

How the hell can you come up with such an idea?

“No, my precious little sister doesn’t have any friends...because she’s dependent on a small baby animal.”

“Don’t talk too hard to the kid.”

“You misheard me.”

A friendly voice broke the silence.

“It’s just sad, I can’t help but do something.”

His red eyes glowed dangerously.

“As an older brother.”

I turned my head instead of responding to the words that didn’t require further discussion.

Chaser's men led in a human, a very small girl.

<A life without one single friend?>

<If you needed a 'friend', you should have told me.>

Then the conversation will come back like this. I couldn't take this man any more seriously.

I regretted it.

No wonder he left the room suspiciously. At that time, I did not know that the words that came out after defending Pudding would come back like this.

I stared at the girl.

'By the way, why is she like this?'

She had a skinny body. There, maybe only her face was washed, her body was covered in sticky dust, and her clothes were too big to be hers.

With the long, tangled hair, I could barely recognize it as a girl.

The cheeks were sunken between the sloppy cut hair. I was startled.

Because the girl's piercing eyes were staring at me like she was going to kill me.

It was a mysterious eye. She had silver eyes mixed with gray and white.

There was only one eye like that, but the other eye was melted in green as if it was a gradation of gray and green.

Pie eye, odd eye.

Even if it was only on one side, rare elements overlapped.

My fingertips were trembling. No words came out.

Because I had goosebumps all over my thighs.

Crazy. No, it's really crazy.

Only those words came out.

It was obvious.

"The heir of the white rose."

Because this was the famous original female lead.

"It seems that this level should be suitable for our Iana."

My head turned at Chaser's words. It was an awkward move, like a rusty robot.

"Level?"

"...do you think it would fit my lovely little sister?"

The face of the man who whispered so much was that of a mature adult, but at the same time he looked innocent.

Unsurprisingly, the eyes looking at me were as bright as madness. It's like looking at a clear, bloody lake.

"She was hard to find. She had been hiding for so long."

I mean, a girl with long, dirty hair, dirty hands and feet, oversized clothes with holes that look like she had just been pulled and torn, and a girl with the appearance of a young child full of hatred.....

It's the female lead.

I heard the sound of fantasy shattering inside me.

I wiped my face like a habit.

Chapter 138: Heroine's older sister (1)

Chapter 75. Heroine's older sister (1)

No. Let's be calm. Think calmly.

In this book, Chaser did not fall in love at first sight with the heroine. It wasn't exactly love at first sight.

In the book, Chaser shed some strange nuances about her. He was portrayed and acted as if he had known the heroine before.

Anyway, I didn't think much of the probability because it was a tragic romance in a Rated-19 novel.

One day, *suddenly, I am the saintess of the Great Shrine!* I thought it was like a very random setting of the female protagonist who shouts that.

'... But was this setting hidden?'

It's kind of weird. As expected, the villain seems to have met the heroine before.

To guess with my missing head, 'Iana' may originally have died of a heart attack before I woke up from this body.

If that was the case, this scene would have been the moment before the original story and the heroine meeting the villain alone.

The more I thought about it, the more twisted it felt. I understood the situation, but it was suffocating.

The heroine is staring at the older sister. She's really staring!

Strictly speaking, she's one year older than me, so I'm not an older sister. But everyone said the pretty one is the older sister. So I'm the beautiful older sister.

I barely returned to reality and murmured.

"...why did brother find the heir of the white rose?"

Obviously, the heroine I knew was a beautiful, kind young girl and an innocent and curious person.

It was only 3 years ago, and I couldn't help but wonder why she was like that, no matter how indifferent the country was.

"Did you really bring her for me?"

Chaser's eyes drew a semicircle. With a sweet smile, he taps my shoulder and pulls me off.

"Really. I'm not lying to you. I told you so, Iana."

I was not fooled.

"Okay, so let's say that the number one intention is that, what's next?"

He was a man who could hide the truth without telling me lies. Sure enough, he frowned and smiled as if he was in trouble.

"Hmm, it's no big deal. That girl's father committed a great crime."

"Right."

"I was looking for the disappeared daughter's whereabouts. Plus, she's perfect as my sister's friend."

With this, her place in the residence was decided. Because he just said she's locked up here.

I smirked.

“My brother really likes confinement.”

“Don’t get me wrong. You’re the only one who wants to be here.”

“You speak very well.”

“Don’t you think it’s prettier if I speak well?”

Chaser said so and left a wink. He then leans his body deeply on the sofa with his arms crossed.

“Everyone has a decent handmaiden at your age, my Iana.”

A handmaiden, a young girl of high rank, or the one who sits next to the royal family and the imperial family as a member of the fellowship. After brooding over common sense, he laughed. It was a laugh.

What is this crazy bastard saying now?

What kind of human works comfortably as a handmaiden in the place where she was kidnapped?

I raised my lips carelessly.

‘Is that even a gift?’

It wasn’t the bloody girl from a while ago, but the heroine’s older sister that just opened her mouth.

“Die, you bastard.”

It was the first time she spoke, but it was a cool and heavy blow.

I turned my head away. Chaser smiled brightly.

“It’s a gift, my sister.”

...I wonder where he figures it's a gift?

"Let, let her go!"

"Well, do you need education?"

Even as the heroine's older sister ran wild, Chaser crossed his arms and stared calmly. His smileless eyes seemed to measure something.

And I decided.

"No, just give it to me."

Okay.

"I'll keep it."

I'll have to get the heroine out of here. And.

Obviously, when Chaser does those eyes, people don't die....

<Because my mine needs so many slaves.>

They disappeared.

"Come out."

What do you mean by this, it was the first words as a heroine's older sister after Chaser left.

It's an honor to talk to her, but she breaks my heart a bit.

She followed this sister's words, and instead of quietly walking out, she squatted down.

It goes without saying that the face of the heroine's older sister became even more ferocious.

– Fierce, fierce, nyang.

Waong!

When the unseen Pudding said something, she heard the cry and stared at it.

-Look, did you see it? Human, she's staring at me!

“Get away.”

This one, I don't know which one is the beast.

“You, really man. You are disqualified as a beast.”

You have no more courage than I do. Huh? I tapped the nose of the baby snow leopard hanging from me and lifted my head.

<Just give it to me. You said she's a friend?>

It's good that Chaser gave up and accepted it completely. Her body was tied tight.

It was something Chaser's subordinates had done because they couldn't have her run around and bite. I want to let go of that, but I'm the only one who gets bitten by the momentum.

A basin full of water was swaying gently in front of me.

“Um, I wonder if you should wash your hands.”

“.....”

“...well, yes. You don't want to.”

I just rolled my eyes. She has a lot of scratches on her hands, and I try to wash off the dirt and apply some medicine.

Now I'll just call you by name.

She just stared at the ceiling in disbelief. I'm sorry, I must have been looking and muttering nonsense.

Of course, that's not the case. Seeing how young she looked, I was pricked in conscience to say that I was her older sister.

In the book, she's one year older than Ricdorian, so she's one year older than me. She was too small to be 18 years of age here.

Even though she was 14, I'd believed it. I'd like to ask if it's true that she's really 18, but it seems like the question is only going to increase her wariness.

Hey, even when I say something, her whole body is shouting 'Get off!'.

I sighed.

"...Francia."

She flinched. The eyes, which had been puzzled for a moment, became even more fierce.

Instead of giving attention, I lifted Pudding, which was squatting next to me.

"Hey, Pudding."

-Human! Don't lift me up with my front paw!

"Yes, I'm sorry. Just one question. Do you have any abilities like Aquala?"

Aquala could shoot or create fire. Another guardian deity, Rattan, would hide in Chaser's to protect him or willingly turn into a weapon.

It was, in many ways, a guardian deity that complemented his abilities as a psychic.

If so, maybe Pudding has something it can do?

-Ugh, of course there is. Isn't it possible that the Great One does not exist in the body?

“Language.”

– There is, Nyang.

“What?”

– You'll have very strong powers!

“...And?”

Getting stronger?

“Huu...”

I whistled.

“It's very useless.”

-What? No! No Nyang!

I said that as if I was kidding the baby snow leopard, but my lips were in a big arc.

“Give it to me.”

Aquala sometimes spewed fire even when she wasn't with Chaser.

The fire was weaker than when it was with Chaser, but I wondered if Pudding would be possible in the same sense, but as if it was possible, Pudding hesitated and put its front paw on me.

– Pick me up, Nyang.

As soon as it said that, Pudding placed its tiny jelly-like feet on my forehead.

Immediately, I felt a cool and refreshing feeling in my body. Feeling like I can do anything?

As a test, I bent a pen nib nearby.

‘Oh, I see.’

And Francia was looking at me as if there was such an absurd sight.

Then she seemed to pay attention to the completely bent pen nib for a moment, but then she quickly turned her head away as if she was bewildered.

I smiled.

“Francia.”

She winced again this time, and rolled her eyes fiercely and stared at me. The wariness seems to have gotten stronger. But I didn’t care.

“If I leave your hands alone, I’m afraid it’ll get festered.

“What....”

“...What doesn’t matter. Let’s call it my fault.”

Why do all the main characters here try to resemble beasts instead of human beings?

Ricdorian’s mind and body. It’s a posture that looks like a four-legged beast is about to jump out.

“I just can’t see an injured person.”

I can’t take responsibility, but I need treatment to release my feelings.

I approached her and sat down.

“So, excuse me?”

“What? Ack!”

Her words were cut.

When the tepid water touched her, she was startled. But it was already after I grabbed her wrist and immersed her in it.

Mrs. Sullivan did that. She said that in the first place to teach Helen Keller it was bumping and fighting, pinching and fighting anyway.

I’m sorry for using a noble name here.

It was similar to what I did. It was to hold on to her struggling and wash away her dirt and grime.

“Let go, let go! You demon!”

Of course, she didn’t stand still. However, Pudding’s ability did not escape and made a good effect.

“Come on, if you don’t wash, the dust will ask you to be friends with them. Yuck, yuck.”

I suddenly thought of Ricdoran in beast mode and calmed her down, then she raised her head involuntarily.

Francia stopped her hand as she was trembling. The only clean face was hot with anger.

“Li, li, little devil!”

Perhaps because her body is small, her language system has not yet developed. The cursing wasn’t as varied.

Ugh, how long haven’t you washed that the water get dirty so quickly? The basin strangely spewed out clean water when it felt dirty.

It was the work of the little warlock. Is it a magic item?

I washed her away. Holding her bare skinny wrist and washing, I felt....

That her injuries were more serious than I thought.

Some stab wounds. It was also a mess all over the body. All of them were serious enough, to believe that she came out of a room with blades.

There was also a lot of dust and hardened blood in it. I grabbed her sleeve and pulled it up to her forearm.

“...Oh my gosh.”

Chapter 139: Heroine's older sister (2)

Chapter 76. Heroine's older sister (2)

It was worse inside. My mouth opened as I watched the wounds dripping with blood.

“Let me go!”

She was staring at me with hateful eyes. Previously, if it was just a simple wariness, it was no different from looking at Chaser.

Fear and hate.

“...to cut off my arm? Like your brother?”

However, in the end, maybe it was because I couldn't let go of her hand. Francia bit my hand with all her might and pinched it.

“Come on, wait a minute. I'm not like that.”

At that moment, Francia kicked her leg up. *Whoa!* The basin, which is not too heavy, rises into the air in an instant and overturns.

Drop, drop.

Water dripped from my chin. I slowly wiped my chin with the back of my hand, soaking wet.

Tied up, Francia couldn't get away. Her eyes were full of fear now as she stared. It was probably not her intention to turn the water upside down like

this.

“It’s okay.”

Although the water is a bit dirty. That’s enough. I can wipe it off.

“I’m sorry to startle you.”

-Human! Are you okay!

Shaking my hair, Pudding ran in surprise and I patted Pudding on the head. Like it’s okay.

Complex emotions flashed across her trembling eyes. Fear, alertness, impatience, embarrassment....

“You don’t have to be sorry. It’s my fault.”

Sorry.

Apparently, Francia’s personality was not very different.

“...I, I.”

“Yes. I’m sorry for forcing you, I was surprised too. It doesn’t mean it’s okay though.”

The basin was flipped back up. The water filled up as if it had been.

“It’s said that water can disinfect as well. I want to heal the wounds.”

I washed my hands in clean water.

“You saw this. Water, it’s not dangerous isn’t it? Because I’m covered all over with it.”

“.....”

I patted her cheek and smiled. Then I slowly wiped away the smile.

“You want to get out of here?”

I said frankly.

“I’ll let you run away.”

I continued quickly.

“But not now.”

For a moment, the silver and green eyes that had passed with anticipation quickly cooled.

“Wait for the right moment.”

She didn’t swear anymore. There was no swearing, no shouting, no attacks.

“Because I’m going to get you out.”

I saw the question blossoming in her eyes filled with fear.

“Why?”

The girl, who looked so much younger than her age, blinked the different colored eyes. She was said to be a saintess, and only her eyes were mysterious enough to be sacred.

“...the Domulit’s younger sister who captured me.”

Oh, you knew who Chaser was. Isn’t it strange if you don’t know? There are crest seals all over the place.

“That’s right, isn’t it?”

It was strange that the people of the Empire did not know about the Black Rose. Because she was also a citizen. Rather, I was the one who wanted to ask. She was supposed to be a beautiful and kind young girl.

“How can I trust you?”

On the other hand, the girl in front of me seemed to wield evil with her whole body. Her bare arms with bloody scars, and even her pale complexion.

Go away, don't touch my body, it seemed to shout that.

“Trust me.”

After all, trust that is in mere words is worse than a piece of paper. I know it well.

I took her hand. Before Francia could say anything, instead of saying a few words, I lifted my skirt.

“Can you believe me when you see this?”

Clink.

The moment she saw the chain moving from my ankle, the girl's eyes widened. It seemed as if the dismay had passed.

The chain that saved my life several times happened to have a great effect this time as well.

Francia's eyelids trembled. There seemed to be a glimpse of intense trouble in her eyes as it went down.

Finally she put an end to her troubles. How did I know this? Because she was relaxed. I noticed her answer as the hand that I had grasped lost its strength.

“How can you help me?”

I laughed without answering.

“And I don't know you. Why help?”

“There is someone who comes to mind when I see you.”

The person who wanted to eat well in the cold basement by now, the girl's eyes were soaked in that person's color.

The face that came to mind, how are you doing? I erased the desire to ask for his well-being. The face that was still waiting for me might have discouraged my hope.

"I couldn't get him out of the prison, but I think you'll be fine."

Better than a coal mine.

Friend?

The word friend, and Chaser couldn't have someone he could attach to me.

Because. When he opened those eyes over the past year or so, there has never been a time when a person did not disappear.

Never once.

"Do you know how a wild beast hunts?"

Eyes of different colors stared at me calmly now.

"I know."

It reminded me of the feeling of taming Ricdorian, who was in beast mode.

"How?"

"Wait. Wait until the food arrives."

"Yes. Wait."

I smiled low, holding back the hand that wanted to stroke her.

"Be quiet."

I looked into her eyes.

“Until the time comes.”

– A month later.

Time passed without a hitch. But the passing of time was not meaningless.

It was still the last season of the year, summer. December is summer, it is the season of greenery, so the surrounding area was filled with the fresh smell of grass.

In Domulit’s garden, untimely roses bloomed all year round. One flower has two colors. Orange and black roses.

The Black Rose is the family pattern. Why are orange roses grown?

“Here!”

Instead of looking at the flowers in the flower garden, I lifted my head.

There was a figure running from afar.

It was Francia.

“I found it, I did!”

A month passed like it was, but the meaning of this time was right here.

Francia smiled broadly. Within a month, she had a face that was noticeably fattened. Even her bare arms have now improved to the point of being able to express them as belonging to an ordinary child.

It was an amazing speed.

More than anything else, what has changed is where the anxiousness goes and broad smiles..

“Sister!”

And her calling.

I put my left hand on my chest. Huh, my heart murmured. My heart won't stay.

Her hair, which reflected the twinkling rays of the sun, was slowly glistening. It's still slightly odd, but her cheeks have a pale peach color. It was the reward for my hard work.

Is this what it feels like to raise a child? There was a rush of pride.

-Human, I helped too!

Nyaong!

-Ahem, as this great body has found it! Nyan!

What is this cat!

“This cat is too noisy.”

“I don't think it's a cat.”

Leave it alone. Still I didn't even know if it was a beast or a cat. Watching Pudding chasing butterflies without knowing for a long time, I was immersed in trouble for a while.

‘Can, can I send her to Ricdorian as it is... .’

... I feel like I'm raising it so brightly. The kid is a little bit innocent.

Is it okay to do this? I walked and pondered. Small steps followed naturally.

I stared intently at Francia.

The moment the wariness is broken, the girl opens her heart in an instant. Even me who stabbed the wall was surprised.

“How are you feeling?”

With those words, Francia quickly looked around.

“It’s okay. There’s no one.”

Aquala and Rattan that sometimes hovered around weren’t even here.

“It’s improved a lot. It’s even recovering now.”

Francia opened her hand secretly. There was an unhealed wound on the back of her hand.

But soon, a slight white light flew over the back of her hand, and surprisingly, the wound healed in an instant.

This was her ability as the successor of the White Rose. Recovery. She was capable of all treatments, including self-healing.

“... I think that’s what comes to mind when you use your powers among the roses.”

In Francia’s left eye, a soft but white rose pattern appeared. It was a rose drawn by lines, in the form of a rose in full bloom.

Come to think of it, I haven’t seen Ricdorian or Chaser when they use their powers. However, Ricdorian had no ability, but had a rose pattern.

A tattoo that falls if he can’t find his companion.

“No. Sister, all roses have roses somewhere in their body.”

Francia’s older sister! I was proud and strange of the time she called.

She was the one I used to call the heroine. Because now it’s the other way around. Well, in the world, there are things like this and that, and good things are good.

“...my brother too?”

I wanted to ask.

The hatred she had for Chaser was not at all great. I thought she hated me so much for no reason, even in the book.

I didn't know either the heroine or the villain because they didn't show that they had met each other.

In particular, Francia didn't show anything at all. Did she lose her memory?

Or, if the events here were terrible and she pretended to forget, it was understandable and unfortunate.

It made sense to think that what Chaser had done to me was done to the heroine. Maybe she

wanted to forget.

"Oh, no. I don't think I've seen it. Pretend I didn't hear it."

"No...."

Although her expression darkened, she didn't stop.

"...I know where the tattoo is on the man's body. It's his left chest. Sister."

Huft, Francia took a breath.

"I saw it when he was fighting with my father. His clothes were torn."

I paused. Francia's father, she would later overturn her father's sins and go to the cell.

But the eyes of Francia who put her father in her mouth were overflowing with trust.

"I see."

I hesitated, then changed my words.

"How about this other side's ability?"

“Oh, that’s it!”

Francia looked around and she smiled brightly. After she confirmed that there was still no one around, she sprinted and stood in front of me.

She said look, and she stretched out her slender arms.

Then I saw the white light on her hands and arms, and she moved and quickly formed a form.

What appeared was a huge hammer.

“Come out now!”

“Uh...”

....This is always surprising.

Chapter 140: Promised Day 1 Year Ago (1)

1. 1. Promised Day 1 Year Ago (1)

As I had already seen through Chaser, the roses seemed to be able to turn the guardian deity into their own weapon.

Chaser would sometimes transform Rattan into his own weapon when he went out on his own. It's so bloody that I don't want to remember much, but...

This one was also great.

No, what kind of hammer that violates the laws of matter?

A little lightning at the end, Pi**chu... no, um. It reminded me of Mjolnir in Norse mythology.

Hahaha, since Chaser deals with fire, I think that even if the female protagonist deals with lightning, anything can happen.

... The behind-the-scenes stories don't feel like a R-19 tragic novel anymore.

What kind of bastard's non-existent setting kept coming like the bottom of the iceberg? This is too much. For a book, it was almost transcendental.

As it turns out, I was so worried that I sometimes wondered if I had read a fantasy novel. Of course, it still doesn't seem like the hot three-person scenes are vivid.

Francia squeezed a garden tree to show off some great excitement. Wow, that's great, but only after she broke it did she contemplate.

"It's okay. I'll say I want to see it."

If I say one word like this, Chaser will let it go at least once. Because he knew the power of the white rose.

The employees know that Francia has recovered from the magic of the small warlock. Not just Chaser.

It was also proof that the boundaries were rising.

While contemplating, Francia put her foot out into sight and she exclaimed 'ta-da!'.

"This kid is doing well too!"

Waong! Waong!

-Human, tell her not to touch things like that, Nyan!

Pudding reacted before me. It began to fuss while exposing its cute fangs.

Before my eyes, there was a creature with round ears with closed eyes. White fur, thick feet.

The animal next to the white rose I saw that day... It was a baby bear.

"Kya-woong?"

Like Francia, the baby bear inherited the pie eye, and had an iris gently mixed with a subtle green color.

Although it was cute like a doll, it was too large with Francia's small body.

"Isn't it cute?"

"...I thought it'd be bigger when you're fully awakened?"

“Yes. It will become a grown-up bear.”

An adult bear. I could not easily imagine. I just laughed at the cute little girl holding the bear.

“Sister, then, I will become an adult just like you. I will grow up.”

At the age of 18, despite the age of majority, the secret of her unusually small body was revealed here. It is characteristic of white roses.

And it wasn't long before that time.

She looked very different from Ricdorian, so I asked. The awakening conditions are slightly different for each rose. The conditions that shape the guardian deity are also the same.

Pudding had a similar story.

“...But why were you held here?”

Something I hadn't asked before popped up. It was a word that came out of my mind while I was thinking.

Francia looked at me for a moment with a startled day, but she was not silent.

“I'm going to do Dad a favor.”

She used father and dad interchangeably when she suddenly felt some feelings.

“Dad, so we were always looking for someone.”

Francia wiggled her hand. It looked like she was hesitating.

“Then he got chased, and my father said he might get involved in a crime... he disappeared. It was after he sent me out of a fight with Chaser Domulit.”

Maybe it was an unpleasant memory as Francia's expression was not good.

“At my father’s request, I wandered around and came across a temple. I hate it though.”

“Hate?”

“They keep telling people to look at me and call me a saint. That’s why.”

She said she also ran away from the temple. It was a very different story from the heroine than I remembered.

“While I was running away, I found a clue about what dad asked for. I tried to figure it out, but my body was messed up....”

“Really? Because of what...”

It was a word that came out of a sad heart. So I swear I didn’t mean to get her to say something she didn’t want.

But Francia bit her mouth.

Shaaa. How many times did the gentle wind pass by? Francia opened her mouth.

“I tried to bring the dead back to life.”

She held her hand as if praying.

“I am the white rose of the sublime, chastity and restoration.”

She said a while ago that she hates saints, and she hates temples... She eventually knew her destiny when she became a saint.

“The dead man had a crucial clue.”

Maybe that’s why she looked so holy and noble.

“So I thought I could do it.”

Even the way she murmurs.

“Dad said that. It’s the fate of the roses to find it.”

Even a country that was mostly indifferent to everything couldn’t help but ask.

“What is that?”

Francia’s eyes of different colors turned towards me. Her guardian deity was gone, but there was a soft white light as if protecting her.

“A blue rose.”

Now it has been cut out from history and the history behind it, and it has disappeared.

After Francia’s words, I recalled the slab from the cell.

A blue rose that was open as if someone had broken it.

“I see.”

I was silent for a while, and by the time I spoke again, we had already passed the entire garden.

I looked at the door getting closer and stopped talking.

“Where are you going when you leave?”

“I will wander around again... looking for clues. Well, I don’t know for sure. The people of the family are scattered around. Still, I won’t go to the temple.”

As if her bad memories were firmly established, Francia puffed out her cheeks.

“Don’t, saint.”

“Why.”

I clenched my fists slightly and covered my lips. It was to hold back the laughter.

Even if she said that, she would eventually become the saint. *Go behind her and say she's a saint!* The speaking scene was very impressive.

Even if I wondered what kind of plausible mix up this was, it was a process that forced her to be a saint.

“I don’t like it, when it comes to saints, they’re caught, tied up. It’s almost like being imprisoned. It’s natural for the Pope to do things his own way. It’s absolutely unfair.”

“Pope?”

“Yes. The Pope. Something like the head of a temple.”

I heard that they had similar abilities and a similar position to a saint.

“Then you be the Pope.”

I threw it lightly.

“Sister, it must be born with a great bloodline.”

“Bloodline?”

“Yes. What’s so important? I wonder if there’s any gold in it.”

Did you have the concept of a gold spoon here? I let out a soft laugh.

“So what can I do?”

“What can’t you do?”

Francia now fully puffed her cheeks and looked at me with disapproval. She used to see this when she didn’t understand what I meant.

“What do you mean?”

“Well, right now, you don’t even want to go to the temple, even if you’re a saint, but I’m talking about if you go.”

“If I go?”

She showed a curious face.

“What will sister do?”

I assumed her future and patted her lips.

“If it were me, I would put the Pope into my hands.”

What I saw and heard next to the prisoner was a crime, and the only thing I heard and seen next to the villain was the duke.

“Francia, your name doesn’t really mean much.”

I spread my palm out wide and showed it, then slowly closed it.

“What matters is what kind of power you have.”

There is a saying that if you don’t want to be dominated, you have to be alert, and if you don’t want to be taken advantage of, you have to stand on top.

“From the bottom up, gradually increase the number of people.”

Behind the palm were the fingers of the other hand. It is cleverly covered by the palm of the hand so that it cannot be seen.

“Then you are the real Pope.”

Even with that said, I thought that I would teach this child some really good things. The person who says they are not interested in politics or craftsmanship.

Who cares? Is there a law that only politicians should talk about politics?

“If you’re stronger, then don’t hesitate.”

In fact, even I did not think that Francia would realize it, so it was a possible advice.

Francia tilted her head and looked at my fingers and face alternately.

“...I see.”

She was serious.

“If I’m older, don’t hesitate, like that?”

Umm. The more I questioned, the deeper I got. Does the beautiful and kind young girl only appear after 3 years?

“If I become Pope, will I be able to knock down that devilish bastard in one punch?”

... The child is always the same, she really is like a bear.

After all, I’m that devilish bastard’s sister. I have no intention of taking sides.

I shook my head and told her to forget it. Then we walked out the garden door.

We talked about various things, but a corner of my heart was caught up in one thought all the time.

‘When are you leaving?’

The time of escape kept coming. Unfortunately, I just couldn’t find the right time.

No.

In fact, the right time was approaching.

Chaser would be away for a few days on a regular basis, and that period was coming again this month. That will be in three days. The error is within 2 days.

The warm summer will soon come at the end of the year.

And that time has passed.... The promised day with Ricdorian was well approaching

<One year later, this, the day I get out of this place.>

< ... Please meet me.>

Has time already passed like this?

Ironically, the date of the promise coincided with Chaser's departure.

The promised day.

It was a day I thought I would be able to forget, pretending to have forgotten it with all the time I spent with Francia.

“Sister?”

“Oh, nothing.”

I had to be careful. I must not fail. I'm sure there will never be a next time.

Just once.

This one time I had to succeed unconditionally.

...If Chaser finds out, Francia will....

She will be taken to the coal mine no matter what.

So a failure was not tolerated.

...Just once. We need factors that can make this one-time absolute success.

I needed a number that would never fail.

Chapter 141: Promised Day 1 Year Ago (2)

1. 1. Promised Day 1 Year Ago (2)

As I walked into the hallway, I was silent. It just suits Francia's babbling talk.

The fresh sunlight warms the walls of the hallway. The corridor with open sides created a gentle atmosphere with the side exposed to the sun.

At the end of it, I looked down for a long time, not knowing that there was an unexpected person.

As I walked a little further, Francia pulled the hem of my robe, who was next to her.

"...sister."

It was only when I heard the call from Francia, who was very wary, that I could see right in front of me.

"Miss Iana."

I slowly lifted my head.

There stood a man with a cold and sharp impression that was very foreign to the warm sunlight.

The cold eyes that seemed to freeze the surroundings just by standing still, and the transparent glasses that could not alleviate them. And a slim and large physique that doesn't go well with the glasses.

It was Lenag.

“Long time no see.”

His brown hair hung in the wind slowly swaying.

There was still an atmosphere standing on the edge on the day when it seemed like he would pull out the sword if I was wrong, and his faint smile was still there.

However, his face, which he had struggled to soften, gradually hardened.

Crinkle-

As I walked, the chain made a blunt sound and hit the floor.

Clink-

When it hit the floor one more time, a horizontal line appeared on Lenag's face. Immediately, his face contorted in an awkward way.

“...Excuse me, Miss Iana, is that okay?”

Why? He had an unbelievable face. I couldn't understand why the world looked like it had collapsed.

“The chain?”

I patted Francia, who was wary of him, and responded indifferently. Lenag covered his lips with the back of his hand at my soft voice.

Then his eyes went wide.

“I, I.”

The fierce eyes that seemed like a needle wouldn't hit, and the bottom of the eyes were red. There, a single teardrop as thick as a pearl was dripping from there. It makes for a really pitiful look.

I'm at a loss for words.

Why are you crying?

Francia next to me is pulling the hem of my clothes and whispering, *is he crying?*

I put my index finger to my lips. However, I was so embarrassed that I couldn't even think of a word.

I didn't know about anyone else, but I didn't know that this man would cry so badly.

Tears dripped down to the floor, drawing black circles. It had been a long time since my head stopped thinking in the middle of the day because it was painful and mournful.

"...what did your brother do?"

Why does his voice match so wonderfully? I felt like I was going to be drenched in tears for nothing.

It is said that it is a superb view when a handsome man cries. I wanted to wipe my face.

No, is it the hobby of the men around me to cry? Why... do you cry when you see me?

He bit his lip softly and then let it go.

"My God, I didn't send you out to see this..."

Although his face was sharp, he always had a soft voice, but his soft voice felt cold and hard.

No, it felt like a rigid person. He touched his cheek with a large, thick hand. Like someone who doesn't know what to do.

Then I opened my mouth slowly.

“No, uh... this isn’t Lenag’s fault either.”

I called his name naturally, but he was startled. Lenag, right? Because I called his name at the end....

“Uh, then, Marquis.”

“I like the name.”

“Yes, Lenag....”

...You are still asserting yourself while crying.

“I’m fine.”

If I had listened to that sound as soon as I was handcuffed or chained, it would have touched me no matter how much, but now that I’ve gotten used to it, I didn’t really care.

Because I didn’t feel anything.

“I don’t care.”

I just kicked my feet and laughed.

“I think so.”

I scratched my cheek and held out my hand. A hesitant hand brushed past his arm.

At that moment, Lenag’s expression seemed to have gotten more blurred.

“And it’s not Lenag’s fault.”

I couldn’t see him for a while as he covered his eyes with his hands. The tears hanging from the tip of his chin were the only evidence he couldn’t stop crying.

His white shirt was pulled taut.

“You’re not to blame? So don’t think so.”

It’s not really. He also saved my life.

“... Because of my negligence.”

His red eyes appeared as he gently lifted his hand. I was startled by the sharp eyes under the glasses, but rather.....

The falling tears robbed my eyes.

I need a handkerchief at times like this, but I didn’t have that kind of attention to detail. I don’t think Francia does.

Francia was rolling her eyes. It was a face full of awkwardness, but it was also full of curiosity.

Maybe it was because I saw her guardian deity a while ago, but the way she hides behind me and sticks her head out looks similar to this. A baby bear.

“I think we should talk about something else...”

To refresh the atmosphere, I comforted him, patted his arm and turned around.

“Why are you here, I’m surprised.”

Contrary to the fact that he was Chaser’s right arm in the book, he was a person who I had not been able to see for the past year or so. I thought he was busy.

He himself is a Marquis and in charge of the management of the cell, so why don’t he send subordinates instead of coming and going?

Whether my efforts worked, or whether it was hypothetical, Lenag took his hand away.

The slightly reddened skin was impressive. As he took off his glasses to wipe the pool of water, I looked at his half-dropped eyes and took a deep

breath.

... It looks really scary and sharp.

It was as if a sword had been made into a human. A masterpiece that is so sharp that no one can touch it.

There are tears in the eyes of such a person, so this is....

“I came here for business with your brother.”

As soon as Lenag raised his gaze, I quickly avoided his gaze. I’m afraid he would find out what I was thinking about while watching me even though he can’t hear me.

Hmmm, I’m not unscrupulous.

I just coughed and vented for nothing. Lenag looked at me like that and said a word.

“I could send my men, but I wanted to come in person.”

“Yes? Oh, yes.”

I nodded. Prison is comfortable, but sometimes frustrating. I understand.

“But he wasn’t in the mansion.”

There I paused. Chaser isn’t in the mansion?

“He’s not?”

“Yes, they said he went out, but I was told it would take a few days.”

So it seems that it was the butler and the little warlock who greeted Lenag. I could tell by the stories I heard one after another.

‘Is Chaser going out?’

I remembered his regular outing. He's been out around this time for a long time, so this time... it's faster than other months.

I pressed my lower lip with my index finger and thumb and then removed it.

If Francia was to run away, now was the 'red flag'.

'If you miss this, you have to wait another month.'

And there may be something else next month. The future could not be left unknown.

then....

As I was about to open my mouth, a hand reached out in front of me.

"Miss Iana, would you like to go outside with me?"

.... What? I blinked my eyes at the sudden sound.

"I'll help you get out of here."

The man's face, with the tears stopped, was infinitely serious. Yes, even though he spoke softly, he was a polite and gentle man.

"You've already done it once. Twice is not difficult."

That one time seemed to refer to accepting me in the prison and providing convenience there.

I was puzzled.

The suggestion you made for me thinking about this is really good, and I'm grateful... If the convenience in the prison was my brother's order or request.

How about now?

“Why?”

I knew it was not the time to ask such a question. Still, the candid words popped out.

“Why?”

Lenag was a little perplexed. Soon, a softer voice came back, softer than before the crying.

“Because I’m your fiancée.”

“Yes?”

Surprise erupted from the voice.

Who? Who’s what? Maybe I was too surprised, he made a more surprised face.

“Since when?”

“...that’s right, since your brother suggested it. I took the offer at once, but...”

“Ah.”

“Is there a problem?”

It reminded me. I remembered

I remembered that I had paid for this book’s side story as well.

Obviously, the supporting actor in the book, Lenag, cooperated with the villain, Chaser. The reason for this doesn’t appear in the main story, but it’s because Lenag loved Chaser’s unnamed younger sibling.

Yes. It was on the side.

“Did you get engaged?”

At the same time as the forgotten facts floated to the surface, my insides became more complicated.

Why did I even think of this now? I could no longer see this man's hand as before.

I also understood the slightly strange proposal and excessive convenience in the cell.

"No, it's not."

Even the face that shed tears as he looked at me now.

Were you engaged? This is because of my memory.

"...I appreciate the offer, but I'll turn it down. It's not because I don't like you. Lenag doesn't have to sacrifice.

"It's not a sacrifice."

I was weak against these daytime tickles. Regardless of the feelings I had for this man, the gaze upon me seemed to tickle the back of my neck. Because he was far from me

"It's natural for you to be with me in the future."

"Ah, yes..."

As soon as I realized this man's tickling heart, I couldn't help but feel itchy cheeks.

But I quickly changed my expression. As long as I knew that Lenag wasn't on Chaser's side, but mine.

He felt Francia hiding behind me and sticking her head out.

"Then please help this child, not me."

"Child?"

He was the most reliable ally when he was on my side. There is nothing as reassuring as when the bad guy was on my side.

“Yes, helping this child is helping me. Please take this friend out.”

He must have heard my voice resounding again and again. But there was no reaction.

“Understood.”

Chapter 142: Promised Day 1 Year Ago (3)

1. 1. Promised Day 1 Year Ago (3)

After a few moments, he nodded his head. So easy? Without asking who it is or why?

He answered easily, I didn't believe it. This man was a man who was sure to keep his word.

"I'll listen."

He said so and held out his hand once more. More outstretched than before.

"You go out too."

What? It was an unexpected word.

"She goes out and you go too. It's not difficult for me."

... It's not difficult. You're going to lose Chaser for sending me out. There was no way this man didn't know what I knew.

"Where do you want to go?"

My lips were burning. There were definitely words about to come out. But I kept my mouth shut.

"I'll think about it."

I took his hand and only held his fingertips, but Lenag slightly lowered his head. Avoiding eye contact.

“Can’t you answer me after we take this kid?”

Whether I’m going out of here or not, it’s a waste of time. First of all, let’s start with the female lead. If Chaser left, it was something that had to be resolved quickly.

Francia grabbed the hem of my robe.

I gave a gaze towards her.

“Francia, remember? If you wait for an opportunity.”

“...come out when you have the chance.”

Although Francia was still young and confused, she replied bluntly.

“Yes, that’s it. Here’s your chance.”

She and I promised. No, it means that she responded in advance to the sudden separation.

So even at this moment, we didn’t panic.

“This is the successor of the White Rose.”

“Of the white rose? Oh...”

Lenag shook his head. A cold gaze passed over Francia over his glasses.

“Okay. I understand the situation.”

He seems to know about the happenings with the White Rose, the Rosenia family, and Chaser. Because he was a collaborator.

I consulted with Lenag and decided to send Francia out right now.

He expected Chaser not to be away for very long, and I agreed.

“Francia, be careful and you must not be caught again.”

“Don’t worry. I’m better now.”

Francia smiled brightly. She then burst into tears. She hesitated, then smiled broadly again.

“Sister, I will never forget this grace.”

She grabbed my hand and held back tears.

“I... I know you saved my life.”

The female lead, although she was young in her physical age ahead of the awakening, she was not like that.

“If I wake up, I won’t be able to move much even if I see His Majesty’s eyes. My dad said that.”

The female lead touched my heart.

“I will become a stronger white rose than anyone else.”

Considering the weapon she used, it didn’t seem like an easy thing. Although it seems to be getting further away from the R-rating.

“I want to be a wonderful person like my sister.”

....Me? She pricked my conscience.

In the meantime, a gentle breeze blew and shook her brightly colored hair.

“Sister, I will awaken and become a wonderful woman. Even then.”

Francia grabbed my hand tightly.

“I’ll do it like my sister.”

I smiled and answered ‘yes.’.

The shape layered behind the long, swaying hair was a familiar face. Had I really helped Francia only with a pure heart? I wasn’t thinking of anyone, but the looks overlapped?

No.

I was thinking of that at this moment too.

Ricdorian, if we had met a little longer.

Did I hold your hand and smile at the last moment? Will we meet again, I wonder if we made a promise.

“See you again, definitely!”

Francia left the mansion with a brief goodbye. I don’t know what’s going to happen now that she’s out of my hands....

As long as Lenag is out, things won’t turn out badly.

I had such a belief.

<I will come back as soon as possible.>

Three days have passed since Lenag left his last goodbye and the two of them left.

Lenag had not contacted yet. Although he agreed to contact me as soon as he returned. I wasn’t sad about it because I thought it wasn’t easy.

Isn’t no news good news?

I went out to the garden and stared blankly at the flowers. The orange roses in Chaser’s garden were in full bloom today.

‘Soon it’s the end of the year.’

I fell into thought.

When Chaser went out on a regular basis, it usually lasted about a week. So, now that 3 days have passed, there are still 4 days left to come back.

And.

“The date”

There are two days left until the day with Rcdorian.

I’ve asked Chaser. How long does it take to get to the prison from here? He answered. If it’s official, it’ll take 4 days.

It was in line with what Lenag said.

<But it’s different if you’re riding a horse alone.>

Chaser smiled, and insignificantly informed me that there was a shortcut.

He didn’t seem to think that I was going to go back to the prison.

<“Chechen, it takes two days to get across there. Iana.>

“Chechen.”

The city, half a day away from here, was more of a lawless zone than a city. All kinds of crime and gambling, and pleasure intersects.

Can I go there alone?

No, if I ask Lenag....

-Human, why do you look like that, Nyan?

The snow leopard, who was in my arms, tilted its head. Yes, I have to return this snow leopard as well.

Maybe the reason is enough.

I shut my eyes softly.

‘I didn’t want to keep my promise.’

I opened my eyes slowly.

“There should be plenty of excuses.”

I had no intention of hiding my desire to go. No, I wanted to go. The prison wasn’t good. It was comfortable, but I didn’t like the overall gloom.

Even if I live in such a prison again.

Because I don’t want that man to cry because of disappointment.

-Human? Human? Where are you going? Nyan! I’m going to fall, Nyan!

I didn’t need to turn around in a hurry, so I walked faster. I ran.

Clink, clink

The sound of heavy chains followed my footsteps. How do I get this off? I already know that there was a way.

The little warlock knows how to take it off. Because he made it.

Occasionally, if my ankle was hurt or if I whined that it was wet, he would let it go with a sigh.

Chaser didn’t even say anything about it. Now, over a year later, it was such a light thing for us.

So, there is a way.

It’s not like you don’t even know the way. Now, if only Lenag comes back....

“Haa...haaa.”

My feet stopped at the entrance to the garden. No, it would be more that I stopped automatically.

Unbelievably, there was Chaser in front of me.

“...brother?”

Unlike the other days, my voice was full of embarrassment. It's bound to be. That's probably because Chaser's look was a mess.

Torn clothes and messy hair.

Wherever the scabbard had been thrown away, blood dried up on the tip of the long sword, and the undried blood fell to the floor.

A black dagger was floating around Chaser. It was a weapon transformed from his guardian deity, Rattan.

“Iana...”

And they all disappeared the moment he stumbled.

He was walking. Following his steps, blood runs down his fingertips and leaves traces.

It's not weird.

It was not uncommon for Chaser to come dripping with blood. He was also covered in blood.

But today, he felt strange. His fingertips were trembling and his heart felt like it was beating in my ears.

The sound gradually grew louder as Chaser approached.

Why? Because this is the first time Chaser was in such a mess? Because his hair was messy and his clothes were torn?

No, no.

The closer he got, the more I realized. The blood dripping from his fingertips, that was Chaser's blood.

He finally came closer and bowed his head. I flinched at the look of his face that reached up to my lips.

However, his face brushed against mine and fell onto my shoulder.

“A moment.....”

He, who would normally have stretched out his hand first, said without a budge of his hand. He just put his forehead on my shoulder.

“Iana, please stay like this for a moment. Please.”

I couldn't move at the sound of his weak voice. Compassion and boundaries were entangled in waves.

Kyaaaah! Hyaaaa!

For some reason, Pudding in my arms jumped down and raised its head towards Chaser. It was the first time I saw its tail raised threateningly and its fangs exposed, as fierce as a beast.

Even when asked with a mouth shape, Pudding did not look at this side. Chaser didn't care either.

“Iana.”

Chaser raised his head. The moment I looked into his eyes, my heart sank.

Excited? No. Because unfamiliar anxiety took over my heart.

“I finally killed him.”

The red lips gave a deep smile. As if in ecstasy, as if rejoicing.

“I killed Grand Duke Hernim.”

A terrifyingly beautiful voice pierced my chest like a thorn. I didn't know why it was so painful.

I regretted giving this man my shoulder. I regretted the pity.

I closed my eyes slowly.

It felt as if something had disappeared from my chest and a black curtain was cast over it. I couldn't catch anything that scatters like smoke.

I realized it myself. The reason I wanted to leave to keep my promise was that I wanted to spend a peaceful life with him.

I really liked that time.

Now it was impossible for me to spend a peaceful life with him. Because if my identity is revealed at any time, I won't be perfect.

<Promise, keep it.>

The promise with Ricdorian was only two days away.

Three days later, Lenag visited the mansion. Although he was bewildered by Chaser's presence, he saw a chance and whispered to me.

Would you like to leave?

I looked down at him who suggested that, and smiled brightly.

"No."

What was this man thinking at the moment when our eyes crossed? Now that Chaser appeared, I couldn't leave anymore.

I am well aware of the meaning his father had for Ricdorian. After his father disappeared, he also harbored a hatred for Chaser.

He will be forged like a sword in his cell with hatred.

<Will you keep your promise, Iana?>

And there was no reason to leave. Because the promised day has passed.

Chapter 143: The original story started

1. 1. 1. 1. The original story started

—3 years later.

Only three noble duchies in the vast empire, one was praised for having the strongest power among the duchies.

The Duke of Domulit was as busy as any other day.

The master of this place, the Duke of Domulit, loved to be ascetic and clean.

Employees of this place had to fasten their buttons to the end, and always wear clean clothes.

Although it was inconvenient, no one dared to disobey because he did not spare any expense for maid and servant clothes.

Veronica, a maid who has been here for three years, was also one of them.

“Ugh... it’s heavy. Heavy.”

While she was muttering while looking at the decorations around her, the colleague next to her hushed and cautioned her.

‘Alright. Alright.’

It usually was a job that required quiet and solemnity, but it wasn’t as tight as it is today.

Veronica looked at the decorations around. They are in the process of a ceremony. It is to see if there is anything distracting in the middle.

Because today was none other than the day of the funeral.

The deceased was the Duke of Domulit.

No, he was exactly the previous Duke of Domulit. He was known for spending a quiet time recuperating in the back room after Chaser Louve Domulit, the young master who inherited the title two years ago, became Duke.

He was an old man who was more famous for his evil deeds, and had repeated countless evil deeds and vicious atrocities from his youth.

Even so, the fact that there are so many mourners proves the power of the young current duke, not the dead old duke.

“Our duke became the youngest duke. There is no one who received an official title at such a young age as the duke.”

“Oh, why not? He, why that red rose...”

“Ugh, hush! Be quiet.”

As the grand funeral was over, there was a little bit of space among the employees.

Veronica watched as she and her colleague chatted as they gathered the list handed to them

by the butler.

The two left the ceremony and headed towards the back of the mansion. The other building’s courtyard hallway was silent.

“If you don’t be so careful with your mouth, you will disappear quietly.”

Her colleague had seen her just a moment ago, so she clicked a tongue at Veronica. That was correct.

Hearing those words, Veronica recalled a sudden memory. When she came here three years ago, she was careless.

There was a time when, to be precise, she would say that her eyes were careless.

<I've never seen you before.>

At that time, she was very young and a clumsy maid.

So, when she saw the first beautiful woman she had ever seen in her life, instead of taking care of her expression, she was rude and stared at the woman.

Looking at the woman's curly pink hair, small face with all the features under it, and the purple eyes blinking indifferently, there seemed to be no one who wouldn't take a moment's time.

But the woman was the master Veronica was supposed to serve.

As she never took her eyes off for the second time and the moment she looked at the woman's ankles, she was rude again once more.

No one wouldn't be surprised to see the chains.

She was dizzy just thinking about that moment.

<Oh, my ankle?>

She can't help but took off her gaze to the woman's face that was grinning as she rolled her eyes.

<It's interesting, right.>

Even if she goes back, it will be difficult. The lady caught Veronica's gaze faster than Veronica, and she readily forgive Veronica.

If she hadn't, Veronica wouldn't have been in this position three years later.

Thinking about it, she was indeed a strange lady.

The lady, who had returned from the prison one day, was indifferent to the world, she was indifferent to everything, and like flowing water, she paid no attention to anything.

Is she a pessimistic person?

It may be right that she is indifferent. All she has by her side is a strange baby animal who she doesn't know if it's a cat or not, and her fiancé who occasionally visits her.

Most of the time, she would sit in the garden and pass her time idly.

Everyone in this mansion knew she had lost her smile as of 3 years ago. She hadn't changed much.

She didn't always smile well in the first place. She was like that even before going to the prison.

But for some reason, it was caught in Veronica's mind.

The lady was not a heartless person.

<Let's do it once.>

It's going to be a lot of trouble.

The way she smiled as she held up her index finger that day was the same.

"Oh, Lady."

Veronica quickly raised her head at her colleague's words. The lady really was standing in front of her.

Iana Rose Domulit.

She was like the most precious jewel in this mansion.

She wore a black dress, staring blankly into the garden next to the hallway.

It must be because of that thinness and the black veil that creates a calm and pitiful atmosphere.

In fact, her gaze was indifferent.

“Greetings, lady.”

“Ah.”

Iana turned her head. Her expression was no different from before.

“Hi.”

She waved her hand politely.

As it was during the funeral, Iana also wore mourning clothes, but she did not go to the central building where the funeral is currently held.

She did not go due to the orders of her brother, Chaser.

It was a fact that any employee of the mansion knew that this place was nothing more than a gigantic cage in which she was confined.

All of a sudden, her colleague was not walking in the first place. Her colleague was flustered by her lady.

She was the one who feared that she would disappear without a trace as she talked.

Veronica is also afraid that her neck will be gone, but....

“.....Are you okay?”

The purple eyes returned to Veronica. Iana had a puzzled face. Then, *ah*, she touched her veil and smiled a little.

“I’m alright.”

Veronica knew. When Iana saw the mansion’s master, Chaser, shackling her, she smiled like that.

“It’s my father, but... I don’t have a lot of feelings.”

Even when Chaser appeared with blood on him, she smiled like that.

“Thank you.”

Sometimes Veronica had doubts.

Lady, are you really okay?

I could feel the maid’s gaze staring at me. She had neatly pulled up hair, a calm face, and a familiar face.

She was one of the maids I saw often.

If there’s anything unusual, it’s that she sometimes hesitates and then says something to me like this, or at one point, secretly handed me snacks.

She was memorable.

“What are you carrying with you? A list?”

But as she has a purpose for standing here today, she quickly nodded.

That list was her goal for today, if I was right.

“Ah, yes. This is the list of attendees at the Schirmela conference.”

Schirmela Conference. The country was so wide that it was difficult to contain the power of the local nobility, and to overcome this, the imperial family held conferences rotating in large cities every year.

Not just anyone was allowed to attend, only high-ranking nobles could participate.

A Duke like Chaser, for example.

And I heard that there will be questions about who will attend the funeral.

The list will contain the names of those who are obligated to attend the funeral and those who do not.

If someone were to take the list, this would be the only way, and my predictions came true.

When I asked if I could take a quick look, the maid hesitated, and she pushed out the list.

“Well, lady, are you going out?”

“Huh? Right.”

I nodded indifferently.

“Maybe it’s difficult because of this.”

Clink.

The sound of chains still resounded pleasantly. The maid bit her mouth tightly.

I looked down the list, found the name I was looking for, and only checked it before putting it out again.

“Thank you.”

There was no way to stop the smile from flowing out.

“You can go.”

The maid hesitated to look at me, and she carefully opened her mouth.

“La, lady...”

“Huh?”

Even after 3 years, her tone of voice went back and forth. It was a habit that was not easily broken.

“My mother used to say I have a habit of laughing when I’m not okay.”

“....What?”

For some reason, the maid’s eyes seemed to pass by with a brief regret. Did I see it wrong?

But without further ado, she said goodbye and walked away. As if afraid I would catch her.

Left behind, I tilted my head. *What?*

“What. Am I too fat?”

-Human, ... You don’t seem to know what you look like, Nyan.

After three years, Pudding, who had already learned to make a mature voice, responded.

Pudding, who was quietly in my arms, tapped me with its tail and jumped off. It was quite big. Now, if I hold it, it was heavy.

– I have come to realize that this body is human. Nyang.

“What? Creepy.”

I casually ignored it and turned my back. It made a fuss.

– What, why are you ignoring me, Nyan! Human! Human!

Waoonng, Nyaongg!

It said it was definitely a snow leopard, but what it does is no different from that of a cat. Is it because they are the same feline species?

“Noisy.”

I looked it up, and when a cat is 3 years old, it is like a young man who is over 20 years old in human age.

I ignored the nagging Pudding, who is now a young man, with an unbalanced name of Pudding.

Three years have passed.

Not much has changed as time has passed. Just my hair length? Oh, and it's time to socialize. There must have been something that allowed me to go outside.

According to the laws of this country, Lords and Ladies over the age of 20 must attend a banquet held by the imperial family at least once.

And at this time, I have to attend the debutante banquet.

I was 22 years old, so I had postponed it for two years.

When was that, a few months later?

I looked up at the sky.

The season was spring. Summer is coming soon.

It's been 3 years... In other words, it's quite a while since the original story started properly.

At least it's time for Ricdorian to get out of prison.

I was reminded of a list I saw a while ago.

‘Ricdorian von Hernim.’

I smiled as if I could see it. The original story started well.

Chapter 144: Aim for a moment of carelessness

81. Aim for a moment of carelessness

Since he could not have attended the funeral of the enemy, he must have been a compulsory participant. After all, it's impossible for someone who is a Grand Duke to miss a meeting.

I knew that Ricdorian had become the Grand Duke.

Hernim was not a family whose title was inherited naturally by the death of its predecessors. Even a successor must have qualifications to bear the name of the Grand Duke.

The fact that Ricdorian's name is listed here means that he has officially become the Grand Duke.

-Human!

Don't nag, the first thing I got tired of was Pudding. Pudding was lying flat in front of me. Without hesitation, it showed me its belly and cried.

— Are you really going to do it, nyan?

I squatted and wiped the snow leopard's belly. It was our style of reconciliation.

“I have to.”

— Weren't you depressed, nyan?

“I guess so.”

I admitted frankly. Because I was sorry I couldn't go to see him.

“But three years... it's been a long time.”

Three years was a time for even my excited heart to disappear. Thinking it was just a passing season.

– Didn't you say you won't see him anymore, nyan? Is that okay, nyan?

“That's because I didn't keep my promise that day.”

On that day three years ago, Pudding was also there, so it saw and knew. And it knew the promise between me and Ricdorian.

“Because I've given up on getting along with him now.”

Even if I was locked up, I could hear news from time to time.

In recent years, Chaser's forces have been fighting more frequently. Or where the knights rush out.

In the book, the first thing Ricdorian prepared for when he got out of the prison was to take revenge.

“Hey, you have to let go now.”

3 years. The time I was notified of when I first met Pudding was approaching.

It's time for Pudding to meet Ricdorian. Otherwise, his life would be in danger.

-But why was it three years later, nyan?

Pudding followed me and asked. Instead of answering, I spread my arms out. As if Pudding was waiting, it jumped into my arms.

“Do you know when accidents happen the most?”

– I don’t know, nyan.

I whispered while stroking the fluffy hair.

“When you’re careless.”

The chance to ever connect with him was buried, but I remain obligated to return this lovable guardian spirit to him.

3 years. This time I waited silently, I waited for him to be completed like in the book.

To make him a little stronger.

Every time I tried to return it, Chaser caught my heart. What if Chaser uses a trick when Ricdorian is weak?

-...What are you going to do with that scary black rose, nyan?

He doesn’t need to be killed, I had no choice but to cripple him.

“Ah, Chaser.”

No, is that all? It was also that I didn’t want to face the wounds I had given. I honestly admitted that I was a coward.

And now the moment that can no longer be postponed has arrived.

“It’s okay.”

I looked up at the sky and raised my lips.

“I’m not afraid of the consequences anymore.”

Chaser, a year after meeting that man, I realized the depth of this man’s obsession with me.

Now, 3 years later.

Because I know he'll forgive me no matter what I did.

"I'm going to meet Ricdorian."

The Schirmela meeting approached quickly.

Speaking of Schirmela, the metropolis where this conference was held, it was very close to the domain of Domulit, and it was also a neutral area that followed only the imperial family.

In other words, neither the territory of the rising Hernim nor the territory of the Domulit, which already possesses great control.

"This is absurd!"

Marshmel hit the table.

As always, it was a desk that wouldn't budge with his tiny hands.

But his red fingertips were enough to show his mood.

I stared intently at the young warlock who was Chaser's closest aide.

"You're so cute today."

"What?"

"Oh, did I say it out loud? I'm sorry."

Marshmel immediately looked like he was soon going to grab the back of my neck, then I grabbed the cheeks with one hand and released it. It was puffy cheeks.

"No, I don't agree with this. I'm against it!"

“Um, why? It’s not so difficult. It’s not strange, is it strange that I want to go to the Schirmela meeting?”

I rested my arms on the desk and put my cheeks on it.

“I might want to go out too.”

“Who’s letting anyone go out? It’s a problem that you’re sneaking around! Lady, wake up!”

“I’m up. And I know that Mister Marshmallow will help.”

“Who is Marshmallow!”

It’s been 3 years, but the anger is still there. Now I just have to get used to it.

“What’s wrong with you? I can’t help you.”

He was a loyal servant in the book. But in reality for 3 years, I knew he had a slightly different relationship than I had expected.

Of course he’s loyal... It sounds like there is room.

“Hmm, is it going to look like this? I know this and that, should I tell my brother?”

“What, what?”

“Last time you experimented with the chain, my finger almost flew away, and you forgot one magic while changing the chain and I almost got assassinated...”

“...”

“More?”

This man admired and followed Chaser, but at the same time was very, very, very afraid.

Well, it's strange that you're not afraid when you look at it from the side.
He's such a crazy person.

I smiled.

"What I ask for is not difficult. I just want to take a look at it for a while?
But it's hard if I keep going like this, so I'll pretend to be a maid and let Mr.
Candy covers my face a little."

"Candy..."

"That's not it. Well, all right. Shall we go to my brother right now?"

".....eekk."

The young face in front of me, his plump cheeks turned red, and tears welled up. Although the mind is an adult, the body is inevitably a child, so he was honest with his emotions.

It's strange that such a person is a genius of black magic.

"Um, there's still room left in my brother's coal mine..."

"Got it! I got it!"

Seeing the little warlock pounding on the table and complaining, I smiled indifferently and triumphantly.

-"...You're a vicious human, Nyan...."

Seeing that, Pudding quietly murmured.

On the day of the Schirmela meeting, the Domulit moved in time with the meeting.

It was only a two-hour journey from the city, so there was no need to leave a day or a few days early as in other places.

On the morning of the departure for Schirmela, Chaser came to my room.

To be precise, I just woke up from breakfast and thought we were going to eat together.

I stopped watching and sat in front him.

“Iana?”

“Eat.”

I nodded my head. Like I don’t care.

“The rice you eat alone cools down quickly.”

I muttered indifferently and turned my head. My relationship with Chaser was neither good nor bad. It seemed to stand still like 3 years ago.

He looked at me strangely and lowered his head. He seemed to smile a little. The smile was as usual, yet different.

After eating like that, he decided to take me to my room, and it was now that we arrived together.

He said he had something to show me, too, and he brought out something.

“....What is it?”

I couldn’t hide my bewildered expression when I saw what appeared from his hand.

“Dog collar.”

“No, no. I know it’s a dog collar too.”

Why are you holding it like you’re doing it? I was stunned.

“I heard that you’re bored these days.”

“It’s a rumor.”

“You sighed.”

It must have been a sigh I sighed while thinking about sneaking out.

“...It’s a misunderstanding.”

“I wondered if you needed something stimulating, but I thought I’d have to think about what you like.”

No, is this what you prepared after thinking about it?

“I heard you like this.”

Me? me?

It was unheard of. I now open my mouth slightly, revealing absurdity. It was a story that could not be overlooked.

“Who likes that?”

“Um, isn’t it?”

Chaser tapped the dog collar to his lips and tilted his head.

“...I heard that you played with Hernim’s successor like a dog in the prison.”

At that moment, I held back my breath.

“Wait, the source is Le, no, it’s the Marquis of Valtaze, isn’t it? That Marquis?”

Who would talk to him? I don’t know why he said that to Chaser now.

“That’s right. It’s been a while since I’ve heard it.”

Four years or so? Chaser whispered and stretched out his fingers.

I think he heard it when I was in the prison. I didn't know why he was doing this now.

Chaser smiled bashfully as he brought the collar to his mouth.

"If you like it, I'm willing to match it. I do."

"No, that's fine. And I don't like it."

"Really? There's no need to hide it."

He murmured.

"I heard that you threw wooden sticks and made him bring it back, then bark."

"...it's been misunderstood."

"Really?"

Chaser didn't really believe it.

The source is the prison general manager, so I thought it would be.

I resented Lenag once again and averted my eyes slightly. Chaser caught my face, following the avoided gaze.

"Iana."

Chaser's hand grabbed my hand and made it unfold. Then he put his face there.

".....what are you doing?"

His eyes were half-folded and he gave out a mischievous smile.

"Do I have to bark?"

He licked his lips.

“Woof.”

You must be crazy. I spit out my heart as it was.

“...you must be crazy.”

I couldn't take the dog collar from Chaser. However, one was eventually kicked out of my room with a dog collar.

Chapter 145: In Schirmela (1)

1. 1. In Schirmela (1)

“Why are you so happy?”

I got a glimpse of Chaser’s face, but he seems to be in a very good mood today. I think it’s from eating.

While sweeping his face, Chaser knocked on the door outside.

“I’ll be back, Iana.”

Stay safe for me, my sister. A friendly voice was heard one after another, followed by the sound of footsteps.

I waited for the footsteps to completely disappear, then opened the door when I couldn’t hear it anymore.

“Pudding, are you ready?”

Waong, Pudding’s cries were heard in the small pocket. Okay, it went well

I left the room and moved quickly. Originally, there were no people in the hallway where my room was, and I couldn’t even see them downstairs because of today’s schedule.

Even so, I put on the cloak all the way to my head, just in case, and finally took off the cloak when I got there.

There was a Marshmel with a sulky expression.

“I don’t know if this is a good thing or not, really.”

“Sure, it’s a good thing.”

I quickly received what the little warlock gave me. After a while, I changed into a maid’s uniform and appeared from behind the partition.

“Do you get it? This is a secret that only you and I need to know!”

“Yes, of course, of course.”

Marshmel will also come along to the Schirmela bound trip today. And I decided to go with him as a maid.

Apparently, with his body like this, whenever he goes out, he always has one person at a time.

“Take my hand.”

The little black warlock grabbed my sleeve and muttered something, and a magic circle appeared under his feet, and a black light burst out.

And when I opened my eyes, I looked in the mirror, and I saw a face with brown hair and freckles.

A face with a gentle expression was looking at me.

Whoa, this works really well.

I moved quickly at his words that we had to move when there’s no one.

I was worried that Marshmel was going with Chaser, but it was nothing.

There were more than ten carriages going to Schirmela, and instead of riding with Chaser, he rode a distant carriage.

“Master hates the hustle bustle.”

Inside the carriage, I heard the little warlock’s nagging, but I listened to it through one ear.

The carriage departed, and I gave my eyes to the scenery outside the window.

‘I’m really going out.’

It was easy. I thought about it, but I erased it. It’s not that I didn’t want to go out, but it was too much of a burden.

I thought it would be a little different if Chaser became the duke, but the threat only got severe, it did not disappear.

“Because the fight was fierce.”

The funeral of the predecessor Duke Domulit, which took place recently, I know the reality of this funeral.

The previous duke suffered from an illness for some reason, and Chaser extended the duration of this illness.

It means that he has forced a strange person to live, as if he was about to die.

Only in order for him to inherit the dukeship at a satisfactory time.

Thus, he ascended the throne after removing all his father’s loyal vassals, his men.

Watching that bloody fight from the side, I thought that his resentment was piling up this much but... I couldn’t say it because in this fight, Chaser would be eaten if he didn’t win in the first place

Of course, Chaser not only had the guardian deities’ abilities, but also had many talented subordinates around him. Didn’t this little warlock in front of me always disguise himself on Chaser’s outings and follow him, despite his shortcomings in appearance.

‘What was his identity? A child of a distant relative.’

As I was thinking, the carriage stopped. And the little warlock's nagging, which had been pouring for two hours in a row, finally stopped.

"It's a castle."

A large castle could be seen through the window.

Schirmela.

And it was the place where Ricdorian would be.

When I arrived at Schirmela's castle, the lord and many people greeted Chaser.

I sneaked out and got caught among the maids carrying the luggage. No matter how disguised his identity, Marshmel was in the entourage following Chaser, and he would move separately because he was not on a good look that stood out.

However, when we moved, the distance with Chaser was too close if I went with him, so I decided to move separately.

Buried among these countless maids.

<Don't do anything stupid, come quickly. Miss!>

Marshmel's voice filled with concern passed through my ears, but he had nothing to worry about.

Because I had no intention of escaping.

Comfortable confinement is better than life-threatening freedom.

Why don't they believe me?

"Hey, can you move that?"

"Yeees!"

I mimicked a sweet voice and moved my luggage diligently. Occasionally, another maid looked at my pocket and asked what it was, but I muttered and said it was my personal belongings.

Pudding, be patient.

It was two hours after I got out in the midst of the maids.

“Oh, my waist. Honey, you worked hard too. Would you like to go and drink some water?”

“Yes.”

At the kind advice of the maid I was working with, I finally got out of the pile of luggage. I would have done my best.

I was going to go find the little warlock.

“Can I take a look around before that?”

It’s been a long time since I got out. Still, it was not that there was no nostalgia outside, but I moved my steps toward the garden.

I know Marshmel’s room anyway, so it’ll be okay for a little bit. Taking a walk at this moment, thinking that I’m a little carefree.

Unlike Domulit, Schirmela’s garden was mostly made up of wonderful garden trees.

I wandered around the greenery to my heart’s content, avoiding major roads that nobles go.

Even if I run into someone, a maid’s suit will be a proper identification.

“Pudding.”

As I whispered softly into my pocket, *waongg*, the wailing sound returned.

I thought it must have been very stuffy, so I looked around and quickly untied the cloth.

“Are you okay?”

– It’s not okay at all, Nyan....

Pudding’s face looked tired. I smiled at the face and sat down by the tree.

“Would you like to come out for a second? Oh, but...”

Pudding is the problem. The appearance of a snow leopard was very noticeable. It had a unique color and shape that would not be forgotten if caught by chance.

Come to think of it, Aquala has completely changed her appearance.

“Hey, can’t you change your look? Like an ordinary cat.”

Pudding’s ears perked up.

– I can do it, Nyan.

“That’s right, even if you can’t... what?”

You can? You can? It was weird.

“Are you kidding me? Then why didn’t you tell me until now?”

– You didn’t ask, Nyan!

Pudding was imposing. I quickly pinched the bastard’s cheek. *Hwaaak*, I pinched its cheek while it kept hitting at me.

– It hurts! It hurts!

“Cry for what you did. Huh?”

-Human, your hands hurt! Nyan!

“Just change quickly.”

Soon after, Pudding moved and changed its shape. It can't change the color of its hair, just plain gray, but it was a cat

‘It’s a cat after all.’

This was enough to make it seem inconspicuous even if I ran into someone. Pudding, which became a cat, hugged me and cried.

-By the way, human, it is a little weird. Obviously it didn't work at first... It was possible at some point, Nyan.

“Are you talking about the transformation?”

— Yes, Nyan.

Does that have anything to do with Ricdorian's condition?

The only thing that changed during the three years was Ricdorian's situation. Pudding was happy to be able to feel the outside air now, and the sound of crying was charming.

‘Shall we go back now?’

While getting up from my seat, I suddenly raised my head.

Wow. The tree I was leaning on a while ago was bigger than I thought. Like a few hundred years, to exaggerate, a thousand years. It was like a mountain tree, so thick and large and tall.

It reminded me of when I was a child, climbing a tree in the yard. At other times, I thought I wouldn't have done it at all if I had been in a mansion.

“Pudding, give me some of that. That made me stronger.”

Pudding went *nyan*? It asked back about it, but it gave me strength. Soon my body felt lighter and more energetic.

– Don’t do anything stupid, Nyan.

After 3 years of using it for various things, I was good at using it.

“What’s wrong with you?”

I smiled and climbed the tree.

My body was very light, so I climbed up and sat on the nearest branch.

Wow. I knew it.

The view of the garden from the height of 2-3 floors was very beautiful.

It’s a good thing I got up. Looking towards the building, I could see people busily moving through the cleaned glass windows.

I wiggled my knees.

The gentle breeze felt good. I feel fortunate to have done something I hadn’t done before.

As I was contemplating the garden like that, I stopped at some point.

‘What.’

I blinked my eyes wide.

“...why is there a red rose over there?”

It’s there, right?

In the middle of Schirmela’s garden, a place right from the center was full of red roses. No, it is filled only with red roses. I hardened my expression.

It was spring, so it wasn’t strange that there were roses, but...

In this empire, there is a law against growing roses arbitrarily. Especially the color.

It symbolizes power among the nobility.

“.....Obviously this was a neutral area.”

It was the meeting place of all the high-ranking nobles. Such a place grows red roses in the garden.

There was only one.

This is the territory of Hernim, Ricdorian.

Schirmela went under Hernim. When?

I’ve heard that it was a neutral area until recently... I swallowed my breath.

My heart was pounding at the fact that Ricdorian had learned at least this way. Rather than excited, the thought that he is really here.

Shaaaaa!

The wind blew. The branches swayed and the shadows of the leaves danced.

I should go down now, but while I was thinking, someone passed under the tree.

A tall, tall man.

I opened my eyes wide, giving him a glance.

Silver hair, the fluttering hair was silver.

“Ri..”

Ricdorian?

Chapter 146: In Schirmela (2)

1. 1. In Schirmela (2)

I quickly shut my mouth. But the sound had already leaked out.

No, not all silver hair is Ricdorian. As I thought so, another thought appeared that it might be, so I lifted my head.

.... I've seen you grow up already.

I know. How could I not know.

The man reacted promptly and stopped walking.

He slowly shook his head.

And in three years, I saw the blue eyes. It was really Ricdorian.

“Who are you?”

First, the two eyes that I met again were as cold as if they were frozen.

There is no coincidence in everything in the world, but I never thought that we would meet again like this. Not at all.

At the reunion after three years, a suffocating silence passed. I couldn't choose what to say in a situation completely different from what I had imagined.

When I did not answer, Ricdorian seemed to have come up with an answer of his own.

He looked at me, narrowed his eyes and muttered, '*maid?*'.

I was able to peek on him in the meantime. Except for his height, which was taller than I remembered, his figure had clearly grown.

Maybe it was because I saw him in a dark cell at that time. Seen from a bright place, even more shiny silver hair, a high and long nose, and a graceful jawline.

It's neat and it adds maturity... It was dangerous.

... You grew up really well.

Hoo. Oh my, I didn't just drool, didn't I? I pretended to be holding my breath with the back of my hand.

"What is a maid doing in a place like this?"

I was a little perplexed. Hmmm, he wasn't the kind of person to ask this coldly. After all, does time change people?

"I'm sorry. The weather is nice."

I rolled my eyes and opened my mouth. As usual, a calm and indifferent voice came out.

"It's a good weather for a walk. Wait."

At that, Ricdorian furrowed his eyebrows slightly. His lips flapped, and he didn't say a word.

He could go as he is, but surprisingly, he kept looking up this way. Why aren't you going?

No, I'm in trouble with him.

It's rather embarrassing to look at him like this.

"Aren't you coming down?"

Coming down. It was an issue I hadn't thought of. I was a maid, right. The maid should come down and greet him.

The moment I got the idea, I was embarrassed.

'I am using Pudding's power now.'

It was pretty tall. Under non-ordinary circumstances, this amount can be easily jumped. The problem was that it was an unusual move for an ordinary maid.

But I couldn't think of anything else...Should I crawl down?

Also, while using Pudding's power, there will be no ordinary movements.

"... Pudding. Put me back the way I was."

I whispered softly into Pudding's ear. I felt the power draining from my body.

I just kept moving.

Fortunately, the tree had many twigs here and there, and I could see the bright spot where I came from.

Maybe step on that and go down somehow?

Having tried that, I realized after one step that I had been very wrong.

'I can't go down anymore!'

My arms were trembling. Now I couldn't even borrow Pudding's power. Ricdorian's gaze was still fixed behind my back.

Looking back, he was observing with a cold expression on his face.

Let's just jump.

I thought I would be fine, since I was half way down thanks to all my strength. Just look down and go with your eyes closed

Jump!

It was when I got down.

I guess it was higher than I thought?

I screamed inside, something hard wrapped around my waist.

I took a deep breath and opened my eyes, and there was a white face. The well-swept nose and lips, as well as delicate eyelashes, flickered.

Ricdorian looked at me coldly and indifferently, and then put me down.

“You’re being careless.”

The cool voice, like crushed ice, made my lips draw a downward curve for no reason.

‘Well, I guess not.’

The realization that he no longer knew who I was great.

Hahaha, it was a shameful thing to be upset here.

Either way, Ricdorian just turned around and left me.

“Wait, wait a minute. Grand Duke!”

I hurriedly ran and stood in front of him. Ricdorian slightly frowns on his beautiful brow.

I asked with an awkward smile at the eyes that were asking me ‘what?’.

Then I took Pudding and put it in his face.

“What are you doing?”

“Excuse me...”

I gulped and said,

“Can you feel anything?”

Nyang?

For some reason, Pudding didn’t even talk to me and cried once. Are you nervous too?

Ricdorian looked at me and Pudding alternately, as if he did not understand.

“...I don’t like cats.”

That was the only answer. He just left the place.

“Lady, why are you wearing a blanket?”

Inside Marshmel’s room, outside of the blanket, the small warlock’s voice resounded.

I poked my head out of the blanket. Sure enough, there was a face that looked at me pathetically.

It was a gaze that did not understand why I was doing this until this evening, half a day after I was reunited with Ricdorian.

“You should at least tell me why. Why are you like this?”

“..I want to be alone.”

“This is my room.”

I know. Because I didn't know when the magic on my face would break, so I decided to share a room.

The word is 'share a room', but he slept in a separate study room. His manners were unnecessarily good. No one would see a six-year-old warlock as a man with a heart.

'If you look at it, there's a big problem with your sexual preferences.'

Marshmel tilted his head.

"Why do you look like you've seen a ghost?"

"No...."

I lay down again.

My mind replayed the moment I met Ricdorian.

I didn't think of it until I ran into Ricdorian. I just thought of passing Pudding to him.

That's what I thought about...

'Come to think of it, once he knows what Pudding is, he will also know who I am.'

The person who took Pudding and sealed it was Chaser. There's no way he can't help but think of Chaser.

Aside from finding out that I'm Iana from the prison... I might end up in Ricdorian's hands.

Even revealing that I am Iana is a problem. It will only be a matter of time before he knows I'm Chaser's sister.

'Should I just close my eyes and throw Pudding away?'

And for him to get out of the prison means he lost the restraints around his neck, and to be free... it means he had met his 'companion'.

I was worried if it would go well. Did the original story flow safely?

Will his future be okay when I release the female lead? I was a little worried though.

How to endure the bitterness that comes in for no reason, and toss Pudding to him without being misunderstood as Chaser's sister.

And Pudding will only reveal it's true self only after it is left with Ricdorian.

Even if he doesn't know who I am until then, I will have already returned to Domulit. It didn't matter.

'But, why didn't Pudding say anything before?'

Pudding was a bit odd. If it was like before, it would hit me with its tail and look pitiable, it would have seen Marshmell often, and it would nag me.

Pudding was lying on its back next to me, just like a cat. I tapped its back with my finger.

"Pudding."

Poke

.

"Hey."

– Don't do it, human, Nyang.

Tak. The tail pounded on the bed twice. That means it was uncomfortable.

"What's wrong with you? Where does it hurt?"

I then lifted my upper body.

Marshmell moved away from my place.

It was evening and I thought I was going to bed.

– Weird, human. It’s weird, nyang.

“What?”

I turned my head after checking that Marshmel had closed the door tightly and left.

-Human, is that human the real Heirnim’s successor?

What?

I blinked my eyes. What are you talking about? I heard something so strange that I couldn’t understand it at once.

“Of course?”

Ricdorian was undoubtedly Hernim’s successor.

“What’s the matter?”

– I don’t think he’s the successor.

“What? Why? On what basis?”

Pudding has now turned its body around and digs deep into me. This is what it used to do when it was often scared. The tail wrapped around my hand.

– That man... he was ‘complete’, Nyang.

The awakening.

“That thing you do when you meet your ‘companion’?”

-No. I'm not saying that. I'm talking about what he can do when he meets me. The successor must become one body with me to become 'complete'.
Nyang!

With its ears crumpled, Pudding trembled.

– It's impossible, Nyang.

A small voice came out as if it could not be heard.

– The successor was complete without me. Complete without me, Nyang!

I couldn't say anything. I would give some advice in any field I know, but there was nothing I could say.

“You really didn't feel that Ricdorian was the heir?”

-Actually... I felt it, Nyang. But I felt the awakening and became scared,
Nyang.

Pudding seemed terrified by the unknown.

“Can't you be wrong? And it wouldn't be okay without you.”

I slowly remembered the Ricdorian in the prison.

Even then, he looked like an adult. In addition, his physical ability was superior, and he used his strength when running in prison.

How strong was he when he lifted me up.... Hmmhmm.

If awakening was necessary to use his power, it would have been impossible without Pudding.

Chapter 147: Don't you want to raise it?

1. 1. Don't you want to raise it?

Still, he looked like he had grown up.

‘Maybe it had something to do with it?’

Rather, after hearing Pudding's story, I became concerned. Even then he...
He became very ill after growing up or after exerting his strength.

There were times when I was worried that he might be out of breath looking at him with a fever.

If he now takes off his restraints and awakens without Pudding, he would be suffering side effects.

At least, it may be a side effect that doesn't end with just suffering from a fever.

Maybe it's a big threat to life?

I whispered urgently.

“No, Ricdorian needs you.”

I thought of the three roses I had seen. In common, everyone did not keep their guardian deity apart for a long time.

“I guarantee it.”

Chaser's guardian deities always stayed by his side, except for occasional visits to me.

It wouldn't be any different than Ricdorian.

At least that's the natural relationship.

"Let's check again."

The Schirmela Conference will be held over a total of three days. And at the end of the 3rd day, a small banquet is held, and they separate and disperse again.

After today, there were two days left. At least for Ricdorian, how to hand over Pudding completely without immediately showing that Pudding is his guardian deity.

So what should the first word be?

"Don't you want to raise the cat?"

When I said that, Ricdorian had an absurd look.

Yes, it must be embarrassing for a maid to say something like this in the first place.

Of course, I was also embarrassed. Because I didn't expect to see him right away.

I talked to Pudding and thought it was time to hand it over. But come to think of it, there is no way we can meet.

Marshmell thinks I'm here to get some air.

I'm a maid, so it's good to be inconspicuous, but instead there's restrictions on a maid's behavior.

After much deliberation, the next day, just in case, I went to the same place yesterday at the same time, and he was there.

Isn't that a miraculous coincidence?

If the Grand Duke liked this path, I would be very grateful.

"...I think I said I don't like cats."

He replied sullenly.

What kind of maid asks this, I'm glad he didn't ask that. What I have to say has become more difficult.

"Then you don't like animals?"

Pudding can be transformed, so I guess we just need to know the symbol.

"I don't like it. But why is the maid asking this?"

"...sorry."

Even if I change my position, he might be curious. The maid he met for the first time asked him if he wanted to raise a cat.

"Is it your master's question? Whose maid are you from?"

Oh my. The tricky question is back. I blamed my mouth for thoughtlessly trying to say Domulit.

"It's a secret."

Instead, I thought I was screwed for a moment while babbling nonsense.

"I was personally curious about cats."

What maid dares to treat the Grand Duke like this? This was the first time I was attacked headfirst... This is the level of female lead rudeness.

That's why people shouldn't do things they've never done before.

I had time for self-reflection as I felt Ricdorian's gaze rapidly cooled.

To be honest, I am also a victim, but am I not taking some kind of solidarity responsibility? That's what Chaser did.

I can't just let Ricdorian die, can I?

Pudding says Ricdorian has awakened alone, but I don't know if he had escaped from the rule that if he doesn't take Pudding back in three years, he might die.

Probably, I thought he wouldn't get away with it.

The so-called reality hit me and I let out a slow sigh without realizing it.

"I'm sorry for being rude, Grand Duke."

I bowed my back. Anyway, I have to fix it.

"Actually, there is a small gathering among the maids that followed the Grand Duke"

I remembered one of Uncle Paradis' old-fashioned advice. Most of them were advice about cheating.

"I am one of them, and I was so curious that I dared to forget my identity and be rude. Please forgive me."

Uncle said, people should hide among people.

In other words, don't make the other person feel weird by making my thoughts not mine but the thoughts of a lot of people. That's what I mean by this.

Actually, there is nothing wrong with that.

The term is a ‘follower’ but it’s actually a fan club. To be honest, I also like Ricdorian.

I especially liked his face, especially the crying face.

“...raise your head.”

As I listened with my head down, I thought that his voice had become very low.

I lifted my head and now I felt a very elevated gaze.

His legs are so long.

“What are you curious about?”

“....Yes?”

Instead of being immersed in emotion, I asked back in a bewildered way.

Seeing Ricdorian frowned, I hurriedly straightened my expression.

“Uh, sorry. Maybe I’m wrong.”

“I didn’t hear it.”

Ricdorian said, narrowing his eyes.

“Normally, I don’t have time to hang out with idle chatter, so just cut it short. I also have a question for you.”

“...for me?”

What does he mean he has a question for me. Even though I thought it would not be at that moment, my back shivered. I hope I wasn’t caught.

When I glanced down at Pudding, it didn’t even look at Ricdorian as it had decided to turn away from him.

“Are you a maid from another family?”

“Yes? Yes... that’s right.”

He looked lost in thought for some reason. The coolness. The most unsuitable thing for the former Ricdorian was hanging there.

After the innocent look disappeared, there was nothing but frosty cold. I didn’t feel it before, but the colors seemed to accentuate this atmosphere even more.

“And I don’t think we will ever meet again.”

The hesitation that had crossed his face was completely gone. Ricdorian tilted his head and swept his lips.

“Then... you do one.”

“...Yes? I’m sorry. I couldn’t hear you.”

I couldn’t hear it because it got too small in the middle. What did he say?

“...I said that if you give me one consultation, I will grant your request.”

His words were cut short. It doesn’t matter. Request? Is he talking about me?

“Are you talking about my request?”

“Yes, I think you have something you want from me.”

That was it.

“Yes, there is.”

“Yes, then let’s exchange.”

I accepted his offer, even though I thought it was strange. Because it was on my side that was in a hurry and he had nothing to lose.

By the way, what kind of advice would a Grand Duke ask of an unknown maid?

Maybe he was trying to kill secretly that even the rats and birds won't know. A misguided imagination ran wild next to Chaser.

"...But, what kind of consultation do I have to do? May I ask?"

If I'm curious, it's better to ask honestly. Was it too direct? However, Ricdorian was not in a bad mood.

Nodding his head slightly, he was silent for a moment. He seemed hesitant even though he suggested it.

"There is a person I know.... They left a question for me. I hope you can answer this question."

Well? I felt a sense of deja vu.

"I thought about it for years, but I couldn't come up with an answer."

"Why would I..."

"Because I feel the same way about you."

At that moment, Ricdorian's eyes changed. Sharpened and ferocious like a beast, his gaze quickly passed.

Before I could step back in surprise, his face was in front of me. Ricdorian put his head between my shoulder and neck without getting too close.

"...you definitely smell different, but why?"

Then he muttered languidly.

"Do you feel that way?"

Gulp. My throat fell. I didn't know what to say.

Did you notice? No. No. There was no sign of recognition in his eyes and face.

Angry, surprised, or embarrassed. Because I didn't feel that way at all.

'Your face has changed completely.'

So what did you mean by saying this?

"Why aren't you talking?"

Oh. I shrugged my shoulders.

I could see Ricdorian returning to his spot. That wouldn't be a bad thing. As I said this, he had an insignificant look.

"Oh, yes, yes. Good."

As he said, it wasn't bad for me.

I was just wondering. It's an honor, I added.

"Then I'll see you here tomorrow evening."

Ricdorian nodded vaguely as he spoke of the place and time.

We're not talking right now? As if he knew my thoughts.

Ricdorian added indifferently.

"It's time for the meeting."

Oh. Come to think of it, Marshmel was also talking about the meeting time.

Chaser will also be in the conference room at this time, so... I can go around at this hour

There was the little warlock who took good care of this and that, while pretending not to.

Thinking of Marshmel, I clasped my hands and raised my gaze with a smile.

Then I should go to Ricdorian as well.

I don't know why you keep staring at me.

The magic is working right now, right? Can you see my face, huh?

Chapter 148: I want to ask (1)

1. 1. I want to ask (1)

In order to send Ricdorian quickly, I wanted to give him a quick answer.

“All right.”

On the other hand, I wondered if Ricdorian would meet Chaser in the conference room. I heard that everyone had just arrived yesterday and had only a light dinner.

<The atmosphere was a mess.>

I also knew from Marshmel’s grumbling that Ricdorian was not present.

If this was Ricdorian’s territory, I thought it would be a bloody meeting in many ways.

Shaaaaa. As the wind blew, I smoothed my lower ears and dropped my head down.

If it’s me, because I just have to go back and do my job.

Meanwhile, Ricdorian’s feet moved slowly. It looked like he was going now.

It was at that moment that the cloak shook, and he paused as he turned around. Why did he look at me again half-turned?

“You.”

I was still not accustomed to watching the cold face.

“What’s your name?”

I blinked at Ricdorian’s question. Then I bowed my head and responded.

“It’s Veronica.”

Ricdorian looked slightly offended when he heard the name.

Because there was a wrinkle between his forehead.

Why did you look upset? I didn’t have time to ask him, who had disappeared without a trace.

Third day in Schirmela.

The time Ricdorian spoke of came much faster than expected.

<Lady, are you done with your walk?>

Marshmel looked at me locked in the room since noon yesterday and was puzzled, but on the other hand, he seemed satisfied.

I must have just gotten tired of it, of this face.

In fact, it happened often while studying with him. I showed interest in what he taught, but I quickly lost it.

In this way, I was no different than my teacher, who was short-spoken. Chaser also allowed it.

It was the first thing I asked for because it was a strange feeling to be called with such respect by a young child.

Anyway, today, I intervened among the maids and helped out. Just staying in the room made me a little sore.

Some people came to ask for help because there was not enough manpower.

“Oh my gosh, your fingertips are pretty good, kid.”

“Yes? Thank you.”

What I felt while working for a short time was that, surprisingly, the household chores were suitable for my aptitude.

Should I change jobs when I return?

With an absurd thought, I followed my colleague and got up from my seat.

We were folding a napkin for today’s party, and I’m going to move this napkin.

Still, it looked like it was going to be peaceful. Just when I thought of that.

Things happened.

Kuang!

Kyaa! One of the maids screamed a little. It was a scream that was cut in half as if she had struggled to endure it.

I widened my eyes at what was happening in front of me. Surprisingly, my heart was pounding.

It was a corridor across each other. From here, you could see the hallway over there.

And at the far end of the hallway I’m standing in, a dusty wind blows. While the wind subsides...

I saw a broken wall.

“Keeuuu...”

And beneath it was a man moaning. Upon closer inspection, it looked like a knight wearing silver armor as white as snow on his chest.

The moment I saw the rose carved on the armor, I swallowed a gulp.

It was also because I saw Ricdorian standing still over the dust.

And opposite him stood a man of a stature that could not be compared with him. It was impossible not to recognize the slim silhouette.

It was Chaser.

Chaser, who had been silent until now, smiled slightly.

“Oh my gosh, my mistake.”

He gently patted his black gloved hands. Looking at the face, it looked like so.

“My path is blocked by your subordinates. This was a bad occurrence.”

Not even with his hands, he tapped the heel of his shoe on the floor.

“You are raising a very loyal subordinate. Grand Duke.”

Ricdorian frowned and smiled. It was a chilly day.

“Bad occurrence?”

He shook his head from side to side, showing the momentum to run at any moment.

“Destroying the property of someone else’s mansion and catching a knight is a crude excuse for a bad occurrence.”

“Ah.”

Chaser grinned. It wasn’t a friendly smile like for me.

“You’d better keep the knights in check.”

His red eyes sank low as if relaxed.

“I’ll hear it from my knight.”

Ricdorian smiled wryly with a face like a saint at first glance, and then moved on with his steps.

It was that moment.

Kuang!

Ricdorian, who disappeared in an instant, appeared next to Chaser.

“Your knight is looking with disrespectful eyes, Duke. They must be educated.”

Ricdorian looks to the side, but then, “*Paak.*” A harsh sound was heard. At the same time, a man fell out.

The knight was like a bear.

Such a person flew away with one light flick of Ricdorian’s sword.

Ricdorian lowered his posture slightly and smiled.

“At the same time, dust is sitting on your shoulder. I thought it was an unnecessary shoulder, so I wouldn’t have tried to remove it.”

Ricdorian’s eyes looking at Chaser were like cold fire.

“It’s like an arm that only does useless things, so let me know when you no longer need it.”

Burning blue, but hotter than anything else.

“I’ll take it out of the world.”

Chaser faced each other leisurely in the thin distance that had blocked Ricdorian’s sword.

“I’m just grateful that you took care of my limbs. I almost misunderstood you.”

Even though his entourage had fallen out, Chaser’s voice was tolerant.

“Even a rat wouldn’t do this as a neat surprise attack, is it a rude greeting?.”

In addition, he was friendly as he was to his close friend.

“I have to do things quietly. Like the master of Schirmela who has changed without even a mouse or a bird knowing.”

Ricdorian only returned the ridicule.

“Funny. What’s wrong with showing mine?”

Neither side was going to back down.

‘Woah. It’s brutal.’

It was Chaser who made a sudden move in a tense situation with no retreat.

Chaser turned around, tapping his shoulder with a sly smile.

He turned..... he’s coming this way, right?

I wasn’t far from Chaser. My hurried movements here seemed to make me more noticeable.

‘Marshmel never said I would never stand out.’

If he were my master, I’d say he’s a terrible bastard. It’s a very overrated statement for Chaser, but some agree.

Glancing sideways, my fellow maid clasped her waist deeply.

The same was true of the people around them.

I hurriedly imitated their actions.

Step. Step.

Black shoes came into view.

The steps passing by were graceful and smooth.

Pass, pass, quick, quick.

A cold sweat ran down my back.

Stop.

Because the black shoes stopped when they finally passed me.

“Hmm.”

A familiar sound was heard above my head. My palms got wet.

‘I haven’t been able to hand over Pudding yet.’

The reason I was worried about getting caught was because I knew too well what was going on the moment I got caught.

It would be taken by force . And I may not even see Marshmel in the future, but that’s okay, as he can change it over time.

I couldn’t return Pudding, Ricdorian’s guardian deity.

An unfulfilled goal flashed before my eyes.

Meanwhile, Chaser stretched out his hand.

“Would you like to raise your head?”

It was a soft voice. However, the tone was not as friendly as it was to me.

Feeling the possibility here, I raised my head.

Then I stopped when looking at his chest.

“More.”

Chaser did not let me go.

“Raise it more.”

Finally, I swallowed my breath and lifted my head completely.

His eyes met with a gentle smile. The figure of a beast, hunting to its fullness and stretching contentedly, seemed to flutter behind him.

“Where do you belong?”

Without realizing it, I looked down at my clothes. There was no place who would be happy with this slightly grayish black suit.

<Oh, what should I do? I’m sorry!>

An hour ago. The maid, who was carrying a water bowl, made a mistake and got my clothes soaked, so I was borrowing clothes from this place.

That’s how lucky I was.

“As, as you can see...”

I stuttered on purpose, as if trembling. Chaser, it’s not me. Like a protest.

“Ah, belonging to Schirmela.”

Chaser also seemed to recognize at a glance.

From my point of view, the maid clothes worn by each family were similar, but I didn’t know how to recognize them.

“Hmm, that’s weird. It’s nice to see a strange woman.”

Chaser rubbed my chin with his fingertips.

“Do you have a lover?”

I glanced at the outstretched hand. Are you asking for my hand?

With hesitation, I gave my hand, Chaser kissed the back of my hand. It wasn't the way he left it on my fingertips as seriously as he usually did.

But even so, I had a strange feeling.

“Are you thinking of moving the mansion? Domulit is a good place.”

... Is he flirting with me now?

If I were a real Schirmela's maid, it wouldn't have worked.

Because Domulit's evil deeds were widely spread among the people.

“Oh dear, just kidding.”

Chaser said so and let go of my hand. I was relieved in my freed hand.

“But if you have any thoughts, tell my knights before the night is over.”

Chaser pulled up his red lips and tilted his head and whispered into my ear.

“It's okay if you come to my room directly.”

He only bowed his head, but everyone around here would have heard it. Because he didn't lower his voice at all.

Chapter 149: I want to ask (2)

1. 1. I want to ask (2)

Chaser just walked away.

As soon as Chaser walks away, a fellow maid raises her head and says ‘how are you doing!’ and patted my shoulder.

Her face was bright red.

“The Duke’s voice is so good. Oh my gosh.”

Her mouth didn’t know how to stop the babbling.

“I thought you weren’t interested in this kind of thing... Oh my oh my! Did you hear his voice a while ago? Hey, are you going already?”

“Ouch, ow, it hurts.”

Although it had been less than three hours since we met, she was an overly friendly person. It reminds me of Sally in prison... . It wasn’t bad in many ways either.

My shoulder was a little sore.

“Why! Duke Domulit is famous for not paying attention to women!”

That Chaser. Ironically, he never gave a glance to a woman even though he looked like everyone in the world would be captivated by him.

So many rumors were all about the other’s unrequited love for him. There were even men. It was obvious that he was debauched in the book, but it

was a very strange thing.

“What are you going to do? What are you going to do, huh?”

“Even if you ask me what to do...”

Tomorrow I’ll go back to Domulit. He was the man I would come back to.

Even so, the maid asked if there would be a rise in my status.

“Just.”

As what happened, I was about to say no, but I paused.

I felt a warm gaze. When I turned my head..... at the end of the hallway, a figure remained.

Ricdorian was watching this way.

Also with a very scary face.

“Where do you belong?”

I turned my head to the question.

There, in the dark night, a man was seen.

The silver hair fluttering in the wind was perfect for this night. Even the silver stars were like decorations for him.

I paused my answer for a moment and looked around.

It was a quiet garden with the sound of grasshoppers. How did time pass so quickly?

Oh right. After bringing the napkins, the maid’s job was over and I came back. Refusing the maids to have a drink with them off-duty.

And time passed quickly.

The time that Ricdorian asked to meet was quickly approaching. And the time he suggested was....

“Excuse me, is it okay if you don’t go to the party?”

It was time for the party to be in full swing.

Ricdorian glanced at me and spat out with a cold face.

“I think I asked first.”

For some reason, he felt colder than yesterday. He’s been cold the whole time since we reunited....

“Ah, sorry.”

“Your clothes were different between the two days.”

I don’t know why he made an appointment at this time, but as if he was planning to go to the party, he was dressed in nice clothing.

Huh, he’s really grown up.

I couldn’t hide my happy feeling as I looked at the shoulder line.

I hugged Pudding tightly in my arms. Today, Pudding, who looked like a gray cat, didn’t say anything. It was just a meaningless nyan.

“I am not affiliated with Schirmela. Today, my colleague accidentally spilled water, so I was lent clothes.”

I waved my sleeves.

Apparently, he was not the type to memorize maid clothes for each mansion like Chaser.

Even in the book, the two male protagonists are polar opposites.

If Chaser was good and focused on all kinds of dark tactics such as conspiracies, schemes, and power making, then this is the male protagonist, Ricdorian.

With his overwhelming and mighty strength, everything was pushed away like a bulldozer.

He actually had that much power.

Just by looking at the blow flying out of the blue today, I thought that he had become very similar to the book.

... So, have all the happy and ambiguous scenes in the prison passed?

I just had a weird idea. No. No. I quickly shook my head to erase the red imagination.

“So, where do you belong to?”

It was something I didn’t know why he was so obsessed with my affiliation from before. It’s hard to tell, but....

“...and what does it have to do with Chaser Louve Domulit?”

It’s because of the cold glare in his eyes... I think he’ll be able to understand.

What’s the relationship?

“I saw him for the first time today...”

It’s a brother and sister relationship, a relationship that is publicly known. The thought of trying to be honest is gone, and I don’t think I should not be dishonest.

And I wasn’t lying. At least it’s the first time he’s seen this face.

I responded blatantly.

“And it’s not difficult to tell the affiliation...”

I can’t tell you because I’m afraid your eyes will turn around if you find out.

“Didn’t I tell you that I was a maid of another family, and that we would never meet again?”

As it happened today, I realized that the conflict between Chaser and Ricdorian was more than I expected. I didn’t know if it was a joke.

“Therefore?”

Of course, it’s not that I didn’t know, but actually seeing it was a different feeling.

There is a hole in the wall and people are bleeding, just by looking at each other’s fiercely glaring eyes.

In particular, Chaser was not associated with the female protagonist. Unlike the original, he did not go to prison.

Even though the two were not related to the female protagonists, they were enemies. It’s a pretty deep grudge too.

“Since it was so, wouldn’t it be useless to tell you about my affiliation?”

Originally, Chaser would have gone to prison at least once for what Francia had caused. Maybe this is my fault for releasing Francia early.

Still, I’m really glad that Ricdorian was able to release the restraints.

“...Right.”

But I’m so sorry for him.

Because it was only later that I realized the possibility that I might have changed his fate for the worse.

It would have been impossible if Francia and Ricdorian hadn't met at all. I regretted it later.

Then, even if I sent Pudding, he would have died. This was also the reason why I came here with all sorts of effort.

I didn't want you to die. Even if this bothers Marshmel now.

When found out, even my freedom that was otherwise small would disappear altogether.

The night when the grass bugs buzz was romantic. However, when I was standing here, he and I did not talk about romance.

He would have realized the world as much as the sharpened lines. It was a pity that I couldn't see him in the prison at that time.

"Just ask me a question, that's it."

Tsk, Ricdorian laughed coldly. It was so beautiful that I couldn't take my eyes off it, but I knew it in the flickering light.

That his eyes are getting colder.

"How is it even like this?"

"Yes?"

He shook his head lightly.

"Yeah. It's so similar, I guess I can stop now."

Ricdorian took a step back, narrowing it down.

"Did you ask why I didn't go to the party a while ago?"

He continued without giving me a chance to answer.

“First, there will be my subordinates who will keep the mess even if I don’t go. Second, I still have to keep my place... but I’m desperately curious.”

The garden we were in was on the outskirts of the garden, so there was hardly any light. All we had was the bright light of the mansion behind him.

It was also possible to recognize the degree of his expression.

“I want an answer so desperately that I want to hold on to it even if it’s only a thread.”

His face, with his longing expression in his mouth, was shining as cold as ice. Excessively elegant appearance was poison to such a gentle atmosphere.

Because I couldn’t take my eyes off him.

“Then will you answer me?”

“...what kind of question?”

I asked calmly so as not to panic. His eyebrows twitched.

It seemed like he was hesitant to put it in his mouth.

“...if you broke your promise. What was the reason you didn’t keep your promise?”

“Yes?”

“If it were you.”

Ricdorian bit his lip and pulled it off.

“If it’s you, what do people like you think when they don’t keep their promises?”

Thud. I gripped my trembling heart. It seemed that the distance that was already close seemed too distant.

“Answer me. What did you think when you didn’t keep your promise?”

I hesitated and asked one thing.

“Well, by the way, can I ask you a question?”

“Say it.”

Is it okay for the maid to say something like this now?

“You said it was a question left by one person... I knew what kind of question it was. Who left it? Since I was asked to think about it.”

I licked my lips.

How do you think I can know the answer? I was standing close to the door just like when I was standing over the bars.

“For an honest answer.”

To grab the doorknob or not.

“...a woman.”

A woman? Is that all? I couldn’t judge based on that alone.

“A little more.”

“It’s someone I knew a while ago.”

“And?”

A hint of hesitation crossed Ricdorian’s face.

“Memories, it’s bittersweet. I want to See her in many ways.”

I replied with a long thought.

“Is this your first love?”

“What?”

It’s a person of the opposite sex, you met for a while, but you haven’t forgotten her for a long time, it’s bittersweet to remember, but you remember it nevertheless and want to see her.

Is it not?

“That.....”

Ricdorian’s gaze flickered for a moment. He briefly covered his face with his hands as if to cover the shaking.

The light that fell on his head flickered to and fro. Because he shook his head left and right once.

A moment later, when his hand fell, a certain emotion resurfaced on the small face that had disappeared between the large hands.

I opened my eyes wide.

Because the fever gradually rose as I saw the face.

“...you’re talking nonsense.”

He turned his head slightly, with his ears flushed.

“No.”

He muttered a little.

“It’s not like that.”

As if repeating to himself.

His voice was as cold as ice. It’s different from the blushing face

“...I hate her.”

This chapter was a rollercoaster of emotions! At first it was ‘aww Ricdorian’ and then it goes ‘whaaat Ricdorian!!’ ._.

Chapter 150: Ricdorian's Heart

1. Ricdorian's Heart

At this moment, I didn't know if I should be grateful or embarrassed for the bright light.

At the same time I realized I remember this man more clearly than I thought.

"I hate her."

The face of the man who murmured hatred turned red, reminiscent of a day in the prison.

A fun and peaceful time.

"I see."

I struggled to open my mouth. To be honest, I didn't really want to answer that.

This was Iana's answer, not as a stranger in a maid outfit. And I had no intention of bringing out the buried story again.

It's better to forget the lines you didn't catch and the roads you didn't take. Because it only calls for regret and pity. So I adapted well and lived.

His words rocked my indifference and caused a stir.

But now I couldn't help but reply to the man who was staring at me.

"If it were me... because you asked me to think it's me so I'll answer."

Yes, I would like you to listen to me thinking that it was Iana at the time wearing a maid's mask. I think I had a lot to talk about when I wanted to visit you.

Sorry. I've forgotten a lot in three years.

"I am selfish."

I raised my head.

"And shameless."

The blue eyes fluttered in the light.

"If I didn't keep my promise... I should've felt sorry? Just being selfish and brazen doesn't mean you don't feel sorry."

I felt Pudding's temperature in my arms, I touched Pudding's soft feet and let it go. It was fortunate that there was Pudding at this moment.

"But over time, I'd have forgotten. I had no choice but to say that."

I laughed a little.

"What if there's a situation, that person wouldn't know. As that person, I would have been a shameless and mean person who didn't keep my promises. I guess so."

That day I didn't leave you, I thought so. You're going to think of me now as shameless and mean.

Over time, I thought. I'd rather you just keep hating me. Then it will remain as a memory.

The only way to find out the truth was to dust the memories.

Despite my advice, Ricdorian eventually hated Chaser who killed his father.

"Then maybe I forgot."

“...”

“Forgetting, happiness... umm. I don’t know about happiness but I may have lived in peace.”

Grab. I glanced sideways at the sensation of being hit in my arm. Suddenly, Ricdorian grabbed my forearm.

It didn’t hurt. I just looked at the white hand that grabbed my clothes and thought for a moment.

The beast version of him caught me so well, I would say. While whining ‘kiing, kiing’.

“Forgot?”

Right.

...with a face like this now.

“I mean, if it would have been me, Grand Duke.”

I didn’t panic. Instead, I smiled softly. Pretending not to know whether he’s scouring my face or not.

“Did you have your answer?”

As I spoke while looking at his hands, his fingertips seemed to tremble once.

Then, without hesitation, he let go.

“....yes.”

When he raised his head, I saw a look of disapproval on his face. He covered his trembling eyes with the back of his hand for a moment.

The intensity of the light pouring down from behind has weakened. It looked like someone had turned off a light.

Deep blue eyes appeared between his fingers.

“It’s answered.”

He spit as if biting his lips.

“Very much.”

His voice was painful and cold as frost stinging.

“I don’t mean to believe it.”

I didn’t know that the temperature of the murmuring voice would change. I blinked at his words.

“It’s just a reference opinion...yes. That’s right.”

Ricdorian mumbled so softly, and then slowly tilted his head.

“If you forgot, it’s okay if you don’t let it be forgotten.”

The small voice that entered his mouth became less audible as he moved back. I only heard ‘If you forgot’.

The confused expression on his face gradually disappeared. He asked with a calm face.

“That’s the answer. So what do you want?”

He went straight to the point.

It wasn’t unusual because we had originally agreed to give and receive one by one.

I felt strange at this reaction. But what’s good is good.

I took a small sigh and took a step back. And I stretched out my arm as far as the step back.

“Didn’t I ask the Grand Duke if he likes cats?”

There was no time. I also had no intention of hiding the main point any more.

“I wish the Grand Duke would raise this cat.”

Ricdorian made a strange expression. It was an incomprehensible face.

“...it’s not difficult, but why?”

It was a face like ‘do you wish for this’. I smiled inside.

“It’s not that I won’t listen to it. It’s just a silly thing to say.”

“Yes, I felt it too.”

I glossed it over with laughter.

“I know it’s a rude and strange offer, but it’s urgent.”

Although Pudding was suddenly lifted, it did not cry and was quiet. It didn’t even talk to me.

It has been in this state since I faced Ricdorian yesterday. I think it was shocked, but I thought it would get better with time.

With affection, he stroked it with his thumb.

“It’s a cat that I love very much, but due to circumstances, I can’t keep it anymore.”

Anyway, I also knew that there were some nonsensical parts of what I was saying. One, it didn’t matter.

“I have to leave soon... I can’t find a place to live.”

After tonight, I won’t see you anymore. What if I look like a weird person in his head?

I literally started talking without filtering it.

“If I can get someone to raise it for me, it’s possible that I want them to have a lot of money and I like good-looking people. My cat loves to be in luxury.”

Ricdorian opened his mouth with a frown on his face.

“...Did you say you were my follower?”

“Yes, it is.”

It’s a word I just said out of the blue because I don’t have a word to replace ‘fan club’, but the tone is a bit strange.

“I accept the offer.”

Ricdorian pondered it, then continued.

“Then why don’t you come and raise it in my mansion?”

“What?”

After dropping the bomb, he looked nonchalant.

“Raise it yourself.”

....Yes?

“If it’s a cat you love so much, shouldn’t it go with you?”

No... If it was a real pet, I might be. No no. Wait a minute. It’s not that I don’t like Pudding... Isn’t this a bit too extreme a proposition?

“As you said, I’ll raise it. So I’ll take a look. But I can’t spend all my time.”

He was suddenly logical. He logically explained every side of it.

“I don’t know where you’re going, but it looks like you’re going to another family or another area? I’ll offer you better conditions than there.”

Why would you, holding on to a maid whom you didn’t know before a while ago?

Why are you suddenly saying something reasonable?

“I also need someone to take care of this cat. You do that.”

If I was actually going to take care of the cat, it was a very welcome offer. Yes, if it’s simply because the environment makes it impossible to raise it...

If it wasn’t for me being tied down. I couldn’t hide my awkward smile.

“Thank you for your words, but...”

“Why are you rejecting me?”

Ricdorian tilted his head.

“Chaser Louve Domulit would have offered the same thing.”

I paused.

Uh.... I thought he’d heard it, but I didn’t think he’d mention this. I already knew that his physical abilities were unusual.

“Of course, the duke’s intentions must have been different from mine.”

He even spoke out about Chaser. Very blatantly.

“I don’t make dirty offers.”

I have no time to answer. Because his head was tilted toward me.

“Or... Have you already accepted Domulit’s offer?”

As he got closer, he was immersed in the shadow. His face seemed to be engulfed in darkness for an instant.

“No!”

Startled, I shook my head. Why would I take that bastard’s proposal?

“If I had accepted it, I wouldn’t have been here with the Duke right now.”

Having said this up to this point, even Ricdorian seemed to agree.

“Anyway, I hope you will accept it. Since it is an animal you cherish so much, wouldn’t it be better to raise it yourself?”

Apparently, this person was suggesting it as a favor. It didn’t feel like the words were twisted like Chaser’s.

Thank you so much for your consideration....

I was about to say no once again, but suddenly Ricdorian’s pulled out one hand that was holding Pudding and brought it to his lips.

His lips brushed as if they were about to touch the back of my hand. No contact though. My back spread straight.

The ascetic and pure kiss evoked a rather strange imagination.

Because I already knew well what he did while holding my hand.

“I want you to accept it.”

He whispered softly. The clear voice in my memory was very low.

As if declaring that time has passed.

“Because I’m grateful to you.”

The way he greeted a maid like he would to a noble seemed to be a form of gratitude as he said. It was meant to be respectful.

Anyway, I'm very grateful for this kindness....

How to refuse. It was around the time that I went crazy thinking about escaping, which was less feasible, whether I would just throw Pudding in his arms and run away.

“And I don't like animals very much, but I try to give them affection...”

Ricdorian suddenly reached out and touched Pudding's head. Then he hardened his face.

Startle.

I felt Pudding's body tense up. As if the tension was contagious, I brought Pudding into my arms.

Ricdorian took a step back and was staring at me.

“You, what are you?”

Chapter 151: My Iana

1. 1. My Iana

... Why did things happen like this?

It was frustrating. The relaxed atmosphere from a little while ago was nowhere to be found.

Waaaaonggweeeonngg

Pudding suddenly cried for a long time.

– Hu, human!

Pudding called me urgently, but there was no time to answer.

Ricdorian had one hand on his sword.

“Who are you, why my power...”

Ricdorian muttered a little.

I wanted to answer that, but no words came out.

It must have been because a red light was glimmering in his hand.

When Chaser used his power, it turned black, and when Francia used her power, it turned white. Naturally, that would be Ricdorian’s power.

The problem was I couldn’t figure out why he was doing this. There was only vigilance in his dark blue eyes.

“Why do I feel my power in you?”

...me? Not from this cat? I clapped my lips. He must have been a little misunderstood. This is not the time, but we need to clear up the misunderstanding.

I didn't know where to start talking.

“Duke, you misunderstood something...”

“Misunderstood?”

Ricdorian's hand moved.

“You say I won't recognize my power? Are you deceiving me now?”

No, that's because you felt that power not from me, but from this cat.

“Where did you feel that power, think again.”

In the end, I put aside the introduction and get into the point.

“What?”

“Think about it.”

Ricdorian must have had contact with Francia. Then there was no way he could not have known about the guardian deity.

I don't know the circumstances that led to Ricdorian getting Pudding taken from his body.

Judging from the time period, he was very young, so he can't remember, I'm just guessing.

I didn't want to say that this is your guardian deity. As it's like giving him the answer.

‘Of course, all the time we’ve talked up to this point, it’s like his eyes are covered.’

I didn’t want to take my hands off his eyes.

“If you draw that sword, you will regret it.”

There was certainty in my voice. At the same time, I was smart enough to see the confusion creeping over him.

“I’m begging you, can you take it without asking any more questions?”

With the little bit of politeness that had remained, I even stopped pretending to be a maid.

“You promised. You’ll listen.”

Promise, the moment the word came out, his face became strange. He dropped his hand from the sword. The red light that rose like a haze had not been erased.

– Human, human! Listen to me, Nyan!

Pudding cried over and over again and scratched my wrist with its front paw. I’d like to hear it too, but look at the situation.

I flinched back. I don’t think it will be accepted easily like this. Now what?

....I really have no choice but to tell the truth.

The worries didn’t last long. It was time to face him after making a short decision.

I trembled.

Suddenly, a hand with a red haze bloomed right next to my cheek.

Touch, it was a hand that touched and fell very lightly.

One moment.

<Lady, do you know?>

Marshmell's words echoed behind.

<This magic works better than I thought, still. If you meet the Master, do not face him. Especially when the Master uses his strength.>

Why?

<Magic and roses are like water and oil in opposite directions.>

The reason he said was this: 'the rose basically has the ability to dispel magic.' And he warned.

<It will come undone.>

Shaaaaa.

A strong wind blew from behind. The wind that came behind me forced me to look.

I couldn't see in front because of the long hair that came loose all of a sudden, the hair that obscured my vision...

I saw that this fluttering hair was pink.

It was my original hair color.

'I'm caught.'

The moment I slowly removed my hair, I could see eyes that had grown as if torn in front of me.

Just in time, the last light that had lit us went out. It seemed that all the lights in the room had been turned off.

We met in darkness and silence. It was Ricdorian who broke the silence.

In the dark, only the vague expression and the jaw are barely visible. He opened and closed his lips.

An indescribable expression flashed across his face. It was like watching the seasons change.

In an instant, the temperature rose, and the seething gaze captured me eagerly and anxiously. He had an unbelievable face.

His mouth twitched a few times, as if he couldn't speak, and then he reached out his hand.

“Don't.”

Had it not been for the low voice, his hand would have touched my cheek.

I slowly pulled back my body.

As the hard thing touched my back, I could feel the familiar scent.

“Iana, found you.”

It was a thick scent that seduced people, and it was a scent that sometimes took one's mind drastically.

“You can't do this, Grand Duke.”

At the sound of the familiar voice, my back straightened. I could tell without looking.

It was Chaser.

“You're trying to touch mine.”

Ricdorian flinched at this.

He looked at me with his outstretched hand. His hand slowly clenched into a fist.

Ricdorian's gaze gradually faded away.

"... yours?"

He seemed to have lost his gaze to Chaser, but I could tell by looking down for a moment.

An unusual black light was emanating from the floor.

The distant music was heard from somewhere. It was light and elegant music that did not go with this atmosphere.

However, a pleasant dance song made this situation feel more foreign and tense.

Ricdorian shone his eyes fiercely in the tense air. This was not the time.

"Pudding!"

I called the cat I was holding a little. Pudding trembled.

I lifted Pudding and whispered as loudly as possible only to this cat.

"Go, come on!"

Now was the chance. The black light emanating from Chaser's feet was unusual.

As if something was about to happen, my senses sounded an alarm.

Besides, now that Chaser noticed me, it seemed like there would be no chance if it wasn't now. No. There will be none. The situation was urgent.

"Now is your chance, come on! Hurry!"

But for some reason the gray cat didn't budge. Rather, it grabbed my hand with its clawed foot. The claws caught on my sleeves and scratched my flesh. It seemed so urgent that I didn't even know it.

– No, no, Nyan!

No? I was perplexed.

-Why why... are you sending me?

Why am I sending...

That's because you're Ricdorian's guardian deity. If you don't go there, Ricdorian's life is in danger. You say he'll disappear too.

I still remember those words clearly. I couldn't figure out why he was being like this.

– No, human!

But Pudding desperately rubbed its paws against mine.

-The, the heir of the red rose doesn't need me anymore!

Pudding spit like that, but I couldn't believe it.

– Are you going to abandon me, Nyan... ?

Waaong, waaong, a cry was heard. I hesitated.

It wasn't what I intended with Pudding, but... I was weak to the sound of the beast's crying.

<*Kiing, kiiinnng, kiing! Keunngg..*>

To be precise, it was a habit that started with a boy who mimicked beasts.

-I, I... I won't go.

The beast clings to me, crying desperately. The silver-haired boy looked overlaid from the gray, or even silver-haired cat.

– A little more.... Stay with me more, stay with me human.

<Promise. Keep it... ?>

– Don't throw me away, Nyan.

I remembered a memory I never wanted to remember. I remember thinking that I buried it so I wouldn't take it out anymore.

– I don't want to go.

<Promise, you will keep it.>

The gaze that pretended to be confident, but trembled endlessly and looked at me anxiously.

“Iana!”

The crying boy was erased, and there, he who had become a full-grown man was shouting.

Red light and black light collided in front of me. *Rumble*. Chaser's beast, Aquala, spread its large wings.

“...do you really don't want to go?”

– I won't go, Nyan.

“Is Ric, the heir, really okay without you?”

It was not unusual for things to turn around. If it was okay, I could have picked it up like this and thrown it at Ricdorian.

Perhaps Pudding realized what I meant, Pudding was more anxiously clinging to me.

– It's true, Nyan. The heir doesn't need me, Nyan, I want to be with you, human, Nyan!

“...I won't forgive you if you say that and then get into trouble.”

Pudding probably didn't know what I meant by 'trouble'. It was the death of both. Pudding would disappear, but for me it was no different from death.

Pudding hesitated to answer, but said once again: no.

Then it buried its face completely in my arms.

-... Human, you were lonely.

I was lonely?

Meanwhile, the black light came up to my legs and wrapped around Chaser's feet.

I tried to move it as a test.

'My feet won't move.'

I looked at Ricdorian with a huge sword in one hand.

He looked at me frightened by my gaze.

"Do you have a hobby of kidnapping people?"

Ricdorian's eyes filled with hatred.

"Chaser, you... again."

"I think you misunderstood."

Pudding, unchanging from my hand, was lifted up and grabbed by Chaser. His fingertips touched his lips.

"This was from the beginning, Grand Duke."

Chaser pressed his lips.

"No way. This is. It's my Iana."

My Iana, Chaser put my name out. Instead of my usual nickname 'my sister'.

"...my Iana?"

Ricdorian's eyes created an earthquake so great that it could be recognized even in the dark.

It was a sad and incomprehensible gaze.

Ricdorian's lips moved slightly. Like he couldn't find anything to say.

For a moment he seemed confused, like a lost child. But soon, an outburst of raw feeling erupted from the orderly face.

"Why?"

Here I felt.

He was there 3 years ago.

A 17-year-old Ricdorian who must have waited anxiously for me on the day of his appointment.

I thought he hated me.

No, I thought he would hate me.

So I buried it. I thought you hated me.

"Don't go."

Note: I get teary eyed tling this chapter T.T

Chapter 152: Really Goodbye

1. 1. Really goodbye

A crying voice came from Ricdorian. He let go of his sword and stretched out his hand.

Chaser's black light left a scratch on his wrist, but he didn't care and stretched out his hand.

Crack, crackle...

The forcibly digging hand almost touched me. It was within reach if I stretched out a little.

"Take my hand, Iana!"

His fingertips touched me.

"Come with me... go with me."

If I hold on to him like this, I could catch Ricdorian.

"...you said we'd meet again."

He whispered as if crying. I looked at my legs without saying a word and then raised my head. The black light came up to the waist.

"I told you, Grand Duke."

I knocked out his hand.

"I'm selfish and shameless."

I'm sorry again. My legs still didn't move.

"I didn't mean to keep my promise to you."

Why is the timing always like this? Thinking about it, I can only come to one conclusion.

....I don't think we're meant to be.

I smiled a little.

I muttered a little with the shape of my mouth.

'I'm glad you're healthy.'

Did he see it? It didn't matter if he didn't see it.

'Good job.'

I gave a small compliment as I would to him a long time ago, who was rational or to him in the form of a beast.

'What a good boy.'

I'm glad you're okay. The fact that he awakened alone and safely climbed to the top as the Grand Duke, I was proud of what he achieved.

'But this time it's really good bye.'

But why is your last face shedding tears?

"Goodbye."

I don't think I'll ever forget about it after another three years. I think so.

There was no longer only sadness on his face that passed by for a moment.

"...do what your heart wants?"

Amidst the sorrow, I felt a sense of persistence enough to give me goosebumps.

Finally, his face completely disappeared from my sight.

— *Tweet, tweet, tweet*

I didn't like the sound of birds at first. To explain this, we have to go back in time, largely because in the previous world, we woke up to the sound of pigeons every morning.

However, the sound of birds in this world was as clear and cheerful as that of an oriole, unlike the dull and unpleasant sound of pigeons.

<... I like the sound of birds.>

So I casually said that.

That's all. The next day, Chaser rescued the clearest bird on the continent.

I said I didn't like the birds in the cage, so he made a bird's nest in the garden.

It's been 3 years since he made a nest like that.

From one day, the sound of birds became a clear alarm every morning, and it was then that Aquala appeared as a canary-like bird.

Tweet, tweet, tweet.

I rubbed my eyes as I listened to the clear sound. I couldn't wake up. When I opened my eyes properly, I saw a black canary.

“...Aquala.”

Aquila chirps when she hears me calling her name. She was a guardian deity whose hobby was to come to me as an alarm in the morning.

Outside the window, I could hear the clear sound of birds, like Aquala's chirping.

It's like 10 o'clock. Instead of trying to get up, I lifted the blanket.

'Why am I sleeping here?

Oh, I cried all night and fell asleep.

Pudding stuck to the inside of my thigh and was asleep. Pudding that rolled around my body looked like a cat with white, silvery fur, not gray.

I don't know why, but since it went to Schirmela, it's always been like a cat.

.... I think it might have noticed that I liked this side more.

Animals are quick-witted. Aquila in the form of a canary, too. They seem to act so much that I can't hate them.

Three days have passed since I met Ricdorian. If I could tell you what changed in three days, I sweated a lot to soothe Pudding that had been crying for three days...

"Good morning, Iana."

Then it must have been that there was one more crooked beast in my room.

"Did you sleep well?"

Sitting on the couch over there, elegantly cross-legged Chaser, is technically not a beast, but a primate.

If what you are doing is no different from that of an animal, then you are a beast.

"...Did you stay up all night in my room today?"

Chaser smiled silently. It would mean an affirmation.

It wasn't embarrassing. No, it wasn't embarrassing anymore and it was a familiar thing.

It's already been 3 days since this guy became this. To be precise, it was after returning from Schrimela where I met Ricdorian.

We shared the same room, but mine was too spacious. It would actually be nice that the villain gave it to his dear sister, whom he cherishes.

Even though we were in the same room, it was almost no different from any other space. He's so far away.

Perhaps he fell asleep on the sofa near the end of the room. He looks really messy, but because that guy did it, it became picturesque too.

On the first day, I thought it was some kind of sofa pictorial.

'I thought I was crazy. No, I'm already crazy.'

Of course, as I said, talking about sofa pictorials on the first day, and even I couldn't help but be surprised at this time.

In fact, if I go back to that day and recall, when I just came back to the mansion, I was completely frozen.

Because it was a situation where I couldn't help but be nervous.

I'm assuming the worst case will be being imprisoned more deeply here.

.... Ankle shackles and chain sets, what's next? My whole body is tied tight. Or maybe even like Rapunzel. While thinking so,

<You worked hard, Iana.>

However, contrary to expectations, Chaser said that, he also tapped my shoulder.

<Relax, my sister.>

The face talking looked very pleasant.

It was incomprehensible.

<But today I am also very tired. I don't think I can walk anymore.>

<Huh?>

The next moment, even when he fell on the sofa in my room and looked up at me from an elegant angle.

<Can I go take a break?>

When he asked that, I wondered what this man was thinking. What kind of nonsense is this? But with that thought, as the saying goes, this man overcame the awkwardness of his words with a bright face.

It was a temptation as if he had said something of 'Would you like to eat ramen?' Of course, I looked at this man with eyes wondering if he was crazy.

On the one hand, it was strange.

After that, he spent the night in my room, and he didn't say anything.

Why is it more frightening if the person doesn't say anything in a situation where he's supposed to get angry? It was just that.

He's not temperamental, and he doesn't even mention Ricdorian.

It was a strange outcome for me to have even thought of being locked up in a tower. At first, I decided to think that good things are good, but... I couldn't help but feel a little uncomfortable.

I wasn't the only one feeling this way.

It must have been the second day after returning to Domulit, Marshmell said, running back and forth.

It was a face tired of contemplation.

<It's because of the Lady!>

He said this, but I was relieved.

I was worried that I might not be able to see this person because he might have been found helping me.

I checked all ten of his limbs, especially his fingers and toes, to make sure he was okay, and Marshmel got angry when I asked if I would check it again.

It was our own way of reconciliation.

Anyway, Chaser didn't show his temper even to Marshmel who took me.

This made me and the little warlock even more terrified.

Ah. Correct. The fear of the little warlock, not me was truly terrifying. I was more concerned with anxiety rather than fear.

... I wonder if I can see this person for a long time.

<So, don't worry about it like that! When the lady says it, it's like a real deal!>

In any case, such a day of fear has passed and it is now.

Even this morning, I naturally took my gaze away from the man who was wandering around my room.

'Isn't there a sign of messiness even when someone wakes up from sleep?'

Aren't normal people a bit ugly when they wake up? The main characters in the book were the main characters, so there was no way they were ugly.

Even Ricdorian....

<Don't go.>

I thought about it and then stopped.

I clapped my lips.

Immediately, I shook my head.

'Let's not think about it.'

A low breath could be heard nearby. When I lifted my head, there was Chaser standing quietly within walking distance of me.

"Why?"

Why are you staring at people? If you have something to say, you don't say it.

"Just."

Chaser smoothed his ear for a moment and slowly blurred his words.

Water dripped from the tip of his head. I wondered where he went, did he wash his face?

Contrary to what I thought a while ago that there was no disheveled appearance, the black hair I saw up close was a little...

It was disheveled.

But even this is digested in a different way.

Are you sleeping without unbuttoning?

That's uncomfortable. Even today, his buttons were tied to the point of suffocation, creating a stoic atmosphere.

"...so you weren't angry?"

In response to Chaser's following question, I put on an expression that wanted to say something else.

Angry? Why me? Rather, isn't it supposed to be you.

"That's what I want to ask."

I tilted my head. I was about to speak, but Chaser's hands were faster than that.

Chaser took my hand that was holding my chin gently and spread my palm out.

Then he bowed his head, and naturally placed my hand on top of his head.

"Pat me."

"...why are you doing this all of a sudden?"

"But, you."

Chaser looked up at me, tilted his back for a while.

"You like this, don't you?"

Chaser narrowed his eyes conspicuously.

"Woof."

"..."

I held my breath, looking at the dripping hair and his face alternately.

And without hesitation, I pulled his hair out.

"Ouch, it hurts. It hurts."

"Don't talk nonsense."

I said no. We had a strange misunderstanding before. If I forget, he would bring a dog collar and related tools in the future. On the day he brought the whip, I could not bear it and threw it away.

Still, this human said I liked it and he smiled.

“You really like it, don’t you?”

Chapter 153: Changed (1)

1. 1. Changed (1)

“I said no.”

I brushed off my hands, wiping the water from his head.

Chaser grabbed my fingertips waving in the air. He brought my hand to his mouth and buried his lips.

“It’s still in my hands.”

He wiped the remaining water from my fingertips with his mouth. As I trembled at the soft touch, his red eyes were darkly folded in half.

“Can I do it?”

“No.”

“Well, this isn’t my cup of tea either.”

Chaser tilted his head.

“Then what would you like?”

I didn’t even get excited as I looked at the man who looked at me as if he had done a good job.

It’s as natural as breathing.

“I thought you would be mad. Iana.”

“Why?”

Chaser rubbed his cheek against my hand, adding without giving me time to speak.

“Because I was forced to bring you.”

Forced to bring me?

I remembered what happened at Schirmela three days ago.

“You want to go outside, don’t you? I interrupted that.”

It wasn’t a very *Chaser* word. However, the red eyes looking up at me again were full of doubts. Maybe he was hiding his plan.

“Aren’t you mad?”

“....no.”

“Why? I think you’re going to feel bad about being forcibly brought back.”

If it were normal, it would be.

I pulled my hand out of Chaser’s hand.

“I don’t. I don’t even want to.”

I clasped my hands, stretched them out, and whispered quietly.

“I know who you are.”

While Marshmel was so terrified, I felt sorry for him, but I didn’t think what would happen to me.

“I don’t do anything useless even if I say it.”

Chaser slightly curved his eyebrows at my indifferent reply.

It also had a friendly smile as if it had been like that for a while.

“If you were going to do anything to Marshmel, I might have stopped you...”

I know that this is not out of love.

“Ah,” he mumbled a little.

“Because you don’t want him to die?”

“.....”

“My dear sister, you always blocked my sword.”

Complaining and anger are of no use to a human who has already been turned away.

If I had been able to appeal to him emotionally, many of his former people would not have been taken into slavery in a distant coal mine.

He was a human who didn’t blink an eye even though I cried so much.

“It’s strange.”

Chaser’s face moved closer.

He stared intently into my face.

The red eyes might surprise you, but it wasn’t unfamiliar anymore.

“...I thought it was okay to be hated.”

Drop. Drops of water falling from him fell from the floor. Wet eyes stared at me.

“Maybe this is good.”

Chaser smiled for a moment and lowered his eyes. He pulled back soon.

“Now, I don’t want to.”

But as soon as he lifted it up, he bowed his head and grinned.

“I really want to ask.”

Looking at him, I brought out the question I had been holding back.

“I thought I was going to be tied up and sent to the tower somewhere this time.”

“I will not.”

He smiled playfully.

“I don’t want to be hated.”

The seriousness between us lasted less than a few minutes. This has always been what Chaser intended.

“And.”

Chaser bowed his head, removed my hand from his neck, kissed the inside of my wrist, and let it go.

When he lifted his head again, the glistening madness of the day passed as he smiled softly and tenderly.

“Because I’ll get rid of it.”

He said so in my ear. *Have a good day*, and whispered.

With the promise of coming back tomorrow afternoon. He said this, but he will appear tonight or early in the morning. To get a moment’s sleep.

I’m just going to say that it’s only hard on his body, but....

I stared at the door that Chaser had closed. Chewing on the words he left behind.

Get rid....

No way.

.....Is he talking about getting rid of Ricdorian?

“You’re still alive today.”

Hello, Mr. Marshmallow. The little warlock did not respond to my calm greeting, but frowned at the words that followed.

“I-that! I’ll say ! Don’t say it!”

As a child with plump cheeks, it wasn’t scary for him to get angry.

Instead, I walked over to his side, squatted at eye level, and grinned.

“It’s because I’m happy, happy. The joy of being able to see you today.”

“Kiik!”

“It’s a joke, joke.”

I knew he was already out of Chaser’s range. Even so, the little warlock was worried about it.

“Don’t worry too much.”

I let go of the joke and patted his slender shoulder.

In fact, I had both regret and gratitude. I was most worried about Marshmel when I returned because I thought we wouldn’t be found out.

It was also a substitute for this kind of regret to keep joking around.

“Don’t be too afraid. If you do, I’ll jump in front of that sword.

I said with a pat.

“I was going to do it when I came back.”

It didn’t happen though. Of course, the subject of that sword is Chaser.

“I’ll be ready to die. Don’t worry. I’ll save you.”

Marshmel put down the thesis he was reading and looked at me with a strange expression.

I tilted my head.

“why?”

“....Lady’s is. Even if you’re here, I don’t know.”

What do you mean? Who is full of affection and love like me? I handed it like a joke, and he came back saying that I had no conscience.

“By the way, please teach me that magic.”

I smiled moderately and brought out the main point. Marshmel had an unexpected face.

“You say you’re not interested in magic anymore?”

“The human heart is like a reed. Originally.”

Chaser taught me a lot. The subject of teaching, that is, the teacher, was Marshmel in front of me and taught me more than I expected.

The problem was that I didn’t really have the will to do anything.

Some of the things I quit about two years ago were black magic.

At that time, I quit so quickly, I don’t know, but there are many things that black magic can do more than I thought.

“I think I’ll become an archmage.”

“Lady, do you have a lifespan of about 240 years?”

“Why, is it possible if I can live until then?”

“Right.”

Contrary to commonly known magic, black magic was also related to work behind the scenes, secret things, and life research.

“Yes, it’s a joke, and my passion isn’t burning anymore. It’s just because of this friend.”

I picked up the cat that was in my hand. It has grown quite a bit since three years have passed, and now it is quite heavy.

“This...”

It looked different, but he seemed to recognize it at a glance.

“Is it the guardian deity of the unlucky rose?”

“That’s right.”

Marshmel was also aware of Pudding’s existence .The appearance of the snow leopard was so unique that there would have been no way of not knowing.

In addition, Marshmel seemed to know who brought Pudding and how. I didn’t tell him though.

Marshmel rolled his eyes. He tilted his head as if puzzled.

“Why did it look like this?”

“You mean the condition?”

I glanced at Pudding and shrugged.

“I don’t know.”

Pudding was quietly held by me without making a single cry. But the pointy eyes seemed full of dissatisfaction at a glance.

It seems that even that little warlock can see it.

“It’s the third day. It’s been like this.”

In fact, it has already been 3 days since Pudding was in this state. It’s been like that since the day I separated with Ricdorian.

Did he just do that? Weeping all night long, I thought it was some kind of lost person.

Even when I asked what was going on, I couldn’t hear a voice, only crying, so I had no way of knowing.

If it wanted to fall asleep, it dug into my arms and slept. In the morning, it was found between the legs or between the arms.

I put Pudding down on the desk and pinched it’s cheeks.

“Stop and talk.”

Pudding glared at me.

“How do I know if you don’t talk?”

After saying that, I hesitated a bit and then asked.

“Are you in pain?”

I would say nothing if it’s only been a day or two, but on the third day, I was a little worried.

Pudding’s bulging eyes seemed to slide down. Soon after, Pudding’s hand hit me hard.

It doesn't hurt.... The feeling was odd. Why am I hit?

-Really, are you worried about me, Nyang? That's right!

"Oh, it hurts. Then you think I'm really not worried, or am I faking?"

– Human, you have no affection! It does not exist!

"I'm always full of love and affection..."

"Not that."

Marshmel broke into the conversation. He probably won't hear Pudding's voice, and he wants to refute what I said.

– How can you throw away this body so easily, Nyan! Heartless! Ruthless! Cold blooded! Ummoral!

"...that would be immoral."

What did I do? I got a little embarrassed.

-If I didn't say no, you just... will you try to send me, Nyang?

As time passed, Pudding's vocabulary increased remarkably. It was still a child's voice, and it wasn't far from that level, but it was like a child growing up.

It's been three years since he's done such a thing.

And it wasn't just words. Unlike in the past, Pudding now understands emotions.

– You didn't even say goodbye?

Sometimes I felt like it was more sensitive than I am. Right, just like now.

For me, I was just being faithful to Pudding's words .

Three years ago, it told me that if it didn't return, Ricdorian might die, and Pudding would disappear. I didn't want Ricdorian to die, and I didn't want the cat to disappear.

But on the contrary, it seemed that my faithful efforts felt cold to Pudding.

Chapter 154: Changed (2)

1. 1. Changed (2)

Children are particularly sensitive to the emotions of adults. Because an adult is a child's whole world.

I wondered if this would apply to Pudding as well. The baby guardian deity who is separated from the body like a newborn in the world.

The first person it met... And if it's me who's trying to force it away.

I bit my lips tightly.

'How is it so similar?'

Obviously I was talking about Pudding, but why does my heart hurt? Without the fluttering grown-up silver hair.

"I'm sorry."

I was quick to admit and agree. When I apologized sincerely, Pudding sneaked up to me and rubbed its head. Then it licked my hand with its tongue.

-... that's good to know. Cherish this body... a little more. Nyang.

Pudding digs into me and whispers softly.

— I might disappear soon.

"What?"

I tried to bring it out in a hurry because it said something that could not be overlooked, but I missed the timing because Marshmel suddenly interrupted me.

“Then the black magic is for that guardian deity?”

“Yes? Oh, yes... I have something to ask you, and it’s like that.”

After answering that, he quickly turned his head. Then I whipped up Pudding and went to a corner of the room.

“What do you mean you might disappear?”

I whispered almost audibly only to Pudding. I glanced at Marshmel who looked at the paper again as if he was not interested.

It was an attitude that I was used to.

– Literally, Nyang....

Pudding held its feet together like a child scolded and hesitated.

“What, you. You definitely promised me? You said nothing would be wrong.”

The white cat flinched.

“When if you say that and get sick, I won’t forgive you.”

The beast’s blue eyes wandered aimlessly through the air, not knowing what to do.

– This, human. Are you mad, Nyang... ? The heir of the red rose will be safe, Nyang. It seemed like he didn’t need this body anymore.... Really Nyang!

“I didn’t just say that for Ricdorian.”

I said firmly.

“I need you to be safe, too. Pudding.”

Waaong waaongg waonng!

Pudding suddenly cried. However, I could not ask the reason for the crying.

Bugh. Because this beast suddenly jumped in head first and I got a strong shock from it.

Cough.... this cat.

– Human, human, human!

“Cough, why?”

-As expected, this great body is not wrong when it comes to human eyes, Nyang!

“Yeah... are you scolding me right now?”

It was not enough to hit my body, so it laughed out loud, this was ridiculous.

... Cats are all monsters.

“...the master or the beast.”

– What, Nyan?

“It’s nothing. What are you going to do? You bastard.”

I grabbed the hair and shook it wildly. Cute is still cute.

– That’s... nyang. This body thought hard, Nyan.

“Huh, did you think of a solution and made an accident?”

-Ahem, this body sees far ahead!

“It looks dark.”

As I glanced down, Pudding quickly straightened its posture. It's the attitude of pushing its stomach out and asking me to touch it.

– Hey, pet me first and calm down, human! Pet! Nyang!

.....I decided to pat it first and think.

Peace of mind came quickly.

After some time, I asked, “What's the method?”

-Human, let's make a contract with this body, Nyang!

“What?”

I removed my stroking hand. It wasn't something I immediately understood.

“What are you talking about?”

You say you are the guardian of the red rose?

When we talked with this meaning in mind, Pudding jumped to its feet.

– No one can do it, Nyang.

“I suppose so.”

-But human, I think you can do it.

Me? It sounded like an absurdly nonsensical story. Ricdorian was the successor of the red rose, and Pudding was a guardian deity for him. That common sense still didn't make sense.

– Don't you think you can do it, Nyan?

“Aside from the rebuttal... is there any evidence?”

Pudding seemed to contemplate for a moment with its mouth shut.

-Human, you have a strange soul. Nyang.

Pudding said it did not know why, it said it was its sense.

– So I think we can do it. Nyang.

I don't think there's anything wrong with the sense of a beast.

'Ah, is it because of the possession?'

This body was not originally mine. When Pudding says this, it makes sense... I mean, there's room for it anyway.

I counted quickly. The reason didn't matter. The most important thing is...

"I don't know what you mean... If you say that 'contract' or what, you won't disappear?"

I lowered my voice and whispered.

– Yes, Nyang.

I thought it must have some reason for its confident voice.

If so, I'm glad....

I'm a little hesitant. Is it right for me to keep taking Pudding like this?

If we sign a contract, we'll be together.

<... You said we'd meet again.>

The hand that was trying to stroke Pudding stopped involuntarily. My head was screaming that it's not good to accept, but....

Then this little guardian deity will disappear from the world.

I laughed a little.

It's so sad. I don't think I can erase your traces forever.

I closed my eyes and opened it again.

“Yeah, let's do it.”

Pudding stuck out its head at me and rubbed my hands. Surprisingly, that was the whole process of the contract.

Is it important to keep our mind tied?

-Human, now you can talk with me in your head, Nyang!

Really? Can you hear me?

– I hear you, Nyang!

It was real. It felt strange to talk with my head.

So, does Chaser communicate like this?

– It looks like so, Nyang!

Reading everything in my head, it's a bit like... Come to think of it, I didn't even think about it.

– Ah, human. And there must have been a rose print somewhere on your body! It's proof that you signed a contract with this body, Nyang!

.....what?

Don't tell me the color....

– It's a red rose, Nyang!

I hurriedly looked at my hands and arms.

I lifted my skirt and looked at my legs. But it was nowhere to be seen.

No, there is Marshmel over there, so I wanted to see it separately.

I took a short breath, huh, and slapped the cat's head.

“Tell me this quickly.”

It wasn't painful, but somehow, Pudding was dazed and cried.

That's why there is a saying that when you sign a contract, you should look at the contract and look again. It was my fault for not listening to the term beforehand, but... I hope I am not in the wrong place.

What would have happened if Chaser caught me without knowing it.

I decided to check it thoroughly while taking a shower.

I put Pudding down on the table and lay it out on the soft sofa. Marshmel looked at me, clicked his tongue and waved his hand.

The black light seemed to flutter around, and the blanket flew out of its own accord and covered the legs.

“What happened, Lady? It looks like you just lost your temper.”

“This cat touched my temper.”

“Do you have a temper to touch? The young lady has a high critical point, no, that's not it.”

Why are you treating people as Buddhas?

How can people not be angry?

We have to live efficiently.

Even if I get angry, I'm the only one who's tired of things for no use.

“I don’t have any temperament, it’s been screaming and nailing me.”

Outrageous.

“It was rummaging around my body earlier, and my skirt was lifted.”

Then Marshmel looked at Pudding a little pathetically. The guardian deity, who suddenly became a cat that played a prank, became angry.

– It’s unfair, Nyang!

Be quiet. Deceitful guardian. If I had known that I would get tattoos on my body, I would have been more careful.

Well. I would have done it eventually.

“Well, anyway, Sir Marshmel, can you teach me black magic?”

I was very upset that the contract was possible. What if it suddenly comes off?

I protested in my head that Pudding is not like that, but people always have to be prepared.

I tossed around the theory of guardian deity in my head, and to find a way to raise this guardian deity well.

“It’s not difficult to learn.”

Marshmel tilted his head.

“But, lady, Do you have time to learn?”

“Yes? Why?”

Marshmel said with his eyes wide open, as if he didn’t know.

“Because it’s the imperial banquet soon.”

“Oh, that.”

I closed my eyes and recalled the words I remember.

What was it, ah.

According to the laws of this country, Lords and Ladies over the age of 20 must attend at least one banquet held by the imperial family. And unconditionally, they have to participate in the debut party banquet for the first time....

Having thought of that, I quickly frowned.

“Can I go there?”

Before, I thought I was going to go, but now it’s unknown.

It must be so, didn’t I go to Shirmela and get into a big accident? From Chaser’s point of view.

He didn’t say anything, but I thought leaving could be going to be another thing.

“I think it would be difficult to make such an accident like that.”

“You can go.”

The following afternoon, the answer Chaser returned to me was that. It was a surprising answer.

I turned my back after taking measurements. The man who had just wrapped the tape measure backed away quietly.

“Am I really going?”

“Huh.”

Chaser was sitting cross-legged on a sofa not far away. He was comfortably wearing furry clothing on his shoulder, but it was a silhouette that was getting worse today.

It's really good for eye candy.

Thinking again I concentrated on Chaser's words.

"His Majesty's has ordered the participation of the former nobles. There is nothing we can do about it."

Chaser revealed a tone that was rarely difficult. He was genuinely in trouble, not exaggerating as usual.

"Especially because he pointed out our family."

As if to ask a similar question, I calmly asked a question.

"What did he say?"

"When will you bring out the precious jewel in your house?"

His Majesty the Emperor did?

Chapter 155: Changed (3)

1. 1. Changed (3)

I don't know who he was, but I wondered why he said that. He was a character who appeared and disappeared for a while in the book.

He did not have many appearances but instead I remembered that there were long episodes about 'her and her tiara'.

Maybe Francia, Ricdorian, and Chaser were all intertwined?

"That's funny."

Chaser tapped his chin and slowly wiped the smile from his red eyes.

"I can't believe he compared you to a jewel."

He turned to me with only his lips raised.

"Even if His Majesty the Emperor, he can't force me."

"But you are still listening, right?"

"Right."

Chaser smiled as he nodded.

It's not yet time for him to disobey the imperial family, adding stories.

"I'm in trouble if the imperial family raises the hand of the red rose in this matter."

I flinched at Chaser's honest reason. The moment I heard the red rose, I had no choice but to react.

"That way, there will be more swords to target Domulit..."

It was me who was in danger.

They will target the weak first.

"Why? Don't you want to go?"

Chaser stared at me tenaciously. Like someone looking for something. I shook my head.

"I don't think much about it."

However, his gaze did not fall. Rather, he smiled sweetly and opened his lips.

"I don't want to let you go."

An enchantingly dizzying tone melted in my ears.

"Is there something that bothers you?"

It was a word that gave a lot to think about, no, it did not hide its intentions.

I shook my head again.

"Nothing."

It was sincere. It's not that I didn't think of Ricdorian, but.... To be honest, I found out that it was just Schirmela's business.

This side and that side are more polar opposites than I can imagine, they are like water and oil.

In addition, Pudding, which was my only purpose, also returned to me. There was no more chance of bumping with Ricdorian.

... On the surface, it makes sense.

I swept my chest slightly.

Conscious of Chaser's gaze, I lowered my hand, pretending it was just a meaningless gesture.

Chaser smiled, and said 'really?' and didn't ask any more.

"That's why you were matching clothes?"

"It's just a matter of fact."

I looked at the fabric as if sick of it. Seeing it piled up like a mountain, I sighed. When will I look through all of that?

"...the house is overflowing with clothes."

Overflow. Really overflowing, It overflows and flows.

Besides, I didn't even wear a fancy dress. Isn't it natural when you only live in the mansion, when would you need it?

Thanks to that, the clothes he put together will be rolling around in my closet.

"I won't bother you for long. You can just measure and go back."

It was nice to hear that. But I don't even need the measuring.

"You don't even have to measure it."

Even if you just look at it with your own eyes, nothing has changed, but some things will change. However, Chaser showed a negative gesture to this word.

Rather, he walked up to me and, saying he was going to show me, carefully grabbed my wrist.

“You’ve gained a little more weight than before.”

“Really?”

I stared intently at my wrist. ... I don’t know?

I asked Pudding, just in case.

‘Am I fat?’

-Human, they say that humans gained weight because people like you, Nyang?

‘No. Has anything changed?’

-...change? This body doesn’t know, Nyang.

It couldn’t see it, but I could feel suspiciousness.

The beast that has stuck with me for three years without missing a single moment said it didn’t even know.

One of the maids took the measurements, and when I heard the measurements that came out, there was a little increase. In other words....

About 1/3? I heard that it takes at least 2kg to show a change in a person’s body.

I was stunned.

‘No, how did he know this?’

Chaser smirked. *Am I right?* It seems he wanted to say this.

“How do you know this?”

“I’m attentive.”

Attentiveness that freezes to death. I muttered to myself, thinking that one more madman achievement had been added.

“I wonder if it’s something to be thankful for to His Majesty the Emperor. I’m thinking about it.”

“Why all of a sudden?”

“Didn’t he give me a chance to show you off to the whole world?”

I stared at him with cold eyes. Seriously, if you look at him like this, he only look like a stupid little sister fan.

No, do you know what kind of crazy person there is under the guise of that smirk? Even more absurd.

“Lady, what kind of dress do you like?”

I said I didn’t need to be there, but the maids surrounded me and asked if I needed something of my taste.

Among the faces, the person who asked this question had a familiar face.

‘Was it Veronica?’

She was the maid who spoke to me on the day of a funeral not long ago, and also the one who I borrowed her name from at Schirmmela.

“Something comfortable.”

I answered firmly.

“Then the color is...”

“Something comfortable.”

“...Uh, the shape...”

“Very comfortable.”

“Any opinions on decorations or lace....”

“Um... is it comfortable?”

Veronica made a troubled face for a moment. sorry. But I really don't want it to be uncomfortable.

I must have been accustomed to the comfortable life of the mansion. Except for the shackles, it's a life where you don't need to lift a hand.

“...can't I just wear something like brother?”

“Me?”

“Give me a pair of uniform pants.”

“Hmm, that's not too bad. Uniforms can only be worn by knights, Iana.”

“Really?”

“What can I do to make a suggestion this time? The uniforms of the young ladies....”

“It's fine.”

Chaser was not a knight, but a duke, a title that included knighthood. So he's going to be himself.

In the end, I tried to compromise as much as possible.

“Then let's take it in the form of a chemise like this.”

Perhaps the dress that will come out in the future looks like Juliet's dress from the movie <Romeo and Juliet>. That was what the draft looked like.

Veronica, who served me by my side, showed a polite yet sometimes helpless face.

I glanced at her and turned my head away.

“Brother.”

I pointed my finger underneath.

“Please remove the shackles.”

At that moment, a dead silence fell in the room. There were also people who were holding their breath.

“Why?”

Chaser asked slowly.

“It draws attention too much. I want them to stop looking at this.”

Then, for a moment, a strange expression flashed across Chaser’s face. It was a feeling that was difficult for me to describe.

“I’d rather you change it to something else.”

I made a suggestion while tilting my head. I didn’t think Chaser would stop the monitoring.

“We’re going to the imperial banquet anyway.”

Chaser nodded his head after a brief silence.

“...okay.”

Chaser looks at me with a friendly yet slightly foreign eye.

“I guess Iana doesn’t like attracting attention, either.”

.... either? It was a big deal. So he doesn’t like attracting attention himself either? Because he looks like that?

I was surprised that the story of the shackles had been accepted with pleasure, but on the other hand it was uncomfortable.

<... *Human, you were lonely.*>

Veronica or Pudding, the gazes I saw. I'm really fine.

Why do they see it that way?

Rather, it was both happy and strange going to the royal banquet.

Why, when I try to move away from you, I feel like I'm getting closer again.

The day of matching the dress like that was over.

That night.

When I returned to my room, I lay down on the bed, exhausted. He said that I could step down, but in the end, time passed by while I was making a choice.

I should be able to turn away from the eyes of the maids who look at me like a chihuahua.

They seemed to be burdened to leave Chaser behind, and whenever Chaser's gaze could not be felt, they sent an anxious gaze.

After spending so much time, now.

Pudding tapped me with its front paw.

It bothered me so I left it alone, but this time it pressed me firmly.

– This, human, are you dead! Nyang!

“I'm not dead...”

Then, as if relieved, Pudding relaxed its feet, and this time started kneading with both of its front paws.

I laughed bitterly. This cute message, which doesn't even look like a message, then a knock was heard and the door opened.

It was Chaser who brought a lot of luggage.

“What are you doing at this hour?”

I said this, but in fact, it was no wonder that Chaser appeared at any time of the day.

‘What is that?’

He put the luggage down in the corner of the room, and then opened the box. It was like he was trying to show me something. A box that contained something. It looks like a frame, a few pieces of parchment, and what appeared to be a blackboard.

“What is that?”

“...something you used a long time ago.”

Chaser replied softly. I felt incomprehensible. Something I used a long time ago? That's weird. It must be a long time ago....

“Before I go to Kambrakam?”

“That's right.”

No, why are you giving it to me now? Is there anything left?

“Why are you giving it to me?”

It was strange that he suddenly appeared and said this. The only thing that came into my head in this spacious room was the things in the box and my doubts.

“...you said it was burnt.”

I muttered a little. I must have told him that in the past, didn't I?

<All the previous items were burnt out, so I had to bring new ones.>

<Yes. There was a fire in the place where you lived.>

Why are the things I said so still there? If so, why are you giving it to me now? Chaser made a strange face.

<Why is there a fire?>

<I know.>

<“There are too many strange people in the world.”>

Seeing him not answering, my doubts deepened.

He was never one to withhold answers. It was the first time he had ever been so awkwardly silent like this.

He licked his lips.

“I... think I can tell you now?”

What? The air subsided even more as his silence continued again. His expression was dramatic. He had a sad look on his face with a maddening look, and a bitter smile passed by.

-Human, the black rose is strange, Nyang.

Even the quiet pudding sneaked in and said a word.

“What are you telling me?”

If I had to put it in one word, it would be like a person who has undergone a major change of heart.

“Actually there is...”

Chapter 156: Blue Rose

1. 1. Blue Rose

Chaser's change of heart was as foreign as water and oil. It would be more believable to say that Pudding will be a great eagle tomorrow.

However, Chaser did not open his mouth in the end.

It ended with a sting.

“No, rest. Iana. I think it will take a little more time.”

He spoke his words at will, hesitated, judged, and then went out. Before he left, he said a word.

“The rest of the items have been inspected. There will be no magical spells, no poison, no traps.”

With those words, the door closed.

Why did he look bitter from the back?

It was the lightest exit I saw in four years.

— The Black Rose is very strange, Nyang.

“I know... did he have an upset stomach?”

If I didn't turn my words around for nothing, the heavy air left behind by Chaser would suffocate me.

What. He shouldn't have just set the mood and left.

My gaze rested on the box he left behind.

First, I squatted down to take a look.

What was in the box was a few things. Something caught my eye among the things.

-Human, what is it, Nyan?

“Well..... A blackboard?”

I’m trying to express it as a blackboard here too.

It was a small blackboard with nothing written on it.

‘I can’t see the chalk.’

Only one blackboard? I looked back and forth.

On the back of the blackboard, a crooked rose is drawn, as if it was drawn by hand. There were also hollow grooves. I put my finger in it and it just fit.

Blue.

[Iana Rose Domulit.]

This is what Iana had before. ‘Iana’ had sloppy handwriting as if it was bad handwriting. It was in contrast to Chaser, who had a neat handwriting.

Hmm, did I use it while studying? It was when I thought about it insignificantly and put it down.

-Human, that seems a bit strange, Nyang.

“What? Chaser said there was no sign of magic? Poison or something.”

— No, it’s not....

Pudding hit me with its front paw.

-Writings are appearing, Nyang.

What? I hurriedly looked at the blackboard again. Indeed, as Pudding said, there was a faint light on the blackboard and there were letters that I could not see.

No, it was written down.

[“This is not a diary.”]

It was the same typeface as the name written on it. It was bad handwriting, but it wasn’t difficult to recognize.

[“It’s just a simple record.”]

... what’s this?

Without realizing it, I looked at Pudding.

The small cat tilted its head as if it itself didn’t know.

– Human, human. I feel a strange power here.

“A strange power?”

-It’s weird.... When there was the Black Rose, I didn’t feel it at all, Nyang. It is the power of roses.

Even Pudding, who said so, didn’t seem confident in its own words.

“...the power of the rose. Is it Chaser’s?”

No, he said it’s ‘Iana’'s....

– It’s not the power of the Black Rose. Totally different.

“What?”

Surprised, my hand slipped.

My finger tapped and hit the blackboard.

[“I’m going to hide this so no one can see it.”]

What. The text was erased and a new one was written.

“What’s this....”

I pressed it again as a test. When it finished writing, I tapped again, and another text was written.

[“Don’t let brother see it either. No, brother already knows. Does it matter? Because I love my brother? Although my brother wasn’t like that.”]

Except for the handwriting, it felt similar to a touch screen of the previous world.

[“Why didn’t you accept my love? We are strangers.”]

And I couldn’t keep up with the shocking facts that followed.

[“I have picked out only the facts from the life I have lived.”]

....Can I really see this?

Why did Chaser give this to me?

With a face that was so hesitant, not matching his arrogant disposition.

I hesitated, then tapped the blackboard again.

[“I am Iana Rose Domulit. But I am adopted. I mean, there was no blood, but everyone needed me.”]

I opened my eyes wide at the words that came out.

[“I am the Blue Rose.”]

The day of the Imperial Banquet has come.

It was exactly the day before. We have to depart in half a day to get to the Imperial Palace.

They say they offer fancy accommodation, but I'm not interested in that.

I looked ahead and declared firmly.

"I won't ride it."

Then the people around me flinched and looked at me. Among them was Veronica, who was designated as my maid.

"Don't you like it?"

Would I like it? I looked at the carriage with cold eyes.

.... A carriage led by 20 horses appeared. In the prison I had heard the story, but I didn't expect it to look like this.

I can't ride it because it's flashy. This is abuse for horses.

"You're so mean. My sister. I prepared it for a whole month for you."

"It's not a month."

"...one week?"

It sounds like a week. A person who can build such a carriage overnight with one gesture.

Chaser lowered his eyes, revealing a sullen face. It didn't work for me.

Instead, I spoke indifferently.

"...Brother, did you prepare another carriage?"

Then the sullen face smiled sweetly as if it had never been.

He took my hand and kissed it softly.

“My sister, every time you react as if you know me well, I’m in trouble.”

He buried his face in my hands and murmured.

“It’s love, isn’t it?”

Well. Is it true that the frog observing the snake is called affection?

I didn’t have to speak out.

The more this happens, the more I want to push him away, even if I am indifferent.

I closed my eyes and kept silent.

We arrived quickly at the Imperial Palace.

At sunset, when we arrived, a large number of people came out to greet us.

It was truly a landscape that showed the prestige of Duke Domulit.

At the same time, I was seized with the feeling that I was finally out on the right track.

Inside the palace, the maid of the palace was in charge of guiding the way and led me to my room.

For some reason, Chaser was with me on the way to my room.

I stopped walking and stared at him. He quickly noticed my gaze.

As if all his attention was focused only on me.

“Iana?”

“Brother.”

We both called each other at the same time, but Chaser was silent. He was telling me to talk first.

“What are the things you gave me? You said I used them before.”

“Ah.”

Chaser grinned.

“I was cleaning out the mansion’s warehouse, and it came out. I thought it would be nice to return it to you.”

“...after four years?”

I flapped my lips. There were so many things I wanted to say. But one thing had to be checked first.

Did Chaser know the hidden function on the chalkboard?

“You know, Domulit’s mansion is very spacious. It looks like someone put it there and then forgot it.”

It was a bit of a coincidence, but....

“There was a small blackboard there.”

“Blackboard? Ah.”

I looked carefully at his face.

“I see you’re talking about what you used to carry with you. You cherished it quite a bit.”

Chaser clenched his chin and rolled his eyes slightly.

“You’re the one who doesn’t show it to me.”

Just looking at it, Chaser knew nothing from his face.

“After all of your things were burned, it came into my hands. I wondered why you did this because it was a blank blackboard...”

It looked that way on the outside, but on the inside, you don’t know what it’s like.

I’m not good at fighting with brains, and I’m not even good or have talent. Most of the time, I tend to ask and answer questions honestly.

However, I gave up asking any more and turned my head. It required a lot of conversation. It won’t be too late to go back and see it again.

I’m a little tired of the long carriage trip.

“But why is brother accompanying me on the way to my room?”

Chaser bent his eyes.

“Escort.”

The maid seemed to be looking at us. For a moment, she blushed as she looked at Chaser, then skillfully regained her color.

I was reminded of his abilities. It doesn’t work for me, and for some reason, it was almost never used in front of me.

It was also a rare opportunity to see it in action.

“The Imperial Palace banquet starts tomorrow evening.”

“Huh.”

This was already known from Marshmel. Other than that, I was just hearing about all the approximate schedules.

“Originally, we gather four days before the start of the banquet and have lunch and tea parties during the day, or gather and hold a hunting party. You’re free to attend... Most of them participate. Whether it’s a lady or lord.”

I was tired, but listened carefully to Chaser's explanation. Since I had come to an unfamiliar place, it seemed like it would be good to keep listening carefully.

"You mean I have to do it too?"

"No. It's the other way around."

Just then, the maid stopped her steps. At the same time we also stopped. Chaser leaned his back and whispered a little to me.

"You don't have to do anything."

He stood still, took my hand, and left a friendly greeting on the back of my hand.

"You don't like being bothered or tired, don't you?"

I wondered if it was really for me, but... what good is good, I smiled.

"You know me well."

It was also correct.

"Everyone is very interested in my sister who has been to Kambrakam."

"Then who gave such an achievement?"

It's a prison experience. It wasn't ordinary. Once again, my time has come again.

"Then, my sister, see you later."

Chaser only went back after confirming that I had entered the room. It didn't seem like he was going to come all the way here and spend the night in my room.

I heard he was right next to my room. I also wondered why he had to take me here.

However, each room was very large, so it was like using the entire hallway.

“All of the corridors at the east end are the spaces given down to the Duchy of Domulit. Please feel free to use them.”

The maid bowed her head deeply after explaining the room.

Chapter 157: Choose a Partner

1. 1. Choose a Partner

The maids of Domulit's mansion couldn't completely hide their curiosity when they first saw me, but I didn't see anything like that here.

Is it because they're professionals?

"In addition, the east and west end spaces are only for the most valuable VIPs, so we will do our best to alleviate other concerns about convenience and security."

East and west ends? I asked without hesitation.

"Who stays at the west end?"

The maid shrugged her eyes for some reason, and then she quickly looked down. She seemed a little hesitant, but she continued.

"... Grand Duke Hernim uses it."

I paused. My gaze turned to the window.

"Have he arrived?"

"Yes, he has arrived."

The Imperial Palace, close to the shape of a crescent moon, here, we could see the west end from the window at the east end.

But it was so big that it seemed so far away.

‘Not as much as cities to cities.’

You can be indifferent when you are away from one city and the other.

I closed my eyes tightly and opened it.

“Thank you for the guidance.”

Ricdorian, how much did you know about me by now?

The Domulit that Chaser called Iana.

Thinking that far, I moved on. Then I knocked on the door in front of Chaser’s room.

“Brother.”

As soon as I entered the room, he appeared. He did not hide his unexpected expression.

He soon smiled sweetly.

“It’s an honor that you came to me. My sister.”

“I have something to talk about.”

I clenched my fists, opened them, and exhaled a little.

...I wonder if I even need to do this.

“Brother and I are siblings, but we don’t look alike at all.”

He had a somewhat startled face, but soon nodded his head.

“There is no similarity in hair color, eye color, facial features.”

“Really?”

It was. Chaser and Iana didn't look too alike to be siblings. Appearance and subtlety.

It was deceptive to say that we were brothers and sisters. Knowing this, I was silent.

Chaser's face tilted as if it was funny.

"So, my sister, what do you want to say?"

Rather, he emphasized by saying 'my sister' in a sweet voice that seemed to melt.

"I wish I had the same hair color as you."

I remembered the banquet specifications I heard from Marshmel.

"At least let people believe we're siblings."

It was the 'Masked Ball'.

"Change the eyes too."

"It's not difficult."

He crossed his arms and stretched out his long legs. His toes wiggled playfully.

"Then you're only showing this to me?"

As if he was about to change his clothes, he was loosely unbuttoned.

His hair was also swaying softly near his forehead.

It wasn't the usual ascetic duke, he looked like the prodigal youngest son of a wealthy family.

"I don't know why, but I think it's good for me too, so I'll cooperate, Iana."

This started in the sense that all debutants are equal, and it ends by taking off the mask.

It does not matter. I can leave before I take off my mask.

I realized. I don't want to see Ricdorian again.

I don't want to see him face the truth. Whether suffering or looking at me with hatred.

Even if I'm sad, I don't think I want to see you. I was afraid to face you. It was an honest feeling.

"I don't want to be caught in anyone else's eyes...."

"..."

"You can come back anytime, Iana."

The rose and the main character in the book. And again, roses. It was this man's thick scent that deeply penetrated through the shattered and mixed thoughts in my head.

On the day of the imperial banquet.

Dinner came quickly. After all, the only thing I did all day was to lay around in my room, so the time passed really fast.

But if there was any time to be free, there wasn't.

It was because I was busy preparing with the maids who have been busy since morning.

The maids who came together from Domulit were active, not hiding their excitement unlike usual.

'These people have been overwhelmed by Chaser....'

I just felt sad for no reason.

“Lady, do you like it?”

In the eight-hour long stretch, I felt like I was going to faint, but instead of making it obvious, I smiled.

“Yes. I like it.”

It wasn't that it's not pretty. I was quite surprised to see myself in the mirror.

Damn, is this really me? I wanted to say it, but I didn't.

“It's a comfortable garment that the lady wanted. It is said that it was made with maximum convenience in mind.”

The finished dress looks like the red Juliet dress from the movie <Romeo and Juliet> and

was similar. Still, the white fabric looked elegant.

“It is said that the chemise form was mixed with other clothing forms.”

“Yes, I like it.”

I gave a smile to the one who explained and those who looked at me. Eventually, while looking proudly at the happy expression on their faces.

The maids left a scarf made of muslin and then disappeared. Marshmel came in as if crossing them.

The cloaked little warlock couldn't keep his mouth shut.

“Wow, clothes are wings.”

“Thank you. It's nice because it's comfortable.”

“It's not comfortable, like a lady.”

Marshmel toddled towards me. Soon after, as he heard from Chaser, he immediately cast a spell on me.

“Where do you want the magic to go?”

“Well.”

Casting the magic is not the end, you have to choose a medium to hold the magic on. I looked at the accessories and chose one indifferently.

“That.”

It was a mask.

“...Aren't you going to take your mask off at the banquet?”

“I'll go before that.”

Marshmel gave a bizarre look, but then he agreed, saying, *well, it doesn't matter.*

“If it happens again, tell the master not to use the power of the rose.”

“Is it going to go away?”

“Yes.”

Is there anything in the Imperial Palace Banquet to fight for? I nodded indifferently.

“If you come later, I'll be there too. Don't worry.”

“Oh, Marshmel, will you be there too? That's great.”

Marshmel cast a spell and went back. When it was time to attend, someone knocked on the door.

I wondered if it was the royal servant, but an unexpected person greeted me.

“Miss Iana.”

It was Lenag.

“Iana.”

Chaser was also next to him.

I didn't even have time to be happy with the face I haven't seen in a long time. It was crazy to look at Lenag, who politely said hello, and Chaser, who leaned against the door.

....seeing the villains in the book all at once makes me feel very strange.

I hugged Pudding in my arms tightly. Then I turned around.

-Human, but why? Nyang. You want this body to come in?

‘Now that you're three years old’, I whispered to Pudding, who became aware.

‘Yes, come in for a second.’

I forgot to say iy, but after contracting with Pudding, I learned two things.

One was that Pudding's appearance can become translucent, and it was able to go back and forth with having a real body. It made itself invisible and was able to pursue me.

I found out shortly after signing the contract.

Another one... It said it found a mark on my body.

‘It was on the inside of the left thigh, maybe?’

It's a good place to not be seen in the eyes of others, but it's a strange feeling. It's a mark on my thigh.

It is also a red rose like that of Ricdorian's.

I shook my head, grasping all the cloudy feelings.

However, the atmosphere in front of me was not so serious.

Come to think of it, wasn't Lenag my fiancée?

From what I heard, it sounds like there was some kind of deal with Chaser, but the fiancée was right.

I thought of this because I remembered the nature of this ball.

'Ah.... I forgot for a moment that it was a party that needed a partner.'

From what I've heard, it sounds like they're talking about something similar.

"Miss Iana needs a partner."

"Who said that?"

"The duke doesn't seem to feel the need. Isn't it?"

"No way."

My eyes moved back and forth between the two men talking like ping-pong.

"I'm here to do my part. Duke."

"You seem to forget your title sometimes. Marquis."

"A higher position does not necessarily bring glory. If you hold your hand, how many nasty men, no, Lords will appear?"

"What can I do when I'm good at this? And I'll be by her side."

I think I heard it wrong for a moment, but it seems like there was a lot of swearing.

Chaser folded his arms and tilted his head.

“I’m going to be by her side without ever leaving.”

Before I knew it, I put on the mask and watched their fight in earnest.

I had long lost interest.

‘...why are they fighting?’

Perhaps I was the only one who thought this way, an innocent voice echoed in my head.

-Human, why are those humans fighting? Nyang.

‘I do not know. I guess they like to fight.’

Let’s leave them alone.

“So, who will be with my sister?”

Finally sparks flew at me.

I blinked my eyes bewildered.

“What?”

“Your partner.”

Partner.... They say that they only stay together when they enter, and when they go in, then go separately. Marshmel wanted to say this, but I couldn’t do it because of the two persistent gazes from both sides.

Soon, I opened my mouth reluctantly.

“Anyone is fine.”

Seriously, it didn’t matter who it was. Disappointment flashed across Lenag’s face then.

Chaser gave a deep smile.

Gently holding my hand, with a smiley voice.

“You have to choose me here.”

His thumb gently stroked the palm of my hand. He tickled me and whispered softly into my ear.

“I’m sad, huh? Do I have to bark so you’ll choose me?”

“Bark, what?”

“Woof.”

Chaser took my hand and placed it on his cravat.

“I can wear the necklace right now.”

Chapter 158: Lenag's Sincerity (1)

1. 1. Lenag's Sincerity (1)

... I was able to bet ten months of Pudding's snacks on the fact that this necklace was the dog collar I threw away.

What is this crazy man talking about now?

“What are you doing?”

But Chaser slipped his lips into my palm.

“Woof.”

I couldn't stand the strangely curved eyes and opened my mouth.

“Crazy!”

However, it did not end here.

Lenag, who had been watching silently, suddenly intervened. He still had his hair loosely tied with a cold, sharp face today.

“Miss Iana.”

Hesitation crossed his face.

“...can I bark too?”

“Are you insane?”

Lenag flinched for a moment, then slowly lowered his head.

“Because it seems like the Duke is doing...”

“My brother is the one who’s weird.”

“That’s too mean, Iana.”

You stay still.

“I’m well aware of Miss Iana’s tastes.”

Even now, four years later, this man had a huge misunderstanding.

But I couldn’t say anything, because it was ridiculous. The next moment, the man flapped his lips.

“I just...”

It was a spectacular sight to see a man who was much taller than me looking gloomy.

Because he was handsome from this side too.

“...I think Miss Iana likes barkers.”

What?

When I looked again, wondering if I had heard it wrong, I had no choice but to stop.

This gloomy man was sincere.

I was speechless.

I didn’t know what to say to the man who put his hand on his chest and stared at me seriously.

... How on earth should I respond to someone who says something seriously absurd?

In fact, it had been a long time since I had seen Lenag.

There has been a weak bond between me and him since 3 years ago when he offered to run away.

It didn't deepen.

It was because Lenag was busy during this time, and also because Chaser prevented him from seeing me by any means.

Of course, he couldn't completely stop it, so Lenag saw my face like this often.

He's been very busy lately, so I guess he made time to come to a banquet like this.

I know that a noble like Lenag does not have to attend the debutante.

'Is it because of me?'

Raising my head, this man gently avoided my gaze. He gently covered his face with the back of his hand.

I saw the red cheeks that could not be covered under his large hand.

He can't even hide it anymore

If anything has changed over the past three years, these are the things. That he no longer hides these actions from me.

He was like a lonely wasteland, sharp like a snake navigating the land, and when he showed this appearance, even though time had passed, I still felt a little strange.

When I did not respond, Lenag's question flowed naturally. Soon after, from Chaser...

The question came back as to which one to choose.

“Who are you going with?”

I tilted my head.

‘I wonder if this is something I have to choose....’

“I like either way...”

I glanced at Lenag. His long eyes trembled.

“Isn’t it better to go with your fiancée if possible?”

In the eyes of others.

Although he didn’t say a word, a red color flashed on Lenag’s face. From this point of view, unlike his appearance, he responded immediately.

Chaser paused for a moment, then smiled softly.

“Not necessarily.”

He was smiling, but it was a smile that made the other person feel nervous. And this was his specialty.

Look at those eyes, he’s going to cause trouble.

-Human, will you choose, Nyang?

If I spoke wrong it seemed that word would spread that Valtaze and Domulit had a big fight today.

In the end, I compromised dramatically.

Then let’s do this, the two men silently listened to me. Distracted humans were no different from gentle sheep for this moment.

Ten minutes later, I was walking down the hallway with Lenag.

We had reached the agreement that Lenag and I walked down the hallway together, and at the entrance I would join Chaser.

....I wondered what kind of agreement this was. I stared at the floor indifferently.

“It’s a nice day.”

However, my gaze did not stay on the floor for long.

“Do you like summer?”

I was automatically pulled up by this man’s calm voice.

Four years after being released from prison, many things have changed. Ricdorian has grown, and Chaser reveals his true heart. I think that what hasn’t changed was myself, but in the eyes of others, I may have changed too.

So this man has changed.

But he was also the most consistent of those around me. That was amazing.

In the prison, there was a bit of a misunderstanding, and even if I knew that he was good at calculating...

Now I know he’s sincere. Also, he was always sincere....

“Summer is a strange season, for me.”

In the previous world, both the beginning and the end of a year were winter. On a cold day, we spend the year blowing steam and start the new year with the sound of a bell.

However, here everyone ends the year elegantly and gracefully in the warm weather that is a little hot, and welcomes the start of the new year with the hot sun.

“So if you ask me if I like it... I don’t think so.”

Summer has always been a season when a lot of things happen to me.

Meeting Ricdorian, finding out that I am Chaser's younger sister, letting the female lead escape....

And I don't keep my promise. If you count an understanding, it's close to bad.

"But I don't think it means much."

It was like that now. I muttered a little, but I felt a stinging gaze.

"That's not true."

When I raised my eyes, there was a still but deep gaze there. Yes, he was always a

serious-faced guy.

"It means something to me."

The man who spoke his words softly stretched out his hand. I was puzzled for a moment and took his hand.

Come to think of it, I was being escorted, but I didn't even hold his hand.

What came to mind was because I'm not bright in this area. Even if I learn the theory, how do I know when I am locked up in a mansion?

However, Lenag will be different.

He laughed as if he had sensed the meaning of my gaze.

"I was so nervous, I forgot to put my hand out. I apologize for the rudeness."

I pretended not to notice the sweat on his trembling fingertips and palms.

"No."

There was always something I wanted to ask Lenag. He must have seen Pudding disappear. He didn't say anything.

Of course, it's not that he doesn't know about Pudding as much as he's seen it for three years, but he never asked first.

As if he wouldn't ask if I didn't want it.

"I have a question for you."

Instead of mentioning his deep consideration, I brought up another story.

"Does Lenag have a guardian deity?"

"Yes."

He nodded.

I guess so. Because he was a 'rose' too.

It was a question I hadn't asked before.

I didn't ask him as much as he didn't ask me. It was not a consideration.

"Are you curious about my guardian deity?"

Before I could answer, he reached out. It was the hand that wasn't holding me.

Soon after, the sleeve of his hand slowly moved like something crawling.

It was a 'snake' that raised its head.

"Yellow Rose, the guardian deity of Valtaze is a snake. The name is Azur."

I had already guessed it by seeing it on the stone slab once, but I only thought of it and finally saw the pure white snake in front of my eyes was different from that.

“It’s not yellow.”

It was pure white. However, as far as the eyes are, they are the same golden color as Lenag.

“Azur...”

“Yes.”

The snake looked at me as if to say hello and quickly stuck out its tongue.

The speed seemed to be twice as fast.

‘It’s very small.’

It was smaller than I thought. When I found out that the guardian deity of the yellow rose was a snake, I thought it was the size of a house. Something like an anaconda.

However, this one was so small and cute that I thought it was a baby snake. Its head was pointed, but its eyes were round.

It didn’t feel right with this man with a sharp impression in many ways.

If I exaggerated, someone who didn’t know would have thought it was a snake-shaped bracelet.

“It’s okay to touch it.”

“Yes?”

“Ah, because it seems like you’re looking at it.”

By the way, Pudding shouted “Don’t touch the head! Nyang Nyang Nyang!”. I guess it’s jealous too.

However, I ignored it and touched the white snake.

‘...smooth.’

As I gently touched its, Azur closed its eyes and moved softly. I looked at Lenag, not knowing what it meant.

“It feels good.”

Ah. It felt good.

“By the way, the snake, no, Azur looks small, is it still young?”

“No. It’s an adult.”

It meant that it awakened. So, is it intentionally in a small form?

Aquala, who would become a giant eagle if she could, would take the form of a canary if she was bored.

“I prefer the smaller form, as it’s an efficient form to infuse venom.”

... Yes?

“It’s also effective for inducing carelessness.”

Aha.... such a terrifying meaning.

I nodded with a frown on my face and slowly removed my hand.

A poison beast that I thought was a baby snake. I was scared.

Then Lenag rolled up his hand and smiled slightly. It was a smile that disappeared without a trace as soon as it appeared.

“Don’t worry, Miss Iana will never be bitten.”

No, but still. You never know.

Accidents always happen when you think it is the safest, and when you are careless.

As if I had seen this far, Lenag took my hand tightly.

It's a weak force, but it clearly shows its presence.

“...I'm a little saddened. There's no way I'll put you in danger.”

With a fairly sincere face, I only knew then that I must have been rude.

“I'm sorry.”

“Ah... No. I didn't mean for you to apologize.”

Lenag hurriedly shook his head.

“I just want you to know that I'm not dangerous...”

Chapter 159: Lenag's Sincerity (2)

1. 1. Lenag's Sincerity (2)

While holding the other hand, it was after the long snake wrapped around his hand had come and disappeared without a trace.

I smiled more awkwardly at his troubled face.

“No. I was scared for a moment.”

I hesitated and spoke frankly.

“Then... I'm sorry Lenag, but we don't know when we'll be enemies either.”

Chaser was increasing his number of enemies day by day. It could be said that he was getting stronger that much, but I didn't know if the shadows darkening was a good thing.

Of course, I remember what Lenag did for me. I have no intention of forgetting. But I never thought that he would always be by my side.

“Lenag, you know my situation, right?”

It's not that I don't trust him, it's that I consider the possibility that his relationship with me could be disrupted by Chaser's involvement.

“You never know when that will change.”

I talked about this possibility frankly. He has already given and done a lot to hide and smile.

“Maybe one day we won’t be engaged.”

I pointed out Chaser’s dangers.

He’s a smart man and he won’t not know what I’m talking about.

Saying that, I tried to get my hands off him. However, the hand did not fall.

“If you say so, do you feel uncomfortable?”

“...I didn’t mean to hurt you. That one day you and I could break up for unintended reasons.”

“I’m not going to.”

I didn’t mean it so seriously. There is just such a possibility, I just wanted to talk about it. I knew I had gone too far and tried to apologize.

But the next moment he stopped me.

“I like you, Iana.”

Under the moonlight, under the glasses, with a crying expression.

“Ah....”

I already knew it, but never mentioned it.

What kind of change of heart that had happened. I didn’t know how to react.

Not knowing what to do, the warm fingertips moved.

“I’m not looking for an answer.”

Said the man with hot cheeks and a crying expression under the cold blue moon.

I hesitated and answered.

“Don’t cry.”

I felt like I needed something to comfort him. I think so... There were no words that came to mind.

“...Your glasses got wet.”

At the very least, this is the consolation that came out. I thought it was the worst.

-... Human, you are not good at comforting, Nyang.

Even the three-year-old guardian deity, who is much younger than me, did not hide it.

However, despite this poor comfort, he smiled a little.

“I already know you don’t feel the same way as me.”

He quietly admitted. And said again,

“I like you.”

With the hand not holding me, he took off his glasses and tucked them into his chest pocket.

“...I’m sharp enough to wear glasses that don’t fit right away with the word ‘scary’.”

Without being surprised by the contents, the man bowed his head and remained blushing.

“I love you.”

It was bitter because it was a sweeter confession. Enough to suffocate in this sweetness of the air...

“I can’t learn how to speak... I don’t know how to express it.”

He hesitated with a puzzled face. A smile as if drawn on a sharp face was shown. It was awkward as if it had been forced, but his face was tinged with red.

“I’m not wasting it even if I give you everything.”

Just looking at this man’s face, which was close to raw, evoked coldness and cruelty.

“I don’t care if you make fun of me and play with me.”

However, the sadness in his long eyes was enough to be felt even by me who was indifferent.

“...just let me stay by your side.”

After hesitating for a while, I finally spoke.

“...I can’t be that bad of a person.”

I have no intention of playing with him. It’s just that I just don’t have a heart.

How to make you understand what I said, a pure smile bloomed in the sharp face.

“Yes. Iana.”

It was a small smile that reminded me of a small and delicate forsythia flower that was not suitable for this size.

“I will protect you.”

So our conversation ended here.

“Duke Chaser Louve Domulit and the Duke’s sister Iana Rose Domulit is entering!”

It was like seeing a scene from somewhere when announcing the distinguished guest loudly through a loud megaphone.

Where did I see it? I must have seen it somewhere in the book.

A huge door opened.

There was no tension towards the new place. Because it was a place that I would come out soon anyway.

“You don’t look good.”

Chaser, who was looking at me from the side, shed a word. When he said that, I stopped looking at people and the hall.

“What’s going on?”

“...it’s not like that. No.”

Even after saying that, Chaser’s gaze did not fall from me. I walked for a while until we stopped.

The Emperor has not yet appeared.

Perhaps after coming all the way with Chaser, I wondered if he would show up soon.

Chaser asked the wrong thing in the meantime.

“What did Marquis Valtaize say about the eyes and hair under the mask?”

“Uh... He didn’t say anything.”

In fact, Lenag didn’t comment on my hair and eye color being the same color as Chaser.

“It’s just that there are words that can’t be mentioned that are obvious.”

In reality, rather than that, it seemed that Lenag was a character that didn't ask well in the first place, but I didn't answer like that.

It was better than trying to pretend to be casual for nothing.

Chaser groaned and rolled his eyes dizzily, but didn't say any more.

That was the moment.

“Grand Duke Ricdorian von Hernim is entering!”

The sound of the loudspeaker, which seemed a bit tacky, echoed through the hall once again.

The door opened and someone walked in.

It was a very bold step.

The people who were in full swing approaching us stopped walking and bowed their heads.

It was a Ricdorian with a pure white formal dress. The epaulettes on his shoulders reflected the splendor of gold. Without realizing it, I hid my hand behind my back and squeezed it tightly.

Ricdorian, who turned his head, came out briefly and met my eyes. His head turns indifferently, as if it was an illusion or a coincidence.

Since then, people have flocked to me, so I have had little time to think.

Those who approached showed up with either curiosity or a visible smile, and as I had been taught, I said my name and left only greetings.

“I'm sorry, but my sister isn't feeling well today.”

It's really easy, if I just say hello like this, Chaser will take care of me.

‘I wish the Emperor would come sooner.’

So I can step back, right?

It was time to greet the person who had just appeared.

Thump, thump.

Someone walked past the person. No, even if you get through it at first, people will find out soon enough and paved the way

“It’s been a while, Duke.”

Ricdorian was in front of me.

He was wearing a white mask as if he was following the rules of the day, but it was very thin and small.

Like that of similar shape to Chaser’s, except with a mesh attached.

“Hmmm, what is this?”

Chaser swung the glass he was holding.

“How dare I, the Grand Duke to find me.”

Champagne swirled around in the glass.

A whirlwind is hitting. Both in the glass and in my mind.

“I don’t think it’s been that long since Schirmela?”

Even though Chaser had deliberately mentioned Schirmela, Ricdorian didn’t blink.

“Preferably, Duke, I want to forget your face quickly. For the sake of the mood.”

“It must not be a face you can easily forget. That’s a relief.”

Chaser took the word with a self-congratulatory compliment. Ricdorian's blue eyes frowned slightly.

"I heard that the most precious person in Domulit had made a special visit. I came to see it in person."

Ricdorian immediately raised his lips. It was close to a cold laugh.

It was not like the face of the Ricdorian I remember.

"You'll have to try hard not to lose it like me. Don't you think so?"

"You mean like your father?"

Ricdorian's smile grew colder.

"...right."

Ricdorian smiled slowly and turned to me. I took a small breath. My mouth was dry.

I had to say a greeting.

In the midst of people's gossip, I opened my lips relatively calmly.

"Greetings, Grand Duke."

I have to say the greetings as I learned....

"...I am Duke Domulit's younger sister."

"This is the first time I've seen such disrespect."

Ricdorian pointed out my attitude right away.

"Duke, your sister is just as rude as you are."

Ricdorian lowered his head with piercing eyes.

“To greet without contact. Is this how you do introductions?”

Chaser’s hand rested on my shoulder.

“It’s up to my sister. Will you understand? You’re higher than the head of Domulit.”

“You’ll be in trouble if she disappears?”

Ricdorian took turns looking at Chaser and me.

“It’s really nice to have two of the same color as you.”

Chaser grinned.

“The Grand Duke doesn’t think it’s rude to come here and argue, is it?”

“Ah, yes. I’m just here to confirm the person who is a topic of discussion.”

Ricdorian’s eyes turned to me. It was close to an expressionless expression without warmth.

Soon he turned around indifferently.

There seemed to be no regret at all in his return.

Why do I feel sorry? No, I was sad. Because we didn’t recognize each other.

‘I’m sorry.’

I bowed my head and smiled.

The next moment the Emperor entered. It was the real beginning of the party.

“I’m tired, I want to rest.”

It was about an hour after the party started that I said these words.

Chaser took his eyes off the servant who had just approached. He had little worries in his face.

“Do you want to come with me?”

“No, you go alone.”

The servant who came to Chaser was a servant directly under the Emperor. The Emperor called Chaser. I think this was probably a sign to bring me along.

“I don’t want to be nervous anymore.”

Chapter 160: Hello, Iana

1. 1. Hello, Iana

Even though I wasn't nervous all the time, I calmly told lies. Either way, Chaser will be paying attention.

It was true that I was tired.

It was the same as in the past and now that I do not fit well with a place with a lot of people. In the city in the previous world, I couldn't stand it for long.

"Alright, then I'll be back. In the meantime..."

"No."

I grabbed Chaser's clothes who was about to call Lenag and shook my head.

I didn't want to see Lenag now. No, I don't want to face him with this tired mind.

<Please feel free to answer any time.>

No matter how it is, reuniting with the person who confessed on the same day was burdensome.

"...Is there anyone else?"

Chaser made a strange expression for a moment, then recalled a smile. It was a very happy expression.

There was also a gaze that seemed to measure the situation.

“Alright, I’ll call Marshmel.”

Marshmel is a person I’m comfortable with. I have no worries there. Chaser’s hand reached over my cheek.

“I have something to tell you when I get back.”

He hesitated for a moment.

“It’s something I couldn’t tell you. I hope you listen.”

I’ll be right back. He whispered a little and walked away. I didn’t keep my eyes on him for long.

The hesitant Chaser’s face I had seen in the mansion flashed past. It was the first time I had seen it, so it was stuck in my memory.

....if he’s going to talk, it’s probably talking about a story that was passed through without being able to get resolved when he handed over ‘Iana’s things.

Will I hear about the blue rose? Iana’s identity is engulfed in a veil.

This was not the only question. Former ‘Iana’ loved Chaser. Chaser, on the other hand, buys ‘Iana’.

He didn’t love her... This didn’t match up.

I remembered the red eyes that looked at me. It seemed that this matter should not be taken lightly. Is this because of his hesitant face?

After a while, I exhaled at the secluded balcony.

Next to me was Marshmel, who had been called by Chaser’s subordinates.

Marshmel was wearing a long cloak, and I don’t know if he knew he was dragging it at his toes.

“Why are you sighing like that?”

I laughed a little at the less blunt words from Marshmel. It’s... it wasn’t work-like.

I scratched my cheek. Then I said, leaving out the things that bothered me the most.

“I’ve been confessed.”

A squeaking noise was heard next to him.

“...wh, who? Is it alive?”

“Lenag.”

Hearing my words, Marshmel said ‘ah’ in a voice that seemed to have realized. Then he frowns.

“What, lady? You already know that.”

I already realized it and knew it. It was a little different from what I noticed, but he nodded.

“Really?”

“Lady already knows, right? It’s unnecessary.”

Marshmel pressed his fist against my cheek and then released it.

“The heart of the master.”

At that moment, a strong wind blew, and I couldn’t respond right away.

As I was about to speak, the balcony door opened. I turned around and saw a strange man standing there.

“Are... are you alone, Lady? I’ve been looking for you for a while.”

This ordinary-looking man spoke to me while hesitating as if he had gathered some courage.

“I have a party.”

“Do, do you still have it now?”

This is difficult.

Normally, I would have just refused and left the place, but somehow it doesn't seem like he'll just let me go back.

I didn't even want to leave. I was just so tired.

That was then.

Tsk, Marshmel clicked his tongue.

“Lady, are you related to this loach too? It's annoying.”

At the same time, the man shouted, ‘Uhuh’. The man's body is pulled back and thrown inward. The door slammed shut on its own. *Hwak*, the curtains went down and I couldn't see the inside anymore. It was an instant thing.

Bang bang.

Only one sound could not be hidden.

Marshmel murmured that this isn't enough and pressed his little finger to his forehead.

“Lady, be sure to repay this kindness. Get it?”

A black light seemed to flow from Marshmel, and then a large man was standing there.

I easily recognized that it was Marshmel with the same hair color.

“Wow, that's great.”

The long earrings that flowed from his ears fluttered. He looked at me and took off his earring.

Soon it became a long wand, and he shook it.

The door that had been knocked on soon became quiet.

“Hmmm.”

I applauded briefly.

“Is that you Marshmel?”

“...yes.”

No wonder. The figure I knew in the book was obviously an adult. I thought it was weird.

“Could you be an adult?”

“I can’t stay long.”

He spoke briefly. It was a tone that suited the nervous and indifferent face very well. Handsome.

“You were handsome.”

“Huh, nothing comes out even if you flatter me, Lady.”

However, the tone of voice is not at all different from when he was a child. I laughed out loud.

Meanwhile, the curtain was pulled.

“This will make it less troublesome.”

“What kind of troublesome thing is it? A person who talks with me and disappears without even a mouse or a bird knows?”

“You know it well.”

Even so, what? I didn’t deny it.

His dark blue hair was a color that matched the moonlit sky very well.

“More than that.”

Marshmel looked at me more than ever.

“Is that the face of a confessed person?”

“Why.”

“...the Lady knows but you don’t know.”

“Ah, in that sense, can you do one favor from someone who knows but doesn’t know?”

“What.”

“Can you bring me a drink while in that shape?”

“...huh?”

Marshmel clicked his tongue. I thought it would suit him well with such a handsome man with a sensitive appearance.

“I’m so thirsty. It seems like my brother’s business is going to be long, but if I go out, it’s going to cause trouble.”

That was true. People were running at me here as soon as Chaser disappeared.

Marshmel sweeps his hair, and he muttered.

“I’ll come soon. Wait a minute.”

A soft black light flashed around me. It was a castle, Marshmel’s magic.

So Marshmel came out. Waiting for him to come, I frowned as I looked out the glass door.

Oh damn.

The man who flew away a while ago was approaching. And with several young people like him.

... He doesn't know to give up

Their direction was clear, and it was clear that it would be annoying if we bumped into each other like this.

My worries didn't last long. Better than coming all the way here to see blood. I risked a bit of annoyance and left the terrace.

‘Anyway, thanks to the magic, Marshmel knows where I am.’

The thick darkness in the hallway completely obscured me. He didn't seem to notice when I was standing there.

I wanted to go anywhere, but it was the end of the hallway. A small pavilion was seen. It was a garden that would have been bright during the day.

“There are roses in bloom too.”

When I went into the garden and saw the roses, I had gone quite deep.

It was when I slowly straightened my upper body hoping that Marshmel would come to me soon.

Shaaaaaa-

A strong wind blew, and the black hair flew wildly. I struggled to grab my hair and pull it down, and in front of me was a shadow.

“We meet again.”

It was Ricdorian.

He speaks to me calmly. I unknowingly saw my hair still dyed black. I bowed my head. It was a necessity to bow down like this and go back.

“Wait a moment.”

If he hadn't called.

“Excuse me.”

Ricdorian, who spoke suddenly, approached.

“Do you know where the fountain is?”

The image of him approaching and asking is the same as the cold and stern look in front of Chaser.

The attitude was indifferent.

“...I do not know.”

....It's my first time here too. How do I know?

I staggered back with my feet. I hoped he wouldn't come any further. However, he stopped with the wind.

“Then do you have any thoughts of looking for it with me?”

“....what.”

“Then you'll take me.”

“...no, I don't want to.”

Ricdorian paused. It didn't look like he was upset. He looked at me and rubbed his chin.

“The younger sister of the Domulit head who didn't even tell me her name.”

I flinched.

“How come you’re only refusing so much. However, the politeness you show in your attitude is different from that of your brother.”

What can be known from such a short answer. I didn’t know if this was sarcastic or not.

“I wonder, does the face under the mask resemble your brother?”

“...can’t you tell when you see the color.”

I frowned and looked around. Strangely, there was no sign of Marshmel appearing.

It wasn’t just that.

....the surroundings were strangely quiet.

Even though I felt strange, there was nothing I could do right away. I pretended not to be flustered by what I was about to say, naturally.

“The Grand Duke is a wise man, so you can judge by this.”

“I don’t think you look alike.”

The eyes turned to Ricdorian. Before long, Ricdorian was taking off his mask.

“Isn’t it?”

He spoke in a polite tone, and at the same time, I felt a cold and twisted gaze. No. Deeper than that.

It was sinking.

“Because it’s not your hair color.”

He stretched out his hand. My mask falls off at his hand.

“Isn’t that right, Iana?”

The wind ruffled my pinkish hair.

“Should I say it again?”

At the last moment, you were clearly crying. To make my heart bleed.

But why are you smiling now?

“Hello, Iana.”

On the day we met again, Ricdorian smiled with a completely different face.

It was a very dark night sky. Under the dark silver moon, like his silver hair. He whispered softly.

“I’m going to kidnap you from now on.”

A streak of a smile crossed his cheek. The eyes of love and hatred.

“You didn’t see me.”

I didn’t know if he wanted to be angry or if he was smiling happily.

“I should at least hate you.”

The image of him crying desperately in my memory disappears. The wind blew, and Ricdorian in front of me said with a smile.

“Don’t you think so?”

The beast’s eyes flashed in the darkness.

Me: Aaaaaaaaaaaaa

Chapter 161: I Kidnapped You

1. 1. I Kidnapped You

I flapped my lips.

I have a lot to say, but I don't know if there really is much. It felt like the tank in my heart was full of water, but when I looked into it, it felt as if there was nothing.

My untidy hair was swaying in the wind.

I felt a glimmer of light from Ricdorian. From the moment I saw him, it continued to turn softly.

Red light.

It was the light that removed the magic from me. It was also the power of the rose he had.

Marshmel has already said it.

The power of magic and roses is like water and oil, they will repel it.

Thinking about it, it seems that the reason why Jair cast a spell on Ricdorian 4 years ago was aimed at repulsing the magic and Ricdorian's power in an attempt to stabilize the power.

In fact, after the magic, didn't he suffer side effects all the way back and forth as a young man?

Thinking about it now, I wonder if this is also a way for a person who thought of Ricdorian to do it. The reason why so many thoughts came to me

in such a brief moment was because the Ricdorian I had seen had something deep and unrecognizable altogether.

I never thought this man would have such dark, wet eyes.

“Ricdorian.”

Rather, I thought that even though he would be hurt, he would just be shining.

Because you were that kind of person.

“Are you calling me now?”

I thought that even the cruel chains of the prison would not be able to bind his splendor and nobility in the future.

My mouth clenched.

But I realized it was already too late. The blue magic circle that spread under my feet was revealing its existence.

I’ve already seen it once.

‘What Chaser wrote...?’

It had a similar shape. The detailed shape looks a little different, but in the context of a certain function.

Before I could say anything, a strong wind blew.

Instinctively, I closed my eyes and raised my hand. The last thing I saw was Ricdorian’s white and blue cloak flying wildly.

“Ugh...”

When I opened my eyes and lowered the back of my hand that covered my face, I was in a completely different space.

It was a room I had never seen before.

It was very tiring. *Huff huff*. Only breathing was heard.

I slowly raised my head.

“Iana.”

A subtle yet low voice called out to me.

“Welcome to my castle.”

It was in a quiet room, but as if the window was open, the air was shaking.

I knew the identity of this room by his voice, but there were no words to say.

“I... kidnapped you.”

A voice full of love.

His eyes seemed to be asking, ‘What are you thinking now?’.

Darkened eyes, swaying silver hair.

What can I say to you?

To this man who seems to have become completely different.

The wind blew constantly.

I feel sorry and sad at the same time. I came to regret rejecting Ricdorian’s hand.

“Iana.”

But I knew.

Even if I went back to that situation, I would have acted like that.

It seemed meaningless to say that I acted that way for you.

Nevertheless, at this moment, I spoke frankly.

I glanced at his hand holding me. Ironically, the way he held me was the same as four years ago.

If I touch it, will it fly away?

If I hold it, will it break?

His hands are so careful.

While his face was as cold as a tree branch in the middle of winter.

I slowly opened my mouth.

“It doesn’t matter.”

This may not be the answer Ricdorian wanted. Unsurprisingly, his cold expression faded.

“If I could go back to that moment.”

My words didn’t stop.

“I will do the same over and over again.”

I will not go to see you, I will shake off your hand.

“For you.”

I didn’t expect much because I did it regardless of whether he will believe it or not.

However, I expected that there would not be a good response.

Unsurprisingly, his face was terribly contorted.

“For me?”

It wasn't enough that the face was getting fiercer, the voice got even lower.

Now, as if a quiet sound was buzzing in a cave, the voice that had become more hoarse continued.

“Don't be ridiculous.”

He talked as if he was going to devour me.

“If you really thought of me, you knew the best way.”

Even at this moment, shining in the moonlight, the beautiful blue eyes darkening was so enchanting.

“Why, I don't know.”

He muttered as if to himself. With a cold laugh.

“That mean and handsome duke's only sister.”

He twisted his lips.

“Yes, you're clever, aren't you?”

Like that guy, he whispered softly.

“There's no way you didn't know my heart.”

The ice-pick-like voice accurately penetrated the target.

“I've always wondered. Why didn't you come out that day?”

For a moment, strength entered his hands. It didn't hurt, but I felt it instead. Even if I try to back away, there's no place to back away.

“Are you sick or was it a situation? You didn't forget me, did you? What if you had forgotten? No way you..... Like me, like father?”

I flinched.

Ricdorian himself had no idea what his father's story was telling me.

"The foolish boy thought about it for three years. His trust was abandoned like torn promises and his heart turned away to hatred."

He smiled. For some reason, it was a smile that cut through my heart.

"Was it that easy and simple for you?"

The promise you and I made was so light, so did you break it?

'Maybe it was at first.'

I shook my head slightly. I thought that I had to answer. "No."

One calm answer seemed to be the catalyst that stimulated him even more.

"Lies, you said it with your mouth. Shameless and selfish."

Obviously I said so.

"Nevertheless, I wanted to get down on my knees."

The blurry eyes instantly regained their light.

"The moment I saw you again, I forgot to think about it. I reached out my hand desperately and desperately."

Reflecting on what happened in Schirmela, what he showed was a deeper and more raw emotion.

-Human..

It was then that the restless Pudding's voice was heard. I clasped my hand as if it was okay and opened it.

'It's okay, don't worry.'

Perhaps Pudding felt an unusual energy from Ricdorian. Because it felt the same to me.

“By the way, you’re the princess of Domulit. You’re that man’s only sister.”

It’s time to go back. I lowered my eyes, closed them and opened them.

“Why, no answer? Am I wrong?”

There was a slight hint of nervousness that passed by the cold voice.

“No. That’s right.”

What has already been revealed cannot be reversed. It was a fact that would all be revealed at the banquet anyway.

A high-ranking noble who had just debuted had to introduce themselves at least once in front of the emperor or in front of the public.

I used a trick to avoid this, but now what’s the use?

“I’m Iana Rose Domulit, as you said, I am from Domulit.”

Iana’s identity cannot be ignored. The four years I experienced there were like nothing else.

Ricdorian seemed even more annoyed by my calm introduction.

“Ha, so you deceived me in the first place?”

Now, he felt like a ferocious beast that was on the verge of starvation for a few days.

“From the day we met in the prison, who you are, did you approach me while hiding your identity?”

“No.”

I shook my head. it wasn't so. I do not want to allow misunderstandings to pile up even when I'm criticized. I grabbed his finger in urgency.

"The day I met you, I didn't even know who I was."

"You want me to believe that?"

"Really."

His fingers twitched as I grabbed his hand.

"I lost my memory."

It was the most honest thing I could say. Even if it is revealed gradually that it is a different soul or different body.

"I am different before I enter the prison and after I enter the prison."

For now, I wanted to start with what he could believe and what he could understand.

"If you had researched me, you would know, didn't you hear that I had a heart attack and my heart stopped and then started beating again?"

Ricdorian did not answer.

"Ricdorian, I've been..."

Biting my lip and continuing my words, a knock sounded as if interrupting this moment.

Knock, knock.

It was a restrained and heavy sound that could not be ignored. "Duke, are you here?"

When a voice as serious as the knock followed one after another, Ricdorian's face, which had never changed, responded. I felt my eyebrows go up.

“The ‘plan’ has gone awry.”

Are you back? It's urgent. Ricdorian's eyes roll slowly at the words left by the heavy voice.

Soon his lips opened. *Open the door.* With those words, the door opened.

It was so dark between the gaps in the door that it was impossible to see who was standing.

“...Iana, you better not run away.”

As if to listen to the rest of the story next time, I could feel him trying to turn around. Without realizing it, I grabbed the hem of his clothes.

I thought he would shake it off, but he stopped. For a moment, he looked at my hands with sullen eyes.

It was surprising.

“...don't you want to tie me up?”

I quickly told the business. It looked urgent, so I had to say just what I had to say.

“What?”

“Aren't you going to tie me up?”

Ricdorian's expression was strange.

No, it was weird.

“I'm a hostage.”

“.....”

“Then shouldn't you tie me up?”

Like that guy, I was casual.

“If you’re going to tie me up, the ankles are better.”

It was convenient to think that only the place where I was confined had changed.

“You....”

At that moment, Ricdorian’s face shattered horribly.

He was like a man who heard things he couldn’t hear.

Chapter 162: Fantastic peculiarities of the male protagonists of this novel

1. 1. Fantastic peculiarities of the male protagonists of this novel

A suffocating silence passed. Ricdorian was the first to speak out in the tight air.

“Don’t talk nonsense.”

He soon returned with a cold face and spoke his intentions lowly.

“I won’t tie you up. I won’t lock you up. I won’t do anything I hate the most.”

Seeing that, it must have been. Since childhood, being trapped in chains and prison cells is everything in his world, isn’t it?

It was an understandable reason.

Is he making a difference in one bad thing? It was strange.

“...Hey, isn’t that already a bad thing when you said kidnapping?”

I don’t know what’s different.

“.....”

He looked back at me once and turned around. Without answering my question.

“Don’t go anywhere.”

I’m sure he means don’t run away... The order sounded like a pleading request.

“I have no intention of neglecting you, so it would be better to erase the thought of escaping in advance.”

Returning to the Grand Duke’s stiff tone, he even turned his head. But for some reason, the tone was a little awkward.

“Why?”

Why are you doing this? He said he hates me, and now he sees me with love-hate eyes.

“Why do I have to answer?”

But there was no answer. If it’s clear what I’ve heard, he left without answering.

I was not hurt by the cold reply. Rather, it was understandable.

I glanced at the door where he disappeared and then slowly stared at the floor.

-Human.....

The white cat, which suddenly appeared, rubbed its body anxiously at my feet.

-Are you okay, Nyang Nyang?

I laughed bitterly. After signing the contract, Pudding’s feelings have vaguely crossed over to my head.

I knew Pudding was worried.

-Human, human, what should we do now? Hmm?

I smiled and patted Pudding's head playfully.

"My name. You never called me once. Huh?"

After signing the contract with me, Pudding, who shared all the daily life with me, knew and felt a lot. Even though that category is still at the limit of its young personality, it sounds like its thinking quite deeply.

So, Pudding's concern is not just because of Ricdorian's ferocious appearance.

"... it's okay."

I slowly raised my hand.

On my wrist, there were two bracelets.

It was a gift from Jair a long time ago.

Somehow, I had no use for all of my magic, but I brought it here.

Neither Chaser nor Marshmel knew. Because I didn't use it in front of them.

It was also my insurance that no one knew because I don't know when I was going to be kidnapped.

Of course, I was safe thanks to Chaser, his guardian deities, and his capable subordinates who appeared before using this.

"Ha....."

I give the bracelet a long look. After loosening the bracelet and holding it in my hand, the next thing I went to was the bare bottom of my wrist.

I exhaled shallowly, calming Pudding that was rubbing its body from below.

When I pressed my wrist behind the sigh, blood rushed out. Then slowly... A single pattern was drawn on the wrist.

It was a black rose.

I pressed down on the black rose. At the same time, a soft and ecstatic voice as if waiting was heard.

– *Hello, Iana.*

A low, dangerous voice, as if to hide his anger.

– *Where are you now?*

I didn't say anything.

Just as Ricdorian had not answered me a moment ago, only silence pressed the air heavily.

It wasn't because I was under pressure again. It wasn't because the years had passed so smoothly that I was scared by such things.

This tattoo may even convey the sound of breathing, but Chaser would also feel a quiet silence through the tattoo.

This was my first time communicating with this tattoo. It was also a strange feeling.

This was the 'insurance' that Chaser gave me.

So that one day I will be able to use it when I am away from him. Since I had never been kidnapped, I had nothing to use it for....

He wouldn't have thought of such a situation either.

– *Iana?*

Chaser's voice continued softly.

-... *can you hear me?*

It was quiet, but I could feel the impatience creeping in.

-Can you.....answer? If not.

After a brief pause, he spoke again.

-Answer, you don't want to?

From the side, Pudding raised its hair. It looked like it was going to go downhill at any moment.

But when I quickly brought my index finger to my lips, it felt my will, and it struggled to suppress the sound.

I stroked Pudding as if it did well, then stroked the tattoo. Black light was covered by the palm of my hand.

Soon, I pressed my wrists so tightly that they hurt.

1, 2, 3....

After a few seconds, I raised my hand.

Suddenly the light was off.

“Ha.... “

I checked the restored wrist again and let out the breath I had been holding back.

“Oh my.”

The sound of a grumbling rang out.

Sitting on the sofa wasn't enough, so I stretched out like I did in Domulit's mansion.

Wherever I sleep, I should be comfortable like in my own home. Even if this is a new thing, my posture was so natural. In any dangerous situation, it

is a law to get a good night's sleep.

‘That’s how you use your head.’

As if Pudding had been waiting, it climbed onto my thigh and sat down on my body.

-Human....

Pudding lying on my thigh caught me with a worried expression. The white ears wiggled.

-Are you okay, Nyang?

I smirked as I stretched out.

“Will it be okay?”

I dared to cut off the communication with the great villain. He will need time to decide whether this is intentional or not.

It’s kind of a grace period.

A time. No, I bought my time by trickery, but it won’t last long.

I’ll probably have to choose.

“Should I stay here or go back?”

I closed my eyes. The little guardian deity in the shape of a cat cried for a long time as if comforting me.

In my head, I heard a voice asking, “*Human, what do you want to do?*”

“What should I do about it?”

I closed my eyes and stroked the soft fur.

“Kidnapping or confinement?”

An older brother who will soon find and pursue me, and a cold Ricdorian who harbors love and hate for me.

What are the options? I smirked. Then I opened my eyes.

Strictly speaking, Chaser didn't kidnap me but I was confined, and Ricdorian didn't confine me, but kidnapped me.

... The male characters in this novel are fantastic.

I stopped laughing out loud.

I had a strange feeling. The more I think that the place where I lay my back on is not Domulit, the more I feel like I have to go back to Domulit.

It felt like someone was begging me to go back in my head.

It was really weird.

I don't feel that way, but I can't believe I feel that way...

However, the body that stretched prevailed over the thought.

"Oh, I'm sleepy."

For comfort, my dress did not tighten. Thanks to that, it became a great nightgown for this moment.

Actually, I knew it myself. It wasn't that I didn't have any means I could use while Ricdorian grabbed me and moved me.

Chaser and Marshmel prepared me for danger, and as a result, even if I was left alone, they made a hole for me to get out of.

Like that tattoo on my wrist.

If I had borrowed Pudding's power at the very least, I would have steered away that hand that held me without any struggle.

“I.”

And where I want to stay...

“I want to be here.”

Pudding flinched at my decision.

But I closed my eyes without saying any more.

“..I wish he just fed me well.”

He won't starve me because he was angry, right?

Then should I grab Pudding and eat it?

-I, I can hear you, human!

Such a terrible word!

Pudding, who did not understand the nonsense, jumps up and down, the fur that bristles along has a serious atmosphere.

The voluntary first day of confinement passed like this.

Next day.

With a click, the door opened and Ricdorian came in quietly, startled when he saw me lying on the sofa.

Somehow, he had forgotten his cold face and his eyes were startled.

Ricdorian looked at me slowly and then blinked. He could not erase the surprise.

“... you're really good at adapting.”

Even so, I was pulling and dragging something like a blanket from somewhere to cover me.

It was a really comfortable position. I grinned.

“My specialty is adaptability.”

I adapt to everything. As I said, it didn’t seem like something to be proud of.

What’s good is good.

“But what is that?”

Ricdorian was holding something in his hand. It was my turn to be surprised this time as I saw the various trays and plates laid down.

I stared at him as he returned to his original cool face. Then I had my doubts.

“Eat it.”

Eat this?

It was truly a luxurious spread. I was accustomed to all the luxuries in Domulit, but these are surprisingly numerous and diverse.

.... Wasn’t I a prisoner here?

Of course, I’m not really a prisoner. It was not something that anyone would go out of their way to give when they’re angry.

“...Does the Grand Duke deliver things directly here?”

At that, Ricdorian frowned slightly.

He was just sitting right across from me, who was saying something. As if telling me to eat the food.

Ummm, sitting like that means watching me eat....

“Is it poisonous?”

“What?”

“I’m kidding.”

It was a very familiar conversation to me, so it was a question that came to mind without realizing. Ricdorian had a strange expression on his face.

“From yesterday, you...”

However, he murmured so much that he did not continue to the end.

Well, the thing that people are trying to say when they feel cramped the most....

I don’t know how to cut it off like this. I was curious but didn’t ask.

What can I say to the Grand Duke who raised his word and said, “Don’t do useless things with your whole body right now?”

I just smiled and said.

“Thanks.”

It was just that I was hungry. I couldn’t eat anything at the banquet because I was nervous.

Do you know, I was very nervous about meeting you.

“Actually, I thought you’d starve me.”

He was so cruel, and he took me here with a completely different face than before.

I was a bit worried as I was following along. Meals should be eaten well.

“...you are still easygoing.”

“Really.”

I lay down on the sofa, raising my head and resting my face on my arms.

My pink hair was flowing smoothly. The hair that was meticulously maintained for the banquet was mine, but I was amazed at its luster.

“You haven’t changed at all.”

“Did you want me to change?”

“.....”

Why? The more we talked, the more I felt like I was back in a prison cell.

In front of me is a large adult, no more a 16-year-old boy.

Is that why?

“Are you mad at me?”

Without realizing it, like that day in the cage, I asked gently, affectionately.

“Not at all.”

Ricdorian responded firmly.

After a moment of silence, Ricdorian whispered coldly. Then he slowly closed his eyes.

“I didn’t forget that you broke your promise.”

The shards embedded like ice fragments left scars on both sides of me. Because his face never looked comfortable when he said that. The now-heavy voice had a great impact on my heart.

“The fact that you shook off my hand.”

As he said that, he didn't take his eyes off me, with a face I didn't even want to see.

There were so many things on his face that it was difficult to fathom.

"I will never forget it."

He spat it out.

"Because I've been waiting."

Why?

"But whether angry or not."

Gradually, his voice felt more like embarrassed rather than a cold feeling at first.

"...from the beginning, I had no intention of starving you."

Chapter 163: Earlobes are still red

1. 1. Earlobes are still red

He turned his face away. I couldn't see his face or cheeks as he turned his body around.

I just stare at the back of his ear that I can see through his hair. No, I was just thinking about the last cold face I saw.

“...I thought it would have changed.”

Ricdorian's cool voice continued slowly.

“I didn't know it would change like this.”

There was no subject, but I could tell that it was meant for me without asking.

I judged whether the redness of his earlobes, which I could see slightly, was my mistake.

Then I completely gave up. Since when did I calculate and move one by one?

I smiled and opened my mouth.

“How?”

It didn't take long for Ricdorian's gaze to return.

“How did you want me to change?”

I slowly released my arm that was holding my chin as if I was falling down. Then I turned around and gave him a smile.

Towards a completely different face.

“I’ll do whatever you want.”

There is something I had to atone for Ricdorian. Well, it was so light that I never thought I would make an ‘atonement’.

Just as I thought it would be a light feather to me. If it gets farther away, it will fly away.

I did not know that I would regret the lightness of that time. Did I think it was too easy?

If I had known you’d be struggling this long. If only I had known that you weren’t just blaming me.

It’s not that I’m disappointed and sad that I’ve seen this change. I changed him so far.

I felt sad and sorry for what I did. Even if it wasn’t for me, he was a person who would go through a lot of pain and trials.

That was then.

He jumped up.

“Whatever?”

“.....uh?”

So I thought I’d listen to whatever he had to say. If it’s something I can do. If he wants the Domulit mansion, I can’t give it to him right now.

Of course he won’t, though.

But it was unexpected that it would come so soon.

We were now close with only one square table in between us. Ricdorian just bowed his head.

“Whatever, will you do it?”

A white hand, a hand with a lot of scars in the past three years, touched the table. The bones are thick and the fingers are long.

It was a hand that was in contrast to the still neat and even pure face that could not be easily imagined just by looking at his face.

“Iana.”

I shuddered when a low voice called me.

“Hey, I asked if you could do whatever for me.”

A sculpturally towering face was staring at me.

It’s a cold face, but there’s a chill going around here... Only the dark blue eyes seemed to flutter like blue flames.

Surprised by the heat, I felt a burning thirst in my throat.

Ricdorian gradually drew closer.

Clink.

There was a sound of plates colliding with plates. It was due to being pushed against his hand.

There was no time to pay attention to the plate, which was pushed out and barely draped over the end of the table.

As I got a little closer, I felt like I could feel his breath. I stared at him, neither pushing nor responding.

I just stared and felt the air vibrate. The fact that my heart is actually beating inside me.

He bent his head.

His head, which was slowly bent, went down even further. It was about to brush against my lips...

When his breath touched my earlobe, my spine straightened out. My fingers gripped the hem of my shirt.

“Eat.”

The voice from the breathing sound dug deep into my ears.

Then Ricdorian fell back, but he had already drawn the ripples.

No, I couldn't escape from the ripples left by the voice.

.... How am I supposed to eat in this situation?

You seduced me, you twisted me.

Didn't you?

I didn't want to eat, let alone breathe in the air.

‘The older I get, the more demanding I get.’

Obviously, I saw him as an adult for a while 4 years ago, but it was a different feeling.

Of course it will. He wasn't that cold back then. More than that, I don't know why he's saying that in my ears.

I leaned back, placed my hands on my chest, and narrowed my eyes.

Come to think of it, Ricdorian was always shy and he would always turn red but very rarely sometimes had an innocent face as if he was wondering what the problem was.

<You held me like this when you gave me cookies.>

After doing something very daring.

<... Did you not like it?>

When I lifted my head, the illusion of seeing the boy's clear gaze overlapped.

Four years later, Ricdorian stood still. It felt like he was still waiting.

I sighed a little and straightened my posture. And took a spoon. Somehow the spoon was lifted, but the food couldn't go over.

'.... It's embarrassing.'

-Human, aren't you hungry, Nyan?

'No, I was hungry... '

The navel clock, which had stimulated the stomach a while ago, was broken.

Hunger has long since been washed like a stain on white laundry.

"...why don't you eat?"

When I put down the stew after a few spoonfuls, Ricdorian said. His eyes narrowed slightly. Like a little perplexed.

"Isn't it to your taste?"

A smile came out.

It was funny. Obviously, where is a kidnapper who takes care of the taste of the hostage after kidnapping?

I thought it would only apply to the crazy people in my house. Of course, that crazy person is Chaser.

"It's not that I don't like it."

On the contrary, the taste was very good. It was comparable to the skill of a chef who Chaser said that he had searched the continent to bring.

“I was supposed to eat less.”

It wasn’t a lie. I just omitted the words ‘very, very, very rarely, about once every three years?’

My creed is that eating well and sleeping well is the best, but I can’t resist eating.

Even when Chaser stared at me or smiled sweetly but cruelly, I ate comfortably even in front of that terrifying gaze, but not in front of the Ricdorian.

Ricdorian did not hide his displeasure anymore.

He didn’t have to speak with his lips, but that was the way he looked at the food.

What are you going to do without me eating more?

‘Looking that way, he resembles Pudding.’

– Nyang! I’m not like that!

‘Why, it’s the same color as you. It’s like a sullen face.’

– Sullen?

‘Well. It’s just that when you’re pouting, it’s sullen.’

– What is it, Nyang? This great body never gets upset, Nyang!

The 3-year-old guardian deity was a mess in my head. Waaong waaongg.

I let out a voice that was half a cry and half a talk and lifted my gaze.

Pudding refuses to show up to Ricdorian. It seemed that it was grunting about whether I would send it to Ricdorian if it came out.

I felt it because my mind was connected. Ricdorian was still staring at me. I spoke to him slowly.

“I don’t want to eat.”

No, I strongly expressed my intentions, but there was no change in Ricdorian’s face.

“I said it. I wouldn’t starve you.”

Rather, he just answered this way. He’s stubborn in strange places.

I laughed mischievously.

It was because I thought that the composition of him looking down and me looking up was the opposite of that in the prison.

“If you want me to eat properly.”

I chose the words he would hate at any moment. Then he tilted his head.

“Will you feed me?”

Now, his appearance was like a hedgehog screaming, *don’t touch me*. After all, there’s no point in being mature and soothing here anyway.

Rather, it would have been better for him to be disgusted and left.

“...feed you?”

Unsurprisingly, Ricdorian’s expression was not serious. It must have been as intended, it was time to think.

He hurriedly approached and sat down. Then he carefully moved the spoon.

I glanced alternately at the bread in his hand and meat floating in the spoon.

....why are you doing this?

This cold version of Ricdorian, who I thought he would refuse, listened to me. I was flustered.

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

“...can the Grand Duke do something like this?”

“I don’t know what you’re misunderstanding, but when the battle continued fiercely, I even served the wounded soldiers myself.”

After thinking for a moment, he added.

“...because there wasn’t enough manpower.”

So, it sounds like I should just shut up and eat, but it’s not that you’re short of hands now, right?

“More than that, I don’t know why you see me that way. Isn’t that something you’ve always done too?”

“That’s...”

You were bound by chains and restraints. Hands and feet and neck.

The moment I met Ricdorian without saying that, I realized.

... I raised him wrong.

He had a cold face, but on his frosty face, there was a vivid light that I couldn’t see if I just brushed through.

If you knew him 4 years ago, you would recognize it, his eyes are vivid with innocence that doesn’t suit him now.

“What is the problem?”

I was confused. What is he talking about without knowing this now? He's an adult, and he's the Grand Duke.

I was embarrassed even when I took the spoon.

Ricdorian's face is calm, but why do I feel like I'm being deceived?

I worked with a villain who acted up for 3 years. I was confident that I could recognize any pretense.

"This makes me feel like I'm in prison..."

The spoon stopped at the words that came out without knowing.

Ricdorian's eyes, who had listened to each other, turned to me.

Like a water-drenched lily, it is as neat and clean as a lily. Like I said, a lily or forget-me-not would look better than a rose.

"You remember that time?"

"Why can't I remember?"

It's not that old. On the contrary, even now, when I close my eyes, I sometimes think of it.

Sally was a con artist but a sweet friend, and a pleasant uncle baron. They were kind, but counting the guards....

I was obviously locked up, but I had some free time. I used to think like this.

"It was the first time I met you."

And I can't forget meeting Ricdorian. Impressive first meeting.

Come to think of it, is it okay now that Ricdorian had turned into a beast?

"By the way... are you okay with being a beast before?"

Ricdorian paused.

“...why are you asking that?”

“Yes. Because I’m worried...?”

I rolled my eyes. Ricdorian, who has become the Grand Duke, can’t bark woof woof now, can he?

Of course, when he met the female protagonist in the original story, he was only talking to her in beast mode, that is, a wild appearance.

I don’t know how the original will change. I was going to ask more.

“You’re always like that.”

Chapter 164: Misunderstanding

1. 1. Misunderstanding

I was taken aback by the sudden words. But the moment I looked at Ricdorian's face, I couldn't speak any more.

Because he had an angry face. The spoon was placed on the plate.

"...as if I'm giving you everything."

He lowered his head and rubbed his face.

"Don't confuse me again."

I didn't know why he was doing this. Didn't we seem to have a good conversation?

It was a moment, but I observed it quickly.

He had mixed feelings about me, and it was like a manic depression, boiling fire and water.

I didn't think it was going to go away.

However, no time was given to take a serious look at him. For Ricdorian got up and went to the door.

"...meal..."

Meal... He was about to say something, then bit his lip and turned his head away.

That was the last thing. Because he opened the door and walked out.

Left alone, I took a look at the door and the food left behind.

The food is steaming. It hadn't cooled down.

"I thought I knew him well. I don't know about this."

A small cat appeared in front of me as if in response to my murmuring. Pudding wags its tail and rubs its head against my leg.

– Humans are difficult, Nyang.

It was a rather serious tone that did not match the voice of a child.

– But the successor. This body seems to know how it feels, Nyang.

"How does it feel?"

Oh, this three-year-old guardian deity knows such complex emotions? I admired a little.

Pudding stared at me with sulleneyes.

– Human, it feels like when you let me go, Nyang!

Nya, nyaa, nyaaang, nyaaaang, waaaonggg!

In response to the fierce and long cries and nagging, I politely threw out just one word.

"Should I let you go again?"

– N, no, Nyang!

Pudding shook its head and dug into my arms. *Haha*, I burst out laughing.

"I can't be mistaken."

Pudding's eyes, staring at me with hate, were exactly like Ricdorian's.

"Because it's the same."

I tapped Pudding's pale pink nose.

"It's not it?"

— What do you mean, Nyang?

"Nothing."

At this moment, my love for my 3-year-old guardian deity, who was originally lovely, springs up even more.

Ricdorian, maybe it's because of you. My lips went up.

"It's just that I can't hate it... "

I laughed out loud. Suddenly, I thought that it was the feeling of laughing after a long time.

A few days passed. Ricdorian stayed in the room at least once a day.

"....."

One difference from before was that he didn't say anything anymore. However, in the beginning, he said a few necessary words.

In recent times, really nothing. He didn't say a single word

It seemed to show his will that he's not going to say anything like this.

Me? I didn't really care. Actually, as long as Ricdorian is healthy and does not get sick and eat well, it was enough for me.

It's not that I'm indifferent, it's that I didn't want anything as much as I was sorry.

His heart and mental side didn't seem right. The funny thing is that, despite all this, he always listens to what I want.

For example, two days ago. When asked if there's anything I want.

<I want to wear the prison uniform.>

.. He just frowned at my absurd request, and he obeyed it.

Of course, he sometimes made strange faces.

It was not a prison uniform, but I was satisfied that I was able to wear comfortable clothes similar to a prison uniform.

It was so soft that it was as good as the top-quality pajama skirt I wore at Domulit's mansion.

The one I wore there, I had to be careful about whether it would blow off or rip if caught, but this was good because it didn't happen.

<I just had it made.>

Because I heard the answer that it was just made.

Four days have already passed, but the relationship with Ricdorian has been so sluggish.

In other words, we're like chicken and a cow, not caring for each other. Of course not me, but Ricdorian.

At first, I was conscious, but then I started doing this and that without caring for Ricdorian.

At first, I just stared blankly at the sky. It was a familiar action. Next, I toured the room.

-Human, it's amazing, Nyang! There are no bars in the windows, Nyang!

‘There was a place that was not even the Domulit mansion.’

– That, human, wasn't it your room?

‘.... Is that so?’

The window without the bars was strange.

Maybe I have seen it too many times? Familiar things disappeared like air, and the changed environment was amazing.

<It's wide and spacious.>

Looking at the room, it was pleasant. It's not luxurious, but it's a different feeling from Domulit's room, which was filled with only splendor.

Because it was like a prison cell of luxury or ‘gold’.

Then I changed clothes, and then I sat on the sofa and read a book.

Strangely, I didn't want to go out and run around. Maybe I'm used to it

At the same time, I felt the need to go back to Domulit. It was a thought that came to me regardless of my will or mood.

As if I should be.

‘I'm not even surprised.’

But these thoughts did not overcome my laid-back annoyance.

The pursuit of a comfortable life where all I need to do is warm my back and fill my stomach is similar here.

Ah. Let's live comfortably in this complex world. I liked the great environment in which my creed was put to full exercise.

And today, someone opened the door and a stranger appeared.

“Hello, Miss.”

The character I thought was unfamiliar until the appearance was a familiar face.

It was Jaire.

“Jaire?”

“Yes.”

He was wearing a long robe. It’s also not unfamiliar.

Because Marshmel was wearing something like that too. It’s just a little cuter, cuddly, and black. Our little warlock.

“Long time no see.”

I nodded my head to Jaire, erasing the little wizard I was fond of.

“Now, should I call you Lady Domulit?”

“It doesn’t matter...”

I shifted my gaze. Ricdorian came in behind Jaire. Ricdorian, as always, did not say anything and just leaned back. He crossed his arms.

“...just call me what you call me. I like it when it’s comfortable and convenient.”

If that’s what you want, Jaire said, he laughed playfully and clasped his waist.

The movements were quite elegant, but at the same time, there was a sense of humor as a clown would to the audience.

“I didn’t know we’d meet like this. I thought that would be the last time.”

“You still talk a lot.”

“Aren’t we pretty close?”

“You are still making up words that didn’t exist.”

“I’m sad.”

“Really?”

The period he spoke of would probably refer to four years ago in prison. He didn’t care, even though I said it carelessly.

“I should formally introduce myself. I’m Jaire, the sorcerer and counselor of Grand Duke Hernim.”

“I’m Iana.”

“Hahaha, you’re still the same too.”

The hem of his long robe flapped as he waved his hand.

As in the original story, this one seems to have taken the place as the male protagonist’s most faithful subordinate and capable wizard.

As Ricdorian’s right arm, it was a good thing.

“You don’t know how surprised I was when I heard it.”

I stopped looking at Ricdorian, who just had his arms crossed behind, and tried to focus on him.

“You mean?”

It wasn’t easy, but I forcibly looked at Jaire because I thought it was not polite.

“Yes? Don’t you already know?”

That was the moment. Behind Jaire, Ricdorian, who was leaning on his back, abruptly stood up.

However, Jaire, who could not see behind him, was faster.

“I heard that the lady is the successor of the blue rose?”

Stop.

I just stopped. I wasn't interested in Jaire's words, even the fingers he held and stretched out indifferently.

It seemed as if time had stopped for a moment.

‘How does Jaire know this?’

That's weird.

‘Iana’ is the blue rose. I thought this would be very secretive.

I wasn't stupid, so I was able to come to a conclusion quickly.

“You can't see the shadows under the lamp, don't you?”

Jaire, who smiled as I said it was dark under the lamp, did not catch my eye.

“I was really surprised.”

He slowly raised his head and rolled his eyes. You know where my gaze is going.

... What Jaire knew, there was no way that Ricdorian would not know.

At that moment, Ricdorian's eyes met mine in the air.

‘Ah... Did you bring me here for this?’

His eyes looking at me slightly shook. It was the first time it happened.

At the moment I was thinking of this, I wondered why he did that. That's right, I think you'll think that way

"Miss, Miss?"

I wondered how he or Jair knew it, but the truth is, maybe it was something everyone knew except me.

Isn't it?

'Iana' was originally a dead person at this point. Either in book or in real life.

It might have been revealed after she died. The reason I guess is because it's a scene that didn't appear in the book.

"Are you okay?"

When I turned my gaze, there was Jaire with a worried expression on his face.

"...Yes, what."

Did I misunderstand?

No. On the night of the banquet, Ricdorian's face was sincere. I'm not stupid enough not to notice this. However, I wondered if he had any other reason besides resenting me for not keeping my promise.

If that's the case, I think he'd be a little upset. Me too.

"Are you offended by the blue rose question? If it was rude...."

"No."

I lowered my gaze and whispered softly.

Chapter 165: Ricdorian's Truth

1. Ricdorian's Truth

“It does not matter.”

Ricdorian stopped his lips that was about to say no.

“For whatever reason you brought me here.”

He had to say no. He thinks she misunderstood something.

It's a misunderstanding, it's not true, and it's not at all.

“In this situation, I don't think you need to listen to it very much.”

Long eyelashes fell down on Iana's purple eyes. It is a calm face that is not different from usual.

“Isn't it?”

It was dull and indifferent on a white and pale face. They drove him crazy.

She won't know. How she truly drives Ricdorian crazy.

Ricdorian bit his lips. His senses were never wrong.

So, as soon as she heard Jaire, Iana must have misunderstood something.

Did he bring her as the Blue Rose?

Ha, it's ridiculous.

Even if Iana was a slave in the slums of Ropel Street, the lowest point of the Empire, filled with polluted water. Even if she was in the Asqar Coal Mine, the worst slave colony where she could never get freedom once she entered. Even if she was in the worst crime city of Cantala.

He would have searched the world and found her. Whether she is noble or in the lowest position. Ricdorian, no matter what, would have brought her. He already didn't care who Iana was.

When she is just her.

She was meaningful just because she was her.

“Hmm, I must have been quite a meaningful being.”

The one who finally stopped what they were trying to say is not Ricdorian.

“That's interesting.”

Because that seemingly indifferent face looked like it doesn't seem to matter.

He wanted to be in those eyes that seemed to see everything from afar. He always tried.

<You know where I am.>

4 years ago or 3 years ago. And not long ago in Schirmela.

However, the result was always the same.

An indifferent face.

<I told you, Grand Duke.>

Eyes that don't care about anything.

<I had no intention of keeping my promise to you.>

Until the hand that finally pushed him away.

Ricdorian clenched his fist. He wanted to do bad things. No, he wanted to be bad for her.

Even so, if she would see him, he'd rather be the worst human being to her.

...If he can't get her by begging in the end.

Then...

Why? *Rattle*. He was scared. Can this be done? Because he said he hated her because he was resentful. To her, to that kind of person.

Is it worth it? If he really hates her. His hand grabbed his face.

Countless thoughts swirled in Ricdorian. Unpredictable things overflow like waves.

<You useless bastard.>

Ricdorian's shoulders twitched like a seizure.

A dark room, frantically twinkling stars pass by his sight. It wasn't a star in the sky. That star....

Because she didn't make him suffer.

It was the time when his father was alive, he didn't even know that pain was pain.

Ricdorian just stopped walking.

“Well then, miss. Get a good rest. I'll serve you without lack.”

Jaire had already finished explaining everything. Even about Hernim had been looking for the Blue Rose for a long time.

Ricdorian did not stop.

He just concentrated on Iana's still, unchanging, calm face.

In the end, looking at the casual face, he clenched and opened his fist once more.

As he walked down the hallway, Jaire kept his eyes on him. As someone who has been with him for a long time, he was sensitive to the changes in Ricdorian.

Ricdorian sneered inwardly.

Like this, even though he pretends to be visible, why can't she see him?

"Well, Your Excellency. Are you in too much of a hurry?"

Ricdorian did not answer.

The whereabouts of the Blue Rose have long been famous. It wasn't famous because it existed somewhere, but it was famous because it didn't exist.

A rose that has disappeared from this world.

But what the 'roses' knew was different.

The moment one becomes the head of the rose family, one learns something. It was also something that Ricdorian also came to know when he qualified for his ranks and ascended to the rank of Grand Duke.

The fact that only the Black Rose knew the whereabouts of the 'Blue Rose'.

Perhaps the current Marquis of Valtaze and the fleeing White Rose, the head of Rosenia.

And that man, the Duke of Domulit, must have known of course.

"No, he already had it."

Through long research, Hernim found out that the Blue Rose's dynasty was maintained and that it was strictly protected.

But no more was known. One thing he found out after much hard work and effort.

The former Duke of Domulit had only one son, and nonetheless had a daughter.

Could it be the Blue Rose?

It didn't take long from the careful reasoning to the groundbreaking investigation.

“Your Excellency.”

Someone quietly called Ricdorian.

Before Ricdorian's eyes, there was a man with dark green hair.

It was Shero, a subordinate in charge of Hernim's agents.

“I finally figured it out.”

There was a rare joy in his face as blunt as a hound that rolled wildly in the field.

“It's what you most wanted.”

Well, if that's what he wanted. There will be only one at this moment.

Ricdorian's scorn. It is Iana's appearance, the detached and gloomy face passing by and pink hair. He himself knew it was quite serious.

What should he do?

It was a fever that he had before he even realized it.

Ricdorian took the papers coldly and scanned them. It was a more indifferent and insensitive face than usual.

However, as he read the documents, his waist straightened. Ricdorian's eyes opened wide enough that they couldn't grow any longer.

"...is this true?"

"Yes, it's finally revealed."

Shero nodded his head.

"You don't know how thorough Domulit's surveillance is."

Chaser Louve Domulit's stronghold was stronger than any other castle in the world.

The culmination point was the mansion where he was staying.

Those who were sent in during that time either died or went missing. For over a year, Hernim changed the way, They chose not to contact those who were sent in.

"How thorough was the guardian deity of Domulit during that time. It was the same as the Duke of Domulit himself."

It was because the moment they tried to contact them, they knew that they were brutally killed by the guardian deity of Duke of Domulit.

This also came by the countless sacrifices.

Shero reported what was not included in the report in addition to what was written in the report.

"I only found out after two years. Did the infiltrating agent return safely... Your Excellency?"

However, Ricdorian listened to nothing at all. No, he turned his back without hearing everything.

The steps moved quickly. His steps with the power of a rose are incomparable to that of an ordinary person.

He went across the hallway he had come from in an instant.

The more he walked, the more his breathing became harsher. He was blessed with the Red Rose and was born with a constitution that does not tire.

– *Report on Iana Rose Domullet.*

So this breath sound is only what he made consciously.

– *Confinement.*

<Hello, Iana. I am going to kidnap you from now on.>

Strangely here. However, the speed just felt slow or whether he was running fast.

– *Shackles at the ankles.*

<... Won't you tie me up?>

His breath caught his jaw as if he was drowning.

– *Put on shackles and chains,*

<I'm a hostage. So shouldn't I be tied up?>

She has not changed so much in the past three years, has her personality really not changed?

– *Couldn't leave the mansion for even an hour.*

<If you're going to tie me up, it'd be nice to do it in the ankles.>

Ricdorian was much smarter than Iana thought. His brain was fine.

He was ignorant of common sense even during the time he was with her, and he had a beastly sense of humor.

-The Black Rose's surveillance looks so terribly obsessive.

A strange sense of incongruity that he felt briefly at this moment completed a puzzle.

Number of times away from the mansion.

-0 times.

Creak. He opened the door.

“Haa... haa...”

He doesn't think he ran that hard. No. Born in this world, he ran the most desperately.

Just for one other person.

In the quiet room, Iana sat like a painting.

He looked at her and was always enjoying her contemplation. He came here and thought she didn't care for him.

– Estimated that there wasn't much that could be done in the mansion.

<I want to wear a prison uniform.>

When asked if she had anything she wanted, he still thought she was an absurd person.

If one thing....

If all she wanted was to go back to the cramped cell. No, if she wanted to go back to the time when she was laughing freely over the bars....

What had he done?

Ricdorian's face was horribly contorted. It was blurry.

<Because you don't see me.>

He hated Chaser Louve Domulit. He was so disillusioned and hated that he couldn't help but hate him.

<I have to hate you.>

But what makes him different from Chaser?

<Don't you think so?>

His hand that held that slender hand under the moonlight, his smile.

What did he do to her, using the fault and hatred as a shield?

He felt ugly.

“...Ricdorian?”

Quang. Unable to overcome his power, the door knocked on the wall again.

That was then. Iana's face, who had been looking out the window, turned to this side indifferently.

Even when she called his name, she didn't hide her surprise.

Kidnap.

Ricdorian realized at that moment.

In fact. He hopes she doesn't hate him.

“What's wrong with... you?”

I didn't want to leave you as a bad person.

I just.

“...sorry.”

I missed you.

“I’m sorry... sorry...”

The man’s hand covered his face, and his large body collapsed like a piece of crumbling skin.

“Ricdorian?”

Tap, tap, the sound of Iana’s small footsteps rushing, was so light. He couldn’t stand the rush of things.

What the hell did he do?

“What’s wrong, where does it really hurt? Huh? Does it hurt a lot?”

She was very kind to the sick. Four years ago, when she came to the basement where there was no light, he wondered if she was the light, the spring, and the day.

He has never felt such warmth in his entire life.

He wanted to catch it.

He became terribly disgusted with himself.

However, he didn’t want to let go of the hand reaching out to him. It was a hand that he did not want to let go, even if it was wrinkly and dirty.

Iana stayed still on his body when she came to him in an instant. Just like the day they promised four years ago.

“It’s my fault.”

He asked himself. Did he have no choice but to be hated?

No.

Tears dripped down his cheeks.

“Don’t throw me away.”

There was no other way but to beg.

“Please.....”

To beg again and again.

Chapter 166: I want to do well

1. 1. I want to do well

My hesitant hand rested on Ricdorian's shoulder.

‘What do I do.’

I have no talent for comfort. I don't know exactly why he's crying, telling me not to go so sadly.

I know that it's serious enough for someone who wouldn't even open their mouth and go out coldly.

To me, this is a hand as gentle as sunlight. It's a healing hand. I thought back to myself, and patted his shoulder awkwardly.

In the book, he was a man without tears. He was always just, like the tip of the silver sword that was only toward the right. It was really surprising to see the man like this.

This man's childhood was unhappy, and it was by no means easy. Nevertheless, I was both curious and sad about his upright nature. Even though it was a rated-19 novel mixed with tragedy, it didn't mean that the protagonist's character wasn't revealed.

At times, it felt like he was trying to force himself to be just. He was like a beast standing on top of a cliff.

The person who once did so is wretchedly collapsed and was held in my arms. Messed up as if he had been lost out of an unparalleled fight.

Judging by his drooping shoulders... I don't think it's time to ask.

I chose to offer comfort so quietly. Even if it was clumsy, I hope it's delivered.

Please, I hope that the awkwardness will be quickly erased and that you will feel gentle and good for a long time.

For a very long time.

My shoulders were wet, but I didn't care. It's clothes. I can change.

Ricdorian buried his face in my shoulder and didn't know how to remove it.

Since this happened, I wanted to cry my heart out too.

'More than that... It's huge.'

Taking advantage of the moment when his trembling had subsided, I spread his hands apart and measured the length.

It's not exact, but it seems bigger than what I remember. Compared to the grown-up version of him I encountered briefly four years ago.

So, it was Ricdorian who dug into me, but it became something that I did not know whether he was holding me or whether I was buried in him.

I think this has happened before....

As I was thinking about it, Ricdorian raised his head.

I looked at his face carelessly and stopped.

"...Iana...."

His wrinkled face was messed up with tears. Red ears, cheeks, and under the eyes, under the disheveled silver hair....

It was breathtakingly terrifying and sensational.

The neat face, which was always neat and even holy, is so messed up.

I took a deep breath. It's not a time like this, but I couldn't help but feel a little nervous while thinking about it.

Ricdorian carefully took my hand.

Being careful, feeble, and not strong enough to remind me of the time I was in prison 4 years ago.

Then he placed my hand on his cheek, moist with tears.

"Please, don't leave me."

Water dripped from my fingertips. The quivering eyelashes opened slowly. In the meantime, cold transparent eyes were revealed.

"...Huh?"

... To say something like that all of a sudden. I wanted to chase this tension even with an odd sound.

Or it felt like my fingertips would tremble.

"...why are you suddenly saying this?"

"Because it was from the beginning."

It was as if I was suffocating, the strange air was pulling my neck upright.

"I wanted to keep doing this."

you wanted to do this?

"...I told you I won't forgive."

He confessed softly.

"Someone who hurts me."

I closed my mouth.

“It’s good to be just, but when it’s difficult, I’d rather be a villain, so I’ve been doing that all along.”

As you say. And it seemed that I could hear the omitted words.

“When you asked to forget our parting and leave only good memories, I reflected only the memories with you thousands of times.”

I have kept all your words like a scripture.

“...”

“Even on the day you didn’t keep your promise.”

His voice slowly lowered.

“But Iana... I don’t think I can only hate you.”

It was a pitiful sound, like a rough scratch on the inside of his throat.

You still remember my words. 4 years or so.

The feeling of the arrow I shot coming back to me was mysterious and difficult, and it brought a strange excitement.

“Iana, please.”

He grabbed my hand with one hand, wrapped it around the other, and dug into my arms again.

“Don’t leave....”

The weight was on my shoulders, but it felt like I had a stone on my heart. Perhaps he has become so desperate over time. The words didn’t come out right.

I noticed this moment. That this is a moment of choice that has been put on hold.

– Can't you... answer? If not.

It was time to choose

– You're not...answering?

Are you going back to Chaser?

Or stay with Ricdorian.

The worries didn't last long. No, the answer came naturally.

“....alright.”

I've always done what my heart desires.

Even in prison. Even in the shackled Domulit mansion.

“I will be here.”

At the same time, in the corner of my head, the thought of going back to Domulit was strong against my will.

However, it was ignored. At least, it was the first place I wanted to be with my will.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

He raised his head and asked me, with a face that looked like he couldn't believe it.

‘When did I ever break a promise?’, I tried to say that but I stopped.

‘Ah. I didn't keep it, right.’

I briefly reflected on my lack of conscience.

I wasn't depressed. Will I have to make the same mistake again in the future?

"...really, so don't make a face like that."

I'm sorry that I can't give him trust either. I shut my mouth when I tried to add this.

He was staring at me with his languid eyes. Locking me in a hug so big that he no longer feels like a boy again.

... Obviously he rushed in first, when did this happen?

A suffocating silence subsided. It was a silence with a different meaning than before.

"Yes. Now you're by my side."

His eyes held me persistently. While observing and staring meticulously, as if not to miss a single strand of hair.

"By my side...."

A smile appeared on his face, which had been messed up with tears.

The smile mixed with despair that comes after crying was as neat and enchanting as the forget-me-not plant that bloomed after the spring rain.

"Iana."

While I was distracted by that smile, he lowered his head slightly.

It was after his face got closer when I thought 'Oops'.

"... Can I do it?"

As a Grand Duke, no, as an adult, the words evoked a ripple effect beyond imagination.

This one stimulates the strange imagination. Plus, I can see a solid line through the white shirt....

I wanted to avoid his gaze, but there was nowhere to escape.

“...I told you not make me misunderstand.”

I was forced to meet his eyes.

“Don’t you remember this?”

No, I can’t be fooled.

“So can I do it?”

No, so. What.

The words I was about to ask were erased by his neat smile. It was also a very wild smile.

“...Alright. Do it. Do it.”

No matter what, the moment that contains the words ‘do it’.

A soft thing came down on my lips.

As I was afraid to inhale and make a ‘heup’ sound, I parted my lower lip and something entered.

When I opened my eyes, Ricdorian, who was looking at me, slowly opened his eyes. As if I had allowed it.

At the same time, a strong arm dug into my waist.

I thought about raising my hand and grabbing the swaying hair, but that thought quickly faded.

It’s because he didn’t let me think about it.

He grabbed my waist and lifted me up. A sigh escaped from his lips, which had fallen for a moment.

It was because his physical strength was far less than the one he seemed to be good at.

All of a sudden, Ricdorian, who had me on one leg with his knee up, was looking up at me from below.

I backed away with an ‘uhk’ sound, and my back hit the wall. A small vibration passed over the leg that touched it.

It was because Ricdorian laughed softly and came over.

“Iana.”

A low hoarse voice called me. I felt the thrill as if ice was thrown into my heart.

“...I want to do well.”

“What?”

I frowned slightly. In the meantime, Ricdorian carefully clasped my hands and tilted my upper body.

He had to bend quite a bit because he was so much bigger, but he didn’t seem to care.

“Can’t you tell me?”

His eyes, brittle with tears, drew a half moon.

“Huh? Let me know.”

His blushing face was a mixture of shyness and sarcasm. I swallowed a gulp.

Tell you what? If you don't know the meaning of this, you're going to be an idiot.

... Oh look, this looks like a well-prepared table. Can I rush in because it smells good?

I happened to be seduced by a handsome man in front of me, but he said he had no business with it. I kept tilting.

Then I suddenly realized. The Ricdorian I see now has a very different smile and a completely different facial expression compared to when he first ran to this room.

It's like seeing the growth mode that was forced by magic 4 years ago....

It looked like I was going to blush at the darkly maturing appearance, but a strange red warning light sounded the alarm.

But there was no time to think long. Because Ricdorian took my hand and rubbed it against his lips.

"You allowed it."

He blinked his eyes languidly.

"I want Iana to tell me. Can't you tell me?"

Pulling up the red lips from tears, with a rustling voice.

"Until I do well."

Chapter 167: The three shadows of Ricdorian

1. 1. 1. 1. The three shadows of Ricdorian

...what is this man saying now? I stared at him with bewildered eyes.

I have no idea what this man was talking about.

As such, why was his will so explicit?

The first problem is.

‘You must have misunderstood!’

The point was that there was a lot of room for misunderstanding in the content of the words.

In particular, there were words that I did not know how far my imagination would go. As evidence of that, the delusions in my head were running wild like a runaway locomotive.

If Ricdorian hadn’t been holding my hand, I’d have rubbed his face recklessly.

It felt like I didn’t know what to do.

‘When his body grew this big.’

I didn’t even blink an eye despite all of Chaser’s wishes, but that didn’t work out for Ricdorian.

It doesn't feel the same though. Even though they both smiled ecstatically, their feelings were completely different.

Chaser was a man born with temptation, sly and friendly, and smiled as if he would melt people gently.

As much as he is good at smiling, when he sheds tears, even me, who was gloomy, used to lose my gaze for a moment.

On the other hand, Ricdorian was stingy with his smile.

It was the same 4 years ago, so even though he looked shy and puzzled, he didn't smile as well as I thought.

That's why his smiles were rare, and the laughter that seemed to be tempting was even rarer.

Even not so long ago, he was very cold to me. It was just terrifying to see such a contrast.

'Is it all over if I get more demanding?'

I tried to grumble inside so as not to take my gaze away. It was of no use.

Ricdorian kept his lips still in my hands instead of taking them further.

If I were to guess, I think he's waiting....

'Is what you are doing the same as Pudding before you feed it?'

It was something that would make Pudding angry if it heard it, but Pudding is sleeping inside me now.

Very occasionally, it would be quiet, similar to a sleep, but this is no different from the act of sleeping in humans, so I described it as sleeping.

Seeing that Aquala and Ratan did not do this, I wondered if it was because it signed a contract with someone who was not its real owner.

By the way, the way he waited patiently was no different from that of the little guardian deity of the Red Rose.

It's just that those blue eyes are so desperate.

One of Ricdorian's hands loosened and I took advantage of it and pulled my hand out.

I placed my hand on his chin and over his eyes.

"...don't look at me like that, please."

The words that came out after hesitation were weak even when I heard them.

Ricdorian, blindfolded, raised only the tips of his lips.

"What kind of look?"

"Don't smile like that."

Ricdorian grabbed my blinding hand, lowered it slightly, and tilted his head at an angle.

"Then, will you like it?"

The moment I looked at the half-closed eyes, I was out of breath.

...It's more erotic than half-stripping.

The half-closed gaze felt more dense.

If this wasn't a luxurious room, I would have mistaken it for the prison cell. I overlooked the fact that Ricdorian was quite big.

.....is this a dog or a human?

The second problem from here.

Something was strange.

‘...I’m sure it’s Ricdorian.’

Clearly, the one in front of me was Ricdorian, but the feeling was different.

He was the same person as the cold man, until he started tearing up a little while ago and told me not to go.

At least it didn’t feel out of sync.

However, looking up at me now, he had a different feeling.

If I was to find the same impression....

It was similar to when I first met him after he grew up after casting magic in the prison 4 years ago.

No. It was the same.

‘If only he grew up as he was then.’

I think this is what he would look like.

There wasn’t much time to think. Because Ricdorian didn’t let my hand stand still.

I hesitated and stroked his hair. First of all, I don’t think we’re going to bump our lips as recklessly as we did a while ago.

‘I didn’t hate it, though.’

However, he did not show a cold appearance or a seemingly rational appearance at first glance.

After spending three years with Chaser, my senses for people were very well developed.

It was an environment in which a person who had been quietly serving until yesterday can put poison and hold a dagger to one's neck.

"Iana."

He called me in a low voice. After that, the low and hoarse voice made my shoulders tremble without realizing it.

"How long can I wait?"

Ricdorian rolled his eyes.

"Isn't this supposed to happen?"

His thumb gently rubbed my palm.

"I think I like this side more."

His thumb stopped at the inside of my wrist, where my pulse was pounding.

"Your heart."

What do you mean you like it more? I licked my dry lips and lightly patted his head.

"Okay. Step back for now."

"Why?"

"Why? I have to get up. My legs hurt."

Then Ricdorian was hesitant and retreated. No, I thought so, but I was wrong.

My body floated up and I was seated on something hard yet warm. It was on his thigh.

"Are you comfortable here?"

His messy hair wiggled, covering his eyes slightly, then revealing them again.

We got so close that I could even feel the sound of his breathing again.

“...I don’t want to fall.”

Also, it was weird. It’s not that I hate it, but this was a change that made me jump.

It was a feeling that many aspects coexisted but did not harmonize.

As his breath draws closer, *click*.

A sound was heard from the door.

Bump.

“Your Excellency.”

The door opened, and Jaire, who appeared, stopped trying to come in.

Maybe it’s because he just found us, our lips barely touching. I wanted to sigh.

A vibration occurred in the face when Jaire looked sideways.

Even if I said that seeing wasn’t everything, I thought it would be too late.

“Your Excellency....”

Jaire laughed awkwardly.

We’re too close now, so I couldn’t see Ricdorian’s expression well, but I can see that the smile was gone.

“You’re an adult now, aren’t you?”

At that moment, Ricdorian and I looked at Jaire with a cold expression on our faces, as if we had promised.

No, I can't see Ricdorian's well, but I did.

With one heart.

What are you saying now?

“Ummm...”

After a while, the three of us had an unintentional three-way encounter.

“It's a misunderstanding.”

Correction. To be precise, it was a face-to-face meeting between me and Jaire. It's because Ricdorian fell asleep with his body buried in me.

<Your Excellency?>

Not even a minute after Jaire came in, and as soon as we sat face to face on the sofa, Ricdorian leaned his head against my body and closed his eyes.

At first I thought he had only closed his eyes, but the next moment I heard a deep breath.

<Did he sleep?>

He fell asleep. It's also very deep. I wondered if I could do this in a few seconds, but I wondered if I truly could.

“Miss?”

Instead of replying to Jaire, I was just looking at Ricdorian, and Jaire said something.

“...he hasn't been able to sleep.”

I then turned my head.

I just looked at Ricdorian, wondering if it would be okay because he was sleeping so uncomfortably.

“Why can’t he sleep?”

Is he very busy? I remembered Ricdorian last time. He came to my room every day... I thought it wasn’t a very busy time.

“Because he’s busy. And he didn’t want to sleep.”

“Didn’t want to sleep?”

“Yes.”

“No way. Not even a nod?”

“Yes. He hasn’t slept at all.”

At the subtle nuance, I asked, just in case. And a surprising answer came back.

“He’s been sitting leaning all night in front of the door to your room.”

“Yes?”

“We, we’ll stand for him, no matter how much we said, he didn’t listen.”

Jaire shook his head sullenly. Ricdorian said he would do it, so who would win against him?

“...it’s been a week since I’ve been here.”

No matter how much Ricdorian had the stamina of a beast. He haven’t slept the whole time?

No one can survive without sleeping for six days. It must have been possible because it was Ricdorian.

“Yes.”

Judging by Jaire’s expression, it must have never been an easy task for him.

“Why?”

“That’s, because he doesn’t want you to disappear.”

Jaire said with a laugh. Only one eye was serious.

“Even if the miss escapes, I wondered whether or not he would be able to catch you, regardless of whether the escape would succeed.”

“Why is that again?”

“He doesn’t want us to look at you, how can we do that?”

I’m at a loss for words. In the meantime, Ricdorian stubbornly brings meals to me everyday.

What I threw flashed in my mind.

It was a really distant feeling.

Originally, people would choose to escape or hold back when confronted with something they couldn’t understand.

I kept my lips shut. There were a lot of things I wanted to ask, but I didn’t want to ask Jaire.

After a brief pause, I decided to ask something else.

“There is something else I want to ask you.”

The way I talk wasn’t very sophisticated, but Jaire was happy to accept it.

‘Jaire knew about the Blue Rose.’

I was comparing the Blue Rose with Ricdorian a while ago, and I chose one first.

Let's ask something urgent.

"Didn't Ricdorian feel a little strange a while ago?"

"What do you mean strange?"

Jaire's attitude changed. He seems to be a faithful right-hand man. His eyes were serious. He took it as seriously as I responded.

I quickly explained Ricdorian's condition a while ago.

"If I have to find the same example, it feels like I was faced with the grown up him in the person 4 years ago, right?"

"Yes...you mean the side effects?"

"Yes. That's how it looked. It was definitely different from the way he looked when I first entered the room."

"I see."

Jaire laughed bitterly. I widened my eyes.

"You have a good sense. Some people don't recognize it at first glance."

It was a calm acceptance. First of all, it was a tone of bitterness.

"Don't recognize it."

"Yes. It's exactly what you think."

His smiling face was clouded for the first time.

"You will remember that four years ago, his personality was divided into three parts."

He stretched out his three fingers.

The appearance of a beast that speaks, the appearance of rational him, and the appearance of grown up him.

I remembered everything.

“Four years later, those personalities are still not all united.”

I blinked my eyes wide. All of Jaire’s fingers stretched out and his hand pointed at me.

His eyes seemed to speak.

Ricdorian is still experiencing personality confusion.

And this has to do with me.

Chapter 168: Worst problem, worst conclusion

1. 1. 1. 1. Worst problem, worst conclusion

I asked without hesitation. It would be better to ask this directly.

“Is it related to me now?”

Four years ago, when I met him.

There may be many other things besides my involvement, but there must be a reason why Jaire pointed out that it was 4 years ago.

The Jaire I knew was not an easy-going person.

Look at what he did with that good face four years ago in Kambrakan.

At that time too, he made me go to the dungeon at dawn with such a smile.

“Haha, there’s nothing to be vigilant about. Miss.”

Instead of answering him, a strange word flowed out. Jaire waved his hands at me.

As if he was trying to break boundaries.

But I did not fall for it.

“You didn’t answer. May I ask you one more time?”

“Hmm. Really, you’re a girl who seems like you’re going to let it go, but don’t let any gaps.”

Is it because Ricdorian is asleep? His tone softened a little.

Just like the day we had a comfortable conversation in the cell. I didn’t care if he was or not.

“So it’s my fault?”

Jaire stared at me for a moment.

“The Miss’ fault...”

A brief but playful smile faded from his face. With good-looking eyes, the seriousness was vivid.

“Well, to be honest, I don’t know.”

I frowned.

“You don’t know?”

No, you have to make it clear, whether it’s yes or no. What do you mean you don’t know? The answer that stayed in the gray area felt strange.

“There are so many suspicious factors since four years ago that I can’t even guess what it is. Miss.”

“Many?”

“Yes. I thought the Miss was one of the factors, but I don’t know if it’s entirely your fault.”

The words that seemed to catch a floating cloud made me feel more distant.

“What is it? What is that factor? Don’t be vague, talk about it properly.”

I don't know, I'm a person who knows nothing but direct fastballs. Face it directly or completely avoid it.

There's nothing good about being ambiguous.

I didn't want to say it again.

"I explained this to the Miss four years ago. His Excellency's beast-like appearance you saw in the cell is like a curse that is passed down from generation to generation."

"Yes."

He never explained it in detail, but he did say that. I even knew what Jaire didn't explain.

"His Excellency is strangely born with that curse particularly strong."

I remembered the guardian deity sleeping inside me.

....This is probably due to the loss of Pudding.

"Anyway, in order to lift this curse, that is, to unify the personality, three things were necessary."

"Three things..."

Jaire said 'let me explain', and spread his three fingers.

"First, a strong body capable of withstanding the consciousness ahead of awakening."

I thought of the time when Ricdorian met the female lead. It was definitely after he became an adult.

"Second, to unravel the constraint given from birth."

Jaire tapped his neck with his index and middle fingers. I nodded when asked if I remembered what was around Ricdorian's neck.

“Thirdly, the existence of a ‘companion’.”

Jaire’s finger now had only one index finger left.

Third? Companion?

It was a little strange.

“Ah, this part must be unfamiliar.”

Jaire continued to explain the ‘companion’, perhaps because I didn’t understand it.

Of course, there was no way I didn’t know anything about the companion.

How can I not know? It was the key between the female lead and the male lead.

“...that’s why it’s a soul-contracted relationship between lovers. It’s a lifelong existence.”

“Ah yes.”

Jaire’s explanation was a bit strange.

Why was he explaining the restraints and companions separately?

Aren’t these two concepts tied together?

In the book, Francia unties the restraint device that Ricdorian had been wearing since birth.

And she later explained that she was able to release the restraint because she was his ‘companion’.

But now Jaire’s explanation is.....

“In his case, this is where the problem arises.”

Jaire's face grew serious.

"What's wrong?"

"As his body grew, he had a strong body that could withstand the awakening. And I used magic to calm down even his unusually strong power.... thanks to the Miss."

I put the question on hold and focused on him.

"And the day has come. The person who appeared in the dungeon, who helped remove the restraint."

.... it's Francia

As in the original story, it must be when the two met in Kambrakam. So now Ricdorian would have become the Grand Duke.

What's wrong with this?

"The problem is here, here the worst problems arise."

I took a breath.

The main character of this story, Ricdorian, was still silently asleep.

"The worst thing is that the 'companion' and the person who released the restraint are different."

I flinched my hand.

I hoped that Ricdorian would not wake up from my trembling. I glanced at him, then shifted my gaze.

"...different."

"Literally."

Jaire didn't explain further.

He must have thought that it was a fact that I could know enough without explaining it.

As Jaire thought, I felt things he didn't say.

Enough to feel no more.

"What conclusions would you draw from this?"

"....."

"The curse is always lifted when the conditions are met. A strong body, a person who loosens the restraint and a companion must be consistent."

I licked my lips.

"The worst problem. Worst conclusion."

Even though he spoke in a voice that wasn't cold at all, I felt as cold as an ice cube.

"No one expected it. The fact that the person who released the restraint device and the companion will be different people."

Jaire laughed bitterly.

"Haha... Another problem is that it's hard to find examples like this even throughout a thousand years of history."

He gently rubbed his face with the hem of his sleeve. He seemed to be trying to calm himself.

"From the outside, it doesn't seem like much of a problem. But the occasional impulsive appearance puts him in a dangerous situation..."

He let out a long breath.

"He's strong, but he can't always be as safe as his enemy."

Enemy, instead of putting Domulit in his mouth, he said enemy. He doesn't have to be so considerate.

Some of the doubts were cleared by Jaire's explanation. There was one thing that was still unresolved.

"I'm concerned that he will lose his reason once in a while and surrender to his impulses. Very concerned."

Didn't Pudding say Ricdorian needs it to complete the awakening?

Originally, there was no guardian deity that naturally existed in the body of the successor of the Red Rose. No companion was there either.

Nevertheless, the restraint was released and he became what he was now.

"Is Ricdorian's current state also unstable in power?"

"No. His Excellency has awakened. His strength is a complete Red Rose."

This was in line with what Pudding said.

That he awakened.

"...how is that possible?"

"Because His Excellency endured the hell-like side effects and somehow managed to make it through."

Jaire said quietly. But his voice was not serene.

"Hell-like side effects?"

If it was in the past, I would have passed it over. I wouldn't have bothered to listen.

But nevertheless I asked.

"That.."

Jaire flapped his lips. He stopped trying to speak his words.

“Haa, it’s something you should listen from His Excellency. It’s not something I’m going to tell you.”

Saying that, Jaire had a face that didn’t seem likely to answer any more questions.

I gave up neatly and asked for something else.

“It’s a bit of an odd question, but the person who loosened the restraint. Ricdorian is not in love with that person, right?”

There was certainty in my words. Maybe that’s why, even though it was an odd question, he replied while tilting his head.

“Of course, isn’t that obvious?”

On that face that seemed absurd as what kind of question this is, I covered it with a smile.

Oh, as expected.

I guessed it from Ricdorian’s condition. The relationship between the two main characters in the original story seems to be different from what I know.

Because I didn’t think this guy was the kind of person who would fall in love with two people at once.

So ‘companion’.

Uh, um...

I wiped my cheek.

‘It sounds like he was saying it’s me by elimination method.’

But soon a smile leaks out.

Is there any way to get out?

‘I’m the only candidate and there is no other choice....’

Maybe I like this helpless beast. Without a second thought, I wanted to slap the nose of this big, puppy-like beast that was sleeping without a care.

– Hoaam, human? What’s going on? There are strong emotions. Nyang....

‘You woke up?’”

Just at the same time, Pudding that had been sleeping inside me had woken up.

‘You woke up well. Let’s get one blow.’

– Nyang? Wh, what do you mean?

You can’t hit someone who’s sleeping so soundly. I made up my mind only after saying one nonsense.

After that, a calm exhalation escaped me.

“That’s right, Jaire.”

There is one more thing to check. No, this was an assumption.

“Are you saying he doesn’t bark anymore?”

It doesn’t seem like Ricdorian is barking like a dog anymore, given the context.

“Yes, maybe. I haven’t seen anything like that in years.”

“That’s a relief.”

If it were, it would have been difficult to go out in public. It didn’t look like that.

‘It means two things.’

In the end, what has been divided now seems to be, one whether there is reason, or two; whether it acts like an animal with only instinct left without reason.

“If the ‘companion’ reappears, is there any way to turn it around?”

I held my breath for a moment and then asked.

“A way to integrate the personality.”

“No.”

Jaire’s answer was too firm.

Chapter 169: Not solved yet

106. Not solved yet

“The opportunity has already passed. As long as the restraint has been released, there is no way to use the method.”

In Hernim, Ricdorian was given the restraint, and he needed the ‘companion’ to release it.

There is no way to return the constraint that has already been released.

“Now, even if a ‘companion’ appears... there won’t be anything to be done other than make his powers more stable.”

It is said that this was the conclusion that Jaire and Hernim’s aides found after searching tens of thousands of documents for several years.

“Miss, I’m just saying this just in case. Our search for a way has nothing to do with His Excellency’s search for the Miss.”

“Yes, well. Ricdorian doesn’t see me as a tool. You want to say something like that, right?”

At my blunt words, Jaire flinched, then nodded his head.

“Yes.”

I didn’t misunderstand.

There’s nothing else to.

I captured Ricdorian's face, who was sleeping carelessly, and then lifted my head.

He sleeps very well. Beating me.

"He looks uncomfortable."

Anyway, the conversation had to end.

"Isn't there a way?"

"...After much thought and failure, I have found one thing."

Oh, it's not that there is no way. So I listened.

Jaire stared at me with a serious face.

We talked and started.

"After much deliberation, I thought about the existence of the 'Blue Rose'."

'Worst problem. Worst conclusion.'

I've been thinking about one thing all the time. All of these were the words Jaire had spoken.

He knows very well what Ricdorian looks like when he loses his temper.

He's always been a good listener, but when he's like this, he listens less, is a little foolish, and impulsive....

It was also the appearance that embarrassed me the most.

Anyway, after hearing Jaire's story, it's been a while since I've organized my thoughts and realized something.

....Usually, wasn't this the worst outcome?

I am not trying to take Ricdorian's problem lightly. Strictly looking at the situation, Ricdorian is currently doing well as the Grand Duke.

Whether it's position or achievements. With Chaser raising his hand so frighteningly.

Of course, Jaire said that this was done fairly narrowly, but in any case, it was a success in the grand scheme of things and that's how they came all the way here.

The successes so far, and the dangers that may come in the near future, usually cannot be said to be the 'worst results'.

Dangerous but cautious, I don't know.

Moreover, Jaire was not a person who made a fuss.

He was a man who knew how to hit and fall with a smile. His connection and disconnection are accurate.

A man with accurate calculations cannot say the 'worst' hastily.

I concluded.

'There's something you didn't tell me.'

Thinking like this, my thoughts were right. He always pretended to be serious, but he didn't say the most important thing.

This sly human being.

Well. It wasn't something I didn't understand.

Even so....

Even thinking about it, my fingertips tickled.

No, it was tickling a while ago, but now it's gotten to the point where I can't just ignore it.

I shook my head.

“Excuse me.”

At this, someone who had their head bowed like me raised his head together. The silver hair was scattered.

“Are you mad at me?”

At my question, Ricdorian slowly closed his blue eyes and opened them.

....I don't know what kind of beast it is, but his beauty is really amazing.

The movement of the eyelashes, which resembled the color of the hair, evoked admiration as if a sculpture was brought to life.

“... not warmed up.”

Ricdorian muttered. It was nice to hear the sound of a nice voice.

I wish I could hear the words coming out of those lips.

I clenched my chin.

“You kissed me on the lips, but are you saying you hadn't warmed up?”

At those words, Ricdorian turned his face, which had hardened cold. The tip of the ear, which was so pure white, was dyed red.

Just like the petals of a camellia flower.

Looking like this, he looks like a moron, but on the rational side. As he did 4 years ago, his personality seemed to change, but his memories seemed to be shared.

The reddened cheeks were proof.

“I, I didn't warm up.”

“Who says what?”

I clenched my chin and grinned. Laughter came out of nowhere.

‘Why are your cheeks blushing when you say you’re not warmed up?’

It seems that the person who ran to the room that day was the one with the rational side.

I mean, he’s really changed.

As he grew up, his destructive power was terrifying.

I glanced at the hand.

‘Holding hands.’

Ricdorian turned his head and held my hand tightly. I confess, this man, as soon as he entered my room 10 minutes ago, he was like this.

He opened the door and entered cautiously, squatting next to me, looking out the window, and holding my fingertips.

Then, because I didn’t see him, he twitched his hand and rubbed my thumb gently.

Even the dog who licked a hand for the first time wouldn’t do this.

Then I asked if he was upset, and he said no again.

“Excuse me, Grand Duke. You said your anger didn’t go away.”

I moved my fingertips slightly. He flinched.

“Why don’t you let go of your hand?”

His head slowly turned towards me. He looked at me and covered my face with the back of his other hand.

“I haven’t warmed up...”

Even if he tried to cover it up, I looked at the colors under his eyes, but he turned his head away again.

“...Your hand is holding me as you please.”

Oh my, he was making this kind of nonsense. The Grand Duke.

I held back the laughter that was about to come out. It couldn’t be helped that a smirk leaked out.

Wow. Our male lead seems to have separate personalities between his hands and head.

Following the triple personality four years ago; four years later, now, he has given a personality to his hands.

I wondered if he was born from an egg and was thrown a pine cone as a dagger.

Grr. Grr.

There were two beasts under my feet. For some reason, the Grand Duke was the same as Ricdorian, who sat on the edge of the chair.

He put his head next to my ankles and groaned. This was the case with the 3-year-old guardian deity who rubbed its forehead and then nodded, who looks like a cat today.

It was a scene that really made me laugh.

“But, why did you speak like that?”

Isn’t that uncomfortable?

However, Ricdorian, who was looking at me, hardened his expression on how he felt.

He then fell in thought, and he slowly opened his mouth.

“...You don’t like it?”

“No, well. Either way, it doesn’t matter.”

In a way, it was a floating nuance, but I answered plainly in a sense that it was okay.

I don’t have any discomfort. I asked if he felt uncomfortable.

When I answered this, for a moment, he lowered the corners of his eyes. He quickly returned to his original cold expression.

But, doesn’t he know?

He was making a cold expression with a half-red face....

‘Well, I shouldn’t tell you.’

Because it looks good

As I let out a light smile, Ricdorian glanced away. Instead, the force holding my fingertips grew a little stronger.

The room was quiet. It was only natural that there was nothing but him and me and this little guardian deity.

Pudding, who never showed up as soon as he came here, showed up a few hours before Ricdorian was relieved when I told him that I wasn’t going.

The funny thing is that Ricdorian saw Pudding, yet he pretended not to know.

As if they had made a promise.

They pretend not to know each other like a water buffalo and a gazelle inhabiting the meadow.

It's just funny.

‘Why are they doing the same things?’

It was just strange to be at peace when you're in the position of being kidnapped.

Pudding, who had been rubbing its face against my legs, got up.

Then it passed between my legs, cried, and put both its front feet on my thighs.

– Nyang, human. This house is amazing. I can't hear screams and howls, Nyang.

‘That's right, there's no one running to assassinate.’

Pudding's blue eyes were pale.

-Aha, nyang. Are you safe now?

‘Well.’

I slowly turned to my wrist.

It's been over a week since I've been here....

‘Chaser hasn't talked.’

I haven't used the Black Rose tattoo properly, so I don't know what it does.

Is it possible that I can only talk to him? I thought there was no way.

<Call me in case of emergency. Iana.>

Anyway, I didn't contact Chaser. And I didn't do it even though I knew what the consequences would be.

I was out of breath a bit.

‘Imagine. The next situation.’

I took my hand from Ricdorian and covered my wrist.

Let’s put these worries on hold for a little bit longer.

I blinked.

“Ha..”

First, let’s go for a walk to organize our thoughts.

Anyway, the room that Ricdorian gave me was just as spacious as the room that Chaser gave me.

It was enough for me to walk lightly without going anywhere.

I raised my upper body. But when I got up from my seat, two beasts rushed after me as if waiting.

While I was walking, I blinked.

No. Apart from Pudding. Why is Ricdorian too?

“Why are you chasing me?”

“...I can’t?”

“No, there’s nothing that can’t be done.”

Are we moving in the room? I was puzzled, but then I turned around and moved. With two tails attached to me one after another.

The corners of my lips went up.

“Can I go for a walk?”

“If you wish.”

From Ricdorian, unexpectedly cool permission fell. I'm surprised. I thought he would say no or why at least once.

It's a little strange that my ankle is too light.

"Where do you want to go? I can guide you?"

Where did I want to go? I didn't specifically decide on one before asking. First of all, I want to look around the garden.

I wiggled my ankles for a bit, then went near the window.

Ricdorian, who had been following me, asked after a little hesitation in the cold face.

"Is there anything you want to do?"

Perhaps it was because of the cold face, it feels unnatural. He must have gotten used to the role of the Grand Duke. Even though he would feel it himself, the awkwardness he was trying to do seemed a little cute.

He's so big and pure like a cut out water lilies.

It's not bad.

"What do I want to do?"

"Yes."

"Nothing."

I tilted my head. Ricdorian frowned slightly.

"What do you want to have?"

"..nothing."

"What do you like?"

“I don’t have any.”

“...what do you want to eat?”

“...don’t I like to eat anything?”

His tone grew more and more rigid.

“Then. What do you want to do?”

“Isn’t that the same question?”

Like the first, I blinked my eyes wide.

“There is nothing I want to do and nothing I want to have.”

Having said that, I added another word. I don’t know what he wants to say....

“...that is really necessary.”

Then Ricdorian made a face that looked like he was about to cry for a moment. I couldn’t understand why. If he cries, should I wipe his tears?

I thought so, but he didn’t cry. It was just that he was silent.

I turned my back to see if he needed time. I pretended to be looking out the window.

However, it was surprisingly quite noisy outside the window. I tried to pretend to give a glance, but my gaze was taken away.

-Human, there are so many people!

‘Yes.’

As Pudding said, there were a lot of people. Judging by their outfits, most of them seem to be civilians.

“Why are there so many people?”

While muttering a little, something hard burrowed into my waist. And it feels like a wall on my back.

“There’s a big event coming up soon.”

A little murmur answered. A tone that slowly lengthens the end. The sound was so low that it seemed like it was sinking.

I could tell just by the voice.

“I’m sure there will be an event you need to go to...”

My spine straightened out naturally.

This is the other Ricdorian.

I felt embarrassed.

‘.... The change is quite sudden, as it used to be.’

I took a deep breath so as not to say anything.

“Excuse me.”

“Huh.”

Chu.

“Excuse me, are you there?”

“Huh.”

Chu.

“Ricdorian...”

“Yes.”

Chu.

“Neck, stop...”

A kiss on the neck followed with one reply.

I couldn't stand it and covered my neck with one hand. Then I thought I could hear the sound of the wind, but this time.

Chu.

I felt a soft sensation on the back of my hand.

“...you don't like it?”

Chapter 170: What Iana wants to do

1. 1. 1. 1. What Iana wants to do

If you ask me like that. No, how can I say I don't like it when you dig into me like that?

I felt like wrapping my face up. It was a foul. Why is he whispering in my ear like this? I thought my senses weren't so sensitive, but the soft hairs in my ears stood out on edge.

No. This beast, is a human

I sighed heavily as he hugged me with his large body tightly.

However, as I have seen this many times already, I can tell that there was no solution at the time of being caught.

'Yes, do whatever you want.'

Half-resigned, waiting for his answer, Ricdorian suddenly buried his face in my neck.

He took a deep breath in for a while, then exhaled.

"Sorry.."

A few minutes later, the calm voice returned.

No. It may have come back, but the tone was calm and mixed with sighs.

I tapped the back of his hand.

“It’s okay. I’ll try to get used to it.”

Half of it is my responsibility. I haven’t heard yet of the biggest reason his personality needs to be united.

Anyway, I was going to cooperate.

For some reason, Ricdorian was silent for a long time at my words.

He couldn’t even release his arm that was holding me.

I just wanted to ask you a question or something about how this happened.

“If you haven’t calmed down yet, let’s talk. I have some questions.”

“Huh..”

He answered without releasing his arm from my waist. It’s a sloppy answer. Was he still?

I grabbed and released his fingertips to help him come to his senses.

“You know, you were wearing a restraint around your neck a long time ago. How did you get that out?”

There was no answer from him.

His hands are a little stiff. I added to this.

“Well, if you don’t want to answer, don’t...”

“With force.”

“Wi, with force... huh?”

Just a second. What?

Suddenly, I stopped following his words.

Wait a minute. That restraint was released by Francia.

... So Francia ripped it off with her bare hands?

I try to think that it is nonsense, but suddenly a figure of Francia I saw a long time ago passes by.

The bear guardian deity. A figure holding a huge hammer lightly.

“... Is it possible?”

My thoughts changed in an instant. What I saw and experienced completely changed my perception. Well, I think our female lead can do it.

To be honest, that cub should have evolved into an adult bear by now. She would have grown up.

‘Unlike this guy who’s been a kitty cat for years.’

– What kitty cat, Nyang! This body!

‘Yes, yes.’

I continued to fight in my head with Pudding, but there was still no word behind him.

As I was about to get worried, Ricdorian let out a small breath.

Goosebumps sprung up behind my back, but it seemed more like a sigh than an act of seduction.

“Iana.”

He bowed his head. A voice came out with the sound of breathing.

“Because I don’t want to be the same...”

He muttered as he buried his face in me.

The same? With what?

It was an unfamiliar word, but I listened.

“I’ll tell you.”

“What?”

Ricdorian got up slowly and whispered without turning me back.

“...it’s been over a week since you came here.”

A carriage still stands outside the window, and many people are busy moving.

“Someone warmed up on a massive scale.”

His voice was clearly audible as the people moved on the lawn.

“There is a family that is desperately looking for you.”

Those words reminded me of Chaser.

Of course, I thought it was the Domulit.

“Really?”

I grabbed the hem of his clothes and let it go.

It was not an unexpected situation.

When I think about what kind of life I had in Domulit, that feel rather late.

‘.... Since I disappeared like that.’

Has the scale of tracking already grown?

I thought there would be no tracking already.

“...Is it the Domulit?”

“No.”

However, the one that came from the Ricdorian was a completely different name.

“Valtaize.”

Ricdorian said in a voice that he did not want to speak at all.

“It’s Valtaize, Iana.”

Valtaize, the Yellow Rose.

... It was Lenag’s family.

Ricdorian’s voice, who said to me it was Valtaize, seemed to be regretful, or it seemed to be negligent.

Instead of answering, I asked something else.

“Why are you telling me that?”

For Ricdorian, that was a fact that it would be better if I didn’t know.

“...isn’t it better if I don’t know?”

I got out of Ricdorian’s arms and turned around. Then he lifted his head.

Ricdorian did not avert his gaze.

“Because I wanted to tell you.”

He wants me to stay here. Then, shouldn’t he make up my mind to not want to go back?

My mind aside, it was difficult to understand.

“What if I run away? Then what are you going to do?”

He slowly rolled his eyes for a moment, then lowered his head as he exhaled. There was complexity in his hand as he wiped his face.

“...don’t say that. I already regretted it.”

It was an about to cry-face.

“But Iana, I don’t want to hold you or kidnap you.”

I remembered the voice that ran to me and whispered in my arms. *I’m sorry, I’m sorry.* A voice that repeated it over and over again.

“...I hope you have something you want to do. Iana.”

He buried his face in one of his hands and said the same word in a different way.

“I hope you have something you like. Iana.”

I couldn’t understand why you were saying this. I have been calm, at peace, and without anything major.

Once I got used to it and adapted, it wasn’t that difficult every day.

I have always lived a relaxed and comfortable life. Rather, Ricdorian, who would have stayed in the prison for a longer time, suffered a lot.

“Well, I’ve been living well. Grand Duke.”

But am I a strange person because there is nothing I like, and there is nothing I want to do? I didn’t want to argue like this.

Everything. I had no intention of doing it.

Ricdorian reached out and took my hand and rested it on his cheek, and he said nothing.

“Yes, Iana.”

Instead, after silence, he whispered:

“Then let’s make it here. Anything you like or anything you want to do.”

What I like, what I want to do.

“I’ll just ask you this.”

He slowly raised his eyes.

It was a gaze full of deep feeling. It’s something that I can listen to without looking at me so desperately. He was begging me sadly.

“Listen to me, can you?”

I couldn’t understand, but I nodded. It wasn’t a difficult request.

At the same time, I had a different idea.

-Human, we... are we safe, Nyang?

‘I don’t know.’

Lenag is looking for me. The man has always been faithful to his role, and he’s probably still looking for me now.

‘Since he said this, if Domulit had searched me, he would have told me this too.’

A strange and ominous thought ran through my head.

Why is Chaser standing still?

<My dear sister.>

A villain who smiles for me and can do anything without hesitation. Originally, he was a person who was more active than anyone else.

Even if Chaser was behind Lenag, he wouldn't have made Lenag move in the name of Valtaze.

I knew him well.

He was rather the one who would act in the name of Domulit, so I would notice.

So it would be Lenag's own decision to have Valtaze search for me.

'He must have been worried a lot.'

I didn't intend to do this, but I couldn't help it. It would have been nice if there was a way to tell only Lenag the news after that. I felt sorry for him.

I bit my lip.

"Iana."

I raised my head. Ricdorian was staring at me with an incomprehensible gaze.

"Like I said before, I have a meeting at my mansion soon."

He said another story with his cheeks buried.

"...well. Are there a lot of people here?"

I was willing to join him in turning the topic around.

"Do you not like it?"

"No, it's not like that."

I shook my head lightly. Letting go of the thoughts. Let's think about it later.

I don't want to cause any trouble or concern to that person. Will I be able to deliver the news to Lenag? It is a question that cannot be answered right now.

"I've never seen a lot of people in a row. A place with a lot of people gathering. It's like that, because this is the first time since the Imperial Palace banquet."

Rather, there is something I've been wanting to ask Ricdorian all along.

Are you okay with me, Chaser's younger sister?

"Until now... I only see them all at the funeral."

"Funeral?"

I paused for a moment but the words that have already been spit out.

"The funeral of the former Duke of Domulit."

"Ah...."

An indescribable hatred slowly rose on the white, neat face of Ricdorian's. But the moment he saw me, it disappeared.

Still, I saw it clearly...

<After much deliberation, I thought about the existence of the 'Blue Rose'.>

At this moment, it was Jaire's words that had poured in my head.

<Because a Blue Rose can negate all curses on other roses. There are many other abilities, but that is the one we need.>

Ricdorian knows that I am the Blue Rose.

And that day, through Jaire's words, I knew that Chaser and I were not real siblings.

<It's okay to be your older brother.>

You pity me, but you can't deny the time I've lived there.

<It's okay if I'm not your brother.>

I knew. As much as Ricdorian felt sorry for me.

<My Iana.>

That I will still be that man's most precious thing. At this moment, an enchanting and sensual voice that seemed to seduce me passed by.

<I can wait any time. By your side.>

..that guy won't give up on me

-Human, are you okay, Nyang?

'It's okay. Nothing.'

I blinked my eyes deeply. It was a topic that had to be shared someday.

I had been avoiding it all along because I was afraid that it might hurt him. It was also because I didn't want to meet him.

Now there was nowhere to escape.

"Don't you hate Domulit? My brother too."

"Of course I hate him."

Ricdorian's words were shortened. I didn't seem to even feel it.

"Hateful, disgusting."

Ricdorian knows the contradictory feelings he has for his father.

A just personality that suffers from the memories of abuse, but only gets angry at the unfair death.

“By the way, Iana. Actually..... I’m also a bad and worse person than you think.”

I removed my hand that had been resting on Ricdorian’s cheek. Then, holding it slightly, he said, ‘Like the villain you described one day.’.

“If I continue to hate the man who killed my father at this moment.”

It was as if a deep flame was pulsing through his blue eyes. He smiled shyly and sadly.

Coincidentally, he kissed my wrist with the black rose tattoo.

“Will you not look after me anymore or will you take pity on me?”

With his lips in the spot where the man’s tattoo might come out if he pressed his teeth like that. He slowly raised his eyes.

“Because I have bad thoughts.”

His eyes fluttered. He had long eyelashes that drew a half shadow.

Eyes immersed in the shadows evoked a dizzying depth and sensational feeling. For a moment, his innocence is hidden.

“I want you so much that I’m ruined. Iana.”

Chapter 171: You are different

1. 1. 1. 1. You are different

I swallowed a gulp.

I had a lot to say, but it couldn't get out, and it lingered around the tip of my neck.

I have something to say, but my attention was taken from other places than that. The place where Ricdorian's lips went all the way.

Where the Black Rose tattoo is.

If only he gave a little more power over there... The tattoo will appear like blood.

My back was slightly stretched and I felt a sense of tension.

When the tattoo appears, it will naturally connect with Chaser.

It wasn't good to be like that in this situation. Even more so when he showed his deep hatred and disillusionment towards Chaser.

I exhaled slowly, clasping my hands and opening them.

Ricdorian told me that he kept hating the man who killed his father. In other words, an indelible hatred already existed.

Even this is being used as a tool to gain compassion for me.

It was sad, but at the same time I knew what this meant.

“Don’t think like that.”

I moved my finger slightly. He pulled it and grabbed my finger.

The hand holding me trembled for a moment.

“I understood your heart well.”

I couldn’t even imagine what kind of heart it would be to want someone to the point of being ruined.

“I don’t know if I deserve to say this.”

If there was one thing he wasn’t different from four years ago, it was this.

“I hope you don’t think like that.”

He always went all out with his body.

Without thinking about the outcome, with a gaze close to raw, it was as if he would give everything he had.

You were like this 4 years ago when you were hanging on the cage and crying.

“You.”

“Huh?”

“Deserve it, yes.”

As if he felt I was about to get out, he grabbed my hand more anxiously.

Even if he let go of this hand for a moment, I won’t run away.

“Why don’t you deserve it?”

Now, holding my hand with both hands, he brought it to his forehead and said,

“I want to give you everything.”

He looked reverent as if he was praying to God, but the voice that came out was low and weak, as if it were going to break.

“...am I not enough?”

He breathed heavily, like a man who had fallen into the water and was in a hurry. Seeing him like that, my heart throbbed slightly, like when Pudding’s claws stabbed my chest.

I’m sorry.

I stretched out a hand that was not caught while looking at the bent back.

I grabbed Ricdorian’s face and pulled him up. Soon, the watery, but reddened face after he struggled to hold back his tears turned towards me.

“I didn’t mean to see you bend your back like this.”

I hesitated for a moment, then gently rubbed his eyes. He slowly closes his eyes and opens them.

“And the word not enough doesn’t suit you. It’s not for me to judge.”

The caught wrist is still a problem.

“I just said it because I wanted you to cherish yourself a little more.”

That was all I wanted 4 years ago. This is what I sincerely hoped for.

<Because His Excellency endured the hell-like side effects and somehow managed to get through.>

That Ricdorian appeared with only one thing I had hoped for.

Judging from the fact that his closest confidant, Jaire, had a hard time speaking, what he got in return for his awakening was probably not a normal side effect.

I asked him to stay healthy, but he did not listen.

He stood with a more pitiful gaze than in the past.

He had been weeping, but now with his eyes full of deeper and indescribable things.

Have I ever seen eyes like this?

I've seen something similar.

‘Chaser.’

However, it was clearly different from the obsession that Chaser had shown.

“This is a place where you can do that now.”

Instead of talking about his side effects, I said that.

But I couldn't stand the lingering words on my lips and added,

“What kind of pain did you go through before this happened?”

Ricdorian paused. There's no way he didn't know what I'm talking about.

“It hurt.”

He lowered his gaze for a moment at my words filled with conviction rather than a question, and then looked at me again.

“It's only a little hurt, Iana.”

He did not deny the pain. He was different from four years ago when he didn't know pain was pain. That's good though.

Ricdorian touched my hand with his thumb. It wasn't a gesture of seduction.

“Thanks to you for letting me know about pain, I knew I was hurt.”

His thumb pressed against the palm of my hand.

It wasn't painful, but I could feel Ricdorian was holding back something.

"Now you..."

Ricdorian, who was speaking this way, suddenly smiled a little. It was closer to a slightly bitter smile than a bright smile.

"I won't force you to answer."

He pinpointed what I didn't answer.

"Even if you act like that, you're different from that guy."

Then he lowered his head and pressed his lips to my fingertips. This behavior is definitely like Chaser.

"I'll wait."

A face that smiles neatly, pitifully and easily with eyes down.

<I'm going to kidnap you from now on.>

The moment he kidnapped me, I erased the overlapping feelings with Chaser for a brief moment, and something else was left behind.

You are different.

A few days later.

As Ricdorian said, many have reached Hernim's mansion.

Actually, I didn't see many people in person, but I saw a lot of carriages.

"Wow, another one is coming."

Leaning on the railing like now, looking down.

Grand Duchy Hernim.

As the name suggests, the name of the Grand Duchy, the residence was large enough to be called a castle.

In Chaser's case, the force is no less than that of Hernim, but he prefers a mansion he can control, whereas Ricdorian is living in a castle full of tradition.

'Looking at this, I mean, he's pretty straight forward.'

Hernim, the Red Rose symbolizes justice, morality, and passion.

It was a family imprinted on the people as the most righteous guardian of the imperial family.

A family that all the people of the Empire were proud of.

No one could have guessed that the head of that respected family abuses his son in prison.

"Because we don't really know people."

Where I am now is not my room.

To explain where I am, it goes back a few days.

Was it the day before yesterday? Ricdorian came in with Jaire and another person.

<This is Merlin.>

A woman in her 40s wearing a suit and smiling hard is said to be the attendant here.

<It's okay to trust her.>

Ricdorian said that I could trust this person, including Jaire.

<Remember? Merlin is Merida's daughter.>

I remembered. She was one of the few people who was sweet and kind to the young Ricdorian

It was natural to be suspicious of those around me, even if they weren't like Ricdorian or Chaser.

Although the two are a little more special.

<His Excellency gave permission to take a walk in the hanging garden.>

Hanging garden. The structure of the castle here is a bit unusual. A small garden was created around the 4th floor. If you look down, you can see the city landscape and the front of the castle. It was a nice garden.

<Oh, sorry. You told me not to use the word permission.>

When I was here, I felt like I was floating in the air.

<You can go anywhere.>

Flying in the sky is a thought that most people should try at least once, but being here gave me the feeling that that dreamlike wish would come true a little bit.

“Anywhere.”

I laughed bitterly.

“It's like the prison.”

Contradictory, but it was.

In Kambrakam, there was nowhere I couldn't go.

‘.... Thanks to Lenag's backing.’

Currently, Ricdorian has been absent for a while. It's because the guests are coming in succession. Even if the guest was a vassal, it seemed that as the head of the house, he could not help showing his face.

Considering that, he stayed here a while ago and left. Even for a moment, his personality changed, leaving dark lips mark on my neck.

'I couldn't get used to that look.'

When I think of the languid beast-like figure, I get nervous for nothing. It was a reflex feeling.

'I think I need a little more time.'

I shook my head.

Pudding is chasing butterflies in the distance, or sniffing the scent of flowers, and rubbing its body on the grass.

It's a cat, for sure.

I just took my eyes off the 3-year-old guardian deity and looked towards the sky.

'Is Lenag okay?'

I remembered Ricdorian's words.

I felt a bit sorry that the man was looking for me.

'I always seems to cause concern.'

The blue sky had nothing to do with Lenag's color, but reminded me of his coolness.

A man who gives a completely different impression.

"Hmm. How could there be no way to contact only Lenag?"

Chaser's invisible Black Rose tattoo on one hand, and a bracelet Jaire gave to the other arm.

The method seemed elusive.

I want to deliver news.

As I was thinking about it, Pudding sneaked up to me, probably because it was done playing.

-Human, won't you go down, Nyang?

“Why?”

-You liked the garden, didn't you?

I gazed intently at the hanging garden.

This is a garden too, right?

Instead of answering like that, I glanced down at the crowd of people.

“I don't like it when there are many people.”

I shook my hand indifferently.

“When I see a lot of people, I remember someone suddenly drawing a sword and running from among the maids.”

Pudding blinked.

– Were you afraid of that, Nyan?

“No. It's not like that.”

I shook my head.

“...were you afraid that all the maids with you would almost die after that?”

Fortunately, the maids didn't die just because they were among the assassins who had hid themselves.

But it was never known where the missing girls had been sent.

Chaser was such a man.

For me, if he had a purpose, he did anything without hesitation.

That's all I've seen in 4 years.

Pudding, with whom I had some connection, didn't say anything.

Instead, it rubbed its flat forehead against my leg.

I'm fine. When I smiled softly and bent over to pick up Pudding.

Paah.

-Human?

What. Cloudy black smoke emanated from my fingertips. No. It's not smoke, it's light.

The moment I saw the black light, my face hardened.

Black light from my body. Where it came from was my wrist.

The Black Rose tattoo is drawn like blood. The protruding black rose was as captivating as it was in full bloom.

Soon the light emanating from the Black Rose tattoo took on a winged pattern. It gave the feeling of Aquala's wings.

And the light clumps together and *pop!* A dazzling light shone.

I stumbled while trying to avoid the light.

My eyesight is trembling.

‘Ugh. I’ll fall.’

I closed my eyes.

The wind blew gently. It was a warm breeze, but there was no time to enjoy it.

Even though I fell, it didn’t hurt. Someone grabbed my waist and held me so I wouldn’t fall.

When I opened my eyes, a familiar face was in front of me. No words came out.

A beautiful and enchanting face, as if carefully crafted by a craftsman, and curved eyes as if tempting.

When our eyes met, the mysterious eyes curved conspicuously.

It was red eyes.

“Hello, my Iana.”

Chaser grinned.

“How are you?”

Chapter 172: You are a Domulit

1. 1. 1. 1. You are a Domulit

It was a very casual greeting, regardless of the time that had past.

I'm at a loss for words. No, I couldn't find anything to say.

Chaser showed up here? How? Rather....

'Was Chaser able to contact me first?'

It was confusing.

He was able to contact me first. If so, why, why?

He hasn't been in touch until now, has he?

He was able to do it. He didn't do it for more than a week. This fact was extremely unlike Chaser.

This man I knew never was like that.

If that was the case, the people who were dragged from the Domulit mansion to the coal mine would have decreased 40%.

While I couldn't find a word and was bewildered, Chaser's slow gaze was fixed on me.

He seemed to be looking slowly, observing.

I know this gaze.

“No injuries, Iana?”

When the assassin appeared, when it was revealed that I was poisoned....
He used to look at me like this after he had cleared away the threat that had been inflicted on me.

Eyes that meticulously check if there is anything wrong with me. I clenched my fists.

“...let me go.”

I was still trapped in Chaser’s arms. Thank you for holding me so I didn’t fall, but it was too close.

Chaser watched as I pushed him away and raised the corners of his lips.

“The excursion is long. My sister.”

Instead of answering my request, he made an absurd reply. Of course, my body stiffened at that answer.

Was it because I had a foreboding of this moment that I kept wanting to go to Domulit regardless of my will until now?

“You don’t know how much I missed you.”

Because of the close distance, his ecstatic voice echoed through his large torso.

His body was tense. Perhaps this voice is coming from very close.

“Where is here?”

Chaser didn’t take his eyes off me as I couldn’t answer.

“No answer. Shall I guess, Iana?”

Chaser’s face contained a light smile. He couldn’t have known this place. It was none other than Ricdorian’s castle.

“It’s Hernim’s castle.”

The correct answer flowed out of his lips with beautiful curves as if tempting.

He knew it. I had a slight goosebumps.

It was because Chaser’s eyes were asking ‘yes?’.

I blinked my eyes slowly, pretending not to show. So that the surprise doesn’t stay in my

eyes and face, so that I look casual.

“Therefore?”

Fortunately, there was no tremor in my voice.

I didn’t hide my gaze. Chaser was good at spotting lies in others.

So he will know what I really mean.

What’s wrong with this?

“It must have been a lot of fun. Iana.”

Chaser raised his hand without losing his smile. Another hand, not holding my waist, grabbed the hair next to me and put it behind my ear.

It was a gentle and soft touch. Like this soft smile now.

For a moment, I did not miss the red eyes of madness.

I grabbed Chaser’s hand.

Then removed his hand from my head and lowered it slowly.

“How did you get here?”

I changed the direction of the arrow that returned to me.

By answering the questions Chaser asks one after another, I can only go in the direction Chaser wants.

I realized that by seeing many people beside him.

“There’s nowhere I can’t go, Iana.”

That’s right. He was the best villain in the world. I let in a small smirk.

“You know I didn’t ask that, right?”

“Then you know. My sister will know.”

What? I frowned at the words out of context.

“What do I know?”

“That I don’t lie to you.”

I haven’t seen him in over a week, but he smiled happily with a face that boasted its beauty.

“If it’s for you, even if it’s the most dangerous place with the enemy, I can come without hesitation.”

Enemy camps, and dangerous places. Chaser admitted to himself. No matter what he says, this is a dangerous place.

Even when I couldn’t hide my surprise, this man’s face was relaxed.

“There’s nowhere I can’t come for you.”

Chaser lowered his head and buried his face deep into the palm of my hand. It’s like taking a breath that he’d never been able to breathe.

I only found out as I got closer.

“Come back now, my Iana.”

His eyes were darker than the last time I saw them. Like the eyes of a person who has not slept.

Chaser closed his eyes, and took a deep breath.

“...with you, I can sleep.”

His hand holding me was as strong as a chain. What came out of him who buried his face in me was a voice so small that I couldn't believe it was him.

He rubbed his nose in the palm of my hand. Like a gigantic beast acting cute.

“Come back, let me sleep.”

My Iana, the sweet voice filled my ears. It sounded weak and flowed softly enough that I thought I might have heard it wrong.

“Huh?”

If I had lost my mind for a moment, it was such a sweet voice that I would have believed that I had a really sweet relationship with this man.

“... Why are you always doing it, knowing that your abilities won't work for me?”

Our gazes crossed.

“I hope one day it will work.”

“Does it?”

Downstairs, it was noisy with the sound of people moving their luggage. By the time we got to the 4th floor, there was only a faint residual sound.

Chaser slowly opened his closed eyes. His eyes were as bright as blood, red and transparent.

“It’s strange, I thought it would be super effective if it worked, so I always wanted it to work.”

Effective.

“Now.”

Chaser said, ignoring the noise coming from below.

“I hope it doesn’t work.”

“What doesn’t work.”

I did not fall for Chaser’s vague words. I opened my mouth and spat out the words.

“Because I’m the Blue Rose?”

As Jaire said, I could understand why I wasn’t affected by Chaser’s abilities.

<Because a Blue Rose can negate all curses on other roses.>

Chaser’s face remained unchanged. He was just smiling.

“...it’s true that my abilities don’t work because you’re a Blue Rose. Iana.”

Chaser admitted quietly. With a friendly smirk.

“And?”

“And what?”

“And any more questions?”

His attitude was natural. As if he knew it was going to be like this.

Rather, he had an attitude that he would forget the situation and accept any questions.

Like someone who forgot that this place is in the middle of an enemy line.

“Or what about this? What I was trying to tell you at the banquet.”

Chaser pulled his face from my hand.

“Aren’t you curious about that?”

As I got a little closer, it felt like his exhalation could reach me.

His blood-red eyes stared at me tenaciously, as if he had dripped red ink.

“Let’s go back, Iana.”

He spoke softly, as if the excursion had come to an end.

As if the picnic and vacation are all over. It wasn’t funny.

“What if I don’t go?”

Chaser’s eyes drew a round curve.

“How can I force you?”

That wasn’t the answer. No, it wasn’t the voice of a madman who placed shackles on my ankles.

“Are you going to put chains on me and drag me away?”

“No way.”

Chaser’s soft gaze fell from me for the first time.

His gaze turned to my feet.

It was towards Pudding that couldn’t hide.

I said hastily.

“Don’t touch it.”

Now, four years later, I could tell what he was thinking without telling me.

I would have guessed or anyone could, who had seen a man disappear.

“Why? It’s something you’ve been holding since the beginning?”

Chaser tilted his head. With an innocent face, like he couldn’t understand.

But in reality, there was absolutely nothing as innocent as this man’s expression on his face. I swiped Pudding backwards with my foot, while furiously narrowing my eyes.

“You said you would give it to me.”

“Iana, I think it’s been a long time since I’ve seen this expression on your face.”

Chaser smiled softly as if to break boundaries, and raised his palm.

“Is this the first time since you aimed your sword at the maid who got a little closer?”

“Chaser.”

“Yes. That kid was poisoned back then. If she eats it, her heart stops in just three seconds.”

My forgotten memories flashed past.

The day Chaser speaks of was not long after I came to Domulit mansion.

I was kidnapped and suffered in a sea of fire, and soon after, there was a maid assigned to me, a sweet and kind girl.

“Yes, I won’t touch you if you don’t want to. That guardian spirit.”

Chaser quietly retreated. The lines he left behind were strange. No. At least I knew he wouldn't touch Pudding.

Because he let go of my hand, we separated a little bit. However, the waist held by him was still intact.

I turned my head back for a moment. There was only a railing behind it, but there will be a lot of people under the railing.

Also, there will be people on every level, including Ricdorian.

Wait a minute, is he not coming?

I thought. No. It might be better not to come.

"Iana, everything around us is going to target you."

Chaser made a decisive declaration, facing me.

"You know that, right?"

Hernim cannot be a perfect shield. Chaser muttered softly in an ecstatic voice.

"I am not a Domulit."

"Your name is Domulit."

"I'm not your sister."

Then he made a slightly surprised face, as if seeing a child who did not listen.

"Iana, I think you're misunderstanding a little bit, but bloodlines aren't the only things that can make you a Domulit."

Then, a voice as sweet as a warm blanket and soft as a feather tickling slowly pierced my ear.

The wind blew at the same time as the gentle voice.

My body was freed from his arms.

There was a distance, but I still felt trapped by him. This feeling was just vivid.

Raising my head, I felt Chaser's gaze through the wind.

“My companion could be a Domulit too.”

He wanted to hold my hair and tidy it up as if imitating a good brother, then grabbed a few strands and lifted them up.

Then he brought it to my lips.

His gaze turned to me.

A dangerous smile passed through the friendly eyes.

If I allow it, it's like he won't be able to stand it any longer.

“Do you like this side?”

With a dizzying voice.

Chapter 173: I want to hear it with your lips

1. 1. I want to hear it with your lips

For a moment, I almost asked him what he was talking about. But the reason he didn't ask me in the end was... Because I know.

How is this man looking at me? Don't I know well?

He said it himself.

I'll be your brother if you want.

Obviously, that was a word that gave a 'grace period'.

<I can wait any time. By your side.>

The conversation in the garden filled my head, and did not escape. I had to say something, but it was just murmurs.

No words came out. I couldn't move, as if caught in the red eyes looking at me.

His eyes were red, but from time to time the brightness was different depending on the light. Under the brightest light, the light was as clear as the finest ruby, but under the shadows...

It also showed a vivid blood color.

Chaser's eyes were dark and red today.

“Iana.”

He smiled sweetly as if responding to my gaze. And the eyes locked under the light had completely different eyes than before.

It was also the reason why I didn’t speak up hastily.

‘Strange.’

He was barely pretending to be calm, but the Chaser I see now is clearly a little different from what I have seen so far.

I stared intently at his shirt.

Unfortunately, one button is loose. There was only one, but it was a surprise to those who knew him.

Because he was a man who didn’t allow any cracks unlike the time when he was likely to seduce anyone.

“I’ll be sad if there’s no answer.”

Slightly sunken eyes, a dark shade under the eyes.

However, these things erased the usual ascetic appearance, creating a rather pleasant and decadent feeling.

If what I saw behind him was not midday but dark night, it would have been an atmosphere that would have been understandable even if I had seen him in a back alley at night.

“My Iana, would you have thought I wouldn’t know?”

“...what?”

My lips, which had been silent at the unexpected question, opened and the answer flowed out.

Chaser let go of his hand that was holding the tip of my hair. At the same time, he took a step forward.

I staggered back and felt that my ankles were not heavy. My feet are light.

“This is not Domulit.”

I realized again. How heavy has my ankle been?

While I paused for a moment at the change, Chaser approached me and grabbed my fingertips.

He pulled me straight away and buried his lips in the still black tattoo.

He looked like Ricdorian, but it gave off a completely different feeling.

[“I want to give you everything.”]

He rubbed his lips lightly and opened them slowly.

[“...am I not enough?”]

This tone? No, wait. My body stiffened.

...that’s what Ricdorian said.

Chaser just bent his eyes.

[“I want you so much that I’m ruined. Iana.”]

Goosebumps sprung up behind my back.

“Don’t worry, my sister.”

Chaser didn’t stop smiling, but he put his lips on my wrist and then lifted it off.

“That’s all I’ve heard.”

Indeed, is that statement true?

“No matter where, it’s hard to hear the sound in the middle of Hernim.”

His thumb rubs hard on the tattoo and falls off. As if to tell me that he heard it through this Black Rose.

He doesn’t lie to me, but I knew from experience. Not telling lies is not the same as telling all the truth.

He was at least a man who could hide the truth instead of telling lies.

“So what is your answer?”

“...you must have heard.”

Chaser did not respond to my calm voice. No, he was silent for a moment.

Then, after a moment of silence, he whispered quietly.

“I want to hear it.”

It was a slightly muffled pronunciation by burying his lips in my wrist.

“I want to hear it with your lips, Iana. Let me hear it.”

I realized then. The reason the smile I saw now isn’t friendly.

“Huh?”

There was a slight anger in his eyes. No. Is this really a slight anger?

It was a face I had never seen even when I was kidnapped and he turned it into a sea of fire.

The expression on which countless emotions are intertwined like a chain, the usual kindness that stood out and anger intertwined with it.

Chaser opened his lips. He didn’t mean to talk.

Lick.

My fluffy hairs stood up and my thighs were tense.

“Uhk....”

It wasn't enough for his lips to lightly pass over my wrist, he rubbed them hard. Like beasts do.

At the same time, his gaze filled with sharp madness like a bird of prey turned towards me.

With a smile as soft as silk, that didn't harmonize with this moment.

“Listen to me, come on. Huh?”

It wasn't the smile that had only the usual gentleness.

“I.....”

“Yes, my Iana.”

It was a time when my lips were about to open.

“Don't...”

“Oh my.”

Chaser suddenly narrowed his eyes. At the same time, he murmured lightly.

Boom boom boom!

At the same time as his soft voice, there was an enormous sound that seemed to break everything.

The sound that sounded like footsteps or breaking a door was getting closer and closer.

Chaser's eyes seemed to squint to the side. His head turned to the door behind his back.

Chaser returned as he was, bowed his head, and smiled slightly.

"I'm sorry."

It had a nice resonance, but it was a voice with a lot of meaning.

He raised his eyes

"Iana, I gave you a chance."

Chaser glanced at the hand that was holding me, and he spoke.

He lowers his back even more, and the distance draws closer.

"If you wish, I can wait by your side forever."

"....."

A question ran through my head when he asked if I wanted him to be an elder brother. I didn't answer.

"That's too bad"

He mumbles as if I can't hear it.

"Still, the ability does not reach this far."

A black light flew up from beneath his feet. This reminded me of my movement from Schirmela. One was a little different.

"Next time, I'll come to hear your choice."

He gently grabbed my wrist and whispered softly. His lips were almost touching, so even the sound of his breathing could be felt.

"My Iana. This excursion won't be long."

I pushed his body away. He was gently pushed away. It's like he's not forcing anything.

He let go of my wrist.

I still have the feeling of being caught. I opened my mouth calmly, trying to erase the feeling.

"I'm not going."

At my words, Chaser widened his eyes for a moment. Then he reflexively smiled.

As if he didn't hear anything. But the corners of his eyes trembled faintly.

Chaser's feet were gradually getting fainter. His fingertips outstretched to me.

His eyes, which no longer held a smile, looked at me.

"I'll come pick you up."

Bang! With that, the door opened.

"Iana!"

There stood Ricdorian with a messy hair.

It was a close difference. Because Chaser disappeared as soon as the door opened.

Chaser was nowhere to be seen. With a momentary difference, Chaser's appearance suddenly disappeared and he appeared. Still, I thought that Ricdorian wouldn't know.

The black afterimage left behind by Chaser stayed around me like torn paper.

It was like the petals of a black rose that flew away.

‘It’s just like showing off.’

I forgot the situation and smiled.

Black Rose, the man was very similar to the rose he had.

In fact, the black roses that were in full bloom in the Domulit were very coveted and beautiful.

It’s beautiful, but it’s hard to touch, it’s like you’ll get hurt if you touch it.

Ricdorian strode through the black afterimage.

Bzz, bzz.

The more he walked, the strangely pulsing red and black lights collided with his body, creating a small spark like lightning. Some even jumped at Ricdorian and burned the ends of his clothes black.

But he had an indifferent face. No, he didn’t even give a glance as if he didn’t notice at all.

He stopped in front of me and grabbed my shoulder.

Was he going to interrogate me?

However, he was busy scanning my body. As if to see if there were any injuries to me.

As if to prove this, his blue eyes moved busily.

In particular, when he saw the wrist with the Black Rose tattoo that had not yet disappeared, his gaze stayed persistently long.

I glanced at what he was doing.

He finally finished checking and raised his head. His red lips tremble as our eyes meet. He looked like he had a lot to say.

“Are you hurt?”

I'm sure he wouldn't not know the meaning of the black light that stayed around me, so he asked that.

I blinked for a moment, then burst into a small smile.

“Yes, it's fine.”

That man doesn't hurt me. Because I was the person who knew this best in the world.

My relationship with Chaser was very contradictory. The man was a madman who shackled me and locked me up, but he was also the man who saved my life countless times.

I owed my life, but the blood is irreplaceable. It's been 4 years for me. No words could define the relationship between me and the man.

“...the man appeared.”

Ricdorian's hands trembled. His hand falls off my shoulder. As it fell, his eyelids vibrated like dandelions swaying in the wind.

However, it had only fallen a little bit, and Ricdorian's hand that had fallen into the air, as he hesitated, was unable to catch me again.

“Are you going?”

‘Are you leaving me?’ It seemed that these words were omitted before his words.

I shook my head with a smile.

“No.”

Then I grabbed his hand on my shoulder and patted him.

“I said I wouldn't go.”

Still I haven't defined my relationship with Chaser. But I was gradually realizing it.

<If you act like that, you are no different from that man.>

The chains that Chaser put on me, the actions I've been doing...

In fact, everything I was used to.

It was more strange and crazy than I thought.

Chapter 174: Because it's a part of me

1. 1. Because it's a part of me

“You... mean it?”

“Yes.”

His face was noticeably relieved. Perhaps it was embarrassing for him, he turned his head slightly.

The tip of his ear was a little red.

Unexpectedly. Are you embarrassed of this?

It was very cute to see him getting embarrassed about the wrong things.

‘Ah. Because I said I wasn’t going.’

With a sudden thought, I let go of Ricdorian’s hand and bowed to the floor.

And then, I hugged Pudding, who was crying away in the garden even before Chaser left.

– Hu, human! I was afraid, I was afraid. Nyang! I was scared!

‘Yes, yes.’

Pudding, which rarely makes a weak sound, burrowed into my body. I patted and petted the shivering cat as carefully as possible.

Since I first discovered Pudding 4 years ago and decided to have it, Chaser has not been hostile towards Pudding.

Pudding used to see the other side of Chaser at a glance.

In addition, I was well aware of how much Pudding was afraid of Chaser.

– Hu, human. The, the Black Rose was trying to kill me, Nyang.

‘I didn’t let that happen.’

Pudding was crying sadly in my head. I hugged it, but the shaking did not subside easily. A weak voice leaked through the cries.

– But even if that happens... This body would have protected you human, Nyang.

The hand that was stroking Pudding paused for a moment. And then... Soon after, I grabbed Pudding and hugged it tightly. I put my forehead on Pudding’s forehead and exhaled.

Then, as usual, I rubbed it a little.

‘Thank you.’

When I opened my eyes like that, I saw a back standing firmly. Perhaps Ricdorian was waiting for me to calm Pudding.

He blinked.

The pair of blue eyes staring at me were so gentle that if I looked at them, I would have forgotten how cold those eyes were just a few days ago.

Do emotions change people so differently? I suddenly became curious.

And Ricdorian’s eyes staring at me were very similar to Pudding I was holding.

So I decided with a sigh.

‘Yes, I’ll have to ask one more time.’

I lifted Pudding that had been crying cutely as it was.

Like a scene from the movie ‘The Lion King’, my appearance and bewildered Ricdorian with Pudding, it was a composition similar to the one before in Schirmela.

“...what are you doing?”

Ricdorian’s expression darkened as if he had also remembered this.

“Grand Duke, do you know what kind of existence this is now?”

“Grand Duke. I don’t know why the title suddenly changed.”

“Um, was it not good? Then Ricdorian.”

Then Ricdorian’s brow relaxed.... Is he aware that he is that simple?

“Anyway, do you know?”

Ricdorian’s eyes turned to Pudding. He nodded his head slightly.

“I know. The guardian deity of the Red Rose.”

“Yes that’s right.”

The name came out of him, who couldn’t have known. Anyway, it’s a tone that feels far away. Even though he is the Red Rose.

“Are you going to take this kid?”

Reactions erupted from both sides.

– No, Nyang!!

“...take it?”

Pudding was struggling wildly.

At that moment, I lost strength in one hand and Pudding, who took advantage of it, returned to my chest, nailed itself in my arms and dug into it.

‘No, I think we should still talk about it at least once.’

– Too much, human. Betrayal, betrayal, Nyang!

‘That’s not it. Alright. If you don’t want to.’

I was just going to ask or point it out at least once, but the baby guardian deity was so surprised.

‘I was really just asking.’

– A traitor! You’re a traitor, Nyang!

At this rate, Ricdorian couldn’t even say that it was good. I stared intently into his eyes.

“I don’t know what it is, but it seems like it didn’t like it.”

“Hahaha....”

I wondered if there could be a guardian deity who would be cursing at its Rose, but Ricdorian was calmer than I thought.

“I don’t want to either.”

Rather, he spoke firmly with a casual face.

“...Why?”

Although it was said that a guardian deity was essential for awakening, Ricdorian suffered side effects in return and became a perfect rose.

Like Pudding said, he didn't need it anymore, but he still sees its face every time and it's strange that he doesn't talk very much, so I offered it out.

"It doesn't matter. You don't have to give it to me."

Ricdorian leaned his back and made eye contact with me.

"I don't need it anymore."

It was a friendly gesture, but the words that came out were a firm and determined voice.

Even his shy voice seemed to show his clear will.

If I were Pudding, I would be upset, but instead, Pudding looked at me triumphantly as if to prove it.

– Look, look, look, human! Even the Red Rose said he doesn't want me, Nyang!

'No.... Aren't you supposed to be sad?'

– I don't need him either, Nyang!

Pudding rubbed its body like crazy.

-Human, all I need is you, Nyang. Don't throw me away.

I looked at Ricdorian and Pudding in turn, and burst out into an absurd laugh. It was because the appearance of the human and the guardian deity, who assert that they dislike each other, were very similar.

No. Who do you hate when you're so similar?

Anyway, both sides said they didn't like each other, so I didn't mean to force it.

Because I really wanted to ask him about his situation in the future.

“Yes, if you don’t like it, there’s nothing I can do about it.”

I tilted my head. I have to ask this though.

“But Why?”

For Pudding, even if it says it’s been with me for a long time. Isn’t it better for Ricdorian to have a guardian deity?

Ricdorian made a complicated expression for a moment.

“...The guardian deity of the Red Rose is said to be like a part of the body.”

Ah. I know that.

“So keep it.”

“Uh...huh?”

“No, please keep it for me.”

Ricdorian’s hand touched Pudding’s back and pulled it off. Surprisingly, Pudding did not hate it.

I just looked at him with the gaze of why he was asking me to keep it all of a sudden.

“It’s a part of me.”

Ricdorian blinked his eyes slowly. His lips twitched under his slightly cold face.

“It’s part of me, so keep it.”

It looked like he didn’t know what to say.

“...then we’ll always be together.”

Saying that, he blushed. As if he couldn't help himself, he quickly covered his cheek.

I've already seen it all.

However, he covered his face with his hand, and said what he had to say, with a slight red look under his eyes.

"If you can.....I wish you could keep it forever."

He stared intently at me.

"...if I live a long time, I will."

After muttering like this in a bit of embarrassment, Ricdorian suddenly had a startled face.

"Are you sick?"

He quickly lowered his hand and approached me and asked.

I shook my head.

"No, no. There is room for misunderstanding in the statement, but it is not."

I quickly explained

"Because this child is not my guardian deity to begin with. They say its lifespan may be different."

This was something told by the little warlock. Like Chaser's closest confidant, he was knowledgeable about the roses, and he occasionally told me useful stories about the roses.

I didn't ask a lot of questions at the time so as not to get any attention, but I put together a few things.

Marshmel did not know that I had signed a contract with Pudding, but said that I would not be able to sign a contract with the guardian deity of the Red

Rose. He said that even if contracted, the life expectancy is likely to be different.

This is unavoidable due to the difference in power.

Hesitantly, Ricdorian gently embraced me.

“Ha...”

An exhalation erupted from above my head.

It was a daring act for a reasonable person, but seeing his trembling body, it didn't seem like it was meant from a personality change or to seduce me.

“I was surprised. I thought you were sick...”

“I'm healthy.”

Ricdorian took a deep breath. He seemed very surprised.

“Without health, it's a corpse.”

I hesitated, then raised my arm and patted his back awkwardly. What caused the misunderstanding was me.

“What you just said.”

Ricdorian whispered softly as he rested his head on my shoulder.

“Maybe that's fine. The lifespan.”

“Why?”

The answer came quickly from him.

“Because you are a Blue Rose.”

Instead of being surprised, I said ‘oh’ and accepted I'm a rose too, so that's fine.

Suddenly, I was naturally accepting that I was a rose.

I can't help but know what it is because I'm being told here and there and my abilities are revealed.

'It's not a huge ability.'

Chaser's abilities don't work. It is possible to make a contract with the guardian deity of other

roses. I thought it was a little more powerful than I thought.

Jaire said I could negate the curse on other roses.

Besides this, there are other abilities. What else can I do?

And.

'Does the Blue Rose have a guardian deity?'

Naturally, it came to the existence of the guardian deity.

But that thought was soon erased.

Because Ricdorian rubbed his face lightly on my shoulder.

He whispered in a slightly muffled voice as he had buried his face.

"Really, you're not going, aren't you?"

"Of course."

Be sure to keep what you say... It's a prick in my conscience though.

"I can't guarantee that I'll keep what I said now."

I said something wrong. I paused for a moment, then tapped him on the back again.

“For real.”, he said.

It would be awkward if an adult man was grumbling like this, but I didn't feel that way at all.

Rather, when I saw the large beast alone, I felt as if I depended on it with my whole body.

‘I think it would be perfect if there were only ears and a tail here.’

A pleasant scent is felt in his hair swaying in the wind.

I could smell the scent alone in the damp basement cell, and even now I can still smell the scent of that time when he left the cell.

Rather, this refreshing and pleasant scent seems to have grown stronger and more mature and deeper.

I burst out laughing a little more at the neat appearance.

Ricdorian: ‘It's a part of me, keep it. Then we'll always be together’

Me, reading it: asdfghjkl

How did he get so smooth!

Chapter 175: The Instinct of All Roses (1)

1. 1. The Instinct of All Roses (1)

I didn't know what he was holding back like this for, what he couldn't take his head off, and what he was worried about inside.

The part where his hand gripped and wiggled was my wrist.

He was rubbing exactly where the black rose had been.

“Is it bothering you?”

Flinch.

Raising his head, he was helpless, like a man who had been found guilty. Yet, he did not avoid my gaze or let me go.

This person is so upright too.

I slowly pulled away from him and held out my wrist.

“As you may have seen, here, there's a black rose tattoo?”

I put it out in words, knowing that he had seen it.

“....I know.”

He couldn't help but grab my wrist and clenched his fist right in front of me. His fist trembled slightly.

“I know, but I hate it. No. I’m sad.”

He murmured in a cold voice.

“Iana, it’s not that I hate you, I hate this rose.”

“Yes, I know.”

He seemed depressed, so he waved his hand as if to vent.

“Then will you hide this rose?”

“...Yes?”

“Or you can erase it.”

It was something I said sincerely from my heart.

If it was to convey everything Ricdorian had to say, it was neither good for him nor for me.

No, actually, I don’t care if what I’m saying is delivered or not... I didn’t want anything dangerous to happen because of me.

Aside from the contradictory feelings I have for Chaser, this tattoo was enough for me, and I didn’t need it.

“This, it seems to be transmitted to my brother from time to time.”

It seems that my location has already been discovered.

“I don’t think we should keep it.”

Actually, there seems to be no way to erase it, but Ricdorian seemed to know how to hide it.

“I think we have to do something.”

Or disable the function.

I nodded and lifted my head.

“Is there any way?”

“There is.”

Ricdorian answered quickly. He paused, realizing that he had answered too quickly.

“What?”

At the same time, a blush of flower red bloomed on his face. He was shy for no reason.

Why are you doing that?

“That...”

“That?”

He couldn't speak for a long time.

Then, red hot flowers occupied his ears and under his eyes as if they were about to burst.

He covered his mouth with the back of his hand and lowered his head. Even his neck, which at first glance could be seen through the white collar, turned red.

What's wrong with you?

It was similar to what he looked like in the underground cell 4 years ago.

I tilted my head at the completely reddened figure I seldom saw after reuniting again.

“...I, I engrave my rose on you.”

At that point, I was speechless for a moment.

Why was it something to turn red for?

But at Ricdorian's next words, I held my breath.

"The tattooing method...."

"Method?"

"It's, it's a little...."

.....what? Racy? The inaccurate and bizarre words that came out of the neat man's mouth sparked a fire in my imagination.

Let's calm down. Good thoughts. Good thoughts.

'...Actually, I also have a red rose tattoo.'

Pudding, who was listening quietly, tilted its head as if strangely.

– Human, don't you already have a tattoo, Nyang?

'But that's...'

... I can't tell him because of the location.

– Won't you say it, Nyang?

'Yes, I won't.'

The decision was quick.

'To show it..... No, it's kind of perverted.'

That's right, the red rose tattoo I got from signing a contract with this 3-year-old guardian deity....

Well, it was on the inside of my thigh.

"If, if it's okay to engrave..."

What to do. I think he's looking forward to it.

He was too dazzling, and I took my eyes off the sunny face. For some reason, I think I'll have to turn the subject.

Thinking like that, I just stared at the railing.

Goonng!

A huge sound was heard. Ricdorian's eyes and mine met.

Thump thump. The loud earth rumble was heard.

It wasn't just the sound of the ground.

Booooooooo-

There was also a magnificent sound, like the sound of a huge horn. It was a loud sound that could make you think there was a ceremony nearby.

‘What?’

The only difference is that, unlike me, who was surprised, Ricdorian was calm.

I turned around and looked at the railing. And soon I knew the cause of the sound. A huge carriage was coming in through the front gate of the castle wall in the distance.

... No, it was a shocking visual for a carriage.

That's usually..... do you call that a carriage?

The thing that shocked me the most so far is the so-called ‘I want to know’ carriage from Chaser that was led by 20 horses.

That was the ‘horse abuse carriage’....

‘I don't think the horses are leading this one.’

Because it was so huge. It was shocking in another way.

The large carriage is so large that it cannot be expressed in its size, and is decorated with gold patterns and pure white.

There were horses tied in front, but it seemed like it was just tied as a decoration, and the carriage seemed to move alone.

There's no way that huge size can be dragged by only three horses.

“What is that...”

What? Is that a carriage? As soon as the carriage entered the main gate, it stopped. The crowd, who had been chatting, parted in unison.

The carriage door opened and a strange thing was brought in front of the carriage.

– Human, what is that, Nyang?

Pudding asked as we were watching together perhaps it even found it strange.

‘.... Palanquin ... I guess.’

It's like a palanquin, and the number of people who carried it was as much as the carriage.

In addition, the people carrying the palanquin all wore white and wonderful helmets, similar to knights....in a way.

All the upper body was undressed.

‘What a nice sight this is....’

The body is good, but the situation is strange and bizarre.

No, rather, knights who took off their noble platinum helmets and jackets that symbolized abstinence.

I couldn't hide my surprise, but it struck me that Ricdorian was always quiet. At a glance, he didn't seem to care about the situation under the railing.

Just looking down, his eyes were as cold as the day we met again, or even colder than that, and a little dissatisfied.

Like someone familiar with this sight.

Then, someone climbed onto the palanquin. As soon as they got off the carriage, a huge parasol covered them, so I couldn't see who it was.

Then, as soon as I saw the person who had just climbed the palanquin, I opened my eyes wide.

'Francia?'

Sway, sway. Underneath the swaying and gracefully waving hair, the face was definitely Francia.

She was so different in size that I almost couldn't recognize her... There's no way I didn't know that hair color.

Francia naturally climbed onto the palanquin. A huge parasol spread over the palanquin, and soon her face disappeared.

Now she looked like she couldn't even be called a girl.

Then I saw the carriage that Francia had been riding in, a beast with teeth drawn on it, and a long cross wrapped in thorns.

That was the symbol of the temple.

Thanks to the little warlock who beat me to common sense, I was able to recognize the temple sign.

"No...."

What happened?.

Temple.

The imperial family, the grand Duchy and the Duchy share the power of the empire together with it.

However, this is only a glorification of the past, and in the present era, it has entered the path of decline and defeat.

The power is not what it used to be.

Therefore, when in prison, noble prisoners did not often mention the temple. It was also talked about as an insignificant force.

Of course, it is true that even a toothless tiger is a force that cannot be ignored, with the battle paladin fighting with healing and divine power, including the main forces leading them.

... That was Marshmel's opinion.

And in the original story, the female lead who suddenly shouted 'I'll become a saint!', received the so-called hero's buff and achieved dazzling growth, finally becoming a force that cannot be ignored.

This is the original story.

The problem is that, in the original story, Francia was declared a saint long later.

Although I didn't think it would be a deal that would deviate from the original story enough to let go of the female lead.

I looked at the palanquin with complicated eyes.

It's the first time I've seen and heard something like that....

A palanquin carried by half-naked paladins, there was no such thing.

Why am I so sure? If this novel existed because it was an obscene book, there would be no way it could not be written.

It was a book in which the tragic, desires, and pleasurable parts were expressed even with excessive description.

That's why I liked it. There are so many scenes...

Anyway,

... Aren't those people priests?

A scene with priests and flesh did not really harmonize.

“Sister!”

For today, the meeting in Hernim will be held with great joy. The temple was not a vassal, but Francia participated in this event as a collaborator.

So, I am in the same room as Francia, who appears as a saint, but I think that if I were to happen to see her, it will be a long time later. At least after a few meetings.

However, in spite of this thought, Francia came to visit soon.

It had only been a few moments since I looked down the railing.

“Sister, I really miss you. How have you been? Yes?”

In fact, I blinked my eyes slowly, not recognizing her when she ran towards me.

Even so, Francia looked up close....

“Francia?”

“Yes!”

She had become a perfect ‘adult’.

“You’ve become a nice woman, huh?”

Of course, she’s a year older than me, so she’s an adult.

“I promised.”

However, it was a surprising change for me, as she was too young to grow up four years ago.

‘Obviously, I said that I wanted to see ‘growth’.’

I didn’t know she would be so different. What a surprise.

She had grown up just as I had envisioned, looking at the books. She was a beautiful and kind lady in the book, no, she was even more beautiful and kinder than that.

“Are you surprised?”

Chapter 176: The Instinct of All Roses (2)

1. 1. The Instinct of All Roses (2)

When a beautiful woman looks at me in front of me and smiles broadly, my emotions are immeasurable and I am very happy.

“Yes, I was a bit surprised.”

“Hehehe. I’ve grown up!”

A hand in a white glove grabbed my hand and shook it.

Inside the round, good-natured eyes, there were Pie Eye and Odd Eye, which still had silver on one side and green and silver on the other side, giving them a mysterious color.

The darkened eyes gave off a mysterious feeling.

It went well with the pure white outfit she wore now.

‘It’s even sacred.’

I can see that the two of them felt a little similar in the book. Both of them were pure and elegant, as if they had been carefully crafted by God, and there was something incomparable about them.

The present place where I met her was none other than my room. To be precise, it is a small parlor attached to my room.

Next to Francia, Ricdorian with his arms crossed was clearly showing ‘I’m dissatisfied’ with a cold face.

Next to the other side, a handsome man I had never seen was sweating profusely as he looked at Ricdorian.

‘Who is it?’

I turned my eyes away from the person I never saw before and turned to Francia.

“I was very surprised.”

I wondered if the beans I picked up were the seeds from Jack and the Beanstalk for a moment.

Now she looked like me or a little bigger.

Looking at it this way, she gives the impression of being active and mature.

“But I’m glad you’re healthy. You look a lot better.”

It’s not just that she’s gotten bigger and more beautiful. She looked a lot more lively now than she did back then, when she was thin and sharp.

When I sat down on the sofa first, Francia ran over and sat down next to me.

“Sister, sister. You don’t know how desperately I asked for permission to come here.”

She wrinkled the bridge of her nose and put her arms around me.

“The owner of this place didn’t want to let you in, right?”

Ricdorian saw this and narrowed his eyes.

As he watched, instead of sitting across from me, he walked towards the door, folded his arms, and glanced at this side.

“I promised to show you when I find it.”

Like surveillance.

And the unfamiliar handsome man rolled his eyes and naturally went to the back of the sofa and stood up.

Judging by the weak impression and skinny physique, he doesn't seem like an escort.

“Hey, who is that?”

“Ah, the Pope.”

I did not nod and paused.

... Pope?

“I'll explain it slowly, sister.”

When Francia smiled and nodded to the man, he nodded quickly, opened the door and walked out.

Now in the room are me, Ricdorian, and Francia. There were only three people.

‘No, what have you been doing for the past four years, the Pope, no, more than that. Like a pet....’

No. It just seemed disrespectful to the handsome man. I quickly shook my head and decided to think of something else for once.

Then, suddenly, I had a strange idea. Come to think of it, it was Lenag who helped her a few years ago when I let Francia run away.

Maybe Francia has a way to get in touch with Lenag?

‘So that I can only tell him about my news.’

I wanted to deliver the news without going through Chaser. That I'm fine, I'm doing fine.

With that thought in mind, Francia opened her mouth already.

“Sister, I heard you're the Blue Rose?”

It was a home run-class fastball from the start. What kind of story starts in the middle of the mountain?

I smiled and widened my eyes as she threw the nuclear bomb.

“Remember that I said Father and I had something we were looking for? That's... the Blue Rose.”

I didn't know she would be this close. Francia raised her lips softly.

But then she nodded her head calmly.

It looks like this side already knew this. Well. I wondered if I would have known if I had become an assistant for Ricdorian.

At this point, I wondered if it was information that everyone except me knew. It doesn't matter though....

At the same time, I thought it was good.

Even if not, I'm starting to get curious too.

“Because the word came out, speaking of which.”

About the Blue Rose, I knew nothing.

I was reluctant to ask about Ricdorian and with Chaser, the story came naturally, and I didn't have a chance to see him again, but I wanted to ask if I ever met him again.

“What kind of rose is the Blue Rose, and what powers does it have?”

Francia rolled her eyes. The place where her sharp expression touched was where Ricdorian was.

“Hey, Grand Duke. Did you not explain properly?”

When Ricdorian didn’t answer, she made an expression that frowned even more.

But when she came back to me, she was smiling brightly again.

“It seems that the Grand Duke did not explain anything because he was holding sister and not putting her in public.”

“Huh?”

“Rozenia, keep in mind that you are only allowed one hour.”

“Oh, yes. Yes, yes.”

Francia waved her hand as if in annoyance and looked at me. Then she smiled softly.

“Well, it’s only natural, because I’ve been desperately looking for sister, not the Blue Rose from the beginning.”

There was no match between the tone and words.

“But I think I would have done that too. Because I did.”

Francia grabbed my hand tightly. The grown-up beauty collapsed towards me.

“Whether sister is the Blue Rose or not, I would have gone looking for you.”

She pretended to show her muscles by bending her arms like bodybuilders do.

“I have worked hard to break this castle’s gates.”

Somehow, I think it's true that she's become more active and courageous than in the past. It's been a while, but maybe it's just because she looks younger?

Even now, when she has matured, she only looks cute.

She smiled and nodded.

"Back to what you asked."

"It's okay to talk comfortably. It's not like we said goodbye the last time, was it?"

"Is that okay?"

Of course, then, when I answered that, Francia's face bloomed like a bud.

Then she slowly rose from her seat, squatted in front of me, and took my hands in her hands.

"Then talking about this."

This time she held me like I held her hands the day we first met.

"Sister, did I tell you a little while ago that it was the Blue Rose that I searched for with Father?"

"Yes it was."

"Sister, we exist for sister."

I paused. Gradually the smile faded away from Francia's face, and seriousness took over.

"All roses exist with a desire to follow sister after awakening."

Different colored eyes turned to me.

It seemed as if a rose pattern had been drawn on her silver eyes and then erased.

“I have been looking for sister.”

“...are you looking for me?”

“Yes. The reason the Black Rose hid sister so tightly was that he wanted to monopolize you.”

There was a thorn in the voice that was explaining softly.

“Like an instinct.”

Francia’s face with the fierceness as her childhood was vivid.

“Maybe it was because he wanted to watch you dry up alone in the monopoly.”

The sound of grinding teeth permeated her voice. However, this too softened the moment I saw it for a while.

“...that’s how you’re such an object that draws obsession.”

She didn’t mean to say it so wildly. She said and she made a look of helplessness for a moment.

It wasn’t something she couldn’t understand because she knew what I had been through in Domulit in the past.

“Sister is the center of all roses, and the instinct of all roses is to search for the Blue Rose.”

Francia’s hand gently grabbed me. Her hand felt like a rose vine.

“Because you are our king.”

At that moment, I looked at Ricdorian without realizing it. Did I look like I was looking for an answer?

‘What is this nonsense?’

King? Isn’t that absurd? It was crazy.

But in my head, the mural I saw in the cell passed by.

A Blue Rose in the center surrounded by roses. It was now the moment when this position was understood.

At the same time, traces of the empty spaces pass by as if someone dug it up.

The traces aside, it was confusing.

“By the way. Ordinary roses have a faint sensation of feeling a rose before awakening. So, it’s immature, so I don’t know it even if I was right in front of me!”

Without giving me a chance to respond, Francia spoke quickly.

“So my feelings for sister are separate, all right?”

As Francia held the mature face, she explained succinctly. Although she had matured, she was still like a little puppy whining, perhaps because of her big eyes.

I thought it would be stable if Ricdorian coldly said no to it here. I don’t think that’s going to happen.... I wasn’t used to it that much. King. Everything was unfamiliar.

‘Then what about Ricdorian?’

It was instinct. As I focused on him, Ricdorian nodded slowly. Then he opened his well-shaped lips.

“That’s right. Worship and love are different. Iana.”

It was a voice full of anxiety and sorrow.

“It’s true that I feel it faintly before awakening. And unlike other roses, it’s because I lost my guardian deity at a young age. I didn’t have the instinct to find the Blue Rose.”

At first glance, it seemed to be added to avoid any misunderstanding.

“I had no idea.”

Soon there was confidence in that voice.

“Even when I didn’t know you were the Blue Rose, I loved you and made you my companion.”

Chapter 177: Between the usual male and female lead

1. 1. Between the usual male and female lead

Love. At that sound, my hand stopped on its own. It seemed to contain it as lightly as possible, but it couldn't hide what was contained in it.

Without realizing it, my eyes turned towards the door. It was because I was curious about what my ears had picked up.

Ricdorian's eyes were staring at me as if he had waited.

No, he seemed to have only stared at me. He looked at me and his cheeks were slightly colored, but he didn't avert my gaze.

"Wow, this is the first time I've seen someone talking so openly like that."

Parting the atmosphere that was as if there were only the two of us, Francia intervened.

"Are you confessing? What kind of confession did you just make like that?"

Francia crossed her legs. A twisted silhouette rose above her white skirt. Francia smiled.

"Not cool at all."

...Huh?

For a moment I thought I had heard it wrong. When I looked at Francia's face, she had an innocent face.

Her smile was bright, and her voice was so gentle, as if it was on a picnic. It was a sacred, mysterious, and warm appearance that was so well-suited to the position of a saint.

“If it were me, I would have run away. Run away.”

The words that came out were completely different.

There was not a single point of disturbance in her expression, even though it contained crooked words in the thin and pretty voice.

“Isn’t that right, Sister?”

When she asked for my affirmation, I could neither affirm nor deny it, but vaguely clouded my expression.

How am I supposed to react to this?

Clearly, I thought that Ricdorian and Francia had something to do with each other. Looking at Ricdorian, I thought it wouldn’t be the same relationship as in the book.

At least it wouldn’t be love.

But yes....

‘I didn’t think of the sight of them glaring at each other like this.’

There was nothing to say.

Ricdorian narrowed his eyes and stared coldly at Francia.

“I’ve told you once. You’d better watch your mouth.”

“Oh my goodness.”

Francia laughed softly.

“You better correct those words. Grand Duke. To be careful about what you say is... a precaution for those who do not have the power to take responsibility for it.”

Her head tilted gracefully. It was a lively face, but I could feel the dignity was overlaid on it vividly.

“Not me.”

One of Francia's hands pointed to her own chest.

“I live with what I have to say.”

Francia had a round necklace hanging from her chest, and inside the flat plate were the same temple markings as seen from the carriage. It was a much simpler form.

“I came all the way up here for that. That's what it is.”

I don't know, but I seemed like a high-ranking person. Seeing how she held onto me like this.

“You allowed it, too, Grand Duke?”

Francia's words returned to normal respectfully, but her expression was angry as if saying, ‘Why are you changing your words now?’.

Although it soon disappeared between smiles.

“How long are you going to be there?”

At Francia's next words, Ricdorian's frown lines overlapped one more.

“It's my room?”

Behind these two, somehow, a huge cat, and a wild bear seem to howling ‘woowoo’.

I blinked my eyes slowly.

... Why the hell are you guys growling like you can't eat each other?

It was very strange to see the male and female protagonists staring at each other.

"You have to say it correctly. Isn't this Sister's room?"

"The floor you are standing on is Hernim's mansion."

No. I thought at least they wouldn't be in love like in the book. Why are they burning each other?

Somehow, I felt like a lone acorn that fell. How does it feel when you come to attend a quiz show and watch a bokbulbok* survival show?

"Are you aware that you are childish?"

"You would be the only one in the world to give me a term like that. I think you lack judgment."

"Wow. Are you whining now?"

Whining? I tilted my head at the words that did not suit Ricdorian at all. For a brief moment, annoyance flashed across Ricdorian's face.

"Will you stop saying words that Iana might misunderstand?"

"What is it? It's just the answer. You didn't talk about the Blue Rose because you thought you found her because she is the Blue Rose, didn't you?"

"....."

Ricdorian touched his face. It was like taking a small breath.

"... I really forgot."

He said with a sigh.

“Because I didn’t even have time to think about it.”

Looking back, there was something passing by.

Even while Jaire was talking about the Blue Rose diligently, his eyes were fixed on me no matter what he said. Not long after that, he ran up to me and cried, saying he was sorry. Sorry for kidnapping me.

I haven’t had time to ask since then. He seemed very uncomfortable, so I didn’t ask.

“Hnng, I knew it well, but you’re amazing.”

Francia’s expression softened slightly. It wasn’t a tender face though.

“I didn’t think you have that much time”

It wasn’t a sarcastic or sharp tone.

“Francia Orr Rozenia.”

“Yes yes.”

Francia shrugged her slender shoulders. I want you to figure this out on your own, she seemed to be muttering so.

Ricdorian, who had a great sense, must have heard this sound without missing it.

There seemed to be no tension between the two. Like a long-time colleague, no. It only feels like a subtle atmosphere, like seeing coworkers who don’t get along well.

“Well, can I say it to you?”

Francia reached out her hand and gently held my hand.

“Our promise is different.”

She then grabbed it and swung her hand to Ricdorian.

“Isn’t that right, Red Rose?”

Ricdorian also frowned at the seemingly intimidating act, but he didn’t say anything.

“Don’t hold it tight.”

“Why?”

“Iana’s wrist is going to break.”

“Aha.”

Francia nodded and she really released the powers from her hands.

.... What are they talking about now?

“...Hey, it doesn’t break that much?”

Did she agree with what he said? She smiled and didn’t give strength to her hands.

“Your Excellency.”

Then she turned to Ricdorian.

“I’ll tell you one more time. Our promises are different. How long are you going to be there?”

The two stared at each other again. It reminded me of a cat and a small mouse in an animation, the more they look at each other, the less friendly they are.

“You said that if I meet Sister, we’ll be alone.”

At last, the identity of the contract that I was curious about was revealed. The two people’s eyes met tightly without making any concessions.

“.... I’ll be at the door front.”

In the end, it was Ricdorian who took a step back.

“No doubt?”

Francia bowed her chest and pretended to greeted. Of course, it was a greeting that did not feel sincere at all.

Ricdorian left the room. Apparently, the expression ‘in the door front’ really meant waiting at the door.

“If he’s in front of the door, he can hear everything.”

As it was only me and Francia left, she bent her lips when I said this.

“Hernim’s castle has soundproofing magic on the doors of every room, Sister.”

I looked at her for a moment at the explanation, and then she replied with a slight smile.

“Take it easy.”

“Oh, is that okay?”

“Of course. There’s nothing that can’t be done.”

Now, she is a much higher person. No. So so much higher?

‘Even if I’m the second child of Domulit. First of all, all the power in Domulit is owned by Chaser.’

While thinking about it, Francia smiled broadly. This smile was no different from when I was with her.

“So nice!”

Francia's body hugged me tightly. Perhaps she was meant to be held in my arms, but now that she is a little bigger, it looks like I am in her arms.

"Perhaps if it's the ability of the Red Rose, he can ignore the magic and hear the conversation... but it doesn't matter."

She rested her head on my shoulder. It was the same thing she did when she was a child, no, when she was staying at the Domulit mansion for a while.

"Because I wanted to be alone with you."

I was taken aback for a moment, but then I patted her.

She's a little bit older now, but I didn't hate that I had raised her when she was in Domulit for a short time. When I think about it, I think I laughed a lot when Francia was there. You really needed a friend.

I thought so. Because Pudding feels like a pet.

Weeong?

Pudding cried once at my feet as if he felt what I was thinking.

"Ugh, it's hard to get rid of him."

Meanwhile, Francia, who had buried her head in my shoulder, raised her head with a *pu-ha* sound.

"Oh my gosh, I knew he was full of regrets. It's fascinating to see it like this."

The mumbled words seemed to refer to Ricdorian.

"Ricdorian?"

Francia nodded her head.

"Yes, no. Hmm."

She turned towards the door for a moment, then wrinkled her nose once.

“I thought he really wouldn’t have time, when he had been longing for it for so long.”

As she shook her head and wondered if she should take out the hammer if she wanted too, she added.

“By the way, I know you’re happy, but it wouldn’t be the time for you to be like that.”

“Not the time?”

As if she had been talking to herself up to that point, Francia blinked her eyes. Then she smiled brightly. The sight of her scratching her cheek seemed to hesitate for a moment, but then she shrugged her shoulders once.

“Red Rose, the Grand Duke. There’s not much lifespan left.”

It was a light word, but the content was never light.

*bokbulbok: lit translates as luck-no-luck. It’s mostly used in game show varieties for a game where you play to decide the winner and the winner gets something in the end. Mostly seen in Korean variety ‘2 Days 1 Night’, for example they play a game where the winner gets dinner, while the others don’t. So on~

Chapter 178: Scar (1)

1. 1. Scar (1)

I was startled.

Francia raised her hand and tapped her neck, perhaps not feeling my trembling.

“This, thanks to it being forcibly cut off, it has decreased for a long time. The lifespan?”

This. It was a reference to something, but I understood it at once. It was talking about ‘restraint’.

I’ve already heard about this from Jaire. That it was solved without it being under certain conditions. At that time, I remember that it was ripped forcibly with Francia’s hands.

“When did you meet Ricdorian?”

The answer to the question I asked in just in case, came back immediately. Because Francia spoke right away as if it wasn’t a secret.

“Ah, I met him in Kambrakam. At that time... I went in for a while on behalf of Father’s sins.”

Francia shortened her tone of voice.

“Actually, my father was falsely accused too.”

Meeting in the prison was the same as the original story, as I knew.

“I had a hard time back then, Sister.”

Francia was weeping. I hesitated and swept her hair.

Then Francia quickly gathered her expression. It was a bright and beautiful face like petals that just opened in spring, or like buds sprouting.

“When in prison, Ricdorian must have had a restraint around his neck.”

“That’s right.”

“When you met him, the restraint was ripped off?”

“Um, umm... right? Red Roses are crazy too. How do you do your own child with that?”

Francia put her chin on her hand and grumbled. Although not very fond of Ricdorian, the restraints seem to have left an uncomfortable impression.

“Well, isn’t that what a wandering White Rose would say?”

“Wandering?”

“Yes. Leaving an intact estate, they wander in search of the Blue Rose.”

Francia added briefly.

“That is the fate of the White Rose. The Blue Rose must be healed.”

I couldn’t find anything to say at the moment, and covered my mouth. Francia turned her words right away. She went back to her previous story.

“At that time, Grand Duke Red Rose was very, very ferocious. It was so ferocious I thought he would have eaten me without the chain.”

... In fact, he would have eaten her up. But the meaning is different

I didn’t bother to add.

Perhaps the situation has changed, so that ferocity was no longer a monstrous ferocity. No, I think it might have been the same ferocity. When I saw him for the first time, the appearance of the growling Ricdorian was quite brutal.

“Anyway, when we met back then, the restraints around his neck were forcibly taken off. How absurd, strange, and a little scary. I don’t know. I thought there was only the Black Rose who was crazy in the world.”

However, the time to reflect on the memories did not last long. Because the stone that Francia threw lightly had a heavier theme than I thought.

“The Red Roses have tattoos on their chests, and they have to stop the curse of the falling petals. Otherwise, they’ll die.”

Francia gave a slightly uncomfortable expression.

“With no companion and no guardian spirit to protect him. That was crazy.”

Francia’s words continued.

“But he asked me if I was the White Rose and to help him.”

My hand that had been stroking her stopped.

“He has to get out somehow.”

From here on, it was a story that I had not even heard from Jaire.

“There is something he must find using this damned power as a tool.”

“...”

“What did he say? He didn’t say it?”

There was no way that I didn’t know the subject and the object her words were referring to.

‘It’s me.’

That was the fact that I already knew, no. I felt like I had ruminated the fact that I had been chewing.

“He acted casually in situations where he could die. That’s when I felt it again. Of course, roses are obviously crazy people.”

At those words, I thought of Lenag for a moment, but it disappeared quickly. Considering the appearance in the book, isn’t that normal? Anyway, I pondered over Francia’s words.

<Because His Excellency endured the hell-like side effects and somehow managed to do it.>

That day, Jaire did not tell me what these ‘side effects’ were. Just for me to listen directly from Ricdorian.

I kept my lips shut.

‘The hell-like side effects, he said he endured it.’

It’s not over. I wanted to wipe my face roughly. For some reason, it felt like a puzzle that didn’t fit a little bit did fit.

In fact, there is no reason to welcome me as Ricdorian’s subordinate. Even more so, I was the younger sister of Duke Domulit, Ricdorian’s sworn enemy.

Nevertheless, a face that could not be seen at all, a face that seemed to accept it with more smirk and joy than when I saw it in the prison.

I thought it was not enough to wrap it with the Blue Roses. Did he know I was going to save Ricdorian’s life?

Instead of panicking, I carefully organized the situation.

It’s not that I’m not surprised, but if it happened anyway, it’s more efficient to find a way than to panic.

‘Alright.’

Francia freed Ricdorian's restraints.....Wait a minute.

I lifted my head.

“Francia.”

“Huh? Huh, sister?”

Her lips, which had been fine until then, were tightly shut. It sounded like a listening bird. Complimenting her cute appearance, I said quickly, without a second thought.

“That restraint, didn't you release it?”

“The restraint? Oh, the Grand Duke's?”

Francia's strength was well known. Didn't she prove a few years ago when she even showed off her weapon, a hammer bigger than her own body in the Domulit mansion.

It was also an opportunity to feel once more that the roses' bodies were definitely more prominent than normal humans.

So I believed it casually that Francia had ripped it off with her bare hands. However, she said a while ago that Ricdorian had solved it 'by himself'.

“Me? No.”

Francia blinked her eyes and tilted her head. Her face was curious about the intention of the question, but the answer flowed out.

“The only thing I did was heal a ruptured neck that almost made him die from excessive bleeding.”

Recalling that time, Francia touched her own neck. She frowned a little.

“So much blood comes out... I thought I was cleaning out the corpse of the Red Rose.”

Her eyes closed tightly and then opened.

“I used my abilities again and again and used them until I was exhausted. The grace I gave him back then will not be enough to repay for the rest of his life. I managed to save him.”

Francia muttered a little.

“It must have left a scar on his neck. It’s hard to see.”

She goes on to say that it was really troubling back then, even though she had healing powers on her own. She added that it wasn’t an ordinary wound, and if it was a normal person, they would have died of shock.

At the same time I realized why Jaire and Hernim had been desperate

“The petal tattoo, there must not be much left.”

The sun is setting. I like the sunset most out of the day.

The color of the sky is the same when the sun rises and when the sun sets. I liked this similar yet slightly different subtlety and contradiction.

Even in Domulit, if I was staring blankly at the sky, I didn’t realize that time was passing.

<... Aren’t you tired of this mansion?>

In fact, among those who harbored a grudge against Domulit, there were those who gave me affection or felt sorry for me.

In the end, everyone just chose revenge. They always asked me. Why are you spacing out? Isn’t it frustrating? Aren’t you afraid....

“It wasn’t scary.”

Anyway, contrary to their thoughts, I didn't hate to spend time idly. I liked it in my own way.

But now, as usual, I was not completely immersed in the gentle dazedness brought by the serenity.

My head was complicated. It was indeed for a long time.

How many times has it been this complicated? Before Grand Duke Hernim came to the prison, they tried to hurt Ricdorian.

When I've just arrived at the Domulit's mansion after being released from prison, and I'm trying hard to get out, and I'm trying hard until my third attempt.

'It was until I realized that even if the attempt was successful, I couldn't live comfortably outside.'

When there was a little complexity, there was always a solution in the end. Somehow.

The 'nullification' of the blue rose.

In fact, I didn't know that the ability I thought was insignificant would be used like this. Unknowingly, Ricdorian's life is slowly disappearing.

... *weong*.

As I stretched my hand under my knees, Pudding came and rubbed its forehead against my drooping hands.

It felt like comforting rather than acting cute as usual. The reason it didn't speak with my head on purpose was probably because it felt my complexity through my mind.

"It's okay."

I stroked Pudding's head.

“I’ve always been fine.”

I lowered my eyes and lifted it again.

“It will be fine in the future too.”

Yes. It will be. It’s always relaxing and it’s always okay.

When I looked up a little more, someone I had not seen before was standing still.

“So it’s okay if you don’t look like that.”

Why did I only realize now?

Ricdorian, your eyes resemble those who once played me and swung between revenge and compassion. It’s not that you had revenge. Those eyes that felt pitiful, I wondered why I saw them now. And they finally couldn’t turn away from the grudges that had accumulated over the years, but

you know you won’t.

I was convinced. Anyone who sees these straight, unconditional eyes will feel it.

“Come here, why are you standing there?”

Ricdorian came silently and knelt down in front of me.

I let out a small laugh.

I meant to sit across from me. The figure kneeling in front of me like a large beast reminds me of him in the prison.

I really thought that was just like him.

Francia finished her story and went back. She didn’t just want to tell about Ricdorian’s stories but a lot about herself too. She couldn’t do all of them

because she didn't have much time, and in the end, she had to go back soon, promising the next one.

He must have listened to all the conversations I had with Francia today. Even so, his face remained unchanged.

I asked once, just in case.

“Did you hear it all?”

I often said things that had neither a subject nor an object, and he understood it well.

“...if you're talking about the White Rose, yes.”

I'm talking about the fact that your life is short. He was very calm.

I smiled bitterly.

“Why didn't you say that?”

Ricdorian paused for a moment.

Chapter 179: Scar (2)

1. 1. Scar (2)

“It’s an important story.”

He must have felt the quiet oscillations in my voice. Because he was a man with a keen sense of everything about me.

“Excuse me, Grand Duke.”

Ricdorian stiffened his body at the gradually changing voice and his name.

“I don’t talk about myself well to other people. In fact, in the past, I wasn’t really curious about myself either.”

The story of the day when I thought that I could just live comfortably.

“Because it’s useless to talk about what’s already happened.”

For similar reasons, I don’t get angry easily. I don’t raise my voice If there’s no reason to.

“And actually, I don’t really care what other people think. It’s enough just to keep my back warm and eat well.”

The days I lived like that. Those days when other things didn’t matter as long as my comfort was there.

“But why are you?”

I pulled out the hand he was holding. Ricdorian’s eyes widened at the big and determined movement from me.

“Why do you make me regret?”

I tried to smile, but I don't know if it went well.

It was easy to pretend to be calm from fear and unfamiliarity, but the opposite is not easy. The warm and tickling things made me more vulnerable than the bitter emotions.

Your blindness makes me in trouble.

“Even if I go back, I will feel sorry for you, or I may feel more heavily than I do now.”

I bit my lips slightly.

People who usually do not pay attention to their emotions, and those who have let go of them carelessly, are often flustered by the flames burning in their chest. Like me.

<A year later. The, the day I get out of here, Please... Please meet me!>

At that time, four years ago, I didn't have the courage, didn't want to take responsibility, and didn't know how to take responsibility.

“Because that was the best thing.”

So when I go back, I'll abandon Ricdorian again. I was such a person.

“I told you. I'm selfish and shameless.”

Yes. For this selfish reason, matter how many times I go back, I will not put him first and will not consider his wishes.

I will throw him away. I won't keep my promise.

“What a waste. Wasted. Your everything to give me.”

It's sad, it's a pity, it's a waste.

“Are you crazy? Will you risk your life?”

Do you feel sorry for me? I feel sorry for you.

“Why is that, risking your life!”

Watching the sunset, I haven’t been at peace in a long time. Even on the day Chaser came with a blood-stained sword, I looked at the sky indifferently.

All I could think of was the story that Francia had told me. For whatever reason, I took the risk and headed for Schirmela with Pudding.

I wanted you to live. I hoped that I would be happy if possible.

But I can’t believe he’s already messed up. That it happened because of me. How can I not be frustrated and angry?

To this stupid person.

“...angry?”

Even at this moment, Ricdorian looked at me, not knowing what to do. He seemed to prioritize me over himself. What if I hadn’t left this Ricdorian behind? If only I had stayed by his side until the day he was released from prison.

No. If only I had taken his hand and went to Hernim.

A useless assumption was not needed at this moment. And it’s something I don’t usually do.

Disrupting reason and serenity.

Now, looking at the man who had lost the coolness of the reunion, there was nothing but a smile of disappointment.

When I was looking at Ricdorian, I felt like I was seeing a beast that looked at only one master for the rest of its life. It is said that when dogs are

abandoned, they blame themselves instead of resenting their heartless owners.

I couldn't keep up because I was slow, thinking.

Even if I take off and run, I've been chasing after a car that's much bigger than my body, and just ends up with a wounded foot.

Like a dog on TV.

Ricdorian did the same.

"...I will cooperate."

I, who had never been able to avoid his gaze, turned my head first..

"The curse on your body, I'll break it somehow."

There's a saying that the person who tied the knot must untie it. In the end, if I have tied it up, it is also my responsibility to untie it.

"Really, what are you going to do if I wasn't the Blue Rose!"

In fact, the only reason this is possible is because I am the Blue Rose. Of course, even if I wasn't the Blue Rose, I would have somehow found a 'Blue Rose' like Jaire and Hernim.

What if that person doesn't cooperate? What if they had already died? No matter how you look at it, he gambled with a slim chance.

Even if he was urgent and desperate.

He had put his head on the stake. I turned my head and wiped my cheek with the back of my hand. My lips were tightly shut.

A sigh flowed out.

"...how can a person be so foolish?"

With the other hand, I covered my eyes with my hand so that Ricdorian could not see me. I didn't want to show my messy face.

Did I say that he was a man who developed his senses like an animal?

"...Iana."

He hesitated

"Are you crying?"

I didn't answer. It was and it was not. What is crying if you only shed a single drop of water? No words came out of embarrassment.

"No."

Ricdorian clicked his lips.

"Lies. You cried."

His tongue slowly moistened his lower lip.

"Because of me."

Ricdorian's voice was low. Not only high and low, but temptation flowed out as if it was a rest. This was proof that his personality had changed. I mean, when he's like this...

I felt annoyed and tried to pull my hand away. But before that, his hand grabbed hold of it.

Ricdorian was holding my hand and smiling languidly.

"You are crying because of me."

The neat eyes narrowed and folded gracefully. However, the density that was not normally seen fell dripping down.

"I'm happy."

He smiled bashfully and rubbed my hand against his cheek. It was a movement that was not very different from before, but the feeling was different.

“It’s worth risking my life.”

“Is that what you want to say now?”

“Hmm.”

I tried to say something because I was moved by his calm voice, but the moment I saw his face, I dived in.

“Hah, don’t smile like that.”

It was as pure and ferocious as a water lily looking up from the bottom. Creating an inconsistent appearance.

“...I smiled at what I did well. It’s interesting.”

With a sigh, I pushed his forehead slightly, and gently pushed him back.

It didn’t end there, but I raised my upper body. It wasn’t enough to get him up, I stretched my legs out, but was trapped in a large shadow.

I frowned slightly.

“Ricdorian.”

“Huh.”

The hand I reached out was swallowed by his lips. Ricdorian lowered his gaze with his lips in the palm of my hand.

“I’m listening. Iana. Anytime you say it.”

He looked more thirsty than any other day. He tilted his head and kissed my cheek. That was when I thought it was just a light kiss.

Sweep.

Until he licked my cheek a little. Goosebumps swelled up.

“You cried.”

“What... what are you doing?”

I tried to escape, but the sofa was already full. I leaned back against the backrest and closed my eyes.

“Really, you cried for me.”

Ricdorian eyes dazzled and he rolled up the corners of his mouth.

“I’m glad, I’m happy.”

The hand that was holding my hand was pulled up and grabbed his neck. No, he made me grab it. My fingers gently slide down.

<It must have left a scar on his neck. It’s hard to see.>

Francia’s voice was vividly ringing in my ear.

It was still a time when the sun was shining brightly. The sofa in front of the window was bright even without lights.

So I was able to find a faint scar. It was a pale scar on the pure white skin that would not be visible unless you look closely.

Francis said. It is said that the Red Rose has a body that regenerates any wound. In fact, the traces of his father’s abuse often disappeared over time. However, the scar remains. Moreover, despite the healing of the White Rose.

<Did he intentionally leave a scar? I don’t know if it’s inevitable.>

Francia added a bit sarcastically, but the seriousness of the situation was sufficiently conveyed.

“Iana, how a bad person I am.”

Ricdorian whispered to me, facing his forehead with mine. It was a bold contact that he would never have been able to do, but it was no longer his usual self. Sincerity flowed from him, who shared memories and emotions.

“I wonder if Iana will feel guilty looking at this scar. I had such a bad idea.”

Instead of avoiding it, I gently grabbed his cheek.

“...so bad.”

“Huh.

He laughed out loud.

“Because I was that desperate.”

When there was no time to think about life. Don’t you know if you know that it feels pathetic and pitiful?

I gently rubbed his smooth cheeks with my thumb, then he slowly opened his lips.

“I must be punished.”

He lowered his eyes and muttered,

“It’s too bad, you should be punished. You.”

I muttered that as if to comfort him, reminiscing about his dog-like whining personality a long time ago, and then Ricdorian tilted his head to meet my gaze.

Then he slowly bent his eyes.

“Kiss me as a punishment.”

Very desperately.

No one threatened or intimidated, but there was a lot of tension within this short distance.

I looked at him for a long time and then let out a small sigh.

“...close your eyes.”

In fact, Ricdorian asked me to kiss him, but he didn't seem to expect it. I just rolled my fingers into his interlaced hands.

The evidence was that he didn't take any action.

Perhaps that's why? He couldn't hide his surprised eyes even though his personality had changed at my words. However, he has been a good listener for a long time. That's how his behaviour was.

“I like closing my eyes.”

Although irrational, his growth mode was a bit arrogant, the big core was no different. It's still the same, he slowly closed his eyes.

He has silver-colored eyelashes fluttering down. I took a deep breath as I watched his eyelids close.

The hesitation didn't last long.

I grabbed his collar and kissed him. It was just an ignorant kiss on his lips. I said that I would do it, and then did it with a little bit of leeway, but I didn't really want to do more than this.

But, as always, things didn't go as planned.

Chapter 180: As expected, this novel is R-Rated

1. 1. As expected, this novel is R-Rated

The body just flowed down. The interlaced hands gripped me. I opened my eyes in surprise and my lips parted slightly.

“Ric, heup.”

And the lips that did not miss that moment came in through mine. My mouth was just as sweet as when I had candy in my mouth.

A firm hand drew my neck, which was slightly fluctuating, and let it go. Unlike the smooth skin, callused, bumpy rough fingertips were rather irritating to sensitive skin.

A moan came out. It was as if someone had sent an exhilarating electric signal down my back.

The sound that came out of my lips was a voice that made me wonder if it was really mine. My face seemed to turn red at the sound of the gentle flow.

Even in the midst of my confusion, I had a strange thought.

Obviously, 4 years ago and now, I will be the only one. I don't think there was anyone else. However....

Why are you so good?

It's the same as the first time, but is this difference in ability something that God has specifically given to the male lead?

I had a strange feeling.

Perhaps he noticed that I was thinking differently. Ricdorian came in and provoked me in one place.

I came to my senses.

As I ran out of breath, he removed his lips slightly and rubbed it gently. It was a kiss like a bird pecking with its beak.

“Excuse me.”

But I couldn't pay more attention to the lips.

“Why are you pulling the ribbon?”

Ricdorian, who removed his lips off, tilted his head. Before I knew it, the ribbon that had adorned my chest was untied and held in his hand.

Undoing it didn't remove the clothes, but seeing it in his hand gave me a strange feeling. Actually, it seems that it was loosened while lying on the sofa rather than him pulling it. I was skeptical.

Ricdorian came out and looked at the ribbon in turn, and at one point, his face was colored hot.

“This, this is... I took it off.”

“It's not true?”

“N, no. No... it is not.”

He seemed to have returned to his character. Suddenly, he may have returned to the rational side, but the appearance of him waving his hand while blushing was real.

“No?”

“It is not!”

I tilted my head, then agreed. Well. If not, I'm glad. Because I still want to be all ages for the rest of my life.

“My lips hurt.”

Flinch.

Ricdorian rolled his eyes with a reddened face.

“Do you like rough things?”

“Yes, what, uh, what?”

“Kidding.”

It must have been an instinct to run recklessly. At the end, he became softer, but for a moment I thought it would be swallowed as it is.

What to call this?

‘Is it day and night?’

No. If I tell him not to do it, he won't do it again, so is it day and night? I shook my head softly, thinking about something absurd.

‘There is no change in that expression.’

As I was looking at him, I remembered him in the cell and burst into laughter. After laughing, he looked at me blankly.

“Are you going to keep sitting on me?”

“What? Oh...”

If it had been him four years ago, he would have been surprised and would have gotten out of the way quickly. Ricdorian hesitated, but did not move. Instead, he grabbed the back of the sofa with his firm hand.

I asked if he would sit on me, so Ricdorian, instead of putting any weight on me, held on to his strength and kissed me.

To be honest, the size couldn't cover me, so I didn't have enough space, so I wondered if this sofa would have been unbearable if he had been rougher.

It looks like a small sofa that can seat up to three people. Of course, if only I had intended to do that with him.

“Hey, Ricdorian. I'm sorry for the timing.”

I hesitated to speak as usual. I'm sorry that Ricdorian was pricking his ears while blushing.

“Can I say something unscrupulous?”

Having said this, I felt like a really bad person. Ricdorian, rarely naively blinked his eyes, and widened them even more, but I pretended not to know.

“I didn't answer your heart properly in the first place, so I'm sorry for kissing you.”

First of all, I decided to apologize and move on.

“No, it's not! Me too...”

“Yes, yes. I know what you want to say. Can you hear me first?”

Even if I say that I was swept away by the atmosphere, it's right that I did it first. I comforted him and continued to talk.

“I'm insensitive to emotions. Well... To be precise, I don't pay much attention to my feelings or the feelings of others.”

It was true. If only I could be calm, I would look deeply into others. I didn't look, and I didn't even look back at myself.

“So it takes time to think about emotions and face them. I want to think carefully.”

I took his hand on the sofa. As I did, I clasped his hands and put his fingertips to my lips.

Stop. He pauses and even his fingertips turn red. He was a very touch-me-not-plant-like man.

On the other hand, I didn't feel anything big when I put my lips on it. I was curious to see how he would feel, so I tried it.

I don't understand. I didn't feel a little tickle and sweet like when he kissed me a while ago.

"For example, I like you."

Good. Otherwise, I wouldn't have been bothered all the time, and in the end, it wouldn't have become a stone in my heart and I would not sit here.

"But, how deep it is, what color it is, and what shape it is."

Of course, how can emotions be cut and judged by shape and color?

"I don't even know myself."

If there is one special thing, shouldn't it be treated specially?

"I didn't live reading your face."

I haven't cared about these things all along, but looking at the attitude he showed me, somehow I think I should cherish myself a little more.

Like how you see me.

It is precious to touch him whenever I see his lost attitude. I want to know more about the things I feel inside my chest.

"I'm so sorry for kissing you in the garden... Just a little bit."

"Of course."

Ricdorian interrupted me and came in.

“If you’re asking if I can wait. It’s obvious.”

Ricdorian brought the interlaced hands with his serious eyes.

“It’s possible even if you ask me to wait for the rest of my life.”

I was silent for a moment, then replied.

“...you can’t live your life right now. You’re trying to deceive someone.”

Flinch.

“That makes sense...”

“Before making a plausible statement, value yourself first. Okay?”

“That’s what Iana should do.”

“Me?”

When our eyes met, Ricdorian flapped his lips. I smiled slightly as I looked at the quivering lips.

“Okay. I’ll try that too.”

What he wanted to do, what he wanted to have.

And what I wanted to do. I seemed to understand why he asked me.

“I’ll look for what I want to do and what I want to have.”

I lightly rubbed my face against the back of Ricdorian’s hand.

“I’ll try.”

I left behind the obvious answer, and after enjoying it for one day, it felt like we had become bad people.

I wanted to cherish it for once. My life was like running water. I just let my body follow the flow.

From the prison to Domulit, from Domulit to Hernim again. The first place I want to be among them is where he was. I wanted to know more about what this is.

Unfortunately for him, the temperature of all my emotions is so low that I need some time to think about whether this lukewarm love is real love.

“Well then...”

Ricdorian let go of my hand slowly, and got up. Then he lifted me up at once and sat me down properly.

Someone must be a red rose with beast-like powers. I really thought it would make people shine.

“In the future...”

“In the future?”

“Can I kiss you...?”

After hesitating, I wonder if this is what he wanted to say? Instead of answering, I asked the wrong question.

“Before answering, I’m curious to ask, is the way to get a tattoo a kiss?”

“What? Ah. No. It’s not like that... Each rose has a slightly different method.”

“Really?”

I tilted my head.

“How about the Red Rose?”

The more I looked, the more I thought that each rose had its own characteristics. Even if they do one thing, each has a different method.

Chaser's seemed to be engraved without effort. Was there something more?

Meanwhile, Ricdorian bowed his head.

"....ep"

"Yes? I can't hear you."

"...method is... sleep."

Sleep? After asking like that, I realized.

.... Are we going to spend the night?

He expressed it in a pure way, does it mean to have a relationship? When I asked Ricdorian, the answer came out after a really long time with difficulty. *That's right.*

My God. Would you call it romantic? The R-rated setup in the wrong place.

'Somehow, after asking if he could engrave it, I couldn't talk about it.'

Even if it's the first time I ask, does he think I knew? He knows it's not right? Thanks for making me hesitant.

"I already have a red rose tattoo because of Pudding."

If I had said that it was on the inside of my thigh, the atmosphere that had barely been loosened seemed strange.

"No, you don't have to engrave it. I was wrong. That's later..."

No. Even if it wasn't engraved right away, I wanted to talk about the tattoo, but in the end, Ricdorian gave up the word first. While I'm baffled,

"And I'm fine...I'm fine. I can wait."

In the meantime, Ricdorian continued with his head bowed down.

“...continuously, No. I can wait forever.”

Wait forever.

... Is it okay to wait and die?

It couldn't be more extreme. His words made me feel even more unscrupulous. I burst out laughing.

“Even if you like it.”

Then he nodded his head.

“It won't take long.”

The neat man's face bloomed like a flower in front of my eyes. Even I, who had seen his smile, was surprised by his face.

Kiss.

He tilts his head, kisses my mouth slightly, and steps back. And as he looked at me, he did not avert his gaze even though he turned red. When I saw his face dyed red and itchy like a camellia flower, there was a question that bloomed in my heart.

“Is it a characteristic of roses to not change?”

I suddenly asked.

Chaser has been really consistent over the past four years. I was always looking for one. Francia has not changed enough even though I haven't seen her for a while, and so is Lenag.

The highest peak here is Ricdorian in front of me

“... Because we live a little longer than the average person.”

Ricdorian lightly rubbed my fingertips on his cheek, just like Pudding.

“That’s why it might be hard to change.”

One day, the saying that the guardian deity is influenced by the heart and actions of the rose came to mind. Like Aquala and Ratyan, who were obsessed and devoted to me. Pudding and Ricdorian were also similar.

“Like a young tree can be transplanted at any time, but an old tree is impossible.”

His clear blue eyes turned to me. The eyes were as deep as the deep sea.

“You mean your heart is the same too?”

“Yes.”

Ricdorian answered without hesitation. Under the setting sun, he was dyed as red as the sun.

“I love you.”

Seriously, I thought he was a man who could not throw anything other than a fastball.

*) the term day and night used 낮저밤이 describes someone who is sweet during the day but dominating at night, so *quite specific*

Chapter 181: Little Guardian Deities

1. 1. Little Guardian Deities

A vassal meeting held at Hernim Castle. I don't know much about this, but it seems like it's been happening for quite some time.

However, as time passed, the carriages in front of the castle disappeared one by one. With these words of explanation, it is said that the ones who are not important, those who are at the very least or those who have urgent business, will go back.

'I heard that a vassal is not the same as a subordinate.'

I looked down the window while holding Pudding.

The carriages were said to have disappeared, but many still remained.

'It seems to be the same thing.'

— You mean subordinates, Nyang?

And among the carriages that did not disappear, there was a sparkling white carriage that anyone could see.

It is the carriage of the temple. The carriage that Francia was riding in.

'Because it really stands out.'

Even while everyone went back one by one, Francia was still staying in Hernim's castle.

Ricdorian was very dissatisfied with this, but surprisingly, he did not bring it out. Presumably, this also means that there was some kind of promise or deal between the two of them.

– Aha, Nyang! Got it, human. Subordinate.

In the meantime, Pudding, who had been playing with my fingers, lifted its head. Pudding was in its original form, that of a baby snow leopard.

– Human, aren't you talking about between you and me, Nyang!

‘Huh?’

Are you saying that you're my subordinate? I asked if it was right, and it said yes. He also spoke triumphantly with his thick front paws up.

– Human, isn't this body taking care of you, Nyang?

‘Who takes care of who.’

As usual, I put Pudding down on the sofa.

It was the sofa where I kissed Ricdorian a few days ago. I grabbed Pudding's cheek and stretched it out.

“Who is my subordinate? Huh?”

Kyaong, kyaong kyaong, kyaaanng!

“Our Pudding. Has been quiet all this time. Isn't it?”

Kyaang, Kyaong!

-Human, human, I'm wrong, Nyang! I'm losing my whiskers, Nyang!

“You said that you were made with a spirit body.”

-Still, the pain is the same, Nyang!

Three years passed and the three-year-old guardian deity entered its adolescence(?) in terms of the animal age, but it was still rather small in its original form. To the extent that it is still appropriate to call it a baby.

‘Are you deliberately pretending to be a baby animal? Or maybe it didn’t grow up.’

Even if I asked, it wouldn’t tell me, so I don’t know. Sometimes this bothered me a little. Because I was sorry if it didn’t grow up because it met me and signed a contract with me. I’m sorry, but your original contractor, the Red Rose, was sufficient.

I stroked Pudding’s head.

The fact that I could relate to Pudding such as being quiet or rubbing its head in comfort, was because of the contract where Pudding could read my mind from time to time and vice versa.

I used to feel Pudding’s feelings too.

It’s still a young guardian deity, so it doesn’t have deep thoughts. And the biggest thing that comes to mind is....

That he would no longer be sent away. It was a ‘relief’.

... How could this be the same with the Red Rose? Sometimes I feel like I’m raising a Little Ricdorian. A Ricdorian with soft fur and ears and a tail.

... wait.

‘It’s not bad.’”

– ...Human, what else are you thinking about, Nyang?

I smiled and patted Pudding’s head so that it wasn’t hurt.

“It is you. When did you learn Marshmel’s tone?”

That weird way of speaking was the main specialty of our little warlock. Every day, he would look at me strangely and spit out venomous words.

I wonder if he's doing well. He was Chaser's closest aide. He was a good person who was nice to me, but it may be difficult to see him again.

Thinking about it, the relationships here are very shallow. Shallow and fleeting.... It was the same with the noble mates in the cell, and the little warlock in Domulit.

I had a similar personality in the previous world, but it wasn't that there were no people around. It's totally different here. It's as if I don't want to make something valuable.

Sometimes I wondered who would lead me like this. It's a really stupid idea though.

Creak.

I turned my head to the sound of the door opening. There was no one where there should have been one person.

'What.'

My head automatically goes down. And when I looked at something close to the floor, the corners of my lips rose by itself.

"Hi?"

There was a little bear. It's a baby bear.

I was not surprised and greeted the little bear. A little surprised by my greeting, the baby bear looked around and hid behind the door.

Then it just stuck out its head.

Peeking.

'Hng, it's very cute.'

The reason I wasn't surprised to see a bear was because I had already seen it once. It is the guardian deity that Francia boasted hard in the Domulit mansion.

<It's grown a lot!>

It was also a child that she had already shown me once the day before yesterday.

Kyaaong, Kyaaaongg!

Next to it, Pudding expressed its presence saying that this body is cuter and bigger, but I secretly ignored it.

Then a small claw poked my arm, but I also pretended not to know. I put Pudding down for a moment and spread out my hand.

"Come here."

The baby bear crawled and hesitated, but couldn't come closer. Perhaps the guardian deity could not move freely without the will of the contractor, and it was probably sent by the White Rose Francia.

Ummm, what was its name?

"...Calisto?"

The bear's black eyes blinked and blinked. Then it was not enough to get up on both feet, so it set its other feet on the ground.

It ran this way on all fours.

Trudge.

The bear's charge didn't stop until it hit my leg.

It was described as a baby bear, but it was quite heavy, so I stumbled unknowingly.

Oh my, that surprised me. I kept my balance and squatted to face the bear.

The bear also looked like it was curious and stood on two legs. It's so cute to see it holding my hand and whimpering.

"Hello, we met before right?"

The bear whined, grabbed my hand and put it down. Then it even tried to climb on me.

"Um, no."

I covered the bear's forehead and quietly blocked the path.

"If you come up here, there is a scary snow leopard."

I glanced at the sofa.

Even if it didn't, Pudding, which moved its tail and showed its discomfort, raised its fur on edge.

– Human, don't hug it, Nyang! Don't hug it!

'I didn't.'

With a grin, I got up from and sat down next to Pudding.

At the same time, the door opened wide and someone walked in. I wondered who this was and it was the contractor of this cute baby bear guardian deity.

"Sister!"

Francia grabbed the hem of her robe and ran. She shouldn't have to hold onto the hem of her white pants, but her hand held it tightly as if she wanted to run faster.

It looked just like the little bear that was running on all fours a while ago, and I burst into laughter.

“Right, is the meeting over?”

“Yes. It’s over!”

Francia rushed to me as if hugging me and flopped on the sofa. She smelled of a subtle rose scent.

“By the way, Sister is a wonderful person.”

“All of a sudden?”

Francia laughed as she buried her body.

“It’s just. I thought you would have been a great person even if you weren’t the Blue Rose.”

Instead of talking about the meeting, I rolled my eyes at the nonsensical story.

“Sister caught the Red Rose tightly?”

“Huh?”

“We’re having a meeting. The person who’s supposed to be the head of this meeting is totally out of his mind.”

Francia rested her chin with her hands on my thighs. She had a slightly grumpy face.

“There is a lot of work right now. There must be one or two places where Hernim has spread its power. The Grand Duke went out, in the meantime, you guys do it yourself. Of course. Where would he like to go after that?”

“Ummm.”

“The people were just murmuring witnessing him go...”

She shrugged her shoulders.

“It was ridiculous.”

For some reason, it felt like the situation was drawn in front of me with Francia’s explanation.

It had been three days since I had responded to Ricdorian.

‘For three days, Ricdorian’s visits were a little less than before.’

I thought he was just disappointed about this. I pretended not to respond to his confession, but I thought maybe he couldn’t be calm.

Tock, tock.

I felt a small knock on my leg. Francia was tapping my leg as if to awaken my thoughts.

“Sister.”

“Huh?”

Francia made a sullen face while tilting her pretty face.

“Sister, do you like that person more than me, huh?”

Unaware, Francia, who had removed her hand from her chin, grabbed my finger and waved it like a child.

“It’s true that you met him earlier, but I like you too.”

I smiled as soon as I saw the slender fingers holding my fingertips. She had an aspect that I couldn’t hate.

“I already like you.”

“Really?”

She smiled softly as if she was really happy. Then she grabbed my hand and shook it.

“Um, then I’ll give you something. Sister, do you want it?”

After letting go of my hand, what Francia brought in was none other than the baby bear guardian deity.

“...your guardian deity is surprised.”

Callisto’s eyes widened in surprise.

“Why? The Grand Duke said that he dedicated his guardian deity to Sister.”

“It wasn’t dedicated.”

“No?”

“Yes. It’s not. Put it down. Your guardian deity is crying.”

Just as expected. The guardian deity Callisto was looking at Francia with tears in its eyes that seemed to shed tears.

Grabbing Francia’s robe hem with its front paws....

Don’t leave me, I’ll do my best! Like a crying child saying so. Thanks to that, I almost suddenly separated a family.

It felt absurd.

Chapter 182: Iana and 'Iana'

1. 1. Iana and 'Iana'

“Um, if it’s Sister, there’s nothing I can do about it.”

“It’s not ‘there’s nothing to be done’.”

I tapped Francia’s forehead.

“You should cherish your guardian deity. It’s crying.”

“No, I’m not giving it because it’s not important.”

Francia held the bear and put her chin on my leg.

“Because Sister is important, Callisto is important too. It’s good to be with the things I like.”

As she said that, she gave a bashful smile. Looking at that, I thought that I could not help but fall for this figure.

I grabbed her hand and smiled together. Then, after a moment’s hesitation, I opened my lips.

“Just in case, Francia. Can you do me a favor?”

It was something I had been holding for so long.

A favor? Francia asked with her dazzling eyes. Then I told her what I had been thinking all along.

“Could you please contact Marquis Valtaze?”

Is it possible to contact Lenag?

Next day.

Come to think of it, I think I liked the female lead the most when reading the book. Even though I was a reader who had been faithful to the content before that, if I had to find my favorite here, it would have been Francia.

In fact, the one thing I liked more than the character was the R-rated scenes. When I say this, it sounds like a pervert, but I was just being faithful to my desires.

To be honest, I just didn't know that I would get into the novel I thought I would just think of.

Even today, the surname of the pretty male lead, Hernim, used to make me cry out for good thoughts.

He was very busy here. Of course, the meeting was not over since the vassals were still visiting, so it was a busy time, but he was also busy with other things.

Other things.

It was a way to restore Ricdorian's lifespan.

"So many books..."

And it was also the most life-and-death job they were putting their lives for.

"Yes. I've seen them all."

I let out a small sigh of admiration as I looked at the books stacked up to the ceiling. To be honest, I wanted to make a louder noise, but if I did, the precariously stacked books seemed to fall over.

There were so many books. Rolls and rolls of parchment.

“It’s okay to touch.”

“Oh, no.”

Jaire said that it wouldn’t fall over because it was a magically stacked book, but I was still cautious.

I came here for the promise I made to Ricdorian that I would break his curse. To do this, I thought I had to meet Jaire first. Just in time, he came and happily brought me here.

It wasn’t without hesitation. He greeted me with double squinting eyes.

“If the Blue Rose cooperates, I would be most grateful. Have a look.”

When am I going to see all of this? Jaire laughed as if he was joking.

“Since I’m the Blue Rose, so you don’t care that I’m Duke Domulit’s sister?”

“Did I get caught?”

Jaire didn’t even deny it. Instead, he nodded playfully, as in the prison.

“Yes, that’s right.”

It was a fact I already knew, so I was not surprised. Instead, Jaire took what I had offered. He risked his life to investigate over the past few years.

I could feel how desperate he must have been in the hand-stained papers.

“His Excellency is conducting the final meeting.”

“Yes, I heard.”

I heard this from Ricdorian who visited my room in the morning. I think he’ll be able to come back later in the afternoon.

<Never forget m.e>

How is the difference between morning and night? He left behind such a vile remark.

Why are there only vulgar words?

<Huhk, St... stop. There... >

<A little more, huh?>

He also left a lot of kisses. His personality changed in the middle, and my eyes turned around, dragging in Pudding and barely stopping it.

<It's too sensational for a kid!>

I thought he was going to do anything, even if I said things like this. Thinking about the morning, my face was almost red.

The three-year-old guardian deity who became an adolescent(?) asked what it was and naively tilted its head.

– What are you thinking again, Nyang? Rubbing your lips, didn't you do it 3 years ago, Nyang?

‘Quiet.’

It hid itself in my body and let Pudding's chattering words through one ear.

Meanwhile, Jaire's explanation continued.

“There is also a story written about the Miss.”

“Yes.”

I mean, they did research on me. This, too, was not surprising.

“But did you find out about me? It's a bit weird for me to say, but my brother must have been a formidable person.”

“Oh, that.”

Jaire rubbed his chin. There was a hint of worry for a moment, but it was quickly erased.

“There is a man named ‘Shero’ who oversees your operatives. He has struggled for a long time to get people inside Domulit,”

“You mean, it was a success.”

“Yes. I was already making the assumption that Duke Domulit’s younger sister might be the Blue Rose.”

All that was left was to check. I nodded at those words, just then, the door opened and someone came in. I wondered if it was the first time I saw him, but it wasn’t. I opened my eyes wide.

‘That person....’

It was a memorable face. The man also looked at me, smiling kindly and bowing his head. He gave a polite greeting.

“Hello.”

“...we met before.”

Instead of saying hello, I gave an answer that revealed surprise. That’s right, the guy was in prison 4 years ago.

It was the guard I saw.

‘Is the name, Anton?’

He was a competent senior guard who led the guard when Ricdorian ran into a runaway while walking. He was the one who shouted at me to say the starting word, and the memory of that day is a memory that I will never forget.

I remembered.

“You’re Anton, aren’t you?”

“It is an honor to remember the name of this person.”

He smiled politely. Then again, he introduced himself as ‘Anton’, the deputy commander of the Knights of Grand Duchy Hernim.

Ha, Jaire said that he had a lot of colleagues in the prison. It seems that Anton was also one of them.

Well. I would wonder if he didn’t take any action while sending the one and only heir of Hernim into the prison...

I meekly agreed.

“I don’t know if I can tell you this, but it’s nice to see you again here.”

He was a guard who met me quite often until the guard changed completely at Lenag’s orders. In that memory, I nodded in agreement.

“I was wondering if there would be a chance to say hello. Hahaha.”

He smiled broadly and pointed to the report I was holding. There, he said that he had also testified.

“When it was revealed that the Miss was the Domulit lady and the Blue Rose, and that she was in prison. I reported what happened in the prison.”

I guess so. To be honest, there would be nothing special about me in prison.

“Well, it must have been nothing special.”

Then Anton widened his eyes for a moment. Just by looking at it, he wanted to say no.

Why?

“Um, that’s not true, the Miss’ presence in prison...”

“Why me?”

“Slightly, I would say you were noticeable. Yes. You stood out.”

First of all, he said that my appearance was unusual. I glanced at my hair and agreed. It's a rare hair color.

Prisoners have also mentioned it often. Yet none of them knew who I was.

“Well, my hair color is unusual.”

“No, even if it's not the color of your hair...”

Anton was about to say something, but then shook his head, saying no. Then the man scratched his cheek, showing a slightly puzzled face.

“Actually, if you think about it, it was when you went to the basement or when you went to the reception room. You looked good. You looked lively.”

“Yes?”

I tilted my head at the incomprehensible story. When I went to the basement?

Jaire looked at me and Anton with interest, but did not stop Anton.

“...Have you ever seen me before?”

If it was before I went to the basement, it was when I wasn't the owner of this body. When it's 'Iana'.

“Yes? Yes. There is.”

Was it because of this that Anton looked difficult?

“It wasn't that something good had happened, but I was a little reluctant to talk about it.”

He is said to have been in charge of patrolling the noble prisoners before taking charge of the basement cell. Then he saw me once in a while.

He said he saw it right next to me when I collapsed from a heart attack.

Lenag said not to tell this to anyone. Of course, he reported it to Hernim, who is his base. I didn't care about it.

"Actually, you look a lot more lively and good now."

He added that I should take it as positive when I don't respond. He didn't mean to be rude, but I looked better.

"How did I look before?"

"Before, how should I say this? You always looked bloodless and weak."

It was. When I just woke up, Iana's body was sickly and extremely weak.

"Um, and when I called you, there was no answer, and your eyes...."

I spoke softly to him, as if encouraging him.

"It's okay, just tell me the truth."

"I'm not a learned person, so I can't find a proper expression. That... the Miss' eyes at that time, I guess....were a little out of focus"

Out of focus?

"Sometimes even among the guards, there was talk. Because you rarely ate."

Without a serious expression on his face, Anton scratched the back of his head with a large hand. He added that he seems to have been wrong about what he said.

He had a face that looked like he had made a mistake.

"I don't know if I was being too rude."

"It's okay. It's nothing. So what exactly was it like?"

“To sum it up?”

“Yes.”

When I told him it was okay to tell me, a look that he didn't understand passed by him.

... Why? It didn't seem like a story to just pass over.

“Ummm, to put it bluntly. The Miss at the time was like, you felt like a ‘doll’, maybe?”

Chapter 183: I will take Francia's share (1)

1. 1. I will take Francia's share (1)

I blinked at the last word that summed it up. Then, slowly and narrowly narrowed.

I was weak, my eyes seemed out of focus, and I couldn't even eat well.

Under the circumstances, the previous 'Iana' loved Chaser, and she didn't get a heart back from him. And she was brought to the prison by Chaser to escape his father's eyes.

I don't know more than that.

But could the condition of 'Iana' at the time have anything to do with this fact?

The more I thought about it, the more strange it felt. That's probably why Anton also talked about it. I'm different from before, so he brought it up. He tilted his head and seemed to stare at me. I smiled brightly to indicate that I was fine.

Then the corners of his slightly stiffened eyes loosened. He seemed nervous.

"Jaire, can I take this report and look at it?"

The report that Jaire handed over was quite large to read at one time.

Judging from a glance at it, it seemed to be Ricdorian's overall condition so far, the journey to 'The Blue Rose', and general information about the Blue Rose were written down.

The report was pretty neat, so it wasn't difficult to get an overview all at once.

"Are you talking about taking it to the Miss room?"

"Yes."

I thought that this would be difficult, but surprisingly, Jaire graciously allowed it.

Rather, I was surprised so I asked.

"Isn't this important?"

"That's right. It's top secret."

Of course. The life of the Grand Duke is normally a matter of security, is it?

"But, Miss, it's no problem."

"Why?"

"Because you're taking it to the most secure room in Hernim Castle right now."

I was speechless with those words.

"The Grand Duke watches over you all night, who will come in and take it?"

"Wait."

I shook my head.

"Is that person still like that?"

“Yes.”

Jaire smiled brightly. It was clearly said on purpose.

“Please scold him. He protects you without even sleeping.”

“....”

When Ricdorian had just brought me here, I knew he stayed in front of my room without sleeping.

And I thought he was getting better now that I gave him an answer. In fact, at night, he’ll naturally leave the room.

‘I can’t believe he’s staying at the front door.’

Are you a dog that protects the house?

My head hurt terribly. Obviously if I say don’t do it.

He’ll have a sullen face.

<Why not? Huh? Iana. Can’t you tell me with your lips?>

<Of course you talk with your lips, right?>

<Put your lips to my lips.>

He would say something like that.

‘Because I actually went through it.’

In a matter of a few days, I knew roughly where Ricdorian’s personality changed. If I just wanted to talk, he’d block it by spewing out such vulgar words.

“...Okay, I’ll tell him.”

As I've said before, no matter how strong the Red Rose is like a beast, he can't not sleep. Then he'll be a god, not a human? He hardly sleeps every time he guards my room, so there is definitely a problem.

"...should I let him sleep in my room?"

Anton and Jaire, who were just about to leave, flinched at my murmur. Jaire smiled for a moment, then smiled again.

"When can I prepare for the ceremony?"

"What, are you going to get ahead 30 years from others?"

"Oh, do you have any ideas?"

"No. You're talking nonsense."

"...I didn't lose a single word."

Jaire exhaled low and shook his head.

"You think His Excellency is more naive than you guessed."

Then he said in a very serious tone.

"I want you to seriously think about letting him into your room. Isn't it the same as sleeping in the same room?"

"What's the matter?"

"Aren't you asking a question without knowing it?"

Me and Jaire's eyes crossed.

What. I know what you want to talk about. He said this as if he was the parent of an adolescent boy.

"Think carefully. Looking at the historical records of the Red Roses...."

Jaire rolled his eyes. Then he twisted it playfully.

“Really, it wouldn’t be a joke.”

I went back to my room after meeting Jaire. Not long after, Francia visited the room.

“I didn’t have much income today.”

She muttered as she buried herself on the sofa in front of me. She was probably talking about a meeting that there was about a day or two left.

“The conference?”

“Hmm”

The more I see Francia, the more I remember that when I read the book, I thought the heroine’s older sister did good.

Maybe that’s where the favorability comes from. She’s all grown up now, but I didn’t hate her for acting cute like in Domulit.

Francia liked to come and talk to me. In the past few days, when Ricdorian’s visit was rare, it has been filled by her visits.

She buried her face in my thighs and pulled it off. In the place where Francia rested, a fresh and pure scent that went well with her remained. The scent seemed to be a common feature of the roses.

“Today, there were only old-fashioned stories. How long will we continue to talk about sluggish things?”

Francia added sternly.

“When will the war be over?”

I heard that this empire had been at war with the eastern kingdom for several years. Originally, it was a war that would have lasted longer, but there were forces that were active here.

That was the unit led by the saint. Francia grabbed her hair gently and let it go.

‘It has become bigger than I ever imagined. This one too.’

Originally, there were two heads of temples, the saint and the pope, respectively. In this way, it was a form of two heads, but traditionally the authority of the pope was stronger.

If we take the entertainment industry as an example, if the female lead in the book is the star of the agency, the Pope feels like the president of the agency. The splendor of the exterior was taken by all the saints, but in reality the Pope took all the practicality.

‘Looking at Francia’s appearance, it seems a little different.’

It was then. A small sound of footsteps opened. Turning my head as it was unfamiliar.

No, it was a person who I saw the face once, standing there. It seems that Francia was not the only one who entered through the wide open door.

‘Is that person, the person I saw on the first day?’

The man who hesitated was the man I had seen once the day I reunited with Francia here. He must have been standing there the whole time.

Francia’s presence didn’t seem to be bothered by his gaze.

From a closer look, he also has outstanding beauty. He is a handsome man with brown eyes and nice white blonde hair. It was also someone I hadn’t seen since the first day. Without realizing it, I asked again.

“That person...”

“Oh, Sister. I said it right?”

Francia laughed softly.

“It’s the Pope.”

Cough.

Even after listening to it again, the surprising fact made me cough for nothing.

‘Okay.’

Let’s make a hundred concessions and let that man be the Pope. Then all the heads of the temple are here.... Did Ricdorian completely join hands with the temple?

I glanced at the hesitant man. Except he doesn’t turn red.

“He looks just like Ricdorian when he was young.”

I’m not saying they look the same or that they are. He was kind of timid and wary.

“Um, yes. If you are the saint and that one is the Pope... Isn’t one of you supposed to protect the temple?”

“We don’t have to? What we have to protect is here.”

Francia’s finger pointed once at the Pope, then slowly turned towards my chest.

“On top of that, if he’s here, I’ll have more freedom.”

Francia’s index finger pricked my chest.

“Even if it’s not, there is a strong fear of the changing forces, so it’s more convenient to carry him around.”

Then the pope's slender shoulders moved. Ummm, the pope's guts doesn't look that big?

“What about you?”

“Me? There's no problem with me. Moreover, after the awakening.”

I nodded, thinking of Francia's huge hammer. I'm not sure who's going to attack her when she's wielding something like that.

I exhaled a little.

“You've grown up really well.”

Francia grinned at my murmuring.

“Sister said so. Make it to your taste.”

Me? My gaze returned.

“That's why I did it.”

Francia stretched out her long, thin fingers.

“Starting from the very bottom of the temple at the very beginning, build up some contribution in the war.”

One of her fingers was folded.

“If you don't like it, break it.”

... what do you break? I closed my eyes and listened quietly.

“For now, there was only one place to hide from Domulit's eyes for a long time. Marquis Valtaize had the same opinion.”

Francia hesitated for a moment, then looked down at her hand. Francia still had three fingers left. But she folded it all away.

Then she smiled brightly.

“Anyway, I’m a saint in the front and a pope in the back.”

... It seems like a lot of words were missing. I thought so, but I didn’t add it.

Who would have known that a single word that passed just like a spill in the past would have such an impact?

Everyone goes through their own trials and tribulations, and I didn’t have any hobbies to delve into things that were overlooked in hopes that they wouldn’t ask.

Francia didn’t want to lengthen it either, so she turned her words first.

“Sister, there is one thing I want to ask you.”

“Huh.”

I gladly joined her other talk. She erased her serious eyes for a moment, but then returned to her dazzling eyes.

“Why are you trying to get in touch with Marquis Valtaze?”

Those words reminded me of what I had asked Francia yesterday.

<Can you contact Marquis Valtaze?>

<It’s not difficult. I’ll try.>

She gladly answered without asking why. But in fact, she could be wondering why I was looking for Lenag?

“Hmm, well.”

As I watched the flickering and mysterious Odd Eye, a sense of playfulness arose.

“Because I need him?”

Francia blinked her eyes. She was a little surprised because it was an unexpected answer.

Perhaps she was thinking something else, she grabbed her slender chin and nodded her head.

“Do you need the power of the Yellow Rose?”

She seemed to take it a little differently.

“Who for?”

Chapter 184: I will take Francia's share (2)

1. 1. I will take Francia's share (2)

In addition, she tilted her head innocently, and even drew her hand around her neck.

“Huh?”

“If you don’t like it, my kids can do it too.”

“Huh? It’s not like that.”

She jumped up, not listening to my words.

“The Holy Knights. To be honest, the kids only talk about holy swords. They’re no different than wild dogs.”

“Francia.”

Clap. I quickly clapped my hand. Francia paused her speech, perhaps giving the effect of evoking her surroundings.

I first cleaned up the situation.

“No, I’m joking. That’s not why I’m looking for that person. First of all... Are you going to put the Pope like that?”

When the weak Pope met my eyes, he was startled.

“Oh, no. No.”

He shook his hand violently.

“Don’t mind me!”

He didn’t turn red, but his expression of embarrassment was evident. Even with that said, looking at Francia, it doesn’t seem like she has any intention of letting him sit down.

I returned to Francia and pointed my eyes towards the Pope.

“What kind of relationship are you?”

“Um, subordinate? Assistant? Uhm, in the middle?”

What if Francia really followed my story and took the position of a saint on the outside but seized all the powers behind.

That is literally a scarecrow Pope.

“At first it was a strategic alliance, but gradually he came under me.”

“By agreement?”

“Yes. By agreement.”

Francia spread her palms out. It was a seemingly innocent face at first glance, but in reality, the circumstances below must not have been so.

In fact, three years is a short period of time to establish such a position. Ricdorian had even an orthodox bloodline.

Unlike Hernim and Domulit in the book, Francia’s family, Rosenia, was not a very large family. She wouldn’t have been able to show that much power even in the temple. Even in the book, the process of Francia becoming a saint was so sudden that I wondered if there was any possibility. It was not an easy place.

However, Francia took the position not according to the original story and even earlier than the original story.

‘I would say it’s great.’

I bowed my head slightly.

‘It must never have been easy.’

No matter how old the existing power of the temple was, it would not have been easy for Francia to establish herself. It was amazing to have come this far only with the power and name of the White Rose and her own strength.

‘Looking at the fact that she said she was trying to replace the pope.’

And it looks like it hasn’t been sorted out yet.

So, in the end, the Pope. He’s like Hernim’s Jaire or Domulit’s Marshmel.

“I see.”

I nodded, clearing my thoughts.

“Um, Sister, but why the Yellow Rose?”

Lenag’s abilities were roughly known. He wasn’t the main character, but he showed up in one way or another as Chaser’s right-hand villain.

I didn’t know until I came to this world, but it was thanks to the probability that he was the Yellow Rose.

“I’m not trying to kill him. Not even to hurt him.”

Lenag’s ability was suitable for ‘assassination’. It is not for nothing that Chaser with a seductive eye put him by his side.

The reason I feared him in prison was not only because of his sharp face, but also because of his abilities.

“I just wish I could contact him.”

One thing I knew now. That man is the one who can't touch a single hair of mine.

"Because he'll be looking for me by now."

Rather, he was a man who struggled to even hold my hand to go to the banquet. A small smile leaked out. It was a smile of regret.

"Ah, I heard that the Marquis released his people to find his fiancee."

"That's me, you know."

Francia couldn't have not known. Because she heard Lenag's conversation with me in person years ago.

"Yes, I know."

She nodded as if she remembered it too.

"That's right. I also wondered if this was Duke Domulit's ruse."

"That man....."

I bowed my head slightly.

"He won't lend a hand to any ploy involving me."

Because he is such a person. I said indifferently without wiping out a smile.

"And my older brother won't use obvious tactics."

Francia looked at me like that, then slowly nodded her head.

"That's right. Sister knows best about that."

Her eyes seemed to go down for a moment and cover my ankles.

"Actually, even if I listen to Father, he always says that about the Black Roses. They have to have what they want."

Francia's voice gradually became as cold as ice.

"Because they get their power from their possessions."

She was also a person with an indelible grudge against Domulit.

"Hmm, anyway, yes. I can't like him."

Francia smiled lightly at me, trying to clear the heavy air.

Then, trying to find another topic of discussion, she immediately grabbed her guardian deity and held it in my arms.

It still looked like a small bear. It must have been an adult, but somehow this one also has the shape of a baby bear.

"Sister, I thought about it more than that. You didn't accept Callisto."

"It's not that I didn't accept it."

Would Callisto agree? You should also listen to Callisto.

"Ummm... you don't like the way it looks? The Grand Duke said that you like small and cute cats. So our Callisto lost to a small one..."

Francia had a sullen face.

"Is it because it's not a cat?"

Hearing that, I turned to Pudding unknowingly. Where did such a misunderstanding come from? Apparently, Ricdorian had a little misunderstanding when he saw Pudding's appearance.

"I'm sorry. I can't make it into a cat."

"No. No, no."

I waved my hand.

“You don’t have to be sorry. It’s not like that. And it’s a misunderstanding.”

Why is it that all the roses are so anxious that they can’t give me anything?
I also wondered if this is a common characteristic of roses.

“Is it the rose’s will that you keep wanting to give to me?”

“Huh? I just want to give it to Sister.”

Francia replied succinctly.

And with slightly resentful eyes, that seemed to ask, *did you mean that my sincerity looked like that?*

“Strictly speaking, it’s not entirely nothing. Still, it’s not a substitute for will.”

“Yes. I’m sorry.”

At the innocent apology, Francia patted her own lips, and her eyes twinkled.

“Yes. It would be sad if I was misunderstood. As the Grand Duke said, worship and emotions are different. It was not a relationship where we were ruled over from generation to generation. The Blue Rose and us.”

She quickly erased her sullenness.

“It’s twisted, but whenever I look up the records of the past, I think about it.”

“What?”

Francia tapped my thigh.

“What if the Blue Rose hadn’t disappeared.”

Her playful smile reminded me of her youthful days in Domulit, but soon maturity overshadowed it.

Seriously colored it.

“Maybe instead of having a deficiency, we would remain perfect. Like the records of the past.”

“A deficiency?”

“What the Grand Duke and I are going through. I actually didn’t really like the feeling of being obligated to search desperately.”

The sensation of having to search for the Blue Rose is like a tolerable but persistent stimulus.

Francia rubbed her lips with her index and thumb.

“Sister, speaking of His Excellency, did you know that the ‘companion’ of the Red Rose appeared after the Blue Rose disappeared?”

“What?”

The question was answered with another question from me. Francia laughed and explained.

“The Blue Rose has disappeared for centuries. It’s only now known that the Black Rose has taken over, but it’s been very difficult for the other roses.”

There was a period not only in this era, but also in the past, when the Blue Roses did not appear at all.

During this period, the roses took measures to make up for their own lack, and among them, the Red Rose created what is called a ‘companion’.

“Originally, the Blue Roses were the ones they would give their love and passion to, but they don’t appear every time. That’s why they came up with a companion. They’ve survived by making a companion to receive their strength. This isn’t just the Red roses.”

Francia looked down at her hand for a moment.

“The White Roses are for those in need of treatment, the Yellow Roses for those in need of protection, and Black Roses are for those to be obsessed.”

With the same concept as the companion of the Red Rose, other roses also needed a partner or companion.

“It’s better than the ancient times, when you couldn’t even breathe without the Blue Roses.”

Francia added that, and smiled brightly.

“Actually, I’ve contacted Marquis Valtaze.”

“Really?”

As I said that just yesterday, it was quite fast.

“Yes. I haven’t been in touch for years, but there’s a way.”

Francia soon narrowed her eyes and pouted her mouth.

“But even if I asked him to tell me about Sister, he wouldn’t do it.”

After saying that, she added.

“How stingy.”

All roses are the same. Falling in love with one thing. Francia murmured that she had stopped contacting Lenag.

She was grumbling, and her gaze was quite harsh. Although, she soon had a meek face.

“I’ll get an answer from there soon.”

“Thank you.”

When I spoke with sincerity, Francia shook her head.

“It’s nothing, so you don’t have to say thank you. Sister is the one who doesn’t have to say thank you to me.”

Francia’s little finger caught mine. As we promised, we faced each other.

“I’m always there if Sister wants it. It’s the grace that saved me.”

Her lips were gently curved. The afterimage of a neat White Rose seemed to be visible behind her.

“I want to pay it back for the rest of my life.”

Soon Francia’s smile turned into a broad smile.

“Then can I be with Sister for the rest of my life?”

Her eyes bent over beautifully.

Chapter 185: About the engagement relationship

1. 1. About the engagement relationship

The next day. I met Jaire again. However, the place was not a room where books were piled up like a mountain.

“That place is occupied by other assistant wizards.”

Assistant wizards? Someone like Jaire’s subordinates?

“Looks like a lot of people.”

“Rather than that...”

Jaire responded with a thoughtful expression on his face.

“Because you need to be careful of those you will encounter.”

“Oh, from Domulit?”

“Not necessarily, but because not everyone in Hernim’s castle can be trusted.”

He explained.

“Just as there is no impeccable family, we are not without enemies.”

Hmmm, an inside spy seemed to be the subject of vigilance wherever I went. It wasn’t that I didn’t understand, I nodded.

It's not that he was trying to lock myself up, he was trying to protect me from any possible danger. Every time I felt Ricdorian and his subordinates trying to choose a word, I felt strange.

“So, you asked to meet in the garden?”

But from the garden, it looks like an open space, isn't it? Rather, it seems to be vulnerable to security.

Then Jaire said it was okay because this is a garden where no one can come. Then he pointed to the rose blooming here.

“Among the red roses, it is a rose that blooms only in Hernim.”

It was much larger than a normal rose. At first glance, it seemed to be the same size as a camellia. That is why it looks so much more lively and the scent is also very strong.

“It has been grown only in the Hernim's territory since time immemorial. It is a rose that protects the safety of the head.”

I cannot even set foot on it unless Ricdorian permits it.

“Perhaps each rose has a space like this. Is there in Domulit?”

“Ah....”

I suddenly remembered Chaser's garden.

A garden full of black roses. But there were not only black roses. Unlike Ricdorian's garden, where only red roses bloom, two roses coexisted there.

“I think there was.”

Resembling the man, Chaser, the roses there were particularly luscious. In addition, shyly blooming orange roses were in full bloom here and there as if for decoration. So it was a place that had its own attractions.

“Anyway, I'm glad if it's safe. I've seen all the materials you gave me.”

“You saw it quickly.”

“Because I stayed up all night.”

Actually, when I heard that Ricdorian stayed up all night in front of my room, I really thought about putting him to sleep in my room....

I stopped because of one thought.

‘What if he really asked me to get the tattoo?’

To be honest, it’s a thank you from me... No, it’s not about chastity before marriage.

But how can I not care about the different attitudes he had over there. No, I’m not saying it’ll be a joke. There are other words, but just looking at his appearance without reason... I wonder if I can get up in the morning.

‘It’s the first time! I don’t want to hear it anymore.’

Now, I can’t give anyone Ricdorian’s first, he’s mine after all.... For some reason, I felt like I was neglecting the table that was all set.

“Hmm, let’s get to the report, there was an interesting story.”

“Which part are you talking about?”

Anyway, while Ricdorian stayed up all night, I stayed up in the room too. As I read all of them, I felt that most of them were stories I knew.

The reason Ricdorian, whom I read in the book, had to be in prison, or the brutality of the former Grand Duke Hernim. And the story of my prison life and the story of the Blue Rose I heard through Francia.

Since I know it, I put aside the introduction and focus on the main point. I brought up the story I first learned from the report.

“Kambrakam. It wasn’t a prison long ago?”

Turns out, it was so. The prison where Ricdorian and I were was not originally a prison.

“Besides, it is said that a high-ranking prisoner must have the Emperor’s permission to go to Kambrakam. That’s why Ricdorian was also able to go there.”

“Yes. They need permission from the imperial family.”

I knew Kambrakam was a very old building, but.... Surprisingly, it is said that this was a temple that binds, purifies, and calms souls long ago.

“As you said, that’s the story we found in advance.”

Jaire nodded his head with a serious expression.

“So I understand why the Red Rose has sent their successors there every time. Until now, I thought it was because they needed a quiet and secluded place.”

He sighed slightly and said.

“Because there was a rule to send them there, but I didn’t know the exact reason.”

“Because it used to be a temple?”

“Yes, it seems that such power still remains. It binds and purifies souls. That’s why the imperial family takes special care of it. It’s where the ancient power remains.”

Ancient power, what I saw in the hole in the basement had something to do with it? It seemed so.

“So we also thought that if we found the ‘Blue Rose’, we would go there with His Excellency.”

“To help you break the curse?”

“Yes. I even confirmed that the place should be there. Through the literature. Have you seen it?”

“Yes, I saw it.”

The report also described their future plans.

“Then my job is to go back to prison and break the curse?”

“In theory, yes, but...”

Jaire hesitated. I knew what he wanted to say.

Their report was meticulous and seemingly complete, but one thing was missing.

“How? You don’t know that either right?”

How does the Blue Rose lift the curse? This is not written.

“....Yes.”

It is true that the Blue Roses can nullify. And the place, Kambrakam made it possible. However, no matter how much they search, they don’t know what method the Blue Rose uses, or exactly how they use their power.

The problem is.....

‘I don’t know either.’

Now that I know what a Blue Rose is, I couldn’t figure it out.

I asked Pudding, who was hiding inside me, just in case, and the answer came back saying it didn’t know.

“Well, I guess...”

“Is it related to the guardian deity of the Blue Rose?”

“Yes. I was just about to say that.”

It may be. Because the guardian deities knew more about their roses than I thought. I wouldn't know things if Pudding hadn't told me.

“But I don't know much about my guardian deity. I don't have it either.”

“What?”

Jaire had a surprised face and he nodded. It was as if he was muttering that things could not be solved this easily.

‘Does Francia know?’

I immediately shook my head. No, she wouldn't know. If she had known, she would have been able to tell me about it earlier.

Anyone who knows this well....

‘It's Chaser.’

I narrowed my eyes narrowly. There's no way that Chaser, the man disguised as my brother would tell me.

If so, someone who seems to know this information and is close to Chaser, but not on Chaser's side, and who can stand on my side.

.... I know someone like that.

“Is it possible that Hernim can contact Marquis Valtaze?”

I had already put in communication through Francia. But, wouldn't it be faster to get it from Hernim than Francia, who had left the temple for a while?

“Marquis Valtaze? Are you talking about that... Marquis? Master of Kambrakam?”

“Did we know of any other Valtaze?”

Jaire gave a look of astonishment. However, as I reacted bluntly, he gradually regained his composure.

“I don’t know what you’re thinking... it’s not hard to get in touch.”

“Think about it. He’s a rose too. The Yellow Rose.”

Actually, before I was the Blue Rose, Lenag seemed to help even if I wasn’t the Blue Rose.

“Um, it would be nice if I could get his cooperation, but...”

Jaire scratched the back of his neck.

“Isn’t he on Domulit’s side?”

“No.”

At the same time as saying that, someone strode behind Jaire. Not one person

Ricdorian? And Francia?

The two of them were walking in stride as if they were competing.

“He’ll be on my side.”

I continued what I had to say. And Jaire finally agreed. He grinned as if realizing.

“Oh, you were engaged!”

He seemed to have been engrossed in his thoughts and had not noticed Ricdorian’s approach.

“Are you two close?”

....Should he have asked for that? I glanced at Ricdorian’s expression.

Ricdorian stopped his steps and stared at me quietly. Then, for a moment, he stared at the back of Jaire's head... No, it looked like he was staring coldly.

Francia looked at Ricdorian and Jaire alternately with interested eyes.

"Then you can contact him."

"What... yes... um."

Firstly, it's a good thing. Our number one priority is to break the Ricdorian's curse and save his life.

It was clear that Hernim's Archmage, who had the same thoughts as me, couldn't have not seen an inch ahead instead. No, he seemed to be focused only on saving Ricdorian's life.

"It's definitely an engaged relationship, so it's easy to ask for cooperation."

... This person wasn't such an ignorant person. It seemed that the will to save his superior was really strong.

Francia, who had not seen it, said a word.

"Grand Duke, your adviser seems to be tactless."

Francia's eyes, which had been smiling with interest a while ago, were cold.

"He's obviously dragging in another rose?"

Is that one angry? I rolled my eyes and turned to Ricdorian.

Next to me, *hiik*, *Your, Your Excellency!* Hearing the sound, it seemed that Jaire had only just noticed.

The time was already late.

Fortunately, I didn't say anything much. Perhaps, this was fortunate, he suddenly caught my hand while I was reflecting.

Ricdorian grabbed my fingertips and held me seriously.

“Ricdoran?”

He licked his lips.

“..engagement.”

“Yes. I did.”

I accepted that it was true. He investigated me, so there’s no way he wouldn’t not know either.

But Ricdorian had a shocked expression as if he didn’t really know, no, he didn’t know it was true.

.... did you not know?

He calmed his thoughts slowly while having a face that looked like an abandoned puppy. Then he opened his lips seriously.

“Marry me.”

.... What?

When I came to my senses, he was blushing. Then he spoke again. With a shaky voice.

“No, please.....please marry me.”

Suddenly, the red eyes teared up. I don’t know if that was intentional or if it was made up.

“....I’ll do my best.”

“What are you best at?”

“.....all night long?”

It was destructive.

Chapter 186: Invitation

1. 1. Invitation

I couldn't find anything to say, and my lips were twitching, and someone spoke on my behalf.

“Wow, that's awesome.”

It was Francia. When I turned my gaze without realizing it, there was a bright smile on her face. Her expression resembles that of a benevolent saint.

“Can I curse, Sister? Huh?”

She asked brightly. Of course, it goes without saying, Ricdorian frowned.

“Grand Duke, do you like that kind of thing? Do you always seduce like that?”

“Uh....”

I don't hate it if you ask me if I like it. I can't say anything about the answer. Yet in this situation? Honest words seemed to come out of the tip of my throat. But Francia seemed to have noticed my expression first.

“Hng, Sister!”

Francia held my hand with both hands.

“Then. Can I seduce you like that? Will you cut me some slack?”

She lowered her voice, but to me it just looked like her young self from years ago. I lightly patted her forehead without pain.

“No, you look good in your own way.”

With my thumb, I tapped the back of Francia’s hand. She smiled brightly.

“Right, so I’m only going to focus hard on Sister like this, right? That’s right, I should have a chance too.”

Francia put her arms around me. Even I didn’t feel strange in the truly natural series of events.

“Sister, Sister, the Blue Rose has to look after all the roses.”

“Look after?”

“Yes. We were originally beings who couldn’t live without Sister.”

Now, there is still some kind of imprint towards the Blue Rose, added Francia.

“So, you shouldn’t be indifferent to me either. Well, that’s why, just love the White Rose and the Red Rose.”

In Francia’s words, she was talking about Ricdorian and her, but the nuance was strong that she put in the Red Rose in good faith. It was when Ricdorian, who looked at this with displeasure, flapped his lips.

“Your Excellency!”

A cry from far away. It was the voice of a stranger. The sound was never so small that I could hear it too.

Ricdorian, who has sensitive senses, would have heard it louder.

Then a bird flew this way. It looked like a little canary, with a long string wrapped around the ankles. And at the end of the line....

“Letter?”

A white envelope was hanging. It was an unusual envelope.

“Ah, I got a letter.”

“A letter?”

The person who explained was Jaire, who had been silent until now.

“No one can enter this place unless given permission from His Excellency. That’s why we send out birds like this when we need to make a request outside.”

“Animals are allowed?”

“Yes.”

It’s a really interesting system. While I was thinking about it, Ricdorian opened the envelope. At that moment, a faint golden light emanated from the envelope.

“Is it magic?”

Ricdorian narrowed his eyes narrowly.

Magic? The letter in Ricdorian’s hand unfolded by itself. And the expression on Ricdorian’s face, who was reading it, hardened.

“What is it about?”

Francia, unable to overcome her curiosity, gently pushed her head out, and their expressions hardened together.

What’s wrong?

“It is the emblem of the imperial family.”

Jaire quietly explained next to me. It was then that I saw a rose carved on the outside of the envelope. A rose, a crown, and a scepter. I've definitely seen it in Domulit. When I saw the invitation of the Imperial Palace ball.

“Very absurd.”

Francia wrinkled her nose.

“Show this to Sister too.”

“....”

Me? There is no reason for me to see such a letter.... However, Ricdorian graciously handed me the letter, and I naturally began to see the contents.

Except for the rhetoric in the middle, the point is....It was like this.

[...So, Domulit's treasure is in your castle, right?]

Domulit's treasure.

This was nothing but me.

[“The Domulit wants to raise an issue, what do you think? I'm putting it on hold.”]

Raise an issue. No one here would not know the meaning of this word. Just like Ricdorian who looked at it, my expression slowly hardened.

And finally, the owner of the letter asked.

[How is it? What about coming to the Imperial Palace?"]

I can guess who the owner of the letter is, but it was a question with a slightly playful nuance. When I looked up, I could feel the gazes on me. Words did not come out easily. I wasn't surprised or embarrassed.

I slowly organized my thoughts and organized them again. I rolled my eyes once.

“Did my brother want to start a war?”

I shuddered at the words that flowed out calmly. No, the only person who shook his shoulders was Jaire.

Francia looked at Ricdorian calmly.

“Didn’t you say something similar?”

Ricdorian did not answer, but his silence was close to affirmation. When our eyes met, he secretly avoided my gaze.

“It was something without much thought.”

He said with his head turned.

“ ... You don’t have to worry about it.”

He quickly added it, but I could tell.

‘He did.’

Well, if it was that guy, he would be able to do that. No. Rather, if Chaser had not taken any action, I would not have believed it. In particular, looking at Ricdorian’s reaction, it seems that Chaser really did something.

“Iana, you... You can be anywhere you want.”

Ricdorian said confidently. His gaze slowly returns to me.

“Hernim can endure it well enough.”

Sometimes expressions from the unconscious represent the truth.

Endure.

It meant that no matter how much Hernim was, they could not be calm about Domulit’s attack. It didn’t mean I had to go back right away, though..... No, is it? I bit my lip softly.

‘Here it is again.’

In the corner of my head, and in the middle of my heart, there was the shouting, “I must return to Domulit.” It had nothing to do with my will.

“Sister, the temple will not watch idly. Never.”

Francia smiled brightly. She had a benevolent face, but a determined expression flashed over it.

“Like the Grand Duke said, Sister can do whatever you want to do. I will make it happen.”

She grabbed my arm.

“Be where you want to be.”

She also had a confident tone of voice. In fact, I felt grateful for these words as I was not without a sense of bewilderment at the sudden situation. I smiled a little.

“Yes, thank you.”

In fact, I never thought that I should be protected, or that I was worthy of being so cherished by anyone.

That doesn’t mean I’m ugly, but it’s just that, I’m mundane like most people, I thought of myself as normal. That is why, at this moment, I feel as if I am detached and looking at someone else’s story.

– Human, that’s just relaxing, Nyang.

‘Is it?’

But, there are so many people who say they will protect me, and they are more fussy than me, so my side could be more relaxed.

While smiling, the black shadow seemed to flicker forward. This feeling was an illusion, but somehow I couldn’t shake the feeling that this place

was like Domulit's mansion and that Chaser would appear in front of me.

'Is four years too long?'

Maybe it's because I'm not completely familiar with this place, where I can't see the face I see every day. Reluctantly, the thoughts of Domulit and the man's face would flash past me. Like a reflex.

"Iana, I'll be back for a moment."

Meanwhile, Ricdorian talked to Francia and said he would be away for a while. Jaire wants to talk to the person who is waiting outside the garden for a moment. Francia also said that she would go with Ricdorian. After Jaire left, I was quickly left alone.

'This is the safest place in Hernim Castle.'

Jair said that no one is coming here, and it will be safe. That would be true. I blinked my eyes. Being alone, I seemed to have lost my thoughts.

In front of me, I felt like I was getting drunk by the scent of the red roses.

"The Imperial Palace....."

As everyone disappeared, the direction of my thought returned to the previous topic. No one spoke clearly, but the owner of the letter would have been the 'Empress'. Needless to say, the only person in this country who could speak relaxedly to Ricdorian, Grand Duke Hernim was the Empress.

Naturally, my stream of thoughts came to the Empress.

Empress of this country.

'What was the name....?'

I think I heard the long full name from the little warlock, my common sense teacher, but I can't remember. This was the name that came to mind after a long time.

Scarlett Scheherazade.

As the name suggests, she was a female Empress.

‘Originally, she should appear in the story at least once.’

And as the owner of the Empress’s tiara, she was originally a person who gave the main plot material in the original story.

This was quite important.

Because of this tiara, Francia, Ricdorian, and Chaser entered into an uncontrollable love triangle.

It was only now that I couldn’t easily know where the future was going to go. I knew where this tiara was. I may have something to think about. Anyway, according to the little warlock’s lecture, it was like this.

The current Empress is under a very stable rule.

Hernim and Domulit. As the Empress who did not lose her voice and power even when a huge family called to its full power, it could be said that her skill was well proven.

In addition, the Empress chose a balanced power composition between the two families instead of favoring one..... In fact, she actually preferred Hernim who was highly loyal.

Moreover, the Empress had no husband or children. Usually, in such a situation, men from large families would naturally connect with the Empress. In fact, it was said that neither the Empress nor the families wanted it. Such an Empress advised Hernim to bring me.

The name might be an invitation, but the Empress’s words cannot be an invitation.

“Hmm, what should I do.....”

However, Ricdorian would not be able to stubbornly reject this.

Behind the Empress's words, there must also be a meaning that if Ricdorian does not listen, she will grant Domulit a favor. Perhaps Chaser thought this far and told the Empress. He was a man who looked out for a lot of things. I felt a slow pressure on my wrist as I thought. It didn't hurt.

Maybe this is what happens when someone grabs my wrist?

– Human, your wrist!

“Yes, I know.”

I slowly lifted my wrist. Why, even though I did not press it? A black rose pattern was slowly being engraved. From the petals drawn one by one, a black rose is completed.

“..... Chaser.”

The moment I unconsciously called his name, the flowers bloomed. Black energy flowed out like a wave. The energy gathered in a circle shape and moved slowly, then drew a solid figure.

It was a bird with spread wings. little bird. And it was a familiar bird.

“..... Aquala?”

Aquala spread its beak wide. It seemed to want to cry, but there was no sound from Aquala. As if someone blocked it. Not surprisingly, sharp thorns sprouted from Aquala's body. It wasn't from the body.

Biiiiikk!

The red roses nearby were stretching out vines and tightening Aquala's shape.

“Are you okay?”

Chaser was Chaser. This guardian deity was special to me. I owed my life and had my own affection. But Aquala wiggled its beak a few times as if it didn't mind the pain and then rubbed itself on my hand.

“..... Yes. Right. How are you?”

As if answering me, Aquala bites my finger without pain and then releases it. It spread its wings and stroked my fingers. It was the greatest expression of affection a bird could have. A small envelope was placed over the spot where Aquala opened its beak.

The moment I saw this, I stopped rubbing Aquala's head.

“..... A letter from Chaser?”

I took it out of the beak, but I already know the answer. Who would be the one to send this? As if to give me an answer, the envelope opened by itself, and the letter inside came to view.

Gradually, letters are engraved on the unengraved paper.

[“Hello, my dear sister.”]

I'm no longer his sister. The greeting was too mischievous.

Looking at the neat handwriting, I remembered the feeling of exchanging letters with an unknown brother in the prison a long time ago.

[“I want to go by myself, but I can't move. It's sad.”]

I looked around. A rose thorn vine that tied Aquala tightly.

It was as if Chaser couldn't come, just like no one could come in here.

Soon after, Chaser's main idea was written there.

[“My Iana.”]

I opened my mouth slowly. No, I had to open it up.

“What is this.....”

[“Aren't you curious about the guardian deity of the Blue Rose?”]

Probably because Chaser's next words were talking about something I hadn't thought of at all.

["I was waiting for the day I would return it to you."]

Chapter 187: Even if it's a war for you

1. 1. 1. 1. Even if it's a war for you

It seemed as if the dizzying smile, like seducing me was passing by in front of me. The characteristic expression he makes when he wants to sneak over the main words.

[“No matter how difficult it is for me to seal this.”]

“Seal.....”

I stopped reading aloud without realizing it. Pudding was trembling inside me. Pudding's feelings come to me. Fear and nervousness. It was natural to feel what I saw and felt.

‘It's okay. Shh. it's okay.’

I thoroughly comforted Pudding and looked at the letter again.

[“If you have this from the beginning, you will reach the truth quickly.”]

Chaser had the guardian deity of the Blue Rose somewhere in the same way as Pudding had been sealed. As I learned of this, questions ensued. Why did he act like that? And as if to answer that, the following verse came to mind. He didn't want me to get to the truth quickly.

“Truth?”

The story about ‘Iana’ came to mind.

<Before, how should I say this? You always looked bloodless and weak.>

He said I looked completely different.

<Ummm, to put it bluntly. The Miss at the time was like, you felt like a 'doll', maybe?>

Does it have anything to do with this? What in the world made her like this, and why was the guardian spirit sealed, and the guardian deity of the one who loved Chaser?

["Come back to me if you want to know."]

I'm curious, but I don't want to know that much. At the same time as I made an impression, the phrase was changed.

["Of course, you wouldn't move right away just because of this, would you?"]

As if he knows me very well.

"Then..... come..... all the way..... here. How?"

For some reason, the letters were suddenly broken and started to appear. I hurriedly looked at Aquala.

"Aquala?"

Aquala's shape was unstable as if it was a broken screen. It seemed to be in a state of dread, repeating from blurry to darkening.

"Aquala? Are you okay? Aquala!"

Guardians are spirit bodies. In other words, they can freely appear and disappear, but what I saw now is close to being forced to disappear.

This was close to being forced back, that is, reverse summoning.

What's more, I could tell by the red energy that fluttered around Aquala. Hernim is pushing Domulit out. I had heard about this from Marshmel.

“Pudding, is this a reverse summon?”

– Yes, it seems like that.

Guardian deities have no body, but feel pain. In particular, in extreme pain, the form disappears and returns to the contractor, in this case. It is said that it will damage both the guardian deity and those who contract with the guardian deity, and it is also said that it is very painful.

[“Oh my, this seems to be the limit.”]

The handwriting soon returned to its original state. with no broken spots. And Chaser announced the date and place once again.

[“Remember. The Cathedral of Cantala, Iana.”]

Chaser's handwriting, which had spoken the exact location, faded again. Now Aquala seemed to be at the limit. A few more words were written down, but I couldn't recognize them.

It was when I grimaced and bit my lip and let it go.

Aquala shook its head. At the same time, the last neat letters were engraved.

[“..... Actually, I wanted to meet and talk.”]

Why? I can feel a hesitation unlike this man's in the handwriting.

I couldn't take my eyes off of it.

Crunch, crunch. The invisible pen slowly dyes the paper. Black. Like the rose carved on my wrist.

[“I love you, Iana.”]

Followed by,

["I wanted to talk about everything on the night of the fireworks-filled banquet. You disappeared....."]

I thought it was a good thing that the man wasn't in front of me at this moment. Without realizing it, a beautiful smile passed by in the garden as I burst into tears.

["Stay by my side."]

For a while, he wrote it slowly, leaving a gap.

["Any form is fine."]

And gradually the ink fades and disappears from the end. Eventually, the last word written was focused.

["..... I need you, so I can breathe."]

Aquala cried for a long time. It was a long, roaring cry that could not come out of the form of a small sparrow.

["I'm willing to do my best even if it's a war for you."]

Serious and playful words continued.

["My Iana. You don't want to see me go crazy, do you?"]

At the end of this, perhaps truly the end, Aquala's form became very blurry. It seemed that the reverse summon was right in front of me. My heart ached the moment I thought of the pain this guardian deity would feel. It was a pity for the bird I had been living with for four years.

["..... Don't get hurt."]

The moment my hand touched the bird's beak, Aquala leaned its head back. As if looking for the warmth of my hands.

That was the moment.

A faint blue light emanated from my fingertips. I thought it was an illusion because it was so weak..... It was indeed indigo blue like the sea. A mysterious blue color as if looking at the sky from the water. It wraps around Aquala's body and falls. And Aquala disappeared from my sight.

“Ah.....”

All that was left was the thorny vine that had strangled Aquala. Even this goes back to its original place when Aquala disappears. Aquala's letter also disappeared, but I was unable to speak for a while because of the lingering feeling of the last scene.

‘What the hell was that light?’

The blue energy was something I had only seen at the moment when Jaire was casting his magic. It is said that blue light is revealed when using normal white magic, the commonly used “magic”.

However, it was different from the magical blue light I had seen many times. Rather, it was a very vivid and intense feeling, like when Ricdorian, Francia, or Chaser were using their power.....

Could this be the power of the Blue Rose? I stared at my fingers for a while.

‘Somehow, my back itches.’

– Human, are you hurt, Nyang?

‘No, it's just itchy and stinging.....’

I raised my head as I pressed my hand around the middle of my back, which I couldn't reach. The guardian deity of the Blue Rose and the Imperial Family. I wanted to lie down in one place as much as possible and enjoy more serenity, but It seemed difficult to do so.

‘For now, there's still time left until the deadline Chaser said.’

“Pudding.”

I didn't actually say anything, but when Aquala appeared a while ago, I could feel Pudding's power that was trying to protect me. I see things that I have never felt before. It seemed that something was changing inside of me.

The power and guardian deity of the Blue Rose.

I closed my eyes and then opened them. There was a time when I just wanted to be comfortable as if I was entrusting myself to a flowing river. It's always been like that, and I've always wanted to live like that. But the world doesn't always go the way we want it to. It felt like a huge hand was stroking my back.

'It's time to make a decision no matter what.'

Not far away, Ricdorian was running towards me. I smiled as I looked at him getting closer.

"Ricdorian."

I didn't know why he ran in haste as if he had caught fire in his foot.

"Haa, Iana again....."

"Yes. He appeared."

Perhaps he felt the power of the Black Rose. I answered openly. Instead of Chaser, the guardian deity of Domulit appeared. And what Chaser said to me, sealing the guardian deity of the Blue Rose somewhere and about the time and place he mentioned to me.....

"The guardian deity of the Blue Rose is over there. Would the lack of a guardian deity be a big problem?"

The Red Rose was threatened by the lack of a guardian deity. Ricdorian shook his head.

"The Blue Rose has no such qualities. Being perfect by itself... That's why it was called the Blue Rose."

“That’s a relief.”

I said without smiling.

“I was wondering if I should reverse my decision.”

If there is no guardian deity, I cannot use my power, or that if it is detrimental to breaking Ricdorian’s curse. It is difficult to make another time limit, where there is already an urgent situation. I’m glad this wasn’t the case.

At the same time, I felt a little bitter.

‘No. Perhaps it would have been better for me to be hurt.’

It was a useless thought. Clearing my thoughts, I lifted my head. At that moment, the wind blew and scattered the silver hair that looked pure white. It was a picturesque landscape.

“Let’s go to the Imperial Palace.”

“..... Yes?”

Ricdorian looked like he had heard it wrong. But when I just smiled and didn’t reverse it, his expression clouded.

“..... why.”

Why? Ricdorian would have known this better.

“You know better why.”

Now, if the Imperial Family ignores Hernim, it becomes difficult. The balance that was barely maintained would be disturbed.

“You must not turn away from the Imperial Family.”

“..... That’s no problem. It’s not something you should be concerned about.”

“Yes. If it were you, would you be okay with it?”

I cannot pretend not to know. It was a natural situation that even I, who was not familiar with politics, could understand. I nodded my head instead of questioning Ricdorian’s words.

“It’s not just for this reason that I want to go to the Imperial Palace.”

Instead, I came up with another reason.

“It is said that when a high nobleman goes to Kambrakam, they must always ask for permission from Her Majesty the Empress.”

This is the fact Jaire told me, to be precise, the story in the report.

“So, in order to get permission, we have to meet once, right? Our goal is to get into Kambrakan to break your curse. I think it’s a matter of fact.”

So let’s go to the Imperial Palace. The most important thing was to solve the time limit for Ricdorian, which was approaching right away.

“The moment we find a way, we have to solve it in advance so that we can run right away. We don’t have enough time now.”

“But.”

“Listen. Am I the only one nervous? I’m worried about you.”

As soon as I know how to do it, I’ll have to try it in Kambrakam.

He was silent for a long time. Eventually he finally agreed as if my opinion was justified.

I also thought this was correct.

And for the reason I didn’t say.....

[“I’m willing to do my best even if it’s a war for you.”]

Because it would be difficult if war really broke out.

Although it was a little grandiose, Helen, who caused a war between the two countries in the myth, was a disgrace. Even more when considering the results of that beauty. But why? No matter what choice I made..... I felt like I was going to meet that man once again.

“Sister!”

Then even Francia returned to the garden. The story went on quickly.

“You’re going to the Imperial Palace?”

Francia responded without delay.

“I will go with you.”

The number of people going to the Imperial Palace was quickly packed up. We left for the Imperial Palace four days later without waiting long. Very secretly.

Chapter 188.1: Welcome to my castle

1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. Welcome to my castle (Part 1)

There are three special things in this empire that other countries do not have.

To borrow the words of the Baron, who was a former prison cellmate, the three things are as follows:

「Imperial Palace of the Sun」

「Kambrakam」

「Rose of the Five Houses」

The latter two looked boring, and those were people around me too, so I'd like to talk about the first one.

‘The Imperial Palace of the Sun’.

Speaking this way, it was a huge building that has stood tall for over a thousand years.

It is now known as the best and last masterpiece of the inventor who remained only as a legend, and as the name suggests, it is a castle with a sense of majesty and intimidation resembling the sun.

My first impression of this was not so different from the description.

Of course, I had already come to the Imperial Palace to attend a banquet, but the situation was different. At that time, I arrived around sunset and there was Chaser right next to me.

I had just learned that I was the Blue Rose, so there was no time to look around at all.

In addition, until the banquet, I stayed only in the detached palace, which was exclusively for guests. In particular, the palace that the Empress gave to Domulit was a little far from the center. The hall where the banquet was held was also near the annex, and for this reason, I did not see the main palace where the Empress stayed.

‘..... It’s crazy big.’

I raised my head. There was no end in sight. I narrowed my eyes to see the sun hanging from the spire.

Some say that this gigantic castle got its name from the sheer height of the castle and the pointy roof like a spear that pierced the sun.

A castle with the sun on its roof, it was worthy of its name. Above all, it was not only large and majestic to suit the grand name, but also felt even more beautiful thanks to the delicate patterns placed here and there.

<“Once you go, they say you’ll never forget it!”>

In this case, I don’t know how helpful the baron’s guided explanation rather than a guide would be. Even after four years have passed, I remembered this because I reflected on my life in the prison once. In particular, the conversation with that Mister was as interesting as listening to an old story. Suddenly, I remembered the smiling face of the old man.

‘I hope that Mister is doing well too.’

The charges weren’t too heavy, so he might have been released. I don’t know if I’ll ever see him again in my lifetime. If I go then, I should pay a small reward.

“Iana.”

I was walking blankly, thinking, looking at the pillar, and I felt a warm body temperature on my shoulder. As I gently raised my head, I saw Ricdorian with a worried expression on his mature face. Grown up, he had a cool face, but to me he used to soften like this.

“Cold?”

What do you mean cold? I shook my head. I felt the temperature was a little low, but... It's not like that.

Come to think of it, I think he said that the capital is a little colder than the south where Hernim is. The average temperature is low. I remembered Domulit making a fuss and giving me a coat.

Ricdorian looked displeased with something, and he sighed a little.

“Your shoulders were shaking.”

I tilted my head.

“..... Did I?”

Ricdorian stopped his steps and took off his coat. He was now wearing a coat that reached down to his thighs. And he was tall. Therefore, if I put on his coat, it would be like being buried in his clothes. Ricdorian paused as if he felt this too. He seemed to alternately look at his coat.

“..... Will it be heavy?”

He seemed to have a different opinion than me. I laughed out loud at his funny serious face.

“Do you think so?”

Ricdorian's coat was not just a coat, it was hanging from one shoulder. A cloak with a rope-like decoration. The fabric here also looked thick, so I

don't know if I would stagger if I put it on. Ricdorian seemed to get the answer from his own words. Suddenly, a gloomy face passed by.

In the end he and I agreed to remove only a short cloak from his coat. It's a short cloak, but when I put it on, it became similar to the length of a shawl. It was definitely warmer than nothing.

Ricdorian sighed a little.

"Iana, you seem too dull to yourself."

"Really?"

Rather than that, I think I have a constitution that doesn't tolerate cold very well. No, I thought it wouldn't. In the prison, I wore a thin jumpsuit and went underground.

"I thought I was strong in the cold."

"I don't think you're strong, you're dull."

"I see."

As I nodded my head, Ricdorian grabbed my shoulders from behind.

"Not that way, this way."

"Ah."

It's not like I looked ahead. The servant who guided us was walking in a completely different direction. I didn't even know that I had taken my eyes off the garden outside and set foot elsewhere. When I slowly raised my eyes, Ricdorian had a slightly sullen expression on his face.

It looked like he was saying, 'Look, you're dull.' I burst out laughing again.

"I tend to be a little absent-minded."

I admit honestly to what I have to admit. Then I stretched out my hand.

‘Pudding.’

When I called out to the little guardian deity inside, I felt the energy of the guardian deity answering inside me as if its ears were pricked up.

‘Come out.’

As soon as I called, the red energy gathered together, and a beast appeared in my arms. It looked like a small cat, perhaps feeling my will.

“Did you sleep well?”

– Uwwong, Nyang. I slept well. Human.

Sorry for waking you up a bit, I stroked its forehead. Pudding was in a good mood, and it made a scratching sound from its neck. I listened to the scratch, scratch and held it in my arms. Warm. Although it is a spirit body, the body temperature of an animal with body temperature warmed my body just right.

“Look.”

I raised my head and smiled.

“You don’t have to worry.”

Even after putting on the cloak, it seemed like he was worried about my body, so I even summoned Pudding. For some reason, Ricdorian’s expression was not relieved.

Why? I blinked and hugged the guardian deity in my arms.

“What’s wrong?”

“..... me too.”

“Me too?”

Ricdorian smacked his lips.

“..... I too can hug you and move.”

He hesitated as he spoke, then his cheek dyed at my words. Seemingly frustrated. No, after everything he did, now he’s saying something like this?

He was a very cute Grand Duke.

“It’s not bad for me either. Wouldn’t it be too conspicuous?”

The Grand Duke, who once shouted out that he could do something all night long. I raised my lips and made a ‘hmmm’ sound.

“I don’t think the Grand Duke would just hug me. No?”

“Yes?”

“I feel like you’re going to take it off before holding me.”

“Iana!”

It was a small voice, but he must have heard it enough. Ricdorian covered his lips with the back of his hand. I could see his white neck turned red.

“..... That, that kind of thing in a place where there are people.”

“That’s not okay?”

“It makes me want to go home right now.”

You’re being reckless in a strange place. For a moment, I worried that his personality had changed, but his red face remained the same.

Chapter 188.2: Welcome to my castle (Part 2)

1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. Welcome to my castle (Part 2)

At present, we had reached the Imperial Palace as quickly as possible.

Originally, Francia also agreed to set off together, but we decided to make time difference with her because she was too conspicuous. In the meantime, she was coming here to temporarily solve the problem with the Holy Knights and the Temple stationed in Hernim.

<Acckk, I had to conquer it! I should have conquered the Principality in order not to be pushed back!>

<Noisy.>

<Duke, did you think this far? To chase me away! This filthy power!>

Of course, there was a nerve battle between the two roses until this was decided, but Ricdorian was the victor. The victor turned his head and exhaled slightly.

“... Iana, I guess you don’t know.”

The low but clear tone penetrated my ears.

“How conspicuous you are.”

“Me?”

I squinted my eyes. What do I have to get attention for right now? Besides, there weren't many people here. Because it was a secret entry.

As I slowly turned my head, I saw a knight guarding the imperial corridor. The knight who made eye contact with me quickly turned his head. Because it was a close distance, his reddened face was clearly visible.

“Hmm, if you're talking about appearance, it's new.”

The people I met in the prison were surprisingly not interested in my appearance. Is it because in one group, they were the same nobleman and the others were the guards who only saw me as a prisoner? At Domulit, people didn't have time to see my face, or to be exact, me. The attendants couldn't be with me for more than a certain amount of time, and most of them came for revenge, and the guests left for somewhere else. For example, a coal mine.....

‘It was a lively place.’

– Human, you were indifferent, Nyang.

‘I did.’

I nodded my head and patted Pudding's butt.

Seeing this, Ricdorian seemed to exhale one more time, and he soon did.

After that, we met the guide from the imperial palace and followed him without any problems. We arrived at the ornate gate in less than ten minutes. Usually, to meet in the palace would be where the entire hall is an audience room, but it is said that we would meet in another place as we requested a secret audience.

‘It doesn't look small here either.’

As I was thinking about this, the door opened.

“Your Majesty, you have a reserved guest. It is Grand Duke Ricdorian von Hernim.”

At the door, someone announced our visit. My eyes met the man who gave the voice. He was an old man with a beard.

“..... And a party is with him.”

He said this as if he couldn't find a title for me. It must be difficult to recognize who I am by the face. Even at the only event I attended, I had my hair and eye color changed.

“Hoo, did the Red Rose come? Come on in.”

A low voice was heard from inside. It was a low, mellow voice mixed with a hoarse voice for a woman.

Tak. The door closed behind my back.

I followed Ricdorian and walked. For a while, I thought I should send Pudding back, but it was after I had already carried it in. However, for some reason, Pudding that had been quietly held in my arms stood upright. Its ears are laid low to reveal its teeth.

Hwaaaak!

— Human, human!

‘What’s the matter?’

I couldn't even stop Pudding from making a ferocious cry. It happened in an instant.

— Human, it's dangerous here! Dangerous!

Pudding jumped out of my arms and its fur stood. The appearance of even its claws exposed was fierce as if it was about to run.

It was when I told Pudding to hurry and go in.

Kuwaaaak!

A loud noise was heard from inside, as if in response to Pudding's cries. It was the cry of a beast I have never heard. It's like a sharp blade is poking out my ears. My ears hurt all the time I listened.

'Ugh, what is this?'

A large hand wrapped around my ear before the pain grew. It seemed to be Ricdorian's hand. In the meantime, when I closed and opened my eyes, the beast I never saw before was flying in front of Pudding. No, it wasn't a beast I had ever seen. It was just a beast I never thought I would see here.

'..... A bat?'

The beast with cloaked wings was a bat in most aspects. However, its appearance was slightly different from the bats I knew. Black wings and protruding fangs. Up to this point, it resembled a bat, but..... The eyes were as deep purple as amethyst in a cave. Moreover, it was very large. Enough to cover everything if it sits on a person's arm.

"Your Majesty, please withdraw your strength."

Said Ricdorian, who was covering my ears. At the same time, a faint laughter was heard from within.

"Oh my. Wesbet, come here."

The main character of the laughter has a low, mellow voice. The bat flew into the sky. The place where the bat landed was on the back of someone's hand.

The long curtains were blown in the wind. No, it wasn't the wind. All the doors and windows were closed.

"My child must be surprised."

The veil was raised by itself by intangible power, revealing who was there.

"I won't say excuse me, you were the first to make a mistake."

The woman slowly raised her head. The dark brown hair flows like a waterfall. It was a natural style as if she covered one eye and let her hair fall to one side.

“It would have cut it down if I hadn’t called, Grand Duke’s Sword.”

However, her attire was an unusual uniform.

The woman’s face gradually turned and she turned towards me and Ricdorian. In her graceful hand, a scepter resembling a staff flicked.

“Is that the beast of the Red Rose?”

Before long, a neutral white face and strikingly beautiful purple eyes captured me.

“The one holding the beast..... Hoo. It’s an unexpected face.”

She had the same purple eyes as mine, but the feeling was completely different. It had a mysterious feeling as if it was a little darker over there. No, strangely, it seemed that the blue color was slightly mixed.

“This is amazing.”

The woman rubbed her cheek and smiled softly.

“Obviously, it is the guardian deity of the Red Rose. It is connected to others.”

She asked without blinking an eye. It was a direct way of speaking.

“I wonder if you are the legendary Blue Rose, aren’t you?”

While I could not answer, the woman folded her eyes first and smiled.

Behind her was a huge crown, a scepter, and a purple rose in full bloom. It was a symbol of the great imperial family.

“Iana Rose Domulit. No, Domulit’s Treasure.”

Scarlet Scheherazade.

The owner of this country showed me a favor and smiled even deeper.

“Welcome to my castle.”

Chapter 189.1: There are conditions (1)

The chapters lately has been quite long, so i'm splitting it into two >.< this chapter is literally twice the usual chapters!

1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. There are conditions (1)

The Empress correctly called my name, but I bowed my head without panic. I kept my eyes on the floor. I have already met the Empress. Probably because I had an audience at a banquet I had previously attended. Of course, I was wearing a mask at that time, but I couldn't wear it in front of the Empress.

Since then, only Chaser has been called closely and I haven't seen her up close, but she's nevertheless seen my face. Although my hair and eyes were different, it wouldn't be a problem.

She must have become an Empress with a keen eye, even though I also knew that the transformation at that time was at a level of blindfolding. But recognizing that I was the Blue Rose was another thing. She may have said it was a joke, but I don't think there's something an Empress could just say. Or, did she already know on the day she greeted Chaser?

I didn't know which one it was.

“Greetings, Your Majesty.”

Usually, when a nobleman greeted, praise for the Empress was required, but when it was a Duke-level greeting, the simplified greeting was not rude.

As if the Empress didn't care, I continued to raise my head.

"Hmm, Duke Domulit is certainly unpleasant. I didn't know he was hiding this beautiful family member. Moreover, to the point of identity."

By saying that she didn't recognize me even in front of her nose, I knew that the worries I had a while ago were closer to the former. It seemed that she had guessed my identity whatever Chaser said. Or there was some reason why she didn't recognize me.

"What do you do while Domulit's Treasure greets me? Hernim?"

It meant why was he standing still without saying his greetings? Ricdorian only looked at the Empress with a cold expression on his face.

"Hernim knows how to convey loyalty to the imperial family even if it is not formal."

"Hmm, you only lived with your mouth."

Despite Ricdorian's attitude, the Empress only smiled.

'..... Wasn't the relationship between Hernim and the imperial family on good terms?'

Originally that was how it was In the book with the former Grand Duke Hernim. So, the setting was that Ricdorian would continue the loyalty that Ricdorian's father had built up. He hated his father, but he was also a loyal follower of his father, who was suddenly murdered. This coincided with the path of the Red Rose, which had long been loyal to the imperial family.

But judging by Ricdorian's attitude, it seemed that he did not like this position.

'Even when I asked to go to the imperial family, he didn't seem so happy.'

Ricdorian also accepted that there was no way, but he was not willing to give permission. Was it actually difficult? Judging from the fact that he was

allowed to accompany me, it would seem that they were not in a hostile relationship.....

“I do not like this kind of reaction.”

The corner of the Empress’s lips rises. She tilted her head loosely. Contrary to that she said that she was not happy, her face didn’t feel that way at all.

“I didn’t mean to offend, I’d like to ask you.”

“How can I stop Your Majesty’s question?”

Ricdorian took a step back.

“Hmm, the Blue Rose that appeared at this moment. Then there’s Duke Domulit’s younger sister.”

Her gaze swept me away.

He saw me there only once and felt me as the Blue Rose. If the Empress was a rose like Francia or Ricdorian, it wouldn’t be strange, but it was strange on the other hand. The rose family I saw on the stone slate was five in total, four except for the Blue Rose family that had already disappeared. But there was no royal family in it. I’ve never even heard of the Empress being a rose with special powers.

But how did she recognize the connection between me and Pudding at once?

“What would I think of the fact that you, the Red Rose, brought a legendary being?”

“How can I guess what Your Majesty’s thoughts are?”

Ricdorian was more courteous than before, but he was still not in an attitude of attending to the Empress. I could feel it clearly.

“You wouldn’t think that I didn’t know. You wouldn’t be ignorant of my ‘seeing eye’. And yet, you know that to remain silent at this moment and

spare no words is to deceive me.”

An intangible aura swayed from the Empress. It was a familiar haze I had seen in Ricdorian and Francia except that it was purple in color.

I got goosebumps.

Why does the Empress show such energy? There was no purple in the roses on the slate, but I felt something was going wrong.

“Or are you laughing at my inability to come and feel the energy of the Blue Rose from Lady Domulit?”

Was my body changing to match the rose? Or, maybe I just realized what I was feeling from the beginning, but the strange feeling seems to suggest something ominous.

Why does the Empress have the power of a rose? It was simple when you think about it. Each of the roses was a family, and she was the master of the Empire that ruled all the families.

So it's not unusual to have that much power. The slate kept coming to mind. I only saw 5 roses in Kambrakam..... This is the afterimage of the painting I saw all the time. The thought that there are only five roses.

There, the purple rose carved on the Empress's back stood out even more.

“Tell me, Master of Hernim.”

The Empress was silent.

“Did you dare to despise the master of the Empire?”

Then, an energy that could never be ignored flowed from the Empress. Accordingly, Ricdorian also did not stand still. It was an instantaneous situation.

“How can you not recognize my loyalty?”

“Loyalty?”

A bat sitting on the Empress’s armrest spread its wings. The Empress moved her lips slowly and gracefully as if licking her lips, then bit her lip. It was ferocious, but it was so oppressive that it even looked elegant.

“I am not happy with the appearance of the long gone Blue Rose. The existence of a miracle that reappeared in an era when miracles were cut out is good to cause chaos. Isn’t that so?”

She clenched her cheeks and narrowed her eyes.

“If I had found it first, she wouldn’t have been left with this. I remember all the past. What was the result of the appearance of the Blue Rose?”

And the words continued slowly.

“Like the ‘Rose Festival’ in the past.”

Rose Festival. It was the first time I had heard it, but from the Empress’s nuances, it didn’t seem like a good thing.

“My role is to protect the peace of the Empire. Even at this moment, I can cut off that slender flower that hasn’t bloomed and swallow the seed.”

In an instant, a bloody atmosphere overwhelmed the not-so-small room. As if knowing that this was going to happen, Ricdorian was calm. I felt anxious.

There was no one in the room except the three of us.

“How can I add one word to Your Majesty’s decision? If you do, your Majesty. You know I’m not going to watch.”

“.....”

“You’re not a wise man, are you?”

There's no way I didn't know that Her Majesty's words meant that she would wipe me out in front of him. She smiled, but she looked at me with eyes full of intimidation, how can I not know? A little while ago, my attention was focused on that purple light, a mixture of purple and blue that shimmered strangely in her eyes.

It kept causing anxiety. Even though I am originally indifferent to most things. At first, when Pudding asked me to leave, I should have turned around.

'That's why Pudding can say I'm stupid. I have nothing to say.'

A long arm stretched out in front of me in an instant situation. It was Ricdorian's. In an emergency, his chin was tightly shut as if he was ready to engage in a serious situation or a fight.

"Well, good."

The Empress chuckled.

"Actually, the young girl behind you right now is a problem even if she's not the Blue Rose. Hernim."

Chapter 189.2: There are conditions (1) (Part 2)

The chapters lately has been quite long, so i'm splitting it into two >.< this chapter is literally twice the usual chapters!

1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. There are conditions (1)

Ricdorian's title has changed.

"Think of what will happen to the treasure you took. You are not stupid. Doesn't the other side say they're ready to go to war? With what kind of determination did you bring the seeds here?"

The one the Empress spoke of was, of course, Chaser. Why did Ricdorian bring the seeds of discord here? She was asking that.

"It is Your Majesty who has called me to this place."

"Yes. I have called you. I.....had no idea you would bring the seeds."

The Empress's eyes glimpsed at me.

"As long as the 'blue flower' appears, you will follow that Lady even more than me. Sometimes at the expense of competition and sacrifice."

She smiled suspiciously.

"As a burden considering the safety of the Empire, I cannot help but consider it. Do you understand?"

Every word was threatening.

“The moment I realized it, I even thought about whether I should destroy that flower.”

The purple eyes staring at me subsided. At the same time, the energy I felt in her grew stronger.

“There are no two suns under the sky. So far, I’m sure you’ll understand what I am thinking.”

I don’t know why, but I only knew that the Empress was overly wary of the Blue Rose. This seemed to be the cause of the anxiety. Did I make the wrong choice to come here?

That was the moment.

“But still, I don’t like it.”

The Empress stretched out her hand.

“This is tiring. It has a very long history.”

The intangible energy that threatened me and Ricdorian disappeared in an instant. Anger faded from her eyes in front of me, and interest took its place.

“Even more so if the emotion I feel is not mine, but jealousy.”

Interesting...? I did not understand this situation in which the boundary was released in an instant. I didn’t understand what she was saying, but Ricdorian didn’t release his expression as if he had guessed.

“..... You are a strong person, so I think you will overcome it.”

“Hmm, just like before.”

The Empress, who had been exchanging words like that, suddenly turned her head to face me.

“The Lady over there doesn’t seem to know anything. Didn’t you tell her?”

“Yes. She may not know it yet, but today she will know it all.”

“Does she know that you are on a time limit?”

It was a straight ball that came in. Ricdorian paused for a moment, but answered calmly.

“Yes, she knows.”

“I see.”

The Empress slowly straightened her upper body. Her flowing hair was scattered. It appeared and disappeared at first glance, but I watched them carefully.

“Then she just needs to know the facts about me.”

She stroked her chin as if she was having fun. Also, even though the wind was not blowing, the drapery with the rose behind it flew. Now I know. No, it seemed so. That a purple force blowing like the wind shook the drapery.

“The fact that the Imperial Family is in fact an imperfect rose, and that it reigns over the imperfect subject. Oh, should I tell her this too?”

She looked happy.

“My heart is a little worried about showing bad things to a pretty Lady. Right, Lady Domulit, are you good at watching difficult things?”

“What?”

For a moment before I even questioned what it was, the Empress swept her head. A scar appeared from her head where one eye was covered. It was a huge, deep scar with a thread that ran across the top of the eyelid.

It was crushed as if it had been burned, but if you combine the things that appeared here and there, maybe from the forehead to the temple..... It

looked like there was originally a tattoo. A rose tattoo.

“It’s a scar from my resistance to ‘imperfection’. To put it simply, I didn’t want to have the power of a rose.”

She pretended to poke her eyes.

“It was done. It’s pathetic.”

“... As I have said several times in the past, as long as you are sitting there, I do not think there is any need to lower yourself.”

“Is this power in my hands?”

The Empress chuckled in a low voice. She stroked her cheek with her long finger. I was busy organizing what the Empress was talking about. I was always indifferent and slow, but even I could not pass this.

The Empress and the Imperial Family are purple roses that were not on the slate. The Purple Rose was an incomplete rose. And that the Empress stabbed herself in the eye because she didn’t want to have power.... My head spins quickly.

Ricdorian was cursed with the curse of becoming a beast and the curse of shortening his lifespan. Even though he was a perfect rose, wouldn’t imperfection pay a greater price?

However, looking at the Empress’s attitude, it seemed that my reasoning was not wrong. In the meantime, the Empress was having a conversation with Ricdorian, about the envy of when I had entrusted myself to Hernim.

She closed her eyes again and smiled bitterly.

“Yes. Is she okay out of Domulit?”

“Yes, under Hernim’s protection. Rosenia will also protect her.”

“The White Rose already? Whoa. Don’t touch me easily.”

The Empress laughed out loud.

“Well, okay, I got it. I think it would be too bad for me to erase the Lady, who is so pretty from the world.”

The eyes that were curved towards me were full of intimidation, but at the same time, they were attractive. I wondered if this was the charisma of those who reigned.

“Anyway, there must have been a willingness to respond to my summons like this. Do you have any wishes?”

Said the Empress, stroking the bat sitting on the armrest. It was the Empress’s side who invited me to come to the Imperial Castle while bringing up the story of Domulit. So there must be something we want, nevertheless she skillfully led us to the negotiating table.

“I like to be straightforward.”

I was told not to talk about this and that, but to talk about the main point.

“By the way, I don’t really like the slyness in Duke Domulit’s face.”

She smiled and stroked her chin.

“The precariously beautiful things, as always, harbor poison.”

It also meant that Domulit had asked first, but she gave this side a chance.

“Your Majesty is well aware that I will not live long.”

“I do. It’s precisely what this unwelcome power tells me.”

The Empress tapped her blindfolded eyes. It seemed that the power the Empress had was power related to information.

“Yes, I want to go to Kambrakam with Iana. Could you please allow it? This is what I want.”

The Empress exclaimed in admiration.

“Are you going to lift your curse on Kambrakam?”

“That’s right.”

She seemed to have a lot of knowledge as well as power related to information. It was not unusual to become an Empress at a time. Moreover, after quenching her first unusual anger, the Empress continued to show a friendly attitude.

“Not a bad idea. I, too, do not wish for the Grand Duke, the pillar of the Empire, to disappear.”

Hernim was already a huge family that supported the Empire. The disappearance of those in power will cause chaos. The Imperial Family would also be in trouble when the Head suddenly disappeared. Of course, there were benefits to be gained by Ricdorian’s disappearance, but more than that, she seemed to want to maintain the present peace. I found out the next moment.

“So I can give you permission.”

That she was not an easy-going person.

“But there are conditions.”

“... What is it?”

She rolled her eyes and spoke her words with a smile worthy of the monarch’s seat.

“Bring what I need.”

Note: at the beginning, the Empress did call her as ‘flower’ instead of ‘Rose’~

Chapter 190: There are conditions (2)

1. 1. 1. 1. There are conditions (2)

There are things that come and go in a transaction. I thought that she was a person who has definitely considered the price.

“It was already a privilege that the Imperial Family have provided you with Kambrakam for free for a long time ago. Don’t you know?”

“What do Your Majesty want?”

“You are so cool, I love it.”

The Empress crossed her legs and tilted her head. She had an elegant posture, but her appearance was full of dignity.

“The condition is to bring what I need.”

“What do you want?”

“My crown.”

The Empress tapped her head with her long finger.

“The tiara that I cherished. You know? I want to find what was lost.”

I raised my head.

The Empress’s tiara.

‘..... This is where it comes from?’

As the main plot in the original, it also occupied a long story. Of course I knew very well where the tiara was. I couldn’t think for a long time. Because the Empress’s question returned to me.

“Lady Domulit, can you use the power of the Blue Rose?”

“No.”

I politely shook my head. I didn’t fully understand what abilities I had, let alone use my abilities. Records of the Blue Rose that have long since disappeared were rare. Even with Hernim’s vast data collection, I could not find anything other than some abilities of the Blue Rose.

“The data on the Blue Rose has long since been lost. It was all erased as if someone had decided to.”

“.....”

“That force is a force you know. Can you guess?”

Somehow, what force did it? I seemed to know, the Black Rose.

“But there are documents left in the Imperial Household. Most are in good condition.”

Telling that fact meant that she was willing to show it. Unsurprisingly, she was cool. She crossed her arms and smiled.

“If you bring my tiara, I’ll gladly give it to you.”

In a way, it was a problem that would have taken a long time if I didn’t know where and how to get it. However.....

I knew it.

That this was absolutely favorable conditions for us. That said, I do know the whereabouts of the ‘Empress’s Tiara’ very well. I even know its recent

whereabouts.

‘That..... Chaser had it.’

I wanted to wipe my face.

Because I knew that the Empress’s Tiara was sleeping in the basement of the Domulit mansion.

“Do you know where it is?”

Ricdorian next to me asked calmly.

“Do you know?”

“I don’t know where it is.”

“So do I.”

The Empress made a funny face.

“What is that face? Shameless, Grand Duke.”

She seemed to have grasped Ricdorian’s intentions.

“It’s up to you to find it from now on, isn’t it?”

The Empress did not give the mercy of time to those who lacked time. She was fair but cold.

“Let’s go out.”

After leaving the audience room, Ricdorian did not speak for a long time. I respected his silence.

He must have thought a lot about the fact that the Empress had put up an absurd condition. He will be troubled. Of course, if it was Hernim’s

intelligence and human property, there was nothing that can't be found, but if it took a long time, more important things would be missed. His life.

The Empress told us just before we left.

<I'll block anything Domulit-related while you're looking for it.>

Although it was for a limited time, it meant that we would be free from Chaser's pursuit. Anyway, I was Chaser's sister, so if Chaser was looking for me openly, there was no reason to stop him. Still, it was something I was grateful for.

Except that in the future I may have to go directly to Domulit too.

Yes, the problem was this.

I glanced at Ricdorian. It was to see the timing to talk about this and to deliver it. First of all, there were too many ears in the hallway. If we go back like this.....

"Your Excellency."

We turned our backs at the same time. There, a servant was seen breathing a little.

"The Empress wants to see you for a moment."

The Empress? We parted a while ago, but it was a strange thing.

"... We had an audience a while ago."

"She just said to stop by and go back quickly because she had something to tell you."

"Then together....."

"She told you to come quickly."

The servant said so and lowered his head deeply. He apologized for daringly interrupting the Grand Duke. It seemed that the Empress's intention was for him to return as quickly as possible.

“And she said to come alone.”

Ricdorian hardened his expression even colder.

“Similar command.....”

We had already reached the end of the hallway. If we went back, it would take a long time at my pace, so what this command meant was clear.

“It sounds like she was trying to separate me and the party. Am I mistaken?”

“..... forgive me.”

Ricdorian narrowed his eyes. A glimpse of anger flashed through his blue eyes.

“His Majesty has sent this to you, telling you not to worry about leaving the place.”

The servant held out his hand. In the servant's hand sat the Empress's bat, which I had seen in the audience room a while ago. The Empress gave even her guardian deity, so it was inevitable for Ricdorian to follow. At the same time, it seems to be even more uncomfortable.

“Ricdorian.”

Eventually I grabbed the hem of his robe.

“Go quickly.”

I don't know what kind of whim she was using, but the Empress was kind to us first. There was nothing bad about it.

“If she gave it to you now, it won't be bad for you.”

If it was a clue about the tiara, there was no need for it. If it was anything else, there was no reason to miss it.

“Because there is Pudding too. It will be fine for a while.”

When I said this, I thought that I was too unreliable even if I looked at it.

It's like following a movie cliché. When the characters in the movie who said it would be okay would go through bad things. With that in mind, I nodded to Ricdorian. Actually, I don't believe in the Empress, but I was curious as to why she gave up her guardian deity. Moreover, I did not mention Pudding for nothing.

‘Pudding would suffice for an assassination threat.’

– Of course, Nyang. I will protect the weak human, Nyang!

I laughed inside.

‘Alright, alright.’

The guardian deity, who was now three years old, knew how to use its own abilities. As it was originally a partner of the Red Rose, which had concentrated abilities in its body, Pudding's ability was enough to buy time.

Ricdorian would have known this better. Although the connection had already been broken for a long time, they were originally in a relationship where they grew up together, so he could still feel Pudding's power. Ricdorian insisted that he would take me with him when he returned, but in the end he returned to the audience room with a gloomy expression.

And all that was left was the servant and I. I tilted my head.

‘Why doesn't this servant go back?’

Of course, it was strange that he had to pursue Ricdorian's speed as an ordinary human, so he had to stay next to me.

There the bat was still sitting on the servant's hand.

“From now on, what I am delivering is a message from Her Majesty the Empress.”

“..... Yes?”

I was a little perplexed by the servant’s next words. But soon I blinked. The servant looked at me and held out the bat.

– *First of all, please forgive my light jokes, pretty Lady.*

Strangely, the Empress’s voice came from the bat. No, the bat’s mouth didn’t move at all, and it felt like a buzzing sound in my ears. I know that bats are animals that can sense sensations through ultrasonic waves, but I also wondered if this could be telepathy.

– *The reason I separated the Grand Duke from you was because I thought we could see a pretty interesting sight.*

“..... interesting sight.”

What do you mean? I couldn’t guess. However, the bat’s voice felt favorable at first glance.

– *I was unintentionally ferocious a little while ago, but he was looking at you in a good way. It was so cute that he didn’t blink an eye.*

..... cute? I put on a bewildered look. This sister. Her standards were a bit vague.

– *Instability and indifference are characteristic of the Blue Rose. But it is said that such an appearance is the best stimulant for roses.*

Maybe. If that characteristic was true, it also matched my personality to some extent. Although I thought I just had a laid-back personality, pursuing a comfortable, peaceful life.

– *I mean, you’re good at making them nervous.*

“..... The Roses?”

– *Yes. So please forgive me for removing your brave dog, no, rose.*

I think she corrected the title by trying to call him a brave dog now.

– *I want to see something fun.*

I laughed out loud at the playful tone that followed. There were few who could say this about Ricdorian. Having said this, my mind was put at ease.

When I was thinking like that,

Thum, thum, thump.

Footsteps were heard This was a hallway that was surprisingly sparsely populated. So the sound was clear.

– *Oh, he's here. Then I'll go.*

The sound of footsteps approached quickly. I didn't think this was the speed of an average person.

As soon as I thought about it, a large shadow fell over me.

It wasn't just a shadow. I opened my eyes wide. Just blinking once, twice..... three times.

I was surprised by the body temperature that hit me, but..... I felt a heavy breath on my shoulder. It was a breath close to raw that did not suit this man.

Although he was sharp, he was always a refined and elegant man.

I could see the servant taking a few steps back. I couldn't think of the Empress anymore. I just focused my whole body on this panting sound and body temperature. I called him carefully.

“Lenag.”

His breathing stopped for a moment. At the same time, hot exhalations pour out of his throat. Like letting go of everything up until now.

Perhaps those were concerns or worries. I carefully guessed.

“..... Miss Iana.”

He called me low. It was a cautious voice, lest I got sick of his calling.

“I was worried.”

There was a lot in the voice he said after a while. I hesitated and let him go.

Chapter 191: Fiance appeared (1)

1. 1. 1. 1. Fiance appeared (1)

Pretending not to notice that my shoulders were gently getting wet.

I knew he would be worried, with this man's character. He would also be concerned. But I had no way to contact him.

Wouldn't it be better if he had a rose engraved like Chaser? But this man was a man who wouldn't even breathe without my permission.

Lenag slowly raised his head.

“..... sorry.”

Without saying that, I paused. The man's face, visible through thin flowing hair, was a mess.

Tuk. The glasses that were loosely on my shoulder fell to the floor.

Lenag was startled and hurriedly covered his eyes.

“..... Don't, don't look.”

He turned his head away. Oddly enough, only his earlobes were dyed red. Seeing him like that made me a little troubled.

“It will be a mess.....”

I've already seen it all.....

“Um, yes. I didn't see anything.”

Unfortunately I wasn't used to lying. Living a comfortable life was like not having too many things to lie about. He would have heard it all in my voice. I rummaged through my arms and pulled out a handkerchief.

"I don't normally carry things like this."

It was supposed to be a secret entry, but it was still a place to meet the Empress. So, I had a lot of things I didn't usually bring.

"I must have brought it for this moment."

I said in a slightly indifferent tone and reached out to him. Lenag, who was looking at me between his fingers, hesitated and took the handkerchief.

"Thank you."

It was such a polite greeting. While he wiped away the remaining water with the handkerchief, I leaned over and picked up his glasses and cloak.

Ricdorian's cloak, which was hanging on my shoulder that was suddenly held by Lenag, had also fallen off. Seeing what I was picking up, Lenag hesitated. At the same time, his cheeks turned red.

"I'm, I'm sorry, Miss Iana. I suddenly...."

He was a quick man to apologize for what he did wrong. There were no unnecessary things attached to it. As if he'll be punished right away for what he did if I get angry before forgiving him.

"I was so surprised to see you..... no. This is also an excuse. Don't listen to it."

"I've already listened....."

"Ugh"

"Just kidding."

Lenag was at a loss when I handed the glasses. It was a little funny, the man with his shoulders wide open, and a fierce and sharp look became distracted. He doesn't have to be so hard on himself.

‘Hmm.’

Seeing Lenag like that, I had a strange thought.

It's a bit strange for me to think of snakes while looking at this. Watching Lenag's actions, I remembered a small snake that was shy but greeted me warmly.

“Are you sick? I feel like you're emaciated.”

Even though I knew it was an inappropriate greeting after a while, I passed it on to him. He lowered his eyes.

“..... I haven't been doing well.”

“Yes. I heard you were looking for me.”

“Yes. I was looking for yo.”

Lenag put his hand under his glasses.

“..... Very, very anxiously.”

Again, I couldn't help but feel sorry for this. Even if the kidnapping wasn't my intention, this man would have been literally anxiously searching for me. It seems that Chaser did not share information with him.

“I'm so.....”

“No. Don't apologize.”

He shook his head.

“I know it's not your fault.”

Then, after hesitating, he added another word.

“Even if it was your will. That is not wrong.”

Leaving Chaser’s side was a good thing. As a result of that, he searched the entire empire.

In fact, he even jumped on me like this. I couldn’t find anything to say, so I ended up just smiling.

Lenag’s arm was decorated with buttons embellished with snakes. Perhaps it was a symbol of his family. What kind of omniscient rose point of view is this? For some reason, it felt like I could see animals behind every rose I saw. I asked a question I was curious about.

“How did you know about this place?”

“Francia Orr Rosenia.”

A familiar name flowed from Lenag.

“No, I should call her the 127th Saint now. She informed me.”

The reason Ricdorian and I left for the Imperial Palace was kept secret. The fact that hardly anyone from Hernim came was proof.

No matter how strong Ricdorian’s power is, it cannot be without danger as long as Domulit was a great enemy. Nevertheless, the reason he made this decision was because Hernim also recognized that this was a battle of time.

He chose security over safety. So I was relieved only when I heard the source of the information.

“Did Francia make it easy for you?”

Lenag stopped at the name that came out naturally. It was only for one moment.

“I don’t know what the threat is. She asked me to come.”

“Ah.”

“At least until she arrives. That was the price of information.”

When I asked how Lenag could appear in such a hurry, it must have been Francia’s arrangement. Obviously, if there were two roses, even Chaser would not help it.

Francia was late for her departure because she had work to deal with, and it seemed that she was concerned about my safety, as I was vulnerable as she got her feet tied up. I could tell how much she cared about me, in that she offered a deal without hesitation to someone whom she didn’t like very much. It felt like my heart was moved.

“And she didn’t even have to ask.”

“Yes? Why?”

“I thought I would be here soon.”

Lenag said he had heard of it before my entry and he let Francia know that he was running here.

“It was the first time I had ever known that the temple’s carriage was so fast.”

I burst into laughter as I thought that even his appearance would look like Francia. You have used everything available for me, Francia.

I glanced behind. Not too far away, the servant stood still. Along with the bat sitting on the servant’s arm. The bat didn’t say anything, but for some reason I wondered if the Empress had seen it all through the bat.

“We have to move now.”

There was no need to be here anymore after talking with the Empress. Of course, the movement was after Ricdorian had arrived.

Thinking about that, as I moved my steps, my body stumbled and tilted. The floor was slippery. My legs trembled. My overlapped hands were cold. I thought it wasn't that cold, but maybe my legs just froze. As soon as I took one more step, I slipped.

I thought I would feel pain, but it didn't hurt even after a few seconds. When I opened my eyes, I saw an arm holding me tightly.

"Are you okay?"

In front of me was Lenag's surprised face. It's good that he caught me..... Somehow, it became quite banal.

"Um, yes. It's cold and I think my legs are frozen."

"..... I don't think it's something to talk about casually."

"Ahaha. is that so?"

I scratched my cheek as I held him. Somehow, while thinking that men in this world were very good at picking people up.

"I thought I wasn't sensitive to the cold."

It's not just my emotions that were dull. Was it because of my personality that I was insensitive?

"I didn't know before. I guess I'm a little numb to my senses."

My overlapped fingers were cold. But I didn't know my body temperature had dropped so much until I grabbed someone else's hand.

'Maybe this is a bit strange.'

Ricdorian said that I shivered, but I didn't feel it either. Even in prison, I did not feel much cold or heat. Even when other prisoners say that it was unusually cold today and rub their body hard and take a seat on the fireplace. I would just tilt my head and ask 'was it cold?'.

“Could you please put me down for now?”

At those words, a hint of hesitation passed through Lenag’s face.

“..... If your body is cold, wouldn’t it be better to stay like this for a while?”

“Um, that’s true. I want to stand on my feet.”

There’s eyes to see. The bat was looking at me, to be precise, I didn’t know what the owner of the bat was thinking while directing this situation. Even after saying this, Lenag hesitated a little longer. A strange thing flashed across his face full of concern.

“Just a little bit.....”

“Yes?”

Then it was the moment he opened his mouth.

“A little bit more.....”

At the same time, footsteps were heard. The footsteps quickly drew closer. Turning my head, Ricdorian was standing there. Judging by the fact that he had a hardened expression on his face, he seemed to immediately notice the situation when he saw this.

“... Ha, that was why she called me all of a sudden? When I went there, I was only told about my personal information..... I wondered why Her Majesty kept us apart.”

The more he spoke, the colder his gaze gradually became. Ricdorian approached and loosened his neatly bound cravat.

“It was because of this.”

The gaze towards Lenag was wilder and cooler than the face when we met again after a few years. But the moment it turned towards me, it melted away like spring from winter.

“Iana.”

I noticed it right away from the smile and gaze that seemed to be slightly out of focus.

Ricdorian’s personality changed.

He folded his beautiful blue eyes in half and smiled as if melting a person.

“Are you hurt?”

“Uh, huh?”

“She almost fell. I was surprised and came running.”

How did Ricdorian who went to see the Empress know? The source of the information was obvious. I looked at the bat. The bat waved its wings as if it had even noticed my gaze.

“Thank you for helping Iana. Marquis Valtaze.”

“..... It’s not the way Your Excellency used to speak.”

“What does my tone have to do with it?”

Surprisingly, Ricdorian was calm for a change in his personality. Of course, it was always relative. Even the crazy ones could be calm and the calm ones are the scariest... Ricdorian soon revealed his true nature.

“It’s a hot day, isn’t it?”

Whip. The cravat, which had been well bound, broke as it was and fell to the floor.

Ricdorian unbuttoned his buttons as if frustrated and brushed his hair up. Now, rather than being the Grand Duke, he looked more like a debauched noble you would see in that back alley.

He slowly turned his head as if his frustration had been resolved now. Then he smiled at me.

“Can you come here, Iana?”

He groaned as if he was seriously hurt.

“I am really heartbroken.”

Lenag’s hand that was holding me twitched at this.

“Why don’t you let her go now? Marquis?”

Lenag slowly lowered me. My toes touch the floor. Even though it was a stone floor, I felt like I was stepping on a thin ice sheet. I thought Lenag would let me go, but what was this? Lenag turned around instead of getting away. Then he grabbed the back of my hand and kissed his lips on it. He looked very polite. He looked at Ricdorian once, as if to tell Ricdorian that he’s different.

“I listen to only one person.”

Lenag moved his lips slowly.

“I really want to ask you, Your Excellency.”

Beneath his glasses, indifferent, sharp eyes were revealed.

“That is.”

A quite noble, yet with a boring tone.

“What do you want to do with my fiance?”

Chapter 192: Fiance appeared (2)

1. 1. 1. 1. Fiance appeared (2)

It goes without saying that the temperature in the hallway became cooler due to Lenag's words.

"Aha."

Ricdorian did not stop smiling.

"You don't know that Iana decided to stay at my castle, do you?"

He rubbed his reddened eyes and spoke leisurely. Lenag's expression hardened, but only for a moment.

"We don't know if it will last forever."

"....."

Ricdorian had a look on his face. Lenag did not end there and continued.

"Because we are still engaged. I think I would have asked Miss Iana first, who was still unmarried. I guess Your Excellency didn't?"

Ricdorian laughed again.

"Ah. That's something I hadn't thought of."

Then he added quickly.

"Because before that, Iana said she would stay."

“.....”

I looked at the two men alternately and exhaled slowly.

‘This is a catfight. A catfight.’

– Human, aren’t you at the center, Nyan?

Surprisingly, the three-year-old guardian deity stabbed right to the spot. It was a naive tone, as if it didn’t know that hitting me with the facts hurts more.

‘I know.’

I know..... I looked at the two men as if I was looking at someone else’s business. Why was it that them fighting while staring at each other so fiercely didn’t feel like my business... When a person saw a sight that was too unrealistic, it seemed that at that time, they would separate themselves and saw it as if it was someone else’s business.

‘Why are the people who have nothing lacking doing this because of me?’

– Human, isn’t that a little too lacking in confident, Nyan?

‘It’s a little different from confidence..... I think that the more I search for it, the farther away my comfort is? Actually, I’m fine wherever.....’

– You have to move a little, Nyan!

Pudding was very angry.

– I can’t believe my contractor fell down because her legs are frozen! It’s a disgrace, Nyan! You lack exercise!

In the end, the three-year-old guardian deity could not stand it and I blocked my ears to the nagging. Reluctantly, I gave up my erratic escape and returned to reality. I exhaled deeply.

Either way, it was true that conversation was necessary. But.....

I glanced away. I looked at the bat sitting still as if observing, feeling the need to organize this.

“Excuse me.”

The two men shut their lips. The sight of them made me laugh. There were three pairs of eyes on me while I laughed out loud. Two were human and one was a guardian deity. Two of them seemed unable to take their eyes off me.

I held back my laughter and spoke in a more relaxed tone.

“For now, shall we go?”

I didn’t want to become a spectacle any more.

“Why does it matter to you?”

We had to change the place but it was still the Imperial Palace, but I was satisfied with the fact that there was no longer an observing gaze. Fortunately, Ricdorian also regained his reason on the way and was now in his normal form.

However, the clothes were already messed up, the cravat was gone, so he was only buttoning up. In addition, some of the top buttons were missing because we could not pick up the button that had fallen off. He looked so disorganized with such an ascetic face..... It was a bit provocative.

Umm, good thoughts. Good thoughts.

I thought I didn’t have to think good thoughts anymore. For now, I decided to put that thought aside.

The problem was elsewhere.

Ricdorian and Lenag were engaged in the second war of words.

“Come on, stop it now.”

I couldn't stand seeing them, so I stopped Ricdorian and explained it to Lenag step by step. How did we come to this situation, all the reasons and circumstances in which I decided to stay with Ricdorian. In addition, the story about the tiara we received as a condition after meeting with the Empress.

This, of course, included important information that Ricdorian has a time limit.

At least I had the belief that I could confide in anything to this man. However, it may not have been the same for Ricdorian, so I looked at Ricdorian just before we talked, but he nodded with a cold face as if it was okay.

“..... I understand the situation. I understand everything.”

“Wow. Did you understand it all at once? The Marquis is terribly smart.”

“Are you being sarcastic?”

“When did I?”

There was also an incident where a guest broke in while I was explaining to Lenag. Of course, that guest was Francia. In any case, after several incidents, I succeeded in explaining all the circumstances.

“Isn't it right to be sarcastic?”

“No? Why should you be sarcastic? If I was Sister's fiancée, my eyes would turn upside down. You're speaking surprisingly calmly.”

“Francia.”

Seriously, wouldn't I be the one who gets in trouble the most when my fiance, Lenag, went crazy? When I looked at it with this meaning in mind, Francia smiled and she hung on my arm.

Lenag frowned, then turned his head away again. His voice went low.

“Well. It’s not wrong. If you allow it, I feel like I want to turn everything upside down.”

When he opened his eyes again, he had a sharp face different from before.

“Grand Duke, in the end, what you did was nothing but a low-level kidnapping, wasn’t it?”

Lenag whispered quietly. It was only a small voice, but it was a voice filled with anger.

Ricdorian also did not know how to get rid of his cold face. But at the same time, his lips went open and closed. Clenching his fist, guilt flashed through his eyes.

But at least I knew what kind of face Ricdorian made when he was begging for forgiveness.

“Um, Lenag.”

So I calmly called Lenag.

“Can’t you let it slide for now?”

I didn’t say I had forgiven him. This would be impossible for Lenag, who was angry for me. But nonetheless, Lenag’s face was blurred for a moment. If Ricdorian was one who would wept and shed tears, Lenag was the one who would quietly shed long streams of tears.

I hoped he wouldn’t cry because I had already seen it and knew it.

“..... If you wish.”

“Thank you.”

He slowly returned to his calm face. But it was unknown whether he was okay inside.

“As I said, I decided to stay in Hernim castle of my own will. And I intend to help break the Grand Duke’s curse.”

“I think it’s a good thing.”

Lenag exhaled with a sigh.

“The day you let the saint over there escape, you didn’t listen when I asked you to come with me.”

Francia, who was watching silently, shrugged her shoulders.

“You look better now than you were that day. Miss Iana. Just that you’re smiling comfortably..... I am satisfied with that.”

Lenag raised his lips. Then he narrowed his eyes.

“But I don’t know if it’s a good thing to help them entirely.”

“One question. Marquis.”

Ricdorian, who had been silent, slowly released his arms. Ricdorian, whose reason had returned, returned to his original appearance as the Grand Duke.

“Did you know that Iana is the Blue Rose?”

“Yes. I knew.”

Without realizing it, I turned to Lenag’s face. It was because the answer came from him more plainly than I expected.

“Then I would like to ask. If you had known it a long time ago, I think you would know the question I want to ask.”

“I know what you want to say.”

Lenag intercepted the words in a soft but strong tone. Then he lowered his eyes.

“What’s the matter?”

The words that came out of his sharp face were gentle, but at the same time firm.

“It’s just that the one I liked was the Blue Rose.”

It was also a desperate expression that made the viewer lose words.

“And if she’s here to help the Grand Duke, there’s no reason for me to back down.”

“Don’t you think I’m going to kick you out?”

“Do you think I will be kicked out easily?”

Ricdorian tilted his head coldly. Watching the tug of war with a tight gaze, Francia poked me from the side.

“Sister, Sister.”

Francia was suddenly holding something like a cookie in her hand. It was brought in by the attendant when we entered the room.

“Oh my God, it’s true. Right? The young people these days are unbelievable.”

“..... Why are you talking like that?”

“No. That’s what it is. Men are high and low. Obedient. Submissive! Isn’t it?”

“I understand the first one, but what’s with the latter two?”

Maybe it’s because the cookies in Francia’s hand are white. It looked like popcorn at first glance. Francia grinned as she held the popcorn, no, white cookie. Francia’s arm pressed tight against my side.

“No. Therefore. Is it really necessary to have only one?”

“What?”

“Just take both.”

I forgot the two men facing each other and blinked.

“What do you mean?”

“Literally so! After all, the roses have no choice but to argue over Sister.”

Crunch. She put the white cookie to her mouth and bit it cheerfully. In the White Rose’s white hand, the white cookie crumbled into small pieces.

“Worship or reverence. Respect or love and..... Jealousy or obsession. It all entails a desire to like and possess the other.”

The two men seemed to at least be going to take out their swords, so I didn’t take my attention off them and I asked if they were looking beyond desire.

“Yes. Desire. Is there anything wrong with desire? They want to be by your side with such a pure heart. Then, if it got tainted, it will become an obsession.”

It was a problem to impose this desire on the other person, but there was nothing wrong with the desire itself. I looked away slowly. She was smiling and speaking calmly, she certainly looked mature.

“Sister, do you know what happened back in the days when the Blue Rose was intact?”

“What happened?”

Of course I didn’t know.

“The ‘Rose Festival’. A great war waged by the ancient powers took place.”

She explained briefly. It’s held at the request of all roses, and it’s kind of like a territorial battle to find the Blue Rose within a set time. I frowned. It

was a weird way.

“What is that? It’s not even hunting.”

“No. It’s more like a treasure hunt than usual hunting. And you have to be chosen by the treasure. It’s tricky. How dare they hurt the blue rose... it’s not that kind of hunting.”

Francia laughed softly. There was still a white cookie in her hand.

“After many roses have died, the thought ‘I’d rather have them all’ came to life.”

Waving her hands as she ate the cookies, she pointed to the now silent two men.

“Because this is better than war. And.....”

“And?”

“If the Blue Rose gets hurt in this kind of competition, they get eliminated.”

Francia’s smile gradually faded.

“I’m afraid that they’ll even lose their breath, such a waste.”

Swish, she put her hand on her neck and slashed it. It was a pleasant expression, but what was in her eyes was not at all.

“Even if you want to have them all. The Grand Duke won’t be able to say anything.”

She smiled brightly and brought her finger to me.

“And have me too, sister.”

In her words, as if joking, I could feel the intention to ease my feelings. I also smiled. I paused smiling, and tilted my head.

“But aren’t there four roses?”

After I said that, I thought of the Empress, except for that one. There was one more.

The Black Rose.

Having everything, Chaser would also be included, right?

“Should I have them all indeed?”

Chapter 193: The fastest and most dangerous way

1. 1. 1. 1. The fastest and most dangerous way

At the same time, Francia and the two men also turned to me. They looked surprised, as if they had promised.

“Sister, you can’t. What do you mean!”

It seems that the word ‘You can’t do that!’ was stuck in her eyes. Ricdorian also had a similar appearance. Even Lenag.

“Repeat after me, Sister. No.”

“Huh?”

..... Isn’t that what I taught you when you were young?

“You can’t.”

“No, Iana.”

“That’s right! I can’t tolerate it. No. For Sister’s safety, you can’t!”

And at Francia’s continuous urging, I nodded bewildered. How awesome was this teamwork? I understand that they don’t want to hang out with Domulit anymore, but..... I scratched my cheek.

“I understand the meaning.....”

There was still a major story left to tell them. Everyone, I'm sorry to say this while you're excited.

"You will have no choice but to deal with Domulit at least once."

Francia rolled her eyes.

"Why, why?"

"Well, the tiara that Her Majesty the Empress was talking about."

After that, I exhaled.

"Because it's in the basement of Domulit's mansion."

Why did I remember this? This was one of those days when Chaser gathered the best things in the world for me and showed them before my eyes.

<I said I would give you the world.>

When I saw it at that time, I didn't have many feelings. Because, even if that was the main part of the story, I didn't think it had anything to do with me. Of course, there was a time when I didn't know Chaser was going to bring Francia, and then I didn't even know how I would turn the original story upside down by letting her run away. Like I said, it happened before Francia came.

What's more, I couldn't remember this even after making Francia run away, because I thought that even if I had changed the content, it wouldn't have anything to do with that.

That's right, I didn't know at the time that I'd need it, and I didn't know that the Empress would ask me to come to her!

<Everything is yours.>

..... So, in a word, the Empress' tiara in Domulit's mansion is mine.

“... huh.”

The faces of the three people who learned all the circumstances were similar.

Ricdorian had a firm expression on his face, and Francia was no different. No, an expression close to hatred passed by Francia's face. Although he was sharp, Lenag was the most normal among them.

“I have to plant people.”

Surprisingly, the first person to speak up was Lenag, surprisingly. His heavy, subdued gaze turned to me.

“Miss Iana, if you feel responsible in this matter, I will cooperate with the Grand Duke until his lifespan is restored.”

I paused for a moment and then continued.

“I think you'd better stop getting involved with Domulit. However, if you are forced to get involved, I hope that it will be resolved as quickly and safely as possible. May I help?”

I asked as if it was a suggestion, but it seemed that he had made up his mind. Lenag seemed to believe that when this was over, I would no longer be associated with Domulit.

He was holding hands with Chaser, but he didn't really like Chaser that much, and I already knew that it was because of 'Iana'.

“Please don't feel uncomfortable.”

“... Of course.”

“Because I swore I would do anything for you.”

I nodded slowly.

“Of course, it is not an inconvenience. But I feel uncomfortable because I feel like I am being taken care of every time.”

If Lenag cooperated, I would be grateful. Ricdorian may not like it, but..... Even if he accepted this, the first thing to do was to return the lifespan to its original state.

Even at this moment, time was passing.

Lenag was eager to say more. But then nothing, he shook his head.

“... Good. It may sound weird but! Let’s do it somehow.”

Thus, a union was born between the three roses except for Chaser, no, not even the Empress was formed. Although I don’t know it well, it was by no means a formidable alliance in terms of appearance and power.

“This must be the first time in history.”

That night. Francia said as she lay on the bed. She turned towards me with her arms wide open lying on the huge bed. There were no signs of the elegant and straight saint of the day.

When Lenag was there, it seemed like she was trying her best to show her mature appearance. When it’s just me and the two of us, she quickly returns to the way she was a few years ago.

‘Her sleeping habits were probably bad back then, maybe.’

I remember that Chaser secretly punished her several times while she was trying to stick together. Even when I tried to question him, he did not leave a clue at all, leaving only suspicion. Francia must have remembered everything.

Seeing this, I wondered if the roses of the present age have no choice but to get along with each other.

‘No. But how did the love triangle come about in the original story?’

The more I looked at it, the more Francia and Ricdorian’s personalities did not match well. In the book I read, Francia appeared as a beautiful and kind girl, so that actually made me wonder.

“Looking back on history, there is hardly any precedent for roses to cooperate with each other.”

I tilted my head.

“Is it that bad?”

It’s strange to hear that. Even if they were roses, they were a rose and a family. For a long time, wasn’t there a time when the families cooperated or did not bump into each other once? Having said this, Francia shook her head.

“Sister, the roses have been competing with each other since the beginning. That is, to be the Blue Rose’s favorite.”

Francia’s finger poked against my forearm.

“I said you were our king.”

She laughed bashfully. She then said, ‘Like how I took a spot next to Sister today.’ I smiled as I recalled the situation a while ago. The situation a while ago when Ricdorian and Lenag were arguing over me.

To be precise, it was a fight of who would be guarding in front of my room.

<Everyone get out.>

It lasted about two hours, so I ended up kicking them both out. It was the best for me.

Whether it’s Ricdorian who has a history of staying up all night while guarding my door, or Lenag who just ran to the Imperial Palace.

Either way, I wanted them to go back to their room without staying up all night.

“It has been a long time since you disappeared. Our thirst is getting worse, and in this state, we would only see blood when we bump into each other, so we tried to avoid it.”

After Francia said that, she buried her head in my forearm.

“So this was normal for us. There was no rose festival.”

“How is that festival held?”

“The roses go to the imperial palace to ask for a wish.”

“..... Was it to get permission from the imperial family?”

“No. There is a wishing place there.”

Francia said that there is a place in the Imperial Palace that honors the power of roses, the origin of the ancient power.

“If all the roses agree to the festival, then the heavens will be opened.”

“Yes. And?”

“And. It is war.”

A festival. This could mean a ritual or festival, but in reality it was not easy to imagine that it was actually a war. Hearing this reminded me of the war in history where the Trojan Horse appeared. Wasn't that war caused by just one person, the most beautiful woman? Anyway, I just thought it would be better not to happen.

“..... How is it that I am treated like the most beautiful woman in the world?”

“Beautiful woman?”

Helen, the protagonist of the Trojan War, was said to be beautiful enough to lead the world to war. Well, wasn't that called a beauty who tilts the castle?

"No way. How could you compare yourself to that?"

"That's right."

Because I wasn't 'a beauty who tilts the castle'. As I nodded in that sense, Francia laughed.

"Sister is the best even if you look back on history."

"..... my beauty?"

"Yes."

"That's a bit silly....."

"No!"

Francia jumped up and her eyes twinkled. Her eyes of different colors revealed a dazzling light with different colors.

"As long as you are the prettiest in my eyes! Sister is the prettiest."

Thank you for liking me so much..... I tilted my head indifferently. I pondered what else to say, and then I smiled and patted Francia's head.

"Yes. Thank you."

The night with Francia, who occupied the spot next to me like a fish in troubled water, came to an end.

Since then, several days have passed.

In the capital, there were many mansions owned by nobles as there were many people who lived in the estates' land as well. Ricdorian and Lenag

also owned a mansion in the capital, and even Francia had a branch of the temple in the capital. When asked where I wanted to go, I chose Ricdorian's mansion, and although the other two did not like it, they quickly agreed.

For some reason, I felt like I was carrying a dog that was cute and listened to me at every moment, but was very ferocious to others.

There were three ferocious dogs that would bite if they were not satisfied.

‘Gang of dogs.’

– Gang? What is a gang, human?

‘That. Gangster-like kids.’

I stroked Pudding's hair and lifted my head.

I was in the conference room. To be precise, it used to be the office used by Ricdorian, but now it has become a conference room. On the sofa, three roses each sat or leaned their backs, and a beast stood next to each other. Ironically, when I took out Pudding, as if everyone was waiting, they took out their guardian deity too.

It was as if they wanted me to see it.

“It failed?”

It was Francia who spoke up. Next to her in a white robe, the guardian deity Callisto in the shape of a small bear was licking its front paws eagerly. There was a small honey bucket in front of the guardian deity. I gave it as a gift.

“Yes.”

Ricdorian nodded. He picked up the rolled up parchment from the desk and threw it at the two of them each. Lenag, who lightly grabbed one of them, wrinkled his brow slightly and unfolded the parchment. A small snake rested its head on his thigh, and it slept soundly. It was Azul, Lenag's guardian deity.

I didn't have to take or open the parchment. Because it was already in my hands and it was something I knew beforehand.

"It looks like it failed again."

"Yes."

The spy who infiltrated Domulit died. It was already the seventh death. I grabbed the parchment stiffly.

Even if it's the death of someone I don't know at all, no matter who you are, you don't get used to death. Moreover, I expected from the beginning that it would not be easy to infiltrate. And this would have been expected by Ricdorian and the others as well.

The Empress' tiara is in the basement of the Domulit.

A warehouse in the basement to be exact. I didn't think I could get in there from the beginning, but we started by letting people in to find out about the current situation.

"It was expected, but..... The boundaries are getting stronger. But I didn't expect it would be blocked from entering."

Far from entering, they took a detour, but Chaser was utterly rejecting outside contacts, such as those delivering groceries. Even attempts to get him out were thwarted. Ricdorian dismissed it in one word.

"It used to be that kind of place. However, it has only become more and more ferocious."

Ricdorian's expression didn't look good when he said that.

In fact, with the human resources of the three roses, they would have been able to do most things. The problem, however, was that infiltrating the Domulit mansion wasn't the 'most' thing. I asked a question that I had been procrastinating all along.

'Pudding.'

– Yes?

‘Ricdorian’s time-limit, no, lifespan, how much time do we have left?’

Pudding separated with Ricdorian and signed a contract with me, but was originally part of him. The frowning Pudding said in a low voice.

– Very little, nyang.

‘Tell me.’

It was already expected. So I didn’t ask them. Because I knew it was urgent even if I didn’t have to listen. After finally hearing the date from Pudding, I came to a conclusion.

“Will everyone listen to me?”

There was only one way. There was only one way from the beginning. It was the fastest and most dangerous way.

“I will go.”

Chaser listens to only one person in the world. He blindly trusted and obeyed the person’s command.

The one whom he cherished as if he would give her everything in the world.

<My Iana.>

..... That it was me, I knew best than anyone.

Chapter 194: Everything as you wish

1. 1. Everything as you wish

Everyone's faces turned serious at my words. It deserved it, so it wasn't unexpected.

"Sister!"

"Iana, you don't have to go."

Ricdorian stopped Francia and was the first to announce his intentions. Then the rest of them lined up and said,

"Sister, you can't. You knew what the danger was!"

"Yes. I don't think Miss Iana needs to go back."

In particular, Francia desperately shook her head. It's like a face crying out against a marriage. I looked at Ricdorian and Lenag alternately.

"How about calling out the Black Rose instead? Someone, invite him!"

Both are high-ranking nobles. So, they want to create a position where he has no choice but to go.

"First of all, it's difficult for me. My title is lower than that person's."

It was Lenag who answered.

"And the Grand Duke is almost equal in titles, but....."

“Sworn enemies.”

Ricdorian continued.

“It’s strange to invite him and even more strange to respond. I think everyone here knows that. Unless you’re going to let the world know.”

Even Ricdorian who said that was not very comfortable.

Surely there was a way to summon Chaser out, but even if they did, they don’t know what he might have done to the Domulit mansion, and they do not know the geography of Domulit.

‘Besides, he won’t even accept the invitation.’

For me to enter the Domulit mansion and knock out Chaser or do whatever it takes to neutralize him and bring him back would be the quickest. I hesitated and spoke slowly.

“Is there any way to stun the Black Rose?”

“Stun.....?”

“Yes.”

We’ve already covered most of the ways we can do it. They must have known that trying more here would be a waste of human resources.

Above all else, I know the most important fact.

“..... He will be defenseless to me.”

The moment I said these words, the eyes of the three gathered together. It was a gaze that was a little more serious or tenacious than the first time. And Lenag nodded slowly.

“Certainly it is.”

Someone who knew Chaser like me agreed. But his expression was still skeptical.

“But I don’t think that’s a reason for Miss Iana to go there.”

He asked me to reconsider my words, but at the same time I resolutely refused.

“Iana, I can do anything you ask, but..... That’s not possible. Can’t you think again?”

At Ricdorian’s cautious remark, Francia quickly nodded and agreed, saying, ‘*Yes, that’s right!*’ I’m sorry to them, but actually I expected this far. This backlash.

I was surprised that their reaction was stronger and more determined than expected, but on the other hand, I was grateful. Because that’s how much they thought of me.

However, that made me even more determined.

“So, is there a better solution than this?”

If yes, I will step back. The three were silent. Knowing that it was an uncomfortable silence, but they wouldn’t be able to make a point.

I was also not trying to go blindly. At least in order to solve the problem of Ricdorian’s time-limit, I have to go with him to Kambrakam. I didn’t forget this.

“Don’t worry. It’s not that I don’t want to come back like this.”

And lastly, don’t they know now? That everything Chaser did to me was wrong. My thoughts on life there gradually changed and were reevaluated.

“I’ll tell you in advance.”

I slowly raised my head.

They see me as a rose in a glass dome. It was not wrong. But that's not the right thing to say either.

At least, I'm not incompetent enough to be a nuisance with what I'm trying to do.

"I will come back."

I stared at Lenag, looked at Francia, and finally towards Ricdorian.

"Find a way to stun Chaser."

The roses have the same power and ability as Chaser. There will be a way if they look for it. Because I know where the tiara is.

"I'm confident I'll come back with the tiara."

The magic that protects the warehouse will not threaten me.

"When you go back, you won't be able to run far alone."

Chaser's men were sensitive. They were agile, resembling its owner's temperament. If they notice Chaser's strangeness sooner than expected, it will be difficult to escape. But when I come back, I won't have to move alone. I slowly put my hand on my chest.

"So. After I get out, do your best to take me with you."

Looking at Ricdorian, I said clearly.

"So that I can return to you."

The blue eyes that looked at me flickered for an instant. I bent my eyes.

"Please, will you do that for me?"

"....."

"Find what I want to do. You told me that."

At those words, Ricdorian's face gradually darkened. He wiped his face slightly and turned his head away. Covering his lips with the back of his hand.

"..... that's selfish."

"Yes, I am selfish."

I smiled.

"As you saw in prison. I'm selfish."

I moved my gaze mischievously.

"Will you do it?"

This time it was Lenag's turn. Then I told Francia. The two each made a troubled expression or looked sad, but in the end they nodded. As if it was force majeure.

"How can I defeat you?"

Finally, with a bitter smile, Lenag placed a hand on his chest and tilted his head respectfully.

"Everything as you wish."

Once the gist of the operation had been established, the rest of the planning was accomplished quickly. There were two key elements of this operation. One was that I was going myself, and the other was.....

"What is this?"

"It's poison!"

It was poison.

“If you are talking about this poison. It boasts the power to stun 300 elephants.”

“Hmm.”

“When using it, use it on the wrist or neck. Anywhere you can see blood vessels is fine.”

To put Chaser to sleep or to stun him. Surprisingly, Jaire was the one in charge of finding this method. As I quietly listened to the explanation, I rolled my eyes.

“..... Can I use it on people?”

“Yes? Of course, the average person dies.”

Jaire wrinkled his forehead. It was the expression of asking what I was talking about.

“I mean to use it on people?”

“The rose is not an ordinary person.”

Jaire is an archmage. At the same time, he was skilled in several methods. That’s why he was also able to create the ‘Stun Poison’.

“Miss, a rose has a body several times that of a human.”

Physical strength, I muttered without realizing it, and then tilted my head.

‘Why am I not like that?’

Wasn’t Ricdorian the only one who has more physical strength?

“Of course, His Excellency, among roses, had a particularly outstanding body. The ability itself is a matter of the body.”

So even this poison wouldn’t work for Ricdorian, but Chaser was different. The Black Rose has the mental-type ability. Therefore, he was relatively

vulnerable to physical attacks. It was written in old records.

“This is also a record written because the Red Rose and the Black Rose did not get along for a long time. Anyway, isn’t it just the information we need?”

Jaire shrugged his shoulders.

“You should catch the line.”

This was correct. I nodded my head in agreement. Then I looked down at the poison in my hand. It was a small syringe.

“You just stick it in.”

Jaire explained. He said that even I, without physical strength, could use it.

A syringe.

Will I be able to put this into the man?

A few days passed again. The preparations were made quickly, and it was perfect to just leave tomorrow. The preparation took a few days longer than expected because they took turns giving me warnings or absurd self-defense techniques—of course. So, when I returned to my room after the last inspection, it was already late in the evening.

When I reached the front door alone, I stopped when I saw the person standing in front of the door.

“Ricdorian?”

His upper body was upright rather than leaning on his back. He looked at me as if he knew I was walking. It was a bit dark, but it shouldn’t have been a problem for him to see me.

“What’s going on?”

I was already with him today too. Because he didn't want to leave me for a moment. I looked closely and realized one thing. No, it would be correct to assume that he was expecting me.

“Are you trying to stay up all night in front of my room?”

He already has a history of doing that. Lenag also had a hard time trying to stop Ricdorian. But Ricdorian slowly shook his head.

“No. That's not it.”

Somehow, he had a subtly hardened face. It was like looking into my eyes.

Why?

“..... Iana.”

The beautiful red lips opened slowly. A tense tone rang out.

“Tonight.....”

He took a breath

“I want to engrave a rose on you.”

I flinched.

A rose?

..... That thing?

Thousands of thoughts ran through my mind in an instant. It was almost like a storm.

After the silence, I raised my eyes. It was after my look of embarrassment disappeared. Instead of answering, I opened the door.

“Hmm, are you ready?”

“..... ready?”

“Yes. You never know who will be more difficult.”

I turned my head while holding the doorknob. Then I calmly said a word, and immediately his face heated up. Seeing that, I raised my lips.

“Come in.”

Chapter 195.1: I want to engrave (Part 1)

1. 1. I want to engrave (Part 1)

The room was dark with no lights on. It thought of it like the head of an open-mouthed beast.

‘It’s impossible to know which one is the beast.’

Without turning on the light, I trudged over and headed straight to bed. Ricdorian’s footsteps stopped. When I turned around, he couldn’t get any closer to me and stopped.

“Are, are you going straight to bed?”

What kind of shy line is this? I tilted my head gently. He seduced me... Looking at him from a distance, I smiled softly.

“Then not in bed, where are you going to do it?”

Having said that, I looked around the room slowly. The bed was far, but the sofa was closer.

“Won’t the sofa hurt your body?”

“..... What?”

The blue moonlight was illuminating the room. Therefore, even I with a poor body could see very well. I mean, I could see the red face that was about to burn very well. Especially when I looked at his ears, they were so

red that there was no white spot. However, I did not stop there and turned my gaze to one place.

What caught my eye was the balcony.

“..... So, maybe outdoors.....”

“No, no!”

Ricdorian raised his head in amazement. It's a face that he didn't even think about. It was really different from the face he showed during the day. When he was with Lenag or Francia, he had a cool face that seemed to have collected all the frosts of the world, and when he was with Jaire, it was the face of a capable Grand Duke.

I couldn't stand it and laughed out loud.

“Yes, you are a bit like that from the start.”

All of a sudden, a comfortable tone came out of me as if in prison.

“We don't have to be hard on each other.”

It's fine if you take care of me. I sat with my back on the bed. I bent my knees and raised my arms up to my chin. Then I grinned.

He hadn't moved a single step.

“Where do you want to engrave?”

“..... where?”

“Yes.”

Chaser engraved it on the inside of my wrist. At that time, I didn't think about it, but can the rose directly determine the engraving point? Or was it specified?

“Is that something you can decide?”

Ricdorian removed his hand from his face. When I beckoned, he faltered. However, there was still some distance from the bed.

“..... You can decide.”

“How?”

“That..... I mean. That.”

He hesitated, unable to speak. Should he leave it in the middle of the action?

“Why, do you have to engrave during the middle?”

Looking back at his bright face, I knew that I had said the right answer. I whistled inside. Along with the admiration for this conversation that takes place without an object.

“I see. So what did you think?”

When I asked one more time, Ricdorian was at a loss for what to do. As if he didn't know I would ask this.

“Hey, you don't want to talk? Shall I not ask?”

“..... That's not it.....”

“Really?”

His white face, dyed in the moonlight, was red with no white parts. I didn't hate the look of the troubled eyes rolling around. My finger tapped the bed linen.

He tilted his head. His hair wiggled gently. The glowing eyes appeared and then disappeared. I felt like a bad person who made fun of innocent people just looking at him like that. This was also a problem because I didn't hate it.

“If not, let's stop.....”

“There is!”

Ricdorian raised his voice slightly. It was a bewildered look. Hmmm, I meant to stop and just come here to my side.

“I, I don’t want to stop.”

He shook his head as if he misunderstood. Then he walked closer. Now, the distance was less than three steps. At the same time as I was nervous, I felt a strange feeling.

‘A different personality usually appears around this time.’

Today, with his red face that stayed for a long time, I thought his rational state would last long. If I didn’t like it, he wouldn’t.

Even in prison long ago, I liked him.

The version that became a dog, the version that lost reason and left only instinct, each was cute and fatal..... It’s because I thought that this side of him was the perfect figure of him.

He held out his hand.

“..... st.”

“Yes?”

I was lost in thought for a moment and couldn’t hear. His fingers curl up for a moment and then spread out.

“Wrist.”

He no longer trembled. And he didn’t even stutter. My gaze slowly rose. The neatly exposed neck and sculpturally beautiful face was drawn into my gaze.

I stretched out my hand. This was my answer.

“Engrave it.”

It was too far just from reaching out my hand. He realized it and took one more step. As if he needed courage, he exhaled a little. His trembling fingertips grabbed me. The temperature was as hot as boiling. It felt like his warmth was beating at my heart.

Why did he always shake me up at this temperature like another season? The question that filled my heart all the time filled my mind.

“Why are you trembling when you kissed me already?”

“..... Because it’s different. All of them totally require your consent.”

He spoke calmly. No, it sounded like he was trying to calm down.

“This..... Especially because I need more.”

He took two more steps as he saw me waving my hand. His fingertips touched tightly. He bowed his body.

“But why the wrist?”

He gently wiped the arm. As if licking the raised muscles one by one on the rolled up shirt. The hand holding my wrist was strong. But it was a look that didn’t know what to do. He had a cautious face, fearing that I would break if held.

‘You don’t have to hold me like this.’

Ricdorian exhaled. It was hot.

“..... Because that’s where that man carved it.”

Ricdorian’s gaze scanned the inside of my wrist. Is it because of the densely submerged atmosphere, or something caught my eye? All of his careful actions felt rather bizarre, and it felt like my hair stood on end.

“The Black Rose?”

“Yes. does it hurt?”

“No.”

Because your expression was provocative. Instead of pointing out his red face, I shook my head.

“..... They say it cannot be erased.”

I already knew. However, the reply came back about the rose tattoo that cannot be erased once it was engraved.

“So, you want to overwrite it.”

“Can I engrave it, Iana?”

A shrill breath escaped from the gaze with the reverent question. He looked like he was holding back something. I wondered if he was holding on to his personality change.

Regardless of whether it was tolerable or not, I had a strong feeling that it would be. It was such a desperate expression. What he said next made it clear that I wasn't wrong.

“..... Even these things, it's instinctive. I can't leave it to you.”

“Ricdoran.”

I grabbed his hand with my other hand and pulled him. It looked like he had a high fever, so it was something I did without realizing it. He was meekly drawn to me. He got up and buried his face in my shoulder. He gasped heavily. He seemed unable to control his body by forcibly pressing the change. It looked hard.

“I, haa, Iana. I'm always sorry for you.....”

“What are you sorry for?”

“I think I received too much. Huu, I don't think I gave you anything.”

I've never felt that way before, but he was feeling indebted to me. He lowered his head further and rubbed his face. It seemed like an act of trying to calm himself. Unintentionally, he rubbed between the ruffled hem of my clothes, and had buried his face in my chest. I felt a warm breath in my chest, but he didn't seem to feel it yet. I pretended not to know the heat that was clumping in my stomach.

"..... I guess because of my stubbornness, you were forced to accept it."

"... Why do you think so?"

Then, instead of resisting the strange desire that climbed on my toes, I swept his head. His soft hair was slightly damp with sweat.

"Look at me."

He raised his wet gaze.

"Am I the one who will force myself to do something?"

My life was not a life of forcing myself to do things I didn't like, even though I surrendered my body like flowing water.

Of course, this was not to say that I didn't compromise or give up early.

"I don't. And I don't want to do that anymore."

My fingers ran around his cheek and touched his lips. As soon as I touched it, his lips parted openly. I tapped his teeth. Then he smiled slightly. In the gradually increasing atmosphere, there was no longer a situation to take care of or play jokes.

"I wasn't drawn to it for a long time. In fact, I already have a red rose engraved on my body."

At that, he flinched. His eyes seemed to be moving.

"..... where? Why?"

“Did you forget? I have a red rose guardian deity.”

Ricdorian seemed to have noticed the situation with his clear brain. He bit his lip.

“Where is it?”

I hesitated for a moment, but then answered.

“Thigh. It’s on the inside of my thigh.”

“My guardian deity is there.”

“That’s right.”

“..... Can I see it?”

“Yes, of course..... What?”

Chapter 195.2: I want to engrave (Part 2)

132. I want to engrave (Part 2)

Ricdorian raised his head from my chest. I must have fallen for him this way..... After the panting subsided, my posture was strange. Just because his expression changed, the vague and sullen atmosphere changed in an instant to heighten the tension.

“No.”

I shook my head inside. Tomorrow is the operation day. It will be a big deal before the operation day..... I didn't have enough stamina. I admitted frankly. Damn it. It's like ignoring the table that was laid out in front of you! I wiped my face once. It was to pull myself together.

Still, I couldn't take my hand off his shirt. It was a lust created by desire. I didn't even know that I, who was usually indifferent, would have such a desire. These were all miracles created by the man in front of me. To be precise, this superb view took my breath away.

“..... No?”

I didn't want to see him tilting his head. No. The moment he does that, the eroticness rises. Ricdorian's expression gradually changed. The expression he had been holding back was gone.

“Ha, then.....”

Ricdorian gently rubbed my lips with a hand that didn't hold my wrist. He tilted his head to the side and gently rolled his eyes.

His personality had changed.

“What should i do?”

He looked down at me and didn't smile as if he knew something. It was a determined smile that seemed to attract people. One of his hands slowly unbuttoned his button. The moment I saw his chest muscles protruding through my white shirt, I took a deep breath. It was because I saw that my eyes were flowing down and there was a protruding clearly on the side of his thigh. I couldn't not know. He didn't even try to hide his lower body.

“Can I touch your clothes?”

Seeing him dripping with eccentricity and smiling mischievously, I wanted to shout out to him, *lie down here as soon as possible*.

At the same time, *I should not be fooled by the dangerous beastly atmosphere*.

‘..... Somehow, if I say no here, I feel like he's going to lift out the blanket right now.’

I held back my smile and leaned back slightly.

“It's a bit..... No, sure.”

“No?”

“Do it.”

Then, at the sudden permission of my capriciousness, a surprised face flashed across Ricdorian. But he didn't hold it up.

“Which one?”

“..... Right side.”

Ricdorian's large hand grabbed my thigh. While the hand holding it tight was unfamiliar, my spine straightened out naturally. Ricdorian slowly

lowered his head. I thought he was going to lift my thighs right away, but he grabbed me from the top of my feet and let out a slow breath. Like kissing with his breath.

“Ricdorian?”

Unknowingly, I tilted my head to the warm body temperature through the thin clothes. My neck was trembling. To the extent that I have the urge to throw him away like this.

“Why, inside your thighs?”

He buried his lips somewhere on the inside of my thigh. There seemed to be some dissatisfaction in his voice. Can he see it right now? I slowly opened my mouth.

“..... That’s so I didn’t get caught while living with my brother.”

If Chaser had known, it was impossible to know in which direction it would have flowed. His reaction was better. A number of complexities passed through his raised eyes with his lips buried.

“Don’t call him, brother.”

“..... So, Chaser?”

Are you telling me to call his name? I blinked as I gave him my leg. Don’t call him? Ricdorian quickly raised his upper body. It was as if I was immediately trapped in his body.

“Don’t even call him.”

Ricdorian shook his head and headed towards my neck. He bit it like taking a bite, but only moistened it. It didn’t tickle me anymore, but stimulated me intimately. The bed linen was crumpled.

“..... The traces.....”

“I’m not leaving any.”

Kiss. A kiss continued on my neck. His hand clasping my waist slowly rises upwards. I didn't stop him. Instead, I took his hand and naturally placed it on my chest. He looked startled for a moment, then rolled his eyes and smiled mischievously.

"I won't break anything our Iana says. It's a good rose. Can't you not call that guy at all?"

A playful tone rang in my ears, but there was no time for concern. His hand gently rubbed my chest. It wasn't a skillful touch, but a warm breath burst out of my mouth in a near-raw movement.

"Lovely Iana."

Kiss.

"Uh?"

Kiss.

..... driving me crazy. Really.

Eventually, he stopped kissing my body when I raised the white flag. Suddenly, the ribbon on my chest loosened, revealing my upper chest. Saliva pooled in the damp marks on my chest. I grabbed my neck and exhaled. Ricdorian looked at me with a half-red face and grabbed my hand slightly. Then he rubbed his cheek against my palm. I could feel the bulging and inflated bulkiness of his thighs that were in contact with me. It was a presence that was difficult to pretend not to know. He ripped off all my buttons.

Then he took my hand and slowly lowered it onto his thigh.

As if asking for a compliment.

What does he want me to compliment? The answer was not difficult. A heavy feeling in the hand. He gently rubbed my hands that he held together. *Ha*, a breath flowed from him. I licked my lips and moved my hand directly.

“Huu, Ia...na.....”

The friction that comes into contact with the clothes increases. My breathing was also getting faster. The reddened face, the bright corners of the eyes, the dizzying gaze, and the mouth that licks the fingers of my other hand with his tongue. I was out of breath. I felt the volume above my thighs getting bigger and the fabric was slightly damp.

“Haa.....”

Ricdorian grabbed my other hand and kissed the inside of my wrist long. The moment I thought it was all that, a tingling sensation penetrated my wrist.

I opened my eyes wide.

The spot where he had pulled off his lips was left with a slightly reddish mark. It was a blemish that would soon disappear, but he seemed satisfied. Ricdorian's eyes widened neatly.

“In this way, even if the Black Rose's appears, it will look red, right?”

But while holding me with a gaze as if he had done well. I laughed.

“Can I kiss you?”

“Yes. You don't have to ask for permission.”

Chapter 196: Oh my God, a beast?

133. Oh my God, a beast?

As soon as my words flew, his lips swept over me. His lips were cautious, but it didn't take a few seconds for it to turn into a ferocious one. I wrapped my arms around his neck and patted him as if it were okay. As if holding the reins, while gently brushing the back of his head.

Drop. His shirt fell to the floor. Naked, he took off the blanket that was covering me and threw it away.

I exhaled a light breath.

When I opened my eyes, eyes filled with longing were staring at me with a burning heat. I rolled my eyes slightly and he slammed at me. It was right to say that he covered me with his body because he was so big.

I laid still on the bed and looked up at Ricdorian. He closed his eyes and focused only on my lips. The trembling silver eyelashes gave off a neat yet breathtaking look. How about the reddened cheeks or under the eyes?

As I tried to stand still, the cord of my reason seemed to be burning and was about to break. I had to calm down, but my mind soon became cloudy. To be exact, my vision became blurry.

I felt like I saw him unbutton his trousers in the midst of my blurry vision. I couldn't stop him.

“Huk, uh..... Ricdor, uuhhh.”

I didn't think he did that much. Ricdorian knew exactly where I felt and rubbed it.

What's more, he pushed me, giving me the least amount of time to breathe. In a way, he was clumsy like a teenage boy kissing for the first time, but somehow controlling his pace made him feel like an expert. Thanks to that, it was hard to keep up with just kissing each other.

He will eat me. He would eat me up.

I barely opened my eyes. Ricdorian moved his hands busily, without taking his mouth off my lips. I was only wearing thin one-piece underwear. The ribbon tied to the side is untied one by one. There are 6 attached, but 3 of them are loose.

Unlike in the past case, the clothes I currently wore maintained a close balance. In other words, when all the ribbons were untied, the clothes would fall off.

Whip.

2 ribbons left.

Ricdorian abruptly stopped unraveling the ribbon and touched my chest over the thin cloth. Then, he touched the risen peak.

“Uhng, Ric, huh. Ah!”

Somehow, it seems that the Grand Duke's reason has not returned. No, I don't think it'll ever come back. My skirt was rolled up to my knees as I was lying on the bed and moved around with the kisses. Even the blanket to cover my body had already fallen to the floor for a long time.

Ricdorian's hand patted my knee and brushed the side of my thigh. A creepy goosebumps swelled up. It was also because of the cold air, and also..... the touch that passed by was very careful and gentle.

However, unlike the soft touch, his hand was that of a tough swordsman. His hand, holding the sword for a long time, was hard and rough, and when the calluses brushed against me, it provoked a strange stimulus.

Couldn't the calluses disappear with the power of the rose? I thought about it, but it went away soon. I also thought that maybe this was the product of Ricdorian's constant efforts that could not be helped even with the rose's power.

The sensation of tapping and hitting me with his thighs every time he moved was also very annoying. Because this feeling of bulkiness felt like it was going to eat me at any moment.

“.....”

How long will that increase the volume? Perhaps he felt my gaze, he smiled. It was a lazy laugh. Then he pulled it out of my pants. In the midst of excitement, I was caught up in ecstasy. *Tap, taptap*. Ricdorian grabbed me and shook it slightly. Unknowingly, we reached out and our hands overlapped.

“I'll be gentle, Iana.”

I didn't have time to worry about it exactly. It felt like he was only touching with a hand that could not be denser even though I kissed him densely. As if urging my hunger to rise.

Finally, the lips fell.

“Haa, haa.....”

But only one person was out of breath.

I narrowed my eyebrows and stared at Ricdorian. He twitched at my gaze. Then he slowly put his lower body on me. Still our hands were on his lower body, overlapping. A squeak, a blatant sound, and his sweet breath wet my ear.

“Iana.”

The moment a low but sweet voice like cotton candy called me, it was like biting candied fruit in my mouth.

“A little while ago, you said I shouldn’t look at the rose.”

Ricdorian lowered his head. The tip of his nose just hit me.

“My rose on your thigh. If I can’t see it, what about touching it?”

“Uh, yes?”

My voice did not come out properly because of his sweet breath. The hand holding him that was overlaid was already slippery.

“Can I touch it?”

Ricdorian’s fingers lightly touched my folded knee, then fell. The voice asking for permission was polite, clear, and sweet.

I felt a sense of disparity here. No, to kiss me a lot and then to ask politely and bluntly in a messed up state, on the contrary, it sounded like his reason being blown away with no way back.

Unsurprisingly, it was an obsessive gaze. His blue eyes seemed to glow with heat.

The problem was that I was no different. The heat seemed to soak up my brain.

I gently stroked his neck, then grabbed his hair with a snap. Then I pushed him away and raised my upper body. In that state, our exhalation overlaps. I smiled in front of the face that got closer.

“No?”

Come on, tomorrow is a big day. Let’s be patient.

One ribbon left. My clothes were barely holding up. I slowly removed his hand from my thigh. But as soon as it was removed, Ricdorian’s strong arms wrapped around my waist. There was a gasp due to the strength of the movement. Our position changed.

“Ricdorian.”

“Yes.”

He smiled with an obedient look on his face as if he was happy. But his body was neither innocent nor obedient at all. I was momentarily perplexed by the sensation I felt between my thighs. I assessed the thickness with my hands a while ago. My wet hands were full of his traces. What if it even came into me?

The heat seemed to have engulfed the inside of my sizzling stomach. No, that's inevitable because of the size..... can it get in? What. *Whoo*. No. Good thoughts. Good thoughts. Don't bow your head, don't look..... It's better than not saying it, although it would be useful to have good thoughts now.

“Well, I want to go on foot safely tomorrow, right?”

“Yes. Iana.”

He replied innocently. However, it goes without saying that the enthusiasm in his voice was not at all innocent. His finger tapped the remaining ribbon. I grabbed his finger and pulled it down.

“Haa, I'll be honest.”

I put my hand on his cheek and gently wiped it away.

“It's not that I'm not attracted either.”

This was true.

How can I maintain my reason in the face of a man who I can't help but fall in love like this? Normally, I would have just closed my eyes and moved on. But there was something more that I desperately wanted than that. Wouldn't tomorrow be a bigger deal? It was about the coming and going of life!

I exhaled lowly.

“I mean, I am attracted. But there is something more important.”

I raised my head and made serious eye contact. With the playfulness removed.

“And more honestly.”

I must say this. I looked down to say this. And my eyes met his lower body. I nodded. Crazy. No wonder I couldn't grab it with my hands.

I was out of breath on my own.

“If that goes in and out, I wouldn't be able to walk. Can't walk.”

Yes. I really wouldn't be able to walk. I can't guarantee it. I was extremely serious.

It was a size that seemed unlikely. Even now, I was trying hard not to close my eyes after only seeing it once. Oh my God..... I heard he had a body like a beast. That must have been a double meaning!

“So I can't.”

Saying that, I thought that even Ricdorian would have noticed it enough.

The person who lost reason was more raw than usual and had a tendency to do things as he pleases, but he didn't do anything against my will. So, I thought he would have figured it out..... The hand that had fallen from my upper body caught hold of me. Ricdorian took my hand and pressed it to his cheek and lips. Then he slowly opened his eyes.

The hand that touched my round shoulder was dense. I did not hold the flowing hand. It was because it was very strange, but because it was a pleasant touch. He wiped my bare white chest. The soft skin touched by an unfamiliar hand, the senses seemed to welcome his hand.

He lowered his head and bit a handful of my chest. The act of soothing the peak made my legs tight.

“Huuhh, uh, ah!”

Lost in the air, he grabbed my wandering hand and clasped it. Ricdorian removed his lips off and went down and buried his lips on my chest. A large hand gripped the opposite chest carefully over the narrowly draped cloth and then released it. I flinched as the peak was brushed over the fabric.

Ricdorian, who went down leaving a moist trail, buried his head in my lower body. Now the clothes were covering only the stomach and chest to the extent that I wondered if they were even functioning. While not being able to stop him properly, Ricdorian was seated properly, and his forehead and neck were soaked with sweat in an instant. It felt as if I had unconsciously pushed Ricdorian’s shoulder and was restrained by his rigidity.

Ricdorian raised his head between my legs. Then he approached, wiping his shiny lips with the back of his hand. His hands crossed my fingers and grabbed it as he went down.

“Ri, haa..... Ricdorian.”

“Yes.”

The corners of his eyes were beautifully curved. His sweat-drenched hair was very erotic.

“No more.....”

“Yes.”

“Then, hmm?”

Ricdorian’s thing that had been caught in my hand and touched once again was very hard. Soft but hard like an iron core. Even holding it with both hands, the size remains. It looks like the bottom was getting wet.

I rolled my eyes in surprise. As if aware of my reaction, Ricdorian whispered a small whisper to me with a shy but joyful smile on his face.

“Iana, there are so many things you can do in this world without going in and out.”

..... What?

I blinked my eyes wide.

Wait, wait. How do you know that?

“Ricdorian?”

“Yes, Iana.”

Ricdorian’s eyes were red. He smiled mischievously with that face.

“Wa, huht, wait, uhhng.”

His lips poured out in my neck without mercy. I quickly took my hand and covered his lips with both hands. *Talk to me, this man!* I covered his mouth in that sense, but he grabbed my hand and kissed my palm softly. It wasn’t enough, he even rolled his eyes.

From his gaze, it drips languid temptation.

“As long as I don’t put it in, right?”

No, what interpretation, that’s a transcendental interpretation!

I quickly shook my head. It’s not that I don’t know, and I can’t fall for this kind of catchphrase....

“No.”

As soon as I raised my head, I stopped.

Ricdorian was weeping. Also with a very red face. Tears that I didn’t know when they were going to start to fall.

“Really.....”

“.....”

“..... No?”

Drip. I came to my senses at the falling tears.

“..... Really?”

..... I’m doomed.

He buried his head in my neck and rubbed his forehead. My heart sank. Falling from him, the tears that flowed down my collarbone flowed down the ribs of my chest. I wondered what kind of new bizarre stimulus it was.

“Please, Iana.”

Ricdorian’s voice was a little hoarse.

“I think I’m going crazy.....”

Drip. It’s not just tears that fell.....

No, it could be not only the sound of tears falling, but also the sound of the strings of reason falling. I realized it. I realized it was a problem!

I bit my lip.

This is a foul! I shouted to myself.

“Then, just the lips.”

“Just the lips? really?”

“.....”

But there was no more time to think, the red lips covered me eagerly.

The next morning.

At a time closer to late morning, a carriage secretly pulled out of the capital Hernim's mansion. It was more luxurious than a shabby carriage, but not too luxurious.

And in the carriage, I was leaning against the window, lost in my mind. Jaire, who was riding across from me, tilted his head.

“Miss?”

“Yes.”

“Are you feeling uncomfortable?”

He asked me as I was in a daze.

“No.....”

Jaire is an Archmage, who takes on the role of moving me out of the current capital and getting me to a certain point. And he would go back and move the rest of the crew.

As he played one of his most important roles, he had a slightly more tense expression than usual.

“Are you sick?”

“... It's okay, so go ahead.”

I shook my head. If I didn't answer, he felt like he was going to turn the carriage. Literally, my body was fine. No, I'm fine, but I'd say my energy was running low. To be precise, I have to say that I don't have enough energy.....

I looked at the distant mountain.

“Jaire, you are right.”

“Yes? What did I say.....”

Your Grand Duke is like a beast. It’s just..... Afterwards, I took a deep breath.

“Miss?”

“Nothing.”

I swallowed the words I couldn’t bear to say and turned my gaze away. Jaire just tilted his head.

“By the way, Ricdorian’s curse. After getting the Empress’ permission, we will be able to go into the prison side by side and I could use my power, right?”

If we successfully bring the Empress’ tiara, we will be able to enter Kambrakam as promised. And it was only recently that I felt it, but I seemed to have a vague understanding of how to use my power.

This started when Aquala disappeared, when a blue light leaked out of my hand without realizing it.

“Yes. that’s right.”

“Can I just go into Kambrakam?”

In order to relieve the tension on the things that will happen from now on, I deliberately brought out the distant future first.

**me reading this*: “am i in the right book?”*

Chapter 197: That Man's Trick (1)

1. 1. 1. 1. That Man's Trick (1)

“No. It would be unacceptable to go as the Grand Duke's troupe. Because it's going to be loud. We are going to create a suitable crime so as not to attract attention.”

At that, I tilted my head.

“It's a bit strange, can the Grand Duke commit a crime and enter Kambrakam?”

“There will be some damage to his reputation, but that's okay. With a light charge, everyone would think so.”

No matter how hard it looks, I don't have to worry as long as Hernim doesn't fall.

“Actually, if you look back at history, high-ranking nobles were sentenced to go there once. It's often used in a way of having distant relatives go instead of the Head of the family.”

“They hire an agent?”

“Like everything in the world, this is also the case. Power.”

For example, it is said that there are no clean people with money and power. Jaire, who had been talking up to this point, gave a perplexed expression for a moment.

“Excuse me. It wasn't something I could talk about in front of a lady.”

“It doesn’t matter.”

Maybe it meant that I went to Kambrakam for the sins of my brother and my father, but it didn’t matter. Because I didn’t go for real sins.

“I went to Kambrakam because it seems like I didn’t want to get involved in the fight between my father and my brother.”

“Are you guessing?”

“Wasn’t it right?”

As he was talking about this and that, Jaire stroked his chin. It was a face of less tension.

“Come to think of it, thinking of the basement in Kambrakam, an interesting fact has recently been discovered.”

“Interesting facts?”

“Yes. A space to enter with His Excellency.”

“It’s a place where you go to break the curse.”

“Yes. It was also the place where the Blue Rose could break all curses. At the same time..... They said it could move between dimensions.”

At that moment I stopped.

“Dimension? That’s sudden.”

“Yes, it’s a crazy topic for the average person, but it’s been an interesting topic for wizards for a long time.”

However, his lips were faithful to the conversation and continued to spit it out. Jaire said calmly as if he didn’t feel anything strange.

“Isn’t it interesting? I excluded it from the report because it has nothing to do with His Excellency.”

He grinned.

“Isn’t it fun to move between dimensions or someone comes by just memorizing ancient spells?”

He always said nonsense, but..... It was a story I could never overlook. After all, this world was not mine.

“It’s a story I want to study someday. If there is peace.”

It was true.

I woke up one day in the prison.

“I see.”

I kept my lips shut.

In fact, I didn’t pay any attention to how I woke up there. It wasn’t that I didn’t put an effort, but it was close to not having it. As soon as I opened my eyes, I was busy adapting.

Besides, after I got used to it, I thought it wouldn’t matter. It’s already happened, so to know why, I wouldn’t be able to go back anyway. That’s why I didn’t really care what kind of person Iana was or what family it was.

I was just thinking about living a good life in the future.

‘I think that was a mistake.’

Kambrakam, the Blue Rose, and me.

Could this really be irrelevant?

In order to do this kind of movement, a dimensional movement, in Kambrakam..... was said to require great power to execute this ancient spell. It’s not usually huge, but it requires a very, very, very large amount of power. It was said so in an ancient text.

“Jaire, if you want to use that spell.”

“Yes? Are you talking about dimensional movement? It seems that the Miss was also interested.”

“Yes. Let’s say that. Except for breaking Ricdorian’s magic. Is that spell only available for the Blue Roses?”

Jaire blinked and smiled, saying he didn’t expect to be asked such a question by the Miss.

“In conclusion, this may not have to be a blue rose.”

“Then.....”

“But, like I said, it requires tremendous power.”

“How much?”

“Even though a single rose has great power, it is not enough. It’s a strength that one person can never have enough.”

After Jaire finished his explanation, he was silent for a moment. He was looking out the window. A serious expression on his face was telling me. We were not far away from the destination.

“Not much time left.”

I nodded. But my thought was still stuck in the story he told me. Looking out the window, the forest was not clear. It sounds like we still have time to think.

‘Think.’

Let’s assume

What if I had come through a dimension shift? What if someone executed such a spell in Kambrakam? Then who is that person?

Tak, tak, tak, tak.

The wheel of the carriage spins wildly. The wheels in my head also turned violently. Finally, the wheels in my head coincided with where I was heading.

Let's dig a little deeper, let's assume.

'Iana's heart stopped.

If someone used a spell to save Iana. What if it was possible for that spell to summon another soul and awaken an empty body?

Even though it was full of logical leaps, for some reason I didn't seem to have chosen the wrong answer.

My sense was speaking.

The person who used that spell was 'Chaser'.

At the same time, the carriage stopped. I stopped all my thoughts and looked up.

"Then it's time to go, Miss."

There was a large magic circle where the door opened and I followed Jaire's guidance. It was probably a magic circle that would take me to a familiar place. I quietly headed towards the middle of the magic circle. It had already been discussed. Just as I stopped in the middle, a huge wind blew.

Jaire stood at the edge.

"Then I hope you take care of yourself."

"..... Jaire, too."

A blue light enveloped my body. The magic used by wizards is blue. It was a different light from the translucent color like the ocean emanating from the blue rose I had only seen once.

When I closed and opened my eyes, I saw a familiar mansion in front of me. It was the Domulit mansion.

I took a deep breath and started walking.

Back to the mansion.

The mansion standing tall in front of me was nothing different from before. Of course, how much time passed and whether there was any change, it was surprisingly the same.

I've only seen the appearance of this mansion twice.

When I entered this mansion after being released from Kambrakam, and when I got on the carriage to go to the Imperial Castle. Of course, there was that time when I sneaked to Schirmela, but I couldn't see the window because I was hiding, so let's make an exception.

Once again, I was struck by my situation.

I couldn't even take a single step outside. I laid down my eyes. A small laugh leaked out.

'It's not that I didn't know. I turned a blind eye to it.'

It was enough to ring the bell to enter the mansion that I came back to. Of course, I didn't really ring the bell, and it was enough to call a nearby knight and show my face.

I walked along with Chaser's elite men who had rushed out. The destination they were guiding was clear. I walked surrounded by them in a circle as if I was a prisoner, but looking at their faces, the word 'accomplishment' was never suited for me. I don't know if it's something an actor who suffers from extreme fans would know.

'It seems that the boundaries are getting stronger.'

Not that it wasn't, but the security in the mansion was strict. At the funeral of the former Duke Domulit, or when I wandered around with chains, it didn't seem like this..... A large door opened before my eyes, and I was finally reunited with the person I was looking for.

“..... What's going on?”

Chaser was lying on the sofa. He said without looking. Of course, there was a slight annoyance in that voice. Chaser's voice was irritated, so it felt quite fresh. Because he was the man who never had a negative voice in front of me.

And, the room I was guided to..... it was expected that it would be my room in a way.

I burst into laughter.

“You don't even notice that the Blue Rose is nearby, do you?”

At my words, Chaser paused. He also stood up for a moment.

“Iana?”

I was startled.

Is this man really the man I knew? He was a man who was ascetic only in appearance. The messy appearance was not fresh and even unfamiliar. Chaser's shirt buttons were not fastened and more than half were untied. Chaser ruffled his matted hair, and frowned.

“Another fantasy?”

“It's not a fantasy.”

“Everyone's fantasies are like that.”

He was a little skinny. It made him look sharper.

“I said it wasn't a fantasy.”

A delicate smile flowed from between the wrinkled frown lines. Chaser smiled, half covering his face.

“It’s a very convenient ability, but sometimes it gets annoying.”

Between his fingers, his red eyes gleamed low like that of a beast. Along with madness, something incomprehensible murmured.

“Even those who use it brainwash themselves.”

“.....”

“I was just muttering that I wanted to see you. Iana.”

Instead of being scared, I stared at him. This is what I saw countless times when he caught people like rats. Of course, it was only natural that those people were the ones who harmed or were meant to harm me. Because he was extremely sensitive to my dangers.

“Well, it doesn’t matter.”

The anger slowly subsided from Chaser’s face. The subsided madness disappeared in a smile. And all that remained was the soft face I was familiar with. He walked over and raised his hand. His hands went down softly and grabbed my cheeks. It was a careful hand as if handling a fragile and precious thing.

“If only I could see you, what would it matter, Iana?”

His fingers ran down my cheek. His eyes twitched. It was a smile full of temptation, like a devil’s smile.

‘Hey, you’re crazy.’

Whether I was real or not, he should have noticed right away when he saw his men. The door has already been closed, and the subordinate has been out for a long time, but not recognizing this..... Could he be anything but crazy? He was a man who pursued perfection above all else, so he was unfamiliar and strange.

What's more, there was black shadow under Chaser's eyes. He hadn't slept so much that I could see the bloodline bursts on his whites. The problem is that these factors did not tarnish the beauty, but rather only made him look more decadent and sensitive.

On top of that, he was half naked, his buttons unbuttoned, and there was nowhere to put my eyes. I've seen Ricdorian with only his loose shirt, but Chaser is different.

The shock and ripple effect was greater when a person who had been stubborn had it released. Thinking that far, I sighed. No, what else am I thinking up to here?

"Excuse me, brother."

I wiped my face. I admitted that what I had decided to do was overshadowed by the visual.

"I am real."

It was foolish to say such a thing. I can't believe I'm doing this to this man who is not someone else and was so good and playing with people's heads that there's no one else to compare with.

"Yes, Iana."

Chaser smiled languidly as he grabbed my hand. It was the laughter of a predator.

"It's very easy to tell if it's real or not."

"..... Huh?"

Chaser's shadow fell over my face. As soon as I blinked, Chaser turned his head.

I could feel the sweet scent on my face in front of me. It's a scent I remember..... It was the scent I felt in Domulit's black rose garden.

“If I kiss you, won’t the fantasy remain?”

Chapter 198: That Man's Trick (2)

1. 1. That Man's Trick (2)

Wait, wait.

All thoughts were erased at once. But it was after the face had already come close. I felt his exhalation through my lips.

However, his lips were blocked before reaching me. I took a deep breath with my lips covered. while furrowing my brows.

“Don’t mess with me.”

I found out from the middle. No, I would have known only when I saw the eyes of the man approaching me.

“Are you crazy already?”

Chaser was out of his mind. No. Maybe it wasn’t at first. I laughed in vain. It was only natural that I noticed a change. I’ve seen him right next to him the last few years. I knew him as he knew me.

“Get away.”

I wonder if he is not a human being who lives on tricks.

“Oh, it’s real.”

Chaser closed his mouth to me and slowly opened his eyes. Then he put his hand on the back of my hand. Then he buried his lips on my wrist.

“It’s Iana. Really Iana.”

The madness revolving around the half-curved eyes, this was real. It was then that I realized that I had returned to the mansion.

No, it just started.

“Did you finally wake up?”

Chaser smiled softly at me without answering. His eyes were deep, as if exploring me. His hair was clinging to sweat. So was his collar. It looked like he had a nightmare, but I shook my head inside.

“It’s like a dream.”

I don’t know if he has become a nightmare for anyone. Chaser, who mumbled low, dropped his buried mouth.

“You are coming back yourself.”

He opened his mouth and put my finger on his lips.

“Is this your will to stay by my side?”

A small murmur continued even though there was no answer. At the same time, there was a tingling sensation with a delicate pain. It was an odd stimulus.

“Yes? Iana.”

When I tried to pull my hand away, Chaser let me go with ease. As if he was not going to force it. Holding my breath, I grabbed the hand that was hidden behind me. What should I say? No, what should I say first?

I soon admitted.

The fact that I lost my composure for a moment because Chaser showed an unexpected side. I needed time to slowly adjust my reasoning. I closed my eyes.

The scent is thick. I'm afraid that no one will say that these roses are not worthy of their name. Each of them boasted a bitter and deep scent.

Among them, if I had to pick a scent that seduced people the most, it was the man in front of me. There, until now, with an unfamiliar appearance, he embarrasses me.

Which one should I start with, a fastball or a curve? Contemplating, I exhaled a little.

“Did you not sleep?”

What flowed out of me was a routine question. A common question, as if we had talked until yesterday. Chaser's expression was the same as a smile.

“I have a lot of questions. Besides that, I think there are many things you want to ask me. Brother.”

But I noticed that his eyes trembled slightly. Chaser looked down and answered my questions one by one.

“Yes. I couldn't sleep. How about you?”

“I slept well.”

My answer was casual. Chaser asked again.

“Are you going to answer my questions?”

“Do you want to hear it?”

I lifted my head. How are you going to do it? It was an action full of meaning. He will understand my meaning without difficulty. Even though he understood one thing, what he showed was another unexpected behavior.

“No, rather to hear the answer..... I want you to put me to sleep, Iana.”

Chaser bowed to me.

I was startled when his face came closer to mine. What kind of trick is this again? I raised my foot with the intention of kicking him, and his face brushed past mine.

“I’m sleepy…….”

A terrifyingly drowsy voice pierced my ears. With an enchanting, low-pitched resonant sound.

“Let me sleep. Yes?”

He murmured as he rested his head on my shoulder.

“Just once…….”

It was also a voice that was terribly tired.

Instead of looking at his crown, I glanced around the room. Nothing has changed since I was away. My lips opened slowly. Indifferent, yet stern words flowed from me.

“Why? If you don’t have a Blue Rose by your side, you won’t be able to sleep?”

“It’s similar.”

“Oh, insomnia?”

Chaser had said this when he appeared in Hernim Castle. *I couldn’t sleep. Put me to sleep…….* Chaser smirked as he rested his head on my shoulder.

“Yes. But I am doing this because you are not here.”

Chaser’s shoulders trembled. Although I didn’t see him smiling, I could guess that he was smiling as he always did with the gentle sound of the wind.

Chaser grabbed my hand that was hidden behind me. It was an unusually delicate touch. In fact, thinking about it, his hand wasn’t sloppy or ferocious

for a man.

He was the man who always held me softly as if it were about to break. His actions and words were just different. I smiled a little. It wasn't a funny smile. It was a false laugh.

“What is different?”

Chaser shuddered and clasped my shoulder. He slowly raised his head. For a moment, it seemed as if a surprised expression passed by.

But he soon returned to his original face and smiled.

“I guess Grand Duke Hernim didn't tell you about these things.”

A shrill voice drooped.

“As for the side effects of roses.”

Well. I think I heard something like that from Francia. I laughed.

“They told me honestly there.”

“.....”

“I also heard that the Black Roses have been hiding the Blue Roses all along.”

I raised my head.

“Really?”

“As you can see.”

Chaser replied with a smile.

“What did Grand Duke Hernim say?”

“Well, I heard a lot, but I may have forgotten. At least he didn’t hide anything from me.”

Chaser narrowed his eyes as he smiled.

“..... What have I been hiding?”

“You didn’t say anything, did you?”

“I’m sorry if you think like that, Iana.”

Chaser lowered his head and whispered softly in my ear. I rolled my head tight. Because I have not forgotten the purpose of me coming here. Eventually, I looked around the corner of the room and shook my head. Very casually.

“I want to sit down.”

It was close to ignoring his words neatly. Chaser raised his eyebrows at this. However, the smile did not fade.

“Let’s sit down.”

Chaser didn’t answer. I looked at him once.

“What are you doing? You asked me to put you to sleep.”

I got out of his hand and walked first. As I sat down, Chaser slowly walked over to me.

I tapped the seat next to me.

“Aren’t you going to lie down?”

“..... Are you really going to do it?”

“When did I say empty words?”

He and I were acting as if there was no gap. But we would have known each other. This tension that seeps into the everyday atmosphere. Chaser grabbed the back of the sofa and tilted his torso. A long shadow falls on me. Instead of sitting down, with a momentum that seems to attack me. Instead of being scared, I pulled his clothes on. He humbly surrendered his body.

“Are you trying to sing a lullaby?”

Chaser’s attitude was close to knowing that whatever I do is close to a trap, but he falls for it on purpose. Because the person who normally would have asked or questioned me didn’t say a word. Rather, he said these words and quietly laid himself down on the sofa.

I frowned.

“Did I tell you to cut off my leg?”

He laughed shamelessly.

“Isn’t that what you said?”

Tension passed in the silence for a moment. I glanced at him in a resigned tone and placed my hand over his eyes.

“Yes. Well. Sleep.”

My relationship with him was always when he reached out his hand, so this was the first time.

However, neither he nor I made it obvious. In particular, I stared at him calmly. Whether he was really tired or pretending to be tricked, I felt his eyelashes tickle my palms. Soon I knew that his eyes had been closed.

“Why are you being this nice?”

He raised his lips, half revealing his face.

“Is there anything you want from me?”

“Well.”

“Is there anything you want, Iana?”

He was a smart man. So, he must have already noticed the strangeness of the situation. I was curious as to why this man was talking about the point directly.

“Won’t you ask?”

Human silence has several meanings. Things that are hard to say and things you don’t want to say, and things you have so much to say that you can’t bring them out. There may be many more.

Which one was Chaser’s sweet lips at?

What is this guy like when I tried to escape here, when I tried to hide Pudding. Didn’t he ask me questions like interrogating?

“You must have a lot of questions.”

“..... that’s right. Just as you have questions for me, I also have questions for you.”

Chaser said, still blindfolded.

“But I am waiting.”

I lowered my gaze. Because he came out like this, I calmed down my purpose for a moment, and brought out my sincerity.

“You don’t have to do anything for me.”

He flinched.

“No, you don’t have to do that to me anymore.”

Chaser’s hand grabbed my hand that covered his eyes.

“Iana.”

However, I did not stop talking.

“Now, I don’t want to say that what you did to me was bad.”

I just realized it was weird.

“It’s just that I don’t want anything from you.”

I thought he would recognize the meaning of the changed title. After a moment of silence, Chaser opened his mouth.

“..... Did you hate me?”

Chaser asked with the same soft voice that called me the day I was released. But I knew. That this is a voice disguised as composure. I also knew that it was the voice right before the wall collapsed.

“I have no idea.”

Still, I didn’t stop talking.

“I asked if you hate me?”

My hand was still covering Chaser’s face.

“Exactly, I have no expectations of you.”

Perhaps, after this time, the opportunity to talk like this will no longer come.

I don’t know. We didn’t talk like this when we were in Domulit’s mansion. There was a time when I didn’t really have any thoughts, but nevertheless, I just got over the strangeness that sometimes arises.

Maybe me and this man have been living face to face, deceiving each other and ourselves. The mood was different from a few seconds ago. The tension in the air, as if pulling a thread, pricked my cheek. I was not under pressure.

Chaser removed my hand from his face.

“From now on, even if I grant you what you want?”

“Is that meaningful?”

I spoke quietly.

“No matter what I want, you will do what you want, right?”

I didn’t avoid his eyes.

“Like you put shackles on me.”

Chaser acted as he pleased while I was in Domulit.

“Like the day you imprisoned me.”

Of course, I did not forget the days he saved my life.

It’s just that.

“Ha..... . haha.”

Chaser jumped up from his seat. Then he stared at me with a confused look.

“Hahaha..... Iana. Is this my turn to regret?”

At that moment, my vision flipped. When I came to my senses, I could feel the soft sofa behind my back. When I looked up, Chaser was looking down at me.

With a face I have never seen before.

Chapter 199: A bunch of contradictions

1. 1. A bunch of contradictions

The air was tight, like water in a pot that was about to boil over. I didn't know what would happen if it broke.

He immediately looked at me with his eyes reddened from sleep. In the red iris in front of my eyes, the unfathomable things that were silent were surfacing again.

“Now you fall in love with the Red Rose?”

A low growling voice came from him.

“Would he even give you his neck? Why is he sending you back to the limbs alone like this?”

“Is Domulit a lion's mouth?”

He let out a deep laugh at my question.

“It would be the same for the Red Rose.”

It was also the first laugh I had ever seen.

“Iana, are you going to give up on me?”

I tilted my head as he lay down. *Give up?*

“Isn't that something to say when you at least have one?”

“Iana.”

I didn’t answer. Because I had enough up to here. But despite that,

“Why?”

My mouth didn’t stop.

“Huh?”

“Why do you want me to regret it?”

I laughed slowly. Then he went on to say,

“Anyway, I won’t regret it.”

It was pouring out. I didn’t mean to provoke it, but without realizing it, my sincerity came out. I couldn’t pick it up and hold it.

“And I regret doing it when it’s no use. Brother.”

Even though I didn’t reply, Chaser seemed to have noticed a lot already. His laughter grew louder. He and I must know that this wasn’t a joke.

I spoke calmly and quietly.

“You can’t go back to the past just because you regret it.”

The past can never be undone. Now there are no scars left, but sometimes my ankles are so heavy that I have to look into them.

It’s like hearing the sound of a chain without realizing it while walking.

As it turns out, all of this was strange in the end. He was smart, he would have already known.

There was no way this man didn’t know what I had noticed. This man was not ignorant of morals, he was a man who even used morals.

“Already, you think regretting is useless, don’t you?”

You are a smart man.

“What do you regret?”

I put a period in that.

“You’re thinking like this.”

I know this man as much as this man knows me. We were so close. To the point it was too much.

It was this man who approached me, but it was me who allowed the distance.

Thanks to this man, my life was preserved. He kept me alive to this day. Maybe that’s where my mind became loose. Immersed in inertia, without knowing that something went wrong.

My hand hesitates for a moment, then touches his cheek. Then he continued without hesitation.

“But I don’t think it’s wrong either.”

As a human being, I couldn’t help but fall in love with the little warlock and this man who devoted their life to protecting me every time in this space.

“There is something I cannot forgive. Brother won’t repent. We know each other well.”

I hate it but not hate it. It’s actually easy to get rid of the contradictions.

“If you don’t regret it, I don’t need to forgive you either.”

You just have to delete one of them completely.

“I just decided not to think about you.”

Chaser's expression collapsed for the first time.

"..... That's not allowed."

It was shattered, revealing a face close to raw. His face without a single smile showed an expression I had never seen even when he was angry.

"I knew it, did you fall in love with the Red Rose?"

Chaser lowered his voice. An ecstatic and creepy voice that seemed to fill my ears.

"But you know what?"

He smiled with a contorted face.

"Iana. The Blue Rose..... can't love anyone."

I raised my eyes. At a glance, the appearance was so disastrous that it was a mess.

"Think about it."

He tilted his head. His wet hair-clad face was dark and sensual like a demon that had just come out of hell.

"Does your heart race when you see that man? Have you ever felt thirsty when you want to see someone? Have you ever felt so obsessed that you would even risk a war to jump forward?"

I didn't ask whose feelings it was. I just stared blankly

"No, there is not."

It was sincere. If he's talking about love, I've never felt it.

My life has always been as still as still water. I adapt easily to everything, am not easily surprised, and pay little attention to others. As if I was born with this kind of thing.

“A Blue Rose that was required by many roses is born with indifference. All Blue Roses were like that. Iana.”

If this is truly a characteristic of the Blue Rose, then I am the Blue Rose.

“It was the rule set by the primordial rose. If you give too much love to something, other roses will go mad and destroy the world. Then innocent people will be hurt.”

My breathing's crossed.

“Passion of the Red Rose, loyalty of the Yellow Rose, joy and healing of the White Rose, and finally obsession of the Black Rose.”

Numerous unfathomable emotions permeated through the slow voice.

“So, Iana, you can't love.”

I stared at him and slowly opened my mouth.

“You're lying, aren't you?”

This is a lie.

“If you don't lie to me.”

In the past, ‘Iana’ loved Chaser. This is a lie. Chaser, who looked at me, gradually calmed down. Then he lowered his head and let out a laugh.

“Yes, that's a lie.”

After a while, he raised his head and returned to his usual face. However, there was an uncontrollable redness all over his face. Between his laughter, there were tears that seemed to fall from his red eyes.

“But Iana, you said you allow only one lie.”

Long tears ran down his cheeks.

“..... That’s not me, is it?”

Not me, but ‘Iana’.

I did not know that I would be able to ask the questions I felt on the carriage so quickly. I hope this opportunity will come.

“That’s right.”

Chaser meekly admitted. To the extent that I am surprised by the rather light answer. I grabbed his arm.

It was time for the truth to come out.

“Are you the one who brought me here?”

I have finally reached the fundamental question. At this moment when eyes of different colors meet.

“That’s right, Iana.”

This man called me that, even though he knew my name wasn’t Iana. A name that has now inevitably become my property.

“I brought you here.”

Chaser’s hand dug into my defenseless hand and interlocked.

“And I fell in love with you.”

Streams of tears flow down the face with a bitter smile. The man smiled softly even though he was crying.

“I didn’t know it was going to be like this.”

Long, white, delicate fingers grip my hand like a rose vine.

“I didn’t know I was going to go crazy like this.”

A faint light flickered with his clasped hands. The moment I saw the light, I opened my eyes wide.

“I didn’t expect it at all until my sister died.”

The light was blue. It was the light of the Blue Rose that I had once seen in my hand. Chaser’s voice continued to be heard in my ears. It was a voice of deep regret.

“Aren’t you wondering why I know where the guardian deity of the Blue Rose is?”

He was talking about the letter he sent me.

“How was it possible to seal the guardian deity of the Red Rose?”

At the same time, I could feel Pudding, who was preparing to jump out inside me, trembled.

“The power of the Blue Rose is one of two. Go back in time. Go beyond dimension.”

“..... What?”

“My sister had the power to turn back time, and before she died she gave all her power to me. And I went back in time.”

In the end, it meant that he had sealed Pudding and obtained the guardian deity of the Blue Rose because he had gone back in time knowing everything.

I couldn’t get a word out.

“Actually, where I was, the roses must have gone crazy when my sister died unexpectedly.”

“..... Are you saying you saved the world?”

“It’s not that grand. Iana, my sister was a selfish blue rose.”

Chaser bowed his head. At the same time, a dazzling blue light emanated from him. However, it soon mixed with black, creating a subtle and mysterious yet gloomy feeling.

“He wanted me to love her. Only saving me and sending me to the past.”

I remembered the scene Aquala showed me a long time ago. The scene where Chaser was holding ‘Iana’ and crying.

“That child was stupid. If she uses that power, she will disappear. What I saw when I went back was that the soul had disappeared and only the shell remained.”

My body did not move. It seemed to be because of the haze of blue and black light flowing out now.

“I went back to the world where the soul of the Blue Rose was gone, but I had to protect the shell.”

It felt like all the puzzles were coming together.

Duke Domulit’s younger sister who woke up in the prison. A woman who does not know her own crime.

And the appearance of ‘Iana’ that the guards remembered.

< “*I’m not a learned person, so I can’t find a proper expression. That... the Miss’ eyes at that time, I guess....were a little out of focus*” >

“I will somehow save the body and I put it in a temple full of ancient power.”

Kambrakam.

< “*Ummm, to put it bluntly. The Miss at the time was like, you felt like a ‘doll’, maybe?*” >

“But the only thing is that it couldn’t exist again.”

Chaser laughed, wiping the tears away with the back of his hand.

“That’s why I called you.”

He lifted my interlocked hand and brushed it against his lips.

“Iana.”

A deep fragrance is felt through the flickering light.

“My Blue Rose that has crossed the dimension.”

He slowly folded his knees in front of me and looked up at me. Dropping his old face as he said it.

“I was just trying to be faithful to my sister, who was only the shell.”

Unlike other times, the soft voice penetrated more deeply. He murmured once more what he had said earlier.

“I didn’t know I was going to love you.”

Between the laughs, the mad eyes were curved with a dizzying temptation.

“I don’t know I’ll be yearning like this.”

With the tears that could not fall off the tip of his chin.

Chapter 200: Enchanted abyss (1)

1. 1. Enchanted abyss (1)

I stared at Chaser silently. I didn't know what to say in this situation. Just the words Chaser had left blocked my throat like lumps of powder in a liquid.

Frustrated? No, more than that, a lot of thoughts ran through my mind. It was rare for me to feel complex emotions.

Was this the reason I woke up in the prison one day?

“It can't be.....”

I did not open my lips, I kept my mouth shut. Naturally, the words were cut off. The words that couldn't come out of my mouth lingered in my throat.

Is it his fault that I moved to this world and only remembered what's in the book, the original story?

Who I was and what kind of face I was in another world. Is it also his fault that I don't remember having a family?

And is it his fault that I never once wanted to go back to my world?

I was about to ask if it was all this man's fault.

But I covered my lips. I didn't mean to ask. It was only because, as I was about to speak, something like lightning flashed through my head.

It was kind of like a feeling.

I had a strong sense that it wasn't this man's fault. It was a very illogical feeling, but nonetheless, I naturally came to accept this.

I knew this was the power of the Blue Rose.

My power was telling the truth. It wasn't this man's fault, it was my ability. Being too good at adapting to an unfamiliar world, and being indifferent. No, my personality is all of these things. It was thanks to the power and characteristics of the Blue Rose that made me adapt well.

I wiped my face.

The situation was different, but suddenly I thought I seemed to understand Iana. The bad handwriting that had been written in the diary was lodged in my chest.

["Everyone needed me."]

She hadn't written a single word that it was painful, but only those words were distorted. It is so thick as if the parchment could be pierced if pressed a little firmly.

I don't know what kind of life Iana lived.

All I know is that the Black Rose has imprisoned the Blue Rose for a long time, the Blue Rose has lived with their surname being a domulet, and that she loved Chaser. Would it have been the same that something unintended was forcibly intervening in life?

If I hadn't had the characteristics of the Blue Rose, the attention I needed would have been burdensome.

I didn't have time to think about one.

The pain quickly subsided. Faster than it appeared, as clean as the water that soaked into the sponge was sucked.

I hadn't really thought about it for a long time. Even if this is characteristic of the Blue Rose, I was already such a person.

Yes. What has already happened has happened. There is nothing that can be done.

So.

if it's irreversible.

I raised my head up.

Chaser was still kneeling in front of me and holding my hand. Like a devout knight who swore allegiance to the king.

A devout knight? It was a word that didn't quite fit him. I squeezed my lips and reached out to him.

My hand grabbed his collar.

"Why, it's too late now."

He raised his gaze.

"Are you acting like a criminal now?"

"....."

"You have no intention of repenting."

Chaser's lips rose gradually at my words.

"Ah..... Did I get caught?"

Tears were still hanging from the tip of his chin.

"Are you going to do the same if I go back?"

"That's right."

The tears that had been hanging on to it were dripping down.

“I will do that if necessary.”

He smiled.

“And I will love you again.”

He couldn't resist the hand that I was pulling on him and he was dragged along. No, he was pretending he couldn't.

“That's not what I want to hear.”

“What do you want?”

Without answering, I squeezed my hand and pushed him away. Soon he lay on the floor. It probably won't hurt as much as it was a soft carpet.

“Sleep for now.”

Chaser's eyes were now red enough to tell the difference between the color of the iris and the white of the iris. Like a man drenched in fatigue. Of course, I knew he had a plan to say this.

No. I know there's a trick to it, though. I'll never know what's inside him.

“Iana, I don't know what you are thinking.”

Like a lie, Chaser recited the words I was just thinking about. He lay down and looked up at me slowly.

“Is there anything you don't know?”

“Of course. I'm always curious.”

His messy hair and his wrinkled shirt as he lay down were all visible. It was like seeing a vaguely black petal near his left chest.

“From the moment I found out about your existence.”

He grabbed my hand that was holding him by the collar.

“You have always been something of an incomprehensible realm. I was curious because I didn’t understand.”

His voice was lowering little by little. It was a different aspect from being lowered in anger. Low, and gradually diminishing.

“The moment I didn’t understand became fun from some moment on.”

With my eyes half closed, I waited for the day to receive your letter. He murmured. Letter? As I questioned, Chaser pulled my hand and placed it over his eyes.

His lips curled as if they were painted on.

“Even though you were the only unsolvable question mark and problem in my life.”

A shaky breath came out.

“There were more moments that reminded me of you than blinking the eye.”

He said that he thought of me every moment. Then, with a low exhalation, he stopped moving. I counted inwardly as my hand was caught, and when I counted to 40, I slowly released my hand. The hand fell off incredibly easily. *Tuk*. Even his hand holding me fell to the floor.

What was visible under my hand was a sleeping face with his eyelids closed and his long eyelashes pointing down.

His shirt was wrinkled after the struggle, yet his figure was ecstatic decadent, as if he was sculpted this way.

I took a breath.

There was no time to be dazzled by the splendid appearance of this human being. I lifted my hand in the air and carefully placed it in front of his face. *Swish, swish*. I shook it slightly.

‘Did he really fall asleep?’

I think so. Because his face, breathing evenly, looked like he was really asleep. It was a face that bore that much fatigue.

This man was a man who could not close his eyes even if he was to die of exhaustion if there was a need for it.

Didn’t I know him very well?

He would have known that I had a plan from the beginning..... I don’t know why he immediately closed his eyes at my words. I slowly clasped my fingers. I clenched my pocket with my other hand.

‘If now.....’

Can I get the syringe out of my pocket? I waited 30 minutes to confirm, but he did not open his eyes. Is this a battle of patience or is he really asleep..... My pendulum of thought is tilted toward ‘slept’. Still, I couldn’t move.

Then, with the tips of his fingers clenched, he boldly stretched out his hand. And stopped right in front of me.

Snap. my hand was caught

“Are you bored?”

Chaser, who had half-opened his eyes, smiled languidly and kissed my fingertips.

“I’m sorry..... My Iana, just a little more.”

I’ll sleep. He closed his eyes again, resting and whispering in a harsh voice. As he brought my hand to my lips.

Cold sweat runs down my back.

‘How.’

I knew instinctively.

Chaser doesn't sleep. No, to be precise, he doesn't completely fall asleep. He found out about the small movement that I unfolded a while ago.

So that he can open his eyes anytime, anywhere. That he was prepared like a beast so that he could move even at the slightest sign he felt.

'If I took out the syringe.....'

I saw the sleeping face. The color, the man's sweet breath, resounded softly.

Unlike the peaceful villain's face, the atmosphere in the room was full of tension.

The first night at Domulit ended like that.

Jaire said.

My stay there must not exceed a certain amount of time. While I took down Chaser in Domulit and got the tiara out, he said he was going to cause an incident somewhere else.

There are many crime cities near the Domulit estate. They are called 'free cities', but in reality they are lawless areas. The reason why there are so many cities like this is what Chaser intended. To be precise, he inherited what the former Duke Domulit had done and made it bigger.

In any case, Jaire was to attract attention by causing trouble in one of these cities, with the aim of ending crimes.

Lenag and I, who knew the inner workings of Domulit, gave information on which of these cities was important, and Jaire who touched the city directly, and Francia lent Paladins. Chaser knows it's a trap, but he can't help but send people away.

Because they were going to touch something that was worth it.

I've been thinking about it here. Since we have been enemies for a long time, Hernim and Domulit. They must have known each other's faults by themselves.

I waited quietly. Actually, there is nothing I can do after I return to the mansion. When I first lived here, there was nothing I could do. I just ate and slept warmly on my back, and sometimes went for a walk outside.

Pudding didn't come out of me because he was so nervous. If there is something, it has to come out right away.

I also reunited with the little warlock, but we couldn't talk for long. That's probably because Chaser, who had a cruel face, was by my side in the room without missing a single moment.

Of course, the cruel face here was not the face I saw, but the face he showed to his subordinates or the little warlock.

When I look back, as always, he was smiling.

I could only guess from the face of the person who had been hesitant.

Even if I live the same life as before, if I look into it, it sounds like it was different. Chaser never left my side like a determined person.

..... This is helpful.

I was looking for opportunities, so for me, it was better to see him more often than for him to disappear to meet his duties.

'I didn't know that he would meet his duties in my room.'

Today, looking at the person sitting at the desk in my room naturally, I clicked my tongue.

Chapter 201: Enchanted abyss (2)

1. 1. Enchanted abyss (2)

As if he felt my gaze, the soft smile on his face was shameless.

“Keep talking. Do you feel a sense of loss when the Blue Rose disappears?”

No wonder there was a desk in my room that I had never seen before, so I thought it was moved. With this thought in mind, I continued the conversation.

“That’s right. I feel a sense of loss.”

While spying on the opportunity next to Chaser, I didn’t miss another chance. An opportunity to directly ask someone who knows all the information.

“When the Blue Rose is gone, I know instinctively, my life has no meaning anymore.”

“..... Isn’t that too much?”

“Well, once I experienced it, it wasn’t that bad.”

Chaser bowed his head and smiled. A soft laugh followed.

“People sometimes despair, but eventually live, don’t they? It feels like that.”

It was a very quiet laugh to talk about the Blue Rose before me, his sister’s death. It’s strange to laugh, though.

“I don’t know. I did, but what about the other roses? I think they would have been similar.....”

Chaser turned his head.

“The Blue Rose must exist in the same world. So, if there is no soul, bring it from another world..... Perhaps one of the powers of the Blue Rose is the power that allows it to move.”

“What about returning?”

“That would be if the Blue Rose was born into this world. Then you will have the power to return.”

Chaser clenched his chin and informed me.

“But isn’t it strange? A long time has passed since the first rose, and the roses are no longer attached to Blue Roses as they used to.”

His head tilted slowly.

“Do you say you feel thirst?”

“Yes. Tolerable thirst.”

Chaser nodded his head lightly. With a gentle smile.

“Even if the Blue Rose dies, there will only be intolerable pain.”

Said a returner who once lost a Blue Rose. I frowned at this.

“You said we must be in the same world.”

“I didn’t say I wasn’t crazy and hurt, Iana.”

He explained softly. In the past, the pain and loss was so great that it would be better to die, and he went crazy along with it, but now that time passes and there is a void, the pain is dull and only madness comes slowly.

Neither was good, but it was true that the former was far more terrifying.

Here, I have a fundamental question.

Then why did the Blue Rose and the roses have such a deformed relationship? Isn't it too unfair for other roses to have their lives changed by the existence and choices of others? Where did this blindness come from?

In this way, he seemed to be giving away information.

“Why the hell did the relationship become so tilted?”

“Is that because the beginning was like that?”

“How was it in the beginning?”

Chaser was never easy. I asked him a lot. Mostly about the Blue Rose or the roses, and about the Blue Rose's guardian deity..... I also asked about 'Iana'.

Chaser didn't answer everything. In particular, when asked about the Blue Rose's guardian deity or 'Iana', he only smiled and did not listen. Like in this situation now.

“Well.”

Chaser slowly got up from the chair. He walked effortlessly to where I was.

“..... It doesn't matter if you don't listen to it.”

“You still remember, right?”

“.....”

“I'm curious.”

His soft voice pierced my ears. As if he knew what I was thinking.

It certainly was.

I wanted to deal with my powers, I had to know to handle them, and the information is in that man.

“Are you going to make a deal?”

“You can’t say it like that. Iana.”

He laughed and even gave a lecture on villain theory himself.

“You have to use me. You have to eat me to the bone.”

“..... If I say that, will you be taken advantage of?”

“Of course.”

He put his hand on his button.

“Where should I take it off?”

“What?”

“Don’t you have to look at the body to get the bones?”

“Stop being crazy.”

Chaser no longer insisted on his ascetic attire. No, even the time to change clothes seemed to be omitted. Even at changing times, he only disappeared for a brief moment and appeared back in a disheveled, unbuttoned outfit.

It still was even now. I turned my gaze away.

“Because I know now that if I give in too much, you will fly away. What should I do?”

It was a series of explorative battles.

“It doesn’t matter if you don’t listen. Because there is no one to tell you anymore.”

“.....”

“I’m the only one who can give you an answer.”

The languid voice was full of certainty.

“As for the Blue Rose. Especially the information you want, Iana.”

For some reason, his eyes seemed to turn towards my legs for a moment.

“So, you want to tie me up?”

Twitch. My shoulders trembled slightly.

“It doesn’t matter though. If you want to do it anyway.”

“..... no.”

He said in a tone that it really doesn’t matter. If this happened, the trouble would be gone, but it wasn’t that there was no way.

Chaser might release more tension.

“I will tell you one by one.”

However, he answered as if no, and looked at me. At the same time, his hand reached out.

“Even if I regret what is left. I want you to stay by my side.”

His fingers gently touched my ear, and with a sound, he slipped my hair behind my ear.

“... What are you doing?”

Suddenly, his shadow was thickly cast over my face.

“I’m lying flat now, Iana.”

The low whispering voice was seductive, yet low, ecstatic, and subtle.

I raised my eyebrows.

“How?”

“Really.”

Chaser grabbed my chin at my dull expression and pretended to be troubled, then slowly folded his knees.

“I wish I could get down on my knees.”

He crossed his legs and kissed my bare knee. It felt soft and watery to the bare skin.

“Please choose me.”

He then raised his head and met my eyes.

“Please don’t leave me.”

In the eyes overflowing with madness, there was something I had never seen before.

“It’s terrible to share with the other roses.”

In an instant, his gaze changed sharply. However, this was only for a while. He was looking at me with a mixture of madness and earnestness. I removed his hand from my lap. However, the hand that I had been holding to separate from me instead grabbed my hand and entangled it.

“If only I could have a part of you.”

He whispered softly.

“Then I think I can stay in your shadow.”

I stared at my entangled hands and looked away indifferently. It was a small act, but it was enough to provoke his reaction.

His expression crumbled down on my indifferent face.

“If you want, I can bring you to the world.”

As he leaned his face in my hand, he muttered a little, subtly revealing his power. I shook my head.

“It’s okay. Because there is nothing I want in the world you speak of.”

As I said this, I felt a sense of disappointment inside.

“Iana, you..... You keep me locked up in an enchanted abyss.”

While he was muttering, I looked down at his head silently. A small voice that seemed to be cut off leaked out.

“To make you regret it in the end.”

Chaser seemed to give up, but he never gave up.

Now I was suspicious.

Will there ever be a chance to take on a challenge?

However, when a few days passed, the opportunity came.

It was the moment I had been waiting for.

As I said, Chaser did all his responsibilities in my room. I often saw him sitting and looking at the parchment on the desk. He didn’t sit there from the beginning, but after a few days he just brought something and tried to see if he could just stay by my side the whole time.

He deals with his responsibilities here and also receives reports here.

“Duke, there is a problem!”

One subordinate, who came in after knocking politely, had a face full of urgency, unlike the politeness.

“A large-scale riot in Scheruten.....”

“A riot?”

I was beside them listening to everything while the subordinate reported that something had happened. It was natural. Because this was my room.

‘Has it started?’

It was a signal from Jaire. I kept my lips shut. I clasped my hand lightly to relieve my nervousness.

“It’s Scheruten.....”

Chaser’s expression did not change. Rather, he only tilted his head at an angle with a cold face that only the subordinate could see.

He was relaxed.

“What should I do? Should we send more people?”

“Hmm.”

He pulled up one corner of his mouth. His eyes were not smiling at all.

“Let’s watch.”

It was the moment when Chaser gave such an order.

Knock, knock.

A knock at a fast tempo resounded no matter who heard it. As soon as permission was granted, the door opened. From the wide open door, someone came running in.

“Duke, there is a report that Panthes is on fire!”

The subordinate, who came in quickly, mentioned the name of another city.

“Is it arson?”

“No, no.”

The subordinate glanced at me for a brief moment. He seemed to be wary, but he continued quickly.

“During the fight, a huge explosion..... It seems that the handling of firearms is wrong. Explosives to deliver.....”

Explosives, in this empire, were equivalent to munitions. And the fact that it was in the city of crime meant that this man was also involved in the smuggling of munitions. Chaser’s expression changed for the first time. He got up from his seat. But he soon turned his head. Because I was holding onto the hem of his robe. I slowly raised my eyes.

“..... are you going?”

Our gazes crossed in the air. It’s because Chaser can’t go there.

My hand, unable to overcome my nervousness, tightened. It was a brief moment, but it must have been enough for him to notice.

An unexpected light seemed to pass through Chaser’s expression.

“Should I not go?”

The low voice asked me.

Chapter 202: I'll give it to you

1. 1. I'll give it to you

I released Chaser's hand. Then I shook my head carelessly.

"No, it doesn't matter."

As if it doesn't matter if he goes or not. And as my hand went down, his hand grabbed hold of mine.

"Iana, you can do anything."

"....."

"Don't let me go."

Chaser clasped my hands and whispered softly. A strong arm is wrapped around my waist. He bowed his head and whispered his voice directly into my ear.

"If you do that, I will be deceived by anything."

It was a voice with a small laugh. At the same time, at the end of the laugh, there seemed to be a sigh.

"I'll listen to anything."

I rolled my eyes slowly. It was over his shoulder and towards the subordinate. With a glance, Chaser reflexively opened his lips.

"Duke."

Chaser said without looking at the subordinate.

“Go first.”

He said so and slowly turned his head.

“Take the 1st Battalion.”

“Yes! Understood!”

The subordinate had a face that couldn't understand for a moment, but all the light of his doubts was erased by Chaser's words. He greeted as if he had understood.

The 1st Battalion was the most outstanding of the knights under Chaser. In particular, they were unparalleled in the face of people. Because it was a bunch of wild dogs.

I took a deep breath as I had seen how they intercept and deal with intruders next to Chaser's side. Will Jaire and Francia's knights be okay? They will be fine.

Thump thump.

As if to soothe my quietly beating heart, I felt a gentle energy inside. This is Pudding's energy. I smiled as if it was licking the back of my hand.

‘Thank you.’

Then the door closed and only me and Chaser were left in the room.

I heard footsteps rushing outside. It was probably the knights who were waiting in front of my room.

Then the commotion subsided, and silence came.

My hand was still in Chaser's hand. Somehow, the room feels more spacious than usual. His eyes crossed with mine.

“Is there anything you want?”

Chaser said something out of the ordinary.

What I want. What I wished for.

Oddly enough, Chaser and Ricdorian were asking me the same thing. However, when I talk about a wish that goes against my will, the reaction is different. Because Ricdorian was a man who listened while crying, whereas Chaser was a man who would listen to me selectively. And he was the man who made me gave up.

Years ago, when I decided to give up running and stay in the Domulit mansion, he asked.

My wish then was that I wanted to take a walk in the garden.

“Why. Will you bring me a bunch of worldly treasures?”

Then he piled up the mansion full of rare things that I would never see again.

“There’s nothing I can’t do if you want.”

He said it was a gift to me.

“Did you put all my stuff in the basement?”

At that time, there was no way that I could not be unaware of the gentle voice that seemed to be trying to calm me down. Even now he was trying to comfort me like that.

“I put it. The warehouse.”

He tilted his head and smiled softly.

“So you can bring it whenever you want.”

Chaser gave me a lot of gifts, but most of them went back to the warehouse. It was because I didn't use it and was indifferent to it. And I confirmed that it is still the same today.

‘Everything is in the warehouse.’

The same goes for the tiara. Fortunately, I've been to the warehouse before. As long as it was within this mansion, I could go anywhere.

Chaser allowed me to go in and out of my own private room. As if it doesn't matter what I do if I stay here. Even if it was a place where Domulit's secrets were piled up, he'd be happy to give it to me if I wanted to.

Among the countless days that Chaser gave me presents, I remembered the day when he gave the Empress' tiara.

<It suits you well. As expected, it must be yours.>

The day when he rejoiced as he crowned me.

If everything stays the same, the plan will be fine. After checking everything, I slowly lifted my head.

‘All that's left.’

I'm going to knock this guy down. I pondered for a few days.

‘The stabbing place is the neck or the wrist.’

There should be other places where the bloodline is exposed. I heard that putting it in a place with a thick layer of skin won't do any good. After much deliberation, I always found the exposed neck to be the easiest.

His wrists were always covered by his coat. So, what can I do to insert this syringe into this man's neck?

At first, I tried several times the moment this man was sleeping.

However, after all these failed attempts, I only came to know one thing. He doesn't relax even for a moment.

I exhaled lightly.

“Brother.”

As I flicked my hand, Chaser bowed softly like a butterfly drawn to a flower. He and I became very close. As I was sitting on the sofa, I was locked up by him and I looked up.

‘I have no intention of pitying you, but.....’

I slowly lowered my eyes.

I must have stayed in this mansion for too long.

He was a man who committed the never-before-seen crime of murdering his father, but suffered as much abuse and resentment left by his father as a legacy. An environment that cannot survive without becoming evil. I don't want to understand, but it sounds like I know the reason.

This is how it feels to know something you don't really want to know.

Cumbersome and annoying.

It was like a thin piano string wrapped around my wrist to know the circumstances in which this man was forced to grow up. It's thin and transparent, so you don't feel it when it's loose, but it's only when it's taut that you suddenly notice its presence. Just like now.

I have no intention of stopping him from doing so, but I can't help but let my heart weaken a bit. Time leaves a trace. I wonder if this man even thought about it this far.

Then I opened my lips and spoke quietly.

“Is the Blue Rose obligated to pay attention to all the roses?”

Chaser blinked his eyes in surprise for a moment, then lowered his head and smiled.

“It is not obligatory. If you don’t do that, one will go crazy.”

Rustle. His fine black hair fluttered in front of me.

“The one that didn’t get attention.”

Chaser pressed his lips together with his thumb and rubbed it like stretching.

“Do you know why the Yellow Rose has the flower language of betrayal?”

A soft voice lightly tells an old story.

“For a long time..... they almost never got a choice.”

Thinking of the figure of a man with long long hair, Lenag, I flinched.

“They became traitors the moment they stole the Blue Rose once. Since they were the ones who made loyalty their purpose in life, they didn’t even protest. By the way, the guardian deity is also a snake, so it was good to be misunderstood.”

Chaser added a word with a smile.

“Well, it wasn’t just a misunderstanding, as most of them hide their snake-like nature behind it. The Yellow Rose of this era was just a particularly unusual man.”

“Lenag.”

“Yes. I can’t help but let go of him because he was only looking at you.”

I slapped his hand that was approaching my cheek and raised my eyes.

“If he became a traitor with just one bad deed, how about the Black Rose?”

It was to point out the atrocities done by the Black Rose. Chaser replied calmly with a smile.

“The Black Rose is the most impatient.”

“If you don’t be loved, will you die?”

“Yes.”

The smile faded from his eyes for a moment. Serious gazes overlapped in the air.

“If you don’t love me.”

Chaser whispered as he bowed his head.

“I think I’m going to die.”

I thought for a long time.

There is no moment when this man relaxes.

Yes, if so. There was only one way.

“Then.”

I’ll have to make himself relax. I grabbed him by the neck and pulled him tight.

“I’ll give it to you.”

“What?”

He didn’t have time to answer. Because I closed Chaser’s mouth. With my lips. His eyes widened. For the first time, I saw the red eyes that were wide open as if they were about to tear apart.

He felt a soft touch on his lips and wrapped his hand behind my neck. I stretched out my hand straight back.

The number of syringes Jaire gave me was three.

‘It was in case of failure.....’

Jaire knew it too.

If I fail even once, that’s the end of it. That there will be no more opportunities. Isn’t that what hunting is all about? From the moment we set this beastly man as our goal, we both knew it.

If we don’t eat him, we’ll get eaten.

So, just before the last move, Jaire said he was sorry after saying goodbye. The life of his master must have been more important than me. I didn’t mean to blame him. It was the plan I insisted on despite the strong opposition of the roses.

Therefore.

I don’t want to fail.

Feeling that Chaser’s body was still not relaxed, I pulled my lips apart slightly.

Neither he nor I closed our eyes.

“It’s as you say. I don’t know how to love and to be loved.”

I narrowed his eyes as Chaser would.

“But.”

Like mocking him.

“I’ll give it to you at least once.”

While imitating his arrogance. My fallen lips overlap again. This time, too, was the moment when he stood still, observing him and judging the opportunity.

“..... Heup!”

My vision was completely turned. I just blinked my eyes wide.

Suddenly, the posture was reversed and I sat between Chaser's legs. He grabbed my waist and looked down at me.

I felt his tight thighs on my buttocks.

When our eyes met, he gave a languid smile.

Fortunately, my hand was still outstretched and the syringe hidden in my sleeve remained undetected. However, my lips were blocked and I could not speak.

His eyes slowly curve deeper and deeper. Eyes shining dangerously between the eyelids. The red eyes were as good as those of a beast.

Because it grabbed me tightly as if all his desires had been released.

Chaser closed his eyes. It's as if he was going to ignore everything from now on.

His kiss was skillful and gentle, unlike Ricdorian's clumsy but raw kiss. Even I, who had no idea, was so moved that I flinched.

He found a surprisingly sensitive place and touched it. I shifted my gaze while holding back my eyes from closing in on what I was looking for.

No more need to hide.

The syringe came out of my sleeve.

Without delay, I put it around his neck. Our lips parted and then overlapped again.

I thought Chaser would pull the syringe or jump up and throw me, or at least look at me with angry eyes. This moment was the most important. A cold sweat fills my hands.

However, Chaser's behavior was completely different from what I expected.

Chaser grabbed one of my hands and thrust the syringe deeper.

Chapter 203: So you will see

1. 1. So you will see

I widened my eyes.

He digs deeper, not letting go of the slightly opened lips. His hand was clasped tightly around my waist and gently rubbed over my waist.

“Huhk.....”

A strange sensation penetrated my spine. All the while, his gaze was fixed on me. As if to watch him sleep while stabbing him. It was a gaze that was intense and tenacious.

It was extremely poisonous, but it took some time for the drug to take effect. Even to buy time, I couldn't separate him.

As if recognizing the difficulty of not being able to take it off, Chaser entwined my hands and grinned. Then he pulled his lips apart for a moment and pressed them deep inside my neck and wrists.

“You..... Heup.”

However, for a moment, our lips met again.

Tick tock. The second hand flows.

I looked at the clock and held back the pleasure that flowed.

Chaser found a spot where I felt and gently rubbed and licked it. So much so that I couldn't stand it and grabbed his hand and locked him in my hand.

Still, he could not dig deep into my lips, and the ribbon on my chest gently loosened.

It was a close kiss, like running over a cliff.

I grabbed his neck and grabbed a handful of Chaser's back. I stared at him, Chaser smiled and pressed our lips together. His hand didn't move any more, just holding my waist.

The lips fall slowly.

And *tuk*, the syringe fell.

In an empty state.

I looked down at the empty syringe and raised my gaze. As I exhaled from the intense kiss, I gasped for breath.

"Hmm."

It was Chaser who spoke first.

"Cystamine poison, altapha grass, and curse magic were mixed. I don't know about the other one. Is this a new poison?"

Chaser whispered softly.

"I'm sure it's enough for me to listen. Iana."

The distance was still close as our lips had just separated after a violent kiss. I squeezed my lips shut as the exhalation pressed against my lips.

"I suppose so."

I casually rubbed my lips with the back of my hand and let out a voice.

"It is said that even three hundred elephants will be defeated, no matter how much you do, you will be knocked down."

“Aha.”

He didn't even respond to my words. My expression became strange.

“It's toxic. You might die.”

I poked his chest and looked at him indifferently. Chaser grabbed my finger and rolled his eyes.

“If it's in your hands, it's okay to die.”

“..... You are crazy.”

I stopped joking and hardened my expression.

“You. You know..... Why did you let it happen?”

He couldn't have not known. It was a series of incomprehensible events. This man, he's not the kind of man to be beaten, he's the one to grab me and pay me back the result with addition.

“So that. You will look after me.”

I could imagine what his face would have been like without seeing it myself. He was looking at me with an incomprehensible look.

“I don't think you're going to die like this.”

My tongue slowly wet my lips.

“It wasn't bad either.”

Chaser lowered his head and placed his head on my shoulder. Even though I was a little tired, I could feel his body slowing down at a glance.

“I don't think you're just running away, what do you need?”

Chaser hit exactly my intentions. I suddenly got goosebumps. Immediately, I bit my lip.

“..... The Emperor’s tiara.”

He was still noticing everything.

“Ah. That.”

Chaser’s laughter pierced my ears. It was a lower voice.

“..... Looks like you need it again this time.”

“Again this time?”

Chaser said nothing more.

“It’s in the basement. Do you know where it is?”

“..... I know.”

Chaser smirked. He groaned softly and rubbed his head against my shoulder.

“Take it.”

“You’re just giving it?”

“If you need it. Originally it was yours.”

I couldn’t see his face, but I could tell. Chaser’s voice was slowly getting smaller and lower as if crawling through a cave. It was a voice that sounded like a sleepy one.

Watching him fall asleep quietly without any resistance, I couldn’t help but ask.

“Why?”

He was the man who kept me locked up and tied up all the time.

“Why are you giving it?”

If I find this, I will leave without delay. He won't be unaware of that fact.

"You did me a favor."

Chaser whispers.

<Come and put me to sleep.>

I wanted to ask there.

"..... What are you doing?"

Isn't this your way?

"I love you, Iana."

But Chaser who answered was already asleep. I pushed his body and gently pushed him onto the sofa.

I turned my back on him, leaving him stunned as if asleep.

My bitten lip tingled, but I didn't care. I opened the door and walked away.

There was nobody in the hallway. It seemed that all of them had rushed to the city where Jaire was at Chaser's command. The people who guarded the mansion, especially around my room, were the most talented.

As I ran down the empty hallway, I had a strange feeling. It got bigger and bigger as I went down the stairs going down to the basement.

<I love you, Iana.>

Why is everyone so blind? I've never had true love. But there are things I've seen.

Love doesn't just mean sacrificing everything you have. It felt like a taut piano string was pulling me. Do I regret it? No. I would have laid him down the same way if the same moment came. Still, I didn't want to be in this space anymore. So maybe what was holding my ankle back.

I stopped walking slowly.

It was because I got to the basement. And I saw a small figure standing in front of the basement door.

“Marshmel.”

Because I am a human being, I may have given affection to those around me. Even to the one who snatched me up and to his cute subordinate.

“Long time no see, miss.”

Without change, the little warlock turned around. In his hand was a long wand, which I could not see very well. I know what that is. It was something he used to cast large-scale magic. For example, when he extended the chain that binds my ankles to the length of the mansion.

“Yes, long time no see.”

We greeted each other warmly as if there was no gap. To be honest, I was the only one who smiled warmly.

“I missed you.”

“What? Do you want to see me die by my master?”

“Hey, you won’t die.”

“Why?”

I shrugged my shoulders.

“I have put your master to sleep.”

Marshmel made a tired expression.

“You dear to do that. To Cheser.”

“Dear? You mean dare.”

“Dear!”

“Yes Yes. Dear.”

Both me and Marshmel have a relaxed expression on our faces, but I’m sure we both know. A thick layer of tension beneath the water. Marshmel let out a low sigh. I called such a marshmel.

“So you came to catch me?”

“No.”

Marshmel shook his head.

“I think I heard such a similar order.”

Then he murmured without looking at me.

“I couldn’t hear the exact order.”

So, it meant that he was going to close his eyes. I don’t know if he was going to let me pass or if he was letting me out.

“Then I need something over there, can you go? I’m busy right now.”

“Miss, you haven’t changed.”

“Of course. How can people change easily?”

As I opened the warehouse door, Marshmel’s wand touched my shoulder.

“Lady, did you receive the letter I sent you?”

“What? I never received anything like that.”

Marshmel frowned slightly. He gently shook his little head.

“Oh no. I’ve asked Marquis Valtaze. This man.”

“That’s why you should have been better.”

“What?”

I smiled and entered the warehouse. Strict surveillance magic and high-level multi-trap magic were applied to the warehouse, but I was an exception. Because Chaser made Marshmel modify this magic and made me unaffected.

It wasn’t difficult to get the emperor’s tiara out of the warehouse where I knew the way well. When I came out holding the tiara, Marshmel was standing leaning against the long wand.

“You haven’t gone yet?”

“What, what’s with those eyes like seeing a stray dog.”

“No, I didn’t see it that way.”

I smiled and waved what I was holding from my hand.

Seeing the emperor’s tiara, Marshmel’s eyes widened.

“Miss, are you going to enter Kambrakam?”

“What? Yes.”

“You want to go home?”

“What?”

What is this all of a sudden? I tilted my head, but nodded. And I noticed.

“Did you know Marshmel? About my identity.”

“.....”

“Somehow, from the beginning, you have been hard on me, even as the Miss. You knew I was fake.”

“I treat everyone that way.”

“Don’t brag.”

Marshmel ran a small hand over his head. It was a complicated and awkward expression.

“It’s black magic that saved a body that had lost its soul.”

So it sounds like he knows. Well, he is Chaser’s closest aide, so it might be strange if he doesn’t know. Of course, I thought that he would have known it all by himself. He was amazing.

“Brother seem to believe in Marshmel.”

“The Master must believe in my desperation. I want to go back to my original body.”

An unsuitable adulthood passes by with a face like a small child.

“Yes, I can’t help you, Miss.”

As much as I was attached to him, so was this little warlock. That’s why this mansion is so big and there are no people... It was a lonely place.

“But the Master said, if you’re in danger, I’ll tell you to go to a safe place.”

Marshmel wants to return to his original body, so he can’t betray Chaser.

“It looks like the 2nd Battalion Knights will come to this place? It will move you away from the threat.”

“Yes. Sure.”

I smiled and nodded. I was heartbroken for some reason.

“Thank you.”

After a wide smile, Marshmel’s face disappeared.

When I opened my eyes, I saw a familiar grassy forest. It was the back garden of the mansion.

It was also the place I visited when I first escaped from the mansion a long time ago.

‘Where should I go from here?’

Ricdorian was waiting for every door that could be exited. Time was running out, so I had to get out. With sweaty hands holding the crown from slipping, I lifted up my skirt and tied it up. Then, walking slowly, I untied the things that had adorned my hair. It was done to match Chaser’s taste.

Jewels disappearing through the grass, suddenly I was wearing only one light dress. As I walked, the road split in both directions.

‘Which way should I go?’

As I was thinking, I heard footsteps behind me. The sound of footsteps running in a hurry, at this moment, was never a pleasant sound to me.

“Is it here?”

“Look for it!”

Miss, Miss! I don’t know how they noticed it so quickly, but the 2nd Battalion Knights were looking for me. I looked back with a bewildered look and then quickly looked back at the road. What to do? I think this will be a very important choice. It was when I bit my lip.

Swhiip!

A long arrow hit the ground. I almost screamed in surprise, but managed to cover my lips.

“Did you hear a strange noise over there?”

“It’s an arrow. Crazy! Who shot the arrow? If she gets hurt..... Come on run!”

The sound of footsteps approaching stopped, and soon the sound of moving away was heard.

I then exhaled. At the same time, someone gently grabbed my shoulder.

“That way.”

It was a familiar voice. The main character with a soft voice is.....

Chapter 204: It's the Yellow Rose's turn

1. 1. It's the Yellow Rose's turn

Raising my head, I saw a man holding a longbow. He was on the lookout for his surroundings.

“..... Lenag?”

A golden energy was flowing from the bow. I thought it was a familiar feeling. Just like when Francia turned Callisto into a weapon, a white light emanated from the weapon. The elegant gold color of Azur was flowing from his bow.

Lenag's weapon was a bow. I thought that the elegant curve suited him very well.

“Your weapon suits you so well, Lenag.”

At my greeting, which did not match the situation, Lenag looked confused for a moment.

“Thank you, Miss Iana.”

Having said that, he looked around once more. Then he stood in front of me, covering me, raised his bow and took an aim. At the same time, the shape of the bow became smaller. Curiously, even though there was no arrow pointing, when he pulled the string, a translucent arrow flew off.

Whip-

A groan was heard along with a thumping sound. There was also the sound of something crashing down.

“It would be dangerous to stay here any longer. Iana.”

I also had the same thought. The knights that showed up so far had been dealt with by Lenag, but I did not know how much more would come. In addition, I didn't know how long Chaser would remain unconscious. Lenag folded his knee and held out his hand to me.

“Can you excuse me for a second?”

The moment I saw Lenag's face, I thought he was wearing his glasses even at this moment. As expected, the thought of him wearing glasses stuck very stubbornly.

The moment I thought about it, a bitter smile came out.

“..... Ummm, I can run but.....”

His face seemed to cry out that there was no time.

“We don't have time, right.”

“Yes.”

“So I think that's what I was going to say. I'll excuse you.”

I grabbed his hand and muttered. I took his hand, but he paused for a moment. However, this was only for a moment. Lenag took my hand lightly and wrapped his arm around my waist. Soon after, my toes float.

Really. Everyone carries me well. A human body wouldn't be that light.

The grassy forest sped by. Lenag ran at such a speed that it was unbelievable that he was doing it while holding a person.

“Where are we going?”

There must be an inner gate near here. It was an unfamiliar way to go.

“I will cross the wall.”

“The wall?”

I saw the high wall. Isn't it too high to cross over?

“If you run straight, you will come to a section where the wall is lowered. It's a part where it's more like a partition than a wall.”

“Aha.”

As Lenag said, as we ran a little further, there was a section where the walls were lower for a while. Lenag explained that perhaps that section was originally blocked to build a gate.

“Originally, there was strict surveillance there as well, but there was a commotion and everyone headed towards the inner gate and main gate.”

The knights must have thought I would be going out the gates. Well I actually did that.

“I'm glad I'm such an easy-to-understand person.”

“It's just a pattern that people usually think of.”

Lenag said, looking up at the wall.

“..... And Miss Iana is by no means easy to understand.”

But strangely enough, the word had a faint playfulness. I got a little startled and tried to look at him, but Lenag's movement was faster than that. Lenag, who took a big leap at once, stepped on the stones protruding from the wall one by one. It was like watching a goat climb a cliff.

But when he swooped up to the top of the wall, Lenag jumped down at once without delay. I sighed and closed my eyes tightly.

‘I feel like riding a roller coaster here.’

I remember I didn’t like roller coasters that much in my previous life either.....

When I opened my eyes, we reached the ground again. I let out a slow breath.

“Are you okay?”

Before I knew it, Lenag was looking down at me with a worried face.

“..... I’m okay.”

“You don’t look too good.”

“It’s because I was surprised when we jumped a little while ago. It was a feeling I never knew how to feel.”

I smiled and patted his arm.

“You helped me, so I wouldn’t be so mean to whine here.”

“..... What if I say it’s okay for you to be so mean and whine here?”

“Yes?”

Lenag said ‘it was nothing’ and shook his head gently. His hair, coming loose, moved together.

Come to think of it, while I was holding onto his hem, I might have also been holding his hair. Did it hurt?

“Miss Iana, I have good news and bad news.”

“Which one should I listen to first?”

“As you wish.”

I don't have time, so I asked him to explain both quickly.

"The good news is that from the moment you step out of the wall, you are free from Chaser."

He turned his head and pointed. Lenag moved his gaze to the place he beckoned, and I saw people waiting.

"That is my soldier."

"Ah."

It was a good thing that Chaser's knights were still searching the inside of the mansion.

"Then the bad news?"

Then Lenag closed his mouth for a moment.

"Before I came here, the roses made bets. No, it's more of a fierce deal and negotiation."

The statement was out of the blue, but I listened quietly.

"The Domulit mansion has three gates. The main gate, the inner gate, and the secret back gate."

"Right."

It was a fact that I knew. The back gate wasn't my discovery, but a spy of Hernim's.

"After a fierce argument, we decided to take on defense one by one. Each one is in charge of the main gate, the inner gate, the back gate, and so on."

That being said, that means Lenag was in charge of the inner gate.

"We agreed to take you somewhere safe if Miss Iana appears in our direction."

“Uh..... Thank you.”

I had thought that a fight had not happened. It was only because of Chaser that they got together, but the three of them were often violent like flashes of bombs.

“The bad news. Miss Iana.”

Lenag’s soft voice landed on my ear. It was when I thought that the more I looked, the more I could not balance his soft voice and bloody eyes. His lips were raised.

“The destination would be Hernim’s castle, but my wizard’s skills are not good enough, so it’s difficult to move there at once.”

“Ah..... I see.”

“Yes. So, we will have to go to the Valtaze mansion first, how about that?”

I nodded meekly.

“Contact.....”

“Of course I will.”

Lenag said so and smiled bitterly. After a moment of silence, he continued.

“I can’t help but do it anyway.”

It was a given.

“And with the Grand Duke’s character, he will be persistently in touch soon.”

“Hahaha.....”

There would be a commotion, if he found out that both he and Francia had not met me.

It seemed that Lenag subtly slanted the pronunciation of the word ‘Grand Duke’ but I pretended not to know it. He had to meet again with Ricdorian again anyway. Our purpose was to save his life. It seemed that Lenag was also speaking with this in mind.

In that case. When I got the tiara, It shouldn’t matter where I went. It was more urgent to get out of here right now.

“By the way, Lenag.”

I tilted my head.

“Come to think of it..... you look happy?”

Lenag paused.

“..... You are mistaken.”

He rolled his eyes slightly, then slightly curved them.

“It’s just..... I feel the sadness of not being able to fully serve you due to the lack of subordinates.”

I don’t think he’s making a sad face. Judging by the way he was avoiding my gaze, I thought this man was not good at lying.

But it wouldn’t be a complete lie. In fact, Jaire said that only an Archmage like himself could move that span of distance at once.

Even he was assisted by a magic circle. Thinking of the distance between Domulit and Hernim, I nodded. I agreed with that. When I go out and meet Francia or Lenag, who is not like Ricdorian, of course we cannot go to Hernim right away. I seemed to understand why the three of them were torn about it.

“Then we don’t seem to have time, so let’s go right away.”

I scolded him with a laughing voice. Of course, time was running out. We never know when the door will open and the knights will run out.

As I said that, he bowed his head and smiled slightly. All of them are great people, but how can they be so naive in front of me? While smiling, the question in the corner of my heart grew bigger and bigger. How did this blind relationship start?

“Let’s go.”

Lenag’s wizard drew a familiar magic circle, followed by the blue light of white magic wrapping around us. The moment I saw the blue light, something came to my mind. The blue light on Chaser’s hand.

The man who dangerously had the power of two roses. I knocked him down, but somehow I had a strong feeling that it wouldn’t be the end.

“We’ve arrived.”

When I opened my eyes, I saw an elegantly styled mansion.

“Welcome to the Vataize mansion.”

Lenag, who muttered so much, didn’t look at my face for some reason.

“Lenag?”

“Ah. I’m sorry.”

“I never thought this would happen in my lifetime.....”

He whispered softly without looking at me.

“..... I’m happy.”

Conversely, instead of his face, I could barely see his ears, whose top part had already blushed red. I rolled my eyes and remembered that I was still in his arms. But if I had reminded him of this, his face would have been even more red.

“I wasn’t expecting a situation like this, so I’m worried if I will be able to serve you well, but.....”

For now, we decided to stay at Lenag's mansion for a while before moving again, so it seemed better if we were more comfortable with each other. I casually threw out a nonchalant manner to relieve his tension.

"Don't be nervous."

While stroking his arm.

"If we were married, I would have lived here, right?"

It was an engagement, wasn't it? Of course, it didn't happen, but I meant to assume it would make him feel comfortable. But I guess this was the source of the issue itself. There seemed to be a popping sound from somewhere.

Oops. Did I say something wrong?

"Those..... those words."

When I looked up, Lenag was trying to hide his messy, red face.

Unlike Ricdorian, who recognizes that his face blushes easily, he seemed unfamiliar with himself.

"Uh, are you okay?"

He shook his head as he grabbed his face.

"Haa..... Don't look."

Eventually, he said, as if pleading to me.

"Because I was happy just imagining it. I'm going to be a mess."

Chapter 205: Don't you like it with your heart? (1)

1. 1. Don't you like it with your heart? (1)

Lenag's house was large and elegant. The necessities of each space were properly arranged and in harmony.

Like Hernim, which is large but has a strong feeling of emptiness, this is also large and elegant, but it's the opposite of Domulit, which has a bloody and tense feeling.

'It feels like a real home.'

I looked up at the ceiling with a little curious mind.

As you know, Lenag's occupation is the prison's manager. As his workplace is a prison, his house should probably be the most bleak, but it felt quite strange that the opposite was actually the case. Rather, it was the most homely feeling among castles and mansions I had ever seen.

After resting in the room he showed me, half a day had passed and it was now evening.

"Did you like the meal?"

I slept for a little while, so dinner was held a bit late.

"Yes. It was very tasty."

I'm not particularly picky about meals. Nevertheless, I mimicked using a knife in the air, showing that it was delicious.

“I especially liked the grilled food. Oh, the stew too.”

It really was. I could live even by eating things that weren't quite my favorite, but the ones I ate here were also very delicious. This is a world where magic has developed altogether, so you can eat food hot as if it was freshly made anytime, anywhere.

“I am glad that you liked it.”

Lenag put down the teacup from the other side.

“I'm usually not picky about it, but it was delicious. Really.”

We were having a cup of tea in the parlor after dinner.

“I see. I'm glad the pleasure of making it myself had paid off.”

“Yes?”

The next moment I paused at Lenag's words. I almost forgot the teacup. I quickly set the cup away and raised my head.

“Did you make it yourself?”

“Yes.”

As I asked bewilderedly, he only replied calmly.

“Uh.... You are good at cooking.”

Ordinarily, how did noble men know how to cook? No, they don't. Even if I lack common sense, it was by no means common. My face hardened a little. I think I ate a more valuable meal than I thought.

“I didn't mean to say that you should be burdened.”

“Ah. No. That's not it. I think I ate a more valuable meal than I thought.”

I rubbed my cheek with my index finger and rolled my eyes.

“Then I have to say thank you even more. I don’t think anyone is able to eat it.”

“That... That’s right.”

“What?”

“Because it was a meal for just one person.”

I was speechless and rolled my eyes. Looking at Lenag’s face, it seems that what he said was 100% pure, selfless sincerity. He didn’t even have a face to wish for anything, so I got even more troubled.

I opened my lips as casually as possible.

“I’m just asking, just in case. Did I say that I like a family man before?”

I wondered if this was also what ‘Iana’ left behind. Lenag shook his head.

“You don’t, though. If you like a family man, I’d be happy to....”

“No, no. That’s not what I mean.”

“Do you not like it?”

“No, I was going to say ‘hoo, it’s a good thing’. I didn’t mean to ask like that.”

“I’m sure you’ve never said that before, but... You said something similar.”

Lenag grabbed his chin and nodded his head slightly.

“It was a passing word, so you may not remember it.”

Of course, he paused a moment at those words. So that means ... In other words, he started cooking with just one passing word?

“You said a long time ago that delicious food is good.”

“... It’s delicious, because everyone likes it.”

“You also said that you want to try something made by someone you love.”

“.....”

That seems fine to me too. Coincidentally, I thought that ‘Iana’ and my taste overlapped in some way.

I was speechless and looked over his shoulder. Then, he stroked his face for a long time. A small sigh escaped.

“Thinking about it.”

I grabbed the teacup handle and let it go.

“I have never returned it properly after receiving all the favors.”

“No. I don’t think so.”

Lenag put his hand to his chest.

“It’s a favor that I gave because I liked you.”

This man had a knack for lightening the hearts of other people. And sometimes this makes people’s hearts heavier. Ironically, that is.

“Are we going back tomorrow?”

“For now, we’ll do that.”

Lenag removed his hand from his chest, grabbed the teacup slightly, and set it aside.

“Oh, and the contact.”

The contact would mean it’s a call to Ricdorian, to Hernim’s side.

“I will try to contact them tomorrow.”

“Ah yes.”

I thought he already did. He hasn't done it yet? I tilted my head.

Lenag showed some jewels in front of me. Precisely, it was a jewel-encrusted necklace, with the central jewel gleaming as if on fire. He said this is a communication device. It can communicate from far away.

“... this light is continuously shining?”

“Maybe it's a call from Hernim.”

Lenag said softly.

“I'm getting calls like crazy, but I'm not receiving them.”

“Ahaha, yes.”

I don't think it's something to say so softly. I just smiled while thinking about it.

“Since I have already joined hands with the White Rose, he would have expected Miss Iana to be here by now.”

“Um, that's right.”

“If it wasn't for that, I would have heard the news that a huge number of soldiers were gathered in front of the Domulit Mansion.”

If I hadn't been able to get out, it sounds like there would have been a war. I laughed awkwardly. They don't have to be this unconditional.

“Maybe he might be busy rushing right now.”

Lenag's long finger tapped the handle of his cup.

“If they don't know the coordinates, they won't be able to use movement magic.”

He narrowed his eyes. It was as if he was judging the situation.

“He might be running on horseback.”

Likewise, I had the same thought. If it was Ricdorian, I had a feeling that he would come running somehow. So I didn’t forcefully insist on contacting him. Because I thought I’d see him again tomorrow at the earliest. Maybe he knows too.

Nevertheless, Lenag smiled.

“And by the time the Grand Duke arrives here, I would like to move Miss Iana.”

It was a soft voice like the spring breeze, but the meaning it contained was not.

“... What? Where?”

“To Hernim’s castle.”

“You are mean.”

“Please allow this level of meanness.”

He lowered his head as he lifted the teacup, his face softened.

“I won’t put you at risk.”

“Umm. I think you’ve chosen the wrong target for retaliation.... Aren’t you supposed to do it for me?”

“No. It was a good choice.”

If that’s the case, I don’t have anything to say. I felt sorry for Ricdorian, but for a day or so, I decided to let Lenag’s grumpy attitude slide. Because I owed Lenag a lot.

After drinking tea, we moved from the tea table to the sofa. Since there was no attendant in the room at all, Lenag showed this strange appearance of clearing the table himself.

Perhaps he was comfortable to clean up by himself due to his personality.

He said that he had grown accustomed to it due to the fact that he does not have a separate servant in Kambrakam. I leaned my head on the sofa and closed my eyes after watching him put away the items. I slept for a while as soon as I came here, but I was still tired. It's because I haven't slept well while in Domulit.

'I should have taken the chance.'

Maybe it's because the tension has been relieved, so the sleepiness keeps pouring out without a hitch.

I think I closed my eyes for a while. How long was it?

It felt like something was moving in front of me. Without realizing it, I opened my eyes. And a hand stopped in front of me. Lenag's hand was floating in the air.

"Ah...."

"Ung, Lenag?"

I rubbed my eyes and straightened my neck. I slept in an uncomfortable position and my neck was stiff. When I opened my eyes again, Lenag was standing there with a lost face, not knowing what to do. His hand was still hovering in the air.

He was probably trying to reach out to me.

Lenag was startled and pulled his hand back. He looked perplexed, as if he didn't intend to.

"I thought you were sleeping in an uncomfortable position, so I kept calling you.... You didn't wake up."

“Ah. Were you trying to wake me up? It’s okay.”

I reached out and patted his arm. Then I tapped the seat next to me. He held his breath and sat down next to me.

I glanced at the elegant figure and opened my mouth.

“I think I said that a while ago.”

I thought for some reason, I might not ever have time to talk so quietly and calmly with Lenag in the future again. So, I had to say what I had to say in this moment.

“Is there anything you want from me?”

The eyes of different colors crossed in the calming silence. His golden eyes blinked slowly as if embracing the Yellow Rose. He was a calm and neat man, with sharp eyes and even a surprised look.

“I can listen to it now.”

“... anything?”

A man who had been extremely reluctant until a while ago quietly asked back.

“Really, can you listen to anything?”

Chapter 206: Don't you like it with your heart? (2)

1. Don't you like it with your heart? (2)

If he was usually a playful person, this might look awkward, but he was always a serious and an orderly man. I nodded my head slightly as I met his sharp-forged eyes. Slowly, so he doesn't misunderstand.

“Anything.”

His eyes deepened for an instant. At the same time, a hesitation seemed to pass. To guess..... I don't think there's anything he wanted or he was thinking about it. Perhaps even though he said this, he seemed to be stirring inside.

In the end, I reached out first.

“Did you have anything in mind?”

Pat. When my hand touched him, he flinched. His slightly widened eyes made me burst out laughing.

He was a person with a very scary and serious face as the basics, so even a little surprise would result in him making a completely different expression. I grabbed the tip of his finger. Although he showed a slight embarrassment, he did not avoid it.

“Is what I was thinking right?”

“You're right.”

He breathed in and answered. I could see his neck moving down in a gulp.

“Then tell me.”

His gaze falls down.

“I think you’ll find it difficult.”

“I don’t think so.”

Having said that, I paused for a moment..... Hold it.

‘What if we kiss here?’

It may have been a far-fetched imagination, but I suddenly became serious for no reason. To put it simply, it was inevitable. I don’t think there’s a law saying I can’t do it with all the roses in the same sense as Chaser, but.....

‘It feels like kissing Francia on the cheek while I’m doing this, but Lenag.....’

Having been thinking about something absurd, I shook my head lightly. It was just a stupid idea. I didn’t want to think too much about Lenag. I just wanted to avoid getting serious as much as possible, but I didn’t avoid the situation. The words have already been spit out anyway?

“So what is it?”

“That.....”

Lenag, who lowered his head in hesitation, looked at me. The eyes showed determination.

“Then if you don’t find it difficult.....”

It was difficult.

‘I said I wouldn’t find it difficult, but.....’

I’m sorry for him, but this is difficult. It’s not just difficult. It was *very* difficult. I covered my face. I didn’t know what to say about this situation.

“Excuse me, Lenag.”

He looked at me as if he had been preparing for a while. My lips open and close.

Can I say I’m going to back down now? Is he really going to do it?

However, not a single word could come out of my mouth. Even so, what should I do as the person who brought it up in the first place? I just half buried my face in my hands and shook my head.

“..... nothing.”

As I said that, he laid something down in front of me as if everything was ready.

And seeing him put it down made me even more disturbed. Because it was none other than steaming water in a basin or something. It’s a large basin, but at first glance, I was more disturbed when I looked at the bowl that was covered with gold leaf and looked very expensive.

In the end, I couldn’t stand it and said,

“I’m sorry, Lenag.”

“Yes. Please tell me.”

“Because I’m not the type of person to go back on my words.”

“Yes. Go ahead.”

He lowered his head as if he knew what I was going to say. It was just him and me in the parlor. I think it’s really fortunate that no one else can see this kind of scene.

“Yes, I don’t think this is a good thing, so once again. No. No. I will ask you one last time.”

I pointed down with my finger.

“Are you really okay with this?”

“Yes.”

He laughed a little. Obviously, his hard expression softened as I had allowed him. However,

“You want to wash my feet!”

But the problem is that his wish is absurd.

“Do you have any problems?”

“Don’t you think so? The..... feet. Usually the attendant washes it, and I know how to do it myself.”

“Yes. I am well aware of that.”

No, but why was he making a wish like this? I mean, I was prepared to hear something bigger and grander. I’m fully prepared, too! It was so absurd that I was at a loss for words.

“Why the feet?”

“What?”

“There are the hands, the arms. There’s the body.....”

Then Lenag turned his head and grabbed his cheek lightly. He looked embarrassed and was at a loss of what to do.

“I don’t know if it’s somewhere else, but the body is a little.....”

“No. It’s just a figure of speech.”

Of course, it was not without a guess beforehand.

“Well, Lenag, this is a question that I am cautious about, maybe you have a taste for something like this. A, a desire.”

“What?”

“Maybe towards the foot.....”

“What? I don’t know what you’re talking about, but no.”

He flatly denied it. He seemed to be surprised by the word ‘desire’.

“No, it’s nonsense. I was just asking.....”

I know. I don’t think that’s the case, so I went and started asking the wrong questions. Well maybe he has a desire for..... Liking feet in particular. The nonsense is getting haywire here.

I sighed and asked the real question.

“Is this something that I have said carelessly before?”

“.....”

He didn’t answer. The silence meant an affirmation. I smiled bitterly as I buried my face in my hands again. At this point, I was wondering what ‘Iana’ had in her mind. To resolutely follow her tastes one by one.

Lenag grabbed the end of the bowl and released it.

“Sorry. I think I made a very difficult request.”

Lenag, who tapped the rippling water, immediately lifted his head and looked at me.

“Then this never happens.....”

“No. Please.”

It wasn't that Lenag had strange tastes. I don't know under what circumstances 'Iana' in the past had brought up these words, but he even remembered the passing words. On top of that, I said I would listen. I had no intention of going back.

"Let's get it done once."

I lifted my skirt slightly and dipped my toe into the water. Then he smiled in trouble.

"This is embarrassing."

Rather than embarrassing, I wondered if I had done something like this in my life.

"..... Miss Iana had said something before."

Lenag, who was facing me, exhaled a little.

"Did you run in slippers?"

Excuse me, with a small greeting, his hand gently grabbed my ankle. His hand was so large that my ankle was caught in one hand.

"This is water mixed with herbs."

He was also a swordsman, so a long scar was visible on his hand. No. His weapon was a bow, though?

He poured water over the top of my foot and continued his words.

"I was worried that you might get hurt because you ran in a hurry today."

As he said, there were small scratches on my ankles and the back of my feet. Inside the Domulit mansion, I wore indoor shoes, which were not suitable for running.

However, in order to deceive Chaser's eyes, I could not change shoes beforehand, and there was no time to do so after taking Chaser down. Was

he thinking of something that even I had not thought of? I was a little surprised. Because it was unexpected.

“If you just leave it alone, it will get better soon.”

“That’s right.”

Lenag agreed.

“Of course, wounds are anything over time..... I want your time with pain to be short.”

Looking at his face, I couldn’t bear to say that it didn’t hurt. Eventually I nodded and gave him my foot.

Splash.

For a while, only the sound of water splashing and pouring was filling the parlor. The warm body temperature and the warm water make me feel drowsy. I rubbed my eyes to chase away my sleepiness.

“But I have a question.....”

I still thought this wasn’t the case, but it turns out he seemed softer and more pleasant than usual. So instead of pointing it out, I brought up another story. I intended to drive out the awkwardness through conversation.

“Please say it.”

Come to think of it, I was at a crossroads when I met him at Domulit’s garden today.

“Did the other direction at the crossroads today lead to another gate?”

I asked, just in case. In this slightly awkward situation, I wanted to relax the atmosphere while not having much to say. However, he gave an unexpected response. Lenag looked troubled.

He grabbed my foot and lowered his eyes slightly.

“That’s right.”

I let out a small laugh.

“Lenag, you really can’t lie.”

He rolled his eyes in embarrassment. Like a man who heard words he would never have heard in his life.

“Not necessarily, but..... Maybe in front of Miss Iana.”

I don’t think he’s aware that he was being very honest even with this figure.

“..... Do you not like it?”

“It is better to be honest than to lie.”

As I said that, I lightly rubbed my cheeks that were splashed with water.

“It is difficult and annoying to know whether the other person is lying or not.”

It might be rather lazy to not even make such an effort. Anyway, I felt like that. Saying this, I clenched my chin. Even during a conversation, he looked diligent. He’s a hard worker for just about anything.

As he grabbed my foot, I was able to see Lenag’s face up close, and I saw a small hairline crack in his glasses.

‘Are your glasses cracked?’

It was so subtle that I wouldn’t notice it unless I looked closely. However, I had heard from someone that it was very annoying and bad for eyesight while wearing glasses.

Of course, Lenag wasn’t really bad-eyed, but..... It wouldn’t have had no impact. I tapped Lenag’s shoulder.

“Hey, Lenag. I think there’s a hair crack in your glasses.”

“Oh, did you see it? I don’t have clear glasses.”

“Are there others?”

“There was, but everything was broken.”

He smiled slightly as if nothing was wrong. Glasses are not for battle. And he was a man of position and title that was not far from battle. I pondered for a moment, then removed my hand from my chin.

“Can you excuse me?”

“It’s okay if it’s Miss Iana, but.....”

After hesitating, I cautiously reached out my hand. Slowly, just like when he was holding my foot carefully, I took off Lenag’s glasses.

“Miss Iana?”

“It’s okay.”

I looked into his face and said clearly again. So that he doesn’t miss a word.

“I’m not afraid anymore.”

He looked like he was about to cry.

“So, you don’t have to wear glasses.”

“It’s..... uncomfortable.”

I said one more time.

“It’s not scary.”

He couldn’t stand it and lowered his head. Are you crying?

No, he looks like he will cry. For some reason, it felt certain. But when he looked up, he wasn’t crying.

Instead, in a low voice.....

“I love you.”

He confessed to me.

The moment I saw his face, I knew that he was just not crying yet.

“This feeling I hold even though I know it will be a trouble to you.....
What should I do? Yet I hold them.”

Before he could say anything more, I reached out my hand.

Drop.

The glasses fall to the floor.

“No, Lenag.”

I whispered softly, covering his eyes.

“I have something to tell you.”

Maybe I should have talked a little sooner.

I’m sorry for him, but now I know. I realized it late. I am not the one who should see these tears. What this person, who was too pure with such a sharp face, has in his chest, the feeling..... That should not be taken lightly.

I reflected on the time I had wasted carelessly. And, I just found out now. Why did it have to be today? Why did I have a foreboding that today would be the last time I had a quiet conversation with him?

Because I know I can’t go back to our previous relationship if I tell him everything today.

But I had to tell him.

Me.

I am not 'Iana'.

It was time to say so.

“Don't do it.”

His words were faster. His hands overlapped mine and then grabbed onto it.

“Lenag? Wait, It's not that, it's important.”

I was afraid because it felt like he was rejecting me, so I tried to speak quickly. But he held my hand firmly.

“No. Don't do it.”

Intercepting my words, he said quickly.

“..... what you want to say I know.”

Lenag's lips trembled slightly. Like a tree swaying in the wind, so violently. I felt him closing his eyes. I could feel the water on my palm. Then, a voice so weak that it was unbelievable that it was Lenag's voice came out in difficulty.

“..... I know.”

Chapter 207: It's called love

1. 1. It's called love

He knows, what does he mean by that? I scanned his face, trying not to show my emotions. Because I covered his eyes, I could only see half of his face.

“What do you know?”

“Maybe. Everything.”

It felt like he knew only half of what I was revealing. But at the same time I noticed what he was talking about.

“I know.”

If his words had been mournful as if he couldn't admit it a while ago, now the tone was filled with conviction.

“That you don't remember our first meeting.”

His voice came out so calmly that I was startled. My hands trembled impatiently.

“Maybe, you don't even remember all the memories with me.”

I moved my lips. I didn't know what to say. The lips never opened. In the end, I couldn't find anything to say.

I knew very well that I was too clumsy in comforting people. There was nothing I could do other than being silent in a situation where I couldn't even give comfort.

“Anyone who has seen you before will know.”

He muttered with his half exposed face.

“.....You’re like a..... Different person.....”

How does it feel to have someone you love become a different person one day?

“The fact that you no longer remember what I remember..... I knew right away.”

I don’t know to what extent Lenag knows. But in the end, when you can’t remember amounts to you becoming a different person.

He would know better because he loved Iana.

“So maybe..... maybe.”

I can feel the trembling of his eyelashes. His voice trembled slightly as if following it.

“You woke up from the dead one day and lost all your memories.”

He tried to speak with difficulty.

“The you I know is gone.”

But towards the end, the breath scatters like a pant. His attempts to catch his breath were broken and his breath turned into vapors in each exhalation, but he struggled to finish his words.

“When you open your eyes again, you are..... you are.....”

In the end, he couldn’t speak. I knew what he wanted to say in his silence.

“Completely new.....”

One day, the 'Iana' that this man knows disappears. There was someone else instead.

"I was trying to be calm."

He was the head of a huge organization called Kambrakam. He couldn't not have noticed. I wasn't the only one who pretended not to know and closed our eyes.

I kept my lips shut.

He looked like he didn't want to talk. I didn't seem to want to admit it. Do I have to force the person who had their eyes closed to open their eyes? Or should I continue pretending not to know?

"Maybe, you are right. What if the person you loved is no longer in this world?"

Even so, in the end, I told the man the truth that I didn't want to tell him. What would he do if the person in front of him was just a stranger?

Tears streamed down my palms.

"I told you I know, right? And that was a long time ago..... Maybe I realized it since the first time in a sense."

His lips, which could neither smile nor cry, spat out a soft voice as if caring for me even at this moment.

"Even though I knew it, my heart couldn't help but beat for you in front of me."

His lips clenched and opened.

"Again..... again. Falling in love was not difficult."

I gradually realized.

"What should I do?"

The voice that flows out plainly was actually a confession that came out of his heart.

“Even you who didn’t know your family well, that is lovely.”

He gasped with his mouth shut.

“What should I do…….”

I didn’t ask what confusion he was having. I can only guess with a painful voice. In the end, I didn’t even ask what he had decided to do at the end of that love.

“I won’t ask you what you’ve been thinking. But Lenag, now……. If you realize something, wouldn’t it be right for our relationship to change as well?”

Now that he knows everything. I was trying to tell him that the situation was different. I have no memory, and if he knew that I was someone else, he would only suffer more in the future.

Even more so if that love is attributed to ‘Iana’.

“I can’t give it back to you.”

“You don’t have to give it back.”

“It’s painful.”

Above all, even if he really loved me, I couldn’t give it back to him. He shook his head.

“It doesn’t matter if you don’t remember me. If you can’t get it back, and you can’t remember it, I’ll just have to deal with it.”

His voice sinks low. He ended up throwing the last question and tears altogether.

“Then where should I let the heart that had already loved?”

While gently rejecting my refusal again. It was pathetic to see the strong man who was like a sharp knife collapse.

I looked at him sadly and moved my hand slightly.

“Let’s wipe your tears and talk.”

I thought I should wipe away his tears first, so I tried to remove my hand, but he grabbed my hand and shook his head once more.

“Don’t look.”

He hesitated and added a little.

“It’s ugly.”

“It’s not ugly.”

“.....I hope you don’t...see it.”

To be honest, it’s not appropriate for the situation, but..... The face of the handsome crying man was a superb view. It would never be ugly.

I exhaled a little.

“I see. Alright.”

Then I remove his hand from my hand. His hand flinched, but I didn’t care and placed his hand on my face.

“We can do this, right?”

We covered each other’s eyes. A small laugh leaks out of the slightly ridiculous appearance.

“I’ll pretend I haven’t heard anything.”

I’ve already heard and said everything, but I’m still saying this for his sake.

“You didn’t cry, and I didn’t see it either.”

The truths he said and don’t want to know. This was a consideration for this man’s desperate love.

“So tell me. If you go back, what would you like to do?”

If only we could go back to when I didn’t listen. I added.

This world is the world that Chaser turned back. ‘Iana’ only had an empty body and only her body was alive. I don’t know when he turned it back. Maybe it was after ‘Iana’ met Lenag for the first time? I’m just guessing cautiously.

So.

“I’ll do whatever you want.”

His love should not be taken lightly. I hoped that the man who had loved the dead all by himself would not suffer any more. It was sad. I wanted to give it back to him who could have just finished it carelessly, or done well so far.

Give up or wake up. Whether he falls into the illusion he made himself. So that he can choose.

I heard a small wheezing. I also couldn’t see because my eyes were covered, but he seemed to be smiling.

“Miss Iana, you are such a cruel person.”

He muttered softly, ‘to choose the you of the past or the you of the present’.

“You are in front of someone you will never see again.”

I didn’t actually want to say that, but I waited for his answer without questioning.

“The beginning is a long time ago. Very long. Even so, you want to focus on what’s right in front of you.”

When I opened my eyes, I could see a faint light shining through the crack in my hand. I can see his face split between his wide fingers.

“If the person I see now is you who claims to be someone else.”

Long tears formed at the tip of the sharp and delicate jaw line. How can even tears resemble him? Drops of water that couldn’t even fall, pitifully, flow down to the top of his neck.

“What if I can not erase this heart?”

He took his hand away for a moment.

The large hand caressed my face and covered my eyes again. He must have thought it made me uncomfortable. I quietly let him cover my eyes.

Someone said that the human eye is the window of truth. I’m sure it was a gesture that contained lies.

In another sense, maybe the eyes represent the person. Even with the same body, different people have different eyes. I had a habit of avoiding people’s eyes, so he may have noticed it for a long time.

So in the end.

“You were the only person in Kambrakam that made me smile, and you were always like the raindrops in my life that was like dry land.”

I covered his tears.

“Even if you are no longer there.”

Maybe he ignored the truth that was flowing out of my eyes.

“Like a sunflower that grows toward the sun. I just want to love you just the way you are.”

He was a very warm-hearted man. That's why I thought his hands would be warm.

"As I said, it wasn't difficult to fall in love again."

Contrary to the words, his trembling voice seemed to indicate that it was never easy to see me differently.

"..... I want to love you. Now, I think I will die without you."

He finally uttered one last word.

"The present you..... I want to love you."

Did 'Iana' really know? The fact that there are people who are weeping as if the world has disappeared just at the mention of her disappearance. And the man who wept sadly over his new love was sweet and lovable. So that even the indifferent me felt that my heart hurt so much.

"I will not dare to ask for love."

At this moment, Chaser's words ran through my head. The Yellow Rose that has never been chosen for a long time.

"Can I love you?"

What were the thoughts of those who were labeled a traitor for a long time for just one mistake?

"Even if I'm not the 'Iana' I used to be?"

"....."

He didn't answer. Only tears were dropping. He would have known. The one he loved the first time never comes back. I didn't know what he was feeling.

"Yes. I can breathe just by being right in front of you."

Even if he loves me now, I won't be able to repay him in the same way. And if this is just the illusion of wanting to love the present me.

“Lenag.”

It was an earnest wish from him.

“Allow me to love you.”

Even if this love was an illusion that bloomed in confusion, I was willing to cover it up. To a man who may be in love with someone who is no longer in this world, or who may have started a one-sided love again after a long unrequited love.

“You may love me.”

I gave the saddest permission.

At that moment, his hand fell from my eyes.

“Yes.”

And there was a man with a smile on his face that I had never seen before. A soft smile that no longer had the courtesy of wearing the glasses.

“Iana.”

I realized. My thinking so far is wrong.

“I love you. Just like before. No, maybe even more.”

All he loved was me. He looks straight at me and says love.

“I.”

He carefully grabbed my hand and kissed the back of my hand.

“I will always be one step behind you.”

Acting like he was going to die without me. With that appearance of asking to stay by my side.

“As long as you give me permission.”

“..... Yes.”

After saying this, I thought for a moment. Chaser says that a rose that is not loved ends up going crazy.

At the same time, there was me who understood and accepted this deformed relationship little by little.

“Iana!”

It was two days later that I met Ricdorian again.

The day after Lenag confessed to me, Lenag moved to Hernim’s mansion with an empty face, and his prediction was exactly right. Hernim’s castle, where no one was there, welcomed us. Ricdorian was leaving for the Valtaize mansion. It took him a full day to get back, and after two days I saw him again.

I alternately glanced at the smashed door and Ricdorian. I burst into a small laugh as I thought about what the door’s crime was to be smashed like that.

“Ricdorian.”

There were tears and smiles that bloomed brightly like flower buds bursting at one time on my little call. Running like a large beast, he stopped in front of me and hesitated.

“What are you hesitating about?”

“I was wondering if I could hug you.”

I laughed out loud and then opened my arms.

“Then you can do this, right? Uhp!”

I almost bit my tongue. As soon as I allowed it, my feet floated in the air. He looked up at me, hugging my thighs.

“You surprised me.”

“Ah..... Sorry.”

Ricdorian lowered his gaze sullenly, then said quickly.

“It’s so nice to see you.”

It was then that I realized something was in his hand. It was the Emperor’s tiara. He put it over my head and smiled brightly. The twinkling sunlight reflected on it.

“Iana, the moment I saw you, I was happy as if the sun had risen again.”

This chapter is so long but so beautiful, I don’t have the heart to split it T^T

Chapter 208: Guardian Deity of the Blue Rose

1. 1. Guardian Deity of the Blue Rose

I could not help but panic. Since when can he choose only such pretty words? *This* guy? The guy who barked all the time.

Maybe I still haven't completely recovered from his afterimage as a child. I naturally touched his cheek with a smile.

But as he strode forward for a moment, I was startled and quickly grabbed Ricdorian's neck. Ricdorian just walked over and put me down on the desk.

"Ricdorian?"

Then, without a moment to ask a question, his lips dug into my lips. I blinked in surprise and grabbed the hem of his robe. Then, his hand dipped into my waist in anticipation. I hurriedly put one hand behind my back. While holding out so as not to end up lying down like this, he did not miss a chance and untied the ribbon.

No, wait, it's too intense from the start.....

Ricdorian lifted his lip for a moment, and slowly stroked his lips with his tongue. His red lips and crimson tongue looked odd.

"You said we could do it anytime, didn't you?"

..... He's still missing the idea. I rolled my eyes in embarrassment just before this continued. It's not that I don't want to..... The problem was that he and I weren't the only ones in this room.

“Oh my God, what an eyesore.”

I heard a familiar voice.

“Right, Callisto?”

Because there was Francia, who crossed her arms over Ricdorian’s shoulder and stared at him in an absurd way.

“Should I kill him?”

Kyaang! Kyaaaoong!

“You think he’s an eyesore too? Good.”

Francia raised her pouty lips.

“Go, headbutt him.”

She is going to ram that perverted Grand Duke. A murmur. As I watched the reaction of another similarly unusual person, Lenag, I swept my face. That’s probably because, in Lenag’s hand, Azur suddenly showed up in a fairly large form.

I let out a low sigh, covering Ricdorian’s lips with my hand.

This is a mess.

It was a long time later that the noisy parlor room was dealt with. As I was almost unintentionally going to watch the guardian deities of the Roses’ great war, I felt exhausted without doing anything.

I know there was no fatigue in doing movement magic, so this fatigue was due to the scenery in front of me.

– *Nyan*. What’s wrong, human?

I turned my head and looked to my side.

‘It’s because of you.’

I hit Pudding’s head gently.

– *Nyan*, what did this body do?

What did you do? This 3-year-old guardian deity was the first to jump in, saying that it was important to not miss the fight over me a while ago. No, this guardian deity and the rose were so similar that they made the first provocation and attacked first. Thanks to that, my only word to summarize the situation five minutes before was ‘*a mess*’.

< “*Everyone fight here, I’ll go to my room.*” >

I was just looking at them indifferently but then everyone became quiet at the small words I threw out.

And now this was the situation.

“As you all can see. The Empress’ tiara was brought safely.”

Given the circumstances, the Empress’ tiara was still on my head. As I was about to take it off, Francia jumped up.

“Ack, Sister, don’t take it off! I mean, it suits you well. Totally belongs to Sister!”

Francia spoke loudly with a snort.

“Whether it suits me or not..... I have to return this.”

“Can you use it until you return it?”

“Huh?”

“You can do that!”

Francia clapped as she spoke to herself. Then she strode over and even corrected the crooked crown.

“Suits you well.”

“Uh..... thank you.”

How can I say no to such a dazzling eye? Thinking about it, I nodded my head.

“Everyone thinks so, right?”

Then, I turned my head, and saw Lenag’s eyes, and he also opened his lips with a serious face.

“Suits you.”

“Ah, thank..... you?”

Then he heard me and turned his head shyly. I wondered what the situation was. At first, I wanted them to continue the story.

“So, let’s pass this on to the Empress, and achieve our desired goal.”

Our goal is to enter Kambrakam. The Empress’s request for this has been successfully carried out.

“Should I run straight to the imperial palace?”

“You won’t have to, Iana.”

Said Ricdorian, who was silent.

“If it’s a conversation, we can talk right away.”

“How?”

He said there was this. The imperial family handed him a magic tool so he could communicate at any time. The beads enchanted with communication

magic allowed him to talk to the Empress whenever he wanted. With the master of the empire.

‘Come to think of it, he was the Grand Duke.’

It felt anew that Ricdorian’s position was real. First of all, it is late today, so we decided to contact the imperial family immediately tomorrow morning. The Empress seemed to be sleeping earlier than it seemed.

It was late at night when Ricdorian returned to Hernim Castle. From here to Marquisate Valtaze takes four days to a week at a normal speed, so it was proof of how fast he was going. When we were about to finish the matter one by one, including plans for the future,

Something suddenly came to my mind.

“By the way, Lenag. I have one question for you.”

Lenag, who was organizing the map in front of him, raised his head. He had just described the shortest distance to Kambracam a little while ago.

“What is it? Ask me anything.”

“Ah, it’s nothing. Have you ever received a letter from the warlock of Domulit?”

I said this and added one more word.

“His name is Marshmel.”

Then Lenag flinched. I could guess his face.

<Miss, why didn’t you receive the letter I sent you?>

Marshmel obviously wrote me a letter. From what I heard, it seems that Lenag couldn’t deliver it to me.

<Oh. I’ve asked Marquize Valtaze.>

It's not something I can't understand. Lenag thought he was the only one on my side, and Marshmel was Chaser's closest aide, so he would have been naturally wary. He probably didn't know about Marshmel's relationship with me.

"Sorry. I didn't mean to intercept it."

Lenag said, bewilderedly. He said that he tried to hand it over after confirming the safety through a separate verification.

"However, the moment I saw Miss Iana's face, I was so happy that I forgot everything....."

"No. I didn't mean to blame you."

Fortunately, Lenag had the letter with him, and I was able to receive it. Naturally, instead of separating, the meeting continued a little longer. I opened the letter in front of the roses.

["For the first time in my life, I wrote a letter to the Miss. How ridiculous. It's the end of the world. The end of the world."]

I burst into a small laugh at the complaint that replaced the opening greeting. Unlike the crooked childish handwriting, the disproportionately adult-like words were just ridiculous.

But soon the smile faded from my lips.

"Iana?"

"Sister."

Perhaps they found this strange, there were calls from Ricdorian and Francia. But I couldn't take my eyes off the letter.

My hands trembled slightly.

To summarize the contents of the letter..... It was like this.

[“You asked about the powers of the Blue Rose before, right? Miss, let me tell you. There are no records of the Blue Rose anywhere in the Empire.

Except in one place, Domulit.”]

Obviously, the Empress promised that if we brought the Empress’ tiara, she would not only allow us to go to Kambrakam, but she would also allow us to read information about the Blue Rose.

But isn’t this different from those words?

No. Apart from this..... The letter was filled with shocking stories one after another.

[“Miss, until you wake up on that body. How do you think the black magic that made your body come to life was fixed?”]

I don’t know much about magic.

So even if I don’t know much about magic, I can read this letter properly because he wrote it clearly.

[“It’s the power of the Black Rose.

The Black Rose’s brainwashing remains in the Miss’ body. It was trying to fix the black magic.”]

Chaser’s power is brainwashing. Isn’t that the power to control people unconsciously?

[“Didn’t you keep thinking that you wanted to go back to Domulit? If that was the case, it was still in your body.”]

Without realizing it, I gripped the letter tightly.

[“Miss, if you want to get rid of this. And if you want to use the power of the Blue Rose properly. There is only one thing you have to do.”]

The letter was telling me one thing.

[“Find the guardian deity of the blue rose.”]

I put down the letter.

Somehow, I thought it was a little strange to see him sending me so innocently. As I recalled Chaser’s face the last time I saw him, I let out a dejected smile.

Of course, that doesn’t mean it was forced. Like a man who lived his life as a villain, he made the last bastion until the very end.

The guardian deity of the Blue Rose.

<Aren’t you curious about the guardian deity of the blue rose?>

The words written in the letter Chaser sent.

<I’m just waiting for the day I’ll give it back to you.>

The words in his letter overlap with Marshmel’s letter in front of me.

[“To my dear disciple and to my sin. This is my last kindness to you.”]

The little warlock who spent many years with me. My teacher and close friend left a last favor.

[“Remember it. The Rose and the guardian deity are very closely connected. You must have felt it. You just haven’t figured it out yet.”]

As I read this far, the letter fell from my hand. Everyone seemed to be looking at it in surprise, but there was no time to look back.

“Iana!”

I hurriedly opened the door to the terrace and grabbed the railing. And I stretched out my upper body as if I was about to fall.

After a while.

A faint sound was heard. Why haven't I heard of it?

My shoulders trembled.

'It's you.'

The sound of what I thought was faint, changed. A similar voice like singing a song. The sound was getting louder and louder as it was happy to reach me now.

In a very uplifting mood.

This voice was loud, grand, sweet, as if echoing in the water..... Yet very warm. My hand holding the terrace turned white. I knew instinctively. The sound I hear now is the voice of the guardian deity.

Finally, what Chaser said passes by.

<Remember. The Cathedral of Cantala, Iana.>

Chapter 209: Take me

1. Take me

Recalling the date Chaser said, I smiled in despair. It will be..... only a few days left.

I smiled with my head bowed and slowly lifted my head. Behind me was a hand gripping my waist.

When I turned my back, there was Ricdorian looking at me with worried eyes. The eyelashes that fell gracefully while looking at me drew a round curve. He looked like he was about to cry.

“It’s okay.”

I grabbed his hand and patted him. For some reason, I felt like I had to forget what I was thinking right now and say this instead. I was silent for a moment, then added a word.

“Because my mind is cool.”

I really meant it. To me, it was better to see at a glance that it was an uncomfortable thorny road, like walking in a fog, even if it was a ploy. Because we can come up with a solution.

‘I must have a lot to think about.’

I don’t have much time, though.

“Iana, do you know the face you’re making right now?”

“What kind of face is that?”

“... it was your face when you asked me why I didn’t put you on shackles when you first came here.”

Without realizing it, I touched my cheek. What face was I making? I didn’t know what face he was talking about. But I understand that this face made Ricdorian sad enough to look like that.

“I don’t know, but it’s not something to feel okay about, is it?”

“It is.”

Just as my guardian spirit is like me. It was just a pity that it was locked up for such a long time.

“But I don’t want you to make a face like that, Ricdorian.”

“.....”

“Um, so don’t.”

I grabbed his head and let him lean on my shoulder. Then I patted it a little.

Once again, I thought that I had escaped Domulit. And the thought that I wasn’t even in Marquisate Valtaze, where I stayed comfortably for a short time. The presence of the man with a face that looked like he was about to cry was great.

Francia could be seen over Ricdorian’s shoulder. She stared intently into Ricdorian, then pouted her mouth and raised her finger at me.

Then she grabbed her lips and stretched them out, pretending to cut it off, then put her hand around her neck and slashed it all the way. *I’ll kill the pervert!* As if I could hear a voice saying that, I burst out a small smile.

I lowered my gaze for a moment, then met Francia’s eyes. My lips called out to her without a sound. She nodded as she muttered a little with the shape of her mouth.

‘I’m doing it because it’s Sister’s request.’

I responded with the shape of her mouth.

‘You’re jealous.’

Then she grabbed Lenag and left the room. The door closed and only the two of us were left in the room, me and Ricdorian. I noticed that Lenag had looked at me once before leaving, but left without saying a word. It was a face that showed that he would follow me no matter what I did.

A bitter laugh flowed out.

A cool breeze blew into the quiet room, no, terrace. But I could not feel the cold much. Because his large body almost wrapped around me. I reached out and placed my hand on top of his hair.

The silver hair that was gently fluttering was wrapped around my fingers. Dyed in a soft blue hue that suits the moonlight of this night.

“Ricdorian. It’s out of context, but I have something to tell you.”

I said to the man who was too big to lean on my shoulder that he had to bow down for a long time.

Then, as if noticing that the words were rather unusual, strength entered the arm wrapped around my waist. He buried his face further on my shoulder without looking at me. Like a large beast that was acting like a baby.

“..... I don’t like it when you say you’re abandoning me.”

He mumbled in a pleading. The buried voice was muffled, but it was not difficult to understand. I smiled and shook my head. I thought he was a smart man.

“No. It’s the opposite.”

I looked at the whirl of his hair neatly arranged and slowly turned my head.

“I think the time has come to give you an answer.”

Come to think of it, Ricdorian would have developed his sixth sense like an animal. Whenever I was about to say something decisive, he instinctively noticed and changed his expression. When it's time to say farewell in Kambrakam, or make a promise we'll never see again.

He flinched and took his face off my shoulder.

"It's my turn to return the answer to your confession."

I've been thinking about it all along. Still, the relationship between the Blue Rose and the roses was full of incomprehension. It was as if I was pushing my hands and swimming between what I had achieved in this world and what Iana had made.

Flowers.

The world made of flower-like people. Each of them harbored indescribable wounds, each with a suffocatingly beautiful fragrance. Like the man who has lost all his childhood in the cold underground of Kambrakam.

Ricdorian was staring at me, frozen and nervous. The hand holding me didn't let go, as if it would never go no matter what I said. Ricdorian bit his lip.

"..... Should I cry?"

"I don't know."

I smiled lightly and brought my hand to his lips.

"Don't bite your lips."

"....."

"It will hurt."

His eyes fluttered for a moment. His blue eyes seemed to glisten with water. Under the soft moonlight, my guardian deity was still singing a happy song from a very distant place.

I smiled and opened my mouth slowly. With a broad smile.

“I love you.”

His eyes widened the most they could be. And I couldn’t help but look into his eyes and say it over and over again.

“And I think I should apologize to you.”

Being indifferent to others and to myself means that I have lived without knowing myself well. Chaser lied that the Blue Rose can’t love, but me and ‘Iana’ also loved.

Loved the colorful roses here, like those who have the names of the roses.

“I like you. Now I think I know what this feeling for you is.”

I muttered, pressing my chest tight. *But*, I whispered. At this point in time when I realized that love is love, I knew one more thing.

“Ricdorian, if the love you speak of is exclusive love that excludes others.”

“.....”

“I will probably never throw away the other roses.”

It was a sudden realization that came to me the moment I knew the existence of the guardian deity.

I will not abandon Francia and Lenag.

“I may not be able to focus all my heart on you.”

To throw them away meant to separate the body and mind. Then it was clear that I couldn’t focus solely on Ricdorian. I know that this is love, which tickles every corner of my heart and fills it with warmth.

However, I gave Lenag love. Rather, it was a realization that I realized by looking at Chaser’s misunderstood feelings and Lenag’s honest feelings and

seeing their love. I couldn't turn away from what I had blossomed.

“So.”

I know the blind feelings that Ricdorians show me. My appearance may annoy him.

“I.”

“It does not matter.”

Ricdorian cut my words firmly.

“I only care about one thing.”

“Ricdorian.”

“Do you love me?”

“.....”

I met his eyes.

“Right.”

I know that too. Talking round and round was not my style.

“I love you.”

“Only me?”

“..... only you.”

My heart started beating weakly. Whether he knew this or not, Ricdorian pressed our lips together like stamping his on mine.

“Once more.”

He pressed it again, not even paying attention to me blinking in surprise.

“One more time, huh?”

The languid, sunken eyes were filled with uncontrollable heat.

“..... no.”

“Haa, Iana.”

“..... Because if you do it again, it will wear out. I want you to reconsider.”

There was a saying that if we like someone, we'll look alike. I turned my face away, mimicking Ricdorian's usual act of covering his lips with the back of his hand.

However, Ricdorian moved his face to follow my face as if he had no intention of letting go of me. The blue eyes followed.

“Iana.”

“Don't call me.”

It wasn't an intense tremor. However, the tremor that flowed from the heart must have colored the world, which has been an indifferent black and white, with color.

When I slowly turned my eyes, there was a man's face with an expression I couldn't describe.

Before I could even take a glance, his lips covered me. It was still a clumsy but raw kiss. I slowly closed my eyes. The impatient hand pulled the ribbon above my chest. It wasn't the clothes that went down with the ribbon untied today, but.....

I laughed softly.

“What. The second round that you couldn't do that time?”

When his lips parted slightly, he took a deep breath, and his eyes followed me. All of a sudden, Ricdorian's hand had the completely untied ribbon, no, now a string, and it was fluttering in the air.

"You become like this as soon as I confessed. Was my body really your purpose?"

In spite of my laughter, Ricdorian slowly lowered his eyes instead of smiling. An innocent and noble face was revealed under the moonlight. Contrary to his pure white face, the reddish lips slowly opened.

"No."

The sunken eyes made it impossible to determine which side of his personality was this. He took my ribbon, kissed it and pulled it off.

Then his eyes turned to me. His fingers went down again and placed in front of his neck.

"I'm going to do this."

He took my hand and made the ribbon wrap around his neck. As if it would be a pretty neck decoration if tied up, the red string on his white neck was very well matched.

He lowered his head and bit my lip slightly without pain. With the tips of his ears and the nape of his neck dyed red. He pulled his lips off and slowly folded one knee.

"It's not that I have you. Iana."

A low but clear voice filled my ears. I think I liked this voice in Kambrakam too.

"You take me."

"....."

"I'll be a beast if you keep me chained and you show up anytime."

For the man who was being imprisoned for half of his life, imprisonment is more terrifying than anything else.

“Please allow love only to me.”

He held out the end of the string he had tied up to me.

“If only I could save it for me.”

He grabbed the back of my thigh and pulled it towards him. My skirt lifts, revealing my white ankles.

“I will gladly close my eyes on your rose garden.”

Ricdorian put my foot on one of his thighs sweetly, then grabbed my calf and lifted it up, touching my ankle with his lips.

“..... I love you.”

His hand went down under the skirt that went up to my calf and dug into it little by little. I kept my lips shut so as not to let out a moan at the strange touch.

“Tell me please.”

His eyes closed gently. His ears and neck were dyed red. But I had to admit at this moment that he was a gentle beast only to me.

“Your love is mine.”

Because the man’s face who had been dyed white and blue with lust was clearly visible in this place where the night had descended.

“Right?”

Chapter 210.1: Don't hold it in

1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. 1. Don't hold it in

It was a clean, yet dreary, obsessive voice. But I didn't hate this. Because I know where it came from now.

I just stared at him blankly.

It took me a while. I couldn't spit out the words that were lingering in my throat.

So it was after a little more time that I could speak again. Until then, Ricdorian was still waiting for my reply. He's like the waiting stone and would wait forever.

“..... you're foolish.”

These words came out first. Because his words made me laugh out loud.

I felt it from the first time I saw him, but his soft, clean silver hair and highly pure blue eyes made him noble and holy. He never got along with the underground, the night, and the darkness.

However, the man with his cheeks blushing at me and smiling languidly right now looked better with the moon and night behind him than anyone else. Since when did he become a person more suited to the night than the day?

Did the darkness in his chest make him fit into the night? I was caught up in some kind of unnecessary sentiment.

“Although I am generally indifferent to people, and most of the time, things that happened don’t matter to me.”

I softly added a confession.

“I know I shouldn’t say things like that.”

“It doesn’t matter. If you’re comfortable with me.”

Ricdorian smiled shyly. That’s not wrong though. When I couldn’t erase my expression, he smiled even more deeply.

“Is Iana uncomfortable? Because I take it too easily?”

He raised his hand a little more. His rough fingertips rub against my thighs. I held back the moaning this time again.

He put his lips on my lap. Rather, it seems that he was happy and glad to see me now.

“Please feel more uncomfortable.”

“Huht, Ri..... cdorian”

“Please keep thinking of me like that.”

Without realizing it, I ducked down and grabbed his head. He laughed and a breeze came from his lips on my lap. It was clearly him that had a reddish face, but I still couldn’t tell which personality it was.

“Iana, please answer me.”

He urged for an answer. No, it was close to a request. But I didn’t know if his lips were going to leave my knees.

“What?”

The skirt, which had risen even further, flew up and down like the ends of a curtain and swayed. He carefully grabbed my white thighs and rubbed them

with his fingertips.

“The love is mine, right?”

“Uht.....”

“You’re only going to tell me that you love me, right?”

“..... yes.”

Eventually, I exhaled a hot breath and nodded. I don’t know if he saw my nod though.

His eyes were fixed in one place.

‘You’re looking at it carefully.’

A red tattoo was visible on the inside of my bare thigh. It was a tattoo of a rose in full bloom. Since the place was hidden, I couldn’t see well except when I was washing or changing clothes.

Watching what he was doing, I felt my body heat rising even more. That’s how much he couldn’t take his eyes off my tattoo.

If I leave it like this, it’s like he will just stare at it.

“It’s pretty.”

He mumbled with his eyes half-closed. There was an exhilarating breath from him.

“Pretty.”

The rough fingertips found the exact location of the tattoo and stroked it. I bit my lip at the soft touch.

It was the first time I knew that this place was so sensitive. It was a completely different sensation from touching it while taking a shower.

“Iana, don’t hold it in.”

Ricdorian said as if he noticed me. Then he slowly lowered his face and brought his mouth closer. *Haa*, a low breath hit my underwear. I automatically tensed up my thighs.

“Please don’t hold back, okay?”

“Wh, what?”

He looked up and I looked down.

“Anything.”

Grabbing the back of his head and lowering my head, my hair runs down like a curtain over his head. It was still swinging in the wind. The sweet scent of roses brushed the tip of my nose.

He laughed softly through my hair. Then he lowered his head and kissed my tattoo again.

“If you allow it, just like this..... I want to spend the night with you.”

He whispered softly with his lips buried. There was a shyness that could not be concealed in his ferocious voice. It was no longer necessary to engrave the red rose now. Because his tattoo was already in a very secret place. As if it was settled in my heart.

Still, to ask this question..... It must have been a representation of the desire that fluttered in that red-hot face. I grabbed his cheeks and lifted him up.

“Really.....”

My voice leaked out a little.

“So wicked. You.”

Flutter. The innocent eyes were curved. But even as he smiled, I could feel him looking into my eyes.

“..... Don’t you want it?”

That’s why I realized that it wasn’t that his personality had changed, but he was on the rational side. I smiled softly.

“No. It’s not that I don’t want it. I think you always know only one thing about throwing fastballs.”

“I don’t know bad words or bad things.”

I think so. Seeing him in front of the Emperor or with Chaser, he was a cool and dignified Grand Duke.

“I like this look the most. I just want you to show this look of yourself again.”

“What does it look like?”

“An honest look.”

He leaned on my hand and closed his eyes. His long eyelashes trembled.

“..... Even if I get rejected, I’ll cry and beg at your feet again.”

“..... .”

“It’s also my wish that I don’t want to hurt you anymore.”

He grabbed my wrist with one hand and let it go. As if asking if it was any different from the Black Rose that used to chain me. I bowed my head and smiled.

I stroked his cheek.

“Hmm. I see.”

“.....”

“I didn’t like it because it was different. I liked it because it was you.”

Then he raised his head and looked like he was about to cry.

“You cry a lot.”

“You hat.....”

“I don’t hate it. Is it because I don’t have tears?”

I wiped the tears that tumbled down with my thumb.

“Is it strange to say that I like to see your face when you’re crying because of me? Am I a pervert?”

In the end, would it be strange to say that the face that has turned red because of the tears that flowed out was so pretty?

“Your crying face is so pretty.”

But still, I said frankly. Ricdorian jumped up and lifted me straight up.

“Ricdorian?”

I asked him, but meekly surrendered myself to his solid body and let him do what he was doing. He and I were in the parlor, but right next to the parlor was a small bedroom.

It was a typical noble mansion structure. He laid me down on the comfy bed, clasped his hand with mine and untangled it.

As soon as he put me down on the bed, I couldn’t reach out my hand any more because I was nervous.

“..... is it okay?”

I smiled at the gentle voice that came as if asking for permission, then sat back down. Then, I gathered my long hair and hung it over one shoulder and turned my head halfway.

“What should I do?”

I heard him holding his breath.

“I have a lot of buttons.”

I raised my hand and swiped the button behind my back.

“Undress me.”

Chapter 210.2: Don't hold it in (Part 2)

147. Don't hold it in

Then, the trembling hands unbuttoned the buttons one by one. The trembling was transmitted through my back. Ricdorian paused without releasing it.

“Ricdorian?”

“Iana.....”

He called me strangely, and a surprised voice followed. I tried to turn around, but I couldn't. Because he grabbed my shoulder and brought his lips to my back.

“A rose has appeared on your back.”

“What kind of rose?”

“A blue..... rose.”

The back? It had never been there before. If there was, there would be no way I could never see it through the mirror.

“Are you seeing this for the first time?”

Perhaps it is. I nodded quietly, then the strong arm dug into my waist. A sweet voice followed.

“I like it very much.”

A popping sound was heard as well as the sound of the remaining buttons being pulled off.

At the same time, I felt the place where my back was half exposed. I smiled slightly as I felt the cool outside air tinged me with goosebumps.

“What are you doing? Undress me.”

Pop. The sound of something breaking was heard once more. The last remaining button falls to the floor. I glanced behind me and realized that Ricdorian’s reason had also been cut off.

The low, sunken eyes ran down my spine. As he swept it down with his fingertips, a creepy shiver traveled up.

“... pretty.”

The voice, which had paused for a short time, calmed the atmosphere even more. It felt like my stomach was being squeezed tight.

“Because you’re so pretty.”

“Uht, Ric.”

“I want to swallow you in one bite.”

I focused on his voice while keenly raising my whole body to the sensations Ricdorian gave me. I wonder if his personality has changed. I wish he didn’t. I wanted him to be rational.

And when I turned around to see if my wish had come true, his face was red and there was an expression of helplessness on his face. It’s the look that I like.

The clothes he had removed from my body fell to the floor. Ricdorian laid me down carefully so as not to injure me, and one after another, the shoulders, chest, navel..... he kissed it as he went down. Without realizing it, I grabbed his hand that laid on my chest.

His gentle rubbing hands were tender. He carefully touched the apex and then kneaded it to spread it out. My body quickly heated up in this soft hand. I liked this clumsy touch.

Ricdorian, who stopped between my legs, kissed the red rose tattoo, and then climbed higher and burrowed into the split flesh. My thighs trembled, and a tenseness swelled. My breath was suffocating, but he didn't stop.

I felt like I was falling into a distant place. I pushed my head back and closed my eyes tightly. The white light burst out like fireworks.

At the end as I squeezed my toes tight, it stopped. Stretching like a deflated rubber doll, I breathed in, and then Ricdorian pulled his face away. Under the moonlight, his face and lips were glistening. It felt like my cheeks were burning.

Anticipation revolved in the amethyst-like eyes in the darkness. Ricdorian paused for a moment to kiss me, and then came down to my neck. Then he buried his face for a long time.

“Iana..... This far, shall we?”

I paused while breathing.

“What do you mean?”

Even though it was my first time, I knew very well that this was the appetizer.

“..... You look like you're having a hard time.”

“No way? Can you stand it?”

“.....”

“You never know when the day will come again after today.....”

His lips touched me. I smiled bashfully with my mouth closed and put my hands behind his tight neck.

After that, it was a time when me and Ricdorian gave ourselves to lust.

“..... Iana, relax.”

“Hu, take, take it out....”

“Kuhb, just a little bit more.....”

He looked at me as I sweat profusely and didn't know what to do. The funny thing is that this helpless face and the lower half of the body were the opposite.

“You're, too, bi..... uht”

It was a time of burning passion. It was as if I had seen a bright red vision of a red rose. It was a seductive time filled with sweat and heat.

At one point, Ricdorian let out a long groan as if releasing everything. He grabbed my shoulder and hugged me tightly. His forearms were showing visible veins.

“Haa.....”

He let out a long breath. In his unbroken posture until the very end, I felt his consideration. I wish I could lie down like this, but Ricdorian looked at me from above for a long time.

“..... pretty.”

“... .. yes.”

“Pretty. Iana.”

“Yes.....”

“You're so pretty, I wonder if I can be happy just like this.”

I thought I would never forget the smile I saw at this moment. And the appreciation just ends there.

“Can I do it one more time?”

Until Ricdorian smirked bashfully and said a strange, deceitful word in my ears.

“..... oh God.”

Looking back, I think I really liked books in the previous world. Well, it would have been nice if I enjoyed reading literature that stimulates sensitivity..... My favorite thing to read was obscene books.

To put it in plausible words: erotic books, R-19 books, and adult books. I used to feel like I was holding a children’s book when I happened to see a book of all ages when reading a book with age restrictions.

I really hated the morning chirps of birds.....

Chirp, chirp.

I swept my face as I watched the morning scenery of birds chirping.

‘It’s morning in the blink of an eye.....’

I somehow managed to get my upper body up, but I didn’t know how to get up with the blanket wrapped around me. I can’t even move because of the stinging pain I feel in my lower back and my whole body aches.

‘I have a lot of work to do.’

I slowly looked down. A little while ago, there was a man here who had his tight arms wrapped around me and fell asleep peacefully. But now, he’s not here? It means that in the morning, he woke up in shock when he saw me groaning in pain. Then, he rushed out and brought Francia back.

“I thought there was going to be a war.”

She had a look full of dissatisfaction.

“I was surprised when the Grand Duke came in while I was sleeping. I thought there was going to be a war, really.”

It must have been that she slept loosely, and her light-colored, curly hair was loosely messed up. Even her clothes looked like she was wearing only a robe over her pajamas.

“By the way.”

Francia furrowed her eyes as if displeased. Then she erased the wrinkles, even the ones on her forehead. She was on the verge of getting angry.

“Who is such an ignorant person?”

I just smiled. It wasn't that I was agreeing either. It's already too late to hide. As I lowered the blanket, the shoulders that I could see were tinged with red blush. If it went down further, it would be even more chaotic.

“Sister, can I kill it?”

“Huh?”

“That bastard.”

Chapter 211: Really a beast

1. Really a beast

It's crude..... like her. Even in Domulit a few years ago, her mouth was already rough. I scratched my cheek.

“Well, calm down. This is, uh, consensual.”

“Who doesn't know? Still, he's a bastard.”

“Uh.....”

“To be clear, it's nothing else, sister.”

Francia suddenly smiled brightly.

“The Grand Duke has the power of a beast, so he has to be careful when dealing with weak people, right? The average human's bones are like branches for him.”

“..... is that so?”

Yes, the example was a bit bloody, but it was true.

“That beast-like person uses that power recklessly. Then what will it become?”

“What?”

“A beastly bastard.”

“.....”

I clasped my lips. In fact, unlike what Francia said, Ricdorian wasn't rough. Rather.....

<Iana, relax..... relax just a little bit more..... I, uh, I think you'll get hurt.....>

Even though he broke the bed headboard with his hand, he treated me with great care as if I was a glass artwork. Still, it's painful.....

'Is it because of his other-wordly size?'

I gave up after making a cylindrical shape by hand. It seemed difficult to reproduce.

In any case, it was for the sake of my treatment that Ricdorian brought Francia in a hurry. It was obvious that Francia herself did not know this either, so she was rather upset by this fact.

"I'm sorry I woke you up."

"No. It's not for Sister to apologize!"

Francia shook her head vigorously. Then she smiled broadly and brightly.

"And Sister is always an exception. I can treat you at any time."

I raised my hand without tying the ribbon. I patted her hair and smiled.

"Thank you."

Francia's abilities were truly amazing. As the white light enveloped me, the dull pain disappeared as if washed away.

Then Francia took revenge and erased all traces of Ricdorian from my skin. Like to take it off? If Ricdorian knew about this..... I thought it would just be engraved once again, but I didn't say it to her.

I took out the clothes, put them on and tied them right up to the ribbon, and found myself clean with no traces of yesterday. Yesterday's matter remains

only with the disorganized bedsheets and broken bed board. Francia, who was staring at me, gathered her hands in front of her, and then clenched and opened them. She seemed to have a lot to say.

“Well, Sister.....”

“Yes?”

“You know. I will ask you honestly.”

Francia bit her lip and tried to let go of it to make sure her words came out.

“Do I and the Yellow Rose have to get out of here now?”

Now Francia was not ignorant of what happened yesterday, because Ricdorian had brought her here.

“If the Blue Rose..... chose one. Other roses have to.....”

And she seemed to see that as a ‘choice’. I looked at her slowly and opened my mouth.

“If I ask you to leave, will you leave?”

“Yes.”

“And not see me again for the rest of your life?”

Then, looking at me as if surprised, Francia blinked her eyes wide. Tears filled her round eyes in an instant.

“I don’t want that. Still.....”

“Still?”

“Because it was Sister’s choice.”

She bit her lips tightly.

“I will follow you.”

The way she endured her tears reminded me of the first time I met Francia. The small, miserable girl, her eyes full of fear and horror, but she never cried.

I grinned. Then I came over and clasped her shoulder playfully.

“Then you can stay here.”

“Yes. I’ll leave right away……. Huh?”

“You just have to stay here.”

Like the day we first met. This time, I took one step closer to her and grabbed both of her hands.

“You can stay with me together.”

“…….”

“How can you cut a relationship with people in one day? You, Lenag, and Ricdorian too. There is not just one blind relationship in the world.”

Francia did not shake off my hand like that day. She just looked at me with eyes swaying like a lost child.

“There is no rule that says that there is only one thing that is important to a person.”

Of course, there may be differences in their importance, but nonetheless, the fact that they are all precious does not change. A relationship where I choose one and miserably discard the rest. For nearly a thousand years, someone, no, a lot of unchosen people would have been hurt by this deformed relationship?

“You are important to me too, Francia.”

Tears dripped down the back of my hand that was holding her. Francia didn't even blink her eyes, only the tears were dripping down. Maybe it was because it fell from her big eyes. As thick as jade beads, only big tears were dripping, it made me feel sad. Because she looked like it was the first time she had ever heard of such a word in her life.

"I won't be chosen anyway. I thought I would be abandoned."

Francia said, wiping the tip of her chin with her sleeve.

"We are in that kind of relationship. But if only I could see Sister again."

With a calm voice that penetrates my chest even more.

"It would be nice if I could still see you from afar."

"Why are you thinking like that? No. You don't have to do it now."

I'm not good at consolation, but..... Somehow, I had a feeling that my ability would increase a lot in the future.

"Well, can I give you a hug?"

At the end of my deliberation trying to find what would be good to soothe a crying child, without even having time to listen to an answer, a body similar to mine fell into her arms.

Francia had a smell of innocence.

I heard a long time ago that white roses are the most fragrant of the rose varieties,..... I guess they're not wrong.

"I like Sister the best in the world!"

Because her smiling face was full of a scent that I couldn't find anywhere in the world.

"Calisto, what are you doing? You hug too! Now we're stuck with Sister."

Kyao! Waong! Callisto, who was suddenly summoned by her side, hung wide on my legs with its adorable front paws. The actions of the guardian deity and the rose were very similar.

“Sister, I’m sorry.”

Francia smiled bitterly with tearful eyes.

“What?”

“..... Uh-huh, I was going to try and hold onto Sister, even if I had to cry. Because it’s good to buy sympathy. Because there’s never been anything more pitiful than sympathy.”

“Are you saying it was acting?”

She replied with a smile. Francia said this, but I never thought that those tears were fake and that she was acting. I wasn’t so naive that I couldn’t even recognize it. Still, I decided to pretend not to know.

“It’s okay. I was happy with your acting.”

“.....”

Francia stopped at my words and rolled her eyes.

“Sister seems indifferent, but you are kind.”

“That is a strange thing to say.”

“But I don’t think there are any more appropriate words to describe Sister.”

She nodded as if she agreed, and then she looked back at me.

“Because you are my Blue Rose. I’m so happy you’re our king.”

For a moment, something unknown inside her words flashed through her eyes.

“I’m worse than Sister thinks.”

Francia lowered her head and brought her forehead to me. She put her forehead on me and gave me a beautiful smile.

“Be deceived by me forever, Sister.”

Different colors of light gathered in her different colored eyes. The half-moon eyes were very pretty. I blinked and then smiled.

“Okay. I will.”

A rose that will be with me in the future. I acknowledged my life partner in my heart.

When I finished talking to Francia and opened the door, I ran into an unexpected person at the door.

“Did you sleep well?”

It was Lenag. Has he been in front of my room? No, strictly speaking, it was the parlor, so it wasn’t my room.

“Yes. Good morning..... Well, Lenag. Were you here the whole time?”

Francia had long since left the room. She promised to see me at lunchtime. Francia would have said something if she had seen Lenag, which she probably didn’t, but I asked just in case. It felt like an instinct to do that.

He did not answer, but this also an answer. Because Lenag’s silence was always close to an affirmation. As always, I glanced over the neat figure.

He looked neat, but something was a little odd. Subtly mis-buttoned, or the long hair tied loosely and slightly disheveled than usual.

“..... Early in the morning while I was walking, I heard footsteps. The Grand Duke rushed to somewhere. I thought something had happened to

you.”

I wonder. If he had been standing here all the time, I thought he would have listened to all of my conversations with Francia.

The Roses basically excel in physical abilities. With a body different from that of ordinary people, it would not be difficult to hear the voices beyond this door even if they are not like the most excellent Ricdorian.

Of course, that’s why all the rooms in Hernim’s castle had soundproofing magic as standard, but.....

I glanced at the door. This morning, the doorknob flew off because Ricdorian broke it, and the mouth of the door did not fit slightly because of it. Maybe a leak through the door gap. Either the magic must have disappeared, or it must have been both. I thought about it and lifted my head.

“As you can see, nothing happened. Don’t worry.”

Even with my words, he couldn’t take his eyes off me. Instead of saying the words he couldn’t speak, he looked like he was saying a lot of words with his eyes.

“Miss Iana.”

He muttered a little. It was so low and small that I could barely hear it if I had not listened to it very closely.

“..... just once.”

“Yes.”

“Can I, hug you?”

He paused for a moment as if something was caught in his throat while he was speaking, but continued in a low voice that seemed to get cut off. His face was not red. I looked at him quietly and nodded.

The large body hugged me. Ricdorian always felt like he was about to dig into me, while Lenag's was just like a small hug. It was like a warm blanket. He just covered me with his body temperature. It felt like he was paying attention to whether I would be blown away, so he was so careful that he was neither touching me nor not touching me.

"I love you."

I raised my hand and patted him on the back.

I hope this love doesn't hurt him too much. I hope that my indifferent consideration was not a bad choice.

"You just allowed me to love, it's just that but. "

He shed a little bit of his joy.

"I'm glad I wasn't abandoned."

He moved away after whispering in a caring voice. I only realized it after taking a step back.

He was no longer wearing glasses.

Chapter 212: Enemy or friend?

1. Enemy or friend?

Just two days after that.

It was not difficult to meet the Empress. Upon hearing the news that we were bringing the tiara, the magic circle to the Imperial Palace was immediately opened. Even so, it was still a long distance, but it was not difficult to move because Jaire was here. So, me and Ricdorian entered secretly.

– I feel a bad vibe, *Nyan*.

Pudding whispered from inside me. Those remarks made me flinch and did not walk. After returning to Hernim Castle, Pudding was not with me for a while and walked around Hernim Castle on its own.

At least, while Ricdorian and I were doing things, Pudding wasn't inside of me. So when he came inside after a long time, it felt like a lump in the throat and talked more than the other days.

‘A bad vibe? Tell me more.’

– I don't know, *Nyan*, it feels bad, as if I fell into the muddy ground after the rain. *Nyan*!

For the three-year-old guardian deity, Pudding had a good vocabulary, but there was still a limit to expressing what it experienced. I gave it a little thought and said to Ricdorian, who was walking next to me.

‘Something's strange with Pudding,’ I whispered in his ear, so the servant walking in front of us would not have heard it. Even if they had heard it,

they could guess nothing from these words.

‘The more I think about it, I think the name Pudding was a good choice.’

– I don’t think so at all, *Nyan!*

While listening to murmurs about its name for a moment, we reached the audience room. This time too, because we came in secret, it wasn’t a big room.

The door opened, and a small hall greeted us. Of course, the name may be small, but as it was a place in this huge imperial castle, it was so spacious that it could not be compared with a normal parlor.

Whoosh! Kiiik!

The first thing that greeted us after opening the door was not the Empress’ voice or the servant’s, but the cry of a bat. The bat I saw during my last audience was sitting on the ceiling just above the door and crying.

‘..... Is it a doorbell?’

I thought indifferently as it let out a cry.

– What’s a doorbell, *Nyan?*

‘There is such a thing.’

Unlike the last time the servant announced our visit, the attendant only let us in and closed the door again. I looked around the hall only after the door was closed. No one was there. No, if there was one, it was an old man with a beard that I had seen in the last audience. He looked at us and bowed slightly. It seemed like he did it to Ricdorian rather than me.

“Wesbet.”

As soon as the elegant yet hoarse voice called out, the bat quickly flew up and landed in one place. It was on a white wrist.

“You’re here?”

The veil lifted by itself, and the owner of the imperial castle who was sitting there appeared.

“It’s amazing that we’ll be reunited so quickly.”

She greeted us sitting on a large throne. Her long hair that covered one of her eyes still made her overwhelming. But after seeing Marshmel’s letter, I couldn’t see her like before.

The Imperial Family deceived me by pretending that they do have a record of ‘blue roses’ in their hand.

“Greetings, Your Majesty.”

I grabbed my robe and bowed deeply. Then Ricdorian greeted her. Many things were omitted from his brief greeting.

“Raise your head.”

When I lifted my head, I saw the Empress smiling slowly.

“Yes, this time again, you’re being cheeky. Hernim?”

“I don’t know what you didn’t like about my greeting. My respect is the same as ever, so I dare you will understand it.”

Ricdorian bowed his head as he spoke. Then he lifted his head and took a step forward. Rather than getting closer to the Empress, it was as if he was going to protect me.

“It’s fun.”

Instead of being offended, the Empress rubbed her fingertips under her chin.

“You are being so cheeky because you have good reasons for doing so. Right?”

“Is there any possibility?”

“Of course you should. If you know how hard it has been for me to cut Domulit’s request.”

“What suggestions did Domulit have?”

“They said they would give the Rosnan coal mine as a gift to the Imperial Family. You should know that the offer that I had been eyeing for years was so difficult to cut off.”

It means that Chaser was constantly proposing to negotiate something with the Empress. I could tell what he was hoping for.

“Are you looking to get the point right away? I like you like that, Grand Duke.”

“It is an honor.”

“Oh, of course, I’m not saying I want you to sit next to me, so rest assured.”

The Empress pointed to the seat next to her. Ricdorian did not laugh at the joke that she had no intention of marrying him.

“Okay, let’s keep it simple. Did you bring it?”

“Yes. I brought it.”

She already knew everything because we reported it through communication magic, but the question still came out.

“Iana.”

The Empress’s tiara was in my hands. To be exact, in my box. I opened the box. In the sturdy jewelry box, the tiara was revealed. The Empress, who had been surprised for a moment, quickly closed her mouth. One of her eyes was covered with her long hair today, so it was difficult to recognize her expression.

“It’s real.”

The Empress judged in one word, and then, as she stretched out her hand, a purple haze lifted the tiara. In the blink of an eye, the tiara was in the Empress’ hands.

“..... It’s finally back in my hands.”

The Empress rubbed the tiara. As I was looking at it, I suddenly remembered.

<..... *Looks like it’s needed again this time.*>

Chaser asked if it was needed again this time. It was strange. What Chaser means by ‘this time’ is after he returns. If that’s the case, it means that it was needed before he returned.

Why did he need it? What if Iana needed that? Where would he use it? My stream of thoughts stretched out far.

For a long time, the Black Rose was obsessed with everything about the Blue Rose. To the extent that all information about the Blue Rose is reserved exclusively for the family.

A thought flashed over me. It was a question.

If so, is that something related to the Blue Rose?

As it was a word from Chaser, it might be without a logical basis, I concluded that it might be so. Just then, the Empress raised her head.

“Then can I think of it as granting permission to Kambrakam?”

“I’ll allow you.”

The long-awaited permission was given. Yes, now was the time to put Ricdorian’s life first, not that bizarre question. It was when I swallowed my doubts and shook my head.

“But there was one more thing that I was going to give. Was it about the Blue Rose? I think it was.”

Her sneaky words let me know that she remembered everything, but she only hinted at it. Like negotiating for it.

She looked right at me and turned back to Ricdorian.

“I will only talk about this with the Blue Rose alone.”

With me? I bowed my head slightly and narrowed my eyes. This was a different reaction from the last audience. Even then, the Empress paid attention to who I was, but not this kind of excessive attention.

Did something happen that made her react differently from that time and gave me a private audience? Or has a ‘change’ happened that made her interested in me?

“You didn’t answer.”

The purple eyes with the same color as mine, but with a completely different atmosphere, seemed to say that she had no intention of accepting an opposition.

“... Excuse me, but that seems difficult.”

Ricdorian’s back obscured my vision.

“I know what the roses think of the Blue Rose. Either way, I am the owner of the land you are treading on. Are you going to ignore me now?”

“I don’t think that what I’ve given to preserve that land is by no means small.”

“Therefore? If you don’t back down, are you going to be at odds with me? That’s fun, Grand Duke. I can raise Domulit’s hand even now.”

“Your Majesty.”

I took Ricdorian's hand.

"I am not feeling well right now. The Grand Duke is concerned about my body and my health."

It was not good to quarrel with the Imperial Family here. After all, she was the master of this Empire, and she was the one who gave permission to enter and leave Kambrakam. I blinked my eyes slowly. In a calm gaze. While staring indifferently.

"Unlike His Excellency, who breaks the bones of an ordinary person like a branch of a willow tree, my body is infinitely weak and cannot withstand the outside air for a long time."

"Oh."

I don't like to come forward, but I remember what Chaser told me. The story about the difficulty of the Imperial Family leaning on one side. So now it will be important to keep her mind from turning to Chaser. She will be difficult as an enemy.

"That's why my brother kept me in the mansion."

Of course, there were other reasons why Chaser imprisoned me, but he probably wouldn't have confided to the Empress because of his personality. Unsurprisingly, the Empress slowly nodded her head.

"Hmm, if that's the case. I personally understand that the Grand Duke is sensitive."

"Thank you."

"Your body must be different from other roses."

"... That's right."

I don't know if Blue Roses are actually fragile. But the Empress thinks Chaser's reasons were reasonable. After all, Chaser didn't even tell the Empress about me.

“Nevertheless, I want to talk to you.”

“With all due respect, but is that a story that will guarantee my safety?”

“You are a fierce Lady.”

She laughed out loud in amusement. Then she nodded.

“I swear by everything I have. The story will only be done in 5 minutes. When the story is over, you will safely leave this room. Would this be enough?”

For some reason, the Empress seemed to show an indisputable kindness. I decided to give this a try once.

“Ricdorian.”

I called him.

“After we finish, let’s eat *pudding* together.”

Ricdorian flinched. He seemed to have noticed that I had Pudding in me now. If the Empress posed a danger, I will always be able to deal with it.

Eventually, Ricdorian made a concession and took a step. *Creak*, the servant opened the door.

“Are you nervous?”

“I’m nervous to have a private audience..”

“You don’t look nervous for saying that. Right.”

“I usually don’t have any expressions.”

“Is that so?”

“Do you have anything to say to me?”

Although Ricdorian had not retreated, the Empress burst into laughter as if delighted with my words.

“I would be lying if I said no.”

Ricdorian’s steps stopped. He looked up at the Empress quietly. A dangerous light flashed through his eyes.

It’s like he won’t let the Empress go if she touches me the wrong way.

Is she an enemy or a friend?

What the hell is she up to?

Kiiik, the door is closed.

Chapter 213.1: What was half hidden (1)

150.1 What was half hidden (1)

I saw Ricdorian's face just before the door closed.

He looked at the Empress with a cold, sunken face yet softened his face the moment our eyes met. Then he sighed and whispered to me that he would be right outside the door.

"If anything happens, call me out loud. No. It doesn't matter how small it is."

He said, biting his lips.

"Because your voice can be heard no matter how."

Even the Empress may have heard of it, but he looked like he didn't care. I smiled and answered him reassuringly.

"See you later."

After Ricdorian had completely left, there was only me, the Empress, and the old man who served as the Empress's servant in the quiet space.

"By all accounts. No matter how you look at it, Grand Duke Hernim's actions are courageous. How impudent....."

The Empress, who had been muttering a little, slowly moved her gaze. The mysterious merciful gaze mixed with twilight blue light captured me.

“Then let’s start talking privately. Lady.”

The Empress didn’t say anything like a greeting or sorts as if she wanted to bring up the main point right away. She stroked her own long hair once.

On her hand was the tiara we had offered her. She put the tiara on her long fingers and twirled it.

“First of all, thank you so much for this.”

“No, it’s fine.”

“I’m only telling you now, but I didn’t think you guys would actually bring it.”

“Really?”

It was only after I answered that I realized that my tone might sound rude, but it had already been spilled. Fortunately, however, the Empress didn’t seem to care much. Looking closely, she was someone with a cool corner somewhere.

“So I thought I would do you a favor. Think of it as a quick reward.”

It seemed that she was the person who wanted to go straight to the core without being superfluous, and that she wanted the same for others and for herself.

“Now that I’ve been honest, can I say one more thing? I really wanted to see you. Do you know?”

“..... It is an honor.”

“I told your brother I wanted to see you countless times, but he never showed me.”

People would usually say that this is a family’s honor at this time. I couldn’t spit those words out because *family*.

The tiara, which had been spinning around, stopped. The Empress grabs the tiara thrown into the air.

“Lady, did you feel something when you saw this?”

“Looking at the tiara..... you mean?”

“Yes.”

Tap, tap. She touched the biggest jewel of the tiara with her thumb. Suddenly, her well-shaped lips opened, and unexpected words flowed out.

“This is originally a Blue Rose’s thing. I’m sure you can feel it.”

I glanced at the tiara and nodded. The Empress looked surprised at my calm reaction. Then she frowned slightly.

“I see.”

“You’re not surprised?”

“..... I’m sorry, but there have been so many surprises in the meantime.”

If anyone knew what I was doing recently, they would fully understand. The Empress did not erase her surprised expression and tapped her chin with the tiara.

“Well, no matter how immovable and indifferent are the Blue Rose’s characteristics, I wouldn’t be surprised at all. Then..... Do you already know that you are not the Blue Rose of this age?”

I stopped at her words. She seemed to think that I wouldn’t be surprised by this, but on the contrary, I was surprised. Does that mean that the Empress knows that I have shifted dimensions?

‘That’s ridiculous.’

It was disconcerting and surprising..... At this point, it seems that only Ricdorian and Francia didn’t know. The male and female lead shows off

their uniqueness like this somehow.

I calmly organized my thoughts.

Ricdorian and Francia. These two people did not meet the original 'Iana', so I couldn't tell. How could the Empress notice this? Could she have seen 'Iana'? Judging from 'Iana's' diary, she was imprisoned in the Black Rose's mansion, just like me. The cause was Chaser's father, not Chaser.

"You don't have to be so wary. This is none other than my ability as a rose. Do you know the power of the roses? Just like the healing power of a White Rose."

"Yes, I know."

"Hmm, now you're showing agitation."

"Excuse me, but may I dare ask what your abilities are?"

"Does your tone become subtle when you're flustered?"

The Empress seemed to have regained her composure after her surprise that was revealed unknowingly. She looked down at me with curious eyes.

"You should know that I am closer to an imperfect rose rather than it being an ability. I'm not perfect, so I recognize the perfect. Like an instinct."

An imperfect rose.

Come to think of it, I heard that before. The story that came out during the last audience. There are a total of five roses, including the Blue Rose, painted on the Kambrakam slabs. There is no Purple Rose in it.

"If recognition is simply caused by imperfection, then isn't it an ability too?"

"Well, that's very vague."

The Empress squeezed her temples as if in pain.

“The Rose I am is a being that gets its strength from hatred of the Blue Rose. It’s such a weird thing, isn’t it? Such is the origin of this rose. ”

A story I had never heard of, came out from the Empress. The origin of the rose, I wanted to know. So I nodded. Certainly, the existence of the roses is strange.

“Yes. It’s strange.”

“Yes. I think so. I am going to talk about the origin of this rose.”

“Do we have to start there to know about the Blue Rose?”

“Right. Yes, before we talk..... Do you believe in God?”

“What?”

Suddenly, God. Surely this country believes in God and has temples, but..... As a country with a separate imperial family and temples, they left it up to individual freedom to believe or not believe in God.

“I don’t believe it.”

“Is it? So let me ask you a philosophical question.”

She smiled seductively. She clasped her chin with one hand and patted her own cheek with the other, as if playing a piano.

“If God dies, where do you think the dead god will go?”

We’re not talking about roses, but God. Aside from the contradictory words of *God* and *death*, I just tilted my head at the rambling talk.

“You look like you don’t understand.”

“No.”

“No. What kind of nonsense is this woman talking about right now, you’re thinking so, right?”

“..... I didn’t think so.”

“Really? You’re an honest Lady.”

Instead of repeating my words partially, the Empress let out a small laugh. Marshmel was like that. My personality made it easy for my superiors to tease me and stab me if I made a mistake.

“I was rude. I was surprised and made a mistake.”

Hearing that, I thought, perhaps, that Chaser’s refusal to let me go is a measure against getting stabbed.

“No. It’s the rudeness that I allowed. And no matter what you do, I won’t get angry at you. First of all, because I am..... also a rose. I follow my instincts. Yes, it is inevitable... Shall I say you look lovely?”

Is that why you kept smiling like you were tempting me, Sister? I almost asked this. She meant that it wasn’t really her intention to be like that, but she had a beautiful smile on his face.

“Blue Rose, you must know about the imperfect Purple Rose and the Blue Rose they hate and long for.”

“... Yes.”

“Among those who inherit the blood of the imperial family, those who become the Crown Princes will hear a certain fairy tale. So did I.”

Chapter 213.2

Chapter 213.2

150.2 What was half hidden (1)

The Empress set her gaze in the distance. It's like I was in front of her, but she was putting her gaze on something else.

“I will not mention the fairy tale at length. It's going to be a long and boring story. I am not a storyteller.”

Well. I think people will become great audiences just by looking at this Sister's face. Because she used her eloquent beauty that catches people's attention the more I see it. Was this what they call charisma?

“This is a story about an unknown God.”

Along with the saying that she was not good at being a storyteller, a mellow voice led me to the story.

There was a wise God in this world.

God loved all creation equally and kept the world at peace with those who helped God.

Thanks to that, the world has been in balance for a long time.

Then one day, God, who was watching the world, suddenly ran out of strength and welcomed death.....

But God has so much power that God couldn't be buried in the world God loved even after death.

The dead God got separated into fragments.

The fragments of God are scattered to other worlds, leaving only one fragment in the world that God looked after. Suddenly! One day, a coveted 'rose' bloomed in the place where this single fragment was buried.

It was a small plant that was particularly prized when God was alive. However, because this rose was born from a fragment of God, it became the one and only rose that has never existed in the world.

And the four beings who loved God so much cried over the death of God..... The moment they saw the fragment of God that bloomed in the flower, they gave up their life, their glory and gave up their strength. They became the same flower.

Someone's passionate love.

Someone's protection and belief that they want to keep forever.

Someone's memory of healing pain.

Someone's..... obsession of loving intensely and leaving nothing else.

Everyone has become a silent plant.

Was the fragment of the dead God happy? It was unknown. The fragment that became the flower had no answer.

But one day, more time passed.

Miracles happen.

The day the fragment of God suddenly became human.

How did the other roses change?

They became humans as well!

And after that?

And..... There was one hidden story. There was a being who secretly loved God.

They loved, respected, and looked upon God from afar, but lacked the strength to become anything of God's beings.

Even after God died, it didn't even become a flower.

However, their love for God remained inside, so they called themselves a rose. They missed this heart day by day, and one day it turned different.

Why do I have to love so much?

That's right, it was called 'jealousy'.

"..... Did the hidden being become human in the same way?"

After listening to the story up there, I asked a question. The Empress's mellow voice stopped. She said she wasn't good at telling stories, and that she wouldn't talk much. Yet I felt like I was watching a play.

"Yes."

At the same time, I doubted that I had heard a well-crafted fiction. No, she said it was a fairytale. It just wasn't like a fairy tale.

"So. Are you saying this is all true?"

"Isn't it ridiculous?"

It felt like my head was throbbing, but I couldn't hold my head in front of the Empress. When the Empress asked with a smile, I just kept my lips shut.

.

“To be honest, I think I heard a great founding story.”

“Tell me more honestly.”

“Is God the first Emperor?”

“Unfortunately, not. The Imperial Family is not the main character.”

The Empress’s voice sank a little low. I shook my head.

“Then, the last being that came out..... Was the Imperial Family?”

“That’s right.”

There has been a lot of history since then. This was to summarize only the core.

“The days when the first roses appeared were full of war and chaos. As time passed, the founder of the Imperial Family took over human power. They couldn’t break the blind allegiance of other roses to the Blue Rose. It is not for nothing that the rose family still honors the Blue Rose as king.”

That was plausible. I had heard of it, the roses were beings who chased after God from the beginning and abandoned everything.

“Because the founder of the Imperial Family was the most human being, he could become the master of the Empire. The influence was limited to locking the Blue Rose in this land.

The Empress pressed her temple tightly.

“They themselves still harbors that longing for God, and they call themselves ‘the Purple Rose’.”

I felt that the Empress’s voice had changed a little while ago. I thought it was an illusion, but..... It wasn’t an illusion.

“It seems that the founder of the Imperial Family dreamed of eternity.”

The Empress took a deep breath. It was a breath mixed with many emotions and sorrow.

“They were in love with the Blue Rose, and then they became mad and jealous, and they dreamed of wanting to take her place.”

A twisted, eccentric, crooked smile hung on her graceful face.

“Maybe this is why this power left behind by the ancestors has colored the souls of humans who have had the Purple Rose from generation to generation. Leaving not a single descendant.”

This absurd story and the story about the rose that I knew seemed to make sounds as the teeth in the gears were turning.

“I called this ‘contamination’.”

The Empress slowly raised her hand. I witnessed the Empress’s fingertips trembling. An unfamiliar feeling of insecurity overtook me. Why? The Empress was so kind to me, I couldn’t understand what she meant. Is this the emotion Pudding felt before?

No. It was also different from that. My instincts were screaming so.

What I see now is a different being from the Empress a while ago. This was the ominous feeling I felt when I first met the Empress. Eventually, it seemed that a dark, shady purple whitish seal appeared around the Empress. It wasn’t an illusion.

‘Something else’ is with the Empress.

The Empress had always covered one side of her face with her hair. Blow~. Even in the wind that had blown from somewhere, what had been firmly hidden was lifted by her hand and moved. The moment the scarred half of the face I had seen in the last audience was revealed, I swallowed my breath.

“I tried my best not to swallow my load.”

A face full of scars that were deeply scratched as if it had been scratched by an animal, a huge diagonal line running from the temple to the corners of the eyes and the tip of the lips.

“I only found out after ascending to the throne. As time goes on, the load will become more contaminating.”

“What is it?”

She smiled with this scar on her face. It was a cold smile.

“..... What exactly is that contamination?”

Her eyes revealed a deep, dark light.

“Before that, there is something you need to hear. In the power that I possess, there is a soul that was once a purple rose.”

“What?”

At that moment, I saw a strange blue tinged with purple eyes that I thought had been a brilliant light.

“Simply put, the souls of the previous Emperors. The souls, who have been swayed by this power and possessed by terrible jealousy, are clinging together without rest even after death.”

Her eyes rolled and turned towards me. I felt a chill.

“Thanks to that, the Emperor of the Empire, can make judgments and schemes and was wiser and more sensible than anyone else.”

She tilted her head and smiled with her beautiful face. It was mesmerizing, as if possessing people, but with a gaze filled with madness.

“At the same time, it makes it easier to go crazy.”

Her long hair runs down like a curtain.

“If I hadn’t ruined my face so as not to go crazy, I would have been a mad tyrant over the Blue Rose.”

Chapter 214.1

Chapter 214.1

What was half hidden (2)

Maybe it was after hearing all the stories? I had the illusion that the blue light fluttering in those eyes seemed to be longing for something all these times.

Maybe it's because of her gaze as if she had become a completely different person from a few minutes ago. A heavy feeling of pressure weighed on me.

“That’s why I need you, Lady. Please.”

The absolute person of this country pleaded with me, who was only a Lady.

“Can’t you be my ally?”

It was different from the gazes of my roses so far, but her eyes nevertheless harbored a clear longing.

“Until now, I somehow suppressed this power with the tiara that the first Blue Rose had. I’m afraid it’s going to be difficult.”

“What do you want from me?”

“I want all the Roses that disturb this land to disappear.”

I took a breath. I clenched my fists, then extended them, quietly measuring the distance from me to the Empress. I don’t know yet, but just in case she inflicted harm on me.

“Did you know that the Roses includes me and the Heads of the current Rose family?”

“Is that too difficult?”

I didn't answer. Frustration crossed the Empress's face.

“..... I'm sorry. That was a slip of the tongue.”

It seemed that she had now realized the mistake she had made.

The face, which had been hard until now, collapsed surprisingly quickly. I was really surprised by what I was watching.

“Ha, as you can see, I am barely balancing. It wasn't just my will.”

The Empress covered her eyes. A soft voice leaked from between her thinly open lips.

“Please, help me.”

I widened my eyes.

“I don't want to go crazy.”

Even my clenched fists slipped away at that voice. The Empress's eyes, exposed between her fingers, fluttered.

“I'm not asking you to erase the Roses, just remove this power from me.”

“.....”

“I don't want to lose myself. I want to lead this country for a long time as myself.”

“..... What can I do?”

“Go to Kambrakam.”

The Empress spoke in a slightly calmer voice, showing she had come to her senses.

“Give me the data about Kambrakam. If you go to Kambrakam, you can do it well enough.”

Unfortunately, it all came down to one thing. Kambrakam. The place where I opened my eyes.

There, it was said that not only can Ricdorian’s life be restored to its original state, but also the Empress’ power can be removed.

I swallowed my breath as I looked at the woman sitting in that seat. The matter I’m going to talk about from now on seems to feel like I’ll have to hang my head on it, but I’ve decided to do it nonetheless.

“Is this the end of the story about the Blue Rose you told me?”

“Yes.”

“As expected, the Imperial Family didn’t have any data on the Blue Rose.”

“.....”

I didn’t avert my gaze.

“I don’t dare say anything to Your Majesty, the Empress of the Empire, but I do have one thing to say.”

“What?”

“You have so many great wishes from me, what can Your Majesty do for me?”

I’m sorry for the beautiful Majesty, but I was a person who could draw a line with boldness and decisiveness to unfriendlies.

How could it be different than a child’s selfishness by suddenly appearing, throwing out a huge truth in an old-fashioned story, and half-forcibly asking

me for something? I know that she also has her own difficulties and wounds. However, this kind of thing was unwelcome.

“You and the Grand Duke are allowed to go to Kambrakam.”

“We know this in return for the tiara we gave.”

“.....”

“The material you promised also ends with the story of the origins. Even this was a description of the Purple Rose. You said the information on the Blue Rose was ‘kept’. You lied to me and the Grand Duke.”

“Is that so?”

“Everything about the Blue Rose is said to have long since disappeared, is that true?”

“Did Duke Domulit say that?”

I did not answer, but it seemed to be a sufficient answer for the Empress.

“Not all are lies.”

While she admitted some of her lies, she also gave explanations.

“There are no records of the Blue Roses. I know the whispers of ghosts wandering around me. I know this is useful.”

“You lied that there was a record.”

“Right. I can’t record a ghost’s words.”

“Then, apart from this, what can Your Majesty do for me?”

“I didn’t know there would come a day when I would be asked such a question as I live.”

I expected to get a scolding. For some reason, the Empress laughed slowly instead of getting angry.

“Well. Not bad. You must have something you want, so tell me.”

Rather, I seemed to welcome this side even more.

She grinned. Her face, having regained her leisurely look, revealed a dignified light. At the same time, she looked as excited as a child.

“I can be proud that I know ‘roses’ better than anyone on this earth. All about the Blue Roses as well as other roses. Any questions? I can answer anything.”

Is this really true? I wondered if she was telling the truth or not. The scales tilted toward believing in the figure that had been begging before, please, take away this power.

“I want to reclaim the guardian deity of the Blue Rose that my brother had imprisoned, and restore Grand Duke Hernim’s lifespan in Kambrakam to its original state. But my brother’s abnormal obsession won’t let us alone.”

“So?”

I knew Chaser well. A beautiful but dangerous man with poison and thorns. He was a man who saw love and monopoly as the same thing.

He didn’t seem to know my purpose yet, but..... Upon noticing me trying to save Ricdorian, he might interfere with it at all costs. The woman’s eyes embraced me.

“The essence of my power is similar to that of the Black Rose. So I know it well. That he will never give up on you.”

“Yes.”

“I promise, if we leave it like this, Duke Domulit will surely start a war. Do you already know?”

“.....”

That’s true. Indeed, the other Roses, Ricdorian, Francia, and Renag, also expected it. And I never wanted it. The Empress threw a solution.

“It would be best to kill the Black Rose and annihilate it from this world, but it is practically difficult, so there is no other way.”

The Empress said the cruel words calmly.

“Let’s make a Rose Festival.”

“What?”

Rose Festival. It was a familiar word. But not knowing that it would be mentioned here, I blinked. it. Isn’t this a legitimate fight between roses?

A fight, a war. When asked how to avoid war, she said go to war. What kind of contradiction is this? Is this person already half crazy? Such a reasonable doubt was rising.

Chapter 214.2

Chapter 214.2

151. What was half hidden (2)

Seeing my expression, the Empress smiled.

“Don’t stare. I am going to explain it now.”

“..... I wasn’t staring.”

“Don’t be so cute like that. I am weak against cute ladies.”

She threw a light joke and followed the explanation.

“I said the Rose Festival because of the rules set in this fight. In this festival, if a winner is decided according to the ancient rules, the defeated family can never cause trouble again.”

“What do you mean by not causing problems?”

“There will be no restrictions. For the rest of their life until they die.”

“..... Would they be imprisoned?”

“No, it’s not like that. For example, to create restrictions so that they cannot cause riots, such as ‘do not cause war’ or ‘cannot appear next to the Blue Rose’. Think of it as an unspoken power.”

After listening to it this far, I was deeply immersed in my thoughts. Considering the Roses’ irrational power, it was not incomprehensible. Thinking about it, it’s not a bad proposition.

After thinking, I nodded slowly.

“I see.”

The only thing moving in the silent hall was the bat perched on her shoulder.

A bat. Why was the guardian deity supposed to be a bat? With the bat beside her, the Empress no longer covered half her face. As if there was nothing to hide.

“Is Your Majesty’s only wish to eliminate the power?”

“Yes. Just one.”

In response, she briefly explained the process of the Rose Festival. Like a war over the Blue Rose, she said, and that I can decide the method.

That was never bad information. No, this is very satisfactory information. A plan flashed through my mind quickly.

I thought I might be able to solve this twisted problem if I use it well.

“Thank you.”

“I can get what I want, so there’s nothing to be thankful for. Rather, I am thankful to Lady.”

She had returned to the wise and virtuous Empress, unlike the dark and maddening face she had a while ago. It was only then that I thought about what this person had in her.

Seeing what I had just seen before, I couldn’t completely trust the Empress. Moreover, if she has already deceived me once, there is no way she won’t deceive me again. However, she wants to give up her strength for the sake of the country, so I have decided to believe in some of the desperation.

“Your Majesty, with all due respect.”

What does it feel like to be given power that you did not want one day and to be swung around? Actually, I already know this feeling.

“Actually me too. I don’t like it when otherworldly forces dictate someone’s fate.”

This was the thought I had been thinking about since I woke up one day in the prison. Because I came to a different world regardless of my will. That is why I have always wondered about the roots and origins of this strange and blind relationship.

The Empress fulfilled this question.

The Empress widened her eyes for a moment, then slowly bent her eyes.

“That’s what I think too.”

She said she didn’t want a situation where she would become a tyrant tormented by the ghosts, regardless of her own will.

“The ghosts make right judgments, but the ego makes a dying Emperor. How is it different from a doll?”

I wondered if the Empress’ appearance who spoke like that was her true form. She wasn’t a good person, but she was a good Empress.

The private audience ended after a long conversation.

“Lady, don’t you ever need more roses in your garden?”

With the Empress’s dense and mean jokes.

It was a dark evening when we arrived at Ricdorian’s castle.

As soon as I returned from the Imperial Palace, instead of laying down my weary body, I called everyone. Ten minutes later, Francia, Lenag, Jaire and Ricdorian gathered together in Ricdorian’s office.

“Sister, how did it go?”

Francia asked, curious about the outcome of what had happened in the Imperial Palace, her curiosity visible from her face.

“It worked out.”

I smiled and answered that question, then asked abruptly.

“Francia, do you know the origin of roses?”

“What? Origin? What are you talking about?”

“That. When did the roses exist? It was the first time I heard about the origins.”

“Ah. I don’t know that either. History is not my field, but, well, isn’t it a long time ago?”

Hearing her words, Francia seemed unaware of the origins that the Empress knew. The same was true of Lenag and Ricdorian.

‘Is this information monopolized by the Imperial Family?’

As expected, that’s the position where the original ghost held onto. I thought that might be the case.....It felt like my surroundings were becoming more and more uncommon and becoming a gathering place for abnormal beings. But it seemed like the end was not far away, so I had to be patient.

“I have something to tell you first. Bringing the tiara worked out well, but that doesn’t mean that we got our tickets to enter Kambrakam in peace.”

I looked at not only Francia, but the rest of the people, and finally Ricdorian, and said,

“There is one hurdle left.”

“What kind of hurdle?”

“I think we should break into one place.”

“Where?”

“Domulit’s base.”

No one was surprised by my words. They were just quietly waiting for my words. Of course, Ricdorian frowned slightly.

I said the place’s name.

“My guardian spirit is trapped there. I must bring it before we go to Kambrakam.”

Even now, listening closely, I can hear the faint singing voice. Perhaps I will be perfect only when I meet my guardian deity. Breaking into Domulit is one thing. I brought out the next important agenda.

“And I have one request.”

I looked at each one in turn.

“Let’s start a Rose Festival.”

“..... what?”

The first to answer was Lenag. He blinked quickly in disbelief.

“What do you mean by that?”

“Literally.”

I smiled and pointed to the office desk.

“Everyone, would you like to fight over me?”

Of course, I didn’t mean it, it was a joke to relieve the serious atmosphere for a while. I reached out my hand and tapped my cheek.

“The prize is my love.”

“..... When can I start?”

“What?”

Before I could ask, someone intervened.

“Sister.”

Francia called me with a serious face. I’m stunned by the reaction. I didn’t expect this at all. Huh? I turned my head. Francia said with her serious face.

“You should have told me that as soon as you came in.”

In one hand, with a huge hammer in her hand that I never knew when it appeared.

And the last place I looked..... Ricdorian stood there with a tearful face.

“..... Can I keep my place? Iana.”

Similarly, with his sword drawn out. I held my breath.

..... Dang it, I can’t even joke.

Chapter 215

Chapter 215

I always want to be by your side

Cathedral of Cantala.

It was a very old church built about 200 years ago. It is called the Cathedral of Cantala after the city's name. As a city with an old cathedral, the city also boasts a very historic past. The city has had a large population for a long time in history. However now, the city did not enjoy the same prosperity as before, as if everything was on a path of decline.

This city is located three days away from the Domulit estate, so it is a city under Domulit influence.

A city between Scheruten and Pantes. Here, in Pantes it was also the city where Jaire caused an explosion when I returned to the Domulit mansion.

“There is a cathedral, but it is no longer a place where religion has its power.”

As an expert on temples and religions, Francia came forward and explained.

“Cities nearby are free cities for crime, so in other words crime cities. So it's natural.”

“Is crime rampant there?”

“Not exactly..... rampant. It's a city of corruption rather than crime. It's just they're not religious anymore. It is like a place where the impossible

things sit on their heads, they throw away their heart, and choose reality to pursue pleasure.”

“Well..... Thanks for the explanation.”

“Hmm.”

It seems that Francia’s feelings about Cantala were not very good, so the examples and explanations she gave were explicit.

“The black money about the temple has something to do with it. Even for the temple, it is a place they find troublesome.”

Is that so? The things that came out of Francia’s mouth were things that truly have been that way. It was easy to understand why Chaser chose this city and cathedral.

To sum it up, it’s a crime city. In fact, this is Chaser’s main area. It is the field he knows best, and the most comfortable place to work at. We’re fighting on the stage he invited.

“Cathedral of Cantala’s capacity is no joke.....”

Unfortunately, even if he chose this place, I had to respond. Two days after we met the Empress, we were already staying in a city near Cantala. As time was running out, I left as soon as I was ready.

In fact, each of the roses wanted me to remain in Hernim, but I couldn’t help it because the condition Chaser set was that I went myself. Above all.....

‘Because I need to find my guardian deity.’

I looked over the wasteland. Listening closely, I can hear a small ringing sound. I could feel the sound that seemed to be far away in Hernim Castle was getting closer.

So I knew it. My guardian deity is in that city. At least, Chaser didn’t sell false traps. Of course, I couldn’t understand that man’s intention any more.

“It’s fortunate that there is a city that belongs to Hernim’s territory nearby.”

“Right.”

Ricdorian and Chaser competed for influence as if they were playing a game of land-fighting, so the cities they belonged to were divided here and there in the vast land of the empire. In other words, just because it is a city near the Domulit estate, does not mean that everything is in Chaser’s hands.

With the elite gathered in the city we set up as our garrison, we went into the final inspection. Although it should be considered as an inspection, it was close to revisiting the prepared operation.

In particular, among them, Jaire, the wizard who led them, was the busiest. Ricdorian and Lenag were trying to quickly find and make a magic tool to attach to my body at the command of each leader.

‘You don’t even have to do this..... I want to say that. I guess this is the right thing?’

– Of course, Nyan!

Pudding, who was listening to my thoughts, cried next to me. It was then. A paladin approached and carefully bowed his head.

“Excuse me..... Saintess, Your Holiness!”

“Ah, Sister, give me a moment.”

Francia, who was in the midst of explaining Cantala, waved her hand at me, approached the paladin who called her, and left.

Her disappearing face turned to one that is leading the group. Where did the face that smiled brightly at me went, there was a mature and calm atmosphere, and a dignity different from the Empress instead.

“Even if I think she’s still young..... She’s an adult.”

“You mean the White Rose?”

“Yes. Francia.”

I smiled slightly as I looked at Lenag who was standing next to me.

As Francia went to the paladin, Ricdorian and Lenag stood next to me, respectively.

“The wasteland is really big.”

Between our destination, Cantala, and the city we are currently staying in, there was a huge wasteland. In this place where there was a war a long time ago, farming became difficult and barren because of the poisonous weapons of the time. To this day, it remains such an abandoned land.

“It’s a windy place.”

We were standing on a hill overlooking this wasteland. The wind blew hard. My clothes swayed softly along with my hair.

The wind smelled of sand.

“Thinking about it, it seems like Ricdorian, Lenag, and Francia always call each other Roses.”

In fact, it would include Chaser, but I didn’t even bother to mention the man. It was different from calling other people’s exact titles such as Grand Duke, Marquis Valtaze, and Saintesss.

“If we feel each other’s presence naturally, that’s probably proof that we’re conscious of each other.”

“Really?”

“Yes. It’s a competition.”

Lenag’s answer in the front and Ricdorian in the end. Oh..... Seeing the two men competitively answering, I laughed awkwardly.

I know what they mean. When I looked down slightly, Azul and Pudding were looking at their roses side by side.

“Guardian deity.....”

Speaking of the guardian deity, it was said that the rose and the guardian deity are very similar, and their relationship was similar to that of the roses. As long as Azul and Pudding did not touch each other, they ignored each other.

But whenever Callisto faced Pudding, it roared and squealed. Just like the relationship between Francia and Ricdorian. It still was.

Kyaang!

Huwaaack!

“Oh my, Pudding!”

I quickly grabbed Callisto and hugged it. There was no other meaning, Callisto was right next to me. Francia left Callisto here to leave for a while, but she took advantage of this opportunity to fight each other again.

-Human!

Pudding looked at me holding Callisto with a shocked face.

-Are you holding the bear, THE BEAR!

“No..... Callisto is closer to me?”

Kyaong! Callisto who was in my arms..... Ah. This face is the same as Francia’s face, teasing Ricdorian. The problem was that the baby bear’s cuteness was murderously cute.

HAAAHH!

-Human, did you pet it, Nyan! How can you do that! Human!

“Uh.....”

At that time, Callisto in my arms disappeared into the light. It must have gone back to its rose. After teasing and making fun of everything..... It was just like Francia.

When I heard the sound of laughter and looked to the side, Lenag was smiling slightly.

“Miss Iana, you may be a little embarrassed by these words, but.....”

After he confessed his deepest feelings to me, he laughed more often, and this sometimes seemed like a sad look.

“What a relief.”

Of course. This time, I think he laughed because he was really relieved. Apparently, he equated Pudding with Ricdorian.

“Personally, I support Callisto and the White Rose.”

“Uh, really?”

“The enemy of my enemy is my comrade.”

“..... Is that so?”

“Yes. We have a common enemy.”

“Well, Lenag. That common enemy seems to be glaring at you.....”

“It doesn’t matter.”

Lenag bowed his head, and gently grabbed my hand which was suspended in the air when Callisto disappeared. Then he kissed the back of my hand politely.

“It’s enough for me to look at you.”

After saying that, Lenag, feeling a little embarrassed by his own words, gently blushed, and then released his hand quickly. If Ricdorian was one to be proud of what he said, Lenag sometimes couldn't overcome his shame at what he had said.

Like now.

“Marquis! Where are you!”

At the same time, Jaire called for Lenag. There were also wizards from Marquisate Valtaze under Jaire, so he would share opinions there.

“I'll be right back.”

“Ah yes.”

The place where Lenag went was where the explosive was dropped.

I looked at the remaining roses and guardian deities. Soon after, I laughed out loud. It was funny to see each of them staring at one another. Pudding to Francia's side, and Ricdorian to Lenag's side.

With that laugh, I took a step closer to Ricdorian and carefully took his hand. Ricdorian flinched.

“By the way, Ricdorian.”

“What?”

“We never had a proper date. Right?”

Ricdorian's eyes returned to me. He had innocent eyes, as if he had never glared, and his ears were gently flushed. We confessed our feelings to each other, but since we have an important task ahead of us, we could do nothing with a peace of mind.

“First of all, it has to do with your life. It's sad, but be patient. yes?”

“..... I am not sad.”

“Really?”

Ricdorian dug into my arms. It felt like a huge beast was in my embrace, together with the groaning sound. Then he whispered softly.

“..... maybe a little.”

I laughed and stroked his soft hair.

“When we do it later.”

“The date, Iana?”

“Yes. The date. Where do you want to go?”

Then, as he rubbed his face against my neck, he slowly lifted his head. For a moment, I thought that if he had the ears and tail of a beast, he would sit prettily. He rolled his blue eyes back and forth, then said with a flushed face.

“..... marriage?”

“..... It’s not a date.”

What did he just say so refreshingly? This man.

“Being by your side all day.”

“Isn’t it like that now?”

“Tomorrow too.”

“I think so.”

“And the next day.”

“.....”

Ricdorian buried his face in my neck again.

“The next day. The day after too. Always. Iana.”

His voice went straight into my ears.

“All the time, always, I want to be by your side.”

“..... It is like marriage.”

As I nodded my face nonchalantly, Ricdorian left a kiss on my neck with a slight sound. The slight trembling of his shoulders seemed to show laughter. After the laugh, he opened his mouth.

“Iana, I have a question for you.”

Before I knew it, Pudding climbed up on Ricdorian’s back and cried, asking for me to pat it too.

“What?”

He was silent for a moment as he was choosing his words. I felt a near-raw breath on my neck. The words came out only when I took the spare time to stroke the jealous 3-year-old guardian deity.

“In the final fight, what will you do with the Black Rose?”

I stopped stroking Pudding.

“..... What is there to do?”

“In a fight, there comes a moment when you must put your sword in. Iana.”

Ricdorian’s gaze, who finally met mine, was still without anger or resentment.

“Are you going to kill him?”

He was just waiting for my answer.

Chapter 216

Chapter 216

Please, only me

I kept my lips shut.

The answer had already been set within me, but the tip of my tongue did not allow me to say the words easily. It wasn't simply because it was difficult to answer.

There was something strange about his attitude. Will he kill him if I wanted it?

“Who will kill him if not?”

Ricdorian blinked. It seemed as if his eyes were mixed with doubts.

“Are you really going to stab him?”

“Yes.”

The answer I gave flowed out like a promise, yet it felt more like a well-trained achievement rather than an answer.

“If you wish.”

Whether it was right or wrong had nothing to do with values.

“Anything you command. Even if I die, I will protect you.”

Something was wrong here. I like him being shy. I like him who doesn't know what to say. But this is more than a lover who loves equally.....

“Actually, Ricdorian.”

I know he has a grudge against Chaser. I do not intend to force that grudge, forgive, or revenge. I know the hatred he has, but to put off his decision on me, what his intention was is clear.

Silence clung to my lips like frost. The wind blew in this silence.

“You asked me if I wanted to kill him, right? If I say I want to, blood will be on your hands.”

I said this and took his hand.

“Why?”

“It is your..... wish.”

“Just because you love me, don't rely on me for everything.”

I grabbed his hand and made him bow down to me. A smile crept over my lips.

“Don't look around.”

The blue eyes that trembled for a moment turned back to me. Looking at him back when he kidnapped me, he wasn't kind to others.

“Like the freedom I taught you in prison. Why would you leash yourself?”

“..... Even a leash is fine if you're the one who gives it to me.”

“Do you think I would like the obedience that I would never even consider for myself? Why do you spill blood on yourself because of my decisions?”

“Iana.....”

“I haven’t finished talking.”

Ricdorian flinched at the calm and casual remark. I said it clearly so he could hear it.

“I don’t hate you, even if you have your own decision.”

I loved Ricdorian, not the Rose entangled in this irrational relationship. Even if we are intertwined with the Roses’ bitter love, I want to have equal love, not love in which one side submits.

“You said you loved me not because of the Blue Rose, but because of your will.”

Even if he has become a normal adult, I understand why you’re doing this. Why he was considering obedience as the highest value at this moment.

He thinks that it was natural to erase his will for love. I know why it could only be like this.

“Now, don’t let go of your will.”

I grabbed his cheek.

“You can tell me what you want to do.”

“What if that’s what Iana doesn’t like? What if you don’t like me?”

His face clouded as if he was going to cry.

“Of course I will love you no matter what, but..... Iana. I’m afraid sometimes. I’m afraid that one day you will distance yourself from me. I want you to not look at other people.”

His deepest heart had finally burst out.

“..... Are you jealous?”

“Yes. A lot.”

I could tell by the ringing in my ears.

“..... Please tell me, Iana. How do I deal with these feelings?”

His big eyes and whole body were crying out for love.

“I know it’s greedy. Please, only love me.”

I glanced at him and nodded hurriedly.

“Yes. You are already doing that. Don’t cry. Alright?”

“Huff, Don’t touch the hand.....for more than five seconds.....”

“Hmm, I will. Anything else?”

“Eyes, huff..... no more than ten seconds.....”

“I see. I will try not to face them.”

“Eight seconds.....”

“Huh..... Really. Eight seconds? I’ve never counted..... I will try that too.”

The man in front of me was like a lost child. Still, he held my hand tightly, not wanting to let me go. Longing for affection even in the face of a loved one was still a detriment of this deformed relationship.

Nevertheless, it didn’t show.

“My feelings are not light enough to make me not like you for doing what I don’t like. Who do you think I am?”

I couldn’t say anything more, as I knew this was clumsy jealousy. Still, he calmly wiped away his tears and I said again.

“Why did you suddenly lose your confidence?”

“Not suddenly.”

“I like that look too.”

“.....”

“I’ve been thinking about it, but I don’t think there’s anything to love.”

I patted his cheek and raised myself on a tiptoe. My lips lightly brush it.

“But I love this look. I guess it’s what love is. Don’t be anxious.”

He looked like a big beast whining. Well, there’s no need to take care of your mental health while raising animals.

“I will make less eye contact and hold hands less.”

“The steps.....”

“Steps?”

“No more than three steps.....”

“Pfft.”

I lost it and burst out laughing.

“How have you endured this jealousy until now?”

“..... Even when I saw your rose garden, I said I wanted to be by your side. But now you told me not to hold it in.”

“Yes. I said that.”

I stroked the hair that came to my arms. Treating the man I love as a big dog was funny at times, but at the same time, I found it pleasant.

“Think of this. You are no longer in prison.”

Then, as I was about to open my mouth, someone cast a shadow on me.

“Excuse me, Miss Iana.”

I just looked away without opening my mouth. I saw a man standing at a reasonable distance. It was Lenag. He passed by with a puzzled look as if he felt the air that had subsided heavily between us.

“The wizard Jaire asked to see you, but.....”

Lenag’s eyes slowly rolled to the side.

“Am I disturbing you?”

I don’t know if he heard our conversation. Likewise, there was a high possibility because the Roses had good physical abilities.

“No. You didn’t disturb me.”

It was something I had to tell him at least once anyway. I smiled and shook my head. But as I was about to answer, this time someone tapped my shoulder.

“Sister!”

I felt a weight pressing down on my shoulders. I could tell by the soft scent. When I turned my head, there was a smiling face.

“What. What funny story were you talking about?”

“Ah..... Francia.”

She blinked her eyes and tilted her head. Then she paused.

“What, what. Did I interrupt you?”

“No.”

As I looked at Callisto dangling from Francia's shoulder, her wrath seemed to melt away.

I smiled and shook my head. Ricdorian, looking at this, shrugged his shoulders and showed his palms.

"Iana, please forget about half of the things I said from a while ago."

"Half?"

"..... To ask you to forget everything is a lie, but to ask you not to forget it is....."

Haaa, he exhaled as he buried his lips in the back of his hand.

"Because I'm jealous."

I nodded. In the distance, Jaire was waving his hand vigorously.

"Lady, can you come over here for a second?"

Why was he calling me in such a hurry? I nodded once, and if I didn't, I thought that I wouldn't be able to see Jaire from the place where I was.

"Then Ricdorian let's talk again. Let's talk about the criteria."

"Yes."

Ricdorian smiled brightly. I took a step back from his face, whose white cheeks were dyed red. And the moment I was about to turn my back, Ricdorian's expression hardened terribly.

His head turned in the opposite direction. It wasn't just Ricdorian.

"Miss Iana!"

Lenag, who was closest, pulled me in.

BANG!

A huge roar came as a huge body embraced me. I blinked in the arms that held me.

What's going on? I couldn't figure out what was going on in the blink of an eye. When I lifted my head from Lenag's arms, I saw the landscape not far away. The newly built barracks, quite a distance from me, had been completely smashed.

The ground was hollow as if a meteorite had fallen.

“..... It's black magic.”

Lenag said. And I stiffened my shoulders at his words.

“This is probably.....”

Black magic and Domulit. I didn't have to guess who it was by those combination.

“Ignoring the distance traveled, this magic is the specialty of Duke Domulit's closest aides.”

Lenag glanced into the hole and seemed to be looking at me. But I had no time to pay attention to his gaze.

The place we were in was a place where we had set up a temporary place to stay for the day. Groans and footsteps were heard from everywhere. The knights were calm. Their response was also quick.

As if they knew something like this would happen.

It seemed that I was the only stranger who felt this unfamiliar. I lowered my head, looking at everything calmly.

“This.”

I couldn't take my eyes off those who groaned from their injuries.

“It's a declaration of war.”

It was only when I heard the soft but firm sentence that I realized it.

..... That I had become the true enemy of the one I had embraced. Maybe I had been thinking of it too easily. Chaser, did I mistake him after he let me go so easily? I hope everything will go smoothly.

I felt weird. That man was the villain who made countless people disappear from the book. As long as I was living peacefully, wouldn't he have acted like he didn't care?

The important day.

Tension engulfed my entire body. I rested my hand on my cheek for a while, not doing anything. I wasn't shocked anymore. I just realized that I had been a little too comfortable.

Soon I raised my head.

“Would you mind holding my hand?”

Lenag held out his hand without a word. I took this hand and stood up casually. While I was absent-minded, Ricdorian and Francia went away. I think they gave the words to fix things quickly.

“Let's quickly get ourselves together, everyone.”

With my resolute words, they quickly took care of the barracks. Only Lenag, who handed over his power to Hernim, remained by my side. I brushed my knee.

“Shall we go?”

“Yes.”

I left the place with Lenag and headed to Jaire.

Chapter 217

Chapter 217

Same kind

Everyone was busy with their work, so were the wizards led by Jaire. Jaire came out of the training site and ran to me quickly. He called to test the protection magic of the tool he had just completed.

“Miss, are you hurt? You must have been very surprised!”

“It’s okay. Because it flew to a place far away from me.”

Right. Like it was planned. I twisted my lips up.

“First... here. Please stand here for a moment.”

“What are you doing?”

“I think we need to pull the test run of the tool. I don’t know if the operation date will change.”

Jaire’s words make sense. It was good to make sure that there was no more room for mishap, even if the other side declared war. I glanced at Jaire, who was preparing my arm with a magic tool.

Lenag was looking at Jaire’s hand.

“That, can I do it?”

“What? Ah..... um, uh. Yes.”

Jaire looked around, and moved away from the place.

In fact, the rather spunky Archwizard tended to be wary of the incumbent prison warden. I thought he was going to be brazen.

Lenag, who was handed the tool like that, began to put it on my arm. In the form of a bracelet, several bracelets are stacked on top of each other.

“..... Were you very surprised a while ago?”

“Ah. A little bit.”

I smiled and nodded. Lenag’s eyes looked concerned.

“Something like this happened It must have been strange to Miss Iana.”

“Really?”

“I meant to tell you something in advance.... It is my mistake.”

“Hey, why is it Lenag’s fault?”

I looked away without a smile.

“It’s the fault of the person who cast that magic.”

I looked outside, precisely to the side where Cantala was. I went back to him and said again casually.

“The person who ordered it.”

Lenag put the bracelet on without a word. The bracelet made of string had a jewel in the center and a chain at the end. Come to think of it, didn’t Jaire give me a bracelet in prison?

“Um, Lenag. You don’t have to be like that.”

He grabbed my arm with almost no strength, and worked delicately. Then, the long eyelashes went up immediately. I didn't flinch when I looked at these eyes anymore.

"Are you uncomfortable?"

"No, not like that."

I tapped his hand that was holding my wrist.

"Because you're holding on to it as if it's about to break. You don't have to."

"Ah....."

"I'm stronger than you thought."

As proof of this, I clenched my hand a few times and opened it. Then, looking at him, I saw that Lenag's ears were starting to flush.

..... why? I thought I had seen Lenag for a long time, but I couldn't figure out why this time around.

"I, um..... have been holding on to you for too long."

I didn't even force him to let go right away, but he was startled and let go of my hand. He only calmed down after hearing my explanation that it wasn't like that, but his calmness was also impressive.

"It's done."

"Ah, thank you."

So the misunderstanding was cleared up, and Lenag put all the bracelets on my hands.

"Didn't you say that I could just stretch out my hand and shout?"

"Yes. I heard that if you are in a hurry, you can rip it as is."

I looked worried, disregarding the fact that I was proud of being strong a while ago.

“..... Can I rip it?”

“Ah yes. I don’t think you need to worry. I heard it was made to get ripped even by your power.”

If that’s the case, I’ll be safe. I looked up at the flickering bracelet.

“Lenag, when are you coming back?”

At that moment, Lenag’s eyes sank seriously.

“I will be back soon.”

“I think you should go back sooner.”

He nodded

“..... I think so too.”

Right before the big event, Lenag had a job to do. In the plan, I placed the stem and the three roses filled in the details.

“Your role is the most important.”

It was this man who took on the most important role in the upcoming ‘Operation’, not Ricdorian nor Francia.

“You know? This is a race against time. Be sure to go to the Imperial Palace and ask for the ‘Rose Festival’.”

Ricdorian and Francia’s roles were not light either. But more than that, this man’s role is to hold the rudder of this ship.

“..... of course.”

He spoke in a firm voice, not losing his soft, calm tone.

“Don’t worry, no matter what, I’ll get it done.”

Seeing this man’s face who was always so serious, I smiled.

“I’ve never been worried about you.”

He widened his eyes at my sincere words, then immediately lowered his head. At the same time, he seemed to smile softly.

“..... I am happy to find the meaning of my existence. I will do my best not to make you worry..... I look forward to seeing you again.”

“Yes. Good luck.”

At the same time,

A place far away from Iana. There was a person who looked at Iana, who was busy checking the wizards and the tools. The look on the watcher’s expression frowned as the wizard approached and re-fastened the bracelet to Iana. He was the commander-in-chief of this place, Ricdorian.

“That gaze is very piercing. It will break through.”

There were people who looked at the man and clicked their tongue.

“You have to be jealous in moderation too. If you overdo it, will you still be loved?”

When the grouchy words came one more time, Ricdorian, who was staring at the bracelet with a piercing gaze, glanced away.

“Oh my goodness. Grand Duke.”

Francia tilted her chin and smiled.

“What are you looking at?”

Francia took a look at Iana's side and confirmed her position. It wasn't until she saw that Iana had completely turned her back, that she changed the shape of her smile.

"Oh no. Why that brooding gaze? Oh, so scary!"

She smiled and used a sneering tone without hesitation.

"Don't lose your energy against me for nothing. Shouldn't you be running until your feet are already on fire?"

The Operation will begin soon. In this operation, Francia and Ricdorian are tasked with appearing in front of the Chaser Louve Domulit and fight as fiercely as possible. Their role is infiltration and combat. And it will be a disturbance. Bind Chaser's feet, or at least prevent his minions from doing anything else.

This was also to buy Iana time to go find her guardian deity.

Their king's plan was more radical than expected and at the same time devastating. For her young age, she has been through a lot of battles, which is surprising. Rather, it was an operation that was thought of because she did not think about her well-being.

Francia did not hide her disgruntled voice.

"Why are you so anxious and restless? After all, it is you that Sister loves."

Behind her words, there was a saying as if 'is this not enough'. Ricdorian could not have known this.

"The Red Rose had it full. Some people can't have it even if they want it."

The two had already met and clashed with each other countless times before reuniting with Iana. Ricdorian did not hide his cold expression contrary to the innocent face he had in front of Iana. Then he just silently uttered a word.

"Your attitude changes as well."

Despite his ice-cold voice, Francia did not lose her smile.

“What’s wrong with you? Like you didn’t know I was like this?”

Next to Ricdorian, Pudding stood on all fours. It stayed here instead of following Iana. Pudding did not hide its ferocity and let out a sharp cry.

The fact that it belonged to Iana did not mean that it had lost its essence as a guardian deity. Pudding still shared Ricdorian’s image.

No, it is inevitable that the Rose and the guardian deity will resemble each other. Callisto also showed sharp teeth and claws rather than a cute form.

“Hnng, but even if you are loved, you can’t help but feel anxious, right?”

“I wonder why you are doing this even though there is nothing good about scratching me so gently. Do you want to see the end here?”

Ricdorian, Grand Duke Hernim, was well-known for being cold-hearted but never shy away from a fight. It wasn’t just a rumor.

“Ah, if we fight each other, Sister will really like it!”

Amid the sudden tension, Francia moved her steps and cleverly hid in the shadow of the cliff. She then slowly leaned her back against the stone wall. It was a perfect place. Iana can’t see.

“I’m not going to say that I’ve been living this way.”

She raised her eyes. Her eyes were of different colors, and in one of her eyes, a bright White Rose was drawn.

“Actually, you’re the same too, right?”

“.....”

“I know.”

The last courtesy that had been wrapped around like a shell was erased from Francia. She shows a bright but thorny smile.

“You and I are the same kind.”

As she spoke, someone approached them. It was a member of the paladin. Unusually, he had a white shirt in his hand, and his upper body was not dressed.

“Saint.”

The man with a heavy physique politely bowed his head. Francia nodded her head without looking. As if the knight had been waiting, thump, he knelt down.

The knight's face seemed to come to Francia's waist. Francia leaned her upper body slightly and gently rubbed the paladin under his chin. As if she's very used to it.

In one of her hands, Francia, suddenly held a long stick. She turned it around casually with one hand. It was a long baton that bent in a smooth curve.

“I'm sorry, but I heard all of the conversation you just had with Sister.”

This scepter, called the Holy Monarch's Scepter, was none other than a historical relic that only the Holy Monarch possessed.

“What are you hesitating about?”

To have it in Francia's hands meant that she had all the power of the temple. The size of the scepter has become as small as the palm of her hand. Francia handled it freely, as if revealing that she was the owner of it.

Her lips slightly touched the tip of the scepter.

It also serves as a boost to the priests, doubling their healing powers like hers. The scepter symbolizes the power of the temple, the knight who took off his coat, and the saint in neat and comfortable clothes.

It was the image of the saint, no, the true ‘Pope’ that Ricdorian had seen all along.

“Now there is no way Sister can’t abandon you. Even I wonder if my obsession is really the effect of this terrible rose.”

Ricdorian narrowed his eyes.

“You’re just like that, right?”

Francia sounded quite sarcastic, but she grinned.

“Because you and I are very much alike. Method and values.”

She also had a past in which she had no choice but to live with force. Francia swallowed her last words, biting the scepter. There was a circumstance where Ricdorian and Francia were forced to grow up with the shadow of the world, whether by birth or by environment.

Therefore, they had to live fiercely.

“Maybe we would have connected in a different way if we hadn’t met Sister.”

Francia spat out meaningless assumptions.

“Like an engagement relationship.”

It was a tone with a hint of teasing. Of course, Ricdorian’s expression became even colder.

“What, there’s no better relationship than this to go hand in hand and step on other bastards, right?”

“If you really want to see the end today, I won’t stop you.”

“Who is fighting? Please don’t look at me like that, Your Excellency.”

Francia bent her big eyes and smiled.

“Because I don’t like you either.”

Chapter 218

Chapter 218

Beyond the wall

She didn't forget to add a word here. Francia remembered everything Iana said.

"And it's the way Sister hates."

"....."

"I don't care."

Even if it was just a brief touch, it was a warm moment that will never happen again in Francia's life.

"It is, after all, family."

She therefore respected Iana's choice. Even if her instinct as a rose whispers to get rid of that man and take Blue Rose's side, she can stand it.

"Whether you or me, hiding this damn obsession and nature is for Sister's sake, isn't it?"

"....."

"So I'm saying don't take Sister and don't make such a silly face."

Ricdorian's expression gradually returned to his usual calm. Francia knew how ferocious Ricdorian could be. She's been fighting with him a few times and she had seen it firsthand.

“Enjoy the happiness of the choice that no one else can enjoy. Okay?”

The Red Rose's nature is closer to a beast than what could have been imagined. Nevertheless, that man suppressed that wildness with his own reason and will. There must have been pain like squeezing out blood.

“It is bitter to share my sun.”

Francia removed her hand from the paladin's face she had touched.

“Don't forget that the enemy of the enemy is your friend. If something happens, I will take her away anytime. Me and the Yellow Rose.”

Francia was willing to take the spot next to her if given the chance, even if she had to hold hands with Lenag, she was willing. The chances of that happening are slim though. Instead, at times like this, it was very enjoyable to watch the distorted Grand Duke.

Ricdorian smiled immediately.

“No way.”

He tilted his head at an angle.

“You don't have a place. I'm not going to let that place go.”

“Look at that. You have a bad personality.”

Francia chuckled and looked at Iana.

“How are you hiding this dark inside? Sister should know.”

Francia knew. Even if Iana saw this, she would never abandon or not love Ricdorian. So..... She was just annoyed.

‘I'm jealous.’

The moment she saw Iana, a bright smile was engraved on Francia's face. It was an expression that came out unconsciously. Seeing this, Ricdorian felt

as if he was looking in a mirror.

Is Francia herself pretending to be different inside and outside?

No.

Ricdorian could be sure of this. Iana allowed him to put on his deepest natural look. His and her faces now, these were the most sincere expressions they could make.

“Calm down, this man.”

Francia would then run to Iana with a docile sheep’s face.

“Even a handsome man is ugly when he is jealous.”

The White Rose’s last grudge left an unexpected significant blow. Ricdorian raised his hand and rubbed his face. His face contorted slightly.

“Haa..... Is it ugly?”

That was then. Someone tapped his leg. It was Pudding that continued to stay by Ricdorian’s side till now. The little beast pushed his leg with its front paw. Then tap it

– You’re going to have a hard time, Nyan.

Pudding shook its head.

– For a human who almost became my contractor to be such an idiot, I feel sorry for myself, Nyan.

In fact, he never had a chance to tell Iana, but Ricdorian heard everything she said to Pudding. He, of course, could not hear it depending on the distance, but all of that was possible. Well, it was only natural because Pudding was a part of him and his guardian deity.

Up until now, he didn’t care whether he could hear Pudding or not, but at this moment, he couldn’t.

“..... You have no dignity at all as a guardian deity. Where did you learn that word?”

-What? Idiot? Human taught me that, Nyan!

“That’s a good word.”

When he learned that Iana had told him that, Ricdorian changed his stance without a single speck of embarrassment. Seeing that, Pudding shook its head again.

– You are also seriously ill, Nyang.

But Pudding and Ricdorian were both looking at Iana in the same way.

– Of course our Human is amazing, Nyan. She’s the best, Nyan!

“Of course.”

– Ahem, Nyan!

Pudding said, as expected, she’s a great contractor for me! Ricdorian, who had been wrestling with his guardian deity for a while about Iana’s charm, suddenly raised his head.

‘Is the time coming?’

He looked up at what was the sky, but what he was looking at was the city in the distance, to be precise, the walls. The walls of Cantala. Beyond that wall, the traps created by the Chaser Louve Domulit will be scattered.

‘I said I was going to kill him.’

Ricdorian knew himself well. He knew he wouldn’t get blood on his hands. It’s not that he can’t kill Chaser, it’s that he doesn’t want to hold Iana’s hand with his blood-stained hands.

Because her hand should hold only clean and good things.

More than anything..... The power of Chaser Louve Domulit is ‘attraction’. That is, brainwashing ability. Whatever may be beyond that wall, it will never be easy. Even more so as the roles he and Francia will play is suppression. At the same time, Ricdorian felt the end approaching.

– you, Nyan.

At that moment, Ricdorian coughed violently. An unusually harsh coughing sound resounded one after another. Instead of panicking, Ricdorian skillfully turned his back and entered a blind spot.

“..... Don’t say anything.”

Ricdorian interrupted Pudding’s words.

– You have been taking it easy, your body has been pushed this way, Nyan!

“It never really listened.”

– Your body is slowly not listening, Nyan! What are you doing without knowing what it means to be short of life as a rose!

“Be quiet.”

But nevertheless, Pudding finally spit out with a growling voice.

– When are you going to tell her, Nyan?

This guardian deity has signed a contract with Iana, and although its connection with him has been estranged, Ricdorian has been able to exert some influence on Pudding nonetheless. For example, to prevent this beast from saying anything it wants to say to Iana.

– Your life is worn out faster than you think, so there is not much time left.

“.....”

Pudding’s voice was ferocious, but on the other hand, it didn’t know what to do.

– If you don't go fast, you'll die.

Ricdorian smiled and closed his eyes.

“Even if you don't say that, this fight will be over soon.”

The truth that no one could tell.

This battle was a battle of time.

The next morning, the bells rang in the Cathedral of Cantala, just like any other day. I already felt how loud that bell was while I was staying near this city. It was indeed a huge bell. A grand and heavy sound as if welcoming me to this place.

The gates of Cantala were wide open. The streets were also clean and empty, as if they had not been touched until we came to the cathedral. Even though it was not a small city, the empty square gave me goosebumps.

I felt the vibration of the wall and lifted my head. A faint cry overlaps between the gigantic bells. As if recognizing that I was listening, the crying grew louder.

‘Here you are.’

I knew that the guardian deity of the Blue Rose was here. And finally I put my hand on the door.

“..... Good luck, Ricdorian. And I look forward to your cooperation, Francia.”

There are two doors in the cathedral. The door that Chaser spoke of was the front door. But it wasn't the front door that I was holding onto. I held my breath and turned my head. There was no one near the back door.

It was strangely quiet.

I could see people from afar, but they were just moving around the area as if they were on patrol. Even if they were close, they wouldn't have seen me. Because I was using powerful invisibility magic. More than ten wizards worked together for this purpose.

Then as I stepped inside the back door.

“Welcome, Iana.”

A sweet voice rang in my ear as if seducing me.

“What's the matter? Not coming in. I have been waiting for you.”

I swallowed a gulp, looking at my empty front. Even though Chaser, the owner of the voice, was not here, goosebumps rose on my back as if I had seen him.

It was a given. The words I am hearing now were transmitted through a magic tool, and Ricdorian and Francia, who must have met Chaser by now must have heard it too. Perhaps he said it while looking at Francia, who dressed up as me and covered up with illusion magic.

I hastened my steps.

<I know Chaser better than anyone.>

The words I had said came to mind.

<He must have expected me to show up with the Roses. He will appear at the place where he is supposed to meet me and concentrate all his energy there.>

Because he has to take me.

<Smart and meticulous, but blind.>

As I was walking, I heard a faint voice in my ear. It was a sharp voice.

“But it's strange, Iana.”

Chaser's smile seemed to pass by.

“Why won't you see me?”

The illusion magic was something that will quickly come to light. It wasn't my goal to completely deceive him from the start. I rubbed my face and hastened my feet. I came here to pursue my guardian deity's presence that has since grown bigger.

There was no time. Fortunately, I felt the energy of my guardian deity spreading throughout this cathedral. It wasn't difficult to find because it was calling me.

<He won't give me what I want right away.>

“Rather.....”

I bit my lip.

<It must have been hidden.>

The more I walked, the louder the singing voice called me.

Chapter 219

Chapter 219

Freedom

I moved quickly. As I was in a hurry, my heart beated faster, but at the same time, it calmed down.

I shouldn't make a mistake.

It was an operation involving a group of people. In order for this current fight not to escalate into a bigger war, it was best to find only what I needed quickly and leave. This operation was made because I was the only person who could find the Blue Rose's guardian deity.

'No one is in the hallway.'

– I don't even feel any presence either, Nyan.

Pudding, that was hidden inside me, answered my murmur.

'..... Did he place them all toward the worship hall?'

Chaser had numerous knights. He raised them himself and trained them to be strong, and they were blind enough to die for Chaser. As I felt in the book, it was not loyalty, but blindness.

In addition, he was a man who, if necessary, was willing to brainwash people into doing what he wanted them to do.

"He's a complete villain."

Without muttering that much, I smiled quietly. This was a given. I've seen it countless times without having to pretend to realize it just now. Still, the reason I murmured it is probably because to confess this truth in Domulit was quite impressive.

‘This is no time to be engrossed in the mood.’

I shook my head and turned. Right. Left. The path to find the guardian deity was like walking through a maze. I didn't get lost because of the continuous cry that called me, but overall, the gloomy cathedral made me feel like I was wandering through a maze. As I walked for a long time, relying on the dim light.

– Oh, human.

Suddenly, Pudding called me.

“What's the matter?”

I paused for a moment. It was because of its unusually low voice.

– That's.....

“What is it, is it urgent?”

I took a step back where I had stopped and quickly asked. Is something wrong with Ricdorian?

– No, I know it's not appropriate for this situation, Nyan. By the way..... Human, I think you should know too.

“Why are you taking so long?”

– The Red Rose..... Kyaaangg!

At that moment, there was a sharp cry. It was none other than Pudding that screamed briefly. I stopped walking in surprise.

“What, why are you like this?”

– No, nothing. Nyan. It stings..... I can't believe I can't really talk.....

The rest of the words were so small that I couldn't hear them, but the tone was very dissatisfied.

-Anyway, human, the Red Rose can hear what I say.

“What?”

What is this all of a sudden?

“Since when? He didn't hear it before, did he?”

– I don't think it's been a long time, Nyan. I don't think the Red Rose heard it when he kidnapped you.....

“Right. Not then.”

If he had listened to Pudding at that time, he would have noticed Pudding's true identity.

– Probably recently. What's happened with the Red Rose recently, Nyan?

“..... Recently? There is no such thing.....”

I stopped talking when I tried to say no..... Maybe it's because we did something like that at night?

“..... I have a guess.”

I mentioned a date just in case. Pudding thought for a moment. It said it was around that time.

– Human, he glared at me when I was talking to you, Nyan.

“Really? It sounds real.”

I felt complex subtle emotions. Half the joy that the guardian deity and the Rose communicate, even if my thoughts were not heard but could be

inferred from Pudding's words. I decided to think positively.

It was strange that Pudding had more to say. But it closed its mouth tightly. It's as if someone was holding onto him so that it couldn't open its mouth.

– Haa, human. There is something you must hear. You must know, Nyan!

“Huh? Okay. Please tell me.”

So I only had a short conversation with Pudding and changed direction again.

-Human, you passed me on so lightly.....

“..... Wait a moment. I think I'm almost there.”

Not far away was a small door. Most of the doors of this church were large, but this door was strangely small enough for a person to enter.

“I think it's over there.”

A faint energy seemed to flow like waves around the door. As I moved.

Kuang!

The ground shook. I quickly grabbed the wall decoration and supported my staggering body. When I looked at the ceiling, I saw that the ceiling had cracks. What had happened, I knew right away.

“Kuhp!”

A loud breathing was heard in my ears. Clank, I hear the sound of weapons.

“..... Where is my Iana?”

The voice in my ear was cut off for a moment and then came back. Perhaps Ricdorian was fighting Chaser directly with swords.

“Why do I have to tell you that?”

“Hmm, can you still afford to say that yet? Grand Duke, if you’re here somewhere, she’s not hard to find.”

“If she wasn’t here, you wouldn’t be able to find her.”

Boom! The hallway vibrated once again. I knew that this vibration had come from not far away.

‘..... The battlefield is not far away.’

I could also feel that this vibration was caused by Ricdorian.

“Are they brainwashed again?”

There was a mix of breath in Ricdorian’s voice, muttering a little. I quickly raised my head.

“Pudding, I’ll move quickly!”

Things weren’t so good. Only a few words were heard, but it was not difficult to tell. The voice was constantly interrupted and repeated over and over again. This was a signal that the connection was unstable, and at the same time that Ricdorian was moving his body violently.

Originally, Ricdorian was supposed to turn this tool back on for only for a moment in the operation..... The lack of control was also evidence of this situation. It was never a good situation, as Jaire warned. I have to find it before it gets worse!

Without delay, I ran to the door.

“A little bit more, almost there.....”

I opened the door, muttering impatiently, but the door was locked. I quickly turned my head around. There was an armor decoration nearby. Wouldn’t it be enough to break the doorknob with the sword there?

The moment I thought about it, the scream returned.

– Human, what do you think of me, Nyan!

The little guardian deity broke the doorknob as soon as it showed up in an instant, and said boldly. I smiled bitterly and hurriedly entered the open door. The inside of the door was empty. No, it's so clean that I don't know why it's locked. Rather, this created a strong sense of incongruity. I curled my lips up.

“Normally, there must be a secret passage in a place like this.”

But at this moment, there was no time to find the secret passage. The cry grew louder. Is it saying that there is really not much left now? But strangely, I thought that the cry sounded a little different than before.

..... like a warning.

‘What?’

There was a huge mural painted on the wall. It was a painting of roses that I had seen one day in Kambrakam. I pounded on the wall without looking closely at it.

‘It's empty.’

I knocked on a spot on the wall and then quickly raised my head.

“Oh, Pudding..... go!”

I wanted to say it, but the guardian deity ran right away.

And bang! Slowly, I stared at the crumbling wall. As the thick dusty wind subsided, I could see beyond the wall. There was another space behind the broken wall. It was as expected.

Beyond that, I saw another room closed on all sides.

“A room?”

I saw something in the center of the room. The glittering thing was like a crown. Strangely, it was an item that looked similar to the Empress' tiara..... There was a larger blue gem attached to it than the one on the tiara.

'Is it sealed over there?'

It was as if a blue energy had appeared at first glance. I went inside without delay. At that moment.

– Human!

At the same time as Pudding's sharp voice, there was also the sound of a huge cog wheel turning.

Rattle!

Something grabbed my ankle. When I lower my head to a familiar feeling..... There were shackles wrapped around my ankles. I pulled it, but it didn't budge. Luckily, I ran so fast that I had grabbed the crown by hand.

I burst out laughing in disappointment. I instinctively knew. This is 'fake'.

We, no..... I was deceived. As if to prove this, a clear voice was heard in my ears.

"There you are. Iana."

It was Chaser's voice who laughed happily. He was soon buried by the sound of his soldiers, but I could tell. This exposed my position.

I looked down at the crown closely. Beside me, Pudding was raising its body to tear the chains apart, biting and shaking.

'This is not just 'fake'.'

To be precise, it wasn't 'fake' in the first place. I knew it by the power that was flowing faintly. That the guardian deity must have been sealed in this at

one time. However, it was just moved to another location. Judging from the traces it felt, it was relatively recent.

Rattle. I saw a long line of chains.

“It happened again.”

Come to think of it, this was very familiar to me. From Kambrakam to Domulit’s mansion and briefly to Hernim’s Castle. I was always locked up somewhere with my eyes open. Regardless of my will.

“By the way, Brother. I think you’re wrong this time.”

My first freedom came when Chaser took me out of Kambrakam. However, after a while I was again imprisoned, and the chain was broken by Ricdorian. It was he who freed me from Domulit.

I have always entrusted liberation and freedom to someone.

“Pudding, don’t bite it anymore.”

Pudding stopped chewing the chain until its lips were red. I raised my head.

“You’re watching, right?”

I felt a gaze staring at me from the ceiling. Even though it couldn’t move, I could feel it very close. A part of me.

“Don’t cry.”

A mournful cry was heard. It was as if it was very sad about my appearance.

“It’s okay, I’m used to it.”

Chaser doesn’t seem to know what happens when we’re so close. He just doesn’t know anymore.

“Can you help me?”

The first chain was released by someone else. The freedom entrusted to others only makes us wait for salvation when another captivity comes again.

But now.

It was time for me to break it with my hands.

At the same time as I thought that, a soft energy flowed from the ceiling. A haze of blue like waves enveloped me. It's weak, but that's enough. A blue light bloomed like a flower from my fingertips.

“..... Why is the body of the Blue Rose always so weak? I wondered if I would be like a normal person.”

I wondered why the Blue Rose wouldn't be given such a strong body, with the stamina that never tires after breaking stones with bare hands, tearing iron, or riding a horse.

“But now I know.”

I think I know even though there was only a much weaker power than the original power on my fingertips.

“There was no need for that.”

Crack, crack, crack!

CRASH!

At the same time, the chain shattered like shards of glass.

Chapter 220: Guardian Deity of the Blue Rose

1. 1. Guardian Deity of the Blue Rose

I felt something full inside my body. A blue haze rippled around like a wave. It felt as if I had regained a part of my body I had forgotten, as if I had filled a hole that had been left open.

‘I can’t believe I have this kind of power.’

I had only regained very little of my power. My guardian deity was still bound and sealed. But now I feel it clearly. Where did I lose it..... where should I go.

“Pudding, come here.”

Pudding jumped into my arms. Of course, it made its body smaller just before it was in my arms. I hugged the shrunken beast tightly. Even if I didn’t say it, perhaps it felt my feelings, Pudding turned red and disappeared inside me. I clenched my hand and opened it.

The guardian deity is not here. Now it was clear where I should go.

‘I will go there.’

When I closed and opened my eyes, I was standing in a completely different space.

The scenery of a huge hall spread out in front of me.

People filled the hall. The sound of weapons clashing non-stop and groans could be heard everywhere.

Overall, people in black were oppressing those in white and blue from three sides.

Of course, those in white and blue clothes fighting with their backs to the entrance were Francia and Ricdorian's knights.

The smell of burning and something sharp pierced my nostrils from all directions. The tangy smell here was probably blood. I turned my head unknowingly and met the gaze that was staring at me tenaciously.

“Hello, Brother.”

Not far from the platform. Chaser, who was holding a sword against Ricdorian, retreated.

There was one thing Jaire and the Roses warned of. The Black Rose's powers are enchantment, and maybe there are people who have been brainwashed in the cathedral. As said, there were people in this hall holding and wielding farm equipment, kitchen knives and shovels with their eyes out of focus.

They are probably permanent residents who have disappeared from the city. I smiled bitterly and lifted my head again. In the meantime, Chaser's eyes were fixed on me persistently.

His eyes went wide open in surprise, and it slowly returned to its original position. Chaser pulled back his sword and stepped back. It was an agile movement unlike the relaxed smile. The empty-eyed people filled the void he had left.

“Welcome, Iana.”

He greeted me in his usual voice. But I could tell. That there is confusion in this voice.

I quickly skimmed the situation.

Everything was messed up in a short amount of time. At least Ricdorian and Francia in the distance were all in good shape, but they all looked tired.

Perhaps the fight to subdue people without getting hurt was very difficult. The hall was still filled with the sound of weapons. Only Ricdorian and a few around Chaser stopped fighting.

“Ugh.....”

The moans coming from here and there were actually coming from the knights. Those who were brainwashed didn’t even know they were in pain, and they didn’t even moan.

I was looking down from the top of the stairs, and without hesitation, I jumped into the middle of the fight.

“Iana!”

It was almost two stories high, but looking like I was used to it, I floated my feet with a blue energy. Ricdorian tried to run to me. He approached me, lightly defeating those in his path with a sword covered in red energy.

“Why are you here.....”

“I can’t see you hurt anymore.”

Perhaps, his voice was asking, why did I come this way without hiding. I reached out and kissed Ricdorian’s cheek tenderly.

“Good job, really.”

I already know the situation, so why risk getting hurt further? I turned my head and took a step. Every step I take, the more I feel tied up. My guardian deity was breathing very close.

Even at this moment, the pair of eyes fixed on me didn’t seem to go at any moment. It is Chaser’s eyes standing among the people.

The distance between the villain and me was not far. Because Ricdorian was at the forefront to protect everyone.

I stopped my feet.

“It’s here isn’t it?”

Chaser let out a low breath at my words.

“..... As expected, it looks like I can’t hide it.”

His words were full of regret.

“It would have been safe if you had stayed as you are.”

I laughed bitterly.

“Your way of keeping things tied up is going to get boring now.”

“Iana, you don’t know.”

“What do you mean I don’t know?”

Ricdorian, who suddenly approached me, stood as if protecting me, and pointed his sword. I gently stroked his shoulder.

“Ricdorian, no matter what happens from now on, don’t move.”

Whispering softly so that only he could hear it, I stepped forward in front of Ricdorian. Quickly, I put the dagger in my hand. It was told by Jaire that it was for self-defense, and it was small but sharp and could cut anything. I casually brought it to my neck and drove my hand down.

At the same time, my hand was grabbed. When I looked up, there was a man holding my hand and breathing heavily.

Chaser’s eyes fluttered wildly.

“You, what are you doing?”

A low-pitched voice came out like a threat. Even at this moment, it was an enchanting voice that seemed to seduce me, but I just smiled.

Did he know? How quickly he ran to me in this short amount of time. And the fact that he ran to this place where the enemy was all around.

“I think it’s you who really doesn’t know.”

The reason this man tried to tie me up was probably so that I wouldn’t be endangered in this battle.

“It’s a twisted love, you too.”

The symbol of the Black Rose is ‘obsession’. Was it his fault that he was not right from the root? But everything he did made him cross the river of no return.

“I’m sorry, Brother.”

“.....”

“I don’t want to listen to you anymore.”

Tip, tap. Red drops of blood fell to the ground.

“I didn’t even expect anything from you.”

Words that were never brought out in the end. I don’t think I should say that I felt sorry too. I was afraid that this might have been my brainwashing while living with him, so I pressed it again and again. I didn’t want to give even a small gap in my heart. But it doesn’t seem to matter now. I can let it go without regret.

I left the dagger as it was and passed by Chaser. Chaser didn’t do anything with his eyes wide open. Like someone who is tied to my words.

“You don’t seem to have it in your body, do you?”

I glanced away and saw Chaser’s eyes narrowing.

I glanced at his body carelessly.

I know because it is by my side.

What kind of power?

How to use it.

“Everyone, stop.”

Everyone stopped moving along with my voice that came out like a song.

“I didn’t recognize your plan so I took a shot. So I was fooled.”

I looked up at the ceiling and smiled.

“Actually, the whole hall was a sealing place, wasn’t it?”

A huge blue energy appeared above my head, forming an indescribably beautiful figure. Beneath the waves, a figure fills this gigantic hall.

A huge whale appeared.

The guardian deity of the Blue Rose that has been sealed for a long time. Chains were wrapped around the whale’s huge body. However, it was only a short time before the chain appeared.

Crash! Crumble!

The chains began to crack and shattered into pieces. The scattered chain fragments crumbled and fell like black starlight. As the black starlight poured in, I raised my eyes and looked at my guardian deity.

“Hello.”

A deep, low-pitched sound reverberated throughout the hall. It was the guardian deity’s pleasant singing voice of. I also felt the liberation, joy, and happiness of the guardian deity.

I knew instinctively.

This seal was to be released when I met my guardian deity. That's why Chaser wanted to avoid me facing this guardian deity until the very end.

"You knew I wouldn't be here after all."

Really, that man had a knack for fighting.

I thought he knew me as much as I knew him. In fact, it may have been me who was even more aware of him. But what about now? As long as the seal is lifted, it is no longer relevant.

Everyone was awakened from the brainwashing by the blue wave emanating from the whale. The inside of the hall was filled with the voices of the confused residents in an instant.

"Oh my God."

It would have been nice if it had a happy ending like this, but..... this person was called the final villain of this novel.

"It's amazing. I don't think it's going to get ruined this far....."

I did not know. He covered his face and muttered.

Ricdorian raised his sword again. As Chaser's knights lowered their posture, Hernim's knights raised their swords.

"But, Iana."

Even in this situation when everything went back to its proper place, the man did not stop smiling until the end.

"I'll be in trouble if you think that it's over."

At the same time, a terrifying black energy emanated from him. It was a huge energy that was incomparable to any other time. I hardened my face when I found the blue color through this black energy.

Chaser turned back time with the power of the previous 'Iana', and it seemed that he could use the power of the Blue Rose as well.

I don't know if it's just part of it or all.

I took a deep breath.

In fact, if Chaser brainwash again those who had awakened, things would be unfavorable. Whatever he does, I will block it, and as long as there is a gap, Ricdorian will play an active part.

The power of the Red Rose to crush and destroy like a beast. Those who defended justice were overwhelmingly at a disadvantage in this battle not to injure ordinary people.

I smirked even in this unfavorable situation.

When I see this, the villain gets it very comfortably. How could I not have anticipated such a situation?

"The timing must be right."

I even had the composure to watch Chaser's actions with Ricdorian. It was around the time when the black energy filled the floor of this hall.

Boom.

The hall vibrated violently. Did the ground rumble? It's not. The air was ringing. Then a loud voice came from the sky.

["I asked for permission for the sacred festival that was promised a long time ago, to be held here once again!"]

Light came from the sky. Because it was blocked by the ceiling, I could only see through the window.

Light poured through the stained glass window, and a heavy voice was heard. In a way, it was a sacred sight with the voices of heaven that believers would be amazed by.

[“The 786th Rose Festival has been approved.”]

Fortunately, Lenag got his timing right.

I laughed out loud.

[“According to the sacred rule, all roses will move to the original realm.”]

At the same time, me, Chaser, Ricdorian, and Francia’s bodies were wrapped in a great light. I parted my lips as I smiled brightly.

“Oh dear, we don’t have anything to fight about. Right?”

Chapter 221: Prelude to the Rose Festival

1. Prelude to the Rose Festival

A sacred war with a long history that exists as far back as the time when the original roses were alive. A ritual that had disappeared at one moment was recreated in this place.

While preparing for the festival, there was no way that I would not have known about this.

The rules of the Rose Festival were simple.

Rule one, all Roses return to their territory the moment the festival begins.

Rule two, the Blue Rose moves to the center of the Roses' territory.

Rule three, the Roses look for the Blue Roses.

Isn't it really that simple?

With the system, one winner took everything, monopolizing. So, the stage was no longer here.

Light streamed in through the window. The spectacle of the white light dancing was so sacred and holy that it was like an oracle came down from heaven.

My skirt fluttered among the light. At least no one will be able to move until they are moved. Chaser's eyes grew so large that they couldn't shrink

back. I thought it was because this situation was unexpected, but it was a little different from that. Surprise rather than confusion?

“Iana, did you..... Did you join hands with the imperial family?”

In order to create the Rose Festival, the ‘Imperial Palace of the Sun’, which was built with the founder of the nation, was needed. To be exact, the sacred altar in the middle of that huge and beautiful castle is needed, and the Roses of this age must visit and pray at it.

It was said to be in the middle of the imperial castle under strict surveillance, so it was impossible to make an official request without the Empress’ order. So, the expression ‘joining hands’ was not correct, but it was true that we decided to cooperate.

“Answer me, Iana!”

Instead of answering Chaser’s question, I looked back.

Soon my feet move freely. Earlier, no one could move, but I was the only exception. Because I am the master and this festival was held for me.

I walked slowly and reached a place. It was where Ricdorian was. I reached out to him. Then, in expectation, Ricdorian grabbed my hand. A faint light emanated from Ricdorian’s body. At the same time, the hand that was holding me started to fade.

“Ricdorian, when you return, get ready to go to Kambrakam.”

Ricdorian grabbed my arm and held me in his arms. Holding me from behind, he whispered softly in my ear.

“Yes. I’ll go find you right away.”

The arm that was holding me gradually faded. Ricdorian obediently followed along with the movement. When I looked at where Francia was, she had already disappeared without a trace, perhaps she had already moved quickly.

Maybe the remaining knights would be taken over by Jaire and Francia's lieutenants and quickly retreat. It won't be difficult. Chaser, the commander of the other side, was also summoned back in the same way. I glanced at Ricdorian, but couldn't take my eyes off Chaser.

"You will want to see....."

"I will see you soon."

We talked without looking. I couldn't erase the strangeness. At last, Ricdorian's body that had covered my back disappeared. Was it because the large warm body that covered my back had disappeared?

A cold chill swept behind my back. Alongside an unfamiliar anxiety. Why? Everything is going as expected.....

Crackle!

A huge lightning bolt occurred. Chaser emitted the black energy as if resisting something. He refused to be moved and looked at me with bloodshot eyes.

"Look. Iana. I don't know anything else. But never, never. You must never join hands with the imperial family. You can't trust them."

..... What was he talking about? There was no villain more dangerous than Chaser in the current situation. In a situation like this, he told me to not trust anyone.

It wasn't even funny.

"Don't be ridiculous. The most dangerous person at this moment is none other than you."

"No matter how good it sounds, don't listen. Yes, like what you're doing to me now, doubt everything. Like you always do!"

"What are you talking about?"

Was he try to buy my sympathy now? He was a smart man. It was a reasonable doubt.

“You were the one who made me doubt.”

I saw people being dragged in front of my eyes. I saw shackles and chains on my feet, how can he tell me to trust in him?

I frowned at his unusual face and urgent tone.

“..... I don't believe you anymore.”

Then he narrowed his eyes. As I lowered my head, I could see that my hand was also gradually fading.

“Iana! Please, listen. Hoo, even if you hate me! The imperial family..... !”

My vision completely blackened.

Together with Chaser's last words.

When I opened my eyes, I was in a quiet forest.

‘Did I move?’

I got up slowly. I roughly brushed off the leaves attached to my body and looked around. I thought it was deep forest, but when I sat down and looked at it, I could see a village through the branches of the trees. It was a small town.

“..... It's not too far from where we discussed it.”

Under the rules of the Rose Festival, all roses would be returned to their estate, everyone must have arrived at the estate. But I know that's not all.

I looked up at the sky.

It hasn't started yet..... One more process remained. A terrifying sound thundered in the sky. The thumping was as if the speaker was right next to my ear.

["The Yellow Rose of Neutrality and Balance opened the festival. I am requesting your participation in the festival, state your approval!"]

A voice was heard loudly.

["The Red Rose of Passion and Wildness requests participation in the festival, I agree!"]

["The White Rose of Healing and Respect requests participation in the festival, I agree!"]

And then once again.

One more time.

Once the Roses are moved to the estate, they will go through the verification process to see if they are the successors of the Roses. And here they can choose whether or not to participate once they complete the verification. According to the records, not a single rose has ever been left out.

'Still one person..... left.'

The most important voice was not heard yet. As time went on, it would shift to whether or not to participate. Actually, this wasn't bad either.

Roses who do not participate in this festival will never come to my side again. They must pay a harsh price for it. I clenched my hand and opened it. My palms were full of cold sweat.

Then, after a brief interval, it rang again.

["The Black Rose of Obsession and Lust requests participation in the festival, I agree!"]

I couldn't see it, but I could feel that Chaser was seriously considering it and asked to participate.

'The participation is over.'

For now, we passed the first turning point, participation.'

I exhaled a little. This voice is a kind of 'guide'. To inform and deliver notices to the participants, including myself, the subject of this battle. It was so loud that I thought it was the voice of God, but I couldn't figure out who it was. The Empress, the informant herself, did not know, nor was it listed in the records.

This method to avoid an unfavorable battlefield by starting the festival was successful.

"..... Is this the beginning?"

I looked at the village and tried to figure out the way.

"I have to move fast."

All that was left was to meet Ricdorian and run as fast as possible to Kambrakan. Now that there is not only Pudding in me, but also the guardian deity that has just been released, I have regained my strength so I don't have to worry about safety.

Moreover, I had already obtained the Empress' permission, so all I had to do was run to Kambrakam.

This is the place where the Blue Rose was moved, that is, in the middle of the estate of all Roses, but technically, there was an estate closest to this place. It was the Valtaze estate, Lenag's.

'Chaser must know this.'

Perhaps Chaser knows this too, and thinks I'm heading there.

Most of all, he doesn't know what my purpose is to go to Kambrakam. I just hoped that Lenag would do a good job as a bait. This was also a role that Lenag himself volunteered for.

After confirming all participants and reviewing the operation, it was time to move.

["The last rose requests an approval!"]

..... what?

I quickly looked up at the sky.

What is this sound?

["However, you are not a legitimate participant, so you will go through an evaluation!"]

The voice from the sky seemed to be talking to someone. What the hell is going on? Confused and couldn't think of anything at all, an answer came from the sky.

["The evaluation has been completed."]

I clenched my lips.

["Imperfect being, your participation is not permitted by nature. However I decided to admit one in a thousand years. I will acknowledge your name."]

Imperfect. With this one word, I understood the whole situation.

["The Purple Rose of Incompleteness and Greed requests participation in the festival, I agree!"]

This is the appearance of the fifth rose..... announcing the participation of the imperial family. I swallowed my breath.

‘What is this?’

Of course, this was not in the deal at all.

The Empress asked me for help. And she generously handed over information about the festival to me, saying that she would help anything she could. In particular, the information the Empress had was not just a record, but the memories of the previous Emperors who actually lived through countless histories. It has a higher preservation value than any other record.

As long as the festival was held and all the information turned out to be true, everything had not been a lie. However, for her to participate It's something that hasn't been mentioned.

By now, everyone should have heard this voice. And they must have felt that something was wrong.

For once, nothing has changed. No wonder she helped me so easily, did she even think of it this far? I thought it was just because of the circumstances the Empress had. I had no choice but to think like that.

At that moment, Chaser's last words came to mind.

His words to not join hands with the Empress until the end and not to trust..... His anger was intense. I grinded my teeth.

“Who on earth is telling who not to trust who?”

I clenched my fists and pressed my forehead.

Fortunately, I did not share the operation's strategy because I did not stop feeling uneasy and suspicious of the Empress until the end. I just got permission to use the altar.

‘But she knows I'm supposed to go to Kambrakam.’

What she doesn't know is the route I'm going.

I closed my lips tightly.

Chapter 222: Calculated Betrayal

1. Calculated Betrayal

I have no time to panic. Without a moment to calm the anxiously howling Pudding, I quickly moved forward without even having time to properly dispel my lingering feelings with my guardian deity whom I met for the first time.

‘I must head to the meeting point with Ricdorian.’

It was only the Roses who were affected by the festival, and it had nothing to do with their subordinates. In other words, if I passed by that village, Hernim’s knight would be waiting for me.

Will they be with the magic prepared in advance? The magic was traceable, so I couldn’t use it as soon as I arrived here. I had to hide my direction as much as possible from Chaser, who was running this way by now.

‘Now there is one more person to hide from.’

It was not easy to predict for what reason the Empress participated in the festival, but I had a feeling that it was never a good intention.

My senses told me so. We should not meet. There must be competent wizards in the imperial family, so I had to pay more attention to magic use. As I walked for a while, the bushes shook in front of me.

I instinctively grabbed the dagger hanging from my waist and stepped one of my feet back. A blue light flickered on my fingertips.

“Oh? Hello!”

And what appeared through the bushes was a very small child. She's a cute girl too.

"Are you a guest? Few travelers come to our town!"

I stared intently at the child's outfit and face. I wondered if it was a trick or a ruse, but I didn't feel the unique energy of magic. She feels like a real ordinary person as I can't feel it even with the sharper sense after getting my guardian deity.....

Long ago, when I lived in Domulit, I was taken away by a kidnapper disguised as a child. Without erasing my vigilance, I stepped back.

"... that's right. I'm on my way. Why are you here?"

"This is my way to pick up acorns!"

Showing that fact, the child's hand held a handful of acorns, from her slightly opened pocket. My vigilance has loosened a bit.

"..... Well, this may sound strange, but this place might get dangerous soon. Go home quickly."

"Huh, why? Is there a war? Is the rose coming?"

"What?"

I paused at the term.

"Our village is a village dedicated to the Blue Rose!"

The child smiled broadly with a clear face.

"There, that village."

"... Is there a village?"

"Yes! A long time ago, the Blue Rose of the beginning lived here and loved us. The power from that time remains, and everyone born in the village has

blue eyes!”

The child’s eyes were as blue as the deep sea. It felt different from Ricdorian’s eyes, which had a pale blue color, but I was strangely used to it.

Because this was similar to the color of the light emitted by my guardian deity.

“This was the land where the Blue Rose ruled.”

“..... Are you talking about a territory?”

“Yes. It used to be very, very big, but now it is small.”

The child said with a bright blush on her cheeks, happily explaining.

“Sometimes, the Blue Rose may come back to our village, so the village chief said that we had to take good care of it. The Blue Rose is a precious person who has made us live well up to this point.”

The child spread her hands wide.

“We are the Blue Rose’s people, so we wish the Blue Rose to be happy for a long, long time!”

I was at a loss for words.

“Who is Sister?”

“I.....”

In the child’s bright blue eyes, there was nothing but pure longing and admiration without any selfishness or scheming.

“... Are you waiting even though you have never seen the Blue Rose?”

“Yes. Maybe one day the Blue Rose will come!”

So the child’s eyes came back to me again, *who are you?*

Every Rose has a territory. I heard from the Empress that the Roses' present land is the place where the original rose took root, and I also heard that their family name is the name of the original rose.

There was nothing about the Blue Rose in person or the territory in those useful information. But if all the roses had their own territory..... Wouldn't the Blue Rose have one too?

It felt like I heard the answer right in front of my eyes.

All Roses are summoned to their territory. And that I, too, should be summoned to my territory.

"I am just a traveler who gets lost by chance."

"Ah really?"

The child looked sullen.

"I thought maybe Sister is the Blue Rose. You're so very pretty."

"Really? Thank you."

I had no time. I had to leave this place in a hurry. I smiled slightly and gently stroked the child's head.

"But I think I might be able to meet the Blue Rose when I go to the capital."

"Sister? Really? For real?"

"Yes. Do you have something to say? I will tell the Blue Rose."

She was still a small child who was likely to believe such lies, so she seemed to have fallen for it. As expected, the child smiled broadly. I wondered if the child would tell the Blue Rose to visit this village.

"Hehe, then please tell the Blue Rose to be happy! May the Blue Rose always be happy!"

“..... What?”

But those words were unexpected.

“The village chief said that the Blue Rose is very strong and beautiful, but even then, the Blue Rose couldn’t live as she wanted. She was not free.”

Blue eyes that resembled my whale blinked.

“That’s why the Blue Rose comes back here every now and then.”

The Blue Rose that visited very rarely is probably the past Blue Roses that were summoned here to hold the rose festival.

In the past, the Rose Festival was said to have occurred because the Blue Rose gave up their choice or the fight got too fierce.

“But we were happy and doing well in the land given by the Blue Rose. So we’ll always wish the Blue Rose’s happiness.”

The child spread her little hands wide.

“May the Blue Rose always be free! Always be happy!”

A small village that used to be large, but gradually decreased and now only maintains a small life. People who have the same eye color as the guardian deity. I felt an indescribable feeling.

Even though I had no choice but to accept the name of the Blue Rose, I only felt that it was half believable and yet incomprehensible.....

“..... thank you.”

“Yes?”

“No. I will tell the Blue Rose.”

Why was it chilly under my eyes for a while? I couldn’t figure out the exact reason. There were people who purely wished for my happiness and

freedom in a place I did not know.

I felt grateful. With a helplessness as well.

Now it was really time to leave.

“Then I will go. I hope to see you again.”

The child kindly gave detailed directions through the village and out of this bush. She told me to avoid the hunters’ traps, and told me where the traps were.

“Yes. Pretty sister! See you again! Sister looks pretty and um, mysterious! I want to see you again.”

“Yes. Thank you.”

On that path, I parted with the child and walked like running. By arranging my stamina, the meeting point with Hernim’s knight would not be far away.

A blue aura wrapped around my feet. No matter how much I walked, my feet did not hurt and my speed was much faster than my original speed.

It was around the time when I had just broken through the bush and came out to the huge field.

“You’re here now?”

I met the crowd waiting for me. Unfortunately, it was not Hernim’s knight who I wanted to meet the most. It wasn’t even my roses, which would run at an unbelievable speed.

Flutter~

The long reddish-brown hair fluttered. The Empress, who showed her scarred cheek, was smiling gracefully. Wherever her dress went, she was wearing a uniform.

“I see you again, Blue Rose.”

As soon as she finished speaking, a hugely prepared magic attacked me.

Bang! Bang!

An untimely roar echoed across the wide open field. Some fields were burned, others frozen and scorched.

“Haa, haa.”

In an instant, the hollowed-out lands revealed how huge the magic was and how fierce it was.

I took in a small breath. The dust settled over the blue veil that surrounded me to protect me, and I could see the Empress’ smiling face between them.

“..... It’s unexpected.”

She was smiling, but she was no longer relaxed.

The fight was fierce. Although it was a short time, the fierce and fiery fight told me a lot. I realized that it wasn’t difficult to block this myriad of magic, and that I wouldn’t be defeated at this level.

“Your Majesty, why are you going this far?”

The Empress narrowed her eyes as our realizations crossed.

“Are you asking this now?”

“You should at least have given me time to drink.”

“Your tone is still there. Even though you are cheeky, I’m still in a bad mood.”

The magic stopped for a moment as a smile crept into the Empress’s lips.

“What do you not know, now that you’ve already seen it? I have come to pick you up.”

“You’re not trying to kill me?”

What are these fierce magic for then?

“Ah, as long as I am breathing, your condition doesn’t matter.”

It was only after the magic had stopped that I could properly see the Empress’s face, and only then did I know.

“Hahaha, hahahaha. It’s great to see you again.”

There was something strange about the sharp purple eyes. The whitishness circling around the Empress looked darker than before.

“Even the ghosts say they are happy to see you! What a great day, hahaha!”

They were shapes that evoked an ominous feeling the moment I saw them. I buried Pudding deep inside me so it wouldn’t run out.

She didn’t fully grasp my abilities. So, Pudding had to be left as a trump card. It wasn’t difficult to block the magic. The same was true of the sword too.

Perhaps it was aware of my dangerous situation, my guardian deity did not remove the blue veil that protected me. Rather, it just embraces me in a more blueish tint. It was like being embraced by a warm wave.

“..... thank you.”

A soft cry came in my ears.

“You asked me to help you. Was it all calculated that you came and participated in the festival?”

I wasn’t really curious. It was just a question I asked to find a way.

“Well. Did I ? Hahaha. Maybe I did.....”

The Empress tilted her head. She didn't hide her sharp eyes. Her tone was languid, as if she had taken the wrong medicine, and her words trailed off.

“..... Maybe I don't..... No. Why does it matter? Now I want to have that..... position and power. I did..... I want, everything....”

The Empress' finger stroked my chin.

“The roses of the past used everything they could to win this festival..... I like the Black Rose the most..... Didn't he threaten to destroy something precious? Ah, right!”

As she mumbled her words, she turned her head to the side. The place where we met here was a wide field. Because the land of the field was in a high altitude, the view towards the village was open at the side.

It was the village where the child from a while ago lives.

“I heard that the Black Rose took the lives of innocent people hostage and conciliated them..... Shall we burn that village down?”

I shouldn't have been agitated. But at that moment, the child's bright expression crossed my mind, and I may have revealed my traces without my knowledge.

“Oh?”

I was caught. The expression on the Empress' face showed that she was on the right path.

“Unexpectedly, is it correct?”

“What.”

Her face brightened brightly.

“Attack.”

Her fingers were not pointing at me. The moment I saw the flames heading towards the village, I bit my lip.

“Stop it!”

Chapter 223: Prison ménage à trois

1. Prison ménage à trois

Over, over there!

Unfortunately, my guardian deity must have had to choose one. Either heed my plea or ignore me and protect me. But the subject of the power was me, and my power stopped all magic.

And.

-Human!

A small snow leopard blocked the swords that flew at me. The red energy deflected all the swords and blew the knights away.

But once again, countless swords flew. The moment the sword pierced the snow leopard, I sat down and hugged Pudding tightly. *Whoop*. A blue haze made from my fingertips pulled the pierced sword away.

“Are, are you okay? Quick, quickly. Get..... Get inside me! ”

But this good-natured beast was crying loudly, only worrying about me.

-Human, Nyan! Human, let go of me! Human!

At the same time, an unbearable pain flooded my back. A little late, a blue energy enveloped me. My guardian deity was howling long. Like blaming itself.

“..... it’s okay. It’s not..... your fault.”

When I turned my head with difficulty, I saw the village that was in good condition. Under the high sky, the village was as peaceful as I had seen it. A smoke flows slowly as if cooking a meal.

What is this? Since when did I overflow with love for humanity?

I just laughed.

With this, the magic that came quickly as if waiting for it slammed down on me. It's easy to block, but blood seems to rush on my body. Oh, I think I got hit by something a little bigger than I thought.

‘..... I have to go to Ricdorian.’

And my eyes slowly closed. The Empress' face was amongst the landscape. Ah, now I know.

<I tried my best not to get swallowed.>

Like a snake that glides under her silky, shiny hair. One last glance at the mad Empress' smile, smiling broadly but never in a normal way.

“Hahahaha, I got it! Finally got it! Ahahahaha!”

There. The smile and a firm face that agreed when I said that I didn't like that extraterrestrial forces dictate human fate was not there.

<I don't want to go crazy.>

Her wish that she doesn't want to go crazy never comes true. I smiled for the last time.

‘The enemy has increased.’

I faced the dark.

Drip, drip.

Dripping water. I knew the water dripping was a familiar sound. I was in doubt. That's weird. How do I know this without seeing it? The answer to the question I asked myself came right away.

..... That's a sound I've heard countless times.

The prison had a stone wall, so no matter how well it was built, on a rainy day, this kind of noise was always heard. In particular, Ricdorian's cell, locked in the basement, was even worse. But wait.

'Prison?'

I slowly opened my eyes. Was it something I was thinking about unconsciously?

"It's really the prison cell....."

I saw the structure of the familiar room. It was only the structure that I was used to, but it wasn't exactly the same. It differed from Kambrakan in the material of the stone and the width and shape of the grate.

However, the grate that came down heavily, there was a small flaming torch, and the moist air as a whole. It was a very familiar space to me.

'Anyway, it's the cell.'

I looked down at my hands and took a deep breath. My hands were heavy. When I came to my senses, I expected that nothing so peaceful would await, but..... *rattle*. My hands had cold and heavy handcuffs. The rattling chain was a bonus.

"Huh."

I clicked my tongue.

I can't believe it's the handcuffs now. I thought it was fortunate that it wasn't shackles, but I never thought I would get to experience the full imprisonment set in the cell. I swept my head with my handcuffed hands.

“..... How come I got back into prison after going round and round?”

First, I have to check the condition. Pudding that I was most worried about was asleep inside me. It looked like it had fainted or was recovering as it didn't answer when called.

I'm glad it came back safely to my arms. And my guardian deity also seemed to be doing well too. However, I could not easily use my power perhaps due to what was used in these handcuffs.

‘I'm sorry. As soon as I meet you, I make you suffer a lot.’

It bothered me that I hadn't been able to speak properly with my guardian deity yet. It was because things had turned around. It heard my thoughts and gave a small cry. The sound of muffle ringing seemed to envelop my heart at ease.

This is your way of comforting me.

I smiled slightly and clasped my handcuffed hands.

‘Is it the handcuffs that make my power useless? Or if it's the whole room, I don't know.’

Remembering the last time I saw the Empress' face, she wouldn't have allowed me to walk free. Yeah, I wouldn't normally get tied up. I sighed deeply, recalling old memories.

“I hate being tied down.”

“You don't like restraints?”

“Of course. Who likes it.....”

Instead of answering naturally, I paused.

Confinement, chains, and the familiar voice.

It was a very familiar situation to me, so I answered without thinking. Because that's always been the case in Domulit.

‘Chaser?’

When I turned my head, the owner of the ecstatic voice was smiling. His eyes curved showing he was happy to see me.

“I see you again. Iana.”

However, his situation was not where he could smile leisurely.

Drip, drip.

The sound of dripping water. It was from him. Drops of blood were dripping down his fingertips, both hands tied to the wall. His stoic attire had gone, he was bound to the wall with white shirt half-ripped and only his pants on.

He did not lose his smile as he looked at me as if he was not in pain even while being restrained in a vicious posture where he could neither stand nor sit.

“Isn’t it refreshing to see me?”

“Who.”

I frowned.

“No? I thought you’d like this.....”

“Do you like hanging on chains like that?”

“Of course not.”

I naturally distanced myself from Chaser. Friendliness? There was no such thing anymore. Just like the changed Empress, that man is an ‘enemy’.

“But our Iana. It feels good to see you.”

I didn't answer.

Instead, I slowly opened my mouth as I looked at the figure who was confined next to me.

"..... Who said I agreed with that title? Don't call me that."

"Then *my* Iana?"

Chaser's expression didn't change even though he saw me visibly retreating. I rolled my eyes indifferently and turned my head.

"Say whatever you like. I won't even talk to you anymore."

"Iana."

He was a smart man. I don't know what happened to him to get him hanging over there..... Nevertheless, he was a man who made me feel threatened. On the other hand, even in this state, he was so excited that he spoke casually, so I was speechless.

"It's true that I'm really happy despite the circumstances."

At the same time as Chaser said so, a familiar voice was heard once more.

"Iana, please shut him up."

My rose's voice with a low but elegant reverberation.

"Don't give him a glance, a gaze, or even a look."

Turning my head, I saw a similarly restrained Ricdorian beyond the grate.

"Ricdorian?"

"Yes. Please tell me quickly. So that guy can listen too."

That one is chained tight and covered with fog.

“That you love me.”

The light was dim and almost made him like a silhouette, but I recognized it clearly. No, there was no way I couldn't recognize my rose. Fortunately, his hands were tied, but his movements were not restrained. In addition, the chains attached to the handcuffs were long enough to walk up to the grate.

“Are you really Ricdorian?”

“Yes. Iana.”

Upon closer inspection, I could clearly see his condition too. Ricdorian wasn't in a very good condition either. His whole body was tightly bound with chains, and there was blood all over his face.

“..... Are you hurt?”

I hurriedly knelt in front of the grate and sat down.

“Are you hurt anywhere? How hurt are you?”

The red lips under the blindfold drew a shy curve at my worried voice.

“A little bit. Very little.”

“I don't think it's a little.”

“It's really little.”

Ricdorian was blindfolded, but he seemed to pinpoint my location from the sound.

“I'm only hurt enough for Iana to worry about.”

“..... What is it?”

Ricdorian reached out his hand towards the grate. He couldn't reach out far because of the chain. He asks me to hold his hand.

“It hurts, Iana.”

I sighed and took his hand. His hands were already covered with small wounds. I don't know whose blood this is, but..... It seemed to show that he had been through a fierce fight, no matter whose blood it was. In fact, it wasn't that I didn't have anything to ask Chaser who was behind me.

What he warned me about. Don't trust the imperial family, did he expect this to happen? I could have asked this, but I didn't.

It already happened anyway.

“By the way, why did you even get caught?”

Ricdorian's force was truly overwhelming. It would have been impossible to catch him alive without mobilizing some kind of force.....

Ricdorian smiled bitterly for a moment.

“I had no choice. During the fight with the Black Rose, the Empress appeared, and she pushed a random trick..... .”

When I see him smiling, something flashes through my mind.

“Don't tell me the Empress took me hostage?”

“.....”

Ricdorian did not answer, but I knew that this meant a yes.

“..... You are my only weakness, the weakness of all roses.”

Ricdorian smiled bashfully.

“My body is not a waste if it's to protect you.”

I got furious.

“It’s not the time to say your body not a waste. Do you think I would like to see you get hurt?”

“But..... we meet again like this.”

I stopped talking at the sound of his thirsty voice.

The weakness of all roses. Without realizing it, I almost turned my head.

..... Does that mean that Chaser was also caught because I was hostage? I don’t know the man now. But now I have come too far to understand.

“More than that, Iana, won’t you listen to me?”

“..... what?”

Ricdorian sticks out his tongue and lightly wets his lips.

The white skin seen under the blindfold and the dark red blood stains that contrasted with it. And red lips. It shouldn’t be like this, but..... I seemed to forget the situation and a strange imagination was ignited. I took a breath.

No, wait, I think I’m going to be a real trash if I think about it here. I patted my face with handcuffs. Wake up.

“Tell me that you love me. Okay?”

“Ah.....”

“Hmm, if you’re agitating me like this. It’s very different.”

Chaser’s voice interrupted the conversation that seemed to be of only me and Ricdorian.

I then glanced back.

I don’t know why he kept silent until now..... Chaser stared at us as if piercingly. When he met mine, his red eyes fluttered slightly.

He was a contradictory man. While having no hesitation in harming others.
But he got hurt by one small glance of mine.

I blinked my eyes slowly.

Ricdorian suddenly showing a spoilt side. I was the one who told him not to
endure it any longer.

Then I smiled a little. My lips opened slowly.

“That’s mean. My Ricdorian.”

Chaser flinched.

Chapter 224: This is paradise

1. This is paradise

I grabbed Ricdorian's hand. I grabbed it avoiding the wounds, but felt a slight tremor from him. When I let go of his hand, wondering if it might be painful, Ricdorian's fingers caught me. Telling me not to let go.

"You said you'd let me get tired of it."

Deliberately for Chaser to listen, Ricdorian did not lower his voice. I've decided not to forgive that man, Chaser, anymore. I won't even try to understand.

"My Ricdorian."

The name I was tired of him calling was already given to someone else.

"Lift your head. I told you, you don't have to crouch."

It was a deception to try to understand the one who bound and imprisoned me, the one who shed blood and tears in the eyes of so many. This is a path that this man himself has walked a long way. So far away, there will be no more crossing with mine.

"I can say it again and again if you don't want to be anxious."

It was he who took away my compassion, and this is the result of his creation.

"I love you."

I lifted Ricdorian's hand and gladly kissed it. His blood-stained hands smelled of grass, mud, and a mixture of blood. It's the blood he shed to protect me. Ricdorian flinched, trying to pull his hand back, but he showed weak resistance. Deep inside, he doesn't want to let go. Responding to this, I applied strength to my fingers. And moved my lips.

I kissed the tips of his hands with the broken nail, as Ricdorian did.

"..... It's dirty, Iana."

"Not at all."

The smell of blood stuck to my lips. But if I could comfort my Rose's anxious heart, this would be okay.

"I love only you."

Seeing someone you love hurt and messed up breaks the heart more than I think.

"Now I know. What love is."

I spoke to Ricdorian, but this would be clear to Chaser as well. But it wasn't just for this man to listen to, it was also the truth.

"I said it before. I don't know if I'll ever be able to feel true love."

At this point, I lowered my gaze slightly.

"I have to say it again. I never knew love would change me like this. When I look at you at this moment, it hurts me so much that I want to be hurt instead."

I didn't want you to be chained again. But it hurts because I feel like this is my fault.

"I think it's my fault."

I still want to reach out and wipe the blood away, but I can't even reach his face. Ricdorian lowered his head, perhaps noticing me. He even came close to my hand with the blindfold on and sniffed at me like an animal in the prison long ago.

"Don't get hurt. Iana."

"... How can I not think like that? My heart hurts a lot."

"..... Wherever I am, you make it paradise."

"Don't say that. Prison is a place where you don't have very good memories."

"Nevertheless, this is my paradise now."

He then rubbed his cheek against my hand.

"..... Because you are there."

At the same time, a strangled, small voice came out.

"Iana....."

I did not turn my head at the mournful call I heard behind me.

I didn't care what kind of face Chaser was making. Trying to understand this would be impossible for me and those who were hurt in the past.

"What about Francia and Renag?"

"I don't know. Because they were not with me."

The Rose Festival was still in progress. After shouting their participation, they each must have moved to the promised point in their territory.

I quickly turned my head to check the grate. There are no walls, but grates, so I can see the rooms right next to mine. First of all, there seems to be no one in the cell on the other side, and although the lights were dim, there are

many things that can be confirmed. Likewise, there seemed to be no one beyond Ricdorian's cell. Considering that there is no response to our conversation either, there is no guard.

'The fact that there is no guard..... Do you mean to trust the device built in this room?'

Perhaps, given that Renag and Francia were not in this cell, they did not seem to have been arrested.

Now, how should we move? I am not skeptical. Since the operation has not completely gone off track, we could.

"For now, I think we need to get out of here....."

We must go to Kambrakam before the festival is over. Being conscious of Chaser, I did not say the destination. Because I know Chaser is listening behind me.

"How do I get out of here?"

When I asked this question, two voices answered at the same time.

"Don't worry about that....."

"Don't worry about that, Iana."

Ricdorian stopped talking. Then he shut his lip. I slowly turned my head. There was a man with a picturesque smile. Even though he must have heard all of the previous conversation, Chaser didn't seem to be agitated at all.

I don't know if he was not agitated or if he had set everything aside.

At least I thought it was the latter. The residue of emotions that he couldn't get out of his head was smeared on his face.

"What's the matter? We are in the same situation where we have to go, right? It wouldn't be a bad idea to hold hands with the villain for a while. What do you think?"

Rattle. A thick chain swayed slightly over Chaser's chained up hands. He smiled dizzily as he hung on it. Like a captive demon.

Under the light of the torch, Chaser's red eyes narrowed.

"As you can see, I am a very useful hand. Right?"

You know me well, he looked like he was asking that.

"I know how to get out of here peacefully. Iana."

He said so and did not take his eyes off me. Implicitly telling me to listen to the end.

"Because I shouldn't be locked up for a long time either."

If so, wouldn't it have been better if he hadn't been caught in the first place? I wanted to ask this, but I didn't say anything.

"Why do I want to believe and hold hands with you?"

"Oh dear, Iana. That's kind of sad. In fact, have you ever believed in me? If that's the case, I'm grateful..... Or have you never been?"

"Don't play with words. I know you will catch me again if I leave this place anyway."

"Iana."

"I will never be with you. Ever."

I cut off Chaser's words resolutely.

"Don't try to fool me anymore."

It was then that Chaser's expression sank. No, the smile slowly disappeared, and the face looked like it had cracked. Chaser lost his words for a moment. He soon spoke again. But someone else was faster than that.

“It wouldn’t hurt to listen to it once.”

I looked at Ricdorian in surprise.

“Ricdorian?”

My calling has the question ‘do you mean it?’. Because it wasn’t something I thought would come from Ricdorian and no one else.

“When it comes to tactics, he is a man that no one in the Empire can catch up with. Especially... his bad tactics are unmatched.”

Chaser smiled softly. Like the hardened expression was never there.

“You speak as if you were clean. I’m disappointed. The Grand Duke, who was called my rival.”

“No matter how dirty I am, this side holds the noble hand.”

“Aahh. Will you show off your choice in front of me?”

Chaser inevitably grinded his teeth.

“I want to be with my Iana, but I’m not happy with this kind of help.”

Rattle rattle. The chains around Chaser’s hand moved wildly.

I could see the black energy that was about to bloom from his fingertips forcibly disappearing with a squeak sound. At the same time, a burning scar was left on Chaser’s wrist. But Chaser looked disinterested. Instead, he slowly tilted his head.

“I’m going to break my pride like this and just lay it on the floor.... Isn’t that a low-level method for a trick to be used by the Rose of Justice?”

I let out a small sigh as I listened to the conversation between the two men. Then I gently grabbed Ricdorian’s hand.

“Ricdorian, there is no time for arguing.”

“..... I know, Iana. However.....”

Ricdorian blurred his words, and then he sighed.

“I know there’s a reason that punk is so arrogant. He’s annoyed and wants to get rid of me right away.”

“Why?”

“Well, I should explain it.”

“Shut up.”

Ricdorian said, ignoring Chaser’s words neatly. With a voice that was gnashing his teeth.

“Haa, damn it. I’m not happy either. But we can only get out if we combine the powers of that side and this side. Iana.”

“*Combine the powers?* Ricdorian, the person I’m looking at right now is you, right, it’s not a fake? For real, you mean what you say?”

“... Yes. Iana. It’s unbelievable, but it’s me.”

He was still like that from a while ago, but it was unbelievable that the words came from Ricdorian’s mouth.

“I also hate myself right now.”

Ricdorian gritted his teeth.

“... I know how to give up for the sake of the most important things too.”

I still couldn’t believe it. No one else but Chaser? I know Ricdorian’s feelings for Chaser better than anyone. Hearing Ricdorian’s voice, he didn’t seem very happy either.

“What kind of method is that?”

“..... Iana. What is my position?”

“What? That’s..... You’re the Grand Duke?”

“And over there.....”

The moment Ricdorian just said that.

Screech.

The sound of rusty metal echoed. I knew immediately. This is the sound of the door opening. Unsurprisingly, there was a faint light in the distance. Soon after, the sound of footsteps came along.

“..... Iana, I beg you, will you come with me? The ragged rose in the next room won’t be able to protect you right now. Alright?”

Chaser whispered lowly. I didn’t listen to that. At the same time, the footsteps stopped.

“Are you awake?”

The voice was familiar. Where did I hear it? However, I didn’t have to go through my memories. The moment the unfamiliar visitor took off his cloak, I knew who it was.

“You are.....”

If I remember correctly, he was the old man I saw in the Empress’ audience room. He was the only person who stayed in place when I had the secret audience. He bowed his head politely.

“I’m glad you woke up earlier than expected.”

“Earlier than expected? How long have I been down?”

“Three days.”

I flinched..... I fainted for that long? I thought it wouldn't be long. If this is a prison within the imperial castle, I just thought they might have brought me here using magic.

While I felt as if I had been hit and could not hide my confusion, the man quickly spoke.

“I don't have time, so I'll deliver it quickly. This is the last order of Her Majesty the Empress.”

“The last one, what is that?”

“She said that if I tell you that you are the last person to receive this when she is in her perfect mind, you will understand. After that, she will become the ‘crazy Empress’.”

Chapter 225: I'm not your enemy

1. I'm not your enemy

I stopped breathing. Because I was shaken by those words. *Crazy Empress*, the last time I saw her was just right for the name. Soon, the man handed me a letter. As he held out the letter, I didn't let go of my vigilance and received the letter. Ricdorian from behind told me not to go, but I didn't feel any danger.

“Do you have anything else to say?”

“... What you feared would happen, she said. Lady will know everything.”

As I passed the two men's calls, I reflected on the man's words. I reached a conclusion.

‘..... As expected, she's lost her mind, the Empress.’

I saw the letter crumpled in my hand. Opening it slowly, the words in the letter were as I had expected. *I have reached my limit, I am writing this letter with all my heart.* A sketch was drawn at the end of the paper. It was a pretty detailed map.

‘What is with the map?’

The man kept his place while I read the letter.

“Once you get out of this cell, run straight west.”

He said as soon as I read it all and raised my head.

“The Empress's final arrangement is there.”

He put on his cloak again. Then, without hesitation, he stepped back. His job has ended, and the rest seems to be irrelevant. His attitude felt like he was drawing a line.

“Just follow the directions drawn at the end of the paper. You can use it according to what was written there.”

“I know. If this letter is true, then there.....”

“Yes. Her Majesty has made a way for you to go right where you want to go.”

The destination must be Kambrakam.

“Be careful, Her Majesty has already taken over that area.”

“What? Wait, not yet!”

I reached out to grab the man that was retreating hastily. However, my hand did not reach the man and instead grabbed the grate.

“Are you kidding me? How am I supposed to get out of here?”

The Empress’s letter assumed that I would be taken to the imperial palace, but there was nothing about escaping from the cell.

Hey, is he not coming down the hallway? This is crazy. The man walked away without looking back. Even though I couldn’t stand it and shouted some more, the door was mercilessly closed.

“Wait, wait a minute. Hey! Huh. Crazy.”

This is ridiculous. What is the point of having a passage? I can’t even take the chain off right now! I usually don’t feel much agitation or anger, but I couldn’t stand this now. As I couldn’t contain my anger and banged on the grate,

“Hey, Iana. You don’t have to be so angry.”

I heard a calming voice behind me. When I turned my head, Ricdorian was facing exactly in the direction I was in. When I saw him wearing the blindfold, something filled me up with tears.

“But Ricdorian. Are you saying that now?”

It was a situation where I, who was the strongest, could not use my power properly. Then, Ricdorian and Chaser were also having difficulty moving.

“This is the situation!”

It just felt frustrating that we couldn’t go out right away. Ricdorian continued to talk to me, comforting me with a calm and friendly voice. Oddly enough, I usually played the role of calming him down, but right now, the role was reversed.

It was fine until I found out I had passed out for so long. We had to reach Kambrakam within the set time!

“Your words are always comforting, but Ricdorian, I don’t think it’s okay for now.”

I muttered as I put my handcuffed hands on my forehead.

“... I mean, it shouldn’t have failed. You know.”

Above all, the ultimate goal of this operation is to extend Ricdorian’s lifespan. This man’s life was at stake. He shook his head.

“No. Iana..... I mean, you can get out of this cell without getting angry.”

“What? Is that real?”

“Yes.”

“Why are you saying that now? No, I got agitated. Ha....”

I paused, clenching my forehead. But how? HOW? I looked at Ricdorian and Chaser alternately. One has his whole body tied with chains and is

wearing a blindfold, and the other is hanging from the wall? And I'm also wearing handcuffs. I couldn't understand.

"How?"

"Iana. Do you know my position?"

"Yes. The Grand Duke, I answered earlier, didn't I?"

Ricdroan bit his lip and let out a rough breath. He looked like a man before saying something he didn't like. Finally, a few words came out from the tip of his lips.

"..... What is *over there's* position?"

"That man? He's..... a Duke."

"Then, Iana. Questions."

Chaser's voice suddenly intervened.

"How long can the Empress hold the Grand Duke and the Duke? They are also the head of the two major powers that separate the power from the Empress."

"What?"

"How many people have seen it, taking us who had fallen?"

There must have been more or less their men or knights during the two's struggle, as Ricdorian and Chaser would not have moved alone..... Did they see the Empress taking the two of them?

"It's already been three days."

Chaser tilted his head and grinned. It was a dizzying smile.

"Actually, I waited three days. I don't think I'll ever see you sleeping again."

At that moment, a popping noise was heard. I stared at the ceiling with amazement.

Stones and dust fell from the sky. At the top, I could see a wall that had been torn apart. Chaser had just torn the wall apart. He did not stop there, but glanced at the chains that still bound him, then trampled on it with his feet and pulled it tight.

At the same time, a dark blue energy arose and the iron corroded.

“You.....”

“Of course, I was also waiting for an opportunity.”

Chaser, who was still in handcuffs but waved his hand with an innocent face, smiled softly.

“Don’t make a fuss.”

At the same time, there was the sound of something being torn and crumbling. I quickly turned my head.

Bang!

A wind of dust blew with a huge roar. Through the sinking wind, I could see the grate had fallen.

Then the half-cut chain thumped and fell to the floor. And I could see a large body blocking mine. It was Ricdorian.

“Why are you looking at me like that?”

Chaser smiled leisurely. The dust fluttering in the wind seemed to express the tension at this moment.

“Red Rose, did you foresee this situation too?”

At the same time as Chaser said so, a shout was heard from far away. I heard voices, but I knew it clearly. With the sound of huge footsteps, the

sound of many people moving.

“Your power, my power. Those who have taken an alliance will come here, none other than to find you and me.”

Chaser’s formal tone was languid and sarcastic at the same time.

“It’s just something I’ve been waiting for. We can get out of here as Iana wishes.”

No, that’s wrong. Chaser was not included in the situation where I was hoping to get out. Chaser narrowed his eyes.

“At least it should be based on the premise that you and I are not fighting here. Do you agree?”

“.....”

“If we have to fight, it will become a civil war. Then it will be what the Empress wants.”

A black energy began to fluctuate next to Chaser after he said that. What the haze-like energy created was a giant jaguar and a huge bird.

It was Chaser’s guardian deity that I knew well. I sighed quietly, looking at Rattan and Aquala. Seeing him as an enemy, I couldn’t help but think that he was terrifying.

Pudding is still in me. It would be nice if I could call my guardian deity. It’s a very intimidating proposal for an alliance.

“Who said about holding hands with you?”

“Well, you didn’t take any action. I thought you agreed with me?”

“No.”

Ricdorian looked at Chaser with a fierce face and slowly turned his eyes away. He looked like he was asking me what I wanted to do. I couldn’t

speaking for a while. It was because I had forgotten the situation and felt unfamiliar with his appearance.

‘Certainly, Chaser was Ricdorian’s mortal enemy with a grudge that he will never forget.’

Ricdorian’s face was no longer a passive gaze that blindly handed over the decision to me. Rather, it was as if he had literally left his decision to me.

The belief that he was ready to do anything with me.

It may not have been a long time since I gave advice, but my heart ached for nothing at the change.

You really do whatever I want.

I slowly turned my head.

For some reason, Ricdorian and Chaser released their chains, but I couldn’t. There may be some other way. If we fight in this small cell, it will be a loss to each other. It was especially disadvantageous for us, who were short on time.

“Chaser.”

My lips opened and Chaser flinched for a moment as my call flowed out smoothly. I noticed the agitation in his red eyes, and then slowly opened my eyes.

Then I lowered my gaze slightly. Don’t make eye contact for more than 8 seconds, remember this.

“You want to get out like that?”

The more the red eyes fluttered, the better it was for me. I had to see the gap. I blinked as I gently stroked the chest exposed through Ricdorian’s ripped shirt.

“But you and Ricdorian are easily unchained, so why am I still unable to use my powers?”

“Iana, that’s.....”

“There is no trick, Iana.”

The two men spoke at once, as if competing.

“Iana, every Rose learns to break free from power-binding tools as a child.”

“Young heirs are prone to being kidnapped.”

“Things like that are usually committed by you, Black Rose.”

“Ah, that’s true, but that doesn’t mean we’re safe either. Look, did the previous Emperor go crazy for a day or two? They’ve been tormenting the roses whenever they’ve gone mad.”

I cut Chaser’s words and interrupted.

“So how did you get out?”

Chaser raised one eyebrow, then calmly talked about how to do it.

“..... Instead of focusing your power on the handcuffs, think of it as applying pressure on the outside, on the surface.”

Chaser explained. This method was simpler than I thought, but it was close to a trick or expedient that would be difficult to think of under normal circumstances.

‘Concentrating the power outside and corroding.....’

Then, a force that had never arisen before no matter how hard I tried, formed in the air. Soon, my handcuffs cracked and shattered. The handcuffs, cut in half, fell to the floor.

The moment the handcuffs fell, a tense silence passed between us.

“Iana, I’m not your enemy.”

Like a snake seducing a person, a soft and gentle voice flows from Chaser.

“At least for now.”

He didn’t erase his smile.

“You think so, don’t you?”

As Chaser said, the enemy right now is not him, but that does not mean that he is not an enemy. Putting him behind my back, he will surely hit my back in the future.

I can’t stop here and deal with him. What to do?

Should I say ‘shall we hold hands for a moment?’. A lot of thoughts ran through my mind in a short amount of time. Even while I was thinking, I felt a gaze from Chaser anticipating what I was about to do.

Then as I was going to open my mouth.

CRASH!

The floor vibrated violently. No, it wasn’t the floor. It was a vibration coming down from the ceiling, upstairs. A large stone fell from the ceiling as if it had received great power from above. It was part of the broken ceiling.

Starting with that, the ceiling collapsed like dominoes.

“Iana!”

I didn’t panic.

“Ricdorian, hold me!”

Chapter 226: I'll give it back

1. I'll give it back

As a strong arm wrapped around my body, my vision suddenly flipped. When I came to my senses, my body was moving. The surrounding landscape changed rapidly.

“Ricdorian, where’s the door?”

“A little while ago, the ceiling collapsed and opened.”

It was not appropriate to say that a ‘door’ opened through the dust. It was a broken ceiling. The wall had been torn down. Under these circumstances, staying underground was a very risky choice.

I narrowed my eyes to not get the dust and covered my mouth with my sleeve. Then I lowered my hand and ripped my skirt apart as hard as I could. Borrowing the energy of the Blue Rose, this was not too difficult. I wrapped the cut cloth around Ricdorian’s nose and chin.

It’s not a fire, but it didn’t seem good to inhale a lot of dust. For some reason I felt like I had to do this.

Like a person with abilities that surpassed humans, Ricdorian escaped the underground in an instant. I was concerned about Chaser following us, but finding a way was the first priority.

“Iana, do you know the way?”

“..... Yes. I memorized it roughly.”

The complex Hernim Castle and Domulit's Mansion. And walking around the Imperial Palace helped. Even when the gigantic pillars were shaking, I did not falter.

"*Cough*, Ricdorian. Do you see any angel statues? A stone statue with a trumpet."

"There, I think I see it."

I led the way while being held by Ricdorian.

"Run in a straight line. Go on!"

Strangely, there was no one in the hallway. Even though I heard such loud shouts. It seems that all the people who came to this place had passed by this path. Did they not find a way to the basement? I saw a while ago that the path we came out of was in the middle of a broken ceiling.

Perhaps it was difficult to find where we were.

Did we run for a long time? A sigh came from Ricdorian. Somehow, I felt like I knew why he was breathing awkwardly.

"..... Iana. He's chasing after us."

It was obvious who *he* was. I exhaled a little.

"What should I do?"

Numerous thoughts ran through my mind. I knew for sure. I will never forget the feeling of the chains and the people being led away. However,

"Ricdorian, what would you do if we were to escape from here holding hands with Chaser?"

Ricdorian went silent for a moment. In the meantime, his legs were still running hard.

“..... It’s the best choice right now, and the worst choice I can’t help feeling.”

Ricdorian said in a calm voice, excluding his emotions.

“I’m fine. If it is your will.”

“Ricdorian.”

“It’s not being submissive, Iana. It’s faith.”

I breathed, then exhaled.

“If you, as the Grand Duke, judged at this moment, what decision would you have made?”

“I would have held his hand.”

Ricdorian replied succinctly.

“However..... There are people in the world who you cannot hold hands with even if 100 out of 100 are all beneficial. The Black Rose is that kind of person to me, so maybe I get caught by emotions. Things are different now.”

At that moment, a large decorative cabinet fell and blocked our way. Ricdorian said, jumping over it casually.

“Iana, do you have any plans?”

I was thinking about something, so I asked him that. I was silent for a moment and spoke.

“The Empress’ letter contained directions and instructions on how to use the ancient magic there.”

It was. What the Empress arranged was a ‘passage’ that could lead directly to Kambrakam, but this was a little special, not the usual magic circle.

“It is said that only roses can use it.”

That means Chaser can also use it.

“But.....”

“But?”

“The words end in vague. I thought maybe only the Blue Rose could use it.”

The Empress taught me how to use it, but also gave me inaccurate information. She had never used it herself. As evidence to support it, her explanation felt like she was writing someone else’s record, not her own. Perhaps this was also information she had heard from among the ghosts of the previous Emperors.

“So, the odds are fifty-fifty.”

It was the last favor and help the Empress gave me. I had to use this. No, this is the only way. I glanced over my shoulder.

“Leave that man, or if he ends up chasing us, go with him.”

“If we go together.....”

“That is more of a problem.”

It will expose our purpose. Then we might have to figure out how to really join hands. Without a conclusion, we finally arrived at the place the Empress was talking about.

Beneath another castle, there was a huge underground space. As if to prove the expansive size, a very large door stood in our way. However, the door was ajar; perhaps the huge vibration that struck the Imperial Castle had an effect here as well.

“Did anyone arrive before us?”

“No. That’s not it. Iana. I don’t feel any presence.”

As he said, there was no one inside the hall. We have no time to look around the huge space in detail. In the center of the hall was a magic circle of geometric curves, just as the Empress had described in her letter.

This is the ancient magic circle the Empress spoke of.

‘Somehow, it’s similar to what I saw in Kambrakam.’

Slowly observing the shape, I noticed that it resembles the mural in Kambrakam. There was no time to look at each one of it.

“Ricdorian, come here.”

I put Ricdorian next to me and took a deep breath. But for some reason, for a brief moment, Ricdorian’s expression didn’t seem right. When I turned my head, he was as calm as ever.

“Ricdorian, are you in pain?”

“Ah... no. No, Iana.”

He smiled shyly, his cheeks flushed, as always. Did I misunderstand? I shook my head and quickly raised my hand. We have no time.

I folded one knee and brought my raised hand to the magic circle on the floor.

Thud!

There was a small vibration. As soon as the blue power was generated, not only the floor but the entire hall vibrated.

-Human.....

Just then, Pudding’s voice was heard from inside me.

‘Are you awake? Are you okay?’

A blue haze pooled like water through the hollow magic circle. Before long, the haze that filled the huge magic circle radiated a dazzling blue light.

-Human, Nyan! That's not the problem! Nyan, I have something to say, human, you must listen!

With the scattered light, Pudding hurriedly shouted at me. I wanted it to tell me what was going on, but unfortunately I couldn't focus. It was because I saw a man with his feet on the edge of the pillar of blue light that soared to the ceiling.

Sweat-soaked hair, and a bright smile on his face did not look exhausted or difficult, even though he was taking a few breaths.

“..... Chaser.”

He came after me.

I bit my lip. At the same time, I felt a huge weight on my shoulder.

“Ricdorian?”

“..... Haa, Iana. I have something to say. That.....”

“You? Why is your body hot? Are you sick?”

“Haa, I'm sorry. Now, it's out of control.....”

Obviously, when he brought me here a little while ago, he wasn't hot, his body temperature was normal. However, his body that came close to me was unusually hot. The words flowing out of him were like Pudding's urgent words, which suddenly evoked deep anxiety and fear.

“Why, why? Why are you suddenly like this?”

But Ricdorian that I held gave me no answers. The words were not coming out because he was holding his hot breath. His appearance was reminiscent of how he had a strong fever with medicine in the prison long ago. My heart pounded.

“Wait, wait a little bit and I’ll be fine…….”

“Ricdorian!”

Even at this moment, the light spread steadily. And *flash!* When the dazzling light spread and blinded my eyes, I closed my eyes tightly without realizing it.

I held Ricdorian tightly. Please don’t let him go. Please…… !

But when I open my eyes, I see a new space but……. There was no one in my arms.

“Ricdorian?”

I hurriedly turned my head. The place I was in was the first floor hallway covered in darkness. I was used to the garden view from the side of the hallway, but finding Ricdorian was my priority.

“It looks like he moved separately.”

But soon after, instead of the one I was looking for, I heard a voice I didn’t want to hear much.

“Is that right, Iana?”

When I turned my head, I saw Chaser’s figure standing half-submerged in the shadow of a long pillar. There was a distance between him and me, but Chaser didn’t come close right away.

“Don’t be so vigilant, Iana.”

Reassuring me, he showed the palms of his hands.

“Because I won’t do anything.”

It just sounded like nonsense to me.

“For real.”

On the contrary, he moved half a step back. Trying to prove his point one more time.

“Now I know why you came here. Hmm, are you here to break the Red Rose’s curse?”

“.....”

“I see.”

Chaser continued to talk as he pleased, and then I pretended to listen and rolled my eyes. The situation a while ago made me feel bad, so I couldn’t see properly. But we did move to the right place. This was Kambrakam.

If I meet Ricdorian again here, there would be no problem. Yes, there will be no problem. I clenched my teeth out of his sight. Not to let him know.

“Ah, are you trying to restore the Red Rose’s lifespan?”

I turned my head. For this moment, I was grateful for my indifferent expression. Because nothing will be revealed in my calm face.

“Don’t worry, I won’t disturb you.”

I smiled bitterly.

“How can I believe you?”

“I don’t lie to you, you know.”

Chaser lowered his hand and leaned back. Then he reached out one hand and touched his chest.

“Then how about this, with all my love, I swear I won’t interfere with your purpose.”

I paused. He was a man whose love wanted to be acknowledged by me as the one true love. Although I admitted that his means and methods were twisted, his love was sincere. He was betting on something like that?

That sincerity felt rather abominable here.

“..... You have a natural talent for making me hate you.”

Chaser stiffened for a moment, but then smiled softly.

“Your wit that gently tempts people is your bad charm. If you won’t disturb me, then why did you come after me?”

“Because I want to see you.”

“.....”

“Even if you don’t stare at me like that, I really won’t bother you. Iana.”

Why? It felt as if Chaser was getting closer, even though he was still far away.

“Because in the first place, I was going to return the guardian deity to you and tell you the last truth. This is real.”

“*Real?* Don’t be ridiculous. Do you still have something to say to me? Stop it now. I don’t want to hear anything you say anymore.”

I got up slowly. Right at my first step, I lost my strength and ended up sitting on the floor. But when I lifted my head, I could see Chaser’s figure getting closer. The feeling that he was getting closer was not an illusion.

“I was just trying to give it back.”

“Stop playing with words anymore.”

“Don’t you want to remember?”

“So what.”

“Your memories of the previous world.”

I froze. I looked at him stiffly.

Chapter 227: The ban has been lifted

1. The ban has been lifted

“The reason you were able to be indifferent is because you don’t have longing.”

He said conclusively. Chaser, who used a suggestive tone, never stopped trying to charm me, befitting his abilities. But at this moment, there was nowhere in his voice that seemed to deceive me. I could understand it better because I knew him, so I blankly pondered his words.

What did he just say now?

“I had it.”

Slowly my mind returns. No words came out. It was just absurd. Memory of the previous world? Of course I had that too. What was he trying to deceive now?

“You look confident that you remember. So, Iana, can I ask you a question? What was your name in the previous world?”

“That’s.....”

My well-opened lips couldn’t move anymore.

“Age?”

“.....”

Chaser looked at my frozen face with neither joy nor sorrow. I just looked at him as he smiled softly As if doing his job.

“I’ll give it back now.”

At that moment, Chaser’s hand covered my eyes.

“It was supposed to be yours.”

I couldn’t even move my body, even though I didn’t feel any strength. It was because something ran through my mind. In the dark, for some reason, the moment I first met Chaser passed.

The moment when he appeared as ‘Brother’ in Kambrakam and talked with my eyes closed. Then, he asked me if I had forgiven him. Of course, that is what he said to ‘Iana’, but.....Why do I think now that those words were also spoken to me?

I staggered back. Chaser’s other hand grabbed my wrist and supported me so I wouldn’t fall.

“Huu.....”

My stomach churned. I felt a cold sweat and the pain like my intestines were being squeezed. My vision looked odd. The space turned upside down, the ground was like it was jelly, the sky was falling, and the pain that felt like nausea attacked me so badly.

I wanted to sit down with the sensation of the soles of my feet falling off, but I clenched my teeth and endured it. I couldn’t even remember how I had to endure so much for such a short time.

Chaser slowly removed his hand.

“Come to think about it, Iana. In the end, if I can’t have you.”

A gentle and ecstatic voice pierced my ears like arrows.

“I thought it would be okay if I sent you back to where you were.”

I understood the meaning of those words, but my feelings did not flow properly. It felt like a lot of things were pouring out into my head at random.

Ah, why did I forget?

Chaser wiped the sweat dripping down my chin. His expression was not visible in my blurry vision.

Why did I forget this?

Chaser took a step back. And one more step.

“Sister? Sister!”

At the moment when I felt like I was caught in Chaser’s shadow, a welcome voice came from behind. It was Francia’s voice like a ray of salvation.

But I’m really sorry for her... I don’t feel salvation from that voice now. I wasn’t happy. Something was about to overflow from me.

Looking back at the place where Chaser was, Chaser was nowhere to be found. It didn’t even feel like he was there from the beginning. Like he was completely hidden.

“Sister, what happened? Me and the Yellow Rose somehow took control over here, but when the Empress appeared..... Sister?”

Tears flowed down my cheeks the moment I saw Francia.

“Sister!”

I couldn’t see Francia. I just murmured, looking at the spot where Chaser had disappeared. Chaser, Chaser, Chaser! My emotions, which had never been intense, finally exploded like a runaway train. Laughter flowed along with crying. My head creaks like it’s broken. All I can think of is the man’s smiling face.

“..... you’re really..... trash.”

I knew how urgent this moment was, and what I had to do was to fight the moment. I have to move, I have to move..... ha, haha. A smirk mixed with disappointment leaked out.

“Why, it had... to be now.....”

Still, I had to say this.

“..... go me.”

“Sister? Sister! Sorry. I can’t hear you well. Are you hurt? Huh? In pain?”

Francia’s voice was sobbing. If it was the usual, I would just calmly ask why she was crying, it’s nothing. I would have patted her.

But I couldn’t.

My breathing became short. It felt like my throat was narrowing. Suddenly, boiling waves hit my chest, with nowhere to overflow anymore.

I couldn’t even hold my chest. I grabbed Francia’s shoulder and collapsed.

“Huuh..... huff..... I.....”

My indifference and nonchalance were shattered by the longing and memories that I have been suppressing for 5 years. Everything was useless to stop it.

“Want to go home.....”

Ironically, I was such a very happy person in the previous world.

Very much.

“Sister. Are you okay?”

Francia was busy staring at my face over and over again. She seemed to be conscious of me. The way she rolls her eyes, pretending to tuck her hair behind her ears or tidying up her clothes, reminded me of the little girl in Domulit mansion long ago.

If it had been the usual, I would have smiled brightly, but I struggled and forced my lips up. I smiled so I didn't have to reveal my messiness on the outside.

"Yes. I'm okay."

I gave no explanation or reason. Francia doesn't ask me anything either. On the contrary, she seemed to have guessed something about it.

"Black Rose, that bast, no, that guy. What did he do? It's him again, right?"

Instead of telling her why I was in tears, I had to tell her what had happened over the past three days. Even the fact that I moved here with Ricdorian and Chaser.

"That man really."

Francia bit her thumb tightly with her teeth. It was her habit when she was troubled or anxious.

"I knew things were going to be weird. Damn bastard. We already have the Empress as an enemy now, he even showed up here."

It seems that Francia was trying her best to speak politely in front of me, but she got agitated and failed.

I also received brief information about the situation here from Francia. Originally, Francia and Lenag decided to meet in Kambrakam by using different paths. And they succeeded in meeting safely, but not long after, the Empress led the knights and broke into this place. She said that the Empress at that time really looked like a madman.

The two people, who had already heard the Empress's declaration of participation at the beginning of the Rose Festival, thought it was

suspicious when the Empress said, ‘I came here at the Blue Rose’s request,’. They thought I wouldn’t have said that.

The two of them pretended to be guarding this place according to the Empress’s orders and focused on secretly grasping the surveillance system, and in the meantime, I appeared and now we’re here.

“The Empress said the Black Rose would come running here to harm Sister. So we have to protect you together. He is the common enemy.”

There was no respect for the Empress in Francia’s eyes that had sunk coldly.

“It’s not even funny. She is the enemy too.”

Fortunately, no one was on our way. It was thanks to Francia who threaded a deserted path.

She says it’s been a long time since the central noble prisoners were moved to another ward. It seems that the Empress also knew about the cave beneath Kambrakam.

‘There’s no way she won’t know.’

I listened to Francia and kept myself together. I rubbed my face several times in order not to be shaken. Of course, this did not mean that I was not agitated. My heart was still pounding restlessly.

I closed my eyes tightly.

There were many stories like this from where I was. A story about dying and coming back to life. A story of reincarnation in another world.

One day they woke up and found themselves in the book they were reading.

The main character who became Alice in Wonderland adapted to the world without difficulty. Sometimes they were orphans, sometimes they died in car accidents, sometimes they died of illness. It was as if the author had taken consideration so the main character won’t have any regrets.

Then what about me?

Sadly, I lived happily, then suddenly became a possessor, and forgot my longing for five years.

The main character, who could not give up the longing, was engulfed in it. Like Dorothy, not Alice who ventured into Wonderland, she longed for her warm home.

Now, as Dorothy, I was hesitant to click my shoes.

The moment I regained my memories, it was heartbreaking to have my entire life taken away. I couldn't see anything anymore.

But now?

“Sister?”

Francia stopped walking. I no longer walked, I paused, and tilted my head strangely.

If I decide to go back, there are my roses who will follow me blindly. My Roses.

Anxiety flashed through Francia's pretty face. I smiled showing I was okay.

“Ricdorian must have moved somewhere here. We must find him.”

“If it was the Grand Duke, there would be no problem. What's wrong?”

“..... Ricdorian's physical condition is strange. He has boiling fever.”

Now was not the time to be buried in the tsunami created by memories. I forcibly pressed it down and hardened myself.

“Fever? That can't be true.”

Francia frowned as she tilted her head at an angle and frowned.

“That person has a body that will not budge with an ordinary illness. No matter how seriously injured he gets, he will recover quickly.”

Francia’s voice explaining about Ricdorian was refreshing. Although she hated him, it seemed that she had faith in him.

“That.”

I hesitated to respond to that. Come to think of it, Pudding was going to say something to me. Apparently it called me right before we moved.

‘Pudding.’

I called Pudding for a moment, but there was no answer.

Francia led me to join Lenag for now. Perhaps she realized the seriousness on my face, her steps were faster than before.

As I was walking for a while, I suddenly heard a small whimper inside.

-..... Human.....

It was Pudding. Without stopping, I quickly answered.

‘What’s going on, what were you trying to say? Why the small voice? Are you still recovering?’

There was a lot that I wanted to say. For some reason, it was because of the unexplained anxiety. Whenever I feel like this, bad things happen.....

Thump thump. My heart was beating out of sync.

-Human, I think you should know..... Nyan.

‘Know what.’

-The ban has been lifted. He’s dying, Nyan.

It was strange. Pudding’s voice was too weak for a guardian deity who was recovering.

-It's so critical that it can't improve.....

‘What?’

I asked, even though I seemed to know. Without even needing to ask, my body seemed to tremble. Responding to my nervous heart, the answer flowed out.

-The Red Rose's lifespan is short, Nyan.

This time, I had to stop. I couldn't even hear Francia's voice calling me.

‘When?’

Eventually, after a moment of silence, the heavy sound of the young guardian deity resonated deeply in my chest.

-..... It's today, Nyan.

Chapter 228: Just trust in me

1. Just trust in me

Thud. A huge stone falls on my chest. My heart beat wildly. I couldn't say anything in shock.

At this moment, I didn't even care about the memories of my previous whole world that had constantly shattered me. No, in fact no words came to mind.

Die? Who? Pudding didn't mention death, but at the end it was the same thing. My lips trembled. I tried to hold back the tremors, but to no avail.

“Sister? Sister!”

Just then, Francia shook my shoulder. My appearance reflected in Francia's eyes was filled with emotions I couldn't describe.

My mouth clenched. My voice wouldn't come out.

This is not the time to be helplessly shaken like this. I stopped it. It left a huge shock, but at the same time it gave me time to think.

Why would his lifespan end suddenly? Obviously, the last I heard there was still some time left!

-Human..... that..... I don't know why, Nyang.

Pudding did not even know the reason. It was just that from one day, suddenly, Ricdorian's life was rapidly dying out.

Pudding's explanation that it could not tell me was because of the prohibition, and also because it was weakened, made my eyes dizzy. For the Red Rose, his lifespan was the source of life and strength. Could it be that he was trying too hard to save me? I closed my eyes. Resentment came rushing in like a tidal wave.

‘Why didn’t you say anything?’

I feel sick and sore. It seemed as if a hole had been opened in me, and it was accompanied by a bitter and heavy blunt pain, like sand was sprinkled on a wound.

But it soon subsided. It wasn’t that I couldn’t figure out why he wouldn’t say anything. Why? Because I look busy, and he doesn’t want me to mind him?

No. Perhaps, I don’t know. This soon turned into a blame towards me, it was me who made him unable to speak.

But I shook my head and closed my lip.

No, it’s not anyone’s fault. If I was to look for fault.....

It is in this deformed world where Ricdorian’s body was made that way, and in this power that wields the fate of people at will just like a tyrant. As the resentment, having no place to go, found its destination, it came crashing down.

“Sister.....”

Francia grabbed my shoulder and her lips’ twitched. She was looking for something to say, but at the same time she looked like she didn’t know what to say. I took my hand and placed it over her shoulder.

“Francia. Perhaps. I think something big has happened.”

I could only express the calamity that had occurred in my heart in this way. Because I was unable to express it directly. If I had to explain one thing, what I said in the end was a straightforward word that I didn’t want to say.

“I think Ricdorian is..... going to die.”

Francia's eyes widened.

“Huh? Die? Who? The Grand Duke?”

Even this was incomprehensible to her. Her head, swaying violently, expressed denial.

“Nonsense. Even if I want him to die, it's hard to do! Why? So suddenly?”

Francia raised her voice, asking if any limbs were cut off as she can fix it herself. Wouldn't it be better if that was the case? I quickly explained the situation. As concise and simple as possible.

Listening to the whole story, Francia's mouth dropped, and she said nothing. Like I did, she didn't know what to say. Her expression soon turned stiff.

“For now, let's join Marquis Valtaze. As Sister knows, the Yellow Rose's ability is fortification. He would thread through all of Kambrakam's structure. With the Grand Duke's nature, even if he was dying, he would never have been caught by the Imperial Knights. Even if he dies, he doesn't want to hurt Sister.”

Francia said, biting her fingertips. I also agreed.

“Yes, let's go.”

It was not far to join Lenag after all. I walked diligently with Francia and arrived at the junction.

“Marquis.”

The space we arrived at was an empty cavity on one side of the prison. The prisoners had already been sent to another place, so all the prison cells we passed were empty.

In this place, usually the guards chatted.....

Francia called Lenag, but there wasn't really anyone there. But Francia didn't heed it, and knocked around the wall, and then she pulled out a brick. The stone looked heavy, but she was holding it casually. Before I could say anything, the wall slowly turned.

I seemed to see a yellow energy.

And a familiar face appeared in front of the wide open space. *Haa, haa*. Lenag appeared, heaving his breath with his brown hair scattered haphazardly.

“Miss Iana..... !”

As soon as he saw me, he walked up to me and grabbed my hand. Ooh, I was dragged into the space without a moment to do anything. *Thud*. The door closed behind me, and Francia's small grunting was heard.

“Can't you close the door quietly?”

Instead of giving Francia a gaze, I stared in front of me. It was dark and I couldn't see anything, but I gradually got used to it and saw a silhouette. Lenag. He took a deep breath as he rested his forehead on the back of my hand.

“..... I thought something happened to you.”

He spoke in a broken whisper. His large shoulders went up and down without rest.

“The Empress suddenly appeared and said that she participated at your request, and it is your will to appear here..... I can't believe it. You haven't contacted me for three days, and I don't even have the means to reach you.”

A ray of light leaked in.

“I felt foolish and pathetic because I didn't even have that kind of ability.”

It was a light of the torch from the door on the other side that opened by itself. And it revealed half of the face that was stained with tears and sweat.

“..... And then the Red Rose that should be with you suddenly appears here, fainted, how much I really.....”

The gentle but calm voice was holding back tears, I raised my head without being shaken by the affection. I grabbed Lenag's hand. Our fingers were automatically interlocked.

“Hold on, Lenag. What? Did Ricdorian appear here with you? Where?”

I paused while asking questions hurriedly. It was because I saw the golden eyes blinking slowly. I lifted my unclenched fingers and slowly wiped away his tears.

“..... Sorry. I took your worries lightly. However, when I came here, I met Chaser, and Ricdorian's condition was.....”

I bit my lip and said hurriedly.

“It's not really good. It's dangerous enough. Perhaps... he might die.”

“No. I know. The Black Rose appeared here too, right?”

Lenag knew the situation accurately.

“Did Ricdorian tell you?”

“No, he didn't. He just woke up a little while ago. Right before we go to pick up Miss Iana.”

That means he passed out from a while ago. As expected, he's in bad shape. I felt the impatience again.

“How did you know that Chaser was here? Did you come across him?”

“No.”

He shook his head.

“I didn’t have a chance to tell you my abilities properly. I know anything that happens in this prison.”

Lenag’s voice was faster than usual. He must have sensed something unusual on my face.

He continued to explain with a firm expression.

“To be precise, it is the ability to ‘fortify’ a land into my own fortress. I can create a space in the building I designate as a fortress and move it anywhere. It’s the ability to keep just one person safe.”

In one of Lenag’s hands, his guardian deity, Azul, was wrapped around him.

“My guardian deity can transform into any weapon, but its original basic form is a shield.”

“Then the bow.....”

“It has changed since I heard about the traitor a long time ago. I mean, I don’t deserve to be a shield.”

Lenag, referring to the poison, shield, and the Yellow Rose family symbol, said that it was useful not only as a means of attack but also as a defense.

“I don’t have time to explain any more. This way, Iana.”

Lenag’s explanation was brief, and he quickly led me to another room.

As we walked, Lenag said that this was a space he had specially created, and that even within Kambrakam, only his closest aides would know. As I walked, I felt something familiar. I can’t express them all in words, but the pleasant and affectionate feeling, the energy that causes these feelings.....

My steps got faster. My staggering arms were caught from both sides.

“Be careful.”

“Careful, Sister! I know it’s urgent, but take it slow. Alright?”

Lenag and Francia, who each grabbed my arm, spoke to me at a time. I nodded and walked again. Soon, the door opened, and a familiar face appeared through the gap.

I hadn't seen him for only a short while, but my heart was pounding. There was only one person who made me feel this way. The one who was sitting, jumped up. Ricdorian was wearing a tattered shirt like when he had come out of his cell.

"Iana!"

However, as usual, I was faster than him. Instead of walking and hugging him..... *Snatch*. I grabbed his face.

"I, Iana?"

Ricdorian, whose cheek was caught in an instant, blinked his eyes and gently lowered his head. so that I won't feel uncomfortable. My heart thumped at the sight, and my fingertips trembled, but I strengthened my hand.

I won't cry. Because it ain't over until it's over

"Who told you to act like this?"

I took a breath.

"Who told you..... To be so selfish!"

Ricdorian was astonished. He looked lost.

"Well, Iana. Did..... something happen? I'm sorry if it's because I collapsed a while ago. No. Sorry for worrying you. I haven't been able to take care of my body..... I guess it was because I was tired."

I was taken aback by his shy smile and his words as clear as the blue sky. Does he still think I don't know?

"You mean for me to believe that the Red Rose can feel tired now?"

Ricdorian paused. He tried to make excuses, but a voice from behind me spoke faster.

“How is that possible? The Red Rose. *Tired*. What kind of crap is this? What do you think, Yellow Rose?”

“I don’t want to respond to you in a friendly way, but it is.”

“Right? It was total crap. *Tsk tsk tsk*.”

As Francia made a *tsk tsk tsk* sound with her mouth, a frown and an awkward light flashed on Ricdrorian’s face. At the same time, I thought that Ricdorian might be better at acting than I thought. But what about that?

“You don’t have time anymore right? Tell me the truth. I know it.”

At the same time, Ricdorian, who was smiling, stiffened his shoulders.

“Lies don’t work anymore.”

It wasn’t only Ricdorian who was surprised, but I heard Lenag muttering.

“Why didn’t you tell me?”

As my words flowed, I stared only at Ricdorian. Ricdorian, who had been looking at me for a long time, opened and closed his lips. When something finally came out of his lips, I raised my hand.

“No, don’t tell me.”

My hand covered Ricdorian’s lips. I looked at him and said,

“Because the story will be long.”

Whatever his reason, the story will be long. It wasn’t that I didn’t resent him for this. However, it cannot be denied that the root of all this man’s actions is ‘me’, no matter what. I made up my mind and pulled away from his lips.

“I won’t let you die.”

I emphasized each word.

“Never.”

I will definitely protect him. My gaze turned back for a moment, then returned to Ricdorian.

“Just trust in me.”

I will move directly. I won’t lose to anyone. No one will get hurt. I promise.

“This situation, I will destroy everything.”

Everything, I’m going to finish it all with my own hands.

Chapter 229: Bait and scam

1. Bait and scam

Whatever it was, I couldn't just look ahead and move on. It is also considering the fact that he might die immediately.

If I just jump in front of fire with my arms open, I will only become a fire moth. Just as there is time to deliberately adjust speed and pace in a marathon, we also need preparation. Of course, I can't have it for a long time, but it was a necessary process for us who had been separated for a while.

"I checked with Pudding again."

It was a simple meeting, and the members of the meeting were Francia and Lenag's assistants and subordinates, including Ricdorian, Francia, and Lenag. In particular, there were familiar faces among Lenag's subordinates, and it was only obvious because they were prison guards.

They also seemed to recognize my face, and politely bowed their heads perhaps they had been informed beforehand.

"The only time left for Ricdorian is today, to be exact, one day. So after tonight, tomorrow night."

Francia and Lenag had already gathered only those they could trust.

"Tomorrow night is the end."

Ricdorian, the party involved, looked quite casual. I heard from Pudding that he knew that death was imminent, but he wouldn't have known when exactly. I held back the words boiling inside and looked back at the crowd.

“We have to get to this basement somehow.”

The magic patterns related to roses I saw in the Domulit mansion. Pudding was sealed there, and what is believed to be the original was located underground here.

Not only this, but the senses in my body instinctively shouted that I had to go there. Maybe it's the whispering of the guardian deity of the Blue Rose that dwells within me. If the destination has already been decided like this, it would be better to leave immediately, but we had two variables.

The Empress and the Black Rose.

“For now, the Empress is monitoring by placing the knights thoroughly.”

Lenag, who was handed the baton, explained the situation.

“Currently, all knights and guards have been ordered to report to their superiors as soon as Miss Iana appears.”

He glanced at the ceiling.

“I am acting with the existing guards.”

“What if, for example, I appeared in front of them?”

“Then you will have to listen to the Imperial Knights' orders. If you don't listen, it will be treason.”

The Empress gave each knight great authority. This means that she must have been all about catching me.

“As Miss Iana said, if the Imperial palace is messed up, of course she should return. But she didn't return but left it to the Imperial Knight's commanders.”

“You say that this is not normal.”

“Yes, it is.”

I patted my lips. I already know that the Empress has gone completely crazy. And her obsession with the Blue Rose is also great. She must be aware that I am coming here because I had escaped from where I was imprisoned. She must be quite nervous because she does not know when I will appear.

‘Conversely, can’t we use this?’

I stopped beating myself and fell into anguish. Then I raised my eyes.

“Lenag, how is the Black Rose’s position?”

“It’s the same.”

Lenag shook his head slightly.

“He was not moving from the position I told him.”

Lenag said that he could know the details of the inside of the prison, but that it would be impossible to find out Chaser’s location. However, Chaser was quietly hiding in one place without any effort. It’s like he was keeping the promise he made to me.

“Please keep an eye on him. I don’t know when he will move.”

“Yes.”

I narrowed my eyes. Even if Chaser acts like this, it was just dubious and abominable.

“I’m not quite sure how to hit the back of his head. He is a cunning man.”

“Why do you call him ‘man’? Just call him that punk. Ah! It would be better to call him that bastard. ”

Francia crossed her hands and clenched her chin, smiling.

“All his words sound like a dog barking. It perfectly suits him that he eats people’s backs.”

It was a cruel word that didn't match her smile at all. For a brief moment, Lenag looked exhausted.

"I feel sorry for the dog instead."

Lenag shook his head sullenly.

"It's not something to meddle with, but have you completely removed your innocence now?"

"Oh my, when did you say I showed my innocence?"

Francia smiled and waved her hand gracefully.

"I've always been like this."

Of course, what Francia said was a lie. As I can see, I felt that Francia had become violent as she took off her mask. Before, she was even pretending to be careful with her words.

"And she will love me no matter what I look like."

What had happened inside her? Eyes of different colors looking at me were twinkling with a certainty that I had never seen before. Of course, there was nothing wrong with that.

"That's right."

But the moment I said this, I felt a different bitterness than before. It was because I couldn't accept it as purely as before.

"Look, we're going to live happily together for so long."

I feel nauseous.

I forcibly pushed away the memories of the previous world that once again hit my head. Thanks to the air created by the urgent situation, a drowsy feeling appeared quickly.

“Iana, are you okay?”

However, there were three people in this space who reacted sensitively to me. Ricdorian who grabbed my shoulder. I burst out laughing.

The man, who had never been shaken by the fact that he had only one day left to live, had a worried face as if he was about to cry just because of me.

“It’s okay. I must have used a lot of energy while moving.”

“Are you tired?”

“It is not. Just, mild vertigo?”

As I answered Lenag’s subsequent question, I buried my head on Ricdorian’s shoulder. Ricdorian’s shoulders stiffened for a moment, then I felt a hand patting my back. It wasn’t too bad that it was awkward. Like someone who’s never done it before.

I smiled once more at Ricdorian’s clumsiness. Even if there was a sudden agitation, the habit acquired in the body did not go anywhere, so it seemed that my anxiety was not revealed.

“..... Rather, I have an idea.”

I leaned on Ricdorian’s shoulder and muttered a little. The voice was small, but it must have been heard enough by those present here.

“I can see how much the Empress is paying attention to me now. So..... How about using this to shift her attention elsewhere?”

“Are you talking about using bait?”

Lenag noticed promptly and asked. I nodded.

“Yes. I mean, to show up elsewhere. For example, this is the center, so either in the west or east.”

One of them was a place with a great heinous criminal, and the other was a place where Jaire had been secretly infiltrating. Lenag affirmed that if the latter was the case, there would be a way to infiltrate.

“But who will be the bait?”

Francia, who was listening, asked a question.

“Sister can’t go. You have to break the curse.”

“Right.”

It’s difficult for me to leave because I need my strength to release the spell. Above all else, it’s useless if I go and be the bait.

“Then shall one of us go? Is it me or the Yellow Rose?”

It sounded reasonable, but I shook my head resolutely.

“No. It will be of no use.”

I remembered the Empress’ last appearance.

“The Empress is not in a normal state, but it does not mean that her head can’t be used anymore. Rather, she should be seen as rationally insane. Because she threatened me.”

She decided that she could kidnap me easily, and she casually tried to burn the village. This was the result of her understanding my actions and minute expressions before that, and making a quick judgment. The Empress said that when the spirit resides, she makes wise judgments for the Empire, but only becomes obsessive about the Blue Rose.

“If either of you shows up as bait, she’ll know it’s a trap.”

The only way was to stall time.

“It’s better for the two of you to move with us.”

I never know when Ricdorian will collapse again. I swallowed these words and looked at the two of them alternately.

“Then Miss Iana, who do you prefer? Or, what about my right hand-man or a paladin of the White Rose?”

“No. The same goes for Lenag and Francia’s closest aides.”

I lifted my head from Ricdorian’s shoulder. Then I touched my lips with my finger.

“It would be better for a general guard to be here..... The problem is, the person who will act here must be able to speak properly in front of the Empress, aside from loyalty.”

“You mean they should not be afraid and not to tremble?”

“No. It doesn’t matter if you’re scared or trembling. It’s okay because it’s rather natural. I mean, clever enough to deceive the Empress..... Able to stall time.....”

I spoke and came to a conclusion.

“Yes. Scam.”

I clicked my fingers.

“I need someone to cheat.”

As much as possible, the more unrelated to us, the better. Lenag’s face, who had listened to all the explanations, had a troubled look.

“Is there such a person.....”

The moment I heard Lenag’s words, an idea flashed through me like a lightning bolt.

“Lenag!”

“Yes?”

“Did you say you moved all the prisoners to one place?”

When the Empress came, all of the noble prisoners originally imprisoned here were moved.

“Can you find someone I mentioned? Last name is Palladis, a Baron.”

This is Kambrakam, the prison in which I was imprisoned. That being said, maybe he is still in prison now.

My prison friend who prided himself on being the best when it comes to scams.

The situation was settled as Lenag quickly decided to find the person I was talking to.

Squeak. The door closes.

The time that Lenag suggested was one hour. There was no time, so it seemed that he was going to move as quickly as possible. In other words, we were given a short break and grace period of 1 hour. And I asked everyone for their understanding and was left here.

With Ricdorian.

Fortunately, there were several rooms in this space, and the noise was fairly well isolated. Because it was originally a space that Lenag had created to handle secret affairs without the imperial family’s knowledge.

“..... Iana?”

As soon as the door closed, Ricdorian looked at me innocently. No, the eyes only looked at me before the door closed.

“Stay there for a moment.”

I grabbed the doorknob. I checked the door, opened and closed it again. *Click*. Put the lock back, then I turned around and stared at Ricdorian.

“Ah, I want to see if the door is properly locked.”

Without further ado, I walked towards him. And now I couldn't stand it anymore and grabbed him by the neck.

“Are you sure you are ready?”

“What? What resolution do you have.....”

“You didn't tell me properly. You did something wrong right?”

Ricdorian shut his mouth tightly.

“I should punish you.”

“Please don't leave.....”

“Additional punishment for nonsense.”

I bowed my head, ignoring his words. I swallowed his lips. I glanced at the quickly flushed face, then moved my hand slowly. My fingers ran through the cracks in the torn clothes and pulled the tattered buttons off.

I had no intention of blaming him anyway. Now I have to blame the past. The day is urgent and we don't know what will happen. Of course I wouldn't let him die, but I didn't want to waste my precious time in a fuss. Especially with a meaningless quarrel. I gently parted my lips and whispered with a sigh.

“An hour is short, right?”

“..... Uh.”

The fingers that had been stroking his chest were caught. Ricdorian grabbed my index finger and brought it directly to his lips.

“..... Will you not regret it?”

Ricdorian wanted to stare at the door for a moment, then he whispered softly with a sun-red flushed face.

“You may not be able to walk.”

Chapter 230: Do you want me to be happy?

1. 1. Do you want me to be happy?

The moment I heard those words, I blinked. And soon burst into laughter.

Because it was cute rather than funny. His face blushed as it turned red, holding on to my clothes and giving me advice like warning me. How could it not be lovely?

“Why are you laughing, Iana?”

The hoarse voice came upon me. I brought my uncaught hand to my lips and laughed out loud.

“No, it’s not something someone who might die tomorrow would say.”

Then Ricdorian looked at me with a red face and said,

“..... I don’t think Iana’s words were an offer to give to someone who is going to die tomorrow either.”

“So you don’t want it?”

Ricdorian shook his head.

“That’s not it.”

Perhaps that wasn’t enough, he quickly added.

“Absolutely not.”

Like telling me I couldn't take back the offer.

There was a contrast between the slightly anxious eyes and the hand holding me tightly. Hearing this, I felt a sense of satisfaction and pride for unknown reasons. And love swelled in me.

"Iana?"

Did he also feel that my smile had changed? Ricdorian called me in a question. I grabbed his hand and put it to my cheek.

"Our conversation a while ago. It seemed like what ordinary lovers would do."

I lowered my eyes and brought them back up again.

"I think I've always wanted that."

From the beginning, it was not an ordinary relationship. I woke up in prison, and it was by no means an ordinary place.

"I wanted us to be ordinary."

And layer by layer, my identity was stripped away from *ordinary*. Then, in this world, at least for some people, I was made absolutely indispensable.

I realized that.

Still, I wished that my love could be ordinary.

At least, to be in the same position as ordinary people, no one will be looking up to or obsessing over the other. Just the love that sees me as me. Calm and peaceful.

It was also for me that I asked Ricdorian not to put obedience in love.

Ricdorian went quiet. He just glanced at what I was doing.

Tap, tap. The button on his torn shirt went off. Some had already been unbuttoned, and the rest were tattered, so there were only a few left.

He was an excellent warrior. He has the innate ability of a beast that overwhelms and destroys, and after leaving this place, he must have made great efforts. It could be seen in the beautiful upper body, which was full of tightly knit muscles. Truly, like a masterpiece sculpted by God, it was a body with ecstatic perfect proportions.

Oddly enough, though, he had skin as white as snow. As if from a snowy winter land.

As I undressed him, the gaze was holding me tenaciously. The blue eyes were full of unspoken desire. Suddenly, one of his hands grabbed my leg.

Perhaps he had asked for permission, I nodded lightly. Soon after, the hand that went inside my clothes gently brushed my thigh. His rough fingertips rose little by little and brushed against the tattooed area.

I bit my lip and held back my moan. Then I raised my head.

“Listen to me, Ricdorian.”

I sat gently on his thigh and pressed our lips together. I felt the ferocious flesh between my legs. He put his hands in my skirt. Soon, my underwear fell to the floor. I sat down slowly. The feeling of digging into the flesh was vivid.

“*Hu*, I’ll never let you die.”

I never thought of leaving him like that, but it felt like my will became stronger when I said it out.

“..... Yes. Iana.”

My clothes fell under my feet. It was the clothes that covered my body. Ricdorian lowered his head and placed his lips on the nape of my neck. His exhalation tickled my skin.

“*Haa*, a long time ago. I never once thought, *hu*, I want to live.”

He whispered softly.

“I just left my body, to the flow.”

“*Ah! Ung, ah! Hu-uht.*”

Kiss. Kiss. He left a long kiss along the neckline. The heat filled my throat, so I couldn’t get my answer out.

“..... Until I meet you here.”

The voice left by the deep regret gradually ceases. He buried his lips in the hollow near my collar bone. His moist tongue wet it. His large hands teased the peak of my chest.

“*Haa*, I’ll be your, ordinary lover.....”

“*Uh, Ahng, Ri, Ric.....Huhng!*”

“*Ah, hoo*, I too, wish I could be with Iana for a long time.”

His confession seemed to say: I also didn’t mean to let go of your hand. I didn’t even know he was so desperate. He seduced me with his sweet breath while begging for forgiveness.

The scorching heat bursts out. My eyes were white and my toes curled. Soon a heavy breath broke out from him. I felt something hot down there. A feeling of fullness in my stomach.

“*Haa*, I won’t die leaving you behind.”

Raising his head, he immediately came to my ear and whispered into me.

“I love you. Even these words couldn’t comprehend my heart.”

The breath filled my heart like deep water.

“No matter what I give in my life, it’s not wasted.”

He sounded as if he would dedicate even the world if I wished, and the deepened eyes were like an awl. It was a thorn that pierced as much as it could go and could no longer be pulled out. The blue eyes in the red face, stabbing through me, was telling me this. *You can never live without me.* The words were stuck in my heart. As soon as his lips touched me again, I closed my eyes.

..... There is no doubt that I will save you.

Ricdorian, with his face buried in my chest, descended slowly. I hugged his head.

Suddenly, his flesh that had entered me changed its size again. I lowered my head as I moved up and down to his rhythm, dripping with sweat.

“Ricdorian, *uhk*..... You, *hoo*, do you want me to be happy?”

The flesh that had gone deep inside me paused for a moment.

“Iana, *hu*, that’s..... so obvious.”

He grabbed my sweat-drenched hand and kissed it.

“Maybe more than my life.”

The sweaty face was sublime, and I couldn’t even say a word.

“I wish you peace and happiness. I’m always hoping for it. My Iana.”

The words I couldn’t say escape into my heart like smoke.

Ricdorian. Even if I save you.

If I disappear from this world, will you be okay?

Kambrakam.

The prison, which may have been built for well over a thousand years, was huge and had a complex structure that the average person could not imagine. In addition, although it was very old, in some places it was old and decrepit, but in other places it was clean as if it had just been built, creating a sense of mystery and ominous fear.

For ordinary people, this is the infamous prison, famous for being the place where some of the worst criminals imaginable go.

“Ugh, what a creepy feeling.”

This was no different for the Imperial Guard’s ‘Duable’, the most capable knights of the Empire.

“Didn’t you say this was your first time in Kambrakam?”

A fellow knight sitting next to him threw a word.

“Right. It’s infamous, so what’s the point of coming?”

“It’s my second.”

“What? Were you a criminal?”

The Imperial Guard Martin looked at his colleague with astonishment.

“What are you talking about? I came here once when I was an apprentice knight.”

“Oh, I see. I heard that apprentice knights were sometimes called out as guards?”

“Right.”

The fact that most of the guards here were from the official knights was something that all knights knew. However, to go into detail, there was only a difference between the knight dispatched by the imperial family and the

warden of this place, who belonged to Marquisate Valtaize. In this way, the Marquis was able to train armed personnel within the prison, which was also the authority granted to Valtaize by the imperial family.

“Here, what is it? Rumor has it that an ancient power resides here? Aren’t all ancient powers mysterious? Especially here, it’s creepy for no reason.”

“That rumor is famous. Ghosts appear.”

The colleague shrugged.

“Why, there was a saying that this was not a prison but another building a long time ago. Did anyone die then?”

“Well, it doesn’t look like a prison in terms of size.”

It was. There were iron gates and gratings here and there to indicate that it was a prison, but the antique wall patterns and columns that were occasionally seen caused a strange sense of incongruity.

Thanks to that, Martin shuddered even more.

“Then what if it wasn’t a prison?”

“Well. I don’t know either, but as you know, my younger sister is crazy about this thing.”

“Ah, that younger sister who is obsessed with archeology?”

“Yes. How is she going to get married? Anyway, she likes to stop me and explain. I think she told me that this place used to be a temple?”

“Temple? Aren’t the Light Foundation more centered in the southern part of the Empire?”

“It is. Before that, she said, they worshiped a noble god from a very long time ago..... As you know, it hasn’t been long since the Light Foundation entered the Empire.”

“It is.”

Martin, who remembered the Light Foundation, the largest temple in the Empire, to which Francia belonged, calmly agreed.

“I heard that a long time ago, they may have worshiped some noble god, well. I don’t know the details, but I’m worried about my sister. She doesn’t date and only cares about things like this.”

“It must be a problem for sure.”

There was a moment of silence between the two knights. In fact, Martin had something to say while looking at this gloomy landscape.

“..... By the way, Her Majesty the Empress.”

In the dark night, the wide area was so wide that they were forced to take charge of it. The prisoners who had fallen asleep were far away. At least they knew that there were only two people here, so the words could flow out.

“..... Do you think she is all right?”

“What? Crazy! What disloyalty are you talking about now?”

“Not that.....”

“If you weren’t my best friend, I could have drawn my sword. Do you know?”

Martin hardened his face.

“Don’t do that, think about it. Don’t you think the situation is strange?”

As he became more serious, his colleague also stopped getting angry. Rather, his expression was like he was stabbed in the corner.

“Currently, the imperial castle has been attacked in the capital. Don’t you think it was the Duke’s army? There are even rumors that a rebellion might

have occurred. But we.....”

The heart of the country is the capital. Among them, the imperial castle where the Empress resides has an importance as a leading political and administrative base that cannot be overstated.

“However, Her Majesty was only obsessed with this one place even in this dire situation.”

That was when he was about to talk about it. Martin shut his mouth.

“What? Ah.”

The puzzled colleague quickly stiffened and turned around quickly. It was a dark hallway, where there should obviously be nothing, but soon footsteps were heard. It was an urgent sound, like running from a distance.

“Guards!”

Chapter 231: Do you still like it?

1. Do you still like it?

Eventually, it was a middle-aged man who ran in front of them. Moreover he was wearing the familiar prison uniform.

‘A prisoner?’

Martin was wary, wondering about the man.

“No, you’re not a guard. A knight?”

Martin heard the prisoner’s tone and immediately recognized his identity. A noble prisoner.

Those who had been imprisoned in the central area until recently and were moved to the ward where they were monitoring.

Noble prisoners were treated differently from other prisoners. Among these was the surprising condition of being free to go to the bathroom at night, which gave great freedom in this situation where surveillance personnel were not adequate.

The reason was that they had already identified all of the noble prisoners. Those who were currently enjoying their freedom were those who had not yet been released from prison.

The prisoner who ran, quickly explained the situation of why he was running.

“I am Baron Palladis. Oh well, I’m in a hurry, so…….”

His expression was urgent and looked like he was quite surprised. Martin's face grew serious when he heard all the circumstances.

“Did you see a suspicious person?”

Listening to what the prisoner described, they were not even the Imperial Guards or Imperial Knights dispatched here.

“Oh, was it a woman and a man?”

Moreover, one is a woman. Martin thought of a female knight in the Knight's Order, but couldn't find a match. Above all, there were no female knights among the knights dispatched to this building.

The more he listened, the more similar it was to what the Empress has described. Martin's colleague immediately reported it to the Empress.

After a while, the prisoner was brought before the Empress. Walking behind the knights, the prisoner, Baron Palladis, bowed his head.

‘It's been good so far. Well, of course.’

In fact, Baron Palladis was a prisoner who had not yet been released from prison, as explained earlier. It was easier for him to deceive others than anything else. It was also true that he was a prisoner who was sentenced to prison for such a crime.

And he was already in his third imprisonment. The third time he's been in and out over the years. After this, he should be released for the third time. For some reason, he thought that the situation in Kambrakam was very strange before his release, but he understood the reason only a few hours ago.

‘Hoho, I didn't expect my dear friend to ask me such a big deal.’

The prisoner Baron Palladis' crime is ‘scam’.

In his opinion, the purpose of scammers is largely two things. Survival or money. Baron Palladis was neither. Because he made terrible money from

his first scam. He probably had enough money to live on for the rest of his life.

Then why was he imprisoned in this prison again, because he was addicted to the act of scamming others.

This was no different from gambling addiction. The joy, thrill and happiness of the moment he managed to scam someone. It is very similar to drug addiction in that those who have already tasted it cannot return.

So once a young prisoner friend said,

<Uncle, you're going to be ruined by scams.>

A prisoner with pink hair that stood out. She did not know how conspicuous her appearance was, and her face was simply indifferent to everything without fervent attention and gaze.

He knew from experience that a face like this can sometimes drive certain people crazy. Therefore, he also expected rumors that would later be heard in social circles. In fact, this indifferent friend sometimes says a lot of funny things.

<Because the only time you tell a good story without a reward is to scam.>

She blinked her eyes once in a while and said something strange. Such a person suddenly appeared as a noble person pursued by the Empress. *Hello, Uncle.* Still indifferent, but with a very friendly tone.

<Scams, do you still like it?>

Of course he does. Baron Palladis was delighted with her re-appearance, which once made him forget his boredom in this boring prison.

<Then why don't you risk your life for a big target?>

It didn't matter why she appeared breaking down one of the walls of the prison cell. The prison mate he met again after a long time just told him what to do to satisfy his boredom and hunger for this bad addiction.

“Raise your head.”

He didn't know what his neck would be like if he failed. The situation was completely different from when he sold fake fairy tales and deceived the great nobles. Nevertheless, Baron Palladis accepted the task. It was because it would be less dangerous if he passed it well, and there were enough holes for him to escape.

Don't be too bold when it comes to scamming. At least in the current situation.

At this moment, appropriate fear and trembling would rather increase credibility. When Baron Palladis' story was finished, the Empress twisted her lips.

“..... Is that really true?”

The Empress' gaze, who was rumored to have made the Empire prosperous, was more gloomy and dark than he had expected. Baron Palladis said without hiding his instinctively trembling body.

“Oh, yes! I'm sure, oh my God, Your, Your Majesty. Those unknown people..... they were heading towards the easternmost part of Kambrakam!”

The easternmost part of Kambrakam, it is the place where the most evil of the prisoners are kept. And on top of it was the monitoring room of the Chief Warden.

In the monitoring room, there were wizards that managed the magic circle in this prison. Baron Palladis did not know this far, but Lenag, including Iana, thought this would be a good bait for the Empress.

“Summon all the knights, now!”

At last, listening to the Empress' command, Baron Palladis thought quietly.

Would this be enough, young friend?

“It won’t last long.”

I said walking in a hurry. There was no stopping us as we made our way down the spiral staircase. Those who could already be restrained were knocked out in the hallway, tied up and hidden out of sight.

“Miss Iana is right.”

Things worked out well thanks to Baron Palladis, who willingly agreed to the operation unexpectedly, but this was not a long-lasting move.

A bait is a bait anyway. The Empress will soon notice everything and run to this place. But it didn’t matter. Because I didn’t mean to completely outrun her from the start. It was a success as long as it bought us time. At least enough time to restore Ricdorian’s body.

“Ricdorian!”

When I finally got to Ricdorian’s cell, I made him attack the wall. Despite Ricdorian’s powerful attack, the wall did not budge. I stared at the wall silently and pointed to a spot.

‘When Ricdorian used his power, it was clearly visible.’

A strange pattern appeared and disappeared from a single brick. I quickly grabbed the brick and pooled my power. The wind blew in the cell without even a window. Soon the wind shook me and my companions’ hair wildly.

Thud!

I thought I could hear the bricks collide and fall, and a huge cavity appeared in front of me. It was the cave that I went in with Ricdorian.

“You can go in here.”

I quickly set foot together with my companions. And as soon as I took a step, I noticed it.

..... It's different from the last time, isn't it?

Obviously, when Ricdorian and I went in together, a dark hallway opened up, and I remember that the blue light came soon. However, what appeared in front of me was a more ornate pillar, and the lighting around it was also colorful.

“..... what is this? Ricdorian. Look at that. It seems to be a different place than the one we went into, right?”

“I think so.”

Ricdorian also nodded while looking puzzled, as if he was thinking the same thing.

“Then did we come in the wrong way?”

Francia muttered, growing serious at the same time, I looked down at my hand.

“..... no. I don't think so.”

There was a faint but blue light on my hand. I instinctively knew. We didn't come in wrong. Rather.....

“We got it right. This is it.”

The more I stepped my feet in, the more I felt like I was really on the final stage. For a while, everyone walked silently.

Within our formation, I was placed in the center, Ricdorian in front and Lenag and Francia in the back. Everyone was vigilant and watched the surroundings. On the other hand, I was wary like the Roses, but I felt a little different.

‘It's strange.’

I opened my lips slightly in an indescribable strangeness.

Why do I feel nostalgic in this space? *Nostalgia*, I can only describe it this way. Because this feeling that pierces my chest was longing. I didn't feel this way when I came in with Ricdorian.

Looking at it a little closer, I could see it. It wasn't my longing. It was the feeling of the guardian deity in me. My guardian deity was emitting waves of emotions close to sorrow.

We passed the long hallway and went down the stairs once more. When we finally came down the last stairs, a wide space opened up. For some reason, the space without the window was filled with white light and was as bright as daytime.

It was so wide that it was incomparable to the space I saw at the end of the hallway when I was walking with Ricdorian. And in the center of the space, a huge stone was floating.

No, would it be better to express that in an unusual way? A slate? A headstone?

The square cut stone was engraved with geometric patterns. There I found a familiar pattern. The Roses and their guardian deities. Obviously, that alone was consistent with what I saw when I came in with Ricdorian.

“..... What is that?”

“It looks like an altar.”

“I feel the same way.”

Francia and Lenag spoke in turn.

As they say, the square-shaped stone is laid flat under a headstone that floats in the air. It was as high as my shoulders.

From all angles, it felt like an altar.

I slowly stared at the headstone floating in the air. The more calmly I looked at it, the more I seemed to know everything now. In the place where

the Red Rose was, there were red gems studded in it, like before. However, the jewels that would have been embedded countless times were almost broken, and only one remained, revealing a brilliant light.

As if there was only one petal left.

..... That's Ricdorian's state.

Chapter 232: Anxiety

1. Anxiety

I quickly looked at the other roses. The Yellow Rose is still in full bloom and there is no big difference. For the White Rose, it had black spots as if it was contaminated when I saw it a long time ago, but now it is in full bloom just like the Yellow Rose.

At that time, Francia was on a dangerous escape from Chaser's pursuit, and she had not grown up properly, so is this revealing that she is not now? My eyes turned against the Red Rose.

'Black Rose.'

And that moment I saw the Black Rose, my eyes fluttered. Obviously, even when I saw him a long time ago, he wasn't very normal..... he was miserable.

Petals torn like burned, broken thorns, and flowers crushed like ground charcoal. If that was a dying flower, it looked like dying in its worst form.

Why is it worse than the Red Rose that might really die?

And looking towards the center, the place for the Blue Rose was hollowed out. Far from being a jewel, the shape of the flower is nowhere leaving only the stem and leaves.

'..... why?'

It was strange. If they really represent the state of the roses, won't it be different now, as I had already awakened? Why didn't the Blue Rose appear?

“Iana?”

“Ah.....”

I quickly removed my eyes. Yes, now is not the time to think. There was no time.

“Now do you see a huge spell circle around that altar, that is, around that stone?”

“Yes, I see.”

“Yes. I can.”

“I see it.”

I nodded as I listened to the answers that came one after the other.

“Ricdorian, I think you should be standing there.”

“Can I just stand?”

“Yes. I think you have to stand..... at the center.”

I looked at the altar and narrowed my eyes. I just looked at it and thought of how to use it. To be precise, the guardian deity that dwells in me was sending images into my head in a whisper.

‘..... Why do you know everything?’

Thinking about Pudding, Pudding did not know much. It was born late and didn’t think about much. The same was true of the other guardian deities. However, I could feel the traces of a long time in my guardian deity. As if it had endured a long time.

‘Why don’t you talk to me like Pudding?’

Numerous questions crossed my mind, but now is not the time to seek answers to these questions. And soon I felt like I knew what to do. If only I

could accomplish the last task on this stage.....

“Then, in the meantime, me and the White Rose will stand guard.”

“Yes, please.”

As I took a step toward the altar. I felt a sense of ingenuity in my back. Without realizing it, I looked left and right. Surely there’s no one there?

There was still time for the Empress to pursue us. Besides, when I was here, I already felt that the noise from the underground should not be transmitted to the outside. Still, why do I feel the tension like being pricked with a needle?

The wide road felt like walking on a one-way street. Holding my breath, I took another step. At the same time, my wrist was grabbed and swung backwards.

“Iana!”

Something huge flew past where I was. And *flutter*. Black feathers flowed down where I was.

Suddenly, in front of me, there was a blue wall that I instinctively created. And on both sides, Francia and Lenag, respectively, stood up. I raised my gaze slowly, maintaining the barrier.

The one who came down through the air lightly touched the floor with his toes. Then a huge bird sat down with the man’s outstretched arm. The familiar eagle, Aquala. Chaser smiled and put his feet down completely. The tension that had stretched just a moment ago tightened even more.

“Hello, Iana.”

It didn’t matter how he descended from the air like flying. The important thing was that he appeared in this space.

‘Is this the true nature of my anxiety?’

I had thought of all the scenarios that would occur after I misled the Empress. And this was the worst.

“I was a little tired of waiting.”

Ricdorian’s hand, that was holding my waist, grew stronger. I stared at Chaser with my hands outstretched. Chaser just gave me a soft smile.

“You said you wouldn’t disturb me.”

“Right. Those words don’t change, Iana. I told you I wouldn’t lie to you.”

“Don’t be ridiculous. You showed up here saying you wouldn’t disturb me?”

“Right. It’s a contradiction.”

His voice was as sweet as a song.

“But I don’t really mean to disturb you. To be exact, I came here to fulfill my purpose.”

Aquala, who was sitting on Chaser’s arm, flapped her wings. At the same time, a huge beast appears in front of his thigh. Another of his guardian deities, Rattan. The black jaguar opened his mouth and exposed his fangs sharper than ever. A terrifying cry rang out.

“Your purpose?”

As long as he appeared up to this point at this moment, his purpose could never have been good for me. Unsurprisingly, Chaser tilted his head and showed a picture-perfect smile.

“Yes. Purpose.”

It’s like he was imitating the ‘kind’ brother in Domulit’s mansion.

“To get you home.”

Home? Certainly not Domulit. His fingers point to the back, the altar and the spell circle.

“I’m here to bring you back to your original world.”

The moment he said that, all the roses’ eyes turned to me.

“..... Return to the original world?”

While I was clenching my lips, darkness like smoke settled down in this huge space. The bright space like daytime was gradually encroached. On a moonless night, in pitch-black darkness, Chaser’s body, headstone, and altar are all swallowed up.

The light disappeared, and only the faint light emitted by the jewels could be seen in front of me. A low voice came from right next to me.

“..... Iana, what was he talking about?”

Suddenly, Ricdorian was standing next to me. He grabbed my hand and muttered. His voice sounded choked.

“Are you going back to your original world?”

The sight would not be clearly visible to ordinary people. But maybe it’s because my eyesight improved a little after awakening?

He looked like he was about to burst into tears. It occurred to me that not only Ricdorian, but perhaps the other two were also looking at me with similar eyes.

“..... Just like the man said.”

I didn’t mean to lie anyway. I just put it off for a while because of another important priority.

“I am not from this world.”

I saw Chaser blocking the way.

“I was just an ordinary person who was forcibly dragged here by that man.”

A person who lived a peaceful life, unable to let go of my ordinary memories. A still rage rose from the depths of my heart. But I buried it.

“But Ricdorian, I have not yet decided what to do.... Because I didn’t think of anything but saving you.

I can’t say that I don’t miss that world. It was the honest and best answer I could give at this moment.

I grabbed Ricdorian’s hand.

“Don’t be fooled. Me and you too. I set priorities and it was to put your life ahead of my past life.”

I did not avoid Ricdorian’s eyes.

“My words matter, does that man’s nonsense matter too?”

“Of course Sister’s words matter. Why would you ask?”

Francia’s words passed by right next to me.

“I thought of something more important.”

Ricdorian looked as if he had woken up at my words, and then his face hardened.

“Iana, you are right. Anything.”

“Yes. It’s nice to hear those words at this moment.”

Even at this moment, the Empress will be on the move. I pulled his hand.

“Let’s go.”

Then I turned my head and turned to Francia and Lenag.

“Francia, Lenag! May I ask for a cover?”

A pure white light spreads out around me in the dark space. The light that Francis had shed, and suddenly she was smiling with a huge hammer placed lightly on her shoulder.

“You don’t have to ask me to do that, sister.”

“Of course.”

Lenag also held a weapon that embodied his guardian deity in his hand.

“You just look ahead. We will clear the road.”

This conversation would have been heard by Chaser as well. I disarmed the barrier without hesitation. Then I moved my feet.

“Iana. Behind me!”

Ricdorian, who was holding my hand, pulled me back and put me behind him. Suddenly, a large sword was in his hand, which I had never seen before.

‘Is it Pudding?’

I felt Pudding inside me disappear. Pudding went to Ricdorian of its own will. My sprinting didn’t stop.

“Iana, do I just need to be in that spell circle?”

“Yes? Right!”

A huge spell circle is drawn on the altar and the ground surrounding the altar. When we get to the center, I can activate that. My guardian spirit was saying and whispering over and over again.

“Then go first.”

“What? But you needed it.”

The moment I said that, I stopped. In the darkness that filled the space, something was wriggling on the floor and rising.

“What is that.....”

“Iana, I didn’t tell you before, in fact, this is the space I used once.”

Chaser, who had already moved from among the shadows, was standing with his hands behind his back.

“Because I brought you into this world from here.”

Watching what was happening in the dark gave me an eerie feeling. Like seeing the people who have lost their mind in the cathedral halls.....

“So actually. This is the place where I was fully prepared.”

My enemy, who is stronger than anyone at this moment, laughed with ecstasy.

“How about it, isn’t it the right place to send you back?”

Why? A terrible word came to mind: *if I can’t have it, I’ll destroy it.*

Didn’t that guy say he’d rather send me away if he couldn’t have me? So that anyone can’t have me either?

Boom!

A heavy sound came. The huge roar was enough to awaken me from the eerie sensation.

“Sister!”

The voice was Francia’s. She was shouting as she had blown away the shadow he had just approached.

“Hurry!”

I checked my location with Ricdorian.

“Ricdorian, you must be stepping on the spell circle!”

Chapter 233: The Rose's truth (1)

1. The Rose's truth (1)

Ricdorian nodded deeply when I spoke. There wasn't much time to talk.

"I will. Iana, I do!"

"Don't worry about me!"

Because I ran around the spell circle with Ricdorian, there weren't many distorted shadows around us yet. While Ricdorian took over most of it, I ran straight for the altar. The translucent blue barrier repelled the shadows.

'A single one isn't that strong.'

But even if there were many, there were too many. Fortunately, it was good that they weren't human. But it seemed like they would get up casually even if they were hit down. Like a zombie. There will be no end even if we fight them like this.

It wouldn't be difficult to defeat them if I use my abilities extensively, but then my feet would be tied up. It was better to quickly go to the altar. Looking back, Francia was dealing with numerous shadows too, and Lenag was dealing with Rattan and the shadows at the same time.

The one left is me. I widened the range of the barrier a bit more. Then I ran as fast as I could.

A blue haze rolled over my body like waves. Not only did it look like a wave, but it also played a role similar to a wave. The more I move, the lighter my body becomes. It was pushing my body like a wave.

Bang!

I just ran as fast as I could. Fortunately, it wasn't difficult to get to the front of the altar.

I took a deep breath and reached out my hand. Right before my hand touched it, I quickly checked my back. Ricdorian was continuing the fight as he promised with me and pulled back as far as he could. After confirming that Ricdorian's feet had entered the spell circle, I turned my head. My hand touched the altar.

'Now!'

At that moment. Dazzling light spread from the area I touched.

Baboom. The entire floor vibrated and a huge sound echoed. Like the imperial palace had moved, a green haze filled the gap between the hollows. Mysteriously, my strength was not only blue, but also reddish as it grew.

Why? The power that permeated the spell circle felt like it was no longer mine, even though it was mine. In addition, it seemed that the amplified power was asking me. *What do you want?*

Of course, it was to restore Ricdorian and bring him back to life!

As I shouted loudly into my heart, the light poured in in huge waves. It all happened in a matter of seconds.

Flash-!

My eyes were blinded by the growing light. As I closed my eyes without realizing it. I felt a sharp sensation aiming at me.

The barrier becomes thicker.

Tang!

It wasn't something I did. The guardian deity inside me made it even thicker. And the barrier cracked, and soon after.....

Crash!

It shattered with a sound. A man's face was visible through the intangible haze that shattered like pieces of glass and fell like rain.

"Iana."

It was Chaser. Breaking down my barrier, he lightly landed in front of me. The distance between me and him was less than three steps. I looked at my hand and took a small breath.

'..... I can't get my strength up.'

Squeezing my hand and then opening it. As I glanced over, I could see that a huge red string from the spell circle was connected to Ricdorian. Fortunately, the ancient power reached Ricdorian safely.

'Was it returned at once?'

But I realized It is not something that happens all at once when I lifted the curse and restored Ricdorian's life.

What's left..... will be a matter of waiting until Ricdorian is completely restored.

My gaze went back.

Is the reason my power doesn't rise from me right now is because I put all my energy into restoring Ricdorian's life?

'If not.'

I raised my eyes. Is it because of that blue light that shimmers in Chaser's hand, that same blue light as mine? Either way or both, it was clear that my power wasn't working properly. A feeling of despair ran down my back.

“Iana.”

“.....”

“Come on, there is nothing to be wary of.”

He smiled softly. Disregarding the sound of weapons coming from the side as nothing. His eyes were like a healer. *I won't disturb you.* It seemed to whisper like that.

“I said there was something I haven't told you yet, remember?”

On the other side, the battle was in full swing.

Whatever Chaser did, there were more and more shadows in the basement. In addition, I don't know how it came about, but I saw a shadow in the form of a huge monster, not a human form, and Lenag was fighting a fierce battle with it.

I rolled my eyes.

“I remember. And I said I wouldn't listen.”

Francia had a tool that could summon the paladins to her surroundings. However, she was fighting an equally fierce battle beside Lenag. During this intense battle, she is unable to use the tools. It was obvious that the situation would only get worse as time passed.

“But you have to listen.”

Countless swords floated around Chaser's body. I knew this was Aquala's shape when it was made into a weapon. The voice that was calling me affectionately didn't feel good anymore.

“As promised, I did not interfere with what you were doing, and you achieved what you wished for. Didn't you save the Red Rose?”

The sword floating around Chaser flies towards one place. It was towards Ricdorian, who ran to this place, cutting off the shadows.

“Ricdorian!”

I was surprised to see him, but fortunately Ricdorian lightly hit Chaser’s swords. However, he frowned as he couldn’t help his body being pushed back.

In the meantime, a shadow overtakes Ricdorian. In an instant, the surroundings were filled with shadows that were incomparably blacker than those around Francia and Lenag.

“If left as it is, the Red Rose will recover his original life. If he regains all his strength soon, he’ll be able to take off that shadow without harm. Everything is as you wish, is it not?”

He has something to say to me while letting Ricdorian recover? I couldn’t figure out this man’s purpose at all.

“What the hell do you want!”

“For you to go back to your original world.”

Now he was going to send me back to my world? Even though he was the one who arbitrarily brought me to this world? I couldn’t understand this train of thought. Of course I don’t even want to try.

“Iana, this altar and the spell circle you touched are, as I felt, a place that grants the Blue Rose’s wishes. In other words, it is a space that embraces the power of the Blue Rose.”

A languid yet calm tone flowed from Chaser. However, a dangerous blue haze that made it impossible to move quickly roared around.

It felt like a wind made by a cold knife was blowing around.

“In the meantime, the Black Rose has been working with the imperial family and conducting various experiments and evil deeds through ancient spells. A terrible race.”

It felt contradictory to see him criticizing his family's affairs as the Black Rose himself.

"My father once dreamed of getting the Blue Rose completely, destroying and enslaving the Red Rose family."

Hernim and Domulet were never a friendly family in history.

"Yes. The reason you died was because of a greedy experiment. A dream created by my father's desire to hold all power in his hands."

Chaser smiled.

"He tried to become a rose that was stronger and lived longer than anyone else by using you and me. To cut out your strength until you die."

That's not me. I was no longer silent.

"That's not me."

"Right. It's my younger sister's story, Iana."

Chaser meekly agreed.

In the meantime, I squeezed and opened my hand again, trying to generate strength, but there was still no response. Instead, at this moment, I could feel the power passing over to Ricdorian.

Bang!

I saw Lenag defeating the gigantic shadow monster. Even Francia who was wielding the large hammer. I felt the guardian deity inside me let out a long cry. It seemed to be crying out for a little more patience.

Just a little bit, a little bit more.

"She was my sister, and she loved to write novels."

Chaser's story continued. His voice was calm and gentle, as if it had nothing to do with the fierce scenery. That's why he was creepy.

"Have you seen the records she wrote? The diary."

I quietly recalled 'Iana's records, the calm descriptions of how she loved her adoptive brother and confessed that she was the Blue Rose.

"Besides the diary, I know the story she wrote. She liked to write something."

Now, what does 'Iana's story mean?

I couldn't figure out why he was talking about someone who died and couldn't come back.

"The female lead of the story she wrote was yes, the White Rose over there."

The end of Chaser's words stretched out.

"Usually she wrote herself as the main lead."

"What do you mean now?"

"Iana. I also found out after a while. I was the male lead in that child's story."

For a moment, Chaser's smile passed through the bitterness like a dry branch in winter.

"If this world is a huge story, she probably wanted me to be the male lead of my world."

I held my breath.

Chapter 234: The Rose's truth (2)

1. 1. The Rose's truth (2)

“But unfortunately, there is only one story she has ever completed. It's a story about catching my father in the middle and hacking it to pieces. Am I called the villain there?”

I'm not interested in the past or the truth that man talks about. It was only because of time that I listened to Chaser's words.

“By the way, Iana. By the way, don't you ever think it's weird?”

At that moment, Chaser's tone changed.

“I am not the Blue Rose. But how could I use the power of the Blue Rose?”

“..... Your sister must have given you strength. No, I heard she gave it to you.”

“Yes. Iana. Isn't that strange?”

I don't know what he means by strange. That's why I gave it a rough answer. I wanted to set the tone appropriately. I clearly felt the power inside Ricdorian, which was gradually accelerating and filling up. Yes, just a little more. I can endure it.

“Time and space is the ultimate power allowed only to the Blue Rose, so why can I use it? I was in doubt. Being able to transcend time with the power of the Blue Rose.”

However, Chaser's words forcefully held me back as I tried to pass them by. No, I just couldn't pass it.

“I finally figured it out. This world was already collapsing, and this was because the child who gave me strength is gone.”

The situation wasn't so bad. Unfortunately, my heart skipped a beat.

“At one time, the Blue Rose was the center of the world, and it was a piece of God, so the ripple they made was just ridiculous. But this nonsense was true.”

Chaser's words sounded absurd, but on the other hand, my unconscious mind found evidence. The source of the roses that the Empress had been talking about, the story of a piece of God that had risen to a ridiculous level. And even their huge and mysterious power that goes beyond dimensions.

Wouldn't this kind of power be possible to affect the world in the end?

“As a result, only the Blue Rose could use the power of the Blue Rose. The result was a world collapsing.”

Why, at this moment, does the crushed, shapeless Black Rose of that tombstone come to mind?

“I summoned you here. I thought that bringing another Blue Rose from another place would stop the crumbling world from collapsing even more.”

Chaser grinned.

“And that was an illusion. So, now I'm thinking of returning it back to its original state.”

“..... You're going to let the world collapse?”

“Yes.”

The facts that I had already known and the shocking story intersected. Yet, why doesn't my anxiety go away?

“Ha, what kind of contradiction is that? Even if it's to save the collapsed world, you're the one who brought me here! And now you're going to expel

me?”

Glancing from the side, there were noticeably reduced shadows. The excellent and competent roses were steadily reducing them. Contrary to my expectations that they would be at a disadvantage as time passed, they were showing outstanding abilities instead.

At this rate, we may be able to seize the victory. I bet it is.

Chaser’s lips opened softly.

“Expelling you is just returning you to your original state. Now I want you to return.”

“So, why now.....”

“To go back before I die.”

The voice that could not stand it and tried to spit out stopped just like that.

“Because this world, which I supported with my life, has reached its limit.”

“What nonsense is that?”

I tried hard to stay calm. What does he mean? That man is dying? Support the world? It was too strange to be something I misheard. But I believed the fact that the man never lied to me.

So..... if all is true.

“I can no longer support the world in place of the Blue Rose.”

“You have me!”

“Look in front of your eyes, Iana. Why is that slate empty when you are here?”

“.....”

Even I couldn't have not known. Obviously, even after I woke up, the center of the stone slate was still empty.

"You are the Blue Rose, but you are not the Blue Rose of this generation and this time. Because I forced you to."

"When did you..... When did you know about this? Why, why didn't you tell me earlier?"

"Yes..... I didn't love you at first."

Chaser strode forward.

"After loving you, I tried to find a way."

For some reason, it reminded me of his periodic absence from Domulit. When I asked where he was going, he always had a secret smile on his face.

"In the end, when I realize that there is no use even if you appear and that there is no way to prevent the collapse..... I just wanted to own you. Until I die."

A blade of wind passes right next to my cheek. He reached out and took my hand, but he couldn't do anything.

"This world is already collapsing fast."

His Blue Power didn't hurt me. The sharp blue energy was really the power of the same Blue Rose as mine.

"The power of the Blue Rose that I was forcibly granted and my power. In addition, I brought the guardian deity of the Red Rose, but it was not enough."

At that moment, I thought of Pudding. Compared to other guardian deities, it was late in growing and seemed unusually weak. Pudding's growth was slow..... Was it because it was taken away?

“In history, the Blue Rose never dies even though it may be imprisoned. It lived its own life and died. Iana. Death is always natural, without suicide or homicide.”

The wind stirs.

“At least a long time ago, the roses knew instinctively. That the Blue Rose plays a very important role in the world. Of course, they don’t die easily, but there was a reason they should never die.”

Chaser lowered his head and smiled softly.

“Though she died because of my foolish father.”

At this moment, I felt Ricdorian’s power was complete. It’s not long before all the curses are lifted. A feeling of life rose in my chest. It was a contradictory situation.

“If someone else uses the power of the Blue Rose, the world cannot be maintained like when the Blue Rose did it. So, when I supported the world in place of the Blue Rose, my lifespan was used.”

He casually confessed.

“Still, I thought I would live a little longer because I’m on the strong side, but that wasn’t the case either.”

That look overlapped with the sly look I saw the day I got out of prison. I couldn’t believe it, so my anger rose.

“I’m going to die anyway. When I found out about this before meeting you, I wasn’t impressed at all. It was natural to me. Iana.”

A sweet voice pierced my ears as if this voice was the treasure that God had handed over to this man.

“..... Then why did you bring me?”

“It would be nice if the world would end like this. According to the pact, I tried to do it like a game. To bring a rose from another world.”

My voice was full of confusion.

“I intended to imprison the Blue Rose I summoned and use it to support the world.”

He casually confessed that he tried to use me as a tool.

“After I brought you in, I knew that if I used you as a tool, you wouldn’t last long either. You’re the same Blue Rose, but why? I don’t know why, but this world probably had to be without her. At that time, I thought it wouldn’t matter if you died.”

Regret, doubt, and a faint resentment passed across Chaser’s smooth face. Chaser stared blankly at the hand that held me and slowly blinked his eyes.

“I thought it wouldn’t matter if you died with me someday, too.”

His voice grew smaller and fainter.

“But I fell in love with you. That was the biggest variable in my life.”

He smiled bitterly.

“Should I take you like this, endure as much as I can, and then die together? Or, I was wondering if I would just keep this to myself and send you back when I die.”

Why didn’t you tell me about this in Domulit?

“You know this all along but..... Didn’t tell me?”

I’m not asking because I don’t understand what he’s saying. Rather, my voice trembled because I understood. Even when he spoke as if he would give his life desperately, he did not say the most important thing.

“As you know, I am on my own.”

The man who hides the truth even if he doesn't lie. He was selfish to the end.

“What is your name?”

Chaser didn't answer my question. Like he wasn't saying it on purpose. I just stared at him while holding his hand, Chaser looked down and looked like he was about to cry.

“..... Are you trying to tell me that I don't deserve to hear it?”

I finally understood the meaning of the Black Rose, which was crushed and crumbled in the tombstone and whose shape was unrecognizable. Did he say that he wanted a story in which the deceased 'Iana' was the main lead? If this whole world is a huge prison created by this man. Then originally, the man that 'Iana' will meet must have been the male lead in this prison-like world.

It was just funny.

This complicated, twisted and distorted relationship.

Unreal forces. In the end, the ends of the tangled threads seemed to point only to destruction, and wild emotions rushed in.

“Go back. To your world.”

I was still full of incomprehensible things. Why? Why did this huge world collapse without a single Blue Rose?

But, on the other hand, I knew the answer.

There was once a country for her, and even a temple to worship her. This wasn't meant for the average person. I inherited that power.

“You missed it.”

It's a crazy world.

My usual indifferent and calm appearance was nowhere to be found, and I faced him with a messed up look.

“How do you know that?”

My voice took a lot of rest for a short time and was no longer the same as usual.

“Your memory was always shouting it.”

I felt that the power connected to Ricdorian was fading little by little.

“Because I’ve seen you happy in your world.”

The man who forcibly brought me to this world and took away my memories said so. It couldn’t have been more disgusting. In the end, the resentment that I had endured and that I did not want to explode in the end burst like a bomb.

“Ha, come again now?”

Chapter 235: Choice (1)

1. Choice (1)

My voice became hoarse. It was because the emotions I had been holding back came rushing out in order to save Ricdorian.

“That’s not, that’s not, for you to say!”

“I know.”

I shook off his hand and grabbed his chest tightly. Chaser stared at me with his collar dragged down. Red eyes shimmered with madness and inexpressibility.

“I just had that thought.”

I didn’t cry. But it wasn’t that I longed for love like in Domulit.

“Rather than die here with the end of this world.”

The face looked like one that had given up somewhere, but at the same time, madness and obsession that couldn’t be hidden settled like two sides of a coin. He didn’t take his eyes off me.

“Wouldn’t it be better to go back to the world where you were happy?”

He always pretended to be considerate, pretended to be friendly, but he wasn’t really considerate of me. His consideration was always a tyranny that covered my eyes and ears. it bothered me so much

“I mobilized all the means in the world for you..... I really did.”

But there was no way. The sweet voice was filled with desperation.

“It’s the last gift I can give you before I die.”

No. This is not a gift. Like the precious treasure he threw countless times at Domulit. If it’s something I don’t need, it won’t be a gift.

Tears flowed down my cheeks. The reality of not being able to choose anything made me sick and tired of it.

“..... Do you think I would like that?”

Little by little, little by little. The power I had sent for Ricdorian’s life was returning. At the same time, the image of the crushed black rose passed in front of my eyes. How far can obsession ruin a person?

“If I use my strength, you can maintain this world a little longer.”

He took my hand and whispered softly like a friendly older brother.

“Then you will die. What does that mean?”

The wind blew, ruffling his black hair.

“A world without you has no meaning to me anymore.”

At that moment.

“Go back.”

“.....”

“Because I don’t want to see you risk your life for a world that’s not yours.”

“.....”

“That’s for the other guy too.”

Bang! A roar filled the room. The source of the noise was Ricdorian. He plunged his great sword into the ground, knocking down the last shadow.

A fiery red light swirled violently around the huge sword. The roaring energy was like the dynamic of life.

The last bit of power has returned. No, if I were to measure it, he would be able to demonstrate his strength even if it only returned as much as a finger.

At the same time, a blue light burst from my hand. To be precise, it was in Chaser's hands that caught mine.

"Hurry. Before it's all over."

I noticed he was trying to do something with his remaining blue power.

"I will send you."

As Chaser's words came down. Ricdorian raised his head.

"No. I....."

I quickly turned my gaze away. His full power will return soon..... The moment I thought so, my vision turned upside down. I didn't even have time to see what was going on, my body floated straight up.

Whoop!

An eerie sound pierced my ears. What is this sound? Not knowing what it was, I groped my body. However, what was caught in my hand was something hard and wet. Soon my palms were tingling.

I slowly lowered my gaze. The dagger stopped a very close distance from my chest. But it had penetrated the large man's body instead.

Drip, drip drip.

Then, the blood on the tip of the dagger drips onto the back of my hand.

“.....are you.....”

I don't know much about daggers. However, I knew very well that the place this thick dagger pierced was his heart.

The man's staggering body falls on me. I could feel the heavy breathing in my ears.

“..... alright?”

The dripping blood forms a puddle. Chaser's voice became faint.

The moment I heard that voice, the situation felt even more unreal.

The man who doesn't seem to die even if you kill him, was dying with only one dagger?

It can't be. Because it was an unbelievable sight. I wanted to turn away from the creepy, shady feeling that flowed from the dagger.

But the moment the huge energy passed by Chaser and covered me, I couldn't look away any longer.

Behind the collapsed man's shoulder, I could see a woman smiling with her mouth open. I saw a large tiara studded with familiar blue jewels above the woman's head.

“Did you miss me?”

The Empress wearing the tiara in her royal garb was smiling broadly. With eyes that lost reason in madness. The Empress kicked Chaser in the back. I couldn't overcome his weight and sat down.

I could feel her gaze looking down on me.

“Iana!”

Ricdorian's desperate voice came. When I turned my gaze, I saw him running.

Ricdorian soon confronted the Empress, and Francia and Lenag's voice came from the other side. But they couldn't get to me.

Rumble, rumble!

Chains extending from the floor bound their arms and legs.

“Ha, haha? Hahahaha! Were you here? Haha!”

Although the Empress seemed to have gone mad, there are three roses here. Even so, Francia and Lenag were tied and unable to move.

“Ha, haha. Hahahaha!”

The Empress stamped her feet with a laugh. The color of the aura surrounding the huge spell circle changed in an instant. It was an ominous dark purple.

“I've been waiting for a thousand years, huh?”

Countless swarms of bats appeared on the ceiling and covered the tombstone. At the same time, like growing mold, dark purple spots began to spread like contamination.

Clash!

Before I knew it, the Empress was facing swords with Ricdorian. No, the Empress' weapon was not a sword. It was a black whip reminiscent of a vine.

“Who here has the memories of a thousand years intact? It's me!”

Ricdorian clenched his teeth and snapped the Empress' whip.

“Give me that power! It's mine! Hahahaha! Now the Almighty Rose will be me, not that halfling. Me! Me! I will become God!”

Then countless bats rushed at him. However, it burns or crumbles under his burning red power.

In the meantime, I hurriedly checked Chaser who had fallen on me. His white shirt was already stained with blood, like it had been red from the beginning. I knew nothing about medical care, but this was a great injury.

... No, there was no way that a person could survive after being stabbed in the heart.

“..... Iana.”

Chaser tried to move his hand. However, the attempt became limited to very little movement. I gritted my teeth.

“Stay still. If you want to be treated by the White Rose.”

Then Chaser laughed. While pouring out blood

“Hahaha, are you trying to save me? I don’t think so.”

He then anxiously tried to move his hand.

“Even now, I barely survive because I am the Rose. A few minutes. There is no one, *cough*, who survives, being stabbed in the heart, Iana.....”

“..... Who doesn’t know that?”

I bit my lip. My power returned, but for some reason it did not reach out towards Francia and Lenag. It must have been because of that dark purple chain that bound the two of them together.

Should I move myself? The situation was hopeless. I saw the imperial knights rushing in as soon as the door opened. Fortunately, my strength worked toward the door. The knights were blocked by the blue wall and couldn’t enter anymore.

“You, why did you save me?”

In that fleeting moment, the dagger imbued with this strange power was aimed at me, not Chaser. I, who had put all my energy into returning Ricdorian’s life, couldn’t have stopped or avoided it.

“..... Because you are precious.”

Chaser’s hand moved towards me just a little bit more. I didn’t hold that hand.

“So, thinking about it! Why did you tie me up?”

The long-overdue resentment leaked out toward him. At that time, I didn’t even realize that it was wrong. Chaser laughed, swallowing his blood.

“So that only I can see you. Because I wanted to.”

“..... You are crazy too.”

A vague answer came out. I immediately bit my lips hard.

“That’s enough, enough.”

Chaser’s hand moved a little more. There was still some distance left between him and my hand.

“Live.”

I clenched my fist tightly.

“Live and pay for your sins. I can’t tolerate people like you escaping with death.”

I hate you and I resent you. I can never cut off this feeling. I wish I could just tell you to die!

If only this man hadn’t saved me from so many assassinations in Domulit Mansion.

Could I have been more comfortable disliking and being indifferent to this man?

Laughter, anger, and despair. Laughter broke out at the end.

On the one hand, I gradually realized. Maybe the Blue Rose is made so that they can't turn away from all the roses.

A square engraved on a tombstone, each rose at the apex and connected by a line leading to the center, the Blue Rose.

Did this line mean that he and I cannot be separated?

“Live.”

The spark of his life was dying every moment.

“Live.”

Chapter 236: Choice (2)

1. Choice (2)

I can't say that this man who has already taken away the happiness of so many people deserves to be happy. No, I won't. He dishonors all who are killed and carried away by him.

Also, it would be unforgivable for him to escape by dying peacefully like this.

“A death like this is too comfortable a punishment for you.”

“That's right.”

The man did not turn away from his sinful karma. Chaser's hand and my fingertips were almost touching.

“But, Is that an order?”

I said quietly.

“..... yes. It is.”

“Then..... I'll try, to not, disobey..... the king's, last order.....”

But I also knew while he was saying this. This man's body was rapidly cooling down.

‘My body is strange.’

With him, I felt an abnormality in my body. This was a strange sensation I had felt since the ominous dark purple light contaminated the tombstone

and colored the spell circle. I spread my palms. Just like on the tombstone, there were dark purple stains that settled down like mold.

I felt the barriers against the knights crumbling. Originally, it would have been impossible. I felt that I had tried with all my heart and soul to destroy this dark purple aura.

“..... You won’t, go back?”

Chaser’s dying voice rang in my ears.

“I, was going to, send..... you back.”

Chaser vomited out blood, but stood firm and said in a nonchalant voice.

“..... If you stayed, at Domulit, I would be satisfied. Just one month..... I would be happy.”

Perhaps it refers to the day when I inserted the syringe into him. There was no trace of blood on his lips now.

“Don’t lie.”

“..... You, know that I can’t lie to you.”

He laughed with bloody lips. His eyelids were slowly sinking.

“I don’t want... anyone to have you, if I can’t.... Because you’re mine.....”

He was such a crooked man until the very end.

“But I want you to be happy.”

Still, he loved me the best he could.

“..... Go back, my Iana. To where you were.”

I was never thankful or happy for this love.

“..... You really are a jerk.”

At the same time, the barrier blocking the knights was broken. My body shook strongly.

Whhhhaaa!

The knights came in.

My shaking hand grabbed Chaser's hand. I supported his body. When I glanced away, it seemed that Francia was shouting something at me. But I didn't hear anything, like something was disturbing me.

“Sorry. Because these are, all I learned.....”

When my hand finally reached Chaser, he showed a faint smile.

“Even if I die, the power will remain..... for a while. Iana. Go back, before it's too late.”

He stammered. He moved his stiffening tongue, trying to speak clearly.

“Now is..... your last chance.”

Countless knights ran towards the tied Francia and Lenag. Swords were stuck in their bodies. I tried to send them power, but it was blocked by that chain. In the meantime, dark purple stains came up to my forearms.

No.....

I couldn't get my voice out. The moment I stretched out my hand, a strong nostalgia took over my whole body.

I want to go home. I pictured my family in harmony. I missed my older sister. I missed my mother's warm embrace. I missed the comfort. I missed the familiar sound of the car engine starting and the shadow of a strong father who would pick his daughter up every night.

“..... no.....”

A single tear ran down my cheek. My roses were crying out for me. I couldn't hear that.

I loved my world and grew up in a very harmonious family. In a place where an indifferent personality is so warmly accepted.

Tears flowed.

Sorry.

“..... I. I grew up very harmonious.”

A world that perishes without me.

The burden weighing down on me.

The body temperature of the man in my arms is slowly cooling down.

Give me one last option.

I just hit the floor. I quietly listened to the song of the guardian deity dwelling inside me. I didn't even know if I realized it too late. This song... These were the best words the guardian deity could have said.

‘You knew. The reason why your songs have always been sad..... Is it because you knew?’

Was it because of this reason that I couldn't hear it? The guardian deity did not answer my question. I could only guess that the cries were closer to affirmation.

“Haha, hahaha! Finally, finally, all power is in my hands! In my hands!”

The mad voice came.

“I have been waiting for this moment for a thousand years, a thousand years! All roses, in my hands! The moment I become a god!”

I spread my palms and put them on the floor. My stomach rumbled. I don't know why, but this dark purple stain spreading inside me seemed to be destroying my body.

It was a fight I started. I couldn't just do nothing. *Cough*, a strong cough came out.

“Hey, help..... me.”

I want to end this.

“Ahahaha!”

In line with my strong desire, the energy that had not come out no matter how much I called for it, began to flow little by little. At the same time, I felt a strong pain in my body. I could see the veins on the backs of my hands turned purple and bulging out.

But I didn't care and generated more power. Gradually, from where I was, the purple light faltered backwards and then stretched out towards one place.

I felt like I was blocked by a wall. I need more strength, more and more.

My fingers scratched the floor. My eyes were aching from the pain, but I bit my lip and held it in.

Crash, clatter!

Finally, the chains around Francia and Lenag broke. At the same time, a handful of blood pours out of my mouth. *Drip*. The man receiving the dripping blood stopped moving. I clenched my fists until they turned white.

“Sister! Sister! Sister, are you okay?”

Finally, Francia's voice was clearly heard again.

I slowly raised my head. Carefully putting the man down, I staggered up. Then I stretched one hand towards the ceiling.

All guardian deities can be shaped into weapons.

Like Ricdorian's sword and Francia's hammer. The blue energy in one hand formed an image.

What was nestled in my hand was a long 'scepter'.

Brilliant blue light shimmered like a huge jewel that was incomparable to what the Empress had. I looked at the end of the scepter and slammed it down on the floor.

BANG!

The huge blue power that arose from the floor forms a wave and stretches toward one place. Then, like a blue wave, it circled around and trapped one person.

The Empress' movements stopped. No, she won't be able to move. The bloodshot eyes quickly turned to me.

"Do you think you can stop me like this? No, you're dying, you can't stop me. Ahahahaha!"

"..... I don't like external forces controlling human destiny. Didn't you think the same as me?"

At that moment, the mad Empress' movements stopped. The blue aura rippled like waves, blocking her power. Just like she did to me a moment ago.

"You said you didn't want to go crazy."

I wiped the blood from my lips with the back of my hand.

"You didn't look like such a weak person. I'm disappointed."

"..... phhp, ppfft! Hahahaha! Words like that won't work anymore! The Empress you know has already been eaten!"

“Don’t talk like a third-rate villain. Do you really want to do it because you want to?”

I let out a rough breath and leaned on the scepter like a cane. I didn’t want to fall down. Before I knew it, Francia ran to me and grabbed my body. She tried to cure my messed up body.

I didn’t take my eyes off the Empress.

“You said you wanted to get rid of that power.”

Lenag also came and took a spot next to me.

It was then. The Empress’ face, which had been laughing madly, became hazy. She seemed to tilt her head and look down at her hand.

Then she raised her hand the next moment. The tip of the pointed whip was lodged in her stomach.

“..... now..... hurry.....”

I heard a faint voice

“Kyaaaakk! Crazy bitch! No! No! Are you trying to ruin our thousand-year-old dream! No! No!”

However, the Empress’ weapon remained stuck in her stomach and did not fall out. I made even bigger waves. The waves wrapped around the Empress’ head and lifted the tiara that was placed on her head.

“Do, don’t! No! It’s mine, it’s mine!”

The Empress’ face looked dismayed.

“Ricdorian, now!”

Ricdorian did not miss the chance. The moment the blue power restrained the Empress’ body, his sword pierced the side of the whip.

The Empress' body was torn.

The blazing red power and my power would have made a mess the moment they entered the Empress' body. Despite having a very strong shell, her strength and soul were infinitely fragile.

How I knew this..... It was my guardian deity who whispered in a song.

“Haa, haa....”

As the Empress collapses, my body also stumbles and collapses.

“Iana!”

Finally, the hero who defeated the monster came to me, and tears flowed down his face.

“I, Iana..... Iana.”

Ricdorian ran up to me and held my fallen hand and wept endlessly. I lifted my head helplessly and looked at him blankly.

I used my last strength and returned the Empress and all the Empress' knights to the imperial palace, the place where I had left. Once again, blood was overflowing inside, but I thought I did well.

The Empress would no longer be able to properly use her power. In the first place, her power came from this spell circle and the tiara, the object of the first Blue Rose.

“Why why. Why won't it heal? Heal her quickly!”

“I don't know. I've never had anything like this before. Sister, Sister!”

2 more chapters until the epilogue T.T

Chapter 237: Choice (3)

1. Choice (3)

I blinked slowly.

‘..... I feel another power.’

It wasn't my strength that has already been exhausted. The power of the Blue Rose, which is similar to mine but only slightly different. This was the power that Chaser had left behind. The spell circle revealed great power towards another spell. An order for me to go home.

A huge voice I had never heard before rang in my head.

– **Do you want to return?**

I opened my eyes with difficulty. In a place not far away, I saw something with blue energy. It had no face or expression, but it had a human-like appearance.

The question that it asked would, of course, be the question of returning to my world. I blinked my eyes.

‘I'm going back.’

I muttered to myself. After seeing the dead man, I slowly rose.

I felt a hand holding me back, but I patted it as if it was okay and removed it. I stood up and staggered.

“Sister!”

“Miss Iana!”

I saw Francia and Lenag who were messed up because of me. She who tried to heal me without caring for her body until the end, and my rose who did not spare his body and became a shield. The blue light was vivid and they closed their eyes.

I tried to move. But before that, someone suddenly grabbed my hand.

“Iana!”

It was Ricdorian, messed up with tears. Covered in blood red like his rose.

“Don’t, don’t go. Please. Please.....”

I stared at the hand that I couldn’t hold tight enough. My brittle lips opened.

“My dear rose.”

A weak voice comes out. I raised my hand and cupped his cheek.

“My Ricdorian.”

His tears didn’t stop. Even after wiping and wiping, like it was begging to be wiped over and over again. I wiped his cheek and took his hand off me. I patted him telling him it was okay, then kissed him.

“It’s okay.”

His face looked like he did not understand what was okay. Still, he couldn’t hold me anymore. I turned and staggered toward one place. It was towards the human figure with blue energy. As I approached, the blue figure reached out to me. I looked at the hand and reached out and caught it.

Whoosh!

The blue light suddenly exploded. When I opened my eyes, it was a completely different space.

– Are you going?

Once again the question came. Perhaps this is the last question given.

I'm going back

I muttered to myself once more. Longing and nostalgia rushed like a tidal wave.

Fragments of irrepressible memories occupy my head. Then I suddenly laughed.

By the way, Iana. Can you really throw them away?

Well, I already have the answer.

I call myself Iana.

Still, tears continued to flow.

My beloved world. My family. Now was the time to choose.

“Who are you?”

I asked the blue figure in front of me. It exudes power similar to mine, but it is alien.

Until a little while ago, I thought it was the power left by Chaser. But it was a different feeling than that. The closer I got, the better I got to know it.

“Are you God?”

The bluish figure with neither face nor expression stared at me blankly. I felt that it could see even though it had no eyes. Soon the water-like shape moved and changed its shape. The form of a person wearing a large black cloak. The face under the cloak was still invisible. The chin, mouth, and lips, which were only vaguely visible, were drawn in smooth curves.

I knew this smile was the answer to my question.

“You have another wish.”

A strange voice that was neither male nor female came out.

“Tell me.”

“Before that, I want to ask you one thing.”

“Ask.”

“Would this world really perish without the Blue Rose?”

I opened my mouth. I knew that the presence in front of my eyes was the one who could give me answers to all my questions.

“It may or may not. In order to explain this, I must first know the value of your existence and the uniqueness of this world.”

“Uniqueness?”

“Yes. You’ve already heard that you are a piece of a dead god. This land where you are staying is the land where the pieces of the dead god are locked away. Even on the continent, time and space flow in a special way only here. In other words, only the time of this land can be turned back, or another dimension can be opened.”

“Why..... Did you make it like that?”

“To safely dispose of the pieces of the dead god.”

Are the deaths of the Blue Roses the same as the disappearance of the fragments?

“Did you satisfy your curiosity? Then let’s go back to your world now.”

“Wait. What will happen to the world left behind when I return?”

God in front of me thoughtlessly turned its head to the side, then tilted its head.

“That world will disappear. And by the time you show up, it will come back.”

“By the time I show up”

“Ah. Don’t get me wrong. I mean when you end your lifespan in your original world and return to this world.”

It had a friendly tone, but the voice sounded inorganic somewhere.

“Only then will you meet the roses of your era, live your destiny and die. You now are a soul brought against the law.”

“What are you talking about? I’m sure there must be a Blue Rose that moved to another dimension besides me.....”

“At least those who crossed the dimension are those who have filled their lives in their world. In your world, you would call it reincarnation. Can we go now?”

I moved my lips and closed them. Then I raised my head. I’ve heard everything I need to hear now.

The dialogue was over.

“No. I am not going.”

I took a step back from God. I kept my back straight. The decision has already been made.

“I will give up my world.”

In the end, I can’t abandon those blind people. Maybe I’m already tied to the invisible string that binds us together. It didn’t matter. Because I chose to be tied up.

The smile disappeared from God’s lips. It spoke without expression.

“These are not the roses of your era. You will regret that choice.”

It was an overbearing voice with a different timbre. I shook my head.

“No. They are my roses.”

“Even though you would have to give up a lot of things for that choice? Immense unbearable sorrow and longing will haunt you for the rest of your life?”

“I don’t care.”

I pondered.

The power of the Blue Rose. The power that can move dimensions can be regressed. Regression brings even the dead back to life.

“Can I bring Chaser Domulit back to life with my own power?”

God gave no answer. After a moment of silence, I was given another question instead.

“By human standards, that soul has killed countless others and taken lives. You want to revive a soul with a lot of sinful karma?”

“I will make him live and pay for his sins.”

“If he reincarnates, you will have to pay.”

“No. There is a difference between paying back while remembering and not paying it back at all.”

He has bothered so many people. He may well deserve to die. Even so, I want to let him live and pay for his crimes.

Maybe even if it takes a lifetime to come back to life.

“Please save him and don’t erase this world.”

God changed its posture now. The slightly curved back is straightened. An unapproachable aura was felt through my whole body.

“What if you had to sacrifice all your past lives and past memories to make that wish come true?”

“.....”

“You will have to give all the happiness you have experienced. In there you are gradually forgotten.”

I paused. Countless nostalgic faces flashed through his mind.

My family. Happy smiles that still haunt my heart.

I bit my lip softly. Then, even though I was a little discouraged, I smiled relievedly.

“Yes. I will give up my past.”

I decided to be selfish even a little, a little bit. Because my loving parents have an older sister besides me. They will be fine.

Those who were always harmonious and happy would be better than those roses who only followed me.

Tears wet my cheeks.

I didn't regret it. God stared at me for a long time. As if observing and exploring.

“Now I see that you are the largest piece of the dead god. Right. It was. So maybe the similarity.....”

For some reason, it was a voice full of sorrow.

“One thing cannot pay for the price.”

“What?”

“The price is not enough.”

God replied in a firm voice.

“The world has been twisted once because of you. Those who have already died here cannot be resurrected by turning back time.”

Gradually, my expression faded, but God suddenly spoke.

“So let’s do this.”

A light burst from beneath my feet. The light that flowed from under God’s feet clumped together and floated like a ball made of light.

“According to nature, you must spend the rest of your life in your world and return. This cannot be changed.”

“However!”

“Listen to the end. I won’t erase the world as you wish. Instead, you spend all your life alone in a world where everyone forgets you and doesn’t remember you. That is your price.”

As God beckoned, the orb of light rose above its hand and floated through the air.

“You will also lose all memories of your previous world. This is the second price you have to pay.”

The orb of light placed on God’s hand revealed a twinkle of light.

Soon a space was torn in the form of a half moon between us.

A blue light shimmered between them. With God’s gesture, the sphere of light entered the gap, and the gap slowly closed.

“When you return, I will let this one return as well.”

“What? So, now that.....”

“This is the soul you asked to save. Any problems?”

No, tell me that beforehand.

I stared at God with an absurd face, but I only realized that I shouldn't apply human common sense to a being that could be God.

“At this point, the contract will be done properly. Is there anything else you want to bring?”

Chapter 238: To my world

1. To my world

The tone was patronizing. As expected, I could not hide my surprise, but I soon calmed down.

“Then maybe.....”

God gave a nod at my ensuing question. That means it was possible.

Soon, after a few more talks, God sent me back. It was not my original world, but the place where I had been before, the space where Ricdorian and the roses had been.

“Iana? Iana!”

As soon as I descended into the space, Ricdorian saw me and came running. He paused for a moment when he saw the light spreading behind me. I came closer for a moment.

“Ricdorian, I’m here to say goodbye.”

I don’t know what kind of message this will be. I just smiled broadly. Saying that, Ricdorian’s face seemed to blur, and soon tears welled up again. The neat face seemed like it would fall out of my eyes at any moment.

“I..... I don’t want to, Iana. Without you..... my life.....”

“Ricdorian.”

“I don’t want to. Iana. There’s no point in living without you. I don’t want to.....”

“Ricdorian.”

Calling out to him firmly, I grabbed his cheeks. Eyes full of tears looked at me.

“Will you give me a chance to talk too? I haven’t said anything yet. What kind of message will this be.”

In the future, his answer will determine what kind of goodbye this will be. I smiled sweetly and finally spoke.

“You see, Ricdorian.”

Now, this question may be a question that will shake all of his life and the basis of ut.

“What would you..... give up for me?”

Ricdorian, whose cheeks were held by me, blinked. Then, he smiled broadly as if he had thought of something crazy. It was a dazzlingly bright smile.

“Everything.”

He didn’t even hesitate for a second before he said that. Like he spoke of something natural.

Even if God said it was okay to take any soul, there should not be a hint of hesitation. All he had to give up was everything he had accomplished in this world. He was going to the unknown.

I slowly turned my head.

There stood Francia and Lenag. I went to Francia first after alternating between the two.

“Francia.”

The time God gave me was not that long. Francia spoke first before my words came.

“I will stay here. Sister.”

“..... What?”

Francia seemed to meet Lenag’s gaze for a moment, then she took a step forward.

“I don’t know why, but someone whispered in my head. Someone has to stay here and balance it out. That way, Sister doesn’t get lost and can come back this way?”

She said that and smiled.

“They seem to be kind enough to Sister to do something for Sister that is difficult to say.”

She said she was relieved, and added one more word.

“Me and the Yellow Rose will protect this place.”

“..... I have not expressed a single word of my opinion, White Rose.”

“What. Didn’t you hear that too? Is there more than me and you when the terms are just needing two people?”

“.....”

Lenag was silent for a moment and looked away. Instead of answering Francia, he seemed to have chosen to turn to me.

Francia clicked her tongue and stepped aside. It didn’t take long for Lenag to fill the spot.

He hesitated, but carefully stretched out his hand. Even so, his hand could not reach me. I reached out and took his hand. He then grabbed my hand and bowed his head.

“You are back. I,”

He paused for a moment, like his throat was choked.

“Miss, I

His lips lingered on the back of my hand for a long time. I pretended not to know what had flowed down his cheek.

“I will remain as your milestone.”

I thought he was the same till the end. Even though his farewell was so simple, he was considerate of me until the end.

“Take care of yourself. Until I come back.”

I answered softly and smiled.

“I will definitely come back.”

“..... Yes. I’ll wait. My King.”

I don’t think I’ll ever forget those eyes without glasses.

“Sister, My king.”

Francia came over and held me tightly in her arms. The hug felt childish, wanting to be hug rather than be the one who hugged.

“I will always be by your side.”

I closed my eyes tightly in her arms.

Eventually, the given time passed. The bluish light promised by God enveloped Ricdorian and I. It is said that the shorter the parting is better.

But even though I know that I will come back someday, the parting that is too short leaves a scar on my heart.

That's how I left the world together and crossed the dimension.

When I opened my eyes, the first thing I saw was a very familiar huge building.

Neither the old-fashioned mansion nor the majestic castle were in sight.

Those walking down the street did not wear uniforms with sharp swords or maid uniforms with lace.

A little stuffy air filled my lungs. Only then did I realize that I had come to another world.

Everyone glanced at us as they passed by us. There were also those who looked at me in daze.

Maybe..... Rather than me, it seemed that the person next to me took their attention.

When I turned my head, there was a man who couldn't take his eyes off me. His eyes were fixed only on me.

"Hey, Ricdorian."

"Yes."

"That..... Do you want to look around? It's a different world."

"..... Should I?"

"Oh, is it not amazing?"

"Amazing..... I don't know what's amazing, but I like having Iana by my side."

When I took his hand, he held my hand immediately.

“Your hair is black, Iana.”

“Yes. Why is yours the same.....”

Why is he the only person who remains the same and did not look like a person from this world?

“You know, think carefully. Now that it’s just the two of us, I’ll be alone with you all day, so what if you get tired of it?”

Ricdorian tilted his head.

“I don’t think I’ll be bored all day just by looking at Iana.”

I burst into laughter at those words.

“Um, that sounds good. It’s been a while since I’ve been here, so I don’t feel like I’m familiar with the neighborhoods?”

This was the world I used to live in. However, I had become a person who no longer had any family or relatives here. My gutted chest hurt. Strangely, it really hurts.

“God has no conscience. There are many things to consider, such as resident registration..... real estate..... Ah, really.”

“Um, I’ll do something about it.”

“No, this is a little shameless, but I have to tell God to take responsibility. It is fortunate that at least our right to live was guaranteed.”

I smiled and turned my head.

“Then, shall we go?”

Maybe my family won’t remember I’m here. Because the traces and existence of ‘me’ who lived in this world had disappeared.

I have only vague memories of having a family. There was a feeling of emptiness in the place where those memories had gone. Regret was stuck there too. And a sharp pain. It will probably be a pain for the rest of my life.

But I accepted my choice.

Now all that remains is to live with this man who gave up everything for me.

“Um, Ricdorian. There will be a lot to adapt to in the future.”

“Yes.”

“Ah. Should I start with a name? Something like Cheol-sik, Cheol-su. Sorry.”

“I don’t know what you’re sorry about, but everything is fine, Iana.”

The hand holding me was firm. We moved with light steps toward his and my house, which God gave as a last favor.

“Anywhere with you. And whatever. All good.”

Under the pouring sunlight of an early summer day.

“Oh, I guess it’s here. Not a bad place.”

An unfamiliar house. When I open the door, what comes next to me is a smile as bright as this fresh sky.

A rose in full bloom who loves me.

No, three roses.

And the man I love

“How about it? It’s not a fancy castle, though. I will make it not bad for the Grand Duke to live in.”

“It’s okay to sleep on the ground if Iana and I are together. But I can’t put Iana to sleep on the ground. I’ll do anything. And let me serve you.”

“What is it, then shall we serve each other?”

The cost of choice was harsh, but I did not regret it. I will protect my solid ground.

“I love you.”

I stopped.

“I really love you, Ricdorian.”

Blinking his eyes for a moment, he immediately leaned his upper body.

When I closed my eyes, his lips, rough and close to raw, dug into me. An impatient but loving gesture.

I finally escaped all the prisons that held me.

After this escape, there will be a path that I will make.

“Haa, I love you too. Iana.”

And the name of that path.....

“Forever.”

Happiness.

After the long kiss, I saw a neat face dyed red.

“The days are going to be long. To see your face.”

His face, open like a forget-me-not that had just bloomed, was full of joy.

“..... Will the days be long?”

“Hmm, I don’t think it’s something to say while blushing, Ricdorian.”

I laughed because I loved the man who blushed and always made shy confessions like the day we first met.

“Ricdorian. Maybe the moment right before being happy is more valuable than the happy moment itself.”

I was happy.

“Because I am full of expectations that I will be happy all the time.”

My rose, who had been smiling brightly, kissed me again.

“Ricdorian, someday.....”

The day when the flowers had just withered and the green summer leaves were fluttering down.

“I will propose on the day we return to our world.”

To you.

The day you and I love will continue to be the same.

Chapter 239: Epilogue (1)

1. Epilogue (1)

January.

The blue sky was no different than usual. It was the color of a sky-blue paint that had been overturned.

“Uuugh.”

I put down what I was holding and straightened my back. I saw the green barrel in front of me. The neighborhood dumpster. The bin was full of tightly tied garbage bags.

I quickly closed the cover before the smell spread out. The dumpster in this neighborhood is cleaner than I remember. Garbage was rare even on the road in front of the house.

Someone said that this was due to the beautification of the neighborhood related to economic power. But looking at it like this, it might be that this neighborhood is inhabited by people who are not bad.

The first reason for guessing that way is because I don't know the neighborhood well yet. At least the people don't seem to show their face much.....

“Hello!”

Oh, what a surprise. I flinched and turned my back.

Behind me stood a girl in a neat school uniform. She was 19 years old. It was a familiar face.

“I’m surprised.”

The high schooler burst into laughter. It was a bright laugh.

“You don’t look surprised at all, it’s funny when you say that, Sister.”

She was a student living next door. The place next door to us is also a house with a clear wall, just like ours, but different people lived on the first and second floors.

This student was the youngest daughter of the owner’s side of the house next door.

“Going to school? You leave early.”

“Yes!”

The student next door gave a quick nod.

“Now, I’m a senior in high school, I have to come early. There will be tests from March too. I’m going to die.”

I glanced at the student next door. Indeed. She was soaked in the feeling of not wanting to go to school, the vest was visible through the long padded jacket.

“Does Sister always get up early?”

“You know. I don’t usually wake up early, but I wake up at this time every time.”

Having said that, I murmured softly.

“Maybe I have not adjusted to the time difference?”

The student next door asked ‘what?’. I quickly shook my head. It must be a joke she can’t understand.

But the student next door seemed to have managed to catch a few words.

“Time difference? Wow, is Sister from abroad?”

She showed a curious expression. I guess she looked like she wanted to do anything except go to school.

“You always didn’t tell me where you were from. Was it because you were from abroad?”

“Well, it’s roughly the same.”

Actually, there are other circumstances, but I just glossed over it. Then her eyes lit up.

“Wow, wow. Sister, are you good at English? Or French? German? Spanish?”

I didn’t hate the kid next door. Rather, I liked her. When her eyes were shining so brightly, it reminded me of the Rose I had left in another world.

I smiled.

I probably won’t be able to say that.

I muttered to myself inside. It won’t really be a problem. I will know how to speak any language regardless of my knowledge.

When I didn’t answer, the student next door seemed to figure it out on her own. Holding her chin with her index finger and thumb, she nodded her head.

“No wonder. No wonder. Because Sister was unusual. Even from the first meeting!”

“From the beginning?”

The round eyes stared at me. The hair along the bun, which was tied up as if she hadn’t washed her hair, dangled along.

“You were out of the ordinary. I told my mom that I felt something, like an aura, from you?”

“Aura?”

“Well, celebrities have them!”

I almost burst out laughing, but I held back.

“Oh, why did you laugh? Sister. I really thought that Sister was preparing to be an idol. No. Is Sister an actress? Actress!”

The student next door explained by drawing a square in the empty air. It may be a movie theater screen.

“But wherever I look at Sister, you look Korean. But you’re very pretty, and don’t feel like a Korean either..... You must have lived abroad.”

It sounded gibberish, but I understood the meaning.

As she said, after coming over here, my appearance was transformed to resemble the people here. To be precise, it seems that there is no sense of peculiarity in others’ eyes.

It seemed like my original appearance and ‘Lee Ana’s’ were mixed. But fortunately, I had no problem assimilating into this place with this appearance. First of all, it’s because my hair color and eyes were pitch black.

I scratched my cheek as I listened to the continuous compliments. This kid seemed like Francia, but more like a puppy. For instance, she was closer to Francia during her childhood.

I stopped touching my cheek and tilted my upper body slightly. This kid was smaller than me, so I had to tilt my head. I smiled brightly while making eye contact.

“Thank you for saying I am pretty.”

The kid next door was startled. After that, her cheeks grew red.

“What, what! Are you trying to seduce me? Is that so?”

The kid next door tried to hit my forearm, but ended up quickly grabbing my forearm and shook it. Her fussy reaction was something I was used to.

Rather, I am not bored anymore. The student next door looked at me with her eyes twinkling.

“Sister, I think being pretty is really alright. I really like pretty sisters.”

Then, with a serious expression, she spoke.

“My cousin says that girls are jealous of other pretty girls, but it’s all bullshit. I feel so good when I see you!”

“Uh, um. I know. Really *bull*, no. That’s nonsense.”

I bewilderedly agreed.

“But Brother doesn’t talk nonsense like this!”

“What?”

If it’s Brother, it’s probably this kid’s real older brother, the eldest son next door. Was he a sophomore in college?

I remember that he was very tall and looked quite slender.

The kid next door was looking at me with expectant eyes for some reason. Not knowing what she meant, I tilted my head. But she quietly tilted her head toward my back.

Like looking for someone.

“By the way, sister, today, is he, not here?”

“Not here?”

The kid next door's face flicked back to me. Then, with a flushed face, she raised her voice to the same level as before.

"The handsome Brother!"

Ah, I laughed right away when I realized the answer.

"He, he. How can a person look like that? I am amazed every time I see him. He doesn't come out very much....."

"It's because he doesn't like going out very much."

"That's right, I think he only came out when he was with Sister. Is it because people stare at him? No. I guess they will surely stare."

Well. Rather, it's because he just wants to be in an enclosed space with me all day.....

I decided to leave the truth for the child who is still young.

Maybe my Red Rose is still sleeping peacefully inside the house, half-naked. As the name suggests, with red marks on his body and my body underneath the clothes.

"I guess so."

"Well, there's no helping it. Because he is veeerrry handsome and his eyes are blue. Perhaps since he's a foreigner."

Hearing her words, I smiled and fell silent.

He's not just a foreigner.

His silver hair was too conspicuous, so I dyed it black, but his eyes were still blue because I couldn't do anything about it.

In fact, even when Ricdorian went outside, he didn't seem to pay much attention to the gazes. When we came out, he was only looking at me.

“Anyway, don’t you have to go?”

I didn’t have a watch, but I could tell that time had passed.

We moved around the dumpster, but we were still in front of the wall.

“Ah! Ugh, I hate to go. I hate high school..... If only I could close my eyes and it would be December when I open my eyes.....”

In mourning, her shoulders drooped. Then a muffled voice came out.

Jump!

Slam!

I heard the door open. We turned our backs together and headed towards the sound.

The door that was opened was none other than my house’s. And the inside of the door was empty.

“Oh, Sister. Did the door open by itself?”

It was at that moment that the kid next door spoke. I wrinkled my nose and laughed. Then I said, feeling a strong arm wrapped around my waist.

“Oh, my door has a bit of a problem.”

It acts up when I’m away for a while.

I glanced around, and before I knew it, there was a man wrapped around my back, leaning his face on my neck and exhaling slowly.

“..... Ana.”

Ricdorian’s voice was chillingly low and languid, as if he had just woken up.

“Where have you been.....”

I raised my hand and gently stroked the top of his head.

It wasn't until later that I realized that the roses had their own scent, and it stayed the same in any situation. Even if they do not wash, even if they just wake up, they are just full of their scent, let alone an unpleasant smell.

Weirdly enough.

The student's face who took turns looking at us slightly reddened.

It was probably because of Ricdorian, with his upper body exposed, that gave her nowhere else to look.

“Sorry. Our house's child has.....”

I need to choose the right words.

“Separation anxiety.”

I wondered if it was an expression more appropriate for a pet than a person.

yes, we're finally on the epilogue! the main story has actually ended~

so well at least iana and ricdorian gets to be together but it's a bit sudden considering what happened before?

but let's see where the story goes!

the epilogue and after story will stretch about 25-ish chapters so we would still have more stories to unpack, sit tight!

Chapter 240: Epilogue (2)

1. Epilogue (2)

– What he does is a beast. Don't you think so, Nyang?

Then, Pudding, who had been quiet until now, said a word inside me.

– No matter how the Roses have good stamina, Nyang! To not sleep.....

‘Quiet.’

I quickly covered Pudding's mouth and turned my head.

The kid next door looked like she was asking when did Ricdorian come out, but she seemed to think that she just hadn't seen him pass by.

Rather, it seemed that Ricdorian's face was engulfed in a gaze that showed he did not want to think about anything else.

“I'm going in.”

“Ah..... What? Yes! Sister. Then next time.”

The kid next door couldn't even say goodbye. Because I couldn't listen anymore.

“Uwaah, Ri..... Ricdorian!”

Before I knew it, my feet were floating in the air. He looked at me with eyes that were still sleepy.

“You can't just move around.”

Black hair, now almost indigo, swayed gently, covering his pure white forehead.

“..... You were overworked yesterday.”

A voice that seemed to be scratching from the back of his throat penetrated my ears.

“You should get more rest.”

It’s clearly a whisper of concern, but how can it sound so erotic?

I groaned.

“Don’t whisper right in my ear like that.”

“But Iana. You like my voice. Especially when I just wake up. It’s ra.....”

“Stop.”

I quickly covered his mouth. Then I patted him on the bare shoulder. He was obviously trying to say ‘racy’. This man.

“That’s something you can’t say in front of the kids. Then I’ll go first. The man in my house is like this.”

The student next door stopped nodding blankly and quickly bowed to me while saying ‘ah, please go in!’.

Before she could even finish her words, Ricdorian moved on.

Yoon Jiah, a high school student from South Korea, blinked her eyes. It was as if the incident from a while ago had been etched into her retinas.

With her mouth, she muttered in her dialect, like a habit, “Oh my God, my dear,”.

It was also her habit when she was surprised.

“It’s always amazing to see.”

That handsomeness be bussin today. She muttered, mixing a lot of slang that a teenager would use.

Her mother nags her to stop saying bad words, but this kind of admiration always comes out after seeing the beauty of the people living next door.

It’s been this way ever since they moved in next door to her one day.

One day, they appeared without a rumor and were living a quiet life, unknown what they were doing.

Especially ‘Lee Ana.’ Is Ana the last name or the first name? She couldn’t guess how old the woman was.

She thought Lee Ana was the same age as her brother and going to college, but she said it wasn’t like that.

Actually, it was because Iana herself didn’t even remember how old she was or what kind of person she was while she was in this place. But this was strange for Yoon Jiah

“I have to go and tell the others.”

She was a little more brash and talkative than the others, and she was usually interested in gossip.

In particular, if she knew someone who has more celebrity-like beauty than celebrities, wouldn’t it be a great pride to her peers?

But as soon as she thought so, her expression soon turned hazy.

Then she shook her head gently. Her hair, which was tied up, came loose. Yoon Jiah tilted her head.

‘Oh, what was I thinking just now?’

She blinked her eyes, looked down at her hand, and sighed.

“Oh, I hate going to school.”

She completely forgot about the house next door she had been staring at just a moment ago, not caring as if she couldn't see it.

And walked straight ahead.

In her mind, everything about the mysterious people next door had been forgotten.

It was going to be like this until she saw them again.

As it has been for the past year or so.

“In the world I was in, 18 is an adult, Iana.”

I turned my head away as I sat down. Then, I almost spit out the water I was drinking.

“That..... Putting aside what you just said, Ricdorian. What the hell is that..... you're wearing?”

Ricdorian was wearing an apron on his bare skin. Fortunately, he was wearing pants.....

The pants were very good-fitting jeans that I bought a while ago. I felt full of luxury because my eyes were so indulged.

Looking at his slender and strong curves, he seemed to have jumped out of a famous foreign jeans billboard.

‘I like the face much better this way.’

Ricdorian tilted his head while holding the frying pan.

“You don’t like it?”

“I like it very much, no. Where the hell did you learn to say that?”

After thinking about my question for a while, Ricdorian immediately gave a refreshing answer.

“The guardian of the Red Rose said that.”

He shrugged his shoulders. With a very innocent face.

“If Iana looked at me and I looked like this, she would go crazy…….”

“Pudding!”

I jumped up from my seat. It sounded like the cry of an animal saying ‘from somewhere!’. It won’t be an illusion.

The guardian deity, who sensed the crisis, quickly pulled himself out.

However, as it flew and crawled to get in the palm of my hand, I felt a soft sensation in my hand. So I stretched out my hand.

“You must have tried to run away.”

– What? Nyang? Who wants to run away?

“I saw you move quickly.”

– This body is not running away!

Pudding that had been held in the air was quickly denied.

– I, I just wanted to take a nap, Nyang!

“Under the sofa?”

–

The small snow leopard, sweating profusely and avoiding my eyes, held out the large jelly paws in front of me.

– Hu, human! There is a misunderstanding! Nyang! It's not what this body told him, Nyang! The Red Rose listened to this body's self-talk on its own. Nyang!

Ricdorian couldn't hear Pudding when it was inside me, but when it came out like this, he could hear it. If Pudding consciously blocked it, it seemed that Ricdorian couldn't hear it, but Pudding didn't.

In the end, the culprit was still this little snow leopard.

– Let, let go of this! Nyang!

As soon as my hands loosened, Pudding struggled. But my hands were faster than that.

“Where are you going?”

A blue energy rose from my fingertips to prevent Pudding from escaping.

“You said something useless last time, didn't you?”

– Ouch, Ouch! It hurts! This is animal abuse, Nyang! It's a violation of the Animal Protection Act, Nyang!

“You must be a pet for that. And I'm sorry, spirits like you don't fall under the Animal Protection Act, right? You've been watching TV all day!”

– It is unfair! I feel pain. Nyang!

As I literally pinched Pudding's cheeks and stretched them out.

I suddenly left Pudding and jumped up. Not only me, but Ricdorian, who was holding the cooking utensils, was also looking at one place.

Our gaze was directed to the full-length mirror located in the living room.

The mirror rippled like the cross section of a wave, then drew waves like a lake where a stone was thrown.

Before long, something popped out of the wave. It was as if the mirror was spitting out what it had swallowed.

I put down Pudding and hurriedly headed to the mirror.

There was a piece of parchment under the mirror. To be precise, it was a neatly folded letter envelope.

What was written on the outside of the envelope was a very familiar handwriting.

[“To Sister”]

I looked at it with nostalgic eyes and lowered my eyes with a small smile.

“It’s Francia.”

It was a letter from Francia, from another world.

[“Hello Sister? How are you?”]

Her handwriting was as cheerful as her personality.

[“This time it was my turn to send a letter, so I wrote it quickly, The Yellow Rose’s turn seems to be coming along, but I don’t know why mine feels so slow!”]

As I read the letter, longing came flooding back.

I’ve only been there for about 5 years at most, but it’s a place where I met someone I’ll be with for the rest of my life.

A world where my other roses live and breathe.

I closed and opened my eyes and pushed the pieces of longing away.

“The world over there seems to be going well without any problems.”

After reading all of Francia’s letters, I muttered a little, and then Ricdorian, who had come closer before I knew it, nodded.

As he wrapped his firm arms around me.

“That’s a relief.”

I burst into laughter at the arms that wrapped around me.

“Can you say that, Grand Duke? Today, your wizard will be busy acting as your substitute.”

More than a year after coming here, God showed his last mercy and allowed us to communicate with the world over there by letter.

Although not often, of course, it is limited to two roses and an envelope to each.

Since the envelope was always filled, it was not difficult to find out what was going on over there.

Grand Duke Hernim’s family was currently led by his aide and Archmage, Jaire.

With the cooperation of Francia and Lenag, who are closest to Ricdorian’s, the vassals seemed to have their own understanding.

I don’t know how long this will last though.

They will do their best in each position.

“Jaire says his hair is about to fall out.”

“I’m sure he knows how to make hair grow.”

“..... Can you say that?”

Ricdorian just smiled silently. I couldn't find any lingering feelings on his face, so I smiled awkwardly for a while, then patted his arm.

"He is in charge of Hernim, in this situation where we don't know when we'll be back."

"Yes."

"It may take a very long time."

"Yes."

"I don't know how time will flow on that side and this side in the future. On the other hand, well, Jaire might never see you."

Ricdorian's bright smile did not seem to be erased. I let out a small sigh and drew a similar smile.

"Alright."

If you are satisfied. He seemed quite content with the situation.

'Really, this serious.'

I don't hate him like this, so maybe I'm seriously ill too.

I turned my head to the letter.

In fact, in the letter she gave earlier, there was also a story about Domulet. She seemed reluctant to comment about the rest of Domulit, but it was the information I asked for.

Even now, Domulit, like Hernim, lost its master and all of the blood relatives. They were on the verge of disintegration and collapse.

However, right before it collapsed, someone brought a small child, saying that it was Domulit's bloodline. So the vassals united around the child and barely managed to keep it from collapsing.

The small child used to be occasionally seen near Chaser. I knew while reading the child's description.

The warlock, Marshmel.

I didn't know why he was determined to protect Domulit. I could only guess there was a contract between the two.

In the end, it was said that both Hernim and Domulit families were maintained by loyal subordinates.

I shook my head and tried to finish the letter from Francia. Then, at the end of the letter, I found a few very small words.

It was so small that I wouldn't have noticed it if I hadn't seen it a second time.

[“Sister, I think I am too kind. Phew. When I tried to send a letter, they looked at me so pitifully, so I decided to show mercy for once.]

[..... what. The other one also put my letter in their turn.]

[Anyway! I put it in! That one too!]

I didn't know what she meant, but I soon figured it out. A small piece of paper came out from among the piles of Francia's letters.

It was a small size close to a memo. A size I might have overlooked if I hadn't rummaged through.

Turning the card over, I saw neat writing laid out diagonally.

The moment I read the contents of the card, I burst into laughter.

[Your milestone is always there.]

Chapter 241: Epilogue (3)

1. Epilogue (3)

Even though they are far away, my roses are keeping their place. That brought me unbearable regret, responsibility, and warm longing.

When I closed my eyes, I enjoyed the scenery of the memories that flowed out and I opened my eyes again.

I tapped Ricdorian's arm with my finger.

"Then, shall we go out?"

The price of having to spend all of my life here. But ironically, God not only sent Ricdorian with me, but also did not completely cut me off from the other world.

Sometimes it was questionable. I considered returning to my world more like a price, a punishment.

The more I look back, the more I think it's not just that.

The moment I said this, the mirror rattled violently once. Then it vomited something like it had vomited a letter from Francia before.

This time it was not an envelope, but a neatly folded note.

It is not the parchment of the other world, but the modern one of this world now. I unfolded the paper, checked the contents, and arranged my clothes.

"Shall we go?"

Before I knew it, Ricdorian, who was wearing clothes too, followed me. In his arms was Pudding, who had turned into a cat.

They always fight, but at times like this, Pudding was always calm in his arms.

I smiled to myself and left the house. It was a pretty far outing after a long time.

I said it was a pretty far outing, but the place we arrived at was a park about three stops away from my house.

Perhaps feeling good in the cool air, the guardian deity of the Blue Rose within me let out a song-like cry.

‘Feeling good?’

When I talk quietly, the blue energy wraps around me like a wave and then sweeps me down. It was the way the guardian deity answered me.

‘Next time, when I come out at dawn or at night, I’ll take you out too. Whistle.’

I gave the name of my guardian deity ‘Whistle’ because it always sings a cheerful whistle-like song when I am in a good mood.

Ricdorian was away from me for a while while taking Pudding for a walk.

The 4-year-old guardian deity was wearing a leash and was enjoying a walk in the form of a cat.

It’s funny, but since that guardian deity can only be a cat, I sometimes hear that cats shouldn’t be taken for a walk by people passing by.

So our walks were rare at dawn or at night.

It was under my words that caused the two beings who would normally never separate from me to separate for a moment.

No, I guess they're used to it now.

I sat on a bench and looked at the deep blue sky. I felt it in the morning too, but the sky was blue enough to make it look like it could pour out the river.

"The air is nice."

As I muttered, I felt someone sitting next to me. When I glanced around, the figure of a small grandmother was at the end of my gaze.

She was an ordinary old woman with a slightly curved back, colorful green pants with small flower patterns, a cart made of black wire, and a hat for mountain climbing.

I can see about eight out of ten people like this if I go for a walk through the traditional market.

I put on a puzzled look.

"Why do you always show up like that? I'm surprised."

Then the grandmother smiled kindly through her wrinkled face. Just as she smiles, her wrinkles are fully dug.

"Isn't this the least surprising thing? Hoho."

"It's not like that when I think of the inside."

I shook my head.

"Isn't that right, God?"

I asked, looking at God in the form of a small grandmother.

To be precise, to the God who sent me here from the other world.

The grandmother, no. God, in the form of a grandmother, just laughed. Having already met several times, I shrugged my shoulders as I knew that this was a kind of hobby.

“But why are you always like that? Last time you were pregnant, before that you were a 3-year-old girl.”

Her wrinkled face looked real no matter which side I looked at. Well. This would be natural.

“Haha. Didn’t you hear that? Student. God is in the form of the weakest.....”

“Don’t call me Student.”

What’s the point of calling me that when I’m not a student? I replied casually, and a smile returned from the other side.

“I was careless. Forgive this old lady.”

“Huh, you’re incredibly sincere in your role.....”

This was the third meeting with God. The first meeting was to give us a place to live after coming here and what we needed to live in the future.

In the second meeting, God showed the last mercy so that letters could come and go from the other world. That’s why I’m not sure what the meaning of today’s meeting is.

Now, it’s not like I can go back because my lifespan is suddenly over. At the first meeting, God already gave me a rough idea of how long I would live here.

In other words, it could be said to be the average lifespan of a human being, perhaps a little longer than that.

Ah, I thought that if I had lived here as usual, I would have lived a pretty long life as well.

Who would have known that this longevity would be an obstacle? In particular, this lifespan, in other words, fate, was created by the person who manages this world, so according to the rules, it should not be touched.

I thought there were a lot of rules to follow for the so-called Absolute God. No, perhaps God must keep and protect this major premise.

Putting aside the unsuitable philosophical concerns, I stared at God.

“So why did you ask to see me?”

I only blinked once, but before I knew it, there was a little girl in front of me. Maybe she was 8 years old. She had the appearance of an age in which a square school bag would suit her.

Oh, did God change because my reaction to the grandmother was bad?

“I came to see you. Can I not?”

“..... You know that way of speaking really doesn't match the way you look right now, right?”

“Hmm, is that so? I know you're not inclined to be obsessed with things like this.”

“That's true, but I feel a sense of alienation.”

“Well. I thought you liked children. Is it wrong? Hmm?”

“What?”

“Didn't you like a child like this?”

I looked closely at God's appearance. Even though it was dark, she had long, wavy hair, rough cheeks, and big eyes.

..... Is it young Francia?

Of course, it was a little younger, but if Francia was made into an Asian, she would look like this.

Huh, when I let out a sigh, God innocently tilted her head.

Then, God's appearance changed once more. This time, it was a high school student wearing a school uniform. This time, I thought of someone who makes me feel the same thing as Francia.

"The student next door?"

"I think you like this one these days?"

..... Are you a stalker>

"I hope you don't show that you are watching my every move like that."

I'm not going to tell you not to do something you won't stop doing anyway, so I just hope you don't show it off. I said it in such a way.

"Why, don't you feel that way? Huh? Alright, alright. I should have this kind of fun in my lonely daily life."

"Actually, it's not even fun, is it?"

God's laughing eyes stopped for a moment. The bright eyes immediately rolled to one side. The place God looks sideways to is none other than the side where Ricdorian is.

"How is he doing these days?"

God put an arm on the lap, rested her chin on it, and grinned. That question had nothing to do with my question.

This is how God expresses intention not to answer.

"Is he doing well?"

"As you can see."

I shrugged. As God did, I also glanced towards Ricdorian.

Ricdorian was just preventing Pudding from grazing. Eating grass won't do Pudding any harm like a normal cat, though. It was funny because he was clumsy in admonishing him as if he was raising a real cat. He looked lovely like a green sprout that popped its head in spring.

Did I laugh without even realizing it? I felt a clear gaze and turned my head to see God looking at me.

No, maybe this is an observation.

“Huh, you look happy.”

“That's not the question, is it?”

“I'll say so. So, do you have any questions?”

Instead of answering God's question, I took one look and clicked my tongue in a low voice. Then I took off the jacket that I was wearing.

“..... If you're going to look like that, at least act like your appearance.”

I sighed deeply as I covered God's lap with my jacket. It's winter now. What is with the bare legs under the school uniform? On top of it, sitting cross-legged with a short skirt.

God had a strange expression.

“As expected, you're merciful. Is it because you are the largest piece?”

“If this is mercy, I must have already passed into nirvana? Am I Buddha?”

There was a laugh at my silly joke.

“So what are you curious about?”

If God asks this, it is probably asking after I had guessed everything. In fact, at the first meeting, I asked a lot of questions, but God didn't answer at

that time.

Will there be a different answer now?

I asked, even though I was dubious.

“..... How much is the difference between time over there and here, and how does it flow?”

This was a question I had already asked but never heard an answer to.

This also applies to incoming and outgoing letters, as they couldn't mark the time on the letters, and even if they marked them, they arrived with it being erased.

I also didn't know how much time had passed. I just know that it's been quite a while.

“Time goes by, of course. Because I wanted you to leave the other world as it is. Are you curious about the consequences of your choices?”

The observing eyes were fixed on me once again. God imitates a human being, but with deep eyes that a student of that age cannot contain.

It was an unfathomable depth, as is the meaning of God's existence.

“This might mess you up. Are you still curious?”

“Yes, I am curious.”

God spent a few more moments observing, then spoke.

“Time is much faster this way. That might be a relief for you.”

God smiled.

“But even so, by the time you go back, the humans you know will be very old or not have left, right?”

“This place is faster, so why?”

“Time is fast on this side right now, but at some point it slows down on this side. Still, it’s usually faster this way.”

God’s eyes did not fall from me.

“But the remaining roses over there, the beings you reap, are tied to you, so they won’t age. As time goes by, more and more people will find this strange or reject it.”

God was telling me that this was the result of my choice.

“They weren’t the roses of your generation, they weren’t the ones you should reap.”

“Yes.”

I meekly agreed.

“I chose knowingly. And my roses knew everything and still chose it, right?”

“.....”

“Me.”

For some reason, God did not spit out lies. Only kept silent now Therefore, God’s silence was an affirmation.

“Then that’s fine.”

I could laugh because everything is fine

“Because I decided to give up everything and give everything to those who chose me.”

Chapter 242: Epilogue (4)

1. Epilogue (4)

I instinctively knew that in the future, I may have to live for quite a long time. Maybe an uncountable number of years.

I don't know why. I haven't even asked God yet. Is it because I didn't get to that world the right way in the first place? Maybe. I don't know if it happened because I was against the rules.

Me and the Roses are bound by one destiny. The long lifespan was the same for those tied to me. So, our choices may come with a harsh price, or on the other hand, it may be a paradise inside a fence.

God made no expression. Curiously, I thought that face was closer to God. Then God suddenly turned to me.

“Look over there.”

This was a park. Sunny skies, green grass, colorful bricks, and roadside trees. In the surroundings, ordinary people are enjoying the park on a sunny day in their own way.

Of course, no one among them would have witnessed God's appearance change so quickly.

“What do you want me to see?”

God had no answer. I couldn't help but look at each and every one of them.

People passed in front of the benches we were sitting on. Each with a joyful, happy smile. Among them, there were some who seemed

particularly happy and harmonious than others.

God tugged at my finger at that moment.

“There.”

There? You want me to see those people? My gaze naturally stopped and looked at the smiling people.

It was a happy family of three, a married couple and an adult woman.

For some reason, the moment I saw them, my heart throbbed, albeit for a very short time. No. Rather than hurt.....

“They are your family.”

I blinked. I heard that..... Of course, I couldn't remember.

“Now your family has no memories of you and your existence has been erased.”

What I offered in return was all of my past. Not only memories but also my existence itself. There is no trace of ‘me’ living in this world. Because they all disappeared.

And I even sent the feelings of pain and bitterness in return. So, even if I saw them, I couldn't feel anything. I just felt a dull pain. This is something I will carry with me for the rest of my life. On the one hand, I couldn't figure out why God had shown them to me.

“Why are you showing me this?”

My voice came out calmly.

“It was a choice that I didn't even give to you during the moment of parting. How about saying goodbye?”

Goodbye? Now, why? We don't even remember each other? God turned again as if knowing my heart.

“Is a goodbye without memories seem like a separation?”

I spoke calmly.

“Really? I don’t think there is..... any meaning.”

“I can’t help it if you think so.”

God lightly erased the smile.

“You in the past loved your family very much. It was the same for your family. It was a harmonious family where only pure souls gathered.”

“.....”

“Memories belong to the soul, and even if you take them away, it leaves a mark.”

It was just a word of no importance.

Shiver. Tears flowed from my eyes. I can’t understand. Why? My heart doesn’t throb nor hurt.

“Just as death comes at the end of life, a knot is needed at the end of a kite. Say goodbye.”

I looked at them at the a low whispering voice. The happily smiling family.

I suppose.

“To end it.....right.”

I looked at my family for a while. Then I lowered my head and smiled slightly. Everything has been erased, but traces of it remain.

Now is the time to let go of those traces.

“I’m glad you look happy.”

I don't remember it anymore, but if it was someone I really cherished, I didn't want them to get hurt because of me. As a result, paradoxically, it was a harsh but happy outcome for each other. Tears that remained flowed down once more.

A lot of words and thoughts passed inside.

After a while, I looked away.

The family, which had been harmonious, disappeared at the far end of the park before I knew it.

I didn't say anything or even say goodbye to them. Even so, a refreshing wind blew in my chest, as if there were mint leaves in it.

It was a bittersweet yet refreshing feeling.

“God.”

God came into my eyes.

“It is not my fault that my world and my name were taken from me one day. But don't you think this kind of treatment is cruel?”

God laughed out loud. It's a smile that doesn't match the appearance of a high school student.

“Was it hard?”

I carelessly shook my head.

“It wasn't like that.”

“Then do you resent the person who took you there by force?”

“..... Not even that.”

To resent the person who took me there was like regretting the time I spent in the other world, and my ties with Ricdorian, Francia, and Lenag.

“Of course, to be honest, I think there were times like that. But not anymore.”

I spoke plainly and blinked my eyes. I had something to say.

“Why do you have mercy on me?”

To be honest, the price I paid was unusually generous.

“You say I am merciful, but I think you are more merciful.”

I hesitated for a while and said that.

God said it was harsh, but looking at it slowly, the price wasn't terribly harsh.

Lost memories, indifference remaining in a place where my existence was erased and no right to be hurt.

Lastly, going back to this place and specially allowing Ricdorian to come over together.

Looking back, all the price gave me only the stimulation I could endure. I've been guessing and thinking for a long time. Maybe ever since I came to this world, for a very long time.

“But you weren't actually showing mercy, were you?”

Then I came to a certain conclusion. In fact, maybe I shouldn't be crazy.

“Actually, I shouldn't be broken, right?”

God told me. Originally, I was not the rose of this generation and had to come over a longer period of time.

Roses were created to naturally destroy the fragments of the dead God.

According to the words, I originally had to go back to the other world later, and the fragment of God inside me had to be destroyed there.

“Looking back on everything, I wondered if my mind should be intact. You just didn’t want me to go crazy.”

I laughed lightly.

“Right?”

I wasn’t 100 percent sure. However, the reasoning that started with speculation gained strength after being completed with logic.

“That’s why you showed my family members for the last time right? So that there are no regrets.”

God was silent. Then slowly started to speak.

“You’re right. That’s not all, though.”

She cupped her chin and gently rubbed her cheek with her index finger.

“Actually, if you paid the right price, it’s only right that you carry the pain for the rest of your life with your memories.”

Her deep eyes came up to mine.

“But, as I said, not everything was a safeguard against your mind ruining. Yes..... I wish I could call it mercy, as you put it.”

God’s lips curved.

“Why did you do this?”

The answer to this came out neatly.

“Because I have already judged that going there against your will is like punishment.”

“That’s.....”

I was speechless for a while.

“I cannot deny it.”

Even if the result was happy, not all the process was happy. I acknowledged this. Having said this, I turned my head and looked at Ricdorian.

“Of course I am happy now. I have no regrets about my choice.”

My partner who will be with me for a long time to come.

“I won’t regret it.”

The person who gave up everything without hesitation and chose me alone, and as a result, he was here.

Perhaps this is the only time when Ricdorian would spend the whole day alone with me like now.

“Now I am very happy.”

I raised my head and looked at the sky. It was a blue sky. The sky was a good thing. Because blue skies will exist in this world and the other world.

“I will be happier in the future.”

I didn’t see God, but a small voice flowed from God’s presence.

“I see.”

I didn’t know if God also felt emotions, regret and longing.

“It might be natural for the fragments of the dead God to follow the image of the God.”

It seemed that there was remorse at the incomprehensible words, but I closed my eyes and pretended not to hear it.

After a while, before returning to the residence, God asked me.

“What will you do with the child?”

Knowing who the ‘child’ God asked was, I smiled instead of answering.

“I have to go see him.”

“Ricdorian.”

Currently, Rickedoran is terribly spiky. *Spiky*, an expression that did not suit this man at all, but there was no other way to express it.

Hmmm, he’s pissed off? No, he’s sulky.

Of course, he was the only one in the other world to show such a reaction.....

“Is it because I didn’t go back right away?”

“Iana.....”

He stopped. Then he turned around and stretched out his arm to me. As soon as his strong arms wrapped around my waist, he buried his face into the nape of my neck.

A low, deep exhalation tickled my throat.

“Don’t go..... alright?”

It was a mournful voice, as if sending a lover to a foreign country. I smiled awkwardly and rubbed his hair gently.

Instead of refusing my touch, he buried himself even more.

“Um, I’m already back.”

I glanced at the store in front of me and said.

“And I have to go now. Okay? Ricdorian.”

Then Ricdorian let out a low sigh and slowly moved away from me.

However, his face was that of a person who never wanted to separate from me. Knowing why he acted like this, I let out a faint smile.

Soon after, Ricdorian kissed my lips.

“Quickly.”

“Yes. I’ll come out quickly.”

“Eight seconds…….”

“Okay, I will keep that too.”

Since it’s a promise, I whispered softly and this time raised my toes and kissed him.

The problem is, Ricdorian got hot here and didn’t just stop with a kiss. After patting him for letting me go, I entered the store in front of me.

It was a Saturday morning, but the interior was very quiet. It’s a natural thing. They won’t be doing business today. This was a small cafe. The cute yet antique interior is probably the taste of the person who manages this place.

I chose one of the seats where I could directly face the clerk, like the bar table, and sat down.

When I rested my chin and looked forward, I saw a person with his back turned in front of me. A long, slender silhouette, I’ve seen this back several times.

An apron over a neat shirt, and black pants with a good fit that matched the length of his legs. The man in a neat barista suit turned his back. Then he looked at me and opened his eyes wide. However, this soon turned into a smile as soft as milk.

“You’re here?”

He strode this way. The black hair that covers the forehead, underneath the wavy hair like a shadow, has black eyes instead of the symbolic red eyes.

However, the moment he captured me in it, it gradually turned red, as if sparks would rise. Soon, ruby-like red eyes looked at me.

It was Chaser.

Chapter 243.1: Epilogue (5)

1. Epilogue (5)

“Iana.”

A voice as sweet as sugar, I raised my eyes and moved without a single expression.

“A little late this time.”

“Because there is no set period.”

Chaser lowered his head and gave me a small smile.

“Right. There was no set period. It’s just that you come and energize me before my soul dries up.”

Saying that, he stretched out his hand. However, this hand was blocked by something and could not reach me.

It wasn’t something I did.

His hands, as if trapped in a translucent glass window, showed only his skin that was pressed against something. An indescribable expression passed over Chaser’s face. I closed my eyes pretending not to see it.

“Every time I look at you, it seems like coffee doesn’t go well with you.”

Originally, a soul that had lost its body would disappear quickly, but he was able to stay in this world by paying a price. He has to because he deserved it. After asking God, he came to the space God created and stayed there for a while. His short stay was enough to give him the strength to hold on.

“Because you liked it.”

His red eyes narrowed seductively.

“Me? I don’t like coffee.”

“Ah, you don’t remember now?”

He seemed to be mentioning the memories of me living in this world.
Because he took my past memories, he knows ‘me’ here.

No, only this man would know in this world.

“Well, even at Domulit, you used to drink a cup of tea all the time. I knew it was similar to coffee here.”

“Is it so?”

Chaser held out a cup. Steam flows from the cup.

“I have no regrets about anything else. But not even knowing you were approaching. This alone is a pity.”

He stretched out his arms. His hand was once again blocked by an invisible wall, but he stubbornly reached out to me as far as he could.

Like Chaser said, he doesn’t know when I’ll be here. It is because his senses are confined and limited here. In other words, he wouldn’t have known I was coming today.

This coffee was just hot.

“I think you just made it?”

“It’s not that hard to make it every hour.”

He tapped the cup. In front of him was a glass containing something like mine.

He gracefully sipped his cup.

“Expecting you to come is always a betrayal and yet joy.”

He made it again every time the coffee got cold. Not knowing when I will come.

I let out a small sigh.

It didn't fit him. A person who has been sitting on the throne all his life, is serving people in a world where everyone is equal. Apart from the fact that Ricdorian came over here, I can't help but feel this sense of separation. It's not sad or anything like that. However, I just think that he is a very contradictory man.

“How does it feel to be on the other side?”

Chaser looked down as I spoke.

Rattle-

A familiar sound came from there. Chaser just laughed at the chains and shackles around his ankles.

“Well, you don't know, but actually I wore this a lot when I was younger.”

“But you shackled me up?”

“Because that's the only way I know.”

Our gazes collided tightly. It was him that gently lowered his gaze.

“At the time, I thought this was the best way to keep you safe.”

“That's not all.”

“That's right, I wanted to get my hands on you.”

Except for the physical body, this man was the same as the Chaser Louve Domulit I knew. The way he curved up his red lips, even the red eyes that were said to have been killed but were still full of madness.

“Iana, do you regret choosing to save me?”

“No.”

The man who tried to take me out of the world that was perishing for me, the man who seemed like he would rather die for me, the man who shouted that even if the world perishes, I should return alive.

Even though it was a crooked obsession that no one else could have.

“You won’t be able to live the way you used to.”

I faced him straight.

“You won’t kill anyone.”

As contradictory as this man was, the feelings I had for him were also conflicting and contradictory. But I had no intention of loosening up.

“Pay back.”

Chaser already knew everything. Because I told him as soon as he opened his eyes. We will return to that world someday.

“Even if you save more than the number you killed.”

This man who has killed and tormented countless people can no longer kill anyone Because I made him pay for his sins with his own strength.

Yes. I won’t let him escape to death.

Chaser smiled, tilting his head loosely. His stoic figure, buttoned up to the end of his neck, was no different from that of the other world.

“That doesn’t mean the people I killed will come back alive.”

His hand pressed firmly against the wall. He looked like he was holding back something. I stared at him indifferently.

“Atonement.”

I did not think that by saying this, he would easily atone for his sins just like that.

“If you order.”

He had exerted so much strength that his fingers, pressed against the wall, turned white.

“As much as you want.”

If it was the life and memories of this place that I had sacrificed to keep this man alive, then this wall was the price this man had to pay. Chaser won't be able to reach me until all the sin is washed away. After I finished speaking, I got up from my seat without regret.

“Iana.”

The time of my stay has already been met. I won't be visiting this place until some time has passed.

That man and I knew this very well.

Ironically, the roses are tied to me. No, shackled. This man was no different.

In the end, even my relationship with this man became my responsibility. I didn't regret it though.

I slowly turned my back while holding the doorknob.

Chaser pressed against the wall with his fists clenched. With a face full of thirst, like a lone hunter who had wandered in the desert for ten days.

“Someday, someday! If I save countless people. At that time, Iana..... Can I reach you?”

I didn't answer. I left the store.

Chapter 243.2: Epilogue (5) [End of Main Story]

180. Epilogue (5)

“Iana!”

Ricdorian, who was leaning on a pillar and looking at the sky, turned his head and came running. There seemed to be a long tail wagging behind him as he ran.

No. If it really existed, I think it would be shaking rapidly like a propeller. Beside him, a real beast jumped up and down to greet me.

-Human! Late! You're late, Nyan!

Pudding is definitely a cat, but sometimes it behaves like a puppy. Is this what you call a dog-cat?

I smiled and held Pudding in one arm. Then I stretched out my hand towards Ricdorian.

“Shall we hold hands?”

His blue eyes blinked wide, then smiled broadly.

Maybe the reason I like the blue sky is because it resembles the eyes of my favorite person.

Ricdorian, who felt even more depressed on the days I was visiting Chaser, didn't ask me anything.

That's why I used to tell him the truth first.

"Um, Ricdorian. Sorry."

"Which one?"

"..... That, I don't think I could keep it at 8 seconds."

He told me not to make eye contact for more than 8 seconds, but I felt like I couldn't keep it. So I spoke frankly.

Ricdorian hesitated for a moment, but then he squeezed my hand tightly.

"It's all right."

He says it's okay with a face that's not okay, um..... I'm sorry to Ricdorian, but he gets angry if I say that he looks cute.

In fact, Ricdorian had gone in there with me once. After almost making a life-and-death decision, he ended up waiting in front of the door. At that time, I really thought that Chaser would die. Ricdorian is also injured that he lost consciousness halfway.

In the meantime, we entered an alleyway. The winter trees still looked bare, but I could see the white camellia flowers in full bloom between them.

White camellia, a fairly rare flower.

I stopped reflecting on the past and spoke.

"Maybe a long, long time will pass."

In fact, I'm still not sure if my choice was right or if I had done the right thing.

In everything.

I am not perfect like God. I am insecure. I might one day regret the choices I made. Even though we are in a finite bond like this, I think we will live

like this for a very long time.

“Will there ever be a day when I become dull with things?”

I didn't put the subject nor the object, but many things can be attached to it. For example, this burning love now. It's not that I don't feel insecure, so I was cautious about that question.

Ricdorian stopped walking. Behind him, a white camellia flower resembling his hair came into view. If it snowed here, it would be a very magnificent view.

Ricdorian smiled warmly.

“Iana, I once had this thought.”

I didn't ask what he had thought, but Ricdorian continued slowly.

“Your footsteps in the basement where I was, were always cautious. Like saying that you can leave anytime.”

His fingers dug between mine. He reached out and cupped my cheek with his other hand. White breath broke out like smoke.

“You said it was a relationship that would soon pass.”

Yes. I said something similar to this. Many times.

“But Iana, I always thought. If your cautious footsteps left a mark on my heart. I will never lose you in my life.”

He brought my hand to his lips.

“Should I kneel down in front of you and beg you to take me away?”

“.....”

“You could throw me away someday. If only I could stay by your side..... Until I die, I will chase after you without even stepping on a shadow.”

He lowered his eyes and smiled.

“That’s what I prayed for.”

When he slowly opened his eyes, the deep blue eyes were like the sea, then like the sky again, like a steady unchanging rock.

Why? Oddly enough, tears streamed down my cheeks.

Even though I was looking at this man whose eyes were like the color of the passing spring, I still miss him and love him. Like the season that will come back again, I love him so much.

“But being by your side at this moment, what would be scary and difficult? Now I just need to love you.”

He recited a warm, fiery confession with a red, flushed face.

“I love you. Maybe until the day my life ends. Forever.”

Ricdorian hesitated for a moment, then he looked around. It was an unusual behavior for him, who usually didn’t care about stares at all. While I tilted my head, he cleared his throat.

“I watched a program.”

“On TV.”

“Yes. There.”

Ricdorian slowly knelt down on one knee. I blinked wide. Blue skies, camellias, white hair, and a pure white smile. It was a picturesque landscape.

“..... sorry.”

“What?”

He apologized. The reason I couldn't bear it anymore was because of his loveliness.

"I was going to do it after returning to our world..... You say you would let me only then."

Oh, I think I know what he was going to say next. A happy smile flowed from my lips.

"Will you marry me?"

"....."

"I will make you happy for the rest of your life."

His voice trembled. It was a crude proposal for someone who had always said love. However, from the trembling eyes to the shaking eyes, the sincerity beams in every small part. I knew that this was his whole-hearted proposal.

"..... Oh my God. Are you serious? You couldn't take it back."

"What? Of, of course! Of course, there are many flowers in your garden, but....."

"I will love you."

"..... haha, yes I want to have a little bit of that kind of confidence."

I reached out my hand and placed it on Ricdorian's cheek. Then his eyes blinked several times. Showing he was very happy.

Suddenly, I felt that my fingers were itchy. When I slowly lowered my head, a bright red flower resembling him was blooming on my finger. Very small. Small enough to occupy only the fourth finger, but very covetous.

".....Is it a flower?"

"Yes. I want you to give this finger to me from now on."

“..... Really, you’re very sly.”

We will live for many years to come.

Yet I thought. During my long life, this moment will be framed in gold and hung in my heart forever.

“But it’s romantic.”

I laughed

“I’m so happy that I wish I could stop time.....”

At the end of our story, out of prison, we lived happily ever after, although it will be full of countless stories to follow.

I know now

Written on each page would be ‘happiness’.

“My rose.”

I approached him and pulled him up and hugged him tightly. Holding the one and only ring in the world that has blossomed on my finger precious.

“Will it be like this when we go back? I hope we can be a happy couple.”

As he says, there are many roses in my garden, but I want him to be the closest. I shyly confessed all my heart for the first time.

The wind blows and the camellia petals fall. On his shoulder, on his head, and over the hands that we linked.

“I will love you more than this moment.”

I wished that at this moment the red roses were in full bloom in the garden.

But it didn’t have to be.

“I love you.”

Because there was a rose in front of me that would bloom forever, only for me.

we have reached the end of the main story~

but don't worry we will begin with the after story soon!

so what do you guys think of the 'end'? it borders between closure and also not-closure?? haha.

i haven't read much about the after story but it's about iana's life while she awaits the time to go back to the other roses!

so stay tuned~!

Chapter 244: White Rose Waltz (1)

1. White Rose Waltz (1)

The Empire was a very wealthy and strong country. A place that does not invade, but also does not allow invasion. In the eyes of the surrounding countries, it was truly an invincible country.

What happened to those that had been aiming for this place for a long time? Like an ant that crawled on a tree it couldn't climb, they fell into a swamp of miserable defeat.

However, when historians looked back and recorded it, what was suspicious was a surprising number of victories.

To be precise, a record of victory due to natural disasters.

Strangely, during the invasions the Empire received, there was not a crisis that they were on the defensive.

In every era, great sages made wise decisions, but miraculously, there were many victories that included nature.

For example, floods and droughts in enemy camps, untimely earthquakes and flooding of rivers. Victory, from nature, as if heaven helped the empire.

With this, people called the empire a country where God helped. As the status of the name increased, various religions naturally entered the empire, but they did not become very popular.

It was because there was already a divine being that the people of the ancient empire believed in and followed.

However, as time passed, this existence disappeared hidden somewhere in the back of history, and the Sun Bridge and the Foundation of Light, which came from other countries, took its place.

Now, most of the Empire's people have not remembered the one existence their ancestors followed in ancient times.

It has been said that God is determined according to the faith of the believer. The boundless fall has reached it and it has fallen to an existence that has just collapsed a long time ago.

“What a joke.”

Sitting on the throne, she closed the book.

The woman crossed her legs and lazily swept her hair. The woman's long hair was as bright and brilliant as the sun.

But as she clicked her tongue, her face was full of disapproval. Even so, the woman was so beautiful that no one could take their eyes off her.

Those who looked at her did not dare to meet her eyes.

The woman's eyes of different colors blinked calmly.

“I'm going to burn this stupid book.”

Francia lifted the thick book lightly and tossed it to the floor. *Thud*. A heavy sound rang out, but none of the topless paladins paid any attention.

Francia crossed her legs while sitting on the throne.

“Burn it.”

Someone quickly lowered their head. That is to say, they will not speak of this book ever.

As of today, this history book, which is precise enough to be used as a textbook in educational institutions, will disappear from history.

The one who occupied the throne in front of them was the one who held such power.

The throne.

This refers to the seat of the highest. The only person in the empire who could use it.

However, it was different now. A different authority than the imperial family, she is the one and only king of this huge Foundation of Light.

The temple's sun. She was 'the Pope'.

However, the look on Francia's face after taking her seat of power was nothing short of boredom. She was tainted with terrible boredom.

Everyone in the entourage knew. The young pope, who was once a saint and the leader of the war, has not only helped the Foundation of Light to regain its former splendor over the past seven years. But has led it to enjoy more power.

That their absolute, who took off her shell and took the place of ruler, rarely smiled.

In fact, an elderly bishop called on clowns from all over the country to long for her benevolent laugh.

As a result, he would be leading a lonely temple in a rural area by now.

"I'm curious."

Everyone tensed up and listened closely to Francia's words.

"What happened to my instructions?"

At the low pitched voice, the person closest to her stepped forward.

He once served the pope in disguise, no, the now saint. He was a high-ranking priest who had returned to the position of the second-in-command

of the temple.

He was weak as a child of light, but had a sparkling appearance. He could jump into a cliff without hesitation at Francia's words.

"What you instructed three years ago..... We are now at an intermediate stage."

"What do you mean?"

"Yes. The capital city and surrounding areas. Furthermore, not only has it safely settled in large cities, but the ripple effect is increasing day by day."

The priest raised his large glasses. Francia looked at his glasses and clicked his tongue at the face that came to mind. It's not a very welcome face, but she couldn't help but think of him out of reflex.

"This is the responsibility of the Foundation of Light's branches located throughout the empire, and is spreading to the public at the risk of life and death. The final step is soon. In other words, it would take much less time to spread to the end of the empire than it did at the beginning.....you can look forward to it."

After the priest reported, he looked down at the floor for a while. He couldn't see Francia's face, so he didn't know her reaction either.

He was anxious on the inside.

"That's right."

Francia nudged her chin. Then she stopped wriggling her hand.

<Don't keep poking your fingers. What if you get hurt?>

A nonchalant but friendly voice passes by her ear. It was a remnant of her longing.

<Your cheeks are so white and pretty.>

No, it wasn't. During the day when she said that, Francia's body was full of wounds, and her wounds healed slowly due to her weak strength.

<It's okay if you're not clean. Even if there are more scars on your face. You will look cute to me.>

Francia would have been disgusting. Even so, that smile always seemed calm.

<Francia.>

That little warmth would have been her salvation, 'she' would never have known that.

Francia's mind suddenly returned to a time long ago.

<Brother wants me to learn to dance. It's waltz. Useless.>

She used to dominate her eyes and ears like this when she closed her eyes, a figure that mysteriously never appeared in her dreams.

<Francia, can you dance?>

The time when Francia was temporarily held captive in Domulit Mansion. The days when Iana was the only one on her side there. There was a time when she didn't know that Iana was her king.

<Hmm, among the songs I know, there's a song called 'Puppy Waltz'. That's exactly like you.>

It was a day when Iana, who was not particularly smiling, smiled a lot.

So Francia did her best with clumsy feet, which she learned for the first time in her life. She hoped her sister would smile one more time.

It was also the day when the word *waltz*, which was no big deal, was carved deep into her lungs.

“Doing well?”

Francia asked in a trembling voice. However, this tremor was so small that no one in this place even noticed.

Alas, she was living with a very thick mask now. She waited patiently for a hand to remove this mask.

“Yes. At least in large cities and small and medium-sized cities where people gather, there will be no one who doesn’t know about it.”

The high-ranking priest in front of her, Francia’s right-hand man and closest aide spoke in a clear voice.

“The only god enshrined since ancient times. ‘Blue Rose’. No one regards the noble being as insignificant anymore, Your Holiness.”

“..... What about the village of the Blue Rose?”

“Reconstruction is going well. Residents are also doing their best to help reconstruction. The forest has already been cut down to make a road. As planned, three more years and it will be a great city.”

She thought she was about to shed tears as she heard what she had done and accomplished for seven years.

But she didn’t cry. No. She couldn’t cry unless there was someone who could take her tears.

‘Sister.....’

Everyone, go.

At Francia’s firm command, everyone disappeared from the altar. All that was left was her sitting alone on the throne.

“..... Sister, are you watching?”

She murmured the call in a low voice that would not be heard. Even if she calls like this. She knows that no matter how desperately she calls, the call goes unheard.

Only 7 years have passed.

During the long wait she had to wait, *only* 7 years.

The child cried. Francia, the child in her heart who couldn't grow, wept bitterly for her sister to come back.

However, there was no movement on the young pope's face, who knew the authority on the throne and wielded the sweetness of power.

Seven years ago, after everything was over, the Empress came to her senses and saw Iana. However, the Empress could not find the Blue Rose that finally granted her wish.

That was a given. Because she wasn't in this world.

Perhaps to compensate for this, the Empress showed generous treatment to the roses. Yes. It was a reward. Gratitude for the existence that fulfilled her lifelong longing.

Thanks to this, the Foundation of Light, led by Francia, was able to freely expand the church unlike the past, which was often controlled by the Emperor. The Empress turned a blind eye to Francia's plan to advocate a new god.

No, the Empress did not hesitate to encourage it.

In addition to that, the fact that Hernim and Domulit, who had each lost their heads, did not collapse was also due to the Empress' mercy.

Francia also did not touch Domulit. She didn't hear from Iana what to do with that family.

The punishment is by the king she obeys.

Francia blinked her eyes slowly.

“..... I miss you.”

How many times has she mumbled this in 7 years? Francia didn't know anymore. Because the days are too long to count.

Among the roses, the one with the most vitality was the Red Rose.

“Sister, do you like my present?”

However, among the roses, the longest blooming rose was the White Rose.

“Sister..... My god.”

Because she has to survive longer than anyone else and live while healing the one and only existence.

“No one will ever forget Sister.”

Francia's voice faded as if swallowed inside.

“..... All the people will remember Sister.”

Francia squeezed her hand and then opened it.

“I want you to think of me.”

The little child living in her heart cried out loud. Before she knew it, the baby bear escaped from her body and grabbed Francia by the leg.

Callisto was anxious.

“It's alright.”

Francis bowed her head and smiled.

“From now on, I will be alright.”

It was like a mantra she uttered to herself.

After saying that, Francia raised her head. She stared at the dark space between the pillars, where the light was not vivid.

“What are you doing there?”

Unlike the dignified voice in front of the paladins a while ago, a comfortable but hoarse voice came out.

Someone walks quietly in the darkness where it seemed that no one would be there.

It was a walk that went well with his calm appearance. His quiet appearance like a shadow was rather like an assassin's attempt, but in reality he was a strikingly beautiful young man.

However, the gaze trapped in his glasses was indeed sharp, like a forged knife.

At the same time as Iana left, the man started wearing glasses again. However, the reason seemed different from before. Because he seemed to have locked himself up behind it.

Francia just stared at his appearance, which had not changed at all compared to seven years ago.

“Is trespassing your hobby?”

“Either trespassing or infiltration. You know very well that either is not difficult for me, right?”

Francia glanced at the rose who had the same situation as her.

“Why aren't you old? I feel bad.”

“Who are you to talk? You are in the same situation.”

They already knew. With the departure of their king, their time has stopped.

“I mean, even if I don't show old age, I'm in a position that was considered sacred. Would you be uncomfortable living with that face?”

“Even if that’s not the case, I heard rumors that I bathe in the blood of criminals in prison. Is it your doing?”

“No? Why would I do useless things?”

He had a neat face today. What’s good about that neat look, what makes him so popular.

She remembered clearly the image of Lenag surrounded by the ladies at the imperial banquet a few months ago. Of course, along with his image of leaving without even giving a glance.

In the social world, Lenag was a heart-breaking marquis, longing for his missing fiancée and was alone for a long time.

Indeed, that statement was true, but for Francia that was not even funny.

“Has it been once or twice that you have spread false rumors?”

Chapter 245: White Rose Waltz (2)

2. White Rose Waltz (2)

“Ah, I have to greet those who are in the same situation. I greet you. Are you a eunuch or did you have a foul smell? Because of that rumor, didn’t the beautiful ladies who courted you disappear?”

Francia shrugged his shoulders.

“But I’m not the one who spread the rumor you just said.”

Lenag raised his eyebrows slightly.

“Are you pretending not to be?”

“Oh my goodness. Look at this face. Is it a lying face? Huh?”

Lenag didn’t even budge. Francia clicked her tongue.

Francia sometimes envied and hated that rose that had endured the years as if nothing had happened.

She doesn’t know what this man is hiding in that shell. But who cares?

Francia took the posture as if ‘I did well right’. So what was there to do now? Her attitude clearly reveals her will.

Lenag was already familiar with it as well.

“Did you come to pick up a fight? if you want a fight Callisto will deal with you.”

Then the baby bear looked puzzled. However, Callisto soon faced Lenag too with its small fists and a determined look.

Lenag only responded with a slightly pathetic face.

“That provocation is not funny. I won’t be able to compete with your guardian deity.”

“Oh, look at that? Are you ignoring me now? How strong is my guardian deity?”

“Are you the only one with a guardian deity?”

“What’s wrong with you.”

Francia grinned, resting her chin with her hand on the handle of the throne.

“The bear tore the snake.”

“..... Sometimes you say things like an unintelligible joke, but do you know that, let alone looking dignified, you are looking down on dignity?”

Lenag raised his gaze with cold eyes.

“Huh, only people are funny.”

“I heard you hit some administrative officials with that tongue? They just gnashed their teeth saying they had to put you in Kambrakam”

Francia raised her palm. Lenag stopped at a reasonably close distance.

The distance between the two remaining roses has always been maintained this way for 7 years. They weren’t friends, but they weren’t enemies either.

He was a comrade. A comrade to endure the unknown time.

“So why are you here?”

Lenag made a really strange look.

“Are you asking because you really don’t know?”

Except for another person, it was the maximum change that a man without an expression could make.

“Isn’t today the day to send the ‘letter’?”

“Ah really?”

Francia jumped up from her seat. Mysteriously, her expression, which had withered from boredom, blossomed like a newly blooming blade of grass.

Lenag accepted this without much surprise.

“Why are you pretending to be surprised?”

“It should be like this, more dramatic.”

Of course, Francia couldn’t forget this day. It was a day she would never forget, even if she pretended to forget it.

A letter, the only connection to Iana’s world.

Occasionally Francia wanted to stick her head through the hole that opened every time. It would be the same for the man in front of her.

If the hole hadn’t been small enough for a cat’s head to barely fit, she might have tried with courage.

If she could see Iana, it would be worth risking her life at least 10 times.

In fact, it was only at first that the order of whose letter would be sent first was decided, but over the course of 7 years, the order has long since faded.

Soon the cracks in space will be torn apart. And they’ll only see a small hole like a mailbox.

Francia’s expression, which quietly waited for the time, gradually blurred. This was the first time in 7 years, which is not short.

“You know, Yellow Rose.”

Lenag calmly moved his cold gaze.

“Are you..... Are you really okay?”

Why? It’s okay if she perseveres today. Oddly enough, Francia found it unbearably hard.

It’s just a day no different than any other day.

“The days of waiting for countless long days with these letters without promise like this again.....”

Are you really okay? She asked a comrade walking the same road.

Lenag’s expression didn’t collapse like Francia’s.

Francia, who had seen him for a long time, was not fooled by his outward appearance. She already knows that it is not a short time.

That man had collapsed from within.

Like the last day when he didn’t show a single pain in front of his love, even though his insides would rot.

“..... It’s useless to look back. There is no need to dwell on it.”

“Is this feeling captured by reason? Can it be captured?”

“.....”

“I don’t think so.”

“Nevertheless. You have to capture it.”

Don’t you think so too? The man’s voice seemed to be telling Francia why she was thinking stupid things.

“No, Yellow Rose. I.....”

The young pope, who had taken the throne, collapsed in longing.

“..... As for today..... I can’t stand it.”

It was the tears she had been holding back. It was too wasteful to shed it here, and it hurt her pride.

However, the longing that was finally filled up to the brim dripped down her cheeks like a shower.

“Do you think I am stupid?”

“.....”

“Is my longing foolish?”

Lenag let out a deep breath.

“Whether you collapse outside or inside, it’s the same collapse. Why are you asking something useless?”

Lenag’s voice became ferocious. No matter how quietly it hid its existence like a shadow, the nature of the snake was that of a beast.

“Francia Orr Rosenia. You know everything, don’t ask.”

Lenag’s golden eyes were sharper than ever.

“If you or I lose our temper and wield power, this empire will quickly become a crucible of chaos.”

What they built for 7 years was a huge tower of power.

“So? Do you want to mess with the land on which our king will one day return?”

Francia smiled brightly, holding back her tears.

“Ah, that’s good.”

That looks good. She whispered in a graceful voice.

“I didn’t want to be the only one broken.”

She has a bad character. She was mean and selfish. However, even she had sympathy and compassion to pass on to her comrade who was rotting away inside just like her.

In Francia’s eyes, Lenag was more dangerous than herself.

“I heard that the hand that is catching criminals is getting more and more brutal. Just admit it now. I’m not the only one who is broken.”

“..... to admit that. Why would it matter?”

Lenag showed calm anger through his eyeglasses. He was a man with a quiet light even in his anger.

“I mean, at least express it.”

Foolish Yellow Rose. Francia smiled elegantly.

“An active volcano erupts up and rests. A mountain that blocks the entrance will only destroy itself.”

Mismatched eyes met tightly. They were comrades, but that doesn’t mean they could be friends for the rest of their lives.

If they had to express it, they were more like bad friends who will not be on good terms for the rest of their lives.

At the same time, the space shook. This was a familiar vibration to both Francia and Lenag.

Soon the space will be torn apart and a small hole will be pierced. And if they put a letter prepared in advance there, the small communication will end with that.

Separate with that man, and they won't see each other again for a while.

In fact, years ago, the two were unintentionally embroiled in the scandal of the century, but they cleverly exposed their relationship to everyone by not knowingly handling the rumors.

So they wouldn't be able to see each other until the gap opened again.

'How long will it take next time?'

Francia grabbed her face. If only she could see that person's face just once.

"..... If I live like this, I might die of thirst."

Francia thought those words were the same as her feelings. After saying this, Lenag's face was also full of sorrow.

A very long journey, when he sees the journey they will walk in the future.

That man used to make a face like that only when he thought of one person.

Francia let out a small sigh. In the midst of the silent silence, only Lenag murmured softly.

"Iana."

Lenag muttered into the air. Occasionally he would be lost in his own world and show this.

"..... This is the day I especially miss you."

Miss Iana, the longing voice seemed to have been branded in his heart. For he clung to his chest like a man who had vomited blood.

Francia didn't want to see the open hole again.

That's when she lowered her eyes and held out only her hand with the letter towards the opening.

‘..... Why isn’t it swallowed?’

Pat. A strange sound came. It was the sound of the letter leaving Francia’s hand falling to the floor.

There was no way this would happen. When the hole opens, of course it would swallow the letter.

“Oh, what is it? Are you giving it to me without looking at me?”

It was a voice she had missed. Francia froze with her head turned.

She thought it was just an illusion. No. This must be an illusion.

When she looked up, she could see Lenag’s face staring at one spot.

“I came to receive the letter myself this time.”

A voice that she really misses and long for, a figure she drew even in her dreams but never appeared.

Francia’s face turned slowly.

“Actually, I wanted to see my roses rather than the letter.”

There was a face that didn’t change at all from when they parted. Wearing clothes she had never seen before.

The nonchalantly kind smile awakened the child Francia when she first met her.

“..... sister?”

“Miss Iana.....”

Iana affectionately gazed at her two roses that were in tears.

“Yes. I’m sorry.”

With a broad smile, as if marking the end of a long and sharp longing.

“Did it take too long?”

She greeted them as if they had met yesterday.

Lenag was one step ahead of Francia. His arms trembled as he ran and he wrapped Iana in one arm.

There were streams of tears running across his cold, relentless face.

Francia understood those feelings well. Even if she was a lost parent who had spent years searching for her child, these feelings could not compare. Because even at this moment with her eyes open, she couldn't believe it.

No, her body didn't move.

“Francia.”

However, at one call, Francia moved automatically.

She ran. For this moment, she didn't need the power she'd been building all her life, her throne, or her spot. She could throw it away, she thought.

“Sister? Sister..... Sister! Really really. Sister?”

“..... yes.”

Francia finally fell into the arms of the king she had finally reclaimed and cried like a child. For a long, long time.

“Sorry. I'm really sorry..... I can't even take you.”

Iana's voice became small, tinged with pain and pity.

“I wanted to see your face.I didn't know that making a deal with God would take this long.”

As if she had found her place, her entire heart was directed toward one thing.

If this is the fate, it was the fate that Francia chose herself.

“Francia, Lenag.”

The friendly voice.

“Do you want to go to my house?”

And then, without hesitation, Francia took the outstretched hand.

The passing season was spring.

Ah, spring with pink leaves flowing down one by one, as if the petals were dancing a waltz with joy and happiness.

What about Francia? She had an idea a long time ago that she wanted to dance her clumsy feet with her sister.

She wonders if she was now in this spring landscape where the pink flowers are playing, the whole world will be dyed in Iana’s color.

“Francia, this way!”

“Yes!”

She thought as she ran.

Sister probably doesn’t know how much I like Sister.

My one and only God.

The thing that the pure white rose embraces with reverence. A reverence that only looks up at the sky.

This blind affection, tightly bound like a pure white pillar, would last till death.

Chapter 246: Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (1)

1. Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (1)

—One year before Francia and Renag crossed over to Earth.

“I don’t think this is right.”

Currently, I was standing in front of the table, frowning with my chin clenched.

I could feel my guardian deity Whistle and Pudding, who had been taken out, secretly watching me.

I continued to stare at the table, not paying attention to the little animals.

But there was nothing on the table I was looking at. What I was worried about was not on the table, but actually on my body.

“I don’t think this is right.....”

Currently, I have a long one-piece dress that falls to my size on my body.

I turned round and round. The skirt hem, which came down to my ankles, gently brushed my calves and swayed.

“What’s wrong, Iana?”

Ricdorian sat on the chair on the other side of the table and tilted his head.

His eyes were full of questions.

“It suits you well.”

It was. The white and purple one-piece suit was not only appropriate for going out, but also matched well with me.

“There is nothing that doesn’t suit me, Ricdorian.”

“It is.”

..... It was a joke, but I paused for a moment when I saw him respond quickly.

“Rian, at times like this, weren’t you supposed to give my overconfidence a hard time?

“But it is true.”

“If you keep praising me like that, my confidence skyrockets.”

I shook my head indifferently. Ricdorian smiled brightly.

Then he suddenly leaned his head lazily on the post of the chair and pursed his lips.

“I don’t want to lie, Iana. And..... you just called me by my nickname.”

I looked carefully at my dress and looked up.

“Do you still like it that much?”

His eyes were deeply curved as if they were about to close.

“Yes.”

I clicked my tongue inwardly. If I knew he would like it this much, I would have used it years ago, no, since I was in that world.

It’s already been 6 years since I stayed here. It was by chance, three years ago, that I started calling my partner by a nickname

The name 'Ricdorian' was a name that was not often used abroad. As a result, when I called his name, it felt attention-grabbing.

Without that, he has a striking appearance, so I just used the end of the name as a last resort.....

'I didn't expect him to like it this much.'

Come to think of it, even in the other world, it seemed that long names were shortened in their own way.

Mostly between friends, family and relatives.

I inadvertently recalled that Jaire was called Jer by his parents in the past, and I think I did a good job of making Ricdorian's nickname.

Rather than liking the name itself, Ricdorian seemed to be happy that I came up with a name that only I could call.

"Rose."

My name was called in the neat and beautiful face, like it was carefully crafted by God.

He said he wanted a name that only he could call, so it became a name he started calling.

In addition, fearing it would wear out the more he called it, he even limited the number of times he used it in a day.

'Where does this kind of desperation come from?'

I smiled at him, as Ricdorian had done, then turned my eyes back to my clothes.

"Yes. My Rian."

I pointed to the clothes.

“Will you stop and listen to my concerns? What should I do with this?”

Ricdorian’s gaze followed my fingers as I spoke, but as expected, he looked as if he didn’t know what was wrong.

“..... I’m not sure, Iana. You got it as a gift, right? Can’t you just take it?”

“Ugh..... I would like a normal gift.”

I sighed deeply as I held onto my clothes.

“It’s too expensive to receive this. It was given to me by the lady next door.”

I was surprised when I saw the logo on the inside of the clothes without thinking. I knew this town wasn’t that ordinary, but.....

The family next door, especially the aunt and daughter, liked me very much.

I’m grateful that she treats me like a daughter or a sister, but sometimes I was worried because she gave me a gift that I would struggle to know what to do with. Just like now.

“Uh..... Can’t you just take it?”

Ricdorian blinked when he heard the amount.

This former Grand Duke used to show innocent eyes ‘what’s wrong with that?’ no matter what amount comes out.

He’s a smart person, so it’s not like he couldn’t exchange it with the money over there.

I wonder if it’s fortunate that he was not tainted by this place’s capitalism, no, don’t be stained.....

‘This man, if he was born here, he would have tried to give me a building.’

I let out a sigh as I pondered.

The youngest next door, who was a high school student when we first met, was an adult who had graduated from college.

Since she was taking a leave of absence, it seems that her graduation was quite late. She went to university in the same city, so we've known each other for a long time, so I grew quite attached.

Rather, the more I look at her, the more I think that she was Francia-like, yet different too. The selfish and lively side is cute.

I erased my bright face and sat down in a chair. I said it like a complaint, but I knew I couldn't give it back anyway.

Maybe it was because I was unintentionally separated from my family, and was particularly weak towards adult mothers with children.

"It really suits Iana."

As soon as I sat down, Ricdorian came over and sat down on one knee in front of me.

Then, the face that looked up at me was like a loyal beast. I sighed and let out a smile.

"I heard that I look good with anything?"

"Yes."

"Then, which part of this suits me so well? Anything you like about it?"

I asked with a teasing tone, and for some reason, he looked serious and fell into trouble. It's not a question I asked him to seriously think about.

"Ah, I get it."

Ricdorian smiled with his eyes curved beautifully. Then his cautious hand grabbed my ankle.

"Can I have a moment, Iana?"

“What? Uh, well yes.”

In the meantime, he put one of my ankles on his shoulder. His face dug between my naturally raised legs.

“Rian?”

I can feel the damp exhalation through my thighs. He touched my skin with his fingers and pressed hard on a spot.

“Huuhh.....”

It was none other than the place where the red rose pattern was engraved. He put his lips on it for a while, biting and licking it, then slowly revealed his face.

With half of his hair wrapped around my long skirt, he smiled brightly.

“I think I like this the most, Iana.”

Ricdorian tilted his head loosely, wiping his luscious lips with his thumb.

Unknowingly, I grabbed his cheek.

“..... I don’t think your personality has changed.”

“What?”

I grabbed his cheek and turned it around. He blinked for a moment, then smiled seductively. As if he knew my heart.

Ricdorian raised his upper body. His strong arms gripped the back of the chair, and before I knew it, I was trapped in his large body.

“Do you like that too, Iana?”

“No..... I’ll be happy if it’s you..... no matter what.”

“Even if I’m a little rougher and more ferocious?”

“I do but. You’re not going to do that, aren’t you?”

“If you wish.”

His lips came close enough to touch. His eyes were already gone. I laughed as I looked into the love-struck eyes.

How can a single day not change in six long years?

As I slowly closed my eyes.

Ring-ring.

The obnoxious bell rang through the house. I quickly ignored the sound coming from the living room and tried to grab Ricdorian’s clothes.

“Iana.”

“..... Ignore it.”

Ring-ring.

However, I grabbed my forehead at the sound that resonated loudly wanting to announce its presence.

“Ah, for goodness sake!”

I pushed away Ricdorian and jumped up. To calm me down, he rubbed my shoulders and went to the living room himself.

Returning back, Ricdorian had a small note in his hand.

“Rian, don’t bring that. Throw it away.”

“But Iana, you need it, right?”

I groaned and covered my face with my hands.

“Remember how much we struggled with that. That God is actually not a God, but an evil God?”

“That.....”

Ricdorian lost his words as if he couldn't deny it.

“But Iana's wishes depend on it.”

“That's right..... No, God wants too many things to wish to see my roses in person.”

It was.

Going up to the origin of that note, it was from the day of the fifth year that I missed Francia and Renag so much that I couldn't stand it and asked God if there was any way.

He rubbed his chin for some reason, when he seemed to be stubbornly saying no. Then, he let out vague words that he would consider it if I would do his 'request'.

Both me and Ricdorian knew that 'request' was no different from an order.

And the request I received over the next year or so was honestly not something I could do with my sober mind.

Anyway, I omitted the detailed explanation and put on a disgusted face.

“Why do we have to bridge the rift between dimensions?”

“Ugh. It's an area that God can't touch..... I don't understand, Iana.”

“We went to a different place last time and had a hard time, didn't we? If it wasn't for the person who helped us then, it would have been dangerous. God said so.”

While carrying out God's first request, both me and Ricdorian almost suffered a major disaster.

On the other side of the dimension we met an emperor of some kind of empire by chance? He said that he, like me, had crossed a dimension.

If we hadn't met him, we would never have come back.

It's creepy when I think about it now.

It's a fact I didn't know before, but this world I'm in right now is like a plaza that serves as a connection to multiple dimensions.

Somehow, I heard that there are so many novels with the storyline of going to another dimension.

"Ugh, it's true that I want to see everyone, but..... It's really hard."

God promised.

If I do the first and second requests, he'll let me meet Francia and Renag in person.

If I do the third favor..... he'll shorten the time I stay here.

Whatever the circumstances, I had no choice.

As much as I love Ricdorian, my feelings of sorry and longing grew together.

"Shall we open it?"

I opened the note with a deep sigh

At that moment, Ricdorian and my expressions hardened in sync.

"Rose, isn't this God a pervert?"

Chapter 247: Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (2)

1. Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (2)

I thought there was a point in what Ricdorian said. That would be the case, because the note sent by God contained something absurd even when I thought about it.

‘Pervert..... Mmm, indeed.’

I guess we can call it that.

The expression used by Ricdorian was not used in the commonly used sense of ‘having a perverted dysphoria’.

Is it so strange that there is no other choice but to express it like this. It’s a vulgar word, is it?.

“Ricdorian, what was the first thing we did?”

I asked one more time even though we had already talked about it a while ago. Of course, I didn’t ask because I didn’t know, but it was to reveal this absurdity more effectively.

“..... It was about filling the dimensional rift, right?”

“That’s right. How much did we suffer for it? In fact, it was because God didn’t tell us properly! We found out later that it was an unnecessary hardship, right?”

Ricdorian and I belonged to a special case. First of all, Ricdorian was not the soul of this world.

In my case, I was born in this world, but I stayed in the world where Lenag and Francia were, and unintentionally became deeply involved with the roses and the fate of the other side, so as a result, I became a soul that was neither one nor the other.

I don't know what this state is called, but God said I was a soul that couldn't belong to either side right now.

That would be correct.

Anyway, since neither of us are souls belonging to this world, we are less affected by the world.

From the perspective of the manager of this side of the world, we are no different from illegal aliens, or that we are staying thanks to negotiations with God from the other side.

First of all, I had an obligation to stay here for the rest of my life.

The manager of this side of the world seems to have asked for a few things as a price for Ricdorian and Chaser staying here, and it seems that it coincides with God's request to us.

God's interest must have been consistent right? As a result, we kept going round and round.

That was the first request. We soldered the barriers between dimensions that God couldn't touch with the things handed over to us and our power.

"Yes. Although I asked God first....."

I miss Francia and Lenag. This feeling was truly sincere. But I can't get rid of the feeling that God sees us as free labor.

"What is it, a soul? Return the soul. What kind of illegal alien collectors are we?"

Unable to hold back my anger, I knocked on the table, and the note fell to the floor instead of fluttering around.

Pudding, who was waiting on the floor, jumped up and touched it with its forepaw.

“Pudding, don’t touch it. Dirty.”

– Nyan! I feel a strange power, human!

“I guess so.”

God sent it, so it must be so. I looked at the contents filled with cursive writing with a cold expression.

The more I looked at it, the more the ridiculous content filled my eyes.

[Return souls from another world (0/10)]

10? TEN? There is the content, but the number written there made me dumbfounded even more.

God must have thought of us as a free manpower that he really utilized to the fullest.

“Iana.....”

Starting with a handsome man, to a small snow leopard sitting calmly on the ground and the calm eyes of a small whale floating in the air.

Three pairs of eyes focused on me. They are truly pure and blind eyes that have not changed for a long time.

To be precise, they’re waiting for my decision. After much thought, I sighed.

It was impossible to reject anyway.

I picked up the note and crumpled it in my hand. My anger calmed down before I knew it and I stared at my hand with a calm, nonchalant expression.

..... Even so, I will never forget it.

“Fine. Let’s do it.”

It’s been 6 years since I came here with Ricdorian. There are a lot of differences between this world and the world where Francia and Lenag are, but if there is one that stands out in particular, it will be the caste system.

Second, to the people of this world, Ricdorian and I are very special people.

It wasn’t just about the looks.

Even if I, like the people in the neighborhood, had dark hair and dark eyes, Ricdorian stood out quite a bit.

In addition, he was a pretty, neat, and beautiful handsome man that ordinary people couldn’t even fathom.

This isn’t a farce, it’s the truth. No one can deny it.

As I said, there was one thing that was different, not just in looks.

“Sister? You must be going out!”

A welcome voice greeted us when I left the gate with Ricdorian.

When I turned my head, I saw the student next door wearing comfortable clothes. She’s not a student anymore. The youngest daughter next door was waving her hand.

“It’s been a while!”

The youngest daughter next door said that she had just become a freshman.

She's always so bright. She seemed to have no worries or wrinkles, and I would smile just by looking at her.

“Yes, Jia. It's the weekend, aren't you going somewhere to play?”

“I've been busy all week, so I have to take a break on the weekend. Sister..... ugh It's hard to eat and live.”

Earning money isn't easy, she shook her head.

“Come to think of it, my brother asked if Sister was doing well.”

“Oh really?”

Having lived next door for six years, it was true that we became close to the family from that house, almost like relatives.

“Yes! It's been a while since he's seen your face.....”

“Are you done?”

I felt a solid arm wrapped around my waist, and then a face suddenly came out over my shoulder.

Glancing at Ricdorian, he had a blue chill wrapped around his face, just like he did when he was the Grand Duke before.

..... he's upset.

However, the youngest daughter next door rather not noticed.

“Oh, hello, Brother! What I am saying is that, Sister, my Brother said he wants to....”

“Wants to see?”

However, when Ricdorian's expression turned cold, she did not fail to recognize this.

I hurriedly walked over to Ricdorian's side and covered him with my sleeve.

“Uwaah, Sister!”

“Ahahaha..... sorry. Because our house's child is very shy.”

I had been hiding his face for six years already, but I didn't bother pointing it out.

For some reason, Ricdorian hated the next-door son very much, and this reason was not something I would have guessed. So instead of pointing it out, I would sneak him over like this.

Fortunately, the youngest daughter next door quickly moved on.

“So Sister, where are you going today? A date?”

“Date..... Um, maybe?”

Well, it is a date. Just the purpose will not be sweet.

“I think Sister and Brother seem to be dating and living together for a long time. You look good!”

The aunt next door used to ask, insinuating if me and Ricdorian were not married. We can't get married here, so we'll just stay a little while longer, I said.

“..... look good?”

Ricdorian relaxed his expression and asked. Jia quickly nodded.

“Yes. Very. My mom asks why not get married when you're so close, but I have a different opinion.”

She clenched her fists and said.

“There are times when just being by the side is good. It’s thrilling and heartbreaking enough. If that’s the case, why does it matter if there’s an engagement?”

“Engagement?”

I tilted my head at the unfamiliar word. Isn’t it usually called marriage?

In that world, it seemed that engagements and marriage were used a lot. I miss the other world again.

“Engagement..... marriage.....”

Ricdorian seemed to be muttering with a pensive expression for some reason.

“You sound like you’ve been in love before?”

“Am I? No? I’ve never tried it. Sister.”

It was because of Sister and Brother, she said with tears in her eyes.

I smiled at her.

“Why? I think you must be popular.”

“Not really. Not only am I not popular, but you know that popularity is not just being popular with people who are not, right?”

“Hmm. I think there’s definitely another kind of popularity.”

“What?”

I said it was nothing and shook my head gently.

At the same time, the hand on my shoulder didn’t stop, which the youngest daughter next door probably couldn’t see.

The bluish light that leaked faintly seeped into my hand.

“Sister, have a good trip!”

After parting ways with the youngest daughter next door and walking for a long time, when we passed through an alley, Ricdorian finally spoke.

“Iana, did you clean it up? Again.”

“Um, yes. Well. Yes.”

The blue light was still clinging to my fingertips.

“Don’t use too much force. Even if it’s not, the environment is different from the other world..... I don’t know what side effects will come if it’s exhausted.”

I nodded my head as if I agreed with Ricdorian’s worried words.

“Yes I will. Don’t worry too much. Because I didn’t spend much. And.....”

I let out a deep sigh as I recalled the area around Yoon Jia’s shoulder a moment ago.

“The girl next door to us was too popular with ‘others’.”

Ricdorian nodded his head grimly in agreement.

“I don’t think there would be anything good about being so popular with the spirits. Especially in this world.”

The ‘spirit’ referred to here was simply a ‘ghost’ in the language of this world. Souls who died but did not leave, or fragments cut in half.

This was the biggest difference between me and Ricdorian from the ordinary people here.

Those of us with otherworldly powers could ironically see the spiritual powers of this world: spirits and ghosts.

..... Where are we going to use this for?

Until now, I thought it was a really annoying option, but who knew?

Thanks to this power, I will be able to fulfill God's absurd request.

When we finally arrived at the first milestone set by God, Ricdorian and I groaned.

“..... Rose, do we really have to do this?”

“Ugh. I guess so. Rian.”

In the dark alleyway, above the note God gave me, a black compass was spinning round and round.

This means that this is the exact destination. There was only one person in this alley.

No, to be precise, there was only one boy standing, and he was a middle school student, wearing a school uniform.

In front of the boy, countless children in the same school uniform lay face down on the floor.

Did they have a fight?

I had a strong feeling that it was one-to-many. The boy who was the only one standing had no wounds on his body even though his school uniform tie was disheveled, and all the fallen children were moaning with wounds.

And the standing boy slowly raised his head.

He was a boy with a pure white face and a neat feeling. But the face frowned in an instant, and soon he raised his hand and twisted his lips.

“Kukuhk, this body is the warlock of the Rosifal Empire, kuk, kukuhk. Who dares!”

I was startled and remembered what God had told me.

After giving me the order, God personally sent me another letter, informing me of precautions.

Although I had heard beforehand that the souls who came to this world would be insane.....

“Kukuhk, hahaha, the humans here! Are all weak! Hahahaha!”

I saw the boy and the fallen children once more.

Seeing the boy touching his forehead with his left arm made me even more stunned.

You mean I have to watch this nine more times?

Chapter 248: Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (3)

1. Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (3)

I pretended to stumble and did not see anything kicked under my feet.

Thunk. The kicked can rolls away.

“Who are you!”

The boy who had been laughing madly stopped laughing and jerked his head.

His eyes, shining in the shadows of the alley, were surprisingly deep golden, like molten gold. It is a color rarely seen in this world..... There was a strange magical energy felt near the boy’s body.

This is it. I don’t have to double check.

“No, how long have you been there?! How dare.....”

The boy took a step back. He was ready to fight at any moment.

“Avoiding this body’s eyes. Huh, are you the knights of this world? The guardian?”

I was dumbfounded.

What is he saying now? Ricdorian and I walked in openly. We didn’t even hide our presence. In short, it was the other side was laughing like crazy and didn’t notice us.

“We came in on foot.”

The boy’s eyebrows twitched at my plain words.

“Ha, are you saying that you are strong enough to avoid this body’s sense?
.... Hoo. This world is also interesting.”

“You must have missed it because you were laughing.”

“How funny. This body has not yet adapted to this body, but soon!”

A black tattoo was visible on his white arm. Its shape resembled that of a winged black dragon. It wriggled as if it was alive, and black smoke flowed out.

In the blink of an eye, the boy had a wooden staff in his hand.

That one looks similar to something from a fantasy movie popular in this world. There, it looked like a magic wand owned by an elderly wizard with a white beard growing to his stomach.

An ominous aura emanated from the tip of the curved wooden staff with a wheezing sound.

“The warlock of Rosifal! Dominate!”

“..... what.”

But first I lifted one foot.

Bang!

The moment my feet hit the floor, blue energy rushed like a wave. My energy filled the alley and surrounded the boy.

“What nonsense. How.”

I pressed my hand between my brows with one hand in my large jumper pocket.

“The days are getting colder, but you’re the kind of person who makes my back feel cold again.”

I waved my hand between my brows.

Ruumbleee.

Soon I thought I heard a familiar sound, and then I heard a shout. It was the boy’s scream.

“Hey, what is this! Let go? Let go! How dare you!”

“What is it? It is a chain.”

I just clenched my fists. *Rumble!* The blue chain moved. The chains that had been loosely tied around the boy were tied tight now.

The boy looked at me with surprised eyes and struggled. I thought for a moment about loosening the chains that had blocked his mouth, but I changed my mind.

“Hey, I understand the situation.”

Looking at it a little while ago, it seemed that he was about to shout something the moment the energy formed on the staff.

If he could use magic by shouting something like Jaire, I had to keep his mouth shut.

I sighed and put my other hand in my jumper pocket.

“This place is not as lush as you think.”

Although the only God I saw was the God who sent me from the other world here.

I had heard about the manager of this world from that God. This place acts like a terminal in so many dimensions, so it’s affected a lot, but it’s because the manager here has a strong presence.

The manager and the God of the other world agreed, so I moved like this at the cost of quickly moving over there.

“See. I’m strong enough to overpower you. I was asked to catch you.”

The boy, the warlock from another world, blinked.

“Are you ready to listen quietly?”

What’s the story? To be honest, I had planned to just explain the execution process and send him back to the original world right away.

To do so, the other side needed verbal consent.

The boy nodded slowly.

“Alright. If you do anything nonsense, I will just mummy you with a chain, so remember that.”

I wondered if this person knew about *mummy*, but he must have guessed it roughly so I untied the chain. Only on the face, of course.

And that was the moment.

“*Paha!* How dare you take this body!”

The moment the boy shouted an incomprehensible sound, a desperate energy exploded.

Crash!

The blue chain broke into pieces and then scattered like powder. It didn’t take much effort, and it didn’t take much damage, but the problem was that the chain flew off and the boy’s body was free.

“Ha, I was careless. Kuh, I let my guard down because of your flat face. In fact, the end of this body is not here!”

More than anything, I don't want to hear that way of speaking any more. Is it just me?

I sighed and tried to build my strength again, but faster than that, *thump!* I heard the sound of something hitting the floor.

Looking up, the boy was lying on the floor.

“Ummm, Iana.”

Then, while stepping on the boy's back, Ricdorian tilted his head.

“Can I kill him? Oh, that's not allowed.”

Ricdorian had a huge sword in his hand. That sword engraved with a red rose was a unique weapon shaped by his guardian deity Pudding.

“This person has insulted you.”

Insulted me? Oh, he said I had a flat face.

I wasn't particularly offended, but I looked at Ricdorian and the sword aimed at the boy's neck with a puzzled face.

Pudding, which became a weapon, also clamored in my head not to leave the boy alone.

“..... I don't think it's an insult at all.”

“It's an insult. He's been peeping at you.”

“Was he?”

“I was looking.”

I rolled my eyes and scratched my cheek.

“No killing for now.”

“Then won’t only the soul come out?”

“No. The body belongs to that student.”

I didn’t want to leave a scar on the body of a young man with a bright future. Besides, the soul didn’t come out just by killing like Ricdorian said.

“For now, Rian, hold the sword as it is. Your posture is just right.”

Ricdorian did a better job of subduing than I thought.

Judging by how far away the staff the boy was holding, it seemed that Ricdorian had kicked it away as soon as he stepped out.

I squatted in front of the boy and met his gaze. Because the other side was lying down, it naturally looked like I was looking down.

“Look, actually we came to settle it very peacefully.”

In fact, I heard that it was not these people’s fault that their souls came over. It’s because they came across it by accident.

It’s a very, very rare case to be called artificially like me.

So I don’t blame these people. I made up my mind to solve it very peacefully. Although God advised that there would be conflict.

The boy who was staring at me immediately shouted with a red face.

“You are a siren! A siren! Were there monsters in this world? It’s no use trying to bewitch me with your looks!”

Why are you shouting while tied up? I said while frowning.

“Hey, did you have a crush on me?”

For some reason, the boy’s face turned red uncontrollably. It was as if the body had not seen the sun, and it was visible because it had pure white skin.

“That, that can’t be! This body is the warlock of the great empire Rosifal.....”

“Let him go and tell me.”

“Iana, wouldn’t it be better to kill him too?”

“Rian, don’t be too aggressive.”

However, Ricdorian’s face had already hardened too much.

But as soon as our eyes met, he smiled innocently, as if he had never done that before.

“No. Iana. I don’t mean to kill him. When I think about it. I don’t think this soul needs to go back.”

“..... yes?”

“The guardian deity of the red rose says there is a way to damage even the soul.”

Ricdorian continued to speak kindly with a mild face.

“Can I use that, Iana?”

“No.”

What are you talking about? Ricdorian was visibly sullen at being rejected, saying things that didn’t match his innocent face at all.

At the same time, I felt a cold sweat running down my back for the first time in a while.

Thinking about it, this man was a beast who accepted only my words like his rein. To put it bluntly, wasn’t his power itself beastly?

I quickly lowered my head.

“Did you hear? He wants your soul to disappear without a sound. I just want you to go back quietly.”

He must have overheard our conversation. The boy finally agreed to return with a frozen face, perhaps feeling the unusual atmosphere.

Rather, it seemed that he had succumbed to the sharp, terrifying aura that flowed from Ricdorian.

“Alright, I’ll go back. I will go back!”

At the same time, a huge blue spell circle formation spread in this alley. It was my strength that suddenly led me to perform ceremonies as an errand from God.

“When you go back, don’t come back here again. We may not be able to return you peacefully next time.”

Right before going back, at the same words as my warning, the translucent person who returned as a spirit nodded his head.

After that, I wanted to look at Ricdorian, but he glanced at me.

-If..... you come to my dimension..... At least a name.....

“Rose, the door will close.”

“What? Ah. Right. Run along, you.”

The spirit’s words were too small to be heard, but I couldn’t open the door for long like Ricdorian, so I quickly sent the spirit away.

That’s how our first repatriation was completed.

As soon as the work was over, Ricdorian hugged me tight. Of course, because of his huge size, I drowned.

“Iana, it’s fortunate that the threat went well.....”

“A threat? Ah. Could it be that you said that on purpose?”

Raising his head, Ricdorian rolled his eyes and gave a small smile.

“I knew you were attractive to everyone.”

Ricdorian whispered softly, barely audible.

“But I was really jealous at the end.”

Huh? What could Rian be jealous of?

His lips curved down as I looked back. I immediately smiled and kissed his lips.

Chapter 249.1: Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (4)

1. Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (4)

That's how our first repatriation ended.

Five months later.

On a night when the moonlight was alone in the sky, artificial lights filled the ground in a city where the lights never go out.

A street where neon signs decorate the city like fireworks. Since it was the weekend, there were quite a lot of people.

No. The street was lined with bars, so there's no helping it.

“Uwaaackk!”

There was a man running with a grotesque scream into the street where many people laughed and a number of people were walking.

He didn't just dodge people quickly, but sometimes he hit or caused people to fall.

“Kyaaak, Sister!”

“Ugh. What is this? Hey! Stop there?”

The person who fell did not hold back and spat out swear words, but the sound did not reach the perpetrator.

He had already run a long way to a place where the sound could not be heard.

I stopped running and quickly raised the fallen person.

As I used the power of the rose, it was not difficult to raise someone because my body gradually acquired more than normal physical abilities.

“Are you okay?”

Even though it was a weekday, there were many people on the street. I wondered if I left it like this, there would be a fall or a bigger misfortune.

“You must have suffered because of some strange person.”

“Ah..... thank you.”

The person who got up greeted me with a bewildered face. I smiled and waved my hand.

“You’re welcome.”

Pretending to be calm, I raised the fallen person, but in fact, my heart was already running again.

I quickly turned around and kicked the spot with my leg. When was the last time I ran like this?

No, there were a lot of things to run around for for three months. To make a comparison, I’ll have to take the as a standard before the day God made the second request.

I clenched my teeth.

‘You’ll be finely caught and punished. So why are you running away!’

I started late because I had to raise someone who had fallen, but I wasn't worried.

Because Ricdorian, who ran first in my place, must be chasing after the possessed body. However, I still clenched my teeth. Because I've been chasing for a week already.

This spirit is too good at running away. As soon as he realized our identity, he ran away and managed to avoid us.

At this point, I ended up getting angry even though I used to be indifferent to everything. As I ran, I bit my lip and muttered curses in my heart, but I heard a magnificent yet calm cry in my head.

"Yes. Thank you Whistle, I'm okay."

As my guardian deity, Whistle, calmed me, I quickly got myself together.

"Huh, calm down. Calm."

Looking ahead, it was full of people. I cleverly avoided people and ran to the place where Ricdorian was.

It was easy to see where Rian was. First, I instinctively knew where Ricdorian was. It was close to a sense and ability that could not be explained by logic.

And secondly.

"This way."

The place where Ricdorian stayed was fragrant. To be precise, the strong scent of roses remained where he exerted his strength.

It's a scent that feels very good to me, who has more senses than the average person.

It wasn't difficult to find him with these elements.

And looking at Ricdorian's traces, I could see that he also felt unusually angry. That's because he used his ability quite strongly.

Well, Ricdorian's anger seemed to lie in the fact that this loach-like creature made me angry rather than it was good at avoiding

– Human, come on, Nyan!

“I'm coming, coming.”

Soon, we entered a deserted road. As the uphill road continued, the number of people naturally decreased.

It seemed that Ricdoian had properly lured him down this path.

I finally arrived and saw a man standing tall in the dark open space.

It was Rian.

“Ha, did you catch it?”

I stopped and caught my breath. In fact, I was not out of breath, but I'm trying to gather my mind.

I couldn't calm the anger from the four-day chase, so I want to get this spirit while trying to send it back quickly.

Let's calm down. There was nothing wrong with being cautious.

It was already the 8th spirit.

When I think of the process of the past five months, it was truly a journey that cannot be done without tears.

Yes. I can't go and ruin it now.

I clenched my teeth one last time and straightened my expression. The more I walked, the more I felt Rian's power.

“No. I must say you did a good job of inducing them.”

“Iana.”

Ricdorian, who was holding the sword, turned his head. Perhaps the average person would not have seen that weapon.

A smile as innocent as the spring sun appeared on his face, which had been infinitely cold and sincere.

“You’re here.”

“You already knew I was coming.”

He must have noticed me just as I felt Ricdorian.

Rather than saying that Rean has the ability to find roses like me..... Of course, as a rose, there are also things that make him look for the Blue Rose.

Rather, it would be largely due to the mixture of his and my powers, albeit partly.

Pudding belonged to me, so I couldn’t say it wasn’t mixed.

The biggest thing is, of course, mixing our bodies.

Looking back on the night, um, day, I don’t think there was a time where it was not exaggerated. It was not for nothing that his power was the equivalent of a ‘beast’.

“Iana?”

Ricdorian tilted his head.

At this urgent moment, I couldn’t say that I was appreciating the beauty of my partner, so I quickly came to my senses.

“Sorry. You’re so handsome all over again.”

Ricdorian laughed mischievously.

“I am happy that Rose likes it. I think I should take care of it in the future.”

“You were already born with it. What do you need to care for more?”

When I gave him a thumbs up, Ricdorian’s ears were blushing.

Now, after several years of coming here, Ricdorian still had no interest in this world or society.

Could it be because of the years he has lived as a ruler? Even the people he encountered sometimes had difficulty with Ricdorian Perhaps because of his power, he seemed to cause tension in normal people, such as intimidation and pressure.

So, the only person who admired his appearance unexpectedly and innocently was the youngest daughter next door.

I threw a glance at one place while having a conversation that sounded carefree in some ways.

When I slowly turned my head, there was an old man standing there.

Bzzztt.

However, a spark like lightning flew around the old man, and a certain shape appeared on the old man’s face and then disappeared.

Like a broken hologram that appeared and disappeared repeatedly.

The appearance and disappearance of that young man was the true form of the spirit in that body.

He took turns looking at our faces, then frowned in displeasure.

Chapter 249.2: Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (4)

6. Until two discordant roses become an ensemble (4)

“You pair of cockroaches.”

As the wrinkled lips opened and the words flowed out, I made an absurd face.

What did he just say now?

“Huh, while I haven’t seen you, your language has improved?”

“I have learned.”

I have felt it after going through as many as 8 spirits, exorcism, and repatriation, but the spirits went through a similar adaptation process after possessing this place.

There were spirits who adapted well here, and there were spirits who could not even pronounce the words of this place properly over time.

Before, that spirit definitely belonged to the latter.

However, after a few days of not seeing him, his language appeared to be at a high level now

“I saw it in a little square box. They called men and women like you, cockroaches.”

The spirit said while stroking his chin proudly. His way of speaking sounded unpleasant to me.

After all, the spirit that had made me suffer for a week could not look good no matter what he did.

So far, spirits have come from various dimensions, but as far as I know, the dimension to which that spirit has passed has similar martial arts to that world.

In fact, he moved well while talking about lightening the body or something.

I turned my head and looked at Ricdorian.

“Hey. Pudding, is that your tone? It’s very similar to your initial way of talking.”

To be precise, I looked at the sword and talked to it, and soon I heard a hissing sound in my head.

– Do, do not compare! This body didn’t do that, Nyan!

“Huh, I heard that frogs can’t remember its tadpole days. Have you forgotten about it?”

– I didn’t! It wasn’t like that, Nyan!

“I corrected you a lot. I’m disappointed.”

While talking with Pudding, the old man moved quickly.

Bam!

“Where are you going?”

However, the old man’s movements were soon blocked by a deep blue wall. The translucent blue wall surrounded the old man and us.

It was laid out before the old man arrived here.

“How much trouble did I have to put this on?”

“Kuh, khmmm.”

“I would have cried if I hadn’t been able to use it.”

I narrowed my eyes as the old man averted his gaze with a flustered face.

“Uncle, you’re not listening to people’s words with your heart. Are you really smart?”

“Depending on your needs, sometimes you have to make decisions in order to survive....”

“It’s nonsense philosophy. If that belief moves as needed, where is that belief now?”

The old man’s shoulders trembled at the casually thrown words. Meanwhile, Ricdorian’s hand grabbed my shoulder.

“..... You can’t cry, Iana.”

Rian said with a very serious expression, so I was taken aback for a moment. Then nodded in bewilderment.

“I’m not crying.”

Did I almost cry? Rian seemed to be very concerned about me, so I gathered my expression again.

I smiled and reached out and stroked his cheek.

“You’re so nice. You pay attention to every passing word.”

“I’m not nice.”

Ricdorian slightly lowered his head and put it down for me to stroke. Then he smiled a little.

“Rose, I’m only tamed by your hand holding the reins.”

I agreed with a similarly small laugh.

“I guess so.”

He is a beast that has been tamed only by me in the world, and the more I spend with him, the more I feel it. I think this is a very happy thing.

As I have an exclusive desire and obsession that I didn’t know about myself, my heart grows bigger and bigger.

“Okay then, let’s end small talk here. Shall we do our thing?”

“Yes.”

I turned my head and stared at the old man who was struggling to sneak out.

“Come on, old man. No. Is that a man inside? Anyway, let’s get you home now.”

The old man was struggling until the very end. However, some of my last seven spirits were like this one, so I easily subdued him.

It wasn’t a difficult opponent to deal with unless he ran away like in the first place.

Like the previous process, Ricdorian steadfastly subdued the old man, and a huge ‘door’ opened under the old man’s body.

The blue energy created a strong wind. The door, like a beast’s mouth, only took in spirits, and finally silence fell in the clearing.

I let out a breath, brushing my hair, which was tousled with the wind.

“Finally the eighth is over.”

Where the door and the giant circle disappeared, only the body of the fallen old man and..... a strong scent of roses left.

Ricdorian, who returned the sword form back to Pudding before I knew it, strode forward. He leaned over and kissed my cheek lightly.

It just came to my mind, but if Ricdorian wasn't here, this series of processes would be quite, no. it would be really hard.

The spirits weren't always quiet, so I needed someone to subdue them while I opened the door.

It wasn't difficult for me to subdue them, but I couldn't do it at the same time as opening the door.

I hugged the man that was like asking 'Did I do well?', and patted him on the back.

"Well done."

"Then will you hold me?"

"Where?"

A low laugh echoed in my ears.

"In bed."

I burst into laughter at Ricdorian's bold words.

"Not bad."

Today too, I fell asleep around the time I saw the morning stars. It wasn't bad in many ways. Especially on days when I can send one spirit back and rest in peace for a few days.

Now there are only two left.

I expected this process to be easy, albeit cumbersome.

Just like the previous process.

But this was a mistake.

No. It didn't take long before I realized it was a very, very big mistake.

Bang!

The ground shook violently with an earth-shaking roar. Dirt and stones fall under.

The cracked ground, like a spider's web, looked precarious as if it would collapse at any moment.

“Haa, haa.”

I let out a rough breath that I hadn't breathed in a while and raised my head.

A huge sword was stuck in the place where I was a moment ago.

If I had moved just a little bit later, I would have been cut by that sharp greatsword.

– Hu, human. Do something, Nyan! If this.....

Pudding's pitiful cries echoed in my head. I wanted to answer, but I didn't have the time.

Because the sword flew back to me.

It would be nice if I could get that sword off. It seemed far-fetched to get that sword out when it was tied tightly to the hand with the stem of a rose.

The man finally raised his sword again, tilting his head loosely and looking at me.

Under the clear moonlight, the man who aimed his sword at me smiled beautifully.

Those eyes were absolutely vivid.

“Rian.”

Hearing my call, Ricdorian’s smile deepened. While wielding the sword.

I thought while avoiding the sword.

..... How do I bring him back to his senses?

Looking back at where things went wrong in my head. I had to go back an hour before Ricdorian became strange.

To the time when the God-given mission was accomplished, the notice was just around the corner.